

# THE DOORS OF STONE

*Day Three of the Kingkiller Chronicle*

*A continuation in the spirit of Patrick Rothfuss*

## **A Note**

An unofficial fan continuation, written in homage to Patrick Rothfuss's *The Name of the Wind* and *The Wise Man's Fear*. It is not written, authorized, or endorsed by Patrick Rothfuss or his publishers, and it is not the forthcoming novel of the same name. The characters and world of the *Kingkiller Chronicle* belong to their creator.

## **PROLOGUE: A Silence Waiting**

Dawn came slowly to the Waystone Inn, and when it came it found a silence of three parts.

The first part was the silence of a house that has not yet decided to wake. The fire in the great stone hearth had burned down to a bed of red and grey, and the grey was winning. The chairs sat upside down on the tables like sleeping animals with their legs in the air. Nothing creaked. Nothing settled. The kettle hanging on its iron arm did not so much as tick as it cooled. If there had been a cat, it would have been asleep, and if there had been a dog, it would have been dreaming, and neither of them would have made a sound. But there was no cat and no dog, and so the silence of the house was a plain one, clean and uncomplicated, like a bowl that has been washed and set upside down to dry.

The second part was a waiting silence. It came in under the door and through the chinks in the shutters along with the thin grey light. It was the silence of a town that has learned to hold its breath. In the months past, the people of Newarre had learned many new silences. There was the silence of a road where no carts came. There was the silence of a field left unharvested because the man who worked it had gone off to fight for a king he had never seen. There was the silence that fell when a stranger walked down the only street, and the particular hard silence of a mother who has heard something moving in the dark beyond the edge of the lamplight and knows better than to go and look. All these silences had crept into Newarre and settled there, and on this grey morning they gathered close around the inn as if

they were waiting for something. As if they knew.

The third silence was not an easy thing to notice. If you had walked into the Waystone that morning, you might have stood for an hour among the upturned chairs and never heard it at all. But it was there. It lived in the long bar of dark wood and in the bottles behind it. It lived in the blank space on the wall above the hearth, where a sword hung on two pegs beneath a plaque with a single word burned into it. It lived most of all in the innkeeper, who stood behind the bar with a white cloth in his hand, polishing a stretch of mahogany that did not need polishing.

He had red hair. Not ginger, not auburn, not the color of copper or of rust or of the leaves in autumn. Red, true red, the color of a flame that has been burning for a long time and means to burn for a long while yet. It was the only thing about him that seemed to mean anything at all.

The rest of him was bruised. There was a darkness along his jaw like a smudge of ink, and one of his eyes was swollen, and he moved his left arm with the careful economy of a man who knows exactly where the pain begins and has no wish to go looking for its edges. He did not look like a man who had been in a fight so much as a man who had been caught out in weather. Something had happened to him, and he had let it.

That was the third silence. It was the silence of a man who is waiting, and has been waiting for a long time, and has grown so used to waiting that he has forgotten what it was he wanted. It was the patient, cut-flower silence of a man who is waiting to die.

He polished the bar. Outside, a bird tried a few notes and thought better of it.

\* \* \*

Somewhere above him, a board creaked.

The innkeeper's hands stopped. It was a small thing. A man walking past the bar would not have seen it. But for the space of a breath the cloth lay still on the wood, and the innkeeper's head tilted ever so slightly toward the ceiling, the way a musician's head will tilt

at the first note of a tune he knows too well.

Then the moment passed, and the cloth began to move again in its slow, patient circles.

The stairs creaked. A young man came down them, dark-haired and fine-boned, moving with a graceful, slouching ease that made the stairs seem like a courtesy he was paying to the world rather than a thing he needed. He paused on the bottom step and looked across the room at the innkeeper, and his face did something complicated.

"Reshi," he said.

"Bast." The innkeeper did not look up. "You're awake early."

"I never went to sleep." Bast crossed the room and stood on the other side of the bar. He looked at the bruise along the innkeeper's jaw. He looked for a long time. "It's worse."

"Bruises are always worse on the second day. It's the nature of the thing. You know that."

"I know that you're a terrible liar when you're tired."

"Then it's good I'm not lying." The innkeeper folded the cloth into a neat square and set it on the bar. For the first time, he looked up, and his eyes were a flat and quiet green, like a pond at the edge of a wood. "It's the third day, Bast."

Bast's face went through several shapes before settling on something careful. "Yes."

"Is he awake?"

"Not yet. I checked. He sleeps like a scribe. On his back, with his hands folded, as if someone might come and read him." Bast hesitated. "Reshi. About the story."

"Go and put the kettle on."

"Reshi—"

"The kettle, Bast." The innkeeper's voice was mild. It was always mild. It had the texture of old linen, soft from a thousand washings. "We'll want tea. And porridge. And there's bread from yesterday that can be toasted if you watch it, which you won't, so I'll watch it. Go on."

For a moment it seemed Bast would argue. Something moved behind his eyes, something older and colder than a young man ought to carry. Then it went away again, and he was only a dark-haired boy with an unhappy mouth, and he went into the kitchen.

The innkeeper stood alone in the common room. He looked at the sword above the hearth. It hung there as it always did, grey and plain and unremarkable, the sort of blade a traveler might hang up to pay a debt. The plaque beneath it had been made by a man named Graham, who was good with wood and had been proud of the work. A single word was burned into it in black letters.

FOLLY.

The innkeeper looked at it the way a man looks at a letter he has read so many times that the paper has gone soft at the folds.

Then he began to take the chairs down from the tables, one by one, and set them on their feet. He did it quietly. He did it well. There was a rhythm to it, down and turn and set, down and turn and set, and anyone watching would have said that here was a man who knew his trade and took some pleasure in it.

Anyone watching would have been wrong.

\* \* \*

Upstairs, in the best room the Waystone had to offer, a man named Devan Lochees opened his eyes and lay very still, listening to the sound of chairs being set upon the floor below.

Most people called him Chronicler. He had been called that for so long that he sometimes forgot it was not his name. He was a man past the first flush of youth, with a neat beard and the kind of face that suggests its owner has been told a great many lies and written most of them down anyway. His right hand ached in a dull, familiar way. There was ink ground into the side of his middle finger so deep that no amount of scrubbing would ever take it out. He had spent two long days listening and writing, and his hand knew it even if the rest of him had slept.

He lay there and thought about the story.

He had come to Newarre looking for a legend. He had found an innkeeper. He had been told, in a quiet voice across a quiet table, that the innkeeper would tell the whole of it, the true story, but that it would take three days. Chronicler had laughed at that. He had never taken more than two days to record any story, and those were long ones, the kind where the teller wandered off into his grandfather's childhood and had to be led back by the elbow.

Now it was the third day, and they were not close to done.

He thought about a young man in a red cloak standing before a door without a handle. He thought about a girl with dark hair who never stayed. He thought about a thing in a tree that could see every path the world might take and chose, every time, the one that ended worst.

He thought about the look on the innkeeper's face last night, after the soldiers, as he sat with a wet cloth to his jaw and stared into nothing. It had not been the look of a man in pain. It had been the look of a man who had been expecting pain for a long time, and was faintly disappointed that it had not been more.

Chronicler sat up. He reached for the leather satchel on the chair beside the bed and drew out a sheaf of paper, a fresh bottle of ink, and a pen he had cut the night before. He checked the nib. He checked it again. It was a habit, like a soldier checking his straps before a march.

Then he sat for a moment with the pen in his hand and did not move.

He had spent most of his life writing down true things. He was good at it. Better than good. He could take a man's rambling half-remembered account of a battle and render it down to its bones and set those bones on the page in such a way that anyone reading them would know what had happened, and why, and how it had felt. He had a cipher of his own devising that let him write faster than any man could speak. He had trained his memory until it was a sharp and orderly thing, a room with shelves where every word had its place.

And yet this morning he had the strangest feeling. It was the feeling a man gets when he has been carrying something heavy for a

long time without noticing, and then someone asks him what it is, and he looks down and discovers that it is not his.

The story he was writing was not only a story. He could not have said how he knew that. But he knew it the way you know, walking into a room, that someone has been crying there.

Chronicler put the pen back in its case. He dressed. He went to the window and opened the shutter and looked out at the grey morning and the grey road and the scattering of grey houses that made up the town of Newarre.

Far off, above the trees at the edge of the fields, a thin line of smoke rose into the sky. It did not rise straight, the way smoke from a chimney rises on a still morning. It bent. It leaned, as if something were pulling at it.

Chronicler watched it for a long time. Then he closed the shutter and went downstairs.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper looked up as he came into the common room and smiled. It was a good smile. Warm, practiced, professional. It was the smile of an innkeeper greeting a guest.

"Good morning," he said. "There's tea, and there will be porridge soon if Bast doesn't burn it."

"I heard that," said Bast's voice from the kitchen.

"You were meant to." The innkeeper gestured to a table near the hearth, where two chairs had already been set down and a third was waiting upside down on the tabletop, legs in the air, as if it could not decide whether to join them. "Sit. Eat. Then we'll begin."

Chronicler sat. He put his satchel on the table and did not open it. After a moment the innkeeper brought over a pot of tea and two cups and sat down across from him. He poured. His hands were steady. The bruise on his jaw had gone the color of a plum in the night, and the swelling around his eye had closed it halfway, but his hands were perfectly steady.

"You're hurt," Chronicler said.



"I've been hurt before." The innkeeper set the pot down. "And I suspect I will be again before the day is done. Drink your tea."

Chronicler drank his tea. It was very good tea, and he said so.

"It's the water," said the innkeeper. "There's a spring behind the stable. It comes up cold even in summer. Old Cob says it's the coldest water in three counties, and while Old Cob says a great many things, I've never caught him lying about water." He turned his cup a quarter turn on the table and looked into it. "It's the third day."

"Yes."

"You've been wondering how I'll fit it all in."

Chronicler hesitated, then nodded. "Honestly? Yes. I've recorded a great many stories. I know how long a thing takes to tell. And from where we stopped last night—" He spread his hands. "There's a great deal left. The Maer. The University. The girl. The king. I don't see how—"

"You don't see how I can come to the end of it in a day." The innkeeper smiled again, but this smile was a different animal altogether. It was small and crooked and a little sad, and it did not belong to any innkeeper. "Neither do I. But I said three days, and I meant it. A thing that is said three times becomes true, and I have said it more than three times now." He lifted his cup. "Besides. Some stories are longer than the time it takes to tell them. And some are shorter. You'll see."

Bast came out of the kitchen carrying two bowls of porridge with the air of a man carrying the crown jewels of a small but proud nation. He set them down with a flourish. The porridge was not burnt. It was, in fact, perfect, and Bast looked so pleased with himself that Chronicler almost laughed.

The innkeeper looked down at his bowl for a long moment. Then he looked up at Bast.

"Thank you, Bast," he said.

Something in the way he said it made Bast go still. The young man's eyes, which were a very deep blue, went bright for a moment. Then he sniffed and turned away and said, "It's only porridge, Reshi,"

and went back into the kitchen, and they heard him banging pots there, rather more loudly than was strictly necessary.

They ate. Outside, the morning wore on. A wagon passed on the road, the first in days, its wheels creaking. Someone shouted a greeting and was answered. The silences of Newarre drew back a little, the way they always did in the daylight, and waited.

When the bowls were empty, the innkeeper pushed his away and folded his hands on the table.

"Get out your pen," he said.

Chronicler got out his pen.

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. There was something in his green eyes, something moving under the surface like a fish under ice. Then it was gone.

"I have told you," he said quietly, "how I came to the University, and what I did there, and how I left it for a time. I have told you about the Maer, and the Adem, and Felurian. I have told you a great deal about myself that I would rather not have said aloud." He paused. "Today I will tell you how I lost everything I had worked for. I will tell you how I came to be called Kingkiller. I will tell you about the doors of stone."

He looked across the room, at the sword hanging over the hearth.

"And I will tell you how I came to be here," he said. "Which is, I think, the part you've been waiting for."

Chronicler dipped his pen.

"Where did we stop?" asked the innkeeper, but he did not wait for an answer. He was already somewhere else, somewhere far away and long ago. His voice changed as he began to speak. It grew deeper, and warmer, and somehow younger, and the Waystone Inn seemed to lean in close around the table to listen.

"I came back to the University," said Kvothe, "with more money than I had ever held in my life. And I want you to understand how dangerous that was."

# **PART ONE: THE NAME OF STONE**

## Chapter One

# Return

Money is a kind of weather. When you have none, it is all you can think about, the way a man lost in a snowstorm can think of nothing but the cold. When you have enough, you stop noticing it, the way you stop noticing a pleasant afternoon. But when you have more than enough, when you have suddenly and unexpectedly been handed more than you have ever held, it becomes a storm of a different sort. It gets into your head. It changes the way you walk.

I came back to the University with the Maer's gold in my purse and his letter of patronage folded in my shirt, and I walked like a man who owned the road.

I want to be clear. I was not rich, not the way the sons of barons were rich, the ones who lived in the Golden Pony and paid a man to carry their books. But I had enough to pay my tuition for a year. I had enough to settle my debt with Devi, which was the kind of debt that followed a man into his dreams. I had enough to buy new clothes and a good pair of boots and to eat meat every day of the week if I chose. I had enough, for the first time since I was a boy of twelve sleeping on the rooftops of Tarbean, to stop counting.

That was the danger. When you stop counting, you stop paying attention. And I have always been at my worst when I have stopped paying attention.

\* \* \*

The road from Severen had been long and wet. By the time the stone bridge came into view, rising over the Omethi river in its great impossible arch, I had been traveling for the better part of a month, and I was tired in the particular way a man gets tired when he has been sleeping in inns where the sheets were changed last spring.

But when I saw the bridge, I felt something loosen in my chest.

It is hard to explain what the University was to me. It was not home, not the way the wagons of my troupe had been home. It was not safe; I had been nearly killed there more than once. But it was the place where I had first understood that the world was a thing that could be learned. It was the place where I had found friends who did not want anything from me but my company. It was the place where the Archives stood, windowless and grey, holding every answer I had ever wanted and a thousand more I had not yet thought to ask.

I crossed the bridge at a walk, though every part of me wanted to run. At the top of the arch I stopped, as I always did, and looked out over the river. The water was high and brown with the autumn rains. The trees along the banks had gone gold and red. And there, rising above the rooftops of the town, was the Archives, looking just as it always had: a great square block of stone with no windows at all, like a secret that had decided to stand up in the middle of the road and dare anyone to ask it questions.

I smiled. I could not help it.

Then I went down the far side of the bridge and into Imre, and the first thing I did was buy a pie.

\* \* \*

It was a meat pie, and it was not a very good one. The crust was too thick and the gravy too thin, and there was something in the meat that might have been rabbit and might have been something with more legs. But I ate it standing in the street outside the baker's shop with gravy running down my wrist, and I have eaten meals at the tables of kings that did not taste half so fine.

When I had finished, I licked my fingers, wiped my hands on my new trousers, and went to find my friends.

I found Simmon first. It was not difficult. It was midafternoon, which meant that Sim would be in one of three places: in the Archives, pretending to study; in the Mews, actually sleeping; or at Anker's, drinking cider and arguing about poetry with anyone who would sit still long enough.

He was at Anker's. He was arguing about poetry. The person he was arguing with was a very bored-looking second-year I did not recognize, who had the glazed expression of a man who has made a terrible mistake and is only now beginning to understand its scope.

"—because meter is not a *cage*," Sim was saying, with the fierce earnestness he brought to everything. "It's a trellis. You grow the words along it. And if you just throw it away, the whole thing sprawls. You get—"

"Weeds," I said, dropping into the chair beside him.

Sim turned. He stared at me. Then his face split open in a smile so wide and so bright that I felt my own face answer it before I could stop myself.

"Kvothe!" He threw his arms around me, nearly upsetting the table. The second-year took this opportunity to flee, and I don't think either of us noticed. "Tehlu's balls, you're back! You're actually back! We thought—Wil said—" He pulled back and looked at me, still gripping my shoulders. "You look *terrible*."

"Thank you."

"No, I mean—you look older. And you've got—" He frowned. "Is that a scar?"

I touched my cheek. There was a thin line there, pale against the tan I had picked up on the road. A souvenir of Haert, and of a woman named Vashet who had very firm ideas about how swiftly a student ought to learn to get out of the way.

"It's a long story," I said.

"You always say that."

"They're always long stories. I don't know what to tell you. I lead a very complicated life." I signaled to Anker, who was behind the bar watching us with an expression of mild amusement. He nodded and

reached for a mug. "Where's Wil?"

"Archives. He's been working the desk three shifts a week since you left. Lorren likes him. He says Wil has the soul of a filing cabinet." Sim grinned. "Wil took it as a compliment."

"It probably was."

"That's what worries me." Sim sat back, looking at me with bright eyes. "So. Tell me everything. Where have you been? What happened with the Maer? Did you find the Amyr? Did you—" He stopped. His face did something awkward. "Did you see Denna?"

The mug came. I drank from it to give myself time. It was cider, cold and sharp, and it tasted like home.

"I'll tell you," I said. "But not now, and not here. Let's find Wil first. It's a story I'd only like to tell once."

Sim looked at me for a moment longer. He was not the most perceptive of people. He was too kind for it, and too honest; he took people at their word because it would never have occurred to him to do otherwise. But he had known me for more than two years, and he was not a fool.

"All right," he said quietly. "Wil gets off shift at sixth bell. We'll go to the Eolian."

I nodded. Then, because I could not stop myself, I asked, "Has she been here?"

Sim did not have to ask who I meant.

"Once," he said. "About two months ago. She came to the Eolian and sang, and then she was gone again. She asked about you."

"What did she ask?"

"Whether you were back. Whether we'd heard from you. The usual things." He hesitated. "She looked well, Kvothe. She looked happy."

I nodded and drank my cider and did not say anything. Something in my chest twisted, and I could not have told you whether it was pleasure or pain. With Denna it was often both.

\* \* \*

I spent the rest of the afternoon settling back into myself.

First I went to see Anker about my room. It was still there, the narrow little space under the eaves at the top of the stairs, with its window that opened onto the rooftops. Anker had kept it for me, though I had been gone for most of a year and had not paid a penny in rent. When I tried to pay him now, he waved me off.

"You played here," he said, "before you left. Twice a span. The place was full every time. I figure that's worth something." He scratched his chin. "Course, if you want to start playing again, I won't say no."

"Two nights a span," I said. "Same as before."

He smiled. "Same as before."

It is a small thing, to have a room waiting for you. But I had spent a great deal of my life without one, and I climbed the stairs feeling lighter than I had in months. I opened the door. The room was just as I had left it: the narrow bed, the small table, the window. Someone, probably Anker, had dusted. There was a faint smell of lavender, which was strange until I saw the small bundle of dried flowers tied with a bit of blue thread and set upon the windowsill.

I knew who had left it there.

I went to the window and looked out at the rooftops. The sun was going down, painting the slate and tile with gold. Somewhere out there, beneath the University, in the dark tunnels and forgotten rooms of the Underthing, a small girl with hair like a dandelion's ghost was going about her business.

I would go and see her tonight, I decided. Once the moon was up.

\* \* \*

Wil was waiting for us outside the Eolian when Sim and I arrived. He stood with his hands in his pockets and his dark Cealdish face as unreadable as ever, but when he saw me his eyebrows went up a fraction of an inch, which for Wil was the equivalent of dancing in the street.

"You're alive," he said.

"Evidently."



He considered this. "Good," he said. And then, with no change of expression whatsoever, he stepped forward and embraced me, briefly and hard, and stepped back again. "You owe me three drinks."

"I owe you a great deal more than that."

"True. But three drinks is a place to begin." He gestured to the door. "Shall we?"

The Eolian was just as I remembered it. The great round room with its high ceiling. The stage in the center, raised like an altar. The balconies circling above, where the wealthy and the wellborn sat to look down on the rest of us. The smell of wine and smoke and wood polish, and beneath it, faint and sweet, the smell of music. That sounds foolish, I know. But any musician will tell you that a place where music is played well and often takes on a smell of its own, the way a church takes on the smell of incense even when no incense is burning.

Stanchion was behind the bar. He saw me as I came in and his face broke into a broad grin beneath his beard.

"Look what the cat dragged in!" he boomed. "Kvothe! We'd thought you'd run off to be a pirate."

"I considered it," I said. "But the hours were terrible."

He laughed and came around the bar to clap me on the shoulder. Stanchion was a big man, and his claps on the shoulder were not gentle things. I staggered a little and he laughed again. "Your pipes still good?"

I touched the silver pipes pinned to my cloak. "Still good."

"Then you'll play tonight."

"I don't have my lute. It's at Anker's."

"Then go get it." He grinned. "I'm serious. We've had nothing but fiddlers for two spans. Fiddlers and one very sad man with a hurdy-gurdy. The crowd is starving. You play, and your drinks are free."

I glanced at Sim and Wil. Sim was nodding enthusiastically. Wil shrugged, which from Wil was a ringing endorsement.

"All right," I said. "But I have to tell these two a story first."

\* \* \*

We took a table in the corner, away from the stage. I bought the first round, and the second, and I told them everything.

Well. Not everything. There were things about Felurian I left out, for reasons of both discretion and self-preservation. And there were things about the Cthaeh I did not tell them, because I did not know how, and because some part of me was afraid that if I spoke of it aloud, it would become more real.

But I told them about the Maer, and his troubles with the poisoner Caudicus. I told them about the bandits in the Eld, and the Amyr, or rather, the lack of Amyr. I told them about the Adem, and Vashet, and Tempi, and the long hard days of learning the Ketan. I told them about my sword, which I had left in my room at Anker's because it did not seem polite to wear a sword to a tavern where people played music. And I told them about the Maer's marriage to Meluan Lackless, and how I had helped to arrange it with songs and letters, and how he had rewarded me.

When I finished, Sim was staring at me with his mouth open. Wil had not moved at all, except to drink.

"That's," Sim said. He shook his head. "That's the craziest thing I have ever heard."

"All of it's true."

"I know. That's what makes it crazy." He ran his hands through his hair. "You went into the Fae. You actually went into the Fae. And came out again."

"Keep your voice down."

"Why? Nobody here will believe it." He laughed, a little wildly. "I'm not sure I believe it, and I know you."

Wil set down his mug. "What did Felurian look like?"

"Wil!" Sim hit him on the arm.

"It is a scholarly question."

"It is not a scholarly question. It's a *prurient* question."

"The two are not mutually exclusive." Wil looked at me with his dark, patient eyes. "Well?"

I thought about how to answer that. Then I thought about how she would feel if she knew I had described her to a pair of students in a tavern, and I decided that I did not want to find out.

"She was beautiful," I said. "Beyond that, I'd rather keep my skin."

Wil nodded slowly, as if this confirmed something he had long suspected. "Sensible."

We sat in silence for a moment. On the stage, a fiddler was finishing a reel. The crowd applauded politely. Sim looked at me across the table, and his face was serious for once.

"And the Chandrian?" he asked. "Did you learn anything?"

I hesitated. Then I shook my head. "Not much. Not enough. The Maer's library had a few old books that mentioned them, but nothing I didn't already know. Stories. Hints. Nobody who's actually seen them and lived." I paused. "Except me."

"You'll find something," Sim said. "You always do."

I smiled at him, and I did not say what I was thinking, which was this: I had been at the University for more than two years. I had spent more hours in the Archives than I could count. I had read every book on the Chandrian I could find, and every book on the Amyr, and every book that mentioned either of them even in passing. And I had learned almost nothing.

It was as if someone had gone through the Archives before me with a sharp knife, cutting out every page that mattered.

At the time I thought that was only a turn of phrase.

\* \* \*

I went back to Anker's and got my lute and came back to the Eolian and played until my fingers ached.

I played "Tinker Tanner" to warm up, because the crowd was restless and it's hard for any crowd to stay restless in the face of a tinker's song. I played "The Lay of Sir Savien Traliard" because I had not played it in a long time and wanted to know if I still could. I played two songs I had learned from the Adem, which are not really songs at all but more like patterns of breath and silence, and the Eolian went so

quiet you could hear the candles burning. And I played a song I had written on the road back from Severen, a small, sad thing about a girl who never stayed in one place long enough to be found.

I did not look up at the balconies while I played that one. I did not look for a dark-haired girl with a ring on her finger. I did not look for her the way you do not look at the sun, because you know that if you do, you will be blind for a long time after.

When I finished, the room was silent. Then the applause came, rolling down from the balconies like thunder. I bowed. I smiled. I felt, for a moment, the old sweet hot joy of it, the joy of holding a roomful of people in the palm of your hand.

Then I went back to the table where Sim and Wil were waiting, and Stanchion sent over a bottle of wine, and the three of us drank it, and for a few hours I forgot to be anything but seventeen and glad to be home.

\* \* \*

It was late when I left the Eolian. The streets of Imre were dark and mostly empty. The moon was up, three-quarters full, silver and serene. I crossed the bridge back to the University with my lute on my back and my head buzzing pleasantly with wine.

I did not go to Anker's. Instead I went to a small courtyard behind the Mains, where a grate in the ground led down into darkness. I had brought a few things with me in my pockets: a bit of cheese wrapped in cloth, a small sack of dried apples, a sprig of mint I had picked on the road that morning and kept in a twist of paper.

I knelt by the grate and whistled softly. Three notes, rising.

For a long moment nothing happened. Then, far below, I heard a faint answering sound, a patter of bare feet on stone. A small pale face appeared at the bottom of the shaft, looking up at me with enormous eyes.

"Kvothe," Auri breathed. "You came back."

"I did," I said. "I brought you some things."

She tilted her head. "What sort of things?"

"Good things. Come up and see."

She scrambled up through the grate with the quick, careful grace of a squirrel and sat back on her heels in the moonlight, looking at me. She was thinner than I remembered. Her hair floated around her head like a cloud of silk. She wore a simple dress that had once been white and was now the color of old bone, and her feet were bare and very clean.

"You were gone a long time," she said.

"I know. I'm sorry."

"The moon went round and round." She looked up at it, then back at me. "Seven times. I counted."

"That's right."

"I left you flowers." She said it shyly, looking down at her hands.

"I found them," I said. "They were lovely. They made the whole room smell like a meadow."

She beamed at that, a sudden brilliant smile like sunlight through a cloud. Then she looked at my pockets expectantly.

I laughed and gave her the cheese first. She unwrapped it with great solemnity, sniffed it, and pronounced it "brave." The dried apples were "patient." The mint made her eyes go wide and wondering, and she held the sprig up to the moonlight and turned it this way and that, as if it were a jewel.

"This is from very far away," she said.

"From the road near Tinuë. I picked it this morning."

"It remembers." She pressed it to her nose and closed her eyes. "It remembers the rain."

We sat on the stones in the moonlight and ate cheese and apples together, and she told me about the Underthing, about the new pipe that had begun to drip in Clinks and the place in Tumbrel where a whole family of little grey moths had come to live. She did not ask me where I had been, and I did not tell her. That was one of the things I loved about Auri. She never asked questions that were not hers to ask.

When the cheese was gone, she sat for a while in silence, looking up at the moon. Then she said, quite suddenly, "The doors are sleeping."

I looked at her. "What doors?"

"The deep ones." She did not look away from the moon. "They are sleeping, but they are not sleepy. There's a difference." She frowned, as if trying to make the words fit. "Something is sleeping on the other side of them. And sometimes, when it dreams, the doors dream too."

A chill went through me. I could not have said why.

"Auri," I said carefully. "Which doors are those?"

But she only shook her head. "That's not a proper question," she said, and there was a note of reproach in her voice. "You don't ask a door its business. You wait until it tells you."

Then she stood, all at once, and brushed off her dress. "Thank you for the brave cheese," she said formally. "And the patient apples. And the mint that remembers."

"You're welcome, Auri."

She smiled at me, and then she was gone, back down through the grate and into the dark, the patter of her feet fading away into silence.

I sat there alone for a long time, looking up at the moon.

The doors are sleeping, she had said. But they are not sleepy.

I did not know it then, but I had just been told the first true thing about the rest of my life.

## Chapter Two

### **Anker's**

I came back to Anker's late that first night, after the Eolian, with my fingers aching and my ears still ringing with applause. The common room was nearly empty. Anker was behind the bar, wiping it down with a rag that had been white once, a very long time ago, and he looked up when I came in and jerked his head at a stool.

"Sit," he said. "You look like a man who needs a drink he doesn't have to pay for."

I sat.

The common room was the same as it had always been. Low and dim and warm, with a fire in the hearth and a smell of beer and woodsmoke and the stew that was always, always simmering in the pot. A few students I did not know were sitting at a table by the window, bent over their books. An old man I did not know was asleep in the corner.

Anker drew me a beer without asking and set it on the bar in front of me. Then he leaned on the bar and looked at me.

"So," he said. "Vintas."

"Vintas."

"And the Maer. The big one. Alveron." He shook his head slowly. "Everyone's been talking. That you went off to Severen and did something for the Maer, something big, and now you're his man. That you fought bandits in the Eld. That you went into the Fae and came out again." He looked at me sidelong. "That you learned to fight from the Adem, and they cut off your finger for it."

I held up my hands, all ten fingers. Anker squinted at them.

"Hm," he said. "Well. That one was probably Sim."

"Probably."

\* \* \*

We talked for a while. Or Anker talked, and I listened, and drank my beer, and let the warm dim familiar room settle around me like an old coat. He told me who had come and who had gone, at the University. Which students had failed their examinations and gone home in disgrace, and which had passed and gone home in triumph. Which masters were feuding with which. He told me that the Eolian had a new fiddle player, a woman from Yll, who was very good, and that Stanchion was in love with her, and did not know it yet, and everyone else did.

He told me that Ambrose's father had come to visit, in the spring, and there had been a terrible row in the Golden Pony, and a window had been broken.

He told me about a fire in the Fishery, over the summer, that had nearly burned down Kilvin's workshop, and how Kilvin had put it out himself, with his bare hands, and a bucket of sand, and a great deal of Cealdish swearing.

And then, when he had run out of news, and my beer was nearly gone, he leaned closer across the bar and lowered his voice.

"And there's something else," he said. "I don't know if it's anything. But I thought you'd want to know."

\* \* \*

"There was a man," said Anker. "Last autumn. Just after you left. Just after the term started. He came in one evening, late, and sat at the bar, just where you're sitting now. And he asked about you."

I set down my beer.

"Asked what?"

"Where you were. When you'd be back. Whether you still had your room." Anker frowned. "He was very polite about it. Very pleasant. Asked like he was an old friend. Said he'd met you on the



road, and wanted to look you up." He shook his head slowly. "But I didn't like him. I don't know why. There wasn't anything wrong with him, that I could see. But I didn't like him."

"What did he look like?"

Anker thought about it.

"That's the thing," he said. "I can't rightly remember. I've tried. I've been trying all summer, on and off, whenever I thought of it." He rubbed his beard. "He was a man. Not young. Not old. Nicely dressed, but not flashy. Had a good voice. Very smooth. Like a priest, or a lawyer." He frowned harder. "And he had a mark on his hand. Here." He touched the back of his own right hand. "A sort of pale mark. Like a scar, or a burn. I noticed it when he paid."

"What did you tell him?"

"Nothing." Anker looked at me. "Told him you'd gone away and I didn't know where and didn't know when you'd be back. Which was true." He paused. "He smiled at that. Paid for his drink. Left a jot on the bar. Too much. And went away." He was quiet for a moment. "And the next morning, there was frost on the step."

I did not say anything.

"In autumn," said Anker. "Early autumn. Warm night. There was frost on the step, like a ring. Just where he'd been standing when he went out." He shook his head. "I scraped it off with my broom. It was gone by noon. I told myself it was nothing. A cold spot. A trick of the weather." He looked at me. "But I thought you'd want to know."

\* \* \*

I sat very still at the bar. The fire crackled. The students by the window laughed at something in their books.

A man with a mark on his hand. Frost on the step, in a warm autumn.

I did not know, then, who it had been. There were too many possibilities, and not enough facts, and I did not want to think about any of them. I told myself that it was probably nothing. A creditor of Ambrose's, perhaps. A lawyer from the Jakis estate. Some stranger with a grudge. I told myself that frost is only frost, and a mark on a

hand is only a mark.

I did not believe myself. But I told myself anyway.

"Thank you, Anker," I said.

"Don't thank me." He took my empty mug and refilled it. "Just don't bring any trouble into my place. I've only just had the roof fixed."

\* \* \*

I found out later who it was. Not for a long time. Not until a hall in Imre full of candles burning blue, and seven figures standing among them, and one of them, pale and cold, with a pale mark on the back of his right hand where the scar had been left by something older than the world.

Usnea, perhaps. Or Grey Mardou. I have never been sure which. The seven do not always look the same, and they do not always look like themselves. They wear their signs lightly, when they want to walk among us.

But one of them had come to Anker's. Had sat at the bar where I was sitting. Had asked about me. Months before I sang the song that brought them to the Eolian.

They had been watching me, all that time. Long before I knew they were there. Long before I thought I was the one hunting them.

\* \* \*

I did not sleep well, that night, in my narrow room under the eaves. I lay on the bed in the dark and listened to the tavern settle around me. The creak of the floorboards. The tick of the cooling hearth. The small scratching of mice in the walls.

And once, very late, a sound on the step outside. Like footsteps. Stopping. And then going away.

In the morning, I went out and looked.

There was nothing on the step. No frost. No mark. Only Anker's broom, leaning against the doorframe, and the grey autumn light, and the street beyond, going about its business.

I stood there for a long time anyway.

\* \* \*

"Did you ever find out?" said Chronicler. "Which one it was?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a moment.

"No," he said. "I asked Haliax, once. In a manner of speaking." He looked at the fire. "He didn't answer. They don't, usually." He was silent for a long moment. "But I think it doesn't matter which one. I think that's the point. They're all the same, in the end. The same patience. The same cold." He looked at the window, at the frost creeping across the shutters, very slowly, from the edges in. "They came to see me, once, at the very beginning. Before I knew anything. And they left a ring of frost on the step, so I'd know they had been there, when I was ready to know."

"And now?"

The innkeeper looked at the frost for a long time.

"Now I'm ready," he said.

## Chapter Three

# Admissions

Admissions came three days after my return, and I went to it the way a man goes to a dentist he has paid in advance. There was still some dread in me, the old reflex of a boy who had once stood before the masters with nothing in his pockets but nerve. But there was something else, too. A kind of sly eagerness. For the first time, I wanted to see what they would do.

The line for admissions stretched out of Hollows and down the steps and halfway across the courtyard. It was a cold morning, clear and bright, and the students waiting in line stamped their feet and blew into their hands and complained to one another about the questions they expected to be asked. I saw a few faces I recognized. Fenton, who had once beaten me in a sympathy duel and never let me forget it. Mola, the pretty Medica student with a sharp tongue and sharper eyes. A pair of Ambrose's hangers-on, who saw me and stopped talking and watched me with the flat, measuring look of dogs who remember a kick.

Ambrose himself was not in line. I noticed that. I noticed it the way you notice that a sound you have grown used to has stopped.

When I finally stepped inside the hall, it was just as it always was. The long crescent table, the nine masters seated behind it, the chancellor in the center with his hands folded. The dust in the air. The hush. A single chair in front of the table, set there for the student to stand beside like a man at the gallows.

"Kvothe," said the Chancellor. His name was Herma, and he had been Master Linguist before he took the chair; his voice still carried the precise, slightly amused cadence of a man who had spent a lifetime correcting other people's grammar. "Welcome back. We were not certain we would see you this term."

"Neither was I, Chancellor."

A ripple of something went through the table. Not laughter exactly. The masters were not given to laughter during admissions. But Arwyl smiled, and Elodin, lounging at the far end with his feet up on the table, made a small noise that might have been a snort.

"You have been away for some time," Herma said. "Nearly a year, according to the Bursar's records. We understand you were in Vintas."

"I was, sir. In the service of Maer Alveron."

"So your letter said." Herma lifted a sheet of paper from the table in front of him. I recognized the heavy cream stock and the seal pressed into the wax at the bottom. The Maer had been generous with his letters. "The Maer speaks highly of you. He says you have done him great service, and that you enjoy his continued patronage. He asks that the University extend to you whatever consideration it might see fit."

"That's very kind of him."

"Mm." Herma set the letter down. "It is not the University's practice to take the opinions of nobles into account when setting tuition. You understand that, I hope."

"Of course, sir."

"Good." He folded his hands again. "Then let us begin. Master Brandeur?"

Brandeur, the Master Arithmetician, leaned forward. He was a narrow man with a narrow mouth and an unpleasant habit of asking questions to which there was no answer. He asked me three of them, and I answered each as best I could. Then Mandrag asked me about the rendering of pure stibnium from its ore, and I answered that with rather more confidence. Kilvin asked me about the properties of

heat-sympathetic alloys, and I talked for a solid quarter of an hour, and when I was done he nodded his great shaggy head and said, "Good. This is good. Why have you not been in my shop?"

"I've been in Vintas, Master Kilvin."

"Vintas has forges." He frowned at me. "A man should not neglect his craft simply because he is traveling. The hands forget."

"Yes, Master Kilvin."

"You will come to the Fishery. Tomorrow. I have a project that will interest you."

"Yes, Master Kilvin."

Arwyl asked me three questions about the circulatory system, and I got two of them right. Lorren asked me about the Tak-Diawl schism in the early Aturan church, and I told him more than he wanted to know, and his expression did not change at all, which was the best I could hope for from Lorren. Hemme asked me a question about the legal status of sympathists under Modegan law that was deliberately obscure, and I answered it anyway, because I had spent two spans in the Maer's library doing little else but reading legal histories while waiting to be summoned. Hemme's lips went thin. He did not ask a second question.

That left only Elodin.

He had not moved throughout any of it. He sat with his feet on the table and his hands folded over his stomach and his eyes half closed, like a cat in a sunbeam. When Herma looked at him, he did not seem to notice.

"Master Elodin," said the Chancellor, with the patience of long practice. "Do you have a question for the student?"

Elodin opened his eyes. He looked at me.

It is difficult to explain what it felt like, being looked at by Elodin. Most people look at you. Elodin looked *into* you, the way you might look into a well to see how deep it goes. And he did not always seem to like what he saw at the bottom.

"Yes," he said. "I have a question."

He swung his feet down from the table and leaned forward, his elbows on his knees. The rest of the masters shifted slightly. Elodin was not supposed to ask questions at admissions, not really. Everyone knew he gave the same tuition to every student: he took whatever sum the others had arrived at and added or subtracted a random amount, apparently based on nothing more than his mood. But he had not asked a question in a very long time. I knew that. Everybody knew that.

"Where," Elodin said, "did you get the scar?"

I blinked. "Sir?"

"On your cheek. Where did you get it?"

I touched the scar. "In Ademre, sir. From a sword."

"Whose sword?"

"A woman named Vashet. She was my teacher."

"Your teacher cut you."

"Yes, sir."

"Why?"

I thought about that. The honest answer was that she had cut me because I had been careless, and because she had wanted me to remember that carelessness has a cost. But that was not the whole of it. There was a deeper answer, one I had only begun to understand in the long months since.

"Because I was learning the wrong thing," I said slowly. "I thought I was learning how to fight. She wanted me to learn how to listen. The cut was a way of saying so."

Elodin looked at me for a long moment. Then he smiled. It was not a pleasant smile. It was the smile of a man who has seen someone step on a rake and is waiting, with interest, to see how long it will take them to notice.

"Good," he said. "That's a very good answer." He leaned back in his chair and put his feet up on the table again. "I have no further questions."

Herma looked at him with an expression of carefully controlled exasperation. Then he turned back to me.

"Thank you, Kvothe," he said. "Please wait outside while we deliberate."

I went outside. I did not have to wait long.

When I came back, Herma held up a slip of paper with a number written on it. "Two talents, three jots," he said.

I stood very still. It was the lowest tuition I had ever been given. It was, if I was not mistaken, less than half of what I had paid the term before I left.

"Thank you, sir," I said.

"Don't thank me. Thank Master Elodin." Herma's voice was dry. "He subtracted rather a great deal."

I looked at Elodin. He was examining the ceiling as if it held the secrets of the universe. He did not look at me. But the corner of his mouth was twitching.

\* \* \*

I paid my tuition at the Bursar's office with coins from the Maer's purse. The clerk counted them twice and wrote me out a receipt, and I folded it up and put it in my pocket and walked out into the bright cold morning feeling like a king.

I went to find Elodin.

He was not in his office. He was not in the Rookery. He was not in any of the lecture halls. It took me the better part of two hours to find him, and when I did, he was sitting on the roof of the Mains, his legs dangling over the edge, eating an apple.

"You found me," he said, without turning around. "Congratulations. Most students give up after an hour."

"I'm not most students."

"That," he said, "is either the truest or the most arrogant thing you've ever said. Possibly both." He took a bite of apple. "Sit down. You're making the roof nervous."

I sat down beside him, carefully. The roof of the Mains was a steep slope of old slate, and the edge was a long way above the cobbles of the courtyard below. Elodin did not seem to notice. He swung his legs back and forth like a child on a wall.



"Thank you," I said. "For the tuition."

"It wasn't a gift. It was a bribe." He tossed the apple core out into the air. We both watched it fall. It struck the cobbles below with a small wet sound. "I want you back in my class. And I want you to actually pay attention this time."

"I always pay attention."

"You always *listen*. It's not the same thing." He turned to look at me for the first time. His eyes were very dark. "You went away, and you came back different. I can see it. You carry yourself differently. You breathe differently. Someone has been teaching you how to be still."

"The Adem."

"The Adem." He said it slowly, tasting the word. "Interesting. I knew an Adem once. She could split a candle flame with her little finger and never burn herself. She told me it was because she knew the name of the flame, and I told her that was nonsense, and she hit me so hard I couldn't hear out of my left ear for a span." He smiled faintly. "She was right, of course. I was just too young to know it."

"What happened to her?"

"She went home. They always go home." He looked away again, out over the rooftops. "Tell me. Did your Vashet teach you the name of the wind?"

"No," I said. "But she taught me something about it. She said the wind was like the Lethani. You can't hold it. You can only move with it."

Elodin was quiet for a long time. The wind stirred his hair. Far below us, students hurried across the courtyard, small as ants.

"The Lethani," he said at last. "The Adem are very wise about some things. They are very foolish about others. But on that point, I think they are right." He turned to me again. "You called the wind once. Do you remember?"

"Of course I remember."

"Do you remember how it felt?"

I thought about that day. About Ambrose, and the cold, and the sudden terrible clarity that had come over me like a sheet of ice. About the name that had risen out of me without my calling it, and the wind that had come howling at its call.

"It felt," I said slowly, "like being very awake. Like I had been asleep my whole life, and suddenly I woke up."

Elodin nodded. "Yes. That's how it feels. That's how it always feels, the first time." He reached into his coat and pulled out another apple and bit into it. "And then you fall back asleep. And you spend the rest of your life trying to wake up again."

"Is that what happened to you?"

He did not answer. He chewed his apple and looked out over the rooftops and did not say anything at all, for so long that I began to think he had forgotten I was there.

Then he said, "I want you to learn the name of stone."

I stared at him. "Stone?"

"Stone." He gestured at the roof beneath us, at the great grey walls of the Mains, at the Archives rising in the distance. "It's all around you. It's the bones of the world. It's patient and it's old and it's very, very stubborn. It is not like wind. Wind wants to be called. Stone wants to be left alone." He smiled that unpleasant smile again. "You'll hate it. That's why you need to learn it."

"Why?"

"Because," he said, "something is coming, and when it comes, you're going to need to know how to be patient." He stood up, all at once, balancing on the steep slate as if it were a level floor. "Class is on Cendling. Don't be late. Or do. I don't really care." And he walked away along the ridge of the roof with his hands in his pockets, whistling, and did not look back.

I sat there for a long time after he had gone, looking at the stone beneath my hands.

It did not say anything to me. But then, stone rarely does.

\* \* \*

On my way back across the courtyard, I heard the news about Ambrose.

It came to me the way news always comes at the University, which is to say sideways. I was passing a knot of students near the Rookery, and one of them was saying, "—second one in a year. That's what I heard, anyway. Fell off his horse and broke his neck."

"Horses," said another, with the wisdom of the very young. "You can't trust them. My uncle had a horse that—"

"Not the point. The point is, that's two of them dead. Two of the ones ahead of him."

"Ahead of who?"

"Ambrose, you idiot. Who do you think?"

I stopped walking.

The students did not notice me. They were too wrapped up in their gossip. I stood a little distance off, pretending to look for something in my satchel, and I listened.

It went like this. Ambrose Jakis was the son of Baron Jakis, one of the most powerful noblemen in Vintas. Everyone knew that. What everyone also knew, because Ambrose had never let anyone forget it, was that he stood somewhere in the line of succession for the throne of Vintas itself. Not close to the front. Not even particularly close to the middle. Somewhere around thirteenth, the last I'd heard, which was near enough to brag about and far enough that nobody took the bragging seriously.

But now, it seemed, two of the men who stood between Ambrose and the throne were dead.

The first had died a year ago, in the spring. A cousin of the king's, a young lord with a weak chest who had caught a fever in the damp season and never recovered. Nobody had thought much of it at the time. Fevers were common, and weak chests were weak.

The second had died a month ago. A distant uncle of the king's, an older man with a fondness for hunting. He had been riding in the hills near Renere when his horse had stumbled on a slope. He had been thrown. His neck had broken.

"Two deaths in a year," said one of the students. "It happens. It's not like anyone's killing them."

"I didn't say anyone was killing them. I just said it's interesting, that's all. Ambrose left last span. Went back to Vintas. His father sent for him."

"Maybe his father's dying too."

"Maybe. Or maybe his father wants him close by. Just in case."

They laughed at that, the easy laughter of people for whom the deaths of nobles are a kind of theater, something to be discussed and speculated upon and then forgotten. I did not laugh. I stood there with my hand in my satchel, and I felt something cold settle into the pit of my stomach.

Two deaths in a year. It happens.

But I had been in Vintas. I had spent months at the Maer's court. I had seen the way the nobles there played their games of power, the smiling knives and the poisoned cups. I had caught the Maer's own physician slowly killing him for gold. I knew, better than any student lounging in the courtyard, that in Vintas nothing simply happened.

I did not think Ambrose was killing anyone. He did not have the patience for it, nor the subtlety. Ambrose was a man who liked to break things with his own hands and watch them bleed.

But someone might be killing them on his behalf.

\* \* \*

That night I lay awake in my narrow bed under the eaves, listening to the wind move across the rooftops, and I thought about many things.

I thought about Ambrose, and the two dead men, and the long cold line of the Vintish succession stretching away like a road into darkness.

I thought about Elodin, and the name of stone, and the strange grim look on his face when he said *something is coming*.

I thought about Auri, and the doors that were sleeping but not sleepy.

And I thought about Denna, because I always thought about Denna, the way a tongue always goes back to a sore tooth.

It was very late when I finally fell asleep. And when I did, I dreamed of a door. It was made of grey stone, and it had no handle, and no hinges, and no lock. It stood alone in a great dark space, and it was very old. Older than the University. Older than the stone bridge. Older, perhaps, than the world.

In my dream I walked up to the door and laid my hand against it. It was cold. Colder than stone ought to be.

And from the other side, very faintly, I heard something breathing.

## Chapter Four

# The Medica

I had not meant to go back to the Medica that term. I had enough to do. Kilvin wanted me in the Fishery, Elodin wanted me listening to rocks, and the Maer's gold, while generous, would not last forever if I did not keep up my twice-a-span at Anker's and the Eolian. But Arwyl sent a note on the fourth day, written in his small tidy hand on a slip of paper that smelled faintly of camphor, and the note said only this:

*Re'lar Kvothe. We are short of hands. Third bell, if you please.*

You did not refuse Arwyl. It was not that he was frightening, the way Lorren was frightening, or unpredictable, the way Elodin was. He was a small, round, gentle old man with spectacles and a soft voice, who looked like someone's favorite grandfather and smelled like a pharmacy. But he had been Master Physicker for thirty years, and in that time he had saved the lives of half the masters, most of the Arcanum, and a good portion of the city of Imre. People did what Arwyl asked. It seemed the least they could do.

So at third bell I was standing in the long cool white hall of the Medica in a grey apron, scrubbing my hands in a basin of water so hot it turned my skin pink, while Mola stood beside me and told me everything I had forgotten in a year of wandering.

"You'll be on the ward," she said. "Not surgery. Not today. Arwyl wants to see if your hands still know anything before he lets you near a knife." She glanced at me sidelong. "What happened to your face?"

"A teacher."

"A teacher did that?"

"She was very dedicated."

Mola snorted. She was a sharp-faced, sharp-tongued young woman from Vintas who had been a Re'lar in the Medica for as long as I had known her and was, everyone agreed, going to be the best physicker in a generation, if she did not murder someone first. She had never liked me very much. I had never been quite sure why. I suspected it had something to do with the time I had fainted in her arms during my first dissection and she had had to carry me out.

"Well," she said, "try not to bleed on the patients. It upsets them."

\* \* \*

The ward was a long room lined with beds, each one separated from its neighbors by a white linen curtain. It was very clean and very quiet, and it smelled of lye soap and boiled linen and the particular sweetish smell of sickness that no amount of soap can ever quite wash out. There were perhaps twenty patients that afternoon. Students with fevers. A carter with a broken leg. An old woman from Imre with a cough that sounded like a saw going through wet wood. A baby with the croup, and its mother sitting beside it on a stool, white-faced, rocking.

I went from bed to bed. I took pulses and felt foreheads and changed dressings and wrote things down in the ledger at the foot of each bed. My hands remembered, mostly. There is a rhythm to that kind of work, a way of touching people that is firm and gentle at the same time, and my hands had learned it once and did not seem to have forgotten.

It was near the end of the afternoon when I came to the last bed.

The curtain was drawn all the way around it, which was unusual. Beside it, on a stool, an E'lar I did not know was sitting with a book open on her knees, pretending to read. She looked up as I came near, and her face was pale.

"Arwyl said no one's to go in without him," she said.

"Arwyl sent me."

She hesitated. Then she nodded, and looked back down at her book, and I saw that her hands were not quite steady on the pages.

I pulled back the curtain.

\* \* \*

The man on the bed was a trapper. You could see it in him: in the leathery weathered skin of his face and hands, in the thick shoulders and the thin legs, in the way his hair had been hacked short with a knife rather than cut. He was forty, perhaps, or fifty. It was hard to tell. He was lying on his back with the blanket drawn up to his chin, and he was awake, and he was looking at the ceiling.

And he was cold.

I felt it the moment I drew back the curtain. A draft of cold air, coming out from behind it, like the air that comes out of an icehouse when you open the door. It was late summer, and the ward was warm, and the windows were open to the sunshine. But inside the curtain, around that bed, it was winter.

I looked at the ledger at the foot of the bed. It was written in Arwyl's small tidy hand.

*Deran, trapper, of the Eld near Tilt. Brought in by his brother. Frost-burn to the left forearm, severe. Patient insists injury sustained in the forest, in the month of Caitelyn. Caitelyn is high summer. Patient will not say more. Keep warm. Keep watched. Do not let him sleep alone.*

I looked at the trapper. He was still looking at the ceiling.

"Deran," I said.

His eyes moved. Slowly. They found my face.

"You're new," he said. His voice was a hoarse whisper. "Haven't seen you."

"I've been away." I came around to the side of the bed. "May I see your arm?"

He looked at me for a long moment. Then, slowly, he drew his left arm out from under the blanket.

\* \* \*

I have seen a great many wounds. I have seen men who were burned in fires and men who were cut with swords and men who had been



crushed under carts. I have seen what the cold does to fingers and toes in a Tarbean winter, when a boy sleeps on a rooftop without shoes. I thought I knew what frost-burn looked like.

I had never seen anything like this.

His forearm was white. Not pale. White, like marble, like bone, like the belly of a fish. The skin was hard and shiny and cold to the touch; when I laid my fingers on it, very gently, it was like touching a stone that has been lying all night in the snow. And the whiteness had a shape.

It was a hand. The print of a hand, long-fingered and narrow, wrapped around his forearm just below the elbow. As if someone had taken hold of him there, very gently, the way you might take hold of a child's arm to lead him across a road. And where the fingers had touched, the flesh had died.

I did not say anything for a long time.

"It's a hand," said Deran. His voice was very quiet.

"Yes."

"Nobody else will say it. The old man, the physicker, he looked at it and he said *hm* and *interesting* and wrote things in his book. The girl out there won't look at it at all." He laughed, a thin cracked sound. "But it's a hand. Isn't it?"

"Yes."

He closed his eyes.

"I'm not mad," he said. "I want you to know that. They think I'm mad. My brother thinks I'm mad. He says I got drunk and fell asleep in a snowbank." He opened his eyes. "In Caitelyn."

"I don't think you're mad."

He looked at me for a long moment.

"Why not?" he said.

I did not answer right away. I looked at the print on his arm. At the long narrow fingers. I thought about a man with black eyes and frost-colored hair, crouching in front of me in the firelight, a long time ago.

"Because I've seen something like it," I said. "Once."

He told me. Not all at once. In pieces, over the next hour, while I sat on the stool beside his bed and the E'lr outside the curtain pretended to read and the long ward went quiet around us as the afternoon wore on toward evening.

He had been running his traplines in the Eld, in the deep part, where the old trees grew so thick that it was dusk at noon. It was a place he knew well. He had been trapping there for twenty years. He knew every stream and every hollow and every deadfall.

And one evening, coming back along a line he had run a thousand times, he had come around a bend in a stream and found a camp.

"Wagons," he said. "Three of them. Painted. Like players' wagons. Pulled up in a clearing by the water, in a half circle, with a fire in the middle." His face was very still. "I thought it was Ruh. A troupe, lost in the forest. I thought I'd go down and tell them the way out."

"Was it?"

"No." He was quiet for a long time. "It was their wagons. But not them."

I did not ask him what he meant. I did not have to. He told me anyway.

The wagons were empty. The fire was burning, but it was burning blue. And there was no one in the clearing, no one at all, except a man sitting on the step of the nearest wagon with his elbows on his knees, looking into the fire.

"He looked up," said Deran. "When I came down the bank. He looked up and smiled at me. Like he'd been waiting." He swallowed. "His eyes were black. All the way. No white in them at all."

"What did he say?"

Deran looked at me.

"He asked me if I'd seen a red-haired boy," he said. "A singer. About so high." He held his good hand up, level with his shoulder. "Travels with a lute. Might be calling himself something else."

The ward was very quiet.

"I said no," said Deran. "I said I hadn't seen anyone. Not in the forest. Not in months." He was shaking now, very slightly, under the blanket. "And he looked at me for a long time. And then he got up off the step and came across the clearing and took hold of my arm. Like this." He touched the white print, very lightly. "Gentle. Like he was helping me. And he said, *if you do, tell him Ferule was asking.*" Deran's voice cracked. "And then he let go, and I ran, and I didn't stop running until I came out of the forest. Two days later. And my arm was like this."

\* \* \*

I sat very still on the stool beside his bed.

*Tell him Ferule was asking.*

I did not know the name. Not then. I did not know, sitting in the Medica on a warm afternoon in late summer, that I would hear it again in a burning hall, and on a ridge above a burning camp, and in a chamber beneath an old house, spoken each time by a voice made of forgetting. I did not know that I would say it myself, one day, in a small cold room at the top of the stairs of an inn, and watch the man it belonged to flinch.

I only knew that someone had been in the Eld, in a clearing, beside a fire burning blue, asking after a red-haired boy with a lute.

And that the wagons had been painted like a troupe's.

\* \* \*

"Do you know him?" said Deran. "The man with the black eyes?"

I looked at him. At his weathered face and his frightened eyes and his white arm lying on the blanket.

"No," I said.

It was not quite a lie. I did not know his name. I did not know what he was, or why he did what he did. I only knew his face.

Deran looked at me for a long time. He did not believe me. I could see it. But he was too tired to argue.

"Will it get better?" he said. "The arm?"

I looked at the white print. At the hard shiny dead skin, and the cold coming off it.

"I don't know," I said honestly. "I'll ask Master Arwyl."

\* \* \*

I did ask. I found Arwyl in his office at the end of the ward, a small crowded room lined with jars and books and smelling powerfully of camphor. He was sitting at his desk writing in a ledger. He did not look up when I came in.

"You've seen the trapper," he said.

"Yes."

"And?"

"And I've never seen anything like it."

"Nor have I." He set down his pen. He took off his spectacles and rubbed his eyes. "Forty years a physicker, and I've never seen anything like it." He put his spectacles back on and looked at me. "I've read of it, though. Once. In a very old book. There's a copy in the Archives, in the Stacks, in the section on diseases of the northern marches. Very old. Very incomplete. Someone took a knife to it, long ago." He was quiet for a moment. "It describes a man with an arm frozen in the shape of a hand. In summer. And it says the man died, a month later. Not of the arm. Of the cold. It spread. Slowly. Up the arm, into the chest. Into the heart."

I stood very still.

"Is that going to happen to Deran?"

"I don't know." Arwyl looked at me over his spectacles. "I'm going to try to stop it. Heat. Poultices. Sympathy, if Master Kilvin will lend me someone who knows heat-binding." He paused. "You know heat-binding, don't you, Re'lar Kvothe?"

"Yes, Master Arwyl."

"Good." He picked up his pen again. "Then you'll come back tomorrow. And the day after. And every day until we know whether it's spreading."

\* \* \*

I went back every day for a month.

I sat beside Deran's bed with a copper plate in one hand and a hot brick in the other, bound together with a sympathetic link, and I fed the heat of the brick into the copper and the copper into his arm. Slowly. Carefully. A little at a time. Arwyl said too much heat too fast would kill the flesh around the print, and then he would lose the arm.

It was tedious work. It was exhausting. I held the binding for hours at a time, with my mind split in two, and when I stood up at the end of each day my head ached and my hands shook and I was so cold myself, from giving all my heat away, that I had to go and sit by the fire in the Mews for an hour before I could stop shivering.

But the print did not spread.

It did not get better, either. The white skin stayed white and hard and cold. The long narrow fingers of it stayed wrapped around his arm, just below the elbow, as clear as the day he had come in. But it did not grow. It did not creep up his arm toward his chest, the way Arwyl's old book said it would.

"It's holding," said Arwyl, at the end of the month, bending over the arm with his spectacles on the end of his nose. "Whatever you're doing, it's holding." He looked up at me. "I don't know if it'll ever heal. But it's holding."

Deran went home to the Eld a span later, with his arm wrapped in wool and a jar of Arwyl's poultice in his pack. He shook my hand at the door of the Medica with his good hand, and looked at me for a long time.

"If I see him again," he said. "The man with the black eyes. What should I tell him?"

I thought about it.

"Tell him you didn't see anyone," I said. "Tell him the forest is empty."

Deran looked at me for a moment longer. Then he nodded and went away down the road, toward the bridge and the river and the long road home.

I never saw him again. But I heard, years later, from a traveler who had come through Tilth, that there was a trapper in that country with a white arm, who would not go into the deep part of the Eld anymore, and who told anyone who asked that the forest was empty.

\* \* \*

I did not tell anyone what he had told me. Not Sim, not Wil, not Kilvin. Not Denna, when she came back to Imre that autumn.

But I lit Kilvin's candle that night, in my room under the eaves, and I sat and watched it until very late. It burned yellow. It burned yellow all night, and the next night, and the night after that.

I did not find that comforting.

Because I knew now that they did not always make the candle burn blue. They were not always doing something. Sometimes they were only sitting on the step of a stolen wagon in a clearing in the forest, looking into a fire, waiting.

Asking after a red-haired boy.

## Chapter Five

# Rhetoric and Logic

I should not have taken Hemme's class. Everyone told me so. Sim told me, and Wil told me, and Fela told me, and Manet, who had been at the University for thirty years and had seen every kind of foolishness a student could commit, looked at my schedule on the first day of term and laughed until he had to sit down.

"Rhetoric and Logic," he said, wiping his eyes. "With Hemme. You." He shook his head. "Boy, you've got a death wish."

"It's required," I said. "For advancement to El'the. Every El'the has to have sat a term of Rhetoric. Herma put it in my admissions paper."

"Herma did that on purpose," said Manet. "You know that, don't you? He's got a sense of humor, Herma. Not much of one. But it's there." He handed me back my schedule. "Keep your head down. Keep your mouth shut. Don't correct him. Whatever he says, however wrong it is, don't correct him." He looked at me with his wild grey eyebrows drawn together. "You can do that, can't you? For one term?"

"Of course I can," I said.

Manet looked at me for a long time. Then he started laughing again.

\* \* \*

The first class went well. I want that on the record. I sat in the back row of the lecture hall in the Mains, among forty other students, with my head down and my mouth shut, and I took notes, and I did not

correct anyone about anything.

Hemme lectured for two hours on the structure of the formal syllogism. He was not a good lecturer. He had a heavy, droning voice, and a habit of repeating the last word of every sentence, as if to make sure it had arrived. *The major premise establishes the general case. The general case.* He paced back and forth at the front of the room with his hands clasped behind his back, and his round red face shone with sweat under the lamps.

He did not look at me once. I had made sure of that. I had come in late and sat behind a very tall student from Modeg, and I had kept my hair tucked under a cap.

He knew I was there. Of course he knew. Everyone knew. But he did not look at me, and I did not look at him, and we got through the first class like two cats in a very small room, carefully not noticing each other.

\* \* \*

The second class did not go well.

It was not my fault. I want that on the record, too. Hemme was lecturing on fallacies. Common errors in reasoning. The appeal to authority, the false dilemma, the slippery slope. It was actually interesting, or would have been, in someone else's hands. And in the middle of it, he stopped pacing, and turned, and looked straight at the back row.

"Let us take an example," he said. "An example. Suppose a student—a hypothetical student—argues that because he has been admitted to the Arcanum, he must therefore be competent. Competent." His small eyes glittered. "What is the fallacy?"

Forty heads turned to look at me.

I kept my head down. I kept my mouth shut. I thought of Manet, laughing until he had to sit down.

"No one?" said Hemme. "No one at all? Then let me offer another example. Another." He began to pace again, slowly. "Suppose that same student—still hypothetical—argues that because he has written a song, which some people have sung in taverns, he must therefore be a



person of consequence. Consequence." He smiled. "What is the fallacy there?"

A few students laughed nervously. The tall Modegan in front of me slid a little lower in his seat, as if to get out of the line of fire.

"And suppose," said Hemme, stopping directly in front of the back row, "that this same hypothetical student had been absent from the University for nearly a year, on business of his own, and returned expecting to be welcomed back as if nothing had happened. As if nothing. What fallacy would that be, do you think? Mister—" He looked down at his roll. "Kvothe?"

\* \* \*

I looked up. I could not help it. I had been doing so well.

"I'm not sure, Master Hemme," I said. "I don't think it's a fallacy at all."

"No?"

"No. A fallacy is an error in reasoning. An argument that seems valid, but isn't." I kept my voice very polite. "But you haven't described an argument. You've described a student. And a student isn't an argument. He's just a student." I paused. "Unless you're suggesting he's a straw man. In which case, the fallacy would be yours."

There was a silence in the lecture hall. The kind of silence that makes your ears ring.

Hemme's face went from red to purple. I watched it happen. It was like watching a sunset, if the sunset wanted to kill you.

"A straw man," he said. "Straw man." His voice was very quiet. "You're accusing me of the straw man fallacy. In my own class."

"Only hypothetically, Master Hemme."

Somebody in the third row made a sound like a strangled goose. Somebody else put their face in their hands.

\* \* \*

Hemme did not throw me out. I had expected him to. I think everyone had. Instead, he stood in front of the back row for a long moment, breathing heavily through his nose, and then he smiled. It was a very

unpleasant smile.

"Very well," he said. "Very well. Since Mister Kvothe is so fond of hypotheticals, let us have a debate. A debate. Next class. Mister Kvothe will argue a proposition of my choosing, before the whole class, and the class will judge whether he has argued it well." His smile widened. "If he loses, he will write a formal apology to me, on the subject of fallacies, to be read aloud at the start of every class for the rest of the term. The rest of the term."

"And if I win?"

Hemme looked at me as if I had said something in a foreign language.

"If you win," he said, "you may sit in the back row and correct me as much as you like. As much as you like." He turned and walked back to the front of the room. "The proposition is this: *That the Arcanum should have the power to expel any student, for any reason, without appeal.*" He looked back at me. "You will argue for it."

\* \* \*

"He did that on purpose," said Sim that night at Anker's. "You know he did that on purpose."

"I know."

"He wants you to argue for your own expulsion. In front of everyone. And then when it happens—because it will happen, Kvothe, you know it will, sooner or later—everyone will remember that you stood up in Rhetoric and argued it was fair." Sim put his head in his hands. "It's diabolical. I didn't know Hemme had it in him."

"He's cleverer than he looks," said Wil. "Not much. But a little."

"What are you going to do?" said Fela.

I drank my beer. I thought about it.

"I'm going to argue for it," I said. "What else can I do?"

\* \* \*

The lecture hall was packed for the next class. Word had spread. There were students standing along the walls and sitting in the aisles, and a few I did not recognize, who had clearly come from other classes just

to watch. Sim and Wil and Fela were in the front row. Manet was at the back, by the door, with his arms folded and his wild grey eyebrows drawn down.

Hemme sat in a chair at the side of the stage with his hands folded over his belly and a look of deep contentment on his round red face.

"Mister Kvothe," he said. "The floor is yours. Yours."

I stood up at the front of the room. I looked out at the crowd. And I began.

\* \* \*

I argued for it. I argued very well. I want that on the record most of all.

I said that the Arcanum was a community of scholars, bound together by trust. I said that the masters were chosen for their wisdom, and their judgment, and their long experience of the world. I said that there were dangers at the University that ordinary students could not understand: dangerous knowledge, dangerous materials, dangerous names. And I said that a community that held such dangers must have the power to protect itself. Swiftly. Absolutely. Without the delays and distractions of appeal.

"Consider," I said, "a student who has learned something he should not. Something dangerous. A name, perhaps, that he cannot control. Or a binding that could burn down half of Imre. Should the masters have to wait? Should they have to convene hearings and summon witnesses and argue about procedure, while the danger grows?" I shook my head. "No. They must be able to act. At once. On their own judgment. Because their judgment is the only thing standing between the University and disaster."

I saw Hemme nodding, very slightly, in his chair. Smug. Satisfied.

"And the masters are wise," I said. "All of them. Every one. We know this, because they are masters. And we know they are masters because they are wise." I paused. "Which is, of course, a circular argument. But it's a very comfortable circle. Very warm. Very safe."

A few people laughed. Hemme's nod stopped.

\* \* \*

"So yes," I said. "The Arcanum should have the power to expel any student, for any reason, without appeal. Because the masters are wise. And because they would never abuse such a power." I looked at Hemme. "Would they, Master Hemme?"

Hemme did not answer. His face was going purple again.

"They would never," I said, "expel a student out of spite. Or jealousy. Or a personal grudge. They would never let their own feelings cloud their judgment. They would never use their power to punish someone who had embarrassed them, or contradicted them, or asked them a question they couldn't answer." I spread my hands. "That would be unthinkable. That would be a terrible abuse. And since the masters are wise, it could never happen." I smiled. "So there is no need for appeal. None at all. I rest my case."

\* \* \*

There was a silence. And then someone in the back started clapping. Slowly. And then someone else. And then the whole lecture hall was clapping and stamping and cheering, and Sim was standing on his chair, and Wil was shaking his head with his hand over his eyes, and Fela was laughing so hard she had to hold on to the bench in front of her.

And Manet, at the back of the room, by the door, was not laughing. He was looking at Hemme, sitting purple and silent in his chair. And his face was very grave.

Hemme stood up. The noise died.

"The class will judge," he said. His voice was thick. "As agreed. As agreed. Those who believe Mister Kvothe has argued the proposition well?"

Every hand in the room went up.

Hemme looked at them for a long time. Then he looked at me.

"Very well," he said. "Very well. You may sit in the back row, Mister Kvothe. And correct me as much as you like." He turned and walked out of the lecture hall, and the door banged shut behind him.

\* \* \*

"That," said Manet afterward, in the courtyard, "was the stupidest thing I have ever seen a student do. And I once saw a Re'lar try to call the name of iron while standing in a smithy."

"I won," I said.

"You won the debate." Manet looked at me with his wild grey eyebrows drawn together. "And you made a master look like a fool in front of fifty students. Again. And you did it by arguing that masters would never abuse their power to punish someone who'd embarrassed them." He shook his head slowly. "Boy. Think about it. What do you think he's going to do?"

I did not answer. I had not thought about it. I had been too busy winning.

"You made an argument," said Manet quietly, "that's going to come true. And you're going to be standing right in the middle of it when it does."

\* \* \*

He was right, of course. Manet was always right about those things. I did not listen to him. I never did.

But I remembered it, a few months later. In a hearing room in Hollows, with the masters sitting on their dais and Hemme at the end of it, his round red face twisted in satisfaction. With Kilvin arguing for me, and Arwyl, and Mandrag. And the vote going five to three.

Hemme did not say anything, when the vote was taken. He did not need to. He only looked down at me from the dais, and smiled, very slightly.

And I thought: *that would be a terrible abuse. And since the masters are wise, it could never happen.*

It was a very comfortable circle. Very warm. Very safe.

Right up until it closed.

## Chapter Six

# Debts

There are some debts you pay with money, and some debts you pay with time, and some debts you pay with pieces of yourself. The trick of it, the thing that separates the wise man from the fool, is knowing which kind of debt you are in before the collector comes to call.

My debt to Devi was the first kind. Or so I thought.

\* \* \*

Devi lived above a butcher's shop in a narrow alley on the Imre side of the river. You climbed a set of wooden stairs on the outside of the building, stairs that had been steep and treacherous when they were built and had grown steeper and more treacherous with every passing year. At the top was a heavy door with no sign on it. If you knocked, and if Devi was in a mood to see you, the door would open. If she was not, you would stand there knocking until your knuckles bled, and nobody would ever answer.

I knocked.

The door opened almost at once, as if she had been waiting on the other side. She stood there in the doorway, small and fair and pretty as a doll, with her strawberry-blond hair pulled back and a pair of spectacles perched on the end of her nose. Devi was the most dangerous woman I knew, and I had known Felurian.

"Well," she said. "Look who's come crawling back."

"Hello, Devi."

"Don't you 'hello Devi' me." She put her hands on her hips. "Do you have any idea how long you've been gone? Do you have any idea how much interest has accrued on your loan in that time?"

"I have a fair idea."

"I doubt it. You were never very good at sums when you were panicking." She looked me up and down. Her eyes lingered on the scar on my cheek, then on my new clothes, then on the purse at my belt, which was heavier than it had any right to be. Something shifted in her face. "Oh," she said. "Oh, you've been busy."

"I have."

She stepped aside. "Come in, then. Let's see what you've brought me."

Her rooms were just as I remembered them. Warm, cluttered, and full of books. Shelves lined every wall, and every shelf was crammed so tight you could not have slid a knife between the spines. More books were stacked on the floor, on the chairs, on the table. There was a small alchemical bench in one corner with a rack of glass vials that caught the light from the window and threw it back in pale colors. There was a narrow bed, neatly made, with a cat curled up asleep on the pillow. The cat opened one eye as I came in, looked at me with profound disinterest, and closed it again.

Devi cleared a chair for me by the simple expedient of picking up the stack of books on it and dropping them on the floor. I sat. She sat across from me, behind a desk that was so covered in papers it looked like a snowdrift.

"Well?" she said.

I took out my purse and counted out the coins onto the desk between us. Talents, gleaming silver. Enough to pay back the whole of what I owed her, with interest, and a little more besides. When I finished, I looked up.

Devi was staring at the coins. For once in her life, she did not seem to know what to say.

"You're paying it all," she said at last.

"I'm paying it all."

"At once."

"At once."

She looked at me. Her eyes were very sharp behind her spectacles. "Where did you get this much money?"

"The Maer. I did him a service."

"What kind of service?"

"The kind that pays well."

She laughed, suddenly, a bright sharp sound like breaking glass. "You're learning," she said. "Two years ago you'd have told me the whole story, just to see my face." She reached out and began to count the coins herself, sliding them across the desk one by one with a practiced flick of her fingers. When she finished, she nodded. "It's all here."

"I know."

She scooped the coins into a drawer, locked it, and put the key on a chain around her neck. Then she sat back in her chair and folded her hands across her stomach and looked at me with an expression I had never seen on her face before. It took me a moment to recognize it. It was disappointment.

"Well," she said. "That's that, then."

"You sound sorry."

"I am sorry. I liked having you in my debt." She shrugged. "You were entertaining. And you had interesting friends. And there was always the chance that you'd do something truly spectacular and I'd get to watch." She tilted her head. "And your blood, of course. I still have it."

I had not forgotten. When I had first borrowed money from Devi, she had asked for a drop of my blood as collateral. With a drop of a man's blood, a skilled sympathist can do almost anything to him. Devi was a very skilled sympathist.

"I'd like it back," I said.

"I'm sure you would." She did not move. "But the debt is paid. And our agreement was that I would return the collateral when the debt was paid. So." She opened a drawer, reached inside, and drew out



a small glass vial. Inside it, a single dark drop sat at the bottom, dried to a flake. She held it up to the light. "Here you are."

She held it out to me. I reached for it.

She pulled it back.

"Of course," she said sweetly, "there's the question of whether you'd like to borrow again."

I sighed. "Devi."

"I'm serious. You're a man of means now. A man of means has opportunities. And opportunities require capital." She smiled at me. It was a lovely smile. It was the smile of a spider watching a fly bump against the edges of its web. "I could make you a very good rate."

"I don't need to borrow any more money."

"Everyone needs to borrow money eventually. It's one of the great truths of the world."

"Maybe. But not today."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she laughed again and tossed the vial across the desk. I caught it. The glass was warm from her hand.

"Fine," she said. "Fine. Be responsible. See if I care." She leaned back in her chair. "But I'll tell you something for free, since you're a paying customer now and not a debtor. You're going to need something from me before the year is out. Not money. Something else. I can smell it on you."

"What kind of something?"

"How should I know? I'm not a fortune-teller." She picked up a pen and began to write something in a ledger, not looking at me. "But when you need it, you'll come here. And then we'll talk about what it costs."

\* \* \*

I should have left then. I had done what I came to do. My debt was paid, and my blood was back in my hand, and there was no reason to stay.

But I did not leave. Because as I stood up, my eye fell on a book lying open on the corner of her desk, half hidden beneath a sheaf of

papers, and I saw a word on the open page that stopped me cold.

The word was *Valaritas*.

I knew that word. Everyone at the University knew it. It was carved into the face of the Four-plate door, deep in the heart of the Archives, a door of solid grey stone with no handle and no hinges and no lock. Four copper plates were set into its face, and nobody knew what they were for. Nobody knew what lay behind the door. Nobody had ever opened it, not in living memory, and possibly not ever.

"Where did you get this?" I said.

Devi looked up. She followed my gaze to the book, and her face went very still.

"That," she said, "is none of your business."

"It's about the Four-plate door."

"I know what it's about." She reached out and closed the book, firmly, and set a stack of papers on top of it. "And it's still none of your business."

I sat back down.

Devi glared at me. "What are you doing?"

"Staying," I said. "I want to know why you have a book about the Four-plate door."

"Why?"

"Because I want to know what's behind it."

Something flickered in her eyes. It was only there for a moment, and then it was gone, but I had spent a great deal of time learning to read faces. I knew what I had seen.

It was hunger.

"Everyone wants to know what's behind it," Devi said. Her voice was carefully neutral. "Every first-year in the University wants to know. It's a rite of passage. You get into the Archives, you see the door, you wonder what's behind it, and then you grow up and get on with your life."

"You didn't."

"What?"

"You didn't grow up and get on with your life. You still want to know." I nodded at the book. "You're still looking."

She was silent for a long moment. The cat on the bed stirred, stretched, and resettled itself.

"I was expelled," Devi said at last, "for trying to get into the Archives. Did you know that?"

"I'd heard."

"I was expelled for trying to get into the Archives *through a door I wasn't supposed to use*." She took off her spectacles and rubbed the bridge of her nose. "I was a very good student, you know. The best in my year, some said. I was going to be a Re'lar within a term. I had a gift for sympathy, a real gift. Kilvin liked me. Mandrag liked me. Even Lorren liked me, as much as Lorren likes anyone."

"What happened?"

"I got curious." She put her spectacles back on. "I'd been reading about the Archives. The history of the building. Did you know it's older than the University? Not all of it, just the core. The Stacks were built around something that was already there. Some kind of old stone structure. Nobody knows who built it or what it was for."

I shook my head.

"Nobody knows," Devi repeated. "Because nobody asks. That's the thing about the University. Everybody wants to know everything, except the things that are right under their noses." She leaned forward. "I found an old plan of the building. Very old. Older than the Archives, maybe. It showed a set of rooms beneath the Stacks. Rooms that don't exist anymore. Or rather, rooms that aren't on any map now." She tapped the desk with one finger. "And at the center of those rooms, there was a door."

"The Four-plate door."

"No." She shook her head. "Another door. Below it. Much older. The Four-plate door is just the top of the stair. There's something else, further down." She sat back. "I wanted to find it. So I went looking for a way in. And I found one, through the Underthing. And I got caught."

We sat in silence for a while. I thought about Auri, about the doors that were sleeping. About my dream.

"Did you ever find it?" I asked quietly. "The other door?"

"No. I never got close." Devi looked at me. "Why? What do you know?"

"Nothing," I said. "Not really. Just something someone told me."

"Who?"

"A friend."

She looked at me with narrowed eyes. Then she laughed, a small, humorless sound. "You're a terrible liar, you know. You're a wonderful storyteller and a terrible liar. It's a strange combination."

"I'm not lying. I really don't know anything."

"But you want to."

"Yes."

"How badly?"

I thought about that. I thought about the Chandrian, and the pages cut from every book I had ever read. I thought about the Amyr, whose records had been lost or burned or hidden. I thought about my parents, dead in the grass beneath a sky full of stars, and the smell of blood and burning, and a man with black eyes asking me whose parents had been singing the wrong sort of songs.

"Badly," I said.

Devi looked at me for a long time. Then she smiled. It was not her spider's smile this time. It was something warmer, and sadder, and much more dangerous.

"Well," she said. "Then I suppose we'd better talk."

\* \* \*

We talked until the sun went down. Devi told me everything she knew about the Four-plate door, which was a great deal more than I had ever heard. She told me that the four copper plates were not decorative, as most people assumed, but were in fact part of a very old and very complex sympathetic mechanism. She told me that the stone of the door was not granite, as it appeared, but something else, something harder and older that she had never been able to identify. She told me

that the word *Valaritas* was not in any language she could find, not Tema or Siaru or Yllish or Adem or any of the old tongues of the Aturan empire.

"I think it's a name," she said. "Not a word. A name."

"Whose name?"

"The door's, maybe. Or the thing behind it." She shrugged. "I don't know. That's the problem. I've spent six years trying to find out, and I don't know anything more now than I did when I started."

I told her a little, too. Not about Auri. I would never have told anyone about Auri. But I told her about my dream, and the door without a handle, and the breathing on the other side of it. She listened with her chin on her hand and her eyes fixed on my face, and when I was done, she did not laugh.

"That's a strange dream," she said.

"It felt real."

"Dreams do." She hesitated. "Kvothe. What do you want from this?"

"What do you mean?"

"I mean, why do you care? Why do you want to know what's behind the door?" She gestured vaguely. "You've got a good life here. You've got money now, and a patron, and friends. You've got the Eolian. You're one of the best students in the University, whatever the masters might say about your temper. Why risk all that for a door?"

It was a fair question. I thought about how to answer it.

"Because I think the things I'm looking for might be behind it," I said at last. "Or behind something like it. There are things in the world that people have tried very hard to forget. And I think they've hidden them. And I think if I want to find them, I'm going to have to go looking in the places nobody else will go."

Devi nodded slowly. "What things?"

I did not answer. After a moment, she smiled faintly.

"All right," she said. "Keep your secrets. I'll keep mine." She stood, and I stood too. "But I'll tell you this. If you ever decide to go looking for that door, I want to come with you."

"It's dangerous. If we got caught, they'd expel me. And they'd never let you back in."

"They'll never let me back in anyway." She said it lightly, but there was something bitter underneath. "I'm not asking for permission, Kvothe. I'm telling you. If you go, I go. That's the price."

"The price of what?"

She smiled her spider's smile. "Of my help," she said. "You're going to need it. I told you. I can smell it on you."

\* \* \*

I walked back across the river in the dark with my blood in a vial in my pocket and my head spinning.

It was a clear night, and cold. The stars were out, bright and hard and very far away. The river rushed beneath the stone bridge with a sound like distant applause. I stopped at the top of the arch and looked back at the lights of Imre, and then ahead at the dark bulk of the University, and above it all the Archives, black against the stars.

Somewhere deep inside it, beneath the Stacks and the Tomes and the long cool rooms full of books, there was a door made of stone. And somewhere beneath that, perhaps, there was another.

I took the vial out of my pocket and looked at it. It was too dark to see the blood inside. But I knew it was there. A drop of me, taken and held and given back again.

I thought about what Devi had said. *You're going to need something from me before the year is out. Not money. Something else.*

I put the vial back in my pocket and went home.

I did not dream that night. Or if I did, I do not remember it. But when I woke in the morning, my hands were very cold, as if I had spent the whole night holding them against a wall of stone.

## Chapter Seven

# The Tell-tale

The Fishery smelled the way it always had: of hot metal and coal smoke, of quenching oil and scorched leather, of sweat and effort and the particular sharp tang that clings to any place where men and women make things with their hands. I walked through the great doors the next morning and breathed it in, and I felt something in my shoulders unknot that I had not known was knotted.

Kilvin was in his office. He was always in his office, as far as I could tell. I sometimes wondered if he slept there, curled up on the floor beneath his desk like a great bear in a cave. When I knocked on the open door, he looked up from the thing he was working on, a tangle of copper wire and glass that looked like a bird's nest made by a very angry bird, and his face split into a broad grin beneath his beard.

"Kvothe!" he rumbled. "Good. You are here. Come, come. Sit."

I sat. Kilvin set aside his tangle of wire with great care and turned his whole body to face me. Kilvin never did anything by halves. When he looked at you, he looked at you with the whole of himself.

"You have been in Vintas," he said.

"Yes, Master Kilvin."

"You have made things there?"

I hesitated. "A few things. Small things. Mostly I was busy with other matters."

He frowned. "Busy. Everyone is always busy. But hands that do not make things forget how." He held up his own hands, broad and scarred and blackened with a lifetime of work. "These hands have not

forgotten in forty years. Because every day, I make something. Even if it is only a small thing. Even if it is only a nail." He lowered his hands. "You understand?"

"I understand."

"Good." He leaned forward. "Now. I have a project. I think it will interest you."

He reached beneath his desk and pulled out a small wooden box. He set it on the desk between us and opened the lid. Inside, nestled in straw, was a candle.

It was a plain candle, as far as I could tell. White wax, a little yellowed with age, about the length of my hand. The wick was black and curled. There was nothing remarkable about it at all.

"This," Kilvin said, "is a very old candle."

"How old?"

"Nobody knows. It was found in the Archives, in a sealed box, with no label. Lorren gave it to me, many years ago, to see if I could discover anything about it." He took the candle out of the box and held it up to the light. "It is not an ordinary candle. Watch."

He set it on the desk. He took a match from his pocket, struck it, and held it to the wick.

The wick caught. The flame rose, small and steady and yellow.

And then, slowly, the flame turned blue.

I stared at it. I could not help it. My heart had started to pound, and my mouth had gone dry, and every part of me wanted to leap up out of the chair and run. I did not. But it was a near thing.

Blue flame. The sign of the Chandrian.

"What is it?" I said. My voice sounded strange in my own ears.

"I do not know." Kilvin watched the flame with a scholar's interest. "This is the question. Most flames are yellow because of the impurities in the fuel. Sodium, mostly. A pure flame is blue. But this wax is not pure. I have tested it. It is ordinary tallow and beeswax, with some impurities. It should burn yellow." He tapped the desk beside the candle. "And yet."

"And yet it burns blue."



"Not always." Kilvin leaned closer to the flame. "Sometimes it burns yellow. For days, weeks. And then, for no reason I can find, it will turn blue. And then yellow again." He shook his head. "I have tested it for twenty years. I have recorded every time it changes color. I cannot find a pattern."

"May I see your records?"

He looked at me. Something in my voice must have caught his attention, because his eyes narrowed slightly. "Why?"

I hesitated. How much could I tell him? Kilvin was a practical man. He believed in things he could measure and test and hold in his hands. He did not believe in fairy stories.

But he had also kept this candle for twenty years, testing and retesting it, trying to understand why it did something no candle should do. That was not the behavior of a man who dismissed mysteries.

"I've heard stories," I said carefully, "about blue flame. Old stories. They say that when a flame burns blue, it means something is near. Something dangerous."

"What kind of something?"

"The Chandrian."

Kilvin was silent for a moment. Then he laughed, a deep rumbling sound. "Children's stories," he said. "Bogeymen to frighten little ones into bed."

"Maybe," I said. "But I'd still like to see your records."

He looked at me for a long moment. His eyes were very dark, and very shrewd, and I remembered, suddenly, that Kilvin was not a stupid man. He was a practical man, and a careful one, but he had not become the Master Artificer by dismissing things he did not understand.

"Very well," he said at last. "I will show you."

\* \* \*

The records filled three large ledgers. Kilvin brought them out of a cabinet in the corner of his office and set them on the desk, and I spent the rest of the morning poring over them while he went back to his tangle of wire.

He had been meticulous. Every time the candle changed color, he had recorded the date, the time, the weather, the phase of the moon, the temperature in the room, and a dozen other details. He had noted who was in the Fishery at the time and what they were working on. He had noted the condition of the candle itself, how much it had burned down, whether the wick needed trimming. He had even, in a few places, noted his own mood.

At first, I could see no pattern either. The changes seemed random. Blue for an hour on a cold winter evening, then yellow for a month. Blue for three days in the height of summer, then yellow for a year. There was nothing to connect them.

But then I started looking at the dates.

I had spent a great deal of time in the Archives. I had read a great many histories, and a great many records, and a great many old accounts of strange happenings. And as I looked at the dates in Kilvin's ledgers, some of them began to seem familiar.

Here: a span of three days, eleven years ago, when the candle had burned blue. I knew that span. It was when a farmstead near Hallowfell had burned to the ground with the whole family inside. Nobody had ever discovered what had caused the fire. The local constable's report, which I had found in a dusty box in the Stacks, said that the neighbors had seen strange lights in the sky that night, and that the ashes had been cold to the touch by morning.

Here: a single evening, seven years ago. I knew that one too. It was when a wedding party in the hills north of Anilin had been slaughtered. Every guest, every servant, every musician. The bride and groom had been found holding hands, their faces pale and peaceful, as if they had simply gone to sleep.

Here: a span of four days, six years ago.

I stopped reading. My hands had begun to shake.

Six years ago. Late summer. I knew that date. I knew it the way you know the shape of your own scars.

It was the day my troupe had died.

\* \* \*

"Master Kilvin," I said. My voice was very steady. I was proud of that, later. "Where was this candle six years ago? In late summer?"

Kilvin looked up from his work. "Here," he said. "In this office. It has always been here."

"Always? It's never been moved?"

"Never." He frowned. "Why?"

I did not answer. I was thinking.

The candle had burned blue on the day my troupe died. But my troupe had died hundreds of miles from here, in a wood near the border of the Commonwealth. The candle had been here, in this office, in the Fishery, the whole time.

So the candle was not showing when the Chandrian were near *it*. It was showing when the Chandrian were near *anyone*. When they were active, when they were abroad in the world.

Or at least, when they were doing something.

I looked back at the ledgers. At the dates, scattered across twenty years like stars in a dark sky. Some of them I recognized. Many of them I did not. But I was willing to bet that if I went into the Archives and searched through the records for each of those dates, I would find something. A fire. A massacre. A family found dead in their beds with frost on their eyelashes in the middle of summer.

"Master Kilvin," I said. "I think I know what this candle is."

\* \* \*

I told him. I told him about my troupe, and about the Chandrian, and about the signs. I did not tell him everything. I did not tell him about the conversation I had heard in the firelight, or about the man with black eyes who had asked me whose parents had been singing the wrong songs. But I told him enough.

Kilvin listened without interrupting. When I finished, he was silent for a long time.

"You believe this," he said at last. It was not a question.

"I've seen them, Master Kilvin. With my own eyes."

"And you think this candle shows when they are near."

"Not near. Active. When they're doing something." I tapped the ledger. "I can prove it. Give me a span in the Archives, and I'll find a record for every one of these dates."

Kilvin looked at the candle, still burning blue on his desk. Then he reached out and snuffed it with his fingers. The smoke curled up, grey and thin.

"If this is true," he said slowly, "then this is a very dangerous thing."

"Yes."

"And a very useful one."

"Yes."

He looked at me. "What would you do with it?"

I had been thinking about that since the moment the flame turned blue. "I'd study it," I said. "I'd find out how it works. Why it works. And then I'd make more of them."

"More?"

"A candle that burns blue when the Chandrian are near. A lamp. A ring. A stone you could carry in your pocket." I leaned forward. "If I could make something like this, something small and portable, something that could warn people, then maybe nobody else would have to—"

I stopped. Kilvin was looking at me with an expression I had never seen on his face before. It took me a moment to recognize it. It was compassion.

"Maybe nobody else would have to lose their family," he said quietly.

I did not answer. I could not.

Kilvin nodded slowly. He picked up the candle and put it back in its box and closed the lid. Then he pushed the box across the desk toward me.

"Take it," he said. "Study it. Find out how it works. And if you can make more—" He paused. "If you can make more, I will help you."

I stared at him. "Master Kilvin—"

"I have kept this candle for twenty years," he said. "I have tested it and measured it and recorded it. And in all that time, I have never understood it. Perhaps you will." He smiled faintly. "And if you do not, at least it will be in the hands of someone who cares."

\* \* \*

I took the box back to my workbench in the Fishery and set it down and sat staring at it for a long time.

My workbench was just as I had left it. My tools were still there, in their places. The half-finished projects I had abandoned when I left for Vintas were still there too, covered in a fine layer of dust. Someone had swept around them, but no one had touched them. That was the unwritten law of the Fishery: a man's bench was his own, and you did not touch another man's work.

I opened the box. I took out the candle. I held it in my hands.

It was an ordinary candle. Tallow and beeswax, a little yellowed with age. I could feel the faint oily smoothness of it against my fingers. It smelled faintly of honey and of old dust.

But there was something else. Something beneath the surface. It was hard to describe. The best I can say is that it felt the way a word feels when it is on the tip of your tongue. Something almost there. Something just out of reach.

I closed my eyes and let my mind slip into the Heart of Stone.

It is a difficult thing to explain, the Heart of Stone. It is a way of thinking, a way of holding the mind apart from itself, so that you can see clearly without being swayed by fear or hope or anger. It is the first thing any sympathist learns, and the last thing he ever masters. I had learned it young, from a man named Abenthy who had traveled with my troupe when I was a boy. I had used it every day since.

In the Heart of Stone, I looked at the candle.

And I saw something.

It was very faint. The barest trace of a binding, woven into the wax itself. Not a sympathetic binding, not like anything I had ever learned. It was older than that. Stranger. It was like looking at a piece of cloth and suddenly seeing that it was not woven at all but knotted,

every thread tied to every other thread in a pattern so complex that it made my eyes ache.

I opened my eyes. My head was pounding.

I looked at the candle for a long time. Then I put it back in its box and closed the lid and sat there with my hands flat on the bench, breathing slowly, waiting for the pounding in my head to fade.

Knots. Not sympathy. Knots.

I did not know what that meant. Not yet. But I knew, the way you sometimes know things without knowing how, that it meant something important.

\* \* \*

"You look like someone stepped on your grave."

I looked up. Fela was standing beside my bench, her arms folded, her head tilted to one side. She was wearing a leather apron over her clothes and there was a smudge of soot on her cheek. Her dark hair was pulled back in a braid.

"Fela," I said. "Hello."

"Hello yourself." She smiled. "Sim told me you were back. I didn't believe him until I saw you walk in this morning. You've been sitting there staring at that box for an hour."

"Have I?"

"You have." She came closer and leaned against the edge of my bench. "What's in it?"

I hesitated. Then I opened the box and showed her.

She looked at the candle for a long moment. Then she looked at me. "It's a candle."

"It is."

"You've been staring at a candle for an hour."

"It's a very interesting candle."

She laughed. "Of course it is." She reached out and touched it with one finger, lightly, the way you might touch a sleeping animal. Then she drew her hand back, frowning. "That's strange."

"What?"

"It feels—" She hesitated. "It feels like stone. Doesn't it? Not like wax. Like stone."

I stared at her. Fela had been studying naming with Elodin for as long as I had. Longer, in fact. And she had done something I had never managed: she had found a name. The name of stone. I had heard it from Sim, who had heard it from her, who had been reluctant to talk about it. She had called the name once, by accident, the way I had called the wind. She had split a stone in half with a word.

"What do you mean?" I asked.

She shook her head, still frowning. "I don't know. It's just a feeling." She looked at the candle again. "There's something in it. Something that doesn't belong. It feels like the way a stone feels when there's something hidden inside it. A fossil, or a crystal, or a crack." She looked up at me. "Where did you get it?"

"Kilvin. It was found in the Archives."

"The Archives." She nodded slowly. "That makes sense. The Archives are full of old things." She was quiet for a moment. Then she said, "Kvothe. Can I tell you something strange?"

"Of course."

"Sometimes, when I'm in the Archives, I feel like the stone is listening." She laughed, embarrassed. "That sounds mad, I know. But it's true. The whole building is made of stone, and sometimes when I'm there, especially down in the lower levels, I feel like it's listening to me. Like it's waiting for something." She shook her head. "Elodin says that's what happens when you learn a name. You start to hear things you couldn't hear before. And it doesn't always make you happy."

I thought about Auri, and the doors that were sleeping. I thought about my dream, and the breathing on the other side of the stone.

"What do you think it's waiting for?" I asked.

Fela looked at me. Her eyes were dark and serious.

"I don't know," she said. "But I don't think it's something good."

\* \* \*

That night, alone in my room under the eaves, I lit the candle.

I do not know why I did it. It was foolish. If the candle burned blue, it would mean the Chandrian were abroad somewhere in the world, doing something terrible, and there would be nothing I could do about it. And if it burned yellow, it would mean nothing at all.

But I lit it anyway. I set it on the windowsill and struck a match and held it to the wick, and I watched the flame catch and grow and steady.

It burned yellow. A warm, ordinary, homely yellow, the color of every candle I had ever seen.

I sat on the edge of my bed and watched it for a long time. I watched it until the moon rose over the rooftops and the stars came out and the sounds of the University faded into the deep quiet of the night.

It stayed yellow.

At last, when my eyes were growing heavy and the candle had burned down a finger's width, I leaned forward to snuff it.

And just before my fingers touched the wick, the flame flickered. It was only for a moment. A single heartbeat. But in that heartbeat, I saw it turn.

Not blue. Not quite. It turned a pale, cold, silvery color, like the light of the moon on snow. And then it was yellow again.

I sat very still. My heart was pounding.

I had never seen that color before. Kilvin had never recorded it in his ledgers. I did not know what it meant.

But I knew, the way you sometimes know things, that something, somewhere, had just woken up.



## Chapter Eight

# Manet

If you spend enough time in the Fishery, sooner or later you will learn everything Manet knows. It is not that he teaches it. Manet does not teach, not really. It is that he is always there, at his bench near the kilns, with his wild grey hair and his burn-scarred hands and his clothes that smell of smoke, and if you stand near him long enough, what he knows begins to soak into you the way smoke soaks into cloth.

Manet had been an E'lr for thirty years. Everyone at the University knew that. He had come to the University as a young man, before most of the current masters, and he had never left. He had never advanced. He had studied everything and mastered nothing, and he had been perfectly happy about it the whole time. He knew more about the practical side of artificing than anyone except Kilvin, and possibly more than Kilvin, though you would never have got either of them to admit it.

I went to him on the fifth day after Kilvin gave me the candle.

I had been working on it every spare moment. Sitting at my bench with the candle in its box and the ledgers open beside it, looking at the strange knotted binding I had seen in the heart of the wax. Trying to understand it. Trying to copy it.

I could not. Every attempt failed. I would melt down a little of Kilvin's ordinary beeswax, and pour it into a mold, and try to work the binding into it as it cooled. I would try with sympathy. I would try with sygaldry, scratching runes into the wax with a fine steel point. I

would try with things I did not have names for, things I made up as I went along, half by instinct and half by desperation.

Nothing worked. The candles I made were only candles. They burned yellow, and they went on burning yellow, and they did not do anything else at all.

\* \* \*

Manet was at his bench, grinding something in a stone mortar with a stone pestle. He did not look up as I came over.

"You've been staring at that box for five days," he said. "Kilvin's worried about you."

"Kilvin said that?"

"Kilvin grunted in a worried way." Manet ground his pestle. "I've known him long enough to translate." He tipped the contents of the mortar into a jar and looked up at me with his bright shrewd eyes. "What's in it?"

I hesitated. Then I opened the box and showed him.

He looked at the candle for a long time. He did not touch it. Then he looked at me.

"That's the old blue one," he said. "Kilvin's mystery candle. He's had it for twenty years."

"He gave it to me."

Manet's eyebrows went up. They were very expressive eyebrows, wild and grey and bristling, like two small animals living on his forehead.

"Did he now," he said. "Well. He must think a great deal of you." He looked back at the candle. "And you've been trying to make another one. Haven't you? For five days. And failing."

"How did you know?"

"Because I tried too." Manet smiled faintly. "Twenty years ago. When he first got it. I spent a whole term trying to copy it. Every method I knew, and some I invented." He shook his head. "Never got close."

\* \* \*

He took me outside, into the yard behind the Fishery, where the scrap metal was piled and the slag heaps smoked and nobody ever went unless they had to. He sat down on an upturned crate and took out a pipe and filled it very slowly with tobacco from a leather pouch.

"Sit," he said.

I sat on another crate.

He lit the pipe. He smoked for a while, looking at the slag heaps.

"Do you know," he said at last, "why I never became a master?"

"People say you couldn't choose a field."

"People say a great many things. Some of them are even true." He blew out a thin stream of smoke. "I couldn't choose. That's true. But it's not the whole of it." He looked at me. "When I was about your age, I made something. Something I didn't understand. I'd been trying to make a lamp that would burn without fuel, drawing heat from the air around it. Everyone told me it couldn't be done. I did it anyway." He smoked for a moment. "It worked for eleven days. Then it drew all the heat out of my room, and the room next to it, and the room next to that, and three students nearly froze to death in their beds before Kilvin broke it with a hammer."

I stared at him.

"I didn't understand it," said Manet. "That was the problem. I'd made it, but I didn't understand it. I'd got it right by accident, by fiddling, by trying things until something worked. And when it went wrong, I didn't know why, and I couldn't stop it." He looked at the slag heaps. "After that, I decided I wasn't going to make anything I didn't understand. Ever again. And it turns out that when you make that rule, you don't make very much."

"And the candle?"

"The candle," said Manet, "wasn't made by someone who understood it either. I'd bet my beard on it."

"How do you know?"

He looked at me for a long moment with his bright shrewd eyes.

"Because nobody understands it," he said. "Not Kilvin, not me, not Lorren, not anyone. And I don't think the person who made it did

either. I think they did it the way I made my cold lamp. By feel. By instinct. By reaching into something they didn't have a name for and pulling out whatever came to hand." He tapped his pipe against the crate. "Some things aren't made, Kvothe. They're *found*. Somebody finds the shape of them, in the dark, by accident, and puts it into wax or iron or stone. And then it's there, and it works, and nobody knows why."

\* \* \*

"The binding in it," I said slowly. "In the wax. I can see it, a little. When I look with the Heart of Stone. It's not like sympathy. It's like—" I struggled for the word. "Knots. It's like looking at cloth and seeing it's not woven but knotted."

Manet was very still.

"Knots," he said.

"Yes."

He did not say anything for a long time. He smoked his pipe and looked at the slag heaps, and his face was very strange.

"There was a woman," he said at last. "When I was young. Not a student. A peddler. She came through Imre once, when I was a second-year, and she sold charms in the market. Little things. Cords with knots in them. She said they'd keep you safe on the road, or bring you luck, or make a girl love you." He laughed softly. "Everyone said she was a fraud. I bought one anyway. For luck."

"Did it work?"

"I don't know." Manet reached into his shirt and drew out a thread. There was something on the end of it, very small and very dark and very old. A knot. "I've worn it for forty years. I've never been killed on the road. I've never been very unlucky." He looked at it. "I've never married, either. So I can't speak to that part."

I looked at the knot on the end of his thread. It was very small. Very simple. A few loops of dark cord, twisted around each other.

But I felt it. Very faintly. The same thing I had felt in the heart of Kilvin's candle. A kind of tightening. A kind of holding.

"It's the same," I said. "Isn't it? The same kind of thing."

Manet looked at me. Then at the knot. Then he tucked it back inside his shirt.

"I don't know," he said. "Maybe. I've never known what it was. I only know that some nights, when I'm lying in bed and can't sleep, I hold it in my hand, and it feels like someone's holding my hand back." He smiled faintly. "Foolish, I know. An old man's fancy."

"It's not foolish."

"No?" He looked at me. "Well. Maybe not." He knocked out his pipe. "I'll tell you something, Kvothe, since you're the first person in forty years who's looked at that knot and seen something in it. Don't try to copy the candle. You'll fail. I did. Kilvin did. Everyone does."

"Then what should I do?"

"Find the person who made it," said Manet. "Or someone like them. Someone who knows how to find the shapes in the dark." He stood up, slowly, with a hand on his back. "And when you find them, be careful. People who can do that kind of thing—" He hesitated. "They're not always safe to be around. The peddler woman who sold me this knot. I asked about her, years later. Nobody knew where she'd gone. But there was a story, in a town in the south, about a woman who sold charms in the market and was found one morning in her wagon, frozen solid. In summer."

He looked at me.

"I've always wondered," he said, "if she found a shape in the dark that someone else didn't want found."

\* \* \*

I went back to my bench. I did not try to copy the candle again.

But I did something else. I took a single hair from my own head, a long red one, and I tied it around the base of Kilvin's candle, very carefully, in a knot. The simplest knot I knew. A single loop, doubled back on itself.

I did not know why. It was not sympathy, or sygaldry, or anything I had been taught. It was only a feeling. A shape I had seen in the dark, the way Manet said.

And that night, in my room under the eaves, when I lit the candle, it burned yellow. As it always did.

But when I snuffed it, and sat in the dark, and held my hand over it, I felt something I had not felt before.

It was warm. Not the warmth of a flame just snuffed. A different warmth. The warmth of something alive.

I did not know what it meant. I did not know anything.

But I slept, that night, with my hand resting on the box, and I did not dream of doors.

## Chapter Nine

# The Dates

I spent the next nine days in the Archives with Kilvin's ledger.

Not the whole ledger. Kilvin would not let it out of the Fishery; he said it was the only copy, and that twenty years of careful observation should not be carried across a courtyard in the pocket of a student who had once set fire to his own cloak in the Artificery. So I copied out the dates. Every day the candle had burned blue, in twenty years. There were a hundred and thirty-one of them.

I wrote them on a long strip of paper, in a column, in my smallest hand. And then I took the strip of paper into the Archives, and I began to look.

\* \* \*

Wil helped. He did not want to. He said that he had a great deal of work of his own, and that my projects had a way of becoming everyone's projects, and that he still had not forgiven me for the business with the lamp in the Tomes. But I showed him the strip of paper, and told him what it was, and he looked at it for a long time with his dark Cealdish eyes.

"A candle that burns blue when the Chandrian are abroad," he said.

"Yes."

"And you want to find out what they were doing. On each of these days."

"Yes."

Wil looked at the column of dates. A hundred and thirty-one of them.

"This is going to take months," he said.

"I know."

He sighed. "What do you need?"

\* \* \*

What I needed was news. Records. Anything that noted, on a particular day, in a particular place, that something strange had happened.

The Archives are full of such things, if you know where to look. Not in the Tomes, where the scholars read, but down in the Stacks, in the dusty forgotten corners where the University keeps everything it has ever been given and never thrown away. Broadsheets from Imre and Anilin and Tarbean, stacked in bundles tied with string. Letters from the University's correspondents, scholars and physicians and priests all over the Four Corners, reporting on the weather and the harvest and the local curiosities. Tax rolls. Court records. The ledgers of a hundred merchant houses, bequeathed to the Archives by heirs who did not want them.

And constables' reports. Boxes and boxes of them. The University had an arrangement, going back two hundred years, with the magistrates of the Commonwealth: copies of any report concerning *unexplained phenomena* were to be sent to the Archives for study. Most of the reports were nonsense. Lights in the marshes. Two-headed calves. A woman in Hallowfell who claimed her cat had spoken to her in Tema.

But not all of them.

\* \* \*

It was slow work. We went through the dates one at a time. Wil took the broadsheets and the correspondents' letters; I took the constables' reports. We worked every evening, after his shift at the desk, and every morning before my classes, down in a forgotten corner of the Stacks by the light of a single sympathy lamp.

And slowly, date by date, a pattern began to emerge.



*Fourteen years ago, in the spring:* a wedding party in the hills south of Anilin. Thirty-one guests, all dead, in the barn where the feast had been laid. The constable's report noted that the candles on the tables had been found burned down to nothing, and that the wax had pooled and hardened *in a strange blue color*.

*Nine years ago, in the autumn:* a Tehlin monastery near the Small Kingdoms. Eleven monks, dead in the chapel. The report was brief and frightened and did not say how they had died. It said that the iron on the chapel door had rusted through overnight, *as if a hundred years had passed in a single night*.

*Seven years ago, at midwinter:* a cartwright's family outside Tinuë. A father, a mother, four children. Found in their beds, with frost on their eyelashes, in a house where the fire was still burning in the grate.

*Six years ago, late in the summer:* a troupe of Edema Ruh in the woods near the border of the Commonwealth.

I did not need a report for that one. I stopped, when I came to that date on the strip of paper. I sat for a long time in the dim red light of the Stacks with my finger on it. Wil did not say anything. He knew.

After a while, I moved my finger to the next date.

\* \* \*

Not every date had a massacre. That was the strange thing. That was the thing that kept me awake, those nine nights, lying in my narrow bed at Anker's and staring at the ceiling.

Some of the dates had nothing at all. Nothing in the broadsheets, nothing in the letters, nothing in the constables' reports. The candle had burned blue, and the world had gone on, and no one had noticed anything.

"Maybe they were traveling," said Wil, when I told him. "Maybe the candle burns blue whenever they're—out. In the world. Not just when they're killing."

"Maybe."

"Or maybe they were doing something no one noticed," said Wil. "Something quiet. Something that didn't leave any bodies." He looked

at me. "That's worse, I think."

I thought so too.

And some of the dates had things that were not massacres, but were strange in other ways. A bridge in Atur that collapsed on a still day, with no flood and no storm, killing no one. A library in Modeg that burned, with every book in it, and not a single person hurt. A famous singer in Vintas who lost her voice overnight and never sang again.

A scholar in Yll who had been writing a history of the Creation War, and who was found dead at his desk, with his last page burned to ash in his hand.

A tinker on the north road, near Hallowfell, who had been telling a story in an inn about seven strangers in the woods, and who disappeared the next morning, leaving his donkey and his cart behind.

\* \* \*

"They're hunting stories," I said to Wil, on the ninth night.

We were sitting in our corner of the Stacks, surrounded by boxes and bundles and the dry sweet smell of old paper. The strip of dates lay on the table between us, marked now with small notes in my hand and Wil's.

"Stories," said Wil.

"Songs. Histories. Anything that tells about them. About what they are." I touched the strip. "My parents were writing a song. The scholar in Yll was writing a history. The tinker was telling a tale in an inn. The library in Modeg—" I stopped. "I'd wager it had something. Some book. Some record. Something true."

"And the bridge?"

"I don't know. Maybe something was carved on it. Maybe somebody sang a song on it once." I shook my head. "I don't know. But I'd wager it's the same. Every time. Someone, somewhere, starts to tell the truth about them. And they come."

Wil was quiet for a long time.

"Then you'd better be careful," he said at last. "Hadn't you."

"I'm always careful."

Wil looked at me with his dark calm eyes. He did not say anything. He did not have to.

\* \* \*

There was one more date. I have left it for last, because I found it last, and because it frightened me more than any of the others.

It was at the very bottom of the strip. The most recent. Kilvin had noted it only a few months before, while I was in Vintas. A single day in late spring. The candle had burned blue from dawn until noon, and then gone back to yellow.

I searched everything for that date. Every broadsheet, every letter, every report. There was nothing. No massacre. No fire. No bridge or library or singer. Nothing at all.

Until, on the last night, going back through the Archives' own records to see if I had missed anything, I found it in the most unlikely place of all. The admissions register of the Archives. The daily list of everyone who had come in through the great doors, with their names and their business, kept by the scriv at the desk.

On that day, in late spring, while I was far away in Severen, one visitor had signed the register. A gentleman scholar from the south. With a letter of introduction from a lord in Renere.

His name was written in a small, neat, slanting hand.

*Brand.*

\* \* \*

I did not know, then, what it meant. I want to be clear about that. I did not know, then, that I had seen that hand before, or would see it again, in six old ledgers in a cold corner of the Stacks. I did not know about the old man in the Maer's garden. I did not know anything.

I only knew that on the day a quiet gentleman with a letter from Renere came into the Archives, Kilvin's candle had burned blue from dawn until noon.

And I knew, from the register, what time he had left.

Noon.

\* \* \*

I showed Wil. He looked at the register for a long time. Then he looked at the strip of dates. Then he looked at me.

"Kvothe," he said slowly. "The candle's supposed to burn blue when the Chandrian are doing something. Anywhere in the world."

"Yes."

"Then why would it burn blue for a man reading books in the Archives?"

I did not answer. I did not have an answer. Not then.

I folded the strip of dates, very carefully, and put it in my pocket. I put the register back on its shelf. And I went back to Anker's, and lay in my narrow bed, and stared at the ceiling, and did not sleep at all.

\* \* \*

"Did you ever find out?" said Chronicler. "Why it burned for him?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "Eventually. It's in the story. You'll see." He looked at his hands. "But I'll tell you now what I didn't know then. Kilvin's candle doesn't only burn for the seven. It burns for anyone who is doing their work. Their master's work." He paused. "It burned for him because he was in the Archives looking for something the Chandrian wanted found. He was working for them. Or with them. Or they were working for him." He shook his head. "I've never been sure which. I'm not sure he's sure."

"And the other dates? The ones with nothing?"

The innkeeper looked at the fire.

"Those are the ones that frighten me," he said. "Even now. A hundred and thirty-one days in twenty years. And for forty of them, I never found anything at all." He was quiet. "Forty times, something was done in the world that served the Chandrian. And no one noticed. No one died. No one wrote it down." He looked at Chronicler. "That's the real danger. Not the fires. The quiet. The things that happen that no one ever notices, until the day they look up and see the shape the stones have made."

## Chapter Ten

# Patience

Elodin's class met that term in a small round room at the top of the Rookery, a room I had never been in before and was never able to find again afterward. I do not mean that it moved. I mean that I climbed the stairs of the Rookery a hundred times in the years that followed, and I never once came to a door that led to that room. Elodin, when I asked him about it later, said only that some rooms are shy.

There were five of us that term. Fela, of course, who had been with Elodin longest and who sat in the chair nearest the window with her hands folded in her lap like a novice at prayer. Uresta, a quiet Cealdish boy with long fingers who had been studying with Elodin for two terms and had not, as far as anyone knew, spoken a single word in class. Brey, whom I had met before, a tall and cheerful young man from the Small Kingdoms who laughed too loudly at everything. Inyssa, a Vintish girl I did not know, who wore her hair cut short as a boy's and watched everything with eyes the color of slate.

And me.

Elodin came in late, as he always did. He was carrying a stone.

It was a plain stone, grey and roughly round, about the size of a man's fist. The kind of stone you might find in any field or riverbed. He set it on the floor in the center of the room and stood looking down at it with his hands in his pockets.

"This," he said, "is a stone."

We waited.

"It is a very old stone. Older than anyone in this room. Older than the University. Older than the Aturan Empire, or the empire before that, or the empire before that. It was here before there were people to name it, and it will be here after there are no people left to remember what it was called." He looked up at us. "What is it thinking?"

Nobody answered.

"Come now," Elodin said. "Somebody guess."

"Stones don't think," said Brey, and laughed.

Elodin looked at him. Brey stopped laughing.

"How do you know?" said Elodin.

"Because they don't have brains."

"Neither does the wind. Neither does fire. Neither does the sea. And yet I have known all three of them to have very strong opinions." Elodin crouched beside the stone. "Stone thinks. It thinks very slowly, and it thinks about very few things, and it almost never changes its mind. But it thinks." He looked around at us. "Your task for this term is to find out what."

"How?" I asked.

Elodin smiled at me. "By listening."

"To a stone."

"To a stone."

"For a term."

"For as long as it takes." He stood. "Some of you will hear it in a span. Some of you will hear it in a year. Some of you will never hear it at all, and you'll go back to your alchemy and your sympathy and your nice safe lives, and you'll be the better for it." He looked at me again. "And one of you will hear it, and then you'll wish you hadn't."

He walked to the door. "Class dismissed," he said, and left.

We sat in silence for a long moment. Then Brey laughed nervously. "Well," he said. "That was helpful."

Nobody answered him. We were all looking at the stone.

\* \* \*

I want to tell you that I heard the stone that first day. I want to tell you that I sat in that round room and closed my eyes and let my mind go

still, and the name of stone rose up in me like water in a well.

But it did not happen that way. It did not happen that way at all.

I listened to that stone for three spans. I sat with it in the round room for hours at a time, until the light through the window went from gold to grey to black. I carried it with me back to my room at Anker's and set it on the windowsill beside Kilvin's candle and stared at it until my eyes ached. I took it to the Fishery and set it on my bench while I worked. I took it to the Archives and set it on the table beside my books. I even, on one memorable occasion, took it to the Eolian and set it on the stage beside me while I played, which caused a great deal of confused whispering in the balconies and did nothing whatsoever to help me hear it.

It did not speak to me. Not a word, not a whisper, not so much as a sigh.

I tried everything. I tried the Heart of Stone, holding my mind still and cold and clear. I tried the opposite, letting my mind wander, letting it drift and dream, the way Elodin had once told me to do when I was trying to find the name of the wind. I tried Spinning Leaf, the mental trick that had helped me once before. I tried the breathing exercises the Adem had taught me, the long slow breaths that were meant to still the body and open the mind.

Nothing.

The stone sat on my windowsill and was a stone, and nothing more.

\* \* \*

"You're trying too hard," said Fela.

We were sitting on the roof of the Mains together, where I had gone to get away from the stone for an hour and where she had come, she said, to see what I was doing. It was a cold, bright afternoon. The wind was sharp. Below us, the University spread out like a map.

"How can I try too hard?" I said. "I'm not trying at all. I'm just sitting there. Listening."

"No," Fela said. "You're waiting. That's different."

"What's the difference?"

She thought about it. "When you listen to someone," she said slowly, "you're not waiting for them to say something. You're just—there. With them. You're paying attention to them. You're not thinking about what you want them to say, or when they're going to say it. You're just letting them be." She looked at me. "When you sit with that stone, you're waiting for it to talk. You want it to talk. You're hungry for it. And the stone can feel that, and it doesn't like it."

"The stone can feel that."

"Of course it can." She shrugged. "Stone doesn't like hunger. Stone doesn't like anything that wants something from it. It's been here forever, and it'll be here forever, and everything that wants something from it eventually goes away. Rain wants to wear it down. Roots want to crack it open. Men want to cut it and carve it and build things out of it. And the stone just waits. It waits for all of them to go away." She smiled faintly. "It's very good at waiting. Much better than you."

I thought about that. "So how did you hear it?"

She was quiet for a long time. The wind blew her hair across her face and she pushed it back with one hand.

"I stopped wanting to," she said at last.

"What do you mean?"

"I mean I gave up." She laughed softly. "I'd been trying for months. I was so frustrated I wanted to scream. And one day I was sitting with it in the round room, and I just thought, *fine*. Fine. I'm never going to hear it. I'll just sit here with it, because it's quiet and it's peaceful and I like it here. And I stopped trying. I just sat with it." She looked out over the rooftops. "And after a while, I don't know how long, I realized I could hear it. It had been talking all along. I just hadn't been quiet enough to hear."

"What did it say?"

She looked at me. Her eyes were very dark.

"It said *no*," she said.

"No?"

"That's all stone ever says, really. No. No, I will not move. No, I will not change. No, I will not break." She shook her head. "Except



that when you really hear it, it's not just no. It's—" She struggled for the words. "It's the most patient no in the world. It's a no that's been saying itself since before there was anyone to hear it. It's a no that will keep saying itself long after the last person is dead. It's not angry, and it's not afraid. It just *is*." She hesitated. "It's the most beautiful thing I've ever heard."

We sat in silence for a long time after that.

"I don't think I can do that," I said at last. "Stop wanting."

"I know." Fela smiled. "You've never stopped wanting anything in your life. It's one of the things I like about you." She stood up and brushed off her skirt. "But you'll have to learn. Elodin wouldn't have given you stone if he didn't think you needed it."

She started to walk away along the ridge of the roof. Then she stopped and turned back.

"Kvothe," she said. "When you do hear it. Be careful."

"Careful of what?"

She hesitated. "When I split that stone. The first time. I didn't mean to. It just happened. I heard the name, and I said it, and the stone broke." She looked down at her hands. "I've never been able to do it again. Not on purpose. But sometimes, late at night, I can still hear it. Stone. All around me. The walls, the floor, the foundations of the buildings. It's all saying no, all the time, very quietly. And sometimes—" She stopped.

"Sometimes what?"

"Sometimes," Fela said, "I hear something else. Underneath. Something that isn't saying no."

"What is it saying?"

She looked at me, and there was something in her face I had never seen before. It was fear.

"I don't know," she said. "I don't want to know."

And then she was gone, down the far side of the roof, and I was alone.

\* \* \*

That night I went down into the Underthing.

I told myself that I was going to see Auri, and that was true, in its way. I brought her a pear and a small paper twist of salt and a ribbon of blue silk I had bought in Imre. But I also brought the stone. I carried it in my pocket, a hard round weight against my hip, and as I climbed down through the grate and into the dark, I felt it grow heavier.

Auri found me in the place she called Mantle, a long low room with a curving ceiling where an old chimney came down through the stone. She was sitting on a ledge with her feet dangling, humming to herself, and when she saw me her face lit up.

"Kvothe!" she said. "You came down."

"I did."

"You never come down." She tilted her head. "You always call me up."

"I wanted to see where you live," I said. "If that's all right."

She considered this seriously. Then she nodded. "That's all right," she said. "But you have to be polite. The Underthing doesn't like rude people."

"I'll be polite."

"And you have to be quiet. Some of the rooms are sleeping."

"I'll be very quiet."

She smiled at me and slid down off the ledge. "What did you bring?"

I gave her the pear, and she pronounced it "earnest." The salt was "honest." The ribbon made her go very still, and she held it in both hands and looked at it for a long time without saying anything. Then she tied it in her hair, carefully, and looked at me with shining eyes.

"Thank you," she said softly. "It's the color of being brave."

We walked through the Underthing together. Auri led the way, her bare feet silent on the stone, and I followed with my sympathy lamp held low. She showed me the places she loved. The Crumbling, where the ceiling had fallen in long ago and a thin shaft of moonlight came down from somewhere far above. The Twelve, a great round room with twelve doorways, each leading somewhere different. Tumbrel, with its family of little grey moths, who fluttered up around

us as we passed and settled again on the damp walls like a scattering of ash.

And as we walked, I felt the stone in my pocket grow heavier and heavier.

It was not a real weight. I knew that. It was the same stone it had always been, no bigger, no denser. But it felt heavier, the way a word can feel heavier when you are about to say something you know you should not.

At last we came to a place I had never been before. It was a narrow passage that sloped downward, steeper than any I had seen in the Underthing. The walls were rough and unfinished. The air grew colder as we went.

"Where does this go?" I asked.

Auri stopped. She turned and looked at me, and her face was very serious.

"Down," she said.

"Down where?"

"Just down." She hesitated. "It's not a proper place. It doesn't have a name. I don't go there very often."

"Why not?"

She looked at the passage, sloping away into darkness. "Because it's too loud," she said.

I listened. I heard nothing. The passage was utterly silent, silent the way only deep places are silent, a silence so complete it seemed to have weight.

"I don't hear anything," I said.

Auri looked at me. There was something almost pitying in her eyes.

"You're not listening," she said.

And then, very quietly, she began to walk away, back the way we had come. After a moment I followed her. But as I turned, I felt the stone in my pocket shift, very slightly, as if it wanted to go the other way.

\* \* \*

I did not hear the stone that night. I did not hear it for many nights after.

But I began to notice things. Small things. The way the walls of the Archives felt cooler under my hand than the walls of other buildings. The way the paving stones of the courtyard seemed to hum faintly underfoot on very cold mornings. The way the great grey bulk of the stone bridge seemed, when I stood at the top of its arch and looked down at the river, to be holding its breath.

I did not know what any of it meant. I told myself it was nothing. I told myself it was the product of too little sleep and too much listening, the way a man who stares too long at a blank wall will begin to see faces in it.

But at night, lying in my narrow bed with the stone on the windowsill beside the candle, I would sometimes wake with a start, my heart pounding, certain that I had heard something. A voice. A word. A single long syllable, very deep and very slow, spoken from somewhere far below me.

And every time, when I lay still and listened, there was nothing. Only silence. Only the wind moving across the rooftops, and the distant sound of the river, and the slow patient silence of stone.

It would be months before I understood what I had been hearing. And by then, of course, it was too late.

## Chapter Eleven

# A Matter of Tallow

The duel was Fenton's idea. I want that on record.

He found me in the Fishery on a grey afternoon late in the autumn, when I was at my bench working on a heat-funnel for Kilvin and thinking about stone. He came and stood beside my bench with his arms folded and a smile on his face that I had seen before, on other faces, usually shortly before someone got hit.

"Kvothe," he said.

"Fenton."

"I hear you've been learning stone. With Elodin."

"Trying to."

"And not doing very well, I hear." His smile widened. "Three spans, and you can't hear a pebble."

I did not look up from my work. "Who told you that?"

"Everyone knows. It's all over the Arcanum." He leaned against my bench. "The great Kvothe, who called the wind at fifteen. Can't hear a rock."

I set down my tools. I looked at him.

Fenton was a Re'lar, like me. He was a year older than me and had been in the Arcanum a year longer, and he had always resented the fact that I had passed him. He was good at sympathy. Very good. He had beaten me in a duel once, my first year, in front of half the Arcanum, and he had never let me forget it.

He was also one of Ambrose's friends. Not one of the close ones, the ones who followed him about like hounds. But close enough to be

seen with him, and to laugh at his jokes, and to pick fights on his behalf when Ambrose could not be bothered to pick them himself.

"What do you want, Fenton?"

"A rematch," said Fenton. "Sympathy. In the Mains, in the old dueling room. Tomorrow at sixth bell." He smiled. "Unless you're afraid."

\* \* \*

I should have said no. I know that now. I knew it then, a little. I had more important things to worry about than Fenton's pride. There was the candle, and the stone, and the cut pages in the Archives that no one could explain. There was Denna, and her knots. There was the strange cold feeling I had been carrying since I heard about the Chandrian in the Eld.

But I was seventeen. And he had said *afraid*.

"Sixth bell," I said.

\* \* \*

Sympathy duels are an old tradition at the University. Older than most of the masters, older than the Arcanum itself. They are not forbidden, exactly, but they are not encouraged either. The masters prefer to pretend they do not happen. Which means they happen a great deal, in empty rooms after dark, with an audience of students who have bet more than they can afford on the outcome.

The rules are simple. Each duelist has a candle. Each candle is identical, poured from the same batch of tallow, with a lock of the duelist's hair worked into the wax so that the candle is bound to him, sympathetically. The duelists sit at opposite ends of a table. The candles are lit.

The object is to put out your opponent's candle while keeping your own lit.

That is all. It sounds very simple. It is not. Because every trick you use against your opponent's candle, he can use against yours. Every binding you make, he can break. Every drop of heat you steal from his flame, he can steal back. It is a battle of wills, of

concentration, of the ability to split your mind in two and hold two bindings at once while your opponent is trying to break both of them.

I had lost to Fenton, my first year, because he had been better at holding two bindings. I was very good at sympathy, but I was young, and I tired easily, and he had simply outlasted me.

I was not young anymore. Not in the ways that mattered.

\* \* \*

The old dueling room was in the basement of the Mains, a long low room with a stone floor and a vaulted ceiling and a single long table down the middle. By sixth bell, it was packed. Word had spread, the way word always spreads at the University. The great Kvothe, returned from his mysterious travels, against Fenton, who had beaten him once before. Students were crammed along the walls three deep, and standing on benches, and sitting on each other's shoulders. Money was changing hands. A great deal of money.

Sim was there, looking anxious. Wil was there, looking bored, which meant he had bet heavily on me and was very nervous. Fela was there, standing near the door, with her arms folded and her face serious.

Fenton was already at the table when I came in. He was sitting very straight, with his hands folded, and he did not look at me.

I sat down at the other end.

The candles were brought. Two identical white tallow candles, each about the length of a hand, set in brass holders. A Re'lar I did not know, one of the ones who organized these things, took a lock of hair from each of us with a small pair of scissors and worked it into the soft wax at the base of each candle while we watched. Mine went into one candle. Fenton's into the other.

Then the candles were set in front of us, and lit.

\* \* \*

For the first few minutes, nothing happened.

That is how it always goes. Each duelist feels out the other. Tests his defenses. Makes small probing bindings, the way a swordsman

makes small probing thrusts, to see how his opponent responds. Fenton's first probe came almost at once: a quick thin binding, reaching across the table toward my candle, trying to link its flame to the cold stone of the floor.

I felt it coming. I broke it without effort. I sent a probe of my own back toward his candle, and he broke it just as easily.

We went back and forth like that for a while. Small bindings, quickly made and quickly broken. The crowd along the walls was very quiet. They knew this part. They were waiting for the real fight to start.

Then Fenton made his move.

It was a very good move. I will give him that. He made three bindings at once. One reaching for my candle's flame, trying to link it to the stone floor. One reaching for my candle's wax, trying to link it to a bucket of water by the door. And one reaching for me.

Not for my candle. For me.

I felt it settle on me like a cold hand on the back of my neck. A binding between me and the lock of my hair in the candle's wax. And through that, between me and the stone floor. He was trying to link *me* to the cold. To draw the heat out of my body and into the stone, so that I would be too cold to concentrate.

It was a clever trick. It was also, strictly speaking, against the rules. You were not supposed to bind your opponent directly, only his candle. But the rules of sympathy duels were never very strictly enforced.

I felt the cold begin to seep into me. I felt my fingers go numb. I felt my concentration start to waver.

And I thought about stone.

\* \* \*

I had been listening to stone for three spans. Sitting with Elodin's pebble in the round room at the top of the Rookery, in my room under the eaves, in the Underthing with Auri. I had not heard it. Not yet. But I had learned something, in all that listening.

I had learned what it felt like to be patient.



Fenton was pulling the heat out of me, into the stone floor. And the stone was taking it. Cold, patient, uncaring. It did not want my heat. It did not want anything. It simply took what was given, because that was what stone did.

I stopped fighting.

I let the cold come. I let it seep into my fingers and my arms and my chest. I did not break Fenton's binding. I did not try to hold my heat. I simply let it go, the way you let go of a rope when you know you cannot win a tug of war.

And as I let go, I let my mind go still. The way I had learned in the round room. Not reaching. Not wanting. Just being there, with the stone, while the cold came in.

And I felt it.

Not the stone's voice. Not its name. I was still too far from that. But I felt its patience. The long slow endless patience of something that has been itself since before the world had a name. I felt it the way you feel the warmth of the sun on your face with your eyes closed.

And in that patience, there was room. Room for me to be cold, and not care. Room for my fingers to go numb, and my breath to go white, and my concentration to slip—and not fall.

I sat at the table in the old dueling room with my body growing colder and colder, and I was as still as a stone.

\* \* \*

Fenton frowned.

I saw it. I saw him feel it, across the table. His binding was working. The heat was flowing out of me, into the floor. By all rights I should have been shivering, fumbling, losing my grip on my own candle's defenses.

But I was not. I was sitting very still, with my hands folded on the table and my eyes half closed, and my candle was burning straight and steady and yellow.

He pushed harder. I felt the cold deepen. My breath came out in a plume of white. Someone in the crowd along the wall gasped.

I did not move.

And then, very slowly, I reached across the table.

Not with a binding. With the patience. With the stillness. I reached across the table toward Fenton's candle the way stone reaches toward the sea: not quickly, not forcefully, but inevitably. I did not try to snuff it. I did not try to steal its heat. I simply laid a single thin binding between its flame and the cold stone of the floor, the same binding he had been trying to lay on mine.

And I let it sit there.

Fenton felt it. He broke it at once, with a quick hard twist of his mind.

I laid it again.

He broke it again.

I laid it again.

\* \* \*

We went on like that for a long time. Longer than any sympathy duel I had ever seen. I would lay the binding, and he would break it, and I would lay it again. Over and over. Patiently. Without hurry. Without force.

It was not a clever strategy. It was not a strategy at all. It was stone. It was the sea wearing away the cliff, one wave at a time. It was the root cracking the rock, one hair's breadth a year.

And Fenton was not stone.

He was tired. I could feel it. He was holding his binding on me, drawing my heat into the floor, and he was defending his own candle against my endless patient binding, and he was doing both at once, and it was costing him. His face was pale. There was sweat on his forehead, despite the cold. His hands were clenched on the table.

And I was cold, and still, and patient, and I did not care.

"Give up," he said. His voice was strained. "You're freezing. I can see your breath. You can't hold on much longer."

I did not answer. I laid the binding again.

He broke it. His hands were shaking.

I laid it again.

*"Give up!"*

I laid it again.

And this time, he did not break it.

He tried. I felt him try. I felt his mind twist, reaching for the binding, trying to tear it loose. But he was too tired. His concentration was too frayed. He had been holding two bindings for too long, fighting too hard, and he had nothing left.

The binding held.

And his candle, very slowly, went out.

\* \* \*

The old dueling room was silent.

Then it exploded. Shouts and cheers and groans and curses. Money changing hands. Students pounding on the walls. Sim leaping up and down, shouting something I could not hear. Wil sitting very still on his bench with his eyes closed and an expression of profound relief on his dark face.

I did not move. I sat at the table with my hands folded and my candle burning, and I let Fenton's binding go, and I let the heat come back into me. Slowly. The way the sun comes up in winter.

Across the table, Fenton was staring at me. His face was grey. His hands were shaking.

"How?" he said. His voice was barely a whisper under the noise of the crowd. "How did you do that?"

I thought about it.

"I stopped fighting," I said.

He stared at me. Then he laughed, a short broken sound, and put his face in his hands.

\* \* \*

Fela found me afterward, outside the Mains, in the cold dark courtyard. I was sitting on the steps with my cloak wrapped around me, still shivering a little, while students streamed past me and slapped me on the back and shouted congratulations.

She sat down beside me. She did not say anything for a while.

"You heard it," she said at last. "Didn't you? The stone. In there."

"No."

"You did. I felt it. When you went still." She looked at me with her dark serious eyes. "You didn't hear the name. But you heard something."

I thought about it. About the patience. The long slow endless patience, and the room it had made in me.

"I heard it being patient," I said.

Fela looked at me for a long moment. Then she smiled. It was a small smile, and a real one.

"That's the first step," she said. "That's how it starts. You hear it being patient." She stood up. "The name comes later."

"How much later?"

She looked down at me. Her smile widened, very slightly.

"Be patient," she said.

And she walked away across the dark courtyard, laughing softly, and left me sitting on the steps of the Mains in the cold.

## Chapter Twelve

# The Missing Pages

It was Wil who first put the idea of the knife into words.

We were sitting in the Tomes, the great reading room of the Archives, late on a Cendling evening. The room was nearly empty. A few scattered students bent over their books at the long tables, and the red light of the sympathy lamps pooled around them like small warm islands in a dark sea. Wil was working his shift at the desk, but it was a slow night, and he had come over to my table to see what I was doing.

What I was doing was staring at a book with a hole in it.

Not a literal hole. The book was intact. Its binding was whole, its spine uncracked. But when I turned to the chapter I wanted, a chapter titled "On the Seven and Their Works," I found that the chapter was three pages long. The first page began with a paragraph of introduction. The third page ended with a list of sources. And in between, where the meat of the chapter should have been, there was only one page, and that page was about the tax policies of the Aturan provinces.

"That's strange," Wil said, looking over my shoulder.

"It's more than strange." I turned the page back and forth. "Look at the numbering. Page two hundred and eleven. Then two hundred and twelve. Then two hundred and thirteen. They're consecutive. Nothing's missing. But the text doesn't connect. It goes from the introduction of one chapter straight into the middle of another one, and then back again."

Wil leaned closer. He studied the pages for a long time with his dark eyes narrowed.

"Rebound," he said at last.

"What?"

"The book's been rebound." He pointed to the gutter, the narrow space between the pages where they met the spine. "See the stitching? It's different in this section. Newer thread. Someone took the book apart, removed some pages, replaced them with pages from another book, renumbered them, and sewed it back together." He straightened. "It's very good work. I've never seen better."

"Who would do that?"

Wil shrugged. "A scriv, maybe. Sometimes when a book is damaged, the scrivs will repair it with pages from a duplicate. But they're supposed to note it in the catalog." He frowned. "And they don't usually renumber."

I sat back in my chair. I felt cold.

"Wil," I said. "How many books have you seen like this?"

"Like what?"

"Books where the pages don't connect. Where it feels like something's missing."

He thought about it. "A few," he said slowly. "Not many. You notice it, sometimes, if you're reading closely. But most people don't read closely. They skim. They look for what they need and move on."

"Do you remember which books?"

He looked at me for a long moment. "Why?"

I told him. I told him about the years I had spent searching for information on the Chandrian and the Amyr, and how every trail seemed to lead to a dead end. I told him about the books with chapters that were too short, and the histories that skipped over entire decades, and the indexes that referred to pages that did not seem to exist. I had always thought it was simple bad luck, or bad scholarship, or the ordinary loss and decay that comes to any collection of old books.

But now I was not so sure.

"You think someone's been cutting out pages about the Chandrian," Wil said. His voice was carefully neutral.

"I think someone's been cutting out pages about something."

He was quiet for a long time. Then he said, "That would take a very long time. Years. Decades. There are millions of books in the Archives."

"I know."

"And they'd have to know exactly which pages to take. They'd have to read everything. Every book, every scroll, every scrap of paper."

"I know."

"And they'd have to do it without anyone noticing." He shook his head. "It's impossible."

"Is it?"

He did not answer.

\* \* \*

I went to see Lorren the next morning.

His office was on the top floor of the Archives, a long narrow room lined with books from floor to ceiling. He was sitting at his desk, writing in a ledger, when I knocked. He looked up at me with his calm, expressionless face, and for a long moment he did not say anything.

"Re'lar Kvothe," he said at last. "What can I do for you?"

"I have a question, Master Lorren. About the books in the Archives."

"Ask."

"Has anyone ever been caught removing pages from books?"

He set down his pen. It was a small gesture, but from Lorren it was the equivalent of a shout.

"Why do you ask?"

I told him. I told him about the book with the rebound section, and about the other books I had found over the years with gaps in them. I did not tell him what the gaps were about. I had learned, long ago, that Lorren did not like to hear about the Chandrian.

He listened in silence. When I was done, he was quiet for a long time.

"Show me," he said at last.

I showed him. I took him down to the Tomes and pulled the book from the shelf and opened it to the rebound section. He looked at it for a long time. He ran his long fingers over the stitching. He held the pages up to the light.

Then he closed the book and put it back on the shelf and turned to me.

"Thank you, Re'lar," he said. "I will look into this."

"Master Lorren—"

"I will look into this," he repeated. His voice was very calm. It was always very calm. But there was something beneath it now, something hard and cold, like the edge of a knife under a silk cloth. "You may go."

I went.

But as I left the Tomes, I looked back, and I saw him standing there beside the shelf, his hand resting on the spine of the book, his head bowed as if in prayer. He stood like that for a long time. And I remember thinking, as I walked away, that he did not look like a man who had just learned something new. He looked like a man who had just been reminded of something old.

\* \* \*

It was three days before I saw Lorren again. And when I did, it was not in the Archives. It was on the steps of the Mains, early in the morning, where I had stopped to buy a hot bun from a vendor before class.

He came down the steps toward me and stopped. He looked at me for a long moment with his calm, colorless eyes.

"Re'lar Kvothe," he said. "Walk with me."

I walked with him. We crossed the courtyard in silence and went out through the gates and along the road toward the river. It was a cold, bright morning. The trees along the road had lost most of their leaves, and the ones that remained were brown and brittle and rattled in the wind.



"The book you showed me," Lorren said at last. "I have examined it. You were correct. It has been rebound. Twenty-six pages were removed and replaced with pages from another volume."

"Do you know who did it?"

"No." He walked on in silence for a while. "I have examined other books. Books on similar subjects. I have found eleven more with similar alterations. The work is very old. Some of it is very, very old. Older than my tenure as Master Archivist. Older than my predecessor's." He paused. "Some of it is older than the University itself."

I stopped walking. Lorren stopped too, and turned to face me.

"That's impossible," I said. "The Archives are part of the University."

"The Archives," Lorren said, "are older than the University. The University was built around the Archives. Not the other way around." He looked at me. "Did you not know?"

"I'd heard. But I thought it was just a story."

"Most true things are, eventually." He began walking again, and I hurried to catch up. "The core of the Archives, the oldest part, was here before anyone came to this place. Before the bridge, before the town. There are records, very old records, that speak of a great stone building standing alone on the bank of the river. Nobody knew who had built it or why. The first scholars who came here found it empty. They filled it with books."

"Who built it?"

"I do not know." He was silent for a moment. "There are those who say it was built by the Amyr."

I stopped walking again.

This time Lorren did not stop. He walked on, his hands clasped behind his back, his long black robe fluttering in the wind. After a moment I ran to catch up.

"Master Lorren—"

"I know what you are going to ask," he said. "And I am going to tell you something. Once. I will not repeat it, and if you ever tell

anyone that I said it, I will deny it, and I will bar you from the Archives for the rest of your life. Do you understand?"

"I understand."

He walked on for a while in silence. Then he said, "When I was a young man, younger than you are now, I was a student here. And like many students, I was curious about the Amyr. I read everything I could find about them. And I found, as you have found, that there was very little to read."

"The pages were missing."

"Some of them. Others were never written at all." He glanced at me. "The Amyr did not like to be written about. They were an order of great secrecy, even at the height of their power. Their records were kept in a cipher that has never been broken. Their members were known to one another by names that were not their own. And when the Church disbanded them, they did not go quietly into the night. They went somewhere."

"Where?"

"Nobody knows. But there were rumors, when I was a boy, that some of them had come here. That they had taken refuge in the Archives, in the old stone rooms beneath the Stacks. That they had hidden themselves among the books, the way a leaf hides among other leaves." He stopped walking and turned to face me. "I searched for them. For years. I read every book in the Archives that might have held a clue. I explored every room I could get into. I became Master Archivist, in part, because I thought it would give me the access I needed to find them."

"Did you?"

He looked at me for a long time. His face was as calm as ever, but his eyes were very tired.

"No," he said. "I found the Four-plate door. And I found that I could not open it. And I found, eventually, that I did not want to." He turned away, looking out at the river. "There are some questions, Re'lar Kvothe, that are better left unanswered. There are some doors that are better left closed. I learned that lesson a long time ago. I hope,

for your sake, that you learn it too."

He began to walk back toward the University. Then he stopped and looked back at me.

"The pages were cut by someone who knew exactly what they were looking for," he said. "Someone patient. Someone who has been doing this for a very long time. Longer than any man could live." He paused. "If you go looking for them, they will know. And they will come looking for you."

He walked away. I stood alone on the road beside the river, watching him go.

The wind rattled the dead leaves on the trees. The river rushed past, cold and brown and swift.

*Longer than any man could live*, he had said.

I thought about the Chandrian. About Cinder, with his black eyes and his cold smile, who had not aged a day in all the stories I had ever heard about him. About Haliar, who could not die. About the seven who had been walking the world since before the fall of the Aturan Empire, since before there was an Aturan Empire.

If anyone could spend centuries in the Archives, cutting pages from books, it was them.

But the Chandrian could not have done it. Not alone. They could not have walked into the Archives without anyone noticing. Their signs would have given them away. The blue flame, the rot, the rust, the cold. Someone would have seen.

Which meant that someone else had done it for them.

Someone human. Someone patient. Someone who had been walking among us, perhaps for a very long time, cutting away the truth one page at a time.

\* \* \*

I went back to the Archives that afternoon and spent the rest of the day in the Stacks, searching.

I did not find the Amyr. I did not find the Chandrian. But in a dusty corner of the lower Stacks, in a section devoted to the genealogies of minor Vintish nobility, I found a thin book bound in

faded blue leather. Its title was stamped on the spine in flaking gold letters: *The Lines of Loeclos, with Some Account of Their Holdings and Obligations.*

I almost did not take it down. I was looking for something else. But the name caught my eye, and I remembered a rhyme that children in Vintas sang, a rhyme about a lady and seven things she kept. I remembered the Maer's new wife, Meluan, and her family, and the strange box she had shown me, the box with no lid and no lock that had seemed to hum under my fingers.

I took the book down. I opened it.

It was a genealogy. Names and dates, marriages and deaths, stretching back hundreds of years. The family had been called Loeclos, once. Then Lockless. Then Lackless. The names changed, but the line ran on unbroken, from mother to daughter, father to son, like a thread through the long cloth of history.

And beside some of the names, written in a tiny cramped hand in the margins, there was a mark. A small symbol, like a knot. I did not recognize it. But I had seen something like it before. I had seen it in the heart of Kilvin's candle, woven into the wax.

I turned the pages slowly, my heart pounding.

And near the end of the book, on a page that was otherwise blank, I found a single line of writing in that same cramped hand. It was in a script I did not know. But beneath it, someone had written a translation, in faded brown ink that might once have been blood:

*The door holds while the line holds. The line holds while the name is kept.*

I read it three times. Then I closed the book, and sat for a long time with my hands flat on its cover, feeling the cool leather beneath my palms.

I did not know what it meant. Not yet.

But I noticed something else, as I sat there. Something that made my skin prickle and the hair stand up on the back of my neck.

In the genealogy, there was a gap. Near the end, in the last few generations. A page had been removed. Carefully, cleanly, with a very

sharp knife. The edge of it was still visible, a thin strip of paper along the spine.

The page before the gap listed the children of a lord named Lackless who had died some twenty years before. Two daughters. The younger was named Meluan.

The elder had no name at all. Where her name should have been, there was only a small black mark, as if someone had pressed the tip of a pen against the page and held it there until the ink soaked through.

I stared at that black mark for a long time. And as I stared, a memory rose up in me, unbidden, the way a fish rises in a still pond.

I was very young. We were camped somewhere in the hills, and I had learned a rhyme from a boy in a village we had played in. A rude rhyme, about Lady Lackless and the things she kept under her dress. I was proud of it. I sang it at the fire that night, loud and bright, the way children sing the things they know they should not.

My mother had not laughed. My mother, who laughed at everything. She had gone very still, and very pale, and she had taken me by the arm and walked me away from the fire and told me, in a voice I had never heard her use before or since, that it was not a kind song, and that I was never to sing it again. And then, strangest of all, she had held me tight, much too tight, and I had felt her shaking.

I had not understood. I had been a child. Children do not understand their parents; they only remember them.

But I remembered other things now, sitting there in the dusty light of the Stacks. The way she never spoke of her family. The way she would change the subject, smoothly and completely, whenever anyone asked where she had come from. The way my father had written a song for her once, a song about a woman who had left a great house and a great name behind her for love, and how she had asked him never to play it anywhere but around our own fire. The way she held a fork, and a teacup, and herself, as if she had been taught to do so by someone who expected her to one day sit at the tables of lords.

An elder daughter, whose name had been blotted from the book. A girl who had run away.

My mother's name had been Laurian. That was what my father called her. That was what she called herself.

But I knew, sitting there with the blue book open in my hands and the black mark staring up at me like an eye, that it had not always been her name.

Her name had been Netalia. Netalia Lackless. She had run away from her family to marry a trouper, one of the Edema Ruh. She had changed her name, and given up her house, and gone out onto the roads with a red-haired man who made songs. She had sung with him, about the Chandrian, songs they had pieced together from old men in taverns and from old books in forgotten libraries.

And one night, beneath a sky full of stars, she had died for it.  
She was my mother. And her sister was married to the Maer.

## Chapter Thirteen

### Denna

I did not sleep that night. I sat on my bed with the blue book in my lap and read it again and again, until the candle burned low and the words swam before my eyes. I read the names of my grandfather and my grandmother, and their parents, and their parents before them. I traced the line of my blood back through the centuries, from Lackless to Lockless to Loeclos, until it disappeared into a darkness so old that the names were written in a script I could not read.

I had always thought of myself as Edema Ruh. That was my family, the only family I had ever known. My father's people, the troupers and the tinkers and the traveling players, who belonged to no land and no lord and carried their homes on their backs. I had been proud of that. I still was.

But now I knew that I was something else, too. I was the grandson of a lord. I was the nephew of the Maer's wife. I was the last of an old line that stretched back further than any history I had ever read.

And I was, perhaps, the reason my parents had died.

I did not know that yet. Not for certain. But the thought had lodged itself in my mind like a splinter, and I could not work it free. *The door holds while the line holds. The line holds while the name is kept.*

What door? What line? What name?

I did not know. But I knew that the Chandrian had come for my parents because of the songs they sang. And I knew, now, that my

mother had come from a family that guarded something. Something old. Something that someone had tried very hard to hide.

What if it had not been the songs at all? Or not only the songs?

What if they had come for her?

\* \* \*

I did not tell anyone what I had found. Not Sim, not Wil, not Devi. I did not know how. It was too large, too strange, too close to the bone. I carried it with me the way you carry a stone in your shoe, feeling it with every step, unable to set it down.

I went to class. I went to the Fishery and worked on Kilvin's candle, trying to understand the strange knotted binding at its heart. I went to the Archives and searched for more books on the Lackless family, and found nothing. I went to the Eolian and played, and the crowd applauded, and I smiled and bowed and felt nothing at all.

And then, on a cold grey afternoon a span after I had found the blue book, I came around the corner of the Eolian and nearly walked into Denna.

\* \* \*

She was standing outside the door with her back to me, talking to Deoch. She wore a dress of deep green and a cloak the color of autumn leaves, and her dark hair was braided in an intricate pattern that wound around her head like a crown. She was laughing at something Deoch had said, her head thrown back, and the sound of it went through me like a knife.

I stopped. I could not help it. My feet simply stopped moving, and I stood there in the middle of the street like a fool, staring at her.

Deoch saw me first. His eyes flicked over her shoulder and met mine, and something passed across his face. Sympathy, maybe. Or amusement. With Deoch, it was hard to tell.

"Well," he said. "Look who's here."

Denna turned.

I have tried, many times, to describe what it was like to see Denna. I have never succeeded. I have written songs about it. I have



written poems. I have lain awake at night searching for the words. And I have never found them.

The best I can say is this: when Denna looked at you, you felt seen. Not the way Elodin saw you, digging into the depths of you to find what was hidden there. Denna saw you the way the sun sees the earth. She shone on you, and you grew.

She looked at me now. Her eyes went wide. Her lips parted. And for a moment, just a moment, I saw something in her face that made my heart turn over in my chest. It was joy. Pure and simple and bright, like a child's.

Then it was gone, smoothed away behind the careful, practiced smile she wore for strangers.

"Kvothe," she said.

"Denna."

We stood there looking at each other. Deoch looked from one of us to the other. Then he cleared his throat.

"I'll just," he said, and gestured vaguely at the door. "Inside. Things to do." And he went.

Denna and I stood alone in the street.

"You're back," she said.

"I'm back."

"When?"

"A little over a month ago."

"A month." She tilted her head. "And you didn't send word?"

"I didn't know where to send it."

She laughed, a small soft sound. "No," she said. "I suppose you didn't." She looked at me for a long moment. "You look different."

"So I've been told."

"You've got a scar." She reached out and touched my cheek, very lightly, with the tips of her fingers. Her fingers were cold. "Who did that?"

"A teacher."

"A teacher cut your face?"

"She was a very dedicated teacher."

Denna laughed again, and this time it was a real laugh, bright and surprised. "Of course she was," she said. "Only you would find a teacher like that." She let her hand drop. "Walk with me?"

"Where?"

"Anywhere." She smiled. "It doesn't matter. I just want to walk."

\* \* \*

We walked. We went down to the river and along the bank, past the docks and the warehouses and the little shacks where the fishermen mended their nets. The wind was cold and the sky was grey and it smelled like rain, but I did not care. I would have walked through a blizzard beside her. I would have walked through fire.

She asked me where I had been, and I told her. Not everything, but more than I had told Sim and Wil. I told her about the Maer, and his court, and his marriage. I did not tell her that I had written the love letters that won him his bride. I told her about the Adem, and she listened with bright eyes, asking questions about their women and their customs and their strange silent language of hands. I told her about Felurian, a little, and she laughed at me and said she did not believe a word of it, and I did not try to convince her.

And then, because I could not stop myself, I asked her where she had been.

She was quiet for a while. We had come to the end of the docks, where the bank rose up into a low grassy bluff overlooking the river. She sat down on the grass and wrapped her arms around her knees and looked out at the water.

"Here and there," she said at last. "The usual places."

"With your patron?"

She glanced at me. There was something wary in her eyes. "Sometimes."

"Is he still—" I hesitated. "Are you still working on the song?"

"Yes." She looked back at the river. "It's nearly done. I've been working on it for so long. Longer than I've ever worked on anything." She smiled faintly. "He says it's the most important thing I'll ever write."

"Your patron says that."

"Yes."

I sat down beside her on the grass. The wind blew her hair across her face, and she pushed it back with one hand. And as she did, the sleeve of her dress fell back from her wrist, and I saw the bruise.

It was fading. Yellow-green at the edges, the color of old grass. But it had been a bad one. I could see the marks where fingers had gripped her, four on one side and one on the other, dark against her pale skin.

She saw me looking. She pulled her sleeve down quickly.

"It's nothing," she said.

"Denna."

"It's nothing, Kvothe. I fell."

"You fell onto someone's hand?"

She turned to look at me, and her eyes were hard. "I said it's nothing. Leave it."

I wanted to leave it. I wanted to, more than anything. I wanted to let the moment pass and go back to sitting on the grass beside her, watching the river, pretending that the world was a simple place where nothing bad ever happened to anyone. But I could not. Because I remembered a voice from a tree in the Fae, a voice like honey poured over broken glass, telling me things I had not wanted to hear.

*When he beats her, it's not out of anger. He does it because he knows she will come back. He enjoys that.*

"Who is he?" I said. My voice was very quiet. "Your patron. What's his name?"

"You know I can't tell you that."

"Why not?"

"Because I promised." She looked away. "Because he'd know. He always knows. And he'd leave, and I'd have nothing." Her voice cracked slightly. "I've had nothing before, Kvothe. I've been nothing. I won't go back to that."

"You wouldn't have nothing. You'd have—"

I stopped. I had been about to say *me*. But I knew how that would sound. I knew what she would say. I had nothing to offer her. A room at an inn. A few talents in my purse. A patron of my own who would forget me the moment I stopped being useful. It was more than I had ever had before. But it was not enough. It was not nearly enough.

"You'd have your music," I said instead. "You'd have your voice. You don't need him for that."

She laughed, bitterly. "Don't I? Who do you think pays for my dresses? My rooms? My lessons? Who do you think opens the doors for me, so I can sing in the halls of lords instead of the back rooms of taverns?" She shook her head. "You don't understand. You've never had to understand. You've got your pipes and your talent and your University. You've got people who look at you and see something worth investing in." She looked down at her hands. "When people look at me, they see a pretty girl. That's all. And pretty girls are a copper a dozen."

"That's not true."

"It is true. You just don't want to see it." She stood up abruptly, brushing the grass from her skirt. "I should go."

"Denna—"

"I should go." She did not look at me. "I'm sorry. I'm glad you're back. I really am. But I have to go."

She walked away along the bluff. I watched her go, and I did not follow her. I wanted to. Every part of me wanted to run after her and take her hand and tell her that I would find him, her patron, whoever he was, and I would make him pay for every bruise he had ever left on her skin.

But I did not. Because I knew that if I did, she would never forgive me. And because I knew, deep down, that she was right. I did not understand. Not really. Not yet.

\* \* \*

I sat on the bluff for a long time after she had gone. The rain came, finally, soft and cold, and I let it soak me through.

I thought about the Cthaeh. I had tried very hard, in the months since I had left the Fae, not to think about it. About its voice, its words, the terrible gleeful certainty with which it had told me things. I had told myself that it was a liar. That it had wanted to hurt me. That nothing it said could be trusted.

But I had seen the bruise. And I could not stop thinking about it.

I thought about the song, too. Denna's song. The one her patron had commissioned. I had heard part of it once, months ago, before I left for Vintas. It was a song about Lanre. But not the Lanre I knew, the Lanre of Skarpi's story, the hero who fell and became a monster. In Denna's song, Lanre was a hero still. A man wronged. A man betrayed by those he had loved and served, who had turned against them only because they had turned against him first.

I had been angry when I heard it. I had told her it was wrong, that the story was not like that, that Lanre was a traitor and a murderer. She had been angry too. She had said I did not know. She had said nobody knew. She had said that history was written by the winners, and that perhaps the losers had a story too.

We had not spoken for a long time after that.

I thought about it now, sitting in the rain. About why anyone would want to tell that story. About why a rich and secretive patron would pay a young singer to spend years of her life writing a song that made a monster into a hero.

I did not know the answer. But I knew, the way you sometimes know things, that it mattered. That it mattered more than almost anything.

\* \* \*

When I finally went back to Anker's, soaked and shivering, there was a letter waiting for me.

It was folded small and sealed with a drop of plain wax. My name was written on the outside in a hand I knew. I opened it with cold, clumsy fingers.

*I'm sorry, it said. I didn't mean to be cruel. I'm staying at the Grey Man in Imre until the end of the span. If you want to find me, you know*

*where I'll be. If you don't, I understand.*

*D.*

And beneath that, drawn very small in the corner of the page, there was a mark. A tiny knot, looped and twisted in a pattern that made my eyes ache to look at. I had seen it before. I had seen it in the margins of the blue book, beside the names of my mother's family. I had seen it in the heart of Kilvin's candle.

I sat on my bed with the letter in my hands and stared at that knot for a long, long time.

I did not know what it meant. But I knew, now, that I would have to find out.

## Interlude: Knots

Kvothe stopped speaking, and the Waystone Inn came back into itself.

Chronicler blinked. For a moment he had forgotten where he was. He had been sitting on a grassy bluff above a cold river in the rain, his clothes soaked through, a girl's footprints fading in the wet grass beside him. Now he was sitting at a scarred table in an empty common room, and the fire was crackling in the hearth, and there was ink drying on his fingers.

He flexed his hand. It ached. He looked down at the page in front of him and saw that he had filled it to the very bottom with his tiny, crabbed cipher, and had begun, without noticing, to write sideways along the margin.

"You didn't know," he said. "About your mother. Before that."

"I suspected." The innkeeper was looking at the fire. "I had pieces. I had a rhyme she scolded me for singing, and a way she held her cup, and the look on the Maer's wife's face when she spoke of her lost sister. I had all the pieces, lying there in front of me. I simply hadn't put them together." He smiled faintly. "It's a strange thing. You can be very clever about everything in the world except yourself."

Bast came out of the kitchen with a fresh pot of tea. He set it on the table and did not leave. Instead he pulled out the third chair, the one that had been sitting upside down on the tabletop, and set it on its feet and sat in it backward, his arms folded across its back.

"The knot," he said. "On her letter."

The innkeeper glanced at him. "Yes."

"You never told me about the knot."

"There are a great many things I've never told you, Bast."

"But that one." Bast's voice was strange. Tight. "Reshi, that's—you know what that is. You must have known, even then. That's not a lover's mark. That's not something a girl draws at the bottom of a letter because she thinks it looks pretty."

"I didn't know. Not then." The innkeeper poured himself a cup of tea. His hands were steady. "I thought it was Yllish. A story knot. You've seen them. The Yllish used to tie stories into their hair, into cords, into the fringes of their clothes. A knot for a birth, a knot for a death, a knot for a promise kept or broken. Denna wore them in her braids. I'd noticed that long before. I thought it was a fashion."

"It's not a fashion," Bast said.

"No," the innkeeper agreed. "It's not."

Chronicler looked from one of them to the other. "What is it, then?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment. He turned his cup a quarter turn on the table, the way he had that morning.

"Do you know how writing began?" he asked at last.

Chronicler hesitated. "I've read some theories. Most scholars agree that it began with merchants. Tallies. Records of trade. A mark for a sheep, a mark for a bushel of grain. Over time the marks became more complicated, and—"

"That's how *our* writing began," said the innkeeper. "Tema. Aturan. Siaru. The writing you use every day. It's a way of keeping track of things. It's a way of remembering." He lifted his cup and did not drink from it. "But there's an older kind of writing. It doesn't remember things. It *makes* them."

Chronicler felt a small chill go down his spine. He did not say anything.

"The Yllish knew it," the innkeeper went on. "Or some of them did, once, a long time ago. Before they forgot. A true knot, tied in the true way, doesn't record a story. It binds it. It fixes it in place, the way a nail fixes a board. Tie a man's death in a cord, the old way, and he'll stay dead. Tie a promise, and it will be kept, whether the one who



made it wants to keep it or not." He set down his cup. "Tie a name—"

He stopped.

The fire popped. A log shifted in the grate, sending up a shower of sparks. Bast was very still in his backward chair, and his eyes were fixed on the innkeeper's face.

"Tie a name," said Chronicler quietly, "and what?"

The innkeeper looked at him. His green eyes were very dark.

"We'll get to that," he said. "It's later in the story."

Chronicler wanted to press. Every instinct he had, every habit of a lifetime spent pulling stories out of reluctant mouths, told him to press. But there was something in the innkeeper's face that stopped him. It was not anger, and it was not fear. It was something older and quieter than either. It was the look of a man standing at the edge of a very deep hole, looking down.

"All right," Chronicler said. He dipped his pen. "Later."

"Later," the innkeeper agreed.

Bast made a small sound, low in his throat. The innkeeper glanced at him.

"You don't like it," he said.

"I don't like any of it." Bast's voice was low and fierce. "I don't like that she drew it. I don't like that she drew it *to you*. I don't like that you're telling it now, like this, out loud, with him writing it down." He jerked his chin at Chronicler. "Some things shouldn't be said, Reshi. Some things shouldn't be written."

"And some things," the innkeeper said mildly, "have to be."

They looked at each other for a long moment. Something passed between them that Chronicler did not understand. Then Bast looked away. He stood up, abruptly, his chair scraping on the floor, and went to the window and stood looking out with his back to them and his arms folded tight across his chest.

The innkeeper watched him for a while. Then he sighed and turned back to Chronicler.

"He's worried about me," he said. "He's always worried about me. It's a very tiring habit. I've tried to break him of it, but he's stubborn."

"I can hear you," said Bast, without turning around.

"I know. That's why I said it." The innkeeper smiled faintly. "Where was I?"

"The Grey Man," said Chronicler. "In Imre. She said she'd be there until the end of the span."

"Yes." The innkeeper nodded slowly. "Yes. I went, of course. How could I not? I went the very next day." He paused, looking down into his cup. "And that was the beginning of it. The real beginning. Everything I'd done up to then—the Maer, the Adem, even Felurian—that was all just prologue. That was the stage being set. The real story started the day I walked into the Grey Man and asked her to teach me how to read her knots."

"Did she?"

The innkeeper looked up. For a moment, just a moment, his face changed. The bruises were still there, and the swollen eye, and the careful weariness of a man who has been waiting a long time. But something else showed through underneath, bright and sharp and hungry, like a blade catching the light.

"She did," said Kvothe. "God help us both. She did."

\* \* \*

Outside, a cart rattled by on the road. Someone laughed. The noon bell rang faintly from the little church at the far end of the town, a thin cracked sound that the people of Newarre had long since stopped hearing.

At the window, Bast stood very still. He was watching the tree line at the edge of the fields, beyond the last of the houses. The smoke Chronicler had seen that morning was still there, a thin grey thread against the pale sky. It still leaned. Bast watched it for a long time, and his lips moved silently, as if he were counting.

Then he turned from the window and went back to the table and sat down in his backward chair, and when the innkeeper began to speak again, he listened without interrupting.

But his hands, folded on the back of the chair, were clenched so tight that the knuckles had gone white.

## Chapter Fourteen

# A Story Tied

The Grey Man was an inn on the western edge of Imre, a tall narrow building of grey stone with a slate roof and a sign that showed a man in a grey cloak with his face in shadow. It was not a cheap inn, but it was not one of the grand ones either. It was the kind of place where respectable merchants stayed when they came to Imre on business, the kind of place where the sheets were clean and the food was plain and nobody asked questions.

Denna was sitting in the common room when I came in, at a table near the window with a pot of tea in front of her and a book in her lap. She looked up as the door opened, and when she saw me, she smiled.

It was a real smile. Not the careful one she wore for strangers. It went all the way up to her eyes.

"You came," she said.

"You knew I would."

"I hoped you would." She closed the book and set it aside. "That's not the same thing."

I sat down across from her. She poured me a cup of tea without asking. We sat in silence for a while, sipping our tea and looking out the window at the grey street. It was not an uncomfortable silence. It was the kind of silence that only happens between people who know each other very well, or who want to.

"I'm sorry," she said at last. "About yesterday."

"You don't have to be."

"I do. I was cruel. You were only trying to help." She looked down into her cup. "I'm not used to people trying to help me. I don't know what to do with it."

"You could let them."

She laughed softly. "Maybe. Someday."

We were quiet again for a while. Then I took her letter out of my pocket and unfolded it and laid it on the table between us.

"This," I said, and touched the knot in the corner. "What is it?"

She looked at the knot for a long moment. Then she looked at me. There was something careful in her face, something guarded.

"Why do you ask?"

"Because I've seen it before. Or something like it." I hesitated. "In a book. And in something else."

"What book?"

"An old one. In the Archives."

She was quiet for a long time. Then she reached up and touched her hair, the intricate braid that wound around her head like a crown. Her fingers found something there and held it.

"It's Yllish," she said. "A story knot."

"I know that much. But what does it mean?"

She hesitated. Then she reached into her hair and drew out a thin cord, dark brown, about as long as her forearm. It had been woven into her braid so cleverly that I had never noticed it. She laid it on the table beside the letter.

The cord was knotted. Dozens of knots, maybe hundreds, running along its length. Some were small and simple. Some were large and complex, looping and twisting around each other in patterns that made my eyes ache to follow. It looked, at first glance, like a child's toy. A bit of string that someone had fiddled with to pass the time.

But the longer I looked at it, the more it seemed to mean something. The way a page of writing in a foreign script can seem to mean something, even when you cannot read a word of it.

"Everyone thinks the Yllish knots are just decoration," Denna said quietly. "Pretty things, like embroidery. But they're not. They're a

language. A very old one. Older than Tema, older than Aturan. Some people say it's the oldest writing in the world."

"Can you read it?"

"Some of it." She touched one of the knots with the tip of her finger. "This one means *beginning*. Or *birth*. Or *spring*. It depends on what's around it. This one means *road*. This one means *a promise*. This one—" she touched a large, complex knot near the center, "—this one means something like *a story that is told many times and changes in the telling*. There isn't a word for it in Aturan."

I stared at the cord. "Who taught you this?"

She looked up at me. For a long moment she did not answer.

"My patron," she said at last.

I felt something cold settle in my chest. "Why?"

"Because it's part of the song." She wrapped her arms around herself, the way she did when she was uncomfortable. "The song isn't just a song, Kvothe. It's—" She struggled for the words. "It's a history. A true history. Or it's meant to be. My patron says that the old stories were written down wrong. That the people who wrote them had their own reasons for telling them the way they did. And that if you want to know what really happened, you have to go back to the oldest sources. The ones that were written before anyone had a reason to lie."

"And those sources are written in knots."

"Some of them." She nodded. "He has a collection. Cords and ropes and tapestries, very old, from all over the world. Some of them are so old they crumble if you touch them. He's been teaching me to read them. So I can write the song properly. So I can tell the truth."

"The truth about Lanre."

She looked at me sharply. "Yes."

I took a deep breath. I did not want to fight with her again. I did not want to lose her again. But I could not let it go.

"Denna," I said carefully. "I've heard the story of Lanre. The one the old storytellers tell. And in that story, Lanre was a traitor. He betrayed his friends. He destroyed the city of Myr Tariniel. He killed thousands of people."

"I know that story."

"Then why—"

"Because it's not the whole story." Her voice was calm, but there was steel beneath it. "It's the story the winners told. It's the story Selitos told, after he cursed Lanre. After he blinded himself with a stone, so he'd never have to look at what he'd done." She leaned forward. "Did you know that part? That Selitos blinded himself?"

"Yes."

"Why would he do that? Why would a man put out his own eye, if he were only punishing a traitor?" Her eyes were very bright. "Maybe because he knew he was wrong. Maybe because he couldn't bear to look at the truth."

I opened my mouth to argue. Then I closed it again.

I did not know the answer. I had never thought about it. In Skarpi's story, Selitos had put out his own eye as a kind of oath. A sacrifice. A way of binding himself to his purpose, so that he would never be deceived again. That was how I had always understood it.

But I had never asked why. I had never questioned it.

"I don't know," I said at last.

Denna sat back. She looked, for a moment, almost disappointed. As if she had wanted me to argue. As if she had wanted me to have an answer.

"Neither do I," she said quietly. "That's why I'm writing the song."

\* \* \*

We talked for hours. I asked her about the knots, and she told me what she could. She showed me the simple ones, the ones that stood for common words and ideas, and she showed me how they combined to make more complex meanings. She showed me how the direction of a loop could change a word from past to future, and how a double twist could make it a question instead of a statement. She showed me how some knots could only be read in relation to the knots around them, the way a single note of music means nothing until you hear the notes that come before and after.

I was fascinated. I had always loved languages, and this was a language unlike any I had ever encountered. It was not written in lines on a page, flat and still. It was written in three dimensions, in loops and twists and tensions. It had a *shape*. When you held a knotted cord in your hands, you could feel its meaning, the way you could feel the shape of a word in your mouth.

And there was something else. Something I could not quite put my finger on. As Denna showed me the knots, as I held the cord in my hands and turned it this way and that, I felt the same strange prickling I had felt when I looked into the heart of Kilvin's candle. The same sense of something almost there. Something just out of reach.

"Denna," I said. "When you tie these knots. When you write in them. Does it feel like anything?"

She looked at me for a long moment. "What do you mean?"

"I mean, when you tie a knot that means *road*, does it feel like—" I did not know how to say it. "Does it feel like more than just a knot? Does it feel like you're making something?"

Something flickered across her face. It was there and gone so fast I almost missed it. But I saw it. It was fear.

"Sometimes," she said very quietly. "Sometimes it does."

"What does it feel like?"

She looked down at the cord in my hands. "It feels," she said slowly, "like the knot is holding on to something. Like it's reaching out and catching hold of something and not letting go." She shivered. "My patron says that's how you know you've tied it right. When it holds."

"Holds what?"

She shook her head. "I don't know. He won't tell me. He says I'm not ready yet."

I looked at the cord. At the hundreds of knots running along its length, each one holding on to something, each one reaching out and not letting go.

"Denna," I said. "This song. When it's finished. What will it do?"

She looked at me. Her eyes were very dark.

"It will tell the truth," she said. "That's all. It will tell the truth about Lanre, and everyone who hears it will know what really happened." She paused. "My patron says that's the most important thing in the world. The truth. He says that a lie told long enough becomes a kind of prison. That the old story of Lanre is a prison. And that my song will set him free."

"Set who free?"

She did not answer. She reached out and took the cord from my hands and began to weave it back into her hair, her fingers moving quickly and surely.

"I should go," she said. "It's getting late."

"Denna—"

"I'll be here until the end of the span." She stood up. "Come back tomorrow. I'll teach you more, if you want."

"I want."

She smiled at me. It was the careful smile again, the one for strangers. But there was something beneath it, something sad and tired and very, very young.

"I know," she said. "That's what worries me."

\* \* \*

I went back the next day, and the day after that, and every day until the end of the span. Denna taught me the knots, and I learned them faster than she expected. I have always learned quickly, and this was a language that seemed to want to be learned. By the end of the span, I could read simple cords on my own, and I could tie a few simple words.

But I never tied a knot that held. I tried. I tried every day, tying and retying, feeling for that strange sense of something reaching out and catching hold. It never came. My knots were only knots. Loops of string, twisted and tied. They meant things, but they did not *do* anything.

Denna's did. I could feel it. When she tied a knot, something changed. The air around her hands seemed to tighten, the way the air tightens before a storm. And when she was done, the knot was not just



a knot. It was a thing that held.

I asked her once how she did it. She looked at me for a long moment and then shook her head.

"I don't know," she said. "It just happens. Sometimes it holds and sometimes it doesn't. I can't make it happen. I can only let it."

It sounded like something Elodin would say. It sounded like the way I had called the wind.

It sounded like naming.

\* \* \*

On the last day of the span, Denna left.

She did not say goodbye. She never said goodbye. I came to the Grey Man in the morning and her table by the window was empty, and the innkeeper told me she had paid her bill and gone before dawn. She had left a note for me. It was folded small and sealed with plain wax.

Inside, there were no words. Only a single knot, tied in a short length of dark cord and pressed flat between the folds of the paper.

I held it up to the light. It was a complex knot, looped and twisted in a pattern I had never seen before. I turned it this way and that, trying to read it. It took me a long time. It was not a word I knew, but I could make out pieces of it. A knot for *road*. A knot for *promise*. And at the heart of it, holding it all together, a knot I had only seen once before, in the center of the cord she wore in her hair.

*A story that is told many times and changes in the telling.*

I did not know what it meant. I still do not know, not entirely.

But when I held it in my hand, I felt it. Just for a moment. The faint tightening of the air. The sense of something reaching out and catching hold.

It held.

I have it still. I have carried it with me every day since. Through everything that happened after, through fire and blood and darkness, through the loss of everything I had and everything I was, I have kept that little knot of cord.

It is the only thing she ever gave me that she did not later take back.

## Chapter Fifteen

### A Sonnet for Fela

"It's terrible," said Wil.

"It's not terrible," said Sim.

"It's the worst thing I have ever read. And I have read Master Hemme's treatise on the rhetorical uses of silence, which is four hundred pages long and contains no silences whatsoever."

"It's a sonnet," said Sim, with great dignity. "It's supposed to be difficult."

"It's supposed to be *good*."

We were sitting at our usual table in the corner of Anker's, late on a Theden evening, with three mugs of cider and a plate of Anker's terrible fried bread between us. Sim had a sheet of paper in his hand. He had been holding it for most of an hour. He had read it to us three times, each time with more feeling than the last, and each time Wil's face had grown a little more pained.

I had not said anything yet. I was trying very hard not to.

"Kvothe," said Sim. He turned to me. His thin eager face was flushed. "You're a musician. You understand meter. Tell him it's good."

I looked at the paper. At Sim's cramped untidy handwriting, and the lines that had been crossed out and rewritten and crossed out again, and the small blot of ink at the bottom where he had apparently wept.

"It's heartfelt," I said carefully.

Wil laughed so hard he choked on his cider.

\* \* \*

It was about Fela. Of course it was about Fela. Sim had been in love with Fela for as long as I had known him, and possibly longer, the way the moon is in love with the sea, which is to say helplessly and with a great deal of pulling this way and that. They had been walking out together since before I left for Vintas, and I had been glad for them both.

But while I was away, they had quarreled. Sim would not tell me about what, except that it had been very stupid, and entirely his fault, and had involved a remark about Elodin's class that he had meant as a joke and she had not taken as one. She had not spoken to him in two months. She passed him in the Archives without looking at him. She had moved to the other side of the round room at the top of the Rookery.

And now, he said, he was going to win her back. With a sonnet.

"She loves poetry," he said. "She told me so. Last term, in the Archives. She said there's nothing more romantic than a man who can tell you how he feels in fourteen lines."

"She may have been joking," said Wil.

"She wasn't joking. Fela doesn't joke."

"Everyone jokes."

"Fela doesn't. She's very serious. That's one of the things I love about her." Sim looked at the paper in his hand. His face fell. "Is it really that bad?"

Wil opened his mouth. I kicked him under the table.

"Read it again," I said. "Slowly. And this time, let me listen."

\* \* \*

He read it again.

I will not reproduce it here. Sim would never forgive me. But I will tell you that it compared Fela's eyes to the dark water of a mountain lake, and her hair to the night sky, and her voice to the sound of a river running over stones. I will tell you that it rhymed *heart* with *apart* and *eyes* with *skies* and, in one memorable couplet, *Fela* with *a stellar*. I will tell you that the meter lurched and stumbled like a drunk

man on a frozen road.

And I will tell you that by the end of it, I had stopped wanting to laugh.

Because under the terrible rhymes and the lurching meter, there was something true. Something that shone through the bad writing the way a candle shines through a dirty window. It was clumsy and awkward and ridiculous, but it was Sim, all the way through. It was the way he looked at her when she wasn't looking. The way he went quiet when she came into a room. The way he had once walked all the way across the river in the rain to bring her a book she had mentioned wanting, and left it on her doorstep without a note, and never told her it was from him.

"Well?" said Sim, when he was done. He looked at me anxiously.

I thought about it.

"The rhymes are bad," I said. "And the meter needs work. And you should never, under any circumstances, rhyme *Fela* with a *stellar*."

Sim's face fell.

"But," I said, "the thing underneath it is good. The thing you're trying to say. That's good." I held out my hand. "Give it to me. Let's fix the parts that aren't."

\* \* \*

We worked on it until closing. And then Anker threw us out, and we went up to my room under the eaves and worked on it until the candle guttered. Wil came with us, grumbling, and sat on my bed and made acid remarks, some of which were actually helpful.

It was hard work. Harder than I expected. It is one thing to write a song; you have the melody to carry you, and the rhythm, and the listener's ear forgiving a great deal for the sake of the tune. A sonnet has nothing but itself. Every word has to earn its place.

And it was Sim's sonnet. That was the difficult part. I could have rewritten it from top to bottom in an hour, and it would have been better, and it would not have been his. Fela would have known. She would have read it and seen my hand in it, and it would have been

worse than the bad version, because it would have been a lie.

So I did not rewrite it. I sat beside Sim at my narrow table and asked him questions. *What do you mean here? What does it feel like when she does that? What's the thing you'd say to her if you weren't afraid?* And he answered, haltingly at first and then faster, and I helped him find the words that were already in him, under the bad rhymes, waiting to be dug out.

The mountain lake stayed. Sim insisted, and he was right; Fela did have eyes like dark water, and it was the first thing anyone noticed about her. The night sky went. The river over stones stayed, but changed: Sim said her voice was not like a river but like the stones themselves, patient and quiet and very old, and I told him to write that down, and he did.

*A stellar* went. I made him promise.

\* \* \*

By the time the candle guttered out, we had fourteen lines that were almost good. Not perfect. Sim would never be a great poet; his gift was for feeling, not for form. But they were honest, and clean, and they scanned, and every word in them was his.

He read it aloud one last time, in the dark, with the moon coming through my window.

When he finished, nobody said anything for a long moment.

"Well," said Wil at last, from my bed. His voice was rough. "That's not terrible."

Sim turned to him. "Really?"

"Really." Wil cleared his throat. "It's still not *good*. But it's not terrible." He paused. "If a man wrote that for me, I'd think about it."

Sim stared at him. Then he laughed, a startled, delighted laugh, and folded the paper very carefully and put it inside his shirt.

"Tomorrow," he said. "I'll give it to her tomorrow. In the Archives. After her shift."

\* \* \*

He did not give it to her tomorrow. Or the next day. Or the next. He carried it around inside his shirt for nine days, and every day he came back from the Archives with his face pale and his hand pressed against his chest where the paper was, and every day he said *tomorrow*.

On the tenth day, Wil lost patience.

"Give it to me," he said.

"What?"

"The sonnet. Give it to me. I'll give it to her."

Sim went white. "You wouldn't."

"I would." Wil held out his hand. "I work the desk in the Archives. She comes past it every afternoon. I'll give it to her, and I'll say it's from you, and then it'll be done, and you can stop walking around like a man with a stomach ache."

"No!" Sim clutched his chest. "No, no, no. You can't. What if she laughs? What if she hates it? What if she—"

"What if she doesn't?" said Wil.

Sim stopped.

"You've been in love with her for three years," said Wil. His voice was very calm. "Three years, Simmon. You've brought her books and left them on her doorstep. You've walked her home in the rain. And then you said one stupid thing, and instead of saying you were sorry, you've spent two months writing poetry about it." He looked at Sim with his dark patient eyes. "What if she's been waiting for you to say something? What if she's been waiting all this time for you to just come and say it?"

Sim stared at him. His face was very pale.

"She hasn't," he said. "She can't be. She's Fela. She's—she's beautiful and brilliant and she knows the name of stone. And I said that stupid thing, and I'm—" He stopped. "I'm me."

"Yes," said Wil. "You are." He held out his hand again. "Give it to me."

\* \* \*

Sim did not give it to Wil.

He gave it to Fela himself. That same afternoon. In the Archives. He walked up to her while she was shelving books in the Stacks, with his face white and his hands shaking, and he took the paper out of his shirt and held it out to her without a word.

I know, because Wil told me. He had followed at a discreet distance, to make sure Sim did not lose his nerve and run.

"She read it," said Wil. We were at Anker's that evening, the two of us. Sim was not with us. "Right there. Standing in the Stacks, with an armful of books. She read it twice. And then she looked up at him."

"And?"

Wil was quiet for a moment. His dark face was very still. But there was something in his eyes. Something warm.

"She said, *What took you so long?*" he said.

I stared at him. Then I began to laugh.

Wil did not laugh. Wil almost never laughed. But the corner of his mouth twitched, and kept twitching, and he picked up his mug of cider and drank from it to hide it.

"They're walking along the river," he said. "Right now. Holding hands." He set down his mug. "It's disgusting."

"It's wonderful."

"It's both." Wil looked at me. "Most wonderful things are."

\* \* \*

I have thought about that sonnet many times since. About Sim, sitting at my narrow table in the dark, digging the true words out from under the bad ones. About Fela, standing in the Stacks with her arms full of books, reading it twice.

*What took you so long?*

I have thought about it because of what came after. Because of the Eolian, and the fire, and a girl kneeling in the dark with her hands pressed against the stone, holding up a building for three hours while it burned above her. Because of a young man with one eye and a black patch with a white star on it, weeping openly at the foot of a bridge. Because of a poem, very bad, that does not scan, lying folded in the bottom of a chest of roah wood in a room at the top of the stairs of an

inn.

I have thought about it because it was the last easy thing. The last simple thing. A boy and a girl and an apology in fourteen lines and a walk along the river.

Everything after that was harder.

But they had that. Sim and Fela. They had the walk along the river, and the holding hands, and *what took you so long*. And no matter what came after—no matter the fire, or the war, or the door—no one could ever take that away from them.

I am glad I helped. It is one of the few things I did in those years that I have never regretted.



## Chapter Sixteen

# The Wrong Sort of Songs

Count Threpe found me at the Eolian three nights after Denna left. I was sitting alone at a table near the back, nursing a mug of cider and not playing, which was unusual enough that Stanchion had come by twice to ask if I was ill.

"Kvothe!" Threpe dropped into the chair across from me with the delighted, slightly breathless air he brought to everything. He was a small man, round and bright-eyed, dressed in a coat of such a violent shade of blue that it seemed to hum. He was the only true patron of the arts I had ever known: a man who gave money to musicians because he loved music, and asked for nothing in return but the chance to listen. "My dear boy. I heard you were back and I simply didn't believe it. You've been gone an age. Tell me everything. No, don't. Play me something first, and then tell me everything."

"I'm not playing tonight, Threpe."

He blinked at me. "Not playing? Are you ill?"

"Stanchion asked the same thing."

"Stanchion is a very perceptive man, for someone who spends his life pouring beer." Threpe leaned forward and peered at me. "You look terrible. Is it a girl?"

I laughed despite myself. "Isn't it always?"

"Almost always. The rest of the time it's money, and you look too well-dressed for it to be money." He waved to a serving girl and ordered a bottle of wine, then turned back to me. "Is it the girl? The dark one? Dianne?"

"Denna."

"Denna, yes. She's calling herself that again, is she? I can never keep track." He sighed. "Lovely voice. Lovely girl. Terrible taste in patrons, if the rumors are true."

I went very still. "What rumors?"

Threpe looked at me. He was a kind man, but he was not a stupid one. He had spent his whole life among the nobility of Imre, and he knew how to read a face as well as any courtier.

"Ah," he said. "So it's that kind of trouble." He was quiet while the serving girl brought the wine and poured two glasses. When she had gone, he lifted his glass and looked at it rather than at me. "I don't know much. Nobody does. That's rather the point of him, I think. But I've heard things." He took a sip. "He pays very well, whoever he is. He's been paying for her lessons for years now. Singing, harp, languages. Old languages, mostly. Very old ones. She came to me once, a year or two ago, and asked if I knew anyone who could teach her to read Old Yllish. I didn't, of course. Nobody does. It's a dead tongue. But she seemed to think it was very important."

"Did she say why?"

"Something about a song she was writing. A very long song, about the old days. The Creation War and all that." He shrugged. "I thought it was charming. Most young singers are content to write about love and sheep. She wanted to write an epic." He smiled fondly. "Ambitious girl."

"Have you heard any of it?"

"Bits. Here and there. She played a few verses for me once, at a party at the Cuttlebones'." He frowned slightly. "It was very good. Very powerful. But—" He hesitated.

"But what?"

"But it made me uncomfortable." He set down his glass. "I don't know how to explain it. The music was lovely, and her voice was lovelier. But there was something in the words. Something that got under the skin. I remember I went home that night and couldn't sleep. I kept thinking about it. About Lanre. About how perhaps he'd been

treated unfairly by history." He laughed awkwardly. "It's absurd, of course. He's just a character in a story. But for a few days afterward I found myself feeling rather sorry for him."

I looked down into my cider. "It's a good song, then."

"It's a very good song." Threpe peered at me again. "Why? Are you jealous?"

"No," I said. And then, because Threpe deserved honesty: "Yes. A little. But that's not it."

"Then what is it?"

I did not answer right away. I was thinking about my parents. About the song my father had been writing, the song about Lanre, the one he had worked on for years and never finished. I had heard pieces of it as a child, sitting by the fire in the evenings while he played and my mother sang. I had not understood most of it. But I remembered how it had felt. It had not made Lanre a hero. It had not made him a villain either, not exactly. It had made him a man. A man who had done a terrible thing, for reasons that seemed good to him at the time, and who had become something worse than a man because of it.

My father had spent years gathering the pieces of that story. He had talked to old men in taverns and old women in villages. He had read old books in forgotten libraries. He had been trying to find the truth.

And then the Chandrian had come, and he was dead, and his song was dead with him.

"Threpe," I said. "If someone were writing a song about Lanre. A true one. The oldest version of the story, the one that nobody tells anymore. Do you think people would want to hear it?"

Threpe looked at me with sudden, sharp interest. "Are you writing one?"

"I'm thinking about it."

"A rival song. To hers." His eyes lit up. "Oh, that's delicious. That's absolutely delicious. The two best young singers in Imre, dueling over the soul of a legend." He clapped his hands. "Of course people would want to hear it. They'd flock to it. They'd fight over

seats." He leaned forward eagerly. "When can I hear it?"

"It's not written yet."

"Then write it! Write it quickly!" He poured more wine into my cup, sloshing some onto the table. "I'll fund it. Whatever you need. Paper, ink, lessons, research. Name it."

I looked at him. He meant it. He always meant it; that was the wonderful thing about Threpe. He was a man who believed in music the way a priest believes in God.

"I'll need to do some research," I said slowly. "Old sources. Very old. The kind that aren't in the Archives."

"Done. I know a man in Anilin with a private library you wouldn't believe. And a woman in Renere who collects old ballads. And—" He paused. "Well. I know a great many people. We'll find what you need." He lifted his glass. "To the true story of Lanre. May it be sung from every rooftop."

I lifted my glass and touched it to his. But I did not drink.

Because as he said it, a cold shiver had gone down my spine. I remembered a man with black eyes, standing over the bodies of my family. I remembered his voice, soft and reasonable and utterly without mercy.

*Someone's parents have been singing entirely the wrong sort of songs.*

\* \* \*

I went home that night and did not sleep. I sat at my table with a candle and a sheaf of paper and my lute across my knees, and I tried to remember.

It was hard. I had been so young. And I had spent so many years trying not to remember, trying to bury those memories so deep that they could not hurt me anymore. When I had lived on the streets of Tarbean, I had locked them away in a place in my mind that I called the doors of sleep, and I had not opened those doors for a very long time.

But I opened them now. Slowly, carefully, the way you might open a door onto a room where something terrible had happened. I let

the memories come.

I remembered my father at the fire, his lute in his lap, his fingers moving on the strings. I remembered his voice, low and rich, singing words I did not understand. I remembered my mother beside him, her head on his shoulder, singing the harmony.

I remembered pieces of the song. A line here, a verse there. A melody that rose and fell like the wind in the trees.

*In the city of Tariniel, where the white towers rise...*

*Lanre, who loved her more than light, more than breath...*

*And Selitos saw, and his eye was a stone...*

I wrote them down. Every scrap I could remember. I wrote until my hand ached and the candle guttered and the sky outside my window began to go grey with dawn.

When I was done, I had three pages of fragments. Lines and half-lines, bits of melody scrawled in my own private notation, notes to myself in the margins. It was not a song. It was not even the beginning of a song. It was the ruin of a song, the broken pieces of something that had once been whole.

But it was a start.

I looked down at the pages in the grey light. At my father's words, rescued from the dark. At my mother's harmonies, scribbled in the margins.

And I made a promise to myself. I would finish it. I would find the rest of the story, the true story, and I would write the song my father had never been able to finish. I would sing it at the Eolian, in front of everyone. I would sing it so loudly that the whole world would hear.

I was seventeen years old. I did not know what I was promising. I did not know that some songs are more dangerous than swords.

Or rather, I did know. I had known since I was eleven years old, standing among the bodies of everyone I had ever loved. I simply did not care.

\* \* \*

That morning, on my way to the Fishery, I stopped by my room and lit Kilvin's candle.

I had fallen into the habit of lighting it every morning and every night, the way some people say a prayer. I would strike a match, hold it to the wick, and watch the flame catch and steady. And every morning and every night, it burned yellow.

It burned yellow that morning too. A warm, cheerful, ordinary yellow.

I watched it for a long moment. Then I leaned forward to snuff it. And just before my fingers touched the wick, I saw it flicker.

Not blue. Not the pale moon-silver I had seen once before. It flickered darker, for the barest instant, as if a shadow had passed across it. As if something, somewhere, had turned its head to look at me.

I snuffed the candle. I sat very still for a long moment, listening to my own heart beat.

Then I picked up my three pages of fragments and folded them carefully and put them in the inside pocket of my cloak, next to my heart, and went to the Fishery.

I told myself it was nothing. A draft. A trick of the light.

I have always been a very good liar, when the person I am lying to is myself.

## Chapter Seventeen

# The Countess's Library

Threpe kept his word. He always did. It was one of the things that made him so rare among the nobility of Imre, who generally regarded their word as a kind of loose currency, to be spent freely and redeemed never.

Six days after our conversation at the Eolian, a note came to Anker's, written in Threpe's large looping hand on paper so thick it was nearly card. *My dear boy*, it said. *Tomorrow at noon. Wear something without holes in it. We are calling on the Countess Laverne.*

I did not know who the Countess Laverne was. I asked Sim, who knew everyone in Imre worth knowing, mostly because his father was a duke and he had grown up having to be polite to them.

"Laverne?" He looked up from his book with an expression of horror. "Oh, Kvothe. Oh, no."

"What?"

"She's a hundred years old. She's deaf in one ear and mad in the other. She has seventeen cats and she dresses them in little velvet coats." He shuddered. "My mother made me go to tea with her once when I was nine. She pinched my cheek so hard it bruised."

"Threpe says she has a library."

"Oh, she has a library." Sim closed his book. "Everyone knows about the Laverne library. Her husband collected books. Old ones. He spent his whole fortune on them, and then he died, and she's kept them ever since, and she won't let anyone see them." He looked at me. "Nobody gets into that library, Kvothe. Nobody. Masters from the

University have been trying for forty years."

"Threpe's getting me in."

Sim stared at me. Then he shook his head slowly.

"Of course he is," he said. "Of course he is."

\* \* \*

The Countess Laverne lived in a tall narrow house on the richest street in Imre, a street of tall narrow houses built of pale stone with tall narrow windows and tiny gardens behind wrought-iron fences. Hers was the tallest and narrowest of them all, and the oldest, and the most in need of paint. Ivy grew over most of its front. Several of the windows were shuttered. A cat sat on the doorstep, wearing a small velvet coat of deep burgundy, and watched us come up the walk with an expression of profound contempt.

Threpe was wearing a coat of such a brilliant shade of green that it seemed to buzz. He knocked on the door with his cane.

"Now," he said, while we waited. "The Countess is a very dear old friend. Very dear. But she's a little—eccentric. You mustn't be alarmed by anything she says. Or does. Or by the cats."

"Sim said she pinches cheeks."

"Only children's." Threpe patted my arm. "You'll be fine. Just be charming. You're very good at being charming, when you want to be."

The door opened. A very old manservant looked out at us, bent nearly double, with a face like a walnut. He looked at Threpe. He looked at me. He looked at Threpe again.

"Count Threpe," he said, in a voice like a creaking hinge. "Her ladyship is expecting you." He looked at me again. "Both of you."

\* \* \*

The Countess Laverne received us in a sitting room on the second floor, a room so crowded with furniture and ornaments and cats that it was difficult to see where one ended and the next began. There were cats on the chairs and cats on the tables and cats on the mantelpiece and cats on the windowsills. There were cats in baskets and cats in boxes and one very large grey cat asleep in a copper pot on the hearth.



Every one of them was wearing a small velvet coat.

The Countess was sitting in a chair by the window. She was very small and very old, much older than Lady Tamsin in Renere, whom I would not meet for another year. Her face was a mass of wrinkles. Her hair was white and thin and piled on top of her head in an elaborate arrangement held in place by what appeared to be several hundred pins. She wore a dress of black silk that had been in fashion sixty years before.

And she had a cat in her lap. A small white one, in a coat of blue velvet.

"Threpe," she said. Her voice was surprisingly strong. "You're late."

"I'm exactly on time, my lady."

"That's late, for you. You're always early." She peered at me with bright black eyes. "Who's this?"

"This is Kvothe, my lady. The musician I told you about."

"The Ruh." The Countess looked at me for a long time. "The one who plays at the Eolian. Who won his pipes at fifteen."

"Yes, my lady."

"Come here."

I went. I stood in front of her chair. She looked up at me with her bright black eyes, and then she reached up and took hold of my chin with her small bony fingers and turned my face this way and that, the way you might inspect a horse.

"Hm," she said. "Hm. Yes." She let go. "You look like your mother."

\* \* \*

I went very still.

"My lady?"

"Your mother. The Ruh singer. Laurian." The Countess stroked the white cat in her lap. "She played here once. In this house. Twenty years ago. Maybe more. My husband was still alive. He heard her sing in the market and he brought her home, the whole troupe of them, and they played in the great hall downstairs for a span." She smiled. It

made her face crack into a thousand new wrinkles. "She had the loveliest voice. And the loveliest manners. My husband said she held a teacup like a duchess."

I did not say anything. I could not.

"She was interested in the books," said the Countess. "Very interested. My husband let her into the library. He let her read there, every afternoon, while the others rehearsed. He said she was the only person who had ever asked him the right questions about them." She looked at me. "Threpe tells me you're interested in the books too."

"Yes, my lady."

"About Lanre."

"Yes."

The Countess looked at me for a long time with her bright black eyes.

"That's what she was interested in too," she said softly. "Lanre. And the white city. And a family called Lackless." She stroked the white cat. "My husband thought it was very odd. A Ruh singer, wanting to read about an old Vintish family." She smiled faintly. "But then, he thought everything was odd. That's why I married him."

\* \* \*

The library was on the top floor of the house, under the roof.

It was not a large room. I had expected something grand, a vast hall of shelves like the Tomes in the Archives. But it was a small room, long and narrow, with a sloping ceiling and a single round window at the far end. The walls were lined with shelves from floor to ceiling. The shelves were full of books.

And they were old. I could smell it the moment the walnut-faced manservant opened the door. That smell of old books, dust and leather and ink and time. Some of them were bound in leather, cracked and faded. Some of them were bound in wood. Some of them were not bound at all, only stacks of loose pages tied with string. There were scrolls in pigeonholes and cords with knots in them hanging from pegs.

"Forty years my husband collected," said the Countess. She had come up the stairs with us, very slowly, leaning on the manservant's arm and Threpe's. She stood in the doorway now, looking at the shelves. "Forty years. Every penny we had. I used to be so angry with him." She was quiet for a moment. "And now they're all I have left of him. So I keep them. And I don't let anyone touch them."

She looked at me.

"But you may," she said. "For your mother's sake. She was the only one of all of them who ever really read them."

\* \* \*

I spent the whole of that afternoon in the Countess Laverne's library, and every afternoon for a span after.

It was an extraordinary collection. The Count had not been a scholar; he had been a collector, which is a different thing. He had bought whatever he could find, whatever was old and rare and strange, without much regard for whether it was important. So the shelves were full of the most bewildering mixture. Books of hours and books of spells. Herbals and bestiaries. Histories of kingdoms that no longer existed, written by men whose names no one remembered. Collections of old songs, and old recipes, and old riddles.

And some of it was about Lanre.

Not much. A few volumes. A few scrolls. A cord of Yllish knots, very old and very faded, that I could barely read. But it was more than I had found in the Archives. And it had not been cut.

That was the thing I noticed first. None of it had been cut. The chapters were whole. The pages were numbered in order. Nothing was missing.

Whoever had been going through the Archives with a knife had never been in the Countess Laverne's library.

\* \* \*

I found the ballad on the fourth day.

It was in a small book bound in green leather, very worn, stuffed at the back of a shelf behind a row of herbals. It had no title. Inside, it

was a collection of songs, written out by hand in a script so old and so faded that I could barely read it. Some of them I knew. Most of them I did not.

And one of them was about Lyra.

Not about Lanre. About Lyra. His wife. The one who had called him back from death at Drossen Tor with her voice speaking his name.

It was a short song. Only a few verses. It told of Lyra standing on the battlefield among the dead, with her husband's body in her arms, and calling his name. Not shouting it. Singing it. The song said that she sang his name as if it were the most beautiful word in the world, and that death itself could not bear to hear it sung so, and let him go.

And then there was a verse I had never heard in any version of the story.

It told of Lyra, later. After. Standing in a garden in a white city, with her husband beside her. Asking him if he remembered what it had been like. Being dead.

And Lanre said: *I remember nothing. Only a great quiet, and your voice at the end of it.*

And Lyra said: *Then I will always sing to you. So that if you ever go back to that quiet, you will hear me, and come home.*

\* \* \*

I sat in the Countess Laverne's library with the green book in my lap and read that verse over and over until the light through the round window began to fail.

I did not know why it moved me so much. It was only a song. A few lines, in an old book, by someone whose name was long forgotten.

But I thought about my mother, sitting in this same room twenty years ago, reading these same books. Asking the Count the right questions. I thought about the song my father had been writing, the one about Lanre, the one he never finished. I thought about my mother's voice, singing harmony beside him by the fire.

I wondered if she had read this verse. I wondered if she had put it into my father's song.

I wondered if that was why they came.

\* \* \*

On the last afternoon, the Countess came up to the library herself. She came very slowly, on the manservant's arm, with a cat in a purple velvet coat trailing behind her. She stood in the doorway and watched me for a while, sitting at the small table under the round window with the green book open in front of me.

"You found something," she said.

"Yes, my lady."

"Show me."

I showed her. She came and sat in the chair across from me and put on a pair of spectacles that hung around her neck on a chain, and she read the verse about Lyra. She read it twice. Then she took off her spectacles and looked at me.

"Your mother found that too," she said.

I stared at her.

"She read it to my husband," said the Countess. "Aloud. In this room. I was sitting just there." She pointed at a chair by the door, now occupied by a fat orange cat in a green coat. "She read it, and then she closed the book, and she sat very still. And my husband asked her what was wrong." The Countess was quiet for a moment. "And she said, *Nothing. It's only that I've heard this before. My father used to sing it to me when I was small. And he told me never to sing it to anyone. Ever.*"

"Why?"

The Countess looked at me with her bright black eyes.

"She didn't say," she said. "She only said her father told her it was dangerous. That it was an old song, from the keeping, and it wasn't meant for other ears." She paused. "My husband asked her what *the keeping* meant. And she laughed and changed the subject. And the next day, the troupe left. Very suddenly. Before dawn. They didn't say goodbye."

\* \* \*

I sat very still.

*From the keeping.* I did not know, then, what it meant. I would not know for months. Not until I stood in a Chamber of Watches beneath the Archives and read a book with a burning tower on its cover.

But I knew it meant something. I knew it the way you know, sometimes, that a key will fit a lock before you have tried it.

"Thank you, my lady," I said.

The Countess looked at me for a long moment. Then she reached across the table and put her small bony hand on mine.

"Be careful, boy," she said. "Your mother was frightened, that last night. I saw it. She was frightened the way people are frightened when they've found something they shouldn't have." She squeezed my hand. "I'd hate for you to find the same thing."

"I'll be careful."

"No, you won't." She smiled, and her face cracked into a thousand wrinkles. "You're her son. You'll be exactly as careful as she was." She let go of my hand. "Keep the book."

I stared at her. "My lady—"

"Keep it. I've no use for it. I can't read that old script anyway." She stood up, slowly, with the manservant's help. "And I think she'd want you to have it."

\* \* \*

I kept it. I have it still. It has traveled with me through everything since, wrapped in oilcloth at the bottom of one pack or another, and it is the only book from those years I never lost.

I put the verse about Lyra into *Tarinie*, when I wrote it. Near the end. After Lanre's grief, before the fall of the white city. It is a very short verse. Only a few lines. Most people who hear the song do not even notice it.

But Haliar noticed. I know he did. I saw the shadow shift when I sang it, in the Eolian, with the candles burning blue.

*Then I will always sing to you. So that if you ever go back to that quiet, you will hear me, and come home.*

I think, sometimes, that it was the cruelest thing I have ever done.  
To sing that verse to him. To remind him of that promise, and that  
voice, and the garden in the white city, ten thousand years gone.

And I think, sometimes, that it was the kindest.

I have never been able to decide.

## Chapter Eighteen

# Ambrose

I saw Ambrose one last time before he left the University for good. I did not know it would be the last time, not then. If I had, I might have done things differently. Or I might not. I have thought about it a great deal, over the years, and I have never been able to decide.

It was a cold morning near the end of the term. The first snow had fallen overnight, a thin white dusting that turned the courtyard into a clean sheet of paper and made the whole University look new and strange. I was crossing toward the Archives with my satchel over my shoulder and my breath steaming in the air, and I was thinking about my father's song, as I did most mornings now. I was not paying attention.

That was my mistake. I have always been at my worst when I am not paying attention.

"Well, well," said a voice. "If it isn't the little Ruh."

I stopped. I turned.

Ambrose was standing on the steps of the Mains, looking down at me. He was dressed for travel, in a long coat of dark grey wool trimmed with fur, and a pair of riding boots polished to a mirror shine. There was a sword at his hip, a real one, with a jeweled hilt and a scabbard of tooled leather. His hair was carefully arranged. His rings glittered in the cold light.

He was not alone. Two of his usual hangers-on stood a few steps below him, looking bored and cold. And behind him, near the door of the Mains, stood a third man, tall and white-haired, leaning on a



walking stick of dark polished wood with a silver head.

I knew him. It took me a moment, because he was so utterly out of place, the way a friend's face is hard to recognize when you meet it in a city where you did not expect it. But I knew him.

It was Bredon.

I had spent long evenings with Bredon in Severen, at the Maer's court, sitting across a tak board from him while the candles burned down. He had taught me the game. He had taught me, or tried to teach me, a great deal more than the game: how to move through a court full of knives without being cut, how to smile at a man you despised, how to lose a small thing gracefully in order to win a large one. He had been kind to me when very few people at that court had been kind. I had liked him. I had liked him a great deal.

And here he was on the steps of the Mains, in the snow, standing behind Ambrose Jakis like a shadow.

He saw me recognize him. His eyebrows rose, and he smiled, and lifted his stick an inch off the ground in a small, courtly greeting, the way he used to at the start of a game.

"Ambrose," I said. I did not look away from Bredon. "I heard you were leaving."

"You heard right." Ambrose came down the steps toward me, slowly, his boots crunching in the snow. "My father has sent for me. There are matters at court that require my attention."

"I'm sure there are."

He stopped a few feet away from me. He was smiling. Ambrose was almost always smiling, but this was a different smile than usual. It was not the sneer he usually wore when he looked at me. It was something smoother, more confident. It was the smile of a man who knows something you do not.

"You've heard the news, I suppose," he said. "About my cousins."

"I heard two of them died."

"Three," Ambrose said. "As of last span. My uncle Lorin caught a chill on a hunting trip and never recovered. Very sad. He was a great favorite of the king's." He did not look sad. "That puts me seventh in

line, now. Seventh." He savored the word. "Do you know how many people in the world can say that, Ruh? Seventh in line for the throne of Vintas?"

"Seven, I'd imagine."

His smile flickered. Then it came back, broader than before. "Very clever. You always were clever. Too clever by half, my father says. He says that's what gets your kind into trouble." He took a step closer. "He says that one day someone's going to teach you a lesson about knowing your place."

"And is that you?"

"Me?" He laughed. "No. Not me. I'm leaving, remember? I have more important things to do than waste my time on a gutter rat with a lute." He leaned in, close enough that I could smell the wine on his breath, and the perfume he wore, something heavy and sweet. "But I'll tell you something, Ruh. As a parting gift. You think you're special. You think because you've got a little talent and a little money and a patron who likes your songs, you're something more than you are. But you're not. You're nothing. You're a thief and a liar and the son of thieves and liars, and one day, very soon, the world is going to remember that."

I looked at him. I did not say anything.

There was a time when those words would have made me angry. When I would have lashed out at him, with my fists or my wits or something worse. I had done it before. I had broken his arm once, in a manner of speaking, and set his rooms on fire, and done a dozen other things that I was not proud of and would do again in a heartbeat.

But I had spent months among the Adem. I had learned, from Vashet and Tempa and Shehyn, what it meant to be still. To let the anger rise and pass, like wind over water. To choose the moment of action rather than let it be chosen for me.

And so I looked at Ambrose, and I let the anger rise, and I let it pass.

"Safe travels, Ambrose," I said.

He stared at me. For a moment, just a moment, I saw something flicker in his eyes. Confusion, maybe. Or disappointment. He had wanted a fight. He had wanted me to lash out, so he could leave the University with one last victory over me, one last story to tell his friends at court.

I had not given it to him.

"You'll regret this," he said. His voice was low and ugly. "When I'm king. You'll regret all of it."

"You're seventh in line, Ambrose. You're not going to be king."

He smiled. And that smile, that one, was the worst of all. Because it was not a boast. It was not a threat. It was a secret.

"We'll see," he said.

He turned and walked away across the courtyard toward the gates, where a carriage was waiting. His hangers-on scurried after him. Bredon followed more slowly, his stick tapping on the frozen stones.

As he passed me, he paused.

"Kvothe," he said warmly. "What a pleasant surprise. I had heard you'd come back to your books."

"Bredon." I did not know what else to say. "You're—traveling with him?"

"With young Jakis? For a little way." He glanced toward the carriage, and his expression was the gently rueful one of an uncle who has been saddled with an unruly nephew. "His father and I are old acquaintances. The Baron asked me to see the boy safely home, and I had business in Renere in any case. An old man takes his company where he finds it." He looked back at me, and his eyes were bright and interested. "You look well. Older. Something has happened to you."

"A great deal has happened to me."

"Good. That is what youth is for." He smiled. "You must come and play with me again, when you are next in Severen. I have missed our games. No one at court has the nerve to lose properly."

"I'd like that."

"I know you would." He looked at me for a moment longer, that mild, patient, measuring look, and something in it made me want to

step back. "You have an interesting face, you know. I noticed it the first time we met. It reminds me of someone I knew long ago."

"Who?"

He only smiled. "Nobody you would know," he said. "Good day to you, young man."

He walked on toward the carriage. I watched him go. He did not look back.

\* \* \*

I stood in the courtyard long after the carriage had rattled away through the gates and down the road toward the bridge. The snow had begun to fall again, soft and silent, settling on my hair and shoulders. Students hurried past me on their way to class, their heads bowed against the cold. None of them looked at me.

I was thinking about Bredon.

I told myself it meant nothing. Bredon knew everyone in Vintas worth knowing, and half of those who were not. It was perfectly natural that he should know Baron Jakis. It was perfectly natural that an old man with business in the capital should share a carriage with a young one. Bredon had always seemed to drift through the world like that, easily, at the edges of things, turning up at the elbows of important people with a joke and a tak board.

And yet I stood in the snow and felt the wrongness of it like a stone in my boot. Because for the first time since I had known him, I had looked at Bredon and seen, instead of my kindly old teacher, a man standing behind Ambrose Jakis. And he had looked entirely at home there.

It would be many months before I saw him again. And when I did, I would remember this moment, standing in the falling snow, watching him walk away. I would remember how he had looked at me, and what he had said.

*It reminds me of someone I knew long ago.*

I would remember, and I would understand. And I would wish, more than I had ever wished for almost anything, that I had followed him to his carriage that morning and asked him, plainly, what he was

doing there.

\* \* \*

That evening I told Sim and Wil about the encounter. We were sitting at Anker's, sharing a bottle of cheap wine and a plate of bread and cheese, and I told them what Ambrose had said, and about Bredon.

"Seventh in line," Sim said, shaking his head. "That's absurd. Three deaths in a year and a half. Nobody's that unlucky."

"Nobody's that *lucky*," Wil said. "From Ambrose's perspective."

"You think it's murder," Sim said.

Wil shrugged. "I think it's Vintas."

"It's not Ambrose," I said. They both looked at me. "Doing it himself, I mean. He doesn't have the patience. Or the skill. Ambrose is a bully. He likes to hurt people he can see. Poisoning a man on the other side of the country and waiting a month for him to die isn't his style."

"His father, then," Sim said.

"Maybe." I thought about Bredon, and his stick, and the patient, measuring way he had looked at me. "Or someone else."

"Who?"

I did not answer. I did not know. But I remembered the smile Ambrose had given me, the secret one, and I felt a chill that had nothing to do with the snow outside.

*We'll see*, he had said.

"There's something else," Wil said slowly. He had been quiet for a while, turning his cup around and around on the table. "I heard something today, at the Archives. From one of the scrivs." He hesitated. "It's probably nothing."

"Tell us anyway."

"The king," Wil said. "Roderic. He's ill."

Sim and I both stared at him.

"How ill?" I asked.

"The scriv didn't know. Just that he took to his bed a span ago, and hasn't been seen at court since. His physicians say it's a winter fever." Wil shrugged. "Could be nothing. Kings get sick like anyone

else."

"Could be," I said.

We sat in silence for a long time after that. The fire crackled in the hearth. Outside, the snow kept falling, soft and white and silent, covering everything.

I thought about the Maer, and his long illness, and the physician who had been slowly poisoning him for gold. I thought about the Vintish court, with its smiling knives and its poisoned cups. I thought about Ambrose, seventh in line, riding away through the snow in his fur-trimmed coat with a secret smile on his face.

And I thought about Bredon, my old tak teacher, with his kind grandfather's eyes, and the way he had looked at me as if I were a piece on a board.

I did not know it then, but the game had already begun. The pieces were already moving.

And I was already losing.

## Chapter Nineteen

# Snow on the Underthing

The snow came the night before Ambrose left the University, without any wind, and by morning the whole of it was white and silent and strange.

I went to see Auri before breakfast. I had not meant to. I had meant to go to the Archives, where I had a stack of scriv ledgers waiting for me and a headache already waiting behind them. But when I came out of my room at Anker's and saw the rooftops, white and soft and unbroken as a sheet of new paper, I found my feet taking me the other way.

She was on the roof of the Mains. Of course she was. She was standing at the very edge of the great slanting slope of lead and slate above the courtyard, barefoot in the snow, with her arms held out from her sides like a child pretending to be a bird. Her hair was a pale cloud around her head, and there were snowflakes caught in it, and she was looking up at the sky with her mouth open.

I climbed up by my usual way, over the apple tree and the gutter and the long low roof of the tanning shed. When I came over the last ridge, she heard me and turned, and her whole face lit.

"Kvothe!" she said. "Look! Look what it did!"

"I see it."

"It came in the night, without asking." She turned in a slow circle, her arms still out. "It didn't knock or anything. It just came down and sat on everything. Very politely. Very quietly." She stopped and looked at me, delighted. "It's the quietest thing there is. Did you know

that? Quieter than moonlight. Quieter than the Underthing."

I looked at her bare feet in the snow. They were pink with cold.

"Auri," I said. "Aren't your feet cold?"

She looked down at them as if she had not noticed they were there.

"Yes," she said, with great seriousness. "Very. It's proper. You shouldn't walk on snow unless your feet know it. Otherwise you're being rude." She wiggled her toes. "I'm introducing myself."

\* \* \*

I sat down on the ridge of the roof. The slates were cold through my trousers. After a moment, Auri came and sat beside me, tucking her feet up under the hem of her dress.

"I brought you something," I said.

It was a pair of socks. Thick grey wool, knitted by the old woman who sold them from a basket on the Stonebridge. I had bought them with the last jot in my purse the week before, thinking of exactly this.

Auri looked at them for a long time. She did not take them.

"They're very nice socks," she said at last.

"They're for you."

"I know." She looked at them sadly. "But they're not *for* me. Do you see? They're for someone who wears socks." She reached out and touched one with a fingertip, very gently, the way you might touch a sleeping bird. "I'm not someone who wears socks. Not yet. Maybe someday. But not now."

I did not know what to say. I held the socks in my lap.

"You could give them to the stones," Auri suggested. "The ones by the chimney. They're always cold. They'd like socks."

So I got up and went to the chimney at the end of the roof, and I tucked the socks into the crack between two of the stones, where the snow had not reached. Auri watched me with grave approval.

"There," she said. "Now they know someone cares about them. That's important. Everything should know someone cares about it."

\* \* \*



We sat for a long time after that. Below us, the University was waking. Students crossed the courtyard in dark cloaks, leaving lines of footprints in the snow. Someone was laughing somewhere. The bells in the Chancellor's tower rang the hour, and the sound was muffled and strange, as if the snow had wrapped it in wool.

"Kvothe," said Auri. "Can I tell you a secret?"

"Always."

She leaned close. Her breath smelled of apples.

"The snow goes all the way down," she whispered.

I looked at her.

"Into the Underthing," she said. "Not the snow itself. The snow stays up here, where it belongs. But the *quiet* goes down. Through the grates, and the cracks, and the old drains. All the way down, into the deepest places." Her eyes were very wide. "Places that are never quiet. Places that are always humming, or ticking, or sighing. When the snow comes, they go quiet too. Just for a little while."

"Which places?"

Auri looked at me for a long moment. Then she looked away.

"The door," she said. "The one that isn't a door. Down past Tumbrel and the Old Throat. It hums, all the time. Very low. You can hardly hear it. But I can." She hugged her knees. "Not when it snows. When it snows, it goes quiet. And I can sleep."

I did not say anything for a moment. My heart was beating hard.

"Auri," I said carefully. "Does the door ever do anything else? Besides humming?"

She did not answer right away. She picked up a handful of snow from the slates beside her, and looked at it, and let it fall between her fingers.

"Sometimes it listens," she said. "That's worse than the humming." She brushed her hands off on her dress. "When it listens, I sing to it. Very softly. Nursery songs. The kind you sing to babies so they'll sleep." She looked at me. "It likes that. It stops listening, and goes back to humming, and I can go away."

"Who taught you to do that?"

"No one." She looked surprised. "It's just proper. When something is listening in the dark and it's frightened, you sing to it. Everyone knows that."

\* \* \*

I did not know that. Not then. I thought about it later, many times. I thought about it on the ridge above a burning camp with a baby in my arms, and I thought about it in a cell in the Tower of Thorns, listening to a man tap on the stones, and I thought about it in an inn at a crossroads, on a night when the wind came looking for me and I told it, very gently, to go away.

*When something is listening in the dark and it's frightened, you sing to it.*

It was the truest thing anyone ever told me about doors. I did not understand it for years.

\* \* \*

"Will you come down?" said Auri. "Into the Underthing? I want to show you."

"Show me what?"

"The snow-quiet." She stood up, brushing snow off her dress. "You have to see it. It only lasts a day, maybe two, and then the humming comes back." She held out her hand. "Please?"

I took her hand. It was very cold and very small. And I followed her down off the roof of the Mains and across the snowy courtyard, where students turned to stare at the barefoot girl and the red-haired boy walking hand in hand, and through a grate beside the Masters' Hall that I had not known opened, and down.

\* \* \*

It was quiet in the Underthing.

I had been there many times by then. I knew the Underthing the way you know a house you visit often: not all of it, but the rooms that matter. I knew Mantle and the Twelve and Billows. I knew the Crumbledown and the Downside and the Grey Tree. I knew that the

Underthing was never silent. There was always water running somewhere, and wind moving through old pipes, and the settling and creaking of stone, and a hundred other small sounds that I had long since stopped hearing.

That day, they were gone.

Not all of them. The water still ran. The wind still moved. But underneath them there had always been something else, something I had not known I was hearing until it stopped. A low, faint, constant hum, so deep it was more a feeling than a sound, like the vibration of a great bell long after it has been struck.

It was gone. And the silence it left behind was enormous.

We walked through Billows with our footsteps echoing, and through the Twelve, and down the long sloping tunnel that Auri called Tenders. She did not speak. Neither did I. It did not seem like a place for speaking.

At the end of Tenders, there was a place where three tunnels came together. Auri stopped there. She pointed down the left-hand tunnel, which sloped steeply into darkness.

"That way," she said, very softly. "Past the Old Throat. That's where the door is." She looked at me. "We won't go all the way. It's not polite, when it's sleeping. But you can listen from here."

I listened.

And there, very faint, very far away, at the very edge of hearing, I heard something. Not a hum. Something else. Something slow and steady and soft, rising and falling, rising and falling.

Breathing.

I felt the hair rise on my arms.

"It's asleep," Auri whispered. "The snow makes it sleep. Isn't it lovely?" She was smiling. "It's like a baby. When it's asleep, it's just a baby. You'd never know it could be anything else."

\* \* \*

We went back up after a while. Auri took me the long way, through the Grey Tree and the Crumbledown, and showed me a place where snow had drifted down through a broken grate and made a little white

hill on the stone floor, pristine and perfect, like something in a story. She would not let me touch it.

"It came all this way," she said. "It should be allowed to rest."

When we came out into the courtyard, the light was already fading. I had missed breakfast and lunch and three shifts in the Archives, and Lorren would be furious, and I did not care at all.

"Thank you," I said. "For showing me."

Auri looked at me very seriously.

"You needed to know," she said. "Everyone who walks in the Underthing should know that it's asleep sometimes. So they can be quiet." She tilted her head. "And so they know it's there. When it's awake."

She turned to go. Then she stopped, and turned back.

"Kvothe," she said. "The socks. Will you check on them? In the spring? To see if the stones liked them?"

"I promise."

She smiled. And then she was gone, back through the grate beside the Masters' Hall, into the dark.

\* \* \*

I did check on the socks, that spring. They were still there, tucked into the crack between the chimney stones, damp and grey and a little moldy.

And the stones on either side of them, I swear, were warm to the touch.

I told Auri. She was not surprised at all.

## Chapter Twenty

# The Cellarage

Winter came down on the University that year like a lid on a pot. The snow that had fallen the morning Ambrose left did not melt. More came after it, and more after that, until the courtyards were white and the eaves were hung with icicles as long as my arm, and the river froze along its edges into shelves of grey ice that groaned and cracked in the night.

I spent most of that winter underground.

Not all of it. I still went to classes, and to the Fishery, and to the Eolian twice a span to play. I still ate with Sim and Wil at Anker's and argued with Fela about stone and read in the Archives until Wil threw me out at closing. But more and more, as the days grew short and the nights grew long and bitter, I found myself going down into the Underthing.

It was warmer there. That was part of it. The deep tunnels held their heat the way a banked fire does, and even on the coldest nights, when the wind howled across the rooftops like a pack of wolves, the air below was still and mild. Auri had made the Underthing her home for years, and I began to understand why. It was quiet. It was private. It was a world unto itself, with its own geography and its own weather and its own strange, patient logic.

And it was full of stone.

I brought Elodin's stone with me whenever I went down. I would sit in one of Auri's rooms, in Mantle or the Twelve or the long echoing hall she called Vaults, and I would take the stone out of my pocket and

set it on the floor in front of me, and I would listen.

I did not hear it. Not yet. But I was learning, slowly, what Fela had meant about waiting. About wanting. About the difference between listening and hunger.

It was not easy. I have always been a hungry person. I have always wanted things, and wanted them now, and gone after them with everything I had. I did not know how to sit still and want nothing. I did not know how to let the world be what it was without reaching out to grab it.

But the Underthing was teaching me. Slowly, patiently, the way stone teaches everything.

\* \* \*

Auri did not seem to mind my presence. If anything, she seemed pleased by it. She would come and sit with me sometimes while I listened, humming softly to herself or arranging small things in patterns on the floor. Pebbles. Bits of glass. Leaves she had gathered in the autumn and kept pressed between the pages of an old book. She never asked what I was doing. She seemed to understand, in her strange way, that it was not a thing that could be explained.

Other times she would take me places. She would appear at my elbow with no warning and take my hand and say, "Come. There's something you should see." And she would lead me through the tunnels, down passages I had never known existed, through doors that seemed to open only for her, to show me a thing she had found.

A room where the water dripping from the ceiling had built up, over centuries, into a great pale column of stone, smooth and gleaming as bone.

A long narrow gallery where the walls were covered in writing, faded almost to nothing, in a script I did not know.

A tiny round chamber, no bigger than a closet, where the acoustics were so perfect that a whisper spoken at one side could be heard as clearly as a shout at the other. Auri stood at one side and I stood at the other, and she whispered my name, and it came to me as clear and sweet as a bell.

"This is Hush," she said, when I had come around to her side. "It's where the Underthing keeps its secrets."

"What secrets?"

She looked at me with her enormous eyes. "If I told you," she said, "they wouldn't be secrets anymore."

\* \* \*

It was in the second month of winter that she first took me to the Cellarage.

I had come down late, after a long night at the Eolian. I was tired and my fingers ached from playing, and I wanted nothing more than to sit somewhere quiet and warm and let the stone be a stone. But when I came down through the grate behind the Mains, Auri was waiting for me at the bottom, and there was something in her face I had never seen before.

It was worry.

"Kvothe," she said. "Come. Quickly."

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing's wrong." She took my hand and began to pull me along the tunnel. "Not yet. But something's awake. And you should see it before it goes back to sleep."

She led me deep. Deeper than I had ever been. Down through the Twelve and along the passage she called Downway, past the place where the tunnels stopped being brick and started being stone. Past the steep narrow slope she had shown me once before, the one she said was too loud. We went down it now, and I felt the stone in my pocket grow heavy, heavier than it had ever been.

At the bottom, there was a door.

It was not a large door. It was old and grey and made of wood so dark with age it was almost black, bound with bands of iron that had rusted to the color of dried blood. It stood half open. Beyond it, there was darkness.

"This is the Cellarage," Auri whispered. "It's very old. Older than anything else down here. It was here before the Underthing was the Underthing."

"What is it?"

She did not answer. She let go of my hand and stepped through the door into the darkness. After a moment, I followed.

\* \* \*

I held up my sympathy lamp and turned it slowly, letting the red light play across the room.

It was a large room, much larger than I had expected. Its ceiling was low and vaulted, supported by thick round pillars of rough grey stone. The floor was stone too, uneven and worn smooth in places, as if by the passage of many feet over many years. The air was cold and dry and smelled of dust and something else, something faint and sweet, like old flowers pressed between the pages of a book.

And the room was full of things.

Chests. Barrels. Crates. Long wooden boxes that looked disturbingly like coffins. Heaps of cloth, rotted almost to nothing. Racks of weapons, rusted and broken. Shelves of pottery, cracked and dusty. Piles of books, so old their bindings had crumbled away, leaving only stacks of loose pages brown and brittle as autumn leaves.

It looked like a storehouse. Or a treasury. Or a tomb.

"What is all this?" I breathed.

"Things people forgot," Auri said. She was standing a little way ahead of me, very still, her pale hair floating around her head like a cloud. "Things they put away and never came back for. Some of them are very sad. Some of them are angry." She turned to look at me. "You mustn't touch anything. They don't like to be touched."

"I won't."

She nodded and turned back. She began to walk slowly between the heaps and piles, and I followed her, holding my lamp high. The red light fell across rusted helmets and cracked shields, across moldering tapestries and heaps of tarnished coins. I saw a harp with no strings. A child's wooden horse, its paint long since faded. A crown of blackened silver set with dull stones, lying on its side in the dust as if someone had dropped it and walked away.

And then, at the far end of the room, I saw the bed.



It was a great bed, carved of black stone. It stood on a low dais at the center of the far wall, surrounded by a ring of pillars. Its posts were carved with twisting vines and leaves, so delicate and so real that I half expected them to move in the draft. Its canopy had long since rotted away, leaving only a few tattered strips of cloth hanging from the frame like cobwebs.

And on the bed, there was a man.

He lay on his back with his hands folded on his chest. He was tall and very thin, and he was dressed in the remains of what had once been fine clothes, a long robe of some dark rich fabric embroidered with thread that had once been gold. A crown sat on his head, a simple circlet of pale metal that gleamed faintly in the red light of my lamp. His face was gaunt and grey, the skin stretched tight over the bones. His eyes were closed.

He was, quite obviously, dead. He had been dead for a very long time.

And he was breathing.

\* \* \*

I stood very still. I did not breathe. I watched the dead man on the bed, and I watched his chest, and I waited.

It rose. Very slowly. So slowly I would not have seen it if I had not been watching for it. It rose, and paused, and fell.

A long time passed. I counted my own heartbeats. Twenty. Thirty. Forty.

It rose again.

"Auri," I whispered. "What is that?"

"That's the Sleeper," she whispered back. "He's been sleeping for a very long time. Longer than anyone. He's sleeping so deep that he's almost dead. But not quite." She was quiet for a moment. "Sometimes he dreams. And when he dreams, he wakes up a little. Just a little. And then he goes back to sleep."

"Is he awake now?"

"A little." She took a step back, toward me. "That's why I brought you. He's been waking more lately. Since the autumn. Since you came

back." She looked at me, and her eyes were very wide. "I think he knows you're here."

A chill went through me. "Why would he know that?"

"I don't know." She shook her head. "But he's been dreaming about you. I can tell. The whole Cellarage has been dreaming about you."

I looked at the man on the bed. At his gaunt grey face, his folded hands, his pale crown. I looked at the things piled around him, the weapons and the treasures and the forgotten, broken things. And I understood, suddenly, what this place was.

It was a barrow. A tomb for a king. The kind of place where the old kings of the north had been buried with their treasures around them, deep in the earth, to sleep until the end of the world.

Except that this king was not sleeping the way the dead sleep. He was sleeping the way the living do. And he was dreaming.

"Auri," I said very quietly. "I think we should go."

"Yes," she said. "I think so too."

We turned and began to walk back toward the door, slowly, carefully, the way you walk past a sleeping dog. The red light of my lamp swung across the heaped treasures. My footsteps sounded very loud on the stone.

We were halfway to the door when I heard it.

It was a sound like breath. Long and slow and deep, like wind moving through a cave. It came from behind us, from the bed on its dais. And beneath the sound of breath, so faint I could barely hear it, there was something else.

A voice. A single word, spoken so slowly it was almost not a word at all. A long deep syllable, like the grinding of stone on stone.

I did not know the word. But I knew, the way you sometimes know things, that it was a name.

And I knew, with a certainty that turned my bones to water, that it was mine.

\* \* \*

We ran.

I am not ashamed to say it. I ran as fast as I have ever run, out of the Cellarage and up the steep narrow slope and back through the tunnels, Auri's hand in mine, her bare feet slapping on the stone beside me. We did not stop until we reached the Twelve, and even then, I stood in the center of the great round room with my heart hammering and my lamp shaking in my hand, listening for footsteps behind us.

There were none. The Underthing was silent.

Auri was breathing hard beside me. She was trembling. I put my arm around her, and she leaned against me, her head against my chest, the way a frightened child leans against its mother.

"I'm sorry," she whispered. "I shouldn't have taken you there. I shouldn't have. It wasn't proper."

"It's all right, Auri."

"It isn't all right." She pulled away and looked up at me, and her eyes were full of tears. "He knows you now. He's seen you. And now he'll dream about you, and when he dreams, he wakes." She shook her head. "It isn't all right at all."

I did not know what to say. I held her until she stopped trembling. Then I took her back to Mantle and sat with her until she fell asleep, curled up on her little bed of blankets with her hands tucked under her chin.

And then I sat alone in the dark, with the stone in my pocket, and I thought about what I had seen.

A king in a barrow, sleeping. Dreaming. Waking.

Speaking my name.

I did not know who he was. I did not know how he had come to be there, or how long he had slept, or what he wanted. I did not know how he knew my name, or why he had spoken it.

But I remembered something Skarpi had said, years ago, in a tavern in Tarbean. Something about the old days, before the Aturan Empire, before the Creation War. When there had been kings in the world who were more than kings. Who had been namers, and shapers, and things that were not quite human.

When they died, Skarpi had said, some of them did not die all the way.

I sat in the dark and listened to the silence of the Underthing, and I did not sleep at all that night.

## Chapter Twenty-One

# The Name of Snow

Elodin held his class on the roof of the Rookery that winter. In the snow.

There were four of us left by then, of the five who had begun the term. Fela and I, and Uresta, the quiet Cealdish boy with long fingers who had never once spoken in class, and Inyssa, the Vintish girl with her hair cropped short as a boy's, who was taking the class, she told us, because her father had said naming was a waste of time. Brey had dropped out at midterm. I do not blame him. It was a very strange class, even by Elodin's standards.

"Today," said Elodin, "we will learn the name of snow."

He was sitting cross-legged on the flat lead roof, in the middle of a drift, in his black master's robe. He had no hat and no gloves and no boots. His feet were bare and blue with cold, and there was snow in his hair and on his eyebrows and melting on his cheeks, and he looked as happy as I had ever seen him.

We stood around him in a half circle, shivering, in cloaks and scarves and every layer of clothing we owned.

"Master Elodin," said Inyssa through chattering teeth. "Couldn't we learn the name of snow indoors?"

Elodin looked at him with bright interest.

"Could we?" he said. "Let's think about that. Where is the snow, Inyssa?"

"Out here."

"And where would we be?"

"In there." Inyssa gestured at the stairwell door. "Where it's warm."

"And would the snow be in there with us?"

Inyssa opened her mouth. She closed it again.

"There you are," said Elodin cheerfully. "Sit down. All of you. In the snow. Go on."

\* \* \*

We sat. The snow soaked through my trousers in an instant. Beside me, Fela made a small unhappy sound and tucked her hands into her armpits.

"Close your eyes," said Elodin.

We closed our eyes.

"Now," he said. "Tell me what snow is."

"Frozen water," said Inyssa promptly.

"Wrong."

"It is frozen water. Master Mandrag says—"

"Master Mandrag is very clever about water," said Elodin. "And very clever about ice. But he is not clever about snow, because he has never sat in it. Try again."

Nobody said anything. The wind moved across the roof, light and cold, and I heard the soft hiss of snow blowing across the lead.

"It's quiet," said Uresta.

We all turned to look at him. It was the first word any of us had ever heard him say. His voice was soft and low and a little hoarse, like a door that has not been opened in a long time.

Elodin turned his head toward her. I could not see him, with my eyes closed, but I heard him turn.

"Yes," he said. "Go on."

"It makes everything quiet." Uresta's voice was very hesitant. "When it falls. Everything goes still. The birds stop. The carts stop. People talk softer." He paused. "It's like the whole world is holding its breath."

"Good," said Elodin. "Very good. What else?"

\* \* \*

"It's patient," said Fela, after a while. "It doesn't fall all at once. It comes down one flake at a time, and each one is so small it hardly matters. But it keeps coming. And in the morning, the whole world is covered."

"Yes."

"It forgets," I said.

I had not meant to say it. It came out of me the way things sometimes did, in Elodin's class, from somewhere below thinking.

Elodin was quiet for a moment.

"Go on," he said.

"It covers things up," I said slowly. "The roads, and the fields, and the footprints. All the marks people make. It covers them over, and makes everything smooth and new, as if nothing had ever happened there." I paused. "And then it melts. And everything's still there underneath. Just the same as before." I did not know where the words were coming from. "It doesn't really forget. It only pretends. For a while."

The wind moved across the roof. Nobody said anything.

"Open your eyes," said Elodin.

\* \* \*

We opened our eyes. He was looking at me. His face was very still, and there was something in his eyes I did not understand then, and did not understand for years.

"That is a very sad thing to know about snow," he said. "At your age."

I did not say anything.

"But it's true," said Elodin. "All of it. What Uresta said, and Fela said, and you said. Even what Inyssa said, in its dull little way. Snow is frozen water. And it is quiet. And it is patient. And it forgets, or pretends to." He scooped up a handful of snow from the drift beside him and held it out on his palm. "All of those things are in its name. And more. Much more. More than we could say if we sat here until

spring."

We looked at the snow in his hand. It was already beginning to melt.

"That is the first lesson," said Elodin. "A name is not a word. A name is everything a thing is. All at once. All the way down." He closed his hand. Water dripped between his fingers. "You cannot say it. Not with your mouth. You can only know it. And then, sometimes, if you are very lucky and very careful, you can let it speak through you."

\* \* \*

"Master Elodin," said Inyssa. "Can you do it? Call the name of snow?"

Elodin looked at him for a long moment. Then he smiled. It was not a kind smile, exactly. But it was not unkind either.

"Would you like to see?"

Inyssa hesitated. Then she nodded.

Elodin stood up. He brushed the snow off his robe. He walked to the edge of the roof, barefoot, leaving blue footprints in the white, and stood there looking out over the University. The Archives, grey and windowless. The Mains, sprawling and patched. The Fishery with its chimneys. The whole great muddle of it, roofed in white.

He did not say anything. He did not raise his hands. He only stood there, with his back to us, for a long time.

And the snow stopped.

Not all at once. Not like a door closing. It slowed. The flakes that had been drifting down in their thousands began to drift more slowly, and more slowly still, until they were hanging in the air all around us, motionless, like dust in a sunbeam. Like stars.

I heard Fela draw in her breath.

Every flake. As far as I could see. Over the Rookery and the Archives and the Mains and the river and the town of Imre on the far bank. Hanging in the grey air, perfectly still. Silent. Waiting.

Elodin turned around. He looked at us. His face was pale and there was sweat on his forehead, despite the cold.

"Snow," he said softly, "is also *listening*."



And he let go.

The flakes began to fall again. Slowly at first, then faster, until they were drifting down around us the way they had before, as if nothing had happened. As if the whole world had not, for a moment, held its breath.

\* \* \*

Inyssa dropped the class the next day. Uresta did not come back either. I heard later that he left the University altogether, at the end of the term, and went home to the mountains of Ceald, and became a weaver of the heavy wool blankets they make there. I have always hoped he was happy. I have always hoped he wove snow into his cloth, sometimes, when no one was watching.

Fela and I stayed.

After the others had gone, that afternoon, I lingered on the roof. Elodin was still sitting in his drift, cross-legged, with his eyes closed. I thought he had forgotten I was there. Then he spoke.

"You said it forgets," he said, without opening his eyes. "Or pretends to."

"Yes."

"Where did that come from, Kvothe?"

I did not answer at once. I looked out over the white roofs. I thought of Tarbean. Of three winters, sleeping in doorways and on rooftops, with the snow coming down over the city and covering everything. The blood in the gutters. The bodies in the alleys, in the mornings. The marks of every terrible thing that had happened in the night, smoothed over, white and clean.

And then the thaw. And everything still there underneath.

"I don't know," I said.

Elodin opened his eyes. He looked at me for a long time.

"Someday," he said, "you are going to want very much to forget something. To cover it over. To make everything smooth and white, as if it never happened." He paused. "And you will find, if you are unlucky, that you can."

I looked at him.

"Don't," said Elodin quietly. "That's all. That's the lesson. When the time comes, don't."

He closed his eyes again. After a while, I went away down the stairs, and left him sitting in the snow.

\* \* \*

I did not understand what he meant. I did not understand it for years. Not until a chamber beneath an old house, and a woman with a cord in her hands, and a whole life covered over, smooth and white, as if it had never happened.

Seven years of snow.

And then, one autumn, a scribe with bloody knuckles. And the thaw.

## Chapter Twenty-Two

# Stone

For a span after that, I did not go down into the Underthing at all.

I told myself it was because I was busy. It was the end of term, and there were examinations to prepare for, and a great deal of work to finish in the Fishery. Kilvin had set me to making a new kind of heat-funnel, and I was struggling with it. The Eolian wanted me to play three nights a span instead of two, because the winter crowds were large and restless and hungry for music. And I was working on my father's song every night, late, by the light of Kilvin's candle, filling page after page with fragments and half-verses and melodies that did not quite fit together.

But that was not the real reason. The real reason was that I was afraid.

I have been afraid many times in my life. I was afraid on the streets of Tarbean, when I was a child and alone and every shadow might hide a man with a knife. I was afraid in the Eld, hunting bandits with a handful of mercenaries. I was afraid in the Fae, in the arms of Felurian, when I knew that a single wrong word would mean my death or my madness.

But I had never been afraid like this. It was not the fear of death. It was not the fear of pain. It was something older and deeper and harder to name. It was the fear of being known.

The Sleeper had spoken my name. Not the name I was called by, not *Kvothe*, the name my parents gave me. My true name. The name that was the shape of me, the thing that made me what I was. I had not

recognized the word, but I had known it the way you know your own face in a mirror.

And if he knew my name, he had power over me. That was the first thing Elodin had ever taught me about naming, and the most important. To know a thing's name is to have mastery of it. To know a man's name is to hold him in the palm of your hand.

I did not know who the Sleeper was. I did not know what he wanted. But I knew that he had my name. And I was afraid.

\* \* \*

It was Elodin who found me, in the end. He found me the way he always found people, which is to say without appearing to look.

I was sitting in the round room at the top of the Rookery, the shy room that would not let me find it again after that term. I had come there to listen to the stone, but I was not listening. I was staring at the wall, thinking about the Cellarage, and I did not hear him come in.

"You look," said Elodin, "like a man who has seen a ghost."

I jumped. He was standing in the doorway, leaning against the frame with his arms folded, watching me with his dark unreadable eyes.

"Not a ghost," I said. "Something else."

"Ah." He came into the room and sat down on the floor across from me, cross-legged, like a child. He picked up Elodin's stone and turned it over in his hands. "Tell me."

I hesitated. I had not told anyone about the Cellarage. Not Sim or Wil, not Devi, not Fela. It was Auri's secret, and I had promised long ago never to tell anyone about Auri.

But Elodin already knew about Auri. He had known about her before I did. And he was the Master Namer. If anyone could tell me what I had heard, it was him.

So I told him. I told him about the Cellarage, and the treasures, and the bed of black stone. I told him about the Sleeper, breathing. I told him about the word he had spoken, and how I had known it was my name.

Elodin listened without interrupting. His face did not change. When I was done, he sat for a long time turning the stone over in his hands.

"Well," he said at last. "That's inconvenient."

I stared at him. "Inconvenient?"

"Very." He set the stone down on the floor between us. "You should not have gone there. Neither should she. But she's been going there for years, and it's never noticed her, because she's very small and very quiet and very careful. You are none of those things."

"You know about the Cellarage?"

"Of course I know about the Cellarage. I've been down there. Once. A long time ago." He looked at the stone. "I didn't go back."

"Who is he? The Sleeper?"

Elodin was silent for a long time. When he spoke, his voice was quieter than I had ever heard it.

"I don't know his name," he said. "Nobody does. That's the point of him. But I know what he is." He looked up at me. "He's a guard."

"A guard? Guarding what?"

"What do you think?" Elodin gestured around us, at the walls of the round room, at the Rookery, at the whole University spread out beneath us. "Why do you think there's a University here, of all places? Why do you think the Archives were built on this spot, on this particular stretch of riverbank, when there are a hundred better places a day's ride in any direction?"

I did not answer. I did not know.

"Because something was already here," Elodin said. "Something very old. Something that needed to be watched. And the people who built the Archives, whoever they were, knew that. So they built it here, on top of it, like a lid on a jar. And they put a guard at the bottom, to make sure the lid stayed on." He picked up the stone again. "And then they went away, and people forgot, and the University grew up around the Archives like moss on a rock. And now nobody remembers what's down there, or why."

"What is down there?"

Elodin looked at me. His eyes were very dark.

"A door," he said.

\* \* \*

I did not ask him what kind of door. I did not have to. I had dreamed of it.

"The Four-plate door," I said slowly. "It's not the real door. Is it? It's just the top of the stair."

Elodin raised an eyebrow. "Who told you that?"

"A friend."

"Your friend is well informed." He turned the stone over in his hands. "The Four-plate door is a seal. One of several. It keeps people from going down. There are other seals, deeper. And at the bottom—" He stopped.

"At the bottom?"

"At the bottom, there's the thing the seals are protecting. Or protecting against. I've never been sure which." He set the stone down. "And beside it, sleeping, there's the Sleeper. Who has been down there for a very long time, keeping watch. Dreaming. Waiting for the day when someone comes to open the door."

"And then what? He wakes up?"

"And then he wakes up." Elodin smiled faintly. "And then, I imagine, things become very interesting for whoever is standing in front of the door."

We sat in silence for a while. Outside the window, the snow was falling again, soft and white.

"He spoke my name," I said at last. "Why? Why would he know my name?"

Elodin looked at me for a long moment. There was something in his face I could not read. Something that might have been pity.

"I don't know," he said. "But I can guess. Can't you?"

I thought about it. I thought about the blue book in the Archives, and the black mark where my mother's name should have been. I thought about the line of writing on the last page. *The door holds while the line holds.*

"Because of my family," I said slowly. "Because of who my mother was."

Elodin did not say anything. But he did not look surprised.

"You knew," I said. "About my mother. You knew."

"I suspected." He shrugged. "You have a look about you. Something in the eyes, something in the bones. I've seen it before, in old portraits. In the faces of people who carried a certain name." He picked up the stone again and held it out to me. "Which is why I wanted you to learn stone. Of all the names in the world, that's the one you'll need most."

I took the stone. It was cold in my hand. Colder than it should have been.

"Why?"

"Because," Elodin said, "the door is made of stone. And someday, whether you want to or not, you're going to be standing in front of it. And when you do, you'd better know how to ask it to stay closed."

\* \* \*

He left after that. He stood up and walked out of the round room without another word, the way he always did, and left me alone with the stone.

I sat there for a long time, holding it. Feeling its weight. Its coldness. Its patience.

I did not try to hear it. I did not reach for it. I was too tired, and too frightened, and too full of thoughts I did not want to think. I simply sat there, holding it, the way you might hold the hand of a friend at a funeral. Not asking anything. Just being there.

And after a while, I don't know how long, I realized that I could hear it.

It was very faint. Fainter than a whisper. Fainter than the sound of my own blood in my ears. It was not a word, not exactly. It was more like a feeling. A long, slow, patient feeling, stretching back further than I could imagine and forward further than I could follow.

It was *no*. Just as Fela had said. The most patient no in the world.

No, I will not move. No, I will not change. No, I will not break.

I sat there with the stone in my hands and listened to it, and I felt something I had not felt in a very long time. It was peace. A deep, quiet, bottomless peace, like the peace at the bottom of the sea. The peace of something that has been itself for so long that nothing can ever make it anything else.

I closed my eyes. I let the stone's no wash over me, through me, into me. I let it settle into my bones.

And then, very quietly, I heard something else.

It was beneath the stone's voice. Far beneath. So deep that I could barely feel it, the way you can barely feel the rumble of a cart on a road a mile away. It was not saying no. It was saying something else. Something I could not make out.

But it was not patient. And it was not peaceful.

It was hungry.

\* \* \*

I opened my eyes. The round room was dark. The snow had stopped falling outside the window, and the sky was clear and black and full of stars. I had been sitting there for hours.

I looked down at the stone in my hands. It was just a stone. Grey and rough and ordinary.

But I could still hear it, faintly, at the edge of my mind. Its long slow no. And beneath it, fainter still, that other thing. That hungry thing.

I stood up. My legs were stiff and my back ached. I put the stone in my pocket and went down the stairs of the Rookery and out into the cold clear night.

The stars were very bright. The snow crunched under my feet. The University was silent and dark around me, its great grey buildings looming against the sky.

And I could hear them. All of them. Every stone in every wall, every paving stone in every courtyard, every foundation stone buried deep in the earth. They were all saying no. Softly, patiently, endlessly. A great slow chorus of no, rising up from the bones of the world.



Fela had said it was the most beautiful thing she had ever heard. She was right.

But beneath it, so faint I could almost convince myself I was imagining it, I could hear that other voice. The one that was not saying no. The one that was hungry.

It was coming from the Archives. From deep beneath the Archives. From somewhere far below the Four-plate door, far below the Cellarage and the sleeping king, far below anything I had ever seen.

It was coming from behind the door.

And I knew, with a certainty that I could not explain, that it was listening to me too.

## Chapter Twenty-Three

# The Sleeping King

Auri disappeared on the first night of the new term.

I did not know it at first. I had been busy all day with admissions, standing in line in the cold and then standing before the masters in Hollows while they asked me their questions. It went well enough. Elodin did not subtract anything this time, but he did not add anything either, and Kilvin argued on my behalf for a lower tuition because of the work I had done on his heat-funnel. I came out with a sum I could pay easily from the Maer's purse, and I paid it, and then I went to the Eolian to celebrate with Sim and Wil.

It was very late when I finally went down to the grate behind the Mains. I had a small gift for Auri in my pocket, a honey cake wrapped in paper, and I whistled the three rising notes as I always did.

Nobody answered.

I waited. I whistled again. The shaft below me was dark and silent.

That was not unusual. Auri did not always come when I called. Sometimes she was busy, or asleep, or simply not in the mood for company. I had learned not to take it personally. I left the honey cake on the edge of the grate, where she would find it, and went home to bed.

The next night, the honey cake was still there.

\* \* \*

I went down.

I had not been into the Underthing since the night Elodin had talked to me about the door. I had been afraid to. But I was more afraid of what might have happened to Auri, and so I climbed down through the grate with my sympathy lamp in one hand and Elodin's stone heavy in my pocket, and I went looking for her.

I looked in Mantle. Her little bed of blankets was there, neatly made, and her small collection of treasures was arranged in its careful patterns on the shelf. But she was not there.

I looked in the Twelve. In Vaults. In the Crumbling, where the moonlight came down. In Tumbrel, where the little grey moths fluttered up around me as I passed. In Hush, where I whispered her name and heard it come back to me, clear as a bell, from the empty air.

She was not anywhere.

I stood in the center of the Twelve with my lamp in my hand and my heart pounding, and I tried to think. Where would she go? Where could she be? She knew the Underthing better than anyone alive. She could have been anywhere, in any of a thousand rooms and passages I had never seen.

But I knew. I think I had known from the moment I saw the honey cake lying untouched on the grate.

The stone in my pocket was heavy. Heavier than it had ever been. And when I listened, very carefully, I could hear it saying its long slow no. And beneath it, fainter, that other thing. The hungry thing.

But there was something else now, too. Something between them. A third voice, very deep and very slow, like the grinding of stone on stone.

It was coming from the Cellarage.

And it was awake.

\* \* \*

I went down the steep narrow slope that Auri had called too loud. I understood now what she had meant. The closer I came to the bottom, the louder it grew. Not a sound, exactly. A pressure. A weight on the air, on my ears, on the inside of my skull. It was like standing at the edge of a great waterfall, where the roar is so loud you cannot hear

anything else, cannot think anything else.

The old door at the bottom was standing open. Beyond it, the Cellarage was full of light.

Not the red light of my lamp. A pale, cold, silver light, like moonlight on snow. It came from everywhere and nowhere, from the air itself, and it cast no shadows. In that light, the heaped treasures glittered and gleamed as if they were new. The rusted weapons shone. The rotted tapestries glowed with colors I had never seen before, deep crimsons and royal blues and golds that seemed to burn.

And on the dais at the far end of the room, the black bed was empty.

The Sleeper was standing beside it.

He was taller than I had thought. Much taller. He stood nearly seven feet, gaunt and grey, in his long rich robe with its embroidery of tarnished gold. His crown gleamed on his brow. His eyes were open.

They were grey, those eyes. Grey as stone, grey as ash, grey as the sky before snow. And they were looking at me.

In his arms, cradled against his chest like a sleeping child, he held Auri.

\* \* \*

I did not move. I could not. His gaze held me the way a pin holds a butterfly. I stood in the doorway with my lamp in my hand and my mouth dry as dust, and I could not so much as blink.

The Sleeper looked at me for a long time. Then he spoke.

His voice was very slow. Each word came out of him like a stone being pulled from the earth. It was not a language I knew. It was older than Tema, older than Siaru, older than any language I had ever heard. But I understood it. I understood it the way you understand a dream.

"Key," he said.

I did not answer. I could not.

"*You came back,*" he said. "*I felt you. I felt you listening. You heard the stone. You heard what is beneath the stone.*" He paused, and the pause stretched out for so long that I thought he had fallen asleep again. Then: "*You should not have listened.*"

"Give her back," I said. My voice cracked. "Please. She's done nothing to you."

The Sleeper looked down at Auri, cradled in his arms. Her face was pale and peaceful. Her eyes were closed. She looked, in that silver light, like a figure carved from ivory.

*"She is of a royal line," he said slowly. "I smelled it on her. I have smelled it on her for years, as she crept about my halls. A princess. A daughter of kings."* He looked back at me. *"I am a king. I have been alone a very long time. A king should not be alone in his barrow. A king should have a companion, to sleep beside him until the end of days."*

Something cold went through me. "She's not yours."

*"She is now."* He turned, slowly, toward the black bed. *"She will sleep beside me. She will dream my dreams. And together we will keep watch, as I was set to keep watch, until the door is opened and the world ends."*

"No!"

I did not decide to move. My body moved on its own. I was across the room before I knew it, running between the heaped treasures, my lamp swinging wildly in my hand.

The Sleeper turned his head and looked at me.

And the stone of the floor rose up and caught my feet.

\* \* \*

It was like being grabbed by a hand. The stone flowed up around my ankles like water, then hardened again, holding me fast. I fell forward and caught myself on my hands, and the stone flowed up around my wrists too, and held them.

I was pinned. Kneeling on the floor of the Cellarage, my hands and feet held fast in stone, my lamp lying on its side beside me, its red light spilling across the floor.

The Sleeper looked down at me. There was no anger in his face. There was nothing in his face at all. It was a face of stone, grey and still and patient.

*"You are the key," he said. "I cannot harm you. That is not my purpose. But I cannot let you pass." He turned back toward the bed, Auri still cradled in his arms. "Go back to the world above. Forget this place. Forget her. And never come down again."*

I struggled against the stone. It did not move. It held me the way the earth holds a buried seed, patiently, completely.

And as I struggled, I heard it.

The stone that held me was saying no. Its long slow patient no. No, I will not let go. No, I will not move. No, I will not change.

I stopped struggling.

I closed my eyes. I let my mind go still, the way I had in the round room. I did not reach for the stone. I did not try to make it do anything. I simply listened to it, the way you listen to a friend.

No, it said. No. No. No.

And beneath that, fainter, I could hear the Sleeper. His voice was stone too, but it was a different kind of stone. It was old and tired and very, very lonely. It had been saying no for longer than I could imagine. No to the door. No to the thing behind it. No to everyone and everything that came down the long slope into the dark.

It was so tired.

I opened my mouth. I did not know what I was going to say. I had no plan, no idea, nothing but the stone's voice in my ears and the Sleeper's loneliness in my heart.

I began to sing.

\* \* \*

It was not a song I knew. It was not a song anyone knew. It came up out of me the way the name of the wind had come up out of me once, long ago, in a moment of cold, clear fury. But this was not fury. This was something else. Something quieter.

It was a lullaby.

I sang the stone's no, the long slow patient no that had been saying itself since the beginning of the world. I sang it softly, gently, the way my mother had sung to me when I was very small and could not sleep. I sang it the way you would sing to a child who has been

awake too long, who is too tired to know how tired he is.

*No, I sang. No, there is nothing you must do. No, there is nowhere you must go. No, there is nothing to watch for, nothing to wait for. Rest. Rest. The stone holds. The stone will always hold. Rest.*

The Sleeper stopped.

He was standing beside the black bed, with Auri in his arms. He had been about to lay her down on it. But he stopped, and he stood very still, and he listened.

I kept singing. I sang the stone's no, and I sang the Sleeper's loneliness, and I sang the long slow dark of the Cellarage, the patient silence of the deep places of the earth. I sang of rest. Of sleep. Of the peace at the bottom of the sea.

The stone around my wrists began to soften.

The Sleeper turned to look at me. His grey eyes were heavy. His gaunt face was slack.

"*What is that song?*" he said. His voice was slower than ever.

"It's yours," I said, and kept singing.

He swayed on his feet. His eyes began to close.

"*I am so tired,*" he said.

"I know," I sang. "*Rest. The stone will hold. You can rest now.*"

The stone released my wrists. My ankles. I rose slowly to my feet, still singing, still softly, and I walked toward him across the silver-lit floor of the Cellarage.

He did not stop me. He stood beside the black bed with his eyes half closed and his head bowed. When I reached him, I held out my arms, and he looked at me for a long moment with his heavy grey eyes.

Then, slowly, he placed Auri in my arms.

She was very light. Lighter than she should have been. She was cold, and her skin was pale as ivory, but she was breathing. I held her against my chest and kept singing, and the Sleeper turned away from me and lay down on the black bed and folded his hands across his chest and closed his eyes.

The silver light began to fade.

I kept singing. I sang until the light was gone and the Cellarage was dark again except for the red glow of my lamp, lying on its side on the floor. I sang until the Sleeper's breathing slowed, and slowed, and grew so faint I could barely see his chest rise. I sang until the terrible pressure in the air was gone, and the Cellarage was just a room again, a cold dark room full of forgotten things.

Then I stopped.

The silence was enormous.

I stood there with Auri in my arms and listened. The Sleeper breathed. Very slowly. Very deeply. The breath of a man in the deepest of sleeps.

And just before I turned to go, I heard him speak one more time. It was barely a whisper. Barely a word.

"Key," he said. *"Do not come to the door. Whatever they tell you. Whatever they offer. Do not come to the door."*

Then he was silent, and he did not speak again.

\* \* \*

I carried Auri up out of the Cellarage and up the steep narrow slope and all the way back to Mantle. She did not wake. I laid her on her little bed of blankets and covered her up and sat beside her through the long hours of the night, holding her hand.

She woke at dawn. Or what passed for dawn in the Underthing: a faint greying of the darkness at the top of the old chimney, the barest hint of light.

She opened her eyes and looked at me. For a long moment she did not seem to know me. Then her face cleared.

"Kvothe," she whispered.

"I'm here."

"I was dreaming." Her voice was very small. "I was dreaming I was a queen. In a great hall, with a great king. And we were very old, and very tired, and we were waiting for something." She shivered. "It was a sad dream."

"It's over now."



"Is it?" She looked at me with her enormous eyes. "Did you bring me back?"

"Yes."

"From the Sleeper?"

"Yes."

She was quiet for a long time. Then she said, very softly, "How?"

"I sang to him."

"What did you sing?"

I thought about it. "I sang him the stone," I said. "I sang him to sleep."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she smiled, a small, tired, radiant smile.

"That was very clever," she said. "And very kind. Most people wouldn't have been kind to him."

"He took you."

"He was lonely." She closed her eyes. "Lonely people do foolish things."

She fell asleep again after that. I sat beside her until the grey light at the top of the chimney had turned to gold. Then I tucked the blanket around her shoulders, and left the honey cake beside her pillow, and climbed back up into the world.

It was a bright, cold morning. The snow sparkled in the sunlight. Students were hurrying across the courtyard on their way to class, laughing and talking, their breath steaming in the air.

I stood among them and felt like a ghost. Like a man who has come back from somewhere very far away, and does not quite remember how to be in the world anymore.

*Do not come to the door, the Sleeper had said. Whatever they tell you. Whatever they offer.*

I did not know who *they* were. I did not know what they might tell me, or what they might offer.

But I knew, standing there in the bright cold morning, that I would find out.

## Chapter Twenty-Four

### A Signet

Auri was ill for nearly a span after that.

It was not an illness I understood. She had no fever, no cough, no rash. She ate a little, when I brought her food, and drank a little, when I brought her water. But she slept most of the day and most of the night, curled up on her bed of blankets in Mantle, and when she was awake she was quiet and distant and strange. She did not arrange her treasures in their patterns. She did not hum. She did not ask me what I had brought her, and when I gave her things, she thanked me politely and set them aside without looking at them.

It frightened me more than I can say.

I went down every day. Sometimes twice a day. I brought her food and water and small gifts, and I sat with her while she slept, and I played my lute for her softly, very softly, so as not to wake her. I did not know what else to do.

On the fifth day, I went to Elodin.

\* \* \*

He was in his office, for once. It was a small cluttered room in the Rookery, crammed with books and papers and strange objects whose purpose I could not guess. He was sitting at his desk with his feet up, reading a book upside down.

"She's ill," I said. "Auri. Since the Cellarage. She won't wake up properly."

Elodin lowered the book. He looked at me for a long moment. Then he swung his feet down off the desk and stood up.

"Show me," he said.

I took him down. I had never taken anyone into the Underthing before, and I felt strange about it, as if I were betraying a confidence. But Elodin moved through the tunnels as if he knew them, and perhaps he did. He did not need my lamp. He walked in the dark as easily as in the light.

When we came to Mantle, Auri was asleep. Elodin knelt beside her bed and looked at her for a long time without touching her. Then he reached out and laid two fingers very lightly on her forehead.

He closed his eyes. His lips moved, silently.

After a long moment, he took his hand away and sat back on his heels.

"She's dreaming his dreams," he said quietly.

"What do you mean?"

"The Sleeper. He shared his dreams with her, while he held her. Now she can't stop dreaming them." He looked at Auri's pale sleeping face. "It's like a poison. A very slow one. It won't kill her. But if it goes on long enough, she'll forget how to wake up."

My heart turned over in my chest. "Can you fix it?"

"I can try." He was quiet for a moment. "But I'll need something from her. Something that belongs to her. Something that's truly hers, from before. Before the Underthing. Before she came here." He looked at me. "Do you know if she has anything like that?"

I thought about it. I thought about Auri's treasures, arranged so carefully on her shelf. The pebbles and bits of glass. The pressed leaves. The small bottles and boxes and scraps of cloth she had gathered over the years.

"I don't know," I said. "Maybe."

"Look," Elodin said. "Carefully. And respectfully. She won't thank you for pawing through her things."

\* \* \*

I looked. I went through Auri's treasures one by one, lifting each small thing from its place and setting it down again exactly where I had found it. I did it slowly and carefully, the way you might handle the relics in a church. It felt like a violation. It felt like reading someone's diary while they slept.

But I did it. And at the very back of the shelf, behind a small wooden box with a broken lid, I found a bundle of cloth.

It was very old. The cloth was faded and soft with handling, a pale blue that had once, perhaps, been rich and deep. It was wrapped around something small and hard. I lifted it out and held it in my hand, and I knew, the way you sometimes know things, that this was what Elodin needed.

I unwrapped it.

Inside was a ring. A heavy ring of gold, worn smooth with age, set with a flat oval stone of deep green. There was a design carved into the stone. A seal. I turned it toward the light of my lamp and looked at it closely.

It was a signet ring. The kind of ring that nobles use to seal their letters. The design on the stone was a crest: a tower, and above it three stars, and around it a border of twining leaves.

I did not recognize it. Not then. But I knew what it was. I knew what it meant.

*She is of a royal line*, the Sleeper had said. *A princess. A daughter of kings.*

I stood there in the red light of my lamp with Auri's ring in my hand, and I felt the world shift beneath my feet.

\* \* \*

I gave the ring to Elodin. He took it without comment, without even looking at the crest, and closed it in his fist. Then he knelt beside Auri again and laid his other hand on her forehead.

He began to speak.

I cannot tell you what he said. I did not understand it. It was not a language, or not one I knew. It was names. A long, slow, winding chain of names, one after the other, like beads on a string. Some of

them I almost recognized. Most of them I did not. They seemed to go on forever, rising and falling, twisting and turning, until the air in Mantle hummed with them.

And then, at the end, he said one more name. Very softly. Very gently. The way you might whisper to a sleeping child to wake her.

I knew it was Auri's name. Her true name. I did not hear it clearly; it slipped past my ears like water through fingers. But I knew it.

Auri opened her eyes.

She looked up at Elodin. Then she looked at me. Her face was pale and her eyes were enormous, but they were clear. They were hers.

"Oh," she said softly. "Oh. I was so far away."

"You're back now," Elodin said.

"Yes." She sat up slowly. She looked down at her hands, as if she had never seen them before. "Yes. I'm back." She looked up at Elodin, and something passed across her face. Something shy and wary and old. "You said my name."

"I did."

"Nobody's said my name in a long time."

"I know." Elodin opened his fist and held out the ring to her. "I'm sorry. I had to use this. It was the only way to find you."

Auri looked at the ring. For a long moment she did not move. Then she reached out and took it from his palm, very carefully, the way you might pick up a bird with a broken wing. She held it in both hands and looked at it.

"I'd forgotten this," she said. "I put it away so I wouldn't have to remember."

"I know," said Elodin again.

She looked up at me. Her eyes were wet. "Did you see it?"

"Yes," I said.

"Did you know it?"

I hesitated. "No."

She nodded slowly. Then she wrapped the ring back in its faded cloth and held it against her chest.

"Please don't," she said. "Please don't find out. Please don't ask. I'm Auri now. I'm only Auri. I don't want to be anyone else."

I looked at her. At her pale face, her cloud of hair, her small bare feet. At the ring she held against her heart, and the crest carved into its stone.

"You're only Auri," I said. "I promise."

She smiled at me. It was a small, trembling smile. But it was hers.

\* \* \*

I kept that promise for a long time. I did not go looking for the crest. I did not search the Archives for books of heraldry. I did not ask Lorren or Herma or any of the other masters what a tower beneath three stars might signify.

But I have a very good memory. I have always had a very good memory. And I could not stop myself from remembering.

It was months later. I was in Severen, at the Maer's court, and I was passing through a long gallery lined with portraits and banners. I was not paying attention to them. I was thinking about something else entirely. And then I passed a banner of deep green silk, hanging from the wall, with a crest embroidered on it in gold thread.

A tower. Three stars. A border of twining leaves.

I stopped. I stood there in the gallery and stared at it for a long time. Then I asked a passing servant whose banner it was.

He looked at me as if I were simple. "That's the banner of the royal house of Modeg," he said. "The Ariel line. Surely you know that?"

I did know it. Now.

There had been a princess of Modeg, some years before. A younger daughter. She had been sent away to study, far from home, at a great school across the sea. Some said she was clever. Some said she was strange. And some said that one day she had simply vanished, and that her family had searched for her for years, and never found her, and had finally given her up for dead.

Her name had been Ariel.

I walked away from that banner and did not look back. And I never told anyone what I had seen. Not the Maer, not Denna, not Sim or Wil or Elodin. I never told Auri.

She was only Auri. I had promised.

\* \* \*

I have been thinking, lately, about what it means to keep a secret.

A secret is a kind of name. It is the true shape of a thing, hidden away where no one can see it. And like a name, it has power. To know someone's secret is to hold them in the palm of your hand.

I have known a great many secrets in my life. I have kept some of them and sold others. I have used them as weapons and as shields, as currency and as gifts. I have learned things about kings and queens and gods that would shake the world if they were spoken aloud.

But of all the secrets I have ever kept, the one I am proudest of is the smallest. It is a tower and three stars, carved into a green stone. It is a name I have never spoken.

It is the only promise I have ever made that I have kept perfectly. Everything else, I broke.

## Chapter Twenty-Five

# The Ledgers of the Scrivs

Wil came to me with the ledgers a span after Auri woke.

I was in the Fishery, at my bench, not working. I had been not working a great deal, since the Cellarage. I would sit at my bench with a half-finished project in front of me and a tool in my hand, and I would look at it, and I would think about a king on a bed of black stone, breathing, and a voice like stone grinding on stone saying *key*. And the afternoon would go by, and the project would not get finished, and Kilvin would come by and look at me and grunt in a worried way and go back to his office.

Wil did not grunt. Wil came and stood beside my bench with a stack of old leather-bound books under one arm and his dark face very serious, and he said, "Come with me."

"Where?"

"Somewhere private." He glanced around the Fishery. At the students at their benches, and the apprentices at the forges, and Manet grinding something in his mortar by the kilns. "Not here."

\* \* \*

We went to Anker's. To my room under the eaves. Wil closed the door behind us and set the stack of books on my narrow table and sat down on my bed and looked at me.

"You asked me," he said, "a long time ago. About the cut books. The ones with the pages missing. Rebound, and renumbered."

"Lorren's looking into it."



"Lorren has been looking into it for two months. Lorren has found eleven more books and written a very long report and locked it in his desk and told no one what's in it." Wil folded his hands. "I got tired of waiting."

He tapped the stack of books on my table.

"These are the scrivs' ledgers," he said. "The old ones. The records of who took what out of the Archives, and when, and who brought it back. Every book that leaves the Stacks for the Tomes, every book that goes to a master's office, every book that gets sent to the bindery for repair. The scrivs write it all down. They've been writing it all down since before there was a University."

I looked at the books. They were very old. Their leather covers were cracked and faded, and the pages, where they showed at the edges, were brown and brittle.

"Where did you get them?"

"From the basement of the Archives. There's a room down there, full of them. Hundreds of years of ledgers, stacked up to the ceiling. Nobody ever looks at them. Nobody even remembers they're there, except the old scrivs, and most of the old scrivs are dead." Wil's face did not change. "I've been going down there every night for a month. After my shift. Reading."

"Reading ledgers."

"Reading ledgers." He opened the top one. "Looking for the cut books. Looking for when they went to the bindery, and who sent them, and who brought them back."

\* \* \*

He showed me.

It was slow work, the way he had done it. The ledgers were written in a dozen different hands over hundreds of years, some neat and some crabbed and some nearly illegible, in inks that had faded to brown or grey or nothing. They used abbreviations that had changed a dozen times. They recorded books by their shelfmarks rather than their titles, and the shelfmarks had changed too, whenever the Archives had been reorganized, which had happened, as far as Wil could tell, about

every forty years.

But Wil was Cealdish, and patient, and very good at columns of numbers. He had made a list of the cut books, all twelve of the ones we knew about. He had traced their shelfmarks back through the reorganizations. And then he had gone looking for them in the ledgers.

"Here," he said. He turned the brittle pages of the oldest ledger, very carefully, and laid his finger on a line near the bottom. "Look."

I looked. It was a single line, in faded brown ink, in a small neat hand.

*St. VII. xii. 44. To bindery. Loose leaves. Returned. —B.*

"That's one of ours," said Wil. "The book you showed Lorren. The history of the Aturan provinces, with the chapter on the Seven replaced. Its shelfmark, before the reorganization, was Stacks seven, twelve, forty-four." He tapped the line. "It went to the bindery for loose leaves, and came back. And whoever took it signed for it."

"B."

"B." Wil turned the page. And another. And another. He laid his finger on another line.

*St. II. iv. 108. To bindery. Spine cracked. Returned. —B.*

"That's another one." Another page. "And another." Another. "And another."

He had found them all. Every one of the twelve. And every one of them had gone to the bindery, at one time or another, and come back. And every time, the scriv who signed for it had signed the same way.

—B.

\* \* \*

"When?" I said. My voice sounded strange.

Wil looked at me.

"That's the thing," he said quietly. "That's why I brought them to you."

He laid the ledgers out on my narrow table, side by side, all six of them. He opened each one to a page he had marked with a slip of paper.

"This one," he said, touching the first, "is from two hundred and forty years ago. This one is from a hundred and ninety. This one, a hundred and thirty. This one, ninety. This one, sixty. This one, twenty-two." He looked at me. "The same initial. The same hand. I've compared them. The loops of the B, the way the stroke starts. It's the same hand, Kvothe. Over two hundred and forty years."

I stared at the ledgers.

"A family," I said. "Scrivs. Father to son. Handwriting passed down."

"Maybe." Wil's face did not change. "I thought of that. So I went looking for the scrivs' rolls. The lists of who worked the desk, every term. They're in the basement too." He took a folded paper out of his shirt and unfolded it. "Two hundred and forty years ago, there was a scriv named Brede. A hundred and ninety years ago, a scriv named Bran. A hundred and thirty years ago, Bredwyn. Ninety years ago, Brennan. Sixty years ago, Brand." He looked at me. "Twenty-two years ago, a man named Beredon worked the desk for one term. Just one. And then he left."

"Different names."

"Different names." Wil folded the paper. "Each one worked for a term. Maybe two. Never longer. And then left. And then, forty or fifty years later, another one came. With a name beginning with B. And the same handwriting." He was quiet for a moment. "And every time one of them worked the desk, some of the books about the Seven went to the bindery. And came back with pages missing."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long time.

I sat on the edge of my bed and looked at the ledgers spread out on my table. At the faded brown lines, and the small neat hand, and the single initial at the end of each one.

—B.

I did not think of Bredon. I want to be honest about that, since I have been honest about everything else. I sat there with the evidence in front of me, and I did not think of a kind old man with a walking stick

who had taught me to play tak in the Maer's court.

I thought about the Chandrian. About Cinder, who did not age. About Haliar, who could not die. I thought about a man who could come to the University every forty or fifty years, under a different name, and work the desk in the Archives for a term, and take the books he wanted to the bindery, and come back with pages missing. A man who did not age. A man who had been doing this for two hundred and forty years, and perhaps much longer.

I thought it must be one of the Seven. Or a servant of theirs. Some creature in human shape.

I did not think it might be a man. Just a man. Kept alive past his time by some bargain, some promise, some dark thing he had answered in the night.

I did not think it might be someone I knew.

\* \* \*

"What do we do?" said Wil.

I looked at him. At his dark patient face, and the ledgers spread out on my table.

"We take it to Lorren," I said.

"Lorren already knows about the books."

"Lorren doesn't know about this." I touched the ledgers. "This is different. This is a person. A name, or a set of names. A hand we can recognize." I looked at Wil. "If he comes back—when he comes back—we'll know him. By his handwriting. By his name."

Wil was quiet for a long time.

"Kvothe," he said at last. "Twenty-two years ago. That was the last one. Beredon. One term." He looked at me. "The pattern is forty or fifty years. Which means he's not due back for another twenty years, at least."

"So?"

"So he's not coming back to the Archives. Not for a long time." Wil's voice was very quiet. "Which means he's somewhere else. Doing something else. Right now." He paused. "And we don't know where."

We took it to Lorren anyway.

He listened to Wil explain, sitting behind his desk in his long narrow office, with his long pale hands folded and his face showing nothing. He looked at the ledgers. He looked at Wil's list of names. He looked at the handwriting, comparing the six lines one after another, for a very long time.

Then he closed the ledgers, one by one, and stacked them neatly on his desk.

"Thank you, E'lir Wilem," he said. "This is very thorough work. Very thorough indeed." He looked at Wil with his calm colorless eyes. "You will not speak of it to anyone. Is that understood?"

"Yes, Master Lorren."

"And you, Re'lar Kvothe."

"Yes, Master Lorren."

Lorren looked at us both for a long moment. Then he said something I have never forgotten.

"I knew Beredon," he said.

Wil and I both went very still.

"Twenty-two years ago," said Lorren. "I was a young master then. New to the chair. He came to me and asked for a place at the desk, and I gave it to him. He was very good. Very quiet. Very careful with the books." He looked down at the ledgers. "He was an old man, even then. Kind. Well-spoken. He used to play tak with me in the evenings, in this office, after the Archives closed." Lorren's long pale hands were very still on the desk. "He always won."

"What happened to him?" I said.

"He left. At the end of the term. He said he had been offered a position at court, in Vintas, as tutor to a nobleman's son." Lorren was quiet for a moment. "I was sorry to see him go. He was very good company."

"Do you remember what he looked like?"

Lorren looked at me for a long time. His face showed nothing at all.

"Tall," he said at last. "White hair. A pleasant face. He walked with a stick." He paused. "A stick of dark wood. With a silver head."

\* \* \*

Wil and I walked back across the courtyard in the grey afternoon without speaking.

It was cold. The snow was old and grey and packed hard on the flagstones. Students hurried past us with their heads down. The Archives stood behind us, windowless and grey, holding its secrets.

"A stick," said Wil at last. "With a silver head."

"Yes."

"Plenty of old men carry sticks."

"Yes."

"Plenty of them have silver heads."

"Yes."

Wil stopped walking. He turned and looked at me.

"Do you know him?" he said. "Kvothe. Do you know an old man with white hair and a stick with a silver head, who plays tak and always wins?"

I stood in the cold courtyard with the grey snow under my feet and the grey sky over my head, and I thought about the steps of the Mains, in the first snow of the winter. Ambrose in his fur-trimmed coat. And behind him, near the door, an old man leaning on a stick. Raising it an inch off the ground in a small courtly greeting, the way he used to at the start of a game.

*You have an interesting face. It reminds me of someone I knew long ago.*

"I don't know," I said.

It was a lie. Wil knew it was a lie. I saw it in his face.

But he did not press. That was one of the things I loved about Wil. He knew when to stop asking.

He only looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded, very slowly, and turned, and walked on across the courtyard toward the Archives, where his shift was starting.

I stood alone in the cold for a long time.

And I told myself it meant nothing. That there were a thousand old men with white hair and walking sticks. That Bredon had been at the Maer's court for eleven years, and at the court before that, and had never been a scriv in his life. That it was a coincidence. That it was nothing.

I have always been a very good liar, when the person I am lying to is myself.

It would be months before I stopped. And by then, of course, it was far too late.

## Interlude: Princesses

The innkeeper stopped speaking. For a long time, nobody said anything.

Chronicler's pen had stopped moving. He sat with it poised above the page, a single drop of ink trembling at the tip of the nib. He was looking at the innkeeper with an expression of mingled wonder and something that was almost dismay.

"You told me," he said slowly. "Just now. You told me who she is."

The innkeeper looked at him. His green eyes were very calm.

"Did I?"

"The crest. The tower and three stars. The royal house of Modeg. You said her name."

"I said a princess of Modeg had disappeared. I said her name was Ariel. I said I saw a banner in a gallery." The innkeeper's voice was mild. "I never said Auri was Ariel. I promised I'd never say it, and I haven't." He smiled faintly. "You can draw your own conclusions. That's what scribes are for."

Chronicler stared at him. Then, slowly, he looked down at the page in front of him. At the tiny, crabbed cipher that recorded every word the innkeeper had spoken.

He put down his pen.

"I won't write it," he said.

The innkeeper raised an eyebrow.

"The ring. The crest. The banner." Chronicler's voice was quiet but firm. "I'll leave it out. I'll write that you found a signet ring among



her things, and that you promised never to learn whose it was, and that you kept that promise. That's all."

"That's not the true story."

"It's true enough." Chronicler looked up. "It's the truth she'd want told."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Something moved in his face, something warm and surprised.

"You're an interesting man, Devan Lochees," he said. "I think I underestimated you."

"Most people do." Chronicler picked up his pen again. He looked at the page. Then, carefully, he drew a line through a section of text. "I've found it makes them talk more."

Bast laughed. It was a sudden, delighted sound, and it seemed to surprise even him. He clapped his hand over his mouth, but his eyes were dancing.

"Oh, I like him," he said through his fingers. "Reshi, I like him. Can we keep him?"

"He's not a stray cat, Bast."

"No, but he could be. I'd feed him. I'd take him for walks." Bast grinned. "I'd teach him tricks."

Chronicler gave him a look of great dignity and did not dignify that with an answer.

\* \* \*

"The line," said Chronicler, when Bast had subsided. "About princesses. The one in the stories." He hesitated. "People say you stole princesses back from sleeping barrow kings. I always assumed it was one of those things that grew in the telling. A rescue of some lord's daughter from bandits, turned into a fairy tale."

"Most of the stories about me are like that," said the innkeeper. "Something small that grew."

"But this one wasn't."

"No." The innkeeper looked down at his hands. "This one was smaller than the stories. And larger." He was quiet for a moment. "It was one princess, not many. And one barrow king, who was not

wicked, only lonely. And I did not fight him. I sang him to sleep."

"That's not how the stories tell it."

"The stories never tell it right. That's the trouble with stories." The innkeeper smiled, a little sadly. "In the stories, there's a great battle. I fight my way through a horde of undead warriors with a flaming sword and carry the princess out on my shoulder while the barrow collapses behind me. There's usually a dragon, for some reason. People like dragons."

"There was a draccus in Trebon," said Chronicler.

"And people have never stopped talking about it." The innkeeper shook his head. "No. What really happened was quieter than that. It was a lullaby, sung in the dark to a tired old man who had been waiting too long for something that might never come." He paused. "I think about that sometimes. More than I'd like."

"Why?"

The innkeeper looked around the common room of the Waystone. At the empty tables, the dark wood of the bar, the bottles on their shelves. At the sword hanging over the hearth.

"Because," he said quietly, "I know how he felt."

\* \* \*

Bast had stopped smiling.

He sat in his backward chair with his arms folded across its back and his chin resting on his arms, and he looked at the innkeeper with an expression that Chronicler could not read. It was not sympathy, exactly. It was something older and more complicated than that. Something with teeth.

"Reshi," he said softly. "You never told me about the Sleeper."

"I've never told anyone about the Sleeper."

"But you should have told *me*." There was an edge to Bast's voice. "You know what that means. What he said to you. *Key*. You know what that means."

"I know what it means now. I didn't then."

"But you know now." Bast leaned forward. "And he told you. He *warned* you. *Do not come to the door*. And you—"

"Bast."

The word was very quiet. It was not a command, exactly. But Bast stopped. He sat back in his chair. His jaw was tight and his eyes were bright, but he did not say anything more.

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then he sighed.

"Yes," he said. "He warned me. And yes, I went anyway. You know that. You were there, at the end." He turned his cup a quarter turn on the table. "But we're not at the end yet. We're not even at the middle. And if you keep interrupting, we'll never get there at all."

Bast's mouth twisted. For a moment he looked as if he wanted to say something else. Then he looked away, out the window, at the thin grey line of smoke still leaning above the trees.

"Fine," he said. "Go on."

The innkeeper looked at Chronicler. "Where was I?"

Chronicler glanced at his notes. "Auri was well again. You'd promised not to learn who she was."

"Yes." The innkeeper nodded slowly. "Yes. And the term went on. And for a while, a few spans, things were quiet. I went to class. I worked in the Fishery. I played at the Eolian. I worked on my father's song." He smiled faintly. "It was the last quiet time I ever had. I didn't know that, of course. You never know when the last quiet time is. If you did, you'd savor it more."

He was silent for a moment.

"And then," he said, "Devi came to me with a plan."

\* \* \*

Outside the window of the Waystone, the sun had passed its height and begun its long slow slide toward evening. The shadows of the trees stretched out across the fields like fingers. A few farmers were working in the distance, bent over their rows, their shapes small and dark against the pale earth.

At the edge of the wood, where the smoke rose, something moved.

It was very small. Very quick. A flicker of darkness at the edge of the trees, there and gone again, like a bird darting between branches.

No one in the fields looked up. No one noticed.

Bast noticed. He was sitting very still at the table, his eyes on the window, his face blank. He watched the place where the darkness had flickered for a long time.

Then he looked back at the innkeeper, who was talking now about Devi's rooms above the butcher's shop, and a map spread out on a table, and a plan that was very clever and very foolish in equal measure.

Bast listened. But his hand, resting on the table, had curled into a fist. And beneath the table, where no one could see, his other hand had slipped into the pocket of his coat, and closed around something small and hard and cold.

## Interlude: Why a Scribe

"Why do you do it?" said Bast.

It was a little after noon. The innkeeper had gone into the kitchen to see about the bread, and for the first time in two days, Chronicler found himself alone at the table by the hearth with Bast. The young man was sitting in his backward chair, chin on his folded arms, looking at Chronicler with an expression of frank curiosity.

"Do what?"

"Write things down. Other people's things." Bast tilted his head. "You've been scratching away at that paper for two days and a half. Your hand's all cramped up. I've seen you rub it when you think no one's looking." He nodded at the stack of pages. "Why?"

Chronicler set down his pen. He flexed his fingers. They ached, as they always did by the middle of a long telling, a deep dull ache in the joints that no amount of rubbing would ease.

"It's my trade," he said.

"That's not an answer. That's a way of not answering." Bast smiled. It was not an entirely pleasant smile. "Reshi taught me that one."

Chronicler looked at him for a long moment. Then, somewhat to his own surprise, he told him.

\* \* \*

"My father was a scribe," he said. "In Tinuë. In the counting-house of a wool merchant. He copied ledgers. Bills of sale. Contracts. Twelve hours a day, six days a span, for thirty years." He turned his pen over

in his fingers. "He had the most beautiful hand you ever saw. Every letter perfect. And he never once in his life wrote anything that mattered."

Bast said nothing.

"When I was nine, my grandmother came to live with us. My mother's mother. She was very old, and she was dying, and she knew it. And she had stories." Chronicler smiled faintly. "Oh, she had stories. About the village she grew up in, in the hills above Rannish. About the flood that took half of it when she was a girl. About a man who could talk to bees. About the winter the wolves came down, and her father went out with a pitchfork and never came back." He was quiet for a moment. "She told them to me every night. For a year. And then she died."

"And you wrote them down."

"No." Chronicler shook his head. "That's the thing. I didn't. I was nine. I thought she'd always be there. I thought I'd always remember." He set down the pen. "And a year after she died, I realized I'd forgotten half of them. And two years after, I'd forgotten most of the rest. And now—" He spread his hands. "Now I remember the man who could talk to bees. And that's all. I don't remember what he said to them. I don't remember his name. I don't remember what happened to him."

The common room was very quiet. From the kitchen came the sound of the innkeeper moving about, the clink of a pan.

"So I learned my father's trade," said Chronicler. "But I didn't use it for ledgers. I went out into the world and found old people with stories and sat with them and wrote them down. Every word. Before they were gone." He looked at the stack of pages at his elbow. "I've been doing it for twenty years. I have trunks of them. Rooms full. Stories no one will ever read, most of them. Stories about floods and wolves and men who talk to bees." He smiled. "I can't stop. Every time I meet someone old, I think, *what are you going to take with you when you go?*"

\* \* \*

Bast was looking at him with a strange expression. The curiosity had gone out of it. Something else had come in.

"That's why you came," he said slowly. "Here. For him. Not because he's famous."

"I came because Skarpi told me to." Chronicler hesitated. "And because I'd heard the stories, of course. Everyone has. But—" He stopped. He looked toward the kitchen door. "When I came in that first night, and saw him behind the bar, I thought, *there's a man carrying something heavy. And no one's ever asked him to set it down.*"

Bast did not say anything for a long time.

"He's not old," he said at last.

"No." Chronicler looked at him. "But he's been waiting to die for a long time. Hasn't he? I could see that too."

Bast's face went very still.

"Yes," he said quietly. "Yes. He has."

\* \* \*

The kitchen door swung open. The innkeeper came out, carrying a loaf of bread on a board, and a knife, and a crock of butter. He set them on the table and looked from one of them to the other.

"You've been talking about me," he said mildly.

"No, Reshi," said Bast.

"Yes, Reshi," said Chronicler, at the same moment.

The innkeeper looked at them both. Then, very faintly, the corner of his mouth moved.

"Well," he said, and sat down, and began to cut the bread. "I suppose that's fair. I've been talking about me for two days." He set a slice in front of Chronicler. "Eat. Your hand needs a rest. And then I'll tell you about a set of stairs, and a door, and the worst idea I ever had." He paused. "One of the worst."

Chronicler ate. It was very good bread.

And when he picked up his pen again, a little later, he found that his hand did not ache quite so much as it had. He did not know why. But he found himself thinking of an old woman in a house in Tinuë, telling stories to a boy by the fire, and he found that he was glad, very

glad, to be sitting at this table, writing this down.  
Before it was gone.



## Interlude: Knuckles

"Your hands," said the innkeeper. "What happened to them?"

Chronicler looked down. He had been writing for so long that he had forgotten about his hands, except as things that held the pen. Now he looked at them. The knuckles of his right hand were scabbed and swollen, purple and yellow at the edges, and there was a split across the first knuckle that had broken open again with the writing and was seeping a little, staining the edge of the page.

"Nothing," he said. "I fell."

"You fell on your knuckles." The innkeeper's voice was mild. "Only the right hand. Only the first two knuckles. In a straight line." He looked at Chronicler with his green eyes. "I have seen a great many men who fell, scribe. And I have seen a great many men who hit something. Those are not the same."

Bast, in his backward chair, grinned.

Chronicler felt his face go hot. He put down his pen and folded his hands in his lap, under the table, where no one could see them.

"It's not important," he said.

"Everything's important," said the innkeeper. "You said so yourself, on the first night. The small things hold up the big ones." He leaned back in his chair. "I've been talking for two days. You've been listening. I think I'm owed a story."

\* \* \*

Chronicler did not answer for a long time. He looked at the fire. He looked at his satchel, leaning against the leg of the table, with its pens

and its inks and its stack of blank paper.

"It was in Rannish," he said at last. "Nine days ago. On my way here."

The innkeeper waited.

"There's a square," said Chronicler. "In the middle of the town. With a Tehlin church on one side. And when I came through, there was a crowd in the square, and a fire. A bonfire. In the middle of the day." He was quiet for a moment. "They were burning books."

Bast's grin went away.

"Not many books," said Chronicler. "Rannish is a small town. There aren't many books to burn. A few prayer books that the priest said were heretical translations. An almanac with the wrong feast days in it. Some broadsheets. Songs, mostly. The kind that tinkers sell for a penny." He looked at his hands under the table. "And a book of stories. Old ones. A collection. It had belonged to a schoolmaster who'd died that winter, and his widow had given it to the church, and the priest had read it and decided it was full of pagan filth."

"Was it?" said the innkeeper.

"It had the story of Lanre in it," said Chronicler. "The old version. The one where he's not wholly a villain. And the story of Taborlin, and the story of the Ruh leaving their city, and a dozen others." He was quiet for a moment. "It was a very good book. I could see that, even from the edge of the crowd. Hand-copied. Old. The kind of thing that there might only be one of, anywhere in the world."

\* \* \*

"I went up to the priest," said Chronicler. "I didn't mean to. I meant to walk on. I had somewhere to be. I'd been told—" He glanced at Bast. "I'd been told there was someone in Newarre I needed to see, and I shouldn't dawdle." He looked back at the fire. "But I went up to him anyway. And I asked him, very politely, if I could buy the book. Before he burned it. I said I'd pay whatever he liked."

"And?"

"And he said no. He said it was the devil's work and it would go into the fire like the rest." Chronicler's voice was very even. "And I

said that it was a history. That it was the only record of those stories in that form. That whatever he thought of them, they were *old*, and they were true in their way, and someone should keep them. Even if it wasn't him." He paused. "And he said that the only true stories were in the Book of the Path, and everything else was lies, and lies should burn."

"And then he threw the book in the fire," said the innkeeper quietly.

"And then he threw the book in the fire."

\* \* \*

The common room was very still.

"I hit him," said Chronicler. "I didn't decide to. I've never hit anyone in my life. I'm a scribe. I've spent my whole life sitting at desks, copying things. But I watched that book go into the fire, and the pages start to curl, and I hit him. In the face. As hard as I could." He almost laughed. "It was a very bad punch. I'd never thrown one before. I think I hurt my hand more than his face."

"And the crowd?"

"The crowd didn't like it." Chronicler looked down. "They pulled me off him. And they held me. And some of them hit me back. Not too badly. A few kicks. A few punches. The priest had them stop, after a while. He said I was a madman, and I should be driven out of town, and not harmed further, because Tehlu is merciful." His mouth twisted. "So they drove me out of town."

"And the book?"

Chronicler was quiet for a long time.

"I got some of it," he said.

\* \* \*

He reached down to his satchel. He opened it and took out something wrapped in a clean cloth. He set it on the table and unwrapped it, very carefully.

It was a handful of pages. Old pages, soft and yellowed, the edges black and crumbling where the fire had caught them. Perhaps a dozen

of them. Loose, with the stitching burned away.

"When they pulled me off him," said Chronicler, "I fell against the edge of the fire. And I put my hand in it." He turned his right hand over, showing the palm. It was red and shiny and blistered. "And I grabbed what I could. I didn't look. I just grabbed. And then they were dragging me away and I held on." He looked at the pages. "This is what I got. Twelve pages. Out of three hundred."

The innkeeper leaned forward. He looked at the pages without touching them. His face was very still.

"What's on them?" he said softly.

Chronicler turned the top page toward him. It was written in a small, faded, careful hand, in old-fashioned letters. The top of the page was burned away. But the rest was clear.

*—and the singer went down into the dark place beneath the city, where the door was, and sang to it. And the door listened, as doors do. And it is said that as long as someone sings to it, it will not open. But the singers are all gone now, and no one remembers the song—*

The page ended there. The rest was ash.

\* \* \*

Nobody said anything for a very long time.

The innkeeper sat looking at the burned page. His hands were flat on the table. His face showed nothing at all. But Chronicler, watching him, saw his left hand move. Very slightly. Toward the page. And stop. And curl, slowly, into a fist.

"Where did you say this book came from?" said the innkeeper at last. His voice was very quiet.

"A schoolmaster in Rannish. He'd had it from his father, the widow said. And his father from his. It was very old."

"Twelve pages," said the innkeeper.

"Out of three hundred."

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment. Then he looked up at Chronicler. And something in his face had changed. Something in his eyes. For a moment—just a moment—they were not the eyes of an innkeeper at all.

"You put your hand in a fire," he said, "for a book you'd never read. About stories you didn't know were true. Because a priest said lies should burn."

Chronicler did not answer.

"And you hit him," said the innkeeper. "A scribe. Who's never hit anyone in his life."

"It was a very bad punch," said Chronicler.

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. And then, very slowly, the corner of his mouth moved.

"Skarpi chose well," he said.

\* \* \*

He did not say anything else about it. He sat back in his chair, and after a while he said, "Where was I?" in his ordinary voice, and went on with the story.

But later that night, when the telling was done for the day, and Chronicler had gone up to his room, there was a knock on his door. And when he opened it, there was no one there. Only a small clay pot on the floor of the passage, with a wooden lid. And a folded note, in a quick, neat, slanting hand.

*For the burn. And the knuckles. Rub it in twice a day. It will sting. You'll want your hand. There's a great deal left to write.*

—K.

Chronicler used it, twice a day, as instructed. It stung like the devil.

By the next morning, his hand did not hurt at all. But the knuckles stayed scabbed and dark, the way knuckles do, and every time he looked down at them, holding the pen, he remembered a fire in a square in Rannish. And twelve pages out of three hundred.

And the song that no one remembers anymore.

\* \* \*

He gave the pages to the innkeeper, on the last morning. He did not say why. He only held them out, wrapped in their clean cloth, and the innkeeper looked at them for a long time, and then took them.

"There were three hundred," said the innkeeper softly.

"I know."

"Someone should write the rest down. Before it's gone." He looked at Chronicler. "All the rest. Every story anyone still remembers. Before the priests burn them and the tinkers forget them and the last old man who knows them dies."

"That's a great deal of writing."

"Yes." The innkeeper tucked the pages inside his shirt, against his chest. "You'd better take care of your hands."

## Chapter Twenty-Six

# Plans

"It's the Nighting," Devi said. "Of course it's the Nighting."

She had a map spread out across her desk, pinned flat at the corners with a teacup, an inkwell, a small brass scale, and her cat, who had lain down on the northeast corner and refused to be moved. The map was very old and very large and drawn on something that was not quite paper and not quite parchment. It showed the Archives. Not the Archives as I knew it, with its Stacks and Tomes and long dim reading rooms, but something older. A plan of the foundations. Of the rooms beneath.

"The Nighting?" said Fela.

She was sitting beside me on Devi's narrow bed, her hands folded in her lap, looking at the map with an expression of polite horror. I had not wanted to bring her. I had argued against it for most of a span. But Devi had insisted, and in the end, Fela had insisted too.

"You need someone who can hear stone," she had said, quietly, when I tried to talk her out of it. "You can barely hear it. I can hear it well. If there's a door down there, and it's made of stone, you'll need me."

"If we're caught, they'll expel you."

"I know."

"You've worked so hard. You're almost a Re'lar. You could be a master someday."

"I know." She had looked at me with her dark, serious eyes. "But I've been hearing that thing under the stone for two years now, Kvothe.

The hungry thing. I hear it every night. I want to know what it is." She had smiled faintly. "And I don't want you going down there alone. You'll do something stupid."

I had not been able to argue with that.

"The Nighting," Devi repeated, tapping the map. "The festival. It's the one night of the year when the Archives are empty. The scrivs all go to the feast in Imre, and Lorren locks the doors at sundown and goes to his rooms and doesn't come out till morning." She looked up at us. "It's the only night when nobody will be anywhere near the Four-plate door."

"And you know this how?" I asked.

"Because I tried to do this before." She smiled thinly. "On the Nighting. Six years ago. I got caught because I didn't know about the second seal." She tapped a place on the map, deep beneath the Archives, where a small square room was marked with a sigil I did not recognize. "I made it past the Four-plate door. I got into the stairwell. I got down three flights. And then I hit this, and it went off like a bell, and Lorren was there inside of a quarter-hour."

"You made it past the Four-plate door?" said Fela.

"Not through it. Around it." Devi traced a line on the map with one finger. It ran from the edge of the page, where a series of small dashes indicated what I recognized as the Underthing, up through the foundations and into a narrow shaft that ran alongside the great stairwell behind the Four-plate door. "There's an old air shaft. It was sealed off hundreds of years ago, but the seal's cracked. You can get into it from the Underthing, and it runs straight up to a grate in the side of the stairwell, below the door."

I stared at the map. "How did you find that?"

"I looked." She shrugged. "I told you. Nobody asks about the things right under their noses."

"And the second seal?"

"That's the problem." Devi sat back in her chair. "I don't know what it is. It's not sympathy. Not any kind I've ever seen. It's not alchemy either. It's just—there. A room at the bottom of the third



flight. Empty, as far as I could tell. Stone walls, stone floor, stone ceiling. And the moment I stepped into it, it *rang*." She shook her head. "Not a sound. Something else. I felt it in my teeth. And somewhere, Lorren felt it too."

Fela and I looked at each other.

"Stone," Fela said quietly.

"What?"

"It's stone. The seal. It's made of stone. Named stone." Fela looked at the map, at the little square room. "Someone asked the stone to listen for anyone coming down those stairs. And when you came, it told."

Devi stared at her. "That's not possible."

"It's possible," I said. "If someone knew the name of stone. If they knew it very, very well." I looked at Fela. "Could you ask it not to tell?"

She was quiet for a long time.

"Maybe," she said at last. "If I could hear it. If it would listen." She bit her lip. "I've never asked stone for anything. I've only ever heard it. Once, I broke it, but I didn't mean to. I don't know if I can make it do something on purpose."

"Can you try?"

She looked at me. Her face was pale, but her eyes were steady.

"Yes," she said. "I can try."

\* \* \*

We spent the next two spans preparing.

It was a strange time. On the surface, everything was ordinary. I went to class and worked in the Fishery and played at the Eolian. I ate with Sim and Wil and told them nothing. I worked on my father's song late into the night, and sometimes, when the words would not come, I lit Kilvin's candle and sat watching it burn yellow until my eyes grew heavy.

But underneath, everything was different. Every day after classes, I went down into the Underthing and found my way to the place Devi had marked on her map, where the old air shaft came down through

the stone. It took me three days to find it. It was hidden behind a fall of rubble in a part of the tunnels even Auri rarely visited, and the entrance was so narrow I had to take off my cloak and shirt to squeeze through.

On the other side, the shaft went up. Straight up, into darkness. The walls were rough stone, cold and damp, and there were iron rungs set into them at intervals, so rusted that some of them crumbled in my hand when I tested them.

I climbed it. It took me the better part of an hour, going slowly, testing every rung, bracing myself against the walls when the rungs gave out. At the top, I found the grate. It was old iron, rusted almost through, set into the side of a wide stone stairwell that spiraled down into darkness.

I put my face to the grate and looked through.

The stairwell was enormous. Wider than any stair I had ever seen, wide enough to march an army down twenty abreast. The steps were worn in the center, hollowed out by the passage of countless feet over countless years. Far above me, I could see the underside of a great slab of stone, gray and smooth, with four circles of dull copper set into it.

The Four-plate door. From the other side.

Far below me, the stairs spiraled down and down, into a darkness so deep it seemed to have weight.

I stayed there for a long time, looking down. I did not open the grate. I did not go through. But I listened.

And from far below, faint as a whisper, I heard the stone saying no. And beneath it, hungry, that other thing.

\* \* \*

Fela practiced too.

She did not tell me much about it. She was private about her naming, the way some people are private about prayer. But I knew she went down into the Underthing with me sometimes, to the places where the stone was old and deep, and sat for hours with her hands pressed flat against the walls. I knew she came back pale and shaking, and that she slept badly, and that she would sometimes stop in the

middle of a sentence and stare off into nothing, listening to something I could not hear.

Once, I found her in the Twelve, sitting in the center of the great round room with her eyes closed and her palms flat on the floor. Her lips were moving. She was speaking, very softly, in a language I did not know.

I stood in the doorway and did not interrupt. And after a long time, I heard something.

It was the stone. It was answering her.

Not with words. With a kind of hum, a deep low vibration that I felt in the soles of my feet and the pit of my stomach. It rose up out of the floor and filled the room, and the dust on the walls trembled with it, and the air grew thick and heavy.

Fela opened her eyes. She looked up at me. Her face was white as bone, and there were tears running down her cheeks.

"It listened," she whispered. "Kvothe, it *listened*."

\* \* \*

Devi prepared in her own way. She spent those two spans in her rooms above the butcher's shop, surrounded by her books and her papers and her alchemical bench, working on something she would not tell me about. When I came to see her, the air was thick with strange smells, and there were burns on her fingers, and her eyes were bright and feverish behind her spectacles.

"Insurance," she said, when I asked. "In case the stone doesn't listen."

"What kind of insurance?"

She smiled her spider's smile. "The kind that makes a great deal of noise and a great deal of smoke and gives us a great deal of time to run."

I did not ask any more questions after that.

\* \* \*

The night before the Nighting, I went to see Auri.

I found her in Mantle, arranging her treasures on their shelf. She was well again, or nearly. She hummed as she worked, and she smiled when she saw me, and she accepted the small bag of dried cherries I had brought her with great solemnity and pronounced them "joyful."

I sat with her for a while and watched her work. She was moving her treasures around, trying them in different places, standing back to look at them with her head tilted to one side. It was a slow, careful, patient process. She would move a single pebble half an inch to the left, look at it for a long time, and then move it back.

"Auri," I said at last. "I'm going somewhere tomorrow night. Somewhere deep."

She stopped moving. She did not turn around.

"The deep door," she said. It was not a question.

"Yes."

She was quiet for a long time. Then she set down the pebble she was holding, very carefully, and turned to look at me.

"The Sleeper told you not to," she said.

"I know."

"He told you not to, and you're going anyway."

"I'm not going to open it. I just want to see it. I need to know what's behind it."

She looked at me with her enormous eyes. There was no reproach in them. There was only sadness, deep and quiet and very old.

"You can't see a door without wanting to open it," she said softly. "That's what doors are for."

I did not have an answer to that.

She came and sat down beside me. She took my hand in both of hers and held it, the way she had held her ring. Her fingers were very cold.

"I'll light a candle for you," she said. "In Hush. Where the Underthing keeps its secrets. And I'll ask the stone to be kind to you." She squeezed my hand. "It doesn't always listen. But sometimes it does."

"Thank you, Auri."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she leaned forward and kissed me on the forehead, very lightly, the way a mother kisses a child.

"Be careful, Kvothe," she said. "Be careful and be polite and don't take anything that isn't yours." She paused. "And if the door speaks to you, don't answer. Whatever it says. Don't answer."

"What would it say?"

She let go of my hand. She stood up and went back to her shelf and picked up the pebble she had been moving.

"It would say your name," she said, without turning around. "And it would ask you to come in."

## Chapter Twenty-Seven

# The Stable

I played at the Eolian the night before the Nighting. I did not know it would be the last time I played there for a very long time. You never know which time is the last. If you did, you would play differently.

Or perhaps you would not. Perhaps you would play exactly the same, because that is the only way you know how to play. I have thought about it a great deal, and I have never decided.

\* \* \*

It was a slow night. Half the students were already across the river preparing for the festival, and the other half were saving their money for it, and the Eolian was barely a third full. A fiddler played early in the evening, and a pair of sisters who sang harmony, and a very old man with a hurdy-gurdy who played the same four songs he had been playing at the Eolian for thirty years and was applauded each time as if the songs were new.

I played late. When the crowd had thinned even further and the candles on the tables had burned down to stubs. I played "Tinker Tanner" for the few who were left, and a sad Modegan song about a woman waiting at a window, and a song of my own that I had never played for anyone, a song about a girl sitting on the roof of a building with a candle in her hand. I did not say who the girl was. No one asked.

When I finished, there were perhaps a dozen people left in the great round room. They applauded, quietly, the way people applaud at

the end of a long night. And then they gathered their cloaks and went out into the cold, and the Eolian was empty except for me, and Deoch at the door, and Stanchion behind the bar.

"Stay a bit," said Stanchion. "Have a drink. On the house."

I stayed.

\* \* \*

He poured two glasses of something dark and sweet from a bottle he kept under the bar, a bottle I had never seen him pour for anyone. He came around the bar and sat down at a table near the stage, and I sat across from him, and Deoch came and sat with us, and for a while nobody said anything.

The Eolian was very quiet. Very dim. The candles were guttering. The stage was empty. The balconies circling above were dark. It is a strange thing, an empty hall at night, after music. It seems to hold the music still, somehow, in the air. As if the notes have not quite finished fading.

"Twenty-two years," said Stanchion at last.

I looked at him.

"Twenty-two years I've owned this place," he said. He turned his glass slowly on the table. "Twenty-two years this spring. Did I ever tell you how I got it?"

"You said it was a stable."

"It was a stable." Stanchion smiled. It was a slow smile, under his beard, and it made his big face look younger. "A livery stable. Owned by a man named Horn. He kept thirty horses in here, and a smithy out back, and he let the place go to rot. The roof leaked. The walls were cracked. There was horse dung on the floor three inches deep, and rats in the rafters as big as cats." He laughed softly. "I was nineteen. I'd just come to Imre from the Small Kingdoms with two talents in my pocket and a lute I couldn't play."

"You played?"

"Badly. Very badly. Worse than the hurdy-gurdy man." Stanchion drank from his glass. "I wanted to be a musician. More than anything. I'd heard stories about Imre, back home. About the University, and the

musicians, and the halls where they played for lords and ladies. I thought I'd come here and be famous." He shook his head. "I lasted three months. Played in every tavern that would have me. Nobody wanted to hear me twice."

"What happened?"

"I ran out of money. And I was sleeping rough, in doorways, and one night it rained, and I came in here to get out of it. Horn didn't mind. He let anyone sleep in the loft if they mucked out a stall in the morning." He looked around the great round room. "I lay up there in the straw that night, listening to the rain on the roof, and I looked down at the stalls and the horses and the dung, and I thought, *this is a good room.*"

Deoch laughed. "You thought a stable was a good room."

"I did." Stanchion was not embarrassed. "It was round, you see. Horn had built it round, for some reason. Round walls, round roof. And when it rained, the sound went all around you. Like being inside a drum." He was quiet for a moment. "And I thought, if you took out the stalls, and cleaned the floor, and put a stage in the middle, this would be the best room for music in the world."

\* \* \*

"So you bought it," I said.

"Not then. I didn't have two pennies to rub together." Stanchion smiled. "I worked for Horn. Mucking out stalls. Shoeing horses. Two years. And every night I lay up in that loft and looked down at the room and planned. Where the stage would go. Where the bar would go. How high the balconies should be, so the sound would carry." He laughed softly. "I used to go to the Pony and the Grey Man and every other hall in Imre, and stand at the back, and listen. Not to the music. To the room. How the sound moved. Where it went dead. Where it rang."

"And then?"

"And then Horn died. Fell off a horse, drunk, and broke his neck. And his widow wanted nothing to do with the place. She wanted to sell it to a butcher who was going to tear it down and build a



slaughterhouse." Stanchion's face went grim for a moment. "I went to her. I begged. I had eleven talents saved from two years of mucking stalls. It wasn't a tenth of what the butcher was offering."

"What did she say?"

Stanchion looked at me. His eyes were bright in the candlelight.

"She said, *Can you play?* And I said, *No. Not well.* And she said, *Then what do you want a music hall for?*" He was quiet for a moment. "And I said, *Because I can't play. And I want to spend the rest of my life listening to people who can.*"

The empty hall was very quiet.

"She sold it to me for eleven talents," said Stanchion. "And a promise. That I'd never turn away a musician who was hungry. That I'd always give them a meal and a place to sleep, whether they could play or not." He smiled. "I've kept that promise for twenty-two years."

\* \* \*

Deoch was looking at him with an expression I had never seen on Deoch's face before. Something soft. Something almost like reverence.

"You never told me that," he said. "About the widow."

"You never asked." Stanchion drank. "Nobody ever asks. They just see the Eolian, and the stage, and the pipes, and they think it's always been here. Like the river. Like the bridge." He looked around the room. "They don't know I built every stone of that stage myself. Carried them up from the quarry on my back, two at a time. They don't know I carved every rail on those balconies. They don't know I sat up in that loft for two years, planning."

"I know now," I said.

Stanchion looked at me. Then he smiled.

"You do," he said. "You do. And you'll remember it. You've got that look. The look of someone who remembers things." He reached across the table and put his big hand over mine. "That's why I told you. So someone would remember."

\* \* \*

We sat there for a long time after that, the three of us, in the dim candlelight, drinking Stanchion's dark sweet wine. Deoch told a story about a lute player from Atur who had come to the Eolian twenty years ago and tried to win his pipes by playing with his feet. Stanchion told a story about the night the old Earl of Tarsh had got so drunk in the second balcony that he had fallen into the orchestra pit and landed on a cellist. I told them a story about a troupe of Ruh who had tried to put on a play in a village in the Small Kingdoms and been chased out of town by a goat.

We laughed a great deal. It was a good night. One of the best.

And then, very late, Stanchion looked at me across the table and said, "What are you doing tomorrow night, Kvothe?"

I went very still.

"Tomorrow night?"

"The Nighting. Everyone's going across the river for the festival." He looked at me. "But you're not. I can see it in your face. You've got something planned."

I did not answer.

Stanchion looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded, very slowly, as if I had told him something.

"Whatever it is," he said, "be careful."

"I will."

"No. You won't. You've never been careful in your life." He smiled, very faintly. "But try. For me. The Eolian needs you. Somebody's got to play here when I'm too old to listen."

"You'll never be too old to listen."

"Everyone gets too old for something." Stanchion stood up. He gathered up the glasses and the bottle. He looked down at me. "Go home, Kvothe. Get some sleep. Whatever you're doing tomorrow, you'll want your wits about you."

\* \* \*

I went home. I did not sleep much.

But I remember walking back across the bridge, in the cold clear dark, with my lute on my back and Stanchion's dark wine warm in my

stomach. I remember stopping at the top of the arch and looking back at Imre, at the lights in the windows, and the dark round shape of the Eolian among the other rooftops.

I remember thinking that it was a good room. The best room for music in the world.

And I remember thinking that one day, when I was very old and very famous and very tired, I would come back to the Eolian and sit at a table near the stage with Stanchion, both of us grey-haired, and listen to some young musician play. And I would tell him that I remembered. About the stable, and the widow, and the eleven talents.

I did not know, standing on the bridge that night, that Stanchion had less than a year to live.

I did not know that I would be the reason.

\* \* \*

I have told you that he died on the second balcony of the Eolian, the night I sang *Tariniel*, with his beard gone white and his face gone grey, standing between Usnea and the cellar stairs with two empty buckets in his hands.

I have told you what he said to her. *Not in my place.*

I did not tell you what he said to her after that. The thing I could not hear, from the stage, over the noise of the fire and the screaming. The thing that made Usnea tilt her head, and pause, and look at him with something in her pale face that might have been surprise.

Deoch told me, later. He had been on the stairs below, close enough to hear.

"He said, *There's a girl in the cellar,*" Deoch told me. His voice was very rough. "*She's holding up my walls. You leave her be.*" He was quiet for a moment. "And then he said, *I built this place from a stable. With my own two hands. You can have me. But you can't have her, and you can't have my walls.*"

I did not say anything. I could not.

"And that thing—that woman—she looked at him," said Deoch. "For a long time. With her hand on his chest. And then she took her hand away, and he fell, and she didn't go down the stairs." He looked

at me. "She didn't go down, Kvothe. She stood there, and she listened to you sing, and she didn't go down." His voice cracked. "I think he talked her out of it. I think the old bastard talked a Chandrian out of it."

\* \* \*

The walls of the Eolian stood, afterward. You know that. They stood through the fire, blackened and scorched and cracked, but standing. And Deoch rebuilt the inside of it, stone by stone, the way Stanchion had built it the first time.

He told me, years later, in a letter, that when he was clearing the rubble out of the cellar, he found something carved into one of the foundation stones. Low down, near the floor, where no one would ever see it. Very old. Very worn. Carved with a knife by someone who did not know much about carving.

It was a date. Twenty-two years before. And beneath it, three words.

*A good room.*

## Chapter Twenty-Eight

# Valaritas

The Nighting fell on a cold clear night at the end of winter, when the snow had begun to soften and grey at the edges and the icicles dripped all day long in the thin sunshine. It was a festival of lights, the Nighting, an old Aturan custom that had outlived the empire that invented it. On the longest night of late winter, people hung lanterns in their windows and set candles on their doorsteps and walked through the streets with torches, singing, to remind the dark that it would not last forever.

Imre was ablaze with it. From the top of the stone bridge, looking across the river, the whole town seemed to be on fire. Lanterns hung from every eave. Bonfires burned in every square. The sound of music and laughter drifted across the water, and the smell of roasting meat and spiced wine.

The University was dark.

Most of the students had gone across the river to the feast. The few who remained had shut themselves in their rooms, or gathered in small quiet groups at Anker's or the Mews. The courtyards were empty. The great grey buildings stood silent and shadowed against the stars.

And the Archives stood darkest of all. A great windowless block of stone, black against the sky, like a hole cut in the night.

\* \* \*

We met at the grate behind the Mains an hour after sundown. Devi came wrapped in a dark cloak with a heavy satchel over her shoulder, her pale hair tucked up beneath a knitted cap. Fela came in a plain grey dress and sturdy boots, her face pale and set. I had my sympathy lamp, and a coil of rope, and a small bag of tools, and Elodin's stone in my pocket.

And I had Caesura.

I had not meant to bring it. I had not worn my sword since I came back from Ademre; it did not seem right, somehow, to carry it through the halls of the University. But when I had stood in my room that evening, gathering my things, I had found myself reaching for it. I had strapped it on without thinking, the way you might put on a coat before going out into the cold.

Devi looked at it and raised an eyebrow. "Expecting trouble?"

"I don't know what I'm expecting."

"That," she said, "is the most sensible thing you've said in two spans." She looked at Fela. "Ready?"

Fela nodded. She did not speak. She had not spoken much all day. We went down.

\* \* \*

I led the way through the Underthing. I knew the path well by now. Down through the Twelve, along the passage Auri called Downway, past the steep narrow slope that led to the Cellarage. I did not look down that slope as we passed it. I did not want to know if the silver light was burning at the bottom.

At last we came to the fall of rubble that hid the entrance to the air shaft. I pulled away the stones I had loosened on my earlier visits, and we squeezed through one by one. Devi had to take off her satchel and push it ahead of her. Fela went through without a word, her face white in the red light of my lamp.

Then we began to climb.

It was a long climb, and a hard one. The rungs were rusted and treacherous. The walls were slick with damp. I went first, testing each rung before I put my weight on it, calling down warnings to the others

when I found one that was loose. Devi came next, grunting with effort, cursing under her breath in a steady low stream that would have made a sailor blush. Fela came last. She did not curse. She did not speak at all. But she kept up.

At the top, I pried open the grate. It came away easily in my hands, the old iron crumbling with rust. I passed it down to Devi, who passed it down to Fela, who set it carefully on a ledge inside the shaft. Then I climbed through.

I stood on the great stair beneath the Four-plate door.

\* \* \*

It was even larger than I had thought. Looking at it through the grate, I had seen only a small part of it. Now, standing on it, I could see the whole. The stairwell was a vast round shaft cut down into the living rock, easily fifty feet across. The stairs wound around its edge in a great spiral, down and down and down, into a darkness so deep it swallowed the light of my lamp.

Above us, the Four-plate door was a great round slab of grey stone set into the ceiling. It was even larger from this side. The four copper plates were dull and green with age. Around its edge, carved into the stone, was a ring of writing in the same strange script I had seen in the blue book.

*Valaritas*, it said. I did not know how I knew. I could not read the script. But I knew.

Devi climbed through the grate behind me and stood looking up at the door. Her face was very strange. It was the face of a woman who has wanted something for a very long time, and has finally seen it, and does not know whether to laugh or weep.

"There it is," she said softly.

Fela climbed through last. She did not look at the door. She stood very still at the edge of the stair with her hands pressed flat against the wall, and her eyes were closed.

"It's loud here," she whispered. "So loud."

"The stone?"

"Everything." She opened her eyes. "The stone. And what's under it." She shivered. "It knows we're here."

\* \* \*

We went down.

The stairs were wide and shallow and very old. Our footsteps echoed in the vast round shaft, strange and hollow. Devi walked beside me, her satchel clutched against her chest. Fela walked behind us, one hand trailing along the wall.

One flight. Two. The darkness closed in around us, thick and heavy. The air grew colder. My lamp seemed to shrink, its red light pressed in on all sides by the dark.

Three flights.

At the bottom of the third flight, the stairs ended in a landing. A wide flat space of smooth grey stone, and beyond it, an archway. And beyond the archway, a small square room.

It was exactly as Devi had described it. Stone walls, stone floor, stone ceiling. Empty. Perfectly, utterly empty. There was nothing in it at all.

And yet, standing at the edge of the archway, I could feel it. A kind of tension in the air. A watchfulness. The way a room feels when someone is standing in the dark corner, holding their breath.

"That's it," Devi said quietly. "That's the second seal."

Fela stepped forward. She stood at the threshold of the archway and looked into the small square room for a long time.

Then she knelt down and laid her palms flat on the floor.

I held my breath.

For a long time, nothing happened. Fela knelt with her head bowed and her hands on the stone, and she did not move. Her lips were moving, silently. I could not hear what she was saying.

Then I felt it. A hum. Deep and low, rising up out of the floor through the soles of my feet. The same hum I had felt in the Twelve, when Fela had spoken to the stone and it had answered.

It grew louder. The dust on the walls began to tremble. The air grew thick.



And then, all at once, it stopped.

Fela sat back on her heels. Her face was white and wet with tears. She was breathing hard, as if she had been running.

"It's all right," she whispered. "It said it won't tell. For tonight."

"What did you say to it?" I asked.

She looked up at me. Her eyes were very dark.

"I said please," she said.

\* \* \*

We walked through the small square room. It did not ring. It did not do anything at all. It was only a room, stone walls and stone floor and stone ceiling, and on the far side there was another archway, and beyond that, more stairs.

We went down.

The stairs were narrower now. Steeper. They did not spiral anymore. They went straight down, through a tunnel cut into the rock, so narrow we had to walk single file. The ceiling pressed down low over our heads. The walls were rough and unfinished, marked with the scars of tools.

And there was writing on them.

I noticed it first as a kind of texture, a roughness in the stone at the edge of my lamp's light. Then I held the lamp closer and saw that it was letters. Carved into the walls, row after row of them, in the same strange script as the door above. They covered every surface, floor to ceiling, as far as the light would reach.

"What does it say?" Devi breathed.

"I don't know." I ran my fingers over the letters. They were very old. Worn smooth in places, as if by many hands. "I can't read it."

"I can," said Fela.

We both turned to look at her. She was standing a few steps above us, looking at the wall, her face strange in the red light.

"Not read it," she said. "Not exactly. But I can hear it. The stone remembers what it was carved to say." She laid her hand flat on the letters. "It's names," she said softly. "It's all names. Hundreds of them. Thousands. Every one of them carved by a different hand."

"Whose names?"

She closed her eyes. She listened.

"The ones who kept the door," she said. "The ones who came down here, over the years, to make sure it stayed shut. They carved their names so the stone would remember them." She opened her eyes and looked at me. "They were Amyr, Kvothe. All of them. Every name on these walls. They were Amyr."

\* \* \*

We went down. The stairs went on and on, steeper and narrower, the walls covered with names. Thousands of them. Tens of thousands. Men and women who had come down these stairs over the centuries, in the dark, to keep watch over a door.

I thought about Lorren. About what he had told me, on the road by the river. *There were rumors, when I was a boy, that some of them had come here. That they had taken refuge in the Archives, in the old stone rooms beneath the Stacks.*

He had been right. They had been here. Not hiding. Guarding.

And then, at last, the stairs ended.

We came out into a room. A great round room, like the stairwell above but smaller, its walls rising up into darkness. The floor was smooth grey stone, polished like glass, and in the center of the floor, there was a circle of writing, and in the center of the circle there was a table of stone, and on the table there was a book.

And on the far side of the room, set into the wall, there was a door.

It was grey stone. It had no handle. It had no hinges. It had no lock.

It was exactly the door I had dreamed of.

\* \* \*

None of us spoke. We stood at the bottom of the stairs, the three of us, and looked at the door, and the silence was so deep it rang in my ears.

Then, very faintly, I heard it.

Breathing.

Slow and deep and patient. Coming from the other side of the door. The breath of something very large, sleeping very deeply. The breath of something that had been sleeping for a very long time.

Devi's hand found mine in the dark. Her fingers were cold and shaking. Fela stood on my other side, very still, her eyes fixed on the door, her lips pressed together so tightly they had gone white.

"Don't go near it," Fela whispered. "Kvothe. Whatever you do. Don't go near it."

"I won't."

"Promise me."

"I promise."

I did not go near it. I stood at the bottom of the stairs with Devi's hand in mine and Fela at my side, and I looked at the door.

And from the other side of the door, very faintly, something whispered my name.

## Chapter Twenty-Nine

# Behind the Door

I did not answer.

I want that written down. I want it recorded somewhere, in plain ink on plain paper, that on that night, in that room, with that voice whispering my name from the other side of a door of stone, I did not answer. It is one of the few things I did right, in all the long story of my foolishness. I would like it to be remembered.

The voice was soft. It was patient. It was kind, the way a mother's voice is kind when she calls a child in from the dark. It spoke my name, and it was not the name *Kvothe*. It was the other one. The one the Sleeper had spoken, the one I did not know but recognized the way you recognize your own face. It spoke my name as if it had always known me, and it said, without words, *come*.

I stood very still. I thought of Auri, kneeling by her shelf with a pebble in her hand. *If the door speaks to you, don't answer*. I thought of the Sleeper, with his heavy grey eyes. *Do not come to the door. Whatever they tell you. Whatever they offer*.

I held Devi's hand so tightly I felt the small bones grind together. I did not answer.

After a long time, the voice stopped.

The breathing went on. Slow and deep and patient. But the whisper was gone, and the room was silent again, and I felt something let go of me that I had not known was holding on.

I let out my breath. My whole body was shaking.

"Did you hear it?" I said. My voice sounded thin and strange.

"Hear what?" said Devi.

I looked at her. She was looking at me with an expression of confusion and growing alarm. She had not heard it. She had heard nothing at all.

I looked at Fela. She was looking at me too. Her face was white, and her eyes were very wide.

"I heard it," she whispered. "It said something. I couldn't understand it. But it was talking to you."

"Yes."

"What did it say?"

I did not answer that either.

\* \* \*

We did not go near the door. None of us did. We stayed at the edge of the room, as far from it as we could get, and we went to the table in the center of the circle.

It was a plain table, square and solid, carved from the same grey stone as everything else. The book lay in the center of it. It was very large, as large as the great ledgers in Lorren's office, and bound in something that was not leather. It was pale and smooth and faintly translucent, like old horn. There was no title on the cover. There was only a single sigil, pressed into the surface, a sigil I recognized.

It was a tower, burning.

I had seen that sigil before. In the Maer's library in Severen, in an old book on the history of the Aturan church. It was the mark of the Amyr. The Ciridae. The highest of their order, who wore that sign tattooed on their bodies and answered to no law but their own.

Devi reached for the book. I caught her wrist.

"Don't," I said. "Don't take anything."

"I'm not going to take it. I just want to read it." She pulled her wrist away and looked at me. "We came all this way, Kvothe."

She was right. I let go.

She opened the book.

\* \* \*

It was written in Aturan. Old Aturan, very formal and very archaic, the kind of Aturan that the scholars of the empire had used for law and scripture. It was difficult to read, but not impossible. Devi and I had both studied it. We bent over the book together in the red light of my lamp, and we read.

It was a record. A history, of sorts, though not like any history I had ever read. It had been written by many hands over many years, each entry dated and signed with a name I did not recognize. Some entries were long, pages and pages of dense script. Others were only a line or two.

*The door holds. No change. —Tessaly, watching.*

*The door holds. The Sleeper stirred in the night but did not wake. —Aradin, watching.*

*The door holds. There was a sound behind it at the third hour, like a great beast turning over in its sleep. —Mirren, watching.*

On and on, for hundreds of pages. The same words, over and over, like a litany. *The door holds.* A long patient record of men and women who had come down the stairs into the dark to sit in this room and listen to the breathing on the other side of the stone and make sure that nothing changed.

And then, near the front of the book, before the litany began, there was something else.

It was an account. Written in a different hand from the rest, older and more careful. It had no date and no name. It began simply:

*This is the truth of the doors, set down so that those who keep them may know what they keep.*

I read it. Devi read it beside me. Fela stood behind us, looking over our shoulders, and read it too.

I will not tell you all of it. Some of it I did not understand, then or later. Some of it I have forgotten, or tried to. And some of it is not mine to tell. But I will tell you what I learned that night, standing in the dark at the bottom of the world with my friends beside me and the breathing of something vast and terrible in my ears.

\* \* \*

There had been a war, once. Long ago, before the Aturan Empire, before any empire. A war between those who could name the world and those who could shape it.

The namers were those who understood the world as it was. Who could hear the true names of things and speak them, and by speaking them, command. The shapers were something else. They did not understand the world. They changed it. They made new things, things that had never been, things that had no true name because they had no true nature. They made them out of nothing, out of will and want and the raw stuff of creation.

One of the shapers was greater than all the rest. The account did not give his name. It called him only *the Thief*, because of the thing he had stolen: the moon. He had loved her, the account said, and she had not loved him, and so he had taken her. He had torn a hole in the sky and made a place beyond the world where he could keep her, and he had pulled her into it.

But he could not hold her. Not all the way. She was too much a part of the world, too much a part of the sky. And so she was caught between. Half in the world, half out of it. Waxing and waning. Coming and going. Never able to rest.

The war that followed had destroyed nearly everything. Cities had burned. Whole peoples had vanished. The namers and the shapers had torn at each other until the world itself began to come apart at the seams.

And at the end of it, when the shapers were defeated and the namers were few and broken and the world lay in ruins, those who were left had done a thing.

They had taken the Thief and put him away.

Not killed him. They could not kill him. He was too strong, and too strange, and there was no name in the world that could unmake him, because he had made himself into something that had no name. So they had done the only thing they could. They had shut him away, beyond the world, in the place he had made to hold the moon. And they had sealed the way behind him with doors of stone.

Seven doors, the account said. Seven doors in seven places, each one a face of the same prison. Seven locks on the same box. And each door had its keeping, and each keeping had its keepers, and the keepers were bound to watch the doors until the end of the world.

*The first door lies beneath the house of Loeclos, the account said, and it is the keeper's door, for it alone may be opened, and only by the line of Loeclos, with the key of stone. The line was chosen because it was the Thief's own line, and his blood knows his prison. So it is both the lock and the danger. While the line holds, the door holds. But if the line should come to the door with the key in hand, and speak its name, the door will open.*

*Therefore let the line be kept in ignorance, and let the key be kept apart, and let the name be kept close.*

I stopped reading. I could not see the page anymore. My eyes had gone blurry and my hands were shaking and there was a roaring in my ears like a great wind.

The Thief's own line.

My mother's line.

My line.

\* \* \*

"Kvothe?" Devi's voice seemed to come from very far away. "Kvothe, what's wrong?"

I did not answer. I could not. I stood there with my hands on the edge of the stone table and the book open in front of me, and I tried to breathe.

The line of Loeclos. Chosen because it was the Thief's own blood. His blood knows his prison.

*The door holds while the line holds.*

That was why the Chandrian had come for my mother. Not only for the songs. For the blood. For the line. She had run away from her family, from the house and the name and the knowledge that went with them. She had gone out onto the roads with a red-haired man who made songs, and she had had a son.

And they had found her.



But they had not killed me.

I had always wondered about that. Why they had killed everyone in the troupe, every man, woman, and child, and left me alive. I had told myself it was luck. That I had been off in the woods, playing, and they had simply not noticed me. That Haliar had called them away before Cinder could finish the job.

But I remembered, now, standing in that dark room with the book of the Amyr open in front of me. I remembered Cinder, crouching in front of me in the firelight, his black eyes fixed on mine. I remembered the smile on his face, and the way he had looked at me.

He had not looked at me like a man who had forgotten a child in the woods. He had looked at me like a man who had found exactly what he was looking for.

\* \* \*

"Kvothe." It was Fela. Her hand was on my shoulder, cold and firm. "Kvothe, we need to go."

I looked at her. Her face was white and strained, and her eyes were fixed on the door.

"The stone," she said. "It's getting louder. The seal I asked. It won't hold much longer. It's telling me. We have to go now."

I looked at the door. It had not changed. Grey stone, no handle, no hinges, no lock. The breathing went on beyond it, slow and deep.

But something had changed. I could feel it. The air in the room had grown heavier, thicker, the way the air grows before a storm. The breathing was a little faster. A little less deep.

Something on the other side of the door was waking up.

"Yes," I said. "Yes. We have to go."

I closed the book. My hands were shaking so badly I almost could not do it. I closed it and stepped back from the table, and Devi and Fela stepped back with me, and we turned toward the stairs.

And that was when I saw that Devi had something in her hand.

It was a single page. Folded small. She was tucking it into the front of her satchel, quickly, furtively, the way a pickpocket tucks away a purse.

"Devi," I said. "What is that?"

She looked at me. Her face was defiant and frightened and fierce all at once.

"I didn't take the book," she said. "I only took a page. From the back. It was loose. Nobody will miss it."

"Put it back."

"No."

"Devi, put it back. We don't take anything. That was the rule."

"That was *your* rule." Her eyes were bright behind her spectacles. "I've waited six years for this, Kvothe. Six years. I'm not leaving with nothing."

"Please," Fela whispered. "Please, we have to go. The stone—"

And then, all at once, the room rang.

It was not a sound. Devi had said that, and she had been right. It was something else. A vibration, deep and terrible, rising up out of the floor and the walls and the ceiling, shaking the air, shaking my bones, shaking my teeth in my skull. It was as if the whole world had been struck like a bell.

Fela cried out. She fell to her knees, her hands clapped over her ears.

"It's telling," she gasped. "It's telling, it's telling, I asked it not to but something was taken and now it's telling—"

Far above us, in the Archives, in the University, in the whole wide sleeping world, I felt the ringing go out like a ripple on a pond.

And behind the door, very clearly now, the breathing stopped.

\* \* \*

We ran.

Up the narrow stairs, past the thousands of names carved into the walls. Through the small square room, which was ringing now like a struck gong, so loud it made my eyes water. Up the great spiral stair, around and around, our footsteps echoing in the vast dark shaft.

I did not look back. I did not dare. But I could feel it, behind us, far below. A presence. A weight. Something that had been sleeping and was sleeping no longer.

It was not following us. I do not think it could. But it was awake. And it was listening.

We reached the grate. I shoved Devi through first, then Fela. They scrambled into the air shaft and began to climb down, the rusted rungs creaking under their weight.

I was about to follow when I heard the voices.

They came from above. From the top of the great stair. From the other side of the Four-plate door. Men's voices, raised in alarm, and the sound of running feet, and a sound I had never heard before and hoped never to hear again: a deep grinding rumble, like a millstone turning.

The Four-plate door was opening.

I looked down at the grate. Devi's face looked up at me from the dark of the shaft, pale and terrified.

"Come on!" she hissed. "Kvothe, come on!"

I looked up at the door. A crack of light had appeared around its edge, thin and golden. It was widening.

I looked back down at Devi.

"Go," I said.

"What?"

"Go. Both of you. Get out. Go back to your rooms and don't tell anyone you were here." I reached down and grabbed the old iron grate from the ledge where Fela had set it. "They'll need someone to find. It'll go easier if they find me."

"Kvothe, no—"

"Go!"

I pushed the grate back into its place. It did not fit properly; the rust had eaten away too much of the frame. But it would do. It would hide the shaft from anyone who did not look too closely.

Through the bars, I saw Devi's face one last time. Her eyes were full of tears.

Then she was gone, down into the dark.

I turned and began to climb the stairs toward the light.

## Chapter Thirty

# Caught

Lorren was the first one through the door.

I had known he would be. I had not known what he would look like, coming down those stairs in the golden light of a dozen lanterns, with his black robe billowing around him and his long pale face set like stone. I had seen Lorren angry before. I had seen him on the day I lit a candle in the Archives and he barred me for a year and a half. But I had never seen him like this.

He was not angry. He was afraid.

He came down the great spiral stair so fast that the men behind him had to run to keep up. There were six of them: scrivs, mostly, in their grey robes, carrying lanterns and looking terrified. And behind them, moving more slowly, the Chancellor, Herma, with his white beard and his heavy chain of office glittering on his chest.

I was standing on the landing a flight below the door, in the full light of their lanterns, with Caesura at my hip and my hands held out and empty.

Lorren stopped when he saw me. He stood on the stair above me and looked down, and for a long moment he did not speak. His face did not change. But his eyes went to the stair below me, spiraling down into darkness, and then back to my face.

"How far?" he said.

"All the way," I said.

Something moved behind his eyes. It was there and gone so fast I almost missed it. But I had been watching faces my whole life, and I

knew what I had seen.

It was grief.

"Did you touch the door?" he said. His voice was very quiet.

"No."

"Did you speak to it?"

"No."

"Did it speak to you?"

I hesitated. It was only for a moment. But Lorren saw it.

He closed his eyes. He stood there on the stair, in the golden lantern light, with his eyes closed and his long pale hands hanging at his sides, and he looked, for the first time since I had known him, like an old man.

"Bind him," he said to the scrivs. "Take him up."

\* \* \*

They did not bind me. Herma would not allow it. He came down the stairs past Lorren and looked at me for a long time, his old face creased with worry, and then he shook his head.

"He came up to meet us," he said. "He's not going to run. Are you, Kvothe?"

"No, sir."

"Then there's no need for ropes." He looked at Lorren. "Take his sword, if you like. But no ropes."

Lorren did not answer. One of the scrivs came forward nervously and held out his hands, and I unbuckled Caesura and gave it to him. He took it the way you might take a live snake.

Then they led me up the stairs, through the Four-plate door, and into the Archives.

I had never seen the Four-plate door open before. Nobody had, in living memory. It stood wide now, the great round slab of stone swung back on some hidden pivot, and the four copper plates on its face gleamed dully in the lantern light. As I passed through it, I felt something brush against me. A coldness. A kind of attention. As if the door were looking at me.

I did not look back.

\* \* \*

They took me to Lorren's office. A long narrow room lined with books, lit by the red glow of sympathy lamps. Lorren sat behind his desk. Herma sat in a chair beside it. I stood in front of them.

The scrivs had been sent away. The door was closed. It was very quiet.

"Tell us," said Herma, "what happened."

So I told them. Not everything. I did not tell them about Devi or Fela. I did not tell them about the air shaft, or the Underthing, or Auri. I told them I had found my own way down, that I had gone alone, that I had been curious about what lay behind the Four-plate door and had found a way past it.

I told them about the stairs, and the small square room, and the names on the walls. I told them about the round room at the bottom, and the table, and the book. I told them about the door.

I did not tell them about the voice. Or what I had read in the book.

When I was done, they were both silent for a long time.

"You went alone," said Lorren at last. His voice was flat.

"Yes."

"You found your own way past the Four-plate door. Alone. Without help."

"Yes."

"And you passed the second seal. Alone. Without help." He leaned forward. "Tell me how."

I had known this question was coming. I had been dreading it. I had no good answer, because the true answer would betray Fela.

"I asked it," I said. "I asked the stone to let me pass."

Lorren looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at Herma.

"He's lying," he said.

"Perhaps," said Herma. "Or perhaps not." He was looking at me with a strange expression. "Elodin has been teaching him stone this term. I asked."

"Nobody has passed that seal in two hundred years. Nobody. Not Elodin, not me, not anyone." Lorren's voice was very cold. "And you expect me to believe that a Re'lar with a single name to his credit, and that one called by accident, walked down those stairs and *asked* it?"

"I don't expect you to believe anything, Master Lorren," I said. "But I'm telling you what I told you."

Lorren stood up. He walked around his desk and stood in front of me, very close, looking down at me from his great height. His eyes were pale and very cold.

"Someone was with you," he said softly. "Someone who can hear stone. Someone who asked the seal to be silent, and kept it silent until something was taken. And then it rang." He paused. "What did you take, Kvothe?"

"Nothing."

"Something was taken."

"I didn't take anything. I promise you. On my name and my blood, I didn't take anything from that room."

He looked at me for a long time. I held his gaze. It was not a lie. I had not taken anything. I had been very careful about that.

At last Lorren turned away. He went back to his desk and sat down heavily.

"Search him," he said to Herma.

Herma searched me. He was gentle about it, and thorough. He found my sympathy lamp, and my tools, and Elodin's stone, and the little knot Denna had given me, which he looked at with some curiosity before handing it back. He found nothing else.

"Nothing," he said.

Lorren did not look up. "Then someone else has it," he said. "And they are out there somewhere, in the dark, with a page from the Book of Watches in their hands." He was quiet for a moment. "Do you know what you've done, Kvothe? Do you have any idea?"

"No, sir," I said. "I don't. I only know what I read."

He looked up sharply. "You read the book."

"Some of it."

"How much?"

"The front. The account. The one without a name." I swallowed.  
"About the war. And the Thief. And the doors."

Lorren and Herma looked at each other. Something passed between them, some silent communication I could not follow.

"And the line?" said Herma quietly. "Did you read about the line?"

"Yes."

"Then you understand," said Lorren, "why you should not have gone there."

I did not answer. I did not have to.

\* \* \*

They kept me in Lorren's office all night. They did not lock me in; they did not have to. I sat in a chair by the wall and waited, and they talked in low voices by the desk, and sometimes one or the other of them went out and came back with a book or a paper or a message from somewhere else in the University.

Near dawn, Elodin came.

He came in without knocking, as he always did, and stood in the doorway looking at me. His face was very strange. It was not angry, and it was not sad. It was the face of a man who has watched someone walk toward a cliff for a very long time and has finally seen them go over the edge.

"Well," he said. "You did it."

"I didn't open it."

"No. But you went down. And you listened. And it heard you." He came into the room and sat down on the edge of Lorren's desk, ignoring Lorren's glare. "Did it speak to you?"

I hesitated. Then I nodded.

"What did it say?"

"My name."

Elodin closed his eyes. For a long moment he did not say anything. Then he opened them again and looked at Lorren.

"You know what that means," he said.



"I know what it means," said Lorren. His voice was very tired. "It means he can never go down there again. It means he can never be allowed near the Archives again. Not the Four-plate door, not the Stacks, not any of it." He looked at me. "It means he has to leave."

"Leave?" I said. "Leave the Archives?"

"Leave the University," said Herma quietly.

The world seemed to tilt beneath me. I gripped the arms of my chair.

"You can't," I said. "You can't expel me for this. I didn't take anything. I didn't touch the door. I didn't—"

"You went down the stairs," said Lorren. "That is enough. That has always been enough. It is the oldest rule of the Archives, older than the University itself. No one goes down the stairs." He looked at me with his pale, cold eyes. "Not because of what they might take. Because of what they might wake."

"And you woke it," said Elodin softly. "Or near enough. Everyone felt it, Kvothe. Every namer in the University. Every man and woman who's ever heard the stone. We all felt it wake up and turn its head. And we all felt what it turned its head toward." He looked at me. "You."

\* \* \*

The formal proceeding came later. There were rules, even for this. There were forms to be followed, records to be kept. At the University, nothing ever happened without a great deal of paper.

But I knew, sitting in Lorren's office in the grey light of dawn, that it was already decided. I could see it in their faces. In Herma's worried eyes and Lorren's cold ones. In the way Elodin sat on the edge of the desk with his arms folded and his head bowed, not looking at me.

They were not angry at me. That was the worst of it. If they had been angry, I could have fought. I could have argued, and pleaded, and talked my way out of it the way I had talked my way out of so many things before.

But they were not angry. They were afraid. And you cannot argue with fear.

"Master Elodin," I said at last. "Is there anything I can do?"

He looked up at me. For a long moment he did not answer.

"Yes," he said. "You can go. Quickly. Far away. And you can try very hard to forget everything you saw down there."

"And if I can't forget?"

He smiled. It was a strange smile, sad and fond and a little bitter.

"Then you'll have to be very careful," he said, "about what you remember."

## Chapter Thirty-One

# On the Horns

They called it being put on the horns.

It is an old phrase, older than the University, and nobody knows where it comes from. Some say it refers to the horns of a bull, which toss a man into the air and gore him when he lands. Others say it refers to the horns that were blown in the old days to summon the masters to judgment. Still others say it comes from the Aturan phrase *cornu*, which means a dilemma, a choice between two equally terrible things.

I have been on the horns three times in my life. The first time was for using malfeasance against Ambrose. The second was for conduct unbecoming a member of the Arcanum. Both times I was punished. Both times I survived.

The third time was the last.

\* \* \*

The hearing was held in the Masters' Hall, three days after the Nighting. It was a long room with a high vaulted ceiling and tall windows of old glass that turned the grey winter light into something pale and wavering, like light seen through water. The nine masters sat at a long table on a raised dais. The Chancellor sat in the center, in a high-backed chair. The rest of the room was empty except for a few benches along the walls, where students and members of the Arcanum could sit to watch.

The benches were full. Word had spread. Word always spreads, at the University.

I stood in the center of the floor, alone, in front of the masters. I had dressed carefully that morning, in the best clothes I owned. I had combed my hair and polished my boots. I had thought about wearing Caesura, and then decided against it. It was still in Lorren's office, in any case.

The charge was read out by the Chancellor's clerk, a thin nervous man with ink-stained fingers. He read it in a high, carrying voice that echoed off the vaulted ceiling.

"Kvothe, son of Arliden, Re'lar of the Arcanum, stands accused of trespass beyond the Four-plate door, contrary to the oldest law of the Archives. He stands accused of descending the forbidden stair, and of entering the Chamber of Watches, and of reading the Book of Watches, which no living member of the University may read. He stands accused of waking the Sentinel. How does he answer?"

A murmur went through the benches. Most of them, I think, had not known about the Chamber of Watches or the Book of Watches or the Sentinel. They had not known there was anything beneath the Four-plate door at all. They were learning now, and I could hear the hunger in their whispers.

"I answer that it's true," I said.

The murmur grew louder. Herma raised his hand, and it died away.

"You do not deny the charge?" he said.

"No, Chancellor. I went down the stairs. I entered the chamber. I read the book." I paused. "I did not wake anything. Not on purpose. But I understand that something woke, and that I was there when it did."

Herma looked at me for a long time. Then he turned to the masters.

"Does anyone wish to speak for the student?" he said.

There was a long silence.

Then Kilvin stood up.

\* \* \*

He was a big man, Kilvin, and when he stood, he seemed to fill the whole dais. He looked down at me with his dark shaggy brows drawn together, and then he looked at the other masters.

"I will speak," he said.

Herma nodded. "Master Artificer."

"This student," said Kilvin, "is the most gifted artificer I have seen in twenty years. He has made the arrow-catch, which has saved lives. He has made improvements to the sympathy lamp, which are now used in the Fishery every day. He has made the heat-funnel, which works better than my own." He paused. "He is careless. He is proud. He does not listen. But he is not wicked. He did not go down those stairs to do harm."

"Why did he go down, then?" said Hemme. He was sitting at the end of the table, his fat face twisted in an expression of satisfaction that he did not bother to hide. "If not to do harm?"

"Because he wanted to know," said Kilvin. "Because he is curious. Because he is a student, and students are curious, and that is what the University is for." He looked at Hemme with contempt. "Or have you forgotten, Master Rhetorician? Have you been sitting in your chair so long that you have forgotten what it is to want to know a thing?"

Hemme flushed red. "I have not forgotten the law."

"Nor have I. But the law is not the only thing," Kilvin turned back to Herma. "I ask for leniency. Suspension, perhaps. A term. Two terms. But not expulsion. It would be a waste."

He sat down.

Herma looked at the other masters. "Does anyone else wish to speak?"

Arwyl stood. He was a small man, old and bent, with a kindly face and a quiet voice. "I will add my voice to Kilvin's," he said. "The boy has been a good student in the Medica. He has a steady hand and a quick mind. He saved a woman's life last term, when she came in with a wound no one else could stanch. I would not like to lose him."

He sat down.

Then, to my great surprise, Mandrag stood. The Master Alchemist was a tall, spare man with stained fingers and a sour disposition, and I had never been sure he liked me.

"I will say only this," he said. "The boy is a nuisance. But he is a clever nuisance. And clever nuisances have a way of becoming great men, if they are not crushed too early." He sat down.

Nobody else stood.

Herma looked at Lorren. "Master Archivist. You have been silent."

Lorren sat very still in his chair. His long pale hands were folded on the table in front of him. He did not look at me.

"The law is clear," he said. "Anyone who descends the forbidden stair is to be expelled. There is no provision for leniency. There never has been."

"And yet you have heard three masters ask for it."

"I have heard them." Lorren looked up at last. His eyes met mine, and they were very cold. "But they do not know what I know. They do not know what lies at the bottom of those stairs. They do not know what woke, three nights ago, and turned its head toward this boy." He paused. "If they knew, they would not ask for leniency. They would ask for him to be gone. Far away. As quickly as possible."

A silence fell over the hall. The students on the benches had stopped whispering. They were staring at Lorren, and then at me, and I could see the fear beginning to creep into their faces.

"Master Namer," said Herma quietly. "Do you agree?"

Elodin was sitting at the far end of the table, lounging in his chair with his feet up on the edge, as he always did. But he was not lounging now. He sat very still, with his hands folded and his eyes fixed on me.

"I agree," he said.

My heart dropped into my stomach.

"Not because he deserves it," Elodin went on. "He doesn't. He's been foolish, but not wicked. And he's been brave, in his way. Braver than any of us have been, in a very long time." He looked at the other masters. "But Lorren is right. Something woke. And it knows him

now. It knows his name. And as long as he's here, sitting on top of it, it will be listening for him. It will be *calling* him." He looked back at me. "The best thing for him, and for all of us, is for him to be somewhere else. Somewhere far away. Where it can't hear him."

He paused.

"I'm sorry, Kvothe," he said. "I truly am."

\* \* \*

The vote was taken. It was not close.

Kilvin voted against expulsion. Arwyl voted against. Mandrag voted against.

Lorren voted for. Elodin voted for. Hemme voted for, with an expression of such smug satisfaction that I wanted to climb up onto the dais and break his nose. Brandeur voted for. Herma voted for, with a heavy sigh.

That was five. Five was enough. The ninth master, Master Linguist, did not vote at all; the chair had been empty since Herma had become Chancellor, and they had not yet found anyone to fill it.

"Kvothe, son of Arliden," said Herma. His voice was heavy. "By a vote of the masters, you are hereby expelled from the University. Your name will be struck from the rolls of the Arcanum. You will surrender your gram and any other artifacts made in the Fishery that may be of danger to others. You will leave the grounds of the University within three days, and you will not return." He paused. "Do you understand?"

"I understand."

"Do you have anything to say?"

I looked at them. At the nine masters sitting on their dais, in their robes, beneath the high vaulted ceiling with its pale wavering light. At Kilvin, who looked angry. At Arwyl, who looked sad. At Lorren, who looked at nothing. At Elodin, who looked at me.

I thought about all the things I could say. I thought about arguing, and pleading, and shouting. I thought about telling them about the Chandrian, and my parents, and the Book of Watches, and the line of Loeclos. I thought about telling them that they were making a mistake,

that I was the only one who knew, that I was the only one who could do anything about it.

And then I thought about the Adem. About Vashet, and her hard hands and her harder eyes, teaching me to be still. About the Lethani. About knowing when to act, and when not to.

"No, Chancellor," I said. "I have nothing to say."

Herma looked at me for a long moment. Something moved in his face. It might have been respect.

"Then this hearing is concluded," he said.

\* \* \*

I walked out of the Masters' Hall into the grey afternoon light. The courtyard was full of students, milling about, talking in low voices. They fell silent as I came out. They stared at me. Some of them looked away.

Sim was there. And Wil. They were standing at the bottom of the steps, waiting for me. Sim's face was white and stricken. Wil's face was carefully blank, which with Wil meant he was angrier than I had ever seen him.

"Is it true?" said Sim. "They expelled you?"

"It's true."

"For going down some stairs?" His voice cracked. "That's insane. That's completely insane. Kvothe, you have to appeal. You have to—"

"There's no appeal, Sim."

"There's always an appeal!"

"Not for this." I put my hand on his shoulder. "It's all right. It really is."

"It's not all right!" He was almost crying now. "It's not all right at all! You're the best student in the whole University, and they're throwing you out because you went down some *stairs*!"

"It wasn't just stairs," said Wil quietly.

Sim turned to look at him. Wil was looking at me, and his dark eyes were very steady.

"Was it?" he said.



I looked back at him. I thought about lying. I thought about it very seriously. But Wil had been my friend for a long time, and he deserved better.

"No," I said. "It wasn't just stairs."

Wil nodded slowly. He did not ask any more questions. That was one of the things I loved about Wil. He knew when to stop asking.

"Where will you go?" he said.

"I don't know yet. Vintas, probably. To the Maer."

"When?"

"They gave me three days."

Wil nodded again. Then he did something I had never seen him do before. He reached out and put his arms around me and held me tight, the way you would hold a brother.

"Three days," he said into my shoulder. "Then we'd better make them count."

## Chapter Thirty-Two

### What Lorren Knew

The note came that night, under my door at Anker's. A single folded sheet of heavy paper, sealed with plain grey wax, with no mark pressed into it.

Inside, in a narrow, precise hand I recognized at once:

*The east door of the Archives. Midnight. Come alone. Burn this.*

It was not signed. It did not need to be.

I burned it in the candle flame and watched the ashes curl. Then I sat on my bed and waited for midnight, and did not think about anything, because there was nothing I could think about that did not hurt.

\* \* \*

The east door of the Archives is a small door. Most students do not know it exists. It is set deep in the grey windowless wall on the side facing the Mains, behind a buttress, in a place where the shadows are always thick. It is used by the scrivs, sometimes, when they are carrying crates of books in and out, and by the masters, when they want to come and go without being seen.

It was open when I got there. Only a crack. A thin line of red light from a sympathy lamp, lying across the flagstones.

I pushed it open and went in.

Lorren was standing in the corridor beyond, very tall and very still, in his long black master's robe, with the red lamp in his hand. His face, lit from below, was all hollows and planes, like a carving.

"Re'lar Kvothe," he said. Then he paused. "No. Not Re'lar. Not anymore." He looked at me for a long moment with his colorless eyes. "Kvothe."

"Master Lorren."

"Come with me."

\* \* \*

He led me through the Archives. Through corridors I knew and corridors I did not. Down a narrow stair I had never seen, into a part of the Stacks so old that the shelves were stone, not wood, and the books on them were bound in leather gone black with age. Our footsteps were very loud. The red light of his lamp moved over the spines of the books like blood.

He did not speak. I did not ask. I had learned, over the years, that Lorren did not answer questions he had not decided to answer, and that asking only made him decide not to.

At last he stopped in front of a door. A small iron door, set into the stone at the end of a dead-end passage. There was no handle. There was no keyhole. There was only a small plate of dark metal in the center of it, about the size of a palm.

Lorren set his hand flat against the plate. He said something. A single word, very soft, in a language I did not know.

The door opened.

\* \* \*

It was a small room. A cell, almost. Stone walls and a stone floor and a stone ceiling, very low. A single table and a single chair. A single shelf, holding a single row of books.

And on the table, laid out neatly side by side, the six ledgers Wil and I had brought him two months before. With the six lines of small, neat, slanting script, each one signed —*B*.

"Sit," said Lorren.

I sat in the chair. He did not. He stood by the door with his lamp, tall and dark, and looked at me.

"You are angry with me," he said.

It was not a question. I did not answer.

"You are angry because I voted for your expulsion," said Lorren. "You think I did it because of the Cellarage. Because you went where you were forbidden to go, and broke the rules of the Archives, and embarrassed me before the other masters." He was quiet for a moment. "Or you think I did it because I have always disliked you. Because you were careless with books, once, when you were very young, and I have never forgiven you."

"Didn't you?"

"No," said Lorren. "I did not."

\* \* \*

He set the lamp down on the table, beside the ledgers. The red light fell on the six neat lines of script.

"Beredon," he said. "Twenty-two years ago. A scriv at my desk. Kind. Well-spoken. Very careful with the books." He touched the nearest ledger with one long pale finger. "When you brought me these, I went back through the records. All of them. Every book he touched, in the year he was here. Every shelf he reorganized. Every stack he catalogued." He was silent for a moment. "It took me six spans. I did not sleep much."

"What did you find?"

"Holes," said Lorren.

I looked at him.

"Not missing books," he said. "Those I had already found. Eleven of them, as you know. Twelve, now. No. Holes in the *catalogue*. Places where the record itself had been changed. Very subtly. Very carefully. So that a book that should have been shelved in one place was listed in another. So that a cross-reference that should have led from one volume to the next led instead to nothing." He looked at me. "Do you understand what that means?"

I thought about it.

"He wasn't just removing books," I said slowly. "He was hiding them. From the catalogue. So that even if they were still here, nobody could find them."

"Yes."

"Which books?"

Lorren did not answer at once. He turned and looked at the single shelf on the wall, with its single row of old black-bound books.

"These," he said.

\* \* \*

There were nine of them. I counted. Nine books, bound in black leather, with no titles on their spines. Lorren took one down and set it on the table in front of me and opened it.

I could not read it. It was written in a script I had never seen. Not Tema, not Eld Vintic, not Yllish knot-script. Something older. Something angular and strange, with marks above and below the lines like the marks in music.

"The Amyr cipher," said Lorren quietly. "Their records. What is left of them. Beredon hid them in the catalogue, so deep that no one would ever find them. Not by accident. Not by searching." He touched the page. "I found them because I went looking for the holes. Six spans of looking. And at the bottom of the deepest hole, in a room I did not know existed, in the oldest part of the Stacks, there they were."

"Why hide them? If he's—" I stopped. I did not know how to finish the sentence. I did not know, then, what Bredon was. I only knew that the name Beredon and the name Bredon were very close, and that the old man in the Maer's garden walked with a stick of dark wood with a silver head.

"I do not know," said Lorren. "I have wondered. Perhaps he hid them to keep them safe. Perhaps he hid them to keep them from someone. Perhaps he hid them to keep them for himself, so that he could come back one day and find them where he left them." He closed the book. "Perhaps all three."

\* \* \*

"Master Lorren," I said. "Why are you showing me this?"

He did not answer for a long time. He stood by the table with his hand resting on the closed black book, and he looked at me with his

colorless eyes.

"Because he came back," he said at last.

My skin went cold.

"Last spring," said Lorren. "While you were in Vintas. He came to the Archives. Not as a scriv. As a visitor. A gentleman scholar from the south, with a letter of introduction from a lord in Renere. He asked for a reading pass. He was very polite. Very pleasant. He had a stick of dark wood with a silver head." Lorren's voice was very flat. "I did not see him. I was away, in Anilin, at a conference. The scriv at the desk gave him a pass. He spent three days in the Tomes. He read nothing of consequence. Histories. Genealogies. Books about the noble houses of Vintas." He paused. "And then he asked about a student."

I did not have to ask which one.

"He asked if you were enrolled," said Lorren. "He asked what you were studying. He asked who your friends were, and where you lodged, and whether you had ever been disciplined for entering restricted parts of the Archives." He looked at me. "The scriv told him. The scriv did not know any better. He was a gentleman with a letter from Renere, and he was very pleasant."

\* \* \*

The red lamp flickered. The shadows on the stone walls leaned and steadied.

"When you came back," said Lorren, "I watched you. I watched you go into the Underthing, night after night. I watched you come back with dust on your clothes and stone in your pockets. I knew where you were going. I knew there was something down there, under the Archives. Something old." He was quiet for a moment. "And I knew that a man with a silver-headed stick had come here, a year before, asking whether you had ever been disciplined for entering restricted places."

"You think he wanted me to go down there."

"I think," said Lorren carefully, "that he wanted to know if you *would*. And now he knows. And if he knows, then you are in more danger here, at the University, sitting on top of whatever is down

there, than anywhere else in the world."

I stared at him.

"You voted to expel me," I said slowly. "To get me away from here."

Lorren did not answer. His face showed nothing at all.

\* \* \*

"I could not tell the others," he said at last. "Kilvin would have wanted to protect you here, in the Fishery, behind his wards. Elodin would have wanted to see what you would do. Herma would have wanted a committee." He looked at the black books on the shelf. "And any of them might have spoken of it to someone. And someone might have spoken of it to a pleasant gentleman with a letter from Renere." He paused. "It was simpler to vote. And to let you believe I despised you. And to let you go."

"You could have told *me*."

"Could I?" Lorren looked at me for a long moment. "If I had told you that a man who might be one of the Amyr—or something worse, something that has been hunting the Amyr for a very long time—had come to the University asking about you, what would you have done?"

I opened my mouth. Then I closed it.

"You would have gone looking for him," said Lorren quietly. "Of course you would. You have been looking for the Chandrian since you were twelve years old. You would have gone looking for him, and you would have found him, because he wants to be found by you. And then he would have had you. In whatever way he wants you." He shook his head. "No. It was better that you leave. Angry. Believing the University had cast you out. Believing I hated you. Going somewhere, anywhere, that was not here."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long time. I sat in the stone chair in the stone room with the nine black books on the shelf above me and the six ledgers on the table in front of me, and I did not know what to feel.

"Why tell me now?" I said at last. "If it was better that I leave angry?"

Lorren looked at me. And something happened to his face. Something I had never seen on it before. It was very small, and it was gone almost at once. But for a moment, just a moment, his long cold pale face looked tired. And old. And sad.

"Because I was a student once," he said. "And I was curious about the Amyr. And I went looking. And no one told me anything. No one warned me. No one said *be careful, there are things in the dark that are looking back*." He was quiet for a moment. "I was lucky. I found nothing. And I stopped looking, and became a master, and kept the books. But I have always wished that someone had told me."

He picked up the lamp.

"So I am telling you," he said. "Once. I will not repeat it. And if you ever tell anyone that I said it—"

"You'll deny it," I said. "And bar me from the Archives for the rest of my life."

The corner of his mouth moved. It was not a smile. Lorren did not smile. But it was close.

"You are already barred," he said. "I will have to think of something worse."

\* \* \*

He led me back through the Stacks. Up the narrow stair, through the corridors I knew and the corridors I did not, to the small east door behind the buttress. He opened it. The night air came in, cold and clean.

"Your sword," he said, as I stepped out. "I confiscated it, at the hearing. It is the rule. Expelled students forfeit their weapons." He paused. "I will give it to Kilvin. He will see that it reaches you. I would prefer that you not know how."

"Thank you, Master Lorren."

"Do not thank me." His face was a pale shape in the red light, above the black of his robe. "Go far away. Stay away from old men with silver-headed sticks. And if you find the Amyr—" He stopped.



"Yes?"

Lorren was quiet for a long moment.

"If you find them," he said at last, "do not assume they are what the stories say. The stories were written by people who wanted to be remembered well. The Amyr were very good at that." He looked past me, into the dark. "Perhaps too good."

He closed the door. I heard the lock turn. And I stood alone in the cold beside the grey windowless wall of the Archives, and looked up at the stars, and felt, for the first time since the hearing, something that was not anger.

I did not know what it was. It felt a little like gratitude. It felt a little like fear.

It felt, I think, like being warned.

\* \* \*

I did not listen, of course. I went south, three days later, to Severen. To the Maer's small garden, and a tak board, and an old man with a silver-headed stick who smiled at me across the stones as if I were his favorite grandson.

I have thought, since, about how differently things might have gone, if I had listened.

I have thought that Lorren must have thought about it too. Sitting in his long narrow office, with his long pale hands folded on his desk. Reading the news from Vintas, as it came up the roads. The murder of a king. A trial. A hanging in Renere.

I hope he did not blame himself. It was not his fault. He did everything he could.

He told me once. He did not repeat it.

It was enough. I just did not listen.

## Chapter Thirty-Three

### Three Days

We made them count.

I have thought about those three days many times since. I have taken them out and turned them over in my mind the way you might turn over a smooth stone found on a beach, feeling its weight, its shape, the way the light catches it. They were among the saddest days of my life. They were among the happiest. I did not know, then, that a thing could be both. I know it now.

\* \* \*

The first day, I went to see Devi.

I climbed the treacherous wooden stairs to her door and knocked, and she opened it before my knuckles had finished their second rap. She looked terrible. Her eyes were red and swollen, and her face was blotchy, and her strawberry-blond hair hung loose and uncombed around her shoulders. She looked at me for a long moment without saying anything. Then she stepped aside and let me in.

The room was a wreck. Books lay scattered across the floor. Papers were strewn everywhere. The alchemical bench in the corner had been swept clean, its glassware smashed and scattered. The cat was hiding under the bed, and it hissed at me as I came in.

"I heard," Devi said. Her voice was hoarse. "About the hearing."

"I thought you might have."

"You didn't tell them. About me. About Fela."

"No."

"Why not?"

I looked at her. "Because it wouldn't have changed anything. They'd still have expelled me. And they'd have done worse to you."

"They couldn't do worse to me. I'm already expelled." She laughed, a harsh, ugly sound. "They'd have done worse to Fela, though. She'd have lost everything." She sat down heavily in her chair. "She came to see me, you know. Yesterday. She wanted to go to Herma and confess. I talked her out of it."

"Thank you."

"Don't thank me." She put her face in her hands. "It's my fault. All of it. If I hadn't taken that page—"

"Devi."

"If I hadn't taken it, the seal wouldn't have rung. We'd have gotten out. Nobody would have known. You'd still be—" Her voice broke. "You'd still be here."

I sat down on the edge of her bed. The cat hissed at me again from beneath it. I ignored it.

"Maybe," I said. "Or maybe not. Maybe it would have rung anyway. Maybe it would have heard me. It knew I was there, Devi. It spoke to me." I shook my head. "I don't think we were ever going to get out of there clean."

She looked up at me through her fingers. "It spoke to you?"

"Yes."

"What did it say?"

"My name."

She stared at me for a long time. Then she took her hands away from her face and wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist and sat up straight.

"All right," she said. "All right." She took a deep breath. "Then I'm going to give you something. And you're going to take it. And you're not going to argue."

She went to her desk. She pulled open a drawer, and then another drawer beneath it, and then pressed on something at the back of the second drawer, and a small panel slid open with a click. From behind

the panel she took a folded piece of paper.

It was the page. The one she had taken from the Book of Watches. I knew it the moment I saw it: the same pale, faintly translucent material as the book's cover, the same old Aturan script, faded brown with age.

"I read it," she said. "The night we got back. I sat up all night reading it." She held it out to me. "I think it's yours."

I took it. It was lighter than it looked, and cold to the touch.

"What does it say?"

"Read it yourself." She sat back down. "I'll tell you this much. It's not a record. Not like the rest of the book. It's a warning. Someone wrote it at the very end, after the last entry. After the watchers stopped coming." She was quiet for a moment. "I think it was the last thing any of them ever wrote."

I unfolded the page. I read it.

It was short. Only a few lines, in a hand that was hurried and cramped, as if the writer had been afraid of running out of time.

*The watch is ended. We are too few. The Knife has found us.*

*He comes as a friend. He comes as a teacher. He is patient beyond any patience. He has been cutting the truth from the world for longer than the Empire has stood, one page at a time, one name at a time. He serves the Seven, but he is not of them. He is only a man. That is what makes him terrible.*

*He carries a staff of dark wood crowned in silver. He plays at games. He smiles.*

*If any come after us, beware him. He wants the line. He wants the key. He wants the door opened, and he will wait a thousand years to see it done.*

*The door holds. God help whoever holds it after us.*

\* \* \*

I read it three times. Then I folded it carefully and put it in the inside pocket of my cloak, next to my father's song and Denna's knot.

I thought of Bredon.

I want to be honest about that. I read those words, *a staff of dark wood crowned in silver, he plays at games, he smiles*, and for a single heartbeat I saw him as clearly as if he were standing in front of me. The steps of the Mains in the snow. Lorren's long pale hands on the scrivs' ledgers. *He always won.*

And then I pushed it away. The way you push away a thought of something shameful. I told myself that it was a coincidence. That the page was very old, and the Amyr who wrote it had been dead for centuries. That there were a thousand old men with sticks. I thought of the Chandrian instead. I thought of Cinder, and Haliar. I thought of anything and everything except a kind old man who had taught me to play tak in the Maer's court.

It is a strange thing, how blind we can be to what is right in front of us. I have thought about it a great deal. I think it is because we do not want to see. Because some part of us knows that if we see, we will have to act. And acting is hard, and seeing is easy to avoid.

I did not want to see. And so I did not.

\* \* \*

"What will you do?" Devi asked.

"Go to Vintas. To the Maer."

"And then?"

I thought about it. "I don't know. Find out more. About the doors. About the line." I paused. "About the Knife."

"Be careful," said Devi. She looked at me, and her eyes were very serious behind her spectacles. "Kvothe. I mean it. Be careful. Whoever wrote that page, they were afraid. They were Amyr, and they were afraid. That's not something you should take lightly."

"I won't."

"You will," she said. "You always do. That's the trouble with you." She smiled faintly. "But try, at least. For me."

"For you," I said.

She stood up. She came over and stood in front of me, and for a long moment she did not say anything. Then she leaned down and kissed me on the cheek, very quickly, the way you might kiss a brother

goodbye at a dock.

"You still owe me," she said. "For the page. I want it back someday."

"Someday," I said.

"I'll hold you to that."

\* \* \*

The second day, I went to see Fela.

She was in the Fishery, at her bench, working on a piece of stone. She was carving it, very slowly and carefully, with a small steel chisel. When she saw me come in, she put down the chisel and stood up and came over to me, and her face was so full of guilt and grief that I could hardly bear to look at it.

"Kvothe," she said. "I'm so sorry. I'm so, so sorry."

"You don't have to be."

"I do. It was me. I asked the stone. I made it promise. And then when it rang—" Her voice broke. "I should have been stronger. I should have held it."

"You held it longer than anyone could have." I took her hands. They were cold and rough with stone dust. "Fela, listen to me. You did something no one has done in two hundred years. You asked the stone for something, and it listened. That's not failure. That's the opposite of failure."

She looked at me with wet eyes. "Then why do I feel like this?"

"Because you're a good person. And good people always feel guilty, even when they haven't done anything wrong." I squeezed her hands. "Keep studying with Elodin. Learn everything you can about stone. Someday you might need it."

"Why?"

I hesitated. Then I told her. Not everything. But I told her about the line, and the doors, and the key. I told her what I had read in the book.

She listened in silence. When I was done, she was pale as milk.

"Seven doors," she whispered. "Seven doors, all made of stone."

"Yes."

"And you're—" She could not finish.

"Yes."

She looked at me for a long, long time. Then she took her hands out of mine and went back to her bench and picked up the piece of stone she had been carving. She held it out to me.

It was a small thing, about the size of a walnut. She had carved it into the shape of a closed eye. It was smooth and cool and perfectly made, every line precise.

"I was making it for you," she said. "I was going to give it to you for your birthday. I didn't know what it was for. I just knew I had to make it." She pressed it into my hand. "Now I think I know."

"What is it?"

"It's stone," she said simply. "It says no. Keep it with you. When the door calls your name, hold it. Maybe it will help you say no too."

I held the little stone eye in my palm. I could feel it, very faintly. The long slow patient no.

"Thank you, Fela."

She smiled through her tears. "Come back someday," she said. "When it's safe. Come back and tell me you didn't need it."

\* \* \*

The third day, I spent with Sim and Wil.

We did not do anything special. We ate breakfast at Anker's, the way we always did. We walked down to the river and sat on the bank and threw stones into the water. We went to the Eolian in the afternoon, when it was nearly empty, and I played for them. Just for them. Every song they asked for, and some they did not.

Stanchion came out from behind the bar and listened. Deoch came in from the street and stood by the door. By the time I finished, there were a dozen people in the room, and they applauded when I was done, and Stanchion wiped his eyes with his sleeve and said something gruff about the smoke from the fire.

In the evening, we went back to Anker's and got very drunk.

I do not remember most of that night. I remember Sim reciting poetry, very badly, standing on a table. I remember Wil laughing,

really laughing, which I had seen perhaps three times in all the years I had known him. I remember Anker bringing out a bottle of something very old and very strong from behind the bar and pouring it for us without charging. I remember singing. I remember crying, though I do not remember why.

And I remember, very late, sitting on the roof of Anker's with Sim and Wil on either side of me, looking up at the stars.

"I'll write," Sim said. His voice was slurred. "Every span. I promise."

"I know you will."

"And you have to write back. You never write back. You're terrible at writing back."

"I'll write back."

"Promise?"

"I promise."

Wil was quiet for a long time. Then he said, "Kvothe."

"Yes?"

"Whatever you're going to do. Whatever it is you found down there." He was looking at the stars, not at me. "If you need help, you'll ask. Won't you?"

I did not answer right away. I thought about the page in my pocket, and the Knife, and the doors of stone. I thought about how many people had died because of the songs my parents sang.

"I'll ask," I said.

It was a lie. We all knew it. But they let me tell it anyway, because they were my friends, and because sometimes a lie is the only gift you have to give.

\* \* \*

I left at dawn on the fourth day.

Kilvin met me at the gates. He had my sword. He did not say how he had got it back from Lorren, and I did not ask. He had Kilvin's candle, too, in its wooden box, and he pressed it into my hands.

"You will need this more than I," he said. "Where you are going."

"Master Kilvin, I can't—"



"You can. You will." He looked down at me with his dark shaggy brows drawn together. "And you will write to me. When it burns blue. Every time. You will tell me where and when, and I will keep the records." He paused. "Someday, perhaps, we will understand it together."

I took the candle. I could not speak.

Kilvin nodded, once, as if I had said something. Then he turned and walked back toward the Fishery, his great shoulders hunched against the cold.

I did not see Elodin before I left. I did not see Lorren, or Herma, or any of the other masters. I did not see Auri.

But as I crossed the stone bridge in the grey dawn light, with my lute on my back and my sword at my hip and my whole life packed into a single bag over my shoulder, I stopped at the top of the arch and looked back.

And there, on the roof of the Mains, I saw a small figure standing against the pale sky. A girl, with a cloud of hair floating around her head like a dandelion's ghost. She was holding something up. A candle. Its flame was small and steady and yellow in the dawn.

She did not wave. She simply stood there, holding the candle, and watched me go.

I watched her back until the road turned and the trees closed in and I could not see her anymore.

## Interlude: Customers

The door of the Waystone Inn banged open, and the innkeeper stopped talking.

It was only Graham. He stood in the doorway stamping the mud from his boots, a big, slow, square-shouldered man with a carpenter's hands and a face like a well-worn saddle. Behind him came Old Cob, grey-bearded and bent, leaning on a stick of knotted ash, and Jake, and young Aaron the smith's apprentice, who ducked his head shyly as he came in, the way young men do when they are not yet sure they are welcome among older ones.

"Kote!" Graham called. "You alive in here? Your door's been shut all morning. Thought you might've been murdered in your bed."

The innkeeper rose from the table. It was a smooth motion, and as he made it, something went out of him. Chronicler watched it go. It was like watching a candle snuffed. One moment the man across the table had been someone else, someone with a voice that could fill a room and eyes that could hold you in place like a pinned butterfly. The next moment he was an innkeeper, mild and tired and a little bruised, wiping his hands on his apron.

"Not murdered," said Kote. "Just busy. I've got a guest." He nodded toward Chronicler. "Writing a book."

"A book!" Old Cob squinted at Chronicler. "What kind of book?"

"History," said Chronicler, who had been in this situation before and knew better than to say more.

"History." Old Cob seemed to consider this. "I could tell you some history. I remember when the old king was crowned. The one

before the one before this one. Big to-do, it was. They roasted an ox in Baedn and gave out cider to anyone who could walk."

"That's not history," said Jake. "That's just being old."

"Same thing," said Old Cob serenely, and lowered himself onto a stool at the bar.

Kote went behind the bar and began pouring drinks without being asked. He knew what each of them wanted. Graham took dark beer. Jake took cider. Old Cob took whatever was cheapest, and asked for it in a tone that suggested he was doing the inn a favor. Aaron hesitated, looking at the bottles, and then asked for cider too, and blushed when Kote gave it to him.

"You look terrible," Graham said, peering at Kote's face. "Worse than yesterday. Those soldiers really did a number on you."

"It looks worse than it is."

"Always does," said Old Cob wisely. "Bruises. Always look worse on the second day. It's the nature of them."

Chronicler, at his table by the hearth, glanced up sharply. Kote did not react at all. He only nodded and went on pouring.

"Any news?" he asked.

"Plenty," said Jake gloomily. "None of it good."

\* \* \*

The news, as it turned out, was the same as it always was, only more so.

The war was going badly. Or well; it depended on who you asked, and the people of Newarre did not know which side to ask. The Penitent King's armies had pushed the rebels back from the river at Enfast, or else the rebels had pushed the king's armies back from the hills near Tinuë; there were two stories, and Jake had heard both, and he told them one after the other with equal conviction.

The roads were worse. Carter had come back from Baedn two days ago with a story about a whole caravan found empty on the road near the old waystone at Farrel's Cut, the wagons standing in a neat line with their horses still in the traces, dead, and not a mark on them, and no sign at all of the drivers or the merchants or the guards.

"Bandits," said Graham firmly.

"Bandits take the horses," said Old Cob. "Bandits don't leave dead horses in the traces."

"Then what?"

Old Cob did not answer. He drank his beer.

And there had been more of the spiders. That was what they called them, in Newarre. Nobody knew any better name for them. Black things, hard and shiny as beetles, the size of a dinner plate, with legs like knives. They had come out of the woods last autumn and killed Carter's horse, and then there had been one in town, and then things had gone quiet for a while. But now there were stories again. A shepherd over by Rannish had lost half his flock in one night. A family near the Old Stone Road had found scratches on their door in the morning, deep gouges in the wood, as if something had been trying to get in.

"Came back up from the south, the priest says," Jake said. "Says it's a sign. Says we're being punished for our sins."

"Whose sins?" said Graham.

"Everyone's, I suppose. The priest wasn't specific."

"Never are," muttered Old Cob.

Chronicler watched the innkeeper while they talked. Kote stood behind the bar, wiping it with his white cloth in slow even circles, and nodded, and made small sounds of sympathy in the right places. He did not look up. He did not look toward the window, or the woods beyond it, or the thin grey line of smoke that still leaned against the sky.

But Chronicler noticed that the cloth had stopped moving, just for a moment, when Jake said the word *spiders*.

\* \* \*

"There's something else," said Aaron.

It was the first thing he had said since he came in. Everyone turned to look at him, and he flushed red to the tips of his ears.

"I mean," he said. "It's probably nothing. It's just something I heard. On the road. When I went to Rannish last span for the iron."

"Well, go on," said Graham. "Don't leave us hanging."

Aaron looked down at his cider. "There was a man," he said. "In the inn at Rannish. A traveling man. He'd come up from the south, from Vintas, he said. And he was telling stories." He paused. "About Kvothe."

The room went very quiet.

Kote had not moved. He stood behind the bar with his cloth in his hand, and his face was mild and pleasant and interested. The face of an innkeeper hearing a story.

At the table by the hearth, Chronicler had gone very still. Beside him, Bast had stopped breathing.

"What kind of stories?" said Old Cob.

"The usual ones," said Aaron. "The draccus at Trebon. The fight at Imre. Felurian." He blushed again. "But then he told one I'd never heard. He said—" Aaron hesitated. "He said Kvothe wasn't dead."

Nobody spoke.

"He said," Aaron went on, "that the man they hanged in Renere, the one they said was Kvothe, wasn't him. He said it was some beggar they'd pulled off the street and dyed his hair red. And that the real Kvothe got away. And that he's out there somewhere, hiding." Aaron looked up. His face was flushed, but his eyes were bright. "He said Kvothe's waiting. For something. And that when it comes, he'll come back, and make everything right."

For a long moment, no one said anything at all.

Then Graham laughed. It was a big, easy, comfortable laugh, the laugh of a man who does not believe in fairy tales. "Kvothe," he said. "Waiting. Hiding under a rock somewhere, I suppose, waiting for the right moment to leap out and save us all." He shook his head. "That's the trouble with stories. People always want the hero to come back."

"Maybe he will," said Aaron stubbornly.

"And maybe pigs will fly," said Old Cob. "If he was ever alive to begin with. I heard he was a demon. Horns and all. Only looked like a man on the outside."

"I heard he was seven feet tall," said Jake.

"I heard he was an Adem," said Graham. "Or trained by them. Could kill a man with his little finger."

"I heard," said Old Cob, with the air of a man playing a trump card, "that he killed the king with a word. Just said a word, and the king fell down dead. Right in front of the whole court."

They all looked at Kote. It was a habit, in the Waystone. When there was an argument, you looked at the innkeeper. He had a way of settling things.

Kote smiled. It was a pleasant, professional, innkeeper's smile.

"I heard he had red hair," he said. "But I've heard a lot of things. Who's for another round?"

They laughed, and the tension went out of the room, and Graham slapped the bar and said he'd have another, and so would everybody else, and he'd pay. And the talk turned to other things: the price of iron, and the weather, and whether the Penitent King would raise the taxes again before the harvest.

Kote poured. He smiled. He nodded in the right places.

At the table by the hearth, Bast was staring at him with an expression of naked, burning intensity. Chronicler put a hand on his arm, gently, and after a moment Bast looked away.

\* \* \*

They stayed for the better part of an hour. Kote fed them bread and cheese and cold mutton from the kitchen, and they ate and drank and talked, and when they finally left, they left in good spirits, calling their goodbyes and promising to come back that evening.

When the door closed behind them, the innkeeper stood very still behind the bar for a long moment.

Then he set down his cloth. He came back around the bar and crossed the room and sat down at the table by the hearth. He did not look at Bast. He did not look at Chronicler. He looked at the sword above the fireplace.

"Where was I?" he said.

"You'd left the University," said Chronicler quietly. "You'd crossed the bridge. Auri was on the roof with a candle."

"Yes." The innkeeper nodded slowly. "Yes." He was quiet for a moment. "The boy was right, you know. Aaron. About the man they hanged in Renere."

Chronicler's pen stopped.

"We'll get to that," said the innkeeper. "It's later." He smiled, faintly, at something only he could see. "Everything's later. That's the trouble with this story. Everything important happens at the end."

He closed his eyes. When he opened them again, the innkeeper was gone.

"I went south," said Kvothe. "To Vintas. To the Maer, and his court, and his new wife, who was my aunt and did not know it. I went to find out what the Lackless family had been keeping, all those years. And instead, I found an old man with a walking stick, waiting for me across a tak board."

He looked at Chronicler.

"Write this part carefully," he said. "It's where I started to lose."

## **PART TWO: THE BEAUTIFUL GAME**



## Chapter Thirty-Four

# The Southern Road

There is a particular kind of loneliness that belongs to roads. It is not the loneliness of a room, where the walls press in and remind you that no one is there. It is not the loneliness of a crowd, where everyone is near and no one is close. It is a moving loneliness. It walks beside you. It keeps pace with you, mile after mile, and when you stop to rest at the side of the road, it sits down next to you and waits for you to get up again.

I had known that loneliness before. I had known it as a boy of twelve, walking out of the forest where my family had died, with nothing but a broken lute and the clothes on my back. I had known it on the long road to Tarbean, and on the longer road out of Tarbean, three years later, with a stolen purse and a head full of dreams.

But I had not known it for a long time. And I had forgotten how heavy it could be.

\* \* \*

I went south along the Great Stone Road, the old Aturan highway that runs from Imre down through the heart of the Commonwealth toward the border of Vintas. It was early spring, and the road was a river of mud. Carts sank to their axles. Horses slipped and stumbled. Travelers walked along the verges where the grass held the soil together, their boots caked with clay up to the knee.

I walked with them. I could have bought a horse; I had the Maer's money still, most of it. But I did not want a horse. I wanted to walk. I

wanted to feel every mile under my feet, the way you want to feel a wound, pressing on it to make sure it is still there.

I had been expelled. I kept saying it to myself as I walked, trying to make it real. *I have been expelled from the University.* I had worked for three years to get there, and three more to stay, and I had lost it in a single night. I had lost my place in the Arcanum. I had lost the Archives, with all their books and all their secrets. I had lost my bench in the Fishery and my room at Anker's and my twice-a-span at the Eolian. I had lost Sim and Wil and Fela, and Devi, and Auri. I had lost Elodin, who had never quite been my teacher and was now never going to be.

I had lost it all by going down a set of stairs.

And the worst of it, the part that sat on my chest at night like a stone and would not let me sleep, was that I did not regret it. Not really. Not at the bottom, where the truth lives. I had gone down those stairs and I had learned something I could not have learned any other way. I had learned what I was.

*The line of Loeclos. The Thief's own blood.*

I did not know what to do with that. It was too large. It was like being told that the sky was a lid, or that the ground beneath your feet was the back of a sleeping beast. It did not fit anywhere in my head. And so I walked, and I carried it, and I did not look at it too closely.

\* \* \*

On the fourth day out of Imre, I fell in with a troupe.

I heard them before I saw them. It was late afternoon, and the sun was slanting low through the trees, and from somewhere up ahead came the sound of a fiddle. Not a good fiddle. It was sawing away at "Tinker Tanner" with more enthusiasm than skill, and every third note was flat. But it was a fiddle, and it was being played on the road, and underneath it I could hear the creak of wagon wheels and the jingle of harness and a woman's voice laughing.

My heart turned over in my chest. I began to walk faster.

They were Edema Ruh. I knew it before I came around the bend, knew it from the rhythm of the fiddle and the pitch of the laughter, the

way you know your own mother's voice in a crowded room. And when I came around the bend and saw them, three wagons painted in bright colors gone dull with the dust of the road, I knew it for certain.

A man was walking beside the lead wagon, leading the horse. He was tall and lean and brown as a nut, with a beard going grey and a battered hat pulled low over his eyes. He heard my footsteps and turned, and his hand went to the knife at his belt, the way any Ruh's hand does when a stranger comes up behind him on the road.

Then he saw my face. And my hair. And the lute case on my back.

His hand came away from the knife.

"One family," I said.

His eyes widened. Then a slow smile spread across his face.

"Under the sky," he said. "One family. Well met, brother. Where are you bound?"

"South. Vintas."

"So are we, as far as Rannish. Walk with us?"

"I'd be glad to."

\* \* \*

Their troupe was called Hallow's Company, after the old man who had founded it forty years before. He was dead now, and his son led the troupe: the lean brown man with the grey beard, whose name was Tessit. His wife was Mirra, a round cheerful woman with a laugh like a bell, and she was the one I had heard laughing. There were nine of them in all. Tessit and Mirra and their three children, two of them grown. An old man named Brin who played the fiddle, badly, and knew it, and did not care. A pair of brothers, Kellen and Wat, who did tumbling and knife-work. And a young woman named Illa, with dark eyes and a sharp tongue, who sang.

They took me in without question. That is the way of the Ruh. A Ruh on the road is never a stranger to another Ruh. We share our fires and our food and our songs, and we ask nothing in return but the same.

That night, around their fire, I played for them.

I had not played for Ruh in a very long time. Not since I was a boy. I had played in taverns and in the Eolian and in the halls of the Maer, for lords and ladies and merchants and students. But I had not played for my own people. For people who knew what music was, down in their bones. For people who had grown up with it the way other people grow up with bread and water.

It was different. I cannot explain how. The best I can say is that when I played for the Eolian, I was showing them something. When I played for Hallow's Company, around their fire, with the stars coming out overhead and the smell of woodsmoke and horses in the air, I was not showing them anything. I was just playing. The way you breathe. The way you speak to a friend.

I played "Tinker Tanner," and Brin joined in on his fiddle, and his flat notes did not matter at all. I played "Jenny Nettle," and the children danced. I played "The Lay of Sir Savien Traliard," and Illa sang the Aloine part, and her voice was rough and sweet as honey from a wild hive, and when we finished, Mirra was crying and laughing at the same time and Tessit was looking at me with an expression I did not understand.

"Where did you learn to play like that?" he said.

"My father," I said. "And the road."

"Who was your father?"

I hesitated. It had been a long time since I had said it aloud.

"Arliden," I said. "Of the Edema Ruh."

The fire crackled. Nobody spoke. Tessit looked at me for a long time, and then he looked at Mirra, and something passed between them.

"Arliden's troupe," said Mirra softly. "Oh, child."

"You knew them?"

"Everyone knew them." Tessit's voice was quiet. "Arliden was the best. Everyone said so. The best troupe on the roads. The best songs. The best plays." He shook his head. "And then one year they just didn't come to Hallowfell for the midsummer fair. Nobody knew why. And then the next year there was talk. Somebody had found wagons in the

woods, burned. Nothing left. Nobody knew who'd done it."

"I know who did it," I said.

Tessit looked at me. The fire crackled between us.

"Do you," he said. It was not a question.

I did not answer. After a moment, Tessit nodded slowly.

"You're his boy, then," he said. "The little one. We heard there was one. Red hair, like his mother. We heard he was dead."

"I was, for a while."

Mirra came around the fire and put her arms around me. She smelled of woodsmoke and lavender and bread, and she held me the way my mother had held me, a long time ago, and I did not know what to do. I sat there stiffly in her arms, with my lute in my lap, and my eyes stung, and I could not speak.

"Your mother," Mirra said into my hair. "Laurian. She was the loveliest thing. Voice like a lark. And the way she carried herself, like a queen." She pulled back and looked at me, her eyes wet. "Everyone knew she wasn't born to the road. Everyone could see it. But nobody ever asked. She was Arliden's, and she was Ruh, and that was that."

"Did she ever talk about where she came from?"

Mirra shook her head. "Never. Not once, not to anyone. It was the one thing she wouldn't talk about." She hesitated. "But I remember once, at a fair, somebody sang that old rhyme. The one about Lady Lackless. And your mother went white as milk and walked away and didn't come back to the fire all night." She shook her head. "I always wondered about that."

I did not say anything. I did not have to.

\* \* \*

I traveled with Hallow's Company for nine days. They were among the best days of that year.

We played in villages along the road, in inn yards and on village greens. We put on a play in a market square in Cheshire, a comedy about a tinker who outwits a greedy lord, and I played the tinker, and the crowd laughed so hard that an old woman fell off her bench and had to be helped up. We camped in fields and woods, beside streams,

under the stars. We ate stew and bread and whatever the villages gave us, and we sang late into the night.

I taught Illa three new songs. She taught me a knife trick that Kellen and Wat had taught her, and I cut myself practicing it and she laughed at me until she cried. Brin showed me how to rosin a fiddle bow properly, which I already knew, but I let him show me anyway. The children followed me everywhere and asked me to tell them stories, and I told them about Felurian, leaving out the parts that were not for children, and they did not believe a word of it.

For nine days, I was Edema Ruh again. Just Ruh. Not a student, not an arcanist, not a line or a key or the last of anything. Just a red-haired boy with a lute, walking a road with his people.

It could not last. Nothing like that ever does.

\* \* \*

On the ninth night, we camped near a village called Aldermoor, a day's walk north of Rannish. It was a small place, a few dozen houses clustered around a crossroads, with a mill and a smithy and a little stone church. We had played there that afternoon, and the villagers had been kind, and had given us a whole ham and a cask of cider, and we were feasting on both around the fire.

I had gone a little way from the camp to be alone. I did that sometimes, in the evenings. I would take Kilvin's candle out of its box and light it and sit with it for a while, the way I did every night, watching it burn.

It burned yellow. I watched it for a while, and let my mind drift, and thought about nothing in particular.

And then, without warning, it turned blue.

\* \* \*

I did not move. I sat there in the dark beside the candle, and I watched it burn blue, and I felt my heart stop.

It was not the pale flicker I had seen before, the brief shiver of color that came and went. It was a deep, steady, unwavering blue, the blue of a winter sky at dusk, the blue of a bruise. It burned blue, and it

did not stop.

Somewhere in the world, the Chandrian were doing something.

I stood up. I did not know what I was going to do. I did not know where they were or what they were doing or how I could possibly stop them. I only knew that I had to move. I had to do something.

And then I smelled the smoke.

It was faint at first. Just a thread of it, on the wind, coming from the south. It could have been a cookfire, or a bonfire, or a farmer burning brush. But it was not. I knew it was not. There was something in it, something beneath the ordinary smell of woodsmoke, that set my teeth on edge. Something sour and wrong, like the smell of rot, like the smell of rust.

I snatched up the candle and ran back to the camp.

Tessit was on his feet before I reached the fire. He had smelled it too. So had Mirra, and Kellen, and Wat. They stood around the fire with their faces turned to the south, and their eyes were wide.

"Fire," said Tessit. "South of here. Toward the Deller farm."

"How far?"

"Two miles. Maybe three." He looked at me. "What's that?"

He was looking at the candle in my hand, still burning blue.

I did not answer. I did not know how.

"Stay here," I said. "All of you. Stay here, stay together, keep the fire high. Don't go toward the smoke."

"Kvothe—"

"Please." I looked at him. "Tessit. Please. I know what this is. Stay here."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at the candle. And something in his face changed. Something old and deep and Ruh.

"Go," he said quietly. "We'll stay. Come back to us."

\* \* \*

I ran.

I ran south through the dark, across fields and through hedges, toward the smoke. I had Caesura at my hip and the candle in my hand, its blue flame streaming in the wind of my running but never going

out. I did not know what I would do when I got there. I did not care.

The smoke grew thicker as I ran. Soon I could see the glow of the fire, orange against the black sky. And then I came over the crest of a low hill and saw it.

It was a farmhouse. Or it had been. A long low building of stone and timber, with a thatched roof and a barn beside it and a yard full of carts and tools. It was burning now. The roof was a sheet of flame, roaring and crackling, sending sparks spiraling up into the sky. The barn was burning too. The whole yard was lit up orange and red, bright as day.

And the flames were blue.

Not all of them. Most of the fire was ordinary, orange and yellow and red. But here and there, in the heart of it, there were tongues of blue. Cold blue, winter blue, the blue of the candle in my hand.

I stopped at the edge of the yard. I stood there with my chest heaving and my sword in my hand, and I looked.

There were bodies in the yard.

I will not describe them. I have described such things before, and I do not want to do it again. I will say only that there were five of them, and that they were lying in the mud in front of the burning house, and that some of them were very small.

And I will say that the mud around them was frozen. In the middle of spring. On a night warm enough that I had been sitting outside without a cloak. The mud around the bodies was frozen hard as stone, and there was frost on their eyelashes.

\* \* \*

I searched the yard. I searched the barn, as much as I could before the heat drove me back. I searched the fields around the farm, calling out, my voice raw and cracked. I found no one. No survivors. No Chandrian. Nothing but the burning house and the frozen mud and the five small shapes lying in the firelight.

The candle in my hand burned yellow again. I did not notice when it changed.



I stood in the yard as the fire burned down, and I did not know what to do. I had come too late. I had always come too late. I had come too late at eleven years old, running back through the woods to find my family dead. And I had come too late now.

It was nearly dawn when I heard the sound.

It was very faint. A small sound, like a kitten mewling. It came from the well at the edge of the yard, a round stone well with a wooden cover and a bucket on a rope.

I went to the well. I pulled off the cover and looked down.

There was a girl in the bucket.

She was very small. Six, maybe, or seven. She was curled up in the bucket at the end of the rope, halfway down the well, in the dark. Her face was white and streaked with soot and tears. Her eyes were enormous. She was clutching something against her chest.

"Hello," I said softly. "It's all right. I'm not one of them. I'm here to help."

She stared up at me. She did not speak.

"I'm going to pull you up," I said. "Is that all right?"

She did not answer. But after a long moment, she nodded.

I pulled her up. Slowly, carefully, hand over hand on the rope. When the bucket came level with the rim of the well, I reached down and lifted her out and held her against my chest. She was cold and shaking and very light. She did not cry. She was past crying.

"What's your name?" I asked.

She looked up at me. Her lips moved. At first no sound came out. Then, very quietly, she said, "Nell."

"Nell. That's a good name. I'm Kvothe."

She did not say anything. She was looking over my shoulder, at the burned house, at the shapes in the mud.

"Don't look," I said. "Don't look at that. Look at me."

She looked at me.

"Nell," I said. "Can you tell me what happened?"

She was quiet for a long time. Then she held out the thing she had been clutching against her chest.

It was a scrap of cloth. Old and frayed and stained with soot. It had been cut, or torn, from something larger. There were knots on it. Dozens of them, tied into the threads of the cloth, in patterns that made my eyes ache.

"Mama's cloth," Nell whispered. "The old cloth. From Great-Gran. Mama said we had to keep it safe. Always and always." Her face crumpled. "They wanted it. They burned it. I got a piece. I hid."

I took the scrap of cloth. It was warm from her hands. The knots were Yllish. I could read a few of them. *Keeping. Door. Name.*

"Who wanted it, Nell?" I asked. "Who came?"

She looked at me with her enormous eyes.

"First the pretty lady came," she said. "Yesterday. She was nice. She had dark hair and a nice voice and she asked if she could see Mama's cloth. She said she was writing a song. She looked at it for a long time and wrote things down, and she gave Mama a silver for letting her look, and then she went away." Nell's voice cracked. "And then tonight the others came. The cold ones."

I stood very still in the grey dawn light, with the girl in my arms and the scrap of knotted cloth in my hand, and the world seemed to tilt beneath my feet.

*She had dark hair and a nice voice. She said she was writing a song.*

"The pretty lady," I said. My voice sounded very far away. "Did she say her name?"

Nell shook her head. Then she stopped. She frowned, as if trying to remember.

"She wrote it," she said. "In the book. So Mama would know who'd looked." She pointed toward the burned house. "It was in the big book. With all the names of everyone who'd ever looked at the cloth. Mama made everyone write their name."

I looked at the house. It was nothing but ash and blackened stone now, smoking in the dawn. Whatever book had been in it was gone.

"Do you remember what she wrote?" I asked.

Nell thought about it. Then she nodded.

"It was a funny name," she said. "It started with a D. Mama said it was a pretty name. Like a flower."

She looked up at me.

"Dinael," she said.

\* \* \*

I carried Nell back to Hallow's Company. Mirra took her from my arms without a word and wrapped her in a blanket and held her by the fire, rocking her, humming softly. Nell fell asleep almost at once.

I sat down beside the fire. Tessit brought me a cup of something hot and strong and put it in my hands and sat down next to me. He did not ask any questions. He only sat there, a solid, silent presence at my side, while the sun came up over the fields.

I held the scrap of knotted cloth in my lap and looked at it.

Dinael. Denna had used that name once, years ago. Dinael, Dianne, Dinnah, Dyanae. She changed her names the way other women changed their dresses. I had always thought it was a kind of armor. A way of keeping herself safe, of never letting anyone hold her too tightly.

She had been here. Yesterday. She had come to this farm and asked to see an old cloth covered in Yllish knots. She had looked at it for a long time and written things down. She had paid for the privilege and gone away.

And then the Chandrian had come, and burned the cloth, and killed everyone who had kept it.

I did not believe she had known. I could not believe it. Not Denna. Not the girl who had cried over a dead child at Trebon, who had sung "The Lay of Sir Savien" with me at the Eolian with tears running down her face.

But she had been here. And she had been sent here. By someone who wanted to know what was written on that cloth. By someone who had then sent the Chandrian to make sure no one else would ever know.

By her patron.

I sat there by the fire as the sun came up, and I felt something settle into me that I had never felt before. It was not anger. Anger is hot, and this was cold. It was not fear. Fear makes you want to run, and this made me want to be very still.

It was purpose. Cold and clear and hard as stone.

I would find him. Denna's patron. Master Ash, or whatever he called himself. I would find him, and I would learn who he was, and what he wanted, and why he had sent a girl who loved songs to a farmhouse where a family kept an old cloth, knowing that she would be followed by death.

And then I would stop him.

I did not know how. I did not know when. But I knew, sitting there in the dawn with the smell of smoke still in my hair and the scrap of cloth in my hands, that I would.

It was a promise. And unlike most of the promises I have made in my life, I kept it.

God help me. I kept it.

## Chapter Thirty-Five

# A Toll on the Southern Road

Somewhere south of the Commonwealth border, on the road to Vintas, I was robbed by the politest highwaymen in the Four Corners.

I was traveling alone that day. Tessit's troupe had stopped for two nights in a village to play a wedding, and I had gone on ahead, restless, meaning to let them catch me up at the next town. I had my lute and my sword and a pack with a change of clothes and a little food, and a purse with what was left of the Maer's money. It was more than I liked to carry on a lonely road.

It was late afternoon. The road ran through a stretch of woods, old beech and oak, with the light coming green and gold through the leaves. I was walking slowly, humming to myself, thinking about Denna. And about her patron, and the Maer, and what I had come south to find. And about my own foolishness, which was considerable, and which I was trying hard not to think about.

And then a man stepped out of the trees in front of me, and bowed.

\* \* \*

He was tall and thin, with a long mournful face and a drooping grey mustache, and he was dressed like a gentleman who had fallen on hard times: a velvet coat, very worn, with patches at the elbows, and a hat with a bedraggled feather in it. He had a sword at his hip, which he did not draw. He swept off his hat and bowed very low, the feather brushing the dirt of the road.

"Good afternoon, young sir," he said. "I hope I find you well."

I stopped. I looked at him. I looked at the trees on either side of the road, where I could hear, now that I was listening, the small sounds of other people moving. Three of them. Perhaps four.

"Well enough," I said. "And yourself?"

"Oh, middling, middling." He replaced his hat. "The damp gets into my joints, this time of year. And business has been slow." He smiled apologetically. "Which brings me, I'm afraid, to the unpleasant part of our acquaintance."

"You're going to rob me."

"I'm going to ask you," he said, "to pay a toll. For the use of the road. It's a very fine road, you'll have noticed. We maintain it ourselves. We fill in the potholes and clear the fallen branches and keep the wolves at bay." He spread his hands. "It's only fair that those who enjoy its benefits should contribute to its upkeep."

"And if I don't?"

He looked pained.

"Then my associates," he said, "who are less courteous than I am, and considerably less patient, will be obliged to collect it on my behalf. And they are not gentle collectors." He sighed. "I do apologize. It's a very crude system. But we are very crude people, in the main."

\* \* \*

Four men came out of the trees. Two on either side. They were not dressed like gentlemen. They were dressed like what they were: hungry, hard-faced men with clubs and knives, who looked at me and my lute and my sword with flat, measuring eyes.

I could have fought them. I want to be clear about that. I had done the Ketan every morning since Haert, on rooftops and riverbanks and in the empty dueling rooms of the Mains. I had Caesura at my hip. Four men with clubs and one with a sword he did not seem inclined to draw: I could have fought them, and I might have won.

But I did not want to. I was tired and sad and I had come to the end of something, at the University, and I did not want to begin whatever came next by killing four hungry men on a road in the

woods. And there was something about the tall mournful man with the drooping mustache that I liked.

So I did what the Ruh do, when there is trouble on the road and fighting is not the answer.

I told a story.

\* \* \*

"How much is the toll?" I said.

The tall man looked relieved. "A modest sum. For a young man of your evident quality—" He looked at my lute case, and at the weight of the purse on my belt. "Shall we say, the contents of your purse?"

"That seems steep."

"The road is very well maintained."

"It is," I agreed. "I noticed that. Very few potholes. And no wolves at all." I looked at him. "I'll tell you what. I'll make you a wager."

His eyebrows rose. "A wager?"

"I'm a musician," I said. "A storyteller. Edema Ruh." I saw the four hard-faced men glance at each other. "I'll tell you a story. Right here. Right now. And if, at the end of it, you can tell me how it ends, then I'll pay your toll twice over. My purse, and my lute besides."

"And if I can't?"

"Then I pass for free," I said. "And you let the next traveler pass for free too. Whoever it is. Whatever they're carrying."

The tall man looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at his four associates. One of them, a broad man with a broken nose, shook his head sharply.

"Now, now, Bram," said the tall man mildly. "Let's not be hasty. It's been a very dull span." He turned back to me, and there was a light in his mournful eyes that had not been there before. "Very well, young sir. A story. But I warn you: I've heard a great many."

"Not this one," I said.

\* \* \*

I sat down on a fallen log beside the road. After a moment, the tall man sat down across from me, on a stump. The four hard men stood around us, uneasily, with their clubs.

And I told them a story about a highwayman.

I did not plan it. It came to me as I began, the way the best stories do. I told them about a man who had been a gentleman once, in a city far away. Who had lost his fortune and his name through no fault of his own, through the malice of a powerful lord. Who had gone to the woods, with nothing but his sword and his good manners, and gathered around him other men who had also lost everything. And who had set up a toll on the road, and collected it courteously from those who could afford to pay, and let those who could not afford it pass, and used the money to feed his men and the poor villages along the road.

"A very noble highwayman," said the tall man dryly.

"Very," I agreed. "And one day, a young man came down the road. A musician. A storyteller. And the highwayman stopped him, and asked for his toll. And the young man said—"

I stopped.

The tall man waited. The four hard men waited. The wind moved in the beech leaves overhead.

"Well?" said the tall man. "What did he say?"

"That's the wager," I said. "You tell me."

\* \* \*

He sat on his stump for a long time. His face was thoughtful. The four hard men looked at each other. The broad one with the broken nose, Bram, scowled.

"He paid," said Bram at last. "The musician. What else? He paid and went on his way."

"Is that the ending?" I said to the tall man. "Is that your answer?"

The tall man did not answer. He was looking at me very carefully, with his long mournful face.

"No," he said slowly. "No, I don't think it is." He stroked his drooping mustache. "I think the young man told the highwayman a story. About a highwayman. A noble one, who had lost everything,



and took tolls from the rich to feed the poor." He paused. "And I think the highwayman listened to the story, and recognized himself in it. Or rather—" He looked at me. "Recognized the man he had meant to be. When he first came to the woods. Before the hunger and the cold and the years made him into something else."

The four hard men had gone very quiet.

"And I think," said the tall man, very softly, "that the highwayman was ashamed. And let the young man pass. Not because he lost a wager. But because he did not want to be the kind of man who would rob a storyteller for telling him the truth."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long moment. Neither did anyone else.

"That's a very good ending," I said at last.

"Is it the right one?"

"I don't know," I said honestly. "I didn't know how it ended when I started. I only knew how it began." I looked at him. "You finished it. So I suppose it's yours."

The tall man looked at me for a long time. Then he laughed. It was a surprisingly warm laugh, deep and rueful.

"Edema Ruh," he said. "I should have known better." He stood up and swept off his bedraggled hat and bowed again, very low. "You win, young sir. Or I lose. I'm not sure which. Either way, you pass for free." He glanced at Bram. "And so does the next traveler. Whoever it is. Whatever they're carrying."

Bram opened his mouth to protest. The tall man looked at him. Bram closed his mouth.

\* \* \*

I stood up. I shouldered my pack and my lute. I nodded to the four hard men, who did not nod back, and to the tall man, who did.

"May I ask your name?" I said.

He hesitated. Then he smiled, his long mournful face creasing.

"I used to be called Lord Ferrin Vell," he said. "Of the Vells of Tinuë. Once upon a time." He shrugged. "Now I'm just Ferrin. The

toll-keeper of Beech Wood." He looked at me. "And you?"

"Kvothe."

His eyebrows went up. "*The* Kvothe? From the University? The one they tell stories about?"

"Some of them are true."

"Hm." He looked at me with new interest. "Well. I'll have a story of my own to tell, then. The day I was bested on my own road by Kvothe the Arcane, with nothing but a tale about myself." He smiled. "I shall dine out on it for years. If I ever dine out again."

\* \* \*

I walked on down the road. The trees closed in behind me. After a while, the sound of the highwaymen's voices faded.

I found out, much later, what had happened to them. It was Stapes who told me, in the Maer's palace, in passing, as if it were a thing of no importance.

A band of highwaymen had been operating in Beech Wood for years, he said, on the southern road. Their leader was a disgraced nobleman. They had been a terrible nuisance. But that summer, something strange had happened. They had stopped taking tolls from anyone who looked poor. They had begun leaving food on the doorsteps of the poorest farms along the road, at night, without a word. And in the autumn, when a patrol of the Maer's soldiers went into the woods to clear them out, they found the camp empty, and a note nailed to a tree.

*Gone to be what we meant to be*, the note said. *Thank the storyteller.*

Nobody knew what it meant, Stapes said. It had become a kind of joke, among the Maer's guards.

I did not tell him. I only smiled, and drank my wine, and thought of a tall mournful man on a stump in a beech wood, finishing my story for me.

It is the only time in my life I ever let someone else write the ending. It is also, I think, one of the few endings I have never regretted.

## Chapter Thirty-Six

# How the Ruh Came to the Roads

Tessit told the story on our sixth night with Hallow's Company, when the fire was low and the children were asleep and there was nothing left in the cider jug but the dregs.

It is an old story. Every Ruh knows it. My father told it to me when I was five, and his mother told it to him, and so on back as far as anyone can remember. There are a hundred versions. This is Tessit's. I have always liked it best.

\* \* \*

*Once, said Tessit, before there were kingdoms, and before there were roads, the Ruh had a home.*

*It was a city. A great one. Built of white stone, on a high mountain, where the air was clean and the sky was close. And the Ruh were its singers. Not its lords, not its soldiers, not its builders. Its singers. They sang in the great hall, and in the gardens, and at the fountains where the children played. They sang the city's history, so it would be remembered. They sang the city's laws, so they would be kept. They sang every birth and every death and every marriage, so that nothing that happened in that city would ever be forgotten.*

*And the city loved them for it. And they loved the city.*

*And then, one night, the city burned.*

\* \* \*

Across the fire, I had gone very still. Tessit did not notice. Or if he did, he did not stop.

*No one knows why, said Tessit. The songs don't say. Some say it was a war. Some say it was a betrayal. Some say a man the city loved went mad with grief and brought it down. The songs don't say, because the ones who knew the songs died in the fire. Almost all of them.*

*Almost.*

*A few of the singers lived. A handful. They were out on the roads, that night, carrying songs to the towns around the mountain, the way the singers always did. And they saw the fire from far off, on the mountaintop, like a torch. And they came running. And by the time they got there, there was nothing left. Only ash, and stone, and silence.*

*And a man with one eye, standing in the ruins.*

*\* \* \**

*I did not breathe.*

*He was a great lord, said Tessit. A namer, some say. Or a king. The songs don't agree. But he was standing in the ashes of the city with blood on his face, and he looked at the singers who had come running up the mountain, and he said:*

*"The city is gone. The hall is gone. The gardens and the fountains are gone. There is nothing left for you to sing to."*

*And the eldest of the singers, an old woman with a voice like a river, said: "Then we will sing to the roads."*

*And the man with one eye looked at her for a long time. And then he said, "Yes. That is what the world will need. Go out onto the roads. Carry the songs with you. And never stop. Never build another city. Never make another home. Because the things that hunt songs will hunt you, and a city can be burned, but a road cannot."*

*And the singers went down the mountain, and out onto the roads. And they never stopped. And they never built another city. And their children were born in wagons, and their grandchildren, and their grandchildren's grandchildren. And they became the Edema Ruh.*

*Edema, said Tessit. In the old tongue. It means "those who remember."*

*And Ruh. It means "the road."*

*The road that remembers.*

\* \* \*

The fire crackled. Nobody said anything for a long time.

"That's not how my father told it," I said at last. My voice sounded strange.

Tessit looked at me across the fire. "How did he tell it?"

"He said the Ruh were cursed. For stealing a song from a king. He said the king cursed them to wander forever, and never have a home."

Tessit smiled faintly. "That's the version for the villages. For the gorgio. They like to hear that we're cursed. It makes them feel better about hating us." He poured the dregs of the cider jug into his cup and looked at them. "My mother told me the other one. The true one. She said her mother told her it was a secret. For the family. Not for anyone else."

"Why tell me?"

Tessit looked at me for a long moment. His lean brown face was very still in the firelight.

"Because you're Arliden's boy," he said. "And Arliden was trying to find that city. Did you know? That was what his song was about. The one he never finished. He'd heard the true version from my mother, one summer, when our troupes camped together. And he got it into his head that it was real. That there'd been a white city, and a fire, and a man with one eye." Tessit shook his head slowly. "He spent years looking. Asking old men in taverns. Reading old books in forgotten libraries." He drank his cider. "My mother said it would get him killed. Looking for things that should stay lost."

I did not say anything.

"She was right," said Tessit quietly. "Wasn't she?"

I looked into the fire. At the red coals and the grey ash.

"Yes," I said.

\* \* \*

I did not tell Tessit, that night, that the city was real. That I had heard the whole story from an old man in a broken lighthouse, a boy who had hidden under a slab of white marble while it burned. That the man

with one eye was still alive, in a round tower in the ruins, keeping watch.

I did not know that last part yet. That would come later.

But I lay awake that night in the back of the third wagon, among the sacks and the costumes, and I thought about my people. About the Ruh. About a handful of singers coming down a burning mountain and out onto the roads, and never stopping. About the thing that hunts songs, and a city that can be burned, and a road that cannot.

*Edema Ruh.*

*The road that remembers.*

I had always been proud to be Ruh. I had been proud in Tarbean, and at the University, and at the Maer's court, where they sneered at me for it. I had been proud the way you are proud of a scar.

That night, for the first time, I understood what I was proud of.

We were not cursed. We were not thieves or beggars or tinkers. We were the last singers of a city that burned. And we had been carrying its songs down every road in the world, for ten thousand years, so that no one would forget.

I thought about Skarpi, hiding under a slab of marble. I thought about my father, looking for the city in old books. I thought about my mother, singing harmony beside him by the fire.

And I made a promise, lying in the dark among the sacks, that I would finish my father's song. The one he never finished. The one about the white city.

I did. It cost me more than I can tell you. But I did.

And when I sang it, in the Eolian, with the candles burning blue, I sang it for the Ruh. For the road that remembers.

I do not think anyone in that hall understood. Except, perhaps, one. A shadow in the center of the room, made of forgetting.

I think he understood very well.

## Chapter Thirty-Seven

# Severen

I left Nell with Hallow's Company.

It was not an easy decision, and it was not mine alone. On the morning after the fire, the headman of Aldermoor came out to the Deller farm with half the village behind him, and they stood in the yard and looked at what was left, and some of the women wept and some of the men swore and the priest said prayers over the frozen mud. They asked me what had happened. I told them there had been a fire. It was true, as far as it went.

They asked about the girl. I told them she was with us. The headman, a heavy grey man named Tobin with a farmer's hands and a farmer's patience, came back to the camp with me and looked at Nell sleeping in Mirra's lap and was quiet for a long time.

"There's no kin," he said at last. "Deller's people are all dead or gone to Atur. His wife's people were from somewhere in the east. Nobody knows where." He looked at Mirra. "She could go to the church. The priest'd take her."

Mirra did not say anything. She only held Nell a little tighter.

"Or," said Tobin slowly, "she could go with you. If you'd have her."

Tessit and Mirra looked at each other. There was a whole conversation in that look, years of it, the kind of conversation that only happens between people who have been married a very long time.

"We'd have her," said Tessit.

And so Nell of the Deller farm became Nell of Hallow's Company, Edema Ruh, one family under the sky. When I left them two days later at the crossroads outside Rannish, she was sitting on the seat of the lead wagon beside Mirra, wrapped in a blanket, holding the reins of the old grey horse while Mirra showed her how. She did not smile. She did not wave. But she watched me go, the way Auri had, and I felt her eyes on my back for a long way down the road.

I kept the scrap of knotted cloth. Mirra had tried to give it back to Nell, and Nell had shaken her head and pushed it into my hands.

"You keep it," she had said. "You'll know what to do."

I did not know what to do. But I kept it.

\* \* \*

It took me twelve more days to reach Severen.

I will not tell you much about that journey. It was long and hard and mostly uneventful. I crossed the border into Vintas at a place called Tiller's Ford, where a bored soldier looked at my letter from the Maer and waved me through. I walked through the rolling green hills of northern Vintas, past vineyards and orchards and great stone houses set back from the road behind high walls. I slept in inns and haylofts and once, memorably, in a church, where the priest caught me in the morning and tried to convert me to a sect of Tehlinism I had never heard of, which apparently involved a great deal of fasting and a total abstinence from music. I declined.

I lit Kilvin's candle every night. It burned yellow every night. I did not know whether that made me feel better or worse.

And every night, before I slept, I took out the scrap of knotted cloth and looked at it.

I could read some of it now. More than I had been able to on the first night. I had spent hours with it, turning it over in my hands, puzzling out the knots one by one the way Denna had taught me. It was slow work. Many of the knots were ones I had never seen before, and some of them were so complex that I could not follow them at all. But I could make out pieces.



*Keeping.* That one was everywhere, tied over and over into the fabric. *Door. Name. Line.* A knot that I thought meant *stone*, though I was not sure. And one, near the center of the scrap, that I recognized with a jolt of cold certainty. It was the same knot I had seen in the blue book in the Archives, beside the names of the Lackless family. The same knot I had seen in the heart of Kilvin's candle.

I did not know what it meant. But I knew, now, that it meant something. It was a mark. A signature. A sign that said *this belongs to the keeping.*

The Deller family had been keepers. Minor ones, perhaps. Distant cousins of some old line. But they had kept a cloth that recorded something about the doors, and they had kept it for generations, and they had made everyone who looked at it write their name in a book.

And then Denna had come. And then the Chandrian.

I did not know how to feel about that. So I did not feel anything. I put the cloth away and blew out the candle and lay in the dark and did not sleep.

\* \* \*

Severen is a city built on a cliff. I have told you about it before, I think. The high city sits on top of the cliff, with its great houses and its gardens and its wide clean streets. The low city sprawls at the bottom, crowded and dirty and loud. And in between, connecting them, there is a single road cut into the face of the cliff, a road so steep and narrow that carts have to be hauled up it by teams of oxen.

The Maer's palace sits at the very top of the high city, at the very edge of the cliff. From its windows, you can look down on the whole of Severen spread out below you like a map, and beyond it the great flat plain of the river valley, stretching away green and gold to the horizon.

I climbed the cliff road on foot, as I had the first time I came to Severen, more than a year before. It was hard going. By the time I reached the top, my legs were burning and my shirt was soaked with sweat and my breath was rasping in my throat. I stopped at the top of the road and leaned against the wall and looked back down the way I

had come, and I remembered the first time I had stood there. How young I had been. How foolish. How sure of myself.

I did not feel young now. I did not feel sure of anything.

\* \* \*

The Maer received me in his study, a long room lined with books and maps, with tall windows looking out over the cliff. He was sitting at his desk when I was shown in, and he rose to greet me with a smile.

He looked well. Much better than when I had first met him, when Caudicus had been poisoning him slowly and he had been thin and grey and trembling. He had filled out. His color was good. His eyes were bright and sharp and clear. He moved like a man who had many years ahead of him and intended to use every one.

"Kvothe," he said warmly. "Welcome back to Severen. I did not expect to see you so soon."

"Nor did I, your grace."

"Sit, sit." He waved me to a chair and sat down himself. "Stapes tells me you walked up the cliff road. You should have sent word. I would have sent a carriage."

"I wanted to walk."

He raised an eyebrow. "Did you? How very Ruh of you." He smiled to take the sting out of it. "Well. You are here now. Tell me why."

I had thought a great deal about how to answer that question. I had rehearsed it on the road, a dozen different ways. I had thought about lying. I had thought about telling him the whole truth. In the end, I told him something in between.

"I was expelled from the University," I said.

The Maer's face did not change. But his eyes sharpened.

"Expelled," he said. "For what?"

"For going somewhere I was forbidden to go. In the Archives."

"And what did you find there, in this forbidden place?"

I hesitated. The Maer watched me with his sharp clear eyes, and I knew that he was reading my face the way I had learned to read faces in his court. He was very good at it. Better than me.

"Old things," I said at last. "Old records. About families. About old lines." I paused. "About the Lackless family, your grace."

Something moved in the Maer's face. It was very small, very quickly controlled. But I saw it.

"My wife's family," he said.

"Yes."

He was quiet for a long moment. Then he rose from his desk and went to the window and stood looking out over the cliff, his hands clasped behind his back.

"You know," he said, "that my wife's family is very old. Older than mine. Older than the crown of Vintas itself. They were lords in these lands before there was a Vintas, before the Aturan Empire, before anyone kept records." He paused. "And you know, I think, that they have their secrets. Every old family does. But the Lackless family has more than most."

"I know about the box, your grace."

He turned from the window and looked at me. "The box."

"The one Meluan showed me. The one with no lid and no lock."

He was silent for a long time.

"She has not shown it to anyone since," he said at last. "Not even me. She keeps it locked away in her rooms, and she will not speak of it." He came back to his desk and sat down. "I asked her once what was in it. She told me that no one knew. That no one had ever known. That it had been passed down in her family for longer than anyone could remember, and that it was never to be opened." He looked at me. "Why do you ask about it?"

"Because I think I know what's in it."

The Maer leaned forward. "Tell me."

I took a deep breath. "A key," I said. "A key of stone."

\* \* \*

I told him some of it. Not all. I did not tell him about the Chandrian, or my parents, or the Book of Watches. I did not tell him about the Sleeper, or the voice behind the door. I did not tell him that his wife was my aunt.

But I told him about the line of Loeclos. About the old family that had kept a door, and the key that opened it. About the rhyme the children sang, and how it might be more than a rhyme. I told him that I thought there were people who wanted that key, and that they might be dangerous.

He listened without interrupting. When I was done, he sat back in his chair and steepled his fingers and looked at me over them for a long time.

"This is a very strange story," he said.

"I know, your grace."

"If anyone else had told it to me, I would have had them thrown out of my study." He paused. "But you are not anyone else. You saved my life. You found the bandits in the Eld. You helped me win my wife." He smiled faintly. "And you have a way of being right about strange things, even when they seem absurd."

"Thank you, your grace."

"Do not thank me yet." His smile faded. "I will tell you something now. In confidence. You will not repeat it."

"Of course."

He leaned forward. "Two months ago, someone tried to enter my wife's rooms at night. They were very skilled. They passed three sets of guards and two locked doors without anyone seeing them. They were discovered only because my wife could not sleep, and was sitting up in the dark, and heard the latch of her bedroom door turn." He paused. "She screamed. The guards came. The intruder was gone. Nothing was taken."

"What were they looking for?"

"My wife believes they were looking for the box." The Maer's face was grim. "She has not let it out of her sight since. She keeps it with her day and night. She sleeps with it under her pillow." He shook his head. "It is not good for her. She is with child, Kvothe. Six months gone. She should be resting, not lying awake every night with a box under her pillow, waiting for someone to come for it."

I was quiet for a moment. Then I said, "Do you know who it was?"

"No. But I have my suspicions." He looked at me. "You have heard, I suppose, about the deaths in the royal family."

"I've heard some."

"Four now. Four in two years. All of them in the line of succession. All of them accidents, or illnesses, or misfortunes." His voice was flat. "And the king himself is ill. Very ill. His physicians say it is a wasting sickness, and that he may not see the summer."

"Poison?"

"Perhaps. Perhaps not. I have had my own people look into it, and they have found nothing." He was silent for a moment. "But I have noticed something. Each of those deaths has moved one man closer to the throne. One man, and one family."

"Jakis," I said.

The Maer looked at me sharply. "You know."

"I know Ambrose. His son. We were at the University together."

"Ah." Something like amusement flickered in his eyes. "Yes. I believe I remember hearing about that. Something about a broken arm, and a fire, and a great deal of shouting." He waved a hand. "Baron Jakis is a powerful man. Very powerful. He has friends in every corner of the court. And his son is now fifth in line for the throne."

"Fifth?"

"Fifth, as of a month ago. Another cousin died. A fall from a balcony, at a party in Renere. Quite drunk, by all accounts." The Maer's voice was dry. "Everyone was very sad."

I sat back in my chair. Fifth. When I had last seen Ambrose, in the snow on the steps of the Mains, he had been seventh. In the months since, two more people had died.

"Your grace," I said. "I don't think Baron Jakis is doing this. Not alone."

"Oh?"

"I think someone is helping him. Someone very patient. Someone very old." I hesitated. "Someone who wants more than the throne."

"What more is there than the throne?"

I did not answer. I thought about the box under Meluan's pillow. About the key of stone. About the door beneath the Lackless house, that could be opened only by the line.

The Maer watched me. He did not press. He was a patient man himself, in his way.

"You will stay here," he said at last. "In the palace. I will have Stapes prepare rooms for you. You will be my guest, and my advisor, and my eyes and ears in matters I do not understand." He paused. "And you will speak to my wife."

"Your grace?"

"About the box. About her family. About whatever it is you know that you have not told me." He smiled faintly. "Do not look so surprised. I know when a man is holding something back. I have been dealing with courtiers my whole life." His smile faded. "She is frightened, Kvothe. More frightened than I have ever seen her. And she will not tell me why. Perhaps she will tell you."

\* \* \*

Stapes showed me to my rooms. They were the same rooms I had stayed in before, a set of three connecting chambers in the eastern wing of the palace, with tall windows that looked out over the gardens. They were cleaner than I remembered. Someone had put fresh flowers on the table and fresh linen on the bed.

Stapes stood in the doorway after he had shown me in, his hands folded, his face as calm and pleasant as ever. He was the Maer's manservant, a small precise man who ran the palace with the efficiency of a general running a campaign. I had not liked him when I first met him. I had come to respect him a great deal.

"Is there anything else you require, sir?" he asked.

"No. Thank you, Stapes."

He did not leave. He stood there for a moment longer, looking at me with his calm, pleasant face.

"If I may say so, sir," he said, "it is very good to have you back. His grace has been—" He hesitated, choosing his words with care.

"His grace has been troubled, of late. And her ladyship even more so. I think your presence will be a comfort to them both."

"I hope so, Stapes."

He nodded. Then he paused again, as if he had one more thing to say and was not sure whether he should say it.

"Sir," he said. "There is a gentleman at court who has been asking after you. He asked the moment you were announced, and he asked me to tell you that he would be pleased to see you at your earliest convenience." A faint smile touched his lips. "He said you would know him by his stick."

My heart gave a strange little lurch.

"Bredon," I said.

"Yes, sir. He has rooms in the western wing. He said that he would be in the small garden tomorrow afternoon, with a board, if you cared to join him." Stapes bowed. "Good night, sir."

He left. I stood alone in my rooms, looking at the door he had closed behind him.

Bredon. Of course. Bredon was always at court. He had been at court when I first came to Severen, and he would be at court long after I left. He was one of those people who seemed to be part of a place, the way a statue in a square is part of it, or an old tree.

I thought about seeing him again, and I felt something warm and glad rise up in me. Bredon had been kind to me when I was new at court and did not know how anything worked. He had taught me *tak*, and patience, and the art of losing gracefully. He had been something like a friend. Something like a teacher. Something, if I am honest, like a grandfather, though I had never had one and did not know what that was supposed to feel like.

I thought about seeing him on the steps of the Mains, in the snow, standing behind Ambrose.

The warmth in me flickered. Just a little.

I told myself it meant nothing. I told myself he had explained it perfectly well: an old acquaintance of Baron Jakis, escorting the son home. I told myself that Bredon knew everyone.

I went to bed. I lay in the dark, in the soft clean bed with the fresh linen, and I listened to the silence of the palace, and I did not sleep for a long time.

And when I did sleep, I dreamed of a tak board. Black stones and white, laid out in patterns on a grid of lines. I was playing, and I was losing, and I did not know why. Every move I made seemed good. Every move seemed to strengthen my position. And yet, stone by stone, move by move, I was being surrounded.

Across the board, I could not see my opponent's face. Only his hands, old and spotted and gentle, placing the stones one by one. And beside the board, leaning against the table, a walking stick of dark wood, with a head of gleaming silver.



## Chapter Thirty-Eight

# The Beautiful Game

The small garden was not small. It was only smaller than the other gardens of the Maer's palace, which were so vast and so elaborate that you could get lost in them for an afternoon. The small garden was merely enormous. It was a walled square of green behind the western wing, with gravel paths and clipped hedges and a fountain in the center where a stone fish spat water into a stone basin. There were benches set along the paths, in the shade of old trees. And under the oldest tree, a great spreading oak whose roots had cracked the gravel of the path, there was a small stone table.

Bredon was sitting at it. There was a tak board in front of him, the stones already laid out in their bowls, black and white. His walking stick leaned against the table beside him. He was reading a book, and he did not look up as I came down the path toward him.

"Kvothe," he said, turning a page. "You're late."

"You didn't say a time."

"No. But you're late nonetheless. I've been waiting since noon." He closed the book and set it aside and looked up at me, and his face broke into a smile of such warmth and pleasure that I felt my own face answer it before I could stop myself. "Sit. Sit, my boy. It's good to see you."

I sat. He looked at me across the board, his bright old eyes moving over my face, my clothes, my sword.

"You've changed," he said. "I said so in the snow, and it's even more true in the sun. You carry yourself differently. You're harder

around the edges. Something's happened to you."

"A great many things have happened to me."

"Yes. I heard." He picked up a white stone and turned it in his fingers. "Expelled. From the University. At seventeen." He shook his head slowly. "Do you know, I think that must be some kind of record."

"I'm told it is."

"Well. There are worse things to hold records in." He set the stone down on the board, at one of the corner points. An opening move. The same one he always made. "Your move."

I looked at the board. I picked up a black stone. I placed it.

We played.

\* \* \*

I have tried, over the years, to explain tak to people who do not know it. It is not easy. It is a very simple game, on the surface. Two players, black and white, taking turns placing stones on a grid of lines. The object is to surround your opponent's stones and capture them, while protecting your own. That is all. A child can learn the rules in an afternoon.

But underneath the simple rules, there is a depth that goes down and down, like a well with no bottom. Every stone you place changes the shape of the board. Every move opens some possibilities and closes others. The best players do not think in terms of single moves. They think in shapes, in patterns, in long slow flows of influence that stretch across the whole board and take dozens of moves to play out.

Bredon was the best player I had ever met. He had told me once that he had been playing for sixty years, and I believed him. He saw the board the way a master musician hears a song: not as a series of notes, but as a whole, a single shape unfolding in time.

When I had first played him, the year before, he had beaten me so thoroughly and so easily that it had been almost funny. I had lost every game, dozens of them, one after another. But I had learned. I had studied. I had thought about the game on the long road to Ademre and back, laying out imaginary boards in my head and playing against imaginary opponents. And by the time I left Severen, I had been able

to hold my own against him. Sometimes. For a while.

Now, sitting across the board from him in the small garden, I found that I had forgotten nothing.

We played for an hour. The board filled with stones, black and white, in patterns that shifted and flowed like water. Bredon was attacking on the eastern side, a long slow push that I could see coming but could not quite stop. I was building on the western side, a wall of black stones that I hoped would hold.

"You've been practicing," Bredon said.

"Only in my head."

"That's the best kind of practice. The board in your head is always perfect." He placed a stone. "Tell me about the University. What did they expel you for?"

I hesitated. I placed a stone.

"I went somewhere I shouldn't have."

"Where?"

"Down a set of stairs."

He laughed. It was a warm, delighted laugh, the laugh of a man who has heard something genuinely funny. "Down a set of stairs! They expelled you for going down a set of stairs?"

"They were very important stairs."

"They must have been." He placed a stone. "In the Archives, I suppose?"

I looked up. He was looking at the board, not at me. His face was mild and interested.

"Yes," I said. "In the Archives."

"Beneath the Four-plate door?"

I did not answer. I placed a stone.

Bredon looked up at me. His eyes were bright and kind. "Ah," he said. "I've touched a nerve. I'm sorry. It's none of my business, of course. I was only curious." He smiled. "Old men are always curious. It's the only vice we have left."

"How did you know about the Four-plate door?"

"Everyone knows about the Four-plate door. It's famous." He placed a stone. "I visited the University once, many years ago, when I was young. I saw it. A great grey slab of stone with four copper circles. I remember thinking that it looked like a face. A very old, very patient face, waiting for someone to come and talk to it." He shook his head. "I always wondered what was behind it."

"Nobody knows."

"Nobody? Not even you?" He looked at me with mild amusement. "You went down the stairs, after all."

I placed a stone. I did not answer.

Bredon watched me for a moment. Then he smiled, and let it go, and returned his attention to the board.

\* \* \*

He won that game. He won it slowly and gracefully, in the way he always won, surrounding my western wall so gradually that I did not notice until it was too late. When he placed the last stone and my wall collapsed, I sat back and laughed, because there was nothing else to do.

"Beautiful," I said. "I never saw it coming."

"You never do. That's what makes it beautiful." He began to gather up the stones, sorting them into their bowls. "Again?"

"Again."

We played again. And again. The afternoon wore on. The shadows of the old oak stretched out across the garden. Servants came and brought us wine and little cakes and went away again. Bredon won the second game, and the third. I won the fourth, barely, by a single stone.

"Well done," he said, when I placed the winning stone. He looked genuinely pleased. "Very well done. You played that like a master."

"I got lucky."

"There's no luck in tak. Only patience." He sat back and looked at me. "Tell me. Do you remember what I told you about the beautiful game?"

I thought about it. He had told me a great many things, the year before, over the tak board. Most of them I had forgotten. But I remembered that.

"You said that winning isn't the point," I said slowly. "You said that anyone can win, if they're good enough. The point is to win beautifully. To play a game that's worth remembering."

"Yes." He nodded. "And?"

"And you said that sometimes the most beautiful game is the one you lose."

"Yes." He smiled. "Do you understand that now? Better than you did then?"

I thought about it. I thought about the Four-plate door, and the Masters' Hall, and the long lonely road south.

"I think so," I said. "I think sometimes you have to lose something to win something else. Something bigger."

"Close. Very close." He picked up a single white stone and held it up between two fingers, looking at it in the slanting afternoon light. "But it's more than that. The beautiful game isn't about sacrifice. Sacrifice is crude. Anyone can throw away a stone to gain a stone. The beautiful game is about *time*." He set the stone down on the empty board, at the very center. "It's about playing a game so long, so patient, so slow, that your opponent never realizes they're losing. They think they're winning. They win every battle. They take every stone you offer them. And then, at the very end, they look down at the board and see that every stone they took was a stone you wanted them to take. Every battle they won was a battle you arranged for them to win. And the shape of the board, the shape you've been building all along, one patient stone at a time, has closed around them like a hand."

He looked at me. His eyes were very bright.

"That's the beautiful game," he said. "Winning so slowly that no one ever knows you've won. Not even the one you've beaten. Not until it's far, far too late."

\* \* \*

I sat there in the dappled shade of the old oak and looked at him, and I felt something cold go down my spine. I did not know why. He had said nothing sinister. He had said nothing I had not heard him say before, in one form or another. He was an old man talking about a game.

But there was something in his voice. Something in his eyes. A kind of hunger, very old and very patient, like the hunger of a tree for light.

"That sounds lonely," I said.

He blinked. Then he laughed, a little surprised. "Lonely?"

"To win like that. So that no one knows. Not even the one you beat." I shrugged. "It sounds lonely. What's the point of winning if no one knows?"

He looked at me for a long moment. Something moved in his face. It was there and gone so fast I almost missed it.

"You're very young," he said at last. His voice was gentle. "When you're young, you want people to know. You want them to see. You want applause." He smiled. "When you're old, you learn that applause is a very small thing. The shape of the board is what matters. Whether anyone sees it or not."

He picked up the stone from the center of the board and put it back in its bowl.

"Enough philosophy," he said. "It's getting late. The Maer dines at sundown, and he'll want you at his table." He reached for his stick. "Come back tomorrow. We'll play again."

"I'd like that."

"I know you would." He stood, leaning on his stick. He looked down at me with his kind grandfather's eyes. "It's good to have you back, Kvothe. I've missed our games. There's no one else at court who plays with any real *heart*."

He began to walk away down the gravel path. Then he stopped and turned back.

"Oh," he said. "I nearly forgot. I heard something today that might interest you. About a friend of yours."

"Which friend?"

"A young lady. A singer. Dark hair, lovely voice. I believe you know her." He smiled. "She's in Severen. Arrived a few days ago, I'm told. Staying in the low city, at an inn near the river. The Mill Race, I think it's called."

My heart stopped.

"Denna," I said.

"Is that what she's calling herself these days?" Bredon's smile widened. "I never can keep track. Well. I thought you'd want to know." He lifted his stick an inch off the ground in his small courtly salute. "Good evening, Kvothe."

He walked away. I watched him go, down the gravel path between the clipped hedges, his stick tapping on the stones. The late sun turned his white hair to gold.

I sat alone under the old oak, with the empty tak board in front of me, and I did not move for a long time.

\* \* \*

I did not go down to the low city that night. I wanted to. Every part of me wanted to. But the Maer had invited me to dine with him, and you do not refuse the Maer. And besides, I needed to think.

Dinner was long and formal and very dull. The Maer sat at the head of the table, and Meluan sat at his right hand, pale and heavy with child, picking at her food and saying nothing. I sat halfway down the table between a minor lord who talked about horses and a minor lady who talked about the lord who talked about horses. I smiled and nodded and made polite conversation and did not taste a single bite.

I was thinking about Denna. About the Deller farm, and the frozen mud, and a little girl in a well saying *Dinael*.

I was thinking about Bredon, and how he had known she was in Severen, and how he had known I would want to know.

And I was thinking about Meluan, sitting at the head of the table with her hand resting on the swell of her belly, and the box that she kept under her pillow, and the look on her face when she had shown it to me, the year before. The look of a woman guarding something she

did not understand, and did not want, and could not put down.

She looked up once, during the long dull dinner, and met my eyes across the table.

I do not know what she saw in my face. But she went very pale, even paler than before, and looked away quickly, and did not look at me again.

After dinner, when the guests were dispersing into the gardens and the long galleries, Stapes found me.

"Sir," he said quietly. "Her ladyship asks if you would attend her in her rooms. Now, if you please."

"Now?"

"Now, sir." His face was calm, but his eyes were not. "She was quite insistent."

I looked at him. Then I nodded.

"Lead the way," I said.



## Interlude: A Game of Tak

"Do you play?" said the innkeeper.

Chronicler looked up from the page he had been blotting. The innkeeper had stopped speaking some time ago, at the end of the first game in the Maer's small garden, and had gone behind the bar, and had come back with a flat wooden box under his arm. He set it on the table and opened it. Inside, nested in green felt, were two bowls of smooth river stones, black and white, and a board of dark wood with lines inlaid in pale ash.

"Tak?" said Chronicler. "A little. Badly. My uncle taught me, when I was a boy." He looked at the board. "I haven't played in years."

"Good," said the innkeeper. "Neither have I."

Bast, in his backward chair, made a small strangled sound.

The innkeeper looked at him mildly. "Something wrong, Bast?"

"No, Reshi." Bast's face was perfectly innocent. "Nothing at all. Only that you've played every night for six years. With Graham. In the kitchen. After closing."

"That's not playing," said the innkeeper. "Graham doesn't play tak. Graham plays *at* tak. There's a difference." He began setting out the board. "Our scribe is tired. His hand is cramping; I've been watching him flex it for the last hour. He needs a rest, and so do I. And I find myself wanting to play." He looked at Chronicler. "Unless you'd rather not?"

Chronicler looked at the board. At the smooth black and white stones in their bowls.

"I'd be honored," he said.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper gave him white. White moves first.

Chronicler hesitated over the board for a long moment. Then he placed a stone near the center. It was the only opening his uncle had ever taught him. He was aware, as he did it, that it was a very ordinary move. A beginner's move.

The innkeeper looked at it. He did not smile. He picked up a black stone and set it down, apparently at random, at the far edge of the board.

They played.

\* \* \*

It was not a long game. Chronicler had known it would not be. He played carefully, cautiously, the way his uncle had taught him: guarding his corners, building slowly, never overreaching. And the innkeeper played—Chronicler did not know how to describe how the innkeeper played. His stones seemed to go down without any thought at all, quickly, almost carelessly, scattered across the board with no pattern Chronicler could see.

And then, somewhere around the twentieth stone, the pattern was suddenly there. All at once. Chronicler looked down at the board and saw that every one of those careless scattered black stones had been placed exactly where it needed to be, and that his own careful white groups were surrounded, cut off, every one of them, and that there was nothing he could do about it. Nothing at all.

He sat back in his chair and looked at the board for a long moment.

"I've lost," he said.

"Yes."

"When? When did I lose?"

The innkeeper looked at the board. He reached out and touched a single black stone, near the edge. The second stone he had played.

"There," he said.

Chronicler stared at it. "That was the second move."

"Yes."

"You knew. From the second move."

"No." The innkeeper shook his head. "I didn't know. I hoped. There's a difference." He began gathering up the stones, black into one bowl and white into the other. "Your first move told me how you think. Careful. Honest. You open in the center because your uncle told you the center is strongest, and you believed him, and you've never tested it." He smiled faintly. "It was a good opening. It was a good opening for someone who wants to be safe. But I didn't want to be safe."

\* \* \*

"Play again," said Bast. "Play him again, Reshi. Properly."

The innkeeper looked at him. "That was properly."

"No it wasn't." Bast leaned forward in his chair, his eyes bright. "You were playing Chronicler. Play the other way. The way you played the old man." He looked at Chronicler, with a sly, wicked grin. "Make it beautiful."

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment. His hands, gathering the stones, had stopped.

"I don't remember how," he said.

"Yes you do." Bast's grin had gone. His voice was very soft. "You're remembering everything else. You can remember that."

The innkeeper looked down at the board. At the empty lines, pale ash on dark wood.

Then he looked at Chronicler.

"Would you mind?" he said. "It's not a fair game. I should tell you that. It's not really a game at all. Not the way you mean." He paused. "But I'd like to try. If you don't mind losing again."

Chronicler looked at him. Then he picked up a white stone.

"I'm used to it," he said.

\* \* \*

The second game was different.

Chronicler played the same way, at first. Careful. Center. Corners. But the innkeeper's stones did not scatter this time. They went down slowly. Deliberately. Each one placed after a long pause, with a kind of attention Chronicler had seen in very old craftsmen, bent over their work. Each one placed not to win, Chronicler realized after a while, but to *answer*.

When Chronicler built a wall, the innkeeper's stones curved around it, not to break it but to echo it, like a second voice in a song. When Chronicler made a mistake, left an opening he should not have left, the innkeeper did not take it. He played beside it instead, and the shape the two stones made together was strange and lovely, and Chronicler found himself staring at it, forgetting the game entirely.

"Oh," he said, without meaning to.

The innkeeper did not look up. He placed another stone.

And slowly, stone by stone, the board began to fill with something Chronicler had never seen on a tak board before. Not a battle. Not a siege. Something more like a conversation. Two lines of stones, white and black, weaving around each other in long spirals, like the grain in a piece of wood, like the patterns of frost on a window, like two people dancing who had been dancing together for a very long time.

Chronicler forgot that he was losing. He forgot that he was playing. He placed his stones where they seemed to want to go, and the innkeeper answered them, and the pattern grew, and it was the most beautiful thing Chronicler had ever seen.

\* \* \*

He did not know how long they played. The fire burned down. Bast got up, at some point, and put more wood on it, and sat down again, and did not say a word. The light in the windows changed.

And then, at last, the innkeeper set down a stone, and sat back, and folded his hands.

Chronicler looked at the board.

He had lost. He could see that. His white stones were surrounded, every one. But they were surrounded the way a garden is surrounded

by a wall. Held. Kept. The black stones did not crush them. They cradled them.

And in the very center of the board, where he had placed his first careful beginner's stone, the black and white together made a shape. He could see it now, clear as ink on paper. A circle. With seven lines running out from it, like the spokes of a wheel, or the rays of the sun.

Or the doors of a house.

\* \* \*

Nobody said anything for a long time.

"Where did you learn that?" said Chronicler at last. His voice was hoarse.

"From an old man," said the innkeeper, "in a garden in Vintas. Who taught me that the point of tak isn't to win. It's to make something beautiful, with someone else, even if one of you is going to lose." He looked at the board. "He told me that a beautiful game tells you everything about the person you're playing. Their fears and their hopes and the way they think. Everything they are." He was quiet. "He told me that the most dangerous man in the world is the one who can play a beautiful game and still win."

"Bredon," said Chronicler.

"Yes."

"The old man. From the story. Who was really—" Chronicler stopped.

"Yes," said the innkeeper. "I didn't know it then. That's why the story's the way it is." He reached out and touched a black stone, near the center of the circle. "He played like this. Every game. Every time. So beautifully that you forgot he was winning. So beautifully that you forgot to ask what he was winning *for*."

He began gathering the stones. Black into one bowl, white into the other. The pattern came apart under his hands, stone by stone, until the board was empty again. Pale ash on dark wood.

"I learned to play from him," he said quietly. "And I learned too well. And that was part of the trouble." He closed the lid of the box. "When you learn to play a beautiful game, you start to see the whole

world as a board. Everyone in it as stones. And you start to think that if you just place them carefully enough, beautifully enough, it will all come out right in the end."

"Doesn't it?"

The innkeeper looked at him. His green eyes were very old.

"Sometimes," he said. "And sometimes the man across the board has been playing a different game the whole time. And you only find out at the very end, when you look down, and see the shape your stones have made. And realize you've drawn a door."

\* \* \*

He took the box back behind the bar. He put it on the shelf, beside the bottles. He came back and sat down and picked up his cup.

Chronicler looked down at his hand. It was not cramping anymore. He flexed it. He picked up his pen.

"The garden," he said. "Bredon had just asked you to follow him."

"Yes." The innkeeper looked at the fire. "He wanted to show me something. He said it would explain a great deal." He was quiet for a moment. "It did. Though not in the way he meant."

He began to speak again. And Chronicler wrote.

But Bast, sitting in his backward chair with his arms folded across its back, did not listen to the story. He was looking at the box on the shelf behind the bar. And there was something in his face, something bright and fierce and fragile, that Chronicler would not have a name for until much later.

Hope.

## Chapter Thirty-Nine

# A Box with No Lid

Meluan Lackless received me in a small sitting room off her bedchamber. It was a beautiful room, all soft greens and golds, with a fire burning in a marble hearth and heavy curtains drawn across the windows. It was very warm. It smelled of lavender and woodsmoke and something else, something faint and bitter, like the smell of an apothecary's shop.

She was sitting in a high-backed chair by the fire. She had changed out of her dinner gown into something looser and simpler, a robe of pale grey wool that fell around her in soft folds. Her dark hair was unbound and fell over her shoulders. Her hands were folded on the swell of her belly.

And in her lap, beneath her folded hands, there was a box.

It was just as I remembered it. A small box of dark wood, about the size of a loaf of bread, smooth and polished and faintly glowing in the firelight. There was no lid. There was no lock. There were no seams, no hinges, no joins of any kind. It was as if it had been carved from a single piece of wood, and then someone had taken whatever was inside and sealed it in with nothing at all.

"Sit," said Meluan.

I sat, in a chair across from her. Stapes closed the door behind me and left us alone.

For a long time, she did not say anything. She sat looking at me across the firelit room, her dark eyes very steady, her hands resting on the box. I waited. I had learned, in the Maer's court, that there is a time

to speak and a time to be silent, and that the second is usually longer than you think.

"My husband tells me," she said at last, "that you were expelled from the University."

"Yes, my lady."

"For going somewhere forbidden. In the Archives."

"Yes."

"And that while you were there, you found records. About my family."

"Yes."

She was quiet again. The fire crackled. Her fingers moved on the surface of the box, very slightly, the way you might stroke a sleeping cat.

"Tell me," she said, "what you found."

I told her. I told her about the blue book, *The Lines of Loeclos*, with its long genealogy stretching back into darkness. I told her about the knot-marks in the margins, and the line of writing at the end. *The door holds while the line holds. The line holds while the name is kept.* I told her about the Book of Watches, and the account at the front of it, and the seven doors, and the keeper's door beneath the house of Loeclos that only the line could open, with the key of stone.

I did not tell her about the Thief. I did not tell her that her line was his line. I did not know how.

She listened in silence. Her face did not change. But her hands had gone still on the box, and they were pressed down on it now, hard, as if she were afraid it might fly away.

When I finished, she was silent for a very long time.

"I have never heard any of that," she said at last. "Not a word. Not from my father, not from my grandmother, not from anyone." She looked down at the box. "They told me only that I was to keep this. That it was the most important thing our family possessed. That it had been passed down from eldest daughter to eldest daughter for longer than anyone could remember, and that it was never, ever to be opened." She laughed, a small bitter sound. "As if it could be. There's



no lid. There's no lock. There's no way in at all."

"May I see it, my lady?"

She looked at me. For a moment I thought she would refuse. Then, slowly, she lifted the box from her lap and held it out.

I took it.

\* \* \*

It was heavier than it looked. Much heavier. It was like holding a stone, not a box of wood. And it was warm. Not the warmth of the fire, or of Meluan's hands. A warmth of its own, deep and steady, like the warmth of a living thing.

And it was humming.

I had felt that the first time I held it, a year ago. A faint vibration, just at the edge of perception, like a sound too low to hear. I had thought, then, that it was my imagination. I knew better now.

I closed my eyes. I let my mind go still, the way I had in the round room, the way I had in the Cellarage. I did not reach for the box. I did not try to make it do anything. I simply held it, and listened.

It was stone.

Inside the box, beneath the wood, there was stone. I could hear it. Its long slow patient no. But it was different from other stone. It was not saying no to everything. It was saying no to one thing. One particular thing. Over and over, patiently, endlessly. *No. No. No.*

It was saying no to a door.

And beneath that, fainter, woven into the stone's voice like a thread through cloth, there was something else. A name. Not the stone's name. Another name. A long, winding, complicated name that I could not quite hear, the way you cannot quite hear a word spoken in another room.

But I knew it. I knew it the way I had known my own name when the Sleeper spoke it, and when the voice behind the door whispered it. I knew it the way you know your own face.

It was a name that belonged to my family.

\* \* \*

I opened my eyes. Meluan was staring at me. Her face had gone white as milk.

"What did you do?" she whispered.

"Nothing. I only listened."

"It sang." Her voice was shaking. "It sang when you held it. I heard it. It's never done that. Never, not in all the years I've had it." She pressed her hands to her belly. "What are you?"

I looked at her. At her white face and her frightened eyes and her hands pressed against her unborn child. At the box in my lap, warm and humming.

I had not planned to tell her. I had thought about it a great deal on the road south, and I had decided that it would be better not to. She had no love for the Edema Ruh. I knew that. Her sister had run away with one, and her family had never recovered from the shame. She had told me once, the year before, that she hated the Ruh more than any people on earth.

But she was frightened. And she was my mother's sister. And the box had sung.

"My lady," I said. "Your sister. Netalia. The one who ran away." She went very still.

"How do you know her name?" she said. Her voice was very quiet.

"Because it was in the book. The blue one. Her name had been blotted out, but I knew it anyway." I took a deep breath. "She ran away with a trouper. An Edema Ruh. A red-haired man named Arliden, who made songs."

Meluan did not move. She did not breathe.

"She changed her name," I said. "She called herself Laurian. She traveled the roads with him for twelve years. She sang. She was happy. And she had a son." I looked at her. "Red hair, like his father. Green eyes, like his mother."

"No," Meluan whispered.

"She died when he was eleven. They both did. Killed, along with everyone in their troupe, by people who didn't want the songs they

were singing to be heard." I swallowed. "The boy lived. He lived in the woods for a while, and then on the streets of Tarbean. And then he went to the University. And then he came to Severen, and met a lady named Meluan Lackless, and helped the Maer win her hand."

"No," she said again. Her voice cracked.

"My lady," I said. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. But she was my mother."

\* \* \*

For a long time, neither of us moved.

The fire crackled in the hearth. Somewhere in the palace, very faintly, a bell was ringing the hour. Meluan sat in her high-backed chair and stared at me, and her face was white as bone, and there were tears running down her cheeks. She did not seem to notice them.

"You're lying," she said.

"I'm not."

"You're lying. You're Ruh. Ruh lie. It's all they do." Her voice rose. "You've heard the story somewhere. You've pieced it together. You want something from me. Money, or power, or—"

"I want nothing from you, my lady."

"Everyone wants something!"

"I don't." I held out the box. "Take it back. I don't want it. I don't want anything. I only wanted you to know."

She stared at the box. Then she reached out, very slowly, and took it from my hands. She held it against her chest the way Auri had held her ring.

"She left," Meluan said. Her voice was very small. "She left me. I was fourteen. She was seventeen. We shared a room, we shared everything. We used to lie awake at night and whisper about the men we'd marry, the houses we'd have, the children." Her face crumpled. "And then one day she was gone. Just gone. She didn't say goodbye. She didn't leave a note. She just went off with some—some *tinker*—"

"He wasn't a tinker. He was a trouper. He was the best trouper on the roads."

"I don't care what he was!" She was crying openly now. "She left me. She left all of us. My father never spoke her name again. My mother died of grief. And I—" She stopped. She pressed her hand to her mouth. "I had to be the eldest daughter. I had to keep the box. It should have been hers. It should have been *hers*, and she just *left*—"

She broke off. She bent over the box in her lap and sobbed, great heaving sobs that shook her whole body.

I did not know what to do. I sat there in my chair and watched her weep, and I felt helpless and cruel and very, very young.

Then, slowly, I got up. I crossed the room and knelt beside her chair. I did not touch her. I only knelt there, close, so she would know I was there.

After a long time, her sobs quieted. She sat up. She wiped her face with the back of her hand, like a child.

"Was she happy?" she whispered. "With him. Was she happy?"

I thought about my mother. About her laugh, bright as a bell. About the way she sang with my father around the fire at night, her head on his shoulder. About the way she held me when I was small, and the way she smelled, of woodsmoke and lavender and the road.

"Yes," I said. "She was the happiest person I ever knew."

Meluan closed her eyes. More tears slid down her cheeks. But her face had changed. It had softened, somehow. Something in it had let go.

"Good," she said quietly. "Good. I'm glad."

\* \* \*

We talked for a long time after that. Hours. The fire burned down to embers and Meluan did not call for more wood. She wanted to know everything. What my mother had been like, on the road. What songs she sang. What she laughed at. Whether she ever spoke of home.

I told her what I could. It was not easy. I had spent so many years not remembering, locking those memories away behind the doors of sleep. But I opened those doors now, for her. I let the memories out. And as I told her about my mother, I found that I was remembering things I had thought were lost forever. The way she hummed while she

cooked. The little scar on her left thumb, from a knife that slipped when she was cutting bread. The way she said my name when she was angry, and the way she said it when she was not.

Meluan listened to all of it. Sometimes she laughed. Sometimes she cried. Once she reached out and took my hand and held it, very tightly, and did not let go for a long time.

It was near dawn when she finally asked the question I had been waiting for.

"The box," she said. "You said there was a door. Beneath our house. And the line could open it, with the key." She looked down at the box in her lap. "Is that what this is? The key?"

"I think so."

"And you're of the line."

"Yes."

"So you could open it." Her voice was very quiet. "The door. You could open it."

"I don't know," I said honestly. "Maybe. I don't know how. And I don't want to."

"Why not?"

I thought about the Book of Watches. About the account at the front of it. About the Thief, locked away beyond the world with his stolen moon. About the breathing on the other side of the door beneath the Archives, and the voice that had whispered my name.

"Because I think there's something behind it," I said. "Something that was put there for a very good reason. And I think if the door is ever opened, something terrible will happen."

Meluan looked at me for a long time.

"Then someone must make sure it never is," she said.

"Yes."

She looked down at the box. Then, slowly, she held it out to me.

"Take it," she said.

I stared at her. "My lady—"

"Take it. I don't want it. I never wanted it." Her voice was steady, but her eyes were wet. "It should have been hers. She was the eldest. It

should have gone to her, and then to her child. To you." She pressed it into my hands. "Take it far away. Keep it safe. Keep it from whoever wants it."

"I can't. Your husband—"

"My husband will understand. Or he won't. It doesn't matter." She laid her hand on her belly. "I have a child coming. A child of the line, like you. And I don't want this child to grow up with this thing under their pillow, afraid of every sound in the night. I don't want them to be a keeper. I want them to be a child." She looked at me. "Please. Take it."

I looked down at the box in my hands. It was warm, and heavy, and humming. Its long slow no.

I thought about all the people who wanted it. The one who had come into Meluan's room at night. The Knife, with his staff of dark wood crowned in silver. The Chandrian.

I thought about how much safer it would be, here, in the Maer's palace, behind walls and guards and locked doors. And how much more dangerous, in my hands, on the roads, with the Chandrian already hunting me.

And then I thought about Meluan, lying awake every night with the box under her pillow. Listening for footsteps. Waiting.

"All right," I said. "I'll take it."

She closed her eyes. Her whole body seemed to sag, as if a great weight had been lifted from her shoulders.

"Thank you," she whispered.

\* \* \*

I went back to my rooms as the sun was rising. The palace was quiet, the long galleries empty and grey in the early light. I carried the box under my cloak, pressed against my side. It was warm through the cloth. I could feel it humming against my ribs.

I did not know, then, what I had done. I did not know that the box had been safe in Meluan's hands precisely because she did not know what it was. I did not know that a key in the hands of the line is a very different thing from a key in the hands of anyone else.

I did not know that I had just done exactly what someone had been waiting, very patiently, for me to do.

I only knew that my aunt had wept in my arms, and called my mother by her name, and given me a box. And that for the first time since I was eleven years old, I had a family again.

It was a very small family. Just one frightened woman in a green room, and her unborn child. But it was mine.

I went to sleep that morning with the box under my pillow, the way she had. And for the first time in many months, I slept without dreaming.

## Chapter Forty

# The Maer's Table

There is a particular kind of war that is fought across dinner tables. It has no swords and no armies and no banners. It has spoons, and salt cellars, and the exact order in which people are seated. It has compliments that are insults and insults that are compliments. It has silences that last exactly one heartbeat too long.

I had learned to fight in that war the year before, at the Maer's court, with Bredon's help. I had not been very good at it. I had been young and proud and far too quick with my tongue, and I had made a great many enemies who did not need to be enemies. But I had learned. And by the time I left Severen for Ademre, I could hold my own at a dinner table against most of the courtiers in Vintas.

I had not expected to need that skill again so soon.

\* \* \*

The Maer's dinner, on my third night back in Severen, was a small one. Only forty guests. The Maer at the head of the long table, with Meluan at his right hand. The Maer's cousin, a thin sour man named Lord Warren, at his left. And then, in careful descending order down both sides of the table, the lesser lords and ladies of the court, arranged by rank and favor and the subtle calculus of who had offended whom most recently.

I was seated two-thirds of the way down, on the left. Below the salt, but not far below it. It was a carefully calculated position. It said, to everyone who knew how to read such things: *This young man is the*



*Maer's guest, and he has done the Maer great service, but he is a Ruh, and a commoner, and he is not one of us.*

I did not mind. I had been seated below the salt before.

What I minded was the woman across from me.

\* \* \*

Her name was Lady Ennet. She was perhaps forty, handsome in a sharp-edged way, with dark hair piled high and a necklace of pearls that must have cost more than most villages. She was the wife of a minor lord from the eastern marches, and she had, I learned later, a younger sister who had run away with a troupe of players twenty years before and never been heard from again.

She hated the Ruh. She hated them the way some people hate spiders, with a deep instinctive loathing that had nothing to do with reason. And she had been seated directly across from a Ruh, at the Maer's own table, and she did not intend to let the evening pass without making her feelings known.

She began with the soup.

"I understand," she said, to the lady on her left, in a voice pitched to carry exactly as far as me and no farther, "that the Maer has taken to collecting performers. Like a child collecting pretty stones."

The lady on her left tittered.

I did not look up from my soup. I had learned, at the Maer's court, that the first rule of dinner-table warfare is never to acknowledge the first shot. It shows you are wounded.

"I suppose it's charming," Lady Ennet went on. "In its way. A little Ruh, performing at dinner. Like a trained monkey." She sipped her wine. "One does worry about the silver, of course."

The lady on her left tittered again. Several people nearby had gone quiet, the way people go quiet when they sense blood in the water.

I finished my soup. I set down my spoon. I looked across the table at Lady Ennet and smiled.

"My lady is very kind to worry," I said. "But she needn't. I've been in the Maer's house for three days now, and I've counted every

piece of silver on this table twice." I paused. "There's a spoon missing from your setting. I assumed you'd taken it for safekeeping."

\* \* \*

It was not a very good riposte. I have made better. But it landed.

Lady Ennet looked down at her place setting. There were three spoons beside her plate. There should have been four. The fourth was lying on the floor beneath her chair, where she had knocked it with her elbow during the first course, and a servant had not yet noticed to retrieve it.

The people nearby laughed. Not loudly. Not cruelly. Just the small surprised laugh of people who have seen a clever thing.

Lady Ennet's face went very red. Then very white.

"How dare you," she said.

"My lady?"

"How dare you imply—"

"I implied nothing, my lady." I smiled again. "I only said you'd taken it for safekeeping. Which was very wise of you, with a Ruh at the table." I picked up my wine. "One does worry about the silver."

\* \* \*

I thought that would be the end of it. It usually was, at the Maer's court. A shot, a counter-shot, a laugh, and then everyone moved on to the fish course and pretended nothing had happened.

It was not the end of it.

Lady Ennet did not speak to me again through the fish. Or the fowl. Or the roast. She talked to the lady on her left, and the lord on her right, and she did not so much as glance across the table at me. I thought she had given up.

Then the sweet course came. And she set down her fork and looked across the table at me, and her face was calm and cold and terrible.

"You're Ruh," she said. Not loudly. But the people nearby heard it, and went quiet.

"I am."

"Where from?"

"The road, my lady. The Ruh are from the road."

"Your family. Your troupe. Which one?"

I hesitated. It was the barest hesitation. But she saw it.

"Arliden's troupe," I said.

Lady Ennet went very still.

"Arliden," she said slowly. "The trouper. The one who made songs."

"Yes."

"He had a wife." Her voice was very quiet now. "A singer. Laurian."

I did not answer. I did not have to. She was looking at my face, at my hair, at my eyes. And something was happening in her own face. Something I did not understand.

"My sister," said Lady Ennet, "ran away with a troupe. Twenty years ago. The summer she was sixteen." Her voice had gone flat. "She sent a letter, once. Only once. From a town in the Commonwealth. She said she was happy. She said she was singing. She said she'd met a woman in the troupe who was teaching her, a woman with the most beautiful voice she'd ever heard." Lady Ennet looked at me. "The woman's name was Laurian."

\* \* \*

The table had gone utterly silent. Not just the people near us. The whole table. Forty lords and ladies, with their forks halfway to their mouths, staring.

At the head of the table, the Maer had set down his wine glass. Beside him, Meluan had gone white as milk.

"What happened to her?" I said. My voice was very quiet. "Your sister."

Lady Ennet looked at me for a long moment.

"I don't know," she said. "She never wrote again. I waited. For years. I sent letters to every town in the Commonwealth where the Ruh were known to play. No one knew where she'd gone." Her voice cracked, very slightly. "And then, a few years ago, I heard a story.

From a traveler. About a troupe that had been found in a forest, burned. Everyone dead." She looked at me. "Arliden's troupe."

I did not move.

"Was she there?" said Lady Ennet. "My sister? Her name was Karis. She'd be thirty-six now. Dark hair, blue eyes. She had a little scar on her chin, from falling out of a tree when she was seven." Her voice was shaking now. "Was she there? When they died?"

I sat very still at the Maer's table, with forty faces turned toward me, and I opened the doors of sleep, just a crack, and I looked.

I saw the troupe. The wagons. The fire. The faces around the fire, singing. My father, and my mother, and Trip, and Shandi, and Teren, and old Abenthy before he left us.

And a young woman with dark hair and blue eyes and a small scar on her chin. Sitting beside my mother, learning a harmony. Laughing when she got it wrong.

Karis. We had called her Kari. She had joined us the summer I was eight. She had taught me to whistle through my fingers.

She had been there. At the end. I had seen her. Lying in the grass beside the burning wagon, with her dark hair spread out around her head and her blue eyes open, looking at the stars.

\* \* \*

I closed the doors of sleep.

I looked at Lady Ennet across the table. At her sharp handsome face, and her pearls, and her eyes, which were blue. I had not noticed, before. They were very blue.

"Yes," I said quietly. "She was there."

Lady Ennet made a sound. A small broken sound, like the sound a bird makes when it hits a window.

"She taught me to whistle," I said. "Through my fingers. She was very good at it. Better than anyone. She could whistle so loud it made the horses jump." I paused. "She was happy, my lady. She was so happy. She laughed all the time. She was learning to sing, and she was getting good, and my mother said she'd be the best voice in the troupe someday."

Lady Ennet was weeping. Silently. At the Maer's table, in front of forty lords and ladies, with her hand pressed against her mouth.

"She talked about you," I said. I did not know, until I said it, that it was true. But it was. It came up out of the dark with the rest. "She said she had an older sister who was very beautiful and very proud and very angry with her. She said she was going to write to her, someday, when she was famous. So her sister would know she'd done the right thing."

Lady Ennet stood up. She stood up so suddenly that her chair went over behind her with a crash. She stood at the Maer's table with her face wet and her hand over her mouth, and she looked at me.

Then she turned and walked out of the dining hall. Very straight. Very fast. Without a word to anyone.

\* \* \*

No one said anything for a long time.

Then, at the head of the table, the Maer picked up his wine glass. He looked down the long table, at all the frozen faces, and he said, in a perfectly ordinary voice:

"The pudding is very good tonight. My compliments to the kitchen."

And slowly, uncertainly, the table began to eat again. And talk again. And the war of the dinner table resumed, as it always did, as if nothing had happened.

But I did not eat. I sat at my place, two-thirds of the way down the table, with my hands in my lap and my spoon untouched, and I looked at the empty chair across from me.

\* \* \*

She found me later that night, in the gardens.

I was sitting on a bench under an old oak, in the dark, not thinking about anything. I heard footsteps on the gravel path and looked up, and she was standing there. She had changed out of her dinner gown into something plainer. She had taken off the pearls. Her face was pale and her eyes were red.

"May I sit?" she said.

"Of course, my lady."

She sat on the bench beside me. She did not say anything for a long time.

"I was cruel to you," she said at last. "At dinner. About the silver. About the monkey." She looked down at her hands. "I've been cruel to every Ruh I've met, for twenty years. Because of her. Because she left." She was quiet for a moment. "I told myself they'd stolen her. That they'd turned her head with songs and pretty words and taken her away. I told myself it was their fault."

"It wasn't anyone's fault, my lady. She wanted to go."

"I know." Lady Ennet's voice was very small. "I know. I think I always knew." She looked at me. "You said she was happy."

"She was."

"Truly?"

"Truly." I looked at her. "My lady, I was a child. I didn't understand much. But I understood that. She was one of the happiest people I've ever known."

Lady Ennet closed her eyes. Tears slid down her cheeks. She did not wipe them away.

"Thank you," she whispered.

\* \* \*

We sat together on the bench under the oak for a long time. She asked me questions about Kari, and I answered them as best I could. What songs she sang. What she laughed at. Whether she had ever fallen in love. I did not remember all of it. I had been so young. But I remembered some. And I told her what I remembered.

At last she stood up. She looked down at me in the dark.

"You're Laurian's son," she said. "Aren't you? Not just one of the troupe. Her son."

"Yes, my lady."

She looked at me for a long moment. Something moved in her face.

"The Maer's wife," she said slowly. "Meluan. Her sister ran away with a Ruh too. Everyone at court knows the story. Netalia Lackless." She was quiet. "I saw her face, at dinner, when you said your mother's name."

I did not say anything.

Lady Ennet looked at me for a long time. Then she nodded, once, very slightly. As if she had decided something.

"I won't say anything," she said. "To anyone. I owe you that. For Kari." She paused. "But be careful, boy. This court has ears everywhere. And some of them belong to people who would be very interested to know who your mother was."

"Anyone in particular?"

Lady Ennet was quiet for a moment.

"The old man," she said. "The tak player. Bredon." She looked at me. "He was sitting at the far end of the table tonight. Did you see him?"

I had not. I had been too busy with Lady Ennet, and the silver, and Kari.

"He was watching you," said Lady Ennet. "The whole time. Especially when you said Laurian's name." She drew her shawl around her shoulders. "He smiled."

She turned and walked away down the gravel path, into the dark.

I sat on the bench under the oak for a very long time after she had gone. And I did not go to play tak with Bredon the next day, as I had planned.

I told myself I was tired.

## Chapter Forty-One

# Stapes

Stapes found me in the hallway outside the Maer's chambers, very late, after the dinner. I was standing at a window, looking out at the dark gardens, trying to decide whether I had just been threatened or befriended. With the Maer, it was often both.

"Master Kvothe," said Stapes. "A word, if you would."

I turned. He was standing a few paces away, straight-backed and grey, his hands folded in front of him. He had been standing behind the Maer's chair all through dinner, the way he always did, pouring wine and removing plates and saying nothing. I had almost forgotten he was there. That was the point of Stapes. You were meant to forget he was there.

"Of course," I said.

He did not speak at once. He looked out the window beside me, at the dark gardens and the lights of Severen below the cliff, spread out like coals in a hearth. He was quiet for so long that I began to wonder if I had misheard him.

"You're wondering what he wants from you," Stapes said at last.

"I'm always wondering what he wants from me."

"Yes." Stapes allowed himself the smallest of smiles. "So is everyone. So, sometimes, is he." He looked at me. "I have served His Grace for thirty-one years. Since he was a boy of nine. I have dressed him and fed him and nursed him through the fevers and sat up with him through the nights when he could not sleep. I have seen him married and widowed and married again. I know him better than



anyone living." He paused. "And I will tell you something, Master Kvothe, that I have never told anyone. Because I think you need to hear it. And because I think, perhaps, you are the only one who could understand it."

\* \* \*

"When His Grace was a boy," said Stapes, "he had a brother."

I had not known that. I had read a great deal about the Alverons, in the Archives and elsewhere. I did not remember a brother.

"You won't have heard of him," said Stapes, as if he had heard my thought. "No one has. He was two years older than His Grace. His name was Aurel. He was the heir." Stapes looked out at the gardens. "He was a bright boy. Brighter than His Grace. Quick and clever and laughing, and everyone loved him. He could charm a bird out of a tree, the old servants used to say. He could charm a tax collector out of his ledger. He was going to be a great lord, one day. Everyone said so."

"What happened to him?"

"He drowned." Stapes's voice did not change. "In the mill race. Below the old mill, at the foot of the gardens. You'll have seen it."

I had. A narrow channel of dark water, cut through the rock, running fast and deep down to the great wheel. I had walked beside it only that afternoon.

"He was eleven," said Stapes. "His Grace was nine. They were playing. A game. The kind of game boys play, running along the edge of things, daring each other." He was quiet for a moment. "Aurel slipped. His Grace saw him go in. He ran for help. By the time help came, it was too late."

I did not say anything.

"I was the one who pulled him out," said Stapes. "I was a footman, then. Twenty-two years old. I went into the race with a rope around my waist, and I found him caught against the grate above the wheel, and I brought him up. And His Grace was standing on the bank. Nine years old. Soaking wet, because he'd tried to go in after his brother, and the gardener had pulled him back." Stapes looked at his hands. "He didn't cry. Not then. He just stood there, looking at his

brother on the grass. And then he looked at me. And he said, *I should have held on to him.*"

\* \* \*

The hallway was very quiet. Somewhere far off, a door closed.

"The old Maer was never the same," said Stapes. "He had loved Aurel best. Everyone knew it. And now he had only the second son. The small, quiet, sickly one, who did not laugh, who did not charm anyone, who watched and listened and never said what he was thinking." Stapes paused. "He was not kind to His Grace, after. He did not mean to be cruel. But he looked at His Grace, and he saw the son who had lived, instead of the son who should have. And His Grace knew it. Every day. For fifteen years."

"That's terrible."

"It is." Stapes looked at me. "But I am not telling you this so that you will pity him, Master Kvothe. He would hate that more than anything. I am telling you so that you will understand."

"Understand what?"

"Why he holds on." Stapes's voice was very quiet. "To everything. To his lands, and his title, and his secrets, and his wife. To every thread of every plan. He holds on so tightly that sometimes the things he holds on to cannot breathe." He looked out at the gardens. "He has spent his whole life holding on. Because the one time it mattered, he didn't. And his brother went into the dark water, and did not come back."

\* \* \*

I thought about the Maer at dinner. About the way he had watched me across the table, with his pale sharp eyes. About the way he had said *Meluan* when he spoke of his wife, as if the name were something fragile he had to carry very carefully. About the box with no lid, and the way he had looked at it.

"Why tell me?" I said. "Why now?"

Stapes did not answer at once.

"Because he is going to ask you to do something," he said at last. "Soon. I do not know what. He does not tell me everything, though he tells me more than anyone. But I have seen that look on his face before, and I know what it means. He is going to ask you to do something dangerous. For him. For his house. For Her Grace." He looked at me. "And he is going to hold on to you, while you do it. Very tightly. Because he cannot help it."

"And you want me to let him?"

"No." Stapes shook his head slowly. "I want you to remember that he holds on because he is afraid. Not because he is cruel. Not because he wants to own you. Because he is afraid that if he lets go, you will go into the dark water too." He paused. "And I want you to remember, when the time comes, that sometimes the kindest thing you can do for a man like that is to hold on back."

\* \* \*

I did not understand what he meant. Not then. I thought about it later, on a ridge above a burning camp, with a baby in my arms and the Maer's wife walking away into the shadow of the Chandrian. I thought about it in the grey dawn, when I carried that baby back to the Maer, and he took her from me with shaking hands, and held her so tightly I thought she would cry.

She did not cry. She looked up at him with her dark eyes. And he looked down at her, and his face did not move at all. But his hands, holding her, began very slowly to relax. The way a man's hands relax on a rope when he has finally pulled something out of the water, and knows it is breathing.

And Stapes, standing behind him, put one hand on his shoulder. Very lightly. The way you touch someone who might break.

\* \* \*

But that was later. That night, in the hallway outside the Maer's chambers, I only nodded, and thanked him, and said I would remember.

Stapes inclined his head. He turned to go. Then he paused.

"One more thing, Master Kvothe."

"Yes?"

"The mill race." He did not look at me. "His Grace had the grate above the wheel taken out, after. And the wheel stopped. The old mill has not ground a single sack of grain in thirty years. It just sits there, at the foot of the gardens, with the water running past it." He was quiet for a moment. "The gardeners asked him, once, if they should tear it down. It's an eyesore, they said. And he said no. He said, *Leave it. It's a reminder.*"

"Of what?"

Stapes looked at me. His grey eyes were very calm and very sad.

"Of what happens," he said, "when you let go."

He bowed, very slightly, and went away down the hallway, his footsteps making no sound at all on the thick carpet. And I stood at the window for a long time afterward, looking down at the dark gardens, at the place where I knew the old mill stood, silent, with the water running past it in the dark.

## Chapter Forty-Two

### One Ear

Meluan sent for me again three days later. Not through the Maer, and not through Stapes. A maid I had never seen before found me in the library, late in the afternoon, and curtsied, and said that her ladyship wished to see me, if I was not otherwise engaged, and would I follow her please, and could I be quiet on the stairs.

I followed her. Up a narrow back stair I had not known was there, and along a corridor hung with faded tapestries, to a small door at the end. The maid knocked twice, opened it, curtsied again, and was gone.

It was not the room where I had met Meluan before. That had been a formal room, a lady's receiving room, all silk and gilt and high-backed chairs. This was something else. A small room at the top of the house, under the eaves, with a sloping ceiling and a single round window. There was a narrow bed, and a washstand, and a chest at the foot of the bed. The walls were bare. The floor was bare boards, scrubbed pale.

Meluan was sitting on the bed. She was not dressed as a lady. She was wearing a plain grey wool dress, like a servant's, and her dark hair was loose down her back, and her feet were bare. She looked, I thought, about fourteen years old.

"Close the door," she said.

I closed it.

\* \* \*

"This was my room," she said. "When I first came here. Before we were married. Alveron gave it to me because I asked for somewhere small. He thought it was very strange. He had forty rooms ready for me, each one grander than the last." She almost smiled. "I didn't want any of them. I wanted a room like the one I grew up in. Under the eaves. With a round window. So I could lie in bed at night and look at the stars and pretend."

"Pretend what?"

She did not answer. She reached down to the chest at the foot of the bed and opened it. It was nearly empty. Some folded linens. A small wooden box. And, lying on top of the linens, something small and grey and soft.

She lifted it out and held it in her lap.

It was a rabbit. A child's toy, made of grey felt, stuffed with something that had gone lumpy with age. It had two black buttons for eyes, one of them hanging by a thread. And it had one ear. Where the other ear should have been, there was only a small ragged hole, neatly darned shut with grey thread.

\* \* \*

"Her name was Moss," said Meluan. She was looking down at the rabbit. "The rabbit. Netalia named her. She made her for me when I was four, out of an old cloak and two buttons from Father's waistcoat. She got in terrible trouble for the buttons."

I did not say anything.

"The ear came off when I was six," said Meluan. "The dog got it. I cried for two days. Netalia tried to sew a new one on, but she was terrible at sewing, and it came out crooked, and I cried harder." She touched the darned hole with one finger. "So she took it off again, and darned the hole, and told me Moss had lost her ear in a great battle with a dragon, and it was a badge of honor, and only the bravest rabbits had one ear." She smiled faintly. "I believed her. I believed everything she said."

"I believed my mother too," I said. "Everything she told me."

Meluan looked at me.

"What did she tell you?" she said. "About—about before. About where she came from."

"Nothing," I said. "She never talked about it. Not once. I asked, sometimes, when I was little. She always said she came from the road, like everyone else in the troupe. That the road was her mother and her father and her house." I was quiet for a moment. "I didn't know she had a sister. I didn't know anything."

Meluan looked down at the rabbit again.

"I was holding Moss," she said, "the night she left."

\* \* \*

"I was asleep," said Meluan. "We shared a room, you know. At the house. Under the eaves, with a round window, like this one. She had the bed by the window and I had the bed by the door. And that night I went to sleep with Moss under my chin, the way I always did. And when I woke up, her bed was empty." She was quiet for a moment. "And her things were gone. Her clothes, and her comb, and the little silver mirror Grandmother gave her. And her lute. She'd been learning the lute, in secret. From a troupier who came through at midsummer. Father didn't know." She swallowed. "I didn't know either. Not until that morning. When I saw the empty place against the wall where she'd kept it hidden under a blanket."

"She didn't say goodbye."

"No." Meluan's hands tightened on the rabbit. "She didn't say anything. She just went. In the night. Like a thief. And I lay in my bed for an hour, holding Moss, looking at her empty bed. And I didn't cry. I remember that. I didn't cry at all. I just lay there and thought: *she'll come back. She's only gone for a walk. She'll come back for breakfast.*"

"But she didn't."

"She didn't." Meluan looked up at the round window, at the late afternoon light coming in, gold and slanting. "I waited for her to come back for years. Every night. I'd lie in bed with Moss and look at the stars through the window and pretend she'd come climbing in through it. With her lute. Laughing. Saying she was sorry, she'd only been gone

a little while, and wasn't it a grand adventure." Her voice broke. "I did that for years. Long after Father died. Until I was twenty, and far too old for rabbits. And then I stopped. Because there was no point anymore. She wasn't coming back."

\* \* \*

I did not know what to say. I sat on the floor of that small bare room, with my back against the door, and looked at my aunt on the narrow bed with the one-eared rabbit in her lap. And I thought about my mother. Climbing out of a round window, in the night, with a lute on her back. Not looking back. Because if she looked back, she would not be able to go.

I did not know, then, why she had gone. I did not know about the door, and the humming, and her name being called in the night. I did not learn that until much later, from a letter in a scorched box on a rock in the hills. I only knew that my mother had left her little sister asleep, holding a rabbit with one ear. And had never gone back.

"I'm sorry," I said. It was all I had.

"Don't be." Meluan wiped her eyes. "It's not your fault. It's not anyone's fault. She did what she did." She looked at me. "And she had you. And she was happy. You said so."

"She was."

"Then that's something." Meluan looked down at the rabbit for a long moment. Then she held it out to me.

\* \* \*

"Take her," she said.

I stared at her. "My lady, I can't—"

"You can. You must." Her voice was very steady. "I've been sleeping with Moss under my pillow for twenty-three years. Every night. Even after I married. Alveron thinks it's very odd. He's never said so, but I can see him thinking it." She almost smiled. "But I'm going to have a child. In the winter. And I can't be a woman who sleeps with a one-eared rabbit under her pillow, waiting for her sister to climb in the window. Not anymore." She pushed the rabbit into my



hands. "I have to stop waiting. I have to be someone's mother."

I looked down at the rabbit. It was very soft, and very worn, and it smelled faintly of lavender and dust.

"What should I do with her?" I said.

Meluan looked at me for a long time.

"I don't know," she said at last. "Take her to wherever Netalia is. Her grave. Wherever they buried her." She stopped, seeing my face. "What?"

"There's no grave," I said quietly. "There wasn't anything left. To bury. Only ash. In a clearing in the woods, at the edge of the Commonwealth." I looked at the rabbit. "I don't even know where it is anymore. I ran. I was eleven. I never went back."

Meluan closed her eyes.

"Then keep her," she said. "Keep her until you know what to do with her. You'll know. Someday." She opened her eyes. "Netalia always knew what to do with things. She'd look at something broken and know exactly how to make it into something else. A one-eared rabbit into a hero. A button into an eye." She looked at me. "You have her face, you know. Around the eyes. When you're thinking. I saw it at dinner, the first night, and I nearly dropped my glass. You'll know what to do."

\* \* \*

I kept Moss. I carried her with me in the bottom of my pack, wrapped in a handkerchief, to Renere and to Tarbean and across the sea to Imre. I carried her into the Fae, and up into the Stormwal, and down again, and into the Maer's camp in the hills. I did not know what to do with her. I did not take her out and look at her. But I kept her.

And on a morning in the spring after everything, on a ridge above a valley in the western hills, when a small girl with dark hair and dark eyes, not yet two years old, toddled across the grass to me and reached out one small hand and touched my face, I knew.

I did not remember Moss. I did not remember Meluan, or the small room under the eaves, or the round window. I did not remember anything. But my hand went into my pack, the way it had gone to the

chest, the way it had gone to the corner of bread. And it came out with a small grey rabbit with one ear. And it put the rabbit into her hands.

She held it. She looked at it with her dark solemn eyes. And then she put the one ear in her mouth and chewed on it, very seriously, the way very small children do.

Mirra laughed.

"She likes it," she said. "What's her name? The rabbit?"

I did not know. I did not know anything.

"Moss," I said.

\* \* \*

"Does she still have it?" said Chronicler. "Lark?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a moment.

"I don't know," he said. "I hope so." He looked at the fire. "I hope she sleeps with it under her pillow. And I hope that someday, when she's old enough, someone tells her it lost its ear in a great battle with a dragon. And that only the bravest rabbits have one ear."

He picked up his cup. His hand was not quite steady.

"And I hope," he said, "that she never, ever has to wait for anyone to climb in through a window."

## Chapter Forty-Three

# The Mill Race

The Mill Race was an inn at the bottom of the cliff, in the part of the low city where the river bent close against the rock and the great wheels of the grain mills turned day and night with a sound like slow thunder. It was a respectable place, clean and quiet, the kind of inn where merchants' wives stayed while their husbands did business in the high city. It had a small walled courtyard with a pear tree in it, and a common room with whitewashed walls and a floor of scrubbed flagstones, and a landlady named Orla who looked at me when I came in as if I were something her cat had brought her.

"The singer," I said. "Dark hair. I was told she was staying here."

Orla looked me up and down. Her eyes lingered on my sword, and my lute case, and my face.

"And who might you be?"

"A friend."

"She's had a lot of friends asking after her." Orla folded her arms. "Most of them didn't carry swords."

"I'm a musician. The sword is for the road."

"Hm." She did not look convinced. But after a moment she jerked her head toward the courtyard. "She's out back. Under the pear tree. Been sitting there all morning with her harp, not playing it. If you upset her, I'll have you thrown in the river."

"I'll try not to upset her."

"Try harder than that," said Orla, and went back to her kitchen.

\* \* \*

Denna was sitting on a bench under the pear tree with her harp in her lap. She was not playing it. She was looking at it, her fingers resting on the strings, her head bowed. The pear tree was in blossom, and the petals had fallen around her like snow, in her hair and on her shoulders and on the strings of the harp.

She did not look up as I came across the courtyard. But I saw her fingers tighten on the strings, and I knew she had heard me.

"Kvothe," she said.

"Denna."

"I heard you'd been expelled." She still did not look up. "I heard it three days ago, from a traveler who'd come down from Imre. He said you'd broken into the Archives and tried to steal something and the masters threw you out." Now she looked up. Her eyes were very dark. "Is it true?"

"Mostly. I didn't try to steal anything."

"But you broke in."

"I went somewhere I shouldn't have."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she laughed, a small tired sound. "Of course you did," she said. "Of course." She moved her harp aside and patted the bench beside her. "Sit. Tell me."

I sat. The pear blossoms fell around us, white and soft and faintly sweet.

I did not tell her. Not about the stairs, or the Chamber of Watches, or the door. I told her only that I had gone looking for something in the Archives, something about my family, and that I had found it, and that it had cost me everything.

"Your family," she said. "I thought you didn't have any family. I thought they were all dead."

"They are. Mostly." I hesitated. "But I found out who my mother was. Where she came from. Before she met my father."

"Who was she?"

I looked at her. I thought about telling her. I wanted to. I wanted to tell her everything, the way I had told Meluan. I wanted to lay it all out in front of her, the blue book and the black mark and the box under

my pillow, and let her see it, and let her tell me what it meant.

But I thought about the Deller farm. About the frozen mud, and a little girl in a well.

"Someone important," I said. "Once. A long time ago. It doesn't matter now."

She looked at me for a long moment. She knew I was holding something back. She always knew. But she did not press. That was one of the things that made Denna so dangerous to me: she never pressed. She simply waited, with those dark eyes, until you gave her what she wanted of your own free will.

"All right," she said softly. "Keep your secrets. We all have them."

\* \* \*

We sat under the pear tree for a long time. She played a little, eventually. Not a song, just a few idle chords, the way a musician will play when she is thinking. I listened. The mill wheels turned in the distance with their slow thunder. The pear blossoms fell.

"Why are you in Severen?" I asked at last.

She glanced at me. "Work."

"For your patron?"

"Yes."

"The song?"

"Yes." She plucked a string. It rang out, clear and sweet, and faded. "It's nearly finished. There's just a little more I need. A few more sources. Old ones." She looked down at her harp. "He's sent me all over, these last few months. Up into the Commonwealth, down into Atur, across to the Small Kingdoms. Anywhere there's an old family with an old story. I go and I listen and I write it down."

"Old families," I said slowly. "With old stories. Like the Dellers?"

Her fingers went still on the strings.

She did not look at me. She sat very still under the pear tree, with the blossoms falling around her, and her face went white. Not all at once. Slowly, the way milk spreads in water. First her lips, then her cheeks, then her whole face, until she looked like a statue carved of

ivory.

"How do you know that name?" she whispered.

"I was there," I said. "The night after you left."

She turned to look at me. Her eyes were enormous.

"What do you mean?"

I told her. I told her about the blue candle, and the smoke on the wind, and the burning house. I told her about the frozen mud, and the five shapes lying in it. I told her about the well, and the little girl in the bucket, and the scrap of knotted cloth.

I did not tell her what Nell had said about the pretty lady. I did not have to. I saw it land in her face, the whole weight of it, the moment I said *the night after you left*.

When I was done, she sat there under the pear tree with her hands pressed flat against her harp strings, so hard that the strings cut into her fingers. She did not seem to notice. She was staring at nothing.

"No," she said. "No. That's not—they were fine. When I left them, they were fine. Mistress Deller gave me cider. The little girl showed me her kitten. They were *fine*."

"I know."

"It was an accident. A fire. Fires happen. A lamp tipped over, or—"

"Denna." I took her hand. It was ice cold. "The mud was frozen. In spring. There was frost on their eyelashes. The fire burned blue." I held her eyes. "It wasn't an accident. You know what it was. You've been writing a song about them for three years."

She pulled her hand away. She stood up so suddenly that her harp fell off the bench and struck the flagstones with a discordant jangle of strings. She did not pick it up. She stood there with her arms wrapped around herself, shaking.

"You're wrong," she said. "You're wrong. They're a story. The Chandrian are a story. They're not *real*."

"They're real. I've seen them. They killed my parents."

She stared at me.

"They killed my parents," I said again. My voice was very steady. "And everyone in my troupe. Because my parents were writing a song about Lanre. A true one. And the Chandrian don't like true songs about Lanre." I paused. "They killed the Dellers because the Dellers had a cloth that told the truth about something. Something old. And someone sent you to read it first, so they'd know exactly what was on it before they burned it."

"No." She shook her head, again and again. "No. No. He wouldn't. He wouldn't do that. He's not—he's *kind* to me, Kvothe. He's the only one who's ever been kind to me. He's taught me so much. He's—"

She stopped. Her hand had gone to her wrist, to the place where I had seen the bruise, all those months ago on the bluff above the river at Imre. She pressed it there, hard, as if something under the skin hurt.

"He's kind to me," she said again. But her voice had changed.

\* \* \*

I stood up. I picked up her harp from the flagstones and looked it over. One of the strings had snapped, and there was a small crack in the soundboard near the base. I set it carefully on the bench.

"Denna," I said. "Who is he?"

She shook her head. She was crying now, silently, the tears running down her white face.

"I can't," she whispered. "I promised. I swore it. If I tell, he'll know, and he'll leave, and—"

"And what? You'll be alone? You'll be poor?" I stepped toward her. "Denna, people are *dying*. Children are dying. That little girl lost her whole family, and she's six years old, and the last kind thing anyone did for her was you giving her mother a silver penny to look at a cloth." My voice cracked. "Please. Tell me who he is."

She looked at me. And for a moment, just a moment, I thought she would tell me. I saw it in her face. I saw her mouth open, and her breath catch, and the name rise up behind her lips.

Then something changed. Something closed.

"I can't," she said. "Kvothe, I *can't*. You don't understand. It's not just a promise. It's not just words." She held up her hand. On her wrist, just below the place where the bruise had been, there was a thin cord tied in a knot. I had never noticed it before. It was so fine and so dark it was almost invisible against her skin. "He tied it," she whispered. "When he first took me on. He said it was a promise. A binding. He said if I ever told anyone his name, or anything about him, the knot would know."

I stared at the cord. At the knot. It was small and complex, looped and twisted in a pattern I could not read. But I could feel it, even from where I stood. The faint tightening of the air. The sense of something reaching out and catching hold.

It held.

"What happens?" I asked quietly. "If you tell?"

She looked down at the knot on her wrist.

"I don't know," she said. "He never said. He just smiled." She shivered. "I've never wanted to find out."

\* \* \*

We stood in the courtyard of the Mill Race, under the pear tree, with the blossoms falling around us like snow, and we did not speak for a long time.

At last she bent down and picked up her harp. She held it against her chest. Her fingers found the broken string and touched it, gently, the way you might touch a wound.

"I need to think," she said. "Please. I need to be alone. I need to think about this."

"Denna—"

"Please, Kvothe." She looked at me. Her eyes were red and swollen, but they were clear. "I'm not running away. I promise. I'm not going anywhere. I just need to think." She paused. "Come back tomorrow. In the evening. I'll be here."

I looked at her for a long moment. I wanted to stay. I wanted to take her by the hand and lead her away from Severen, away from Vintas, away from her patron and his knots and his songs and his



errands to old families with old stories. I wanted to take her somewhere safe, somewhere no one could find her.

But I did not know anywhere like that. I never had.

"All right," I said. "Tomorrow evening."

She nodded. She turned and walked toward the inn, clutching her broken harp. At the door she stopped and looked back at me.

"Kvothe," she said. "The little girl. Nell. Is she all right?"

"She's with a troupe. Edema Ruh. Good people. They'll take care of her."

Denna closed her eyes. "Good," she whispered. "Good."

She went inside. The door closed behind her.

I stood alone under the pear tree for a long time. Then I turned and walked out of the courtyard and into the street.

\* \* \*

I did not go back up to the high city. Not right away.

Instead, I found a tavern across the street from the Mill Race, a dim smoky place called the Wheel and Wedge, full of millers and dockhands and river men. I bought a mug of beer I did not drink and took a table by the window, where I could see the door of the Mill Race through the dirty glass.

And I waited.

I am not proud of this. I want you to know that. I had told Denna I would come back tomorrow evening, and I meant it. I did not intend to break my word. But I had seen her face when I said *the Dellers*. I had seen the knot on her wrist. And I knew, the way you sometimes know things, that she would not stay in her room and think.

She would go to him.

She would go to him and ask him if it was true. Because that is what you do, when someone you trust has been accused of something terrible. You go to them. You look them in the eye. You ask.

And if she went to him, I would follow. And I would see his face.

It was dusk when she came out. She had changed into a dark cloak with a deep hood, and she walked quickly, with her head down, the way people walk when they do not want to be noticed. She turned

left out of the courtyard and went up the street toward the cliff road.

I left my beer on the table and followed her.

\* \* \*

She went up. Up the long steep road cut into the face of the cliff, past the teams of oxen hauling carts, past the beggars and the pilgrims and the late-working porters. I followed a long way behind her, keeping to the shadows, keeping other people between us. She did not look back.

At the top of the cliff road, she turned right, into the high city. She walked through the wide clean streets, past the great houses behind their high walls, past gardens and fountains and statues of long-dead Maers. The lamplighters were out, and the streets were filling with soft golden light.

She walked for a long time. She seemed to know exactly where she was going. She turned down one street and then another, through a small square with a fountain, down a narrow lane between two high garden walls.

At the end of the lane, there was a door in the wall. A plain wooden door, painted green, with no handle on the outside.

Denna stopped in front of it. She stood there for a moment, very still. Then she raised her hand and knocked. Three times, then twice, then once.

The door opened.

I was at the other end of the lane, pressed into the shadow of a doorway. I could not see who opened it. The light from inside was too bright, and the door was angled away from me. I saw only a hand, holding the door. An old hand, spotted and gentle.

Denna went inside. The door closed behind her.

I stood in the shadows at the end of the lane, and I did not move for a long time.

I knew that lane. I had walked down it before. The year before, in my first months in Severen, when I had been new at court and did not know anyone. Someone had shown it to me. Someone had walked with me down this lane, on a warm summer evening, and told me that at the end of it, behind the wall, there was a private garden, very old

and very beautiful, that belonged to an old friend of his.

He had said he sometimes played tak there, when he wanted to be alone.

## Chapter Forty-Four

### **Master Ash**

The wall was old stone, roughly dressed, twelve feet high and topped with a coping of flat slate. It had been built to keep out thieves and to keep in privacy, and it was very good at the second and only moderately good at the first. I had spent three years on the rooftops of Tarbean. I had climbed the outside of Ambrose's rooms at the Golden Pony in the dark, with no rope, in the rain. A garden wall in Severen was not going to stop me.

I found a place where an old ivy vine had grown up the wall from the lane side, thick as my wrist, its roots cracking the mortar. I climbed it slowly, testing each handhold, making no sound. At the top I lay flat along the coping, in the shadow of an overhanging branch, and looked down into the garden.

It was beautiful. Bredon had not lied about that. It was a small garden, much smaller than the one behind the Maer's palace, but it was old in a way the palace gardens were not. The trees were ancient and gnarled, their branches twisted into strange shapes by centuries of wind. The paths were paved with mossy stone. There was a pool in the center, round and still and black, with water lilies floating on its surface. Around the edges, in the deep shadows under the trees, there were statues so old and weathered that I could not tell what they had once been meant to show.

And beside the pool, under a lantern hung from a low branch, there was a table and two chairs. A tak board sat on the table, the stones laid out in their bowls.

Bredon was sitting in one of the chairs. Denna was standing in front of him.

\* \* \*

I could hear them. The garden was very quiet, and sound carried across the still water of the pool.

"—true?" Denna was saying. Her voice was shaking. "Just tell me. Is it true?"

Bredon looked up at her. His face was mild and kind and a little puzzled, the face of a grandfather whose granddaughter has come to him with a skinned knee.

"Is what true, my dear?"

"The Dellers. The farm near Aldermoor. The one you sent me to, to read the cloth." She took a breath. "They're dead. All of them. Burned in their house. And the mud was frozen, and the fire was blue, and—"

"Who told you this?"

"It doesn't matter who told me!"

"It matters a great deal." Bredon's voice was still gentle. "Sit down, Denna. You're upset. Sit, and have some wine, and tell me what you heard and who you heard it from."

"I don't want to sit. I don't want wine. I want you to tell me if it's true."

Bredon looked at her for a long moment. Then he sighed. It was a small, sad, tired sound.

"Yes," he said. "It's true. I heard the news three days ago. I'm very sorry. They were good people."

Denna stared at him. "You *knew*?"

"I knew they had died. I did not know how." He shook his head. "A fire, I was told. A terrible accident. I didn't want to tell you. I knew how it would upset you. You're so tender-hearted, my dear. It's one of the things I love most about you."

"It wasn't an accident."

"Wasn't it?"

"The fire was *blue*." Her voice cracked. "The mud was frozen. In spring. Those are the signs. The signs from the song. From *our* song. The one you've had me writing for three years." She stepped closer to him. "It was them. The Seven. You know it was them."

Bredon did not answer. He looked up at her with his mild, kind face, and he did not say anything at all.

"You sent me there," Denna whispered. "You sent me there to read the cloth. And then you sent *them*."

"No."

"Then who? Who sent them?"

"Nobody sends them, my dear. They go where they will." Bredon leaned back in his chair. "I sent you to read the cloth because it was important to the song. It contained a version of the story I had never seen before. A very old version, from before the lies. I needed to know what it said." He paused. "Others needed to know as well. Others who are not as gentle as I am. I did not tell them where to find it. But they have their ways of learning things."

"You're lying."

"I am not." His voice was very calm. "I have never lied to you, Denna. Not once in all the years I've known you. I have kept secrets. I have told you that there were things you were not ready to know. But I have never lied."

"Then tell me the truth now." She was crying. "Tell me what they are. Tell me what you are. Tell me what the song is *for*."

Bredon looked at her for a long time. Then he rose from his chair, leaning on his stick. He was taller than her. I had never noticed that before; he always seemed to stoop a little, the way old men do. But he did not stoop now. He stood straight, and he looked down at her.

"The song," he said quietly, "is for the truth. That is all it has ever been for. There is a man who was wronged, a very long time ago. His name was taken from him. His story was stolen and twisted and made into a lie, and the lie has been told so many times and for so long that it has become a prison. He cannot escape it. He cannot rest. He cannot even die." He paused. "Your song will set him free. That is what it's

for."

"And the Dellers? Were they part of the lie?"

"Everyone who keeps the old story is part of the lie. Everyone who tells it, everyone who remembers it, everyone who writes it down." Bredon's voice was very gentle. "That is what makes it so strong. It lives in a thousand places. In books and songs and cloths and carvings. Every time someone tells it, it grows stronger. Every time someone forgets it, it grows weaker." He reached out and touched her cheek, very lightly. "Your song will be told a thousand times. And every time it is told, the lie will grow weaker. And one day, it will break."

Denna stood very still. She did not pull away from his hand.

"And the people who keep the old story?" she whispered. "What happens to them?"

Bredon took his hand away.

"Some stories have to end," he said, "so that others can begin."

\* \* \*

I was shaking. I lay on top of the wall with my face pressed against the cold slate, and I was shaking so hard I was afraid they would hear it.

It was Bredon. Of course it was Bredon.

I had known. Some part of me had known since the steps of the Mains, since I had seen him in the snow behind Ambrose. Some part of me had known since the moment Devi put that page in my hand, with its hurried cramped writing. *He carries a staff of dark wood crowned in silver. He plays at games. He smiles.* I had known, and I had not let myself know. Because he had been kind to me. Because I had liked him. Because I had wanted, so badly, for there to be one old man in the world who looked at me and saw something worth teaching.

The Cthaeh had told me. It had told me in the Fae, in that terrible honeyed voice. *Her patron. The one she calls Master Ash.* It had told me that he beat her. It had laughed about it.

I had not believed it. Not really. I had told myself that the Cthaeh lied, that it twisted everything, that nothing it said could be trusted.

But it had not lied. It had only told me the truth in a way that would hurt me most.

And now, lying on the wall, I understood the shape of the board. Bredon had known I would come to Severen. He had known I would come to him, and play tak with him, and trust him. He had known about Denna, and the Dellers, and me. He had told me where to find her. He had known she would come here tonight, after I spoke to her. He had known I would follow.

He had known all of it. Every move. Every stone.

I was a piece on his board. I had always been.

\* \* \*

"I want to stop," Denna said.

Bredon looked at her. "Stop what?"

"The song. All of it." She wrapped her arms around herself. "I don't want to write it anymore. I don't want to be part of this. I don't want anyone else to die because of me."

"No one has died because of you."

"The Dellers—"

"The Dellers died because they kept a lie. Not because of you." Bredon's voice was still gentle, but there was something underneath it now. Something hard. "You are very close, Denna. So very close. A few more verses, a few more sources, and the song will be finished. Everything we've worked for. Everything you've suffered for." He paused. "You can't stop now."

"I can. I will."

"You will not."

The words were very quiet. But they fell into the still garden like stones into the black pool, and the ripples spread out and out.

Denna lifted her chin. "Or what?"

Bredon looked at her for a long time. His face did not change. It was still mild and kind, still the face of a grandfather. But his eyes had changed. They had gone flat and cold and very, very old.

Then he reached out and took her wrist. The wrist with the knotted cord.



He did not grip it hard. I want to be clear about that. He did not twist it or wrench it or do any of the things I would have expected. He simply took it, gently, the way you might take a child's hand to lead them across a street. And he held it.

And Denna cried out.

It was not a loud sound. It was a small, choked, broken sound, like the sound a bird makes when it hits a window. Her knees buckled. She sagged against him, her face twisted in pain, and he held her up by the wrist, gently, and looked down at her with his kind grandfather's face.

"You will finish the song," he said softly. "Won't you, my dear?"

"Yes," she gasped. "Yes. Please."

"Good." He let go.

She fell to her knees on the mossy stones beside the pool. She knelt there, cradling her wrist against her chest, sobbing. The knotted cord on her wrist was glowing faintly, a dull red light, like an ember.

Bredon looked down at her for a moment. Then he turned and sat back down in his chair and picked up a white stone from the bowl on the tak board and turned it over in his fingers.

"You can come down now, Kvothe," he said. "I know you're there."

\* \* \*

I did not decide to move. My body moved on its own, the way it had in the Cellarage when I ran at the Sleeper. One moment I was lying on the wall. The next I was in the garden, dropping the twelve feet to the mossy ground and rolling to my feet with Caesura already in my hand.

Denna looked up. She saw me. Her face went white with horror.

"No," she whispered. "Kvothe, no—"

I did not listen. I was across the garden in three strides. I was at the table. I had Caesura's point at Bredon's throat.

He did not move. He sat in his chair with the white stone in his fingers, and he looked up at me with his mild, kind face. The point of my sword was resting against the skin just below his jaw. A single push, and it would be over.

"Hello, Kvothe," he said. "I'm glad you came. Would you like to play?"

"Get up," I said. My voice did not sound like mine. It was very cold and very quiet. "Get away from her."

"I'm not near her. She's over there, by the pool. I'm here, at my table." He glanced at the tak board. "I've set up the stones. I thought we might have a game."

"I'm going to kill you."

"Are you?" He did not seem worried. "Well. That's certainly one way to end a game. Not a very beautiful one. But I suppose it's effective." He tilted his head, very slightly, so that the point of my sword pressed a little harder against his throat. A single bead of blood welled up on his skin, dark in the lantern light. "Go ahead. If you're going to do it."

I stood there. My hand was shaking. The point of my sword was trembling against his throat, and the bead of blood was growing, sliding down his neck and into the collar of his shirt.

I wanted to. God, I wanted to. I wanted it more than I have ever wanted anything. I wanted to push, and feel the steel slide into his throat, and watch his mild kind face go slack and empty. I wanted to kill him for the Dellers, and for Nell, and for my parents, and for every bruise he had ever left on Denna's skin.

But I did not.

Because Vashet had taught me. Because the Adem had taught me. Because I had spent months learning the Lethani, and I knew, standing there in that garden with my sword at an old man's throat, that this was not it. This was not the right action. This was not the right time. This was anger, and anger is not the Lethani. Anger is the opposite.

And because Denna was behind me, on her knees by the pool, saying *no, no, Kvothe, please, no*.

"Why?" I said. My voice cracked. "Why her? Why me?"

Bredon looked up at me. His face was still kind. But his eyes, those flat cold ancient eyes, were very steady.

"Put down the sword," he said, "and I'll tell you."

I did not move.

"Put down the sword, Kvothe. You're not going to use it. You know you're not. And you want to know. You've always wanted to know. It's your great weakness, your hunger for knowing. It's why you went down the stairs." He smiled faintly. "Put down the sword, and sit, and play with me. And I'll tell you everything you want to know."

I looked at him. At his kind face, and his cold eyes, and the thin line of blood running down his neck.

Then, slowly, I lowered my sword.

Behind me, Denna let out a long shaking breath.

Bredon smiled. He gestured to the empty chair across the table.

"Sit," he said. "Your move."

## Chapter Forty-Five

# The Game Explained

I did not sit.

I stood beside the table with Caesura in my hand, point down, and I looked at him. He looked back at me. After a moment he shrugged, as if it did not matter to him one way or the other, and placed a white stone on the board. The corner point. His opening move. The same one he always made.

"You can play standing," he said. "Some people prefer it. It makes them feel they're in control."

"I'm not here to play."

"Everyone is here to play. Everyone, everywhere, always. The only question is whether they know it." He folded his hands on the head of his stick. "Ask your questions, then. I'll answer what I can."

Behind me, I heard Denna get to her feet. I heard her footsteps on the mossy stone, coming closer. She stopped a little way off, to one side, where she could see both of us. I did not look at her. I could not.

"Who are you?" I said.

"You know who I am. I'm Bredon. I've been Bredon for a long time now. Longer than you would believe." He smiled. "Before that, I had other names. None of them would mean anything to you."

"Master Ash."

"That's what she calls me. I let her. It's a small joke between us." He glanced at Denna, and his face was fond. "She thinks it's because I'm grey. It's not, entirely."

"You serve the Chandrian."

He raised an eyebrow. "Serve? No. I don't serve them. They're rather crude, most of them, and very limited. Cinder in particular. He has all the subtlety of a thrown brick." He shook his head. "No. I don't serve the Seven. I serve the one they serve. There's a difference."

"Haliax."

Bredon's face went still. Just for a moment. Then the smile came back.

"You've been reading," he said. "Good. I like a well-read opponent." He placed another stone on the board. "Yes. Haliax. Although that's not his name either, not really. That's the name that was put on him. The name that was *cursed* into him." His voice changed, very slightly. Something harder came into it. "His name was Lanre. He was the greatest man who ever lived. He was betrayed by the people he loved and served, and he was punished for it with a curse so terrible that it has lasted for longer than the stars have had names. He cannot die. He cannot sleep. He cannot forget. He cannot so much as rest his head for a single moment without the weight of what was done to him crushing down on him like a mountain."

"What was done to him? He destroyed Myr Tariniel. He killed thousands."

"Did he?" Bredon looked up at me. "Were you there?"

"Of course not."

"Then how do you know?"

"Because the story says so."

"Ah." He smiled. "The story. Yes. The story that was written by the man who cursed him. The story that has been told and retold for thousands of years, by people who were not there and did not know and never bothered to ask whether it was true. The story that the Dellers kept on a cloth, and the Amyr kept in a book beneath the Archives, and your parents were trying to sing." He placed another stone. "That story."

I stood very still.

"You knew about my parents."

"Of course I knew. I've known about you for a very long time, Kvothe. Since before you were born." He looked at me with his kind cold eyes. "I knew your mother."

\* \* \*

The garden was silent. The lantern swung gently on its branch, casting shifting shadows across the table and the board and Bredon's face. The black water of the pool was perfectly still.

"You're lying," I said.

"I'm not. I told Denna, and I'll tell you: I don't lie. It's inelegant." He sat back in his chair. "I knew Netalia Lackless when she was a girl. I was a friend of her father's, in those days. I used to visit the Lackless house, and play tak with the old lord, and tell stories to his daughters by the fire." He smiled faintly. "She was a clever child. Much cleverer than her sister. She asked questions. Too many questions. She wanted to know about the box, and the door, and the old rhyme. She wanted to know everything."

"And you told her?"

"Some of it. Enough to make her curious. Not enough to make her afraid." He shrugged. "I thought, at the time, that she might be useful. A clever girl of the line, who knew enough to be interested but not enough to be careful. I thought I might guide her toward the door. Gently. Over many years." His smile faded. "But she was cleverer than I thought. She saw what I was doing. Not all of it, but enough. And she ran. She ran away from her house and her name and her family and everything she knew, and she hid herself among the Edema Ruh, where no one would ever think to look for a lady of the line."

I thought about my mother, pale and shaking, walking me away from the fire. *It's not a kind song. You must never sing it again.*

"She hid from you," I said.

"From me. From the Seven. From everyone." Bredon nodded. "And she was very good at it. It took us years to find her. Years. By the time we did, she had a son."

He looked at me.

"Cinder was supposed to bring her to me," he said quietly. "Her, and the boy. Alive. That was the plan. She would come to the door, and I would explain things to her, and in time, perhaps, she would understand." He shook his head slowly. "But Cinder has no patience. And your father had been singing about Lanre, the true story, the old one, very loudly and very well. And Cinder lost his temper." He paused. "By the time I heard, it was over. Everyone was dead. Everyone except you."

"You're saying you didn't want them killed."

"I'm saying it was a waste. A terrible, stupid, wasteful thing." His voice was very quiet. "I don't like waste, Kvothe. It's inelegant. And your mother was a remarkable woman. I was fond of her." He looked at me. "I'm fond of you, too. I have been since the first day you sat down across a board from me. You play like her. Did you know that? You play exactly like her. Too clever by half, and too proud to see what's in front of you."

\* \* \*

My hand tightened on Caesura's hilt. I felt the anger rise in me again, hot and red and roaring. I wanted to raise the sword. I wanted to bring it down.

I did not. I breathed. I let the anger rise, and I let it pass.

"Why didn't Cinder kill me?" I said. "That night. He had me. He could have. Why didn't he?"

Bredon smiled. It was a slow, satisfied smile, the smile of a man watching a stone placed exactly where he wanted it.

"Because Haliax told him not to," he said. "Haliax came, at the end, and saw you. A little red-haired boy, alone in the woods, with his mother's eyes. The last of the line." He paused. "And Haliax said *he is needed*."

The words fell into the garden like stones into water.

*He is needed.*

"Needed for what?" I said. But I already knew. I knew the way you know the answer to a riddle the moment before you hear it.

"You know what for," said Bredon gently. "You went down the stairs. You read the book. You know what you are." He placed another stone on the board. "You are the key, Kvothe. Or rather, you are the hand that turns it. Only the line can open the keeper's door. Only a child of Loeclos, with the key of stone in hand, speaking the door's true name." He smiled. "Your mother would never have done it. She knew too much, and she was too afraid. But you? You're young. You're curious. You're hungry. You want to know what's behind every door you see." He looked up at me. "And you're a namer. Do you know how rare that is? A child of the line who can speak true names? It hasn't happened in a thousand years. We thought it might never happen again."

"I'll never open it."

"Won't you?"

"Never."

"Hm." Bredon looked at the board. "You said you'd never go down the stairs beneath the Four-plate door, too. I imagine. At some point." He placed a stone. "And yet."

\* \* \*

"Why?" I said. My voice was hoarse. "Why do you want it opened? What's behind it that's worth all this?"

Bredon was quiet for a long time. He sat looking at the board, at the pattern of black and white stones, his old spotted hands resting on the silver head of his stick.

"There is someone behind it," he said at last. "Someone who was put away. Someone very powerful. Someone who can shape things. Change things. Make new things out of nothing, and unmake old things into nothing." He looked up at me. "Someone who could unmake a curse. Even a curse like the one on Lanre. Especially a curse like that."

"You want to free the Thief so he'll break Haliar's curse."

"I want to free the one you call the Thief so he can give my master what he has wanted for longer than the world has had a name." Bredon's voice was very soft. "Rest. Peace. An ending. That's all Lanre



has ever wanted. To be allowed to die." He paused. "Is that so terrible? To want to help a man die, when he has been suffering for ten thousand years?"

"And the rest of the world? What happens to it, when the Thief is free?"

Bredon smiled. It was a very small smile, and very sad, and very old.

"Some stories have to end," he said, "so that others can begin."

\* \* \*

Denna made a sound. A small choked sound, like the one she had made when he held her wrist. I turned to look at her.

She was standing a few feet away, beside the black pool. Her face was white. Her wrist was cradled against her chest, the knotted cord still glowing faintly red. Her eyes were fixed on Bredon, and they were full of something I had never seen in them before.

It was understanding.

"The song," she said. Her voice was barely a whisper. "The song isn't to free Lanre. Not from the lie. It's to—" She stopped. "It's to weaken the curse. So that when the door opens, and the Thief comes out, he can break it more easily." She looked at Bredon. "That's it, isn't it? That's what I've been writing. A key. Another key. A key for the curse."

Bredon looked at her with great fondness.

"You always were clever," he said. "Much cleverer than you give yourself credit for. That's why I chose you."

"You used me."

"I taught you. I gave you everything you have. Your voice, your harp, your knots. Your *name*." His voice was gentle. "You were a nameless girl sleeping in ditches when I found you. Now you're the finest singer in three kingdoms. Is that using?"

"Yes," said Denna. "Yes, it is."

She turned and looked at me. And for a moment, just a moment, I saw the whole of her. Not the careful smile or the practiced charm or the shifting names. Her. The girl beneath. Frightened and furious and

grieving and utterly, utterly alone.

"Kvothe," she said. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry."

"It's not your fault."

"It is. It's all my fault." She shook her head. "I didn't know. But I should have. I should have seen." She looked at the cord on her wrist. "I think I did see. I just didn't want to."

\* \* \*

Bredon rose from his chair. He leaned on his stick and looked at the two of us, standing in his garden in the lantern light, and his face was full of something that might have been affection, or might have been the satisfaction of a craftsman looking at a finished piece.

"You're both very young," he said. "You think that knowing a thing changes it. That if you understand the shape of the board, you can somehow step off it." He shook his head. "You can't. No one can. The board is the world. And the game has been going on for a very long time."

He picked up his stick and tapped it once, lightly, on the mossy stones.

"Denna will finish the song," he said. "She'll finish it because she has no choice. The knot on her wrist will see to that. And she'll sing it, in every great hall from here to Atur, and people will weep, and the lie will grow weaker." He looked at me. "And you, Kvothe. You'll go to the door. You won't mean to. You'll swear you never will. But you'll go. Because it's what you are. Because you can't see a door without wanting to open it."

"You're wrong."

"Perhaps." He smiled. "We'll see."

He turned and began to walk away across the garden, toward a small door in the far wall that I had not noticed before. His stick tapped on the stones.

"You could stop me," he said, without turning around. "You have a sword. I'm an old man. It would be easy." He paused at the door. "But you won't. Because you still don't know enough. You don't know what I know, or who else knows it, or what will happen if I die. You're

afraid that killing me will make things worse. And you're right to be afraid." He opened the door. "That's the beautiful game, Kvothe. It isn't about winning. It's about making sure your opponent is always, always too afraid to move."

He stepped through the door. It closed behind him.

I stood alone in the garden with Denna, beside the black pool, under the swinging lantern. The tak board sat on the table between us, its stones laid out in their half-finished pattern.

I looked down at it. And I saw, for the first time, the shape of what he had been building. Stone by stone. Move by move. All along the edges of the board, quietly, while I was paying attention to the center.

It was a door.

## Chapter Forty-Six

# Breaking

We left the garden the way I had come in. There was no other way; the green door in the lane had no handle on the outside, and it was locked from the inside, and I did not want to go through the door Bredon had used. So I made a stirrup of my hands and boosted Denna up the ivy to the top of the wall, and then I climbed up after her, and we dropped down together into the dark lane on the other side.

She landed badly. She had been cradling her wrist, and she could not catch herself properly, and she stumbled and went down on one knee on the cobblestones. I helped her up. She did not thank me. She did not say anything at all.

We walked. Neither of us said where we were going. We simply walked, through the dark streets of the high city, past the great houses behind their walls, past the gardens and the fountains and the statues. The lamplighters had finished their rounds, and the streets were lit with soft gold pools of light, and between the pools there was darkness.

At last we came to the edge of the cliff. There was a low wall there, and beyond it nothing: only the long drop down to the low city, and the lights of the low city spread out below like a scattering of coals, and beyond them the black ribbon of the river and the dark plain stretching away to the horizon.

Denna sat down on the wall. She did not seem to care how close she was to the edge. I sat down beside her.

For a long time we sat there in silence, looking out over the dark.

"Let me see your wrist," I said at last.

She hesitated. Then she held it out.

The cord had stopped glowing. It lay against her skin, thin and dark and almost invisible, tied in its small complicated knot. Beneath it, her skin was red and angry, as if it had been burned. I touched the cord very lightly with one finger. It was warm.

I tried to read the knot. I had learned a great deal from Denna, in those days at the Grey Man, and I had learned more on my own since, puzzling over the Dellers' cloth. But this knot was beyond me. It was so small and so tight and so intricately woven that I could not even see where it began and ended. It was like trying to read a word written in a language made of shadows.

But I could feel it. The tightening in the air. The sense of something reaching out and catching hold.

It held. It held very, very hard.

"Can you take it off?" I asked.

"No. I've tried." Her voice was flat and tired. "I've tried everything. I tried to untie it, and I couldn't find the ends. I tried to cut it, and the knife slid off as if the cord were made of iron. I tried to burn it, once. The candle went out." She took her wrist back and held it against her chest. "It doesn't come off. It never will. Not unless he takes it off. Or unless I die."

"There has to be a way."

"There isn't."

"There's always a way. Everything that's tied can be untied." I thought about it. "Elodin might know. The Master Namer. He knows things about bindings that nobody else does. If I could get you to the University—"

"You've been expelled."

"Then I'll bring him here. I'll write to him. I'll—"

"Kvothe." She put her good hand on my arm. "Stop. Please."

I stopped.

"You heard what he said," she said quietly. "I'll finish the song. I have no choice. If I try to stop, if I try to run, if I try to tell anyone—" She held up her wrist. "You saw what happened. That was just a warning. A little squeeze. He can do worse. Much worse." She shivered. "He told me once, when he first tied it, that it could stop my heart. Just like that. If I ever betrayed him." She looked at me. "I thought he was joking. He was smiling when he said it. He's always smiling."

I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.

"So I'll finish the song," Denna went on. "And I'll sing it. And the lie will grow weaker, and the curse will grow weaker, and one day, maybe, the Thief will come out from behind his door and break it." She laughed, a small broken sound. "And the world will end. And it will be my fault."

"It won't be your fault."

"Whose fault will it be, then?"

"His."

"He'll say it was mine. He'll say I chose it. He'll say I could have stopped at any time, if I'd been willing to die." She looked out over the dark plain. "And he'll be right. I could have. I could still."

I went very cold.

"Denna," I said. "Don't."

"I'm not going to." She smiled, faintly, without looking at me. "I'm too much of a coward. I've always been a coward. I've spent my whole life running away from things, because running is easier than standing still and letting them hit you." She was quiet for a moment. "But I thought about it. Just now, in the garden, when he let go of my wrist. I thought about how easy it would be. Just stop the song. Just stop, and let the knot do what it does, and be done."

"Please don't."

"I said I'm not going to." She turned and looked at me. Her eyes were wet. "You'd never forgive me. And I couldn't stand that. I couldn't stand you not forgiving me."

\* \* \*

We sat on the wall at the edge of the cliff for a long time. The moon rose, a thin crescent, pale and sharp as a sickle. It cast very little light. The city below us was dark and silent except for the distant slow thunder of the mill wheels.

At some point, Denna leaned against me. I put my arm around her. She fit there, against my side, as if she had been made to fit there. Her hair smelled of pear blossoms.

"Tell me something," she said. "Something true. Something that isn't about any of this."

I thought about it. Then I told her about the Adem. Not the fighting, not the Ketan or the Lethani. The small things. The way they eat in silence, and talk with their hands, and laugh with their whole bodies when they laugh at all, which is not often. The way the children run wild on the hillsides in summer, brown as nuts, and the grown-ups pretend not to see them. The way Vashet had scolded me for singing, and then later, when she thought no one was listening, had hummed one of my songs to herself while she sharpened her sword.

Denna laughed at that. A real laugh, soft and surprised.

"You made a warrior woman hum your song," she said.

"I'm very persuasive."

"You're very *something*." She tilted her head up and looked at me. Her face was very close to mine in the dark. "Tell me another."

I told her about Auri. Not her name, and not the ring. Just the little things. The way she named everything she saw, and gave everything a personality. The way she called cheese *brave* and apples *patient*. The way she had stood on the roof of the Mains with a candle, the morning I left, and watched me go.

"She sounds lovely," said Denna softly.

"She is."

"Do you love her?"

"Not like that." I thought about it. "Like a sister. Like someone who needs to be kept safe."

"Everyone you love needs to be kept safe," said Denna. "Have you noticed that? You collect us. Lost things. Broken things." She was

quiet for a moment. "Is that what I am to you? A lost thing?"

"No."

"Then what?"

I did not answer right away. I looked down at her face in the dark. At her eyes, and her mouth, and the small crease between her brows that appeared when she was worried.

"You're the only thing I've never been able to find," I said. "Even when you're right beside me."

She looked at me for a long time. Then she reached up, with her good hand, and touched my face. Very lightly. The way she had touched my scar, all those months ago, outside the Eolian.

And then she kissed me.

\* \* \*

I will not tell you about that night. Some things are not for stories. Some things belong only to the people who lived them, and to no one else.

I will tell you only that it was the first time, and the only time, and that afterward we lay together in my bed in the Maer's palace, in the dark, with the thin moonlight coming through the window and falling across the floor, and she slept with her head on my chest and her wounded wrist cradled between us. I did not sleep. I lay awake and listened to her breathing and felt her heart beating against my ribs, and I thought that I had never been so happy, and I had never been so afraid.

I thought about Bredon. About his mild kind face and his flat cold eyes. About the tak board, and the shape of the door.

I thought about the box, beneath my pillow. I could feel it there, a hard warm lump beneath my head, humming its long slow no.

I thought about the knot on Denna's wrist, and what it could do.

And sometime near dawn, I think, despite everything, I slept.

\* \* \*

When I woke, she was gone.



I knew it before I opened my eyes. I knew it the way you know, waking, that it has snowed in the night: by the particular quality of the silence. The bed beside me was cold. The room was empty. The grey light of early morning was coming through the window, and it fell across the floor where her clothes had been, and there was nothing there now.

I lay there for a long moment, not moving. Not letting myself think.

Then I reached under my pillow.

The box was gone.

\* \* \*

I sat up. I looked under the pillow, and under the other pillow, and under the bed. I looked in my pack, and my trunk, and the wardrobe, and behind the curtains. I looked in every corner of every room. I knew it was useless. I did it anyway.

The box was gone.

And on the table by the window, where I would be sure to see it, there was a small length of dark cord, tied in a knot.

I picked it up with shaking fingers. I held it up to the light.

It was a complex knot, looped and twisted in a pattern that made my eyes ache. But I could read it. She had made sure I could read it. She had tied it slowly and carefully, using only the knots she had taught me herself, in the Grey Man, on those long afternoons.

*Forgive.* That was the first knot. *Keep.* That was the second. *Safe.* The third. And at the heart of it, holding it all together, a knot I had only seen once before: in the center of the cord she wore in her hair, and in the little knot she had left me when she went away from Imre.

*A story that is told many times and changes in the telling.*

And beneath it, very small, one more knot. One I had never seen. It took me a long time to puzzle it out. It was made of pieces I knew, put together in a way I did not. *Door*, and *no*, and *hand*, twisted around each other so tightly that they became something new.

I sat on the edge of the bed with the cord in my hands and turned it over and over, and at last I understood.

*Without the key, the hand cannot open the door.*

\* \* \*

She had taken it to protect me.

I sat there in the grey light and understood that, all at once, and the understanding was like a knife in my chest. She had listened to Bredon in the garden. *You'll go to the door. You won't mean to. But you'll go.* She had lain awake beside me in the dark, the way I had, and she had thought about it. About the box under my pillow. About what I was, and what I could do, and what Bredon wanted.

And she had decided that the only way to keep me from opening the door was to make sure I could not.

She had taken the key. Not to give it to him. I knew that, the way I knew her face. She had taken it to hide it. From him, and from the Seven, and from me. She had taken it somewhere she thought none of us would ever find it.

She had done it because she loved me.

And she had not asked. She had not trusted me to make the choice myself. She had made it for me, the way Bredon made choices for her, and she had gone away in the night, the way she always went away, and left me a knot to say she was sorry.

I sat there on the edge of my bed and held the cord in my hands and I did not know whether to laugh or weep or scream. So I did nothing. I sat very still, the way Vashet had taught me, and I let it all rise and pass.

It did not pass. It rose and rose and did not stop rising.

\* \* \*

I went down to the Mill Race. Of course I did. Orla the landlady met me at the door with a face like thunder.

"She's gone," she said. "Paid her bill in the middle of the night and went off with her harp and her bags. Didn't say where." She looked at me with narrowed eyes. "What did you do to her?"

"Nothing."

"Nothing. She came in last night looking like a ghost, and went out again, and came back an hour before dawn looking worse, and packed up everything she owned, and was gone before the cock crowed." Orla folded her arms. "If that's nothing, I'd hate to see something."

I did not answer. I turned away and walked out into the street.

I went to the garden with the green door. I climbed the wall again, in broad daylight, not caring who saw. The garden was empty. The table beside the black pool was bare. The tak board was gone. The lantern hung dark on its branch. There was no sign that anyone had ever been there at all.

I went back to the palace and asked Stapes where Bredon's rooms were. He told me. I went there. They were empty too. Swept clean. The bed stripped. The wardrobe bare. A servant I did not know was polishing the floor, and when I asked her where the gentleman who had lived here had gone, she looked at me blankly and said that the rooms had been empty for a month.

I stood in the empty room, in the late morning light, and I understood.

He had gone. They had both gone. He had played his stones and made his moves and set his shape upon the board, and then he had simply stepped away, the way he always did, leaving me to stare at the pattern and try to understand what I had lost.

And the box was gone too. The key. Somewhere out there in the world, in Denna's hands, being carried to a hiding place I did not know.

And Bredon had a cord around her wrist that could stop her heart.

I stood in that empty room and I realized, slowly, with a horror that crept up my spine like cold water, that Denna had not hidden the key from Bredon at all.

She had only moved it from a place he could not reach, to a place he could.

It was the most beautiful move I had ever seen. And I had not even seen him make it.

## Chapter Forty-Seven

# What Orla Found

Orla sent for me four days later.

I did not expect it. I had not been back to the Mill Race since the morning Denna left. I had spent those four days in the Maer's library and the Maer's gardens and the Maer's wine cellar, mostly the last, turning the shape of Bredon's game over and over in my mind and finding, every time, that I had lost. I did not want to see the room where Denna had stayed. I did not want to see Orla's face, like thunder, asking me what I had done.

But a boy came to the palace gate on the fourth morning, a skinny redheaded potboy with flour on his apron, and asked for "the musician with the red hair, what was sweet on the harp girl." And the guards, who had heard a great deal about me by then and liked very little of it, sent him up to my rooms with a look that said they hoped he was a debt collector.

"Missus Orla says come," said the boy. "Says she's found something. Says don't dawdle."

\* \* \*

Orla was in the courtyard of the Mill Race when I got there, under the pear tree, sitting on the bench where Denna and I had sat, and played, and not quite said the things we wanted to say. The blossoms were gone now. The tree was green and ordinary. Orla had a basket of mending in her lap, and she did not look up when I came through the gate.

"Sit," she said.

I sat. On the other end of the bench, as far from her as I could get.

She went on mending for a while. A man's shirt, torn at the elbow. Her needle went in and out, very quick, very neat. She was a big woman, broad in the shoulders and hips, with grey hair scraped back into a knot and forearms like a baker's. Her face, when it was not like thunder, was plain and tired and not unkind.

"I had the room turned out," she said at last. "Hers. Yesterday. For the next guest. Merchant's wife from Tinuë, coming up the river." She pulled her thread tight. "Girl I had doing it found something. Under the mattress. Pushed right in, between the ropes and the ticking, where you'd never find it unless you took the whole bed apart. Which we did, because the ropes wanted tightening."

She set down her mending. She reached into the pocket of her apron and took out something and held it out to me without looking at me.

It was a cord. A short length of dark cord, braided from three strands, about as long as my forearm. And tied along it, one after another, a row of small, neat knots.

\* \* \*

I took it. My hands were not steady.

"I can't read it," said Orla. "Can't read anything, much. Certainly not knots." She picked up her mending again. "But I know what it is. My grandmother was from Yll. She used to tie letters like that, for her sister in Rannish. Said it was better than ink. Said ink could lie, but a knot couldn't." She glanced at me, sidelong. "You can read it. Can't you? She taught you. I saw you, the pair of you, under this tree. Her tying and you frowning."

"Yes," I said.

"Well, then." Orla went back to her needle. "Read it. I'll not look."

\* \* \*

I read it.

It took me a long time. Denna's knots were very small and very tight, and some of them I did not know. Yllish knot-script is not like letters. It is more like music. The same knot can mean different things depending on the knots around it, and the tension of the cord, and whether it is tied over or under. Denna had taught me the basics, at the Grey Man, and in this courtyard, under the pear tree. But she knew a great deal more than she had taught me.

But I could read enough.

K, the first knot said. The knot she used for my name. A small, neat, looping knot, like a flame.

And then:

*Forgive me.*

*He will kill you if I do not take it. He told me so. He was smiling when he said it.*

*I will keep it safe. Safer than he thinks. I know things about knots that he does not know I know.*

*Do not follow me. Please. If you follow me, he will know that you know, and he will stop being patient.*

*I am doing this so you will not have to.*

And then, at the very end, a knot I did not know. A complicated one, looped over and under itself three times, with a small twist at the end. I turned it over in my fingers for a long time, trying to read it. I could not.

\* \* \*

I sat on the bench under the pear tree with the cord in my hands and did not say anything for a long time. Orla mended her shirt. The mill wheels turned in the distance, with their slow thunder. A cat walked across the courtyard, very dignified, and disappeared under the gate.

"Well?" said Orla at last. "What's it say?"

I told her. Not all of it. But enough.

Orla did not say anything for a while. She pulled her thread through, and knotted it, and bit it off with her teeth.

"I thought it'd be something like that," she said.

I looked at her.

"She came in that night looking like a ghost," said Orla. "I told you. And went out. And came back looking worse." She folded the shirt in her lap, very neatly. "I've seen that look before. On a girl's face. In a mirror, mostly." She did not look at me. "When I was twenty I was married to a man in Tinuë who kept a tavern by the docks. He was very charming. Everyone said so. Very kind. Very generous. Very clever with his hands." She smoothed the folded shirt. "And one night he told me, very kindly, what he'd do to my sister if I ever left him. Smiling. The whole time."

The mill wheels turned. The pear tree rustled.

"I left anyway," said Orla. "Three years later. In the night. Took my sister with me, and his strongbox, and never went back." She looked at me at last. Her face was very plain and very tired. "That's the look. The look of a girl who's been told what'll happen to someone she loves. By a man who smiles."

\* \* \*

"Why didn't you tell me?" I said. "The morning she left. You asked me what I'd done to her."

"Because I thought it was you." Orla shrugged her broad shoulders. "The smiling man. I didn't know you. You were young, and clever, and very charming, and the Maer's pet besides. I thought, *there he is. That's the one.*" She looked at me steadily. "I was wrong. I'm sorry for it. But I'd think it again, in the same place. Better to think it and be wrong."

"Yes," I said. "I suppose it is."

She looked at the cord in my hands.

"That last knot," she said. "The one you can't read."

"Yes?"

"My grandmother used to tie that one." Orla's voice had changed. Softer. "At the end of her letters to her sister. I asked her once what it meant. She said it didn't mean anything, exactly. It wasn't a word. It was more like—" She frowned, searching for it. "Like a hand. Holding. She said you tie it at the end when there's something you can't say in words. When you need the other person to know you're

holding on to them, even if you're far away." She looked at me. "She said it was the oldest knot there is. Older than letters. Older than Yll."

I looked down at the knot. Looped over and under itself three times, with a small twist at the end.

A hand. Holding.

\* \* \*

I did not follow her. I want that on the record. I wanted to, more than anything. I sat in my rooms in the Maer's palace that night with the cord in my hands and a map of Vintas spread out in front of me, and I worked out every road she could have taken, and every town she could have reached, and every place she might have gone to ground. I could have found her. I am almost sure of it.

But I did not go. Because she had asked me not to. Because she had tied it into a cord, where it could not lie. *If you follow me, he will stop being patient.*

It was the first time in my life I did what Denna asked me to. It was very nearly the last.

\* \* \*

"Do you still have it?" said Chronicler. "The cord?"

"No." The innkeeper looked at the fire. "I gave it back to her. Later. Much later. In Imre, the night before she left for the last time." He was quiet for a moment. "She looked at it for a long time. At the last knot. And then she said, *You kept it.* And I said, *You asked me to hold on.*"

He did not say anything else for a while. Chronicler waited.

"She tied that knot again, you know," said the innkeeper at last. "Once more. At the end." He put his hand into the pocket of his apron. Chronicler did not need to see what was in it. He had seen the innkeeper's hand go there a hundred times in three days. "She sent it to me by a tinker. A single knot, on a short length of cord made of her hair." He did not take it out. "I didn't know what it was, when he gave it to me. I only knew that when I held it, something in my chest stopped hurting."



"The same knot," said Chronicler slowly. "Looped three times. With a twist at the end."

"The same knot." The innkeeper took his hand out of his pocket. It was empty. "A hand. Holding." He looked at the scribe. "The oldest knot there is."

## Interlude: Hands

The innkeeper stopped speaking. His hands were flat on the table in front of him, and Chronicler saw that they were pressed down so hard that the tips of the fingers had gone white.

Nobody said anything. The fire crackled in the grate. Somewhere outside, a dog was barking, far off, a thin lonely sound that came and went on the wind.

Bast was the first to move. He stood up from his backward chair, very slowly, the way a cat stands when it has seen something in the grass. His face was pale. His eyes were very dark, darker than Chronicler had ever seen them, dark as deep water.

"She took it," he said. His voice was very quiet. "She took the key and gave it to *him*."

"She didn't give it to him," said the innkeeper. "Not then. Not willingly."

"It doesn't matter. She took it." Bast's hands were shaking. "Reshi, you never told me. You never told me any of this. I thought—I always thought it was the other way. I thought he took it from you. I thought—"

"I know what you thought."

"You let me think it!"

"Yes."

"*Why?*"

The innkeeper looked up at him. His face was very tired.

"Because you would have hated her," he said. "And I didn't want you to hate her."

Bast stared at him. For a long moment he did not speak. Then he made a sound, low in his throat, a sound that was not quite human. It was the sound a fox makes in the night, the sound of something wild and hurt and furious. He turned away from the table and went to the window and stood there with his back to them, his arms wrapped around himself, his whole body rigid.

"I do hate her," he said, without turning around. "I've always hated her. You know that. Even before. Even when I thought—" He stopped. "She's always been the thing that hurt you. Every time. Every single time."

"She didn't mean to."

*"It doesn't matter what she meant!"*

The words cracked through the common room like a whip. The bottles behind the bar rang faintly. The fire in the hearth leapt up and then sank low, as if it had flinched.

Chronicler sat very still. He had seen Bast angry before, in the last two days. He had seen him threatening and sly and dangerous. But he had not seen this. This was something else. This was something old and cold and very far from human, looking out through a young man's eyes.

The innkeeper did not flinch. He sat at the table with his hands flat on the wood and looked at Bast's back.

"Bast," he said quietly. "Come and sit down."

Bast did not move.

"Bast."

For a long moment, nothing happened. Then, slowly, the rigid line of Bast's shoulders softened. He turned from the window. His face was wet. He came back to the table and sat down in his backward chair and put his arms on the back of it and put his face in his arms.

The innkeeper reached out and laid one hand on the back of Bast's dark head. He did not say anything. He simply left it there, the way you might lay a hand on a frightened animal.

After a while, Bast's shoulders stopped shaking.

\* \* \*

Chronicler looked down at his page. He had stopped writing somewhere in the middle of the last part of the story, and he had not noticed. The last line on the page was half a word, trailing off into a smear of ink where his pen had slipped.

He looked at it for a long moment. Then he looked at his own hands.

They were shaking.

He did not know when that had started. He did not know why. He only knew that as he had listened to the innkeeper's voice, telling about the empty bed and the missing box and the knot on the table, something in him had gone cold and still, the way the air goes cold and still before a storm.

He had recorded a great many stories. Some of them had been sad. Some of them had been terrible. He had written down accounts of battles and massacres, of plagues and famines, of men who had done things so cruel that he had had to stop and go outside and walk around the block before he could continue.

But he had never felt like this. He had never felt as if the story he was writing was reaching out of the page and taking hold of him.

He thought about the knot. *A story that is told many times and changes in the telling.* He thought about what the innkeeper had said, that morning, about the old writing. The kind that did not remember things but made them.

He looked at his page, with its tiny crabbed cipher, its lines and loops and marks.

He wondered, for the first time in his life, what exactly he was doing.

\* \* \*

"Why did you tell it?" he asked. His voice came out rough, and he cleared his throat. "That part. About that night. You didn't have to. You could have said she took the box and left and that would have been enough."

The innkeeper was quiet for a moment. His hand was still resting on Bast's head.

"Because it's true," he said. "And because I promised you the true story. All of it. Not just the parts that make me look clever, or brave, or wise." He smiled faintly. "There aren't many of those, as it turns out. Most of the story is me being a fool."

"But that part—"

"That part more than any." The innkeeper looked down at the table. "You have to understand. Everything that happened afterward, everything I did, every choice I made. It all came back to that night. To waking up and finding her gone and the box gone and the knot on the table." He was silent for a moment. "If you don't know about that night, you can't understand the rest. You'll think I did what I did for glory, or revenge, or because I'm a monster. And some of that's true. But it isn't the whole of it."

"What's the whole of it?"

The innkeeper looked up at him. His green eyes were very dark.

"I loved her," he said simply. "That's all. That's the whole of it. I loved her, and she was bound, and I couldn't cut the cord. And everything I did afterward, every terrible thing, I did because I was trying to find a way to cut it."

Bast lifted his head from his arms. His eyes were red. He looked at the innkeeper for a long moment, and something passed between them that Chronicler did not understand.

"Did you?" Bast said quietly. "Find a way?"

The innkeeper did not answer. He took his hand from Bast's head and folded both hands on the table in front of him and looked at them.

They were steady now. Perfectly steady. But Chronicler, watching them, saw something he had not noticed before. On the inside of the innkeeper's left wrist, just below the heel of the hand, there was a thin pale line. A scar. Very fine, very old, running all the way around the wrist like a bracelet.

It was the kind of scar that a cord leaves, if it is tied very tight, and left for a very long time.

\* \* \*

"It's getting on toward evening," the innkeeper said at last. He glanced at the window. The light had turned golden and slanting, and the shadows of the trees stretched long across the fields. "The regulars will be in soon. I'll need to start supper."

"I'll do it," said Bast.

The innkeeper looked at him.

"I'll do it," Bast said again. He stood up. His face was still pale, but his voice was steady. "You keep talking. I'll do supper. I know how. I've watched you a hundred times."

"You'll burn the stew."

"I won't burn the stew."

"You always burn the stew."

"I won't *this* time." Bast's mouth twisted into something that was almost a smile. "Trust me, Reshi."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then he nodded.

"All right," he said. "Go on. And don't forget the thyme."

Bast went into the kitchen. They heard him moving about in there, banging pots, rather more quietly than he had that morning.

The innkeeper turned back to Chronicler.

"You've stopped writing," he said.

Chronicler looked down. He was still holding his pen, but it had dried in his hand. He dipped it in the inkwell.

"I'm sorry," he said. "I'm ready."

"No, you're not. Your hands are shaking." The innkeeper leaned forward and looked at him, and there was something in his face that was almost kind. "It's all right. It gets to everyone, eventually. The story. I've seen it happen before." He paused. "Do you want to stop for a while?"

Chronicler looked at him. He thought about it.

"No," he said. "No. I want to hear what happened next."

The innkeeper smiled. It was a small, crooked, rueful smile.

"That," he said, "is exactly how it gets you."

He leaned back in his chair and looked out the window, at the long golden light on the fields, and the dark line of the trees, and the

thin grey smoke still leaning above them.

"I went back to the Maer," said Kvothe. "And I told him I had lost his wife's inheritance. And he did the one thing I never expected."

"What?"

"He forgave me." The innkeeper's voice was very quiet. "And then he gave me a job. And the job was to go to Renere, to the king's court, and find out who was killing the heirs to the throne of Vintas." He paused. "Which is how I came to meet Ambrose Jakis again. And how I came, eventually, to kill him."

Chronicler's pen stopped.

The innkeeper looked at him, and his face was perfectly calm.

"Write it down," he said. "I'm not going to say it twice."

## Chapter Forty-Eight

# The Maer's Commission

I told the Maer the truth.

Not all of it. I did not tell him about the garden, or Bredon's confession, or what I had heard about my parents' deaths. I did not tell him about the night Denna spent in my rooms. Some things are not for Maers.

But I told him that his wife had given me the Lackless box, and that I had kept it under my pillow, and that someone had taken it in the night. I told him who, and I told him why, as best I understood it. And I told him that I thought the person she had taken it from me to protect me from now had it within his reach.

The Maer listened to all of it without interrupting. He sat behind his desk in his long study, with the tall windows behind him and the whole of Severen spread out below, and his face did not change at all. When I had finished, he was silent for a long time.

"Bredon," he said at last.

"Yes, your grace."

"Bredon has been at my court for eleven years. He was at my father's court before that. He taught my cousin to play tak. He gave me a book of poems on my fifteenth birthday." The Maer's voice was very flat. "He has dined at my table a hundred times."

"I know, your grace. I'm sorry."

"You are sorry." He looked at me. "You are sorry that a man I have trusted for most of my life is an agent of something so old and so dangerous that I did not believe in it until this moment. You are sorry



that my wife gave away her family's most precious possession to a boy she has known for a year. You are sorry that the boy then lost it to a girl he loves, who is bound by a knot to the man who wants it most." He paused. "Is that the sum of it?"

"Yes, your grace."

The Maer looked at me for a long time. Then, to my utter astonishment, he laughed.

It was not a happy laugh. It was short and sharp and bitter, the laugh of a man who has just been dealt a very bad hand of cards and can see no way to play it. But it was a laugh.

"God's teeth," he said. "When you do a thing, Kvothe, you do not do it by halves."

\* \* \*

He rose from his desk and went to the window and stood looking out, his hands clasped behind his back. It was a gesture I had seen him make many times, when he was thinking.

"My wife," he said. "Does she know?"

"Not yet. I came to you first."

"Good. I will tell her." He was quiet for a moment. "She will be very distressed. Not about the box. About you. She has been—" He hesitated. "Since you spoke with her, she has been different. Lighter. As if something she had been carrying for a very long time has been set down." He turned from the window and looked at me. "She told me, you know. About her sister. About you."

I did not know what to say.

"You might have told me yourself," said the Maer. "It would have been the proper thing."

"I know, your grace. I'm sorry."

"Stop saying you are sorry. It is becoming tiresome." He came back to his desk and sat down. "You are my wife's nephew. That makes you my nephew, by marriage. Did you think of that?"

"No, your grace."

"No. I did not think you had." He steepled his fingers and looked at me over them. "It changes things. Not a great deal, perhaps. You are

still a Ruh, and still a bastard of sorts, and no one at court will ever accept you as anything else. But it changes things between us. You are family now. And I do not abandon family."

I stared at him. I did not know what to say. I had come into his study expecting anger, or cold dismissal, or worse. I had not expected this.

"Your grace," I said. "I lost the box."

"You did not lose it. It was stolen from you. By someone who loved you, if your account is true, and who was trying to protect you." He shook his head. "That is not a crime. That is a misfortune. And misfortunes can be mended."

"How?"

"By getting it back." He leaned forward. "And to do that, we need to know where Bredon has gone, and what he intends. And I think I may know where to begin."

\* \* \*

He told me.

King Roderic was dying. There was no longer any doubt about it. The wasting sickness had taken him slowly through the winter and faster through the spring, and now he lay in his bed in the royal palace at Renere, too weak to rise, too weak to speak more than a few words at a time. His physicians gave him a month. Perhaps two.

When he died, the crown would pass to his heir. His son, Prince Andrian, a young man of twenty with a weak chin and a strong fondness for horses. But Andrian was unmarried and had no children. And after him, the line of succession ran through a tangle of cousins and uncles and nephews, many of whom were now dead.

"Four heirs have died in two years," the Maer said. "Andrian is the only one left between the throne and the next four in line. And of those four, three are either very old, very young, or very foolish." He looked at me. "The fourth is Ambrose Jakis."

"Fifth in line," I said slowly. "But if Andrian dies—"

"Then he becomes fourth. And if one or two of the others should have an accident—" The Maer spread his hands. "He becomes second."

Or first."

I sat very still. I thought about Ambrose on the steps of the Mains, in the snow. *When I'm king*. I thought about his smile. The secret one.

I thought about Bredon, standing behind him.

"Bredon is putting Ambrose on the throne," I said.

"I think so. Or trying to." The Maer's face was grim. "I have suspected for some time that the deaths were not natural. I have had my own people watching. But they have found nothing. No poison, no assassins, no bribed servants. Nothing at all. Every death looks exactly like what it appears to be. A fever. A fall. A hunting accident." He shook his head. "Whoever is doing this is very, very good."

"It's not poison," I said.

The Maer looked at me sharply. "How do you know?"

"Because I know what Bredon can do." I thought about the knot on Denna's wrist, glowing faintly red. *It could stop my heart. Just like that*. "He ties knots, your grace. Old ones. Yllish knots. The kind that don't just mean things, but *do* things. He tied one on Denna's wrist that could kill her if she disobeyed him." I swallowed. "I think he's been tying knots for the heirs."

The Maer was silent for a long time.

"That," he said at last, "is the most absurd thing I have ever heard."

"Yes, your grace."

"If anyone else had said it to me, I would have had them thrown from the cliff."

"Yes, your grace."

"But you are not anyone else." He sighed. "And I have learned, over the last year, that the world is considerably stranger than I had thought." He looked at me. "Can you prove it?"

"I don't know. Maybe. If I could get close to the king. If I could see him. If there's a knot on him somewhere, I think I could find it."

"And then? If you find it?"

"Then maybe I can untie it." I paused. "Or at least I'll know. And we'll know who's next."

The Maer looked at me for a long time across his desk. I could see him thinking, weighing, calculating. He was a very clever man, the Maer. Cleverer than me, in many ways. He had survived the Vintish court for thirty years by being clever.

"The king's court is not a safe place," he said at last. "Not for anyone, and certainly not for you. You are known to be my man. You are known to be Ruh. You are known, in certain circles, to have killed a number of bandits in the Eld and to have done something unpleasant to my former arcanist." He paused. "And Ambrose Jakis will be there. He is often at the palace now, since his father's rise. He will know you."

"I know."

"He hates you. That much is known even in Severen."

"I know."

"If he is what we think he is, if he is Bredon's piece, then he will want you dead. And at the king's court, with his father's power behind him, he will be in a position to arrange it."

"I know, your grace."

The Maer looked at me. Then he sighed and shook his head.

"You are going to go anyway," he said. "Aren't you?"

"Yes, your grace."

"Because of the girl."

I did not answer. I did not have to.

The Maer was quiet for a long moment. Then he opened a drawer in his desk and took out a sheet of heavy cream paper and a pen. He began to write.

"You will go as my envoy," he said, without looking up. "My personal representative to the royal court. It is a common enough thing; I send someone every season to pay my respects and carry my letters and keep my ear to the ground. No one will think anything of it." He wrote a few more lines. "You will carry letters of introduction to certain people at court whom I trust. There are not many. You will carry a purse sufficient to your station, which is to say considerably

more than you are used to. And you will carry this."

He signed the paper, and dripped wax onto the bottom of it, and pressed his seal into the wax. Then he held it out to me.

I took it. It was a letter of commission. It named me as the Maer's envoy, with all the rights and privileges that entailed. And at the bottom, above his seal, there was a line I had not expected.

*The bearer is to be accorded every courtesy due to a member of my house.*

I looked up at him.

"Your grace," I said. "I can't—"

"You can. You will." He did not smile. But there was something in his eyes that was almost warm. "My wife would never forgive me if I sent her sister's son into a nest of vipers without every protection I could give him. And neither, I find, would I."

\* \* \*

Meluan came to see me that evening, as I was packing.

She did not knock. She simply opened the door of my rooms and came in and closed it behind her and stood with her back against it, her hands resting on the great round swell of her belly. She was very pale. Her eyes were red.

"Alveron told me," she said.

"I'm sorry."

"Don't." She came into the room and sat down on the edge of my bed. She looked tired. More tired than I had ever seen her. "Don't be sorry. It wasn't your fault."

"I should have kept it safer."

"You kept it under your pillow. That's where I kept it." She smiled faintly. "It didn't help me either. Not really. It was only luck that I woke that night. Only luck that I screamed." She shook her head. "It was never safe. Not anywhere. I think I always knew that. I just didn't want to know."

I sat down beside her. For a long time, neither of us spoke.

"The girl," Meluan said at last. "The one who took it. Do you love her?"

"Yes."

"Does she love you?"

I thought about the knot on the table. *Forgive. Keep. Safe.*

"Yes," I said. "I think so."

Meluan nodded slowly. "Then she'll keep it safe. As best she can." She looked at me. "Your mother loved your father. And she ran from everything to keep him. To keep you." She was quiet for a moment. "People do strange things for love. Foolish things. Brave things. Sometimes they're the same thing."

She reached out and took my hand.

"Find her," she said. "Find her, and find the box, and bring them both home. And then come back here, to Severen. To us." She squeezed my hand. "You have a family now, Kvothe. Don't forget that."

I looked at her. At her pale tired face, and her red eyes, and her hand in mine.

"I won't," I said.

\* \* \*

I left for Renere the next morning. The Maer gave me a horse, a tall grey gelding with a steady temper and an uncanny tolerance for my lute. He gave me two guards, hard-faced men who said little and watched everything. He gave me a purse so heavy I had to carry it in two parts.

Stapes saw me off at the gates. He stood very straight in the grey morning light, his hands folded, his face calm.

"Good luck, sir," he said.

"Thank you, Stapes."

He hesitated. Then he stepped forward and said, very quietly, so that the guards could not hear:

"Sir. When you are at court. The old gentleman. Bredon." He paused. "He always took his wine with a little honey. Very particular about it. And he always, always sat with his back to the wall." He looked at me. "I thought you might like to know."

I looked at him for a long moment. Then I smiled.

"Thank you, Stapes," I said. "That's very useful."

He bowed. "Safe travels, sir."

I rode out through the gates and down the long cliff road toward the plain. The sun was coming up over the river valley, turning the fields to gold. Somewhere to the north and east, three days' ride away, the royal city of Renere lay waiting, with its king dying in his bed and its heirs dying one by one and Ambrose Jakis smiling his secret smile.

And somewhere out there, beyond that, beyond everything, Denna was riding with a box in her saddlebag and a knot on her wrist, going somewhere I did not know.

I lit Kilvin's candle that night, in an inn at the edge of the plain. It burned yellow. I watched it for a long time.

Then I took out the little knot she had left me, the one that said *forgive*, and held it in my hand until I fell asleep.

## Chapter Forty-Nine

### Harl

The road from Severen to Renere runs northeast across the heart of Vintas, through a country of vineyards and orchards and old walled towns, and it takes six days if the weather is kind. The weather was not kind. It rained for four of the six, a steady grey soaking rain that turned the road to paste and the fields to lakes and got into everything we owned.

I rode the Maer's tall grey gelding, whose name, I discovered on the second day, was Dignity. Harl and Corrin rode behind me on two heavy bay cobs with no names at all, or none they would tell me.

Corrin talked. He was the younger of the two, lean and quick and freckled, and he had served in the city guard of Renere before he came to the Maer, and he was full of stories about it. Drunken lords and knife fights in the Weir and a baker's wife who had once chased him three streets with a rolling pin. He told them well. By the second day I was laughing at them in spite of the rain.

Harl did not talk. Harl rode.

He was a big man, older than Corrin by twenty years, with a broken nose and a grizzled beard and a face like a closed door. He rode with his hood up and his hands loose on the reins and his eyes moving, always moving, over the hedges and the ditches and the dark lines of woods at the edges of the fields. When we stopped, he checked the horses' feet before he checked his own supper. When we slept, he slept last and woke first, and I never once caught him with his eyes closed.



"Does he ever say anything?" I asked Corrin, on the third night. We were in the common room of an inn in a town called Pell, and Harl was outside, seeing to the horses.

Corrin grinned. "Sometimes. When it matters."

"How often does it matter?"

"Not often," said Corrin. "Harl says most talk is just noise. He says a man should only open his mouth to eat, drink, or say something that'll keep someone alive." He took a pull of his beer. "I've known him nine years. I think he's said maybe a thousand words to me. Most of them were *duck*."

\* \* \*

On the fourth day, we were ambushed.

It was not much of an ambush. Six men, ragged and thin, deserters or out-of-work soldiers from some lord's disbanded levy. They came out of a copse of trees where the road ran through a narrow cut between two hills, with rusty swords and one crossbow, and they shouted at us to stop and throw down our purses.

Corrin swore and reached for his sword.

Harl did not reach for anything. He looked at the six men for a long moment. At their thin faces and their rusty swords and the crossbow, which was pointed at me, and which was shaking.

Then he said, in a voice like gravel, "Boy with the bow. What's your name?"

The boy with the crossbow stared at him. He could not have been more than sixteen.

"Dell," he said.

"Dell," said Harl. "When did you last eat?"

The boy's mouth fell open. The men around him shifted and muttered.

"Two days," said the boy.

Harl nodded slowly. He reached into his saddlebag, very slowly, so that no one would mistake it, and took out a loaf of bread. A whole loaf, and a wedge of cheese wrapped in cloth. He held them up.

"Put down the bow," he said, "and this is yours. All of you. Share it." He looked at the others. "Or pick it up again and I'll kill four of you before the other two can run. Your choice."

There was a long silence in the cut between the hills. Rain dripped from the trees.

The boy put down the bow.

Harl rode forward and handed him the bread and cheese. Then he reached into his saddlebag again and took out a few coppers and gave them to the oldest of the men.

"Farm at the bottom of the next valley," he said. "Man named Tobin. Needs hands for the harvest, and he's too proud to ask. Tell him Harl sent you." He looked at them all. "And throw away those swords. They'll get you hanged."

He turned his horse and rode back to us, and we went on through the cut between the hills, and the six men stood at the side of the road with the bread in their hands and watched us go.

\* \* \*

"You knew there'd be a farm," I said to him that evening, when we had stopped. It was the first time I had spoken to him directly in four days.

Harl was crouched by the fire, turning a rabbit on a spit. He did not look up.

"Grew up two valleys over," he said.

"You were going to kill them."

"Four of them." He turned the rabbit. "Wouldn't have come to it."

"How did you know?"

He was quiet for so long that I thought he was not going to answer. Then he said, "Boy's hands were shaking. Men whose hands shake don't want to shoot. They want to eat." He looked at me for the first time, across the fire. "You learn it. After a while. What men want."

"What do I want?"

Harl looked at me for a long moment with his small hard eyes.

"To be too late for nothing," he said. "Never again."

I did not say anything. I did not know how he knew. I had told him nothing about my family, or Tarbean, or the Deller farm.

He went back to turning the rabbit.

"Same as me," he said.

\* \* \*

He did not say anything else that night. Or the next day. But on the sixth morning, as we came over the last rise and saw Renere spread out below us in its bowl of green hills, he rode up beside me.

"The city's bad," he said. "Worse than Severen. Everyone smiling. Everyone with a knife." He looked at me. "You'll want to go places alone. Don't."

"I can take care of myself."

"I know." He looked down at the city. "Take care of us anyway. Me and the boy. We're paid to die for you. I'd rather not."

It was, Corrin told me later, the longest speech he had ever heard Harl make.

\* \* \*

I have told you how he died. In the laundry doorway of the palace at Renere, with his sword drawn, holding a narrow door against a dozen men while I ran.

I did not tell you what he said to me, in that doorway, before I ran. I have not told anyone.

He said, *Go on, sir*. And then, as I turned, one more thing, very low, almost to himself.

*Not too late this time.*

I did not understand it then. I thought about it for a long time afterward, on the barge, and in Tarbean, and in all the years after. And I think now that he had a story too. Someone he had come too late for, once, a long time ago. Two valleys over, perhaps. And that in that doorway, holding it, he had found a way to be on time.

I never learned who. He never told me, and there was no one left to ask.

But I have his name. Harl. Four letters, spoken very seldom. And I have put it in this story, where it belongs, so that someone will remember.

He would have said it was just noise.

It isn't.

## Chapter Fifty

# Lady Tamsin's Cats

Lady Tamsin Aerwen had thirty-one cats, and she knew the name and pedigree and temperament of every one of them, and she liked all of them better than she liked most people.

"Cats," she told me, on the first afternoon, "are honest. They want exactly three things. Food, warmth, and to be left alone when they choose and fussed over when they choose. They never pretend to want anything else." She stroked the grey tom in her lap, a vast shaggy creature named Admiral. "Courtiers want the same three things. But they lie about it."

She was the first of the Maer's three friends I went to see in Renere, though I will tell you of the others in their place. It was in her rooms, in my first days in that city, that I learned the things that would make sense of what I saw at the king's bedside. I came to her in the old wing of the palace on the Maer's letter, the afternoon I arrived. She had read the letter twice, holding it very close to her bright old eyes, and then she had tossed it into the fire and watched it burn.

"Alveron always did write too much," she said. "Sit down, boy. Have a cake. Not that one; Pudding's been at it."

I did not ask which cat was Pudding. I took a different cake.

\* \* \*

She told me things. That was her gift, it turned out. Not power, not money, though she had a great deal of both. Knowing things. She had been at the Vintish court for sixty years, since she was a girl of

fourteen sent to wait on the old queen, and she had spent those sixty years listening. At keyholes and behind curtains and across dinner tables. She knew who had married whom and why, who had poisoned whom and how, whose children were not their husband's and whose husbands were not their children's father's.

And she knew about the Jakis family.

"New money," she said, with profound contempt, of a house that had held its barony for two hundred years. "Old Jakis's grandfather bought the title from a king who needed a war paid for. They've been buying ever since. Land, offices, marriages." She fed Admiral a piece of cake. "The present duke's grandfather married a girl from the eastern hills. Very poor. Very old family. That was the last thing the Jakises didn't have, you see. Old blood. They bought some."

"What family?"

Lady Tamsin looked at me over Admiral's shaggy head.

"Nobody remembers," she said. "A little branch of something older. Some cousin of a cousin of the Lacklesses, four hundred years back. Poor as mice. They'd have sold their daughter to a tinker if the tinker had offered more." She smiled thinly. "That's where Ambrose gets his looks. Not from the Jakis side. The Jakises all look like well-fed pigs."

I sat very still.

"A cousin of the Lacklesses," I said.

"So they say. It's in the genealogies, if you care to look. Nobody does. It's a very thin thread." She stroked the cat. "Why? Does it matter?"

"It might."

Lady Tamsin looked at me for a long moment with her bright old eyes.

"Everything matters, in this court," she said. "Eventually. That's the first thing you learn." She set Admiral down on the floor. He stalked off, offended. "What else do you want to know?"

\* \* \*

"There's an old man," I said. "At court. He plays tak. Bredon."

Something changed in Lady Tamsin's face. It was very small. A tightening at the corners of her mouth.

"Bredon," she said. "Yes. I know Bredon."

"How long has he been at court?"

She did not answer right away. She got up, slowly, leaning on her cane, and crossed the room to a tall cabinet in the corner, crowded with cats. She shooed three of them off the lower shelf and opened a drawer and took out a small book bound in faded red leather. She brought it back and sat down and opened it on her lap.

"My diary," she said. "From my first year at court. I was fourteen. I wrote down everything." She turned the brittle pages carefully. "Here."

She held it out to me. I read the line her finger was pointing to. It was written in a round, careful, girlish hand, sixty years old.

*The old gentleman with the silver stick beat the prince at tak again tonight. He is very kind to me. He says I have a clever face. His name is Master Brand.*

I looked up.

"Brand," I said.

"Brand," said Lady Tamsin. "Sixty years ago. An old man then. White hair. A stick with a silver head. He taught the old king to play tak when the old king was a boy." She took the diary back and closed it. "He left after a year or two. I forgot about him. And then, forty years later, an old man came to court with a stick with a silver head, and said his name was Bredon, and taught the prince to play tak."

"The same man?"

"I was fourteen, the first time. I was fifty-five, the second. My eyes weren't what they had been." Lady Tamsin's voice was very quiet. "But I remember a face. I've always remembered faces. It's how I've survived." She looked at me. "He said I had a clever face. Both times. The same words."

The room was very quiet. Even the cats seemed still.

"He was at the Maer's court," I said. "For eleven years."

"And before that, here. And before that, somewhere else, I expect." Lady Tamsin set the diary on the table. "I've never told anyone. Who would believe me? A mad old woman with thirty cats, saying the old tak player hasn't aged a day in sixty years." She smiled thinly. "They'd put me in a tower."

"I believe you."

"Yes." She looked at me. "I rather thought you might. Alveron says you believe a great many strange things. And that you're usually right."

\* \* \*

She told me one more thing, before I left.

"The king's hair," she said. "Has anyone told you about the king's hair?"

"No."

"They will. Kelm will, if you go to him; he frets about it." She looked at me.

"I was the one who noticed it first. Before the physicians. I visit Roderic every morning; I've known him since he was in swaddling." She was quiet for a moment. "The morning it started, the tangles, there was a girl in his rooms. Very early. Before the valet. A singer. The king's nightingale, they were calling her, though she'd only been at court a month. She'd come to sing for him because he couldn't sleep."

I did not move.

"Dark hair," said Lady Tamsin. "Very pretty. Very sad, I thought. She sat beside his bed and sang to him, and when I came in she was braiding a thin dark cord into the hair at his temple. A charm for sleep, she told me, very prettily. Her patron had given it to her. An old Yllish thing." Lady Tamsin looked at me. "She looked up at me, and she had such a look on her face. As if she'd just realized something. As if she was frightened of her own hands."

"What happened?"

"She left. That same day. Nobody's seen her at court since." Lady Tamsin picked up another cake and looked at it. "The old man was her patron, they said. Bredon. He took her away."



I sat very still in Lady Tamsin's warm crowded room with the cats all around me, and I thought about a girl sitting beside a dying king's bed, stroking his hair, singing. And looking down at her own hands.

*It feels like the knot is holding on to something.*

I did not know, then, sitting in that room, what I would see the next morning, bent over the king's pillow with my lute. I only knew that something cold had settled into my stomach and would not leave.

"Thank you, my lady," I said.

Lady Tamsin looked at me for a long moment. Then she held out the cake.

"Eat something, boy," she said. "You've gone the color of Admiral."

## Chapter Fifty-One

# Renere

Renere is the oldest city in Vintas, and it wants you to know it.

It sits in a bowl of low green hills where three rivers meet, and it has been sitting there for so long that no one remembers who founded it. There were kings in Renere before there was a Vintas, and kings before that, and before that, the stories say, there were things that were not kings but ruled anyway. The city has been burned three times and flooded twice and besieged more times than anyone has bothered to count, and every time it has been rebuilt on top of itself, so that the streets are layered like the pages of a book, the new on top of the old on top of the older still.

You feel it, walking through Renere. You feel the weight of all that history pressing up through the cobblestones. The houses lean together over the narrow streets as if they are whispering secrets. The churches are so old that their stone has gone black and smooth as river rock. And at the center of it all, on a low hill in the middle of the bowl, the royal palace squats like a great grey toad, all towers and battlements and heavy walls, looking down on the city with an air of patient menace.

I rode into Renere on a grey afternoon, with rain threatening and my two guards riding silent behind me. I had never been there before. I did not like it.

\* \* \*

The Maer had given me the names of three people at court whom he trusted. The first was a lady named Tamsin Aerwen, an elderly widow who had been a lady-in-waiting to the old queen and knew everyone and everything. The second was a lord named Petre Ashford, a quiet, bookish man who held a minor post in the treasury and was, the Maer said, the most honest man in Renere, which was not saying a great deal. The third was a physician.

"His name is Kelm," the Maer had told me. "He trained at your University, many years ago. He is one of the king's physicians, though not the chief. He is a good man, and a careful one, and he does not believe that the king's illness is natural." He had paused. "He has written to me twice this spring. Very guarded letters. He is frightened."

The next morning, I went to see Kelm.

He had rooms in a narrow house near the palace, on a street full of apothecaries and bookshops. His door was answered by a servant who looked at my letter of commission for a long time before letting me in. The rooms beyond were small and cluttered and smelled of herbs and vinegar and old paper. Kelm himself was a small grey man in his fifties, thin and stooped, with ink-stained fingers and a pair of spectacles perched on the end of his nose. He looked, more than anything, like a Master of the University. He had the same air of distraction, the same sense that most of his mind was somewhere else.

But when he looked at me, his eyes were sharp.

"You're the Maer's man," he said. "The Ruh."

"Yes."

"The one who caught Caudicus."

"Yes."

He nodded slowly. "Good. Good. I heard about that. Clever work. Very clever." He gestured me to a chair. "Sit, sit. Would you like tea? I have tea. Somewhere." He looked around vaguely at the clutter. "Or wine. I think I have wine."

"I'm fine, thank you."

"Good. Good." He sat down across from me and folded his hands. "You've come about the king."

"Yes."

"The Maer thinks he's being poisoned."

"The Maer thinks he's being killed," I said. "Not necessarily by poison."

Kelm looked at me for a long moment over the top of his spectacles.

"No," he said quietly. "Not by poison. I've tested everything. Every dish, every cup, every bottle of medicine. I've tested his bedclothes and his candles and the water in his washbasin. I've even tested the ink he signs his letters with." He shook his head. "Nothing. Not a trace. Whatever is killing him, it isn't anything I can find."

"But he is being killed."

"Oh, yes." Kelm's voice was very flat. "Yes, he is. I've been a physician for thirty years, and I know what natural illness looks like. This isn't it. He was a strong man, Roderic. Strong as an ox. He hunted every day and drank every night and never had so much as a head cold. And then, last autumn, he simply began to fade." He took off his spectacles and rubbed his eyes. "Not all at once. Slowly. A little weaker every day. A little thinner. A little paler. As if something were drawing the life out of him, one drop at a time."

"Are there any other symptoms? Anything strange?"

Kelm put his spectacles back on and looked at me. He hesitated.

"There is one thing," he said at last. "It's probably nothing. The other physicians laugh at me when I mention it."

"Tell me anyway."

"His hair," Kelm said. "It's been growing. Very fast. Much faster than it should. And it tangles. Every morning, his valet combs it out, and every evening, it's tangled again. Knotted. Snarled up in these little tight knots, like a bird's nest." He shook his head. "The valet cuts them out, and they come back. Every day. The chief physician says it's a symptom of the fever. But I've never seen a fever do that. Not in thirty years."

I sat very still.

"Master Kelm," I said. "I need to see the king."

\* \* \*

It took three days.

Kings, even dying ones, are not easily seen. There are forms to be followed and permissions to be sought and a great many people to be flattered, bribed, or ignored. I had the Maer's letter of commission, which opened some doors. I had Kelm, who opened others. I had Lady Tamsin Aerwen, a tiny, wrinkled, bright-eyed old woman who seemed to find the whole thing enormously entertaining and who opened more doors in an afternoon than I could have opened in a month.

"The king is dying," she said, when I explained what I wanted. "Everyone wants to see him. Half the court is camped outside his door, waiting for him to die so they can be the first to kiss Andrian's ring." She cackled. "Andrian, of all people. The boy can't tell a sword from a spoon. Still. He's the heir, and he'll be king, and everyone wants to be his friend." She looked at me with her bright eyes. "But you don't want to kiss anyone's ring, do you? You want to *look* at the king. Not bow to him. Look."

"Yes, my lady."

"Why?"

I hesitated. Then I told her a part of the truth. "Because I think someone is killing him. And I think I might know how."

Lady Tamsin looked at me for a long moment. Her face, which had been bright and merry, went very still.

"Do you now," she said softly. "Do you, now."

She opened the last door the next morning.

\* \* \*

The king's bedchamber was a great dim room hung with heavy red curtains, lit by a dozen candles and a fire that roared in a hearth big enough to roast an ox. It was stiflingly hot. It smelled of sickness and incense and something else, something sour and wrong that I could not quite place.

There were people everywhere. Physicians in black robes, conferring in low voices by the window. Priests in white, murmuring

prayers at the foot of the bed. Servants, courtiers, guards. A pair of ladies in magnificent dresses, weeping delicately into lace handkerchiefs. A young man with a weak chin and a fine velvet coat, standing by the fire with his hands clasped behind his back, looking bored and frightened in equal measure. Prince Andrian, I assumed.

And in the center of the room, in a great four-posted bed hung with red velvet, the king.

I had seen dying men before. I had seen them in the streets of Tarbean, and in the Medica, and in the Eld. I thought I was prepared for it. I was not.

Roderic of Vintas had been a big man. You could see that in the frame of him, the width of the shoulders and the length of the bones. But there was almost nothing left on that frame now. His skin was stretched over his skull like paper over a lantern, yellow and translucent. His eyes were sunk deep in their sockets. His hands, lying on the red coverlet, were claws.

And his hair.

It spread out across the pillows around his head like a dark stain. It was long, much longer than a man's hair should be, long enough to reach his waist if he had been standing. It was grey and dark in streaks. And it was knotted.

Not tangled. Knotted. I saw it the moment I came close enough to see clearly. Among the long grey strands, scattered through it like burrs in a dog's coat, there were small tight knots. Dozens of them. Some were only a few hairs, twisted around each other. Some were larger, whole locks drawn into intricate patterns that made my eyes ache.

I knew those patterns. I had seen them on the Dellers' cloth, and on the cord around Denna's wrist. I had tied some of them myself, in the Grey Man, with Denna's hands guiding mine.

They were Yllish.

\* \* \*

Kelm had arranged for me to be introduced as a musician, sent by the Maer to play for the king's comfort. It was not unusual. Dying men

often asked for music. I had my lute with me, and I sat down on a stool at the foot of the bed, and I played.

I played softly. Old songs, gentle ones. Lullabies and love songs and the slow sad ballads that people sing at wakes. The priests frowned at me. The physicians ignored me. The weeping ladies stopped weeping and listened. Prince Andrian turned from the fire and looked at me for a long moment, then turned back.

And while I played, I looked at the knots.

It was hard. They were small, and there were so many of them, and they were half hidden in the tangled mass of hair. But I had spent months learning to read the Dellers' cloth, and before that, days learning from Denna. I knew what to look for.

Most of the knots were meaningless. Or not meaningless, exactly, but empty. Decoys. Knots that looked like writing but said nothing, the way a child's scribble looks like writing but is not. They were there to confuse. To hide the real ones.

But the real ones were there. I found them, one by one, as I played. Three of them, woven deep into the hair near the king's scalp, so close to the skin that no valet's comb could reach them. They were tiny, and very tight, and very old-looking, as if they had been there for a long time.

The first said *ending*. I knew that one. It was one of the first Denna had taught me.

The second said *slowly*. Or something like it. *A little at a time. Drop by drop.*

And the third was a name.

I could not read it. It was too complex, too long, a whole cluster of knots woven together into something that was almost a sculpture. But I knew what it was. I knew it the way I had known my own name when the Sleeper spoke it. It was the shape of a man. It was Roderic.

Not the name *Roderic*. The name that was him.

Someone had written his true name into his hair, in knots. And beside it, they had written *ending*, and *slowly*.

And his hair was doing what it said.

\* \* \*

I finished the song I was playing. I began another. My fingers moved on the strings without my thinking about them. I was not thinking about the music. I was thinking about the knots.

Who had tied them? Not Bredon. He could not have gotten close enough. The king's bedchamber was guarded day and night, and the king's hair was combed every morning by his valet. Whoever had tied those knots had been close to the king. Very close. Close enough to touch his hair without anyone thinking it strange.

A valet. A barber. A lover. A physician.

I looked around the room. At the black-robed physicians by the window. At the priests. At the servants. At the weeping ladies.

At Prince Andrian, standing by the fire.

He was looking at me again. Our eyes met, across the room, and he did not look away. There was something in his face I had not expected. Not boredom. Not fear.

Knowledge.

He knew. He knew what the knots were. And he knew that I knew.

I held his gaze for a long moment. Then he turned away, back to the fire, and I looked down at my lute and kept playing.

\* \* \*

When I finished, a physician came and told me that the king needed to rest, and that I should go. I rose and bowed and gathered up my lute. As I passed the fire, Prince Andrian spoke without turning around.

"You play very well," he said.

"Thank you, your highness."

"My father always loved music. He used to have musicians play for him every night. Before." He was quiet for a moment. "You looked at his hair."

I stopped. I did not answer.

"Everyone looks at his hair," said Andrian. "It's grotesque, isn't it? Like something from a story. But you looked at it differently. You



looked at it as if you could read it."

He turned from the fire and looked at me. He was a young man, only a little older than me, with a weak chin and pale eyes and a pleasant, forgettable face. But his eyes were not forgettable. They were very frightened, and very steady.

"Can you?" he said.

I looked at him for a long moment. I thought about lying. I thought about it very seriously.

"Yes," I said. "Some of it."

"What does it say?"

"It says he's dying. Slowly. On purpose."

Andrian closed his eyes. For a long moment he did not move. Then he opened them again.

"Can you stop it?"

"I don't know. Maybe. If I could get close enough. If I had time."

"You'll have time," said Andrian. He glanced at the physicians by the window, the priests at the foot of the bed. "I'll see to it. Come back tonight. After midnight. There's a door in the east wall of the palace garden, behind the yew hedge. I'll leave it unlocked."

"Your highness—"

"Please." His voice cracked, very slightly. "He's my father. He's not a good man, or a wise one, or even a very kind one. But he's my father. And I don't want him to die like this." He looked at me. "Please."

I looked at him. At his weak chin and his frightened eyes.

"After midnight," I said. "I'll be there."

\* \* \*

I did not know, then, that I would never keep that appointment. I did not know that Prince Andrian of Vintas, heir to the throne, would be dead before midnight came.

I only knew that someone had written a king's name in his hair, and that the knots were tied by a hand I thought I recognized. Small and precise and very neat, with a particular way of doubling back on the loops that I had seen before. On the Dellers' cloth. On the cord she

wore in her hair.

On the knot she had left for me on my table, in the Maer's palace,  
the morning she went away.

## Chapter Fifty-Two

# The Yew Hedge

I spent the rest of that afternoon in my rooms at the inn the Maer had arranged for me, a grand old place called the Seven Swans, and I did not play my lute and I did not eat and I did not sit still.

I paced. Back and forth across the thick carpet, from the window to the door and back again, with my hands clasped behind my back the way the Maer clasped his. My two guards sat in the outer room and listened to me pace and did not say anything. They were very good at not saying anything.

I was thinking about the knots.

I had told myself, walking back from the palace, that I was wrong. That I had imagined it. That one knot looks very like another, and a doubled loop is only a doubled loop, and there must be a hundred people in the world who tie Yllish knots with that same small neat precision.

But I did not believe it. I had spent days with Denna, in the Grey Man, watching her hands. I knew the way she tied a knot the way I knew the way she held a harp, or tilted her head when she listened, or said my name. I knew it the way you know a friend's handwriting on a letter before you have read a single word.

She had tied those knots. The ones in the king's hair. The *ending* and the *slowly* and the name.

I did not know how. I did not know when. I did not know if she had known what she was doing. But her hands had tied them.

And I thought I knew why she had not known. Because I remembered something she had said, sitting with me in the Grey Man, her fingers moving through a cord of knots. *He's been teaching me to read them. So I can write the song properly.*

Teaching. Reading. Writing.

What had he given her to practice on? What names had he set her to tying, over and over, in the long quiet evenings, until her hands knew the shapes as well as her voice knew the notes? Had he told her they were names from the old stories? Heroes and kings from the Creation War, to be woven into the fabric of her song?

And then taken the cords she had tied, and carried them somewhere, and put them where they would do their work?

I stopped pacing. I stood in the middle of the room and pressed my hands against my eyes, hard, until I saw colors.

*Some stories have to end, he had said, so that others can begin.*

\* \* \*

At sunset, Lady Tamsin sent for me.

She received me in her apartments in the old wing of the palace, a warren of small crowded rooms full of cats and cushions and portraits of people who had been dead for a hundred years. She was sitting by the fire in a chair much too large for her, with a cat in her lap and a glass of something dark and sweet in her hand. She did not offer me any.

"You saw the king this morning," she said.

"Yes, my lady."

"And you spoke to the prince."

I hesitated. "Yes."

"What did he say to you?"

I did not answer.

Lady Tamsin looked at me with her bright old eyes. Then she smiled. It was not a pleasant smile.

"Very good," she said. "Very discreet. The Maer chose well." She sipped her drink. "I'll tell you what I know, then, since you won't tell me what you know. The prince has been asking questions. Quiet ones.

About his father's illness, and about the deaths of the heirs. He has been asking them for some time, and he has been asking the wrong people." She stroked the cat. "This afternoon, he asked one of them too many."

I went cold. "What do you mean?"

"I mean that Prince Andrian has gone riding." Lady Tamsin's voice was very flat. "He went out an hour ago, alone, on his favorite horse. He told his grooms he wanted to clear his head. He rode out of the city toward the hills." She paused. "He has not come back."

"It's only been an hour."

"It's been an hour and a half. And the sun has set. And Andrian is afraid of the dark; he has been since he was a child. He never rides after sunset. Never." She looked at me. "Someone should look for him. Someone who is not the royal guard, because the royal guard answers to the captain of the guard, and the captain of the guard is Baron Jakis's cousin."

I was already on my feet.

"Which way did he go?"

"The north road. Toward the Hollow Hills." Lady Tamsin set down her glass. "Take a lantern. And your sword. And for God's sake, boy, be careful."

\* \* \*

I found him a little before midnight.

I had ridden out of the city at a gallop, with my two guards pounding along behind me, their lanterns swinging wildly on their poles. We took the north road into the hills. It was a clear night, cold and still, with a thin moon riding high and the stars very bright. The road wound up through the low green hills, past farms and orchards, and then higher, into rougher country where the hills were steep and rocky and cut through with narrow ravines.

We found his horse first. It was standing at the side of the road near the top of a steep rise, its reins trailing, its saddle empty. It was trembling. When I rode up beside it, it shied away and rolled its eyes, and I saw that its flanks were streaked with sweat and that there was

foam at its mouth.

I dismounted and caught its bridle and calmed it as best I could. And as I held the bridle, I felt something under my fingers. A roughness on the leather, just behind the bit.

I held my lantern close and looked.

It was a knot. A tiny knot, tied in a thread so fine and so dark it was almost invisible, wound around the leather of the bridle. I could barely see it. But I could feel it. The faint tightening of the air. The sense of something reaching out and catching hold.

I did not need to read it. I knew what it said.

\* \* \*

We found Andrian at the bottom of the ravine beside the road.

He was lying on his back among the rocks, forty feet below. His arms were flung out to either side. His face was turned up toward the stars. His eyes were open.

His neck was broken.

My guards climbed down to him with ropes and lanterns. I did not go with them. I stood at the edge of the ravine and looked down at the small still shape at the bottom, lit by the swinging lanterns, and I did not move.

It looked like an accident. It looked exactly like an accident. A young man, riding alone at night, on a road he did not know well. His horse shied at something in the dark, a fox or an owl or a shadow. He was thrown. He fell. He died.

It happens. Everyone would say so. It happens every day.

I held the bridle of his horse in my hand and felt the knot beneath my fingers, and I thought about a young man with a weak chin and frightened eyes, standing by the fire in his father's bedchamber. *Please. He's my father.*

I thought about the door in the east wall of the palace garden, behind the yew hedge. Unlocked, now, and waiting for a visitor who would never come, to meet a prince who would never be there.

And I thought about the knot. Small and neat and precise, with a particular way of doubling back on the loops.

I closed my eyes.

\* \* \*

We brought him back to the city on his own horse, wrapped in my cloak. We came in through the north gate an hour after midnight, and the guards on the gate took one look at what we were carrying and began to shout, and in a quarter of an hour the whole city was awake.

By dawn, everyone knew. The prince was dead. Thrown from his horse on the north road, in the dark. A terrible accident. A tragedy.

By noon, everyone knew something else. The king was dying, and the prince was dead, and the next in line for the throne was an old uncle of the king's, a duke of eighty years who lived in a castle on the coast and had not left his bed in three years. And after him, a pair of young cousins, twin boys of six. And after them—

Ambrose Jakis.

Fourth in line. And the three ahead of him were a dying old man and two small children.

I did not go back to Lady Tamsin's rooms that day. I did not go to see Kelm, or Petre Ashford, or anyone else. I sat in my rooms at the Seven Swans with the bridle of Andrian's horse in my lap, and I cut the knot out of the leather with the point of my knife, very carefully, and held it up to the light.

It was so small. Smaller than my smallest fingernail. A few threads of dark silk, looped and twisted around each other.

I could read it now, in the daylight, holding it close to my eye. *Fear*. That was the first knot. *Dark*. The second. *Fall*.

And woven through it, so fine I could barely see it, a name. The shape of a young man with a weak chin and frightened eyes.

I sat there for a long time, holding it. Then I took out the little knot Denna had left me, the one that said *forgive*, and I held them side by side.

The loops doubled back on themselves in exactly the same way.

\* \* \*

That evening, I had a visitor.

He came to the Seven Swans at sunset, with a train of servants and guards behind him, and he did not knock. He simply walked into my rooms as if they were his own, and my two guards stood up and put their hands on their swords, and he looked at them with an expression of such utter contempt that they sat down again.

He was taller than I remembered. Or perhaps he only seemed taller. He was dressed in black, from head to foot, black velvet and black silk and black leather, the colors of mourning. But the black was cut so finely and fit so well that it did not look like mourning. It looked like a crown.

"Hello, Ruh," said Ambrose Jakis.

I did not stand. I sat in my chair by the window with the bridle in my lap and looked at him.

"Ambrose," I said.

"Lord Ambrose, now. My father was made a duke last span, did you hear? Duke of Hallowmere. So I'm a lord in my own right." He smiled. "And very soon, perhaps, something more."

"Fourth in line."

"Fourth in line." He savored the words. "An old man who can't get out of bed. And two little boys." He shook his head sadly. "It's a tragedy, really. So much death in one family. Everyone is saying so."

"Everyone," I said, "is right."

He looked at me. His smile did not falter. But something in his eyes changed. Something sharpened.

"I heard you found my cousin," he said. "On the north road. I heard you brought him home." He came a little closer. "That was kind of you. Very kind. I'll have to thank you properly, sometime."

"There's no need."

"Oh, but there is. There is." He looked down at the bridle in my lap. At the small hole in the leather where the knot had been. Something moved in his face, very quickly, and was gone. "I also heard you visited the king. Played for him. Looked at his hair." He tilted his head. "That was very bold of you. A Ruh, in the king's bedchamber. People are talking."



"People always talk."

"They do. They do." He leaned down, close, the way he had on the steps of the Mains, in the snow. I could smell the wine on his breath, and the heavy sweet perfume. "Let me tell you what they're saying, Ruh. They're saying that a Ruh came to Renere, sent by the Maer of Severen, who everyone knows has ambitions of his own. They're saying that this Ruh went to the king's bedchamber and sat at his bedside and played strange songs, and that the king got worse afterward. They're saying that this Ruh spoke to the prince alone, and that an hour later, the prince rode out to his death." He smiled. "They're saying that Ruh are thieves and liars and poisoners, and that the Maer should be very careful about the company he keeps."

I did not say anything. I looked at him.

"Leave Renere," Ambrose said softly. "Tonight. Go back to Severen, to your Maer, and tell him that the court is no place for his pet musician. And if you're wise, go further than that. Go back to your University." He paused. "Oh, wait. I forgot. You can't."

He straightened up. He smiled down at me.

"Leave," he said, "or I'll make sure that everyone in Renere knows exactly what you are. And then we'll see how long you last."

He turned and walked out. His servants and his guards trailed after him. The door closed.

I sat in my chair by the window and looked at the door for a long time.

Then I looked down at the bridle in my lap, and the two small knots in my hand. The one that had killed a prince, and the one that said *forgive*.

I did not leave Renere that night.

It was the first of many mistakes I made in that city. But it was not the worst.

## Chapter Fifty-Three

# The Unknotting

The door behind the yew hedge was still unlocked.

I had not truly expected it to be. Andrian had left it open for me, but Andrian was dead, and the dead do not keep their appointments, and someone in the palace must surely have noticed an unlocked door in the garden wall and bolted it. But when I came through the dark streets of Renere two nights after the prince's death, with my cloak drawn close and my face hidden in its hood, and slipped down the narrow alley that ran along the eastern wall of the palace garden, I found the door behind its screen of black yew exactly as he had said. Closed, but not locked. It swung open at my touch without a sound. Someone had oiled the hinges.

I stood in the doorway for a long moment, looking into the dark garden. I thought about a young man with a weak chin, walking out here in the afternoon while his father lay dying, and quietly oiling the hinges of a door so that a stranger could come in the night and try to save him.

Then I stepped through and closed it behind me.

\* \* \*

Kelm was waiting for me by the fountain. He was wrapped in a dark cloak, and his spectacles glinted in the thin moonlight, and he was shaking.

"You came," he whispered.

"I said I would."

"They're saying things about you. In the palace. Terrible things." He clutched at my arm. "They're saying you killed the prince. That you bewitched his horse. Duke Jakis has been talking to the captain of the guard all day. They're going to arrest you, Kvothe. Tomorrow, I think. Maybe tonight."

"Then we'd better be quick."

He stared at me. Then he laughed, a thin shaky sound. "You're mad," he said. "The Maer said you were clever. He didn't say you were mad."

"The Maer is very diplomatic."

Kelm shook his head. But he let go of my arm and turned and led me through the garden, along a gravel path between dark hedges, to a small door set low in the palace wall. He had a key. He unlocked it with shaking fingers and we slipped inside.

\* \* \*

We went up through the servants' passages, narrow dark corridors that ran behind the walls of the palace like the veins beneath skin. Kelm knew them well. He had been the king's physician for eleven years, and in that time, he told me in a whisper, he had learned every hidden stair and back corridor in the royal apartments.

"The chief physician goes to bed at midnight," he murmured as we climbed. "The priests leave at one. After that, there's only the night nurse and the guards at the door. The nurse is a friend. She'll let us in by the dressing room and say nothing."

"And the guards?"

"The guards stand outside the main door. They don't come in unless someone calls." He glanced back at me. "Don't make anyone call."

We came out at last into a small dim room hung with the king's robes and smelling of cedar and camphor. A stout grey woman in a white apron was waiting there. She looked at me with sharp suspicious eyes, then at Kelm, and then she nodded once, curtly, and opened the door into the bedchamber.

It was just as I remembered it. The great red bed. The roaring fire. The heat and the smell of sickness. But it was empty of people now, the physicians and priests and courtiers gone to their beds, and in the dim firelight it looked less like a king's chamber than like a tomb.

Roderic lay in the center of the bed, exactly as he had lain before. His eyes were closed. His breathing was very shallow. His hair spread out across the pillows around him, long and grey and knotted.

It was longer than before. Much longer. It had grown in two days more than it should have grown in a year. It spilled off the pillows and down the sides of the bed and onto the floor, a great grey tangled mass, full of knots.

"It's worse," Kelm whispered. "Since the prince died. It's been growing so fast. The valet cut it this morning, and by noon it had grown back." He looked at me. "What is it? What's happening to him?"

"His name is being written," I said. "In his own hair. And the words are saying *end*."

\* \* \*

I knelt beside the bed. I pushed back my sleeves. I took a candle from the bedside table and held it close, and I began to search through the king's hair for the three knots I had found before.

It took a long time. There were so many knots now. Hundreds of them. Most were empty, decoys, meaningless tangles meant to hide the true ones. But the true ones had grown too. When I found them at last, deep in the hair near the king's scalp, they were larger than before. More complex. The knot that said *ending* had spread out into a great sprawling tangle, looping around itself again and again, like a vine strangling a tree.

And the name. The name was there, at the center of it all. Woven so tight and so deep that it seemed to be part of his skull.

I looked at it for a long time. I tried to read it. I could not. It was too complex, too intricate, too much. It was like trying to read a whole book written on the head of a pin.

"Can you untie it?" Kelm whispered.

"I don't know."

"You have to try. Please. He's dying. He'll be dead by morning."

I looked at the knots. At the tight, neat, precise loops, doubling back on themselves in that particular way.

I thought about Denna, in the Grey Man, her fingers moving through a cord. *It feels like the knot is holding on to something. Like it's reaching out and catching hold of something and not letting go.*

I thought about what I had told her, sitting on the wall at the edge of the cliff in Severen. *Everything that's tied can be untied.*

I did not know if that was true. I had said it because I wanted it to be true. Because I could not bear the thought that it was not.

But I reached out anyway. And I took hold of the knot that said *ending*. And I began to try.

\* \* \*

I cannot tell you how long I worked. Hours. Kelm said later it was nearly four hours, but it did not feel like hours. It felt like no time at all, and it felt like years.

I did not try to untie the knot with my fingers. I tried that first, and it was useless; the hairs were too fine, the loops too tight, and every time I thought I had found an end, it slipped away from me and vanished back into the tangle. I tried cutting a single strand, very carefully, with the point of my knife, and the knife slid off the hair as if it were made of steel.

So I stopped trying to untie it. I stopped trying to do anything to it at all. I let my mind go still, the way I had in the round room at the top of the Rookery, the way I had in the Cellarage when I sang the Sleeper to sleep. I did not reach for the knot. I did not want anything from it. I simply held it, the way you might hold a bird, and listened.

And after a while, I heard it.

It was not like hearing stone. Stone says no. This was something else. This was a voice saying *yes*. Over and over, very softly, very insistently. *Yes. End. Yes. End. Yes. Slowly. Yes.*

It was a voice that had been told what to say, and was saying it, and could not stop.

I listened to it for a long time. I listened until I understood it. Not the words, but the shape. The way it was bent. The way it had been made to say something it did not want to say.

Because it did not want to. I could feel that. The hair did not want to kill its king. It was his hair. It had grown from his body. It had been part of him since he was born. It had been bent and twisted and knotted into a shape that said *end*, and it was saying it, because it had to. But it did not want to.

I opened my mouth. I did not know what I was going to say. I had no name for this, no word for it. I did not know the name of hair, or of knots, or of ending.

But I knew what it felt like to be bound. To be tied into a shape you did not choose. To be made to say *yes* when every part of you wanted to say *no*.

I began to hum.

\* \* \*

It was not a song. It was barely a tune. It was the stone's *no*, the long slow patient *no* that I had learned in the round room and sung to the Sleeper in the dark. But it was softer than that, gentler. It was not *no* to the whole world. It was *no* to one thing. One small thing. One word, knotted into a king's hair by a girl who had not known what she was doing.

*No*, I hummed. *No, you don't have to. No, you're not what they made you. No, you can let go.*

I felt the knot shift under my fingers.

It was very small. The barest movement, like a sleeping animal stirring. But I felt it. One loop, one tiny loop, deep in the heart of the tangle, loosened. Just a little.

I kept humming. I held the knot in my fingers and hummed to it, softly, the way you would hum to a frightened child. *No. No. You can let go now. It's all right. You can let go.*

Another loop loosened. And another.

And then, slowly, like ice melting in spring, the knot that said *ending* began to come apart.

\* \* \*

It did not come apart all at once. It came apart loop by loop, strand by strand, over what felt like hours. I kept humming the whole time. My voice grew hoarse, and then it cracked, and then it was barely a whisper. But I kept humming. I did not dare stop.

At last, the knot was gone. There was only hair in my hand. Long grey strands, smooth and straight, lying loose across my palm.

I let go. I sat back on my heels. My whole body was shaking. My hands were numb. My throat felt as if I had swallowed a handful of gravel.

"Did it work?" Kelm whispered.

I looked at the king.

He was still lying in the center of the great red bed, with his eyes closed. He was still thin and yellow and terrible. But his breathing had changed. It was deeper. Slower. Easier.

And as I watched, his eyes opened.

\* \* \*

He looked at me. His eyes were pale grey and very clear. They were not the eyes of a dying man. They were the eyes of a king.

"Who are you?" he said. His voice was a thread, barely audible. But it was steady.

"A musician, your majesty. Sent by the Maer of Severen."

"Alveron." Something moved in his face. It might have been a smile. "Clever Alveron. Always sending me clever things." He closed his eyes, then opened them again. "I've been dreaming. A long time. Dreaming of being tied. Tied up in ropes, very tight. Couldn't move. Couldn't speak." He looked at me. "Were you the one who untied me?"

"Only one of the ropes, your majesty. There are others."

"Yes. I can feel them." He was quiet for a moment. "I'm still dying. Aren't I?"

I did not answer. I did not have to.

"Yes," said Roderic. "I thought so. But it's different now. Before, it was like being drowned. Slowly. Dragged down into the dark by

something I couldn't see." He breathed in, slowly. "Now it's just dying. Just an old man, dying. That's—" He smiled faintly. "That's better. Thank you."

"Your majesty," I said. "Who did this to you? Do you know?"

He looked at me for a long moment. His pale eyes were very steady.

"My son is dead," he said. "Isn't he? Andrian."

I hesitated. Then I nodded.

"I dreamed it," said the king. "I dreamed him falling." He closed his eyes. A tear slid out from beneath one lid and ran down into the grey hair at his temple. "He was a foolish boy. Weak. I was always hard on him. Too hard." He opened his eyes again. "Who did this? You ask me who did this?"

"Yes, your majesty."

"The same one who did it to my son. And my cousins. And my uncle. And my nephew." His voice was growing fainter. "An old man. With a stick. He came to court years ago. Played tak with my father. Everyone loved him." His lips twisted. "I loved him. He taught me to play when I was a boy. He used to sit with me in the garden and tell me stories about the old kings."

"Bredon," I said.

"Is that what he calls himself now?" Roderic's eyes were drifting closed. "He had another name, when I was a boy. Something else. I can't remember." He was quiet for a long moment. Then his eyes opened again, suddenly, and fixed on mine. "He wants the throne. Not for himself. For the Jakis boy. For Ambrose. Because Ambrose is—"

He stopped. His breath caught.

"Because Ambrose is what, your majesty?"

Roderic looked at me. His pale grey eyes were very wide.

"Because Ambrose is of the line," he whispered. "The old line. On his mother's side. A very distant branch. Very thin. Very weak." He gripped my wrist with his clawed hand, and his grip was surprisingly strong. "Not strong enough to open it. Not alone. But strong enough to hold the key. Strong enough to carry it to the door."



And a king can go anywhere. A king can command anyone." His grip tightened. "A king can make the true heir come."

I stared at him.

"Ambrose is a Lackless?"

"A drop. A single drop. From four hundred years ago." Roderic's voice was fading. "But a drop is enough. For a key." His grip loosened. His eyes began to close. "Stop him, musician. Whoever you are. Stop the old man. Stop the Jakis boy. Don't let them—"

He did not finish. His hand fell away from my wrist. His eyes closed.

He did not open them again.

\* \* \*

Kelm was weeping. The night nurse was weeping. I was not weeping. I was sitting on my heels beside the king's bed, with a handful of loose grey hair in my lap, staring at the dead man's face.

*Ambrose is of the line.*

And then the door of the bedchamber burst open.

I heard the crash of it before I saw it. I turned my head, very slowly, as if I were moving through water. The main door of the king's chamber had been flung back so hard it struck the wall. And in the doorway, lit from behind by the lanterns in the corridor, there were men. Guards, in the livery of the royal house. A dozen of them. With swords drawn.

And at their head, dressed all in black, with a smile on his face that I will remember until the day I die, Ambrose Jakis.

"There he is," said Ambrose. His voice was very loud in the silent room. "There's the Ruh. Kneeling at the king's bedside, with the king's hair in his hands." He looked at the bed. At the still yellow face on the pillow. His smile widened. "Oh," he said. "Oh, dear. It looks as though we're too late."

He looked at me.

"Arrest him," he said. "For the murder of the king."

## Chapter Fifty-Four

# Flight

There is a moment, in any fight, when the world goes very slow.

I have felt it many times. In the alleys of Tarbean, when a man with a knife stepped out of the shadows. In the Eld, when the bandits came at us through the trees. In Ademre, on the practice grounds, when Vashet's sword came whistling toward my face and I had one heartbeat to decide which way to move.

It is not that time stops. It is that you begin to see it. Every grain of it. Every drop. The world does not slow down so much as open up, like a flower, and you can see every petal of it, every vein in every leaf.

I felt it now, kneeling beside the dead king's bed with a handful of grey hair in my lap and a dozen guards in the doorway.

I saw Ambrose's smile. I saw the lantern light gleaming on the guards' drawn swords. I saw the captain at the front, a big red-bearded man with a scar through one eyebrow, taking a step forward into the room. I saw Kelm, frozen by the window with his hand over his mouth. I saw the night nurse, backing slowly toward the dressing room door.

I saw the fire, roaring in the great hearth. A dozen candles, burning in their sconces around the room. And the door to the dressing room, standing half open behind the nurse, leading back to the servants' passages.

I let the grey hair fall from my hands. I rose to my feet.

"I didn't kill him," I said.

"Of course you didn't," said Ambrose. "You just happened to be kneeling at his bedside in the middle of the night, when no one was supposed to be here, with his hair in your hands, when he died." He laughed. "Take him."

The guards came forward.

\* \* \*

I did not draw my sword. That was the first thing I decided, in that slow bright moment. There were twelve of them, and they were the king's guards, and they had done nothing wrong except follow the orders of the wrong man. I did not want to kill them.

So instead, I reached for the fire.

I had not done sympathy in anger for a long time. Not since Ambrose, in the Commons, the day I called the wind. I had been careful since then, very careful, the way you are careful with a dog that has bitten you once. But I did it now. I did it without thinking.

I split my mind. One part of me held the link, the binding between the great fire in the hearth and the dozen candles around the room. The other part of me reached for the heat.

And I pulled.

Every candle in the room flared at once. Not a little. A great deal. Each flame shot up two feet high, white and roaring, like a torch dipped in oil. The room went bright as noon. Brighter. So bright that the guards cried out and threw their arms over their eyes.

And then, all at once, I let go. And every candle went out.

The fire in the hearth went out too. I had pulled too much from it; it had nothing left. The room plunged into darkness so sudden and so total that it was like being struck blind.

I was already moving.

\* \* \*

I had the whole room in my head. I had seen it in that slow bright moment, every chair and table and curtain, every step between me and the dressing room door. I crossed the floor in five strides, in the pitch dark, while the guards shouted and stumbled and crashed into each

other behind me. I found the door by memory. I went through it.

The nurse was there, in the dark of the dressing room. I felt her hand on my arm.

"This way," she hissed. "Quick."

She pulled me through the dark, through the hanging robes, to the narrow door at the back that led into the servants' passages. She pushed me through it.

"Left," she said. "Then down. Then right at the bottom. It'll take you to the laundry. The laundry door opens on the kitchen yard." She squeezed my arm. "God go with you, lad."

"Come with me."

"Me? I'm too old to run." She laughed, a short hard sound. "Besides, they'll need someone to tell them which way you went. And I'll tell them wrong." She pushed me again. "Go!"

I went.

\* \* \*

Left. Then down. The servants' stairs were narrow and steep and utterly dark. I went down them by feel, my hand trailing along the rough stone wall, my feet finding each step by instinct. Behind me, far above, I could hear shouting. Doors slamming. Running feet.

At the bottom, I turned right. A long narrow corridor, smelling of soap and wet linen. I ran along it. At the end, there was a door, and beyond the door a great low room full of steam and copper tubs and lines of washing hanging from the ceiling like ghosts.

The laundry. There was a door at the far end, with a crack of moonlight showing beneath it. I ran for it.

It opened before I reached it.

My guard was standing there. One of the two the Maer had sent with me. His name was Harl. He was a big quiet man with a broken nose and a grizzled beard, and in all the days we had ridden together he had never said more than ten words to me at a time.

He had his sword drawn. He looked past me, into the laundry, and his face was grim.

"Heard the shouting," he said. "Figured you'd come out this way. Corrin's with the horses. Round the back of the kitchen yard." He jerked his head. "Go on."

"Come with me."

"No. They'll be right behind you. Someone's got to hold the door." He stepped past me into the laundry and turned to face the corridor. "Go on, sir. The Maer'd have my hide if I let you get caught."

"Harl—"

"Go."

I went. I ran out into the kitchen yard, into the cold moonlight, and I did not look back. I heard the shouting behind me grow louder. I heard the clash of steel. I heard a man cry out.

I did not know, then, whose voice it was. I told myself it was one of the palace guards. I told myself that Harl was a soldier, a veteran of a dozen campaigns, and that he could hold a narrow door against a dozen men for as long as it took.

I found out later that he held it for nearly a quarter of an hour. Long enough for me to reach the horses. Long enough for Corrin and me to ride out through the kitchen gate and into the dark streets of Renere. Long enough for us to lose ourselves in the maze of alleys and lanes around the palace hill.

He killed three of them before they brought him down.

I never learned if he had a family. I never learned where he was from, or why he had become a soldier, or whether he liked music. I knew him for eleven days, and in all that time he said perhaps a hundred words to me. And then he died holding a door so I could run.

I have thought about him often, over the years. I have thought about all the people who died so I could run. There are more of them than I like to count.

\* \* \*

Corrin and I rode through the dark streets until the horses were blown. Then we left them in an alley and went on foot. Corrin knew Renere; he had served in the city guard as a young man, before he went to work for the Maer. He led me through a part of the city I had never seen,

down by the rivers, where the streets were narrow and crooked and the houses leaned together overhead so that you could barely see the sky.

"Lady Tamsin," I said, as we ran. "We need to get to Lady Tamsin."

"She's in the palace. We can't get back in."

"Then Kelm. Or Petre Ashford."

"Kelm'll be arrested by now. He was in the room." Corrin shook his head. "And Ashford's rooms are in the treasury. That's in the palace too." He looked at me. "There's nobody, sir. We're on our own."

"Then we need to get out of the city."

"The gates'll be shut. They'll have shut them the moment the king died." He was quiet for a moment, thinking. "But there's the rivers. Three of them. They meet down at the Weir, south of the old market. Boats go out at dawn, carrying goods down to the coast. If we can get on one—"

"Can we?"

"Maybe. If we can pay."

I touched the purse at my belt. The Maer's purse, still heavy with silver.

"We can pay," I said.

\* \* \*

We hid until dawn in a boathouse by the Weir, among coils of rope and stacks of oars and the smell of river mud and tar. Neither of us slept. We sat in the dark and listened to the bells of Renere ringing across the city, one after another, a great slow tolling that went on and on. The death knell. The king was dead.

And beneath the bells, closer, the sound of men searching. Tramping boots on cobblestones. Voices calling. Doors being pounded on. Once, very close, a group of guards went past the boathouse door, and I heard one of them say *the Ruh* and another say *red hair, can't miss him*, and I put my hand on Caesura's hilt and held my breath until they had gone.

When the sky began to grey, Corrin went out. He was gone a long time. When he came back, his face was grim.

"There's a barge," he said. "Going downriver to Sevván and then out to the coast. Carrying wool. The bargemaster will take us, for a price." He paused. "A big price."

"Pay it."

"There's more." Corrin hesitated. "They're saying things, sir. In the market. Everyone's talking about it." He looked at me. "They're saying the Maer's Ruh killed the king. With witchcraft. They're saying you sang him to death. That you bewitched the prince's horse and then went to the king's bed in the night and pulled his hair out by the roots and sang a song over him until his heart stopped."

I did not say anything.

"They're saying the Maer sent you," Corrin went on quietly. "To clear the way for himself. They're saying the Maer wants the throne." He looked at me. "Duke Jakis has already called for the Maer's arrest. For treason."

I closed my eyes.

This was it, then. The shape of the board. I had been so busy looking at the knots in the king's hair that I had not seen the pattern Bredon was building all around me. He had not needed to kill me. He had not needed to stop me. He had only needed me to come to Renere and do exactly what I did. Go to the king's bedside. Try to save him. Be found there, with his hair in my hands, when he died.

And now I was the Ruh who had killed the king. And the Maer, who had sent me, was a traitor. And Duke Jakis, whose son was fourth in line for the throne, was the only man in Vintas who could be trusted.

It was beautiful. It was the most beautiful move I had ever seen.

And I had played my part in it perfectly.

\* \* \*

We got on the barge at dawn. The bargemaster was a sour, narrow-faced woman named Brisk who took the Maer's silver without counting it and told us to get down in the hold among the wool bales and not come out until she said so. We got down in the hold. It was dark and hot and smelled of sheep. We lay among the bales and listened to the river slapping against the hull and the bargemaster

shouting orders and the long slow creak of the sweeps as the barge pushed off from the Weir and began to move downstream.

We did not come out until noon. By then, Renere was far behind us.

I climbed up on deck and stood at the stern and looked back. The river was wide and brown and slow, winding between low green hills. Far behind us, on the horizon, I could just see a smudge of grey that might have been the city. Or might have been cloud.

Corrin came and stood beside me. He did not say anything for a long time.

"What now, sir?" he said at last.

I thought about it. I thought about the Maer, in Severen, with Duke Jakis calling for his arrest. I thought about Meluan, heavy with child, in her green room. I thought about Harl, dead in the laundry door. I thought about Kelm, and the night nurse, and Lady Tamsin, and everyone else in Renere who had helped me and who would now pay for it.

I thought about Denna, somewhere out there, with a box and a knot and a man who could stop her heart.

And I thought about the king, lying in his great red bed, gripping my wrist with his clawed hand. *Ambrose is of the line. A drop is enough. For a key.*

"You go back to Severen," I said. "To the Maer. Tell him everything. Tell him what happened in Renere, and what the king said to me before he died. Tell him about Ambrose. Tell him to prepare."

"Prepare for what?"

"War," I said. "It's coming. Duke Jakis will put his son on the throne. The old duke and the twins will die, one way or another. And when Ambrose is king, he'll come for the Maer. For Severen. For Meluan." I looked at him. "Tell the Maer to protect her. Whatever else happens. Tell him to keep her safe."

"And you?"

I looked out over the brown river, at the hills rolling away to the south. Somewhere beyond them, a long way off, was the sea. And



beyond the sea, far to the west, was Tarbean.

"I need to find someone," I said. "An old man. A storyteller. He knows something I need to know."

"Where?"

"Tarbean."

Corrin stared at me. "Tarbean? That's the other side of the world."

"Not quite. But nearly." I smiled faintly. "I've been there before. I know my way around."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he shook his head, slowly, the way the Maer did when I said something he did not understand.

"You're a strange one, sir," he said.

"So I'm told."

\* \* \*

Corrin left the barge at Sevvan, three days downriver, to ride back north to Severen. I stayed on until the coast. At the mouth of the river there was a small, dirty port town called Hallow's End, and there I bought passage on a merchant ship bound west along the coast, for Tarbean.

I stood at the rail as the ship pulled out of the harbor. The wind was fresh, and the sails bellied out, and the land fell away behind us, green and brown and hazy in the afternoon light.

I lit Kilvin's candle that night, in my tiny cabin below decks. It burned yellow for a long time. And then, very late, just as I was about to snuff it, it flickered blue. Only for a moment. A single heartbeat.

Somewhere, far away, something had happened. Something cold.

I sat on my narrow bunk in the dark, with the ship rocking beneath me and the candle burning yellow again, and I wondered where. And to whom.

I found out, much later, that it was the night the old duke died. The one who had not left his bed in three years. He died peacefully, his physicians said, in his sleep. They found frost on his pillow in the morning.

The twins died a span later. A fever, the physicians said. It went through the nursery and took them both in a single night.

And on the first day of summer, in the great cathedral at Renere, with the bells ringing and the crowds cheering and the banners of the Jakis house flying from every tower, Ambrose Jakis was crowned King of Vintas.

I was in Tarbean when I heard. I was sitting in a tavern in Waterside, with a mug of cheap beer in front of me and a storyteller's chair empty by the fire.

I remember that I laughed. I do not remember why.

## **Interlude: Harl's Bread**

The innkeeper stopped, and looked down at his hands, and did not go on.

Chronicler waited. He had learned, over two days and a half, that there were silences in this telling that were not pauses. Places where the story ran up against something too heavy to carry past, and had to stop, and set it down, and rest.

This was one of them. He could tell. The innkeeper was sitting very still with his hands flat on the table and his eyes on nothing, and his face had the look it got sometimes. Not Kote's look, mild and tired. Not Kvothe's, bright and hungry. Something between. Something older than either.

Bast was watching him too.

"Reshi," he said softly. "You never told me about Harl."

"No."

"Why not?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time.

"Because I didn't know him," he said at last. "That's the terrible thing, Bast. I didn't know him. Eleven days. He said maybe a hundred words to me. He gave his bread to a boy with a crossbow and he held a door so I could run, and I never learned where he was from, or whether he had a wife, or what he liked to eat." He looked down at his hands. "How do you tell a story about a man you never knew?"

"You just did," said Chronicler.

The innkeeper looked at him.

"You told me he gave his bread away," said Chronicler. "You told me he said most talk is noise. You told me he checked the horses' feet before his own supper. You told me he held a door for a quarter of an hour against a dozen men." He tapped the page in front of him. "That's knowing someone. That's more than most people get."

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment.

"It's not enough," he said.

"It's never enough," said Chronicler. "That's why we write it down."

\* \* \*

The innkeeper looked at him for a long time. Then something in his face eased. Very slightly.

"You're very wise, for a man who writes about dragons for a living," he said.

"Draccus," said Chronicler, with dignity. "And I don't write about them for a living. That was one book."

"It was a very good book."

"You've read it?"

"I had a copy at the University. Before." The innkeeper smiled faintly. "It was the first thing I ever read that made me think the world might be bigger than I'd been told."

Chronicler stared at him. He opened his mouth, and closed it again, and found that he did not know what to say.

Bast laughed. It was a sudden, surprised sound, and it broke something in the room, and the heaviness lifted a little.

"Look at his face, Reshi," said Bast. "You've struck him dumb."

"So I have." The innkeeper stood up. "I'm going to make some stew. We've been sitting too long. And then I'll tell you about Tarbean." His face changed, very slightly. "Which is worse than Harl, in its way. So you'll want to eat first."

He went into the kitchen.

\* \* \*

Chronicler sat very still at the table. He looked down at his page. At the last line he had written. *He said maybe a hundred words to me.*

He picked up his pen. And in the margin, very small, in plain letters, not in his cipher, he wrote a single word.

*Harl.*

He did not know why. It was not how he recorded things. It was not his method. But he wrote it, in the margin, where it would be seen by anyone who ever read these pages. Plain, and small, and permanent.

Bast was watching him.

"What's that for?" he said.

Chronicler looked at the name for a moment.

"So someone will remember," he said.

## Chapter Fifty-Five

# Tarbean

I smelled Tarbean before I saw it.

It came to me across the water on the third morning out from Hallow's End, while I was standing at the rail watching the grey coast slide by. A thin sour thread of it on the wind. Smoke and sewage and rotting fish, tar and brine and the hot rank breath of a hundred thousand people packed too close together. It was faint at first, so faint I thought I had imagined it. Then it grew stronger. And then, all at once, it was everywhere, filling my nose and my mouth and the back of my throat, and I had to grip the rail with both hands to keep from being sick.

It was not the smell that did it. I had smelled worse. I had smelled the Deller farm, and the king's bedchamber, and the bottom of a ravine in the Hollow Hills. It was the memory. Every breath of that smell was a door opening, and behind every door there was a boy of twelve, starving, shivering, alone, curled up in the rain on a rooftop with his arms wrapped around a broken lute.

I had spent three years in Tarbean. Three years that I do not like to talk about, even now. I have told you some of it. I have told you about Trapis and his cellar full of lost children, and about the Tehlin priests and their bread, and about Pike and his friends and what they did to my lute. I have told you about the sea of rooftops where I slept, and the gutters where I ate, and the long cold nights when I did not think I would live to see morning.

I have not told you all of it. There are things about Tarbean that I have never told anyone. Things I did, and things that were done to me. Things I have locked away so deep that even I do not go looking for them.

And now I was going back.

\* \* \*

The ship came into harbor a little after noon. Tarbean's harbor is a great sprawling mess of piers and wharves and jetties, built out into the water without plan or order over hundreds of years, so that the whole waterfront looks like a mouthful of broken teeth. Ships of every size crowd the piers, from tiny fishing smacks to great three-masted merchantmen from Yll and Atur and the Small Kingdoms. The noise is incredible. Gulls screaming, men shouting, chains rattling, the thud and creak of cargo being loaded and unloaded. It never stops. Not day or night. Not ever.

I walked down the gangplank onto the pier with my lute on my back and my sword at my hip and my pack over my shoulder. My legs were unsteady after three days at sea. The pier seemed to sway beneath me. I stood for a moment at the foot of the gangplank, letting the noise and the smell wash over me, and I waited to feel something.

I did not feel anything. That was the strange thing. I had braced myself for fear, or grief, or anger. I had expected to be overwhelmed. But I stood there on the pier in Tarbean, in the middle of the noise and the stink and the crowds, and I felt nothing at all. Only a kind of distant, hollow calm, like the calm at the center of a storm.

I did not trust it. But I was grateful for it.

\* \* \*

I went to Waterside first.

I do not know why. It was not where I needed to go. Skarpi, if he was still alive, if he was still in Tarbean at all, would not be in Waterside. But my feet took me there anyway, through the crowded streets and the stinking alleys, down toward the part of the city where the poor lived and died.

It had not changed. That was the first thing I noticed. It had been six years since I left, and in six years, Waterside had not changed at all. The same crooked streets. The same leaning houses. The same beggars on the same corners, or ones so like them that there was no difference. The same children, thin and dirty and hollow-eyed, darting through the crowds like fish, their small quick hands reaching for purses.

I saw one of them reach for mine. A boy of about ten, with a filthy face and a shock of pale hair. He came at me from the side, quick and quiet, the way I had been taught to come at marks when I was his age. I felt his fingers brush the strings of my purse.

I caught his wrist.

He froze. He looked up at me, and his eyes were enormous in his thin face, and I saw the terror in them. The terror of a child who knows exactly what happens to pickpockets who get caught.

I did not hurt him. I held his wrist, very gently, and I looked at him.

"You're too slow," I said. "You came at me from the left, which is good, but you looked at my purse before you touched it. Don't look. Never look. Look at their face, or at something past them. Your hand knows where the purse is. Let it find it on its own."

He stared at me. His mouth fell open.

I let go of his wrist. Then I reached into my purse and took out a silver talent and pressed it into his hand.

"Go to the Tehlins on Hillside," I said. "The big church with the iron doors. Tell them you want bread, and give them this, and they'll feed you for a month."

He looked at the coin in his hand. He looked at me. Then he turned and ran, and was gone into the crowd before I could say anything else.

I stood there for a long moment, looking at the place where he had been. Then I went on.

\* \* \*

Trapis's cellar was still there.



I found it at the end of a narrow dead-end alley, down a short flight of stone steps, behind a door that was just as battered and ill-fitting as it had been when I was a child. I stood at the top of the steps for a long time, looking at that door, not moving.

Then I went down and knocked.

For a long time, nothing happened. Then I heard footsteps, slow and shuffling, and the door creaked open, and a face looked out at me.

It was not Trapis. It was a young woman, perhaps twenty, thin and plain, with lank brown hair and tired eyes. She was wearing a stained apron over a patched dress. There was a baby on her hip, and it was crying.

"Yes?" she said.

"I'm looking for Trapis."

Her face changed. Something went out of it. "Trapis," she said. "Oh." She looked at me more closely. "Did you know him?"

*Did.* I felt something cold settle in my chest.

"Yes," I said. "A long time ago. When I was a boy."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she stepped aside.

"Come in," she said. "He's in the back."

\* \* \*

He was dying.

It was the second time in a month that I had sat at the bedside of a dying man, and I remember thinking how strange that was. How the world seemed to keep putting me in the same place, again and again, as if it were trying to teach me something I refused to learn.

But Trapis was not a king. He lay on a narrow cot in the back of the cellar, beneath a thin grey blanket, in the same room where he had always kept the sickest of the children. There was a candle burning on a stool beside him. The room smelled of sickness and of something else, something clean and sharp, like vinegar.

He was very small. Smaller than I remembered. He had always been a small man, stooped and thin, with a round bald head and gentle hands. But now he was tiny, shrunk, a little bundle of bones under the blanket. His skin was grey and papery. His breathing was shallow

and slow.

But his eyes were open. And when I came into the room and knelt beside his cot, they found my face, and they knew me.

"Well," he said. His voice was very faint. "Well, well. Look who's come back."

"Hello, Trapis."

"Hello, lad." He smiled. It was the same smile. Exactly the same. Gentle and tired and utterly without judgment. "You've grown."

"A little."

"More than a little." He looked at me, his eyes moving slowly over my face, my clothes, my sword. "You look well. You look—" He paused, searching for the word. "Strong. You look strong."

"I'm not, really."

"You are. I can see it." He reached out one thin hand from beneath the blanket and laid it on my arm. His fingers were cold and very light, like the touch of a moth. "I always knew you would be. Even when you were small. Even when you were sick. There was something in you. Something that wouldn't give up."

I did not trust myself to speak. I nodded.

"Where have you been?" he asked. "All this time?"

So I told him. I sat beside his cot in that dim room with his hand on my arm, and I told him everything. The University, and the Archives, and Elodin. Denna. The Maer and Meluan. The Adem, and the Fae, and the Chandrian. The king's bedchamber, and the knots, and Harl dead in the laundry door.

I had not told anyone all of it before. Not all at once, not like that. But I told Trapis. And he listened, the way he had always listened, with his head tilted a little to one side and his gentle eyes fixed on my face. He did not interrupt. He did not ask questions. He simply listened, the way you would listen to a child telling you about a bad dream.

When I was done, he was quiet for a long time.

"That's a great deal," he said at last. "A great deal for one young man to carry."

"Yes."

"Are you tired?"

The question took me by surprise. I thought about it.

"Yes," I said. "Very."

"I thought so." He patted my arm gently. "It's all right to be tired, you know. Even heroes get tired. Especially heroes." He smiled faintly. "Especially the ones who don't think they're heroes at all."

"I'm not a hero, Trapis."

"No? What are you, then?"

I did not know how to answer that. I sat beside his cot and looked at his thin grey face, and I did not know what to say.

"You're a boy who came back," said Trapis softly. "That's what you are. You went out into the world and you did all these great and terrible things, and then you came back here. To this cellar. To a dying old man who fed you soup when you were small." He closed his eyes. "That's not nothing. That's not nothing at all."

\* \* \*

I stayed with him that night. I sat beside his cot and held his hand, and the young woman, whose name was Mae, brought me a bowl of thin soup and a heel of bread, and I ate it sitting on the floor. It tasted exactly the way it had tasted when I was twelve. Salty and weak and faintly of onions. It was the best thing I had eaten in months.

The children came to look at me. There were a dozen of them in the cellar, maybe more. Thin, pale, silent children, some of them sick, some of them simply lost. They stood in the doorway and stared at me with their enormous eyes, and when I smiled at them, they did not smile back. They only stared.

I took out my lute and played for them. Softly, so as not to disturb Trapis. I played "Tinker Tanner" and "Jenny Nettle" and a silly song about a pig who wanted to be a king. And slowly, one by one, the children came into the room and sat down on the floor around me and listened. And by the end, one or two of them were smiling. And one very small girl, with a wild tangle of black hair and a bandage around her head, had crept into my lap and fallen asleep there.

Trapis woke once, near midnight, and looked at me sitting on the floor with my lute and the sleeping child and the ring of children around me.

"There," he said softly. "You see? That's what you are."

Then he closed his eyes again.

He died a little before dawn. Very quietly. I was holding his hand, and I felt it go still, and I looked up and saw that he had stopped breathing. His face was peaceful. He looked like he was sleeping.

Mae came in and saw, and she sat down on the floor beside me and wept. The children woke and saw, and some of them wept too, and some of them only stared. The little girl in my lap did not wake. I held her and let her sleep.

I did not weep. Not then. I sat there with Trapis's hand in mine until the grey light of dawn came down the stairs and through the door, and then I laid his hand on his chest and stood up and gave the sleeping girl to Mae.

"What will you do?" I asked her. "Now that he's gone."

She looked at me with red eyes. "Keep going," she said. "What else? The children still need feeding. The sick ones still need looking after." She shook her head. "He'd have wanted that. He always said it didn't matter who did the work, so long as someone did it."

I took out my purse. The Mae's purse. I opened it and poured everything that was in it into her hands. Silver and gold, talents and marks and royals, more money than she had probably ever seen in her life.

She stared at it. Then at me.

"This is too much," she said.

"It's not enough," I said. "It'll never be enough. But it's what I have."

She looked at me for a long time. Then she closed her hands around the coins and held them against her chest.

"Thank you," she whispered.

"Don't thank me. Thank him." I looked at Trapis, lying still on his cot. "He saved my life. More than once. I never paid him back."

"You just did," said Mae.

\* \* \*

I left the cellar as the sun was rising over Tarbean. I climbed the stone steps into the narrow alley and stood there for a moment, blinking in the grey morning light.

I had no money now. Not a penny. I had given it all away. I had my lute, and my sword, and the clothes on my back, and the few things in my pack. Kilvin's candle. The scrap of the Dellers' cloth. Fela's stone eye. Denna's knot. The page from the Book of Watches.

It was very little. But it was more than I had had the last time I walked these streets.

I turned and began to walk toward Hillside. Toward the part of the city where the Tehlins kept their great churches, and the courts of justice, and the prisons where they kept men who told the wrong sort of stories.

I was going to find Skarpi.

And this time, I promised myself, I would listen to the end.

## Chapter Fifty-Six

### Pike

I found Pike on my second day in Tarbean, on the steps of a church in Hillside, begging.

I did not know him at first. Why would I? The last time I had seen him, he had been fourteen, big for his age, with a broad flat face and small mean eyes and a pair of fists he used on anyone smaller than himself. He had been the leader of a pack of older boys who ran the alleys near the docks. He had caught me, the first winter I was in Tarbean, in an alley behind a tannery, and he and his friends had held me down and taken my father's lute and smashed it against a wall.

I had been twelve. It was the last thing I had of my father's. I watched them break it, and I lay in the alley afterward with blood in my mouth, and I did not cry. I was past crying, by then.

I had hated him for a long time. Longer than I like to admit. I had imagined, many nights, on the rooftops of Tarbean, what I would do to him if I ever found him again, when I was bigger. I had imagined it in great detail.

And now here he was. On the steps of the church of Tehlu in Hillside, with a tin cup in front of him.

He had no legs.

\* \* \*

They had been taken off above the knee. Both of them. The stumps were wrapped in filthy rags and tucked under him on a little wooden board with iron wheels, the kind that legless beggars push themselves

around on with their hands. His hands were thick and callused and black with the dirt of the streets. His broad flat face was the same, but thinner, and covered in a patchy beard. His small eyes were the same too. But there was nothing mean in them now. Only a kind of dull patience, like the patience of an old dog.

I stood at the bottom of the church steps and looked at him, and I did not know him.

He looked up at me. He held up his cup.

"Spare a copper, sir?" he said. "For a poor cripple? Tehlu bless you."

I knew his voice.

\* \* \*

I did not move. I stood at the bottom of the steps with my hands at my sides and looked at him, and I felt it rise up in me. The old hate. The old rage. The boy in the alley with blood in his mouth, watching his father's lute splinter against a wall.

*Here he is, it said. Here he is, at last. Helpless. Alone. No one to hold you down this time.*

I had a knife on my belt. I had Caesura on my back. I had spent months learning the Ketan from the Adem, and I could have killed him before he knew I had moved.

I did not move.

"What happened to your legs?" I said.

He blinked up at me. People did not usually ask. They usually dropped a coin, or did not, and walked on.

"Cart," he said. "Ran over 'em. Down by the docks. Six years back." He shrugged, the way you shrug about the weather. "Surgeon took 'em off. Said they'd rot otherwise. Took my money too. All of it." He held up his cup again. "Spare a copper?"

"Six years ago," I said.

"About that."

It would have been not long after I left Tarbean. After I stole a purse and bought passage and walked out of the city toward the University with my head full of dreams. While I was learning

sympathy and playing at the Eolian, Pike had been lying in an alley by the docks with his legs crushed under a cart.

"Did anyone help you?" I said.

He looked at me for a long moment. Something moved in his small eyes.

"Trapis," he said. "The old man. With the cellar." He looked down at his hands. "Carried me there himself. Couldn't have weighed more than a sack of feathers, the old fellow, but he carried me. Put me on a cot and fed me soup for three months." He was quiet for a moment. "Never asked for nothing. Never asked what I done."

I stood very still.

"He died," I said. "Yesterday."

Pike looked up at me. His face went slack.

"Trapis?"

"Yes."

Pike did not say anything for a long time. He sat on his little board on the church steps with his cup in his hand, and his face did something complicated, and then he looked away down the street.

"Good man," he said at last. His voice was rough. "Better than me. Better than most." He wiped his nose with the back of his hand. "Better than I deserved."

\* \* \*

I sat down on the steps beside him.

I do not know why. I did not decide to. I sat down on the cold stone beside the boy who had smashed my father's lute, and I looked out at the street with him, at the carts going by and the people hurrying and the gulls wheeling over the rooftops.

"Do you remember a red-haired boy?" I said. "About twelve. Came to Tarbean about nine years ago. Played a lute."

Pike was quiet. Then he turned his head and looked at me. At my face. At my hair.

I watched him remember.

His face went white under the dirt and the beard. His hands tightened on the edge of his board. He did not try to push himself



away; he could not have gone fast enough, and he knew it. He only sat very still, and looked at me, and waited.

"You," he said.

"Me."

"You've come to—" He stopped. He swallowed. "Go on, then. Get it over with. I'll not fight you." He laughed, a short ugly sound. "Can't fight anybody, now."

I looked at him. At his thin face and his stumps wrapped in rags and his black callused hands.

"Why did you do it?" I said. "The lute. Why?"

Pike was quiet for a long time.

"'Cause you had something," he said at last. "And I didn't." He looked at the street. "You came into Waterside with your red hair and your lute, and you were starving same as the rest of us, but you had that lute. You'd sit in doorways at night and play it, soft, and everybody'd stop and listen. Even me." He was quiet for a moment. "I hated you for it. Hated you so bad I couldn't breathe. 'Cause you had something beautiful, and nobody could take it off you. Not the cold, not the hunger, not anybody." He looked down at his hands. "So I took it."

I did not say anything.

"Didn't make me feel any better," said Pike. "Thought it would. Didn't." He shrugged. "Nothing ever did. Not till Trapis."

\* \* \*

We sat on the church steps for a long time. A priest came out of the church and looked at us, a red-haired man with a sword and a legless beggar sitting side by side on his steps, and frowned, and went back in.

At last I stood up.

Pike looked up at me. He was still waiting. For the blow, or the knife, or the curse.

I reached into my pack. I did not have any money; I had given it all to Mae, the day before. But I had something. A small thing I had bought in the market that morning with the last copper I found in the bottom of my pack, because it reminded me of something, and I did

not know what.

It was a wooden whistle. A child's toy. Painted red, with the paint worn off at the mouthpiece.

I put it in his cup.

Pike looked down at it. Then up at me.

"What's that for?" he said.

"Music," I said. "Something beautiful. That nobody can take off you."

He stared at me. His small eyes were very wide.

I turned and walked away down the street. I did not look back.

But at the corner, before I turned it, I heard something behind me. Very faint, over the noise of the carts and the gulls. A thin wavering sound. Three notes, badly played, going up.

I stood at the corner and listened to it for a long time.

Then I went on to look for Skarpi. And I found, as I walked, that the old hate was gone. Not buried. Not locked behind the doors of sleep. Gone. Like a stone taken out of a shoe you have been walking on for nine years without knowing why it hurt.

I have never missed it.

## Chapter Fifty-Seven

# The Half-Mast

The Tehlins had not forgotten Skarpi. Neither had I.

I remember the day they took him. I was twelve years old, sitting on the floor of a tavern in Waterside called the Half-Mast, listening to an old man with bright eyes tell the story of Lanre. He had told it over several days, a piece at a time, and I had come back every day to hear the next part. It was the first story I had heard in years that made me feel anything. It made me feel as though the world was bigger than the gutters of Tarbean. As though there were mysteries in it, and wonders, and things worth knowing.

And then, in the middle of a telling, the door had burst open and the Tehlins had come in. Priests in grey robes, and men of the Justice behind them with their iron-shod staves. They had taken Skarpi by the arms and dragged him from his stool, and they had accused him of heresy, of telling lies about Tehlu and the angels. And Skarpi had laughed at them, and called one of them by a name I did not recognize, and said something about Tehlu's fat, and let them take him.

I had never seen him again. I had always assumed he was dead. Burned, perhaps, or hanged, or rotting in some Tehlin dungeon.

But Chronicler—

\* \* \*

The innkeeper stopped. He looked across the table at Chronicler.

"You knew him," he said. "Didn't you? Skarpi."

Chronicler went very still. His pen stopped moving.

"Yes," he said quietly. "I knew him."

"You told me, the first night. When I asked you who had told you where to find me." The innkeeper's green eyes were very steady. "You said a friend. An old storyteller. You didn't say his name."

"No."

"But it was Skarpi."

Chronicler was silent for a long moment. Then he nodded.

"It was Skarpi," he said. "He came to me in Tinuë, last autumn. I'd known him for years; he used to come by my rooms sometimes to argue about history. He told me that a man I'd been looking for was alive, and running an inn in a little town called Newarre, and that if I wanted the true story, I should go and ask for it." He paused. "He said you'd give it to me. He said you'd been waiting for someone to ask."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long time. Then he smiled. It was a small, strange smile, sad and wry and not at all surprised.

"Of course he did," he said. "Of course." He looked down at the table. "He always did like to arrange things."

At the window, Bast had turned around. He was looking at Chronicler with an expression Chronicler could not read.

"You didn't tell us that," Bast said. "That he sent you."

"You didn't ask."

"We *should* have asked." Bast's voice was sharp. "Reshi—"

"It doesn't matter, Bast." The innkeeper did not look up. "It doesn't change anything. If anything, it makes more sense." He was quiet for a moment. "Skarpi always knew more than he said. And he always said it at exactly the right time."

He looked up at Chronicler.

"Let me tell you how I found him," he said. "The second time."

\* \* \*

The Tehlins, as it turned out, had not burned Skarpi. Nor hanged him, nor left him to rot. They had tried him before the Justice on Hillside, before a court of three priests and a magistrate, for the crime of heresy. And he had been found guilty. And he had been sentenced to death by burning.

And on the morning of his execution, when they came to his cell to take him to the pyre, they had found the cell empty. The door was locked. The bars were whole. The guards had seen nothing. Skarpi was simply gone, as if he had never been there at all.

I learned all this in a single afternoon, from an old Tehlin clerk in the records office of the Justice, who remembered the case very well and was only too happy to talk about it for the price of a mug of beer. He told me that the priests had searched the city for him for a month. That they had offered a reward. That they had never found a trace.

"Some said a demon took him," the old clerk said, wiping foam from his lips. "Some said the Duke of Gibea, the old heretic, came back from the dead to carry off his own. Some said he was an angel in disguise, sent to test us." He shrugged. "Me, I think somebody bribed a guard. But you didn't hear that from me."

"Did anyone ever see him again?"

The old clerk looked at me. He hesitated.

"There's talk," he said at last. "In Waterside. That he comes back, sometimes. To the Half-Mast. The old tavern where he used to tell his stories." He shook his head. "But that's just talk. People in Waterside'll say anything."

\* \* \*

The Half-Mast was still there.

It had changed more than Waterside had. The sign had fallen down and been replaced with a new one, painted by someone who had clearly never seen a ship; the mast was bent at an impossible angle, and the sails were the wrong shape entirely. The old bar had been torn out and replaced with a new one, cheap and badly made. The floor had been covered in sawdust. The windows had been boarded up.

But the room was the same. Long and low and dark, with a great smoky hearth at one end and a scatter of rough tables and benches. And beside the hearth, in the corner, there was a stool.

It was empty. But it was there.

I went in and sat down at a table near the hearth. I ordered a mug of beer I could not afford, with the last copper I had found in the

bottom of my pack. It was terrible beer, thin and sour. I drank it slowly and watched the door.

I waited all afternoon. People came and went. Sailors, dockhands, fishwives, beggars. A pair of whores who looked at me and laughed and went away. A drunk who tried to pick a fight with me and then fell asleep on the floor. None of them was Skarpi.

I waited all evening. The tavern grew crowded and loud. The fire roared in the hearth. Someone began to play a fiddle, badly. I sat at my table with my empty mug and watched the door and the stool, and I did not move.

It was near midnight when the fiddle stopped.

I did not notice at first. The tavern was so loud, and I was so tired, and my eyes had begun to close in spite of myself. But then I realized that the room had gone quiet. Not silent. There were still people talking, still mugs clinking. But quieter. As if someone had come in and everyone had turned, without meaning to, to look.

I opened my eyes.

There was an old man sitting on the stool by the hearth.

\* \* \*

He had not come in through the door. I had been watching the door all day and all evening, and I would have seen him. And he had not been there a moment before. I was sure of that. But he was there now, sitting on the stool with his hands folded on his knees, as if he had been sitting there all along.

He was just as I remembered him. Tall and thin, with a long white beard and hair the color of old snow. His face was lined and weathered, the face of a man who has spent his life outdoors. His clothes were ragged. And his eyes were very bright, bright and dark at the same time, like the eyes of a bird.

He was looking at me.

"Well," he said. His voice was just as I remembered it too. Deep and rich and warm, with a faint lilt to it, like the voice of a man who has spent his life telling stories. "Well, well. Look who's come back to hear the ending."

The tavern had gone very quiet now. Everyone was looking at him. Or rather, everyone was looking at the stool by the hearth, and at the old man sitting on it, with the vague uneasy expression of people who have just seen something they cannot quite explain.

"Hello, Skarpi," I said.

"Hello, Kvothe." He smiled. His teeth were very white. "You've grown."

"Everyone keeps saying that."

"Everyone keeps being right." He looked around the tavern. At the staring faces, the half-raised mugs, the fiddler frozen with his bow in the air. "It's a bit crowded in here. Shall we find somewhere quieter?"

"Where?"

He stood up. He did not seem to move so much as unfold, like a heron rising from a pond.

"I know a place," he said.

\* \* \*

He took me out of the Half-Mast and through the dark streets of Waterside. Down toward the harbor, and then along it, past the piers and the wharves and the moored ships creaking at their ropes. The moon was up, three-quarters full, silver on the black water.

He did not speak as we walked. Neither did I. I had a thousand questions, but I did not ask them. I had learned, over the years, that some people will tell you things only when they are ready, and that asking before then is worse than useless.

At last we came to the end of the harbor, where the piers gave out and the city gave out and there was only a long, low spit of land running out into the sea. It was rocky and bare, with a few stunted trees clinging to it, and at the very end of it, there was a ruin.

It had been a lighthouse once. You could see that from the shape of it: a round stone tower, tall and narrow, rising out of the rocks. But the top of it was gone, fallen in long ago, and the stones were black with age and slick with sea spray. There was a doorway at the bottom, with no door in it.

Skarpi led me through the doorway. Inside, the tower was hollow, a tall round shaft of stone open to the sky. Moonlight came down through the broken top and fell on the floor in a pale silver circle. There was a fire burning in the center of the circle, small and bright, with no wood to feed it. And beside the fire, there were two stones, flat-topped, like stools.

Skarpi sat down on one of them. He gestured to the other.

"Sit," he said. "You've come a long way."

I sat. The fire was warm. It crackled softly, though there was nothing in it to crackle. I looked at it, and then at Skarpi.

"Who are you?" I said.

He smiled. "That's an interesting question. Most people start with *what*."

"All right. What are you?"

"A storyteller." He spread his hands. "That's all I've ever been. I tell stories. True ones, mostly. Which is why the Tehlins didn't care for me." He chuckled. "They prefer their stories with the edges filed off."

"You escaped from a locked cell."

"I did."

"How?"

"I asked the door to let me out, and it did." He shrugged. "Doors are very reasonable, if you ask them properly."

I stared at him. "You're a namer."

"I know some names. Not many. Door is one. Fire is another." He nodded at the small bright flame between us. "Stone, a little. Wind, when it's in a good mood." He looked at me. "You know some names too. I can hear them on you. Wind. Stone. Something else, something newer. Something tangled." He tilted his head. "Knots, is it? You've been learning knots?"

"A little."

"Hm." He looked at me for a long moment with his bright bird's eyes. "Dangerous thing, knots. Much more dangerous than names. A name is a thing that is. A knot is a thing that's made to be." He shook his head. "The Yllish knew that. Most of them forgot. The ones who



didn't forget—" He stopped. "Well. That's another story."

"I didn't come for another story," I said. "I came for the end of the one you started. The one about Lanre."

Skarpi smiled. It was a slow, warm, delighted smile.

"Yes," he said. "Yes, I thought you might have. You were always the one who came back." He settled himself on his stone, folding his long thin hands on his knees. "Where did I leave off?"

"Selitos," I said. "He'd cursed Lanre. At the ruins of Myr Tariniel. He'd put out his own eye with a stone, and he'd cursed Lanre with his own name, and he'd said something about a curse on all of Lanre's followers." I paused. "And then the Tehlins came."

"Ah. Yes." Skarpi nodded slowly. "Yes, that's where we were." He looked into the fire for a long moment. "That's where most people stop. Right there. At the curse. Selitos puts out his eye and curses Lanre, and Lanre becomes Haliar, and the Seven become the Chandrian, and Selitos founds the Amyr, and everyone goes home." He shook his head. "That's the story as it's usually told. That's the story the Amyr told, and the Tehlins told, and your parents were trying to tell."

"Is it wrong?"

"No. It's not wrong. It's just not finished." He looked up at me. His eyes were very bright in the firelight. "The story doesn't end with the curse, Kvothe. The curse is where the story *begins*."

He leaned forward.

"Listen," he said. "And I'll tell you the rest."

## Chapter Fifty-Eight

# The Rest of the Story

*This is what Skarpi told me, in the broken lighthouse at the end of the world, with the sea breathing on the rocks outside and a fire burning between us that fed on nothing at all.*

\* \* \*

When Selitos had spoken the curse, he stood for a long time among the ruins of Myr Tariniel, with the blood running down his face from his ruined eye and the stone still clenched in his fist.

The city was gone. The white towers had fallen. The great gardens had burned. The people, all the people, the singers and the scholars and the children playing in the fountains, were dead. And Lanre, who had done this, stood before him with his own name hung around his neck like a millstone, and could not die.

Selitos looked at him with his one good eye. And Lanre looked back. And for a long moment, neither of them spoke.

Then Lanre said, *Why?*

It was not the question Selitos had expected. He had expected rage. He had expected curses of his own, or pleading, or laughter. He had not expected a single word, spoken so quietly, like a child asking why the sky was dark.

*Why what?* said Selitos.

*Why did you not kill me?* said Lanre. *You could have. You know my name. You could have spoken it and unmade me. I would have let you.* He looked at the ruins around them. *I came here to be killed. I*

*came here so that someone would finally end it. And you did not.*

Selitos was silent for a long time.

*Because death is too small for what you have done, he said at last. Because a thousand thousand souls died here tonight, and your death would pay for none of them. Because if I killed you, you would have what you want. And you do not deserve to have what you want.*

And Lanre laughed. It was a terrible sound, like the sound of a great bell cracking.

*Then you are no better than I am, he said. You have done this for the same reason I did what I did. Because you are angry. Because you are grieving. Because you want someone to suffer as you suffer. He shook his head. We are the same, you and I. We are both men who have lost everything, and who have decided that the world should pay.*

And he turned and walked away into the dark, with his six companions behind him, and Selitos let him go.

\* \* \*

That is the end of the story, as it is usually told. But it is not the end.

Because Selitos did not sleep that night. He sat among the ruins of Myr Tariniel with his bleeding eye and the stone in his hand, and he thought about what Lanre had said. And the more he thought about it, the more he feared that it was true.

He had not cursed Lanre for justice. He had cursed him for grief. For rage. For the thousand thousand souls who had died, and for his own helplessness to save them. He had taken Lanre's name, his own true name, and twisted it into a shape of endless suffering, and bound it to him forever. And he had done it not because it was right, but because it was what he wanted.

And that is a very dangerous thing, for a namer to do. Because a name is a true thing. It is the shape of what a person is. And when you twist it, when you bend it to your will, you do not only change the one who bears it. You change yourself.

So Selitos looked into himself, that night, among the ruins. He looked with his one good eye, and with the eye he had put out, which could no longer see the world but could see other things. And he saw

that Lanre was right. He had become something that he did not want to be. Something that took names and twisted them for vengeance.

And he wept.

\* \* \*

*Skarpi stopped. He looked at me across the fire.*

*"That part isn't in any of the books," he said. "The Amyr didn't write it down. They didn't want anyone to know that their founder had wept, or why." He smiled faintly. "They preferred him stern and one-eyed and certain. It made a better symbol."*

*"How do you know it, then?"*

*Skarpi looked at me for a long moment. His bright bird's eyes were very old.*

*"Because I was there," he said. "I was a boy, then. A very young boy, younger than you were when your family died. I had lived in Myr Tariniel all my life. I was one of the children playing in the fountains." He looked into the fire. "I was the only one who lived."*

*I stared at him.*

*"That was—"*

*"A very long time ago. Yes." He nodded. "Longer than you can imagine. Longer than I like to think about." He smiled, a little wryly. "Selitos found me in the ruins, the morning after. I was hiding in a fallen fountain, under a slab of white marble. He dug me out with his own hands. And he looked at me with his one eye, and I looked at him, and neither of us said anything for a long time."*

*"And then?"*

*"And then he asked me what I wanted to be, when I grew up." Skarpi laughed softly. "Can you imagine? The city was burned. My parents were dead. Everyone I had ever known was dead. And this terrible bleeding man with one eye dug me out of the rubble and asked me what I wanted to be."*

*"What did you say?"*

*"I said I wanted to be a singer," said Skarpi. "Like my mother. She sang in the great hall of the city, and people came from all over the world to hear her." He was quiet for a moment. "Selitos looked at*

*me for a long time. And then he said, 'Yes. Yes, I think that is exactly what the world will need.'*"

*He looked back into the fire, and took up the thread of the story again.*

\* \* \*

Selitos went out from Myr Tariniel and gathered to himself those who had survived the war. Namers and warriors and scholars, and others who were not quite any of those things. And he made two orders.

The first was the Amyr. You know of them. They were to be the sword. They were to hunt the Seven wherever they went, and stop them wherever they could. They were to do whatever was necessary, however terrible, for the greater good. That was their oath and their curse. *For the greater good*. They were Selitos's anger, given form and purpose.

But the second order, fewer people know. Selitos called them the Singers. And they were not a sword. They were something else.

Selitos had understood, among the ruins, what his curse had done. He had bound Lanre to his name, and bound his name to a story. The story of what he had done at Myr Tariniel. And as long as that story was told truly, as long as people remembered it and sang it and wrote it down, the curse would hold. Lanre would remain Haliar. He would remain cursed, and unable to die, and unable to forget.

But if the story was forgotten, or changed, or told falsely, the curse would weaken. Because a curse spoken in a name is only as strong as the truth that holds it. And the truth is only as strong as the people who remember it.

So Selitos made the Singers. They were to be the keepers of the true story. They were to sing it, and tell it, and teach it, wherever they went. Not the pretty version. Not the heroic version, or the simple version with a clear villain and a clear hero. The true version. The whole of it. Lanre's love, and Lanre's fall, and Lanre's grief. Selitos's rage, and Selitos's tears. All of it.

Because only the true story would hold. A false story, however beautiful, would be a crack in the wall. And through that crack, over

time, the curse would bleed away.

\* \* \*

*"The Chandrian kill the Singers," I said slowly. "That's why they killed my parents. My father was writing the true song."*

*"Your father was writing a very good song," said Skarpi. "Not the true one, not all of it. He didn't have all the pieces. But he was close. Closer than anyone had come in a long time." He looked at me. "And your mother knew some things that she should not have known, from her own family. Things about the doors. She put them into the song, in little ways. Hints. Clues." He shook his head. "That made it doubly dangerous. It was a true song about Lanre, and a map to the keeper's door, both at once."*

*"So they came."*

*"So they came."*

*I was silent for a long time. The fire crackled. The sea breathed outside.*

*"And now someone's writing a false song," I said. "Denna. Bredon's making her write a song that makes Lanre a hero. To weaken the curse."*

*"Yes."*

*"And when the curse is weak enough—"*

*"Then he will open the door," said Skarpi quietly. "Or try to. And the Thief will come out. And the Thief, who can unmake anything, will unmake the curse." He paused. "And then, perhaps, many other things."*

*"The world."*

*"Perhaps. The Thief was never very fond of the world. He wanted a different one. One he had made himself." Skarpi looked into the fire. "That's what the war was about, in the end. Whether the world would be as it is, or as he wanted it to be."*

\* \* \*

There is one more piece, *Skarpi said*. One more piece of the story, that I have never told anyone. Not in the Half-Mast, not in any tavern or

hall. Because it is not a piece that should be told in public. It is a piece for the one it belongs to.

It is about the Thief. The one who stole the moon.

Before the war, before he became what he became, he was a man. A shaper, but a man. And like all men, he loved. Not only the moon. There was a woman, too, a mortal woman, who lived in the hills where the Lackless house now stands. He loved her for a little while, the way shapers love things, fiercely and briefly and without thought for what it would cost. And she bore him a child.

A daughter. The first of the line.

When the war was over and the Thief was sealed away beyond the doors, Selitos found that child, now grown, with children of her own. And he looked at her with his one eye, and he saw the Thief in her. In her blood, in her bones, in the shape of her name. He saw that she was bound to her father, as all children are bound to their parents, in ways that cannot be broken.

And he understood that this was the key.

Because the door that held the Thief was made to be opened by no one. But a door that cannot be opened by anyone is a door that cannot be kept. It will crack, over time. It will weaken. It will fail. A true lock needs a true key, so that it can be checked, and tended, and held.

So Selitos made the keeper's door. The first of the seven. And he made it so that it would open only to the Thief's own blood, with a key of stone, speaking the door's own name. And he gave the key to the Thief's daughter, and he bound her line to the keeping. *While the line holds, the door holds.* As long as the line lived, and kept the key, and kept the name close, the door would be tended and would not fail.

But it was also the greatest danger. Because the line that could keep the door could also open it. And if ever a child of that line came to the door with the key in their hand and the name on their lips, and chose to speak—

\* \* \*

*Skarpi stopped. He looked at me across the fire, and his bright eyes were very sad.*

*"You know the rest," he said.*

*I did. I knew it the way you know the ending of a song you have heard a hundred times, even when the singer stops before the last verse.*

*"The Thief's daughter," I said. My voice sounded very far away. "She was the first Loeclos."*

*"Yes."*

*"And my mother was her descendant."*

*"Yes."*

*"And I—"*

*"And you are the Thief's own blood," said Skarpi gently. "Many, many times removed. Diluted by a thousand generations. But still there. Still bound." He paused. "And you are a namer. The first of the line in a thousand years who can speak true names. Who could, if you chose, speak the name of the door."*

*I sat very still. The fire was warm on my face. The sea breathed outside.*

*"That's why Haliar spared me," I said. "That's why Cinder didn't kill me. He is needed."*

*"Yes."*

*"They want me to open the door."*

*"They need you to open the door. No one else can. Not truly. Ambrose has a drop of the blood; he can carry the key, but he cannot turn it. Meluan has more of it, but she has no gift for names. Her child, when it is born, may have both, or neither. It will be many years before anyone knows." Skarpi looked at me. "You are the only one, Kvothe. Right now, in all the world, you are the only one who can open it."*

*"And I won't."*

*Skarpi smiled. It was a very old smile, and very tired.*

*"That's what your mother said," he said. "When she was your age. I told her the same story, in a tavern in the Lackless hills, long before she met your father. She said she would never go near the door. Never."*



*And she kept that promise. She ran away from everything to keep it." He shook his head. "But you're not your mother. You're something else. You're a namer, and a Ruh, and you've never met a door you didn't want to see behind." He leaned forward. "So I'm going to ask you something. And I want you to think very carefully before you answer."*

*"What?"*

*"Will you sing?" said Skarpi. "Will you take your father's song, and your mother's hints, and all the pieces I've given you tonight, and make the true song? The whole of it? And will you sing it, where people can hear it, knowing what it will bring down on you?"*

*I looked at him across the fire.*

*"You're asking me to become a Singer."*

*"I'm asking you to become the last Singer," said Skarpi quietly. "Because I'm very old, Kvothe. Older than I have any right to be. And the others are all gone. The Chandrian found them, one by one, over the centuries. I'm the only one left." He looked into the fire. "And if the song isn't sung—truly, fully, well—then the girl's song will win. And the curse will break. And the door will open, whether you go to it or not." He looked up at me. "Because they'll make you. They'll find a way. They always do."*

*I sat there in the broken lighthouse for a long time, looking into the fire that burned on nothing.*

*Then I said yes.*

*\* \* \**

That is what Skarpi told me, and what I told him.

I have thought, since, that I should have said no. That if I had refused, if I had walked away from that lighthouse and taken ship for somewhere far away and never sung a note of the true song, perhaps things would have gone differently. Perhaps fewer people would have died.

But I do not think so. Not really. Not at the bottom, where the truth lives.

I think the board was already set. I think the stones were already placed. I think that Bredon, and Skarpi, and Selitos, and the Thief behind his door, had all been playing their games for so long that there was no move left to me that was truly mine.

Except one. There was always one.

But I did not know that yet.

## Chapter Fifty-Nine

# The Last Singer

I stayed with Skarpi in the broken lighthouse for nine days.

I do not know how he lived there. There was no food that I could see, and no water except the rain that collected in a hollow in the rocks outside, and no bed except the bare stone floor. And yet every evening there was bread beside the fire, fresh and warm, and a jug of cold clean water, and sometimes cheese, and once, memorably, a whole roast chicken, glistening with fat. I asked him where it came from, the first night. He only smiled and said that people in Waterside were very kind to old storytellers.

I did not ask again.

By day, he taught me. Not in the way the masters at the University taught, with lectures and books and examinations. He taught me the way a musician teaches another musician: by singing, and listening, and singing again.

He sang me the true story. All of it. Not in words, the way he had told it to me by the fire that first night, but in song. Long songs, old songs, in languages I did not know and languages so old they were barely languages at all, only shapes of sound. He sang me the fall of Myr Tariniel, and the betrayal at Drossen Tor, and the death of Lyra, and Lanre's grief. He sang me Selitos weeping among the ruins. He sang me the Thief and his stolen moon, and the war that followed, and the sealing of the doors.

He sang them to me over and over, until I could sing them back to him. Until the melodies were in my bones and the words were in my

blood. Until I could feel the shape of the story the way you feel the shape of your own hand in the dark.

And then he made me sing them myself.

\* \* \*

"No," he said, on the third day. "No, no. You're singing it like a performance."

I stopped. I had been singing the fall of Myr Tariniel, standing in the center of the lighthouse with my lute in my hands, and I had thought I was singing it well. The notes were right. The words were right. My voice was strong and clear and full of feeling.

"What's wrong with that?"

"Everything." Skarpi was sitting on his stone by the fire, his long thin hands folded on his knees. "You're singing it to be heard. You're singing it to be applauded. You're thinking about the audience, about how they'll feel, about whether they'll weep in the right places." He shook his head. "That's not how the true song is sung."

"How is it sung, then?"

"The way you sang to the Sleeper," said Skarpi. "The way you sang to the king's hair."

I stared at him. I had not told him about either of those things.

"How do you—"

"I know what I know." He waved it away. "When you sang to the Sleeper, you weren't singing to be heard. You were singing to *him*. You were singing his own loneliness back to him, so that he could hear it and rest. And when you sang to the hair, you weren't performing. You were listening to what it wanted to say, and helping it say it." He leaned forward. "The true song is like that. It's not a story you tell *to* people. It's a story you tell *for* the story. You sing it so that it will be true. So that it will be remembered. So that it will hold."

I thought about that for a long time.

"I don't know how," I said at last.

"Yes you do. You've done it twice already. You just didn't know what you were doing." Skarpi smiled. "That's the trouble with you, Kvothe. You're always doing things before you know how. And then

when you try to do them on purpose, you can't, because you're thinking too hard." He gestured at my lute. "Stop thinking. Sing it again. Not for me. Not for anyone. For Myr Tariniel. For the children in the fountains. Sing it so they'll be remembered."

I looked at him. Then I looked down at my lute. I thought about the children in the fountains, playing in the white city on the last day of its life. I thought about Skarpi, a little boy hiding under a slab of marble, listening to the screaming.

I began to sing.

And this time, when I finished, Skarpi did not say anything at all. He sat on his stone by the fire, with his hands folded on his knees and tears running down his face into his long white beard.

\* \* \*

On the fifth day, he told me about the cost.

We were sitting on the rocks outside the lighthouse, watching the sea. It was a grey day, cold and windy, with low clouds scudding in from the west and the waves breaking white on the rocks below us. Skarpi had brought out the bread and water, and we were eating it slowly, looking at the horizon.

"When you sing the song," he said, "they will come."

"I know."

"No. You don't. You think you know, because they came for your parents. But your parents were singing a piece of it. A fragment. And they came quietly, in the night, in the woods, where no one would see." He looked at me. "You're going to sing the whole of it. In a great hall, before hundreds of people. And the song will be true, and strong, and it will go out into the world like a bell ringing. They will feel it. All of them. Wherever they are. And they will come, and they will not come quietly."

"Then I'll be ready."

"You can't be ready. No one can be ready." He shook his head. "But you can be prepared. That's different."

"How?"

He was quiet for a long time, watching the waves.

"Choose your place carefully," he said at last. "Somewhere with many people, so that the song is heard by many. But somewhere those people can escape, if they need to. Many doors. Open spaces. Somewhere the Seven cannot easily trap them." He paused. "And have friends near. People who know what is coming, and are ready to act."

"And me? What do I do, when they come?"

Skarpi looked at me. His bright eyes were very serious.

"You keep singing," he said. "No matter what. No matter who comes, or what they do, or what they say to you. You keep singing until the song is done. Because if you stop in the middle, the song is broken. And a broken song is worse than no song at all." He paused. "A broken song is a lie."

"And after?"

"After, you run." He smiled faintly. "You're good at that. I've heard."

\* \* \*

On the seventh day, I asked him the question I had been carrying since the first night.

"Why me?" I said. "You've been alive for thousands of years. You've known hundreds of namers, thousands of singers. Why didn't you teach one of them? Why wait for me?"

Skarpi was silent for a long time. We were inside the lighthouse, by the fire, and night was falling outside.

"I did teach them," he said at last. "Many of them. Over many years. Some of them were very good. Better than you, some of them. Better voices, better hands, better hearts." He looked into the fire. "The Chandrian found them all. One by one. Sometimes before they ever sang a note. Sometimes after. But they found them."

"Why didn't they find me?"

"They did. Six years ago. In a forest near the edge of the Commonwealth." Skarpi looked at me. "But they let you live. Because they needed you. Because you are the key." He smiled, a small, bitter smile. "Do you see? It's the one protection no one else ever had. They cannot kill you. Not until you've opened the door. Haliar has

forbidden it."

I sat very still.

"So I'm safe," I said slowly. "From them. As long as I don't open it."

"From death. Not from pain. Not from loss." Skarpi's voice was very quiet. "They'll kill everyone around you, Kvothe. Everyone you love. They'll burn everything you care about. They'll hurt you in every way a person can be hurt, short of killing you. Because they want you broken. They want you desperate. They want you to come to the door on your knees, begging for it to be over." He looked at me. "That's what they did to Lanre, you know. That's how the Thief turned him. Not by force. By grief. By taking everything he loved, one piece at a time, until he would do anything, anything at all, to make it stop."

The fire crackled. Outside, the sea breathed against the rocks.

"You're telling me this," I said, "and you still want me to sing."

"I'm telling you this because you should know," said Skarpi. "Because you deserve to know what it will cost. And because if you're going to do it anyway, you should do it with your eyes open." He paused. "Your mother didn't know, when she started. She thought it was a game. A clever song about an old story. By the time she understood, it was too late."

"Would she have stopped? If she'd known?"

Skarpi looked at me for a long time.

"No," he said. "No, I don't think she would have. She was very stubborn. Like you." He smiled. "But she would have been more careful. She would have hidden you better."

\* \* \*

On the ninth day, I left.

Skarpi walked with me to the end of the rocky spit, where it met the harbor. The morning was clear and bright, and the sea was calm, and the gulls were wheeling and crying over the water.

"Where will you go?" he asked.

"Imre. The Eolian. It's the best place I know for a song to be heard. It has many doors. And I have friends there."

He nodded. "Good. That's good." He was quiet for a moment. "Kvothe. One more thing."

"Yes?"

"The girl. Denna." He looked at me. "She's singing her song too. All over Vintas, now. In the great halls. People are weeping at it. It's very beautiful, they say."

I did not say anything.

"She doesn't know what it is. Not all of it. She knows some of it now, I think. But she's bound, and she's frightened, and she's alone." Skarpi's voice was very gentle. "When you sing your song, she'll hear of it. And she'll come. Bredon will make her. Because a true song and a false song, sung against each other—" He shook his head. "That's a battle. And whichever song is stronger will win."

"Then mine has to be stronger."

"Yes." He looked at me with his bright old eyes. "But remember. She didn't choose this. She's not your enemy. She's a girl with a knot on her wrist, singing because she has to." He paused. "Don't sing against her, Kvothe. Sing for her. There's a difference."

I looked at him for a long moment. Then I nodded.

"I'll remember," I said.

"I know you will." He smiled. "You always remember. That's your gift. And your curse." He reached out and laid his long thin hand on my shoulder. "Go on, then. Go and sing. And when it's over, if you're still alive, come back and tell me how it went."

"Will you be here?"

"I'm always here. Or somewhere." His smile widened. "I'll find you. I always do."

He let go of my shoulder. I turned and began to walk along the harbor toward the piers, where the ships were loading for the morning tide.

When I looked back, a moment later, he was gone. The rocky spit was empty. The broken lighthouse stood alone at the end of it, black against the bright sea.



But on the wind, very faintly, I thought I heard someone singing. An old voice, rich and warm, singing an old song in a language so old it was barely a language at all.

It was the fall of Myr Tariniel. And it was being sung for the children in the fountains.

## Interlude: The Tinker

A bell was ringing on the road outside.

It was a small bell, bright and tinny, and it rang in a steady jingling rhythm, the way a bell rings when it hangs from the harness of a slow-moving donkey. It came closer. And with it, under it, a voice. An old man's voice, cracked and cheerful, singing a song that every child in the four corners of civilization knows.

The innkeeper stopped speaking. For a long moment, he did not move. Then he turned his head and looked toward the door, and something went across his face that Chronicler had not seen there before.

It was fear.

It was only there for a moment. Then it was gone, smoothed away, and the innkeeper was an innkeeper again. He rose from the table and wiped his hands on his apron.

"A tinker," he said. "We haven't had a tinker through in months."

"Reshi," said Bast. He had come out of the kitchen at the sound of the bell, a wooden spoon still in his hand, and he was standing very still in the doorway. "Reshi, don't."

"Don't what, Bast?"

"You know what."

The innkeeper looked at him. His face was mild. "It's a tinker," he said. "The town will want pots mended and needles sold. I'll want salt, and some thread, and news from the road." He smiled faintly. "It's only a tinker."

"There's no such thing," said Bast, "as only a tinker."

The innkeeper did not answer that. He went to the door and opened it.

\* \* \*

The tinker was very old. That was the first thing Chronicler noticed about him, coming to stand beside the innkeeper in the doorway. He was old and bent and brown as a walnut, with a white fringe of hair around a bald brown scalp and a face so wrinkled that it seemed to be made entirely of smiles. He wore a coat that had once been many colors and was now mostly the color of dust. He walked beside a small grey donkey, which was so laden with packs and bundles and dangling pots and pans that it looked like a walking tinker's shop all on its own.

He stopped in the road in front of the Waystone and looked up at the sign. Then he looked at the innkeeper, standing in the doorway. His eyes were very bright, and very black, and very merry.

"Well, well," he said. "An inn. And an innkeeper. And a guest, with ink on his fingers." His eyes flicked to Chronicler, and then past him, into the dim common room, where Bast stood in the kitchen doorway with his spoon. "And another one, too. My, my. It's a regular crowd."

"Welcome to the Waystone," said the innkeeper. "Will you be wanting a room?"

"A room? No, no. Tinkers don't take rooms. We sleep under the sky, like the Ruh, like the birds." The old man chuckled. "But I'd take a drink, if one was offered. And a bit of bread. And a place to spread out my wares, so the good people of this town can come and see what I've brought them." He looked around at the quiet street, the shuttered houses, the empty square. "If there are any good people in this town. It seems very quiet."

"It's a quiet town."

"Hm. Yes. I can see that." The tinker looked at the innkeeper for a long moment. "Quiet towns are the ones with the most to say. You just have to know how to listen."

\* \* \*

He spread out his wares on a blanket in the inn yard, and the people of Newarre came.

They came slowly at first, the way people do in a town that has grown wary of strangers. A woman with a cracked kettle. A man with a knife that needed sharpening. A pair of children who stood at the edge of the yard and stared at the donkey with enormous eyes until the tinker called them over and gave them each a sugared almond from a paper twist in his pocket. Then more came, and more, until it seemed that half the town was crowded into the inn yard, haggling and laughing and holding up pots and ribbons and bright glass beads to the afternoon sun.

The tinker sang as he worked. He sang "Tinker Tanner," of course, but other songs too. Old songs, strange songs, songs in languages Chronicler did not recognize. He mended pots and sharpened knives and sold needles and thread and salt and spices and little bottles of something that he swore would cure anything from gout to heartbreak. He told jokes, very bad ones, and laughed at them himself until he wheezed. He was, Chronicler thought, watching from the door of the inn, the most cheerful man he had ever seen.

And he never once took his bright black eyes off the innkeeper.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper stayed inside. He stood behind the bar and polished glasses that did not need polishing, and he did not go out into the yard. Chronicler sat at his table by the hearth, with his pen and his papers, and watched him.

Bast had come to sit across from Chronicler. He was holding his wooden spoon in both hands, twisting it, and his face was pale.

"What is it?" Chronicler asked quietly. "About the tinker?"

Bast did not answer at first. He watched the innkeeper behind the bar. Then he said, very low, "Do you know the saying? About tinkers?"

"A tinker's debt is always paid," said Chronicler. "Everyone knows that."

"Do you know what it means?"

Chronicler hesitated. "That tinkers are honest? That if you do a tinker a kindness, he'll repay it?"

"That's what people think it means." Bast twisted the spoon. "It means more than that. Tinkers aren't just peddlers. Some of them are. Most of them. But some of them are something else." He looked out the window at the old man in the yard, laughing with a knot of children around him. "Some of them walk the roads because the roads need walking. Because there are debts in the world that need to be paid, and someone has to carry them. And when a tinker comes to your door, it's because something is owed. By you, or to you." He looked back at the innkeeper. "And he's come to collect."

"Collect what?"

Bast did not answer.

\* \* \*

It was near sunset when the tinker came in.

The crowd in the yard had dwindled away. The last of the townsfolk had gone home with their mended pots and their bright new ribbons. The donkey was dozing in the shade of the stable. The tinker packed up his wares, slowly, humming to himself, and then he walked into the common room of the Waystone Inn and went straight to the bar.

"A drink," he said. "If you please. I've been talking all afternoon, and my throat's as dry as a Tehlin's sermon."

The innkeeper poured him a mug of cider. The tinker drank it off in one long swallow and set the mug down on the bar and wiped his mouth with the back of his hand.

"Ah," he said. "That's good cider. Very good. Better than you'd expect, in a town like this." He looked at the innkeeper. "You make it yourself?"

"I buy it from a farmer up the road."

"Hm. Well, he makes good cider." The tinker set a coin on the bar. The innkeeper pushed it back.

"On the house," he said.

The tinker looked at the coin, and then at the innkeeper. His bright black eyes were very merry.

"Now that," he said, "is a kindness. And a tinker never forgets a kindness." He picked up the coin and turned it over in his fingers. Then he held it out. "I'll give you something for it."

"There's no need."

"There's always a need." The tinker smiled. "Hold out your hand." The innkeeper hesitated. Then, slowly, he held out his hand.

The tinker did not put the coin in it. Instead, he reached into the pocket of his dusty coat and took out something small and dark and pressed it into the innkeeper's palm, and closed the innkeeper's fingers over it with both his own brown wrinkled hands.

"There," he said. "That's for you. You'll need it."

The innkeeper looked down at his closed hand. He did not open it.

"What is it?" he said. His voice was very quiet.

"Something you lost," said the tinker. "A long time ago. On the road." He let go of the innkeeper's hand. "I found it, and I've been carrying it ever since, waiting to find you. It's been a very long walk." He smiled. "But a tinker's debt is always paid."

"I don't owe you anything."

"No. You don't." The tinker picked up his empty mug and looked into it. "But someone owed you. A long time ago. And they asked me to carry it for them, until the time was right." He set the mug down. "The time is right."

"Who?"

The tinker looked at him for a long moment with his bright black eyes. Then he reached across the bar and patted the innkeeper's cheek, very gently, the way an old man pats a child.

"You'll know," he said. "When you open your hand."

He turned and walked out of the Waystone Inn. At the door, he paused and looked back, and his eyes found Chronicler, sitting at the table by the hearth with his pen in his hand.

"Write carefully, scribe," he said. "Every word. Every one." His eyes crinkled. "Some stories are very heavy. But they're heavier still if

you drop them halfway."

Then he was gone. They heard the jingle of the donkey's bell in the yard, and the old man's cracked voice singing "Tinker Tanner," fading away down the road, until it was gone.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper stood behind the bar with his hand closed. He did not open it. He stood there for a long time, very still, looking at nothing.

"Reshi," said Bast softly. He had risen from the table and come to stand at the end of the bar. "Reshi. Open it."

The innkeeper did not move.

"Please."

Slowly, the innkeeper opened his hand.

Chronicler, from the table by the hearth, could not see what was in it. He saw only the innkeeper's face, looking down at his open palm. He saw it change. He saw it go very white, and very still, and then crumple, just for a moment, like a paper lantern when the candle inside it goes out.

Then the innkeeper closed his hand again. He put it in the pocket of his apron. He picked up his white cloth and began to polish the bar.

"Supper," he said. His voice was perfectly steady. "The regulars will be here soon. Bast, is the stew ready?"

Bast stared at him. "Reshi—"

"Is the stew ready, Bast?"

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked away.

"Nearly," he said.

"Then go and finish it. And don't forget the thyme."

Bast went into the kitchen. The innkeeper polished the bar. Chronicler sat at his table and looked down at his page, at the half-finished line of cipher where he had stopped writing when the bell began to ring.

After a while, the innkeeper came back to the table and sat down. He did not say anything about the tinker. He did not say anything about what was in his pocket. He folded his hands on the table and looked at Chronicler.

"Where was I?" he said.

"Tarbean," said Chronicler. His voice was not quite steady. "You'd left Skarpi. You were going back to Imre."

"Yes." The innkeeper nodded. "Yes. I was going back to Imre. With no money and a head full of songs." He smiled faintly. "It was a long way to go on no money. I had to work my passage."

His hand, Chronicler noticed, had gone to the pocket of his apron. It rested there, very lightly, over whatever the tinker had given him. As if he wanted to be sure it was still there.

"Go on," said Chronicler.

And Kvothe went on.



## Chapter Sixty

# The Wind's Daughter

The ship was called the *Wind's Daughter*, and she was the ugliest vessel in the harbor of Tarbean.

She was a coastal trader, broad in the beam and low in the water, with patched sails and a hull so thickly crusted with barnacles that she seemed to have grown a second skin. Her paint had worn away years ago. Her rigging was a tangle of old rope and older knots. She listed slightly to port, even at anchor, like a drunk leaning against a wall.

Her captain was a woman named Hessa Tern, and she was the second ugliest thing on the *Wind's Daughter*. She was short and broad and weathered, with a face like a clenched fist and a voice like a gull with a grievance. When I came up the gangplank and asked if she needed a hand for the voyage east, she looked at me the way you might look at a fish that has flopped onto your deck uninvited.

"Can you sail?"

"No."

"Can you cook?"

"Badly."

"Can you fight?"

"Yes."

She looked at my sword. Then at my lute. Then at me.

"And what's that for?" she said, jerking her chin at the lute case.

"Music."

"Music." She snorted. "I've got no use for music. Music doesn't haul line or bail bilge or keep the pirates off." She turned away. "Go

find another ship."

"I can do something else," I said. "Something useful."

She looked back at me over her shoulder. "What?"

I looked up at the patched sails, hanging limp in the still harbor air. Then I looked at her.

"I can call the wind," I said.

\* \* \*

It was not entirely true. I want to be honest about that.

I had called the wind once, at the University, in a moment of cold fury, and it had come roaring at my call and nearly killed a man. Since then, I had never managed it again. Not on purpose. I had heard it, sometimes, at the edges of my mind. I had felt it moving in me, the way you feel a word on the tip of your tongue. But I had never been able to reach out and take hold of it and make it come.

But I had spent nine days with Skarpi, singing the true song. And somewhere in those nine days, something had shifted in me. Something had opened. When I stood on the rocks outside the lighthouse and watched the sea, I could hear the wind the way I had learned to hear stone. Not its name, not quite. But its shape. Its voice. The long restless yes that it said to everything, the way stone said *no*.

I thought, standing on the deck of the *Wind's Daughter* in the still air of the harbor, that I might be able to call it. If I was very quiet. If I did not want it too much.

Hessa Tern looked at me for a long moment. Then she laughed, a harsh barking laugh like a seal.

"Call the wind," she said. "All right, pretty boy. Call it. If you can put wind in my sails, right now, in this dead calm, I'll carry you to Imre for free and feed you on the way. If you can't, you'll swim off my ship and I'll throw your pretty lute after you."

The crew had gathered to watch. A dozen hard-faced men and women, leaning on the rails and grinning. They had heard this sort of thing before, I suspected. Every harbor has its share of charlatans who claim to command the weather.

I set down my lute case. I walked to the bow of the ship and stood there, looking out over the still grey water of the harbor.

I closed my eyes.

I did not reach for the wind. I did not call it. I did not want it. I thought about Skarpi, sitting on the rocks, watching the sea. I thought about the way the wind had moved over the water, restless and endless, going everywhere and nowhere, touching everything and holding nothing.

And after a while, I heard it.

It was far away. Out beyond the harbor mouth, beyond the headland, out on the open sea. It was moving there, the way it always moved. Restless. Curious. Saying yes to everything it touched.

I did not call it. I simply listened to it. And then, very softly, I began to hum.

It was not a song. It was barely a tune. It was the wind's own voice, its long restless yes, hummed back to it the way I had hummed the stone's *no* to the Sleeper. I hummed it the way you would hum to a friend you had not seen in a long time. *Hello. I hear you. I've missed you. Come and see.*

The wind heard me.

\* \* \*

I felt it turn. Far out on the open sea, beyond the headland, I felt it pause in its restless wandering and turn its attention toward the harbor. Toward the ugly ship at anchor, with its limp patched sails. Toward me.

It came.

It came slowly at first. A breath of air across the water, ruffling the grey surface into little cat's-paws. Then stronger. A breeze that lifted my hair and tugged at my cloak. Then stronger still, a steady wind blowing in from the sea, cold and clean and smelling of salt.

The sails of the *Wind's Daughter* stirred. They lifted. They filled.

Behind me, I heard the crew go silent.

I kept humming. I did not open my eyes. The wind was all around me now, moving over me and through me, playing with my hair and

my cloak and the loose ends of the rigging. It was curious about me. It wanted to know who I was, who had called it so politely. It swirled around me like a cat around a stranger's legs, sniffing, testing.

I let it. I did not try to hold it or command it. I only hummed, softly, and let it come and go as it pleased.

And then, very gently, I stopped humming.

The wind did not stop. It kept blowing, steady and strong, filling the sails of the *Wind's Daughter* until they cracked and bellied out against their ropes. But it was not blowing because I told it to. It was blowing because it wanted to. Because it had come to see who was calling, and liked what it found, and decided to stay a while.

I opened my eyes. I turned around.

Hessa Tern was standing on the deck behind me, staring at the sails. Her mouth was open. The crew were staring too, every one of them, at the sails and then at me and then back at the sails.

"Well," said Hessa Tern at last. Her voice was hoarse. "Well, well. Well, God's bloody teeth."

"Do I get my passage?" I said.

She looked at me. Then she began to laugh. She laughed and laughed, bent over with her hands on her knees, until tears ran down her fist of a face.

"Get my ship out of this harbor," she said, when she could speak. "And then you can have anything you want."

\* \* \*

The *Wind's Daughter* sailed east along the coast for eleven days. It should have taken twenty. The wind stayed with us the whole way, steady and strong, filling our sails from dawn to dusk and dusk to dawn. The crew said they had never seen anything like it. Hessa Tern said she had been sailing for thirty years and never had a voyage so fast or so easy.

I did not call the wind again. I did not have to. It seemed content to stay with us, playing in the rigging and whistling through the shrouds. Sometimes, at night, when I was sitting on the deck with my lute, it would come and swirl around me, lifting my hair and tugging at

my sleeves, and I would play for it. Soft songs, restless songs, songs about roads and journeys and places far away. It seemed to like those best.

I spent those eleven days writing.

I had my father's fragments, and the pieces Skarpi had given me, and my own memories of the story. I had the true song in my bones, the way Skarpi had sung it to me in the broken lighthouse. But that song was old. It was in languages no one spoke anymore, in forms no one understood. If I sang it at the Eolian, the way Skarpi had sung it, no one would understand a word.

So I had to make it new. I had to take the old true song and put it into words that people could hear. Into Aturan, and into melodies they would recognize, and into a shape that would hold them in their seats and make them listen. Without losing any of the truth.

It was the hardest thing I have ever done. Harder than learning sympathy, harder than the Ketan, harder than hearing stone. It was like trying to pour the sea into a cup without spilling a drop.

I worked at it every day, from dawn until my eyes gave out. I sat in the bow with my lute across my knees and a sheaf of paper on the deck beside me, weighted down with a belaying pin against the wind. I wrote and crossed out and wrote again. I sang the verses to myself, over and over, until the crew began to hum them as they worked.

And slowly, verse by verse, it began to take shape.

\* \* \*

On the ninth day, we met the pirates.

They came out of the dawn mist off the coast of the Small Kingdoms, three long low ships with black sails and many oars. They came fast, the oars flashing in the grey light, and they came straight for us.

Hessa Tern saw them first. She was standing at the wheel, and she went very pale, and then she began to shout orders in her gull's voice. The crew ran to the rails with pikes and crossbows and belaying pins. Someone rang the ship's bell, a harsh clanging sound that echoed out over the water.

I stood in the bow with my lute in my hands and watched them come.

"Kvothe!" Hessa Tern shouted from the wheel. "Can you give us more wind? Enough to outrun them?"

I thought about it. The wind was still with us, playing in the rigging. But the pirates had oars. They did not need the wind. And they were close, very close, closing fast.

"No," I shouted back. "Not enough."

"Then what the bloody hell can you do?"

I looked at the three black ships, cutting through the grey water toward us. At the oars flashing in the dawn light. At the men crowding the bows, with swords and axes and grappling hooks.

I looked at the wind, playing in our rigging.

And then I looked at the pirates' sails. Black and furled, bound tight to their yards, because they did not need them.

I put down my lute. I walked to the very tip of the bow, where the bowsprit jutted out over the water. I stood there with the spray in my face and the wind in my hair, and I closed my eyes.

*Hello, I hummed to the wind. Hello, friend. Would you like to play a game?*

\* \* \*

It was not a very kind thing I did. I am not proud of it.

I asked the wind to go and look at the pirates' sails. That was all. I did not tell it what to do when it got there. I only asked it to go and look, and to be curious, the way it was always curious. And the wind, which had been bored for nine days playing in our rigging, was delighted to have something new to look at.

It went. It swept across the grey water toward the three black ships, and it found their furled sails, bound tight to their yards. And it was curious. It wanted to know what was inside them. It tugged at them, gently at first, then harder. It worked its fingers into the bindings and pried at them. It pulled and teased and worried at them, the way a cat worries at a ball of string.

The bindings gave way.

All at once, on all three ships, the black sails burst free of their yards. They billowed out, huge and flapping, catching the wind full on. And the wind, delighted, filled them to bursting. It pushed them. It shoved them. It sent the three black ships lurching and heeling over, their oars tangling, their men falling and shouting, their bows swinging wildly away from the *Wind's Daughter* and toward the rocky coast.

I heard the crash of oars snapping. I heard men screaming. I heard the grinding shriek of a hull striking rock.

I opened my eyes.

The three black ships were in chaos. One of them had run aground on a reef near the shore, its hull cracked open, men leaping into the water. The other two were heeled over at crazy angles, their sails flapping wildly, their oars trailing broken in the water. They were drifting away from us, fast, pushed by a wind that had found a new game and did not want to stop.

On the deck of the *Wind's Daughter*, no one spoke.

I turned around. The crew were staring at me. Hessa Tern was staring at me from the wheel. Her face was white.

I walked back along the deck to where I had left my lute. I picked it up. My hands were shaking.

"Go," I said. "While they're busy. Go."

Hessa Tern stared at me for one more moment. Then she began to shout orders again, and the crew ran to obey, and the *Wind's Daughter* swung her ugly bow toward the east and fled.

\* \* \*

No one on the ship spoke to me for the rest of that day. They did not look at me, either, except in quick sidelong glances when they thought I would not notice. They gave me a wide berth when they passed me on the deck. At supper, they left an empty space around me on the bench.

I understood. I had seen the same thing at the University, after I called the wind at Ambrose. People are afraid of what they do not understand. And they are more afraid of it when it has just saved their lives.

That night, Hessa Tern came and found me in the bow. I was sitting with my lute, not playing it, looking out at the dark water.

She stood beside me for a long time without speaking. Then she said, "Who are you?"

"Nobody. A musician."

"Musicians don't sink pirate ships."

"I didn't sink them. The wind did."

"Because you asked it to."

"I asked it to look. It decided what to do on its own."

She was quiet for a long time.

"My mother used to tell me stories," she said at last. "When I was a girl. About the old namers, who could speak to the wind and the sea and the stone. She said they were all gone now. Killed in the old wars, or died out, or went away." She looked at me. "She said if you ever met one, you should be very polite to them. And very careful."

"That's good advice."

"Is it?" She looked out at the dark water. "Should I be careful of you, pretty boy?"

I thought about it. I thought about the three black ships, and the men screaming in the water, and the way the wind had laughed as it pushed them onto the rocks.

"Yes," I said. "I think you should."

She nodded slowly. Then, to my surprise, she sat down beside me on the deck.

"Play something," she said. "Something that'll make me forget I'm afraid."

I looked at her. Then I picked up my lute, and played "Tinker Tanner," with all the silly verses, and after a while, she began to laugh. And after a while longer, some of the crew drifted over, and sat down on the deck around us, and listened. And by the end of the night, they were singing along.

The wind stayed with us all the way to the mouth of the Omethi, and then, as if it could not bear to leave off a good game, up the long brown reaches of the river, pushing the ugly old ship against the



current until the stone bridge rose out of the morning mist ahead of us,  
and I was home.

## Chapter Sixty-One

# The Drowned Bell

On the tenth night aboard the *Wind's Daughter*, the night after the pirates, Hessa Tern told me why she had become a sailor.

We were sitting in the bow, where I always sat, with my lute across my knees and the wind playing in the rigging above us. The crew were asleep, or pretending to be. The sea was calm, black and silver under a half moon. Far off to the north, the coast was a low dark line, with here and there a single light.

"See that?" said Hessa Tern. She pointed with her pipe at one of the lights. It was higher than the others, and brighter, and it did not flicker. "That's the lighthouse at Keth. Where I was born."

I looked at it. A small bright point of light, very far away.

"There's a bell," she said. "Under the water. Off Keth. You can hear it on still nights, if the tide's right. Ringing."

I looked at her. Her fist of a face was very still in the moonlight.

"A bell," I said.

"A church bell. Big one. Bronze. They say it's been there three hundred years." She puffed her pipe. "My grandmother told me about it when I was small. She said there used to be a town there, where the sea is now. A fishing town, with a church and a square and a harbor. Called Old Keth. And the people of Old Keth were greedy. They fished too much, and they didn't give anything back. Not to the sea, not to the poor, not to anyone."

"And the sea took them."

"The sea took them." Hessa Tern nodded. "One night, in a storm. The whole town slid into the water, church and square and harbor and all. And the bell went down with the church, and it's been ringing ever since. Down there. In the dark." She looked at me. "My grandmother said it rings for the drowned. So they'll know the way home."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything. I sat with my lute in my lap and looked at the distant light.

"I didn't believe her," said Hessa Tern. "Of course not. I was a sensible child. I thought it was a story to frighten children away from the water." She smiled thinly. "And then, when I was eleven, my father's boat went out one evening and didn't come back."

The wind moved in the rigging. The sails creaked.

"There wasn't a storm," she said. "It was a calm night. Still. Like this one. My father went out with my two brothers to set the pots, the way he did every evening. And the boat didn't come back. They never found it. Never found any of them." She drew on her pipe. "My mother went mad. Sat on the harbor wall every night for a year, looking out at the water. And one night, I sat with her. And I heard it."

"The bell."

"The bell." Hessa Tern's voice was very quiet. "Very faint. Very far down. Ringing. Slow. Like a church on a feast day." She was silent for a long moment. "My mother heard it too. She turned to me, and she had the strangest look on her face. And she said, *They're home, Hessa. They found the way.*"

\* \* \*

"She died that winter," said Hessa Tern. "Of a cough. And I went to sea the next spring, at twelve, as a ship's boy on a coaster out of Keth. Because I thought—" She stopped.

"You thought you'd find them."

"I thought I'd find the bell." She laughed, a short hard sound. "Stupid. A child's idea. I thought if I could find the bell, I could find the town, and if I could find the town, I could find my father and my

brothers. I thought they'd be down there, in Old Keth, in the drowned square, sitting on the church steps, waiting for me."

"Did you look?"

"For thirty years." She knocked out her pipe on the rail. "Every time I passed Keth. I'd drop anchor off the point, where the bell is supposed to be, on still nights, and listen. And sometimes I'd hear it. And sometimes I wouldn't." She was quiet. "I sent divers down, twice. Paid them good money. They never found anything. Just sand and weed and dark."

"And now?"

"And now I'm old and ugly and I've got a ship that lists to port." She grinned, a fierce crooked grin. "And I still drop anchor off Keth, on still nights, when I'm passing. And I still listen." She looked at me. "Tomorrow night, we'll pass Keth. It'll be still. I can feel it. I'm going to drop anchor."

"Why are you telling me?"

Hessa Tern looked at me for a long moment with her small hard eyes.

"Because you called the wind," she said. "And sank three ships with it. And the crew think you're a devil, and I think you're something else, and I don't know what." She looked out at the distant light. "And because I thought, maybe, a man who can talk to the wind can talk to the sea. And ask it where the bell is."

\* \* \*

I did not know what to say. I did not know how to talk to the sea. I had never tried. The wind had come to me, on the dock at Tarbean, because it was curious, and I had not asked it for anything. The sea was not the wind. The sea was old and deep and very cold, and it did not seem to me to be curious about anything.

But the next night, we dropped anchor off the point at Keth.

It was very still. Hessa Tern had been right. There was no wind at all; the sails hung slack, and the wind that had followed us all the way from Tarbean had gone quiet, the way a dog goes quiet when it lies down to sleep. The sea was flat and black and glassy, and the moon lay

on it like a silver coin.

The crew stood along the rail and did not speak. They had heard the story, all of them. Every sailor on that coast had.

Hessa Tern stood in the bow with her hands on the rail and her face turned toward the water.

I sat on the deck beside her with my lute. I did not play. I closed my eyes, and I let my mind go still, the way I had in the round room at the top of the Rookery, the way I had on the rocks outside Skarpi's lighthouse.

And I listened.

\* \* \*

At first there was nothing. The creak of the hull. The small lapping of the water against it. The breathing of the crew along the rail.

Then, very faint, very far down, something else.

It was not the bell. I want to be honest about that. It was not a sound. It was more like what I had heard in the stone, the patient no, only different. The sea did not say no. It did not say yes, either. It said something I did not have a word for. Something like *always*. Something like *here*. Something like *everything that falls into me is kept*.

I listened to it for a long time. And then, very softly, I began to hum.

Not to the sea. I did not know how. I hummed the only thing I could think of. A lullaby. A Ruh lullaby, the one my mother used to sing. A song for bringing children home.

And far, far below the black glassy water, something rang.

\* \* \*

Everyone on the *Wind's Daughter* heard it. I know, because they told me afterward, every one of them, in hushed voices, as if they were afraid of being overheard.

It was very faint. Very deep. Very slow. A single note, like a great bronze bell struck once, far off, in a church on a feast day. It came up through the water and through the hull and through the soles

of our feet, and it hung in the still air for a long, long time.

And then it rang again.

And again.

Three times. Slow. Like someone at the door, knocking.

Hessa Tern was standing at the rail with both hands gripping it so hard her knuckles were white. Her fist of a face was wet in the moonlight. She did not make a sound.

When the third note had faded, she let go of the rail. She stood very straight.

"Thank you," she said. To the water. Not to me.

And then she turned and walked aft, past the silent crew, and went down into her cabin, and closed the door.

\* \* \*

We weighed anchor at dawn. The wind came back, as if it had only been waiting, and filled the sails, and we went on east along the coast.

Hessa Tern did not speak to me for two days. On the third, she came and sat beside me in the bow, the way she had the night after the pirates. She did not say anything for a long time.

"It didn't ring for me," she said at last. "Not once. In thirty years. I heard it, sometimes. But it never rang when I was listening for it." She looked at me. "It rang for you."

"It rang for them. For your father. Your brothers."

"Did it?"

"I don't know," I said honestly. "I only hummed. I don't know what it heard."

Hessa Tern was quiet for a long time.

"My mother said it rings so the drowned know the way home," she said at last. "I always thought that meant it rang for them. For the drowned. So they could find the church." She looked out at the sea. "But maybe it rings for us. The ones left on the wall. So we'll know they found it."

She did not say anything else. But she did not drop anchor off Keth again, she told me, years later, when we met by chance in a harbor town I will not name. She said she did not need to.

She said she had heard them knock.

## Chapter Sixty-Two

### Imre Again

Being expelled from the University does not mean being banished from Imre. That is a distinction that matters a great deal to students, and not at all to anyone else.

The University and Imre stand on opposite banks of the Omethi, connected by the great stone bridge. They are two towns, with two sets of laws and two sets of magistrates. The masters of the University can expel a student from the University's grounds, bar him from the Archives and the Fishery and the Medica, strike his name from the rolls of the Arcanum. But they cannot stop him from walking across the bridge and buying a pie in Imre. They cannot stop him from sitting in a tavern in Imre, or sleeping in an inn in Imre, or playing his lute in the Eolian.

I had known that when I left. I had thought about it on the road south, and in Severen, and in Renere. I had told myself that it did not matter, because I would not be coming back.

But I came back. Of course I did.

\* \* \*

I walked off the *Wind's Daughter* at the docks on the Imre side of the river on a warm grey morning in late summer. Hessa Tern stood at the top of the gangplank and watched me go. She did not say goodbye. But as I reached the bottom, she called after me.

"Pretty boy!"

I turned.



"If you ever need a ship," she said, "you come find the *Daughter*. You hear me? You come find me. Doesn't matter where you're going or who's chasing you. You come find me."

I looked up at her. At her fist of a face, and her weathered hands on the rail, and the ugly old ship behind her with its patched sails.

"I will," I said.

She nodded once, sharply, and turned away. And I walked up from the docks into the streets of Imre, and I did not look back.

\* \* \*

The first person I saw was Devi.

It was not planned. I did not go looking for her. I was walking up the street toward the Eolian, with my lute on my back and my pack over my shoulder, thinking about nothing in particular, and I came around a corner and there she was, standing outside an apothecary's shop with a basket on her arm.

She saw me. She stopped. Her mouth fell open.

Then she dropped the basket and ran at me and threw her arms around my neck so hard that I staggered backward and nearly fell.

"You *idiot*," she said into my shoulder. "You stupid, stupid *idiot*. Do you know what they're saying about you? Do you have any idea?"

"Some idea."

"They're saying you killed the king of Vintas!" She pulled back and glared at me. Her eyes were wet behind her spectacles. "They're saying you sang him to death! They're saying you're a demon and a witch and a murderer and there's a bounty on your head of five hundred royals! *Five hundred!*"

"That much?"

"Don't you *dare* be flattered." She hit me on the arm, hard. "Don't you dare."

"I'm not flattered."

"You are. I can see it. You're preening." She hit me again. Then she threw her arms around me again, and held on, and I felt her shaking. "I thought you were dead," she whispered. "When we heard. We all thought you were dead."

I held her. I did not know what else to do.

"I'm not dead," I said. "Not yet."

\* \* \*

She took me to her rooms above the butcher's shop. She made me climb the treacherous stairs, and then she made me sit down in a chair, and then she made me drink a cup of something hot and bitter that she said would put the color back in my face. Then she sat down across from me and folded her arms and said, "Tell me."

I told her. Some of it. Enough.

When I was done, she was quiet for a long time.

"You're going to sing it," she said. "The true song. At the Eolian."

"Yes."

"And the Chandrian are going to come."

"Yes."

"And you're going to keep singing, no matter what happens, until the song is done."

"Yes."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she took off her spectacles and rubbed her eyes.

"You know," she said, "when I first met you, I thought you were the most interesting person I'd ever lent money to. I thought you'd do something spectacular someday, and I'd get to watch." She put her spectacles back on. "I didn't think it'd be *this* spectacular."

"Neither did I."

"When?"

"I don't know yet. Soon. I need to finish the song. And I need to talk to Stanchion, and Deoch. And I need—" I hesitated. "I need help, Devi."

She raised an eyebrow. "From me?"

"From everyone."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she smiled her spider's smile.

"Well," she said. "I did tell you you'd need something from me before the year was out."

\* \* \*

Sim and Wil came that evening. Devi sent for them, by some means I never discovered, and they came up the treacherous stairs at dusk, and when they saw me, they stopped in the doorway and stared.

Sim recovered first. He came across the room and grabbed me by the shoulders and looked at me, and his face did something complicated. Then he pulled me into a hug so tight I could not breathe.

"You're alive," he said. "You're alive, you're alive, you're *alive*."

"I'm alive."

"We heard—"

"I know what you heard."

"Is it true? Did you—"

"No," I said. "I didn't kill the king. I tried to save him."

Sim pulled back and looked at me. His eyes were very bright. "I knew it," he said. "I *knew* it. I told everyone. I told Wil, I told Fela, I told everyone who'd listen. I said, Kvothe would never do that. Never. Not in a thousand years."

"Thank you, Sim."

Wil had come into the room behind him. He stood by the door with his hands in his pockets and his dark face unreadable. When Sim finally let go of me, Wil came forward and looked at me for a long moment.

"You look terrible," he said.

"I've had a difficult summer."

"Hm." He was quiet for a moment. Then he held out his hand. When I took it, he pulled me into a brief hard embrace, the way he had the day I left, and then stepped back again. "You still owe me three drinks."

I laughed. It came out of me before I could stop it, a sudden startled laugh, and it felt strange in my throat, as if I had forgotten how.

"I'll pay you back," I said. "Someday."

"You'd better." Wil looked at Devi. "Well? What's the plan?"

Devi looked at me. I looked at Sim and Wil, standing there in her cluttered room, their faces full of worry and loyalty and something I did not have a name for. The kind of look that says, *whatever it is, we're with you.*

I thought about what Skarpi had told me. *They'll kill everyone around you. Everyone you love.*

I thought about telling them to go. To leave. To get as far away from me as they could, and never come back.

And then I thought about the Eolian, full of people. About the Chandrian coming. About needing friends who knew what was coming, and were ready to act.

"Sit down," I said. "All of you. I'm going to tell you a story. And then I'm going to ask you to do something very dangerous."

\* \* \*

I told them.

I told them about Skarpi, and the true song, and the Singers. I told them about Denna's song, and the curse on Lanre, and what would happen if it broke. I did not tell them about the door, or the line, or what I was. That was too much. That was a burden I did not want to put on them.

But I told them enough. And when I was done, I told them what I needed.

"I'm going to sing the song at the Eolian," I said. "Soon. As soon as it's finished. And when I sing it, the Chandrian will come. I don't know how many of them. I don't know what they'll do. But they'll come, and they'll want to stop me."

"Then don't sing it," said Sim. His face was white. "Kvothe, if you know they're coming—"

"I have to sing it. If I don't, the other song wins. And then worse things happen."

"What worse things?"

"Things I can't explain. Not right now." I looked at him. "Please, Sim. I need you to trust me."

Sim looked at me for a long time. Then he swallowed and nodded.

"What do you need?" said Wil.

"I need the Eolian to be ready," I said. "I need people who can get everyone out, fast, when things go wrong. I need the doors to be open, all of them. I need water, lots of water, in case of fire." I paused. "And I need someone who can do sympathy. Good sympathy. Fast. Someone who can hold a binding while everything around them is falling apart."

"I can do that," said Devi.

"So can I," said Wil.

"And me," said Sim, though his voice was shaking.

"And one more thing." I looked at Devi. "Fela. I need Fela."

Devi raised an eyebrow. "Why Fela?"

"Because she knows stone," I said. "And the Eolian is made of stone."

\* \* \*

Fela came the next day.

She came up Devi's treacherous stairs in the afternoon, in a plain grey dress with her dark hair braided, and when she saw me, she stopped in the doorway, the way Sim and Wil had. But she did not run at me or throw her arms around me. She only stood there, looking at me, with her hand pressed flat against the doorframe.

"You came back," she said.

"I came back."

"Did you need it? The stone eye?"

I reached into my pocket and took it out. The little carved eye, smooth and cool, saying its long slow no. I held it up.

"Not yet," I said. "But I think I will."

She looked at it for a long moment. Then she came into the room and sat down across from me.

"Tell me," she said.

I told her. When I was done, she was silent for a long time. Her hands were folded in her lap, and she was looking down at them.

"You want me to hold the Eolian," she said at last. "If they come. If they try to bring it down. You want me to ask the stone to stand."

"Yes."

"I don't know if I can. It's a very big building. And stone doesn't like to be asked for things." She looked up at me. "And if there's fire—real fire, the kind they bring—stone cracks. It can't help it. It's not saying no to fire. It's saying no to change. And fire changes everything."

"I know. I'm asking anyway."

She looked at me with her dark serious eyes.

"You're asking a lot," she said.

"I know."

"You're asking us to risk our lives."

"I know."

"For a song."

"For the true song," I said. "For every song that's ever been sung true. For everyone who died so it could be sung." I looked at her. "Fela, I know it's too much. I know I shouldn't ask. But I don't have anyone else."

She was quiet for a long time. Then she reached out and took the stone eye from my hand, and held it, and closed her fingers around it.

"All right," she said. "I'll hold it. As long as I can." She gave the eye back to me. "But you'd better sing well, Kvothe. You'd better sing better than you've ever sung in your life."

"I will."

"Promise me."

"I promise."

She smiled faintly.

"You always say that," she said. "And then you do something mad instead."

"This time I'll do both."

She laughed. It was a small, surprised laugh, and it made her look younger.

"That," she said, "I believe."

I stayed with Devi. She had a small room at the back of her apartment, barely more than a closet, with a narrow cot and a window that looked out over the rooftops of Imre. She gave it to me without asking and without charging, which was so unlike Devi that I almost worried she was ill.

"Don't read anything into it," she said, when I tried to thank her. "It's an investment. If you survive this, you'll be famous. And famous people pay their debts." She smiled her spider's smile. "Eventually."

I spent the next nine days finishing the song.

I worked on it day and night, in Devi's little back room, with the window open and the sounds of Imre drifting in. I worked on it at the table in Devi's main room while she worked at her alchemical bench and pretended not to listen. I worked on it on the roof, at night, under the stars. I worked on it until my fingers bled and my voice cracked and my eyes burned from lack of sleep.

Threpe came, the third day. Devi had sent for him too; she seemed to know everyone. He burst into her rooms in a coat of such a violent shade of purple that it made my eyes water, and he threw his arms around me and wept and laughed and said he had known, he had always known, that I would come back and do something magnificent. He brought me paper, and ink, and a bottle of very good wine, and a stack of old books and scrolls from the private libraries of his friends, full of fragments of old songs and old stories that I had never seen before.

"It's everything I could find," he said. "Everything about Lanre, and Selitos, and the fall of the white city. Some of it's in languages I can't read. Some of it's probably nonsense. But it's all yours." He looked at me with shining eyes. "Is it true? Are you really going to sing the true story? At the Eolian?"

"Yes."

"When?"

"Soon."

He clapped his hands. "Oh, I'll be there. I'll be in the front row. I'll bring everyone. Everyone who matters." His face fell slightly. "Is it true there's a bounty on your head?"

"Yes."

"Five hundred royals?"

"So I'm told."

"Hm." Threpe looked thoughtful. "Well. I suppose we'll have to make sure no one collects it." He smiled brightly. "I'll bring my guards too."

\* \* \*

On the ninth night, I finished.

It was very late, well past midnight. I was sitting on Devi's roof, under the stars, with my lute in my lap and a sheaf of paper beside me, weighted down with a loose slate. I played the last verse. I sang the last line. And then I sat there in the silence, with my hands resting on the strings, and I knew it was done.

It was not perfect. No song ever is. There were places where the words did not quite fit the melody, and places where the melody did not quite carry the words. There were pieces of the story I had left out, because they were too long or too strange or too terrible to put into a song. There were pieces I had changed, a little, to make them fit.

But it was true. At the bottom, where the truth lives, it was true. It was the fall of Myr Tariniel, and the betrayal at Drossen Tor, and Lyra, and Lanre's grief, and Selitos weeping among the ruins. It was the Thief and his stolen moon and the war that followed. It was all of it, the whole of it, as true as I could make it.

I called it "Tariniel." After the white city. After the children in the fountains.

I sat on the roof for a long time after I finished, looking up at the stars. They were very bright, and very far away, and very cold.

Somewhere out there, Denna was singing her song. In some great hall in Vintas, before some lord and his court, with her harp in her lap and a knot on her wrist. Singing a beautiful lie about a man who was wronged.



And soon, very soon, I would sing mine. And we would see which one was stronger.

I did not light Kilvin's candle that night. I did not want to know what color it would burn.

## Chapter Sixty-Three

### Deoch

Deoch came to find me on the sixth night of the nine I spent finishing *Tariniel*. He did not come to Devi's rooms. He did not know about them. He came to the roof.

I was sitting on the ridge of Devi's roof, above the butcher's shop, with my lute and my papers and a candle stub in a jar. It was very late. The streets of Imre were empty and dark below me. I was working on the verse about Lyra, the one I had found in the Countess Laverne's green book, and it would not come right.

And then there was a scraping sound on the slates behind me, and a grunt, and a curse, and Deoch's handsome face appeared over the edge of the roof, red with effort.

"God's teeth," he said. "How do you do this? Every night? You're mad."

"Probably."

He hauled himself up onto the slates and sat down beside me on the ridge, breathing hard. He was a big man, Deoch, broad-shouldered and easy-moving, and he was not made for rooftops. He looked down at the street far below and went a little pale.

"How did you find me?"

"I asked Threpe. Threpe asked Devi. Devi told Threpe to tell me that if I fell off her roof and died she'd charge my estate for the cleanup." He grinned weakly. "She's a charming woman."

"She is, actually."

"I know. That's what frightens me." He looked at me. "Can I talk to you? About something?"

I set down my lute.

\* \* \*

He did not say anything for a long time. He sat on the ridge of the roof with his big hands clasped between his knees and looked out at the dark rooftops of Imre.

"Denna," he said at last.

I waited.

"You know I knew her before you," he said. "Before anyone, almost. When she first came to Imre. She was fifteen, maybe sixteen. She sang for coppers outside the Eolian. Stanchion wouldn't let her in; she was too young, and she didn't have any pipes." He smiled faintly. "I used to bring her out a cup of cider and a heel of bread. Between sets. She'd sit on the step and eat it, and we'd talk."

"You loved her."

"Everyone loves her." Deoch did not look at me. "That's the trouble with Denna. Everyone loves her, and no one can keep her. She comes and she goes, and every time she comes back, you think, *this time*. And every time, she goes again." He was quiet for a moment. "I stopped hoping, after a year or so. I thought I'd stopped. I thought I'd got over it."

"And?"

He laughed softly. "And then she came to the Eolian tonight."

I went very still.

"Not in," said Deoch. "Not to sing. She came to the back door, late, after closing. Where I used to bring her cider." He looked at me. "She was wearing a dark cloak with a hood. She wouldn't come in. She stood in the alley and she asked me if you were in Imre."

"What did you tell her?"

"I told her yes." Deoch looked at his hands. "I told her you were going to sing a song at the Eolian at the dark of the moon. She already knew. She'd seen the posters." He was quiet for a long moment. "She asked me not to tell you she'd come. Then she asked me to tell you."

"Which was it?"

"Both." Deoch smiled crookedly. "That's Denna. She always means both."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long time. I sat on the ridge of the roof and looked out at the dark rooftops, and I thought about Denna in an alley behind the Eolian, in a hooded cloak, asking about me.

*Don't tell him. Tell him.*

"Was she all right?" I said at last.

Deoch thought about it.

"No," he said. "I don't think so. She looked thin. Tired. There was something on her wrist; she kept touching it, the whole time we talked, like it hurt." He looked at me. "And she was frightened, Kvothe. I've seen Denna a lot of ways, in three years. Sad and angry and drunk and silly. I've never seen her frightened. Not like that."

"What did she say?"

"Not much. She asked about you. And then she said—" Deoch hesitated. "She said, *He's going to do something brave and stupid, isn't he?* And I said yes, probably, that's what you do. And she laughed, the way people laugh when they want to cry. And she said, *Then I have to be there. I have to. Even if—*"

He stopped.

"Even if what?"

"She didn't finish." Deoch looked at me. "She just touched the thing on her wrist again, and went away up the alley, and didn't look back."

\* \* \*

We sat on the roof for a long time after that. Neither of us said anything. Below us, a cat crossed the street, very slowly, and disappeared into an alley. Far off, a watchman called the hour.

"Why tell me?" I said at last.

Deoch did not answer right away.

"Because she's in trouble," he said. "Real trouble. The kind I can't help with. The kind that frightens her." He looked at me. "And you're the only one I've ever seen her look at like she looks at you."

"How does she look at me?"

Deoch was quiet for a long moment. Then he smiled. It was a sad smile, and a fond one, and it made him look older.

"Like you're a door," he said. "And she's standing outside it in the rain. And she wants to come in more than anything in the world. And she's afraid that if she does, she'll never be able to leave."

I did not say anything. I could not.

"I never got that look," said Deoch. "Not once. Three years. I got fond looks, and grateful looks, and *you're so sweet, Deoch* looks." He laughed softly. "I got a lot of cider drunk. But I never got that look." He stood up, carefully, balancing on the ridge with his arms out. "So I thought you should know she's here. And that she's frightened. And that she's going to be at the Eolian, the night you sing, whatever happens."

"Thank you, Deoch."

"Don't thank me." He looked down at me. "Just keep her safe. If you can. Whatever it is. Whatever's hurting her wrist." His voice was very quiet. "Someone should. And it was never going to be me."

\* \* \*

He climbed down off the roof, very slowly, cursing the whole way. I heard him land in the alley below with a thump and a groan, and then his footsteps, going away.

I sat on the ridge of Devi's roof until the candle in the jar burned out. And then I picked up my lute and my papers, in the dark, and I went back to the verse about Lyra.

It came right, that night. All at once. The way things sometimes do, after you have stopped trying.

*Then I will always sing to you. So that if you ever go back to that quiet, you will hear me, and come home.*

I sang it, three nights later, in the Eolian, with the candles burning blue. I sang it looking at no one. Not at the balconies, not at the crowd,

not at the shadow in the center of the room.

But I knew she was there. On the first balcony, beside a white-haired man with a stick. With her hand pressed against her wrist.

And I think she knew who it was for.

## Chapter Sixty-Four

# Preparations

Stanchion did not want me to sing it.

"Five hundred royals," he said. He was standing behind the bar of the Eolian in the grey hour before opening, with a rag in one hand and a glass in the other, and he was not polishing either one. "Five hundred royals on your head, Kvothe. Do you know how many people in Imre would sell their own mothers for five hundred royals?"

"Most of them, I'd imagine."

"All of them. Every last one." He set down the glass. "And you want me to put you on my stage. In front of everyone. With your hair shining like a bonfire under the lamps."

"Yes."

"And you want me to put up posters. All over town. Telling everyone exactly when and where you'll be."

"Yes."

He stared at me. Stanchion was a big man, broad and bearded, and when he stared at you it was like being stared at by a bear that has just been told a joke it does not find funny.

"You've gone mad," he said. "That's it. You've been out in the world too long, and it's cooked your brains."

"Probably."

"Why?" He leaned on the bar. "Why here? Why now? Why like this? If you want to sing some song, fine. Sing it. Sing it in a barn in the Commonwealth where nobody knows you. Sing it on a ship. Sing it to the fish. Why do you have to sing it here, with posters, in front of

every bounty hunter from here to Atur?"

I looked at him for a long moment. Then I told him. Not all of it. But enough.

When I was done, Stanchion was quiet for a long time. He picked up the glass again and turned it over in his big hands, looking at it as if it held some answer.

"The Chandrian," he said at last.

"Yes."

"The real ones. From the stories."

"Yes."

"And you want to sing a song that'll bring them here. To my place."

"I don't *want* to. I have to." I leaned forward. "Stanchion, the Eolian is the best place I know. It's round, with doors all the way around. It's built of stone. It's got the best acoustics in the Four Corners. When a song is sung here, it's heard. Truly heard. Not just by the people in the room, but—" I stopped. I did not know how to explain it. "It goes out. Into the world. Like a bell ringing."

"And that's what you need."

"That's what the song needs."

He looked at me for a long time. Then he set the glass down very carefully on the bar.

"I've owned this place for twenty-two years," he said. "I built it up from nothing. When I bought it, it was a stable. A stable, Kvothe. Horse dung on the floor and rats in the rafters. I cleaned it out with my own two hands. I laid every stone in that stage myself." He looked out at the empty room, the tables and chairs, the balconies circling above. "It's the only thing I've ever made that mattered."

"I know."

"And you're asking me to risk it."

"Yes."

He was silent for a very long time. Then he sighed, a great heavy sigh that seemed to come up from the soles of his boots.



"Tehlu's balls," he said. "All right. All right. But I want water. Barrels of it, all around the room. And buckets. And I want every door open, and a man on every door, and I want Deoch on the front door with his big stick." He glared at me. "And if my place burns down, you're paying to rebuild it. Every stone."

"Every stone," I said.

\* \* \*

Deoch did not argue. He only looked at me for a long time, with that easy handsome face of his gone very still, and then he nodded and said, "When?"

"Four days. At the dark of the moon."

He nodded again. "I'll be there." He hesitated. "Kvothe. Denna. Will she come?"

I looked at him. Deoch had known Denna longer than I had. He had loved her, once, or thought he did. I had never been sure how he felt about her now.

"I think so," I said. "I think she'll be made to."

His face tightened. "Made to."

"It's complicated."

"It's always complicated, with her." He looked away. "Is she in trouble?"

"Yes."

"The kind you can help with?"

"I don't know. I'm going to try."

Deoch was quiet for a long moment. Then he said, very softly, "Good. Somebody should."

\* \* \*

The posters went up the next day. Threpe had them printed on good paper, with his own coat of arms at the top, and he had them pasted up on every wall and door and lamppost in Imre. They were very simple. They said:

*At the dark of the moon, at the Eolian, the Ruh Kvothe will sing a new song.*

"*Tariniel.*"

*The true story of the fall of the white city.*

That was all. No price, no time, no mention of bounties or kings or anything else. Threpe had wanted to say more. He had wanted to say *the greatest song of the age* and *not to be missed* and a dozen other things. I had made him take them out.

"Just the truth," I told him. "That's all it needs."

By noon, everyone in Imre was talking about it. By evening, everyone at the University was talking about it too. Students crossed the bridge in droves to look at the posters and argue about them. Some said I was mad. Some said I was a murderer who should be arrested on sight. Some said I was a hero, falsely accused, come back to clear my name. Some said the song was a trap, and that the whole thing was a trick by the Maer of Severen to lure the new king of Vintas's men into Imre and kill them.

Nobody said anything about the Chandrian. Nobody knew to.

\* \* \*

On the second day, Elodin came.

I was sitting on Devi's roof in the late afternoon, going over the last verses of the song for the hundredth time, when I heard a sound behind me. I turned. Elodin was sitting on the ridge of the roof a few feet away, his legs dangling, eating an apple. I had not heard him climb up. I had not heard anything.

"Hello, Kvothe," he said.

"Master Elodin."

"Not your master anymore. You've been expelled." He took a bite of apple. "Just Elodin. Or, if you prefer, that mad old bastard from across the river. That's what most people call me."

I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.

He chewed his apple for a while, looking out over the rooftops of Imre. Then he said, "I saw the posters."

"I thought you might."

"Everyone's seen them. The whole University is buzzing like a kicked hive." He glanced at me. "Lorren is very unhappy. He came to

see me this morning, to ask if I knew what you were planning. He was very pale. I don't think I've ever seen Lorren pale before."

"What did you tell him?"

"That I had no idea what you were planning, which was true. And that whatever it was, it was probably very foolish, which was also true." He took another bite of apple. "Then he asked me if I thought he should do something about it. Send the constables. Have you arrested. Something."

"And?"

"And I told him that if he did, I'd set his beard on fire." Elodin smiled faintly. "He went away after that."

I stared at him. "Why?"

"Why what?"

"Why would you do that? You voted to expel me."

"I did." He looked at me. "I voted to expel you because you needed to be somewhere other than on top of that door. You still do. But you're not on top of it now. You're across the river, singing songs." He shrugged. "That's not a crime. Not even at the University."

We sat in silence for a while. The sun was going down, painting the rooftops of Imre with gold and red.

"The song," Elodin said at last. "The one on the posters. *Tariniel*. What is it?"

I looked at him for a long moment. Then I told him.

Not all of it. Not about Skarpi, or the Singers, or the line. But about the true song, and the curse, and the false song Denna was singing. I told him what I thought would happen when I sang it.

Elodin listened without interrupting. When I was done, he was quiet for a long time. He had finished his apple, and he was turning the core over and over in his fingers.

"That's very dangerous," he said at last.

"I know."

"No. You don't." He looked at me, and his dark eyes were very serious. "You think you know. You think it's dangerous because they'll come and try to kill you. But that's not the danger. That's just the risk."

He tossed the apple core out over the edge of the roof. We both watched it fall. "The danger is the song itself."

"What do you mean?"

"A true song, sung truly, is a kind of naming." Elodin's voice was very quiet. "You know that. You've done it. You sang the Sleeper to sleep, and you sang the knots out of a king's hair. You've been naming with your voice, Kvothe, whether you knew it or not." He looked at me. "And you want to sing the true name of Lanre's story. The whole of it. In front of hundreds of people. With every ounce of skill and heart you have."

"Yes."

"Do you know what happens when you speak a name that large? That old? That full of power?" He shook his head. "It doesn't just go out into the world. It goes *through* you. It uses you. It burns through you like fire through dry grass." He paused. "I've seen it happen. I've seen namers speak names that were too big for them. Some of them went mad. Some of them died. Some of them—" He stopped.

"Some of them what?"

He was quiet for a long time.

"Some of them forgot who they were," he said at last. "The name was so big, and so true, that it filled them up. It pushed out everything else. Their own names, their own selves. When it was over, they were empty. Just shells, with the shape of a person and nothing inside." He looked away, out over the rooftops. "I know a little something about that."

I looked at him. At his lean face and his dark restless eyes, and the faint lines of old pain around his mouth.

"Elodin," I said. "What happened to you?"

He did not answer for a long time. Then he stood up, all at once, balancing on the ridge of the roof as if it were solid ground.

"Ask me after," he said. "If you're still yourself. I'll tell you then."

"And if I'm not?"

He looked down at me. For a moment, just a moment, his face was very gentle.

"Then it won't matter," he said. "Will it?"

He turned to go. Then he stopped and looked back.

"Hold onto something," he said. "When you sing. Something small. Something that's yours. Something that reminds you who you are." He paused. "A name is a big thing. But it's easier to hold onto a small one."

Then he walked away along the ridge of the roof, and dropped down over the edge, and was gone.

\* \* \*

I sat on the roof until the sun went down. I thought about what he had said. About the song going through me. About forgetting who I was.

I took out the things I carried. I laid them on the slates in front of me, one by one, in the last of the light.

Kilvin's candle, in its wooden box.

The scrap of the Dellers' knotted cloth.

The page from the Book of Watches, folded small.

Fela's stone eye.

And Denna's knots. Both of them. The one she had left me at the Grey Man, the first one, with *road* and *promise* and *a story told many times*. And the one she had left me on the table in Severen, with *forgive* and *keep* and *safe*.

I looked at them for a long time. Then I picked up the first knot, the one from the Grey Man. The one she had given me before any of it. Before the box and the garden and the knots in the king's hair. When she was only a girl I loved, teaching me to read her secret language.

I held it in my palm. I felt it, very faintly. The tightening in the air. The sense of something reaching out and catching hold.

It held.

I tied it to a length of thread and hung it around my neck, under my shirt, against my skin. It lay there, small and light, over my heart.

*Something small. Something that's yours.*

It was not mine, exactly. But it was the closest thing I had.

\* \* \*

On the third day, there was news from Vintas.

It came by way of a merchant who had just arrived in Imre from Renere, and who told it in the common room of the Grey Man to anyone who would listen. Devi heard it from a friend who had been there, and she came home and told me, standing in the doorway of my little back room with her face very white.

King Ambrose of Vintas had declared the Maer of Severen a traitor to the crown. He had stripped him of his lands and titles and ordered his arrest. He had called his banners, and the banners of every lord who owed him fealty, and he was marching south toward Severen with an army of ten thousand men.

The Maer had called his own banners in reply. He had refused to surrender. He had closed the gates of Severen and was preparing for a siege.

It was war. Civil war, in Vintas. The first in two hundred years.

"And there's more," said Devi. She hesitated. "The merchant said—he said there's a singer traveling with the king's court. A young woman. Very beautiful. She's been singing a song about Lanre in every town they pass through, and people are weeping in the streets." She looked at me. "He said the king calls her his nightingale. And that an old man with a walking stick is always at her side."

I sat very still on my narrow cot.

"Is she coming here?" I said.

"The merchant didn't know. But he said the king's court has an envoy in Imre. A lord, sent to negotiate with the Commonwealth for supplies and loans. The envoy arrived yesterday." Devi's voice was very quiet. "He brought a singer with him. For entertainment."

I closed my eyes.

Of course. Of course he had. The board was set. The stones were placed. Bredon had heard about my posters, about the song and the Eolian and the dark of the moon, and he had sent Denna here to meet me. To sing her song against mine.

*A true song and a false song, sung against each other, Skarpi had said. That's a battle. And whichever song is stronger will win.*

"Kvothe?" said Devi. "Are you all right?"

I opened my eyes. I looked at her.

"Tomorrow night," I said. "At the Eolian. She'll be there."

"How do you know?"

"Because he wants her to be," I said. "Because it's the move he'd make. It's the beautiful one."

Devi looked at me for a long moment.

"Then you'd better be more beautiful," she said.

## Chapter Sixty-Five

# Two Songs

The Eolian was full by sundown.

I had never seen it so full. Not on the night I won my pipes, not on the busiest night of the year, not ever. People were packed shoulder to shoulder on the main floor, crowded around every table, standing along every wall. The balconies were so full that Stanchion had posted men at the top of every stair to keep anyone else from going up, for fear the old wood would give way. People were sitting on the edge of the stage. People were sitting on the bar. People were standing outside in the street, crowded around every open door and window, craning their necks to see in.

Stanchion had done everything I asked. Every door stood open, all the way around the great round room, and there was a man at every door. Barrels of water stood along the walls, with buckets hanging from their rims. Deoch stood at the main door with a stout oak staff in his hands and a look on his face that made even the drunkest students think twice about pushing past him.

My friends were in their places. Devi was on the first balcony, directly above the stage, with a satchel full of things she had spent four days making and would not tell me about. Wil was on the second balcony, across the room, near the north door. Sim was on the main floor, near the south door, with a candle in a lantern and a look of terrified determination on his face.

And Fela was in the cellar.



I had not asked her to go there. She had chosen it herself. "The foundations," she had said. "That's where the stone is strongest. That's where I can hear it best." She had gone down the cellar stairs an hour before sunset with a lantern and a blanket and nothing else, and she had not come up since.

I did not know if she could do what I had asked. I did not know if anyone could. But she had gone.

\* \* \*

I waited in Stanchion's office behind the bar, with the door closed and my lute in my lap, and listened to the noise of the crowd through the wall. It was like the sea. A great restless roar, rising and falling.

I was not nervous. I want to be honest about that. I had played in the Eolian many times, before crowds almost as large. I had played before the Maer and his court. I had played for Felurian, which is a thing that would make any musician nervous, and I had survived it.

I was not nervous. I was something else. Something that did not have a name.

It was like standing at the top of a very high cliff, looking down at the sea far below, knowing that you are going to jump. Not afraid, exactly. Not excited, exactly. Just very, very aware. Of everything. Of every breath, every heartbeat, every tiny movement of the air.

I sat in Stanchion's office and tuned my lute. I tuned it three times. It did not need tuning. But it gave my hands something to do.

Then there was a knock on the door, and Stanchion put his head in. His face was very strange.

"She's here," he said.

I did not ask who. I did not have to.

\* \* \*

She was on the stage when I came out.

I had not expected that. I had thought she would sit in the balconies, with the envoy from Vintas and his retinue. I had thought she would wait for me to sing, and then answer. But she was on the stage, sitting on a stool at the very center of it, with her harp in her lap.

She looked beautiful. She always looked beautiful. But there was something different about her now. She was dressed in black silk, very fine and very expensive, cut close to her body. Her hair was braided in an intricate crown around her head, and there were cords woven into it, dark cords knotted in patterns I could not read from where I stood. Her face was pale and composed and very still.

And on her wrist, the knot. I could see it from across the room. It was not glowing. But it was there.

The crowd had gone quiet when she came out. They had not expected her either. They were staring at her, and whispering, and some of them were pointing. I heard her name, and other names. Dianne. Dinael. The king's nightingale.

She looked up. Across the crowded room, over the heads of hundreds of people, her eyes found mine.

For a long moment, neither of us moved.

Then she looked away. She looked up at the first balcony, where a man in the rich clothes of a Vintish lord sat with a glass of wine in his hand. The envoy, I supposed. And beside him, in the shadows, a figure I could not quite see. Tall and white-haired, leaning on a stick.

Denna looked back down at her harp. She laid her fingers on the strings.

And she began to sing.

\* \* \*

I will not tell you her song. It is not mine to tell. And even now, after everything, I cannot bring myself to repeat it. It was too beautiful, and too terrible, and too much a part of her.

But I will tell you what it was like.

It was like being in love. Truly in love, the first time, when you are young and everything is new. It was like the moment when you look at someone and realize that you would do anything for them, anything at all, and that the world has changed its shape around them without your noticing. It was warm and sweet and aching and full of longing.

It was about Lanre. Of course it was. It was about a great hero, the greatest who ever lived, who loved a woman more than light, more than breath. Who fought for his people and bled for them and died for them. Who was brought back from death by his wife's love, and then betrayed. Betrayed by the people he had saved, by the friends he had trusted, by a jealous old man with one eye who could not bear to see him happy.

It was about grief. About a man whose wife was taken from him by the cruelty of others, and who wept for her until his tears turned to ash. About a man who was cursed for his grief, punished for his love, damned forever for the crime of caring too much.

It was about injustice. About a lie told so long and so often that it had become the truth. About a hero turned into a monster by the stories of his enemies.

And it was beautiful. God help me, it was so beautiful.

I stood at the edge of the stage and listened, and I felt it working on me. Felt it slipping in under my defenses, the way water slips into cracks in stone. I felt myself begin to believe it. To feel sorry for Lanre. To feel angry at Selitos, and the Amyr, and everyone who had told the old story.

I looked around the Eolian. The crowd was silent, enraptured. People were weeping. Great strong men, with tears running down their faces. Old women, clutching each other's hands. Students, with their mouths open and their eyes shining. They were all feeling it. All believing it. All being changed by it, a little, in some small deep place they would never notice.

And I understood, standing there, what Skarpi had meant. About the song being a crack in the wall. Every person in this room who heard it, who wept at it, who went home and thought about poor wronged Lanre as they fell asleep—every one of them was a crack. A tiny weakness. A place where the truth had been worn away and replaced with something prettier.

And there were hundreds of them. Here, tonight. And thousands more, in all the towns and cities and halls where she had sung it.

The curse was bleeding away. I could almost feel it.

\* \* \*

She finished. The last note hung in the air for a long moment, trembling, and then faded.

The Eolian was silent. Utterly, completely silent. Not a cough, not a whisper, not a creak of a chair. It was the silence that comes after something so beautiful that people do not know how to respond to it.

Then the applause came. It came like a storm breaking. It thundered down from the balconies and rolled across the floor and shook the walls. People were on their feet, shouting, stamping, weeping. It went on and on.

Denna did not smile. She did not bow. She sat on her stool with her harp in her lap and her head bowed, and she did not move.

When the applause finally began to fade, she stood up. She picked up her harp. And she walked off the stage, past me, very close.

As she passed, she turned her head, just slightly. Her eyes met mine. They were wet.

"I'm sorry," she whispered. So softly that only I could hear.

Then she was gone, up the stairs to the first balcony, where the envoy and the white-haired man were waiting.

\* \* \*

I walked out onto the stage.

The crowd saw me and began to murmur. A ripple of sound went through the room, whispers and exclamations. *The Ruh. The kingkiller. That's him.* I heard someone laugh. I heard someone else hiss.

I did not look at them. I sat down on the stool Denna had left, still warm from her, and I laid my lute across my knees.

I closed my eyes. I thought about what Skarpi had said. *Don't sing against her. Sing for her.*

I thought about what Elodin had said. *Hold onto something. Something small.*

I touched the knot hanging around my neck, under my shirt. The one she had given me at the Grey Man, before everything. *Road.*

*Promise. A story told many times, and changes in the telling.*

And then I opened my eyes, and I began to play.

\* \* \*

I began with the white city.

Not with Lanre. Not with the war, or the betrayal, or the curse. With Myr Tariniel, on the last day of its life. With the white towers rising against a blue sky, and the gardens full of flowers, and the fountains full of children playing. With a woman singing in the great hall, her voice rising like a bird. With a little boy hiding under a slab of white marble, listening.

I sang it the way Skarpi had taught me. Not to be heard. Not to be applauded. For the city. For the children. So that they would be remembered.

And the Eolian went quiet.

I felt it happen. The murmuring stopped. The hissing stopped. The whole great round room went still, the way a forest goes still when the wind dies. I did not look up. I did not look at the crowd. I kept my eyes on my lute, on my fingers moving on the strings, and I sang the white city into being.

And then I sang Lanre.

Not the Lanre of Denna's song. Not the wronged hero. Not the monster of the Tehlin sermons either. The true Lanre. A man. A great man, a brave man, a man who loved his wife more than light and more than breath. A man who fought for his people and bled for them and died for them at Drossen Tor, and was brought back by his wife's voice speaking his name.

I sang his love for Lyra. I sang it so that everyone in the room could feel it, the way I had felt it in the broken lighthouse when Skarpi sang it to me. I sang their happiness, and their fear, and their grief.

I sang Lyra's death. How she was taken, in the war, not by Selitos or the Amyr or any of Lanre's friends, but by the war itself. By the shapers and the thing they had made of the world. How Lanre held her body in his arms and called her name, as she had called his, and she did not answer.

And I sang what came next.

I sang the Thief. The one who stole the moon. How he came to Lanre in his grief, in the dark, and whispered to him. *I can bring her back. I can shape a world where she lives. But first, this world must end.*

I sang Lanre's choice. How he believed the Thief. How he wanted to believe. How grief can make a man believe anything, if it promises to end the grief.

I sang Myr Tariniel burning.

\* \* \*

The crowd was silent. I could hear people weeping, but it was different weeping than before. It was not the sweet ache of Denna's song. It was harder. Deeper. It was the weeping of people who have been shown something true and terrible and cannot look away.

I sang Selitos, standing among the ruins with his bleeding eye. I sang the curse. I sang Lanre's question, *why did you not kill me*, and Selitos's answer, and Lanre's laughter like a cracked bell.

And then I sang Selitos weeping.

I sang it softly. So softly that the people at the back of the room had to lean forward to hear. I sang an old man alone among the ashes of everything he loved, looking into himself and seeing what he had become. I sang his grief, and his rage, and his shame. I sang the little boy he dug out of the rubble, and the question he asked him, and the answer the boy gave.

*I want to be a singer. Like my mother.*

\* \* \*

I was nearly at the end. The last verses. The founding of the Singers, and the Amyr, and the sealing of the doors. I could feel the song building in me, rising toward its close, like a wave rising toward the shore.

I could feel something else, too.

It had started, I think, somewhere around Lyra's death. A pressure. A fullness. As if the song were growing larger inside me than

I was. As if it were filling me up, the way water fills a cup. Every verse I sang made it grow. Every note. Every word.

I remembered what Elodin had said. *It doesn't just go out into the world. It goes through you. It uses you.*

I felt it using me. I felt it pushing at the edges of me, pressing against the inside of my skin. I felt myself getting smaller, and the song getting larger, until I was only a thin shell around something vast and old and true.

I held onto the knot around my neck. I held onto it with everything I had. *Road. Promise. A story told many times.*

I kept singing.

And that was when the candles began to burn blue.

## Chapter Sixty-Six

# Cold

It began with the candles on the tables nearest the stage.

I saw it from the corner of my eye. A flicker. A change in the color of the light. The warm yellow glow that lit the edge of the stage went pale, and then paler, and then it was blue. A deep, cold, winter-dusk blue, the color of a bruise, the color of the candle in Kilvin's box on the night of the Deller farm.

Then the candles on the next ring of tables. And the next. And the next. A ripple of blue spreading outward from the stage like a stone dropped in a pond. Up the walls. Along the balconies. Into the great iron chandeliers that hung from the ceiling, until every flame in the Eolian was burning blue.

And the cold came.

It came all at once, like a door opening onto winter. My breath smoked in the air. Frost bloomed on the glasses on the tables, on the brass rails of the balconies, on the strings of my lute beneath my fingers. The wine in people's cups went cloudy and thick. Someone's breath caught in a gasp that turned to a white plume.

The crowd noticed. Of course they noticed. There was a rustle, a stir, a murmur that grew rapidly toward something louder. People turned in their seats to look at the candles. People stood up. Someone laughed nervously, and then stopped laughing.

I did not stop singing.

*You keep singing, Skarpi had said. No matter what. No matter who comes.*



I kept singing.

\* \* \*

I sang the founding of the Amyr. Selitos gathering the survivors of the war, the warriors and the namers and the scholars. Giving them their oath and their burden. *For the greater good.* I sang it the way it was, grim and necessary and terrible, and the words came out of me in clouds of white breath.

And the first of them appeared.

He was standing on the first balcony, at the rail, not far from where Denna had gone. I had not seen him come. No one had. He was simply there, where a moment before there had been a lady in a green gown. He was tall and pale and very still, with a face like a knife. His hair was the color of frost. His eyes were black. Not dark. Black. Pure and depthless, like holes cut in the world.

Cinder.

I had seen him last when I was eleven years old, crouching before me in the firelight among the bodies of my family. He had not changed at all. Not a line on his face, not a hair on his head. He looked exactly as he had looked that night. He would look exactly the same, I understood, a thousand years from now.

He looked down at me from the balcony. And he smiled.

My voice did not falter. I want that written down. I looked up at the man who had murdered my mother and my father and everyone I had ever loved, and he smiled at me, and my voice did not falter. I kept singing.

\* \* \*

Then the others came.

A woman in grey, on the second balcony, with a face so pale it was almost translucent, and around her, where she stood, the wood of the balcony began to go soft and dark and crumbling. *Usnea*, I thought. *Rot.*

A man on the main floor, near the north door, stocky and dark, and around him the iron of the door's hinges went red and flaking, the

iron bands on the water barrels bled rust down the wood. *Stercus*.

A shape by the east wall that was hard to look at, a smudge of grey mist where a man should have been, and the air around it thickened and dimmed until the blue candles there were barely visible. *Grey Mardou*.

A woman near the stage, young and lovely and terrible, and the flowers that Threpe had set on the edge of the stage in honor of the evening withered and blackened as she passed them. *Pale Alenta*.

And one more. A man standing in the very center of the room, among the tables, with blue fire dancing along his arms and in his hair and in his open mouth when he smiled. *Cyphus*.

Six of them. Six of the Seven.

The crowd saw them.

\* \* \*

I have heard a great many screams in my life. I have heard men scream in battle, and women scream in childbirth, and children scream in the night. But I have never heard anything like the sound the Eolian made when the crowd saw the Chandrian.

It was not one scream. It was hundreds. It rose up from every corner of the room at once, a great wordless howl of terror, and it shook the walls and rattled the glasses and drowned out everything else.

And the crowd broke.

They ran. All of them, all at once, in every direction. They surged toward the doors like water toward a drain. Tables went over. Chairs splintered. People fell and were trampled. The balconies shook with the stampede of feet.

And Stanchion's men were ready.

They stood at every door, and they did not run. They held the doors open and shouted, and they pulled people through, and they shoved people out into the street, and they went back in and pulled out more. Deoch stood at the main door with his oak staff, and he did not use it on anyone. He used it to hold back the crowd so that it did not crush itself in the doorway. He shouted in a voice like a trumpet, *slow*,

*slow, one at a time, everyone out, everyone out, and somehow, impossibly, they listened.*

I saw all this from the stage, in pieces, in flashes, the way you see things in a lightning storm. I did not stop singing.

\* \* \*

Stercus moved first.

He raised his hands, and the iron in the room answered him. The great chandeliers groaned on their chains as the links rusted through. The iron nails in the balcony supports bled red. I heard wood cracking, and a shriek of tearing metal, and one of the chandeliers began to fall.

It did not fall. It stopped in mid-air, swinging wildly, twelve feet above a table full of screaming students. I looked up and saw Wil on the second balcony with his hand outstretched and his face twisted in concentration. He had bound it. Somehow, in the chaos, he had found something to bind it to, and he was holding it up by main force of will.

His face was grey with effort. His arm was shaking. He could not hold it for long.

Below him, Sim was pulling students out from under the chandelier. He was shouting. I could not hear what. He grabbed one boy by the collar and hauled him out, and then a girl, and then another boy. When the table was empty, he looked up and shouted something at Wil, and Wil let go, and the chandelier crashed down onto the empty table in an explosion of splinters and blue fire.

I kept singing. I sang the Singers. Skarpi's order. The keepers of the true story, who would go out into the world and sing it wherever they went. I sang their oath. I sang it so that the Chandrian could hear it.

Cyphus heard it. He turned toward the stage, and the blue fire on his arms leapt up, and he threw it.

\* \* \*

It came at me like a wave. A great rolling wall of cold blue flame, washing across the floor toward the stage, devouring tables and chairs as it came. I felt the heat of it and the cold of it at the same time,

burning and freezing, and I knew that if it reached me, I would die.

It did not reach me.

A cloud of white smoke exploded in front of the stage, thick and choking and smelling of lime and sulfur. The blue flame hit it and hissed and faltered. Where it touched the smoke, it went dim and grey and sputtered out.

I looked up. On the first balcony, directly above me, Devi was leaning over the rail with her satchel open and her face fierce. She had another clay ball in her hand, the size of an apple, wrapped in waxed cloth. She threw it. It hit the floor at the edge of the stage and burst, and another cloud of white smoke billowed up, and the blue flame retreated from it like a dog from a whip.

"Keep singing, you idiot!" Devi shouted. "*Keep singing!*"

I kept singing.

\* \* \*

Then the balconies began to fall.

It was Usnea. She had been walking slowly along the second balcony, her pale hands trailing along the rail, and everywhere she touched, the wood went soft and black and rotten. The rail. The floor. The great beams that held the balcony to the wall. It rotted away beneath her fingers like old bread, and the whole balcony began to sag.

There were still people on it. A dozen, maybe more, trapped by the crush at the stairs. They screamed as they felt the floor tilt beneath them. They clung to the rail, and the rail crumbled in their hands.

And beneath my feet, I felt the stone of the stage begin to hum.

It was very faint at first. A vibration, deep and low, rising up from somewhere far below. From the cellar. From the foundations. It grew louder. It spread outward through the floor, through the walls, up into the stone pillars that held up the balconies.

Fela.

She was down there, in the dark, with her hands pressed flat against the foundations of the Eolian. And she was asking the stone to stand.

The stone pillars under the second balcony stopped trembling. They held. The rotting wood above them sagged and cracked and crumbled, but the pillars held. They held the weight of the balcony by themselves, by stubbornness, by the long slow patient *no* of stone, and the people on the balcony scrambled across the sagging floor to the stairs and down and out.

Usnea stopped. She turned her pale face downward, toward the floor, toward the cellar. She tilted her head, as if listening.

Then she smiled, and began to walk toward the cellar stairs.

\* \* \*

I could not stop her. I could not stop singing. I could only watch, with the song pouring out of me, as she drifted along the balcony toward the stairs that would take her down to where Fela knelt alone in the dark.

And then Stanchion was there.

I do not know where he came from. I had not seen him since the Chandrian appeared. But he came up the stairs to the second balcony like a bull, with a bucket of water in each hand, and he stepped between Usnea and the cellar stairs.

"Not in my place," he said. His voice was a roar. "Not in *my place*, you rotten bitch."

And he threw the water at her.

It did nothing. Of course it did nothing. Water is not a weapon against something like Usnea. It splashed over her and ran down her pale grey dress and dripped onto the floor, and where it touched the rotting wood, the wood hissed and bubbled.

But she stopped. She looked at him. She looked at this big bearded man with his empty buckets, standing between her and the stairs, and I saw something move across her face. Surprise, perhaps. Or curiosity. As if she had not expected anyone to stand in her way.

Then she reached out, very gently, and laid her pale hand on his chest.

I saw Stanchion's face change. I saw it go grey. I saw the color drain out of it, the way color drains out of a leaf in autumn. I saw his beard go white. I saw his big strong body shrink and wither, as if all

the years he had lived and all the years he had left were being drawn out of him at once.

He did not fall. Not right away. He stood there with her hand on his chest, and he looked at her, and he said something. I could not hear what. But his lips moved, and she tilted her head, and something in her face changed again.

Then she took her hand away, and he fell.

\* \* \*

I did not stop singing.

I want to be very clear about that. I want it written down, in plain ink on plain paper. I watched Stanchion die. I watched a man who had been kind to me, who had given me a place to play and a place to belong, who had built the Eolian from a stable with his own two hands, fall on the rotting boards of his own balcony with his beard gone white and his face gone grey.

And I did not stop singing.

It was the hardest thing I have ever done. Harder than anything that came before, and harder than almost anything that came after. Every part of me wanted to stop. To throw down my lute and run to him. To scream. To call the wind and tear Usnea apart. To do anything, anything at all, except sit on that stool and keep singing.

But Skarpi had told me. *If you stop in the middle, the song is broken. And a broken song is a lie.*

And I would not let Stanchion die for a lie.

So I sang. I sang the sealing of the doors. I sang the seven doors in seven places, and the keepers set to watch them. I sang the line of the Thief's daughter, bound to the keeping. I sang it with tears running down my face and my voice cracking and breaking and the song pouring through me like fire through dry grass.

And Usnea turned away from Stanchion's body, and looked down at me on the stage, and her face was very strange.

She did not go down to the cellar. She stood at the top of the stairs, with her pale hands at her sides, and listened.

\* \* \*

Cinder came down from the first balcony.

He did not use the stairs. He simply stepped off the rail and drifted down, slowly, like a leaf falling, and landed on the floor of the Eolian among the wreckage of the tables. He walked toward the stage. His boots made no sound. The frost spread out from his feet across the floor as he walked, white and crackling.

He stopped at the edge of the stage. He looked up at me.

"Stop," he said.

His voice was soft. Reasonable. Exactly as I remembered it. It was the voice of a man asking you to pass the salt.

I did not stop.

"Stop singing, boy," Cinder said. "You know I can't kill you. But I can hurt you. I can hurt you very much." He smiled. "I can take your hands."

I looked down at him. At his black eyes and his frost-colored hair and his smile. I looked at him the way I had looked at him when I was eleven years old, crouching in the firelight.

I kept singing.

Cinder's smile faded. Something moved in his black eyes. Anger, perhaps. Or something older and colder than anger.

He reached up and took hold of my left wrist.

\* \* \*

His hand was cold. Colder than anything I have ever felt. Colder than ice, colder than the bottom of a winter lake. It was the cold of the space between the stars. It went into my wrist and up my arm and into my chest, and I felt my heart stutter and my breath catch.

My fingers went numb on the strings. They stopped moving. The lute went silent.

But I did not stop singing.

I sang without the lute. I sang with nothing but my voice, cracked and broken and shaking with cold. I sang the last verse. The one Skarpi had taught me in the broken lighthouse, on the ninth day. The one that

was not in any book, or any song, or any story anyone had ever told.

It was a very short verse. Only a few lines. It was about a little boy, hiding under a slab of white marble, listening to his city burn. And an old man with one eye, digging him out with his bare hands.

And what the boy said, when the old man asked him what he wanted to be.

*A singer, I sang. Like my mother. So that no one will forget.*

The last note left me. It went out into the Eolian, into the frost and the blue fire and the wreckage and the smoke. It went out through the open doors into the streets of Imre. It went out, I think, much farther than that.

And then I stopped.

\* \* \*

The Eolian was silent.

Not quiet. Silent. The kind of silence that has weight. The kind of silence that presses on your ears like deep water. The blue candles burned without flickering. The frost glittered on every surface. The smoke hung in the air without moving.

Cinder was still holding my wrist. He was looking up at me. And his face had changed.

He looked, for the first time since I had known him, uncertain.

"That," he said slowly, "was not in the old song."

"No," I said. My voice was a croak. "It wasn't."

He stared at me. And I saw something in his black eyes that I had never expected to see there. Something that looked almost like fear.

And then, from the center of the room, where Cyphus stood among the wreckage with blue fire dancing on his arms, a shadow began to grow.



## Chapter Sixty-Seven

# Haliax

It was not a shadow the way a shadow is cast by a candle. It was not the absence of light. It was something else. It was a place where light went to be forgotten.

It rose up out of the floor in the center of the Eolian, among the overturned tables and the splintered chairs and the pools of blue fire. It rose slowly, like smoke, like mist, like the dark that pools in the corners of a room at dusk. It was the shape of a man. Tall and broad-shouldered and very still. But there was no man inside it. Or if there was, he was so far away, so deep inside the dark, that he could not be seen.

The blue candles dimmed around it. The frost on the floor crept back from it, as if even the cold were afraid.

The Chandrian went still.

All of them, at once. Cyphus, with his dancing fire. Stercus, with his hands full of rust. Grey Mardou, a smudge of mist by the east wall. Pale Alenta, beside the withered flowers. Usnea, at the top of the cellar stairs, beside Stanchion's body. Cinder, at the edge of the stage, with his cold hand around my wrist.

They went still the way hounds go still when their master walks into the room.

"Ferule," said the shadow.

It was a voice. It came from the shadow, or from everywhere, or from nowhere. It was deep and quiet and very tired. It was the voice of a man who has been awake for ten thousand years.

Cinder let go of my wrist.

He did not want to. I saw that. His fingers loosened slowly, reluctantly, one by one. But they loosened. And he stepped back from the edge of the stage and bowed his head.

"Lord," he said.

\* \* \*

The shadow turned toward me.

I cannot tell you how I knew it turned. There was no face to see, no eyes, nothing but the shape of a man made of forgetting. But I felt it. I felt its attention fall on me like a weight. Like the weight of the whole sky.

"So," said Haliax. "You are the one who sings."

I did not answer. I could not. My voice was gone, burned out of me by the song. My left arm hung numb and useless at my side. My whole body was shaking with cold and exhaustion and something else, something I did not have a name for.

"It was a good song," said Haliax. "The best I have heard in a very long time. Better than your father's. Better than any of the Singers'." He paused. "You put in the child. The boy in the fountain. No one has ever put in the child before."

I looked at the shadow. I made myself look at it, though every part of me wanted to look away.

"Why not?" I whispered. My voice was barely a breath.

"Because no one knew," said Haliax. "Only Selitos, and the child himself. And Selitos never told." The shadow seemed to shift, very slightly. "So the old storyteller is still alive. The last of them. I wondered."

I did not say anything.

"You should not have put him in," said Haliax quietly. "It makes the song truer. And I have had quite enough of truth."

\* \* \*

On the first balcony, someone moved.

I looked up. Denna was standing at the rail, with her hands gripping it so tightly that her knuckles had gone white. She was staring down at the shadow in the center of the room. Her face was the color of chalk.

Beside her, in the shadows, Bredon stood leaning on his stick. He was not looking at the shadow. He was looking at me. And he was smiling.

The shadow did not look up. But it said, "Is that the girl? The one who sings the other song?"

"Yes, my lord," said Bredon. His voice carried clearly across the silent room. "That is Denna."

"Hm." The shadow was quiet for a moment. "Her song is very beautiful."

"Thank you, my lord."

"It is not true."

"No, my lord. That is rather the point."

"Yes." The shadow sighed. It was a sound like wind through a ruined city. "Yes. I suppose it is." It turned back to me. "And yet. I find I prefer his."

Bredon's smile faltered. Just slightly. Just for a moment.

"My lord?"

"His is true," said Haliax. "It hurts. I had forgotten what it was like, to hear it sung true. To hear Lyra's name in a voice that did not lie." The shadow was very still. "It hurts very much."

No one spoke. No one moved. The blue candles burned without flickering.

"Every time the true song is sung," said Haliax, "I remember. Every time. It is the curse. Selitos made it so. I cannot forget. I cannot rest. I cannot die. And every time someone sings it true, I remember it all again, as if it were yesterday." The voice was very quiet. "Your parents sang it. Your father's song was very good. Very close. I remembered, when I heard it. I remembered everything."

He was silent for a long moment.

"That is why they died," said Haliax. "Not because the song was dangerous. Not because it made the curse stronger. Because it hurt. And I wanted it to stop."

\* \* \*

I stared at the shadow. I could not speak. I could not move.

"You understand now," said Haliax. "Don't you? What I am. What I want." The shadow seemed to lean toward me. "I want it to stop. All of it. The remembering. The grief. The endless weight of what I did and what was done to me. I want to rest." A pause. "I want to die."

"And for that," I whispered, "you'd end the world."

"The world ended for me a very long time ago," said Haliax. "In a white city. In the arms of a woman who would not wake." The voice was very gentle. "What is one more ending?"

\* \* \*

On the balcony, Denna made a sound.

It was a small sound. A gasp. I looked up. She was clutching her wrist, the one with the knot, and her face was twisted in pain. But not the pain I had seen in the garden. Something else.

The knot was glowing. Not red, this time. A pale, cold, silvery light, like the light Kilvin's candle had shown once, in my room at Anker's. Like moonlight on snow.

And it was loosening.

I saw it. Even from the stage, across the ruined room, I saw it. One loop of the knot slipping, just slightly. Just a little. The way the king's hair had loosened when I hummed to it.

Denna stared down at her wrist. Then she looked at me. Her eyes were enormous.

Bredon had seen it too. He turned toward her, and for the first time since I had known him, his face was not mild. It was not kind. It was something else entirely. Something old and cold and furious.

He reached for her wrist.

"Leave her," said Haliax.

Bredon stopped. His hand hung in the air, an inch from Denna's arm.

"My lord," he said. His voice was very controlled. "The song. His song. It has weakened the binding. If I do not—"

"I said leave her." The shadow did not raise its voice. It did not need to. "The binding was tied in a false story. The true story loosens it. That is the way of things." A pause. "You knew that when you tied it."

"I did not think he would sing it so well."

"No," said Haliar. "Neither did I." The shadow turned back toward me. "He is very good, your little key. Better than you told me."

Bredon lowered his hand. He looked down at me from the balcony, and his face was calm again, mild again. But his eyes were not.

"Yes, my lord," he said. "He is."

\* \* \*

"Ferule," said Haliar.

Cinder stepped forward. "Lord."

"We are finished here. Gather the others."

Cinder looked at me. At my numb arm, and my shaking body, and my face wet with tears. He looked at me for a long moment with his black eyes.

"Lord," he said. "He sang the true song. He sang it here, in front of hundreds. It will spread. It will undo years of work." He paused. "Let me take his hands, at least. Let me take his voice. He does not need either to open the door."

"No."

"Lord—"

"He is needed," said Haliar. And the words fell into the silent room like stones into deep water. "Whole. With his hands and his voice and his name. He is needed, Ferule. As he is." The shadow was very still. "You will not touch him again. None of you will. Not until he stands before the door."

Cinder was silent. Then he bowed his head.

"As you say, lord."

\* \* \*

They left the way they had come. Not through the doors. Simply gone, one by one, like candles snuffed. Cyphus first, his fire guttering out. Then Stercus, and Grey Mardou, and Pale Alenta. Usnea stood a moment longer at the top of the cellar stairs, looking down at Stanchion's body. Then she was gone too.

Cinder was the last. He stood at the edge of the stage and looked up at me.

"You think you've won something," he said softly. "You haven't. You've only made him sad. And when he's sad, he's patient. And when he's patient—" He smiled. "Well. You'll see."

He was gone.

Only the shadow remained. It stood in the center of the ruined room, among the wreckage, and it looked at me.

"You will come to the door," it said. "You know that. Whatever you tell yourself. You will come." A pause. "And when you do, I will be waiting. And I will thank you."

"Why?" I whispered. "Why thank me?"

"Because," said Haliax, "you will be giving me the only gift anyone has ever given me that I truly wanted."

And then it was gone too. The shadow sank back into the floor like water into sand. The darkness drained out of the air. The blue candles flickered, and guttered, and went out.

And in the sudden dark, I heard the roof beginning to burn.

\* \* \*

It had caught somewhere near the top of the north wall, where one of the chandeliers had fallen. Ordinary fire, now. Yellow and orange and red. It licked along the old dry rafters, crackling, spreading. Smoke began to pour down into the room.

I tried to stand. My legs would not hold me. I fell off the stool onto the stage, and my lute fell beside me with a discordant jangle of strings.

I lay there on the stone, in the dark, with the fire crackling above me and the smoke thickening around me. I could not move. I was empty. Completely, utterly empty. The song had gone through me like fire through dry grass, and there was nothing left. Not my voice. Not my strength. Not my thoughts.

Not my name.

I lay there on the stage and I tried to remember who I was, and I could not. I knew there was a word for it. A name. The shape of me. But it was gone. The song had pushed it out. There was only a thin empty shell, lying on a stone floor in a burning building, with the smoke coming down.

*Hold onto something*, someone had said. Someone. I could not remember who. *Something small*.

My right hand moved. It moved on its own, slowly, the way a sleeping man's hand moves. It found my chest. It found something there, under my shirt. Something small and light, on a thread around my neck.

A knot.

I held it. I did not know what it was. I did not know why it mattered. But I held it, and I felt it. The faint tightening in the air. The sense of something reaching out and catching hold.

*Road*, it said. *Promise. A story told many times, and changes in the telling.*

And beneath that, woven into it so fine I had never noticed, one more knot. A very small one. It said a name.

Not my name. Hers.

I held it, and I remembered her. Dark hair, and a laugh like a bell, and hands that knew how to tie a story into a cord. I remembered sitting with her in the Grey Man, learning her secret language. I remembered her face, looking at me across a crowded room.

And remembering her, I remembered the one who had loved her.

*Kvothe*, I thought. *My name is Kvothe.*

It came back. Slowly. Like water filling a cup. My name, and my self, and everything I was. It came back into the empty shell, and filled

it, and I was myself again.

\* \* \*

Hands found me in the smoke. Strong hands, pulling at my arms. Voices shouting. I heard Sim, and Wil, and Devi. I heard Deoch, roaring orders. I felt myself lifted, carried. My lute banged against my legs; someone had picked it up.

We went out through the north door, into the night, into cold clean air. They laid me down on the cobblestones of the street. People were everywhere. Crowds, pressed back against the buildings across the street, staring at the Eolian as it burned.

I turned my head and looked.

The roof was a sheet of flame. It roared up into the night sky, orange and red and gold, throwing sparks high into the air. The smoke billowed up black against the stars. The heat of it was like a hand pressing against my face, even from across the street.

But the walls stood.

The stone walls of the Eolian stood firm and straight, with the fire raging above them. They did not crack. They did not fall. They held, stubborn and patient, saying their long slow *no* to the fire.

And down in the cellar, I knew, a girl with dark hair was still kneeling in the dark with her hands pressed flat against the foundations, asking them to stand.

"Fela," I croaked. "Fela's still inside."

Wil was kneeling beside me. He looked at me, and then at the burning building, and his face went grey.

He stood up and ran back into the fire.



## Chapter Sixty-Eight

# Ashes

Wil came out of the fire with Fela in his arms.

I will never forget it. I was lying on the cobblestones with my head in Devi's lap and Sim kneeling beside me, and I was watching the north door of the Eolian, which was a black rectangle full of smoke and roaring orange light. And I saw a shape come out of it. A man, bent almost double, stumbling. His clothes were smoking. His hair was smoking. He was carrying something in his arms.

He came out into the street and fell to his knees on the cobblestones. People ran to him. Someone threw a bucket of water over him and it hissed on his coat. Someone else took the thing he was carrying out of his arms and laid it down gently on the stones.

It was Fela. Her grey dress was scorched black. Her dark hair was singed. Her face was covered in soot and her eyes were closed.

But she was breathing.

I tried to get up. I could not. Devi held me down with one hand on my chest and said something sharp that I did not hear. Sim ran to Fela and knelt beside her and put his ear to her chest, and then looked up at me and nodded, and his face was wet.

Wil was kneeling on the cobblestones with his head bowed. His hands were held out in front of him, palms up, and even from where I lay I could see that they were burned. Red and raw and blistering.

He did not make a sound. He knelt there with his burned hands held out, and he looked at Fela, and his face was very still.

\* \* \*

They told me later what had happened.

Wil had gone in through the north door and down the cellar stairs, through the smoke and the heat. The fire had not reached the cellar; the stone floor of the main room lay between it and the flames. But the smoke had. It was pouring down the stairs like water, thick and black and choking, and by the time Wil reached the bottom, he could not see his hand in front of his face.

He found Fela by feel. She was kneeling where she had knelt all night, with her hands pressed flat against the great stone foundations. She was unconscious. But her hands had not moved. They were still pressed against the stone, so hard that when Wil tried to pull them away, he could not.

She was holding it. Even unconscious. Even with the smoke filling her lungs and the fire roaring overhead. She was holding the stone, asking it to stand, and she would not let go.

Wil told me afterward that he had begged her. He had knelt beside her in the smoke and the dark and begged her to let go, to come away, to let the building fall. She did not answer. She did not hear him.

So he had taken hold of her wrists, and he had pulled. And the stone had been hot. Very hot. Hot as a forge, from the fire above. And when he pulled her hands away from it, he had to press his own hands against it, to brace himself.

He held them there for a long time. Long enough to pull her free. Long enough to lift her in his arms and carry her up the stairs and out through the smoke.

His hands were never the same afterward. He could still use them, mostly. He could still write, and hold a cup, and turn the pages of a book. But the skin never healed properly. It stayed tight and shiny and pink, like the skin of a newborn thing. And he could never again do fine sympathy work. The kind that needs delicate fingers, and a sensitive touch.

He never complained. Not once. When I tried to apologize to him, much later, he looked at me with his dark calm eyes and said, "She held the building up for three hours, Kvothe. Three hours. With

nothing but her hands and her will." He looked down at his scarred palms. "I held a hot stone for a minute. I think I got the better end of the bargain."

\* \* \*

The Eolian burned until dawn.

The roof went first, falling in with a great roar and a shower of sparks around midnight. Then the balconies, the old dry wood going up like kindling. Then the stage, and the bar, and the tables and chairs, and everything else that could burn. By the time the sun came up, grey and pale through the smoke, there was nothing left inside the walls but ash and charcoal and blackened stone.

But the walls stood.

They stood all through the night, while the fire raged inside them. They stood when the roof fell. They stood when the balconies collapsed. They stood in the grey dawn, blackened and scorched and cracked in places, but upright. A great round ring of stone, open to the sky, with smoke rising out of it like a chimney.

People came to look at it, that morning. Hundreds of them. They stood in the street and stared at it with the vague numb expressions of people who have seen something they cannot understand. They talked in low voices. They pointed at the walls.

"Should've fallen," I heard one man say. He was an old stonemason, grey-bearded and bent, with the thick hands of his trade. "Fire like that. Should've cracked 'em right through. Should've brought the whole thing down." He shook his head. "Never seen stone hold like that. Never in my life."

I did not say anything. I sat on the steps of a house across the street, wrapped in a blanket someone had given me, and I looked at the walls.

Fela was asleep inside the house behind me. A physician from the Medica had come in the night and looked at her and said that she had breathed a great deal of smoke, and that she was very weak, but that she would live. He had looked at Wil's hands, too, and wrapped them in cool wet cloths, and given him something for the pain.

And he had looked at me, and frowned, and asked what had happened to my arm.

I did not know how to answer. My left arm was still numb from the elbow down. The skin of my wrist, where Cinder had held it, was white and cold and hard, like the skin of a man who has been frozen. I could move my fingers, a little. But I could not feel them.

The physician had looked at it for a long time. Then he had said, very quietly, that he had seen frostbite before, in the northern mountains, but never like this. Never in summer. Never in the shape of a hand.

\* \* \*

They brought Stanchion out a little after dawn.

Deoch carried him. He went into the smoking ruin of the Eolian alone, when the fire had died down enough, and he came out with Stanchion's body in his arms. He had wrapped it in a tablecloth he had found somewhere, a big white cloth only a little scorched at the edges. He carried it out into the street and laid it down on the cobblestones, very gently, and knelt beside it.

The crowd went quiet.

Deoch knelt there for a long time. His face was black with soot and his clothes were burned and his hands were blistered. He did not seem to notice. He knelt beside Stanchion's body and looked at the white cloth, and he did not move.

I got up. I walked across the street, slowly, with the blanket around my shoulders. I knelt beside him.

He did not look at me.

"He built it from a stable," Deoch said. His voice was hoarse. "Did you know that? A stable. Horse dung on the floor and rats in the rafters."

"He told me."

"He told everyone. He was so proud of it." Deoch laughed, a broken sound. "He laid every stone in the stage himself. He carved the balconies. He picked out every table. He hung every lamp." He shook his head. "Twenty-two years. Twenty-two years he spent on that place.

It was his whole life."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't." Deoch looked at me for the first time. His eyes were red and wet. "Don't be sorry. He knew. He knew what was coming. You told him, and he knew, and he did it anyway." He looked back down at the white cloth. "He told me, last night. Before it started. He said, 'Deoch, if anything happens to me, make sure the boy keeps singing.'" His voice cracked. "He said it was the most important thing he'd ever done. Letting you sing that song. He said it was worth more than the whole building."

I did not say anything. I could not.

"You did keep singing," said Deoch. "You kept singing, the whole time. Even when she—" He stopped. "Even when she killed him. You kept singing."

"Yes."

"Good." He reached out and laid his blistered hand on the white cloth, over Stanchion's chest. "Good. That's what he wanted."

\* \* \*

The constables came at noon.

I had been expecting them. I had known they would come. Five hundred royals is a great deal of money, and I had sung in front of half of Imre. Someone would have gone to them. Many someones, probably.

There were a dozen of them, in the grey and blue of the Imre watch, with truncheons at their belts and a magistrate at their head. They came marching down the street toward the ruins of the Eolian, and the crowd parted before them like water before a ship's bow.

I was sitting on the steps of the house again. I saw them coming. I did not move. I did not have the strength to run.

The magistrate stopped in front of me. He was a thin, severe man in a black robe, with a gold chain of office around his neck. He looked down at me with an expression of distaste.

"Kvothe," he said. "Called the Ruh. Called the Arcane. Called the Kingkiller." He held up a paper, heavily sealed. "I have here a warrant

for your arrest, issued by the court of King Ambrose of Vintas and recognized by the council of Imre, for the murder of King Roderic. You will come with us."

I looked up at him. I did not say anything.

"Did you hear me? You will come with us. Now."

"He's not going anywhere," said a voice.

It was Threpe. He came pushing through the crowd with half a dozen men in his livery behind him, big men with swords and hard faces. His coat was purple and his face was red and he looked, for the first time since I had known him, genuinely angry.

"Count Threpe," said the magistrate stiffly. "This is a matter of law. You have no standing—"

"I have every standing. I'm a member of the council of Imre, and I have been for thirty years." Threpe planted himself between me and the constables, his small round body quivering with indignation. "And I say the council does not recognize any warrant issued by a usurper who took his throne over the bodies of four murdered heirs."

A ripple went through the crowd. The magistrate's face went white.

"That is treason," he said.

"It's the truth," said Threpe. "And everyone in this street heard the truth last night. Didn't they?" He turned to the crowd. "Didn't you? You heard him sing it. You saw what came to stop him. You saw what came." His voice rose. "Are you going to let them take him? After that? After he kept singing while the whole world was burning down around him?"

The crowd was silent. Then someone, somewhere, said, "No."

And someone else said it. And someone else. It spread through the crowd like fire through dry grass, until the whole street was saying it. *No. No. No.* Not loudly. Not angrily. Just steadily, patiently, like stone.

The magistrate looked around at them. His face had gone from white to red.

"This is a lawful warrant," he said. "Any man who interferes with it—"

"Is exercising his rights as a citizen of Imre," said Threpe. "To question the authority of a foreign king." He smiled, not very pleasantly. "Take it to the council, magistrate. We'll discuss it at the next session. In a span or two. Or three." He waved a hand. "In the meantime, the boy stays here. Under my protection."

The magistrate looked at him. Then at the crowd. Then at me.

Then he turned on his heel and marched away, and his constables marched after him.

\* \* \*

The crowd did not disperse. They stayed in the street, all through the afternoon, standing around the ruins of the Eolian and talking in low voices. Some of them brought food and left it on the steps where I sat. Bread and cheese and fruit. A jug of wine. Someone left a small bunch of flowers, and I looked at them for a long time.

Threpe sat with me. He did not say much. He only sat there on the steps beside me, with his men standing guard around us, and looked at the blackened walls of the Eolian.

"Stanchion was my friend," he said at last. "For twenty years. He used to let me sit at the bar after closing and drink his best wine and talk about music until dawn." He shook his head. "I'll miss that."

"I'm sorry, Threpe."

"Stop saying that. Everyone keeps saying they're sorry. As if being sorry does anything." He was quiet for a moment. "What did you see, Kvothe? Last night? At the end? When everyone else had run, and you were alone on the stage, and there was that—that *thing*, in the middle of the room?"

I looked at him. I did not know how to answer.

"I was on the first balcony," Threpe said. "I didn't run. I couldn't. I was frozen. I saw it all." He shivered. "I saw that shadow. I heard it speak. I didn't understand most of what it said. But I heard it say that it wanted to die." He looked at me. "Is that true? Is that what it wants?"

"Yes."

"And to get what it wants—"

"It needs me to do something," I said. "Something I won't do."

Threpe looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded slowly.

"Good," he said. "Good. Don't do it."

\* \* \*

That night, Denna came.

I was in the house behind the Eolian, the one where Fela was sleeping. The owner, an old widow named Merrra, had given me a room at the top of the stairs, with a narrow bed and a window that looked out over the ruins. I was lying on the bed, not sleeping, looking at the ceiling. My arm ached with a deep bone-cold ache that would not go away.

I heard the window open. I turned my head.

She was climbing in over the sill. She was wearing a dark cloak with a deep hood, and her face was hidden in shadow. But I knew her. I would have known her in the dark, in a crowd, in a dream.

She dropped down into the room and stood by the window. She pushed back her hood.

Her face was pale and drawn. Her eyes were red. She looked as though she had not slept in days.

"Kvothe," she whispered.

I sat up. "Denna."

She did not move. She stood by the window, with her hands clasped in front of her, and looked at me.

"I'm so sorry," she said. "About Stanchion. About the Eolian. About all of it." Her voice cracked. "I didn't know. I didn't know they'd come. He told me it was just a song. He told me it didn't matter. He told me—"

"It's all right."

"It's *not* all right." She was crying now. "It's not all right at all. People died. Stanchion died. And it's because of me. Because of my song. Because I sang first and made them angry and—"

"Denna." I got up. It was harder than it should have been; my legs were still weak. I crossed the room to her. "Denna, look at me."



She looked at me.

"It wasn't your song that brought them," I said. "It was mine. They came because I sang the true story. They'd have come if you'd never sung a note."

She stared at me. "But he said—"

"He lies," I said. "Not with words. With everything else. With the shape of what he tells you. You know that. You've always known it."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she held up her wrist.

The knot was still there. But it was different. Looser. One of the loops had slipped, and hung slack, and the whole knot seemed somehow smaller. Less tight. Less sure of itself.

"It's been like this since your song," she said. "Since the last verse. I felt it let go. Just a little." She touched it with one finger, wonderingly. "I can say things now. Things I couldn't say before. Not everything. But some things." She looked up at me. "I can tell you his name. His true name. The one he had before Bredon."

My heart stopped.

"Tell me," I said.

She opened her mouth. And then she stopped. Her face twisted. Her hand went to her throat.

"I can't," she gasped. "It's still—it's still holding that. That part. I'm sorry. I'm sorry." She took a shaking breath. "But I can tell you other things. I can tell you about the box."

"Tell me."

She looked at me with red wet eyes.

"I hid it," she said. "After Severen. I took it from under your pillow, and I rode all night, and I hid it. Somewhere I thought no one would ever find it. Not him, not you, not anyone." She swallowed. "And then I went back to him. Because I had to. Because the knot—" She held up her wrist. "And he asked me. The first night. He asked me where I had been. And I tried not to tell him. I tried so hard." Her voice broke. "But the knot pulled. And I told him."

I closed my eyes.

"He has it," I said.

"Not him. He gave it to Ambrose." She was weeping openly now. "Ambrose keeps it with him. Always. In a chest in his tent, guarded day and night. He's marching south with it. To Severen." She looked at me. "To the Lackless lands."

I opened my eyes. I looked at her.

"And the knots," I said quietly. "In the king's hair. On Andrian's bridle. Did you tie them?"

She went white. Whiter than I had ever seen her.

"What knots?"

I told her. I watched her face as I told her. I watched it crumple, piece by piece, the way the Eolian's roof had crumpled into the fire. I watched her understand.

"The practice cords," she whispered. "He gave me names. Old names, he said. From the history. Kings and princes from the old stories. He said I needed to practice tying them, so I could write them into the song." She pressed her hands against her mouth. "I tied them for months. Dozens of them. Over and over. *Ending*, he said. *Put ending beside them, because they're all dead now.*" She was shaking. "I thought they were *dead*. I thought they'd been dead for *hundreds of years.*"

"I know."

"I killed them."

"No. He did. He used your hands. But he did it." I took her wrists, very gently, the good one and the knotted one. "Denna. Listen to me. You didn't know."

"That doesn't matter!"

"It matters to me."

She stared at me. Tears were running down her face. She was shaking so hard I could feel it through her wrists.

"What do I do?" she whispered. "Kvothe, what do I do?"

I looked at her for a long moment. At the knot on her wrist, loosened by the true song. At her face, wet and white and terrified.

"Go back to him," I said.

She stared at me. "What?"

"Go back to him. Stay with him. Stay with Ambrose's court." I held her wrists tighter. "Be my eyes. Tell me where they go. Tell me what they do. Tell me when they go to the door." I paused. "Can you do that? With the knot the way it is now?"

She looked down at her wrist. At the loosened knot. She was quiet for a long time.

"I think so," she said at last. "Some things. Not everything. But some things." She looked up at me. "I could write them. In knots. He'd never think to look at the cords in my hair."

"Then do it."

"It's dangerous."

"I know."

"If he finds out—"

"I know." I let go of her wrists. I touched her face, very lightly, the way she had once touched my scar. "It's all dangerous, Denna. Everything. But this way, at least, we're playing our own game. Not his."

She looked at me for a long time. Then she laughed. It was a small, broken, astonished laugh, and it made her look very young.

"Our own game," she said. "Against *him*."

"Why not? He taught me to play."

She laughed again, and then she was crying again, and then she was in my arms, and I held her while she shook. We stood there in the dark room at the top of the stairs, with the ruins of the Eolian smoking outside the window, and we held each other.

And when she left, a little before dawn, climbing back out the window into the grey light, she turned back once and looked at me.

"I'll write," she said. "I promise. In knots."

"I'll read them."

She smiled. It was a real smile, the kind that went all the way up to her eyes.

"I know you will," she said. "You always do."

Then she was gone.

## Chapter Sixty-Nine

# Stanchion's Wake

They buried Stanchion on the fourth day after the fire, and the whole of Imre came.

I had not known how many people he knew. I suppose I should have. He had been behind the bar of the Eolian for twenty-two years, pouring drinks and taking coins and listening to music, and in that time half the musicians in the Four Corners had passed through his doors, and every one of them had eaten his food and slept under his roof at least once when they were hungry. He had kept the widow's promise. He had never turned one away.

They came back for him.

\* \* \*

The burial was in the old cemetery on the hill above Imre, among the yews, where the town put its merchants and its minor nobles and its guildmasters. Stanchion was none of those things. He had bought the plot himself, twenty years before, Deoch told me, because it had a view of the river and the bridge and the Eolian's roof. He said he wanted to be able to keep an eye on the place.

There was no roof to keep an eye on now. Only blackened walls, open to the sky.

They carried him up the hill in a plain pine coffin, six of them. Deoch at the front, on the right. Threpe, who was much too small and too old to carry anything and insisted anyway, at the front on the left. Four musicians behind them: a fiddler from the Small Kingdoms, a

harpist from Atur, a big bearded piper from the north who had won his talent pipes forty years before, and the old man with the hurdy-gurdy, weeping openly.

I did not carry him. I could not. My left arm was still dead from the elbow down, and Cinder's handprint burned cold on my wrist. I walked behind the coffin with Sim on one side of me and Devi on the other, and Wil and Fela behind us, Wil with his hands wrapped in white bandages and Fela leaning on his arm, still pale and coughing from the smoke.

And behind us, the rest of Imre.

\* \* \*

I looked back once, on the hill path, and could not see the end of them. They filled the path and spilled over onto the grass on either side. Musicians, dozens of them, with their instruments on their backs. Students from the University. Merchants and tradesmen and their wives. Serving girls from the taverns. Beggars from the docks, who Stanchion had fed on cold nights with the leftovers from the kitchen. A pair of whores from the Wharf Street houses, dressed in borrowed black, holding hands.

And people I did not know at all. Old men and women who had been young when the Eolian was new, and had heard music there on some night forty years gone that they had never forgotten.

"He'd hate this," said Deoch, when we reached the top of the hill and set the coffin down beside the grave. His voice was rough. "All these people. Making a fuss. He always said funerals were a waste of good drinking time."

"He'd love it," said Threpe. He was breathing hard from the climb, and his face was red, and he was weeping without seeming to notice. "He'd pretend to hate it. But he'd love it."

Deoch looked at him. Then he laughed, a broken sound, and wiped his eyes.

"Yes," he said. "Yes, he would."

\* \* \*

There was no priest. Stanchion had never been a religious man. Deoch said he had once thrown a Tehlin out of the Eolian for trying to preach to the crowd between songs, and had said that if God wanted to be heard in his hall, God could get up on the stage and play like everyone else.

So instead of a priest, there were the musicians.

They played. One after another. They stood at the head of the grave, beside the coffin, in the grey afternoon light under the yews, and they played whatever they had played the first time they came to the Eolian. The fiddler from the Small Kingdoms played a reel so fast and bright that people laughed through their tears. The harpist from Atur played a lament. The big bearded piper played something old and wild and northern that made the hair stand up on my arms. The old man with the hurdy-gurdy played the same four songs he had been playing at the Eolian for thirty years, and everyone sang along, even the whores from Wharf Street, even the beggars.

They played for two hours. More. Dozens of them. Every musician in Imre, and many from farther away, who had heard about the fire and come.

And then, when the last of them had played and stepped back, they all turned and looked at me.

\* \* \*

I did not move.

I stood at the edge of the crowd, between Sim and Devi, with my cold dead arm hanging at my side, and I looked at them looking at me. Hundreds of faces. Waiting.

"I can't," I said.

Nobody answered.

"I can't," I said again. "My hand. I can't play. Not with one hand."

Deoch came through the crowd toward me. He stopped in front of me and looked at me for a long moment with his handsome ruined face.

"He told me to make sure you kept singing," he said. "That night. Before. He said it was the most important thing." He held out

something. It was a lute. Not mine; mine had been lost in the fire, or I thought it had, then. It was an old lute, battered and scarred, with a crack in the soundboard mended with glue. "This was his. The one he brought from the Small Kingdoms. The one he couldn't play." He held it out to me. "Sing, Kvothe. You don't need two hands to sing."

I looked at the lute. At Deoch. At the hundreds of faces behind him, waiting.

I took it.

\* \* \*

I could not play it. Not properly. My left hand would not form chords; the fingers were stiff and cold and would not bend. But I could hold the lute against my body with my left arm, and I could strike the open strings with my right hand, one at a time, slowly, the way a child plays.

So I did that. I stood at the head of Stanchion's grave with his old cracked lute that he had never been able to play, and I struck the open strings, one by one, and I sang.

I did not sing *Tarinier*. That would have been wrong. It was not his song; it was the song that had killed him. I sang something else. Something I had never sung for anyone, because I had never finished it. A song I had begun on the road back from Severen, the year before, and set aside, and forgotten.

It was about a room.

A round room, with a leaking roof and rats in the rafters and horse dung on the floor three inches deep. A room that a boy of nineteen looked down at from a hayloft, on a rainy night, and thought was beautiful. A room he cleaned with his own hands, and built a stage in with stones he carried up from the quarry on his back, two at a time. A room he filled with music, for twenty-two years, though he could never play a note himself.

A good room.

I did not know the words, when I started. They came as I sang them. They came up out of me from somewhere very far down, the way the name of the wind had come once, the way *Tarinier* had come

in Skarpi's lighthouse. I sang about the stable and the widow and the eleven talents. I sang about the promise. I sang about a big bearded man standing on the second balcony of his own hall, with two empty buckets in his hands, telling a Chandrian that she could have him but not the girl, and not his walls.

I sang it with one hand, on the open strings of a cracked lute that its owner had never been able to play.

When I finished, no one on that hill made a sound.

\* \* \*

They put him in the ground afterward. Deoch and the four musicians lowered the coffin on ropes, and Threpe threw the first handful of earth, and then everyone threw a handful, one after another, hundreds of them, a long slow line winding past the grave. The musicians threw other things too. A broken string. A fiddle peg. A reed from a pipe.

The old man with the hurdy-gurdy threw in a coin.

"For the ferry," he said, to no one in particular. "He always paid his debts."

\* \* \*

I stayed after the others had gone. I sat on the grass beside the fresh grave with Stanchion's lute across my knees, under the yews, and looked down the hill at the river and the bridge and the blackened ring of the Eolian's walls.

Deoch came back, after a while, and sat beside me. He did not say anything for a long time.

"I'm going to rebuild it," he said at last.

I looked at him.

"The Eolian," he said. "Stone by stone. The way he did. I've got some money saved. Not much. And Threpe will help, and the musicians' guild, and half of Imre, from the look of today." He was quiet for a moment. "It'll take years. But I'm going to do it."

"He'd like that."

"He'd tell me I was doing it wrong. Every step of the way." Deoch smiled faintly. "He'd tell me the balconies were too high and the stage



was too low and I'd put the bar on the wrong side." He looked at the blackened walls. "I'll put it exactly where he had it."

He was quiet for a long moment.

"Keep the lute," he said. "His. He'd want you to have it. He always said you were the best he ever heard."

"Deoch, I can't—"

"You can. You will." He stood up. He looked down at me. "And when it's rebuilt, you'll come back. And you'll play on that stage with two hands, the way he wanted. You owe him a song."

"I just sang him one."

"You owe him another." Deoch's face was very still. "You'll always owe him another. That's how it works, with the dead. You never finish paying."

He turned and walked away down the hill.

\* \* \*

I never played Stanchion's lute on the stage of the rebuilt Eolian. I want you to know that. It is one of the debts I have not paid.

But I kept it. Threpe kept it for me, all through the Fae and the war and the door, through Renere and the Tower of Thorns, and gave it back to me in Imre the autumn I became Kote. I kept it under the bar at the Waystone for seven years, in its case, and never once took it out.

And it is the lute I played, one morning, very recently, in the common room of that inn, for a room full of farmers who had come out of a church at dawn. My own was still upstairs, in the open chest. My hands went to the bar first, and found Stanchion's.

I think he would have laughed at that. I think he would have said it was about time someone played the damned thing properly.

## Chapter Seventy

# What Wil Did Not Say

Wil did not sleep, the nights after the fire. I knew because I did not sleep either, and every night, when I climbed out onto the roof of Merra's house to sit in the cold and stare at the black hole in the skyline where the Eolian had been, he was already there.

He sat on the ridge of the roof with his bandaged hands resting on his knees, palms up, the way the physician had told him to keep them. He did not look at me when I came up. He did not say anything. I sat down beside him and did not say anything either.

We did that for two nights. On the third, he spoke.

"Sim was downstairs today," he said. "With her."

I did not ask who. There was only one *her*, those days.

"He read to her," said Wil. "For three hours. Poetry. That dreadful Eld Vintic stuff he likes, with all the rhymes." He was quiet for a moment. "She laughed at one of them. The first time she's laughed since. It was a very small laugh. It hurt her; she coughed for a long time afterward. But she laughed."

"That's good," I said.

"Yes." Wil looked down at his hands. "It's very good."

\* \* \*

The wind came across the rooftops, cold and damp, smelling of river and ash. Down in the street below, a cart went by, its wheels loud on the cobbles. Somewhere a dog barked, and stopped.

"I sat with her all yesterday," said Wil. "And the day before. And the day before that. I didn't read to her. I don't know any poetry. I just sat." He turned his hands over, carefully, so that the bandaged palms faced down. "She was asleep, mostly. Sometimes she woke up and looked at me and didn't say anything. And then she went back to sleep."

I waited.

"And then Sim came in today," said Wil, "with his book. And she woke up, and saw him, and her whole face—" He stopped.

He did not finish. He did not need to.

\* \* \*

I had not known. That is the truth, and I am ashamed of it. I had known Wil for years by then. I had eaten with him, drunk with him, studied with him, fought beside him. I had trusted him with my life more than once. And I had never known.

I looked at him now, sitting on the ridge of the roof in the cold, with his dark Cealdish face very still and his burned hands resting on his knees. And I thought about him going down the cellar stairs of the burning Eolian, into the smoke and the dark, alone, when everyone else was running the other way. I thought about him kneeling beside her and begging her to let go. I thought about him taking her wrists, and pressing his own hands against the hot stone, and pulling.

I thought about what it must have cost. Not his hands. The other thing.

"How long?" I said quietly.

Wil did not answer for a long time.

"Since the first term," he said at last. "Since the first day she came into the Archives. She had a stack of books on Eld Vintic grammar, and she dropped them all on the stairs, and I helped her pick them up." He almost smiled. "She said thank you. And she smiled at me. And that was that."

"Wil—"

"And then she met Sim," said Wil. "A span later. In the same stairwell. He dropped *his* books." Wil almost smiled. "On purpose, I

think. He'd seen me do it."

"She looked at him," said Wil, "the way she looked at him today. Downstairs. The first time she ever saw him." He shrugged, a small careful movement that did not jar his hands. "And he looked at her the same way. And I thought, well. There it is."

\* \* \*

"You never told her," I said.

"No."

"Why not?"

Wil turned his head and looked at me. His dark eyes were very calm.

"Because she was happy," he said simply. "And Sim was happy. And they were happy together, in that stupid, sweet, ridiculous way that makes everyone around them want to throw things." He looked back out at the rooftops. "What would telling her have done? Made her feel guilty. Made Sim feel awkward. Made everything worse, for everyone, so that I could say something I wanted to say." He shook his head. "No. It was better not to."

"That's very noble."

"It's not noble." Wil's voice was flat. "It's just arithmetic. Three people unhappy, or one. I can count, Kvothe. I'm Cealdish." He paused. "And I wasn't unhappy. Not really. Not most of the time. I got to be her friend. I got to sit with her in the Archives and argue about Eld Vintic declensions. I got to see her laugh." He looked down at his hands. "That was enough. It was more than enough."

"And now?"

He did not answer for a long time.

"Now I've got hands that won't close properly," he said at last, "and she's alive, and she's laughing at Sim's terrible poetry." He smiled, very slightly. "I'd call that a fair trade."

\* \* \*

We sat there for a long time. The wind blew. The stars came out, one by one, cold and far away. In the black gap in the skyline where the

Eolian had been, something small was glowing. An ember, still smoldering deep in the rubble, three days after the fire.

"Kvothe," said Wil.

"Yes?"

"You'll never tell her." He did not look at me. "Or Sim. Ever."

"Wil—"

"Promise me."

I looked at him. At his calm dark face and his bandaged hands. I thought about all the things I had never told anyone. About Auri, and the Cellarage, and the stone that said no. About my mother's name. About Denna, and the cord on her wrist, and what I had begun to suspect about her patron.

Everyone has a door they keep closed. Even Wil. Especially Wil.

"I promise," I said.

He nodded once. Then he stood up, carefully, keeping his hands away from his body, and went back down through the window into the house, and I heard him lie down on the floor in the corner, where he had been sleeping all week, and go very still.

He did not sleep. I could tell by his breathing. But he lay there, and after a while, so did I.

\* \* \*

I kept the promise. I have kept it all these years. I am breaking it now, a little, by telling you; but Wil is a long way from here, and Sim and Fela are married, and happy, and there is nothing in this story that can hurt them now.

And I think Wil would forgive me. I think he would want someone to know. Not so they would pity him. He would hate that. But so that somewhere, in some book, it would be written down: that there was a man once who went into a burning building for a woman who did not love him the way he loved her, and never said a word, and called it a fair trade.

The Amyr would have called that *ivare enim euge*. For the greater good.

I call it the bravest thing I ever saw.

\* \* \*

"He builds bridges now," the innkeeper said to Chronicler. "Did I tell you that? Sim wrote me. Wil stayed at the University. He's Kilvin's right hand. Kilvin taught him the big work, the heavy work, the kind that doesn't need fine fingers. He built a new bridge over the Omethi." He smiled faintly. "He says his hands are too clumsy for fine work now. But they're very good at holding up heavy things."

Chronicler looked up from his page. "Did he ever marry?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a moment.

"Not that I know of," he said. He looked at the fire. "But Sim says Wil eats supper with them every Cendling, in their rooms above the bookbinder's, and argues with Fela about Eld Vintic declensions until the candles gutter. And that Fela says he's the best man she knows."

He picked up his cup.

"I think," he said, "that would be enough for him. I think it's always been enough."

## Interlude: Supper

The door of the Waystone opened, and the regulars came in out of the dusk.

There were more of them than usual. Graham and Old Cob and Jake, of course. Aaron the smith's apprentice. Carter, back from wherever he had been, with his arm in a sling and a sour look on his face. Shep's widow, who did not usually come in, and her sister, who came in with her. A pair of farmers from the far end of the valley whose names Chronicler never learned. They came in stamping and talking and shaking the evening chill from their coats, and they filled the common room with noise and warmth and the smell of woodsmoke and wet wool.

The innkeeper rose to meet them. It was the same smooth motion Chronicler had seen at noon, and the same thing happened. Something went out of him as he stood. The man who had been sitting at the table, with his voice like dark honey and his eyes like green fire, went away, and in his place was Kote, the innkeeper, mild and tired and bruised.

"Evening," he said. "Stew's on. Bast made it."

"Bast made it?" Graham looked alarmed. "Is it safe?"

"I heard that," said Bast, coming out of the kitchen with a stack of bowls.

"You were meant to," said Graham, and grinned.

\* \* \*

The stew was, as it turned out, very good. Better than good. Bast stood behind the bar with his arms folded and watched everyone eat it with

an expression of fierce satisfaction, and when Old Cob grudgingly admitted that it was the best stew he'd had in a month, Bast looked so pleased that Chronicler thought he might burst.

"Thyme," Bast said. "That's the secret. I didn't forget the thyme."

"Good lad," said Kote, without looking up from the bar.

They talked, as they always talked. About the weather, and the harvest, and the war. Carter told a long story about how he had broken his arm, which involved a cart, a mule, and a woman in Baedn whose husband had come home early. Jake told a story about his cousin's wedding, which involved a pig. Old Cob told a story about something that had happened when he was a boy, which involved a great deal of detail and no discernible point.

Kote poured drinks, and laughed in the right places, and said nothing.

And then Aaron, who had been quiet all evening, said, "I heard something else. In Rannish. When I was there for the iron."

The room went quiet.

"About Kvothe?" said Jake.

Aaron flushed. "Sort of. About a song." He looked down at his cider. "The man at the inn, the traveler. He sang some of it. He said it was Kvothe's song. The one he sang in Imre, the night the Eolian burned."

Behind the bar, Kote had gone very still. His cloth had stopped moving on the wood.

At the table by the hearth, where Chronicler sat, Bast had turned his head.

"What song?" said Graham.

"It's called *Tariniel*," said Aaron. "It's about the old stories. About Lanre and the white city. The man said it's forbidden now, in Vintas. The Penitent King banned it. Anyone caught singing it gets their tongue cut out." He looked up. "But people sing it anyway. In secret. In the hills, and the villages, and the back rooms of inns. The man said it's the most beautiful song he ever heard." He hesitated. "He sang some of it. Just a little. Very quietly. And everybody in the inn stopped



talking and listened. And when he was done, there was a woman at the next table crying, and she didn't even know why."

The Waystone was silent. Everyone was looking at Aaron.

"Sing it," said Old Cob.

Aaron went red to the roots of his hair. "I can't sing."

"Just a bit. Just what you remember."

"I don't remember it right. I only heard it once."

"Doesn't matter. Sing what you remember."

Aaron looked around the room. At Graham and Jake and Carter and Old Cob, all looking at him. At Shep's widow, sitting very still with her hands in her lap. At Kote, behind the bar, with his cloth motionless on the wood and his face completely blank.

Then he took a breath, and he sang.

\* \* \*

It was only a few lines. His voice was rough and untrained, the voice of a young man who had never sung anything but drinking songs and hymns. He did not have the melody quite right. He stumbled over one of the words.

But it did not matter.

He sang about a white city on the last day of its life. About towers rising against a blue sky, and gardens full of flowers, and children playing in the fountains. About a woman singing in a great hall, her voice rising like a bird.

It was only a few lines. And when he finished, the Waystone was silent.

Shep's widow was weeping. She sat very still at her table with her hands folded in her lap and tears running down her face, and she did not wipe them away.

Graham cleared his throat. "Well," he said. His voice was rough. "That's a sad one."

"It's not sad," said Shep's widow softly. "It's—" She stopped. She shook her head. "I don't know what it is. But it's not sad."

No one said anything.

Behind the bar, Kote picked up his cloth and began to polish the bar again. His hands were perfectly steady. His face was perfectly calm. He did not look at anyone.

But Chronicler, watching from the table by the hearth, saw that the cloth was moving in circles over the same spot of wood, over and over, the way a man's hands move when his mind is somewhere else entirely.

\* \* \*

They left late. Later than usual. They lingered at the bar and at the tables, talking in low voices, and when they finally went, they went slowly, the way people go when they do not want to leave a warm room for a cold night. Shep's widow was the last. She stopped at the door and looked back at Kote, standing behind the bar.

"Kote," she said. "That song. Do you know it?"

Kote looked at her. His face was mild and pleasant.

"I've heard of it," he said.

She looked at him for a long moment. Then she nodded slowly.

"If you ever hear it," she said, "the whole of it. Will you tell me? I'd like to hear the rest."

"If I ever hear it," said Kote, "I'll tell you."

She went out into the night. The door closed behind her.

Kote stood behind the bar for a long time. Then he set down his cloth and came back to the table by the hearth and sat down across from Chronicler.

He did not say anything. He sat with his hands folded on the table in front of him, and he looked at them.

"It's still sung," Chronicler said quietly. "Your song. After all this time."

"So it seems."

"You didn't know?"

"I knew it was banned. I didn't know it was still—" He stopped. He was quiet for a long time. "I didn't know."

Bast had come to stand beside the table. He looked down at the innkeeper, and his face was very strange. It was full of something that

Chronicler could not name. Something that looked almost like hope.

"Reshi," he said softly. "Do you hear it? They're still singing it. After everything. They're still singing your song."

The innkeeper did not look up.

"It's not my song, Bast," he said. "It never was. It belongs to the white city. To the children in the fountains." He was quiet for a moment. "I was only the one who sang it."

"But they remember it. They remember *you*."

"They remember a song." The innkeeper looked up. His green eyes were very tired. "That's all. A song. Songs outlive their singers. That's what they're for."

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he turned away. He went to the window and stood looking out at the dark.

"It's more than that," he said, without turning around. "You know it is."

The innkeeper did not answer.

\* \* \*

The fire had burned low. Chronicler got up and put another log on it, and the flames caught and crackled and rose, and the shadows in the common room danced.

When he sat back down, the innkeeper was looking at him.

"You're tired," he said.

"A little."

"We can stop. Pick it up in the morning."

"No." Chronicler picked up his pen. "No. You said three days. Today is the third day. If we stop now, we'll never finish."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Something moved in his face. Respect, perhaps. Or something like it.

"All right," he said. "But I warn you. The rest of it is long. And it's not pleasant. There's war, and death, and a great deal of foolishness. Most of it mine."

"I've recorded wars before."

"Not like this one." The innkeeper leaned back in his chair. "And there's a journey. A long one. Through places you've only read about

in stories. The Fae. The mountains. The ruins of the white city." He paused. "I met a god there. Or something close enough to one that the difference doesn't matter."

Chronicler's pen stopped.

"Selitos," he said.

The innkeeper smiled. It was a small, strange, weary smile.

"We'll get there," he said. "First I have to tell you about Elodin. And a place called Haven. And what he told me there, about what it costs to lose your name." He looked at Bast's back, at the window. "And then I have to tell you about how I met Bast."

At the window, Bast went very still.

"Reshi," he said. "You don't have to tell that part."

"Yes, I do." The innkeeper's voice was gentle. "It's part of the story, Bast. You're part of the story. You always were." He turned back to Chronicler. "Get a fresh page. This is going to take a while."

Chronicler got a fresh page.

Outside, the night was very dark. There was no moon. The wind had died, and the trees at the edge of the fields stood still and black against the stars.

And beyond the trees, very faintly, where the smoke had leaned all day, a light was burning. Small and steady and far away.

It was blue.

## Interlude: What Bast Remembered

"Tell him about the first year," said the innkeeper.

He had gone behind the bar to draw a jug of cider for the table. He said it over his shoulder, without turning around. Bast, in his backward chair, went very still.

"Reshi?"

"The first year. Here. At the Waystone." The innkeeper came back to the table with the jug and three cups. "I don't remember it well. I was very grey, that year. I remember working. I remember polishing things. I don't remember much else." He poured. "You remember it better than I do. Tell him."

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at Chronicler.

"You want to hear it?" he said. "From me?"

Chronicler hesitated. He glanced at the innkeeper, who had sat down and wrapped his hands around his cup and was looking at the fire.

"Yes," said Chronicler. "If you'll tell it."

\* \* \*

Bast was quiet for a long time. When he spoke, his voice was different. Quieter. Less sly.

"He didn't talk," he said. "That's the first thing. For the first three months, he didn't say anything that wasn't necessary. *Pass the hammer. The roof's leaking. Supper's ready.* That's all." He looked at the innkeeper. "You used to talk all the time, Reshi. From the moment

you woke up to the moment you slept. Stories and songs and arguments and jokes. You talked in your sleep, some nights. And then you just—stopped."

The innkeeper did not say anything. He looked at the fire.

"He worked," said Bast. "All day. Every day. From before dawn until long after dark. He fixed the roof. He fixed the chimney. He scrubbed every inch of this place, twice. He never stopped. Not once. I'd come down in the morning and he'd already be at it, and I'd go to bed at night and he'd still be at it." Bast looked down at his hands. "I thought, at first, he was trying to make the inn nice. Then I realized he wasn't. He was trying not to stop. Because if he stopped, he'd have to sit still. And if he sat still, he'd feel it."

"Feel what?" said Chronicler softly.

"The hole," said Bast. "Where his name used to be."

\* \* \*

"I tried everything," said Bast. "That first year. To bring him back. I played him songs; I'm terrible at playing, but I tried. I told him stories about the things he'd done. I brought him things. Flowers, and good wine, and once a lute I bought off a traveling bard for three talents." He laughed softly, without humor. "He thanked me very politely and put it in the cupboard under the stairs. It's still there."

The innkeeper's hands tightened, very slightly, on his cup.

"I tried being cruel, too," said Bast. "When being kind didn't work. I shouted at him. I told him he was a coward, hiding in an inn in the middle of nowhere. I told him Denna would be ashamed of him." He looked at the innkeeper. "I'm sorry, Reshi. I said terrible things. You just looked at me. Like you didn't understand what I was saying. Like I was shouting at a wall."

"I didn't understand," said the innkeeper quietly. "I remember now. I didn't understand any of it."

"I know." Bast's voice cracked. "I know. That was the worst part."

\* \* \*

"And then," said Bast, "at the end of the first winter, something happened."

He looked at the innkeeper. The innkeeper looked back at him. Something passed between them.

"Tell him," said the innkeeper.

Bast was quiet for a moment.

"There was a storm," he said. "A bad one. The worst anyone in Newarre could remember. Snow for three days, and wind, and cold so hard the trees cracked in the night. Nobody could get to the inn. We were alone here, the two of us, with the snow up to the windows."

"On the third night, the wind was very loud. Howling around the inn like a pack of wolves. I couldn't sleep. I came down to the common room, and he was sitting by the fire, the way he did most nights. Not doing anything. Just sitting. Looking at the fire." Bast was quiet. "And I sat down with him. And we sat there for a long time. With the wind howling."

"And then?"

"And then the wind said something," said Bast.

Chronicler looked at him.

"Not in words," said Bast. "The wind doesn't talk in words. But I'm Fae, and I can hear things mortals can't. And I heard it. The wind, howling around the inn, all night. And in the middle of the howling, it said something." He looked at the innkeeper. "It said his name."

The common room was very still.

"His real name," said Bast. "The one in the chest. The wind knew it. It had known it since he was fifteen, since the day he called it at the University. And it had been looking for him. For a year. All over the world. And it found him, here, in a snowstorm. And it said his name."

\* \* \*

"And I looked at him," said Bast. "Sitting by the fire. And he'd gone very still. Stillier than usual. And he turned his head. Toward the window. Toward the wind." Bast's voice was very quiet. "And he said, *Hello*."

Chronicler did not breathe.

"Just that," said Bast. "*Hello*. To the wind. Very softly. The way you say hello to someone you haven't seen in a long time, and have almost forgotten, but not quite." He looked down at his hands. "And the wind stopped. All at once. Right in the middle of the storm. Like someone had shut a door. And the snow stopped falling. And the whole world went quiet."

"What happened?"

"Nothing." Bast looked up. "Nothing happened. He sat there for a moment, looking at the window. And then he looked back at the fire. And his face was just the same as before. Grey. Empty. And he didn't say anything else. And after a while, the wind started up again. Not as loud. Just an ordinary wind. And in the morning the storm had passed, and the sun was out, and he got up and went to work, the way he always did."

"Did he remember?"

"No." Bast shook his head. "I asked him, the next day. He didn't know what I was talking about." He looked at the innkeeper. "Do you remember now, Reshi?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time.

"Yes," he said at last. "I remember now. The story brought it back." He looked at the fire. "It was the only time, in seven years. The only time anything reached me." He was quiet for a moment. "The wind came all that way. Looking. And I said hello. And then I let it go."

"Why?"

The innkeeper looked at Bast.

"Because if I'd answered it," he said quietly, "really answered it, the way I used to, it would have been loud. And the waystone couldn't have drowned it out. And something would have heard." He was quiet for a moment. "So I said hello. And then I told it to go away. Very gently. The way you'd tell a dog to go home."

"You told it to go away?"

"Not in words." The innkeeper smiled faintly. "The wind doesn't talk in words either. But it understood." He looked at the window. "It's



been very polite, ever since. It comes by, sometimes. On stormy nights. It howls around the inn for a while, and then it goes away. It never says my name again." He paused. "I think it's been waiting too. Like the rest of us."

\* \* \*

Nobody said anything for a long time.

Then Bast wiped his eyes with the back of his hand.

"That was the night I knew," he said. "That he was still in there. Somewhere. Under all of it. That he wasn't gone, just—put away." He looked at Chronicler. "That was the night I started planning."

"Planning what?"

Bast looked at the innkeeper. The innkeeper looked back at him.

"Later," said Bast. "I'll tell you later. It's not time yet."

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment. Then he nodded, very slightly.

"Later," he agreed.

He picked up his cup. He looked at Chronicler.

"Where was I?" he said.

## Chapter Seventy-One

# What Auri Brought

Auri came on the second night after the fire.

I did not hear her. I was lying awake in the narrow room at the top of Merra's stairs, the way I lay awake every night after the fire, with my frozen left hand wrapped in linen and resting on my chest, and the smell of smoke still in my hair no matter how many times I washed it. Threpe's men were at the door downstairs. The street outside was quiet. The ruins of the Eolian were a black shape against the stars, through the small high window.

And then there was a small soft tap on the glass. And a face at the window. Pale and thin, with a cloud of hair floating around it like a dandelion's ghost.

I got up. I opened the window with my good hand. She did not come in. She crouched on the sill outside, barefoot, balanced on the narrow ledge two stories above the alley, and looked at me with her enormous eyes.

"You're cold," she said.

"A little."

"Not a little." She looked at my wrapped hand. Her face was very serious. "The cold got into you. His cold. I can see it. It's still there, hiding under the cloth. Being cruel." She tilted her head. "That kind of cold doesn't like to leave. It sulks."

\* \* \*

She would not come in. She said the room had too many corners and the corners were cross with each other and she did not want to be in the middle of an argument. So I sat on the floor under the window, with my back against the wall, and she sat on the sill above me with her feet dangling over my head, and we talked.

Or she talked, mostly. Softly, in her quick light voice, the way she did. She told me that the Underthing had been very loud the night of the fire. That the pipes had all been singing at once, and the stones had been humming, and water had run in places where water never ran. She told me that she had hidden in Mantle with her blanket over her head, and sung to the walls until they stopped shaking.

"They were frightened," she said. "The stones. All of them. All the way down. Because the stones over here were frightened." She pointed across the rooftops, toward the black shape of the Eolian. "Stones talk to each other. Did you know? Under the ground. Under the river. They're all one stone, really, if you go down far enough. And when one part is frightened, all the parts are frightened."

"The Eolian's stones held," I said. "Fela held them."

"I know." Auri's face softened. "I heard her. All night. Asking them to stand. Very politely. Very firmly." She smiled. "She has lovely manners with stone. Better than yours."

"Most people have better manners than me."

"Yes," Auri agreed. "But you're getting better."

\* \* \*

She was quiet for a while. She swung her feet over my head. The night wind moved across the rooftops, cold and damp, smelling of ash and river.

"The door heard," she said.

I went still.

"The one under the Archives," said Auri. "The one that isn't a door. It heard the fire. It heard the song you sang before the fire. It heard the stones being frightened." She hugged herself. "It was listening, Kvothe. All night. Harder than it's ever listened. Like a dog with its ears up."

"Did it say anything?"

"No." She shook her head. "It never says anything. It only listens. And hums." She was quiet for a moment. "But the humming changed. After. It's different now. Lower. Like someone humming a tune they've only just remembered."

I did not know what to say to that. I sat with my back against the wall and my cold hand on my chest and I felt the hair rise on my arms.

"Are you frightened?" I said.

Auri looked down at me. Her eyes were very large and very dark in the starlight.

"Yes," she said simply. "But I sing to it. Every night. The way I always do. And it goes to sleep, after a while." She almost smiled. "It likes lullabies. Everything does, really. Even doors."

\* \* \*

"I brought you things," she said, after a while.

She reached into the pocket of her dress. She took out three small things and set them on the windowsill beside her, one after another, very carefully, the way she always set things down.

The first was a feather. Grey and white, barred with black, soft as smoke.

"That's from an owl," said Auri. "She lives in the chimney over the Masters' Hall. She's very wise and very rude. She let me have it. For your hand." She looked at me. "Feathers are good for cold. They remember what it's like to be warm in a nest."

The second was a small stoppered bottle of pale gold liquid.

"Honey," said Auri. "From the bees on the roof of the Mews. I asked them. They said yes, because it's for you, and you once fixed their hive when the wind knocked it over." I had not known that. I had done it absentmindedly, on my way somewhere else. "Rub it into your wrist. Not too much. Just enough. It'll remind the skin that summer is coming."

The third was a key.

\* \* \*

It was a small key. Brass, and very old, with a round bow and a short plain shaft and two teeth. It was green at the edges with age.

I looked at it. I looked at Auri.

"What does it open?" I said.

"Nothing." Auri's face was very serious. "That's why it's for you. It's a key that doesn't open anything. It's been looking for its lock for a very long time, and it never found it, and it's very tired." She touched it gently with one finger. "I thought it would understand you. Because you're looking too. For a lock. For the thing that fits."

I did not say anything.

"You don't have to find it," said Auri. "That's the secret. The key knows. It's been looking for a hundred years and it never found its lock and it's still a key. It's still exactly what it's supposed to be." She pushed it toward the edge of the sill, toward me. "Even if you never find what you're looking for. You're still you. You're still exactly what you're supposed to be."

\* \* \*

I took the three things. The feather and the honey and the key. I held them in my good hand in my lap, sitting on the floor under the window.

"Thank you, Auri," I said. My voice was not steady.

"You're welcome." She looked down at me, and her face changed. It went soft, and sad, and very old. Much older than she usually looked. "Kvothe. You're going away again. Aren't you?"

"How do you know?"

"You have the look." She tilted her head. "The look of someone who's going to go very far. Further than before. Somewhere I can't follow." She was quiet. "I don't like it."

"I don't either."

"Then don't go."

"I have to."

Auri looked at me for a long time. Then she nodded. Once. Very slightly. The way she nodded when something had been settled that she did not like but could not change.

"Then take the key," she said. "And when you get where you're going, and you can't find the lock, and you're very tired, hold it. And remember that it's still a key." She stood up on the sill, balanced on her bare toes, with the night behind her. "And come back. After. Come back and tell me if you found it."

"I promise."

She looked at me. And for a moment, just a moment, there was something in her face I had never seen there before. Something like a princess, looking down from a tower. Something like a girl who had once had a name that was not Auri, and a crown, and a whole kingdom waiting for her.

Then it was gone. And she was only Auri again, small and pale and barefoot on a windowsill.

"You always promise," she said. "It's very sweet."

And she turned and was gone, across the rooftops, quick and light as a moth.

\* \* \*

I used the honey on my wrist. A little, every night, the way she said. The feeling came back faster than the physician said it would. Not all of it. The hand stayed cold, the way Elodin said it always would. But it came back.

I kept the feather in the case of my lute, tucked under the strings at the neck, where it rode with me into the Fae and up into the Stormwal and down into the chamber beneath the Lackless house. It was there, still, when Denna put my lute into the chest. I suppose it is still there.

And I kept the key.

I did not know, then, what it meant. I only knew that it was small and green and old, and that it opened nothing. I carried it in my pocket, through everything, and I did not think about it very often.

But when I came back to Imre, grey and nameless, a year and a season later, and Auri came to me on the roof of the Grey Man in the dark, she looked at me for a long time with her enormous eyes. And then she reached into my pocket, without asking, and took out the key.

And held it up in the starlight.

"You didn't find it," she said.

"No," I said. I did not know what she meant. I did not know her.

She looked at the key. Then at me.

"But you're still a key," she said softly. "See? I told you."

And she put it back in my pocket. And then she gave me a name. A small one. For something that happened. So that I would have something to be, while I waited.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper reached into his apron pocket. Chronicler thought he would take out the knot again, or the little wooden wheel, or the white stone. But he took out something else. A small brass key, green at the edges, with a round bow and two teeth.

He set it on the table.

"It still doesn't open anything," he said. "I've tried it in every lock in the Waystone. For seven years. In the doors and the cellar and the cashbox and the chest." He almost smiled. "It doesn't fit any of them."

"Then why keep it?"

The innkeeper looked at the key for a long time.

"Because she was right," he said at last. "It's still a key. Even if it never finds its lock." He picked it up and turned it over in his fingers. "And so was I. For seven years. Behind that bar. Not fitting anything. Not opening anything." He put it back in his pocket, very carefully. "But still a key."

## Chapter Seventy-Two

# Haven

Elodin came for me on the fourth day after the fire.

I was still in Merra's house behind the ruins of the Eolian. I had not left it since that night. Threpe's men stood guard at the door, day and night, and a crowd of people still gathered in the street outside, though fewer each day. Some of them left gifts on the step. Some of them simply stood and looked at the house, and at the blackened walls of the Eolian across the street, and went away again.

Fela was awake by then, and sitting up, though she was very weak. Wil sat with her every day, his bandaged hands resting in his lap. They did not talk much. They did not seem to need to.

Sim came every morning with bread and news. The news was always bad. The war in Vintas was spreading. Ambrose's army had crossed the river at Tiller's Ford and was marching south through the green hills toward Severen. Towns were burning. Refugees were streaming north into the Commonwealth. The council of Imre was arguing about whether to recognize Ambrose as king, and the argument was very loud and very long and seemed likely to go on forever.

And the bounty on my head had doubled.

"A thousand royals," Sim said, on the third morning. His face was white. "Ambrose raised it himself. There are posters all over Imre. They've got a drawing of you." He hesitated. "It's not a very good drawing. They made your nose too big."

"That's a relief."



"Kvothe, this isn't funny."

"I know." I looked out the window at the blackened walls. "But if I don't laugh, Sim, I'll do something else. And I'd rather laugh."

\* \* \*

Elodin came in the afternoon. He did not knock. He simply appeared in the doorway of my room, the way he always did, leaning against the frame with his arms folded.

"You look terrible," he said.

"Everyone keeps telling me that."

"Everyone keeps being right." He came into the room and looked at my arm. I had it resting on a pillow; it still would not move properly from the elbow down. The white hand-shaped mark on my wrist had not faded at all. "Let me see."

I held it out. He took it in both of his and turned it over, very gently. He looked at the mark for a long time. He pressed his thumb against the white skin. I did not feel it.

"Cinder," he said.

"Yes."

He was quiet for a long moment. Then he let go.

"It'll heal," he said. "Mostly. It'll take time. Months. Maybe a year. You'll get the feeling back, a little at a time." He looked at me. "But it'll always be cold. That hand. Always. Even in summer. Even by a fire. That's what his touch does. It leaves a little of the winter behind."

I looked down at my wrist. At the pale print of a hand on my skin.

"Can I still play?"

Elodin looked at me for a long time.

"I don't know," he said. "Ask me in a year."

\* \* \*

He did not stay long. He looked in on Fela, and spoke to her quietly for a while, and she wept a little and he held her hand. He looked at Wil's hands and shook his head and said something in a language I did not know that made Wil's face go very still.

Then he came back to my room and stood in the doorway again.

"Get your cloak," he said. "We're going for a walk."

"Threpe's men won't let me leave."

"Threpe's men will do what I tell them." He smiled faintly. "I can be very persuasive, when I want to be."

"Where are we going?"

He looked at me for a long moment. Something moved in his dark eyes.

"You asked me a question," he said. "On the roof. Before the song. You asked me what happened to me." He paused. "I said I'd tell you after, if you were still yourself." He looked at me. "Are you still yourself?"

I thought about it. I thought about lying on the stage in the dark, with the fire roaring above me and my name gone. I thought about the knot around my neck.

"Mostly," I said.

"Good enough." He turned away. "Get your cloak."

\* \* \*

Threpe's men did let me leave. I do not know what Elodin said to them. He spoke to the captain for a moment at the door, very quietly, and the captain's face went pale, and then he stepped aside and did not look at either of us as we passed.

Elodin led me across Imre and over the stone bridge, and at the top of the arch he stopped, as I always did, and looked out over the river. The water was low and brown in the late summer heat. The trees along the banks were dusty green.

"You can't go onto the University grounds," he said. "You know that. You've been expelled."

"I know."

"But you're with me. And I'm a master. And masters can bring guests." He smiled. "It's a very old rule. Most of the other masters have forgotten it exists."

He led me down the far side of the bridge and onto the grounds of the University. It was strange, walking there again. Everything was the

same, and everything was different. The same grey buildings. The same courtyards. The same students hurrying to class with their books under their arms. But they stopped when they saw me. They stared. Some of them whispered. Some of them backed away.

I pulled my hood up over my hair. It did not help much.

Elodin did not seem to notice. He walked across the courtyard with his hands in his pockets, whistling, as if he were taking a stroll on a sunny afternoon. He led me past the Mains, and the Archives, and the Fishery. He led me to the edge of the University grounds, where a high wall of old grey stone ran along the northern boundary.

There was a gate in the wall. An iron gate, very old and very heavy, with bars as thick as my wrist. Beyond it, I could see a long low building of grey stone, with small barred windows and a slate roof.

I knew what it was. Everyone at the University knew.

It was the Rookery. Not the one where Elodin had his office, but the other one. The old one. The one they called Haven.

It was where the University kept its madmen.

\* \* \*

"I lived here," Elodin said. "For three years."

We were standing at the gate, looking through the bars. The building beyond was quiet. There was a small garden in front of it, neatly kept, with gravel paths and flowerbeds full of late summer roses. A man in a grey robe was walking slowly along one of the paths, his head bowed, his lips moving. He did not look up.

"I know," I said.

"Do you know why?"

"Everyone says you went mad."

"Everyone is right." Elodin looked through the bars at the man in the grey robe. "But do you know why I went mad?"

"No."

He was quiet for a long time.

"I was younger than you are now," he said at last. "The youngest student ever admitted to the University. Did you know that? Fourteen years old. They called me a prodigy. They said I was the most gifted

namer in a hundred years." He smiled faintly. "I believed them. Why wouldn't I? I could hear names the way other people hear music. Wind, fire, water, stone. They came to me as easily as breathing. By the time I was fifteen, I was a Re'lar. By sixteen, an El'the. By seventeen, I had learned more names than any living master."

"What happened?"

"I got curious." He shrugged. "Like you. I wanted to know everything. Every name. Every secret. And I found out that there was a kind of naming that no one at the University would teach. That no one even talked about. A kind of naming so dangerous that the masters had forbidden it, centuries ago, and written it out of the books." He looked at me. "Can you guess what it was?"

I thought about it. I thought about the knots, and the king's hair, and what Elodin had said on the roof. *Some of them forgot who they were.*

"Changing names," I said slowly. "Not just learning them. Changing them."

Elodin nodded. "Changing them. Taking a thing's true name and making it into something else. Something new." He looked through the bars. "Shaping, the old stories called it. The thing the Thief did, and the shapers who followed him. The thing that started the war."

"You tried it."

"I tried it." His voice was very quiet. "I was seventeen, and brilliant, and stupid, and I thought I could do anything. And I thought, what's the harm? I'll start small. I'll change something small. Something no one will miss." He was silent for a moment. "So I started with myself."

\* \* \*

I stared at him.

"You changed your own name."

"I tried to." He leaned his forehead against the bars of the gate. "I didn't like my name. I thought it was too small. Too ordinary. I thought I could make it bigger. Better. Wiser. Stronger." He laughed softly. "I thought I could make myself into something more than I was."

"What happened?"

He did not answer for a long time. When he did, his voice was very far away.

"I broke," he said. "Not all at once. Slowly. A little at a time. The name I was trying to make didn't fit. It was too big, or the wrong shape, or something. It pushed at me from the inside, like a foot in a shoe that's too small. And the old name, my real name, didn't want to go. It held on. It fought." He closed his eyes. "They tore me in half, the two of them. The old name and the new. They pulled me apart between them. And for a long time, I didn't know which one I was. Or if I was either. Or anything at all."

"Three years," I said.

"Three years in there." He opened his eyes and looked through the bars at the long grey building. "Three years not knowing my own name. Not knowing what I was. Talking to walls. Screaming at night. Eating what they gave me and sleeping where they put me and understanding nothing." He was quiet for a moment. "They thought I'd never come out. The masters. They'd given up on me. Written me off. Another brilliant boy who flew too close to the sun."

"But you did come out."

"I did." He smiled, a small, strange, broken smile. "Do you want to know how?"

"Yes."

"I stopped trying." He looked at me. "I stopped trying to be the new name. And I stopped trying to be the old one. I stopped trying to be anything at all. I just—let go. Of both of them. And sat in the dark, with nothing. No name, no self, nothing." He was quiet for a moment. "And after a long time, something came back. Not the old name. Not the new one. Something else. Something in between. Something that had grown, on its own, in the empty space where the others had been."

"Your name now."

"My name now." He nodded. "It's not the name I was born with. It's not the name I tried to make. It's the name I *became*, when I stopped trying to be anything." He smiled. "It's a strange name."

Crooked. A little broken. It doesn't fit quite right, and it never will. But it's mine."

\* \* \*

We stood at the gate for a long time without speaking. The man in the grey robe had reached the end of the garden path and turned around and was walking back, slowly, his lips still moving. A bird was singing somewhere in the roses.

"Why are you telling me this?" I asked at last.

Elodin did not answer right away. He was looking through the bars at the man in the grey robe.

"Because I saw you," he said. "On the stage. At the end of the song." He turned to look at me. "I was there, you know. In the crowd. At the back, by the south door. I saw everything."

"You were there?"

"Of course I was there. Did you think I'd miss it?" He smiled faintly. Then his smile faded. "I saw the song go through you. I saw it fill you up. And I saw your name go out of you, at the end. Just for a moment." He looked at me. "I saw you lying on the stage, empty. And I thought, *that's it. He's gone. Just like I was.*"

"But I came back."

"You came back." He looked at the knot on its thread, where it showed at the neck of my shirt. "You held onto something small. Like I told you." He paused. "But next time you might not."

"Next time?"

"There'll be a next time. You know there will." He turned back to the gate. "You're a namer, Kvothe. A true one. The first I've seen in a very long time. And you're going to do things with names that no one has done in a thousand years. Big things. Dangerous things." He was quiet for a moment. "And one day, you're going to come to a place where the only way forward is to do what I did. To change a name. Maybe your own."

I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.

"When that day comes," said Elodin, "I want you to remember this. This gate. That building. That man, walking in the garden, talking

to himself." He nodded at the man in the grey robe. "His name is Tamlin. He was a student here, thirty years ago. Brilliant. Like me. Like you. He tried to change the name of the moon."

I stared at the man. At his bowed head and his moving lips.

"He's been in there for thirty years," said Elodin quietly. "He'll be in there until he dies. He doesn't remember his own name. He doesn't remember anything. He just walks in the garden and talks to the moon." He looked at me. "That's what it costs, Kvothe. When it goes wrong. That's what it costs."

\* \* \*

He walked me back to Merra's house as the sun was setting. At the door, he stopped and looked at me for a long time.

"One more thing," he said. "About names."

"Yes?"

"A name can be put down." He said it slowly, carefully, as if choosing each word. "Not changed. Not broken. Put down. Set aside. The way you set down a heavy pack at the end of a long road." He paused. "It's very rare. Very difficult. I've only heard of it being done a handful of times, in all the old books. But it can be done."

"How?"

"You need someone to hold it for you." Elodin looked at me. "You can't just drop it. It has to go somewhere. It has to be kept. By someone you trust, in something that will hold." He was quiet for a moment. "And while it's put down, you're—less. Not empty, like Tamlin. Not broken, like I was. Just less. A shadow of what you were. You can't name. You can't do much of anything, really. You're just a person, walking around, without the thing that makes you you."

"Why would anyone do that?"

"To hide," said Elodin. "Or to protect someone. Or to keep a name safe from someone who wants to use it." He looked at me. "Or to stop being something you don't want to be anymore. Just for a while. Until you're ready to pick it up again."

I looked at him for a long time.

"Why are you telling me this?" I asked again.

Elodin smiled. It was a very strange smile. Sad and fond and a little bitter.

"Because I have a feeling," he said, "that someday you're going to need to know."

He turned and walked away down the street, with his hands in his pockets, whistling. He did not look back.

I stood in the doorway of Merra's house, in the red light of the setting sun, and I watched him go.

*A name can be put down, he had said. You need someone to hold it for you.*

I touched the knot around my neck. The one Denna had given me at the Grey Man. *Road. Promise. A story told many times, and changes in the telling.*

And I did not know, then, what I was thinking. I did not know that I had just been told the shape of my own ending.

But some part of me did. Some deep, quiet part, down at the bottom, where the truth lives.

And it began, very quietly, to make a plan.



## Chapter Seventy-Three

### Vashet

She came on the sixth day, at dawn, and she came through the window.

I was asleep. I had finally begun to sleep again, a little, in the nights since Elodin's visit. Not well, and not long. But enough. I was asleep in the narrow bed in Merra's house, with my cold arm resting on a pillow and the knot around my neck, and I was dreaming of a white city.

I woke because the air changed.

I cannot explain it better than that. One moment I was asleep, and the next I was awake, with my heart pounding and every nerve in my body singing. Someone was in the room. Someone who moved without sound, without shadow, without disturbing the air. Someone who had been trained to move that way, the way I had been trained, on a hillside in Ademre with a sword at my throat.

I did not move. I opened my eyes a crack and looked.

She was standing at the foot of my bed. Small and slim, in the blood-red clothes of the Adem mercenaries, close-fitting and bound with a hundred cords. Her dark hair was cut short. Her face was plain and calm and unremarkable. There was a sword on her back.

She was looking at me with an expression I knew very well. It was the expression she had worn a hundred times on the practice grounds at Haert, just before she knocked me flat.

"You are awake," said Vashet. "Do not pretend. You were never good at pretending."

I sat up. "Vashet."

"Kvothe." She did not smile. The Adem do not smile, not with their faces. But her hands moved, very slightly, at her sides. *Relief*, they said. *And anger. And something else.* "You are alive."

"Barely."

"Barely is enough. Barely is always enough." She looked at my arm on its pillow. Her hands went still. "What is that?"

"A long story."

"Tell it."

\* \* \*

I told it. All of it. The Archives and the door and the expulsion. Severen and Bredon and Meluan. Renere and the king's hair and Ambrose's crown. Tarbean and Skarpi. The Eolian, and the song, and the fire, and what came to stop it.

She listened without interrupting. She stood at the foot of my bed with her hands at her sides, and she did not move, and she did not speak. But her hands spoke. They spoke all the way through. Small movements, subtle and swift, the way the Adem speak when they are not trying to speak. *Surprise. Anger. Grief. Fear.*

When I told her about Cinder's hand on my wrist, her fingers curled into fists.

When I told her about Stanchion, they went very still.

When I finished, she was silent for a long time.

"We heard," she said at last. "In Haert. We heard that the Maer's Ruh had killed the king of Vintas. That he had sung him to death. That he was a demon, and a murderer, and a kingkiller." Her hands moved. *Disgust.* "Shehyn called the school together. She said that one of ours had shamed us. That the sword Caesura had been given to a barbarian who killed kings from behind curtains with songs." She looked at me. "She sent me to take it back."

I went cold.

"Take it back?"

"Caesura belongs to the school. It was lent to you. On condition." Vashet's voice was flat. "The condition was that you would use it

within the Lethani. A sword that has killed a king by treachery is not within the Lethani. It is shamed. It must come home."

"I didn't kill the king."

"So you say."

"I tried to *save* him."

"So you say." She looked at me. "I heard your story. I know how you tell stories. You are very good at making yourself sound right."

I stared at her. I did not know what to say.

Then her hands moved. *Joke*, they said. And then, *I believe you*.

\* \* \*

I laughed. It came out of me before I could stop it, a startled cracked laugh, and it hurt my chest. Vashet watched me laugh, and her face did not change, but her hands said *satisfaction*.

"You were always easy to fool," she said. "Even at the end. Even when you had learned the Ketan and the Lethani and could almost fight like a person." She sat down on the edge of the bed. "Of course I believe you. I knew you. I taught you. You are foolish and proud and you talk far too much and you have no sense of how to be quiet. But you are not a coward. And killing a man in his sickbed with a song is a coward's work." She looked at my arm. "And that. That is not a coward's wound."

"Will you tell Shehyn?"

"I will tell Shehyn what I have seen. She will decide." Vashet was quiet for a moment. "But I do not think she will want the sword back. Not after this."

"Why not?"

Vashet looked at me for a long moment. Her hands were very still.

"Because you stood on a stage," she said, "and sang the truth, while the thing that killed your family walked toward you. And you did not stop. Not when they came. Not when your friend died. Not when Cinder took your arm." She paused. "That is the Lethani, Kvothe. That is the whole of it. To do the right thing, at the right time, for the right reason, and to keep doing it no matter what it costs."

I did not say anything. I could not.

"Shehyn will understand," said Vashet. "When I tell her. She is very wise, for an old woman." Her hands moved. *Joke*. "Do not tell her I said that."

\* \* \*

She stayed. She did not ask if she could; she simply did. She took up a place in the corner of my room, sitting on the floor with her back against the wall and her sword across her knees, and she did not leave. When I slept, she watched. When I woke, she was there. When Sim or Wil or Devi came to visit, she looked at them with her calm Adem eyes and they became very polite and very quiet and left sooner than they had intended.

"Is she going to stay forever?" Sim whispered to me, on the second day.

"I don't know."

"She's terrifying."

"She's supposed to be. She's Adem."

"She looked at me," Sim said, "and I felt like she was deciding which of my bones to break first."

"That's just how she looks at people."

"That's not reassuring, Kvothe."

\* \* \*

On the third day, Vashet made me get out of bed.

"You are weak," she said. "You have been lying here for more than a span, feeling sorry for yourself. Your body has forgotten how to move. Get up."

"My arm—"

"Your arm is one arm. You have two. And two legs. And a back, and a belly, and a head, though you do not use the last one very often." She stood over me. "Get up. We will do the Ketan."

"Now?"

"Now."

So I got up. And in the small cramped room at the top of Merra's house, with the window open and the sounds of Imre drifting in, I did the Ketan.

It was terrible. I had not done it in months, not since before Renere. My body was stiff and weak and slow. My left arm hung useless, throwing off my balance, making every movement awkward and wrong. I stumbled through the first few forms like a drunk, and fell twice, and nearly put my foot through the wall.

Vashet watched without speaking. When I finished the first sequence, she said, "Again."

I did it again. It was slightly less terrible.

"Again."

I did it again.

We did it all morning. Over and over, the same forms, the same sequences, until my legs were shaking and my shirt was soaked with sweat and my breath was rasping in my throat. Vashet did not let me stop. She did not let me rest. She stood in the corner with her arms folded and said *again*, and I did it again.

And somewhere in the middle of the morning, something changed.

I stopped fighting my arm. I stopped trying to move it the way I used to, trying to make it do what it could no longer do. I let it hang. I let it be what it was. And I found, slowly, that my body could move around it. That the forms could shift and adapt, the way water shifts around a stone in a stream. That there was a Ketan for one arm, as well as for two.

It was not the same. It would never be the same. But it was something.

When I finished the last sequence, I stood in the center of the room with my chest heaving and my cold arm hanging at my side, and Vashet looked at me for a long time.

Her hands moved. *Better*.

\* \* \*

That night, she told me about the Lethani.

We were sitting on the floor of my room, in the dark, with the window open and the stars showing through it. I was too tired to sleep. She was too Adem to need much sleep. We sat there together in the quiet, and after a long time, she spoke.

"You asked me once," she said, "what the Lethani is. On the hillside at Haert. You wanted me to explain it."

"You wouldn't."

"No. Because it cannot be explained. Only lived." She was quiet for a moment. "But I will tell you a story. About Shehyn. About a thing she did, long ago, when she was young."

"All right."

"When Shehyn was young, younger than you are now, there was a man in Haert who did a terrible thing. I will not tell you what. It was very terrible. He hurt many people. Children. And when he was caught, he was brought before the school, and the school had to decide what to do with him."

"What did they decide?"

"They argued. For many days. Some said he should be killed. Some said he should be cast out. Some said he should be made to work, to pay for what he had done. They could not agree." Vashet paused. "And then Shehyn stood up. She was very young, and no one expected her to speak. But she stood up, and she walked to where the man was sitting, and she looked at him for a long time. And then she drew her sword and killed him."

I stared at her in the dark.

"The school was very angry," said Vashet. "They said she had acted without the Lethani. That she had not waited for the school to decide. That she had killed in anger, or pride, or haste." She was quiet for a moment. "Shehyn said nothing. She stood before them and let them be angry. And when they were done, she said one thing."

"What?"

"She said, 'He was going to do it again. I saw it in his eyes. And while you argued, he would have had time.'" Vashet's voice was very quiet. "And then she laid down her sword, and said that the school

could do with her as they liked."

"What did they do?"

"They did nothing. They looked at her for a long time, and then they picked up her sword and gave it back to her." Vashet was silent for a moment. "Three days later, they found that the man had hidden a knife in his cell. And a list of names. Children's names."

The room was very quiet.

"Why are you telling me this?" I asked.

Vashet looked at me in the dark.

"Because you are going to face a choice," she said. "Soon. I can see it on you, the way I could see the Ketan in you before you learned it. A choice like Shehyn's. Where you must act, and there is no time to wait, and everyone will say afterward that you were wrong." She paused. "And you will not know if you were right. Not for a long time. Maybe not ever."

"How will I know what to do?"

"You will not know. You will only choose." Her hands moved in the dark; I could not see them, but I felt the air shift. "That is the Lethani, Kvothe. Not knowing. Choosing. And bearing what comes after."

\* \* \*

She left on the ninth day. She stood at the window at dawn, as she had come, and looked at me.

"I will go back to Haert," she said. "I will tell Shehyn what I have seen. And then I will come back." Her hands moved. *Promise*. "You will need me. Before the end. I can feel it."

"How will you find me?"

"I found you this time." She did not smile. But her hands said *amusement*. "You are not hard to find, Kvothe. You are the loudest quiet person in the world."

She turned to the window. Then she stopped and looked back.

"The sword," she said. "Caesura. You still have it?"

"Yes."

"Good. Keep it. Use it well." She paused. "And if you ever use it for something that is not the Lethani—if you ever use it for anger, or pride, or revenge—then I will come and take it back. And I will not be gentle."

"I understand."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then her hands moved, very slightly, in a sign I had never seen her make before. It took me a long time to understand it, after she had gone.

It meant *family*.

Then she was gone, out the window and down into the grey dawn streets of Imre, and I was alone.



## Chapter Seventy-Four

# One Hand

Vashet left on the ninth day. On the tenth, I tried to play.

I had not tried since the fire. I had not wanted to. I had sung at Stanchion's grave with one hand on the open strings of his cracked old lute, and that had been enough, and I had told myself that it would be enough for a while. That the hand would heal, as Elodin said, a little at a time. That I would wait.

But I am not good at waiting. You will have noticed that by now.

So on the tenth day, in my room at the top of Merra's house, with the window open and the smell of the burned Eolian still drifting in on the wind, I took Stanchion's lute out of its case and sat on the edge of my bed and tried.

\* \* \*

My left hand would not do it.

It moved, now. That was something. Felurian had not kissed it yet; that would come later, in the twilight. But in the fortnight since the fire, a little feeling had crept back into it, the way feeling creeps back into a foot that has fallen asleep. Pins and needles, first. Then a dull ache. Then, very faintly, the sense of the fingers, like the memory of fingers.

But they would not bend. Not properly. I could lay them on the neck of the lute, over the frets, and I could press down, a little. But I could not make them go where I wanted. They were stiff and slow and clumsy, like the fingers of an old man with the joint-ache. They slid

off the strings. They muted notes they should have stopped and stopped notes they should have let ring.

I tried a simple chord. The first chord any child learns. It came out as a dull buzzing mess.

I tried again. The same.

I tried a hundred times. Every chord I knew. Every song. The ones I had played since I was three years old on my father's knee, the ones that were in my hands more deeply than they were in my head. My hands knew the shapes. My right hand, the good one, knew them perfectly. It struck the strings clean and bright, the way it always had.

My left hand did not know anything. It had forgotten. Or rather, it knew, but it could not do. Like a man who knows every word of a language but has lost his tongue.

\* \* \*

I sat on the edge of the bed with the lute in my lap for a long time after I stopped trying.

I did not weep. I want to be honest about that, since I have been honest about everything else. I have wept a great deal in this story, and I am not ashamed of it. But I did not weep then.

I only sat there. And I felt something I had not felt since I was twelve years old, sitting in an alley in Tarbean with the pieces of my father's lute in my lap.

It was not grief. It was worse than grief. It was the feeling of a door closing. Of something that had always been there, always been mine, that no one could take from me, being taken.

*You'll get the feeling back, Elodin had said. A little at a time. But it'll always be cold. That hand. Always.*

*Can I still play?*

*I don't know. Ask me in a year.*

I did not want to wait a year. I did not know how.

\* \* \*

Sim found me there that evening. He came up the stairs with a basket of bread and cheese from the market and a bottle of cheap wine,

whistling, and stopped in the doorway when he saw me.

He looked at the lute in my lap. At my face. At my left hand, lying on the strings, stiff and white.

He set down the basket. He did not say anything. He came and sat on the bed beside me and looked at the lute too.

"It won't work," I said at last.

"Your hand?"

"Yes."

Sim was quiet for a long time.

"Elodin said it would get better," he said.

"Elodin said to ask him in a year."

"That's not no."

"It's not yes either."

Sim looked at me with his thin earnest face. His eyes were very bright. He did not have a patch yet. That would come later too, after the Lackless house.

"Play something," he said. "Anyway. With one hand. The way you did at the grave."

"That's not playing. That's plucking open strings like a child."

"It made three hundred people cry," said Sim. "On a hill. In the rain." He looked at me. "I don't care if it's playing. I want to hear it."

\* \* \*

I did not play for him that night. I put the lute back in its case and closed the lid and we ate the bread and cheese and drank the terrible wine and talked about other things.

But I lay awake afterward, in the dark, with my cold hand lying on my chest, and I thought about what he had said.

*I don't care if it's playing.*

And I thought about the Adem. About Vashet, in the small cramped room, making me do the Ketan over and over with one arm hanging useless at my side. About how, somewhere in the middle of that morning, I had stopped fighting my arm. Stopped trying to make it do what it could no longer do. And found that my body could move around it. That there was a Ketan for one arm, as well as two.

Not the same. It would never be the same.  
But something.

\* \* \*

I got up. I lit a candle. I took the lute out of its case again.

I did not try to play chords. I did not try to make my left hand do anything at all. I let it rest on the neck of the lute, lightly, not pressing. I let it be what it was.

And I began to play with my right hand alone.

Open strings, first. Then harmonics: the high ringing bell-notes you can make by touching a string very lightly at certain places along its length, without pressing it down. My left hand could do that. It did not need to bend. It only needed to touch, lightly, and lift away. Like laying a finger on a sleeping child's cheek.

It was not playing. Not the way I had played before. There were no chords. No fast runs. No melody in the ordinary sense.

But there were notes. Bright ringing notes, and deep open ones, and the strange floating bell-notes of the harmonics, like stars coming out one by one in a darkening sky. I could make patterns with them. Slow patterns. Spare ones. Music with a great deal of silence in it.

It reminded me of the Adem songs. The ones I had played at the Eolian my first night back, which are not really songs at all but more like patterns of breath and silence.

It was not the same.

But it was something.

\* \* \*

I played until the candle burned out. Then I played in the dark.

And near dawn, very tired, not thinking, I found that my left hand had moved. Not much. Only a little. It had pressed down, very slightly, on a single string, at a single fret. Just for a moment. Just enough to change one note.

It was a clumsy note. Buzzing and dull. But it was a note that I had made with my left hand, on purpose, for the first time since the Eolian burned.

I sat very still in the grey dawn light with the lute in my lap.  
Then I did it again.

\* \* \*

It took nine months. I want you to know that, because the stories never say it. The stories say that Kvothe was wounded by Cinder and healed by Felurian's kiss, and that is true, in its way. Felurian's kiss gave me the warmth. It gave me the feeling back. But it did not give me the playing.

That, I did myself. With one hand, and then with one hand and a little of the other. With harmonics and open strings and slow spare patterns full of silence. With one clumsy note, and then two, and then a chord, very simple, very slow. Every night. On the road and in the twilight and in the Maer's camp in the hills. On the far side of the Stormwal, in a cave, with scrael clicking outside, playing a lullaby for a sleeping Fae prince with fingers that bled.

Nine months.

And when I sang *Tariniel* again, the second time, on the day I became Kvothe again after seven years of being Kote, in the common room of the Waystone Inn at dawn, I played it with both hands. And the people who heard it said it was the most beautiful thing they had ever heard.

But I will tell you a secret. The most beautiful thing I ever played was not that. It was not *Tariniel* at the Eolian, either, or any of the songs I played for Felurian, or the lullaby I sang to the Sleeper in the dark.

It was one clumsy buzzing note, in a small room at the top of a widow's house in Imre, at dawn, with the smell of smoke still in the air.

I have never played a better one.

## Chapter Seventy-Five

# A Letter in Knots

Denna's first letter came eleven days after the fire.

It did not come by post. It did not come by messenger. It came by way of a small, filthy, freckled boy of about eight, who knocked on the door of Merra's house in the early morning and asked for "the red-haired man what sings." Threpe's guards tried to send him away. He kicked one of them in the shin and bit the other one's hand and shouted my name at the top of his lungs until I came down the stairs to see what the commotion was.

"You're him," the boy said, looking up at me. He had a gap where his front teeth should have been. "The one what sings."

"I'm him."

"Lady gave me this." He held out a grubby fist. "Said give it only to you. Said you'd give me a penny."

I did not have a penny. I had nothing. Threpe's guard, rubbing his bitten hand, sighed and fished one out of his own pocket and gave it to the boy. The boy snatched it, and in the same motion pushed something into my hand, and was gone down the street before any of us could say a word.

I looked down at what he had given me.

It was a cord. A thin dark cord, about as long as my forearm, braided from three strands of what I realized, after a moment, was human hair. Dark hair. And it was knotted.

\* \* \*

I took it up to my room and sat on the bed with it and did not move for a long time.

It was not like the Dellers' cloth, or the cord Denna had worn in the Grey Man. It was simpler. The knots were smaller and plainer, spaced out along the cord at even intervals, like words on a page. She had tied it for me to read. Using only the knots she had taught me, and a few that were obvious from their shape. She had tied it slowly and carefully, so that I would not mistake any of them.

And she had tied it in her own hair.

I sat on the bed and read it. It took me most of the morning. Some of the knots I had to puzzle over for a long time, turning the cord this way and that in the light from the window. But I read it. All of it.

*Siege, it said. Severen. Nine days. Walls hold.*

*King. Tent. Box. Guarded always.*

*Old man. Waiting. For you. He says you will come to Severen. To save your family. He says that is the trap.*

*Not Severen. Lackless house. Near Levinshir. The door is there. Under.*

*When Severen falls, they take the lady. Her blood. And then they wait for you.*

*Do not come to Severen.*

*Do not come to the door.*

*Find another way.*

And then, at the very end, after a gap, one more knot. Small and tight and very neat, with the loops doubling back on themselves in that particular way.

It was the knot that said *forgive*.

\* \* \*

I sat on the bed with the cord in my hands for a long time after I had finished reading it.

*When Severen falls, they take the lady. Her blood.*

Meluan. My aunt. Nine months with child by now, or near enough. Trapped in a city under siege, behind walls that held, for now.

*He says you will come to Severen. To save your family. He says that is the trap.*

Of course it was. Of course. Bredon knew me. He had known me since the first day I sat down across a tak board from him. He knew that I would hear about the siege, and about Meluan, and that I would come running. That I would throw myself at Ambrose's army, alone if I had to, with my one good arm and my borrowed sword, to try to save her.

And when I did, he would be waiting.

*Find another way.*

I sat on the bed and thought about that. I thought about it for a long time.

What other way was there? I could not fight an army. I could not break a siege. I could not walk into Ambrose's camp and steal the box out of his tent. I could not do any of the things that needed doing.

And even if I could—even if I saved Meluan, and got the box back, and somehow kept them both safe—what then? The door would still be there. Beneath the Lackless house, waiting. Bredon would still be there, patient as stone, playing his long slow game. Haliar would still be there, wanting to die. The Thief would still be there, behind his door, breathing in the dark.

It would never end. Not as long as the door could be opened. Not as long as there was a key, and a line, and someone who could speak the name.

*A true lock needs a true key, Skarpi had said. So that it can be checked, and tended, and held.*

But what if the lock did not need to be tended? What if there were a way to close the door so completely that no key could ever open it again? Not the line, not the box, not anyone?

Selitos had made the door. Selitos had made the key, and bound the line to it. If anyone knew how to unmake that binding—how to close the door for good—it was Selitos.

And Skarpi had said, in the broken lighthouse, in the middle of his story, that Selitos still watched. In the ruins of Myr Tariniel. In the



mountains.

I sat up very straight.

\* \* \*

"You want to go *where*?" said Devi.

We were sitting in her rooms above the butcher's shop, all of us. Devi and Sim and Wil and Fela, who was well enough now to walk, though she still coughed sometimes and tired easily. Threpe had come too, in a coat of subdued grey that was, for him, practically mourning dress. And Elodin, who had not been invited but had come anyway, and was sitting on the windowsill eating one of Devi's apples.

"The Stormwal," I said. "The mountains in the north. There's a ruin there, very old. The ruins of Myr Tariniel."

"That's a story," said Sim. "Myr Tariniel. It's a place in a story."

"So was the Chandrian. Until they walked into the Eolian."

Sim opened his mouth. Then he closed it again.

"Why?" said Wil. His hands were still bandaged, and he held them carefully in his lap. "Why there? Why now?"

"Because there's someone there who knows how to close the door. For good. So no one can ever open it again." I looked around at them. "And if I can learn how, then it doesn't matter what Bredon does. It doesn't matter if Ambrose has the box, or Meluan, or anything else. If the door can't be opened, their whole game falls apart."

"Who?" said Fela quietly. "Who's there?"

I hesitated.

"Selitos," I said.

There was a long silence.

"Selitos," said Threpe. "*The* Selitos? The one-eyed man from the stories? The one who founded the Amyr?"

"Yes."

"He'd be—" Threpe did some quick arithmetic on his fingers and gave up. "He'd be thousands of years old."

"Yes."

"He'd be dead."

"Skarpi's thousands of years old," I said. "And he's not dead."

Threpe opened his mouth. Then he closed it again, the way Sim had.

\* \* \*

"The Stormwal is a very long way away," said Elodin, from the windowsill. It was the first thing he had said all evening. "Two months, by road. Three, if the weather turns. And there's a war between here and there, and a king who wants you dead, and a thousand royals on your head." He took a bite of apple. "By the time you get there, Severen will have fallen. And your aunt will be in Ambrose's hands. And the old man will have moved on to the next part of his game."

"I know."

"So you can't go by road."

"No."

Elodin looked at me for a long moment. His dark eyes were very sharp.

"You're thinking of another way," he said. "A faster way."

"Yes."

"Through the Fae."

The room went very quiet.

"The *Fae*?" said Sim. His voice cracked. "Kvothe, are you mad? You barely got out of there the last time!"

"I got out. That's what matters." I looked at Elodin. "The Fae doesn't follow the same rules as the mortal world. Distances are different. Time is different. A journey that takes months here might take days there. If I can find the right roads—"

"And if you can't? If you get lost? If you wander into the wrong grove, or eat the wrong fruit, or speak to the wrong person?" Elodin's voice was very calm. "You could come out in a hundred years. Or never come out at all."

"I know."

"You don't know. You think you know. You went into the Fae once, and you met Felurian, and you came out with your mind and your life and a very nice cloak. You think that makes you an expert."

He set down his apple. "It doesn't. It makes you lucky. And luck runs out."

I looked at him. I did not say anything.

"There are things in the Fae," Elodin said quietly, "that make the Chandrian look like children playing in a garden. Old things. Hungry things. Things that have been waiting a very long time for a mortal with a namer's gift and the blood of the Thief to come wandering into their woods." He looked at me. "You'd be walking into the lion's den with a steak tied around your neck."

"Then what should I do?" I said. "Sit here? Wait? Let Severen fall and Meluan be taken and the door be opened?" I looked around at them. "I don't have any other choice. There isn't time for anything else."

Elodin looked at me for a long time. Then he sighed.

"No," he said. "No, I suppose there isn't." He picked up his apple again. "When?"

"The full moon. Nine days from now."

"And how will you get in?"

"The same way I did before. There's a glade in the Eld. A pool, with a greystone beside it. That's where I went through last time."

Elodin nodded slowly. "And once you're in? How will you find your way?"

I hesitated. "I'll figure it out."

"You'll figure it out." Elodin laughed, a short humorless sound. "Of course you will." He shook his head. "Well. At least you'll have something to write about in your memoirs. Assuming you live to write them."

\* \* \*

They argued for a long time after that. Sim wanted to come with me. Wil said Sim would be more hindrance than help and Sim was offended. Devi said she would come, and I said no, and she said I did not get to decide that, and I said I did, actually, and we shouted at each other for a while. Fela did not say anything. She sat quietly in the corner, with her hands in her lap, and listened.

In the end, I won. I usually do, when I argue. It is one of my less attractive qualities.

"I go alone," I said. "It's the only way. The Fae is dangerous enough for one mortal. For five, it would be a slaughter." I looked around at them. "And I need you here. All of you. I need you to help Threpe keep Imre from recognizing Ambrose. I need you to find out everything you can about what's happening in Vintas. I need you to be ready, when I come back."

"If you come back," said Devi.

"When," I said.

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she looked away.

"When," she said quietly.

\* \* \*

Later, when the others had gone, Fela stayed behind.

She sat in the corner of Devi's room while Devi cleaned up the teacups, and she looked at me with her dark serious eyes. When Devi went out to the landing to shake out the tablecloth, Fela got up and came and sat beside me.

"The door," she said quietly. "Under the Lackless house. It's made of stone."

"Yes."

"Like the one under the Archives."

"Yes. They're the same door. Or faces of the same door. Seven of them."

She was quiet for a moment. Then she reached into her pocket and took something out and pressed it into my hand.

It was a stone. A small flat grey stone, about the size of a coin, worn smooth by water. There was a single mark scratched into it. A line, very straight, with a small curve at one end.

"I made it," Fela said. "After the fire. When I was sick. I couldn't get out of bed, so I lay there and held this stone and listened to it. For days." She looked at me. "It's a piece of the Eolian. From the foundation. One of the stones I held."

I looked down at it.

"I asked it to remember," she said. "What it did. How it held. How it said no, when the fire wanted it to say yes." She paused. "And I think it does. I think if you hold it, it'll tell you. It'll remind you."

"Remind me of what?"

"That stone can hold." Fela's voice was very quiet. "Even when everything else is burning. Even when it's alone in the dark. It can hold." She closed my fingers around the stone. "And so can you."

I looked at her. At her pale face and her singed hair and her dark serious eyes.

"Thank you, Fela."

She smiled faintly. "Just come back. That's all. Come back and give it back to me. I want it back."

"I'll give it back."

"Promise."

I thought about all the promises I had made. All the ones I had broken. All the ones I would break.

"I promise," I said.

\* \* \*

That night, I went down to the river.

Not the docks. Further down, past the last of the warehouses, where the bank grew wild and overgrown and there was an old stone culvert that emptied into the water. It was a drain, from the old days, when Imre had been smaller and the University had been younger. It ran back under the town, under the river, into the dark.

I knelt by the mouth of the culvert and whistled. Three notes, rising.

For a long time, nothing happened. Then I heard a patter of bare feet on wet stone, far back in the dark. And a small pale face appeared at the mouth of the drain, looking out at me with enormous eyes.

"Kvothe," Auri whispered.

"Hello, Auri."

"You're on the wrong side of the river." She looked at me reproachfully. "You're not supposed to be on the wrong side. You're supposed to be on the right side. With me."

"I can't come to the right side anymore. They won't let me."

"I know. I heard." She crept out of the culvert and sat on the stones beside me, her knees drawn up to her chin. "The Underthing told me. The stone was very upset." She looked at me. "You woke the deep door."

"I didn't mean to."

"I know you didn't. But you did." She was quiet for a moment. "It's been dreaming ever since. Very loudly. The whole Underthing can hear it." She shivered. "It's dreaming about you."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. Be careful." She looked at me with her enormous eyes. "You're going away again. Aren't you? I can tell. You have your going-away face on."

"Yes."

"Far?"

"Very far."

"To the other door? The one with the family?"

I stared at her. "How do you know about that?"

"The stone told me." She said it simply, as if it were obvious. "All the doors talk to each other. They're all the same door, really. Just in different places." She tilted her head. "The one here is very worried about the one there. It says the one there is very tired. It says someone's been knocking."

I did not say anything for a long time.

"Auri," I said at last. "If I don't come back—"

"Don't say that." She put her small cold hand over my mouth. "Don't say that. It's not a proper thing to say."

I took her hand away gently.

"If I don't come back," I said again, "I want you to know that you were my friend. My first friend, here. And one of my best." I swallowed. "I want you to know that."

She looked at me for a long time. Her enormous eyes were wet in the moonlight.

"I know that," she said. "I've always known that." She leaned against my shoulder, very lightly, the way a bird might land on a branch. "You're my friend too. My only friend who brings presents."

I laughed. It came out broken.

"I didn't bring you a present tonight," I said.

"Yes you did." She tilted her head up to look at me. "You came to say goodbye. That's the best present. Most people don't."

We sat there by the river for a long time, in the moonlight, with the water rushing past and the lights of Imre glittering on the far bank. She did not say anything else, and neither did I.

When she went back into the culvert, a little before dawn, she stopped at the mouth of it and turned around.

"Kvothe," she said. "When you get to the other door. If it speaks to you. Don't answer."

"I won't."

"Promise?"

"I promise."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she smiled, a small sad radiant smile.

"You always promise," she said. "That's what I love about you. And that's what worries me."

Then she was gone, back into the dark, and I was alone by the river with the dawn coming up grey behind me.

## Interlude: The Question

"Can I ask you something?" said Chronicler. "About Denna?"

The innkeeper had stopped speaking at the edge of the river, with the grey dawn coming up behind him and a letter in knots in his pocket. He had been sitting quietly for some time, turning his cup in his hands. He looked up.

"You can ask," he said. "I may not answer."

Chronicler hesitated. He glanced at Bast, who was sitting in his backward chair with his chin on his folded arms, watching them both with bright, wary eyes.

"She betrayed you," said Chronicler. "Didn't she? Over and over. She worked for Bredon. She tied the knots in the old king's hair. She lured you to Renere, and then to the garden, and then to the door. Everything he wanted from you, he got through her." He paused. "And you keep forgiving her. Every time. You keep running back."

The innkeeper did not say anything. His face did not change.

"I'm not judging," said Chronicler quickly. "I'm only trying to understand. For the book. People will read this, and they'll ask. They'll say you were a fool."

"I was a fool," said the innkeeper mildly. "That's not in question."

"Then why?"

\* \* \*

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time. He set down his cup. He folded his hands on the table. He looked at the fire.

"Have you ever been in love, scribe?" he said.



Chronicler opened his mouth. Then he closed it.

"Once," he said at last. "A long time ago."

"What was her name?"

"Tessa." Chronicler looked down at his pen. "She was a copyist, in Tinuë. In the same counting-house as my father. She had the most beautiful hand I ever saw. Every letter like a little bird." He was quiet for a moment. "She married a wine merchant."

"Did she betray you?"

"No. She just—" Chronicler shrugged. "Chose someone else."

"And do you hate her for it?"

Chronicler thought about it. It was a long time before he answered.

"No," he said. "I think about her sometimes. When I see a good hand. I hope she's happy."

The innkeeper nodded slowly.

"That's the difference," he said. "Between you and most people. And between me and most people. Most people, when they're hurt, want to hate. It's easier. It gives the hurt somewhere to go." He looked at the fire. "I tried to hate her. I want you to know that. After Renere. After the garden. After I found out about the knots in the old king's hair. I sat in my rooms at the Seven Swans and I tried as hard as I have ever tried to do anything. I tried to hate Denna."

"And?"

"And I couldn't find anything to hate." He almost smiled. "I kept looking. I kept turning it over, the way you turn a stone over looking for the crack. And every time, underneath, I found the same thing. A girl alone. A girl with no family and no name and no one in the world who wanted her for herself. A girl who'd been used by every man who ever looked at her, from the time she was fourteen. And one man, finally, who didn't seem to want anything from her at all. Who was kind. Who taught her to tie beautiful things. Who told her she was clever and gifted and important." He was quiet. "Who gave her a *purpose*."

"Bredon."

"Bredon." The innkeeper looked at his hands. "He found her the way he found everyone. He found the hole in her, the empty place where she wanted something, and he filled it. With kindness. With lessons. With a story about a hero named Lanre who was wronged by the world." He shook his head slowly. "And she believed him. Of course she did. It was the first time anyone had ever given her a story to believe in."

\* \* \*

"But she knew," said Chronicler. "Didn't she? At some point. She must have known what he was."

"Yes." The innkeeper's voice was very quiet. "At some point. Not at first. But at some point." He was silent for a long moment. "Do you know what she did, when she found out?"

Chronicler shook his head.

"She didn't run," said the innkeeper. "She didn't tell anyone. She didn't come to me and weep and ask for help." He looked up. "She stayed. She kept working for him. She kept tying his knots. And she learned. Everything he knew. Every knot, every binding, every trick of tying a name into a cord. She let him teach her, knowing what he was, knowing what he wanted, so that she would know how to undo it." He was quiet. "She was playing his game. His beautiful game. Against him. For years. Alone."

The fire crackled. Nobody spoke.

"And when the time came," said the innkeeper, "when the door opened, and my name was hanging in the air, and the Thief was pulling at it, and I couldn't hold it—she was there. With a cord of her own hair in her sleeve. Ready." He looked at Chronicler. "She'd been ready for a year. She told me that, later. She'd been carrying that cord in her sleeve for a year, waiting for the moment. Because she knew. She'd seen the shape of his game. She knew it would come to that. Me, at the door, with my name in the air. And she wanted to be the one who caught it."

"Why?"

"Because she'd helped put me there." The innkeeper's voice did not change. "And she knew it. And she couldn't undo it. So she did the next best thing. She made sure that when I fell, someone would catch me."

\* \* \*

Chronicler did not say anything for a long time. He looked down at his page. At the lines he had written, in his careful hand, about a girl with dark hair walking away into the dark by a river, and a letter in knots.

"You make her sound like a hero," he said at last.

"She was." The innkeeper looked at him. "She was the bravest person I ever knew. Braver than me. Braver than Tempi or Vashet or any of the Adem. I fought monsters with a sword, and a song, and all my friends around me. She fought the most dangerous man in the world with a piece of string. Alone. For years. And she never told anyone. And she never asked for thanks." He was quiet for a moment. "And when it was over, she gave me back. That's the part that matters most. She could have kept my name. She could have held it forever, the way Bredon held hers. And she gave it back."

"Held hers?"

The innkeeper looked at him. And something passed across his face, very quickly. Something old and sad and angry.

"That's later," he said. "That's in the story. You'll see."

\* \* \*

Bast had not said anything all this time. But now he stirred in his chair, and lifted his chin from his arms, and looked at the innkeeper with an expression Chronicler could not read.

"You're leaving something out, Reshi," he said.

The innkeeper looked at him.

"The scribe asked why you keep forgiving her," said Bast. "And you've told him why she's brave. And why she's good. And why she did what she did." He tilted his head. "But that's not what he asked. He asked why *you* forgive her. And that's not the same thing."

The innkeeper did not answer for a long time.

"No," he said at last. "It isn't."

"So?"

The innkeeper looked at the fire. When he spoke, his voice was very quiet. So quiet Chronicler had to lean forward to hear it.

"Because I did the same thing," he said. "To everyone I loved. Over and over. I lied to Sim and Wil. I used Devi's help and never paid her back. I took Auri's trust and walked into the Cellarage and nearly got her killed. I let Fela hold up a burning building so I could sing a song. I let Stanchion die. I let the Maer use me, and I used him back, and a city burned." He looked down at his hands. "I did it all for good reasons. Or I thought they were good reasons. I did it to find the Chandrian. To close the door. To save the world." He was quiet. "Denna did the same thing. For the same reasons. And if I can't forgive her—"

He stopped.

"Then you can't forgive yourself," said Bast softly.

The innkeeper did not answer. He did not have to.

\* \* \*

Chronicler sat very still. After a while, he picked up his pen. He did not write anything. He only held it.

"I'll put it in," he said. "What you said. If you want."

"I want." The innkeeper picked up his cup again. "Put it all in. The foolishness and the forgiving. People will say I was a fool. And they'll be right." He drank. "But maybe someone will read it, someday, who's done something terrible for a good reason. And they'll think: *if he could forgive her, maybe someone could forgive me.*"

He set the cup down.

"That's worth being a fool for," he said. "Don't you think?"

Chronicler looked at him for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "I think it is."

He dipped his pen, and wrote.

# **PART THREE: THE MOON'S ROAD**

## Chapter Seventy-Six

# The Eld

I left Imre nine days before the full moon, in the grey hour before dawn, the way I seem to leave everywhere.

Threpe gave me a horse. Not a tall grey gelding like the Maer's, but a stocky brown mare with a white blaze and a placid disposition and a remarkable indifference to everything. Her name was Pudding. Threpe apologized for the name; it had been his niece's horse, and his niece was nine. I told him it was a fine name. Pudding looked at me with deep brown eyes and chewed her bit and did not seem to care what I thought.

I rode out of Imre on the north road, with my lute on my back and Caesura at my hip and my cloak drawn close around me. Not the shaed Felurian had made. That was folded carefully in the bottom of my pack; I would need it later, in the Fae, and I did not want to be seen wearing it on the roads of the Commonwealth. Instead I wore a plain brown cloak of Threpe's, with a deep hood to hide my hair.

No one saw me go. Or if they did, they did not say so.

\* \* \*

The Eld is an old forest. The oldest in the Four Corners, some say. It sprawls across the hills north and east of Severen, a great dark mass of oak and ash and beech and trees whose names no one remembers, so thick and so tangled that the roads go around it rather than through. People do not live in the Eld. They do not farm it or log it or hunt it, except around its very edges. It is too big, and too dark, and too

strange.

I had been there before. I had spent the better part of a season in the Eld, the year before, hunting bandits for the Maer with a handful of mercenaries. We had found the bandits, in the end, and killed them. And then, afterward, I had wandered off alone in the night, following a sound I could not name, and I had found a glade with a pool in it and a greystone beside the pool.

And in the glade, Felurian.

It took me six days to reach the Eld, riding hard on Pudding's broad brown back. It took me two more to find the glade.

I did not remember the way. Not clearly. I had been following a song, that night, a song I had heard in my bones rather than my ears, and I had not been paying attention to where I was going. But I remembered the shape of the land. The long low ridge running north and south. The stream that cut through it, fast and cold and clear. The place where the stream widened into a pool, surrounded by old beeches with silver bark.

And I remembered the greystone. A tall grey standing stone, taller than a man, set at the edge of the pool. Smooth and old and faintly humming, the way all greystones hum.

I found it on the evening of the eighth day. I came over the top of the long ridge, leading Pudding by the bridle through the thick undergrowth, and there below me was the stream, and there was the pool, and there were the silver beeches, and there, standing tall and grey and silent at the water's edge, was the stone.

The glade was empty.

\* \* \*

I made camp at the edge of the glade, under the silver beeches, and I did not sleep.

The moon rose a little after sunset. It was nearly full, fat and silver and very bright. It climbed slowly up into the sky, and its light came down through the leaves of the beeches and fell on the pool in a scatter of silver coins. It fell on the greystone, and the greystone seemed to glow.

Tomorrow night, it would be full. Tomorrow night, if I stood beside that stone and did what I had done before, I would step through into the Fae.

I sat with my back against a beech and my cold arm in my lap and Fela's stone in my good hand, and I watched the moon climb, and I thought about what Elodin had said.

*Old things. Hungry things. Things that have been waiting a very long time for a mortal with a namer's gift and the blood of the Thief.*

I thought about the Cthae.

I had not let myself think about it for a long time. Not since the Eolian. Not since I had watched Stanchion die and Cinder's hand close around my wrist and a shadow in the center of the room say *he is needed*. I had pushed it away every time it came into my mind, the way you push away a thought of something shameful.

But I thought about it now. I let myself. I sat under the silver beeches in the moonlight and I remembered the tree in the Fae, and the voice that came out of it. Honey poured over broken glass. The voice that had told me about Denna's patron, and what he did to her, and laughed.

It had known. It had known everything. It had known about Bredon, and the knot on Denna's wrist, and the beatings. It had known that I would go back to the mortal world and seek him out. It had known what I would find, and what I would do.

It had known I would come back to the Fae.

And it had told me what it told me, in exactly the way it told me, because it wanted me here. Right here. Sitting under a silver beech beside a greystone, on the night before the full moon, about to step through into its world.

I sat there with Fela's stone in my hand and I felt the shape of the board close around me like a fist.

\* \* \*

In the morning, I sent Pudding home.

It was not easy. She did not want to go. She had grown fond of me in eight days, or at least fond of the apples I kept in my pack, and



when I took off her saddle and bridle and slapped her on the rump, she only looked at me with her deep brown eyes and did not move.

"Go on," I said. "Go home. Threpe will be worried."

She did not go. She put her head down and began to crop the grass at the edge of the glade.

I sighed. I took the last apple out of my pack and held it up so she could see it. Her ears pricked up. I threw it, as hard as I could, down the slope toward the south, toward Severen and the road and the mortal world.

She went after it. She went crashing through the undergrowth, her broad brown rump bouncing, and I heard her find it and heard the crunch as she bit into it. And then, after a moment, I heard her keep going, south and west, toward home.

I stood at the edge of the glade and listened until I could not hear her anymore.

Then I went back to the greystone and sat down to wait for night.

\* \* \*

I spent that day preparing. I took everything out of my pack and laid it on the grass beside the pool and looked at it.

My lute, in its case. Caesura, in its sheath. Felurian's shaed, folded carefully, the dark shadowy cloth of it shifting and rippling in the sunlight like water. Kilvin's candle. The scrap of the Dellers' cloth. The page from the Book of Watches. Fela's stone eye, and Fela's stone from the Eolian. Denna's knots: the one from the Grey Man around my neck, the one from Severen in my pocket, the letter-cord braided from her hair.

And food. Bread and cheese and dried meat and apples, enough for a span if I was careful. I knew better than to eat anything in the Fae. I had learned that lesson the first time.

I looked at it all for a long time. Then I put it all back in my pack, carefully, the way you put things away when you are not sure you will ever take them out again.

I lit Kilvin's candle one last time, sitting by the pool in the afternoon light. It burned yellow. I watched it for a long time. Then I

snuffed it and put it away.

When the sun went down, I put on the shaed.

\* \* \*

It is hard to describe what it feels like to wear Felurian's shaed. It is a cloak, made of shadow. Not dark cloth, but actual shadow, gathered and woven and shaped by the hands of the oldest and most beautiful of the Fae. When you wear it, you feel it moving around you, soft and cool and alive. It clings to you. It shifts with you. It hides you, if you want it to, so that you are only one more shadow among many.

It is also, I discovered that night, very warm. Warmer than it has any right to be. When I drew it around my shoulders, standing beside the pool in the gathering dusk, I felt the warmth of it sink into me, into my bones, into my cold dead arm. For the first time since the Eolian, my left hand did not feel like ice.

I stood there for a long time, feeling it. Then the moon came up over the trees.

\* \* \*

It was full. Round and silver and enormous, hanging low over the eastern ridge like a great lamp. Its light came down into the glade and fell on the pool, and the pool became a mirror. It fell on the greystone, and the greystone began to sing.

I did not hear it with my ears. I heard it with something else. The same thing I had used to hear stone, and wind, and the knots in the king's hair. A long low humming note, rising up from the greystone and filling the glade. It was not a word. It was not a name. It was more like a door opening. A door made of sound.

I walked to the edge of the pool. I stood beside the greystone. I laid my good hand flat against its cold smooth surface.

I felt it humming under my palm. I felt it calling.

And I stepped forward, into the pool, into the moonlight, into the mirror of the sky.

\* \* \*

I did not get wet. That is the first thing I remember. I stepped into the pool, and my foot went down, and down, and I felt the water close over it—and then it was not water. It was light. Silver light, cool and soft and bright, closing over my foot and my ankle and my knee. I took another step, and another, and the light rose up around me, and I did not sink. I walked down into it, the way you walk down a set of stairs.

The glade went away. The beeches and the greystone and the pool and the moon, all of it went away. There was only the silver light, all around me, above and below and on every side. It was very bright, and very quiet, and very still.

I kept walking.

And after a while, I don't know how long, the light began to change. It grew dimmer. Softer. It took on colors, faint at first, then stronger. Violet and grey and deep dusky blue. I felt something under my feet that was not light. Something soft and springy, like moss.

I stopped. I looked around.

I was standing in a forest. But it was not the Eld. It was not any forest in the mortal world. The trees were taller than any trees I had ever seen, so tall their tops were lost in the dusk above. Their trunks were silver and smooth, like the beeches in the glade, but they glowed faintly, the way the greystone had glowed. Their leaves were every color at once, shifting and changing as I watched, green and gold and red and violet.

And the sky above them was twilight. Not dusk, not dawn. Twilight. The endless, shadowless, sourceless light of the Fae, where there is no sun and no moon, only the sky itself, glowing softly from horizon to horizon.

I was back.

I stood there under the impossible trees for a long time, breathing. The air smelled of flowers I did not know the names of, and of rain, and of something else, something sweet and wild and faintly dangerous, like the smell of a thunderstorm on the way.

Then I pulled the shaed close around me, and I began to walk.

## Chapter Seventy-Seven

# The Hollow Market

I walked for what felt like a day through the silver forest, and the light did not change.

That is one of the strangest things about the Fae, and one of the hardest to get used to. There is no sun. There is no moon. There is no day or night, no morning or evening, no passage of time written on the sky. There is only the twilight, soft and shadowless and endless, glowing from every direction at once. You walk, and you walk, and you grow tired and hungry and thirsty, and you look up at the sky to see how late it is, and it is exactly the same as it was when you started.

I had learned, the first time, to measure time by my own body. By hunger and thirst and weariness. By the number of times I stopped to rest. By the aching of my feet. It was not very accurate. But it was better than nothing.

By that measure, I walked for a day. Perhaps a little more. I ate some of my bread and cheese when I grew hungry, and drank from my waterskin when I grew thirsty, and did not touch the streams I passed, though they ran clear and cold and sang softly over their stones. I did not touch the fruit that hung from some of the trees, though it was very beautiful, and smelled of honey and summer.

And I did not know where I was going.

\* \* \*

That was the problem. I had thought about it a great deal, on the road to the Eld. I had told Elodin I would figure it out. But now that I was

here, standing in the silver forest under the endless twilight, I realized that I had no idea how.

The Fae is not like the mortal world. It does not have maps. Or rather, it has maps, but they are not maps of places. They are maps of stories, of feelings, of intentions. Roads in the Fae go where they want to go, not where they were built to go. A path that leads north one day might lead south the next. A grove that is an hour's walk from here might be a year's walk from there. Distances stretch and shrink according to rules I did not understand.

The first time I had been here, I had not needed to know any of that. Felurian had kept me in her glade, and when I left, she had shown me the way out. I had never had to find my own way.

Now I did. And I did not know how.

I stopped at the edge of a clearing and sat down on a fallen log and put my head in my hands.

*You'll figure it out*, I had said. Of course I would. I always did.

\* \* \*

"You look lost," said a voice.

I looked up. There was a woman standing at the edge of the clearing, on the far side, under a tree whose leaves were the color of old copper. She was tall and thin and very pale, with long hair the color of dead leaves and eyes like pools of dark water. She was wearing a dress that seemed to be made of spider silk, grey and shimmering. She was smiling.

"I am lost," I said. There did not seem to be any point in denying it.

"Ah." She tilted her head. "A mortal. Lost in the twilight. How very traditional." Her smile widened. "Where are you trying to go, little mortal?"

I hesitated. I remembered the rules. The ones Felurian had taught me, and the ones I had learned on my own. *Never give your name. Never eat their food. Never make a bargain you do not understand.*

"North," I said. "To the mountains. The Stormwal."

"The Stormwal." She looked at me with her dark-water eyes. "That's a long way. Through some very unfriendly country." She paused. "Why would anyone want to go there?"

"I have business there."

"Business." She laughed, a sound like dry leaves blowing. "Mortals always have business." She came a few steps into the clearing. Her feet made no sound on the moss. "I could help you, you know. If you asked nicely."

"How?"

"There's a market," she said. "Not far from here. The Hollow Market. Everything in the twilight is for sale there, if you know how to ask. Maps. Roads. Directions." She smiled. "I could take you there."

"What would it cost?"

"The market? Oh, it costs nothing to go. Only to buy." She tilted her head. "And taking you there? That would cost you nothing either. I'm feeling generous today. I like the look of you." Her eyes moved over me, slowly. Over my face, my hair, my cloak. They lingered on the cloak. "That's a very fine shaed you're wearing."

"It was a gift."

"From whom?"

"Felurian."

The woman went very still. For a long moment, she did not speak. Then she smiled again, but it was a different smile. More careful.

"Felurian," she said. "Well. You are an interesting mortal, aren't you?" She was quiet for a moment. "All right. I'll take you to the market. For nothing. As a courtesy to the lady who made that cloak." She turned away. "Follow me. And don't step off the path."

\* \* \*

The Hollow Market was in a hollow. That was the first thing I noticed, when we came to it. A great round hollow in the forest floor, like a bowl pressed into the earth, a quarter of a mile across. The sides of the bowl were steep and grassy and dotted with tents and stalls and awnings of every color. The bottom was a great open space, crowded with people.

Or with things that looked like people. Some of them looked very like people indeed, tall and fair and beautiful, dressed in silks and velvets and cloth of gold. Some of them looked only a little like people, with too-long fingers or too-bright eyes or skin the color of bark or moss or stone. And some of them did not look like people at all. I saw a creature like a great grey heron, standing on one leg beside a stall full of glass bottles, haggling with the stallkeeper in a voice like a creaking gate. I saw something small and furry and many-legged scuttling between the stalls with a basket on its back. I saw a woman made entirely of leaves, rustling softly as she walked.

The noise was incredible. Voices in a hundred languages, rising and falling, laughing and shouting and arguing. Music from a dozen different places, pipes and drums and strings, all playing different tunes at once. The clink of coins, the rustle of cloth, the creak of wood.

And the smells. Spices and perfumes and roasting meat and fresh bread and flowers and incense and things I could not name. Some of them were wonderful. Some of them were terrible. Some of them were both at once.

"The Hollow Market," said the woman with the dead-leaf hair. "Everything in the twilight is for sale here." She looked at me sidelong. "Everything. Remember that."

"I'll remember."

"Good." She smiled. "Well. I've done my courtesy. Good luck, little mortal." And she turned and walked away into the crowd, and was gone.

\* \* \*

I spent what felt like hours wandering through the market.

I saw things I cannot describe, and things I would not describe if I could. I saw a stall selling bottled dreams, each one a different color, swirling and shimmering behind the glass. I saw a stall selling memories, pressed flat between sheets of paper like flowers. I saw a stall selling voices, and another selling shadows, and another selling years. A woman offered to sell me a year of my own life back, one I had lost somewhere, and I did not ask her how she had got it.

I saw a stall selling names.

It was a small stall, at the edge of the market, in the shadow of a great old tree. It was hung with strips of cloth, dark and pale and every color between, and on each strip there was writing. Knots, some of them. Some of them were letters I could not read. Some of them were not writing at all, only shapes, twisted and folded into patterns that made my eyes ache.

The stallkeeper was very old. So old that I could not tell whether it was a man or a woman, or whether it had ever been either. It sat on a stool in the shadows behind the stall, wrapped in a great grey cloak, and its face was a mass of wrinkles so deep that its eyes were lost in them.

"Names," it said, as I passed. Its voice was like the rustle of dry paper. "Names for sale. Old names, new names, true names, false names. Names to hide behind. Names to wear. Names to give away." It looked at me from the depths of its wrinkles. "You look like a man who needs a new name."

I stopped.

"Why do you say that?"

"Because your old one is so heavy." The stallkeeper tilted its head. "I can see it on you. Bowing your shoulders. Bending your back. It's a very heavy name. Very old. Very dangerous." It paused. "Very valuable."

I went cold.

"It's not for sale," I said.

"Everything is for sale," said the stallkeeper. "Here." It reached out one long grey hand and touched one of the strips of cloth hanging from its stall. "I could take it off you. Your name. Just for a while. Lighten your load. Give you another one to wear in its place. Something light. Something easy." It smiled, a horrible toothless smile. "And when you want it back, you come here and buy it."

"And the price?"

"Oh, the price is very small. Very small indeed." The stallkeeper leaned forward. "I'd only want to *read* it. While I held it. Just once."



I looked at the strips of cloth hanging from the stall. At the names written on them. At the knots, twisted and folded and tied.

I wondered how many of them had been sold here. How many of them had never been bought back.

"No," I said. "Thank you."

The stallkeeper shrugged. "Suit yourself." It settled back on its stool. "But you'll need it, someday. I can see that too. A day will come when that name is too heavy to carry. And you'll need somewhere to set it down." It smiled its toothless smile. "When that day comes, remember where I am."

I walked away. I did not look back.

But I heard its words for a long time afterward, echoing in my head. *A day will come when that name is too heavy to carry.* I heard them the way I had heard Elodin's. *A name can be put down. You need someone to hold it for you.*

\* \* \*

I found the mapmaker near the bottom of the hollow.

It was a small, neat stall, hung with scrolls and rolls of parchment and lengths of string. The stallkeeper was a small, neat creature about the height of a child, with a round face and round spectacles and a round belly, and skin the color of a ripe acorn. It was sitting behind its stall with a quill in its hand, drawing something on a long strip of parchment, and it did not look up as I approached.

"Roads," it said, in a small precise voice. "Maps. Directions. Routes. Paths. Ways." It dipped its quill. "Where to?"

"North," I said. "To the Stormwal. The mountains. In the mortal world."

The mapmaker stopped drawing. It looked up at me over its spectacles.

"The Stormwal," it said. "Through the twilight."

"Yes."

"That's a very long way."

"I know."

"Through some very unfriendly country."

"So I've been told."

The mapmaker looked at me for a long moment. Then it set down its quill and folded its small acorn-colored hands on the stall in front of it.

"There's only one road that goes there from here," it said. "The Moon's Road. It runs north, through the Deep Wood, past the Long Lake, and out through the Northern Gate into the mortal mountains." It paused. "It also runs past the Grove."

I did not have to ask which grove. I knew from the way it said the word.

"The Cthaeh's grove."

"Just so." The mapmaker nodded. "The Sithe watch that road. Very closely. Anyone who goes near the Grove, they shoot. No questions. No warnings. No mercy." It looked at me over its spectacles. "And anyone who's *been* to the Grove before—anyone who's spoken to what lives there—they shoot on sight, wherever they find them. Because once you've heard it speak, you're poisoned. You're a danger to everyone around you. You're a plague."

I did not say anything. I did not have to. The mapmaker looked at my face and nodded slowly.

"Ah," it said. "You've been there."

"Yes."

"And you want to go past it again."

"I have to."

The mapmaker was silent for a long time. Then it sighed, a small precise sigh.

"Well," it said. "I'll sell you the road. That's my business. But I'll tell you this, for free, because I've never sold a road to a dead man before and I'd rather not start." It leaned forward. "Go quietly. Go quickly. Don't stop. Don't speak. Don't listen. And if you hear it calling you—and you will—don't answer." It paused. "And pray the Sithe are looking the other way."

"What's the price?"

The mapmaker looked at me. Then at my lute case.

"A song," it said. "A new one. One that's never been sung in the twilight before." It smiled faintly. "We get so few new songs here. Everyone's been singing the same ones for ten thousand years."

I looked at it for a long moment. Then I took out my lute. My left hand was still stiff and cold, even under the warmth of the shaed. But I could move my fingers a little now. Enough.

I played it "Tariniel."

Not all of it. Just the first part. The white city on the last day of its life. The towers and the gardens and the fountains. The children playing.

When I finished, the mapmaker was very still. Its round spectacles had fogged, and it took them off and wiped them on its sleeve.

"Well," it said. Its small precise voice was not quite steady. "Well. That's a new one." It put its spectacles back on. "Yes. That will do."

It reached under its stall and took out a length of string. Silver string, very fine, wound on a small wooden spool. It held it out to me.

"Tie one end to your wrist," it said. "The other end will find the road. Follow it. Don't let go." It paused. "And good luck, singer. You'll need it."

I took the spool. I tied the end of the silver string around my good wrist. The other end lifted from the spool, all on its own, and floated in the air like a strand of spider silk caught in a breeze. It pointed north.

I thanked the mapmaker. I put away my lute. And I began to follow the string.

## Chapter Seventy-Eight

# The Lord of Hollow Hours

The silver string led me out of the Hollow Market and north, into a country of long grey grass and low grey hills and single trees standing far apart, each one a different kind, each one very old. It was a lonely country. I walked for what felt like most of a day without seeing anything move but the grass.

And then, on the crest of a low hill, I came to a table.

It was a long table of dark wood, set out in the open under the twilight sky, with a white cloth on it and silver dishes and crystal glasses and candles burning in tall silver sticks. There were chairs down both sides of it, twelve on each side, all empty. And at the head of the table, in a great carved chair, there was a man.

He was eating.

He was tall and thin and very elegant, in a long coat of grey velvet with silver buttons, and a high collar, and lace at the cuffs. His face was long and pale and handsome, and his hair was the color of ashes, and his eyes were the color of old coins. He was eating a peach with a small silver knife, cutting it into very thin slices and laying each slice on his tongue as if it were a precious thing.

He looked up as I came over the crest of the hill. He smiled.

"A guest," he said. "How delightful. Sit, sit. You've arrived just in time for the second course."

\* \* \*

I did not sit. I stood at the end of the long table with the silver string floating at my wrist, and I looked at him.

The string, I noticed, had stopped. It was not pointing north anymore. It was hanging slack in the air, drifting slightly, the way a strand of cobweb drifts when there is no wind. As if it had lost the road.

"I'm on the Moon's Road," I said. "Going north."

"Of course you are. Everyone is, eventually." He laid another slice of peach on his tongue. "But the road passes my table. It always has. And no one passes my table without dining." He gestured at the chairs with his little silver knife. "It's the rule."

"Whose rule?"

"Mine." He smiled. His teeth were very white and very even and slightly too many. "I am the Lord of Hollow Hours. This is my hill, and my table, and my road, for as long as the road is on my hill." He cut another slice. "Sit."

I thought about the rules. The ones Felurian had taught me, and the ones I had learned on my own. *Never eat their food. Never give your name. Never make a bargain you do not understand.*

I pulled out the nearest chair and sat down.

\* \* \*

The Lord of Hollow Hours looked delighted. He clapped his long pale hands, once, and the silver dishes on the table began to steam. I smelled roast meat and fresh bread and spices I did not know, and something sweet, like honey and flowers, that made my mouth water and my head swim.

"Eat," he said. "Please."

"Thank you, my lord. I'm not hungry."

"Everyone is hungry." He tilted his head. "Especially mortals. Especially mortals who have been walking all day through my grey grass with nothing but a little stale bread in their packs." He smiled. "I can hear your stomach from here."

"I'm not hungry," I said again.

He looked at me for a long moment with his old-coin eyes. Then he laughed, very softly.

"Ah," he said. "You know the rules. How refreshing. Most of them don't, these days. They wander in, and sit, and eat, and then they're mine for a hundred years." He cut another slice of peach. "Very well. You won't eat. But you've sat. And the rule is that no one leaves my table without paying for their seat."

"What's the price?"

"Something small." He waved his little knife. "A trifle. Your shadow, perhaps." His eyes went to the shadow, hanging from my shoulders, rippling faintly in a wind I could not feel. "That one. The one you're wearing. It's very fine. Felurian's work, if I'm not mistaken."

"It's not for sale."

"Everything is for sale." He smiled his too-many-toothed smile. "But very well. If not the shadow, then something else. A year. A memory. Your name." His eyes glittered. "No? Then let's make it sporting. Let's play for it."

\* \* \*

"Play what?"

He reached under the table and brought out a small box of polished wood. He opened it. Inside, there were stones. Black and white, smooth and round, nestled in green velvet.

A tak set.

I sat very still.

"You know the game," said the Lord of Hollow Hours. It was not a question. "I can see it on you. You've played. You've played with someone very good." He set the board on the table between us and began to lay out the stones. "If you win, you may go, with your shadow and your name and all your years. And I'll set your little string back on the road."

"And if I lose?"

He smiled.

"Then you'll stay," he said. "For a little while. And play with me again. And again. Until you win." He placed the last stone in its bowl. "Some of my guests have been playing for a very long time."

I looked down the table. At the twenty-three empty chairs.

They were not empty.

I do not know how I had not seen it before. Perhaps it was the twilight, or the candles, or something in the air. But when I looked down the table now, I saw that there was someone in every chair. Very faint. Very pale. Like reflections in a dark window. Men and women, old and young, in the clothes of every age. Each one sitting very still, with a tak board in front of them, and a hand hovering over a stone, as if about to make a move.

As if they had been about to make that move for a hundred years.

\* \* \*

I looked back at the Lord of Hollow Hours.

He was watching me with his old-coin eyes, and his smile, and his little silver knife.

"Your move," he said.

I thought about Bredon. About the small garden in Severen and the old oak and the tak board under it. About a hundred games, and a thousand stones, and a kind old man's voice saying *the beautiful game is about time*.

I thought about how I had never, in all those games, truly beaten him. Not once. Not really. The few games I had won, I had won because he let me.

The Lord of Hollow Hours was not Bredon. But he had been playing for a very long time.

I looked at the board. At the stones in their bowls.

And then I did something that I think no one had ever done at that table before.

I reached into my pack, and took out my lute.

\* \* \*

"What are you doing?" said the Lord of Hollow Hours. His smile had not moved, but something behind his eyes had.

"Paying for my seat," I said.

"We agreed on tak."

"You proposed tak. I didn't agree." I began to tune the lute. My left hand was still stiff; it was only three spans since the fire, and Felurian had not yet found me. But I could make the simple shapes, now. Slowly. "You said no one leaves your table without paying for their seat. You didn't say how."

He looked at me for a long moment.

"And you think," he said softly, "that a song will pay for a seat at the table of the Lord of Hollow Hours?"

"I think," I said, "that you've been sitting here a very long time. With twenty-three guests who never say anything, and a peach you've been cutting since before I was born." I nodded at the fruit in his hand. It was the same peach. I had watched him cut a dozen slices from it, and it was still whole. "I think you're bored. I think that's why you play. And I think nobody has sung at this table in a very long time."

The Lord of Hollow Hours did not say anything. His knife was very still in his long pale fingers.

I began to play.

\* \* \*

I did not play *Tariniel*. That song was not for a place like this. I played the only song I could think of that was as long and as foolish and as endless as his table.

I played "Tinker Tanner."

All of it. Every verse I knew, and I knew a great many. The tinker and the miller's daughter. The tinker and the baron's wife. The tinker and the goat. The tinker and the priest, the tinker and the sailor, the tinker and the three sisters from Tinuë. I played it slowly at first, because of my hand, and then faster, as my hand warmed. I sang every verse with a straight face. I made up new ones when I ran out of old ones. I sang about a tinker who came to a table on a grey hill, and sat down, and refused to eat the peach.



And somewhere in the middle of the fortieth verse, the Lord of Hollow Hours laughed.

It was not his soft smiling laugh. It was a real laugh. Startled and helpless and loud, bursting out of him the way a bird bursts out of a hedge. He put down his knife. He put down his peach. He put his long pale hands over his face and laughed until his shoulders shook.

And down the long table, very faintly, the pale figures in the chairs began to move.

Not much. A turn of the head. A lift of the eyes. A hand, hovering over a tak stone for a hundred years, drawing back. Twenty-three faint faces, turning toward the sound of a tinker's song as if they had just remembered what music was.

I kept playing.

\* \* \*

When I finally stopped, the Lord of Hollow Hours was wiping his eyes with a lace handkerchief. The peach lay forgotten on his plate. The pale guests were all looking at me, their faint faces very still.

"*The tinker and the goat*," said the Lord of Hollow Hours, and began to laugh again. "Oh. Oh, my. I haven't laughed like that in—" He stopped. He looked at the peach on his plate. He looked down the long table at his twenty-three guests, all looking at me. "In a very long time."

"Is my seat paid for?"

He looked at me. His old-coin eyes were wet and bright.

"Your seat," he said, "is paid for many times over." He picked up the peach. He looked at it for a long moment. Then he held it out to me. "Take this. Not to eat. Never to eat." He smiled. "Carry it. It's my hour. My hollow one. The one I've been cutting since before your world had a name." He pressed it into my hand. It was warm and heavy and smelled of summer. "If you're ever caught somewhere you can't escape, cut a slice. Just one. And for one hour, time will stop for everyone but you."

"Why would you give me that?"

"Because you gave me an hour of my own back," said the Lord of Hollow Hours. "The first I've had in ten thousand years." He waved his hand, and the silver string at my wrist lifted and pointed north again, bright and taut. "Go on, singer. Your road is waiting."

I stood up. I put the lute on my back and the peach in my pack.

"And them?" I said. I looked down the long table at the twenty-three faint guests.

The Lord of Hollow Hours followed my gaze. He was quiet for a long moment.

"Ah," he said softly. "Yes. Them." He looked at me. "You want me to let them go."

"Yes."

"They lost," he said. "Fairly. At tak."

"They've been sitting there a hundred years."

"Some of them more." He was quiet. Then he sighed. "Very well. One verse. One more verse of your tinker's song, one they've never heard, and I'll let them go. All of them." He smiled. "If it makes me laugh."

\* \* \*

I sang him one more verse. I will not repeat it. It was about a tinker who came to a table on a grey hill, and found a lord there, eating a peach that never got smaller, and it was very rude about what the tinker suggested the lord do with the peach.

The Lord of Hollow Hours laughed so hard he fell out of his chair.

And when I looked down the long table, the chairs were empty. Truly empty, this time. Twenty-three chairs, and twenty-three tak boards, with the stones still laid out on them in their half-finished games, and no one sitting behind them at all.

I did not see where they went. I hope it was somewhere good.

\* \* \*

I never cut the peach. I want that written down too. I carried it with me through the twilight and the Stormwal and the war, wrapped in a cloth

at the bottom of my pack, and it never rotted and it never grew smaller and it always smelled of summer.

There were times I thought about cutting it. In the burning camp by the river, with Cinder's hand on my wrist. In the chamber beneath the Lackless house, with Denna on her knees and the door screaming. In the Tower of Thorns.

But I never did. Because I did not know what an hour of stopped time would cost, or who would pay for it, and I had learned by then that everything in the twilight costs something.

I gave it away, in the end. To someone who needed an hour more than I did.

But that is a story for another time.

## Chapter Seventy-Nine

# Felurian

She found me on the third day of the Moon's Road.

I had been following the silver string through the Deep Wood, a forest so thick and dark that even the twilight could barely reach the ground. The trees there were not silver, like the ones near the greystone. They were black. Great black trunks rising up into a darkness so deep I could not see where they ended, with bark like old iron and roots like the coils of great snakes. The air was still and heavy and smelled of earth and rot and something else, something sharp and cold, like the smell of a knife.

The string led me along a narrow path between the black trees, winding and twisting. It never stopped. It never slackened. It floated in the air ahead of me, silver and faintly glowing, pointing always north.

I had not seen anyone since the Hollow Market. I had not heard anything, either, except my own footsteps and my own breath and, sometimes, far off in the dark between the trees, something that might have been singing.

And then, on the third day, I came around a bend in the path and she was there.

\* \* \*

She was sitting on a root of one of the great black trees, with her legs crossed and her chin in her hand, as if she had been waiting for me. She was naked, as she always was, and the twilight fell on her skin and made it glow, the way the moon makes water glow. Her hair was long

and dark and fell around her like a cloak. Her eyes were the color of evening.

I stopped. I stood very still in the middle of the path, with the silver string floating ahead of me and my heart hammering in my chest.

I had forgotten. I had told myself that I remembered, that I knew what she was like. But I had forgotten. The mind cannot hold it. It is like trying to remember the exact color of a sunset, or the exact sound of a song you heard once in a dream. The shape stays. The substance fades.

She looked at me. And the substance came back all at once, like a wave.

"Kvothe," said Felurian.

Her voice was soft and sweet and full of music. It went into me like wine. My knees went weak. I put my hand against the nearest black tree to steady myself.

"Felurian," I said.

"You came back." She tilted her head. "I did not think you would. Mortals never come back."

"I'm not staying."

"No." She smiled. It was a small smile, and a little sad. "No, I did not think you would. You have that look. The going-somewhere look." She uncrossed her legs and stood up, in one smooth motion, like water rising. "Where are you going, my Kvothe?"

"North. To the Stormwal."

"On the Moon's Road." She looked at the silver string floating in the air. "Past the Grove."

"Yes."

Her smile faded. She came toward me along the path, slowly, her bare feet making no sound on the black earth. She stopped in front of me, close enough to touch. She did not touch me.

"You have been to the Grove before," she said. "You spoke to it."

"Yes."

"I told you not to go near it. I told you what it was."

"I didn't mean to. I didn't know."

"I know." She reached up and touched my face, very lightly, with the tips of her fingers. Her fingers were warm. "I know you did not. It was not your fault. It called to you, and you were young and curious, and you went." She looked into my eyes. "And now it has its hooks in you. I can see them. Little silver hooks, all through you. Pulling."

I did not say anything.

"It wants you to come back," said Felurian softly. "It has been waiting. Ever since you left. It has been pulling on its hooks, a little at a time, bringing you back to it." Her fingers moved to my hair. "And now you are here. On the Moon's Road. About to walk right past its door."

"I have to."

"Why?"

I told her. Not all of it. But enough. The door, and the line, and Selitos in the mountains. The war, and Meluan, and the box.

She listened with her head tilted and her fingers in my hair. When I was done, she was quiet for a long time.

"The Thief," she said at last. "The one who stole the moon."

"Yes."

"I remember him." Her voice was very far away. "I was young, then. Younger than anything in your world is now. I remember the war. I remember what he did to the sky." She looked up, at the endless twilight above the black trees. "This place. The twilight. Did you know he made it? To hold her. The moon. He made a place beyond the world, and he pulled her into it, and he tried to make her stay." She was quiet for a moment. "And we have been living in it ever since. All of us. In the house he built for a woman who did not love him."

I stared at her.

"The Fae," I said slowly. "The whole Fae. He made it."

"He made it. And then they put him behind the doors, and he could not come back to it." She smiled faintly. "It is very sad, when you think about it. He built a whole world for her, and he never got to live in it."

She walked with me for a while, along the Moon's Road, through the black trees.

She did not ask me to stay. That surprised me. I had been afraid, since I first saw her, that she would try to keep me. That she would use her magic on me, the terrible sweet magic that had held me in her glade for so long the first time, and that I would not be able to resist. I had been holding Fela's stone in my pocket the whole time, clutching it so hard my fingers ached, repeating its long slow *no* over and over in my head.

But she did not try. She walked beside me with her hand on my arm, and she talked about the old days, and the war, and the Thief. She told me things about the Fae that I had never heard, and that I have never told anyone. And every so often, she looked at me sidelong with her evening eyes, and smiled, and did not say anything.

At last we came to a place where the black trees opened out into a small clearing. There was a spring in the center of it, bubbling up clear and cold from between two stones. Felurian stopped beside it.

"This is as far as I go," she said. "Beyond here, the road belongs to the Sithe. They do not like me very much." She smiled. "They do not like anyone very much."

"Thank you," I said. "For walking with me."

"I did not walk with you for thanks." She looked at me. "I walked with you to give you something."

"What?"

She reached out and took my left hand. My cold hand, the one Cinder had held. She lifted it, very gently, and looked at the white print of his fingers on my wrist.

"He hurt you," she said.

"Yes."

"The cold one. The one with black eyes. I know him." Her voice was very quiet. "He was beautiful once. Before. He used to sing." She looked up at me. "Did you know that? He had the most beautiful voice. He sang at the Thief's court, before the war. People came from all over

the world to hear him."

I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.

"Now he is cold," said Felurian. "All the way through. And what he touches, he makes cold." She held my hand in both of hers. "I cannot take it away. It is too deep. It is part of you now." She paused. "But I can give you something to hold against it."

She bent her head. And she kissed my wrist, very softly, right in the center of the white print of Cinder's hand.

I felt it. For the first time since the Eolian, I felt something in my left hand. Not much. Just a faint warmth. Like the memory of summer. Like the last ember in a fire that has almost gone out.

It spread. Slowly. Up my wrist and into my palm and along my fingers. Not enough to take away the cold. But enough to push it back, a little. Enough to make it bearable.

I flexed my fingers. They moved. Stiffly, slowly. But they moved, and I could feel them.

"There," said Felurian. She let go of my hand. "That will help. When you play. When you hold your sword." She smiled. "When you hold someone you love."

"Felurian—"

"Hush." She laid her finger on my lips. "Do not thank me. I did not do it for thanks either." She looked at me for a long time, with her evening eyes. "I did it because you sang to me, once. In my glade. You sang me a song about myself, and it was the truest thing anyone has ever said to me in ten thousand years." She took her finger away. "I am only paying a debt."

\* \* \*

She told me about the Sithe before she left.

"They will know you," she said. "The moment you step onto their road. They will know you have spoken to the Tree. They can smell it on you, the way hounds smell blood." She looked at me gravely. "They will try to kill you."

"I know."



"You cannot fight them. Not even with your Adem sword. They are the finest warriors in the twilight. They have been guarding the Tree since before your world had a name."

"Then how do I get past?"

Felurian looked at me for a long moment.

"You do not get past them," she said. "You go *through* them. You let them see you. You let them come. And when they come—" She hesitated. "When they come, you must tell them the truth. All of it. Why you are there, and where you are going, and what you mean to do."

"And they'll let me go?"

"No. Probably not." She smiled faintly. "But the Sithe are not cruel. They are only careful. If you tell them the truth, and it is a good truth, they may listen. They may decide that you are more dangerous dead than alive." She paused. "Or they may shoot you anyway. It is hard to say, with the Sithe."

"That's not very reassuring."

"No." She laughed softly. "No, it is not. But it is the truth. And you like the truth, my Kvothe. Do you not?"

I looked at her for a long time.

"Yes," I said. "I do."

She reached up and touched my face one last time.

"Then go," she said. "Go and tell it. And if you live, come back someday and sing me another song." Her smile was very sad. "I would like that very much."

She stepped back. And then, between one breath and the next, she was gone. The clearing was empty. The spring bubbled softly between its stones.

I stood there alone for a long time.

Then I looked down at my left hand. I flexed the fingers. They moved. I could feel them. Warm, faintly, at the center of the cold.

I pulled the shaed close around me, and I followed the silver string out of the clearing and into the Sithe's country.

## Chapter Eighty

# The Lantern-Bearer

On the first day past Felurian's spring, among the black trees, I met a child carrying a lantern.

I say *child*. I do not know what it was. It was the size of a child, perhaps eight or nine years old, and shaped like one, with thin arms and bare feet and a mop of dark hair falling into its eyes. It wore a shift of grey cloth that came down to its knees. And it carried, in both hands, held out in front of it at arm's length, a lantern of old green glass, with a light inside it that was not a flame.

It was standing in the middle of the path when I came around a bend between the black trees. It did not move. It watched me come with large dark eyes, very solemn, and held its lantern out, and waited.

I stopped a few paces away. I had learned a little, by then, about the Fae. I had learned that the things that look most harmless are often the most dangerous, and that the things that look most dangerous are often only lonely. I had learned to be polite. And I had learned never, ever, to take anything without knowing what it would cost.

"Hello," I said.

"Hello," said the child. Its voice was very soft and very clear, like water falling into a still pool. "You're mortal."

"Yes."

"You smell of her." It wrinkled its small nose. "The one by the spring. The one who makes cloaks out of shadows. You were with her."

"Yes."

"And she let you go." The child tilted its head. "She doesn't let anyone go. Not usually. You must have given her something very good."

"A song," I said.

The child's eyes widened. It looked at me with new interest.

"A song," it said. "Oh. Oh, that's very good. Songs are the best thing." It held out the lantern a little further. "Would you like to trade?"

\* \* \*

I looked at the lantern. It was very old. The green glass was clouded and cracked, and the iron frame was black with age, and the handle was worn smooth by many hands. And the light inside it—

I looked closer. And my breath caught in my throat.

It was not a flame. It was a room. A tiny room, no bigger than my thumb, glowing inside the green glass. A wagon. The inside of a wagon, painted in bright colors, red and gold and green. With a small window, and a curtain, and a lamp hanging from a hook. And a woman sitting on a bench beneath the lamp, with a child in her lap, singing.

I could not hear the song. The glass was too thick. But I could see her lips move. I could see her hand, stroking the child's red hair, slowly, in time with the music. I could see her face.

My mother's face.

\* \* \*

I do not know how long I stood there. The child did not move. It held the lantern out, very patiently, and watched me with its solemn dark eyes.

"What is it?" I said at last. My voice sounded very far away.

"A memory," said the child. "One of yours. From when you were very small. So small you don't remember it anymore." It looked at the lantern fondly. "I found it lying on the road. A long way from here. A long time ago. You dropped it, I think, when you were a boy. When something bad happened and you had to forget a lot of things all at once." It shrugged its thin shoulders. "People drop them all the time."

When it hurts too much to carry them. They just fall out. I pick them up."

"Why?"

The child looked surprised.

"Because they're pretty," it said. "Because someone should keep them. It's a shame to leave them lying in the road." It held the lantern up, so the light fell on its face. "I have lots. Hundreds. But this is one of my favorites. Look how bright it is. She loved you very much, that woman. You can tell. The ones with love in them are always the brightest."

\* \* \*

I could not look away. My mother, singing. Her hand in my hair. The lamp swaying gently on its hook as the wagon rolled along the road. I could almost smell it. Woodsmoke and horses and the lavender she kept in a little bag beside her bed.

I did not remember this. I had tried, many times, to remember my mother's face. In Tarbean, in the dark, curled up on a rooftop, I had tried so hard that my head ached. And I could never quite do it. I could remember her voice, a little. Her laugh. The way she sang. But her face had faded, over the years, like a painting left out in the sun.

And here it was. Bright and clear and perfect, in a green glass lantern, held out to me by a child in the Fae.

"What do you want for it?" I said.

\* \* \*

The child smiled. It had very small, very white teeth.

"A song," it said. "The song you gave her. The first time, long ago. The one that let you leave her." It tilted its head. "I heard it. Through the trees. Everyone did. It was very beautiful." Its eyes were bright. "I want it. For my collection. I'll keep it in a lantern, like this one, and I'll look at it whenever I'm sad."

I did not understand. "I'll sing it for you. Right now. As many times as you like."

"No," said the child patiently. "Not *sing* it. *Give* it. The song. The memory of it. Where it came from, and how it felt to make it, and what her face looked like when she heard it." It held up the lantern. "One for one. Your song for your mother. That's fair. That's a good trade."

I went very still.

"If I give it to you," I said slowly, "I won't remember it."

"No. It'll be mine." The child nodded. "And this will be yours. You'll remember her face. Always. Every time you close your eyes." It looked at me with its large dark eyes. "Isn't that better? A song you made once, long ago, for a woman who isn't even yours? Or your mother's face, forever?"

\* \* \*

I stood in the path between the black trees for a long time.

I wanted it. I want to be honest about that. I wanted that lantern more than I had ever wanted anything. More than the Archives, more than the name of the wind, more than Denna, even. My mother's face. Singing. Her hand in my hair.

And the song for Felurian—what was it? A song. I had made hundreds of songs. I would make hundreds more. What was one song, against my mother's face?

I reached out my hand.

And stopped.

Because I remembered something. Not a thought. A feeling. Down in the bottom of me, where the truth lives. The feeling of sitting in Felurian's clearing, by the spring, with my lute in my lap, and finding the song. Not making it. Finding it. The way you find a path in the dark, one step at a time, by feel. And the moment when it was finished, and I looked up, and saw her face.

Her face, when she heard it. The most beautiful and dangerous creature in the Fae, weeping. And then letting me go.

That song was why I was alive. That song was why I was walking on this path, and not lying in her clearing forever, wasting away, the way the stories said. If I gave it to the child, I would still be alive. The trade would not change that. But I would not know *why*.

I would not know how I had done it. I would not know that I could.

\* \* \*

"No," I said.

The child's face fell.

"No?"

"No." I lowered my hand. "I'm sorry. I can't."

"But it's your *mother*." The child held the lantern out further, pleading. "Look at her. Look how bright she is. Don't you want her?"

"More than anything," I said. My voice was not steady. "But the song isn't just a song. It's how I got out. It's how I know I can get out." I looked at the lantern, at my mother's tiny glowing face, and my eyes stung. "If I trade it, I'll have her face. But I won't have the part of me that made the song. And I think I'm going to need that part. Where I'm going." I swallowed. "I think she would want me to keep it."

The child looked at me for a long time.

"That's very sad," it said at last.

"Yes."

"And very brave."

"I don't know about that."

"I do," said the child. It looked down at the lantern, and then back up at me. "I've been doing this a very long time. Collecting. Trading. And almost everyone says yes. Almost everyone would rather have something they lost than something they made." It tilted its head. "You're very strange."

"So I'm told."

\* \* \*

The child was quiet for a moment. Then it did something I did not expect.

It held the lantern up to its face, and it looked at the tiny glowing room inside. At the painted wagon, and the lamp on its hook, and the woman singing. It looked for a long time.

Then it opened the little glass door on the side of the lantern.

"Here," it said. "You can look. Just once. For as long as you want. And then I'll close it again, and keep it safe." It held the open lantern out to me. "That's free. That's not a trade. That's just—" It frowned, searching for the word. "Kindness. I think. I've heard of it. I've never tried it before."

\* \* \*

I looked.

I cannot tell you what I saw. I have tried, many times since. I have tried to write it down, and to sing it, and to tell it. And it does not come. I think that is part of the bargain, even though the child said it was free. You can look, in the Fae. But you cannot take it with you.

I remember that she was singing. I remember that the light was warm and gold. I remember her hand in my hair, and the smell of lavender, and the sway of the wagon on the road. I remember that she was smiling. I remember that she looked down at me, at the very small red-haired child in her lap, and her face was full of such love that it hurt to look at.

I remember that I was crying.

And I remember that after a long time, a very long time, I stepped back, and nodded to the child, and it closed the little glass door very gently. And the room inside the lantern went on glowing, small and bright and far away.

\* \* \*

"Thank you," I said.

"You're welcome." The child looked pleased and a little shy, as if it had done something it was not sure it was allowed to do. "I'll keep her safe. I promise. In my collection. With all the others." It hesitated. "And if you ever want to trade, later—if you ever change your mind—"

"I won't."

"No," said the child. "I didn't think so." It stepped aside, off the path, into the shadow of the black trees. "Go on, then. Strange mortal. The birches are that way. The Sithe will find you there." It looked at

me with its solemn dark eyes. "Be careful of them. They're not kind. Not like me."

I walked on. When I looked back, a few paces later, the child was gone. There was only the path, and the black trees, and far back among them, very faint, a small green light, bobbing away into the dark.

\* \* \*

I did not remember my mother's face after that. Not clearly. It faded again, the way it always had, like a painting left out in the sun.

But I remembered that I had seen it. That for a little while, on a path in the Fae, I had looked at her, and she had been smiling. And that was something. That was more than I had had before.

And years later, when a woman with dark hair took my name and tied it in a cord, and I lost everything—my songs and my stories and my friends and my self—I found, when it came back, that one thing had been waiting for me at the very bottom. Under all the rest. The first thing I found, when I went looking.

Not my mother's face. The child had kept that.

But the song for Felurian. Every note of it. Where it came from, and how it felt to make it, and what her face looked like when she heard it.

The part of me that could get out.

I had kept it. And it had kept me.



## Chapter Eighty-One

# The Sithe

They came for me on the second day past Felurian's spring, in a place where the black trees gave way to birches.

I had seen the change coming for some time. The black trees had been growing thinner, and further apart, and the twilight had been growing brighter between them. Then, quite suddenly, there were no more black trees. There were only birches, white and slender and graceful, rising up into a sky that was paler and clearer than it had been in the Deep Wood. The ground beneath them was covered in soft grey moss, and the air smelled clean and cold and faintly sweet, like snow on the way.

It was beautiful. It was the most beautiful place I had seen in the Fae. And I knew, the moment I stepped into it, that I was being watched.

I did not see them. I did not hear them. But I felt them. The way you feel eyes on the back of your neck in a crowded room. The way you feel the stillness of a forest when a hawk is overhead.

I did not stop walking. I did not look around. I followed the silver string, and I kept my hands where anyone watching could see them, and I did not reach for my sword.

And I thought about the Cthaeh.

It was close. I could feel it. Somewhere to the east, off to my right, beyond the white birches. A kind of pressure on the air, like the pressure before a storm. A kind of weight. A kind of *attention*.

It knew I was here.

\* \* \*

The first arrow struck the ground six inches in front of my left foot.

It was very fast, and very quiet. I did not hear it coming. I only heard the soft *thock* as it sank into the moss, and I looked down and saw it standing there, quivering. A long slender arrow, fletched with white feathers, with a shaft of pale grey wood.

I stopped.

I stood very still. I did not look around. I kept my hands at my sides, open and empty.

"I'm not here to go to the Tree," I said. My voice sounded very loud in the silent birch wood. "I'm only passing through. On the Moon's Road. North, to the mountains."

Nothing happened for a long time. Then a second arrow struck the ground six inches in front of my right foot.

"I know you can smell it on me," I said. "I know I've been there before. I know what that means to you." I took a breath. "I'm not going to fight you. I'm going to stand here. And if you want to shoot me, you can. But I'd like the chance to tell you why I'm here first."

Silence. The birches stood white and still around me. The silver string floated in the air ahead of me, pointing north.

Then they came.

\* \* \*

There were five of them. They came out of the birches without a sound, one from each direction, and they stopped in a circle around me, ten paces away, with arrows nocked and bows half drawn.

They were tall. Taller than any man I had ever seen, taller than Felurian, taller even than the Sleeper. They were slender and graceful, with long limbs and long fingers and long pale faces. Their skin was the grey-white of birch bark. Their hair was silver, and hung down their backs in long braids. Their eyes were the color of the twilight sky.

They wore armor of some grey metal that shimmered like water, fitted so close to their bodies that it seemed to be part of them. Their

bows were long and pale and elegant. Their arrows were white-fletched.

They did not look like warriors. They looked like statues. Like carvings of something too beautiful and too terrible to be real.

The one in front of me lowered her bow slightly. She was the tallest of the five, and her silver braids were bound with bands of grey metal, and there was something in her face that made me think she was very old. Older than Felurian. Older than the forest.

"You stink of the Tree," she said. Her voice was cold and clear, like water over stone. "We smelled you the moment you crossed the border. We have been following you since."

"I know. I felt you."

"Did you." She looked at me with her twilight eyes. "Then you know what we must do."

"I know what you think you must do."

A ripple went through the circle. The other four Sithe shifted, very slightly. Their bows came up a little.

The tall one did not move.

"Speak," she said. "Quickly. You have the time it takes me to draw this bow."

\* \* \*

I told them.

I told them everything. I had never told anyone all of it before, not all at once, not in a single breath. But I told the Sithe. I stood in the center of their circle, in the white birch wood, with five arrows pointed at my heart, and I told them.

I told them about the Cthaeh, and what it had said to me, the first time. I told them about Denna and her patron. I told them about the Archives and the door, and the line, and what I was. I told them about Bredon and Ambrose and the king's hair. I told them about the Eolian, and the song, and Haliar. I told them about Selitos, and the mountains, and what I hoped to learn there.

I told them the truth. All of it. As fast as I could, as clearly as I could, holding nothing back.

The tall one listened without moving. Her bow stayed half drawn. Her eyes stayed on my face. When I finished, she was silent for a long time.

"The Thief's own blood," she said at last. "A namer. Walking the Moon's Road. Past the Grove."

"Yes."

"Do you know what you are asking?"

"I'm asking you to let me pass."

"You are asking us to let the Tree's poison walk free through the twilight. Toward the one place in all the world where that poison could do the most harm." Her voice was very cold. "You are asking us to let the key walk past the one who wants the door opened most."

"The Cthaeh doesn't want the door opened. It wants—"

"You do not know what it wants." She raised her bow, very slightly. "No one knows what it wants. No one has ever known. It sees every path the world might take, and it chooses, every time, the one that ends worst. That is all we know. That is all anyone knows." She paused. "And you have spoken to it. You carry its words in you. Every step you take, every choice you make, may be a step on its path. You cannot know. You will never know."

I looked at her. I did not say anything.

"That is why we kill those who have spoken to it," she said. "Not because they are evil. Not because they are wicked. Because they are *poisoned*. Because they carry its will inside them, like a seed, and they do not know it. And wherever they go, whatever they do, the seed grows."

"Then kill me," I said.

The circle went very still.

"If that's what you believe," I said. "If you think I'm poisoned, and that everything I do is the Cthaeh's will. Then kill me. Right now. And the door stays closed, and the key stays in Ambrose's tent, and Haliar never gets his wish." I looked at her. "But if you do—if you kill me—are you sure that's not what it wants?"

\* \* \*

The tall one did not move. Her bow stayed where it was, half drawn, pointed at my heart. But something changed in her face. Something very small.

"Explain," she said.

"It told me about Denna's patron," I said. "It told me exactly what it knew would send me running back to the mortal world, looking for him. It knew I'd find Bredon. It knew I'd lose the box. It knew I'd end up here, on the Moon's Road, walking past its grove." I took a breath. "It knew you'd be waiting."

"And?"

"And it knew you'd want to kill me." I looked around the circle, at the five tall pale faces, the five white-fledged arrows. "What if that's the path? What if the worst ending is the one where the only person who can close the door for good dies here, in the birch wood, with a Sithe arrow in his heart? What if the Cthaeh brought me here so that *you* would kill me?"

Silence. Long and deep and cold.

"Or," said the tall one slowly, "what if that is exactly what it wants me to think?"

"It could be," I said. "I don't know. You don't know. No one knows." I spread my empty hands. "That's the whole problem, isn't it? Once it's spoken, you can never know which choice is yours and which is its. Every path might be the wrong one." I paused. "So all you can do is choose. And bear what comes after."

The tall one looked at me for a very long time.

"You speak like an Adem," she said at last.

"I was taught by one."

"Hm." Her twilight eyes were very sharp. "The Adem have a word for what you describe. For choosing without knowing."

"The Lethani."

"The Lethani." She was silent for a moment. "We have a word too. An older one. It means much the same." She lowered her bow. Not all the way. But a little. "I will think on this."

\* \* \*

That was when we heard the screaming.

It came from the east. From beyond the birches, off to our right. From the direction of the Grove. It was high and thin and desperate, the scream of something caught and terrified, and it went on and on.

The five Sithe turned their heads toward it, all at once, like hounds.

"Another," said one of them. A younger one, by the look of him, with shorter braids. "Near the Grove. Close. Too close."

The tall one looked at me. Then at the east. Then at me again.

"Stay," she said. "Do not move. If you move, we will kill you."

And the five of them were gone, into the birches, toward the screaming.

I stood there alone in the white wood. The silver string floated in the air ahead of me, pointing north. The screaming went on and on.

I did not stay.

\* \* \*

I have thought about that choice a great deal, over the years. Whether I should have stayed. Whether it was my choice at all, or the Cthaeh's. Whether the screaming was a trap, set by the Tree to pull me toward its grove, and I walked into it like a fool.

I do not know. I will never know. That is the nature of the thing.

But I heard someone screaming, and I went. Because I am who I am, and I could not have done otherwise. And because I have heard a great many people scream in my life, and I have come too late to almost all of them.

I did not want to come too late again.

\* \* \*

I ran east through the birches, following the sound. I ran with the shaed billowing around me and my good hand on Caesura's hilt and the silver string tugging at my wrist, trying to pull me back north. The screaming grew louder. So did the pressure on the air, the weight, the attention. The closer I came, the harder it pressed on me, until it was like running into a strong wind.

I did not look toward the Grove. I did not let myself. I kept my eyes on the ground in front of me, and I held Fela's stone so tight in my fist that its edge cut into my palm, and I repeated its long slow *no* over and over in my head. *No. No. No.*

And then I came over a low rise and saw them.

The five Sithe were standing in a half-circle at the bottom of a shallow dell, with their bows drawn. In front of them, at the bottom of the dell, there was a net.

It was a strange net. Silver and fine as spider silk, and it glowed faintly, like the string on my wrist. It was stretched between two birch trees, and it was full of something that was thrashing and screaming.

A young man. Or something that looked like a young man. Slender and dark-haired, with a fine-boned face twisted in terror. He was tangled in the silver net so thoroughly that he could barely move, and every time he struggled, the net tightened, and he screamed again.

His eyes were blue. A very deep blue, like the sky just after sunset.

And his feet, where they stuck out of the net, were not feet. They were hooves. Small and cloven and delicate, like the hooves of a deer.

"He was going to the Grove," said the tall Sithe. Her voice was very cold. "We have been watching him for three days. He came from the south, from the Twilight Court. He came to ask the Tree a question." She drew her bow a little tighter. "He did not reach it. We caught him first." She paused. "But he was very close. Close enough to hear it."

"Did he?" I said. "Hear it?"

The tall Sithe looked at the young man in the net. He had stopped screaming. He was hanging there, breathing hard, staring at the five arrows pointed at him with his deep blue eyes.

"I don't know," she said. "I cannot tell. He was very close." She raised her bow. "It does not matter. He came to the Grove to ask it something. That is enough."

"Wait," I said.

\* \* \*

She did not wait. None of them did. I saw their fingers tighten on their bowstrings. I saw the arrows come back to their full draw.

I did not think. I did not decide. My body moved on its own, the way it had in the garden with Bredon, and in the Cellarage with the Sleeper.

I stepped in front of the net.

Five arrows, pointed at my heart. Five pairs of twilight eyes, staring at me in astonishment.

"If you're going to shoot him," I said, "you'll have to shoot me first."

The tall Sithe stared at me. For the first time since I had met her, something showed on her face. It was not anger. It was not surprise. It was something else. Something that looked almost like fascination.

"You would die for him?" she said. "A stranger? A Fae princeling you have never seen before?"

"I'd rather not die at all," I said. "But yes. If you make me choose."

"Why?"

I looked at her. I thought about it.

"Because he's screaming," I said. "And I've heard too many people scream. And I'm tired of being too late."

The birch wood was silent. Behind me, in the net, the young man with the deer's hooves had gone very still.

The tall Sithe looked at me for a long, long time.

Then, slowly, she lowered her bow.



## Chapter Eighty-Two

### **Bast**

They did not let us go. Not right away. The Sithe are not a people who make hasty decisions, and they had two poisoned creatures in front of them instead of one, and they needed to think.

They took us to a place deeper in the birch wood, a small round clearing with a ring of white stones around its edge. They cut the young man out of the silver net, very carefully, and bound his hands with a cord of the same silver stuff. They did not bind mine. I think they did not think they needed to.

Then they sat down around the ring of stones, the five of them, and they talked.

They talked in their own language, which was not a language I knew, or anything like one. It was soft and cold and liquid, like water running under ice. They talked for a long time. I could not tell what they were saying. But I could tell, from the way the tall one kept looking at me, that they were talking about me.

The young man sat beside me in the center of the circle, with his bound hands in his lap. He did not speak. He was trembling. Every so often, he glanced at me sidelong with his deep blue eyes, and then glanced away again.

I looked at him when he was not looking at me.

He was beautiful. Not the way Felurian was beautiful, overwhelming and terrible. A quieter beauty. Fine-boned and graceful, with dark hair that fell over his forehead and a mouth that looked as if it had been made for laughing. He was dressed in clothes of deep green

and brown, rich and soft, stained with mud from his struggles in the net. There was a thin circlet of dark metal on his brow, half hidden by his hair.

And his feet were hooves. Small and neat and cloven, dark as polished wood.

"Thank you," he said at last. His voice was soft and a little hoarse from screaming. "For stepping in front of me. That was very brave."

"It was very stupid."

"Those are often the same thing." He almost smiled. Then he looked at the Sithe, still talking in their liquid language, and the smile went away. "They're going to kill us both. You know that."

"Maybe."

"No. They are. I know the Sithe. They don't let anyone go who's been near the Tree." He looked down at his bound hands. "I was so stupid. I knew better. My father told me, a hundred times. *Never go near the Grove, Bast. Never, never, never.* And I went anyway."

"Why?"

He was quiet for a long time.

"I wanted to ask it something," he said at last. "Something I couldn't ask anyone else." He looked at me. "Why did you go? The first time?"

"I didn't mean to. I was lost. It called to me."

"It called to me too. That's the thing. It calls to everyone, if they're sad enough. Or lonely enough. Or curious enough." He looked away. "I was all three."

\* \* \*

The Sithe finished talking. They stood up, all five, and came and stood in a circle around us again. The tall one looked down at us with her twilight eyes.

"We have decided," she said.

I waited.

"You," she said, looking at me, "are the key. The Thief's blood. The one the dark one needs. If we kill you, perhaps the door stays closed forever. Perhaps that is the best ending." She paused. "Or

perhaps the dark one finds another way. Another child of the line. The one that is to be born, in the besieged city. And then the door opens anyway, and there is no one left who knows how to close it."

"Yes," I said.

"And perhaps," she went on, "that is the path the Tree wants. The one where we kill you. Perhaps it brought you here for that." She looked at me. "We cannot know. As you said. No one can know."

"No."

"So we have decided to do what the Adem would do. What you would do." She was silent for a moment. "We will choose. And we will bear what comes after."

"And what do you choose?"

The tall Sithe looked at me for a long time. Then she looked at the young man beside me.

"We will let you go," she said. "Both of you. On two conditions."

"What conditions?"

"First. You will never come back to the Moon's Road. Neither of you. Never again. If we ever see you here, we will kill you without a word." Her voice was very cold. "Second. You will take him with you."

I stared at her. "Take him?"

"He has been near the Tree. Very near. Whether he heard it or not, we cannot know. We cannot let him go back to the Twilight Court. If he is poisoned, he will poison them." She looked at the young man. "And we cannot let him wander the twilight alone. He is too young, and too curious, and too foolish. He will find his way back to the Grove, sooner or later. They always do." She looked back at me. "So you will take him. Into the mortal world. Where the Tree cannot reach. And you will keep him there."

"For how long?"

"Until he is no longer foolish," said the tall Sithe. "Which may be a very long time."

The young man made a sound. Half a laugh, half a sob.

"You're giving me to a *mortal*?" he said. "As a—what? A pet?"

"As a charge," said the tall Sithe. "He has shown he will die for you. That is more than most would do." She looked at me. "Will you accept?"

I looked at the young man beside me. At his deep blue eyes and his fine-boned face and his small dark hooves. At the circlet on his brow, and the silver cord around his wrists.

"Yes," I said.

\* \* \*

The tall Sithe cut the cord around his wrists. She did it with a small knife of grey metal, very quickly, and then she stepped back.

"Go," she said. "North, on the Moon's Road. We will watch you until you reach the Northern Gate. If you stray, we will know." She looked at me. "And if you are wrong, mortal—if you are poisoned, and everything you do is the Tree's will—then may whatever gods you have forgive us. Because we will not forgive ourselves."

"And if I'm right?"

She looked at me for a long time. Something moved in her twilight eyes.

"Then we will sing of you," she said. "For a thousand years. As the mortal who walked the Moon's Road and came out clean."

She turned away. The other four turned with her. And then, between one breath and the next, they were gone, back into the birches, and the clearing was empty except for the two of us.

\* \* \*

We walked north.

For a long time, neither of us spoke. I followed the silver string, and the young man walked beside me, a little behind, his hooves making soft clicking sounds on the stones of the path. He kept glancing at me sidelong. I kept pretending not to notice.

At last he said, "What's your name?"

I hesitated. The rules. *Never give your name.*

"You don't have to tell me," he said quickly. "I know the rules. I know mortals aren't supposed to. I just—" He stopped. "I just thought,

since you're going to be keeping me, I should know what to call you."

"Kvothe," I said. "It's the name I'm called by. Not my true name."

"Kvothe." He tried it out. "That's a strange name."

"It's a strange life."

He laughed. It was a real laugh, sudden and bright, and it made him look younger. "I'm Bast," he said. "Bastas, really. Bastas, son of Remmen, Prince of Twilight and the Telwyth Mael." He made a small, ironic bow. "At your service. Apparently. Forever. Or until I'm no longer foolish, which my father would tell you is the same thing."

I looked at him.

"A prince," I said.

"Of a very small court. Very unimportant. Very far from anything." He shrugged. "My father has fourteen children. I'm the youngest. No one will miss me."

"Someone will."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked away.

"Maybe," he said quietly.

\* \* \*

We walked. The birches gave way to open country, rolling hills covered in grey-green grass that rippled in a wind I could not feel. The sky above was paler here, more silver than violet. Far ahead, on the horizon, I could see mountains. Or the shapes of mountains, faint and grey and very far away, like mountains in a dream.

"What did you want to ask it?" I said at last. "The Cthaeh."

Bast did not answer for a long time. I thought he was not going to. Then he said, very quietly, "My mother."

I waited.

"She was mortal," he said. "Did you know that? The Telwyth Mael have mortal blood in them. That's why we have these." He lifted one hoof and set it down again. "A long time ago, one of my ancestors fell in love with a mortal woman, and brought her into the twilight, and she bore him a son. We've been half-and-half ever since. Not quite Fae, not quite mortal. The other courts look down on us for it."

"And your mother?"

"My mother was mortal too. My father found her in your world, in the mountains, and brought her back. She lived with us for a long time. Longer than mortals are supposed to live." He was quiet for a moment. "And then one day she wasn't there anymore. She'd gone back. Through a greystone. To the mortal world. She didn't say goodbye."

"I'm sorry."

"I was very young. I didn't understand. I thought she'd come back. I waited and waited." He looked down at his hooves. "She never came back. My father wouldn't talk about it. Nobody would talk about it. And I thought—" He stopped.

"You thought the Cthaeh would know."

"It knows everything. That's what they say. It sees everything that's ever happened, and everything that ever will." He laughed bitterly. "I thought if I asked it, it would tell me why she left. Where she went. Whether she ever thought about me."

"It would have told you," I said. "But not the way you wanted."

He looked at me. "What do you mean?"

"It tells the truth," I said. "Always. That's what makes it so dangerous. It never lies. It just tells you the truth in the way that will hurt you most." I was quiet for a moment. "It would have told you exactly why your mother left. And it would have told you in a way that made you hate her. Or hate your father. Or hate yourself. And you would have gone back to the Twilight Court with that hate inside you, and it would have grown, and it would have done something terrible."

Bast was silent for a long time.

"Is that what it did to you?" he asked at last.

I did not answer.

\* \* \*

That night, or what passed for night in the twilight, we stopped to rest in a hollow between two hills. There was a small stream there, and a stand of trees with leaves like silver coins, and soft grass to lie on.

I did not sleep. I sat with my back against a tree and my cold hand in my lap and Fela's stone in my good hand, and I watched the sky.

Bast lay in the grass a little way off, curled on his side with his hooves drawn up. I thought he was asleep. But after a while he said, without opening his eyes, "Kvothe."

"Yes?"

"Why did you do it? Step in front of me?" He opened his eyes and looked at me. "Really. Not the thing you told the Sithe. The real reason."

I thought about it for a long time.

"Because I was twelve once," I said at last. "And alone. And there was no one to step in front of me." I looked at him. "And I thought, if I ever had the chance, I'd be the one who did."

Bast looked at me for a long time. His deep blue eyes were very bright in the twilight.

"Then I owe you," he said. "A life-debt. The old kind." He sat up. "Do you know what that means, in the twilight?"

"No."

"It means I'm yours," said Bast simply. "Not as a pet. Not as a charge. As—" He struggled for the word. "As a student. A follower. Someone who goes where you go and learns what you know. Until the debt is paid."

"How long will that take?"

He smiled. It was a strange smile, sad and fond and a little wicked, all at once.

"Forever," he said. "Probably. You've got very bad luck, Kvothe. I can see it on you. You're going to need someone to watch your back."

"I don't need—"

"Everyone needs." He lay back down in the grass and closed his eyes. "Good night, Reshi."

"What does that mean? Reshi?"

"It's an old word," said Bast, without opening his eyes. "In the old tongue. It means *teacher*." A pause. "Or *master*. Or *one who is followed*." Another pause. "Or *fool who steps in front of arrows*. It depends on the context."

I laughed. I could not help it.

And Bast, lying in the silver grass with his eyes closed, smiled.



## Chapter Eighty-Three

# What the Fae Know About Mortals

Bast talked. That was the first thing I learned about him, on the Moon's Road, in the days after the Sithe let us go. He talked the way a stream talks, all the time, about everything, without ever seeming to need a reply.

He told me about the Twilight Court. About his father's house, grown out of a tree so old it had been a sapling when the Thief was still a man. About his thirteen brothers and sisters, most of whom he did not like, and the two he did. About the dark river that ran through the valley, and the lanterns, and the bridges of living vine. About a girl at his father's court with fox-red hair who had broken his heart when he was very young, and another girl with eyes like a cat who had broken it again, and a third, whose name he would not say, who had broken it so thoroughly he was still picking up the pieces.

"You fall in love a great deal," I said.

"All the time." He did not seem embarrassed. "It's the mortal blood. Makes us soft. The Sithe don't fall in love. Felurian doesn't, not really. She falls in *interest*." He grinned. "The Telwyth Mael fall in love the way mortals catch colds. Constantly, and with a great deal of sneezing."

I laughed. He looked pleased.

\* \* \*

He asked questions, too. Hundreds of them. About the mortal world, mostly. What it was like, having a sun that went up and down.

Whether it was true that mortals ate cows. Whether it was true that mortal women had to carry their babies for nine whole months.

"Yes," I said.

"*Nine months?*" He was horrified. "Inside them? The whole time?"

"Yes."

"That's barbaric." He shook his head. "My mother told me, but I thought she was joking. She had a very strange sense of humor." He was quiet for a moment. "She carried me for nine months. In the twilight. It's supposed to be three, for us. She said I was very stubborn and wouldn't come out." He smiled faintly. "She said I've been stubborn ever since."

"Have you?"

"Terribly." He looked at me sidelong. "So are you. I can tell. We're going to argue a great deal, Reshi."

"Don't call me that."

"Why not? It's what you are."

"I'm not anyone's master."

"Teacher, then." He shrugged. "Or fool who steps in front of arrows. Pick one. But you're something, and I'm going to call you something, and Reshi is the only word I know that fits." He grinned again. "You'll get used to it."

I did not think I would. I was wrong about that, as I was wrong about a great many things that year.

\* \* \*

He did not know anything about music. That surprised me more than anything.

"We have music," he said, when I asked. "Of course we have music. The whole twilight is music, if you listen. The trees sing. The rivers sing. The wind sings." He frowned. "But we don't *make* it. Not the way you do. Not with wood and string and fingers." He looked at my lute case with deep suspicion. "Felurian likes it. Mortal music. She says it's the only thing mortals make that's worth the trouble of stealing them."

"She said that?"

"She says it about you." He grinned. "Everyone in the twilight knows about you, you know. The mortal who went to Felurian's glade and came out alive, with a shaed and his wits. They sing about you at my father's court." He paused. "Badly. They don't know the tune."

"There's a song about me?"

"There's a dozen." Bast looked at me. "Didn't you know? You're famous. In the twilight. More famous than in your world, probably." He tilted his head. "Most of them are rude."

\* \* \*

So I taught him "Tinker Tanner."

We had sung it past the Grove, of course, to drown out the Cthaeh. But he had only sung the chorus then, and nonsense syllables for the verses. Now, walking through the grey-green hills with the silver string floating ahead of us, I taught him the verses. All of them. Every one I knew.

He was a terrible student. He forgot the words. He sang the wrong tune. He made up his own verses when he could not remember mine, and they were worse than mine, which is saying something. He laughed so hard at the verse about the tinker and the three sisters from Tinuë that he had to sit down in the grass.

But he learned. By the end of the second day, he could sing forty verses without a mistake. By the end of the third, he was making up new ones that were, I had to admit, very nearly as rude as the old ones.

"This is the best song in the world," he said, lying on his back in the grey-green grass with his hooves in the air. "The absolute best. Why didn't anyone tell me mortals had songs like this?"

"It's a children's song."

"Then mortal children are much wiser than mortal grown-ups." He rolled over and looked at me. "Teach me another."

I taught him another. And another. By the time we reached the Northern Gate, he knew thirty songs, and he sang them all, loudly and badly, at every opportunity.

I have never had a better student. Or a worse one.

On the last night before the Gate, we sat by a small fire in a hollow of silver-barked trees, and Bast asked me the question I had been expecting since the birch wood.

"Why did the Cthaeh talk to you?" he said. "The first time. When you went to it. What did it want?"

I did not answer right away. I looked into the fire.

"It wanted me to go looking for someone," I said at last. "It told me things about a girl I love. About the man who keeps her. Things that would make me angry. Things that would make me go and find him, and do something about it."

"And did you?"

"Not yet."

Bast was quiet for a long time.

"It didn't want you to find him," he said at last. "Not really. It wanted you to find something else. Along the way." He looked at me across the fire. "That's how it works. It doesn't send you where it wants you. It sends you somewhere else, and lets the road take you where it wants." He shivered. "My father told me that. When I was small. He said the Cthaeh is like a river. It doesn't push you. It just makes the ground slope."

I looked at him for a long time.

"And the road took me here," I said slowly. "To the Moon's Road. Past the Grove. To you."

Bast went very still.

"I didn't think of that," he said.

"Neither did I."

We sat by the fire, the two of us, and looked at each other, and I think we were both thinking the same thing. That perhaps the Cthaeh had wanted us to meet. That perhaps everything that happened after—every choice, every kindness, every step we took together—was a step down a slope it had made.

"Does it matter?" said Bast at last. His voice was very small. "If it did? If it wanted us to be here?"

I thought about Vashet. About the Lethani. About choosing, and bearing what comes after.

"No," I said. "It doesn't matter. I stepped in front of those arrows because I chose to. Whatever the Cthaeh wanted. Whatever slope it made." I looked at him. "And you're here because you chose to follow. Didn't you?"

Bast looked at me for a long moment. His deep blue eyes were very bright in the firelight.

"Yes," he said. "Yes. I chose."

"Then that's what matters."

He was quiet for a while. Then he smiled. A small, crooked, relieved smile.

"You'd make a terrible Fae," he said. "You believe in choosing too much."

"I'm not Fae."

"No." He lay back in the grass and looked up at the silver trees. "No, you're something much stranger than that." He was quiet for a moment. "Good night, Reshi."

"Don't call me that."

"Good night, Reshi," he said again, and closed his eyes, and was asleep in a moment, the way the young can sleep.

I sat by the fire and watched him for a long time.

I did not know, then, what the Cthaeh had said to him in the net. I would not know for many years. Not until a cold night at a table by a hearth, with a scribe writing it all down.

But I think I felt it, even then. The weight of it. Something he was carrying, that he would not put down.

And I thought: whatever it is, I'll help him carry it. Whatever it costs.

It was a promise. I did not say it aloud. But I kept it.

He kept his too.

## Chapter Eighty-Four

# Letters in the Dust

On the third night after the Sithe let us go, I found out that Bast could not read.

We were camped in a hollow beside the Moon's Road, among silver grass that whispered when the wind moved through it. I had taken out the little book I carried everywhere, the one I had bought in Imre for a single jot, with its cheap paper and its cracked binding, and I was writing in it by the light of a small fire. Notes, mostly. The things I had learned from the Sithe. The shape of the road. A verse that had come to me, walking, about the color of the twilight.

Bast was lying on his back in the grass on the other side of the fire, with his hands behind his head, watching the sky. After a while he rolled over and propped his chin on his fists and watched me instead.

"What are you doing?" he said.

"Writing."

"I know that. What are you writing?"

I held the book up so that he could see the page. He looked at it for a long moment. His face did something strange. It went very still, and then very bright, and then very carefully careless.

"Oh," he said. "That. Yes. Very nice."

I lowered the book.

"Bast," I said. "What does it say?"

He looked at me. Then at the book. Then at the fire.

"Words," he said. "Mortal words. About—things."

"Which things?"

He did not answer. He rolled back over onto his back and looked at the sky again.

"I can't," he said, after a while. Very quietly. "Read. Mortal letters. I never learned."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a moment. I was surprised. I should not have been. There was no reason a prince of the Twilight Court should know how to read the letters of a world he had never been to. But Bast knew so many things. He knew the names of every flower in the Fae, and which ones would kill you and which ones would only make you wish you were dead. He knew the songs of his father's court, and the dances, and the courtesies, and the insults. He knew how to glamour his face and his voice and the shape of his shadow. He knew a hundred languages, most of which had not been spoken in the mortal world for a thousand years.

But he could not read my little book.

"We don't write things down," said Bast, to the sky. "In the twilight. Not like that. Not in letters. We remember. Or we sing it. Or we weave it into something, or carve it into a tree. But we don't make little marks on paper." He was quiet for a moment. "My mother tried to teach me. Once. When I was very small. She had a book. A mortal book. She'd brought it with her, when she came to the twilight. She used to read it to me."

"What was it?"

"I don't know." His voice was very small. "I never found out. She stopped, before I learned. And then she left. And she took the book with her."

\* \* \*

I closed my own book. I put it down on the grass. I looked at Bast, lying on his back in the silver grass with his face turned up to the sky, and I thought about a boy in Tarbean, twelve years old, who had known how to read, and had no books.

I thought about an old arcanist named Abenthy, sitting in the back of a wagon on the road, with a boy of eleven beside him and a slate between them. Teaching him his letters. Not because he had to. Because he could.

"Bast," I said. "Would you like to learn?"

He did not move. He did not look at me.

"It's a mortal thing," he said. "Why would I want to?"

"Because your mother wanted you to."

He was quiet for a very long time.

"Yes," he said at last. Very softly. "I would."

\* \* \*

I did not have a slate. I did not have chalk, or ink to spare, or paper I could afford to waste. But I had the Fae. And in the Fae, the dust of the Moon's Road is very fine and very silver, and it holds a mark the way wet sand holds a footprint.

I smoothed a patch of it with my palm, beside the fire. I took a twig. And I drew a letter.

"That's A," I said. "It's the first one. It makes a sound like *ah*. Like when you open your mouth to sing."

Bast looked at it. He sat up and crossed his legs and leaned forward, very close, the way a cat leans toward something it has not yet decided whether to pounce on.

"It looks like a tent," he said.

"It does look like a tent."

"Why does a tent say *ah*?"

I opened my mouth. Then I closed it. I had never thought about it. No one had ever asked me that. Not Abenthy, not the masters at the University, not anyone.

"I don't know," I said. "It just does."

Bast looked at the letter for a long time.

"Mortals are very strange," he said.

\* \* \*



It took him longer than it had taken me. I will not pretend otherwise. Bast is very quick in a great many ways, but he had no patience for things that did not make sense, and he found a great many things about mortal letters that did not make sense. Why there were two shapes for every letter, a large one and a small one. Why *c* could sound like *k* sometimes and *s* other times and why no one had just made up a new letter for one of them. Why *e* at the end of a word was sometimes silent, and what it was doing there if it was not going to say anything.

"It's lurking," he said darkly. "It's just sitting there. Lurking. Waiting."

"It changes the vowel before it."

"Then why doesn't it just say so?"

But he learned. Every night, on the Moon's Road, and then in the Stormwal, in caves and hollows and the lee of great boulders, while the wind howled outside. I would draw letters in the dust, or on the snow, or on the frost of a cave wall with my fingernail, and Bast would copy them, frowning, with his tongue caught between his teeth. And then words. And then short sentences, which he read out loud, slowly, sounding them out, with his finger moving under each letter.

*The cat sat.*

*The road is long.*

*Bast is very clever.*

"Is that true?" he said suspiciously, when he had sounded that one out. "Or are you just saying it?"

"It's written down," I said. "So it must be true."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he laughed, delighted, and threw a handful of snow at me.

\* \* \*

The first real thing he read was on the white city's walls.

We had come over the high pass into the bowl of Myr Tariniel, and we were walking through the ruins, among the broken columns and the drifted snow. And on the side of one of the fallen buildings, carved into the white stone, there was writing. Not in the old script of the white city, which neither of us could read. In Tema. Newer,

rougher, scratched into the stone with a knife, by someone who had come here long after the city fell.

Bast stopped in front of it. He looked at it for a long time. His lips moved.

"*Here*," he read, very slowly, sounding out each word. "*I—sat—and—wept*." He stopped. He looked at me. "*Here I sat and wept*." His face was very strange. "Who wrote that?"

"I don't know."

"Someone who came here. And saw it. And sat down. And—" He looked at the words. "And wrote it down. So that someone else would know." He was quiet for a moment. "So that they wouldn't be the only one."

"Yes."

Bast reached out and touched the letters, very gently, the way you touch a thing that might break.

"That's what it's for," he said slowly. "Isn't it? Writing. It's not just for remembering. It's so you're not alone."

I did not answer. I did not need to. He had worked it out himself.

\* \* \*

He carried a little book after that. I gave it to him. My own little book, the cheap one from Imre, with its cracked binding. I tore out the pages I had written on and gave him the rest. And he wrote in it. Badly, at first, in big clumsy letters that wandered all over the page. Then better.

I do not know what he wrote. He never showed me. He kept the book in the inside pocket of his coat, and he took it out at night, sometimes, when he thought I was asleep, and wrote in it by the light of the fire, with his tongue between his teeth.

\* \* \*

"He still has it," said the innkeeper. "The book. Did you know?"

Chronicler looked at Bast. Bast had gone very red. He was studying the grain of the table with great attention.

"He's filled it," said the innkeeper. "Years ago. He's on his fourth, now. Or his fifth. He buys them from the tinkers, when they come

through." He looked at Bast with an expression Chronicler had not seen on his face before. Something very fond, and very sad. "I've never read them. I never asked. I didn't—" He stopped. "I didn't know how to ask, for a long time. I didn't know how to want to know things."

Bast did not look up.

"They're not very good," he said, to the table. "My letters are still terrible. And I can't spell. The *es* still lurk."

"What's in them?" said Chronicler gently.

Bast was quiet for a long moment.

"Him," he said at last. "Every day. For seven years. What he said. What he did. Whether he smiled." His voice was very small. "So that if he ever came back, he'd know what he missed. And so that if he never did—" He stopped.

"So you wouldn't be alone," said the innkeeper softly.

Bast looked up. His deep blue eyes were very bright.

"You taught me that," he said. "In the snow. *Here I sat and wept.*"

The innkeeper did not say anything. He reached across the table, very slowly, and put his hand over Bast's hand. And left it there.

"May I read them?" he said. "Someday? When this is over?"

Bast looked at their hands for a long time.

"They're terrible," he said. "The spelling."

"I don't care about the spelling."

"And some of it's—" Bast swallowed. "Some of it's not very kind. The first year. When I was angry."

"I don't care about that either."

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he nodded. Once. Very slightly.

"Someday," he said.

And Chronicler, who had spent his whole life among other people's words, looked down at his own page and found that he could not see it clearly. He wiped his eyes with the back of his scabbed hand and dipped his pen, and went on.

## Chapter Eighty-Five

# The Tree's Voice

The Moon's Road runs north through the twilight for a very long way, and for most of that way, it runs within earshot of the Grove.

I did not know that when I bought the road from the acorn-colored mapmaker in the Hollow Market. I had thought, from the way the mapmaker spoke, that the road passed near the Grove at one point, the way a road passes near a town, and then went on its way. I had thought that once I was past the birch wood and the Sithe, I would be past the danger.

I was wrong.

The road ran north. The Grove lay to the east. And for three long days after we left the Sithe, the road curved slowly around the Grove in a great wide arc, like the rim of a wheel around its hub, never coming closer, never going further away.

And for three days, the Cthaeh talked to us.

\* \* \*

It began on the first morning, as we set out from the hollow where we had slept. I heard it as a whisper at the very edge of hearing, off to the right, beyond the grey-green hills. Not words. Not yet. Just a voice. Soft and sweet and a little sad, like someone humming to themselves in another room.

Bast heard it too. I saw him stop, and turn his head, and his face go pale.

"Don't listen," I said.

"I'm not."

"You are. I can see it. Don't."

"How am I supposed to not listen?" His voice was tight. "It's right there. I can hear it. I can't just not hear it."

"You can." I took Fela's stone out of my pocket and held it up. "Hold this. Listen to it instead. It's saying no. Say it with it. Over and over. *No. No. No.* Until you can't hear anything else."

He looked at the stone. Then at me. Then, slowly, he took it.

He held it in both hands. He closed his eyes. His lips moved.

After a while, some of the color came back into his face.

"It's very stubborn," he said, without opening his eyes. "This stone."

"That's why it works."

"Where did you get it?"

"A friend gave it to me. She knows stone. She held up a building with it once, while it burned."

Bast opened his eyes and looked at me. "Your friends are very strange."

"You have no idea."

\* \* \*

We walked. The voice followed. It grew louder, slowly, as the morning wore on. Not closer. Louder. As if whoever was humming in the other room had noticed us listening and had begun to hum a little more clearly, for our benefit.

By midday, I could make out words.

*Kvothe*, it said. *Little Kvothe. You came back.*

I did not answer. I walked. I held my own hand pressed flat against my chest, over the knot that hung there on its thread. *Road. Promise. A story told many times.*

*I knew you would*, said the Cthaeh. *I have been waiting. It has been so long, and so dull. No one comes to see me anymore. The Sithe are very strict.*

I walked.

*You have a friend now. A Fae princeling. With hooves. A soft laugh, like honey poured over broken glass. How sweet. How very like you. You always did collect strays.*

Beside me, Bast's hands tightened around Fela's stone.

*Shall I tell him about his mother?* said the Cthaeh. *He wants to know so badly. He came all this way. It would be cruel not to tell him.*

"Don't listen," I said to Bast. My voice was very quiet. "Whatever it says. Don't listen."

"I'm not," said Bast. His face was white. "I'm not listening. I'm not."

*She left because of him,* said the Cthaeh softly. *Did you know that, little prince? Because of you. She looked at you, when you were small, and she saw—*

I began to sing.

\* \* \*

It was not a song I had planned. It came up out of me the way songs sometimes do, all at once, without asking. It was "Tinker Tanner." The silliest song I know. The song every child in the Four Corners learns before they can walk. A song with a thousand verses, most of them rude, about a tinker who travels the roads and gets into trouble.

I sang it loudly. As loudly as I could. I sang it the way you sing in a tavern at the end of a long night, when you are too drunk to care how you sound.

Bast stared at me.

"Sing," I said, between verses. "Sing with me."

"I don't know it."

"Everyone knows it."

"I'm *Fae*."

"Then learn it." I launched into the next verse, about the tinker and the miller's daughter and what happened in the barn. "Come on. It's easy. The chorus is the same every time."

Bast looked at me for a long moment. Then, hesitantly, he began to sing along with the chorus.

He had a good voice. Clear and light and a little wild. He did not know the words, so he sang nonsense syllables. But he sang.

And the Cthaeh's voice faded. Not gone. It was still there, underneath, a whisper at the edge of hearing. But it was hard to hear a whisper over a tinker's song sung at the top of two voices.

We sang all afternoon.

\* \* \*

We made camp that night in the lee of a great grey boulder, in a hollow of grey-green grass. We were both hoarse. My throat felt like I had swallowed sand. Bast had sung himself nearly voiceless; he sat against the boulder with Fela's stone in his lap and his hooves drawn up, looking exhausted.

But the Cthaeh was still there. Quieter, now that we were not walking. But there. A soft voice in the dark, off to the east, humming to itself.

*You cannot sing all night, it said. You will have to sleep eventually. And when you sleep, you will dream. And in dreams, I can say anything I like.*

I did not answer. I took out my lute.

My left hand was still stiff. Still cold, though not as cold as it had been, before Felurian's kiss. I could move the fingers now, a little. Enough to make chords, if they were simple. Enough to play.

I played. Softly, this time. Not "Tinker Tanner." Something else. A lullaby. The one my mother used to sing to me when I was very small and could not sleep. I had not played it in years. I had not let myself.

I played it now. For Bast. For me. Against the dark.

Bast listened with his eyes closed. After a while, his head drooped against the boulder, and his breathing slowed, and he slept.

I kept playing.

*How long can you keep this up?* said the Cthaeh. *A night? Two? Three? Your fingers are already bleeding. That cold hand of yours won't last.*

I kept playing.

*You know I'm right, said the Cthaeh. You always know. That's the delicious thing about you, little key. You always know, and you always do it anyway.*

I kept playing.

*Shall I tell you something? Something true? For free, since you've been such good company?*

I kept playing. But I felt my fingers slow, just slightly.

*When you set down your name, said the Cthaeh, very softly, who will you trust to hold it?*

\* \* \*

My fingers stopped.

I did not mean them to. They simply stopped, on their own, in the middle of a chord. The last note hung in the air for a moment, and faded.

I sat very still in the dark. My heart was pounding.

*There, said the Cthaeh. Its voice was very gentle. There. You've been thinking about it, haven't you? Ever since the madman at the gate. Ever since he told you. A name can be put down. You need someone to hold it for you. A soft laugh. You've been thinking about it every night. Who would you trust? Who would you give it to?*

I did not answer. I could not.

*Your friends? The poet? The Cealdish boy with the burned hands? The moneylender who takes blood as collateral? The Cthaeh's voice was amused. The stone girl? She'd hold it. She'd hold it forever. She's very good at holding things. A pause. Or the princeling, perhaps. Sleeping so sweetly there against his rock. He owes you a life. He'd hold it. He'd hold it very carefully. He'd hold it for years and years and years, and never give it back, because he'd be so afraid of what you'd do with it.*

Beside me, Bast stirred in his sleep. He did not wake.

*Or, said the Cthaeh, and its voice went very soft, very sweet, the girl.*

I closed my eyes.



*The girl with the knots. The one who ties names. She could do it, you know. She's the only one who could. The only one in all the world who knows how to tie a name into a cord so that it holds. The Cthaeh laughed softly. And you love her. And she loves you. And she's bound, body and soul, to the man who wants you most.*

I sat in the dark with my eyes closed and my lute in my lap and I did not move.

*Who will you trust, little key? said the Cthaeh. When the time comes? Who will you give your name to?*

*And what will they do with it?*

\* \* \*

I did not sleep that night. I sat against the boulder with my lute in my lap and Bast asleep beside me, and I listened to the Cthaeh talk.

It did not stop. It talked all night, softly, sweetly, reasonably. It told me things. Some of them I already knew. Some of them I did not. Some of them I have never repeated to anyone, and never will.

It told me about Denna. About where she had been, and what she had done, and what she would do. It told me about Bredon, and his true name, and how old he really was. It told me about Meluan, and the child she carried, and what would happen to them both.

It told me about the door.

I listened. I could not help it. I had tried not to, all day, and I had succeeded, with Bast's help and the tinker's song. But in the dark, alone, with my throat raw and my fingers bleeding and my cold hand aching, I did not have the strength.

I listened. And every word it said went into me like a hook.

\* \* \*

When the grey not-dawn of the twilight came, the Cthaeh stopped talking.

It did not fade away. It simply stopped, all at once, in the middle of a sentence, as if it had been cut off. The silence afterward was enormous.

Bast woke. He sat up, rubbing his eyes, and looked at me.

"Did you sleep?" he asked.

"No."

He looked at my face. His own face changed.

"It talked to you," he said. "All night. While I slept."

"Yes."

"What did it say?"

I looked at him. At his deep blue eyes and his fine-boned face, still soft with sleep. At the stone in his lap, Fela's stone, that he had held all night without knowing it.

"Nothing I didn't already know," I said.

It was a lie. He knew it was a lie. I saw it in his face.

But he did not press. He only looked at me for a long moment, and then he held out Fela's stone.

"Here," he said. "You need it more than I do."

I took it. It was warm from his hands.

We got up. We walked. And on the third day, at last, the road turned away from the Grove, and the voice faded behind us, and was gone.

But the hooks stayed.

I could feel them. All through me. Little silver hooks, as Felurian had said, pulling. And I knew, walking north through the grey-green hills with Bast beside me and the silver string floating ahead, that they would never come out.

*Who will you trust to hold it?*

I did not know. Not then.

But I would.

## **Interlude: The Other Side of the Net**

The innkeeper stopped. He reached for his cup of tea and found it cold, and drank it anyway.

Chronicler set down his pen. His hand ached. He flexed it, slowly, and looked across the table at Bast.

Bast was sitting in his backward chair with his arms folded across the back of it and his chin resting on his arms. He had not moved in a long time. His eyes were fixed on the innkeeper's face, and they were very bright.

"I didn't know," he said. His voice was very quiet. "That it talked to you. All that night. I didn't know."

"I didn't tell you."

"You should have."

"Why? So you could feel guilty for sleeping?" The innkeeper set down his cup. "You'd been screaming in a net for half a day, Bast. You'd nearly been shot by the Sithe. You were exhausted. You deserved to sleep."

"You didn't sleep."

"I'm used to not sleeping." The innkeeper smiled faintly. "It's one of my few real talents."

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at Chronicler.

"Do you want to know what it was like?" he said. "From the other side? From inside the net?"

Chronicler hesitated. He glanced at the innkeeper, who shrugged slightly.

"It's his story too," the innkeeper said. "Let him tell it."

Chronicler picked up his pen. He dipped it. "Yes," he said. "I'd like to know."

\* \* \*

"I was so stupid," Bast said.

He said it plainly, without any particular emotion. The way you might say *the sky is blue*, or *water is wet*.

"I was very young. Younger than I looked. Younger than I am now, by a great deal. And I had been sad for a very long time. Since my mother left. Everyone at my father's court thought I had gotten over it, because I laughed and played and chased girls and did all the things a young prince of the Telwyth Mael is supposed to do. But I hadn't gotten over it. I'd only gotten better at hiding it."

He was quiet for a moment.

"And one day I just—decided. I didn't plan it. I didn't think about it. I woke up one morning and I knew I was going to the Grove. I was going to ask the Tree what had happened to my mother. And nothing anyone said was going to stop me." He laughed softly, without humor. "My father would have locked me in a tower if he'd known. So I didn't tell him. I just went."

"Alone?" said Chronicler.

"Alone. Of course alone. Who would have come with me?" Bast shook his head. "I walked for nine days. Through the Deep Wood. Past Felurian's spring, though I didn't see her. Into the birches. And all the way, the closer I got, I could hear it. Calling. So softly. So sweetly." He shivered. "It knew I was coming. It knew before I did, probably. It was waiting."

"And the Sithe?"

"The Sithe caught me at the edge of the Grove. The very edge. I could see the tree. I could see the flowers on it, the red ones, the ones that smell so sweet. I was maybe a hundred paces away." He closed his eyes. "The net came out of nowhere. One moment I was walking, and the next I was tangled up in silver, hanging between two birches, and I couldn't move."

"And you screamed."

"I screamed." Bast opened his eyes. "Not because of the net. Because of what I heard. When the net caught me."

The common room was very quiet. The fire crackled. Outside, the night was very dark.

"What did you hear?" said Chronicler softly.

Bast looked at the innkeeper. The innkeeper looked back at him. Something passed between them.

"I've never told you," Bast said. "Have I, Reshi?"

"No."

"I've never told anyone." Bast looked down at his folded arms. "It said one thing. Just one. As the net caught me, before the Sithe came. Very soft. Right in my ear, as if it were standing beside me." He was quiet for a long time. "It said, *You will keep him in a cage of your own making. And you will call it love.*"

\* \* \*

Nobody spoke.

Chronicler sat very still with his pen in his hand. He looked at Bast, and then at the innkeeper, and then back at Bast.

The innkeeper had gone very pale.

"Bast," he said quietly.

"I didn't know what it meant." Bast's voice was very steady. Too steady. "Not then. I didn't know who *him* was. I screamed because it was the most horrible thing I'd ever heard, and I didn't even know why. And then the Sithe came, and they had their arrows pointed at me, and I thought I was going to die." He looked up. "And then you stepped in front of me. And I knew."

"Bast—"

"I knew *who*. The moment you stepped in front of me. I looked at you, standing there with your back to me, with five arrows pointed at your heart, and I knew." Bast's eyes were very bright. "I've known ever since. Every day. Every single day. *You will keep him in a cage of your own making.*"

The innkeeper did not say anything. He sat very still with his hands folded on the table.

"And I did," said Bast. His voice cracked, very slightly. "Didn't I? I did exactly that. I've done it for years."

"You haven't—"

"I have." Bast stood up. His chair scraped on the floor. "This place. This inn. This town. These people. Graham and Cob and Jake and all the rest of them." He gestured around the dark common room. "I helped you build it. I helped you hide in it. I helped you forget. Every time you started to remember, every time you started to become yourself again, I—" He stopped. "I was so afraid. Of what you'd do. Of what would happen if you remembered. If you picked it back up. I thought if you stayed here, if you stayed Kote, you'd be safe."

"Bast."

"And then I realized what I'd done." Bast was shaking. "I realized that I'd built you a cage, and I'd told myself it was love. Just like it said. Just exactly like it said." He looked at the innkeeper, and his face was naked with grief. "So I tried to break it. I tried to break you out. And I—"

He stopped. He pressed his hand against his mouth.

The innkeeper was looking at him very steadily.

"And you what, Bast?" he said quietly.

Bast did not answer. He stood there with his hand pressed against his mouth, and he shook his head, over and over.

"Not yet," he said through his fingers. "Not yet. I'll tell you. I promise I'll tell you. But not yet."

He turned and went into the kitchen. The door swung shut behind him.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper sat very still for a long time. Chronicler did not speak. He did not know what to say.

At last the innkeeper sighed. He picked up his cold cup of tea and looked into it.

"He's been carrying that for a long time," he said. "Longer than I knew."

"The Cthaeh's words."

"The Cthaeh's words." The innkeeper set down the cup. "That's what it does, you know. It doesn't lie. It doesn't need to. It just tells you the truth, and then it lets you carry it. And the carrying is what breaks you." He looked at the kitchen door. "He's been carrying that since the day we met. Every day. Wondering if every kind thing he did for me was the cage. Wondering if every time he protected me, he was locking the door."

"Was he?"

The innkeeper looked at Chronicler for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "Sometimes. And sometimes no. It's not always easy to tell the difference, between a cage and a shelter." He smiled faintly. "The Cthaeh knew that. That's why it said it. It knew he'd never be able to tell."

"And what did he do? What was he going to say, just now? *I tried to break you out, and I—*"

The innkeeper was silent for a long time. He looked at the kitchen door. Then he looked at the sword above the hearth. Then, finally, he looked at his own hands, folded on the table. At the bruises on his knuckles, fading from purple to yellow.

"I think I know," he said quietly. "I think I've known since last night." He paused. "But he'll tell it when he's ready. It's his to tell."

\* \* \*

After a while, Bast came back. His eyes were red, but his face was composed. He was carrying a fresh pot of tea. He set it on the table and poured three cups without speaking, and then he sat down in his backward chair again.

"Sorry," he said. "Go on, Reshi. Where were we?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then he reached across the table and laid his hand, very briefly, on Bast's arm.

Bast did not look up. But his shoulders loosened, very slightly.

"The Northern Gate," said the innkeeper. "We'd come to the Northern Gate. At the end of the Moon's Road. And beyond it, the mountains."

He picked up his fresh cup of tea and held it in both hands, the way you hold something warm on a cold night.

"It was snowing on the other side," said Kvothe. "I remember that. We stepped through a ring of greystones, out of the twilight, and it was snowing. Great soft flakes, falling out of a white sky. And the cold hit us like a hammer." He smiled faintly. "Bast had never seen snow before. He stood there with his mouth open, catching flakes on his tongue, and I thought he was going to cry."

"I didn't cry," said Bast.

"You cried a little."

"It was very beautiful snow."

"It was." The innkeeper looked into his tea. "It was very beautiful. And it was full of scrael."



## Chapter Eighty-Six

# The Gate-Warden

Where the Moon's Road leaves the grey-green hills and climbs toward the mountains, there is a gate.

It is not a gate in a wall. There is no wall. There is only the road, running up a long bare slope of silver grass toward a notch in the ridge, and at the top of the slope, standing across the road, two tall grey stones with a third laid across them. A lintel. A doorway with nothing on either side of it. You could walk around it with no trouble at all. The grass on either side was smooth and open and empty.

"Don't," said Bast, when I started to.

I stopped. "Why not?"

"Because it's a gate." He was looking at the stones with an expression I had not seen on him before. Respect, and wariness, and something close to fear. "You don't go around a gate, Reshi. Not in the twilight. That's the rudest thing there is. Worse than breaking a promise. If you go around a gate, the gate remembers. And the next gate you come to won't let you through at all."

"And if I go through?"

"Then you have to pay the warden."

I looked at the stones. There was no one there. Just the road, and the silver grass, and the two grey stones with the third across them, and the notch in the ridge beyond, and the mountains beyond that, white and enormous and very far away.

"What warden?"

Bast did not answer. He was looking at the space between the stones.

After a moment, so was I.

\* \* \*

It was not there, and then it was.

I do not know how else to say it. There was no flicker, no fading in. It was simply the case, all at once, that someone was sitting in the doorway between the stones, on a three-legged stool, with a long clay pipe in one hand and a cup of something steaming in the other. And it was also the case, somehow, that they had always been sitting there, and I had simply failed to notice.

It was a small person. Smaller than Bast. Wrapped in a cloak the color of dry leaves, with the hood pushed back. Its face was old and brown and creased like a walnut shell, and its eyes were very bright and very black and very amused. I could not tell if it was a man or a woman. I am still not sure. I am not sure the question means anything, where the warden is concerned.

"Well," it said. Its voice was dry and light and pleasant, like the rustle of paper. "Two travelers. One of them mortal." It looked at me. "Very mortal. Mortal all the way through. How unusual." It drew on its pipe. "And one of them isn't."

Bast bowed. Low, with one hand over his heart. I had never seen him bow to anyone before.

"Warden," he said. "We ask passage."

"I know you do. Everyone does. Nobody sits on this road for the view." The warden looked at Bast with its bright black eyes. "I know you. Remmen's boy. The one with the mortal mother." It smiled. It had very small, very white teeth. "You've grown."

Bast went red to the tips of his ears. "Warden."

"And you're traveling with a mortal. On the Moon's Road. Toward the mountains." The warden's eyes moved to me. "With the moon's silver on his wrist and a stone in his pocket that says no." It tilted its head. "How very interesting you both are."

\* \* \*

"What's the price?" I said. "For passage?"

The warden looked at me for a long moment. Then it laughed, a small dry pleased laugh.

"Straight to it," it said. "Mortals always are. You have so little time, you can't afford to waste any on manners." It set down its cup on the grass beside the stool. "The price is a riddle."

"You'll ask me a riddle?"

"No, no, no." The warden waved its pipe. "Anyone can answer a riddle. That's easy. That's nothing. No, *you'll* ask *me* a riddle. And if I can answer it, you go back the way you came. And if I can't—" It spread its small brown hands. "Then the gate is open, and you may pass."

I looked at Bast. Bast was looking at the ground.

"How many people get through?" I said.

"Oh, a few." The warden drew on its pipe. "Over the years. Not many. I've been sitting here a very long time, you understand, and I've heard a great many riddles. Almost all of them, I think." It smiled. "But there's always a chance. That's what makes it interesting."

\* \* \*

I sat down in the silver grass in front of the gate. I crossed my legs. I thought.

Bast sat down beside me. He did not say anything. He knew better than to help. In the twilight, a riddle asked with help is not your riddle, and the warden would have known.

I thought of every riddle I knew. There were a great many. The Ruh are fond of riddles; we trade them around the fire on long nights on the road, and I had learned hundreds before I was ten. I had learned more at the University, from Wil and Sim and the others, drinking at Anker's. I had learned some very strange ones from Elodin, which did not have answers, or had answers that were other riddles, or had answers that made you feel as if the floor had tilted underneath you.

The warden would know them all. I was sure of that. It had been sitting on this road since before the Ruh were on the roads, since before there was a University. It had heard every riddle there was.

Every riddle that had been asked.

\* \* \*

"Well?" said the warden, after a while. "I'm in no hurry. But you are."

I looked up at it.

"What's the name of the thing in my pocket?" I said.

The warden blinked. It looked at me. Then it looked at my pocket.

"That's not a riddle," it said. "That's a question."

"It's a riddle if you can't answer it."

The warden looked at me for a long moment with its bright black eyes. Then it laughed again, delighted.

"Oh, very good," it said. "Very Ruh. All right. I'll allow it." It leaned forward on its stool. "The thing in your pocket is a stone. It was cut from the foundation of a building in Imre. A tavern. A place where music lived. It burned, and the stone did not." Its eyes narrowed. "And a woman held it, once, with her whole heart, and asked it to stand. And it stood. And now it says *no*." It sat back, satisfied. "The name of the thing in your pocket is *No*."

I shook my head.

"That's what it says," I said. "Not what it's called."

The warden's eyes went very still.

\* \* \*

"Its name," I said, "is whatever Fela called it. When she held it in the burning Eolian and asked it to stand. She spoke to it. She must have called it something. And it answered." I looked at the warden. "I don't know what she called it. She never told me. I don't think she knows herself; I think it just came out of her, in the fire. But the stone knows. And she knows, somewhere deep, where the truth lives." I spread my hands. "And I don't think you do."

The warden did not say anything for a long time.

It looked at my pocket. It looked at me. Its bright black eyes narrowed, and narrowed, and I could feel it reaching. Not with its hands. With something else. Something older and subtler, the way Elodin reached for the name of the wind.

And then, very slowly, it began to smile.

"No," it said. "I don't."

\* \* \*

It stood up from its stool. It was even smaller standing than sitting; its head came barely to my chest. It knocked out its pipe against the side of the left-hand stone.

"That's the first time in a very long while," it said, "that anyone's asked me a riddle whose answer was a name I didn't know." It looked at me with its head on one side. "Do you know why that almost never happens?"

"No."

"Because mortals don't think of the things in their pockets as having names." The warden tucked its pipe away in its cloak. "Not real names. Only what they say, or what they're for. A key is a key. A coin is a coin. A stone is a stone." It looked at me. "But you do. Somewhere in you, you know that everything has a name. Even a little stone from a burned-down tavern." It smiled. "Especially a little stone from a burned-down tavern."

"Is that good?"

"It's dangerous," said the warden. "It's very dangerous. Most mortals can't bear to think like that. It makes the world too big. Too full." It picked up its stool and its cup. "But it's also how you get through gates."

It stepped aside. The space between the two grey stones was empty. Beyond it, the road ran on up the slope toward the notch in the ridge, silver in the twilight.

"Pass," said the warden. "Both of you. Remmen's boy too; he's with you, and I'm feeling generous." It looked at Bast. "Look after him, little one. He's going to need it. I can smell the mountains on him already. And something older than the mountains."

Bast bowed again. Very low.

\* \* \*

We passed through the gate. I felt it as I went, a small cool tingle across my skin, like walking through a curtain of mist. And then we were on the other side, and the road was climbing, and the notch in the ridge was ahead of us.

I looked back. The gate stood where it had stood, two grey stones and a lintel across the road. There was no one sitting in it. There was no stool, and no cup, and no smell of pipe smoke on the air.

"Where did it go?" I said.

"Nowhere," said Bast. "It's still there. It's always there. You just can't see it once you've paid." He was quiet for a moment. "Reshi. That was very clever."

"Thank you."

"No. I mean it was *very* clever. Too clever." He looked at me sidelong. "Do you know what you did?"

"I asked it a riddle it couldn't answer."

"You asked it the name of something," said Bast. "Something you carry. Something small. And it couldn't find it." He was quiet for a long moment. "Reshi. That means the stone has a name so deep, so hidden, so wrapped up inside itself, that even a gate-warden of the old twilight can't reach it."

I stopped walking.

"Fela," I said slowly.

"Yes." Bast looked at me. "Whatever she did to that stone, in the fire, she did it very, very well." He was quiet. "I'd want to know that. If I were you. If I ever needed something that nobody could open."

I did not answer. I stood on the road in the silver twilight with the stone in my pocket, and I put my hand over it, and I felt it there. Small and cool and stubborn. Saying *no*.

I would remember that, later. In a workshop in the Fishery, in the middle of the night, with Kilvin's roah planks laid out on the bench and Fela sitting across from me with two stones in her hands.

*If I ever needed something that nobody could open.*

\* \* \*

We climbed on. The notch in the ridge came nearer. And beyond it, rising white and enormous against the twilight sky, the Stormwal waited.

Behind us, on the empty road, I thought I heard—very faint, very dry—someone laughing.

## Chapter Eighty-Seven

# The Stormwal

Nobody lives in the Stormwal. Nobody sane.

It is a range of mountains in the far north of the Four Corners, beyond the last of the Commonwealth's cities, beyond the last of the Small Kingdoms, beyond the last village where anyone speaks a language anyone else understands. It is high and cold and bare, a great jagged wall of grey stone and white snow stretching from east to west as far as anyone has ever traveled. The winds there never stop. They come howling down off the peaks, day and night, summer and winter, so fierce and so cold that they can freeze a man's breath in his lungs.

That is why it is called the Stormwal. Because it is a wall made of storms.

There are stories about it, of course. There are always stories. They say that the mountains are the bones of a giant who died in the Creation War. They say that the winds are the ghosts of the namers who fought there, still screaming their names into the sky. They say that there are things in the high passes that are older than the mountains themselves, things that crawl out of the ice at night and hunt anything warm.

Some of the stories are true.

\* \* \*

We came out of the twilight into the Stormwal through a ring of greystones on a high bare shoulder of the mountains, and the first thing I felt was the cold.



I had been cold before. I had been cold on the streets of Tarbean, sleeping on rooftops in the winter rain. I had been cold in the Eolian, with Cinder's hand around my wrist. I thought I knew what cold was.

I did not.

It hit me the moment I stepped out of the ring. It went through the shaed and through my clothes and through my skin and into my bones, all at once, like a hammer blow. My breath froze in my throat. My eyes watered and the tears froze on my cheeks. My cold left hand, which had been almost bearable in the twilight, went dead and white and useless in an instant.

Beside me, Bast gasped. It was a thin, high, strangled sound, the sound of someone who has jumped into a winter lake.

And then he looked up.

It was snowing. Great soft flakes, drifting down out of a white sky, falling slowly and silently all around us. They settled on the grey stones of the ring, and on the bare rock of the mountainside, and on our hair and our shoulders and our eyelashes. The world was white and grey and silent, except for the distant howling of the wind in the peaks.

Bast stood in the snow with his mouth open. He held out his hands, palms up, and watched the flakes land on them and melt. He tilted his head back and let them fall on his face.

"What is it?" he whispered.

"Snow."

"Snow." He said the word as if it were a prayer. "We don't have snow. In the twilight. We don't have weather at all." He caught a flake on his tongue. His eyes went wide. "It's *cold*."

"That's the point of it."

"It's beautiful." His voice cracked. His eyes were wet. "Reshi, it's so beautiful."

I looked at him, standing in the snow with his face turned up and tears on his cheeks, and I did not tell him that the snow would kill us both if we stood there much longer. I let him look.

For a little while.

\* \* \*

The silver string still pointed north. It floated in the air ahead of us, glowing faintly against the white, pointing up the mountainside toward a high pass between two great peaks. I did not know how far it was. I did not know what lay beyond.

But I knew that we could not stay where we were. Not in that cold. Not in that wind.

So we climbed.

It was the hardest climb of my life. The mountainside was steep and bare and slick with ice. The snow grew deeper as we went, first to our ankles, then to our knees. The wind came howling down from the pass, driving the snow into our faces like handfuls of needles. My cold hand was useless. I climbed one-handed, clutching at the rocks with my good hand, dragging myself up.

Bast was better at it than I was. His hooves, it turned out, were made for mountains. They found purchase on the ice where my boots slipped. He went ahead of me, picking the way, reaching back to pull me up over the hardest places. He did not complain. He did not say anything at all. But every so often, when he thought I was not looking, he tilted his head back and caught a snowflake on his tongue.

We climbed all day. At dusk, if you could call it dusk—the white sky only grew a little greyer—we found a shallow cave in the lee of a great boulder, and we crawled inside, and we huddled together against the back wall with the shaed wrapped around us both.

I tried to light a fire. There was nothing to burn. I tried sympathy, binding the heat of my own body to a stone to warm it. It worked, a little. Not enough.

"We're going to die," said Bast, through chattering teeth. He did not sound frightened. He sounded interested. "Aren't we? Up here. In the snow."

"Not tonight."

"How do you know?"

"Because I haven't finished what I came to do." I pulled the shaed tighter around us. "And I always finish what I came to do. Eventually."

Bast laughed. It came out as a cloud of white breath.

"You're insane," he said. "Do you know that?"

"I've been told."

"Good. I like insane." He leaned his head against my shoulder. "Insane people are the only ones who ever do anything interesting."

\* \* \*

The scrael came in the night.

I heard them first. A sound in the darkness outside the cave, beneath the howling of the wind. A clicking. A rattling. Like dry bones knocking together. Like beetles scuttling over stone. It came from somewhere below us, on the mountainside, and it was getting closer.

I sat up. Beside me, Bast sat up too. His eyes were wide in the dark.

"What is that?" he whispered.

I did not answer. I knew what it was. I had heard it before, in the Commonwealth, in the stories of travelers. I had read about it in the Archives. I had never heard it myself.

Scrael.

They are things from the mountains. Black and hard and shiny, like beetles, but the size of a dog or a large cat. They have many legs, long and thin and sharp as knives. They have no eyes that anyone has ever found. They have no mouths either, or not the kind of mouth that eats. They do not eat what they kill. They only kill it.

They come in swarms. Dozens. Hundreds. They come down out of the high places when the winter is hard, and they kill everything they find. Sheep, cattle, horses, men. They cut them to pieces with their knife-legs and leave the pieces lying in the snow.

No one knows where they come from. No one knows what they are. They are not natural. That much everyone agrees on. They are not animals, and they are not Fae, and they are not anything else that has a name.

And they are hard to kill. Very hard. Swords glance off their shells. Arrows bounce. Fire does not burn them.

But I knew something about them that most people do not know. I had read it in an old book in the Archives, years ago, a book about the

monsters of the northern mountains. I had not thought about it since.  
They do not like iron.

\* \* \*

"Bast," I said. My voice was very quiet. "Do you have any iron on you?"

He stared at me in the dark. "*Iron?* Reshi, I'm *Fae*."

Of course. Of course he did not. Iron burns the Fae. They cannot touch it. They cannot bear to be near it.

I had a little. Not much. The buckle of my belt. The nails in my boots. The small knife I kept in my pack for cutting bread. And Caesura, of course. But Caesura was not iron. The Adem make their swords of something else, some alloy of their own that they do not share with outsiders.

The clicking was getting louder. Closer. I could hear individual sounds now, sharp little taps of knife-legs on stone. Dozens of them. Coming up the mountainside toward the cave.

I took off my belt. I pulled the knife out of my pack. I looked at the buckle, and the blade, and the nails in my boots.

It was not enough. It would never be enough. Not for dozens of them.

"Stay behind me," I said to Bast. "Stay against the back wall. Don't move."

"What are you going to do?"

"I don't know yet."

\* \* \*

The first one came into the mouth of the cave a moment later.

It was bigger than I had expected. The size of a large dog, black and gleaming, with its many legs folded around it like the ribs of an umbrella. It had no head that I could see. Just a smooth black shell, faintly iridescent, like oil on water. It paused in the mouth of the cave. Its legs tapped on the stone, feeling. Searching.

Then it came in.

It moved very fast. Faster than anything that size should be able to move. It was across the cave floor before I could draw breath, its knife-legs flashing, and I threw myself sideways and felt one of them slice through the edge of the shaed and graze my shoulder.

I rolled. I came up on one knee with the bread knife in my good hand. The scrael turned, all its legs moving at once, and came at me again.

I stabbed at it. The knife hit its shell and skittered off, the way a knife skitters off a pane of glass. But where the iron touched it, the shell smoked. Just a little. A thin grey wisp, rising from the black surface.

The scrael shrieked. It was a horrible sound, high and thin and grinding, like metal on metal. It reared back, its legs flailing.

I did not wait. I lunged forward and drove the knife into the place where its legs met its body, where the shell was thinnest. I felt the blade go in. I felt something give.

The scrael shrieked again. Then it collapsed, its legs folding in on themselves, and lay still.

I knelt beside it, breathing hard, with the knife in my hand. The blade was smoking. Black ichor dripped from it, thick and foul-smelling.

"Reshi," said Bast. His voice was very small. "Reshi, look."

I looked up.

The mouth of the cave was full of them.

\* \* \*

I do not know how many there were. Dozens. Maybe a hundred. They filled the mouth of the cave and spilled out onto the mountainside beyond, black and gleaming in the grey light, their legs clicking and tapping on the stone. They were not moving. Not yet. They were waiting. As if the first one had been a scout, and they were waiting to see what had happened to it.

I had one bread knife. One belt buckle. A handful of boot nails.

I could not kill them all. I could not kill even a few of them. They would pour into the cave like water and cut us to pieces, and there

would be nothing I could do.

Behind me, Bast was pressed against the back wall. I could hear him breathing, fast and shallow.

"Reshi," he whispered. "I can do something. Maybe. I think."

"What?"

"A glamour. A seeming. I can make us look like—like nothing. Like stone. Like part of the wall." His voice was shaking. "They don't have eyes. I don't know if it'll work on something with no eyes. But I can try."

"Try."

I heard him take a breath. I heard him begin to murmur, very softly, in a language I did not know. It was not the Sithe's liquid tongue, or the old language of names. It was something else. Something light and quick and sly, like a fox moving through tall grass.

And I felt the air change around us. Felt it thicken, and shimmer, and fold. Felt the edges of things blur and soften. I looked down at my own hand, holding the knife, and I could not quite see it. It was there, but it was hard to look at. Like trying to see something at the corner of your eye.

The scrael at the mouth of the cave shifted. Their legs tapped on the stone. They seemed—uncertain. As if they had been following something, and it had suddenly disappeared.

They came in anyway.

\* \* \*

They came in slowly, this time. Carefully. Feeling their way along the floor with their knife-legs, tapping and clicking. They could not see us. Bast's glamour was working, or partly working. But they could feel us. Could sense us somehow, the warmth of us, the life.

They were spreading out. Filling the cave. Moving toward the back wall, where we crouched.

I held my breath. I held the knife. I held Fela's stone in my cold dead hand, so tight that its edge cut into my palm, though I could not feel it.

No, the stone said. No. No. No.  
And suddenly, I understood.

\* \* \*

I have told you that I learned to hear stone in the round room at the top of the Rookery. That I heard it saying no, its long slow patient no, and that beneath it, far below, I heard something else. Something hungry.

I had heard that hungry thing again, in the Chamber of Watches, behind the door. I had felt it in the Cellarage, in the Sleeper's dreams. I had felt it in the Lackless box, humming its no to a door.

And I felt it now. Here. In the scrael.

They were not natural. They were not animals, or Fae, or anything else that had a name. They were *made*. Shaped. Twisted out of nothing by someone who wanted things that would kill.

They were the Thief's.

I do not know how I knew. But I knew. The way you know your mother's voice. They had the same hunger in them that I had heard behind the door. The same wrongness. They were things the Thief had made, long ago, before the war. Or things that had come through from behind the door, slipping through the cracks, the way water seeps through a wall.

And they were afraid of stone.

Not iron. Iron hurt them, but it did not frighten them. Stone frightened them. Because stone said no. And they were made of yes. Of wanting. Of hunger. Of change. Everything they were was the opposite of stone.

I opened my mouth. And I began to hum.

\* \* \*

I hummed the stone's no. The long slow patient no that I had learned in the round room and sung to the Sleeper and whispered to the king's hair. I hummed it into the cave, into the mountain, into the great grey bones of the Stormwal all around us.

And the mountain heard me.

I felt it. Felt the stone of the cave walls wake up, slowly, the way stone does everything. Felt it hear my hum and recognize it. Felt it answer.

*No*, said the mountain.

It was not a sound. It was a vibration. Deep and low, rising up out of the cave floor, out of the walls, out of the ceiling. It was the voice of the Stormwal itself, the great grey wall of stone that had stood there since before the world had a name, saying its long slow patient *no* to everything that was not stone.

The scrael froze.

All of them, at once. Their legs stopped moving. Their shells trembled. The clicking and tapping stopped, and there was only the vibration, the mountain's voice, rising up through the stone and filling the cave.

*No*, said the mountain. *No. No. No.*

The scrael began to shriek.

It was the most terrible sound I have ever heard. A hundred high thin grinding voices, all screaming at once. They reared back, their legs flailing. They scrabbled at the stone floor, trying to get away from it. Trying to get away from the voice.

And they fled.

They poured out of the cave like water from a broken jar. They tumbled over each other in their haste, shrieking, clicking, scrabbling. They went out through the mouth of the cave and down the mountainside, into the grey dark, into the snow, and they did not come back.

\* \* \*

I stopped humming. The mountain's voice faded, slowly, sinking back into the stone the way water sinks into sand.

The cave was silent. Empty. Except for the one dead scrael lying on the floor, and Bast and me pressed against the back wall.

Bast's glamour flickered and went out. He slumped against me, exhausted.

"What," he said. His voice was a thread. "What was that?"



"Stone," I said. My own voice was not much better. "I asked the mountain to say no."

He stared at me in the grey dark. Then he began to laugh. Weakly, helplessly, with his head against my shoulder and tears running down his face.

"You asked the *mountain*," he said. "You asked the mountain to say no. And it *did*."

"Mountains are very reasonable," I said. "If you ask them properly."

He laughed harder. I held him while he laughed. And after a while, I found that I was laughing too.

We did not sleep that night. But we did not die, either. And in the morning, when the grey light came, the snow had stopped, and the sky was clear and blue and very cold, and the silver string on my wrist was pointing up toward the high pass between the peaks.

We followed it.

## Chapter Eighty-Eight

# The Piper in the Ice

On the first day after the storm, following the silver string up toward the high pass, we found a man frozen in the ice.

Bast saw him first. We were crossing a long, steep field of old blue ice below a cliff, roped together, with our boots bound in strips of blanket to keep them from slipping. The wind had dropped. The sky was hard and clear and very blue, and the light off the ice was so bright it hurt to look at, so that I was walking with my eyes half closed, watching the rope ahead of me and nothing else.

Bast stopped. The rope went slack.

"Reshi," he said. His voice was strange. "Look down."

I looked down.

\* \* \*

He was lying about three feet beneath the surface, on his back, with his arms folded across his chest. The ice was so clear above him that he might have been lying under glass. I could see every detail of him. The weave of his clothes. The stitching on his boots. The small white scar on his chin.

He was young. Younger than I had thought, at first glance. Twenty, perhaps. Twenty-two. He had a narrow, clever face and dark hair cut short, and his eyes were closed, and he did not look dead. He looked as if he had lain down on the ice for a moment to rest, and fallen asleep, and would wake in a moment and sit up and brush the frost off his coat and go on his way.

He was wearing clothes I did not recognize. A long coat, cut in a fashion I had never seen, of some dark cloth that had kept its color under the ice. Blue so deep it was almost black. There were patterns stitched along the hem and the cuffs, in silver thread. Circles, and lines, and small angular shapes that were almost letters. And in his folded hands, held against his chest, there was a pipe.

Not a smoking pipe. A musical pipe. A long slender flute of pale bone, with seven holes along its length.

"How long has he been here?" I said. My voice sounded very small in the bright silence.

Bast did not answer at once. He was crouching on the ice, looking down, with an expression on his face I had never seen before. Something between grief and awe.

"A long time," he said at last. "A very long time, Reshi. Look at his coat. Look at the stitching." He touched the ice above the dead man's hem with one fingertip. "Those are namer's marks. The old kind. From before the war." He looked up at me. "He's from Tariniel."

\* \* \*

We did not move for a long time. The sun climbed. The light on the ice grew brighter.

"The war," I said. "The Creation War. That was—"

"Thousands of years ago." Bast looked down at the man in the ice. "Yes."

"He can't have been here that long. He'd have—the ice would have—"

"The Stormwal keeps things," said Bast. "That's what it's for. That's why they built the white city here, in the first place. Because the mountains remember. Nothing rots, up here. Nothing changes." He was quiet for a moment. "My mother told me that. When I was very small. She said that if you climbed high enough into the Stormwal, you could find things from the beginning of the world. Lying in the ice. Waiting." He looked at the dead man's face. "I thought it was a story."

I knelt down on the ice beside him. I looked at the young man's face. At the small white scar on his chin, and the long clever fingers

folded around the bone flute.

"He was a musician," I said.

"He was a namer," said Bast. "They were the same thing, then. Or nearly. Before the war, the singers and the namers were one people. They called things by singing to them. The pipe was how he spoke." He was quiet. "My mother said the pipers of Tariniel could play the name of the wind so sweetly that it would come and lie down at their feet like a dog."

\* \* \*

"What happened to him?"

Bast did not answer. He was looking at the dead man's chest, where his hands were folded. At the bone flute.

I looked too. And I saw what Bast had seen.

There was a crack in the flute. A long thin crack, running down its whole length, from the mouthpiece to the last hole. And the dead man's hands were not just folded over it. They were clenched. The knuckles white, even after all that time. Holding the broken flute together.

"He was running," said Bast quietly. "From the city. When it fell. When Lanre came, and the city burned, and the people ran up into the mountains." He looked up at the cliff above us, at the notch of the high pass beyond it. "He was running this way. Toward the pass. And something caught him. Or the cold caught him. Or he just got tired." He looked back down. "And he lay down here, on the ice. And he held his flute together. And he died."

"Why hold it together? If it was broken?"

Bast was quiet for a long moment.

"Because it was his name," he said. "Or part of it. The pipers put a piece of their name into their pipes. Like the Adem put a piece of theirs into their swords. And if the pipe broke—" He stopped.

"Then the name broke."

"Yes."

I looked at the young man's face. Peaceful, and clever, and very young. With his broken name held together in his hands.

\* \* \*

I thought, then, of many things. I thought of my mother, who had wrapped her name inside another name so that the door could not find her. I thought of Elodin, who had tried to change his name at seventeen and broken himself for three years. I thought of Denna, with a cord around her wrist, and the things her patron had taught her to tie.

I thought of a stone in my pocket that said no.

And I thought: *this is what happens. This is what happens to namers when the world ends. They run, and they hold their names together as long as they can, and then they lie down in the ice.*

I did not know, then, that I would be one of them. That I would lie down, in my own way, in my own ice, for seven years. With my name held together in a box.

I did not know. But something in me did, I think. Because I found that I was crying, kneeling on the ice above that young man from the beginning of the world. And I did not know why.

\* \* \*

Bast let me cry. He did not say anything. He crouched beside me on the ice with his hand on my shoulder, and waited.

When I was done, I wiped my face and looked up at him.

"We should do something," I said. "For him. We can't just leave him here."

"We can't dig him out," said Bast. "The ice is too hard. And even if we could—" He hesitated. "He's been here since the beginning, Reshi. This is his grave. The mountains made it for him. It wouldn't be right to take him out of it."

"Then what?"

Bast looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at the lute on my back.

"You could play for him," he said.

\* \* \*

I took out my lute. My fingers were stiff with cold; I had to blow on them for a long time before they would move. The strings were stiff too, and out of tune from the storm, and I spent a long time tuning them, kneeling on the ice with the sun burning on my back and the wind very soft and very cold around my ears.

Then I played.

I did not play a song. I did not know any songs from Tariniel. Nobody did; they had all been lost when the city fell, the way the city had been lost, the way the young man in the ice had been lost. So I did not play a song. I played what I heard.

I listened to the ice. I listened to the wind, very soft, moving across the bright blue field. I listened to the cliff above us and the pass beyond it and the great white silence of the mountains all around. And I listened, very hard, to the young man in the ice. To his clever face and his dark coat with the silver stitching and his broken flute. And I tried to hear what he would have played. If he had reached the pass. If he had lived.

I do not know what I played. I cannot remember it now. I have tried, many times, and it does not come. It was not a song that was meant to be remembered. It was meant to be played once, on that ice, for that man, and then let go.

But I remember that Bast wept while I played. And I remember that when I finished, and the last note faded out into the enormous white silence, there was a sound from the ice.

\* \* \*

It was very small. A single clear note, high and sweet, like a bird calling once at dawn. It came from beneath the ice. From the place where the young man lay, with his broken flute in his hands.

Bast and I looked at each other.

"Did you—" I said.

"Yes," said Bast. His face was wet. "Yes, Reshi."

We looked down. The young man lay just as he had lain. His eyes closed, his hands folded, his broken flute held against his chest. Nothing had changed.

But the crack in the flute was gone.

I do not know how. I did not do it. I am as sure of that as I am of anything. I did not call the name of the flute, or the ice, or the young man. I only played what I heard.

But the flute lay whole in his hands. Pale and smooth and unbroken, from the mouthpiece to the last hole. And his hands, which had been clenched so tightly, were loose now. Resting on it gently. The way you rest your hands on something you love, when you are no longer afraid of losing it.

\* \* \*

We did not speak for a long time. Then Bast stood up and coiled the rope, and I put my lute away, and we went on across the ice toward the cliff, and the pass beyond it.

At the edge of the ice field, I looked back. The sun was very bright on the blue ice. I could not see the young man anymore. The glare hid him.

"Bast," I said. "What do you think it means?"

He did not answer for a while. He was looking back too.

"I think," he said slowly, "that he was holding his name together for a very long time. All by himself. Since the beginning of the world." He was quiet. "And I think he didn't have to anymore. Because someone came and heard him."

"That's all?"

"That's everything, Reshi." Bast turned away from the ice and looked up at the pass. "That's all anybody wants. Mortal or Fae or namer from the beginning of the world. For someone to come, and hear them. And let them put it down."

\* \* \*

I thought about that, later. Many times.

I thought about it when a woman with dark hair tied my name into a cord and put it in a box. I thought about it through seven grey years behind a bar, holding myself together, alone, with nothing in my hands.

And I thought about it when a scribe came up the road with his bloody knuckles and his satchel full of paper, and sat down at my table, and asked me to tell him the story. And listened.

Someone came, and heard. And let me put it down.

That's everything.



## Chapter Eighty-Nine

# Myr Tariniel

We came over the high pass at noon on the second day, and I saw the white city.

I had been imagining it for years. Ever since I was twelve years old, sitting on the floor of the Half-Mast in Tarbean, listening to Skarpi tell the story of Lanre. I had imagined it the way you imagine any place in a story: bright and clean and beautiful, a city of white towers rising against a blue sky. I had sung it into being in the Eolian. I had made hundreds of people see it with me.

I had not imagined this.

\* \* \*

The pass opened out onto a great bowl in the mountains. A valley, high and wide and bare, surrounded on every side by peaks so tall and so white they seemed to hold up the sky. The floor of the valley was flat and smooth and covered in snow, dazzling white under the clear blue sky.

And in the center of the valley, there was a city.

Or there had been. Once. A very long time ago.

It was white. That much the stories had right. White stone, all of it, so white that it hurt the eyes to look at it in the sunlight. But it was not towers. It was not gardens and fountains and great halls. It was ruins. Great tumbled heaps of white stone, scattered across the valley floor like the bones of some enormous creature. Broken walls, standing alone, with nothing on either side of them. Fallen columns,

lying in the snow like felled trees. Arches with nothing above them. Stairs that led up into empty air.

It was huge. Far bigger than I had imagined. The ruins stretched across the whole valley floor, a mile or more in every direction. There must have been a hundred thousand people living there once. More. It must have been the greatest city in the world.

And it was dead. Utterly, completely dead. Nothing moved there. Nothing lived. The snow lay deep and smooth and unbroken over everything, and the wind moaned softly through the broken arches, and the sun glared down on the white stone, and there was no other sound at all.

I stood at the top of the pass and looked at it, and I could not speak.

Beside me, Bast stood very still. His face was pale. His deep blue eyes were very wide.

"Is that it?" he whispered. "The white city? From your song?"

"Yes."

"It's—" He stopped. He did not seem to know what it was.

"Yes," I said. "It is."

\* \* \*

We went down into the valley. The silver string led us, floating ahead of us over the snow, pointing toward the center of the ruins. We followed it.

It was a long walk. The snow was deep, and the ruins were vast, and we had to pick our way around great heaps of fallen stone and through narrow gaps between broken walls. The wind was softer here, in the valley, sheltered by the peaks. But it was still very cold. And the silence was very deep.

I did not speak. Neither did Bast. It did not seem right, somehow, to speak in that place. It was like speaking in a graveyard. Or a church.

We passed things as we walked. Things I will never forget.

A fountain. Or what had been a fountain. A great round basin of white stone, half buried in snow, with a broken column rising from its center. There were carvings on the rim of the basin, worn almost

smooth by the wind and the years. Children. Carved children, holding hands, dancing around the edge of the fountain in a ring.

I stopped beside it. I brushed the snow off the rim with my good hand and looked at the carved children for a long time.

*I was one of the children playing in the fountains, Skarpi had said. I was the only one who lived.*

I wondered if this was the one. I wondered if he had hidden here, under a slab of white marble, listening to his city burn.

I did not know. I would never know. There were so many fountains.

\* \* \*

A great hall. Its walls still stood, most of them, though its roof was long gone. Its floor was a smooth expanse of snow, and at the far end, there was a raised platform of white stone. A stage. There were steps leading up to it, worn in the center by the passage of many feet.

*She sang in the great hall of the city, Skarpi had said. And people came from all over the world to hear her.*

I climbed the steps. I stood on the stage and looked out over the snow-covered floor, the broken walls, the empty sky. I tried to imagine it full of people. Full of music. Full of a woman's voice, rising like a bird.

I could not. It was too empty. Too cold. Too dead.

Bast stood at the foot of the steps, looking up at me. He did not say anything. But after a while, he held out his hand.

I came down the steps and took it, and we walked on.

\* \* \*

The silver string led us to the center of the ruins. To a great open space, a plaza, surrounded on every side by broken walls and fallen columns. The snow here was smooth and unbroken, except for a single line of footprints leading from one side of the plaza to the other.

Footprints. In the snow. Fresh ones.

I stopped. I stared at them.

They were a man's footprints. Large and deep, made by heavy boots. They came from the east side of the plaza, where a great arch still stood, and they crossed the smooth snow in a straight line, and they led to the west side, where there was a building.

It was the only building in the whole city that still stood whole. A small round tower of white stone, not very tall, with a domed roof and a single door. There was smoke coming out of a chimney in the roof. A thin grey thread of it, rising straight up into the clear blue sky.

And in the doorway, there was a man.

\* \* \*

He was very tall. Taller than any man I had ever seen, taller even than the Sithe. He stood in the doorway of the round tower with one hand resting on the frame, and he looked across the plaza at us.

He was old. That was the first thing I noticed, even from so far away. Not old like Bredon, weathered and worn. Old like the mountains. Old like the stone of the ruined city around him. His hair was white, and long, and fell over his shoulders like snow. His beard was white too, long and full, reaching almost to his waist. His face was lined and hard and very still.

He wore a long robe of grey wool, plain and heavy, belted with a cord. His feet were bare, in the snow.

And he had one eye.

The other was a stone.

I could see it from across the plaza, glinting in the sunlight. A smooth round stone, grey and polished, set into the socket where his left eye should have been. It caught the light and threw it back, like a mirror.

The silver string on my wrist went slack. It fell to the snow at my feet, and lay there, and did not rise again.

We had arrived.

\* \* \*

The man in the doorway did not move. He stood there with his hand on the frame, looking at us. His one good eye was grey, like the stone. It

was very steady.

Then he spoke.

His voice was deep and slow and very quiet. It carried across the plaza without effort, the way a voice carries across still water.

"Singer," he said. "You have come a long way."

I could not answer. My throat had closed up. I stood in the snow at the edge of the plaza, with Bast beside me and the silver string lying dead at my feet, and I stared at him.

"Come," he said. "Come in out of the cold. There is a fire, and tea. And a great deal to talk about."

He turned and went back into the tower. The door stayed open behind him.

Bast was clutching my arm. His fingers were digging into me so hard it hurt.

"Reshi," he whispered. "Reshi, is that—"

"Yes," I said.

My voice sounded very far away.

"That's Selitos."

## Chapter Ninety

# Selitos

The inside of the tower was warm.

That was the first thing I noticed, stepping through the door out of the glare and the cold. Warm and dim and smelling of woodsmoke and herbs and old paper. There was a fire burning in a round hearth in the center of the room, with a copper kettle hanging over it on an iron chain. There were shelves around the walls, curving with the curve of the tower, and they were full of books. Hundreds of them. Thousands. Old books, bound in leather and wood and things I did not recognize, their spines cracked and faded.

There was a table beside the fire, and three chairs. Three. As if he had known how many of us there would be, counting himself.

Selitos was standing at the hearth with his back to us, taking the kettle off its chain. He did not turn around as we came in.

"Sit," he said. "The tea is nearly ready."

We sat. I do not remember doing it. I remember only that one moment I was standing in the doorway, and the next I was sitting in a chair beside the fire with Bast in the chair beside me, and Selitos was setting three cups of tea on the table in front of us.

He sat down in the third chair. He looked at me.

Up close, his face was even older than it had seemed from across the plaza. The lines in it were so deep they looked carved. His skin was brown and weathered, like old leather. His beard was white and long and smelled faintly of smoke. And his eye—his one good eye—was grey and clear and very sharp.

The other eye, the stone, was worse up close. It was smooth and round and grey, polished like a river stone, set into the socket so perfectly that it seemed to have grown there. It caught the firelight and threw it back. And I had the strangest feeling, looking at it, that it was looking at me too. Not the way an eye looks. Some other way. Deeper.

"Drink," said Selitos. "You are cold."

I drank. The tea was hot and strong and tasted of pine needles and honey. It went down into me like fire, and I felt the warmth of it spread out through my chest and into my arms and legs. Even into my cold dead hand, a little.

Beside me, Bast was holding his cup in both hands and staring at Selitos over the rim of it with enormous eyes.

\* \* \*

"You know who I am," said Selitos.

"Yes," I said.

"And you know why you have come."

"I think so."

"Tell me."

I told him. It came out of me the way it had come out for the Sithe, all in a rush, as if it had been waiting behind a dam. The Archives and the door. The line and the key. Bredon and Ambrose and Denna. The Eolian and the song and Haliar. The war, and Meluan, and the box in Ambrose's tent.

He listened without moving. His one good eye stayed on my face. The stone eye glinted in the firelight. When I was done, he was silent for a long time.

"You sang the song," he said at last. "The true one. In a great hall, before many people."

"Yes."

"And you put in the child."

I stared at him. "How do you know that?"

"Because I heard it." He touched the stone in his eye socket, very lightly, with one long finger. "This does not see the world, as my other eye does. It sees names. True things. And when a true thing is spoken,

anywhere in the world, loudly enough—" He paused. "I hear it. The way you hear a bell ringing in a distant town."

"You heard the song. From here."

"I heard it. From here." His voice was very quiet. "I heard the white city on the last day of its life. I heard Lyra. I heard Lanre. I heard myself, weeping among the ruins." He was silent for a moment. "And I heard the child. The boy in the fountain. Asking to be a singer." He looked at me. "No one has ever put in the child. Not in all these years. Not in all the songs."

"Skarpi told me."

"Yes. I thought he might have." Something moved in Selitos's face. It was very small. It might have been a smile. "He was always a good boy. A little too fond of taverns, perhaps. But a good boy."

\* \* \*

He asked me to sing it.

Not all of it. Just the end. The last verse. The one about the child.

I did not want to. My throat was still raw from the cold, and my left hand was still stiff, and I was more tired than I had ever been in my life. But I could not refuse him. I do not think anyone could.

So I took out my lute, and I tuned it with my stiff cold fingers, and I sang it. There, in the round tower at the center of the ruins of Myr Tariniel, before the man who had dug the child out of the rubble with his own hands.

When I finished, Selitos was very still. His one good eye was closed. There was a single tear on his cheek, running down into his white beard.

The stone eye was open. It was looking at me.

"Thank you," said Selitos, without opening his good eye. "Thank you, singer."

\* \* \*

We sat by the fire for a long time after that. Selitos did not speak. Neither did I. Bast sat very still in his chair, holding his cup of tea, which had long since gone cold.



At last Selitos opened his eye.

"You have come to ask me how to close the door," he said. "For good. So that no one can ever open it again."

"Yes."

"And you think I know."

"You made it."

"I did." He nodded slowly. "I made it. And the key. And the line." He looked into the fire. "I made a great many things, in those days. After the war. When everything was broken, and someone had to put it back together." He was silent for a moment. "Some of them I would unmake, if I could."

"Can you?"

"No." He shook his head. "I am very old, singer. Older than anything you have ever met, except perhaps the thing behind the door. And the Tree. And one or two others." He smiled faintly. "My power is not what it was. I could not unmake the door now if I wanted to. I could not even reach it. It is very far from here, and I cannot leave this valley."

"Why not?"

He looked at me with his one good eye. "Because I am keeping watch," he said. "Over this place. Over the ruins of the city Lanre burned. I promised, that night, among the ashes. I promised I would stay here and remember. So that someone would." He was quiet for a moment. "I have kept that promise for a very long time."

"Alone?"

"Mostly." He glanced at Bast. "Sometimes the Fae come. Sometimes mortals. Very rarely. The mountains are not kind to visitors." He looked back at me. "You are the first in nearly three hundred years."

\* \* \*

"Tell me about the door," I said. "Please. Tell me how it works."

Selitos looked at me for a long time. Then he set down his cup, and folded his long hands on the table in front of him.

"The door," he said, "is a name."

I waited.

"All doors are names. You know that, I think. You have heard stone. You know that everything that is, is its name, and that to know a thing's name is to know what it is." He looked at me. "The doors of stone are names too. Seven of them. Seven names, spoken into seven stones, in seven places. And together they make a single name. A very long one. A very old one. The name of the prison."

"And the keeper's door?"

"The keeper's door is different." Selitos was quiet for a moment. "When I made it, I spoke its name into the stone, as I did with the others. But I did something else, too. I wove another name into it. A second name, braided through the first, like two threads in a cord." He looked at me. "The name of the line."

I sat very still.

"The line of the Thief's daughter," said Selitos. "Loeclos, and Lockless, and Lackless. I took the name of that line—not the name of any one person in it, but the name of the line itself, the thing that runs through all of them like a river through a valley—and I wove it into the door. So that the door and the line would be bound together. So that the door would know them, and they would know the door."

"So that only they could open it."

"So that only they could open it. And so that only they could *keep* it." He paused. "A door must be tended. It must be watched. It must be checked, from time to time, to make sure it holds. And the only ones who could do that were the ones the door would answer to."

"And the key?"

Selitos was silent for a long time. Then he raised his hand, and touched the stone in his eye socket.

"This," he said.

\* \* \*

I stared at him.

"When Lanre burned the city," said Selitos quietly, "and I stood among the ruins and cursed him, I took up a stone. A shard of stone from the city's heart, the great white stone at the center of the plaza,

the one that had held the name of Myr Tariniel since it was founded. And I put out my own eye with it."

"I know."

"Do you know why?"

"So you would never be deceived again. So you could see true."

"That is what the stories say. And it is true, in its way." He lowered his hand. "But there was another reason. I did not know it at the time. I only knew that I needed to do it. That I needed to take something from myself, to pay for what I had done. For the curse." He was quiet for a moment. "Later, I understood. When I made the doors. When I made the key."

"The stone," I said slowly. "You split it."

"I split it." He nodded. "One half I kept, here, in my eye. So that I could see. So that I would always know what the key was doing, where it was, whose hands held it. The other half I put into a box with no lid and no lock, and I gave it to the Thief's daughter, and I told her to keep it forever."

"The key of stone."

"The key of stone. Half of my own eye. Half of the heart of Myr Tariniel." Selitos looked at me. "It knows the door, because I made the door. It knows the curse, because I spoke the curse with it in my hand. It knows me, and it knows Lanre, and it knows the line." He paused. "It is the most dangerous thing in the world, singer. And it is in the hands of a boy king who does not know what it is."

\* \* \*

"You've been watching it," I said. "Through your eye. You've seen where it went."

"I have seen." His voice was very quiet. "I saw it in the Lackless house, for a thousand years, passed from hand to hand, from mother to daughter. I saw it in the hands of a frightened woman in a green room, who slept with it under her pillow." He looked at me. "I saw it in your hands. For one night. And then in a girl's hands, riding through the dark. And then in an old man's hands. And then in a boy king's tent."

"You saw all of that."

"I saw all of that." He was silent for a moment. "And I could do nothing. I cannot leave this valley. I cannot reach the key. I can only watch." His one good eye was very steady. "I have watched the old man for a very long time, singer. The one you call Bredon. I watched him take the Amyr apart, one by one, over centuries. I watched him cut the truth from the world's books. I watched him move his pieces toward the door." He looked at me. "I knew his name, once. Before. When he was young, and one of mine."

My heart stopped.

"One of *yours*?"

"He was Amyr," said Selitos. "One of the first. One of the finest. I gave him his tattoo with my own hands." He looked into the fire. "He was the one who carried the Book of Watches down to the Chamber, beneath the place that became your Archives. He was the first to keep that watch."

"And then?"

"And then he sat in that chamber, alone, in the dark, beside the door. For years. Listening to the breathing on the other side." Selitos's voice was very soft. "And one day, the thing behind the door spoke to him. And he answered."

\* \* \*

The fire crackled. Outside, the wind moaned softly through the ruins.

"He was the Knife," I said. "The one in the last page of the Book of Watches. *He comes as a friend. He comes as a teacher.*"

"He was the Knife." Selitos nodded. "He cut his own order apart, from the inside. He knew where they all were, and what they knew, and how to find them. He gave them to the Seven. One by one." He looked at me. "The last of them wrote that page, in the Chamber of Watches, the night before he came for her. She knew he was coming. She wrote the warning so that someone, someday, would know."

"Devi found it."

"Yes. I saw that too." A very faint smile. "She is a clever girl. Too clever for her own good. Like you."

I sat very still with my cold hands wrapped around my cup. I thought about Bredon. About his kind grandfather's face, and his flat cold eyes. About the tak board in the garden, and the shape of the door built along its edges.

"What's his name?" I asked. "His true name. Before he was Bredon."

Selitos looked at me for a long time.

"I will not tell you that," he said.

"Why not?"

"Because a name is a weapon, singer. And you are angry. And angry men should not be given weapons." He picked up his cup. "Besides. You do not need his name to stop him. You need something else entirely."

"What?"

Selitos looked at me over the rim of his cup. His one good eye was grey and clear and very old. The stone eye glinted in the firelight.

"You need to give up your own," he said.

## Chapter Ninety-One

# The Price of a Lock

I did not say anything for a long time.

I sat in the round tower at the center of the dead white city, with a cup of cold tea in my hands and the fire crackling in the hearth, and I looked at the oldest man in the world, and I did not say anything at all.

Beside me, Bast had gone very still.

"Explain," I said at last. My voice was very quiet.

Selitos set down his cup. He folded his long hands on the table.

"The keeper's door," he said, "is two names braided together. The name of the door, and the name of the line. That is what makes it open to the line. That is what makes it dangerous." He looked at me. "If you could take the name of the line out of the door—unbraid it—then the door would be only a door. A name of stone, like the other six. It would answer to no one. No key could open it. No blood. No voice."

"Then how—"

"Only the line can unbraid it." Selitos's voice was very steady. "Only one of the line, standing before the door, with the key in hand, speaking the door's name. Not to open it. To *un*-speak their own part of it. To take the name of the line back out of the stone." He paused. "And to do that, they must give it up. Their share of it. The part of the line's name that lives in them."

"Their own name."

"Their own name. Or the part of it that is the line. Which, in a namer of the line—in someone like you—is most of it." He looked at me. "You would have to take your name out of yourself, singer. And

leave it with the door. Or somewhere else. Somewhere away from you. And you would have to never pick it up again."

\* \* \*

The fire crackled. The wind moaned in the ruins outside.

"What would happen to me?" I asked.

Selitos was silent for a long time.

"You would be less," he said at last. "Not empty. Not dead. But less. You would be a man without a name. You would walk and speak and eat and sleep. You would remember things, some of them. But you would not be *you*. Not really. You would be the shape of a man, walking around a hole."

"Could I name?"

"No. Naming comes from the name. Without it—" He shook his head. "No naming. No sympathy, probably, or very little. Sympathy needs the Alar, and the Alar needs a self to hold it. No music, perhaps. Or music without the fire in it." He looked at me with his one good eye. "You would be ordinary, singer. The most ordinary man in the world. That is the price."

I looked down at my hands. At my good right hand, and my cold left one, with the white print of Cinder's fingers on the wrist.

"And the door?"

"The door would be locked. Forever. Or as close to forever as anything is." He paused. "Unless someone spoke your name again. At the door. With the key in hand."

I looked up.

"The name does not vanish," said Selitos. "Names cannot be destroyed. Not true ones. They can only be set down. Put somewhere. Kept." He leaned forward. "If you gave up your name at the door, it would have to go somewhere. And wherever it went, it would still be the key. The last key. The only key. If anyone ever found it, and carried it to the door, and spoke it there, with the stone in their hand—the door would open. And there would be no line left to close it again."

"So the name has to be hidden."

"The name has to be hidden. Kept. Held. By someone you trust, in something that will hold, somewhere no one would ever think to look." Selitos's voice was very quiet. "And you would have to live the rest of your life without it. Knowing that it was out there. Knowing that if anyone ever found it, everything you gave up would be for nothing."

\* \* \*

"Can it be done?" I asked. "Has anyone ever done it?"

Selitos looked at me for a long time.

"Once," he said.

"Who?"

"Your mother."

\* \* \*

I did not move. I could not.

"Not all the way," said Selitos quietly. "She did not go to the door. She did not have the key; her father still kept it then, and after him, her sister. She could not have unbraided the line from the stone." He paused. "But she knew enough. From her family. From the old stories. From—" He hesitated. "From the man you call Bredon, who told her too much when she was a girl, because he thought she would be useful."

"What did she do?"

"She changed her name." Selitos looked into the fire. "Not the name she was called by, though she changed that too. Netalia to Laurian. She changed the other one. The deep one. She could not take the line out of it. But she could hide it. Bury it. Wrap it in another name, like a stone wrapped in cloth, so that the door would not know her. So that the line would not answer." He was silent for a moment. "It is why they could not find her, for so long. It is why she could hide among the Ruh for twelve years. The door could not feel her. The key could not feel her. She had made herself into someone else."

"And me?"



"And you were born to someone else," said Selitos. "To Laurian, not to Netalia. Your name was shaped in her, and she had wrapped her own name so well that yours grew up wrapped too. Hidden. Quiet." He looked at me. "That is why they did not find you, either, until it was too late. Until you were already born and already grown and already singing."

"Then how did they find us? At the end?"

Selitos looked at me with his one good eye. It was very sad.

"Your father's song," he said. "It was very good. Very true. And when a true song is sung, it rings out like a bell. It is heard." He paused. "They did not find your mother. They found the song. And your mother was singing it."

\* \* \*

I got up from the table. I did not mean to. I simply found myself on my feet, and then walking, and then standing at the narrow window of the tower, looking out at the ruins of the white city.

The sun was going down behind the peaks. The white stone was turning gold, then red, then the color of old blood. The shadows of the broken walls stretched out long across the snow.

Behind me, I heard Selitos's chair scrape. I heard his bare feet on the stone floor, coming toward me. He stopped beside me at the window.

"I am sorry," he said.

"You didn't kill them."

"No. But I made the door, and the line, and the key. I made the curse. I made the Amyr, and the Singers, and all the rest of it." He looked out at the ruins. "Everything that happened to your family happened because of things I did, a very long time ago. Things I thought were right." He was silent for a moment. "I have had a long time to think about whether they were."

"And?"

"And I still do not know." He smiled faintly. "That is the curse of a long life, singer. You never stop doubting."

\* \* \*

We stood at the window for a long time, watching the sun go down.

"Selitos," I said at last. "If I do it. If I lock the door forever. What happens to Lanre?"

He did not answer right away.

"He goes on," he said at last. "As he is. Forever. Cursed. Remembering. Unable to die." He was quiet for a moment. "He wants the door opened so that the Thief will unmake him. If the door can never be opened, he can never be unmade. He will walk the world until the world ends. And then, perhaps, a little while after."

"That's cruel."

"Yes."

"You made it that way."

"I did." Selitos looked at me. "I told you. I have had a long time to doubt."

"Is there no other way? To end the curse? Without opening the door?"

Selitos was silent for a very long time. The sun sank behind the peaks. The ruins went grey, then blue, then dark.

"There is a way," he said at last. "Perhaps. There is always a way, with names. But I do not know it. I have looked, for a very long time. I have read every book in this tower, and every book in every other place I could reach. I have not found it." He looked at me. "Perhaps you will. Someday. You are cleverer than I was, at your age. And you have something I never had."

"What?"

"A voice," said Selitos. "The song you sang. It did something I never could. It made him *remember*. Not just the pain. All of it. Lyra's name, in a voice that did not lie." He was quiet for a moment. "A curse is a name spoken in anger. Perhaps it can be answered by a name spoken in—something else."

"In what?"

He smiled. It was a very old smile, and very tired, and very sad.

"If I knew that," he said, "I would not still be here."

That night I did not sleep. I sat by the fire in the round tower with my lute in my lap and did not play it. Bast slept in a chair beside me, curled up with his hooves tucked under him. Selitos sat across the fire in his own chair, with his one good eye closed and his stone eye open, glinting in the firelight. I did not know if he was sleeping. I did not know if he ever slept.

I thought about what he had told me.

*You would have to give up your name. Leave it somewhere. Never pick it up again.*

*You would be the shape of a man, walking around a hole.*

*You would need someone to hold it for you. Someone you trust. In something that will hold.*

I thought about Elodin, standing at the gate of Haven with his forehead against the bars. *A name can be put down. It's very rare. Very difficult.*

I thought about the Cthaeh, whispering in the dark. *When you set down your name, who will you trust to hold it?*

I thought about my mother. Wrapping her name in another name, like a stone wrapped in cloth. Hiding among the Ruh for twelve years. Singing my father's song.

I took out Denna's knot. The one from the Grey Man. *Road. Promise. A story told many times, and changes in the telling.* And the tiny knot at its heart that held her name.

I held it in my hand for a long time, looking at it in the firelight.

*The girl with the knots*, the Cthaeh had said. *She's the only one who could. The only one in all the world who knows how to tie a name into a cord so that it holds.*

I closed my hand around it.

And across the fire, very quietly, Selitos said, "Yes."

I looked up. His one good eye was open. He was looking at me.

"Yes," he said again. "That would work. If she were willing. If she could do it." He was silent for a moment. "If you could bear to let her."

"How did you—"

"I see names, singer." He touched his stone eye. "And yours is very loud tonight. It has been thinking."

I looked down at the knot in my hand.

"Is it the Cthae'h's path?" I asked. "If I do this? If I give my name to her? Is it what it wants?"

"I do not know," said Selitos. "No one knows. That is the nature of the thing." He looked at me with his one good eye. "You will have to choose. And bear what comes after."

"That's what everyone keeps telling me."

"That is because it is true." He closed his eye again. "It is the only truth there is, in the end. Everything else is just a story."

\* \* \*

In the morning, before we left, Selitos gave me the door's name.

Not the name of the keeper's door. The name of one of the others. The one beneath the Archives. The one I had stood before, in the Chamber of Watches, with Devi's hand in mine.

"So that you will know what it sounds like," he said. "A door's name. So that when you stand before the other one, you will recognize it." He looked at me. "Do not speak it. Ever. Not even in a whisper. Just hold it. Let it sit in you. Let it teach you the shape."

He leaned forward and spoke it into my ear.

I will not tell you what it was. I could not, even if I wanted to. It was not a word. It was not even a sound, exactly. It was more like a feeling. A weight. A great slow deep patient *no*, older than any stone I had ever heard, braided through with something else. Something that was not *no*. Something that was almost a *yes*, held tightly, held down, held back.

It was the shape of a prison. The shape of something holding something else, forever, against its will.

I felt it settle into me. Into my bones. Into the part of me where names live.

When I opened my eyes, Selitos was looking at me.

"Now you know," he said.

"Yes."

"Go, then. Go south. The war is waiting. And the door." He paused. "And the girl."

He walked us to the edge of the plaza. At the great arch on the east side, he stopped.

"This is as far as I go," he said. "I cannot leave the city."

"Will I see you again?"

He looked at me with his one good eye. Then he smiled, very faintly.

"Perhaps," he said. "If you ever find the other way. The one that ends the curse without opening the door." He paused. "If you ever find it, come back. And sing it to me. I would like to hear it very much."

He raised one long hand, in something that was almost a blessing.

"Go," he said. "Singer. Key. Kvothe." He paused. "Go and choose."

We went.

When I looked back, from the top of the pass, he was still standing under the great arch at the edge of the plaza, very tall and very still, with the sun on his white hair and his stone eye glinting.

He was watching us go. He watched until we were out of sight.

I think, sometimes, that he is still watching.

## Chapter Ninety-Two

# The Book of Singers

I did not leave Myr Tariniel the morning after Selitos told me the price. I have told it as if I did, because that is the shape the story wants. But the truth is that we stayed three more days in the round white tower at the center of the dead city, and I spent most of them reading.

Selitos did not object. He seemed, if anything, pleased. He moved about the tower in his bare feet, making tea and feeding the fire and sitting for long hours by the narrow window with his one good eye closed and his stone eye open, looking at things I could not see. And every so often he would come and stand beside the table where I sat, among the books, and look down at what I was reading, and say nothing, and go away again.

Bast did not read. Bast went out into the ruins and wandered among them, and came back each evening with his face very still and his eyes very bright, and did not say where he had been or what he had seen. Selitos looked at him, once, on the second evening, for a long time. And then said, very quietly, "Yes. They are still there. Some of them. The ones who would not leave." And Bast nodded, and did not ask anything else, and neither did I.

\* \* \*

The books in the tower were not like the books in the Archives. They were not like the Countess Laverne's books, either, or the Maer's. Most of them were not books at all, in the way I understood the word. Some were scrolls. Some were tablets of clay, or wax, or thin sheets of

beaten silver. Some were cords of knots. Some were things I did not have names for: stones with patterns in them that shifted when you looked at them, and small boxes that hummed when you held them close to your ear.

Selitos had gathered them over ten thousand years. From every corner of a world that had changed its shape a dozen times since he began. He had read them all. More than once. Some of them, he said, he had read so many times that the words had worn off the page, and he read them now from memory.

"Looking for the other way," he said, when I asked him why. "The way to end the curse without opening the door." He smiled faintly. "It's in here somewhere. I'm sure of it. I simply haven't found it yet."

"Ten thousand years."

"Ten thousand years." He shrugged. "I'm very slow. And very stubborn. Like stone."

\* \* \*

On the second day, he brought me a book I had not asked for.

It was very large and very plain, bound in grey leather that had gone soft and pale with age. There was no title on the cover. He set it down on the table in front of me and opened it, and stood back.

It was a list. Names, written in a hundred different hands, in a hundred different inks, in languages I knew and languages I did not. Page after page after page of them. Beside each name, a date. Or what I thought was a date, in some reckoning I did not recognize. And beside the date, a place.

"The Singers," said Selitos quietly. "All of them. Everyone who has ever carried the true song, since the night I dug a boy out of a fountain and asked him what he wanted to be."

I looked down at the list. At the thousands of names.

"And the dates?"

"When they died." Selitos's voice did not change. "And where. And how, when I know it."

I turned the pages. Slowly. The names went on and on. Some of them had notes beside them, in Selitos's small precise hand. *Burned. Frozen. Taken by rot. Found in a well. Found in a field with frost on her eyelashes. Found.*

There were so many. Thousands. Every one of them someone who had learned the true story of Lanre and sung it, somewhere, to someone. Every one of them hunted and found and killed.

"You write them all down," I said.

"Every one." Selitos looked out the narrow window at the ruins. "It is the least I can do. I made the Singers. I sent them out into the world with a song that I knew would get them killed. I told myself it was necessary. For the greater good." His voice was very quiet. "The Amyr say that. *For the greater good.* I taught them to say it." He was silent for a moment. "The least I can do is remember."

\* \* \*

I found my parents on the last page.

I had not known they would be there. I had not known anyone kept such a list. But I turned the last page of the grey book, and there, near the bottom, in Selitos's small precise hand, I found them.

*Arliden. Of the Edema Ruh. A maker of songs.*

*Laurian. Of the Edema Ruh. Born Netalia, of the line. A singer.*

And beside them, a date. And a place. A forest near the edge of the Commonwealth. And a single word.

*Burned.*

And below them, other names. Eleven of them. Trip, and Shandi, and Teren. Marie, who played the fiddle. Old Hetch. Kari, who taught me to whistle through my fingers, and whose sister sat across from me at the Maer's table. All of them. Every person in my father's troupe. Every one.

*Burned. Burned. Burned.*

I sat very still at the table in the round white tower, with the grey book open in front of me, and I did not move for a long time.

\* \* \*



Selitos came and stood beside me. He looked down at the page. He did not say anything.

"You knew," I said at last. My voice sounded very far away. "When I came. You knew who I was."

"I knew." He was quiet for a moment. "I heard your father's song, the night they died. Very faint. Very far. The last true song sung before yours." He looked at the page. "I wrote their names that same night. And I sat by this window until dawn, and I wept, as I weep for all of them."

"There's a space," I said. "Below them. After Kari. Before the bottom of the page."

"Yes."

"Is that for me?"

Selitos looked at me for a long moment with his one good eye.

"It was," he said. "For a long time. I kept it there. I thought you would be the next. The boy who survived the burning, who would grow up and sing the true song and be found." He was quiet. "I have left spaces for many people. Most of them, I have filled."

"But not mine."

"Not yet." He reached down and turned the page. The next was blank. "You sang the whole song, and you lived. You sang it in front of the Seven and the dark one himself, and you lived." His one good eye was very steady. "No Singer has ever done that. Not in ten thousand years."

"They can't kill me. Because I'm the key."

"Yes. That is why." Selitos closed the book. "But it is not the only reason. You live because you choose to keep living, in spite of everything. That is rarer than you think." He laid his long hand on the grey cover. "When you give up your name, at the door, you will not be a Singer anymore. You will not be anything. And I will not have to fill your space."

"Is that a comfort?"

Selitos looked at me.

"No," he said. "But it is true."

\* \* \*

I asked him for a pen, that evening. He gave me one, without asking why. And ink, very old, in a small stone pot.

I opened the grey book to the last page. To my parents, and the eleven names below them, and the space.

And I wrote in the space. Not my own name. Another one.

*Stanchion. Of Imre. Who could not play, and built a room for those who could.*

*Burned. But his walls stood.*

Selitos read it over my shoulder. He was silent for a long time.

"He was not a Singer," he said at last.

"He let one sing," I said. "In his house. Knowing what would come. He stood on the stair between the rot and a girl holding up his walls, and he told a Chandrian she couldn't have them." I set down the pen. "That's a kind of singing."

Selitos looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded, slowly.

"Yes," he said. "Yes. I suppose it is."

He took the pen from my hand. And below Stanchion's name, in his small precise hand, he wrote another.

*Tempi. Of the Adem. Who taught the singer to be still.*

I stared at him.

"He has not died yet," said Selitos quietly. "Not by your reckoning. But I see names, singer. And his is very bright, and very close to its end." He closed the book. "I thought you should know. So that when it comes, you will not be surprised."

\* \* \*

I did not believe him. Or I did not let myself. I went down out of the Stormwal and through the twilight with Bast and came to the Maer's camp in the hills, and Tempi was there, and I took his hands in mine, and he said *you are my student, you are in trouble, where else would I be*. And I did not think of the grey book at all.

And then he died, in the burning camp by the river, with Cinder's pale sword in him, making the sign for *go*.

And I remembered. Standing on the hill above the Maer's valley, beside his cairn, with Vashet moving my hands into the shape of grief. I remembered Selitos's small precise hand, writing his name in a book of the dead before he was dead.

I have never decided whether that was cruel or kind.

I think, like most things Selitos did, it was both. I think he had been alive so long that he could no longer tell the difference.

I think, if I live long enough, I will be the same.

## Chapter Ninety-Three

# The Children in the Fountain

I have told you that Bast wandered the ruins of Myr Tariniel, those three days we stayed with Selitos, and came back each evening with his face very still and would not say what he had seen. I have told you what Selitos said to him, on the second evening. *Yes. They are still there. Some of them. The ones who would not leave.*

I did not ask, then. But on the third evening, Bast came back from the ruins and stood in the doorway of the round tower and looked at me across the room, where I sat among the books.

"Come," he said. "Please. There's something you should see."

\* \* \*

He led me through the white city in the last of the light. The sun was going down behind the peaks, and the white stone had gone gold, and then rose, and the shadows of the broken walls stretched out long and blue across the snow. It was very quiet. It was always very quiet, in Myr Tariniel. But this evening the quiet had a different quality. It was not empty. It was listening.

Bast did not speak. He walked ahead of me through the ruins, his hooves making small crisp sounds in the snow, and he did not look back.

He led me to the fountain.

The one I had stopped at, the first day. A great round basin of white stone, half buried in snow, with a broken column rising from its center. With carvings on its rim, worn almost smooth by the wind and

the years. Children, holding hands, dancing in a ring.

Bast stopped a little way from it. He stood very still.

"Watch," he whispered. "When the sun goes down. Just watch."

\* \* \*

The sun went down.

The gold went out of the white stone. The rose went out of the snow. The sky above the peaks went from blue to violet to the deep dark blue that comes just before night. The first stars came out, very bright and very far away.

And the children came.

I do not know how else to say it. One moment the fountain was empty. A ruin, half buried in snow, with a broken column and a ring of worn carvings. And the next moment, there were children.

They were very faint. Fainter than the pale guests at the Lord of Hollow Hours' table. Like reflections in dark water. Like breath on a cold window. But they were there. A dozen of them. More. Playing in the fountain.

They were splashing. There was no water in the basin, only snow. But they were splashing, the way children splash in a fountain on a hot day, kicking and laughing and throwing handfuls of nothing at each other. They were chasing each other around the broken column. They were climbing on the rim, and falling off, and climbing on again. One very small girl was sitting on the edge with her feet dangling, singing.

I could not hear her. There was no sound. Only the wind, and the snow, and the great silence of the dead city. But I could see her mouth moving, and I could see the shape of the song on her face, and I knew it was a happy song.

I stood beside Bast in the blue dusk and watched them play.

\* \* \*

"They come every night," said Bast. His voice was very quiet. "When the sun goes down. I watched them the first night, and the second. They play for an hour, maybe. And then—"

He stopped.

"And then what?"

Bast did not answer. He was looking at the children. His face was very still in the dusk.

I looked too.

The children had stopped playing.

All at once. The splashing stopped. The chasing stopped. The very small girl on the rim of the fountain stopped singing. They stood very still in the empty basin, all of them, and they turned their heads. All together. Toward the east. Toward the great arch on the eastern side of the plaza, where Selitos stood each morning to watch us go out.

And their faces changed.

I will not tell you what I saw on those faces. I cannot. It is the kind of thing that there are no words for, and if there were, I would not want to use them. I will tell you only that they were children, and that they had been playing, and that they had turned their heads toward the east at the sound of something coming. Something they had never heard before. Something that was the end of everything.

And they began to run.

Not away. That was the terrible thing. They did not run away. There was nowhere to run. They ran to each other. The older ones grabbed the younger ones. The very small girl on the rim of the fountain was snatched up by a boy of nine or ten, a thin dark-haired boy, and he held her against his chest and ran with her toward the far side of the fountain, toward a fallen slab of white marble that leaned against the broken column.

He pushed her under it. He pushed her into the gap between the slab and the stone floor of the basin, and he crawled in after her, and he pulled her close, and he put his hand over her mouth.

And then the fire came.

\* \* \*

I did not see the fire. There was no fire. Only the blue dusk and the snow and the silent ruins. But the children saw it. I saw them see it. I saw their faces lit orange and red by a light that was not there. I saw them fall.

Not all at once. One at a time. Some of them reaching for each other. Some of them with their eyes closed. Some of them with their mouths open, calling out a name I could not hear.

And then they were gone. The fountain was empty. The snow lay smooth and unbroken in the basin. The first stars shone on the white stone.

Only the slab of marble remained, leaning against the broken column. And in the gap beneath it, for one moment more, very faint, a thin dark-haired boy with his arms around a very small girl, with his hand over her mouth, and his eyes wide open in the dark, staring out at the burning city.

Then they were gone too.

\* \* \*

I stood beside Bast in the dusk for a long time. Neither of us spoke.

"Every night," said Bast at last. His voice was rough. "Every night, for ten thousand years. They play. And then it comes. And they die." He wiped his face with the back of his hand. "I asked Selitos. He said they don't know. They don't know they're dead. They only know the last hour. The playing, and then the fire. Over and over." He looked at the empty fountain. "He said he's tried to lay them to rest. Every way he knows. Names and songs and prayers. They won't go." Bast was quiet for a moment. "He said they're waiting for something. He doesn't know what."

I looked at the slab of white marble, leaning against the broken column.

"The boy," I said. "Under the slab. With the girl."

"Yes."

"That wasn't Skarpi."

Bast looked at me.

"Skarpi was alone," I said slowly. "He told me. He was hiding under a slab of marble, alone, and Selitos dug him out. He said he was the only one who lived." I looked at the fountain. "But that boy wasn't alone. He had the girl."

Bast did not say anything.

"That was his sister," I said. "It must have been. The girl. Skarpi had a sister. And he put her under the slab, and he held her, and he put his hand over her mouth so she wouldn't scream." My voice was very quiet. "And she died anyway. In the smoke, or the heat. With his hand over her mouth. And he lived."

The dusk was very still. The first stars were very bright.

"He never told me," I said. "He told me he was alone."

"Maybe he was," said Bast softly. "After."

\* \* \*

I went back the next evening. Alone. I did not tell Bast. I did not tell Selitos. I went through the white city in the last of the light, with my lute on my back, and I sat down on the rim of the fountain, beside the place where the very small girl had sat with her feet dangling, singing.

And when the sun went down, and the children came, I played.

I did not play *Tariniel*. That was the song of their dying. They had heard it every night for ten thousand years; they did not need to hear it again.

I played the song the very small girl had been singing. I did not know it. I could not hear it. But I had watched her mouth, the night before, and I had seen the shape of the song on her face. A happy song. A children's song. The kind of song that every child in every age of the world knows, about nothing at all, about sunshine and water and running.

I played it the way I had played the stone's no to the Sleeper. Not to be heard. For them. So that they would have something, this once, besides the fire.

And the children stopped playing, and turned, and looked at me.

\* \* \*

Not toward the east. Toward me. A dozen faint faces, like reflections in dark water, turned toward the red-haired stranger sitting on the rim of their fountain with a lute.

The very small girl came and sat beside me. Very close. I could not feel her. There was nothing to feel. But I saw her sit, and dangle



her feet, and look up at me with her faint face, and open her mouth.

And sing.

I could not hear her. But I played what her mouth was shaping. Note for note. Word for word, though I did not know the words. And she sang, and I played, and the other children came and sat around the rim of the fountain and listened.

And the hour came when the fire should have come.

And it did not come.

They sat and listened. They did not turn toward the east. They did not run. They sat on the rim of their fountain in the blue dusk and listened to the very small girl sing, and to a stranger play along. And the hour passed. And the stars came out, all of them, bright and cold and very far away.

And one by one, the children stood up, and walked away into the ruins, and did not come back.

\* \* \*

The very small girl was the last. She sat beside me on the rim of the fountain until the song was finished. And then she looked up at me, one more time, with her faint face.

She smiled.

And then she stood up and walked across the empty basin to the slab of white marble leaning against the broken column. And she knelt down and looked into the gap beneath it, the way a child looks for something she has lost. And then she crawled in. And was gone.

I sat on the rim of the fountain in the dark for a long time.

\* \* \*

Selitos was standing at the door of the round tower when I came back. He did not say anything. He looked at me with his one good eye and his stone eye, glinting in the starlight.

"They're gone," I said.

"I know." His voice was very quiet. "I felt them go." He was silent for a long moment. "Ten thousand years."

"They were waiting," I said. "You said they were waiting for something. You didn't know what."

"And do you?"

I looked back across the dark ruins, toward the fountain.

"For someone to play them something else," I said. "Something besides the fire."

Selitos looked at me for a long time. Then he did something I had never seen him do. He reached out with his long hand and touched my face. Very lightly. The way you touch something you are afraid will break.

"Singer," he said.

That was all. He turned and went back into the tower.

\* \* \*

I told Skarpi, years later, at a crossroads, when I did not remember any of it. I told him about the fountain, and the children, and the very small girl under the slab.

I did not remember telling him. Bast told me, afterward. He said Skarpi sat very still on his bench outside the empty inn and did not say anything for a long time. And then he put his long thin hands over his face and wept.

And then he said a name. A small name. A girl's name, very old, in a language no one speaks anymore.

Bast would not tell me what it was. He said it was not his to tell.

He said it was the name of a very small girl who liked to sing.

## Chapter Ninety-Four

# Lyra's House

On our last morning in the white city, Selitos took me to see where Lyra had lived.

He did not tell me where we were going. He came out of the tower in the grey light before dawn, wrapped in a heavy cloak of white fur, with his staff in his hand, and he looked at me where I sat by the banked fire with Bast asleep beside me.

"Walk with me, singer," he said.

I walked with him.

\* \* \*

We went down through the ruins. Past the great plaza with its broken columns and its drifted snow. Past the fountain with the carved children on its rim. Down a long white street so choked with rubble that we had to climb over it in places, Selitos moving slowly and carefully, leaning on his staff, and me behind him with my good hand out, ready to catch him if he fell.

He did not fall. He had walked these streets for a very long time.

At the bottom of the street, where the city ran up against the side of the mountain, there was a house. Or what was left of one. A small house, by the standards of that city. Two stories, of the same white stone as everything else, with a garden wall around it and a gate that had once been iron and was now a lacework of rust. The roof was gone. The upper story was gone, mostly. But the lower walls still stood, and the doorway, and one window, facing east.

Selitos stopped at the gate. He did not go in. He stood with both hands on his staff, and he looked at the house for a long time.

"Here," he said.

\* \* \*

I did not ask whose house it was. I knew. I had known since we turned into that street. There was something about it, even in ruin. A feeling. The way a room feels after music has been played in it.

"Lyra," I said.

"Lyra." Selitos's voice was very quiet. "And Lanre. When he was home. Which was not often." He looked at the doorway. "She kept this house for eleven years while he was at war. She kept it clean, and the garden weeded, and a lamp in that window every night. So he could see it from the pass. So he would know the way home."

"Did he?"

"Always." Selitos was quiet for a moment. "He told me once that he could see it from the top of the pass, on clear nights. A single light, very small, at the bottom of the city. He said it was the brightest thing in the world."

The wind moved over the snow. Somewhere far above us, among the peaks, a bird was calling. A thin, high, lonely sound.

"May I go in?" I said.

Selitos looked at me with his one good eye. The stone eye, beside it, was very still.

"She would have liked you," he said. "Go in."

\* \* \*

I went in. Through the rusted gate, across the garden, where nothing grew now but snow and a few dry grey stalks of something that might once have been lavender. Through the doorway, which had no door.

It was a small room. The walls were white and bare. There was snow on the floor, drifted into the corners, and the sky above was grey and open where the roof had been. There was no furniture. There was nothing at all. Only the walls, and the snow, and the single window facing east.

And beneath the window, a shelf. Carved into the stone of the wall itself. A small shelf, about the length of my forearm.

There was something on it.

\* \* \*

I brushed the snow away with my good hand. Underneath, the shelf was clean and white. And set into the stone, as if it had grown there, was a lamp.

It was a very simple lamp. A shallow bowl of white stone, with a lip for the wick and a small handle on one side. There was no oil in it. There had been no oil in it for a very long time. But there was a mark on the stone around the lip, very faint, the kind of smoke-stain that only comes from years and years of burning. Every night. In the same place.

I stood and looked at it for a long time.

"She lit it the night he came home for the last time," said Selitos, behind me. He had come in so quietly that I had not heard him. He was standing in the doorway, leaning on his staff. "The night before the battle at Drossen Tor. He came home to her for one night. They sat here, in this room, with the lamp burning in the window. And in the morning, he went to the battle. And she went with him."

"And she died."

"And she died." Selitos did not move. "And he called her back. With her name. The way she had once called him back, when he fell." His voice was very flat. "You know that part. Skarpi told you."

"Yes."

"And then she died again. For good. And he came home. Here." Selitos looked at the lamp. "He came home to this house, and he sat in this room, and he lit this lamp. Every night. For a year. For no one." He was quiet for a long moment. "And then he did what he did. And the city burned."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything. I stood in the small white room with the snow on the floor and the lamp on the shelf, and I thought about a man

sitting here, alone, lighting a lamp every night for a woman who was never coming home.

I thought about a bar at a crossroads, and a man behind it, polishing glasses. I did not know, then, that I was thinking about that. I had not been there yet. But I think some part of me knew. Some part of me looked at that lamp and saw, very far away, a small grey inn with a sword over the bar, and a man waiting there for something that might never come.

"Why did you bring me here?" I said.

Selitos did not answer at once.

"Because you are going to the door," he said at last. "The last door. The one under the house of your mother's family. And when you get there, you will have to give up something. Something very dear. Perhaps everything." He looked at me with his one good eye. "And I wanted you to see what happens. When a man loses what he loves most, and cannot let it go."

"Lanre."

"Lanre." Selitos looked at the lamp. "He was the best of us, singer. Did Skarpi tell you that? The bravest and the kindest and the most loved. Better than me. Better than Aleph. Better than any of us." His voice was very quiet. "And he broke. Not because he was weak. Because he loved her so much that he could not bear the world without her in it. So he decided the world should not be."

\* \* \*

"I don't want to break," I said.

"No one does." Selitos turned from the lamp and looked at me. "But everyone who loves, breaks. A little. That is the price of it. The question is not whether you break. The question is what you do with the pieces." He was quiet for a moment. "Lanre gathered his pieces and made them into a weapon. He made them into Haliar. A shadow that cannot die and cannot forget and cannot stop grieving. That was his choice."

"What should I do? With mine?"

Selitos looked at me for a long time.

"I do not know," he said. "I have been asking myself that for a very long time. About my own pieces." He touched the stone in his eye socket, very lightly. "I made mine into a watch. A long, cold watch, alone at the top of the world. Waiting for a door to open. Listening for a song." He almost smiled. "It is not a very good choice either. But it is better than Lanre's."

"Is there a good one?"

"Perhaps." Selitos looked back at the lamp on the shelf. "Lyra's."

\* \* \*

"She lit a lamp," he said. "Every night. For eleven years. For a man who was far away, who might not come home. Not because she was sure he would. Because she hoped." He was quiet. "She did not know what would happen. She did not know if the war would end, or if he would live, or if the world would go on. She only knew that there should be a light in the window. In case."

He reached out and touched the lamp, very gently, with one long finger.

"That is what I would tell you to do," he said. "With your pieces. When you break. Not make a weapon. Not make a watch." He took his hand away. "Make a light. A small one. In a window. And keep it burning. Not because you are sure. Because you hope."

\* \* \*

We walked back up through the ruins in silence. The sun was coming up over the peaks, and the white city was turning gold and rose in the dawn, the way it must have looked every morning for a thousand years before it burned.

At the top of the long white street, I looked back. The small house at the bottom was in shadow still, against the side of the mountain. I could not see the window from there.

But I thought, for a moment, that I saw a light in it. Very small. Very faint. The kind of light you see at the edge of your eye, and then, when you turn to look, is gone.

I did not say anything. Neither did Selitos.

But when we came to the tower, and Bast came out yawning to meet us, Selitos stopped at the door and looked back down the street the way we had come. And his one good eye was wet.

"She is still lighting it," he said. So softly that only I heard. "After all this time. For him. In case."

And he went inside, and did not come out again until we left.

\* \* \*

"Is that why?" said Chronicler. "The inn? Seven years behind a bar, waiting?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time. He looked around the common room. At the bar, and the bottles, and the sword on the wall. At the window, with its shutters closed against the dark, and the frost creeping in at the edges.

"I didn't know it," he said at last. "Not then. I didn't know anything, then. I didn't choose to keep a light burning. I just kept an inn." He looked at the window. "But I think Selitos knew. I think he saw it. On that last morning. What I was going to be." He was quiet. "A man in a small house at the bottom of the world, keeping a lamp in the window. Not because he was sure. Because he hoped."

"Hoped for what?"

The innkeeper looked at him. At the scribe, and the pen, and the pages stacked three days high.

"For someone to come," he said. "And see the light. And knock."



## Chapter Ninety-Five

# The Twilight Court

We could not go back the way we had come. The Sithe had forbidden it, and I believed them. But we could not go south through the mortal world either. It was two months' hard travel from the Stormwal to Vintas, over mountains and through wilderness and across a country at war. By the time we arrived, it would be over. One way or another.

"There's another way," said Bast.

We were sitting in the shallow cave where the scrael had come for us, on the far side of the high pass, eating the last of my bread. The ring of greystones stood on the bare shoulder of the mountain below us, grey against the snow.

"The greystones go more places than one," he said. "If you know how to ask them. The Moon's Road is only one road. There are others." He hesitated. "My father's court has roads of its own. Old ones. The Telwyth Mael have always had a fondness for the mortal mountains. It's where we came from, in a way." He looked at his hooves. "If I asked the stones to take us to my father's court, they'd do it. And from my father's court, there are roads to everywhere."

"Your father's court," I said. "Where you ran away from. Where the Sithe said you shouldn't go back to, because you might be poisoned."

"I know." Bast looked at me. "But you'd be with me. And you're taking me to the mortal world, like they said. We'd only be passing through." He paused. "And my father would want to know. That I'm alive. That I didn't—" He stopped.

I looked at him for a long moment.

"You want to see him," I said.

Bast looked away. "Maybe," he said quietly. "A little."

\* \* \*

The greystones took us to the Twilight Court.

It was not like the Moon's Road, or the Hollow Market, or anywhere else I had been in the Fae. It was a valley, deep and narrow, cut between two great cliffs of dark grey stone. The cliffs rose up so high on either side that the twilight sky above was only a thin ribbon of violet. A river ran along the valley floor, dark and swift and silent. And along the banks of the river, and climbing up the cliffs on either side, there was a city.

Not a city of stone, like Myr Tariniel. A city of wood and vine and living things. Houses grown out of great trees, their branches twisted into walls and roofs. Bridges of living vine, stretching from cliff to cliff across the valley. Stairs cut into the stone and overgrown with moss and flowers. Lanterns hanging everywhere, from every branch and bridge and eave, glowing soft gold and green and blue in the endless twilight.

It was beautiful. It was one of the most beautiful places I have ever seen. And it was very quiet. As if the whole city were holding its breath.

"It's always like this," said Bast softly, as we walked along the riverbank. "Quiet. My father likes it quiet." He looked around at the living houses, the glowing lanterns. His face was strange. "I'd forgotten how quiet."

People saw us as we passed. Fae people. Some of them tall and fair, some of them small and quick, some of them with hooves like Bast's, or horns, or eyes like a cat's. They stopped what they were doing and stared at us. At Bast, mostly. Some of them whispered. Some of them bowed. One old woman, sitting on the step of a house grown out of a willow tree, burst into tears and covered her face with her hands.

Bast did not look at any of them. He walked straight ahead with his chin up and his jaw tight, and he did not stop until we came to the end of the valley, where the two great cliffs came together and the river poured out of a cave in the rock.

There was a house there. Bigger than the others. Grown out of a tree so old and so huge that its trunk was wider than the Eolian, and its branches reached up the cliffs on either side like arms. There were stairs spiraling up around the trunk, and windows glowing gold in the bark, and at the top of the stairs, a great door of living wood.

Bast stopped at the foot of the stairs. He looked up at the door.

"Wait here," he said. "Please. Let me go first."

I waited.

\* \* \*

He was gone a long time. I sat on a root at the foot of the great tree and watched the river pour out of the cave, dark and swift and silent. People came and went along the riverbank behind me. Some of them stared at me. None of them spoke.

At last, the great door at the top of the stairs opened, and Bast came out. His face was wet. He came down the stairs slowly and stopped in front of me.

"He wants to see you," he said.

\* \* \*

Remmen, Lord of the Telwyth Mael, received me in a round room at the heart of the great tree. The walls were living wood, smooth and golden and faintly warm, and there were no windows. The only light came from a pool in the center of the floor, a round pool of still dark water that glowed softly from below, like a lantern under ice.

Remmen was sitting beside the pool on a low bench. He was tall and lean and dark-haired, like Bast, with the same fine-boned face and the same deep blue eyes. But he was older. Much older. There were lines around his eyes, and his hair was touched with silver at the temples. His feet, where they showed beneath the hem of his long green robe, were hooves.

He looked at me for a long time without speaking. His face was very still.

"You are the mortal," he said at last. His voice was deep and soft and very tired. "The one who stood between my son and the Sithe."

"Yes, my lord."

"Why?"

I told him what I had told Bast. About being twelve, and alone, and having no one to stand in front of me.

He listened in silence. When I was done, he looked down at the glowing pool for a long time.

"His mother was mortal," he said. "Did he tell you?"

"Yes."

"She left. When he was very small. He never understood why." Remmen was quiet for a moment. "I never told him. I could not bear to."

I did not say anything.

"She left because she was dying," said Remmen softly. "Mortals die, in the twilight, if they stay too long. Slowly. So slowly you do not notice, at first. They fade. They grow thin and pale and quiet, like a flower kept too long out of the sun." He looked into the pool. "She stayed with us for thirty mortal years. Longer than any mortal should. Because she loved us. Because she could not bear to leave him." He paused. "And then one day she looked in a mirror and saw what she had become, and she knew that if she stayed another year, she would die. And that he would watch her die. And that he would never forgive himself, because it was his birth that had made her stay so long."

The pool glowed softly. The living walls were very still.

"So she left," said Remmen. "Without saying goodbye. Because if she had said goodbye, she would not have been able to go." He looked up at me. "She went back through a greystone in the mountains, into your world, and she lived there for another eleven years. In a little village in the Stormwal foothills. She married a shepherd. She had two more children." He smiled faintly. "She was happy, I think. I hope. I watched her, sometimes, in the pool."

"Did you ever tell Bast?"

"No." Remmen's voice was very quiet. "I could not. He would have gone to find her. And she would have seen him, and it would have broken her heart." He was silent for a moment. "And then she died. Twelve mortal years ago. Of a fever, in the winter. And after that, there seemed no point in telling him at all."

\* \* \*

I looked at him for a long time.

"He went to the Cthaeh," I said, "to ask it why she left."

"I know. He told me." Remmen closed his eyes. "It would have told him the truth. And it would have told it in the way that would hurt him most. That she left because of him. Because his birth trapped her. Because loving him was killing her." He opened his eyes. "And he would have carried that forever."

"You should tell him," I said. "The truth. The whole truth. Not the Cthaeh's version. Yours."

Remmen looked at me. His deep blue eyes were very sad.

"You are very young," he said. "You think the truth always helps."

"I think the truth told with love helps more than the truth told with cruelty," I said. "And the Cthaeh's already whispered to him. Once. In the net. It's already planted something." I paused. "You can plant something too. Something better."

Remmen was silent for a very long time.

"Perhaps," he said at last. "Perhaps you are right." He looked down at the pool. "I will think on it."

\* \* \*

He showed me the pool, after that. It was a scrying pool, old and deep, that could look into the mortal world if you knew how to ask it. He asked it to show me Vintas. Severen. The war.

It showed me.

I knelt at the edge of the glowing water and looked down into it, and I saw Severen. The city on the cliff, with the Maer's palace at the

top. But it was not the Severen I remembered.

The walls were broken. There were great gaps in them, black and jagged, like missing teeth. The low city at the foot of the cliff was burned; only blackened timbers and tumbled stone remained. Smoke rose from the high city in a dozen places. And over the gates of the Maer's palace, where the Maer's banner had always flown, there was another banner.

Black and silver. The arms of the house of Jakis.

"No," I whispered.

"It fell three spans ago," said Remmen quietly. "By your world's reckoning. They breached the walls with sympathy and fire, and the low city burned, and the high city was taken street by street." He looked at me. "Your Maer escaped. With some of his people. They are in the hills to the south, hiding."

"And his wife?"

Remmen touched the surface of the pool. The image shifted. I saw a camp. A great army camp, sprawling across a green valley. Tents and banners and cookfires. Soldiers everywhere. And in the center of the camp, a great pavilion of black and silver silk.

"She was taken," said Remmen. "In the fall of the palace. She was very near her time. She gave birth in the king's camp, eleven days ago." He looked at me. "A daughter."

I stared into the pool. At the black and silver pavilion.

"Three spans," I said. "Severen fell three spans ago."

"Yes."

"I was only in the twilight for—" I tried to count. The Hollow Market. Felurian. The Sithe. The Moon's Road. "A span. Maybe two."

"Time runs differently here," said Remmen gently. "You know that. You must have known it."

I had known it. I had known it the first time, with Felurian, when I came out of her glade after what felt like days and found that months had passed. I had known it, and I had gambled anyway. I had thought the Moon's Road would be faster than the mortal roads. And it had been. But not fast enough.

"How long?" I said. "How long since I left Imre?"

Remmen was quiet for a moment.

"Nearly five months," he said.

\* \* \*

I knelt there beside the pool for a long time. I did not move. I did not speak.

Five months. While I walked through the silver forest and bought a road for a song and argued with the Sithe and sang to the mountain and drank tea with Selitos. Five months, in the mortal world. The siege, and the fall, and Meluan taken, and her daughter born in the camp of the man who would use her blood to open a door.

*A child of the line*, Skarpi had said. *It will be many years before anyone knows.*

But Bredon did not need to know. Not really. A newborn of the line, with pure blood, not yet named, not yet grown. Not a namer, perhaps. But perhaps she did not need to be. Perhaps a newborn's blood, and a newborn's cry, and the key of stone in a king's hand, would be enough to wake the door.

Or perhaps they were only waiting. For me. With my aunt and her daughter as bait.

"Where are they going?" I said. My voice was hoarse. "The king's army. Where are they going?"

Remmen touched the pool again. The image shifted. I saw the army moving. A great column of men and horses and wagons, winding through green hills. And at the head of the column, a banner of black and silver. And beneath the banner, riding a tall black horse, a young man in black with a crown on his head.

Ambrose.

And beside him, on a grey mare, a girl with dark hair, and an old man on a donkey, leaning on a stick.

"South and east," said Remmen. "Toward the hills."

"Toward Levinshir," I said.

"I do not know your mortal names for places." Remmen looked at me. "But there is an old house in those hills. Very old. Older than the

kingdom that surrounds it. I have seen it in the pool, many times. It has a door beneath it." His deep blue eyes were very steady. "They will be there in nine days."

\* \* \*

Bast found me an hour later, sitting on a root at the foot of the great tree, staring at the dark river.

He sat down beside me. He did not say anything for a long time.

"My father told me," he said at last. "About my mother. Why she left." His voice was very quiet. "He said you told him to."

"I suggested it."

"He said you told him the truth told with love helps more than the truth told with cruelty." Bast looked at the river. "He said he'd never thought of it like that."

"Did it help?"

Bast was quiet for a long time.

"Yes," he said at last. "I think so. It hurts. It hurts a lot." He wiped his eyes with the back of his hand. "But it's a different kind of hurting. It's not—" He struggled for the word. "It's not *poisoned*. If that makes sense."

"It does."

We sat there together by the river for a while.

"He told me about the war too," said Bast. "About Severen. And the baby." He looked at me. "Nine days."

"Nine days."

"Can we get there in nine days?"

"Your father says there's a greystone in the hills near the Lackless house. An old one. He can send us there." I looked at the river. "We'd arrive in the mortal world tomorrow, by our reckoning. But I don't know how long that will be there. A day. A span. It's hard to say, going back."

"Then we should go now."

"Yes."

Bast did not move. Neither did I.



"Reshi," he said. "You know what's waiting there. Don't you? At the door."

"Yes."

"Bredon. And Ambrose. And Cinder, probably. And the Seven. And the thing behind the door." Bast's voice was very steady. "And you're the key. You're the one they need. And you're walking right into it."

"Yes."

"Why?"

I looked at him. At his deep blue eyes, wet with tears for his mother, and his fine-boned face, and the silver circlet on his brow.

"Because my aunt is there," I said. "And her daughter. And Denna." I paused. "And because if I don't go, they'll open it anyway, with the baby. And there won't be anyone there who knows how to close it."

"And you do? Know how?"

I thought about Selitos. About the door's name, sitting in my bones like a stone. About the price.

"Yes," I said. "I know how."

Bast looked at me for a long time. Then he stood up. He brushed off his clothes. He held out his hand.

"Then let's go," he said. "Reshi."

I took his hand. He pulled me to my feet.

And we went to find the greystone.

## Chapter Ninety-Six

# The Shepherd's Song

It was three days' walk through the twilight from Remmen's tree to the greystone he had told us of. Three days, as the Fae counts days, which is to say three long stretches of walking and three short stretches of sleep, beneath a sky that never changed.

Bast did not speak for the first of them.

I did not make him. I knew what Remmen had told him, in the round golden room at the heart of the tree, while I waited outside. I knew because I had asked Remmen to tell him. His mother had not left because of him. She had left because she was dying, slowly, the way mortals die in the twilight. She had gone back through a greystone into the mountains, and married a shepherd, and lived eleven more years. And then she had died. Twelve years ago. While Bast was still a child in his father's court, waiting for her to come home.

He walked beside me along the silver road with his hands in his pockets and his head down, and he did not say anything at all. And I walked beside him, and did not say anything either, and after a while I began to hum. Not a song. Just a hum. The kind of sound you make to fill a silence that is too heavy to carry.

He did not tell me to stop. So I did not.

\* \* \*

On the second day, he spoke.

We had stopped to rest beside a stream. It was a Fae stream, which meant that the water ran uphill for a little way before it

remembered itself, and that the stones in it were very slightly warm to the touch. We sat on the bank and ate the last of the bread from Remmen's kitchens and drank from the stream, which tasted of snow and violets.

"A shepherd," said Bast.

I looked at him. He was looking at the water.

"She married a shepherd," he said. "In the mountains. Father told me. He knew his name, even. He'd watched them. In the pool. For eleven years." He picked up a warm stone from the edge of the stream and turned it over in his fingers. "His name was Aled. He had a flock of black-faced sheep and a dog with one ear and a cottage with a turf roof. And he played the pipes. Every evening, sitting on the wall outside the cottage, while the sun went down." His voice cracked. "And she sang with him."

I did not say anything.

"She sang," said Bast. "Every night. For eleven years. Father said he used to watch her in the pool. Sitting on the wall beside the shepherd with her head on his shoulder. Singing." He threw the stone into the stream. It went in with a small plop, and the water ran uphill around it for a moment, confused. "She never sang at court. Not once. Not in all the years I knew her. Father said she used to, before I was born. But by the time I was old enough to remember, she'd stopped."

"Because she was fading."

"Because she was fading." Bast wrapped his arms around his knees. "She was fading for years, Reshi. The whole time I knew her. And I didn't know. I thought that was just what she was like. Quiet. Pale. Tired all the time." He was quiet for a long moment. "And then she went to the mountains. And she sang again."

\* \* \*

I did not know what to say. I have never known what to say, at moments like that. I know a great many words. I know how to make them sing and dance and weep and laugh. But when someone I love is hurting, all my words go away, and I am left sitting beside them with nothing in my hands.

So I did what I always do, when I have nothing in my hands. I took out my lute.

Bast looked at it. Then at me.

"Don't," he said. "Don't play me something sad. I can't."

"I wasn't going to."

"Then what?"

I did not answer. I tuned the lute. My left hand was still stiff, from the Stormwal, from the cold. But it was better than it had been. It could hold a chord.

And I played him a shepherd's song.

\* \* \*

I did not know any songs from the mountains at the edge of the Stormwal. I did not know what Aled had played on his pipes, sitting on the wall outside his turf-roofed cottage, with his black-faced sheep and his one-eared dog. But I knew shepherds' songs. The Ruh know every kind of song there is. And shepherds' songs are all a little the same, the way shepherds are all a little the same, wherever you go. Slow and simple and wandering, like sheep on a hillside. Songs for evenings. Songs for sitting on a wall while the sun goes down.

I played one I had learned as a child, from an old man in the hills above Ralien, who had played it on a pipe made of a hollow reed. It had no words. It did not need them. It was a song about sitting still, at the end of a long day, with someone you love beside you, and watching the light go.

Bast listened. He did not move. He sat on the bank of the uphill stream with his arms around his knees and his chin on his arms and his eyes closed, and he listened.

When I finished, he did not open his eyes.

"Again," he said.

I played it again.

\* \* \*

The third time, he began to hum.

He did not hum well. Bast has a great many gifts, but singing is not one of them. His voice is too light, and it wanders, and it cannot hold a note for very long before it slides away sideways into something else. But he hummed. Softly. Along with the lute. Following the slow wandering line of the shepherd's song the way a child follows a parent along a path, a step behind, stumbling.

And after a while, his humming began to change.

It was the same song. But it was not. He had found something in it. Some turn of the melody, some small upward lift at the end of a phrase, that I had not played. That was not in the song as I had learned it. He hummed it over and over, that small lift, until I found it on the lute and played it with him.

And then he opened his eyes, and looked at me, and his face was wet.

"That's hers," he said. "That turn. At the end. That's how she used to hum. When I was very small. Before she stopped." His voice was barely a whisper. "I'd forgotten. I'd forgotten it completely. And you played the song and it came back."

\* \* \*

We sat by the stream for a long time after that. I played the shepherd's song over and over, with Bast's mother's turn at the end of every phrase, and Bast hummed along, and sometimes he wept and sometimes he did not.

"She was happy," he said at last. "Wasn't she? In the mountains. With the shepherd. Singing."

"I think so."

"I'm glad." He wiped his face with the back of his hand. "I thought I'd be angry. When I found out. That she left us. That she was happy somewhere without me." He was quiet for a moment. "But I'm not. I'm glad. She sang again. For eleven years. That's more than she had at court."

"She'd have sung for you, too," I said. "If she could. If she'd been able to stay."

"I know." Bast looked at the lute in my lap. "Father said she asked about me. In the pool. She'd look into the stream behind the cottage, sometimes, and say my name. Hoping it would reach me." He swallowed. "It never did. The twilight's too far from the mountains."

"It reached you now."

Bast looked at me. For a long moment he did not say anything.

"Yes," he said at last. "I suppose it did."

\* \* \*

We went on, after a while. Along the silver road, toward the greystone on the bare green hill. Bast walked beside me with his hands in his pockets, the way he had the day before. But his head was up now. And every so often, as we walked, he hummed. That small upward turn. His mother's turn. Over and over, very softly, under his breath, as if he were afraid he would forget it again.

"Reshi," he said, on the third day, when we could see the greystone at last, standing alone at the end of the road.

"Yes?"

"Thank you."

"For what?"

He did not answer at once. He looked at the greystone, and the mortal world waiting beyond it, and the war, and the Maer, and everything that was coming.

"For stepping in front of the arrows," he said at last. "And for the song." He looked at me. "I don't know which is bigger. I keep trying to work it out."

"The arrows," I said.

"No," said Bast. "I don't think so."

\* \* \*

"He still hums it," the innkeeper said. "Did you know that?"

He looked at the kitchen door, where the sound of pots and pans had gone quiet.

"When he's cooking. When he's cleaning. When he thinks no one's listening. The shepherd's song, with his mother's turn at the end."

He was quiet for a moment. "He hummed it every day, for seven years. In the kitchen of the Waystone. While I sat behind the bar and didn't remember anything. I heard it every day. I didn't know what it was."

Chronicler did not write. He waited.

"It was one of the first things that came back, these last three days, while I was telling you the rest," said the innkeeper. "Not the song. I knew the song. But the turn. The little lift at the end of the phrase. And a stream that ran uphill, and a boy with wet eyes saying *that's hers*." He looked down at his hands. "I think he hummed it for me, all those years. The way she hummed it for him. Hoping it would reach me."

"Did it?"

"Eventually." The innkeeper almost smiled. "The twilight's a long way from anywhere. But it reached me."

## Chapter Ninety-Seven

# The Maer in the Hills

The greystone Remmen sent us to stood alone on the crown of a bare green hill, with nothing around it for a mile in any direction but grass and sky and wind. We stepped out of the twilight beside it on a grey afternoon in late autumn, and the first thing I smelled was smoke.

Not woodsmoke. Not the smell of cookfires, or of a farmer burning brush. The other kind. The smell of a village burning. The smell of war.

I stood on the hilltop and turned in a slow circle, looking. The hills rolled away on every side, green and brown and dun, rising toward a line of higher, rockier hills in the south and east. There were no roads that I could see. No houses. No people.

But to the north, on the horizon, there was a smudge of dark smoke against the grey sky. And to the west, another. And to the east, far off, a third.

"Where are we?" said Bast. He was shivering. The wind was cold, and he was not used to wind.

"Vintas," I said. "Somewhere in the south. The hills beyond Severen." I looked at the rocky hills to the southeast. "Levinshir is that way. I think."

"And the Maer?"

"Remmen said he was hiding in the hills to the south." I looked at the smoke on the horizon. "Somewhere."

\* \* \*



It took us two days to find him.

We walked south through the empty hills, keeping to the valleys and the stream beds, away from the ridgelines where we might be seen. Bast kept his glamour close around us, so that from a distance we looked like two more shadows among the rocks. We saw no one on the first day. On the second day, we saw soldiers.

They were riding along a road in a valley below us, twenty or thirty of them, in the black and silver livery of the house of Jakis. They were riding hard, heading west. We lay flat in the heather at the top of the valley and watched them pass. None of them looked up.

"Hunting," said Bast softly, when they had gone. "They were hunting someone."

"The Maer, probably."

"Did they find him?"

"I don't know."

We followed the road west, a long way behind the soldiers. We followed it until dusk, when it came to a place where the valley narrowed between two high rocky shoulders of hill. And there, in the narrowest part of the valley, we found the soldiers.

They were dead. All of them. Lying in the road and among the rocks on either side, with arrows in them. Their horses were gone.

I stood at the edge of the killing ground and looked at the arrows. They were long and grey-fletched, the kind of arrows the Maer's archers used. The kind I had seen in Severen, in the practice yards below the palace.

"Ambush," said Bast.

"Yes."

"The Maer's people?"

"Yes." I looked up at the high rocky shoulders on either side of the valley. "They're close."

\* \* \*

They found us before we found them.

We were climbing the eastern shoulder of the valley in the last of the light, picking our way up among the rocks, when a voice spoke out

of the darkness above us.

"Stop. Hands where I can see them."

We stopped. We held up our hands.

A man came down out of the rocks. Then another, and another. Five of them, with bows drawn and arrows nocked. They wore no livery, only rough brown clothes and cloaks of grey wool, but they moved like soldiers.

The one in front was big and grizzled, with a broken nose and a scar across his chin. He looked at me for a long moment in the dusk. Then his eyes went wide.

"God's teeth," he said. "It's the Ruh."

I knew him. It took me a moment. He was one of the Maer's guards from Severen. Not one of the ones who had ridden with me to Renere. Another one. I had seen him on the palace walls, and in the practice yards.

"Corrin," I said. "Is Corrin with you?"

"Corrin's dead." The big man lowered his bow slowly. "Died on the walls when they breached the south gate. Took five of them with him." He was staring at me. "They said you were dead too. They said you'd run off into the Fae and never come back."

"I came back."

"So you did." He looked at Bast. His eyes narrowed. "Who's that?"

"A friend."

"He's got a funny look about him."

"He's a funny friend," I said. "Take us to the Maer."

\* \* \*

The Maer's camp was in a hidden valley high in the rocky hills, a narrow cleft between two great shoulders of grey stone with a stream running down the middle of it. There were perhaps three hundred people there. Soldiers, mostly, the remnants of the Maer's army. But also servants from the palace, and townsfolk from Severen who had fled when the city fell, and a few families from the villages round about who had nowhere else to go.

They were living in caves and under rock overhangs and in a few ragged tents. There were small fires, carefully shielded so that their light would not be seen from the valleys below. There was very little food. Everyone was thin and grey and tired.

The Maer was sitting beside one of the fires, at the mouth of a shallow cave near the head of the valley. He was wrapped in a grey soldier's cloak, and there was a bandage around his left arm, and his face was hollow and hard in the firelight. He looked ten years older than when I had last seen him.

He looked up as I came into the firelight. For a long moment he did not move.

Then he stood up, slowly, and came around the fire, and took me by the shoulders, and looked at me.

"Kvothe," he said. His voice was rough.

"Your grace."

"You are alive."

"Yes, your grace."

He looked at me for a moment longer. Then he pulled me into an embrace. It was brief and hard and very tight, the embrace of a man who has lost a great deal and has just found one small thing he thought was gone.

"She is gone," he said, into my shoulder. "Meluan. They took her. When the palace fell. I was on the south wall. I could not reach her." His voice cracked. "I could not reach her."

"I know," I said. "I know, your grace. I'm going to get her back."

\* \* \*

Stapes was there. He came out of the cave a little later with a pot of something that might have been soup, and when he saw me, he stopped and stared, and nearly dropped the pot. Then he recovered himself, and set the pot down very carefully on a flat stone by the fire, and bowed.

"Sir," he said. "Welcome back."

"Thank you, Stapes."

"Would you care for some soup?" He hesitated. "It is mostly water, I'm afraid. And a little barley. And something one of the soldiers caught, which I believe was a rabbit."

"I'd love some soup."

He served it to me in a battered tin cup. It was terrible. It was mostly water and a little barley and something that might have been a rabbit. It was the best thing I had eaten in a very long time.

Stapes stood beside me while I ate. He did not say anything. But once, when he thought I was not looking, he reached up and wiped his eyes with the back of his hand.

\* \* \*

And then, a little later, as the fire burned low and the Maer was telling me about the fall of Severen, there was a commotion at the lower end of the valley. Voices raised. Someone running.

A boy came pelting up the valley toward the fire. A soldier's boy, a runner, no more than twelve.

"Your grace!" he gasped. "Your grace, there's people coming up the lower path. A whole crowd of 'em. With wagons."

The Maer was on his feet at once, his hand on his sword. "Soldiers?"

"No, your grace. Not soldiers. They're—" The boy hesitated. "They're *singing*, your grace."

I heard it then. Faint, drifting up the valley on the night wind. A fiddle. Badly played. Every third note flat. And a woman's voice, rough and sweet as honey from a wild hive, singing "Tinker Tanner."

I stood up.

\* \* \*

It was Hallow's Company.

They came up the lower path in the dark, three wagons painted in bright colors gone dull with dust, pulled by tired horses. Tessit was leading the first horse, with his battered hat pulled low. Mirra was walking beside him. Brin was sitting on the seat of the first wagon, sawing away at his fiddle. Illa was walking beside the second wagon,

singing.

And behind them, there were others.

Many others. More wagons, carts, people on foot. Refugees. Families from the villages. Old men and women, children, a few young men with farm tools in their hands and hard frightened faces. They came up the path behind Hallow's Company like a river behind a boat, fifty of them, a hundred, more.

"We found them on the roads," said Tessit, when he saw me. He did not seem surprised to see me. Ruh are rarely surprised by anything. "Wandering. Nowhere to go. The king's men burned their villages." He shrugged. "We heard the Maer was in the hills. We thought he might have room."

The Maer was staring at them. At the long line of ragged frightened people coming up the path in the dark behind the Ruh wagons.

"We have no food," he said. "We can barely feed ourselves."

"We have some," said Mirra. "Not much. But some. We'll share." She looked at the Maer with her round cheerful face gone grave. "That's what people do, your grace. When things are bad. They share."

The Maer looked at her for a long moment. Then he looked at me.

"Ruh," he said.

"Ruh," I said. "One family, your grace. Under the sky."

He looked back at Mirra. And then, slowly, he bowed. A real bow. The kind of bow a Maer gives to a lord.

"You are welcome," he said. "All of you. Whatever we have is yours."

\* \* \*

Nell found me by the fire later that night.

I did not recognize her at first. She had grown. She was taller, and less thin, and her hair was braided in the Ruh fashion, and she was wearing a dress of bright red wool that Mirra must have made for her. She came up to the fire and stood looking at me with her enormous eyes, and I looked back at her, and for a long moment neither of us said anything.

Then she said, "You're the man from the well."

"I am."

"You pulled me up."

"I did."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she came around the fire and sat down beside me, very close, and leaned against my arm.

"I have something for you," she said. "From the pretty lady."

I went very still.

"What pretty lady?"

"The one with the dark hair. The one who came to our farm and looked at Mama's cloth." Nell reached into the pocket of her red dress. "She was in the king's camp. When we played there, five days ago. Tessit said we had to play for the king, or the soldiers would take our wagons. So we played." She held out her hand. "And after, when we were packing up, the lady found me. She knew me. She remembered me from the farm." Nell's voice was very small. "She cried. She held me and cried and said she was sorry. Over and over. She said she didn't know."

I did not say anything. I could not.

"And then she gave me this," said Nell. "And she said, 'Give it to the red-haired man. The one who pulled you out of the well. You'll see him again. I know you will.'" She opened her hand. "And I did. See you again. Just like she said."

In her small palm, there was a cord. Braided from three strands of dark hair. Knotted.

\* \* \*

I read it by the light of the fire, with Nell asleep against my arm and Bast sitting on my other side and the Maer across the fire, watching me.

*Nine days to the door, it said. From the day I tie this. Four days gone now, maybe five.*

*The king has the box. He wears it. Around his neck, on a chain. Never takes it off.*

*The lady is in the camp. Weak. The baby is well. They keep them close to the king.*

*The old man says: the key will come. He says: when the key comes, we will not need the baby.*

*He says: if the key does not come, we will use the baby at the dark of the moon.*

*The old man says you know the door's name now. He says someone gave it to you. He smiled when he said it.*

*He says: he will come. He always comes.*

And then, after a gap, a knot I had never seen. It took me a long time to puzzle it out. It was made of pieces I knew—*hand, name, hold, keep*—twisted together in a new way.

When I finally understood it, I sat very still.

*I can hold it. If you need me to. I know how.*

And then, at the very end, the knot that said *forgive*.

\* \* \*

I folded the cord very carefully and put it inside my shirt, against my skin, next to the knot from the Grey Man.

Across the fire, the Maer was watching me.

"What does it say?" he asked quietly.

"It says we have four days," I said. "Maybe five. Until the dark of the moon."

"And then?"

"And then they open the door. With me, if I come. With your daughter, if I don't."

The Maer went very still. His hollow face was grey in the firelight.

"My daughter," he said.

"Yes, your grace. Meluan had a daughter. Eleven days ago, or near enough. They're both alive. They're both in the king's camp."

The Maer did not say anything for a long time. He sat very still by the fire, with his bandaged arm in his lap, and he looked at the flames.

"A daughter," he said at last. His voice was very soft. "I have a daughter."

"Yes, your grace."

He closed his eyes. His face did something I had never seen it do before. It crumpled, just for a moment, like paper in a fist. Then it smoothed out again.

He opened his eyes. He looked at me across the fire. And his eyes were very hard.

"How many men do you need?" he said.



## Chapter Ninety-Eight

# The Fall of Severen

*The Maer told me this himself, by the fire at the mouth of his cave, on the second night after I found him in the hills. He told it slowly, the way a man tells something he has been carrying for a long time and has not yet found a place to set down. I have tried to set it down here as he told it, in his own words, as near as I can remember them.*

\* \* \*

They came in the spring, *said the Maer*, with the rains.

Ten thousand of them. I watched them come from the top of the cliff, from the window of my study, where you and I used to sit and talk. A great black river of men and horses and wagons, winding up the valley from the north, with the black and silver banner at its head. It took them three days to arrive. I watched the whole time. I did not sleep.

I had four thousand. Less. Three and a half. My own household guard, and the levies of the lords who owed me service and had not yet decided to change sides. The city watch. Some volunteers from the low city, men who had heard that the Jakis boy meant to hang every man in Severen who had ever worn my colors, and had decided they would rather die on the walls.

Three and a half thousand, and the walls of Severen. And the cliff.

I thought it would be enough. God help me, I thought it would be enough. Severen has never fallen. Not in four hundred years. The high

city sits on the cliff like a crown on a king's head, and there is only one road up, and a hundred men can hold that road against ten thousand for as long as they have food and arrows.

I did not reckon on the old man.

\* \* \*

The first month was nothing. They camped in the valley below the cliff, around the low city, and they shot arrows at the walls, and we shot arrows back. They tried the cliff road twice. Both times, we threw them down it. They lost six hundred men on that road in a single afternoon, and we lost nine.

My captains were jubilant. They said the siege would break in a season. They said the Jakis boy would go home with his tail between his legs, and the lords who had followed him would come crawling back to me, begging forgiveness.

I did not believe them. I had seen the old man.

He was in their camp. I could see him from my window, through my glass. Every morning, he came out of a tent near the king's pavilion and sat on a stool in the sun, with a board on a little table in front of him. And he played tak. By himself. For hours. Every morning. Moving the stones, one by one, very slowly.

I knew him. Of course I knew him. He had played tak with me at my own table for eleven years. He had given me a book of poems on my fifteenth birthday. He had taught my cousin, and my cousin's son.

And now he sat in the enemy's camp, below my walls, playing tak by himself in the sun. And every so often, he would look up at the palace on the cliff, at my window, and smile. As if he could see me watching.

I think he could.

\* \* \*

In the second month, the low city burned.

Not by accident. Not by fire arrows, though they had plenty of those. It began in the night, in a dozen places at once. Warehouses by the river. The grain mills. The cooper's yard. The old church of Tehlu,

with its wooden steeple. All at once, in the dead of night, in a dozen places no enemy should have been able to reach.

We found out later how it was done. There was a man in the low city. A baker. His name was Tolly. He had been baking bread for my household for sixteen years. He had a wife and four children and a shop on the square below the cliff road, and every morning at dawn he sent up three dozen loaves to the palace kitchens.

He had sympathy. A little. Not much. Enough. He had learned it as a boy, from a hedge-wizard in his village, and he had used it all his life to keep his ovens hot without wasting wood. And one day, the spring before, an old man had come into his shop to buy a loaf of bread. A kind old man with a walking stick, who bought his bread every morning for a month and talked to him about the weather and his children and the price of flour. And at the end of the month, the old man had given him a small knotted cord. For luck, he said. For his children.

Tolly wore it around his neck. And on the night the low city burned, he went out into the dark and set the fires, one by one, with the sympathy he had learned as a boy. He did not know why. He told us afterward, when we caught him, weeping. He did not know why he had done it. He only knew that the cord around his neck had been warm, all that night, and that he had felt it pulling, and that he could not stop.

I hanged him. From the walls. In front of everyone.

I have not forgiven myself for it. He did not know. I knew he did not know. But the city was burning, and people were dying, and they needed someone to hang.

I have thought about Tolly every day since. He is the first thing I will do penance for, when I find a way.

\* \* \*

The low city burned for three days. Half the people who lived there died. The rest came up the cliff road to the high city, carrying what they could, and we let them in, because what else could we do. And the high city filled up with frightened people and sick people and

hungry people, and the food began to run short.

And the old man sat on his stool in the sun, every morning, and played tak by himself.

\* \* \*

In the third month, the walls began to fall.

Not all at once. Not in a great assault, with ladders and battering rams, the way the old stories tell it. One stone at a time.

It started on the south wall. A single stone, near the base, low down, where no one would notice. It cracked. For no reason. We found it one morning, split clean through, as if someone had struck it with a hammer.

The next morning, another stone. And the next. And the next. Always on the south wall. Always low down. Always in the night, when no one was watching.

My arcanist—I had a new one, after Caudicus, a young man from the University named Pell, very clever, very frightened—my arcanist said it was sympathy. Very strong. Very patient. Someone was binding the stones to something else, something far away, and breaking the something else, one piece at a time, so that the stones broke too.

"Who could do that?" I asked him. "Who could reach so far, and hold so long?"

He did not know. But I did. I looked out my window, the next morning, and saw the old man on his stool in the sun, playing tak by himself. And I saw that there was a pile of stones beside him, on the ground. Small grey stones, like river pebbles.

As I watched, he picked one up. He held it in his hand for a moment. Then he laid it on the tak board, very carefully, in the pattern.

And he closed his hand around it, and squeezed.

That night, another stone cracked in my south wall.

\* \* \*

It took him forty-one days. Forty-one stones. One every night. Slowly, patiently, the way stone does everything. The way the sea wears away a cliff.

On the forty-second morning, the south wall of Severen came down.

It did not fall. It sagged. It slumped, the way a drunk man slumps against a wall, and then slid, slowly, stone by stone, into the ditch at its foot. By noon there was a gap in the wall of Severen fifty feet wide. And through the gap, ten thousand men.

We fought them in the streets. For three days. Street by street, house by house. My captains died. My soldiers died. Corrin died on the south wall, in the first hour, holding the breach with twenty men while I tried to get the women and children out through the north gate.

I did not get them all out. I got some.

\* \* \*

On the third day, I went for Meluan.

She was in the palace, in her rooms, in the green room where you told her about her sister. She was very near her time. She could not run. She could barely walk. I had left her there with four guards and Stapes and a physician, because I thought the palace would hold longest, and she would be safest there.

I fought my way up the cliff road. I do not remember much of it. I remember the smoke, and the noise, and a great many men in black and silver. I remember the gate of the palace, standing open. I remember the courtyard, full of bodies. I remember the stairs.

I remember reaching the door of her rooms, and finding it open, and the four guards dead in the corridor outside, and Stapes lying on the floor inside with blood on his head, unconscious but alive. And the physician dead in a chair. And the bed empty.

And on the pillow, where her head had been, a tak stone. White. Set very carefully in the center of the pillow, the way you would set a stone on a board.

I stood in that room for a long time. I do not know how long. Stapes woke, eventually, and found me there, and took me by the arm, and led me down the back stair and out the postern gate and into the hills. I do not remember that either. I only remember the white stone on the pillow.

I have it still. Here.

\* \* \*

*He reached into his shirt and drew it out. It hung on a leather thong around his neck. A small smooth white stone, the kind you play tak with. He held it in his palm and looked at it in the firelight for a long time.*

*"He wanted me to know," he said at last. "That it was him. That it was a move. That I had lost." He closed his hand around the stone. "He always did like to be sure his opponent understood the position."*

*I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.*

*The Maer looked at me across the fire. His hollow face was very still.*

*"When you go to the door," he said, "will he be there?"*

*"Yes."*

*"Will you kill him?"*

*I thought about it. About the garden in Severen, and my sword at his throat, and a thin line of blood running down into his collar.*

*"I don't know," I said honestly. "I tried once. I couldn't."*

*The Maer looked at me for a long moment. Then he took the leather thong from around his neck, with the white stone on it, and held it out to me across the fire.*

*"Take this," he said. "And if he is there, give it back to him. From me." His voice was very quiet. "Tell him it's my move."*

\* \* \*

I took it. I wore it, under my shirt, beside Denna's knot, all the way to the Lackless house.

I never gave it back. Bredon went through the door before I had the chance.

But I did not throw it away, either. I gave it to the Penitent King, in the end, the morning I left Renere in the back of a cart, under a canvas cover. Stapes carried it to him.

Stapes wrote me, afterward, that the king wore it every day of his life. On the leather thong, around his neck, under the plain grey robes.

And that sometimes, late at night, in the palace, he would take it out and hold it in his palm and look at it for a long time.

Stapes said he never knew why. He said the king never told him.

I think I know. I think it was a reminder. That you can lose everything, one stone at a time, while you are busy watching the center of the board.

And that the game is never over. Not really. Not while you still have a move.

## Interlude: The Waterfall

Bast went out to the waystone while the innkeeper was upstairs.

He did not tell anyone he was going. He slipped out the kitchen door and across the yard, past the well and the stable, and out onto the road. It was late afternoon on the third day, and the light was thin and gold and slanting. The square of Newarre was empty. Everyone was at home, or in the fields, or at Shep's widow's house, where there was always someone sitting with her now.

The waystone stood at the corner of the crossroads, where it had always stood. Tall and grey and weathered, taller than a man, leaning very slightly to the east. There was lichen on its north face, and a crack running down the south side, and at its foot, half buried in the grass, the remains of an old stone bench where travelers used to rest.

Bast stopped in front of it. And the noise hit him.

\* \* \*

It was always like this. Every time. Seven years, and he had never gotten used to it.

Mortals did not hear it. The innkeeper had told him that, the first year, when Bast had come back from the crossroads white-faced and shaking. *It's just a stone, Bast. An old greystone. There are hundreds of them all over the Four Corners.* And it was true; mortals walked past the waystone every day, and leaned on it, and let their children climb on it, and never heard a thing.

But Bast was not mortal. And to Bast, standing in front of the waystone was like standing at the foot of a great waterfall. A roar. A



thunder. A vast, endless, crashing sound that filled his ears and his head and his whole body, drowning out everything else. The wind, and the birds, and the rustle of the grass. His own heartbeat. His own thoughts.

His own name.

That was the thing. That was what the waystone did. It drowned out names. All of them. Anything that tried to speak its name near the stone was lost in the roar, the way a single voice is lost in a thunderstorm. That was why the innkeeper had chosen this place, seven years ago. Or why Skarpi had chosen it for him. Because here, beside the waterfall, the thing in the chest upstairs could scream as loud as it liked, and no one would hear.

Bast stood in the roar and closed his eyes.

\* \* \*

He had come here a great many times, over the years. More than the innkeeper knew. He came when he could not bear the inn any longer. When the silence of it pressed on him like a hand on his chest. When the innkeeper had gone a whole day without saying a single thing that was not *pass the salt* or *the roof is leaking* or *yes*.

He came and stood in front of the waystone and let it drown him. It hurt. It always hurt. But it was a clean kind of hurt, like cold water, and afterward, when he walked away and the roar faded behind him, the world always seemed a little quieter. A little more bearable.

And sometimes, standing in the roar, he talked.

He did not know if the stone heard him. He did not think it could. It was a stone. It did not have ears. But Bast had grown up in the twilight, where everything had ears, where the trees listened and the rivers remembered and even the wind kept secrets. And he could not quite believe that anything as loud as the waystone could be entirely deaf.

So he talked. And the stone drowned out every word. And that was the point.

\* \* \*

"I did something terrible," Bast said now, to the stone.

The roar swallowed it. He could not hear his own voice. He went on anyway.

"Three days ago. Four. I don't know anymore; the days are all running together. I found two men on the road. Soldiers. Deserters. And I brought them to the inn. I lied to them. I told them he had gold." He swallowed. "I wanted them to hurt him. I wanted him to fight back. I thought if he fought back, he'd remember. I thought if he got angry enough—"

He stopped. The roar went on.

"He didn't fight back," said Bast. "He just stood there. And they hit him, and hit him, and he didn't do anything. He just stood there with his hands at his sides and let them." His voice cracked. The stone did not care. "And I couldn't bear it. And I killed them. Both of them. In the common room. With my hands." He looked down at his hands. They were shaking. "And then I carried them out into the woods and buried them. And I came back and cleaned the floor. And I haven't told him. I haven't told anyone."

The waystone roared.

"And now there's a scribe," said Bast. "And the innkeeper is telling him everything. Everything. And every word he says, his name gets louder. I can hear it. Even with the chest shut. Even with the waystone. It's getting louder. It's coming back." He was crying now. He did not wipe his face. "And that's what I wanted. That's what I've wanted for seven years. That's why I did all of it. The soldiers and the scribe and all of it."

He pressed his hands against the cold grey stone.

"So why am I so frightened?"

\* \* \*

The waystone did not answer. It never did. It went on roaring, the way it had roared since before there was a Newarre, since before there was a road, since before anyone could remember. It roared, and Bast stood with his hands pressed against it and his forehead pressed against it and wept.

He did not hear the footsteps behind him. He could not hear anything, in the roar.

But he felt the hand on his shoulder.

\* \* \*

He spun around. His hands came up. His teeth were bared. For a moment, just a moment, his glamour slipped, and something else looked out of his face. Something old and wild and dangerous, from the deep twilight, with eyes like the sea at night.

It was Chronicler.

The scribe stood very still. He did not back away. He had seen Bast's true face before, on the first night, on the road outside Newarre, and he had been terrified. He was terrified now. Bast could see it. But he did not back away.

Bast let the glamour close again. Slowly. His hands came down. He stepped away from the stone, and the roar faded, and he could hear again. The wind, and the birds, and his own ragged breathing.

"What are you doing here?" he said. His voice was hoarse.

"He sent me," said Chronicler. "He said you'd be here. He said you come here, sometimes, when things are hard." He hesitated. "He said to tell you supper's ready."

Bast stared at him.

"He knows?" he said. "That I come here?"

"He said he's always known."

\* \* \*

They stood in the road for a long moment, in the thin gold light. Bast looked at the scribe. At his thin face, and his careful eyes, and the scabs on his knuckles.

"How much did you hear?" he said.

"Nothing." Chronicler looked at the waystone. "I couldn't. It's very loud. Isn't it?" He hesitated. "I didn't know that. I thought it was just a stone. But when I came close, when I put my hand on your shoulder—" He frowned. "I felt it. Just for a moment. Like standing under a bridge when a cart goes over."

"You're a namer," said Bast slowly. "A little. Aren't you? More than you let on."

Chronicler did not answer. That was answer enough.

Bast looked at him for a long time. Then he looked back at the waystone. Grey and tall and weathered, leaning slightly east, with the lichen on its north face.

"I'm going to tell him," Bast said. "Tonight. Or tomorrow. Before it's over." He did not look at Chronicler. "Something I did. Something terrible. I've been carrying it, and I can't carry it anymore." He was quiet. "Will you be there? When I tell him?"

"If you want me to be."

"I don't know if I want you to be." Bast laughed shakily. "But I think I need someone to be. Someone who isn't him. Someone who'll write it down." He looked at Chronicler. "So it's real. So it's said. So I can't take it back."

Chronicler was quiet for a moment.

"I'll be there," he said.

\* \* \*

They walked back to the Waystone together, across the empty square, in the fading light. At the door of the inn, Bast stopped.

"Scribe," he said.

"Yes?"

"He said he's always known. That I come to the stone." Bast's voice was very quiet. "Do you think he knows the other thing too? The terrible thing?"

Chronicler looked at him. Then he looked through the window of the inn, at the innkeeper, moving behind the bar, setting out bowls for supper. Red hair, and green eyes, and a face that was calmer, now, on the third day, than it had been on the first.

"I think," said Chronicler carefully, "that he knows a great many things now. That he didn't know three days ago."

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he nodded, very slightly, and opened the door, and went in.

Behind them, at the corner of the crossroads, the waystone roared. The way it had always roared. The way it would roar long after all of them were gone.

It had heard every word. Of course it had.

It was a stone. Stones are very good at keeping things.

## Chapter Ninety-Nine

# A Council in the Rocks

They came the next morning, up the same path Hallow's Company had come up the night before. Four of them, on tired horses, with a mule carrying their packs.

I was sitting at the Maer's fire at the head of the valley, eating a heel of Mirra's bread, when I saw them. I did not recognize them at first. They were dusty and ragged and thin, like everyone else in the valley. They rode slowly, with their heads down.

Then the one in front looked up, and I saw a thatch of straw-colored hair and a thin eager face, and I dropped my bread.

"Sim," I said.

He saw me. His face went through several shapes very quickly. Then he slid off his horse and ran up the valley toward me, stumbling on the rocks, and I stood up and ran down to meet him, and we collided somewhere in the middle and nearly knocked each other over.

"You're alive," he said. "You're alive, you're alive, you're *alive*—"

"You say that every time."

"Because every time you're *alive*, Kvothe! Every time I think you're dead and you're not!" He was laughing and crying at the same time. "Five months! Five months, and not a word! We thought you were lost in the Fae forever!"

"I was. For a while."

Behind him, the others had dismounted. Wil, with his scarred hands held carefully at his sides. Devi, in a dusty travelling cloak with her spectacles pushed up on her forehead and her satchel over her

shoulder. And Fela, pale and thin, with her dark hair braided and a look on her face that I could not read.

Wil came up and embraced me, briefly and hard, the way he always did.

"You owe me more drinks," he said. "I've lost count."

"I'll pay you back."

"You keep saying that."

Devi did not embrace me. She stood in front of me with her hands on her hips and glared at me.

"Five months," she said. "Do you know how much interest accrues in five months?"

"Hello, Devi."

"Don't you *hello* Devi me." Her voice cracked. Then she threw her arms around my neck and held on so tight I could not breathe. "You idiot," she said into my shoulder. "You stupid, stupid idiot."

Fela came last. She stood in front of me and looked at me for a long moment with her dark serious eyes.

"Do you have it?" she said.

I reached into my pocket and took out the flat grey stone from the Eolian's foundation. I held it out.

"I haven't given it back yet," I said. "I told you I would, when I came back."

She looked at it. Then she closed my fingers over it with her own.

"Keep it a little longer," she said. "You're not back yet. Not really."

\* \* \*

They had come south from Imre when the news reached them that Severen had fallen. Threpe had paid for everything: the horses, the supplies, the bribes at the border. He had wanted to come himself, but his physician had forbidden it. So he had sent them instead, with a purse of gold and a letter for the Maer and a great deal of advice about the proper wines to serve at a war council.

"He said to tell you," said Sim, "that if you die, he'll never forgive you. And that he's commissioning a statue of you for the square in

front of the Eolian, and he'll make them give you a very small nose out of spite."

"That's very like him."

"And Stanchion's—" Sim stopped. "Deoch's rebuilding the Eolian. He started a month ago. He's doing it himself, stone by stone. The way Stanchion did." He looked at me. "He said to tell you it'll be ready for you. When you come back. He said you owe him a song."

I did not say anything. I could not.

\* \* \*

We held a council that afternoon, in the mouth of the Maer's cave.

It was the strangest council I have ever been part of. The Maer sat on a flat rock at the center, with his bandaged arm in his lap, looking like a king in exile, which he was. His captains stood around him, grim and hard-faced men in battered armor. Stapes stood at his elbow, calm and precise.

Tessit and Mirra were there, for the Ruh. Tessit had taken off his battered hat and was turning it in his hands.

Sim and Wil and Devi and Fela were there, sitting on the rocks in a row like students at a lecture.

Bast was there, sitting on a rock a little apart from everyone else, with his legs drawn up and his hooves hidden under his cloak. The Maer's captains kept glancing at him and then glancing away.

And I was there. Standing in the middle of it all, with Denna's cord inside my shirt and the door's name sitting in my bones like a stone.

"Four days," I said. "Maybe five. Until the dark of the moon. That's when they'll open the door."

"Where?" said one of the captains. A lean grey man named Dagon, with a face like a hatchet.

"Beneath the Lackless house. In the hills near Levinshir." I looked at the Maer. "Your grace knows it?"

"I know it." The Maer's voice was flat. "My wife's family seat. It has been empty for twenty years. Since her father died. She would never go there." He paused. "She said it was cold."



"The king's army is marching there now," I said. "They'll arrive in two or three days. They'll wait for the dark of the moon. And then they'll go down to the door."

"How many men?" said Dagon.

"Ten thousand, when they took Severen," said another captain. "Less now. They've left garrisons behind. Seven thousand, maybe. Eight."

"And we have three hundred," said Dagon. "And a handful of Ruh and refugees." He looked at me. "We cannot fight them."

"No," I said. "We can't."

"Then what—"

"We don't fight them. We go around them. Under them. Through them." I looked around the circle. "We don't need to beat their army. We only need to do two things. Get the Maer's wife and daughter out of the king's camp. And get me to the door."

The circle was silent.

"You want to go to the door," said the Maer slowly. "The door they want to open. The door they need you to open."

"Yes."

"Why?"

I looked at him. I looked at all of them. At Sim and Wil and Devi and Fela, at Tessit and Mirra, at Bast.

"Because I know how to close it," I said. "For good. So no one can ever open it again. Not them, not the baby, not anyone." I paused. "But I have to be there. At the door. With the key in my hand."

"The key," said the Maer. "The box. The king wears it around his neck."

"Yes."

"So you need to take it from him."

"Yes."

The circle was silent again. Longer, this time.

"That," said Dagon at last, "is the most insane plan I have ever heard."

"I know."

"You want to walk into the middle of an army of eight thousand men, steal the king's own necklace off his neck, walk out again, and go down into a hole in the ground to fight whatever's waiting for you there." He stared at me. "Alone?"

"Not alone," I said.

And that was when the Adem arrived.

\* \* \*

They came up the lower path in single file, as silent as shadows. Twelve of them. Small and slim, in the blood-red clothes of the Adem mercenaries, close-fitting and bound with a hundred cords. They walked with the easy, unhurried grace of people who know exactly how dangerous they are and do not need to prove it to anyone.

The soldiers at the lower end of the valley saw them and reached for their weapons. The Adem did not stop. They did not even look at the soldiers. They walked straight up the valley, through the camp, past the fires and the refugees and the staring children, until they came to the mouth of the Maer's cave.

The one in front stopped. She was small and plain, with short dark hair and a face that showed nothing at all. There was a sword on her back.

"Vashet," I said.

"Kvothe." She looked at me. Her hands moved. *Relief. Anger. Something else.* "You are alive."

"Barely."

"Barely is enough." She looked around the circle. At the Maer, and his captains, and my friends, and the Ruh, and Bast. Her eyes lingered on Bast for a long moment. Then she looked back at me. "I told you I would come back. Before the end."

"You did."

"This is the end." It was not a question.

"Yes."

"Good." She turned to the Maer and bowed, a small precise Adem bow. "I am Vashet, of the school of Haert. These are my brothers and sisters. Shehyn has sent us." She paused. "We are yours. Until this is

done."

The Maer stared at her. Then at the eleven others standing silent behind her. Then at me.

"Kvothe," he said. "What is this?"

"This," I said, "is how we get to the door."

\* \* \*

Behind Vashet, one of the Adem stepped forward. A man, tall for an Adem, lean and quiet, with pale eyes and a face I knew.

"Tempi," I said.

He looked at me. His face did not change. But his hands moved. *Greeting. Joy. Family.*

I had not seen him since Haert. Since the day he brought me there, to be judged by his school, for the crime of letting a barbarian learn the Ketan. He had stood beside me through it all. He had been my first teacher among the Adem, and my friend.

I crossed the circle and took his hands in mine, the Adem way. He held them. His grip was very strong.

"You came," I said.

"Of course," he said. His voice was quiet and careful, the way it always was, in a language that was not his own. "You are my student. You are in trouble. Where else would I be?"

\* \* \*

We planned all afternoon, and into the night.

Tessit had the first idea. He was sitting on his rock, turning his battered hat in his hands, listening to the captains argue, when he said, quite suddenly, "We played there. Five days ago. In the king's camp."

Everyone turned to look at him.

"They let us in," he said. "The soldiers. They like music. They're bored, marching all day. And the king likes it too, they said. He had us play in front of his pavilion. We got very close." He looked at me. "We could play there again. On the road to the Lackless house. They're camped every night. We could ask to play. They'd let us in."

"And I'd be with you," I said slowly.

"You'd be with us. You're Ruh. You'd fit right in." Tessit smiled faintly. "We'd have to do something about the hair, though."

"Bast can do that."

Everyone looked at Bast. He looked back at them, a little startled.

"I can," he said. "A glamour. I can make his hair brown. Or black. Or green, if you like." He grinned suddenly. "I could give him a big nose. Like on the posters."

"Brown will do," I said.

"And once you're in?" said Dagon. "Once you're in the camp, close to the king, playing your little songs. Then what?"

"Then we get to the Maer's wife and daughter," I said. "And we get them out."

"How?"

I looked at Vashet. She looked back at me, and her hands moved. *Leave it to us.*

"The Adem," I said. "While the Ruh are playing, and everyone's watching them, the Adem will be in the camp. They'll get to the lady's tent. They'll get her and the baby out."

"And the key? The box around the king's neck?"

I did not answer right away. I looked at Devi.

She looked back at me. Then she smiled her spider's smile and patted the satchel on her lap.

"I've been working on something," she said. "On the road down from Imre. Something for exactly this."

"What is it?"

"A surprise." Her smile widened. "You'll like it. It makes a lot of noise."

\* \* \*

It was very late when the council finally broke up. People drifted away to their caves and tents and fires. The Maer went into his cave to sleep. His captains went to see to their men. Tessit and Mirra went back to their wagons.

I stayed by the fire. I sat on a flat rock with my lute in my lap and did not play it.

After a while, Bast came and sat beside me.

"It's a good plan," he said.

"It's a terrible plan."

"It's a terrible plan," Bast agreed. "But it's a good terrible plan. The best kind." He looked at me. "Are you afraid?"

"Yes."

"Good. Only fools aren't afraid." He was quiet for a moment. "Reshi. The door. What you're going to do there. To close it." He hesitated. "It's going to cost you something. Isn't it? Something big."

I did not answer.

"I heard some of what Selitos said," Bast went on quietly. "In the tower. I was pretending to sleep. I heard him say you'd have to give up your name." He looked at me. "Is that true?"

I looked at him for a long time.

"Yes," I said.

Bast was silent. He looked into the fire.

"And the girl," he said at last. "The one with the knots. She's going to hold it for you."

"If she's willing."

"She is. I saw your face when you read her letter. She said she would." Bast's voice was very quiet. "You're going to give your name to the girl who's bound to the man who wants it most."

"Yes."

"That's insane."

"I know."

"The Cthaeh said—"

"I know what the Cthaeh said." I looked at him. "Bast. There's no one else. There's no one else in the world who can do it. Not Elodin, not Fela, not Selitos. Only her. And she's willing." I paused. "And her knot's loosened. The song loosened it. She's not his, not all the way. Not anymore."

"And if she is? If he pulls the cord, and she gives it to him?"

I did not answer.

Bast looked at me for a long time. Then he looked away.

"Then I'll kill him," he said quietly. "I'll find him, and I'll kill him, and I'll take it back. And I'll keep it safe myself."

"Bast—"

"I mean it." He turned to look at me. His deep blue eyes were very bright in the firelight. "I owe you a life, Reshi. The old kind. I'll pay it. Whatever it costs." He paused. "Whatever it costs *me*."

I looked at him. At his fine-boned face and his fierce wet eyes.

*You will keep him in a cage of your own making*, the Cthaeh had said to him. *And you will call it love*.

I did not know that, then. He had not told me. But I think I felt it, somehow. The shape of it. The weight.

"Thank you, Bast," I said.

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he smiled, a small, fierce, crooked smile.

"Don't thank me," he said. "Just don't die."

## Chapter One Hundred

# Tempi's Question

Tempi found me that afternoon, on the rocks above the Maer's cave, where I had gone to be alone.

He did not announce himself. The Adem never do. I was sitting on a flat grey boulder with my knees drawn up, looking out over the hills toward the south, where a smudge of smoke on the horizon marked the king's camp. And then I became aware that he was sitting on the boulder beside me, cross-legged, with his hands resting on his knees, looking at the same smudge of smoke.

I did not know how long he had been there. I did not ask.

"Tempi," I said.

He nodded. His hands moved on his knees. *Greeting. Gentle.*

We sat in silence for a long time. The wind moved in the grass below us. Far off, a hawk was circling, very high, a small dark cross against the grey sky.

"You are going to kill a king," said Tempi at last.

\* \* \*

It was not a question. The Adem do not ask many questions; they think it rude to demand an answer from someone who may not wish to give one. But it was not quite a statement either. It hung in the air between us, waiting, the way Tempi's words often did.

"I don't know," I said. "Maybe. If I have to."

Tempi did not say anything. His hands were still.

"He has Meluan," I said. "The Maer's wife. My aunt. And her child. He's taking them to the Lackless house, to open the door. And if he opens it—" I stopped. I did not know how to explain the door to Tempi. I did not know how to explain the Thief, and the crack, and the things that were pressing against the other side. "It would be very bad," I said at last. "For everyone. For the whole world."

"And to stop this, you will kill him."

"If I have to."

Tempi was quiet for a long moment.

"Is it of the Lethani?" he said.

\* \* \*

I did not answer at once. I had known he would ask. I had been asking myself for days, ever since the Maer had told me about Severen, and the king's army, and Meluan in the black and silver tent. I had asked myself in the twilight of the Fae, and on the long road down from the greystone, and on the rocks the night before, staring up at the stars.

I had not found an answer.

"I don't know," I said. "I thought you might tell me."

Tempi looked at me. His pale eyes were very calm.

"I cannot tell you," he said. "The Lethani is not a thing one person can tell another. You know this. It is a thing you must find. In yourself. In the moment." His hands moved. *Gentle reproach*. "You have learned this. At Haert. From Shehyn. From Vashet. From me."

"I know. But this is different."

"How is it different?"

"Because it's a king." I heard my own voice rise, and I pulled it down again. "Because it's not a bandit on a road, or a man with a sword coming at me. It's a king, sitting in his tent, surrounded by his guards. And I'm going to walk in there with a lie on my face and a knife in my boot, and I'm going to—" I stopped. "It's murder, Tempi. Whatever else it is. It's murder."

Tempi did not answer. He looked out at the smudge of smoke on the horizon.



\* \* \*

"When I was young," he said at last, "younger than you, I went on my first contract. A merchant in Vintas. He had hired the Adem to guard his caravan through the mountains. There were bandits. We fought them." He was quiet for a moment. "I killed a man. My first. He was young, like me. He had a sword, and he came at me, and I killed him. With my hands." He looked at his hands, resting on his knees. "It was of the Lethani. I knew it. I did not doubt."

"But?"

"But the merchant," said Tempi, "was carrying slaves. In the last wagon. Under the cloth. Children. From the south. To sell in Vintas." His voice did not change. "The bandits knew. They had come to free them. The man I killed was the brother of one of the children."

The wind moved in the grass. The hawk turned, high above us.

"I did not know," said Tempi. "When I fought. I did not know. I thought I was doing the Lethani. I thought I was right." He was quiet for a long moment. "Afterward, I went to Shehyn. I told her. I asked her if I had done the Lethani, in killing that man. And she said to me: *You did the Lethani you knew. But the Lethani you knew was very small.*"

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long time.

"What happened?" I said at last. "To the children?"

"I freed them." Tempi's face did not change. "That night. I broke my contract. I took them from the wagon and I brought them to the bandits' camp, in the mountains, and I gave them back." He paused. "The Adem do not break contracts. It was a great shame. I was sent back to Haert. I was not allowed to take another contract for three years." His hands moved. *Acceptance. Old pain.* "It was of the Lethani. The breaking. I knew this, too. But it did not bring back the young man with the sword."

"Why are you telling me this?"

Tempi turned his head and looked at me.

"Because you ask if killing the king is of the Lethani," he said. "And I cannot tell you. But I can tell you this: whatever you decide, you will decide with the Lethani you know. And the Lethani you know may be very small." He looked back at the smoke. "You do not know everything about this king. You do not know everything about the door. You do not know everything about yourself. No one does. That is the way of things."

"Then how do I decide?"

"You decide," said Tempi, "and then you carry it."

\* \* \*

I looked at him. His face was calm and still, the way Adem faces always are. But his hands, resting on his knees, had curled very slightly. *Old pain.*

"That's not very comforting," I said.

"No." Something moved at the corner of his mouth. It was the closest thing to a smile I had ever seen on him. "The Lethani is not for comfort. It is for knowing what to do." He was quiet. "Comfort is for afterward. For friends. For fires at night." He looked at me. "That is why I came."

"To comfort me?"

"To be here afterward." Tempi's pale eyes were very steady. "Whatever you do. Whether it is of the Lethani or not. Whether you know or not." His hands moved. *Family. Promise.* "You will need someone to sit with. After. When you are carrying it. I have carried such a thing. I know its weight." He paused. "It is lighter, with someone to sit with."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything. I could not. I sat on the boulder with my knees drawn up and looked at the smudge of smoke on the horizon, and my eyes stung, and I did not know if it was the wind.

After a while, Tempi reached out and put his hand on my shoulder. The Adem do not touch often, except in fighting and in love. It was a very light touch. Barely there.

"You are my student," he said quietly. "Whatever you do tomorrow, you will still be my student. That does not change."

"Even if I kill a king?"

"Even if you kill a god," said Tempi. "Even if you break the world." He took his hand away. "It is not what you do that makes you my student. It is that I taught you. And I did. And that is finished, and cannot be unfinished."

\* \* \*

He stayed with me until the sun went down. We did not talk much more. We sat on the boulder and watched the light fade over the hills, and the smoke on the horizon turn from grey to black to a faint red glow, as the king's camp lit its fires for the night.

When it was dark, he stood up.

"Tomorrow," he said, "I will be at your left side. Vashet at your right. We will get you to the tent." His hands moved. *Certainty*. "What happens in the tent is yours."

"Thank you, Tempi."

He looked down at me. In the dark, I could not see his face. But I heard something in his voice that I had never heard before, in all the months I had known him. Something very like tenderness.

"Do not thank me," he said. "Come back. That is thanks enough."

And he went away down the rocks, silent as a shadow, toward the fire where Bast was waiting.

\* \* \*

He was at my left side, the next night. He did what he said he would do. He got me to the tent.

And afterward—long afterward, after the door, and the grey, and the Tower, and the hanging that was not a hanging—he was the first of the Adem to come to Hallow's Company, in the western hills, when word reached Haert that I was alive. Before Vashet. Before anyone.

I did not know him. I did not know anyone, then. I sat on the tailboard of a wagon with my hands in my lap and looked at the lean pale-eyed man standing in the road, and felt nothing.

He did not seem to mind. He sat down beside me on the tailboard. He did not say anything. He sat with me for three days, from dawn until dark, and did not say a single word, and then he got up and bowed to me, the Adem way, and went back north to Haert.

Mirra asked me, afterward, who he was. I did not know. I only knew that for three days, sitting beside him, something in me had been a little lighter.

I understand now. He had kept his promise. He had come to sit with me. After. While I was carrying it.

Even though I did not know what I was carrying. Even though I did not know him.

It is lighter, with someone to sit with.

## Chapter One Hundred One

# How to Be No One

Tessit made me into no one that evening, by the light of a cookfire, with a comb and a fiddle and a great deal of patience.

"Sit," he said. "There. On the crate. And don't talk."

I sat. He stood in front of me with his battered hat pushed back on his head and his lean brown face very serious, and he looked at me for a long time. Not at my face. At all of me. The way a carpenter looks at a board before he cuts it.

"Well," he said at last. "The hair's the worst of it."

"I know."

"No, you don't." He pulled a lock of it between his fingers and held it up to the firelight. "You think it's the color. Red like a fire, red like a fox. Everyone in the Four Corners has heard about the red-haired Kingkiller, or they will soon." He let it go. "But the color's easy. Your Fae friend says he'll see to the color, tomorrow, with his glammers. It's what you *do* with it that'll hang you."

"What do I do with it?"

"You toss it." Tessit sat down on the crate across from me. "When you're thinking. You push it back off your forehead with your left hand. Like this." He did it, and it was so exactly the way I did it that I felt myself flush. "And you tilt your head, just a little, when someone's talking to you, so it falls to one side. Like a bird. Like you're listening with your whole face." He shook his head. "You've done it three times since I sat down. A man who's seen you once would know you across a field by that. Dyed or not."

\* \* \*

Mirra did the combing. "A glamour changes the color," she said. "It doesn't change how you wear it. And no Ruh fiddler wears his hair like a lord's poet." She combed it flat and dull and tied it back at the neck with a scrap of string, the way the working men of the troupe wore theirs, so it would hang lank over my shoulders under a hat, while I sat on the crate with my eyes shut.

"Your mother used to do something like this," she said, as she worked. "Dyed hers. Every few months. You wouldn't remember. You were very small. She'd sit on the tailboard, and your father would do it for her, with walnut hulls, and the two of them would laugh the whole time and get it all over everything." Her fingers were gentle on my scalp. "I asked her once why she bothered. Her hair wasn't red like yours. It was dark, with only a little red in it. You had to be close to see."

"What did she say?"

"She said, *Close is what I'm worried about.*" Mirra was quiet for a moment. "I didn't understand. I thought she meant jealous wives, or creditors, or some lord she'd crossed. I didn't know about the door."

I did not say anything. I sat with my eyes shut and let her work, and thought about my mother on a tailboard, laughing, with walnut dye on her hands.

\* \* \*

When the combing was done, Tessit took over again.

"Stand up," he said. "Walk to the wagon and back."

I walked to the wagon and back.

Tessit sighed.

"Again," he said. "And this time, walk like you've never killed anyone."

I stopped. I looked at him.

"You walk like a fighter," said Tessit, not unkindly. "Weight forward. Feet quiet. Hands loose. Eyes going everywhere, counting the exits." He shrugged. "I don't know where you learned it. But any

soldier in that camp will see it the moment you step out of the wagon. And a soldier who sees a fighter where he expected a fiddler asks questions."

"Then how should I walk?"

Tessit thought about it.

"Like Brin," he said.

\* \* \*

Brin was the fiddler of Hallow's Company. He was a stout, balding, cheerful man of about fifty, who played the fiddle with great enthusiasm and very little skill, and who walked everywhere as if the ground were slightly uneven and he were slightly drunk. Which, most of the time, he was.

"Come here, Brin," said Tessit. "Walk for the boy."

Brin walked. He walked from the fire to the wagon and back, with his belly out and his shoulders slumped and his feet shuffling in the grass. He hummed as he went. He scratched his ear. He stopped halfway to look at something on the ground, lost interest, and went on.

"There," said Tessit. "Do that."

I tried. It was the hardest thing Tessit ever asked me to do.

\* \* \*

I had played a great many parts in my life. I had played them on the stage, as a child, in my father's troupe: kings and beggars and heroes and villains and once, memorably, a talking goat. I had played them in the Maer's court, and the Eolian, and the Archives, and a hundred inns and taverns across the Four Corners. I had played Kvothe the Arcane and Kvothe the Bloodless and Kvothe who talked his way into the University at fifteen. I had played the hero of every story anyone had ever told about me.

But I had never played no one.

It is harder than you would think. Everything in me wanted to be seen. Everything I had ever done had been done to be seen. The songs, the stories, the clever tricks, the brave stupid gestures. I had spent my whole life standing in the center of the stage with every light on me.

And now Tessit wanted me to stand at the back. In the shadows. With my shoulders slumped and my belly out and my feet shuffling. Humming tunelessly. Scratching my ear. Being nobody anyone would ever look at twice.

"No," said Tessit, the first time. "You're *acting* like Brin. Everyone can see you acting. Stop acting."

"How do I stop acting and still act?"

Tessit looked at me for a long moment.

"You stop wanting them to watch," he said.

\* \* \*

I tried again. And again. And again. For an hour, by the light of the cookfire, while the children giggled and the dogs barked and Brin sat on a crate eating stew and offering helpful comments.

And somewhere in the second hour, I found it.

I do not know how to describe it. It was not a thing I did. It was a thing I stopped doing. I stopped reaching. I stopped listening for applause. I stopped waiting, in the back of my mind, for someone to turn and look and see me. I let my shoulders go. I let my feet go. I let my face go slack and a little stupid, and my eyes go soft, and I thought about nothing. About stew. About whether it would rain. About a tune that went nowhere.

And I walked to the wagon and back.

Nobody laughed. Tessit did not say anything. He watched me, with his lean brown face very still. Then he nodded, slowly.

"There," he said quietly. "That's it. That's no one."

\* \* \*

Mirra was looking at me strangely.

"What?" I said.

"Nothing." She shook her head. "Only—" She hesitated. "Your mother could do that. Just like that. I saw her do it once, in a town where there'd been trouble. Soldiers in the square, looking at every face. She went from being the most beautiful woman in the troupe to being nobody. Just like that. Like blowing out a candle." She looked at



me. "I never knew how she did it. I asked her. She said, *You just stop wanting to be found.*"

I stood by the wagon in the firelight with my lank tied-back hair and my slumped shoulders, and I thought about my mother. Blowing herself out like a candle, in a square full of soldiers. Wrapping herself in a small name, and a stained face, and a trouper's life, so that the thing beneath her family's house would never hear her.

*You just stop wanting to be found.*

\* \* \*

Tessit gave me the fiddle last. An old one, scarred and cheap, with a crack in the back and strings that would not hold their tune.

"Play badly," he said. "Like Brin. On purpose. Every third note flat." He handed me the bow. "It's the hardest part. I know. You'll want to play well. Your fingers will want to. Every time they reach for the right note, you'll have to stop them."

I held the fiddle. I put it under my chin. I drew the bow across the strings, and played "Tinker Tanner," and made every third note flat.

It hurt. I want you to understand that. It hurt the way it hurts to walk on a broken ankle. Every wrong note was a small betrayal of everything I was. My fingers screamed at me. My ears screamed at me. I played the whole song through, flat and scratchy and clumsy, and when I finished, I was sweating.

Brin applauded, delighted.

"Better than me," he said. "Almost."

\* \* \*

"You'll do," said Tessit, when the fire was burning low. "Tomorrow night. You'll sit on the tailboard of the third wagon and play the second fiddle, badly, and you won't look at anyone, and no one will look at you." He was quiet for a moment. "Except him. The king. He might. He's seen you before."

"He's seen Kvothe before."

"Yes." Tessit looked at me. At my lank hair and my slack face and my slumped shoulders. "Let's hope that's not who he sees."

\* \* \*

He saw me anyway. You know that. I have told you. The barest pause, when his eyes found me on the tailboard. He knew. He had known the moment he saw me.

But I have thought, since, that it was not my face he knew. It was not my hair, or my walk, or the way I held the fiddle. I had done all of those perfectly. Tessit said so, afterward. He said he had never seen anyone learn to be no one so fast.

I think Ambrose knew me because he wanted to. Because he had been looking for me, every day, for a year, in every face. And a man who is looking that hard for someone will find them, no matter how well they hide.

That is the other half of what my mother knew. The half she did not tell Mirra. You can stop wanting to be found. But you cannot stop someone else from wanting to find you.

\* \* \*

"That's what the inn was," said Chronicler slowly. "Wasn't it? Seven years of no one."

The innkeeper looked at him.

"Kote," said Chronicler. "The walk. The face. The polishing. The way you stand behind the bar so no one looks at you twice." He looked down at his page. "Tessit taught you that. By a cookfire. With a fiddle."

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time.

"Tessit taught me how," he said at last. "The grey did the rest. I didn't have to stop wanting to be found, behind that bar. There was nothing left to want." He looked at his hands. "But yes. I suppose it was the same thing. The same part. I just played it for seven years instead of one night."

"And now?"

The innkeeper looked at the frost on the shutters. At the thin line of darkness beneath the door.

"Now," he said, "someone's looking very hard." He picked up his cup. "And I've stopped hiding."

## Chapter One Hundred Two

# The Night Before

We did not sleep the night before the raid on the king's camp. None of us. We sat by the fires in the Maer's hidden valley, in twos and threes, and talked, the way people talk the night before something they may not come back from.

I went from fire to fire. I did not plan it. I only found, as the night wore on, that I could not sit still. That I needed to see each of them, one more time, before the morning.

\* \* \*

Wil was sitting alone at the edge of the camp, on a rock above the stream, with his scarred hands in his lap. He was looking at the stars.

I sat down beside him. He did not look at me.

"Can't sleep?" I said.

"Don't want to." He was quiet for a moment. "If I sleep, I'll dream. And I'll dream about tomorrow. And I'd rather dream about it once, when it happens, than twice."

I looked at his hands. The skin was still pink and shiny and tight, the way skin is after a bad burn. He could move the fingers, but stiffly.

"Do they hurt?" I asked.

"All the time." He said it without any particular feeling. "Arwyl says they always will. A little." He flexed them slowly. "It's all right. It reminds me."

"Of what?"

He looked at me for the first time.

"That I did something," he said. "Once. Something that mattered." He was quiet. "I'm Cealdish, Kvothe. My father is a merchant. His father was a merchant. My whole family, back as far as anyone remembers. We count things. We weigh things. We make ledgers and balance them." He looked down at his hands. "I came to the University to learn to count better. That's all. To come home and help my father count."

"And now?"

"And now I've held up a chandelier with my mind while a Chandrian burned down a music hall. And carried a girl out of a fire. And taught thirty arcanists how to break a riverbank." He laughed softly. "My father will never understand. I'm not sure I do."

"Will you go home? After?"

Wil was quiet for a long time.

"I don't think so," he said at last. "I think I'll stay. At the University. With Kilvin." He looked at his hands. "He says there's a kind of artificing that doesn't need fine fingers. Big work. Heavy work. Bridges and dams and siege engines. He says I'd be good at it." He was quiet. "He says someone should learn it, now. With the door cracked, and things coming through. Someone should know how to build walls."

\* \* \*

Sim was sitting by the big fire with a sheet of paper on his knee and a pen in his hand, not writing. He looked up as I came over and smiled, a little crookedly.

"I'm trying to write a poem," he said. "For tomorrow. For after. For whoever doesn't come back." He looked at the blank page. "It's not going very well."

I sat down beside him.

"You don't have to come," I said. "Tomorrow. You're a poet, Sim. You're not a fighter. You could stay here, with the Maer. No one would think less of you."

"I would." He looked at me. "I'd think less of me." He set down the pen. "Do you know what I was thinking about, just now? Before

you came?"

"What?"

"The first time I met you. In the Mews. My first year. You were so thin, and so angry, and so proud, and you didn't have two pennies to rub together. And you sat down at our table and started talking about sympathy like you'd invented it." He laughed softly. "Wil hated you. Did you know that? For the first month. He said you were insufferable."

"He was right."

"He was. You were." Sim smiled. "But you were also the most interesting person either of us had ever met. And we couldn't stop listening to you." He was quiet for a moment. "I've been listening to you ever since, Kvothe. For three years. Through all of it. The fire and the Chandrian and the door." He looked at me. "I'm not going to stop now. Not tomorrow. I want to hear how it ends."

I did not say anything. I could not.

Sim looked back down at his blank page.

"Besides," he said, with an attempt at lightness, "if I don't come, who's going to write the poem about it? Devi? She'd rhyme *Surprise* with *explode your eyes*."

I laughed. It came out broken.

"That's not a bad rhyme," I said.

"It's a terrible rhyme." Sim picked up his pen again. "Go on. Go see the others. I'm going to try this again."

He did not write the poem that night. He wrote it later. After. When he had one eye, and a black patch with a white star on it, and a great many more things to write about.

It is still a terrible poem. But I have read it more times than I can count.

\* \* \*

Devi was not by any fire. I found her in the back of a wagon, with a lantern and her satchel and a great many small clay pots laid out on a blanket in front of her, sealing them with wax.

"Go away," she said, without looking up. "I'm working."

I climbed into the wagon and sat down across from her.

"I said go away."

"I heard you."

She looked up at me over her spectacles. She had no eyebrows yet; that would come on the Field of Three Rivers. Her face was pale and tired and fierce.

"What do you want?" she said.

I reached into my shirt and took out the page. The one from the Book of Watches, folded small. The one she had given me in her rooms above the butcher's shop, the day after the Nighting. I held it out to her.

"You said you wanted it back," I said. "Someday."

Devi looked at the page for a long time. She did not take it.

"That's not someday," she said. "That's tonight. Tonight's not someday. Someday is after. When it's over and we're all sitting at Anker's getting drunk and laughing about it." She looked at me. "Put it away."

"Devi—"

"*Put it away*, Kvothe." Her voice cracked. "If you give it back to me tonight, it means you don't think you're coming back. And I won't take it. I won't." She looked back down at her clay pots. "You give it back to me at Anker's. Someday. Over a drink. That's the deal."

I looked at her for a long moment. Then I folded the page again and put it back inside my shirt.

"At Anker's," I said. "Someday."

"Good." She sealed another pot. Her hands were shaking. "And you're buying."

\* \* \*

I never did give it back to her. Not really. The next time that page passed between us, it went the other way. She pressed it into my hand in an upstairs room of the Grey Man in Imre, the night before Denna left, when I did not remember who she was or what the page was or why it mattered. *You still owe me for this*, she said. *Don't you forget it.*

I did forget it. For seven years. It lay folded in the bottom of a drawer behind the bar of an inn at a crossroads, and I never once took it out.

I have it in my pocket now. I found it this morning. I intend to pay what I owe.

At Anker's. Over a drink.

\* \* \*

Fela was not by a fire either. She was sitting alone on the flat rock at the head of the valley, where the Maer's cave was, with her palms pressed flat against the stone and her eyes closed.

I did not interrupt her. I sat down a little way off and waited.

After a long time, she opened her eyes and looked at me.

"It's afraid," she said. "The stone. Here. All through these hills." She looked down at her hands, flat on the rock. "It knows something's coming. It can feel the door. Far off. Stirring." She was quiet for a moment. "It's been saying no for ten thousand years. And it's afraid that tomorrow, it won't be enough."

"Will it be?"

Fela looked at me with her dark serious eyes.

"I don't know," she said. "Stone doesn't know the future. It only knows now, and before. Very long before." She took her hands off the rock. "But I'll help it. Tomorrow. Whatever happens. I'll ask it to hold."

"You held the Eolian for three hours."

"I know." She looked down at her hands. "I don't know if I can do it again. It nearly killed me."

"Then don't."

"I have to." She looked at me. "It's what I'm for, Kvothe. I didn't know it, before. I thought I was a student. I thought I'd be a scriv, maybe, or a master someday, if I was lucky. I thought stone was a thing I was studying." She was quiet for a moment. "But it's not. It's a thing I *am*. The way music is a thing you are. I didn't choose it. It chose me." She smiled faintly. "And tomorrow, it needs me."

I did not say anything for a long time.



"Sim loves you," I said at last. "You know that."

"I know." Her smile softened. "I love him too. He writes terrible poems."

"He knows."

"I like them." She looked out at the dark valley, at the scattered fires, at the small hunched shape by the biggest one, bent over a sheet of paper. "They're the only poems anyone's ever written for me. And every one of them is true, even when the rhymes are awful." She was quiet. "Keep him safe tomorrow, Kvothe. If you can. He'll try to be brave. He's no good at it."

"He's better than he thinks."

"I know." She looked at me. "That's what frightens me."

\* \* \*

I did not go to Bast's fire. Bast came to mine.

I had built a small one of my own, at last, near the Maer's cave, and I was sitting beside it with my lute across my knees and my cold hand resting on the strings, not playing. It was very late. The other fires had burned down to embers. The camp was quiet.

He sat down beside me without a word. He held out his hands to the fire.

"You've been to all of them," he said. "I watched you. Wil, and Sim, and Devi, and Fela."

"Yes."

"Saying goodbye."

"Not goodbye."

"Yes it was." He looked at me. "You're not stupid, Reshi. You know what's at the door. You know what you're going to do there." He looked back at the fire. "You were saying goodbye."

I did not answer.

Bast was quiet for a long time.

"You didn't come to mine," he said at last.

"You came to mine."

"That's not the same."

"No." I looked at him. "It's not. I didn't come to yours because I'm not saying goodbye to you."

He went very still.

"You said you'd stay," I said. "Whatever I am, afterward. However much less. You said you'd stay until I'm me again." I looked back at the fire. "I'm holding you to it. So there's nothing to say goodbye for."

Bast did not say anything for a long time. When I looked at him, his face was wet in the firelight, and he was not wiping it.

"That's not fair," he said. His voice was thick. "You can't just—you can't just say something like that, the night before, and expect me to—" He stopped. He pressed his hands against his eyes.

I began to play. Softly. With my stiff cold fingers, clumsily, very slowly. The lullaby my mother used to sing. The one I had played for him in the grey-green hills, while the Cthaeh whispered.

After a while, he took his hands away from his eyes. He leaned his head against my shoulder, the way a child does. And he listened.

We sat by the fire until the sky began to grey in the east. And then we got up, and went to find the others, and walked down out of the hills toward the king's camp.

I have never been able to decide whether I said goodbye to him that night or not.

I think, perhaps, that neither of us has ever stopped saying it.

## Chapter One Hundred Three

# The Players

The king's army was camped in a broad green valley two days' march from the Lackless house, beside a slow brown river, beneath a sky the color of old pewter. There were thousands of tents. They spread out across the valley floor like a field of grey mushrooms, rank on rank, with cookfires smoking between them and banners snapping in the wind. There were horse lines and wagon parks and latrines and a smithy, ringing with the sound of hammers. There were soldiers everywhere, thousands of them, in the black and silver of the house of Jakis and the colors of a dozen lesser lords.

And in the center of it all, on a low rise above the river, there was a great pavilion of black and silver silk.

We came down into the valley at sunset, three wagons painted in bright colors gone dull with dust, pulled by tired horses. Tessit was leading the first horse. Brin was sitting on the seat of the first wagon, sawing away at his fiddle. Illa was walking beside the second wagon, singing "Tinker Tanner."

And I was sitting on the tailboard of the third wagon, with a borrowed fiddle in my lap and a borrowed hat pulled low over my eyes and hair the color of mud.

\* \* \*

Bast had done it that morning, in the Maer's valley. He had sat me down on a rock and stood behind me and put his hands on my head and murmured in that quick sly language of his, and I had felt

something shift. A kind of tingling, starting at my scalp and running down my neck. When he was done, he had handed me a scrap of mirror that Mirra had lent him, and I had looked into it and seen a stranger.

My hair was brown. Not a rich brown, or a warm one. A dull, flat, forgettable brown, the color of old leaves. My face was the same, but somehow not. My nose was a little longer. My chin a little softer. My eyes were not green anymore, but grey, like a rainy sky.

I looked like no one. I looked like any one of a thousand Ruh boys, wandering the roads with a fiddle and a battered hat.

"It won't last forever," Bast had said. "A day. Maybe two. And it'll fade if you get angry, or frightened, or do anything too much like yourself." He had looked at me critically. "So try not to be yourself. For once."

"I'll try."

"You won't," he had said, and grinned. "But try anyway."

\* \* \*

The soldiers stopped us at the edge of the camp. A dozen of them, in black and silver, with pikes. Their sergeant was a heavy, sour-faced man with a scar across his lip.

"Ruh," he said. It was not a question. "What do you want?"

"To play," said Tessit. He took off his battered hat and held it in front of him, humble and hopeful. "We played for the king five days ago, sir. On the road north of here. He liked it. We thought maybe he'd like to hear us again."

The sergeant looked at him. Then at the wagons. Then at Illa, walking beside the second wagon, singing. His sour face softened slightly.

"I remember you," he said. "You had that girl who sang the one about the lady and the lord and the bath." He looked at Illa. "That you?"

Illa smiled at him. It was a very good smile. "That's me."

The sergeant grunted. "All right. Go on through. Set up by the river, near the king's tents. He'll want to hear you after supper." He

looked at the wagons again, and his eyes passed over me without stopping. "And no stealing. Anything goes missing, we'll hang the lot of you."

"We never steal, sir," said Tessit, with great dignity.

The sergeant snorted. But he waved us through.

\* \* \*

We set up on a flat stretch of grass beside the river, a stone's throw from the black and silver pavilion. Tessit and the others unhitched the horses and set out the stage: a few planks laid across trestles, with a painted cloth hung behind for a backdrop. Mirra built a fire. Brin tuned his fiddle, badly. Kellen and Wat began to juggle knives, very fast and very close to each other's heads, and a crowd of soldiers gathered to watch.

I sat on the tailboard of the third wagon with my borrowed fiddle and looked at the pavilion.

It was huge. Black silk walls, rising up into a peaked roof, with silver embroidery along every seam. Silver banners hung from the poles at every corner, snapping in the evening wind. There were guards at every entrance. Many guards. Big men in black armor, with halberds.

And around the pavilion, in a ring, there were smaller tents. Black and silver too, but plainer. For the king's household. His servants, his guards, his favorites.

One of them had a guard at its door who was not in black armor. He was in grey. Plain grey, with no insignia. And he was standing very still.

I looked at that tent for a long time. At its plain black walls, and the guard in grey, and the small window in its side, covered with a flap of silk.

As I watched, the flap moved. A hand pushed it aside. A woman's hand, pale and thin.

And then a face appeared in the window. Pale and thin and very tired, with dark hair pulled back and dark shadows under the eyes.

Meluan.

She looked out at the river. At the Ruh wagons, and the fire, and the soldiers gathered around to watch the juggling. Her face did not change. But her hand, on the edge of the window flap, tightened.

She was looking at the wagons. At the Ruh. The people she had hated all her life, because one of them had taken her sister.

Then she let the flap fall, and was gone.

\* \* \*

The king came out after supper.

The soldiers had been gathering for an hour, more and more of them, until there were hundreds crowded around the little stage by the river. They were sitting on the grass and standing in rows and climbing on wagons to see. They were eating their suppers from tin plates and drinking from leather jacks and laughing and shouting. The fire was high and bright. Kellen and Wat had finished their knife-juggling and Illa had sung two songs, and the crowd was warm and happy and a little drunk.

Then the flaps of the black and silver pavilion were drawn back, and the crowd went quiet.

Ambrose came out.

He was dressed in black, as he always was now. Black velvet, black silk, black leather, cut close and fine. There was a circlet of silver on his head, simple and plain, and it suited him better than I wanted it to. He walked out of the pavilion with his head high and his hand on the hilt of his sword, and his guards fanned out around him, and the soldiers on the grass began to cheer.

And around his neck, on a silver chain, there was a box.

Small and dark and smooth, about the size of a loaf of bread. It hung against his chest like a pendant. No lid. No lock. No seams.

I felt it from across the grass. I felt it the moment he stepped out of the pavilion. A humming, deep and low, like a string plucked somewhere far off. Its long slow *no*, saying itself over and over.

And beneath it, fainter, braided through it like a thread through cloth, the thing I had heard in Meluan's green room. The name that belonged to my family.

It knew me. I felt it know me. I felt it turn, the way a compass needle turns, toward me.

I kept my head down. I kept my borrowed hat low over my borrowed eyes. I held my borrowed fiddle and did not look up.

Beside me on the tailboard, Bast went very still.

"Reshi," he breathed. "Your hair. It's—"

I looked down. At the ends of my hair, where they hung over my shoulders. They were not brown anymore. Not quite. There was a tinge of red in them. Just a tinge. Like the first light of a fire, glimpsed through smoke.

"Stop it," Bast hissed. "Whatever you're feeling. Stop it. It's breaking the glamour."

I closed my eyes. I thought about the Adem. About Vashet, on the hillside at Haert. *Be still. Let it rise. Let it pass.*

I let it rise. I let it pass.

When I opened my eyes, my hair was brown again.

\* \* \*

Ambrose sat down in a great carved chair that his servants had brought out and set on the grass in front of the stage. His guards stood around him. His favorites clustered at his sides. Lords and ladies in rich clothes, glittering with jewels, laughing and whispering.

And among them, at his left hand, a girl in black silk, with a harp in her lap.

Denna.

She did not look at the stage. She did not look at anyone. She sat very still beside the king's chair with her harp in her lap and her hands folded on the strings and her eyes on the ground. Her face was pale and composed and utterly empty.

And behind her, leaning on his stick, Bredon.

He was looking at the stage. At the Ruh. At the wagons. His face was mild and pleasant and interested, the face of an old man enjoying an evening's entertainment. His eyes moved slowly over each of us. Tessit, and Mirra, and Brin with his fiddle, and Illa, and Kellen and Wat.

And me.

His eyes stopped on me. Just for a moment. The barest pause.

Then they moved on.

I did not breathe. I sat on the tailboard with my borrowed fiddle and my borrowed hat and my borrowed face, and I did not breathe.

He had not seen me. He could not have. Bast's glamour was good. I looked like no one.

But he had paused.

\* \* \*

We played.

Tessit played the lute and Brin played the fiddle and I played the other fiddle, badly, on purpose, the way Brin played. Illa sang. Mirra sang. Kellen and Wat did tumbling tricks between the songs, and the soldiers roared and whistled and threw coins onto the stage.

We played "Tinker Tanner" and "Jenny Nettle" and "The Lady and the Lord and the Bath." We played "Leave the Lantern" and "Aloine at the Well." We played a bawdy song about a miller's daughter that made the lords and ladies around the king's chair titter behind their hands.

And all the while, I watched.

I watched Ambrose, lounging in his carved chair with the box on his chest, laughing at the bawdy songs. I watched his guards, standing around him with their halberds. I watched the lords and ladies. I watched Bredon, leaning on his stick behind Denna's chair, smiling.

And I watched the plain black tent with the guard in grey at its door.

Somewhere out there, in the dark beyond the firelight, twelve Adem were moving through the camp. Silent as shadows. I could not see them. No one could. But I knew they were there. I knew that Vashet was leading them, and that Tempa was at her side, and that they were moving toward that tent.

We played "The Wind's Daughter," a sea shanty I had learned on Hessa Tern's ship. The soldiers stamped their feet and sang along with the chorus.



The guard in grey at the door of the plain black tent was very still.

We played "Lanre Turned." A traditional song, very old, one that every Ruh knows. It is not true, and it is not false. It is just a song. The soldiers liked it. Ambrose did not. He scowled and waved his hand, and Tessit stopped playing at once and bowed and moved on to something else.

The guard in grey at the door of the tent swayed slightly. Just slightly. As if a gust of wind had caught him.

Then he folded up, very neatly, and sat down on the grass beside the tent door, and did not move again.

No one noticed. Everyone was watching the stage.

I began to play faster.

\* \* \*

We were halfway through "The Ballad of Sir Savien Traliard" when Bredon stood up.

He did it slowly, leaning on his stick, the way an old man stands. No one paid him any attention. He was only an old man, getting up to stretch his legs, or to find a privy, or to get another cup of wine.

He did not go to find a privy. He walked around the back of the king's chair, and along the edge of the crowd, and toward the plain black tent.

My fingers faltered on the fiddle strings. I missed a note. Beside me, Illa glanced at me sharply and sang a little louder to cover it.

Bredon walked to the tent. He looked down at the guard in grey, sitting on the grass beside the door. He looked at him for a long moment.

Then he turned and looked at the stage.

He looked straight at me.

And he smiled.

\* \* \*

I stopped playing. I could not help it. My hands stopped on the strings, and the fiddle went silent, and I sat there on the tailboard of the wagon and looked at him across the firelit grass, and he looked back at me,

and he smiled.

He knew. He had known from the moment he saw me. The pause. The barest pause, when his eyes found me on the tailboard. He had known, and he had let me sit there, and play, and watch, and think I was hidden.

And now he stood at the door of the tent where my aunt and her daughter were kept, and he smiled at me, and he raised his stick an inch off the ground in his small courtly salute. The way he always did, at the start of a game.

*Your move*, it said.

Beside me, Bast hissed. "Reshi. Your hair."

I did not look down. I did not need to. I could feel it. The glamour was breaking. Peeling away like old paint. I could feel the red coming back into my hair, bright and fierce, like a fire catching.

I stood up. I set down the fiddle. I took off the borrowed hat.

And in the firelight, in front of the king and his court and eight thousand soldiers, my hair burned red.

\* \* \*

The crowd went silent. All at once, like a candle snuffed.

Then someone said, "That's him."

And someone else said, "The Ruh. The kingkiller."

And someone else, somewhere, began to shout.

Ambrose was on his feet. His carved chair had gone over behind him. He was staring at me across the firelit grass, and his face was white, and then red, and then something else entirely. Something I had seen on his face once before, a long time ago, in the courtyard of the University, when I called the wind.

It was fear.

"Take him!" he shouted. His voice cracked. "Take him! Take him alive!"

The guards around him surged forward.

And that was when Devi's surprise went off.

## Chapter One Hundred Four

# Fire in the Horse Lines

I did not know, until much later, what Devi had made.

She told me afterward, sitting by a fire in the Maer's valley with her spectacles pushed up on her forehead and a cup of Mirra's terrible tea in her hands. She had spent the whole road south from Imre working on it, in the back of a wagon, with a portable alchemical bench she had built herself from a traveling chest and a great many stolen glass tubes. She had not slept much. She had burned her fingers a dozen times. She had nearly blown up the wagon twice.

"It's a kind of firework," she said. "Only bigger. Much bigger. And louder. And with a delay." She smiled her spider's smile. "I call it the Surprise."

She had made nine of them. Small clay pots, sealed with wax, each about the size of a man's fist. Inside each pot there were two chambers, separated by a thin wall of something that dissolved slowly when it was wet. When you broke the seal and poured in a little water, the wall began to dissolve. And when it was gone, and the two chambers mixed—

"Well," said Devi. "You saw."

\* \* \*

I saw.

The first one went off in the horse lines, on the far side of the camp. I did not see the pot. I only saw the light. A great blossom of white fire, rising up into the night sky with a sound like the world

cracking open. It was so bright that for a moment the whole valley was lit up like noon, every tent and banner and soldier thrown into sharp black silhouette.

The second one went off a heartbeat later, near the wagon park. Then the third, by the smithy. Then the fourth and fifth and sixth, one after the other, all around the edges of the camp, until the night was full of white fire and thunder.

And the horses screamed.

There were thousands of them in the horse lines. Cavalry mounts and draft horses and pack mules. They had been dozing in the dark, tethered in long rows, and suddenly the world had exploded around them in fire and noise. They went mad. They reared and plunged and screamed. They tore at their tethers. And the tethers broke.

They poured out of the horse lines like a river bursting its banks. Thousands of them, stampeding through the camp in the dark, maddened with terror. They trampled tents and overturned wagons and scattered cookfires. Soldiers ran shouting in every direction. Some of them were trampled. Some of them were knocked into the river. Some of them simply stood and stared.

The seventh Surprise went off in the center of the camp, not fifty yards from the king's pavilion. The eighth went off beside it. The light was blinding. The noise was like being struck by a hammer.

And through it all, the ninth pot sat quietly in a patch of grass at the edge of the firelight, near the Ruh wagons, and did nothing at all.

"That one was for smoke," Devi told me later. "Just smoke. Lots of it. I put it there for you, so you'd have cover." She sighed. "It was a dud. I don't know why. I think the water didn't get in properly."

"It's all right," I said. "The others were enough."

"They were, weren't they?" She looked very pleased with herself. "They really were."

\* \* \*

In the chaos, I ran.

Not away. Toward. Toward the black and silver pavilion, toward the overturned carved chair, toward Ambrose.

He was standing where his chair had been, with his sword half drawn and his face white in the flashing light. His guards were scattered around him, some of them knocked down by the stampede, some of them running after the horses, some of them standing and staring at the fire in the sky. The lords and ladies of his court were fleeing in every direction, screaming, their fine clothes flapping.

And the box was on his chest. Hanging from its silver chain. Humming.

I felt it call to me. I felt it know me. I ran toward it.

A guard stepped into my way. A big man in black armor, with a halberd. He swung it at me, a great sweeping blow meant to take my legs out from under me.

I did not think. My body moved. It moved the way Vashet had taught it to move, on the hillside at Haert, a thousand times, until the movements were in my bones. *Tree Falling. Breaking Lion. Water Flows Around.*

I was inside the halberd's swing before it could reach me. I was past the guard before he knew I was there. He stumbled, overbalanced, and fell.

Another guard. Another. I went through them the way water goes through rocks in a stream. I did not draw Caesura. I did not need to. My body knew what to do, even with one arm cold and weak. It had been waiting to do this for a long time.

And then I was in front of Ambrose.

\* \* \*

He had his sword out now. A fine long blade, with a jeweled hilt and a gleaming edge. He held it in front of him the way a man holds a sword who has been taught by the best masters money can buy, and has never had to use it in earnest.

His face was white. His eyes were wide. The light of Devi's fire flashed across them, white and gold.

"You," he said. His voice cracked. "You."

"Hello, Ambrose."

"*King* Ambrose." He tried to sneer. It did not quite work. "You're under arrest. For murder. For treason. For—for—"

"For what? For singing?"

His sword wavered. "Stay back. I'll kill you. I swear I'll kill you."

"No," I said. "You won't. You can't. You need me." I took a step toward him. "Don't you? That's what he told you. The old man. You need me alive, to open the door."

Something moved in his face. Something I had never seen there before.

"How do you know about the door?"

"I know everything, Ambrose. I always have. That's why you hate me." I took another step. "Give me the box."

"No."

"Give me the box, and I'll let you walk away. Right now. You can go back to Renere and sit on your throne and be king, and I'll never come near you again." I held out my hand. "Just give me the box."

He stared at me. At my hand, held out. At my face, lit by the flashing white fire.

For a moment—just a moment—I thought he would do it. I saw it in his eyes. The fear. The confusion. The part of him that had never wanted any of this, that had only ever wanted to be rich and important and admired, and had not understood what it was getting into.

Then his face hardened.

"No," he said. "It's mine. It's *mine*. He gave it to me. He said I was the only one who could carry it. He said I was *special*." His voice rose. "He said I was of the *line*!"

"You're a drop," I said. "A single drop, from four hundred years ago. He's using you, Ambrose. He's always been using you. The way he used Denna. The way he used everyone."

"*Liar!*"

He lunged at me.

\* \* \*

It was not a good lunge. It was a lunge made in fear and rage, wild and overextended. I stepped aside and let it pass me, and as it passed, I

reached out with my good hand and took hold of the silver chain around his neck.

And the box sang.

I felt it the moment my fingers touched the chain. A great surge of sound, rising up out of the box and into my hand and up my arm and into my chest. Its long slow *no*, suddenly very loud. And beneath it, braided through it, the name of my family. Of the line. Of my mother, and her mother, and all the mothers before, back and back to a woman in the hills who had loved a shaper for a little while.

It knew me. It knew me the way a dog knows its master's hand.

And beneath that, fainter, something else. A voice. Far away. Very deep. Very old. Saying my name.

Not my called name. The other one. The true one.

*Come*, it said. *Come to the door*.

I felt my fingers tighten on the chain. I felt myself begin to pull.

And then a hand closed around my wrist.

\* \* \*

It was cold.

Colder than anything. The cold of the space between the stars. It went into my wrist and up my arm, and my fingers went numb on the silver chain, and they opened.

The chain slipped out of my grasp. The box swung back against Ambrose's chest.

I turned my head.

Cinder was standing beside me. He was holding my wrist. My good wrist, this time. The right one. His black eyes were looking into mine, and his face was very close, and he was smiling.

"No," he said softly. "Not here. Not yet."

"Let go of me."

"I can't touch you, little key. You know that. The lord forbade it." His smile widened. "But I can stop you. That's different." He tightened his grip. The cold went deeper, into my bones. "You'll have your chance. At the door. Not before."

*"Let go."*

"Or what?" He tilted his head. "You'll call the wind? You'll sing at me? You'll hum your little song to the stones?" He laughed softly. "Go on. Try."

I opened my mouth.

And something struck Cinder from the side, very fast and very hard, and knocked him away from me.

\* \* \*

It was Tempi.

He came out of the dark and the smoke and the flashing fire like a red arrow, and he hit Cinder with his shoulder, and Cinder staggered. His hand came away from my wrist. I felt the cold begin to drain out of my arm.

Tempi did not stop. He moved. He moved the way the Adem move, the way I had seen him move a hundred times on the practice grounds, fluid and swift and utterly without waste. He struck at Cinder. Once, twice, three times. His hands were a blur.

Cinder was faster.

I had never seen anything move as fast as Cinder moved in that moment. He was simply *there*, and then he was somewhere else, and then he was behind Tempi, and there was a sword in his hand. A long pale sword, the color of ice.

"Tempi!" I shouted.

Tempi turned. He saw the sword. His face did not change. Adem faces never change.

But his hands moved. Just for a moment. As the sword came down.

Go, they said.

\* \* \*

I do not remember what happened next. Not clearly. I remember the sword coming down. I remember Tempi falling. I remember a sound that I think was me, screaming.

I remember Bast. His hands on my arms, pulling me away. His voice in my ear, shouting. *Reshi, come on, come on, we have to go,*



*Reshi, please.*

I remember Ambrose, standing where I had left him, with the box on his chest and his sword in his hand and his face white as bone. Staring at me.

I remember Cinder, standing over Temp's body, with the ice-pale sword in his hand. Looking at me. Smiling.

And I remember Bredon. Standing at the door of the plain black tent, a little way off, leaning on his stick. Watching it all with his mild, kind, interested face.

He raised his stick an inch off the ground. His small courtly salute.

And then Bast pulled me into the dark and the smoke, and I did not see anything else.

\* \* \*

We ran. Through the burning camp, through the stampeding horses and the shouting soldiers and the smoke. Bast's glamour was wrapped around us both, tight and thin and flickering, and people looked at us and saw nothing, or saw only two more shadows fleeing the fire.

At the edge of the camp, where the river bent around a stand of willows, the others were waiting.

Vashet was there. And the other Adem, ten of them, standing in a ring. And in the center of the ring, sitting on the ground with her back against a willow trunk, there was a woman in a pale grey robe, with dark hair and a thin white face.

She was holding a baby.

"Kvothe," said Meluan. Her voice was a thread. "Kvothe. You came."

I fell to my knees beside her. I could not speak. I looked at her, and at the baby in her arms. A tiny thing, wrapped in a grey blanket. Asleep. Its face was red and crumpled and very small.

"Her name is Netalia," said Meluan. She was crying. "I named her Netalia. After my sister. After your mother." She looked at me. "I hope that's all right."

I could not answer. I put my hand very gently on the baby's head. Her hair was soft and fine and dark. She did not wake.

"Tempi," said Vashet. Her voice was very flat. "Where is Tempi?"

I looked up at her. I did not say anything. I did not need to.

Her face did not change. Adem faces never change. But her hands, at her sides, went very still.

Then they moved. One small movement. A sign I had seen only once before, on a hillside in Ademre, when an old woman had died.

It meant *grief*.

\* \* \*

We could not rest. Not there. The camp behind us was still burning, still roaring with the shouts of soldiers and the screams of horses, but it would not stay that way for long. They would come looking for us. For Meluan. For the baby. For me.

"We have to go," said Vashet. "Now. Before they organize."

"She can't walk," I said. I looked at Meluan. Her face was grey. Her hands, holding the baby, were shaking. "She had the child eleven days ago. She's too weak."

"Then we carry her."

Two of the Adem came forward and lifted Meluan between them, very gently, the way you lift something fragile. She did not protest. She only held the baby tighter against her chest.

We ran. Into the dark, away from the burning camp, along the riverbank and then up into the hills. The Adem carried Meluan. Bast ran beside me, his glamour flickering. I ran with my hand on Caesura's hilt and my heart pounding and Tempi's last sign burned into the backs of my eyes.

Go.

\* \* \*

They caught us at the top of the first ridge.

Not soldiers. Not guards. Something else. Something that came out of the dark ahead of us, standing on the crest of the ridge against

the starlight, very tall and very still.

A shadow. Shaped like a man. With no man inside it.

We stopped. All of us, at once. The Adem set Meluan down on the grass and drew their swords and formed a ring around her. Vashet stood at the front of the ring, with her sword in her hand and her face showing nothing at all.

The shadow did not move.

"Singer," said Haliax.

His voice came from everywhere and nowhere. Deep and quiet and very tired.

"You have taken something from us," he said. "The child. The lady."

"They're not yours," I said. "They never were."

"No." The shadow was quiet for a moment. "No, I suppose not." It seemed to look past me, at Meluan on the grass, with the baby in her arms. "The child is very small. Very new. Her name is not yet shaped." A pause. "It would not have worked, I think. Not with her. Not truly. The old man thought it might. I did not."

"Then why did you take her?"

"To bring you." The shadow turned back to me. "As it did. As he knew it would."

I did not say anything.

"Keep the child," said Haliax. "She is nothing to me. But the lady—" The shadow seemed to shift. "The lady has the blood too. Older. Stronger. Shaped by many years. She is not a namer, as you are. But she is enough to wake the door. Enough to crack it. Enough to let a little of what is behind it through." A pause. "Enough to make you come."

"No."

"Yes." The shadow did not raise its voice. It did not need to. "Ferule."

\* \* \*

He was behind us. I had not seen him come. None of us had. He was standing among the Adem, inside their ring, beside Meluan. His

ice-pale sword was in his hand. His black eyes were on me.

"Lady," he said. He bowed, very slightly, to Meluan. "You will come with me."

"No," said Meluan. She held the baby against her chest. "No. No."

"You will come," said Cinder. "Or the child will not live to see the morning." He looked down at the baby in her arms. "I cannot touch the key. But I can touch *her*."

The Adem moved. All ten of them at once, swords flashing. They moved toward Cinder like a closing fist.

Cinder did not move. He only smiled.

And the ground beneath the Adem went cold. Frost bloomed out from Cinder's feet across the grass, white and crackling, faster than a man could run. It crept up the Adem's boots. Their legs. They stopped moving. Their swords hung in the air, frozen in mid-swing. Their breath plumed white.

They were not dead. I could see their eyes moving. But they could not move anything else.

Only Vashet was still free. She had been standing at the front of the ring, beside me, beyond the reach of the frost. She stood very still, with her sword in her hand, and looked at Cinder.

Cinder looked back at her.

"You are the teacher," he said. "The one who taught him the Ketan." He smiled. "I killed your friend tonight. The quiet one. He was very good. Better than you, I think."

Vashet did not answer. Her face showed nothing.

But her hands moved. One small, sharp gesture. I had never seen it before.

It meant *I will remember you*.

\* \* \*

"Stop," said Meluan.

She was standing up. I do not know how. She had been too weak to walk a moment before. But she was standing, with the baby in her arms, in the center of the frozen ring of Adem. Her face was white as bone. Her eyes were very steady.

"Stop," she said again. "I'll come."

"Meluan, no—"

"I'll come." She turned and looked at me. Her face was calm. Her eyes were wet. "Take her. Please. Take her and keep her safe."

She held out the baby.

I took her. I do not remember deciding to. I only remember that one moment Meluan was holding the baby out to me, and the next I was holding her against my chest, small and warm and asleep, wrapped in her grey blanket.

"Keep her safe," Meluan whispered. "The way your mother kept you. Hide her. Wrap her name. Don't let them find her." She reached out and touched my face. Her fingers were ice cold. "She's the last. After you. After me. She's the last of us."

"I'll get you back," I said. My voice cracked. "I swear. I'll come to the door. I'll get you back."

Meluan looked at me for a long moment.

"I know you will," she said softly. "That's what they're counting on."

She turned away. She walked out of the frozen ring, past Cinder, toward the shadow on the ridge. Cinder followed her, with his ice-pale sword.

At the crest of the ridge, the shadow waited. When Meluan reached it, it seemed to open, like a cloak. She stepped into it.

And then they were gone. All of them. The shadow, and Cinder, and Meluan. Gone into the dark, as if they had never been there.

The frost on the grass began to melt. The Adem stumbled forward, gasping, as their limbs came free.

I stood on the ridge in the starlight with my aunt's daughter in my arms, and I did not move for a long time.

## Interlude: The Candle

"Do you still have it?" said Chronicler. "The candle? Kilvin's?"

The innkeeper looked up. He had just stopped speaking, at the end of the ridge above the burning camp, with Meluan walking into the shadow and a baby in his arms, and he had been sitting very still for a long time, looking at his hands.

"Yes," he said.

"Here?"

"Upstairs." The innkeeper was quiet for a moment. "In a drawer. I haven't lit it in years."

Chronicler hesitated. "Would you? Now?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then at Bast. Bast had gone very still in his backward chair.

"Reshi," Bast said softly. "Maybe not."

"Why not?"

"Because of the smoke," said Bast. "This morning. Over the woods." He looked at the window. "You saw it. How it leaned."

The innkeeper looked at the window too. At the thin grey line of smoke above the trees at the edge of the fields, still there in the late afternoon light, still leaning.

"Yes," he said quietly. "I saw it."

He stood up. He went to the stairs. He went up.

\* \* \*

He was gone a long time. Chronicler heard him moving about overhead, in the room at the top of the stairs. A drawer opening. A

long silence. A drawer closing.

When he came down, he was carrying a small wooden box. Plain and old, with a sliding lid. He set it on the table between them and sat down and looked at it.

"Kilvin gave it to me," he said. "In his office in the Fishery, with his great scarred hands. He'd kept it for twenty years." He slid back the lid. "I've kept it for nearly half as long again."

Inside, nested in old straw, there was a candle. Plain white tallow, yellowed with age, about the length of a hand. The wick was black and curled. Kilvin's ledger was folded underneath it, the pages soft as cloth from handling.

The innkeeper took it out. He set it upright in a pewter dish from the bar. He took a match from his apron pocket.

He looked at Chronicler.

"You understand," he said. "What it means. If it burns blue."

"Yes."

"It won't mean they're coming. It only means they're doing something. Somewhere. Anywhere in the world."

"I understand."

The innkeeper struck the match. He held it to the wick.

\* \* \*

The flame caught. Small and bright and yellow. It steadied. It rose.

They sat and watched it. All three of them. Nobody spoke.

It burned yellow. A warm, ordinary, homely yellow. The color of every candle Chronicler had ever seen.

He let out a breath he had not known he was holding.

And then the flame bent.

Not flickered. Bent. As if a draft had caught it, though there was no draft, though the door was closed and the shutters were closed and the air in the common room was perfectly still. It bent sideways, toward the window. Toward the woods beyond the fields. Toward the leaning smoke.

And it stayed bent. Leaning. Like the smoke.

And very slowly, from the tip downward, it began to turn blue.

\* \* \*

Nobody moved. Nobody breathed.

The blue crept down the flame the way frost creeps across a window. Slowly. Steadily. From the tip, down, and down, until the whole small flame was blue. A deep, cold, winter-dusk blue. The blue of a bruise.

And it was leaning toward the woods.

"Oh," said Bast. Very softly. His face was white. "Oh, Reshi."

The innkeeper did not say anything. He sat very still and looked at the blue flame, leaning toward the window, and his face showed nothing at all.

Then he reached out and pinched it out between his finger and thumb.

The smoke curled up, thin and grey. It did not rise straight. It leaned. Toward the window. Toward the woods.

\* \* \*

"Not somewhere," said Chronicler. His voice did not sound like his own. "Not anywhere in the world. There." He looked at the window. "It was pointing."

"Yes."

"Kilvin's candle doesn't point. You said. It shows when they're doing something, anywhere—"

"It's never pointed before." The innkeeper was looking at the smoke from the snuffed wick, drifting toward the shutters. "Not in all the years I've had it. Not in all the years Kilvin had it." He was quiet for a long moment. "It points now because he's close. So close it can feel him. The way a compass feels the north."

"Who?"

The innkeeper looked at him.

"You know who," he said.

Chronicler did know. He had been writing about him for two and a half days. A man with black eyes and frost-colored hair, who crouched in front of a boy in the firelight among the bodies of his



family and smiled.

"He's out there," said Chronicler. "In the woods. Right now."

"He's been out there since this morning. Maybe longer." The innkeeper put the candle back in its box, very carefully, and slid the lid closed. "Since the first day. Since I started telling."

"And you kept telling."

"Yes."

"Why?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. His green eyes were very calm.

"Because I'm not finished," he said.

\* \* \*

He put the box on the shelf behind the bar, beside the bottles. He came back and sat down. He picked up his cup of cider, and looked at it, and set it down again.

Bast had not moved. He was sitting in his backward chair with his arms folded across its back, and he was staring at the innkeeper with an expression Chronicler could not read.

"Reshi," he said. "We could go. Now. Tonight. Out the back, into the dark. He'd never find you. He never found you before."

"He never looked before," said the innkeeper. "Not really. He didn't know there was anything to look for." He looked at the window. "He knows now."

"Then we run faster."

"Bast." The innkeeper's voice was very gentle. "I've been running for seven years. Sitting very still behind a bar, in a town no one's heard of, beside a stone that drowns out names. That's a kind of running." He looked at his hands. "I'm tired of it."

Bast stared at him. His deep blue eyes were very bright.

"Then what do we do?"

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time. Then he looked at Chronicler, and at the pen lying on the table beside the stack of pages, and he smiled. A small, crooked, rueful smile.

"We finish the story," he said.

He picked up his cup. He drank. He set it down.

"I carried my aunt's daughter back to the Maer at dawn," said Kvothe. "And he held her for the first time, sitting on a rock at the mouth of his cave. And she opened her eyes and looked at him." He paused. "They were dark eyes. Like her mother's. Like my mother's."

Chronicler picked up his pen.

Outside, beyond the shutters, beyond the fields, at the edge of the woods, the smoke leaned. And the light began, very slowly, to fail.

## Chapter One Hundred Five

# Netalia

The Maer held his daughter for the first time at dawn, sitting on a flat rock at the mouth of his cave, with the grey light coming up over the hills and the smoke of the king's burning camp still rising on the horizon behind us.

I put her in his arms. He took her the way a man takes something he has never held before and is terrified of breaking. Awkwardly, carefully, with his whole body gone stiff. She woke as he took her, and opened her eyes, and looked up at him.

They were dark eyes. Not green, like mine, or grey, like his. Dark, like her mother's. Like my mother's.

The Maer looked down at her for a long time. He did not say anything. His face did not move. But his hands, holding her, began very slowly to relax.

"Netalia," I said. "Meluan named her Netalia."

The Maer closed his eyes.

"After her sister," he said.

"Yes, your grace."

He opened his eyes and looked down at the baby again. She was looking back at him with her dark solemn eyes, the way very young babies do, as if they know something they will forget as soon as they learn to speak.

"She told me once," said the Maer quietly, "that if we had a daughter, she would name her Netalia. I told her that was a terrible idea. That it would remind everyone of the scandal. That people would

talk." He was silent for a moment. "She said she did not care what people said. She said her sister was the bravest person she had ever known, and she wanted her daughter to have a brave name." He looked up at me. "I did not understand, then."

"And now?"

He looked back down at the baby.

"Now," he said, "I think I do."

\* \* \*

He did not ask me what had happened to Meluan. He did not need to. He had seen it in my face when I came up the valley at dawn with the baby in my arms and no one beside me. He had seen it in the Adem, walking behind me with their swords sheathed and their faces showing nothing.

He only asked one thing.

"Is she alive?"

"Yes, your grace. They need her alive. For the door."

"And you will go there."

"Yes."

"And bring her back."

I did not answer right away. I looked at him. At his hollow grey face and his bandaged arm and the tiny baby in his lap.

"I'll try," I said.

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded.

"That is all anyone can do," he said.

\* \* \*

We buried Tempi that afternoon.

The Adem had brought his body back from the camp. I do not know how. I did not ask. Vashet and two of the others had gone back into the dark, while the rest of us were fleeing, and they had come back an hour before dawn carrying something wrapped in a red cloak.

They buried him in a high place, on a shoulder of the hills above the Maer's valley, where the wind blew clean and cold and you could see for miles in every direction. The Adem did not use a coffin. They

did not use a shroud. They laid him in the earth in his red clothes, with his hands folded on his chest and his sword laid beside him, and they covered him with stones.

Then they stood around the cairn in a ring, all eleven of them, and they did not speak.

I stood with them. I did not know what else to do. I did not know the Adem customs for death. I had only seen one Adem funeral before, in Haert, for an old woman I had barely known, and I had not understood most of what happened.

But I knew this. The Adem do not weep. Not with their faces. Not with their voices. They weep with their hands.

And standing on that hillside in the cold wind, I watched eleven Adem weep for Tempi. Their hands moved slowly, all together, in a long silent pattern. Over and over. Grief, and love, and memory, and a word I did not know. The same pattern, repeated, like a song.

I did not know the pattern. But I let my own hands move. Clumsily, badly, the way a barbarian's hands move when he tries to speak Adem. I did not know what I was saying. I only knew what I felt.

Beside me, Vashet glanced at my hands. Something moved in her face. Not an expression. Something smaller than that.

Then she reached out and took my hands in hers and moved them, gently, into the right shape. The shape of the pattern the others were making. And held them there.

We stood on the hillside until the sun went down, with our hands moving together. And I wept for Tempi the only way I could. The Adem way.

\* \* \*

That night, I sat with Vashet by the Maer's fire. The others had gone to sleep. The fire was burning low. The baby was asleep in a basket beside the Maer's bed in the cave, with Mirra watching over her.

Vashet sat across the fire from me with her sword across her knees. She had not spoken since the burial.

"He taught me," I said at last. "First. Before you. He taught me the first forms of the Ketan, on the road through the Eld. He didn't know any Aturan. I didn't know any Adem. He taught me with his hands."

"I know."

"He didn't have to come here. None of you did."

"We did." Vashet looked at me across the fire. "You are ours. Shehyn said so, when she sent us. She said, *he has shamed us by being accused, and honored us by what he did at the singing-house. Go and help him. He is ours.*" Her hands moved. *Family.* "Tempi wanted to come. He asked to lead us. Shehyn said no, I would lead. He argued." Her hands moved again. *Amusement. Grief.* "He never argued with Shehyn. Not once in his life. But he argued about this."

I did not say anything. I could not.

"He knew," said Vashet quietly. "I think. He knew he would not come back. I saw it in him, on the road. He was very quiet. Even for Tempi." She looked into the fire. "He told me, the night before we came into your valley, that he had been thinking about the Lethani. About what it means to follow it truly. He said he thought it meant going where you are needed, even when you know the cost." Her hands were very still. "He said he thought you understood that better than any Adem he had ever known."

"I don't understand anything."

"No," said Vashet. "You do not. But you do it anyway." She looked at me. "That is the Lethani too."

\* \* \*

We made our plan the next day.

It was not a complicated plan. There was not much to plan. The king's army was moving toward the Lackless house. They would be there in two days. They would go down to the door at the dark of the moon, three nights from now. And they would take Meluan with them.

And I would be there.

"Not alone," said Vashet.

"Not alone," I agreed.

But there were not many who could come. The Maer's soldiers were too few to fight the king's army, and too many to sneak past it. The refugees and the Ruh could not fight at all. And my friends—

"We're coming," said Sim.

We were sitting in the mouth of the Maer's cave, all of us. Sim and Wil and Devi and Fela. Bast. Vashet and the ten remaining Adem. The Maer, with the baby in his lap.

"Sim," I said. "You can't."

"Why not?"

"Because it's going to be very dangerous. Because the Chandrian will be there. Because there'll be things there I can't even describe." I looked at him. "Because you're a poet, Sim. You write sonnets. You argue about meter. You're not a soldier."

"Neither are you," said Sim.

I opened my mouth. Then I closed it.

"He's right," said Wil quietly. "None of us are soldiers. But we're not useless either." He held up his scarred hands. "I can't do fine sympathy anymore. But I can still do the big kind. Heat. Fire. Motion. I can still hold a binding, if it's a strong one." He looked at me. "And I'm not letting you go down there alone."

"And I've still got some Surprises," said Devi. She patted her satchel. "Well. I've got materials for some Surprises. And a lot of other things. I'm very well prepared." She smiled her spider's smile. "I'm always very well prepared."

Fela did not say anything. She sat on the rock beside me with her hands folded in her lap, and she looked at me with her dark serious eyes.

"The door is made of stone," she said at last.

"Yes."

"And it's cracked. Or it's going to be. When they open it."

"Maybe."

"Then you'll need someone who can ask the stone to hold." She looked at me. "Like at the Eolian. When everything's burning and falling down, and there's only one thing standing between you and the

end. You'll need someone who can ask it to stand."

I looked at her. I looked at all of them.

"You could die," I said. "All of you. You could die down there."

"We could die up here," said Devi. "Waiting. Worrying. Wondering." She shrugged. "I'd rather die doing something."

"I wouldn't," said Sim. "I'd rather not die at all." He swallowed. "But I'd rather die doing something than live knowing I didn't."

\* \* \*

The Maer was the last to speak.

He had been sitting quietly through all of it, with the baby in his lap. He had not said anything. He had only listened.

Now he looked at me.

"Kvothe," he said. "Come here."

I went and knelt beside his rock. He looked down at me with his hollow grey face.

"My wife asked you to hide our daughter," he said. "To wrap her name, the way your mother wrapped yours. So they cannot find her."

"Yes, your grace."

"Can you do that?"

I thought about it. I thought about what Selitos had told me. About my mother, wrapping her deep name in another name, like a stone wrapped in cloth.

"I don't know how," I said honestly. "Not yet. But I know someone who might."

"Who?"

I looked at Tessit and Mirra, sitting a little way off by their wagons. At Nell, in her red dress, curled up asleep against Mirra's side.

"The Ruh," I said. "My mother hid among the Ruh for twelve years. No one found her. Not the Chandrian, not the Amyr, not the old man. The Ruh are very good at hiding. They're very good at being no one." I looked back at the Maer. "If she were raised among them—if she grew up Ruh, with a Ruh name, on the roads—"

"She would be safe," said the Maer slowly.

"Safer than anywhere else."



"And she would never know who she was."

"Not until she was old enough to understand. Not until it was safe to tell her."

The Maer looked down at the baby in his lap for a long time. She was asleep. Her small face was peaceful.

"I have been Maer of Severen for twenty years," he said at last. "My father was Maer before me, and his father before him. I have spent my whole life being someone. Being important. Being *seen*." He touched the baby's cheek with one finger. "And now I am in a cave in the hills, with nothing. No city. No palace. No wife." He was quiet for a moment. "And the only thing I have left, the only thing that matters, I must give away. So that no one will ever know she was mine."

"Your grace—"

"No." He looked up at me. His face was very hard. "No. You are right. It is the only way." He looked down at the baby again. "It is the price. For everything. For the war, and the city, and my wife. For not seeing Bredon for what he was, all those years. For being so busy being someone that I did not notice the thing growing in my own house." His voice cracked, very slightly. "It is my penance."

He stood up. He carried the baby across the cave mouth to where Tessit and Mirra were sitting. They looked up at him. Mirra's round face went very still.

The Maer knelt in front of her. The Maer of Severen, knelt in the dirt in front of a Ruh woman.

"Will you take her?" he said. "Will you raise her as your own? Will you keep her safe, and hidden, and never tell anyone who she is?"

Mirra looked at him for a long time. Then she looked at the baby. Then at Tessit.

Tessit looked back at her. There was a whole conversation in that look. Years of it.

"We'll take her," said Mirra softly. She held out her arms. "One family, your grace. Under the sky."

The Maer looked at her. Then, very slowly, he placed the baby in her arms.

Mirra held her against her chest. She began to hum. A soft, low, wordless tune. A Ruh lullaby. I knew it. My mother used to sing it to me.

The Maer knelt there in the dirt and watched his daughter being held by someone else. His face did not change.

But his hands, resting on his knees, were shaking.

\* \* \*

I sat with him later, by the fire, when everyone else had gone to sleep. He did not speak for a long time.

"What will you call her?" I asked at last. "Among the Ruh. She'll need a Ruh name."

The Maer looked into the fire.

"Mirra asked me that," he said. "I told her to choose. It is her daughter now." He was quiet for a moment. "She said she would call her Lark. After your mother. After the way she sang."

I did not say anything. I could not.

"Lark," said the Maer softly. "It is a good name. A small name. The kind of name no one would ever look for." He was silent for a moment. "Better than Netalia. Better than Lackless. Better than anything I could have given her."

He looked at me.

"Go to the door," he said. "Bring my wife back. And then close it. So that Lark never has to."

"I will, your grace."

He looked at me for a long time. Then he reached out and laid his hand on my shoulder.

"I believe you," he said. "God help me. I believe you."

## Chapter One Hundred Six

# A Letter to a Younger Sister

The Maer sent for me that evening, after the council, when the others had gone to their fires.

He was sitting at the mouth of his cave, where he had sat that morning when I brought him his daughter. She was asleep now, in a basket lined with an Adem cloak, at his feet. He had a small box in his lap. A traveling desk, of dark lacquered wood, with brass corners and a brass lock. The lacquer was scorched along one side, and the brass was blackened.

"One of your Adem brought this out of the camp," he said, when I knelt beside him. "The tall one. Tempi. He found it in the black tent, in the confusion, after. He thought it might be important." The Maer turned the box in his thin hands. "It was my wife's. She has had it since she was a girl. She took it everywhere."

He opened it. Inside there were papers, pens, a stick of sealing wax, a small silver knife for cutting quills. The ordinary things of a lady's writing desk. And beneath them, in a hidden compartment in the bottom, which the Maer opened by pressing on one corner of the base, a single folded letter. Old and soft and yellowed, the creases worn nearly through.

"I did not know this was here," said the Maer. "In all our marriage, short as it has been. I did not know." He held it out to me. "It is addressed to her. But I think it is meant for you."

\* \* \*

I took it. My hands were not steady. I unfolded it, very carefully, in the last of the light.

It was written in a young hand. Quick and slanting and a little careless, with ink blots where the pen had been dipped too deep. The kind of hand that belongs to someone who has a great deal to say and is afraid she will not have time to say it all.

I knew that hand. I had never seen it before, and I knew it. I had seen it in a hundred small places, all my childhood, without knowing what I was seeing. On the labels of the jars in our wagon. On the margins of my father's songs, where she had made corrections. On the little slate she used to teach me my letters.

My mother's hand.

\* \* \*

*Mel*, the letter began.

*I don't know if they'll let you read this. I don't know if it will even reach you. I'm giving it to a tinker, which Father would say is the same as throwing it in the river. But tinkers are the only people I trust anymore, and this one has kind eyes, and he says he's going north. So.*

*I'm sorry. That's the first thing. I'm sorry I didn't say goodbye. I'm sorry I left in the night, like a thief, without even waking you. I stood in the door of your room for a long time. You were asleep with your mouth open, the way you always sleep, and you were holding that awful stuffed rabbit, the one with one ear. And I wanted to wake you so badly. But if I had woken you, I wouldn't have been able to go. You would have cried, and I would have stayed. And I can't stay, Mel. I can't.*

*I know what they're saying. That I ran off with a trouser. That I've shamed the family. That I'm a whore and a fool and a disgrace to the name. Father will have blotted me out of the book by now. I know he will. I can see him doing it, pressing the pen into the page until the ink soaks through.*

*It's all true. I did run off with a trouser. His name is Arliden and he is the cleverest, silliest, most wonderful man in the world, and he makes me laugh until I can't breathe, and I love him. But that's not why*

*I left.*

*I left because of the door.*

\* \* \*

I stopped reading. I looked up at the Maer. He was watching me, very still, in the fading light.

"Go on," he said quietly.

\* \* \*

*You know about the door. You've heard the rhyme. We all have, since we were babies. Father made sure of it, though he doesn't understand a word of it, and neither did his father. But you're too young to have heard it the way I heard it. You haven't lain awake at night and heard it humming.*

*I have. Since I was twelve. Since the summer I went exploring in the old cellars, where Father says we mustn't go, and found a stair behind the wine racks, going down. And at the bottom, a little cold room with an empty chair and a lot of old knotted cords hanging on the wall. And beyond it, a door that isn't a door.*

*Nobody told me what it was. Nobody knows anymore. I think somebody used to. I think there used to be someone who sat in that chair. But there hasn't been, not for a long time. Not since Great-Grandmother Liss, who went down to the cellars one night when Grandfather was a boy, and never came up again, whatever the family says.*

*It hums, Mel. The door. In the night. You can't hear it with your ears. You hear it with something else. And it's not just humming. It's listening. It knows I'm the eldest. It knows my name. And every night, it says my name. Very softly. Like someone calling from the bottom of a well. And every night, I want to answer.*

*I couldn't bear it anymore. I couldn't lie in that house one more night with it calling my name. I thought I would go mad. I think that's what happened to Great-Grandmother Liss. I think she answered.*

*So I left. With the one person in the world who could take me somewhere the door would never find me.*

\* \* \*

*The Ruh are always moving. Did you know that? They never stay anywhere more than a few days. They never have a house, or a village, or a name that stays the same. They have a hundred names, for a hundred towns. They're like water. They don't hold still long enough to be caught.*

*Arliden says that's why the Ruh were made. To be the ones who move. So that the things that hunt names can never find them.*

*I'm going to be one of them, Mel. I'm going to change my name. Not just the one people call me. The deep one. I'm going to wrap it up in another name, the way you wrap a stone in cloth so it won't clink in your pocket. Arliden's grandmother knows how. She's very old and very strange and she chews mint leaves all day long and she says she learned it from a woman who learned it from a woman who learned it from the Ruh who came out of the burning city at the beginning of the world.*

*When she's done, I won't be Netalia anymore. Not in any way the door can hear. I'll be someone else. A trouper's wife. A singer. Someone small and ordinary and always moving.*

*And the door will stop calling. Because there'll be no one there to call.*

\* \* \*

*I'm writing to tell you three things, and then I have to go, because the tinker is waiting and he keeps looking at me with his kind eyes as if he knows exactly what I'm writing, which he can't. Can he?*

*The first thing is: I love you. I've always loved you. Even when you took my ribbons and cried when I took them back. Even when you told Father about the boy from the mill. You were my little sister and I was supposed to take care of you and I'm sorry I'm leaving you there alone.*

*The second thing is: when Father dies, the house will be yours. You'll be the eldest, now that I'm gone. And the door will start calling you.*

*Don't answer it, Mel. Whatever it says. Whatever it offers. Don't ever, ever answer.*

*And the third thing is this. If you ever have a daughter—and I hope you do; I hope you have a dozen, and they're all as stubborn and as clever as you—*

*Don't teach her the rhyme.*

*Don't let them take her down to the cellar. Don't let them tell her she's the keeper. Don't let her learn her own name in that house.*

*Give her a small name, Mel. A plain one. The kind no one would ever look for. And let her grow up somewhere the door can't hear.*

*I'll try to do the same. If I ever have a child. I'll give him a name like wind in the grass. Like water. Like nothing at all. And I'll teach him to sing so loud that he never hears anything calling.*

*I love you. Burn this.*

*—Tally*

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long time. I sat on the rock at the mouth of the Maer's cave with the letter in my hands, and the light faded, and the first stars came out over the hills. The baby in the basket stirred, and made a small sound, and was still.

*Tally.* I had never known that. My mother's name for herself, when she was a girl. Before she was Laurian. Before she was anything but a frightened eldest daughter in a cold house on a ridge, a keeper no one had taught to keep, lying awake at night listening to a door say her name.

*I'll give him a name like wind in the grass.*

*Kvothe.* It means *to know*, in some tongues. But in the old Ruh cant, the one my father taught me when I was very small, it means something else. It is the sound the wind makes in dry grass, at the end of summer, when the stalks rub together.

I had never known she chose it for that. I had never known she chose it at all.

\* \* \*

"She did not burn it," said the Maer quietly.

"No."

"She kept it. For twenty years. In a hidden drawer, in a box she carried everywhere." He looked down at the basket at his feet. "And when we married, and I told her that if we ever had a daughter, she must not name her Netalia, it would remind everyone of the scandal—" His voice caught. "She looked at me so strangely. I did not understand. I thought she was angry."

"She wasn't angry."

"No." The Maer was silent for a long moment. "She was remembering. A letter from her sister. Asking her to give her daughter a small name. And I had just told her she could not give her daughter her sister's name." He closed his eyes. "She must have thought I understood. And then she must have realized I didn't."

\* \* \*

I folded the letter, very carefully, along its worn creases. I held it out to him.

The Maer shook his head.

"It is yours," he said. "It was always yours. It was written to my wife, but it was written about you. About what your mother did, and why. About the name she gave you." He looked at me with his hollow grey eyes. "And about what she asked. For Meluan's daughter. For Lark."

"A small name," I said.

"A small name. The kind no one would ever look for. And somewhere the door cannot hear." The Maer looked down at the sleeping baby. "The Ruh. Your mother's people. She was right, and you were right. That is where Lark must go."

He reached down, very gently, and touched his daughter's cheek with one finger.

"Tomorrow," he said, "we go to the door. You, and your friends, and your Adem. And I will stay here, with my daughter, and wait." His voice was very quiet. "And if you come back—if my wife comes back—we will decide together what to do. And if you do not—"



He did not finish. He did not need to.

"Then Mirra will take her," I said. "And the Ruh will keep her. And she'll never learn the rhyme."

The Maer nodded slowly. He did not look up from the basket.

"Tally," he said, very softly, as if trying the name. "She must have been very brave."

"She was," I said. "I didn't know how brave. Until now."

\* \* \*

I kept the letter. I kept it through the door and the grey and the Tower of Thorns. It went into the chest, in the end, folded small, beneath the humming box with no lid. I do not remember putting it there. I think Denna did. I think she read it, first. I think she must have understood it better than anyone.

When I opened the chest, it was the last thing I found. At the very bottom. Under everything else.

*I'll teach him to sing so loud that he never hears anything calling.*

She did. She taught me to sing. And for twelve years, among the Ruh, I never heard anything calling.

And then I stopped singing. For seven years. And the whole world went quiet.

And in the quiet, very faint, very far away, something began to call my name.

\* \* \*

"Is that why?" said Chronicler softly. "Why you're telling it? Why now?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment.

"No," he said at last. "I'm telling it because Bast begged, and Skarpi sent you, and I was tired of being small." He looked at the fire. "But I think it's why I can. Why the telling doesn't frighten me the way it should." He was quiet. "She wrote that I'd sing so loud I'd never hear anything calling. And a story is a kind of song. The oldest kind." He looked at the frost on the shutters. "So I'm singing. As loud as I can. And let him come. Let him call. I'm not listening anymore."

He picked up his cup. His hand was very steady.  
"Where was I?" he said.

## Interlude: The Regulars

They came in at dusk, the way they always did. The innkeeper heard them before Chronicler did. He stopped speaking in the middle of a sentence, and turned his head toward the door, and something in his face shifted. Settled. Went quiet and mild and ordinary, the way a pond goes still after a stone has sunk.

"Reshi," said Bast softly.

"I know." The innkeeper stood up. He smoothed his apron. "It's evening. They'll want their drinks." He looked at Chronicler. "Put the pages away. Just for an hour. It's better if they don't see."

Chronicler gathered the pages. He slid them into his satchel, and wiped his pen, and set it in its case. When he looked up again, the innkeeper was behind the bar, polishing a glass. And the door was opening.

\* \* \*

Graham came first. He always did. He was a big slow man with a face like a well-worn saddle, and he came in stamping the cold off his boots and rubbing his hands together.

"Kote," he said. "Evening. Cold one tonight. Frost already on the fields, and it's hardly dark." He sat down on his stool at the bar. "The usual."

The innkeeper drew him a beer. He set it on the bar. Graham looked at it, and then at him, and his big slow face creased.

"You look better," he said. "Than yesterday. Bruises are going down."

"They are."

"Hm." Graham drank. "Still don't know why you didn't let us come and deal with those two. We'd have come. Me and Jake and the boys."

"I know you would," said the innkeeper. "Thank you, Graham."

Graham looked at him a moment longer. Then he shrugged, and drank again, and turned on his stool to look around the room. His eyes fell on Chronicler, at the corner table by the hearth, and stayed there.

"Your scribe's still here," he said.

"He is."

"Three days now." Graham squinted. "What's he writing, anyway? All day, every day? Jake says he saw him through the window at noon, scribbling away like a man possessed."

"A history," said the innkeeper mildly. "Of the region."

"Of Newarre?" Graham laughed. "What's there to write about Newarre?"

"More than you'd think."

\* \* \*

Jake came in next, with Carter behind him. Then Old Cob, walking slowly, leaning on his stick. Then two of the younger men from the farms on the south road, whose names Chronicler did not know. They settled into their places at the bar and around the nearest table, the way water settles into the low places of a field, each one knowing exactly where he belonged.

The innkeeper served them. He drew beer and poured cider and ladled stew into bowls. He moved behind the bar the way he always did, quietly, efficiently, with no wasted motion. Chronicler, watching him, thought that you would never know. You would never know that an hour before, this same man had been sitting at a table with his eyes blazing, telling how he had carried his aunt's daughter out of a burning camp with the Chandrian at his back.

He was just Kote. An innkeeper. Polishing glasses.

But Chronicler noticed, now, the things he had not noticed on the first night. The way the innkeeper's eyes moved, every time the door

opened. The way his hand went, every so often, to the pocket of his apron, and rested there, on something small. The way he stood behind the bar with his weight balanced on the balls of his feet, very slightly, like a man who expects to have to move quickly.

He had been standing like that for seven years, Chronicler thought. And no one had ever noticed.

\* \* \*

"Heard a thing today," said Carter. "From a tinker on the Rannish road."

"The same tinker?" said Jake. "The one who came through the other day?"

"No. Different one. Younger. Came up from the south." Carter drank. "Said the Penitent King's raising taxes again. For the war. Said there's rebels in the north now, as well as the east. Said there's talk of a levy. Every village to send two men."

The room went quiet.

"Two men," said Graham slowly. "From Newarre?"

"From everywhere."

"We haven't got two men to spare. We've barely got enough to bring in the harvest." Graham shook his head. "Who'd go?"

Nobody answered. Nobody looked at anyone. But Chronicler saw that several of them glanced, very quickly, toward the door. Toward the smithy across the square, where a light was burning in the forge window. Where a young man with a smith's arms and a boy's face was working late.

The innkeeper polished his glass. His face did not change.

\* \* \*

"And there's something else," said Carter, lowering his voice. "The tinker said. About the Kingkiller."

"Oh, not this again," said Jake. "They hanged him. Everybody knows they hanged him."

"That's what I said. But the tinker said there's a story going round. In the south. That they hanged the wrong man." Carter leaned in. "That

it was a beggar with dyed hair. And the real Kingkiller's still out there. Wandering the roads. In disguise."

"That's been going round for years," said Graham. "Every tinker from here to Tinuë tells it."

"But this tinker said something new," said Carter. "He said there's a song. A new one. Going round the taverns in the south. About the Kingkiller. And the song says he didn't kill the king for spite, or for money, or for the Maer. It says he killed him to close a door." Carter looked around at them. "A door into somewhere bad. And he gave something up, to close it. Something important. And now he's hiding, and waiting, and one day he'll come back."

The room was silent.

"What did he give up?" said one of the young men from the south road.

"The tinker didn't know. The song doesn't say. Just that it was something he couldn't live without, and he gave it up anyway." Carter shrugged. "It's a sad song, the tinker said. He sang a bit of it. I didn't like it. Gave me the shivers."

Behind the bar, the innkeeper had stopped polishing. He was standing very still, with the glass in one hand and the cloth in the other.

Nobody noticed. Nobody but Chronicler, and Bast in the kitchen doorway.

And Old Cob.

\* \* \*

Old Cob had not said anything since he came in. That was unusual. Chronicler did not know Old Cob well, but on the first night, Old Cob had talked from the moment he sat down until the moment he left. He had told the story of the winter the river froze. He had told the story of the tinker who sold his father two goats sewn together. He had told the story of the Kingkiller, with its three kings and two dragons, and the part where the Kingkiller escaped from prison by turning into a crow.

On the second night, he had said almost nothing. Tonight he had told nothing at all. He sat at his place at the end of the bar with his

cider in his gnarled hands, and he watched. He watched Chronicler, at the corner table, with his empty hands and his satchel full of pages. And he watched the innkeeper.

When Carter finished speaking, and the room was silent, Old Cob looked up from his cider. He looked at the innkeeper, standing very still behind the bar. For a long moment. His faded eyes were very sharp.

Then he said, into the silence, in his thin cracked old voice:

"I heard that song too. Years back. Different tinker."

Everyone turned to look at him.

"How does it go?" said Graham.

Old Cob did not answer at once. He looked at the innkeeper. The innkeeper looked back at him.

"Don't remember," said Old Cob at last. "Not the words. Just the end." He turned his cup of cider in his hands. "At the end, it says he's waiting for someone to come and ask him. To tell the whole story. And when someone does—" He stopped.

"What?" said Jake.

Old Cob looked at Chronicler. At the corner table by the hearth. At the satchel full of pages.

"Then he'll be done waiting," said Old Cob.

\* \* \*

Nobody said anything for a long time. The fire crackled. Outside, the wind was rising.

Then Graham laughed, a big uneasy laugh, and slapped the bar.

"Well, that's cheerful," he said. "Cob, you're a proper ray of sunshine tonight. Kote, another round. On me. Before this old crow has us all jumping at shadows."

The innkeeper drew the round. His hands were steady. His face was mild. He set the mugs on the bar one by one, and the talk moved on, to the harvest, and the frost, and the price of barley in Rannish, and whether Carter's new horse would ever be as good as old Nelly had been.

And after a while, one by one, the regulars went home.

\* \* \*

Old Cob was the last. He climbed down off his stool, slowly, with a grunt, and pulled on his coat, and wrapped his scarf around his neck. At the door, he stopped. He looked back at the innkeeper, behind the bar.

"Kote," he said.

"Cob."

The old man looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at Chronicler, still sitting at the corner table. Then back.

"You tell it right," said Old Cob. Very quietly. "The whole thing. Don't leave any of it out." He paused. "Not even the running."

The innkeeper did not answer. But he nodded, once, very slightly.

Old Cob nodded back. And then he went out into the cold, and the door closed behind him, and they heard his stick tapping on the frozen road, going away.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper stood behind the bar for a long time after that. He did not polish anything. He stood with his hands flat on the wood and looked at the door.

"He knows," said Chronicler softly.

"He's always known. A little." The innkeeper took his hands off the bar. "Everyone knows a little, in a town like this. They just don't know that they know." He came around the bar and sat down at the table again, and folded his hands. "Cob knows more than most. He's seen things. I told you."

"The Hollis farm."

"Yes." The innkeeper looked at the fire. "He ran, that night. He's been ashamed of it for twenty years. He thinks it makes him a coward." He was quiet for a moment. "He wants me to put it in. The running. So that someone knows he wasn't the only one."

"Will you?"

"I already have." The innkeeper looked at Chronicler. "Haven't I?"



Chronicler thought of the pages in his satchel. Of a boy of twelve in a forest at dusk, running from a camp full of bodies. Of a young man in a burning inn, running from a shadow made of forgetting. Of a grey man on a bridge at dawn, watching a woman with dark hair walk away, and not running after her.

"Yes," he said. "You have."

"Good." The innkeeper unfolded his hands. "Get your pages out, then. We've a long way to go tonight. And I don't think we have much time."

Chronicler got out his pages. He uncapped his ink. He dipped his pen.

Outside, the wind was rising. And on the shutters, very faint, very slow, the first thin feathers of frost were beginning to creep in from the edges.

## Chapter One Hundred Seven

# Levinshir

I had been to Levinshir once before.

I do not know if I told you about it. It was on the road back from Ademre, alone, more than a year before. I had come upon a troupe of false Edema Ruh on the road—men who wore the colors and sang the songs but were not Ruh at all, only bandits in borrowed clothes. They had stolen two girls from a farm near Levinshir, and they were keeping them in their wagons, and doing things to them that I do not like to think about.

I killed them. All of them. I burned their wagons. And I brought the girls home.

I was not proud of it, afterward. Not the killing. The girls, yes. I was proud of bringing them home. But I had killed those men in a cold fury, one by one, in the night, and I had enjoyed it. That frightened me. It still does.

The girls' names were Krin and Ellie. I had not thought about them in a long time.

I thought about them now, as we came over the last ridge and saw Levinshir below us in the valley.

\* \* \*

It was a small town. Smaller than I remembered. A few dozen houses clustered around a crossroads, with a church and a mill and an inn. The same as a thousand towns across the Four Corners. Gray stone and brown thatch and green fields running away to the hills.

But it was empty.

We could see that from the ridge. No smoke from the chimneys. No people in the streets. No animals in the fields. The doors of the houses stood open. The mill wheel was still. A cart stood abandoned in the middle of the crossroads, with its traces empty.

"They've run," said Vashet. "From the army."

"Or been taken," said Wil.

We went down into the town. Carefully, slowly, with the Adem spread out ahead of us and Bast's glamour thin around us all. There was no one there. The houses were empty, their doors swinging in the wind. There was food on some of the tables, half eaten. There were clothes on the lines, flapping.

In the inn, there was a fire still smoldering in the hearth.

"A day," said Vashet, crouching beside it. "Maybe less. They left in a hurry."

I stood in the doorway of the inn and looked out at the empty crossroads. At the abandoned cart. At the hills beyond the town, rising toward a high rocky ridge in the east.

And on the ridge, faint against the grey sky, a shape. A house. A great old house, built of dark stone, with towers at its corners and a wall around it. It stood alone on the ridge like a crow on a fence post.

"There," I said.

\* \* \*

We found Krin on the road out of town.

She was sitting on a stone at the side of the road, with a bundle on her lap and her face in her hands. She was older than I remembered. Taller. Her hair was longer, and she was wearing a woman's dress now, not a girl's. But I knew her.

She looked up as we came down the road. She saw the Adem first, in their red clothes, and her face went white with terror. She grabbed her bundle and started to run.

"Krin," I said.

She stopped. She turned. She looked at me.

For a long moment, she did not move. Then her face changed. It crumpled, the way a child's face crumples just before it cries.

"You," she said. "It's you."

"It's me."

She dropped the bundle. She ran at me and threw her arms around me and held on, sobbing, the way she had held on to me in the back of the false troupe's wagon, the night I burned it.

"You came back," she said into my shirt. "You came back. I always knew you would. Everyone said you were dead. Everyone said you were a murderer. But I knew. I knew you'd come back."

I held her. I did not know what else to do.

\* \* \*

She told us what had happened, sitting on the stone at the side of the road, with the Adem standing guard around us and Bast crouched beside her with a waterskin.

The king's army had come through two days before. Not all of it. Only the front of it, a few hundred riders in black and silver. They had come into Levinshir and told everyone to leave. Everyone. Right away. They said the king was coming, and the king wanted the town empty. They said anyone who stayed would be hanged.

"Most people went," said Krin. "To their cousins in Hollowfell, or to the hill farms, or just away. Anywhere." She wiped her eyes. "My mam went. My da. My little brothers. They wanted me to go too."

"Why didn't you?"

She looked at me. "Because of the house," she said.

I went very still.

"The Lackless house," said Krin. "Up on the ridge. It's been empty for years. Since the old lord died. Nobody goes there. Everyone says it's cold. Everyone says it's haunted." She looked up at the ridge, at the dark shape of the house against the sky. "But I went there. Once. When I was little. On a dare. With Ellie."

"What did you find?"

Krin was quiet for a long time.

"There's a door," she said at last. "In the cellars. Way down. Past the wine and the old furniture and the rats. Down a long stair. At the bottom." She shivered. "It's made of stone. It doesn't have a handle. We went down and looked at it, and we were so scared we couldn't move." She looked at me. "And it talked to us."

"What did it say?"

"I don't know. Not really. It wasn't words." She wrapped her arms around herself. "But Ellie said it was asking us to come in. And we ran. We ran all the way home and never told anyone."

"Where's Ellie now?"

Krin's face changed. "She died," she said quietly. "Last winter. Of a fever." She looked down at her hands. "She was never the same, after the wagons. After what they did. She was always sad. And then she got sick, and she didn't want to get better."

I did not say anything. I put my hand on her shoulder.

"I stayed," said Krin, "because when the soldiers came, they were talking. About the house. About the door. They said the king was going to open it. They said the king had a key." She looked up at me with wet eyes. "And I thought, somebody should tell somebody. Somebody should know. And I didn't know who to tell. So I stayed, and I waited, and I thought maybe somebody would come." She laughed, a broken sound. "I didn't think it would be you."

\* \* \*

We left Krin with two of the Adem, to take her to the hill farms where her family had gone. She did not want to go. She wanted to come with us. She said she knew the house, knew the way down, knew where the door was.

"You've told us enough," I said. "That's all we needed. You were very brave to stay."

"I'm not brave. I'm stupid."

"Those are often the same thing," said Bast, and grinned at her.

She looked at him. At his fine-boned face and his deep blue eyes. She blushed, very slightly.

"Who's he?" she whispered to me.

"A friend."

"He's very handsome."

"Don't tell him," I said. "He already knows."

She laughed. It was a small, surprised, watery laugh. Then she hugged me one more time, fiercely, and went with the Adem down the road toward the hills.

At the bend in the road, she turned and looked back.

"Kvothe," she called. "The door. Don't answer it. Whatever it says. Don't answer."

"I won't," I called back.

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she went around the bend and was gone.

\* \* \*

"Everyone keeps telling you that," said Bast, as we started up the long road toward the ridge. "Don't answer the door."

"I know."

"Auri told you. And Krin. And the Sleeper, back at your University. And Selitos, sort of."

"I know."

"Why do you think that is?"

I looked up at the house on the ridge. Dark stone, against the grey sky. Towers at its corners, and a wall around it, and no light in any of its windows.

"Because," I said, "they all know I'm going to."

## Chapter One Hundred Eight

# The Lackless House

The king's army reached the ridge the next afternoon, and by nightfall there were fires all around the Lackless house like a ring of fallen stars.

We watched from a high rocky outcrop half a mile to the north, lying flat among the heather with Bast's glamour thin over us. We watched the long black column wind up the road from Levinshir, rank on rank of soldiers and horses and wagons, with the black and silver banner at its head. We watched it spread out across the slopes below the house and settle there like a flock of crows, pitching tents, digging latrines, lighting fires.

We watched a smaller group ride up to the house itself. Twenty or thirty riders, with the banner of Jakis and a covered wagon in their midst. They went in through the gate in the wall around the house, and the gate closed behind them.

"She's in the wagon," said Vashet softly. "The lady. I saw her face at the window."

"And the king?"

"On the black horse. At the front."

"And the old man?"

Vashet was quiet for a moment. "On the donkey," she said. "Behind the wagon. With the girl."

I lay in the heather and looked at the house. At its dark stone walls and its four towers and its windows with no light in them. It was very old. Older than Severen. Older, perhaps, than Renere. It looked

less like a house than like something that had grown out of the ridge, the way a stone grows out of the earth when the soil around it washes away.

"Tomorrow night," I said. "The dark of the moon."

"Tomorrow night," said Vashet. "And tonight, we find a way in."

\* \* \*

Fela found it.

She did not tell us how. She lay in the heather on the high outcrop with her palms pressed flat against the rock, and her eyes closed, and her lips moving, for most of an hour. When she opened her eyes, her face was pale and her hands were shaking. But her voice was steady.

"There's a way," she said. "Under. The ridge is hollow. There are caves, very old, running all through it. Some of them go up under the house." She pointed down the slope to the north, away from the army, toward a steep gully choked with brambles and loose stone. "One of them comes out there. In that gully. It's very narrow. Very old. It hasn't been used in a long time." She paused. "But the stone remembers people walking through it. Long ago. People carrying things. Going up, and coming down."

"Where does it go?" I asked.

Fela looked at me with her dark serious eyes.

"Down," she said. "It goes down. To the same place the stairs in the house go." She shivered. "To the door."

\* \* \*

We went at midnight.

There were nineteen of us. Nine Adem, with Vashet at their head. Sim and Wil and Devi and Fela. Bast. Me. And four of the Maer's soldiers, the best he had left: Dagon, with his hatchet face, and three others whose names I have never forgotten, though I will not tell them here. They have families still. They would not want to be remembered for this.

The Maer had wanted to come. He had argued for a long time. I had told him no. I had told him that someone needed to stay with the



rest of his people. That someone needed to be alive, afterward, to lead them. That his daughter needed a father, even if she would never know him.

In the end, he had agreed. But when we left, at midnight, he stood at the mouth of his cave and watched us go, and his face in the firelight was the face of a man watching his whole life walk away into the dark.

\* \* \*

The gully was steep and treacherous, choked with brambles and loose scree. We went down it slowly, in single file, with the Adem leading and Bast's glamour stretched thin over all of us like a cloak that was too small. At the bottom, half hidden under a fall of rock and a tangle of blackthorn, there was a hole.

It was very small. Barely wide enough for a man to squeeze through on his hands and knees. Beyond it, there was darkness.

Fela knelt beside it and put her hand on the stone at its edge. She was quiet for a moment.

"This is it," she said.

We went in.

\* \* \*

I will not tell you much about that passage. It was long and narrow and very dark. For the first hundred yards we crawled, on hands and knees, over sharp stones, with the rock pressing down on our backs. Then it opened out, a little, and we could walk bent over. Then a little more, and we could walk upright.

The walls were rough and unworked, the natural stone of the ridge. But here and there, as we went deeper, there were marks on them. Carvings. Very old, worn almost smooth. I held my sympathy lamp close and looked at them.

They were knots.

Yllish knots, carved into the stone. Long lines of them, running along the walls like words on a page. Some of them I could read. *Keeping. Door. Line. Name.* The same knots I had seen on the Dellers' cloth, and in the blue book, and in the heart of Kilvin's candle.

"The keepers," I said softly. "They came this way. To tend the door."

"They did," said Fela. Her hand was trailing along the wall. "For a long time. Hundreds of years. Thousands. The stone remembers their footsteps." She was quiet for a moment. "And then they stopped coming. A long time ago. Before your grandmother's time. Before her grandmother's." She looked at me. "Something happened. Something made them stop."

"What?"

Fela shook her head. "The stone doesn't know. It only knows they stopped." She looked down the passage, into the dark. "And that since then, the door has been alone. For a very long time. And very lonely."

\* \* \*

We went down.

The passage sloped steadily downward, winding through the heart of the ridge. The air grew colder as we went. Colder than it should have been, even so deep underground. Our breath began to smoke in the light of our lamps.

And I began to hear it.

At first I thought it was the wind. A faint, low sound, somewhere far ahead, rising and falling. But there was no wind this deep. And the sound was too regular. Too steady. In, and out. In, and out.

Breathing.

The same breathing I had heard in the Chamber of Watches, beneath the Archives. Slow and deep and patient. The breath of something very large, sleeping very deeply.

But it was different here. Faster. Shallower. Less deep. The breath of something that was not quite asleep anymore. Something that was dreaming, and stirring in its dreams, and very close to waking.

Beside me, Fela had gone very pale.

"It knows," she whispered. "It knows we're coming. It knows *you're* coming."

\* \* \*

We stopped to rest in a place where the passage widened into a small round cave. There was a trickle of water running down one wall, and a flat stone floor, and a low ceiling that dripped.

The Adem spread out around the edges of the cave, silent and watchful. Dagon and his men sat against the wall with their swords across their knees. Sim sat down heavily on the floor and put his head between his knees. Wil sat beside him and put a scarred hand on his back.

Devi sat down across from me and began to take things out of her satchel. Small clay pots. Glass vials. A coil of copper wire. A handful of what looked like iron nails.

"What are those?" I asked.

"More Surprises," she said. "Smaller ones. I made them on the way. And these—" she held up the nails, "—are for the scrael. If there are any. Iron. Heated. With a little something extra." She smiled her spider's smile. "They'll go through a scrael's shell like a hot knife through butter."

"Devi," I said. "Thank you. For coming."

She looked up at me. For a moment, her face was very serious.

"You still owe me a page," she said. "From the Book of Watches. You said you'd give it back someday." She went back to sorting her pots. "I'm not letting you die before you pay your debts."

\* \* \*

Bast came and sat beside me. He did not say anything for a while. He was holding something in his hands, turning it over and over.

"What's that?" I asked.

He held it up. It was a small knife. Very plain, with a wooden handle and a short blade.

"It's iron," he said. His voice was tight. "Devi gave it to me. For the scrael. She said I'd need it." He looked down at it. His fingers were red where they touched the handle, as if he had been holding something hot. "It burns. It burns so much."

"Then don't hold it."

"I have to." He closed his fingers around the handle. His face tightened. "If there are scrael. If they come. I have to be able to fight them." He looked at me. "I can't just glamour everything, Reshi. Not down here. Not with *that* so close." He nodded down the passage, toward the breathing. "It's too loud. It's drowning me out."

I looked at him. At his fine-boned face, tight with pain. At his hand, closed around the iron knife, the skin going red and blistered.

"Put it away," I said. "In your boot. Only take it out if you need it."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded, and slid the knife into his boot, and flexed his burned fingers.

"Reshi," he said quietly. "When we get there. When you do what you're going to do. With your name." He hesitated. "Will you still be you? Afterward?"

I did not answer right away.

"I don't know," I said at last. "Selitos said I'd be less. Not empty. But less."

"Less how?"

"I don't know. I've never done it." I looked at him. "I suppose we'll find out."

Bast was quiet for a long time.

"I'll stay with you," he said at last. "Afterward. Whatever you are. However much less. I'll stay." He looked at me. "I owe you a life. I'll pay it. I'll stay until you're you again."

"What if I'm never me again?"

Bast looked at me with his deep blue eyes.

"Then I'll stay forever," he said simply.

\* \* \*

We went on.

The passage wound down and down. The breathing grew louder. The air grew colder. Frost began to form on the walls, glittering in the light of our lamps. Our breath came out in great white plumes.

And then, ahead of us, there was light.

Not the light of lamps. Not the light of torches. A pale, cold, silvery light, like moonlight on snow. The same light I had seen in the Cellarage, beneath the University, when the Sleeper woke.

We stopped. We stood in the passage, all nineteen of us, and looked at the light.

"That's it," said Fela. Her voice was barely a whisper. "The chamber. The door."

I looked at the light. I listened to the breathing.

And beneath the breathing, faint and far away, I heard something else. Voices. Human voices. Someone talking, low and steady. Someone else answering. And beneath them, very soft, someone singing.

A woman's voice. Singing a song I knew.

Denna.

She was singing her Lanre song. The false one. The beautiful one. And the breathing, behind the door, was keeping time.

## Chapter One Hundred Nine

# The Last Keeper

We rested twice in the keepers' tunnel before we came to the silver light. I have told you about the first time, in the small round cave with the trickle of water, where Devi sorted her Surprises and Bast held an iron knife until his fingers blistered. I have not told you about the second.

It was deeper. Much deeper. The passage had been winding down through the heart of the ridge for what felt like hours, and the air had grown so cold that our breath hung in front of our faces like smoke, and the carvings on the walls had grown thicker. Knots. Lines and lines of them, spiraling along the stone, so dense in places that the wall seemed to be made of nothing else.

And then the passage opened into a small chamber, no bigger than a cottage kitchen, and in the chamber there was a chair.

\* \* \*

It was carved from the living rock. A stone chair, plain and square, facing the passage that led onward and down. Beside it, a stone shelf. On the shelf, a lamp. Not a sympathy lamp; an old clay oil lamp, the kind you see in very old paintings, dry and cracked. And beside the lamp, a spindle, and a bundle of dark cord, and a small clay cup.

Fela stopped in the doorway. She put her hand flat against the wall.

"Someone sat here," she said softly. "For a long time. Years. Every day."

"A keeper," I said.

"The last one." Fela closed her eyes. "The stone remembers her. She came down every day for forty years. She sat in the chair and she tied knots. All day. Every day." Fela's voice was very quiet. "The stone remembers the feel of her hands. Small. Quick. Always moving."

"What was she tying?"

Fela was quiet for a long time, with her hand on the wall and her eyes closed.

"Names," she said at last. "The names of the keepers. All of them. Back and back and back. She was tying them into cords, so they wouldn't be forgotten." She opened her eyes. "The stone says she was afraid. Toward the end. Afraid that she was the last. That no one would come after her."

I looked at the bundle of dark cord on the shelf beside the lamp. I did not touch it.

"Was she?" I said. "The last?"

Fela did not answer right away. She moved her hand along the wall, slowly, the way a blind woman reads a face.

"Something happened," she said. "Near the end. Someone came down the tunnel who wasn't a keeper. A man. Old. With a stick." She stopped. Her face had gone very pale. "The stone remembers the stick. Tapping. On the floor. Coming down."

Everyone in the small chamber went very still.

"He talked to her," said Fela. "For a long time. She was sitting in the chair, and he was standing in the doorway. Where I am." She stepped out of the doorway, quickly, as if it were hot. "He was very kind. The stone remembers his voice was kind. And she listened. And then—" Fela stopped.

"And then?"

Fela looked at me. Her dark eyes were wet.

"And then she got up," she said. "And went with him. Up the tunnel. Out into the world. And she never came back." She was quiet for a moment. "The stone waited for her. For a long time. It didn't understand. Nobody ever came again."

I looked at the chair. At the lamp, and the spindle, and the bundle of cord.

"When?" I said. "When did this happen?"

Fela put her hand on the wall again. She was quiet for a long time.

"Stone doesn't count years the way we do," she said at last. "But not very long ago. For stone." She hesitated. "Sixty years? Seventy? A little more?"

I did the arithmetic in my head. The blue book in the Archives. *The Lines of Loeclos*. The long genealogy running back into darkness, and the last few generations before the gap where a page had been cut. My grandfather. My grandfather's mother.

"She had a name," I said. "The stone would know it. If she sat here forty years."

Fela closed her eyes. Her lips moved.

"Liss," she said at last. "Or something like it. The stone doesn't hear names the way we do. But her hands, when she tied—" She stopped. She opened her eyes. "Kvothe. She was tying a cord for herself, near the end. With her own name in it. The stone remembers."

"Where is it?"

We all looked at the shelf. At the bundle of dark cord beside the dry lamp.

I reached out. I did not decide to. I took up the bundle, very carefully. It was very old and very dry and it crackled in my hands. It was not one cord but many, tied together at one end. Dozens of them. Each one knotted along its length, dense and intricate.

And at the end of the bundle, tied on last, a short cord. Shorter than the rest. Newer. With only a few knots in it, and then nothing. As if the hands tying it had stopped in the middle.

I looked at it for a long time in the red light of my lamp. I could read some of it. Not much. The knot for *keeping*. The knot for *door*. The knot for *line*.

And a name. A small name. Not a true name, not the kind Denna could tie. Just a word, knotted in a cord, the way you would carve it on



a stone.

*Liss.*

\* \* \*

"My great-grandmother," I said.

I did not know it for certain. I have never known it for certain. But I knew it the way you sometimes know things. Standing in that cold small chamber with the keepers' cords in my hands, I knew it.

*Liss Lackless.* She had been in the blue book. I remembered the name now, in the long list of the last generations. *Liss, daughter of Harrow, keeper.* And beside it, in the margin, the small knot-mark I had seen beside so many of the names. And then a date. And nothing else.

No death recorded. Only the date. As if she had simply stopped.

"He took her," I said. "Bredon. He came down here and he talked to her and he took her away. The last keeper." I looked at the chair, empty for seventy years. "And after her, no one came. My grandfather never came. My mother came once, a frightened girl of twelve, and ran, and kept running. They didn't know. No one told them."

"Why?" said Sim softly. He was standing just behind Fela, with his thin face very pale in the lamplight. "Why take her? Why not just—"

"Kill her?" I shook my head. "He doesn't kill, if he can help it. He says it's inelegant. He moves you. He talks to you, and he's kind, and he shows you another road, and you walk down it yourself." I looked at the bundle of cords in my hands. "He didn't need her dead. He needed her gone. He needed the keeping to stop. So the line would forget. So that when it came time, whoever came to the door wouldn't know how to tend it. Only how to open it."

The small chamber was very quiet.

"The beautiful game," I said. "He's been playing it for seventy years. Longer. He took the keeper away, and the line forgot, and my mother ran away from a house full of secrets she was never taught to understand." My voice was very steady. "And then he found her. And then he found me."

\* \* \*

Vashet had not come into the chamber. She was standing in the passage beyond, with the other Adem, watching the way ahead. But she turned her head now and looked at me.

"Kvothe," she said. "We cannot stay."

"I know."

"The cords. Will you take them?"

I looked down at them. At the dozens of dark knotted cords, dry and crackling, with the names of all the keepers back and back and back to a woman in the hills who loved a shaper for a little while. And the short one at the end, stopped in the middle.

"No," I said. "They belong here."

I laid them back on the shelf. Very carefully. Beside the dry lamp and the spindle and the clay cup. Exactly where she had left them, seventy years ago, when she got up and walked away with a kind old man and never came back.

And then I did something I had not planned. I took the thread from around my neck, the one with Denna's knot on it. *Road. Promise. A story told many times.* I did not take the knot off. I only held it, for a moment, over the short cord at the end of the bundle. Over *Liss*.

"I'm here," I said. Very quietly. To the chair, or the cords, or the stone. "I came. Someone came. You weren't the last."

Fela made a small sound behind me.

"It heard you," she whispered. "The stone. It heard you, Kvothe. It's—" She stopped. She pressed her hand flat against the wall. Her face was wet. "It's been waiting seventy years for someone to say that."

I put the thread back around my neck. I picked up my lamp.

And we went on, down the passage, toward the silver light.

\* \* \*

I have thought about Liss Lackless a great deal since. About the forty years she sat in that chair, tying the names of the dead so they would not be forgotten. About the day a kind old man came down the tunnel,

tapping his stick, and talked to her, and she got up and went with him.

I have wondered what he said. What story he told her. What other road he showed her, that was more beautiful than the chair and the cords and the cold.

I have never found out. There is no one left to ask. But I think I know the shape of it.

I think he told her she was free.

I think he told her that the keeping was a cage, and she had been in it too long, and she deserved to see the sun. I think he told her it was love.

And I think she believed him. Because it was half true. The Cthaeh only ever tells you half. So did Bredon.

And the half that hurts is always the half you do not hear until it is too late.

## Chapter One Hundred Ten

# Beneath

The passage opened out onto a ledge, high up in the wall of a great round chamber, and from that ledge I looked down and saw the door.

The chamber was enormous. Bigger than the Eolian. Bigger than the Masters' Hall at the University. It was a vast round space carved out of the living rock of the ridge, with a domed ceiling so high it was lost in shadow and walls that curved down and down to a floor of smooth grey stone, polished like glass. The walls were covered in carvings. Knots, thousands of them, running in long spiraling lines from the floor to the ceiling. The names of the keepers, I thought. All of them, all the way back, to the first.

There was a stair on the far side of the chamber, wide and shallow, winding down from an archway high in the wall. That must be the stair from the house above, I thought. The one Krin had gone down as a child, on a dare, with her friend Ellie.

And at the bottom of the chamber, set into the wall directly opposite the stair, was the door.

It was grey stone. Smooth and plain and utterly featureless. It had no handle. It had no hinges. It had no lock. It was taller than three men and wider than a wagon, and it was perfectly, impossibly flat, like a sheet of still water turned on its side.

It was exactly the same as the door beneath the Archives. Exactly the same as the door I had dreamed of, all those months ago, in my narrow bed at Anker's. And it was different. It was breathing.

I could see it. The whole face of the door was moving, very slightly. Swelling out and sinking back. Swelling out and sinking back. In, and out. Like the side of a sleeping animal.

The silver light was coming from it. From a thin bright line down its center, running from top to bottom. A crack. Hair-fine. Barely visible. But it was there.

\* \* \*

There were people on the floor of the chamber.

Soldiers, first. Fifty or sixty of them, in the black and silver of the house of Jakis, standing in a ring around the edges of the floor with torches in their hands. They were very still. They were very pale. Several of them were shaking. I could see the torchlight trembling on their faces.

Then, in the center of the floor, facing the door, a smaller group.

Ambrose was there. He was standing in front of the door, a few paces from it, in his black clothes, with his silver circlet on his head and the box on its chain around his neck. He was very still. His face was white. His hands were clenched at his sides.

Meluan was there. She was kneeling on the stone floor beside Ambrose, with her hands bound in front of her and her head bowed. Her pale grey robe was stained with dirt. Her dark hair hung loose over her face. A soldier stood behind her with a hand on her shoulder.

Cinder was there. He was standing a little apart, to one side, with his ice-pale sword sheathed at his hip and his hands folded behind his back. He was looking at the door. He was smiling.

And the others were there. The rest of the Seven. I saw Usnea, pale and grey, standing near the stair. Stercus, dark and stocky, near the wall. Pale Alenta. Cyphus, with blue fire flickering along his arms. Grey Mardou, a smudge of mist at the edge of the torchlight.

And Bredon.

He was sitting on a stool at the edge of the floor, a little way from the door. There was a small table in front of him, with a tak board on it, the stones laid out in their bowls. He was not looking at the door. He was not looking at Ambrose, or Meluan, or the Seven. He was

looking at the board. As if he were in the middle of a game.

And beside him, sitting on the floor with her harp in her lap, was Denna.

She was singing.

\* \* \*

I lay on the ledge high above the chamber, with Bast on one side of me and Vashet on the other, and I listened to her sing.

It was the Lanre song. The false one. The one she had sung at the Eolian, the night it burned. But it was different, now. Softer. Slower. It was not a song for an audience. It was a song for the door.

She was singing it to the door. And the door was listening.

I could see it. The breathing of the door had changed. It was keeping time with her song. Swelling out on the long notes, sinking back on the short. In, and out. In time with her voice. As if the door were singing along.

And the crack down its center was widening. Very slowly. So slowly I could barely see it. But it was. With every verse she sang, the silver line grew a little brighter. A little wider.

"She's opening it," Bast breathed. "Reshi, she's opening it. With the song."

"No," I said. "She's weakening it. The curse. The song weakens the curse, and the curse is part of what holds the door. It's all one thing. Lanre's curse and the Thief's prison. They were made together, by the same man, on the same night." I watched the silver line. "Every time she sings the false story, the whole binding gets a little weaker."

"Then stop her!"

"I can't. Not from here." I looked at Denna. At her bowed head, and her fingers moving on the harp strings, and her pale face in the silver light. "And she's not doing it because she wants to."

I could see her wrist. The one with the knot. It was glowing. Dull red, like an ember. Brighter every time she faltered, every time her voice wavered. And every time it glowed, she flinched, and her voice steadied, and she sang on.

Bredon was pulling the cord.

\* \* \*

"What do we do?" whispered Vashet.

I looked down at the chamber. At the soldiers with their torches, and the Seven, and Ambrose, and Meluan, and Bredon at his tak board. At Denna, singing. At the door, breathing.

"We wait," I said.

"For what?"

"For him to make his move." I watched Bredon. He had picked up a white stone from the bowl and was turning it over in his fingers, the way he always did when he was thinking. "He knows I'm coming. He's been waiting for me. He's not going to open the door without me, not if he can help it. The lady's blood can crack it. Denna's song can weaken it. But only a namer of the line can open it all the way." I paused. "He's waiting for me to show myself."

"Then don't."

"I have to. Eventually. That's the whole point." I looked at Vashet. "But not yet. Not until I'm ready. Not until I know what he's going to do."

Vashet looked at me for a long moment. Then her hands moved. *Patience*, they said. And then, *good*.

\* \* \*

We waited.

Denna sang. Her song went on and on, verse after verse. She sang Lanre's glory at Drossen Tor, and his death, and his return. She sang his love for Lyra. She sang the betrayal of his friends, and the jealousy of Selitos, and the terrible injustice of the curse.

And the door breathed. And the crack grew.

At last, she came to the end. The last verse. The one where Lanre, wronged and cursed and alone, stands among the ruins of the world his enemies have made, and weeps for all that was taken from him.

Her voice broke on the last line. She stopped. She sat with her fingers still on the harp strings, and her head bowed, and her shoulders shaking.

The chamber was silent. Utterly silent. Even the breathing of the door had stopped.

Then Bredon set down his white stone on the tak board. It made a small, sharp click in the silence.

"Well," he said. "That's done."

He looked up. Not at the door. Not at Ambrose. Up. At the ledge. At me.

"You can come down now, Kvothe," he said pleasantly. "I know you're there. I've known for some time. You breathe very loudly, for someone who studied with the Adem."

\* \* \*

Beside me, Vashet's hand closed on my arm. I felt her fingers tighten. *Don't*, they said.

I did not listen. I stood up.

I stood on the ledge, high above the chamber, in the silver light of the cracked door, and every face on the floor below turned up to look at me.

The soldiers. The Seven. Ambrose, with his white face and his clenched hands. Meluan, lifting her head, her dark eyes wide in her thin face. Cinder, smiling. Bredon, at his tak board, with his mild kind face turned up toward me like a flower toward the sun.

And Denna.

She had lifted her head. She was looking at me. Her face was wet with tears. Her eyes were very dark.

She did not say anything. But her lips moved. Silently. One word. *No*.

\* \* \*

"Come down," said Bredon. "Please. We've all been waiting for you. It's very rude to keep people waiting."

I looked down at him. At his board, with its stones laid out in their pattern.

"Let the lady go," I said. My voice rang out in the great round chamber, strange and hollow. "Let her go, and I'll come down."



"Oh, I don't think so." Bredon smiled. "I think you'll come down anyway. Because you want to know. You've always wanted to know. It's your great weakness, your hunger for knowing." He gestured at the door. "And there it is. The last door. The one that's been waiting for you since before you were born." He looked up at me. "Don't you want to see what's behind it?"

"No."

"Liar." He said it gently, fondly, the way a grandfather says it to a child caught with his hand in the cake tin. "You've been lying to yourself for so long, Kvothe. Telling yourself you only want to close it. Only want to save your aunt. Only want to keep the world safe." He shook his head. "But I know you. I've watched you. I've played with you. And I know that underneath all of that, underneath everything, there's a little boy who just wants to know what's on the other side."

I did not answer. I stood on the ledge and looked at him.

"Come down," said Bredon softly. "Come down, and play one last game with me. And then, whatever happens, at least you'll know."

\* \* \*

I looked at Vashet. She was still lying on the ledge beside me, with her hand on my arm and her face showing nothing. But her eyes were very steady.

*Choose, they said. And bear what comes after.*

I looked at Bast. He was lying on my other side, with his hand in his boot, on the handle of the iron knife. His face was white. His deep blue eyes were very wide.

*I'll stay, they said. Whatever you are. However much less.*

I looked down at the chamber. At Meluan, kneeling on the stone with her hands bound. At Denna, sitting with her harp, her lips still shaping the word *no*.

At the door, breathing.

And then I went down.

\* \* \*

There was a stair cut into the wall below the ledge. Narrow and steep and very old, spiraling down along the curve of the chamber wall. I went down it slowly, one step at a time, with my hand on the cold carved stone of the wall and my eyes on the floor below.

Behind me, I heard the others moving. The Adem, spreading out along the ledge. Sim and Wil and Devi and Fela, crouching low. Dagon and his soldiers, drawing their swords. Bast, very close behind me, on the stair.

I did not look back. I kept going down.

The soldiers on the floor did not move to stop me. They stood in their ring with their torches, pale and shaking, and watched me come. The Seven did not move either. They stood where they were and watched me with their strange cold eyes.

Only Cinder moved. He took a step toward the foot of the stair, his hand on the hilt of his ice-pale sword.

"Ferule," said Bredon mildly, without looking up from his board. "Leave him. He's coming. Let him come."

Cinder stopped. He looked at Bredon. Something moved in his black eyes. Then he stepped back, and folded his hands behind his back again, and smiled.

I reached the bottom of the stair. I stepped out onto the smooth grey floor of the chamber. It was very cold. Colder than the passage. Colder than the Stormwal. The cold came up through the soles of my boots and into my bones.

I walked across the floor toward the door.

\* \* \*

I walked past the soldiers. Past the Seven. Past Cinder, with his black eyes and his smile. Past Meluan, kneeling on the stone, who looked up at me with her thin white face and whispered my name.

I walked past Denna.

She did not look up this time. She sat with her harp in her lap and her head bowed, and her hands were shaking on the strings. But as I passed her, very softly, so softly that only I could hear, she spoke.

"I have a cord," she whispered. "In my sleeve. Ready. When you need it."

I did not stop. I did not look at her. I kept walking.

I stopped in front of the door.

It was even bigger up close. Taller than three men. Wider than a wagon. Smooth and grey and perfectly flat, like a sheet of still water turned on its side. The silver crack ran down its center from top to bottom, glowing faintly. And the whole face of it was breathing. Swelling out and sinking back. In, and out.

I could feel it. The breath of it. Cold and slow and deep, on my face, on my hands. Like standing in front of a great sleeping beast.

And I could hear it. Not the breathing. The other thing. The voice. Very faint. Very far away. Coming from the other side of the stone.

Saying my name.

My true name. The one the Sleeper had spoken, and the voice beneath the Archives, and the box on Ambrose's chest. The name that was the shape of me.

*Come in, it said. Come in, child of my child. Come home.*

I stood in front of the door and listened to it call me.

And behind me, at his little table, Bredon picked up a black stone and held it out.

"Your move," he said.

## Chapter One Hundred Eleven

# Kingkiller

I did not take the stone.

I turned my back on the door, which is the hardest thing I have ever done, harder than keeping my voice steady while Stanchion died, harder than walking away from Tempi's cairn. I turned my back on the door while it breathed on my neck and whispered my name, and I looked at Bredon, sitting at his little table with a black stone held out between two fingers.

"No," I said.

Bredon lowered his hand. He did not seem disappointed. He seemed interested.

"No?" he said.

"I'm not playing your game anymore."

"Everyone is playing. Always. I told you that." He set the black stone down on the edge of the board, carefully, the way you set down something you will want again later. "But very well. If you won't play, I'll simply tell you the position. It's quite simple, really." He folded his hands on the head of his stick. "Behind you is a door. In your head is its name. Around the young king's neck is its key. On the floor beside him is a woman of the line." He tilted his head toward Denna, still sitting on the floor with her harp. "And on that girl's wrist is a cord that I can tighten whenever I like."

"I know the position."

"Then you know how it ends." He smiled. "You speak the name. The door opens. I let the girl go, and your aunt, and all your little

friends up on the ledge. You'll have saved everyone. You'll be a hero." He paused. "Isn't that what you've always wanted?"

"And the world?"

"The world will be different." Bredon shrugged. "Better, perhaps. Worse, perhaps. Who can say? But different. And my master will have his rest, after ten thousand years." His voice softened. "Is that so terrible, Kvothe? To give an old man his rest?"

"You're not asking for his rest. You're asking for the Thief."

"I'm asking for a door to be opened. What comes through it is not my concern." He picked up the white stone again and turned it over. "You're very young. You think everything has to be decided. That there must be a right answer and a wrong one. But the world is not a tak board. Most moves are neither right nor wrong. They are only moves." He looked at me. "Speak the name."

"No."

Bredon sighed.

"Very well," he said. "Then we'll do it the slow way."

He looked at Ambrose.

\* \* \*

I will tell you what Ambrose did, because I have promised to tell the truth, and because it matters. What I did next only makes sense if you know what he did first.

He had been standing very still in front of the door, a few paces to my left, with the box on its chain around his neck and his hands clenched at his sides. He had not spoken since I came down the stair. He had not looked at me. He had been looking at the door, with a strange expression on his white face. Hungry. Afraid. Awed. The expression of a boy at the edge of a cliff, looking down.

When Bredon looked at him, he flinched. Then his face hardened.

He turned to Meluan, kneeling on the floor beside him. He took her by the arm and hauled her to her feet. She cried out. She was very weak. She could barely stand.

"Ambrose," I said. "Don't."

He did not look at me. He dragged Meluan forward, toward the door. With his other hand, he pulled a knife from his belt. A small jeweled knife, the kind a nobleman carries to cut his meat at table.

He cut her palm. Quickly, carelessly, the way you might cut a rope. She gasped. Blood welled up, very dark in the silver light.

Then he lifted the box from his chest, still on its chain, and pressed it against her bleeding palm, and pressed her palm against the door.

\* \* \*

The door screamed.

It was not a sound. Or not only a sound. It was a shock that went through the whole chamber, through the stone of the floor and the walls and the domed ceiling, through my feet and my legs and my chest and my teeth. It was like being inside a great bell at the moment it is struck.

The soldiers in their ring cried out. Several of them dropped their torches. One of them fell to his knees and clapped his hands over his ears.

And the crack in the door opened.

Not all the way. Not even very far. But the thin silver line down the center of the door widened, suddenly, violently, to the width of a hand. And through it poured light. Silver light, cold and bright and blinding. And wind. A wind so cold it burned, howling out of the gap in the door, whipping my hair and cloak and tearing at my clothes.

And beneath the wind, a voice. Very deep. Very old. No longer whispering.

YES, it said.

Meluan was screaming.

\* \* \*

Her hand was stuck to the door. I could see it. Her palm, pressed flat against the stone beside the crack, with the box pressed against the back of it and Ambrose's hand pressing the box. The blood from her cut palm was running down the face of the door in dark lines. And the

door was drinking it.

I could see that too. The blood did not drip to the floor. It ran across the stone and sank into it, the way water sinks into dry sand. And where it sank, the stone glowed. And the crack grew wider.

And Meluan was fading.

Her face was going grey. The color was draining out of it, the way color drains from a leaf in autumn, the way it had drained from Stanchion's face when Usnea laid her hand on his chest. Her dark hair was going white at the temples. Her hand on the door was thinning, the skin going papery and translucent over the bones.

The door was not drinking her blood. It was drinking her. Her life. Her years. Her name. The part of her that was the line.

"*Ambrose!*" I shouted. "*Stop! You're killing her!*"

He turned to look at me. His face was lit silver by the light pouring out of the crack. His eyes were wide and bright and wild.

"It's working," he said. His voice was high and strange. "Do you see? It's *working*. He said it would. He said the blood would wake it, and the key would turn it, and a king could command it." He laughed. "And I'm a king. I'm a *king*. And it's listening to me!"

"It's not listening to you. It's eating her."

"She's *nothing!*" His face twisted. "She's just a woman. Just a vessel. Just blood. He said so. He said the door wants the line, and she's the line, so give it to her." He turned back to the door. "And when it's open, I'll be more than a king. He promised. The one behind it will make me more than a king. He'll make me—"

He stopped. He looked down at Meluan, sagging against the door with her grey face and her white hair and her thin papery hand pressed flat to the stone.

"It's too slow," he said. "It's taking too long." He raised the jeweled knife. "He said if it was too slow, I should give it all of her. All at once."

He pressed the blade against her throat.

\* \* \*

I have thought about that moment more than any other moment of my life.

I have taken it out and turned it over and looked at it from every side, the way you look at a stone you have carried in your pocket for so long that you know every edge and hollow of it by touch. I have wondered whether there was another way. Whether I could have called the wind and knocked the knife from his hand. Whether I could have spoken his name and bound him. Whether I could have talked to him, the way I had talked to him in the burning camp, and made him see.

Maybe I could have. I do not know. I will never know.

But I know that there was no time. The knife was at her throat. His hand was already moving. And I knew, the way Shehyn had known, looking into the eyes of a man with a list of children's names hidden in his cell, that he was going to do it. That he would do it before I could finish a single word.

*You will face a choice, Vashet had said, sitting on the floor of my room in the dark. Where you must act, and there is no time to wait, and everyone will say afterward that you were wrong.*

I drew Caesura.

I did not decide to. I want that understood. I did not stand there and weigh it and choose. My hand went to the hilt, and the sword came out of its sheath with the sound it always made, like a breath let out, and I was moving. The way the Adem move. The way Vashet taught me. Without anger. Without hesitation. Without thought.

*Tree Falling. Water Flows Around. Lightning in the Hand.*

Three steps. The last one long.

The blade went into Ambrose Jakis just below his left arm, where the fine black velvet of his coat stretched over his ribs. It went in cleanly and deeply, the way Adem swords go in, and it found his heart.

\* \* \*

He did not scream. He did not cry out. He made a small sound, a sort of hiccup of surprise, the sound a child makes when it is startled.

The jeweled knife fell from his hand. It clattered on the stone floor.



He turned his head and looked at me. His face was very close to mine. His eyes were wide. There was no anger in them. No hatred. Only confusion. The confusion of someone who has been told a story all his life, and has just discovered that it was not true.

"Oh," he said.

He looked down at the sword in his side. He looked back up at me.

"He said," said Ambrose Jakis, King of Vintas. "He said I was special."

Then his knees gave way, and he slid off the blade, and fell.

\* \* \*

He lay on the stone floor in front of the door, in the silver light, on his back. His silver circlet had fallen off and rolled away. The box was still on its chain around his neck, lying on his chest, rising and falling as he breathed. Once. Twice.

Then it stopped rising.

I stood over him with Caesura in my hand. The blade was red to the hilt. It was dripping on the stone.

Beside me, Meluan had slid down the face of the door and was lying in a heap at its foot. Her hand had come away from the stone when Ambrose fell. It was grey and thin and bloodless. Her hair was white. But she was breathing. I could see her chest moving.

She was alive.

And the chamber was silent.

\* \* \*

I looked up.

Every face in the chamber was turned toward me. The soldiers, in their ring, with their fallen torches guttering on the stone. The Seven, standing very still. Cinder, with his black eyes wide, and something on his face I had never seen there before. Denna, on her knees beside her harp, with her hand pressed against her mouth.

And Bredon. At his little table. With a white stone halfway to the board.

He was looking at me. His face was not mild anymore. Not kind. Not interested. For the first time since I had known him, it was simply still. As if a wind had blown across it and wiped it clean.

Then, slowly, he set the white stone down on the board.

"Well," he said quietly. "*That* was not the move I expected."

\* \* \*

Somewhere at the edge of the ring, a soldier spoke. A young man, barely more than a boy, with a torch in his shaking hand. His voice was high and thin and cracked with terror.

"He killed the king," he said. "He killed the *king*."

And someone else said it. And someone else. It went around the ring of soldiers like fire through dry grass. *He killed the king. The Ruh killed the king. The Ruh. The kingkiller.*

*Kingkiller.*

I stood in the silver light with my red sword in my hand and my enemy dead at my feet and my aunt breathing in a heap against the door, and I heard them say it. The word. The name. The one that would follow me for the rest of my life, into every tavern and every town and every story. The one I would never be able to put down.

*Kingkiller.*

I have been called many things. Kvothe the Bloodless. Kvothe the Arcane. The Ruh. Maedre. Reshi. I have been called hero and liar and madman and demon.

But that is the one that stuck. That is the one they remember.

And the worst of it, the thing I have never told anyone until now, is this: it is the only one that is entirely true.

\* \* \*

The soldiers moved first.

Not toward me. Away. They broke from their ring and fled toward the stair, dropping torches, shoving each other, stumbling. Most of them. Not all. A dozen or so stood their ground, gripping their swords, their faces white and furious.

"Take him!" someone shouted. An officer, by his voice. "*Take the kingkiller! Kill him!*"

They came at me.

And from the ledge above, with a sound like a single breath, the Adem came down.

\* \* \*

I did not see all of what happened next. I was in the middle of it, and the middle of a fight is the worst place to see anything. I saw pieces. Flashes. The way you see things in a lightning storm.

I saw Vashet drop from the ledge like a stooping hawk and land among the soldiers, her sword already moving.

I saw Dagon and his men come down the narrow stair, three steps at a time, shouting the Maer's name.

I saw Devi at the top of the stair, with a clay pot in each hand, throwing them one after the other into the fleeing soldiers, and the white fire and thunder of the Surprises going off, and men screaming.

I saw Wil, halfway down the stair, with his scarred hands raised and his face grey with effort, and a guttering torch on the floor suddenly flaring up into a pillar of flame between a soldier and Sim.

I saw Sim, pale as milk, with a sword he did not know how to use held out in front of him, standing over Meluan's body at the foot of the door.

I saw Fela on the ledge, on her knees, with her palms pressed flat against the stone and her lips moving.

And I saw Bast.

He was beside me. I had not seen him come down the stair. But he was there, at my shoulder, with the iron knife in his hand and his face twisted with pain. He did not look at me. He was looking at the door.

"Reshi," he said. His voice was a whisper. "*Reshi, look.*"

I looked.

The door was still open. The crack still gaped, a hand's width wide, pouring out silver light and freezing wind.

And something was coming through it.

## Chapter One Hundred Twelve

# What Came Through

The first thing through the crack was a hand.

It was long and grey and very thin, with too many joints in its fingers and nails like chips of flint. It came out of the silver light slowly, feeling its way, the way a blind man's hand feels along a wall. It curled around the edge of the crack. It gripped the stone.

And then it pulled.

The door groaned. It was a deep sound, a sound that came up through the floor and into my bones. The crack widened. Not much. A finger's breadth. But it widened.

A second hand came through beside the first. Then a third, lower down. Then a fourth.

They were not all the same. That was the worst of it. The first was long and grey and many-jointed. The second was small and black and shiny, like a beetle's leg, ending in a hooked claw. The third was pale and soft and perfectly human, a woman's hand, with a ring on one finger. The fourth was not a hand at all, only a shape, a smudge of darkness with the suggestion of fingers.

They gripped the edges of the crack, all of them, and they pulled.

\* \* \*

"*Scrael*," said Bast.

He was right. Behind the hands, in the silver light pouring through the gap, I could see them. Black shapes, gleaming, crowding against the other side of the crack. Dozens of them. Hundreds. Their

knife-legs clicking and scrabbling at the stone. Trying to get through.

And other things. Things I could not see clearly. Shapes that moved wrong, that bent in ways that nothing should bend. A thing like a man made of wet leather, with no face. A thing like a great pale worm, coiling and uncoiling. A thing like a shadow that had learned to stand up.

They were all pressing against the crack. All reaching through. All pulling.

"*The door,*" I said. *"It's still open. Ambrose opened it and nobody closed it."*

"Close it, then!"

"I can't. Not without the key."

We both looked down at Ambrose's body, lying on the stone at our feet.

The box was still on its chain around his neck. Lying on his chest. Humming. I could hear it, even over the screaming of the wind and the clash of swords and the shrieking of the Surprises. Its long slow *no*.

I knelt. I reached for it.

And a boot came down on the chain.

\* \* \*

It was Cinder.

He was standing over Ambrose's body, over me, with one foot planted on the silver chain. His ice-pale sword was in his hand. His black eyes were looking down into mine.

"Not yet," he said softly.

I looked up at him. I did not move.

"You can't touch me," I said.

"I know." He smiled. "I'm not touching you. I'm standing on a chain." He pressed down with his boot. The chain bit into the dead king's neck. "And I'm not going to move until the door is open. All the way open. And the lord has passed through." He glanced toward the stair. "He's coming now. Can you feel him?"

I could. A darkness at the top of the stair. A weight. A place where light went to be forgotten.

Haliax was coming down.

\* \* \*

And then something struck Cinder in the chest, very hard, and knocked him backward off the chain.

It was Vashet.

She had come across the chamber from where she had been fighting the soldiers, and she had not slowed down. She hit Cinder with her shoulder, the way Tempa had hit him in the burning camp, and he staggered. And before he could recover, before he could move with that impossible speed of his, she was on him.

Her sword was a blur. Faster than I had ever seen her move. Faster than I had known anyone could move. It came at Cinder from every direction at once, high and low and left and right, a storm of steel.

Cinder parried. His ice-pale sword flashed. But for the first time, I saw him struggle. I saw him step back. And back. And back.

"*You killed my friend,*" said Vashet. Her voice was very calm. Very flat. Adem voices are always flat. "*The quiet one. You said he was better than me.*" Her sword flashed. "*You were wrong.*"

Cinder's sword went wide. For a heartbeat, a single heartbeat, his guard was open.

Vashet's blade went through it.

It did not go into his heart. He was too fast for that, even then. He twisted, impossibly, like smoke. But her blade caught his face. It laid open his cheek from the corner of his black eye to the corner of his mouth.

Cinder screamed.

It was the first time I had ever heard him make a sound that was not soft and reasonable. It was a high, thin, terrible scream, like ice cracking on a winter lake. He staggered back, with his hand pressed to his face. Black blood welled up between his fingers. It steamed in the cold air.

Vashet stood in front of him with her sword raised. Her face showed nothing. But her hands, the one on the hilt and the one at her

side, moved. Just slightly.

*I told you, they said. I will remember you.*

\* \* \*

I did not waste the moment. I knelt beside Ambrose's body and took hold of the box.

I lifted it off his chest. I pulled the chain over his head. It came free, and the box was in my hands.

It sang.

I felt it all through me. Its long slow *no*, loud and clear and joyful, like a dog that has found its master. And beneath it, the name of the line. My mother's name. My name. Braided through the stone like a thread through cloth.

And beneath that, the voice from behind the door. Very close now. Very loud.

*YES, it said. YES. CHILD OF MY CHILD. YOU HAVE THE KEY. YOU HAVE THE NAME. COME. OPEN. COME HOME.*

I stood up with the box in my hands. I turned to face the door.

The crack was wider now. Much wider. The hands had pulled it open to the width of a man's shoulders. The silver light pouring through it was blinding. The wind was a howling gale. The things behind it were pressing forward, reaching, clawing. A scrael had got its front legs through the gap. The wet leather thing had got its head through, its faceless head, and it was turning slowly from side to side, as if looking for something.

As if looking for me.

\* \* \*

"Kvothe."

I turned.

Bredon was standing beside me. He had left his table and his tak board. He was leaning on his stick, a few paces away, and his face was calm again. Mild again. The face of a grandfather.

But his eyes were not calm. They were very bright. Brighter than I had ever seen them.

"You have the key," he said softly. "You have the name. You're standing at the door." He smiled. "This is the moment. The one we've all been waiting for. Your whole life has been leading here."

"Get away from me."

"Speak the name, Kvothe. Open the door. Let him through." Bredon's voice was very gentle. "And I'll let her go."

He raised his hand. There was a cord in it. Thin and dark. It ran from his fingers across the chamber, through the air, glowing faintly red, to where Denna knelt beside her harp.

To the knot on her wrist.

"No," I said.

Bredon tightened his fingers.

Across the chamber, Denna screamed.

\* \* \*

I turned. I could not help it.

She was on her knees on the stone floor, with her wrist held up in front of her. The knot on it was blazing red, bright as a coal. The cord running from it to Bredon's hand was taut as a bowstring. And she was screaming. Her whole body was rigid, arched back, her face twisted in agony. Her other hand was clawing at her chest, over her heart.

"*Stop it!*" I shouted. "*Stop it! You're killing her!*"

"Yes," said Bredon calmly. "I am."

He tightened his fingers a little more. Denna's scream cut off. She made a small choking sound. Her hand on her chest clenched.

"The knot," said Bredon, "is tied to her heart. I told her so, when I tied it. I told her if she ever betrayed me, it would stop." He looked at me. "She has betrayed me. Several times. She has been sending you messages, tied in her hair. She thinks I didn't know." He smiled faintly. "I always know."

"Let her go."

"Speak the name."

"*Let her go!*"

"Speak the name, Kvothe," said Bredon softly. "Or watch her die. Those are your moves. There are no others." He tightened his fingers.



"Choose."

\* \* \*

I looked at Denna. On her knees on the stone, with her face going grey and her hand clawing at her chest and the knot on her wrist blazing red.

I looked at the door. At the crack, gaping wide. At the hands and claws and faceless heads pressing through it. At the silver light, and the freezing wind, and the voice calling my name.

I looked at the box in my hands. Humming. Singing. Waiting.

And I thought about what Selitos had told me, in the round tower at the center of the dead white city.

*Only one of the line, standing before the door, with the key in hand, speaking the door's name. Not to open it. To un-speak their own part of it.*

To un-speak it. To take the name of the line back out of the stone.

But to un-speak a name, you must first speak it.

I understood, then. Standing there with the box in my hands and Denna dying on the floor and Bredon's bright eyes on my face. I understood what he had been waiting for. Why he had needed me here, at the door, with the key and the name. Not to open it. He could not make me open it. No one could make me open it.

He needed me to speak the name. For any reason at all. Because the moment I spoke it, the door would hear. And the door would open. And whatever I meant to do afterward—un-speak it, close it, lock it forever—it would be too late. The Thief would already be through.

That was the beautiful game. That was the shape he had been building all along, stone by stone, move by move. Not a trap to make me open the door.

A trap to make me try to close it.

\* \* \*

"Reshi."

It was Bast. He was beside me, with his burned hand on my arm. His face was white. His eyes were very bright.

"Reshi, I know what you're thinking. I can see it on you." His voice was shaking. "Don't. Don't do it. If you speak the name, it'll open. You know it will. He knows it will. That's what he wants."

"I know."

"Then *don't!*"

"If I don't, Denna dies."

"Then let her die!" Bast's voice cracked. "Let her die, Reshi. She's one person. One. And if that door opens—"

I looked at him. At his fierce, frightened, beloved face.

"I can't," I said.

"*Why not?*"

I did not answer. I did not need to. He saw it in my face.

He let go of my arm. He stepped back. His face crumpled, just for a moment, and then went very still.

"Then do it right," he said quietly. "Whatever you do. Do it right."

\* \* \*

I turned to face the door.

I held the box in both hands. I felt it singing. I felt the name of the line braided through it, and the name of the door, and my own name, all wound together like three strands of a single cord.

I closed my eyes.

And I spoke.

I spoke the name of the door. The keeper's door. Not the one Selitos had given me, the one beneath the Archives. This one. I had never heard it. No one had ever told it to me. But I knew it. I had known it since I first touched the box in Meluan's green room. It had been in me all along, the way my own name was in me. Because it *was* my name. Part of it. The part that was the line.

I spoke it. And the door heard.

\* \* \*

It opened.

Not all the way. Not at once. But the door that had been sealed for ten thousand years heard its name spoken by the one voice in all the

world it had been made to answer, and it opened.

The crack became a gap. The gap became a doorway. The grey stone slid back on either side, silently, smoothly, the way a curtain slides back from a stage.

And beyond it, there was nothing.

Not darkness. Not light. Nothing. A place that was not a place. An absence so complete that it hurt to look at, the way the sun hurts to look at. It was the space between the stars. It was the silence after the last note of the last song. It was the place where names go when they are forgotten.

And in the center of it, very far away and very close at the same time, there was something.

I cannot describe it. I have tried. I have lain awake a thousand nights trying to find the words. There are no words. It was not a shape. It was not a color. It was not a sound.

It was a *want*.

The purest, deepest, most terrible want I have ever felt. A hunger so vast and so old that it had become a thing in itself. It wanted everything. It wanted the world. It wanted the moon. It wanted to take all the names of all the things that were, and unmake them, and make them into something else. Something it had chosen. Something that would love it back.

And it turned toward me. And it spoke.

*CHILD OF MY CHILD*, said the Thief. *THANK YOU*.

And the things that had been pressing against the door came pouring through.

## Chapter One Hundred Thirteen

### **Denna's Knot**

They came through the door like water through a broken dam.

Scrael first. Dozens of them. A black gleaming flood, pouring out of the nothing beyond the doorway, their knife-legs clicking and scrabbling on the stone floor. They spread out across the chamber in every direction, fast, faster than anything that size should move.

And behind them, the other things.

The wet leather thing with no face. It came through slowly, unfolding itself from the gap like a man climbing out of a well. It stood up on the chamber floor, tall and thin and glistening, and turned its faceless head from side to side. Then it went toward the nearest soldier. The soldier screamed. The leather thing wrapped its arms around him. And when it let go, the soldier was gone, and the leather thing had a face. His face. And it smiled with his mouth.

A skin dancer. I did not know the name then. I learned it later. A thing that takes men's skins and wears them, and walks among other men, and no one knows.

The great pale worm came through, coiling and uncoiling, and where it passed, the stone of the floor went soft and grey and crumbled.

The shadow that had learned to stand came through, and where it passed, the torches went out.

And more. Things I have no names for. Things that I have seen in my dreams every night since, and will see every night until I die.

\* \* \*

The chamber became a battlefield.

I saw the Adem meet the scrael in a ring of red, their swords flashing, and I saw the scrael's knife-legs glance off the Adem's close-bound clothing, and I saw an Adem woman go down with a leg cut out from under her and two of her brothers stand over her and keep fighting.

I saw Devi at the top of the stair, pulling Surprises from her satchel and hurling them into the black flood, and I saw the white fire bloom among the scrael and hear them shriek. I saw her take out a fistful of iron nails and hold them up in one hand and do something with the other, some binding I could not see, and the nails glowed red-hot and then white-hot and then flew from her hand like arrows and punched through the scraels' shells like paper.

I saw Wil on the stair below her with his scarred hands raised, pulling the heat out of the dropped torches and the Surprises' fire and throwing it in great sheets across the floor, a wall of flame between the scrael and the stair.

I saw Dagon and his three soldiers fighting back to back at the foot of the stair, their swords rising and falling, and I saw the skin dancer wearing the soldier's face come toward them, smiling, and I saw Dagon turn to meet it, and I saw what happened to Dagon.

I do not want to tell you what happened to Dagon.

\* \* \*

And I saw Sim.

He was still standing over Meluan at the foot of the door, with the sword he did not know how to use held out in front of him. He had not moved. The scrael were pouring around him, past him, on either side, and he had not moved. His face was white as milk and his hands were shaking so hard the sword blade rattled. But he had not moved.

A scrael came at him. It came very fast, its knife-legs flashing. He swung the sword at it, wildly, like a man swatting at a wasp. The blade struck the scrael's shell and glanced off.

The scrael's leg came up and across. It caught Sim across the face.

He cried out and fell back. His hand went to his face. Blood welled between his fingers.

The scrael reared over him.

And then Bast was there, with the iron knife in his burned hand, and he drove it down into the place where the scrael's legs met its body, and the scrael shrieked and smoked and collapsed.

Bast stood over Sim with the knife in his hand. His hand was blistered and blackened where it held the iron. His face was twisted with pain. He did not let go.

"Get up," he said to Sim. "*Get up. Get her. Get her away from the door.*"

Sim got up. His hand was still pressed to his face. Blood was running down his cheek. But he got up, and he bent down, and he took Meluan under the arms, and he dragged her away from the door, across the floor, toward the stair.

\* \* \*

I saw all of this. In pieces. In flashes. Standing in the open doorway with the box in my hands and the nothing at my back and the Thief's voice in my ears.

*THANK YOU*, it kept saying. *THANK YOU. THANK YOU.*

I could feel it coming. Not yet. It was very far away, in the center of the nothing. But it was coming. Slowly, the way a great tide comes in. The things pouring through the door were only the edge of it. The foam on the wave. The wave itself was behind them.

And when it came through, it would be over.

I looked down at the box in my hands.

*Only one of the line, standing before the door, with the key in hand, speaking the door's name. Not to open it. To un-speak their own part of it.*

I had spoken the name. I had opened the door. I had done exactly what Bredon wanted.

But I was still standing in the doorway. With the key in my hand. And the name still in my mouth.

\* \* \*

I closed my eyes.

I stopped listening to the Thief's voice. I stopped listening to the screams and the shrieks and the clash of swords. I stopped listening to everything, except the box.

Its long slow *no*. And the name braided through it. The name of the line. My mother's name. My name.

I listened to it the way I had listened to the stone in the round room at the top of the Rookery. The way I had listened to the Sleeper, and the king's hair, and the wind on Hessa Tern's ship. Not reaching for it. Not wanting it. Just listening.

And I found the place where the line's name was braided into the door's name. The place where the two strands were twisted together. Like two threads in a cord.

I found the end of my strand.

And I began to pull.

\* \* \*

It was like pulling out my own spine.

I cannot describe it better than that. It was the worst pain I have ever felt. Worse than the Eolian, worse than Cinder's hand, worse than anything before or since. I felt my name coming out of the door, strand by strand. And as it came out of the door, it came out of me.

Not the name *Kvothe*. The other one. The deep one. The name that was the shape of me. It unwound from the door's name the way a thread unwinds from a spool. And as it unwound, it pulled out of me. Out of my chest, out of my bones, out of the place where names live.

I felt myself getting smaller. Thinner. Emptier. The way I had felt on the stage at the Eolian, at the end of the song. But worse. So much worse. Because at the Eolian, the song had pushed my name out, and it had come back. This was not pushing. This was pulling. This was tearing.

And it was not coming back.

I opened my eyes.

\* \* \*

My name was hanging in the air in front of me.

I could see it. I do not know how. Names are not things you can see. But I could see mine. A thread of silver light, very thin, very bright, unwinding from the face of the door and from my own chest at the same time, the way a spider's thread unwinds from its body. It hung in the freezing wind between me and the open doorway, trembling, shining, getting longer and longer.

And it was drifting toward the nothing.

The wind from the doorway was pulling it. The Thief was pulling it. I could feel the hunger reaching out for it, the vast terrible want turning toward the thread of my name like a flower toward the sun. If it reached the nothing, the Thief would have it. The last key. The only key. The name of the line.

And then no one could ever close the door again.

I tried to pull it back. I could not. I had nothing left to pull with. I was too small. Too thin. Too empty.

The thread drifted toward the doorway.

\* \* \*

A hand caught it.

A small hand. A woman's hand. Pale and thin, with long fingers and a thin dark cord tied around the wrist in a knot that was not glowing anymore.

Denna.

She was on her knees on the stone floor beside me. I had not seen her come. I had not seen anything. Her face was grey and wet with tears. She was gasping for breath, one hand pressed to her chest. But the other hand was up, in the air, in front of the doorway. And the silver thread of my name was caught in it. Wound around her fingers.

She looked up at me.

"I have a cord," she whispered. "In my sleeve. I told you."

She let go of her chest. She reached into her sleeve. She pulled out a cord. Thin and dark and braided from three strands. Her own



hair.

And she began to tie.

\* \* \*

I have seen Denna tie knots a thousand times. In the Grey Man, teaching me. In the garden at Severen. In the cords she wore in her hair. I had watched her hands move, quick and neat and precise, and I had thought I knew what she could do.

I did not know.

Her hands moved so fast I could not follow them. They moved through the air in front of the doorway like birds, like flames, like water. They wound the silver thread of my name around the dark cord of her hair and tied it there. Knot after knot after knot. Looping and twisting and doubling back, in that particular way she had, that I would have known anywhere.

And each knot held.

I felt it. Each one. I felt my name caught in the knot, and held there. Not pulled toward the nothing. Not drifting. Held. Safe. Kept.

She tied and tied. Her face was grey. Her lips were white. Blood was running from her nose, down over her mouth and chin. Her hands were shaking. But they did not stop.

The silver thread unwound from my chest and from the face of the door, and she caught it, and she tied it. Knot after knot. Until the last of it came free. Until there was nothing left in me but a hole where it had been. Until there was nothing left in the door but its own name.

She tied the last knot.

And the door closed.

\* \* \*

It did not slam. It did not crash. It simply closed, the way a flower closes at dusk. The two halves of grey stone slid back together, silently, smoothly. The silver light narrowed to a line. The wind died. The Thief's voice went quiet, in the middle of a word.

Whatever was caught in the gap when it closed was cut in half. I saw it. Scrael, sliced through their shells as neatly as if by a knife. The

great pale worm, cut in two, both halves writhing on the floor. A grey many-jointed hand, severed at the wrist, lying on the stone with its fingers still curling.

And the door was shut.

Not perfectly. I saw that, even then. There was a line down the center of it, where the two halves met. Hair-fine. Barely visible. A crack, where there had been no crack before. A place where the stone did not quite fit.

But it was shut. And it was only a door now. A name of stone, like the other six. It did not answer to the line anymore. It did not answer to anyone.

There was no line anymore. Not in the door.

It was all in the cord. In Denna's hands.

\* \* \*

I did not see what happened to Bredon. Not all of it. I was on my knees on the stone by then, with the empty box in my lap. I had nothing left. I could barely see.

But I saw a little. I will tell you what I saw.

I saw him standing at the edge of the doorway, just before it closed. Leaning on his stick. With the dark cord that ran to Denna's wrist in his hand, slack now, forgotten.

He was looking into the nothing. At the vast terrible want in the center of it. And his face was not mild, or kind, or interested. It was full of something I had never seen on it before.

It was love.

"Master," he said softly. "I've waited so long."

And he let go of the cord. And he stepped through the doorway, into the nothing, just as the two halves of the door slid together.

I do not know if he made it through. I do not know if the door caught him, the way it caught the scrael and the worm. I do not know if he is on the other side now, with the Thief, in the place between the stars. I have wondered, every day since. I have dreamed of him, standing in the nothing, leaning on his stick, smiling.

But I know that the moment the door closed, the knot on Denna's wrist came undone.

It simply fell apart. The loops loosened and slipped and unwound, and the dark cord slid off her wrist and fell to the stone floor, and lay there. And she looked down at it. And she made a sound. Half a laugh and half a sob.

She was free.

\* \* \*

The shadow came down the stair.

I saw it, dimly, through the grey haze in my eyes. A place where light went to be forgotten, shaped like a man. It came down the stair slowly, step by step, the way a pilgrim walks the last mile to a shrine. The fighting stopped as it passed. The Adem and the soldiers and the scrael all went still. Even the skin dancer, wearing Dagon's face, stood motionless and watched it go.

Haliax crossed the chamber floor. He came to the door. He stood in front of it.

He did not speak. He stood very still before the grey stone, with its hair-fine crack down the center. Then he raised his hand—or the shape of a hand, made of shadow—and laid it flat against the door.

The stone said no.

I felt it. Even empty as I was, I felt it. The long slow patient *no* of the door, saying itself to him. *No. No. No.* The name of a prison, answering no one.

Haliax stood with his hand on the door for a long time. Then he took it away.

He turned. He looked at me, kneeling on the floor with the empty box in my lap.

"Singer," he said. His voice was very quiet. Very tired. "What have you done?"

I could not answer. I had no voice left.

"It is locked," said Haliax. "Truly locked. Forever. The line is gone from it." The shadow was very still. "No one will ever open it again."

He was silent for a long moment.

"You have given me forever," he said at last. "Do you know that? You have taken away the only door that led to my ending. And you have given me forever." The shadow seemed to shift, very slightly. "I do not know whether to hate you or thank you."

He turned away.

"Ferule," he said.

Cinder was standing at the edge of the chamber, with his hand pressed to his ruined face. Black blood was still running between his fingers. His black eyes were fixed on Vashet, who stood a few paces away with her sword raised, watching him.

"Lord," said Cinder. His voice was thick.

"We are finished here," said Haliax. "Gather the others."

And then they were gone. All of them. The Seven, and the shadow, and the things that had come through the door. The scrael, the skin dancer, the pale worm's severed halves. Gone, like candles snuffed. The chamber was empty of them.

Only the dead remained. And the living.

\* \* \*

I was lying on the floor. I do not remember falling. I was lying on my side on the cold stone in front of the door, with the empty box beside me, and I could not move.

Someone was holding me. Someone was saying my name. Not my true name. I had none. The other one. *Kvothe*. *Kvothe*. *Kvothe*. Over and over. I did not recognize it. It was only a sound. A word someone was saying.

I looked up. There was a face above me. Dark hair, and dark eyes, and blood on the lips.

I did not know who she was.

I knew I should. I knew there was a name for her, and a story, and a great deal of feeling, somewhere. But I could not find it. It was on the other side of the hole where my name had been. Everything was on the other side of it. I was empty.

She was crying. She was holding something in her hand. A cord, dark and braided, full of knots. It was glowing faintly, a soft silver glow, like moonlight on snow.

She took my left hand. My cold hand, with the white print of a dead man's fingers on its wrist. She wound the cord around the wrist, over the print. Around and around. And she tied it. Tight.

"There," she whispered. "There. It's close to you. It'll stay close. Until we find somewhere safe."

I looked at the cord on my wrist. At the knots, glowing softly.

And for just a moment—just one moment—something came back. Not much. A flicker. A single thread, reaching out from the cord on my wrist and into the hole in my chest.

And I knew her.

"Denna," I whispered.

She laughed. She was crying and laughing at the same time.

"Yes," she said. "Yes. It's me. I'm here."

I looked at her face for a long time. And I tried to hold onto it. The name, and the face, and the knowing.

Then the flicker went out. And I was empty again. And I did not know her.

But I remembered that I had. For a moment. And that was something.

That was something.

## Interlude: A Draft Under the Door

The innkeeper stopped speaking, and the Waystone was cold.

Chronicler noticed it first as a stiffness in his fingers. He had been writing for so long, so fast, that his hand had become a thing apart from him, a machine of bone and ink that went on moving while the rest of him sat listening. But now it slowed. It fumbled. He looked down and saw that the ink on the tip of his pen had gone thick, almost jelly-like, the way ink goes in a cold room in winter.

He looked up. His breath was smoking in the air.

The fire in the hearth was still burning. He could see it, bright and yellow, crackling over the logs Bast had piled on an hour before. But it was not giving off any heat. It was as if the fire were a painting of a fire, hung on the wall.

"Reshi," said Bast. His voice was very quiet.

The innkeeper did not answer. He was sitting very still at the table, with his hands folded in front of him, looking at the window. The shutters were closed. But around their edges, where they did not quite meet the frame, there was frost. White and feathery, creeping inward across the dark wood like the fingers of a slow hand.

"Reshi," said Bast again. "It's here. It's close."

"I know."

"You have to stop. You have to stop telling it. Right now. Every word you say, it gets closer. It can *hear* you. It can hear your—" He stopped.

"My name," said the innkeeper. "It can hear my name coming back." He did not look away from the window. "I know, Bast. I've

known since the first night."

\* \* \*

Chronicler set down his pen. His hand was shaking, and it was not only from the cold.

"What's here?" he said. "What's close?"

The innkeeper turned his head and looked at him. In the yellow, heatless firelight, his face was very pale, and the bruises on it were very dark. His eyes were green and steady and very old.

"You know what," he said. "You've heard the whole story. Or most of it." He glanced at the frost on the shutters. "The cold is his sign. Ferule's. Cinder's. When he's near, the fire burns and gives no heat, and water freezes in the cup, and the breath goes white."

Chronicler looked down at the cup of tea by his elbow. There was a skin of ice on it.

"He's coming here," he said. His voice sounded very far away. "Now. Tonight."

"Not yet. Not tonight, I think. He's still out in the woods. Beyond the fields. He's been there all day." The innkeeper nodded toward the window. "That smoke you saw this morning. That was his. Did you notice how it leaned? Toward the inn. Toward me." He was quiet for a moment. "He's waiting. He's waiting for it to be strong enough. For me to be loud enough. And then he'll come."

"Loud enough?"

"My name." The innkeeper looked down at his hands. At the thin pale scar that ran around his left wrist like a bracelet. "It's been very quiet, for a long time. So quiet no one could hear it. Not him. Not the Seven. Not the thing behind the door." He touched the scar with one finger. "But I've been telling the story. For three days. And every word of it is a piece of me. And every piece I tell, I get back."

He looked up at Chronicler.

"Stories are names too," he said. "Did you know that? The oldest kind. Elodin told me once, a long time ago, that the best way to learn the name of a thing is to hear its whole story. Every piece of it. From the beginning." He smiled faintly. "I didn't understand him, then. I

thought it was one of his riddles."

Chronicler stared at him.

"You've been—" he said. "All this time. Three days. You've been—"

"Remembering," said the innkeeper. "Yes. Putting myself back together. A piece at a time. Out loud." He looked at the frost creeping across the shutters. "And it's working. I can feel it. Can't you, Bast?"

Bast did not answer. He was standing by the window with his arms wrapped around himself, staring at the frost. His face was very white.

"I can feel it," he whispered.

\* \* \*

"Then stop," said Chronicler. He heard his own voice rise, and could not stop it. "If it's bringing him here—if every word you say brings him closer—stop. Don't tell any more. I don't need the rest. I'll write what I have. I'll leave tomorrow, and I'll—"

"No," said the innkeeper.

"*Why not?*"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at Bast, at the window. Then at the sword above the hearth, hanging on its two pegs beneath the plaque that said FOLLY.

"Because I have to finish it," he said. "I said three days. It's the third day. And a thing said three times becomes true." He was quiet for a moment. "And because if I stop now, halfway, with my name half back and half gone—" He looked at Chronicler. "Do you remember what the tinker said? This afternoon?"

Chronicler remembered. *Some stories are very heavy. But they're heavier still if you drop them halfway.*

"If I stop now," said the innkeeper, "I'll be neither. Not Kote. Not Kvothe. Something in between. Something torn." He smiled faintly. "Elodin knows what that's like. He spent three years in Haven learning. I'd rather not."

"And if you finish?"

The innkeeper did not answer right away.



"Then I'll be myself again," he said at last. "Or close enough. And he'll come. And we'll see." He picked up his cup of tea, and looked at the skin of ice on it, and set it down again. "Either way, it ends tonight. One way or another. I've known that since the first day, too."

\* \* \*

Bast turned from the window.

"Reshi," he said. "Let me go out. Let me go out there and find him. Before he comes. I can find him. I can—"

"No."

"I can *hold* him. Delay him. Give you time."

"No, Bast."

"*Why not?*"

The innkeeper looked at him. His face was very gentle.

"Because he'd kill you," he said simply. "And I'd have to finish the story knowing that. And I don't think I could."

Bast stared at him. His deep blue eyes were very bright. Then he looked away.

"Then what do I do?" he said. His voice cracked. "What do I *do*, Reshi? I can't just stand here. I can't just stand here and watch him come."

"You can bar the door," said the innkeeper. "And put more wood on the fire, even if it doesn't warm anything. And make another pot of tea. And sit down, and listen." He paused. "That's all any of us can do, right now. Listen."

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he went to the door and dropped the heavy bar into its brackets. He went to the hearth and piled on more wood. He went into the kitchen and came back with a fresh pot of tea, steaming, and set it on the table.

The steam from the pot rose into the air, and froze, and fell back onto the table as a fine white dust.

Bast sat down in his backward chair. He folded his arms on the back of it. He did not say anything else.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper poured the tea. It was hot for a moment, in the cups. Then it was not.

He wrapped his hands around his cup anyway, as if for warmth. He looked at Chronicler.

"Are you ready?" he said.

Chronicler looked down at his pen. At the thickened ink on its tip. He dipped it in the inkwell. The ink there was thick too, almost solid. He stirred it with the nib until it loosened.

"Yes," he said.

"Good." The innkeeper nodded. "Because this next part is the worst of it. The part after. When I was nameless." He looked down at the scar on his wrist. "I don't remember all of it. Not clearly. You'll have to forgive me for that. It's like trying to remember a fever dream. Pieces. Flashes. Colors and sounds, but not much sense." He was quiet for a moment. "But I remember enough."

He closed his eyes.

"The first thing I remember," said Kvothe, "is the grey."

\* \* \*

Outside the Waystone Inn, the night was very still. No wind stirred the trees at the edge of the fields. No dog barked in the town. No owl called.

The frost crept across the fields. It crept across the road. It crept up the steps of the Waystone, and across the porch, and up the door, white and feathery, like the fingers of a slow hand.

And beyond the trees, at the edge of the woods, a blue light burned. Small and steady and far away.

Waiting.

## **PART FOUR: NAMELESS**

## Chapter One Hundred Fourteen

# Grey

The first thing I remember is the grey.

Not the color. The world. Everything in it. The stone of the chamber floor beneath my cheek, and the torches guttering on the floor, and the faces that bent over me. The silver light still glowing faintly in the crack down the center of the door. Denna's dark hair, and her dark eyes, and the blood on her lips. All of it grey. Not the grey of stone, which has a color of its own, rich and deep and various. The grey of ash. The grey of a picture drawn in charcoal and left out in the rain.

I had not known, until that moment, how much of the world I saw with my name.

You do not know it either. No one does. You look at a candle flame and see yellow, and you think the yellow is in the flame. It is not. Not all of it. Some of it is in you. Some of it is the part of you that knows fire, that has always known it, that leaps up in recognition when it sees a flame. The part of you that has a name, and knows that fire has one too.

Take away the name, and the flame is still there. It still burns. It still gives light. But it is only light. Only heat. Only a thing, burning, that means nothing to you at all.

That is what I remember. Lying on the floor of that chamber, with the cord of my name tied around my wrist, looking at a world that had gone to ash.

\* \* \*

They carried me up the stair.

I remember that too, in pieces. Hands under my arms. The stone steps going past beneath me, one after another, grey and endless. Someone breathing hard close to my ear. Someone else saying *careful, mind his head*.

I remember the cellars of the Lackless house. Great dark rooms full of broken furniture and empty wine racks and the smell of damp. I remember rats, their eyes glinting in the torchlight, scattering from our path. I remember the kitchens, cold and bare, with a great black iron range and a long table scarred by centuries of knives.

And I remember the hall.

It was the great hall of the Lackless house. A long, high room with a timbered ceiling and tall windows at one end, and a hearth at the other so big you could have stood up in it. There were banners hanging from the rafters, rotted and faded, so old that their colors were gone and their devices unreadable. There were portraits on the walls, dark and cracked, of men and women in the clothing of other centuries.

They laid me down on the long table in the center of the hall. I lay on my back and looked up at the rotting banners, and I did not know what they were. I knew they were banners. I knew they had once had colors, and meanings, and names. But I did not know what any of that meant. It was like looking at writing in a language I had never learned.

Someone was holding my hand. My left hand. The one with the cord around the wrist.

I turned my head and looked at her.

She was sitting on a bench beside the table, bent over me. Her face was grey. Her hair was grey. Her eyes were grey. Everything was grey. But there was something in her face that made me want to keep looking at it. Something that tugged at me, the way a hook tugs at a fish.

I did not know her. But I wanted to.

"Can you hear me?" she said.

I nodded.

"Do you know where you are?"

I thought about it. I did not.

"Do you know who I am?"

I looked at her for a long time. At her grey face, and her grey eyes, and the tears running down her cheeks. I felt the cord on my wrist, tight against my skin. I felt something in it, very faint. Like a voice in another room.

"You tied it," I said. My own voice sounded strange to me. Flat. Toneless. Like a lute with no strings. "The cord. You tied it."

She made a sound. Half a laugh, half a sob.

"Yes," she said. "Yes. I tied it."

"Why?"

She looked at me for a long moment.

"Because you asked me to," she said. "A long time ago. Before you knew you were asking."

\* \* \*

The others came.

I remember them coming into the hall, one by one, out of the dark. Some of them walking. Some of them limping. Some of them being carried.

A small fair woman with spectacles, carrying a satchel. She came and stood beside the table and looked down at me and said something sharp and angry and full of grief, and I did not understand it.

A dark man with burned hands, who stood at the foot of the table and did not say anything at all, only looked at me with a face like a closed door.

A girl with dark hair and a pale face, who knelt on the floor beside the bench and put her hand flat on the stone and closed her eyes.

A thin young man with straw-colored hair, with a bandage tied across half his face. Blood had soaked through the bandage over his left eye. He stood at the edge of the group and stared at me, and his one visible eye was very wide.

And a slender young man with dark hair and deep blue eyes, who came and stood at the head of the table and looked down at me, and

whose face, when he looked at me, did something I did not understand.

I did not know any of them. Not their names, not their faces, not what they were to me. They were grey shapes in a grey room, making sounds I did not understand.

But the young man with the blue eyes reached down and touched my hair, very gently, the way you touch a sleeping child. And his hand was shaking.

"Reshi," he said.

The word meant nothing to me. But I felt the cord on my wrist tighten, very slightly. As if something inside it had heard.

\* \* \*

They talked, around me. I lay on the table and listened to them talk, and did not understand most of it.

Some things I understood. Words, here and there. The way you understand words in a foreign language that are almost like words in your own.

*Army*, I understood. *The king's army. Outside. Thousands of them.*

*Dead*, I understood. *The king is dead. Everyone knows. The ones who ran up the stair told them.*

*Coming*, I understood. *They're coming. The officers. The duke. They're coming here.*

*Kingkiller*, I understood.

That word, I understood very well. I did not know why. It was only a word. But when they said it, something moved in the hole in my chest. Something heavy and cold, like a stone sinking in dark water.

\* \* \*

The small fair woman with spectacles was arguing with the dark man with burned hands.

"We can't stay here," she said. "The whole army's outside. When they find out the king's dead in the cellar, they'll tear this place apart."

"We can't move him either. Look at him. He doesn't even know where he is."

"Then we carry him."

"Through eight thousand soldiers?"

"Through the tunnel. The way we came."

"With the wounded? With the lady? She can barely stand. Sim can barely see." The dark man shook his head. "We'd never make it."

"Then what do you suggest?"

The dark man did not answer. He looked at me, lying on the table.

The slender young man with blue eyes was still standing at my head. He had not moved. He had not taken his hand from my hair.

"I can glamour him," he said quietly. "Make him look like someone else. Like one of the soldiers. We can walk out through the front door."

"All of us?"

"Not all of you. I can't hold that many. Not after tonight." His voice was very tired. "Him. Maybe one or two others."

"And the rest of us?"

The blue-eyed young man did not answer.

\* \* \*

That was when the small dark woman in red came into the hall.

She came from the stair that led down to the cellars. She walked very straight, very quiet, and her face showed nothing at all. There was blood on her red clothes. There was a sword in her hand.

She came to the table and looked down at me.

I did not know her. But I knew her hands. I did not know how. I watched her hands, hanging at her sides, and I felt something stir in the hole in my chest. As if I had seen those hands before, a thousand times. As if they had taught me something.

Her hands moved. A small gesture. I did not know what it meant. But the cord on my wrist tightened again, very slightly.

"The Adem will hold the door," she said. Her voice was flat. "The front door of this house. While the rest of you go out through the tunnel. We will hold it until you are gone."

"Vashet," said the dark man with burned hands. "There are eight thousand of them."



"There were eight thousand at the camp by the river. Tempi held his piece of it." She did not look at him. She was looking at me. "We will hold ours."

"You'll die."

"Perhaps." Her hands moved. Something I did not understand. "It is the Lethani."

\* \* \*

I sat up.

I do not know why. I did not decide to. My body did it on its own, the way a body will sometimes move before the mind has caught up. I sat up on the long table in the grey hall, with the cord of my name tied around my wrist, and I looked at the woman in red.

"No," I said.

Everyone went still.

The woman in red looked at me. Her face did not change. But her eyes did.

"No," I said again. My voice was still flat and strange. I did not know where the word was coming from. I only knew that it was right. "No one else dies. Not for me. Not tonight."

"Then how—"

"I'll go out," I said. "Through the front door. To the army. To the duke."

The whole hall was silent.

"They want the kingkiller," I said. "I'm the kingkiller. I'll go to them. And while they're busy with me, the rest of you go out through the tunnel. With the lady. With the wounded." I looked at the woman in red. "No one else dies."

"Reshi," said the blue-eyed young man. His voice was very small. "Reshi, you don't know what you're saying. You don't know who you are right now. You can't—"

"I don't need to know who I am," I said, "to know what's right."

I looked down at the cord on my wrist. At the knots. Glowing very faintly. Silver, like moonlight on snow.

"Somebody told me that," I said slowly. "A long time ago. I don't remember who." I looked up. "Choose. And bear what comes after."

The woman in red went very still. Her hands, at her sides, were motionless.

Then they moved. One gesture. Very small.

I did not know what it meant. But I found that my own hands were moving to answer it. Clumsily. Badly. Like a man speaking a language he has forgotten, whose mouth remembers the shapes of the words even when his mind does not.

The woman in red looked down at my hands. Something moved in her face. Not an expression. Something smaller.

"Yes," she said quietly. "That is the Lethani."

\* \* \*

They argued. Of course they argued. The small fair woman shouted and the straw-haired young man wept and the dark man with burned hands stood very still with his jaw clenched. The girl with dark hair knelt on the floor with her hand on the stone and did not say anything.

And the one who had tied the cord—the one with the grey face and the tears—sat on the bench beside the table and held my hand and did not let go.

In the end, they could not stop me. I do not think they could have, even if I had been myself. Maybe especially then.

The blue-eyed young man was the last to give up. He stood at the head of the table with his hands clenched and his face white, and he looked at me for a long time.

"Then I'm coming with you," he said.

"No."

"I owe you a life. The old kind. I'll pay it."

"Then pay it by living," I said. "By going with them. By making sure they get out."

He stared at me. His deep blue eyes were very bright.

"That's not fair," he said. "You don't even know who I am. You can't just—you can't just *tell* me what to do, when you don't even know who I *am*—"

"I know you'd die for me," I said. "I can see it on you. That's enough."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then his face crumpled, and he turned away, and he put his hands over his face, and his shoulders shook.

\* \* \*

The one who had tied the cord did not argue. She did not shout or weep or plead. She only sat on the bench and held my hand.

When the others had begun to gather themselves, to lift the wounded and help the lady with white hair to her feet and make for the cellar stair, she leaned close to me.

"I'm coming with you," she said.

"No."

"Yes." She looked at me. Her grey eyes were very steady. "Not because I owe you. Not because I love you, though I do." She touched the cord on my wrist. "Because of this. Because I tied it. Because if anyone tries to take it off you, or pull on it, or use it, I need to be there. I'm the only one who knows how it's tied. I'm the only one who could undo it."

"They'll hang you."

"Maybe. Maybe not. I was the king's nightingale. His favorite singer. I've got friends at court." She smiled faintly. It did not reach her eyes. "And even if they do, it doesn't matter. This matters more." She held my wrist. "You matter more."

I looked at her. At her grey face and her grey eyes and her grey hair, and the tears on her cheeks, and the blood on her lip.

I did not know her. I did not know her name, or what she was to me, or why the sight of her face made the hole in my chest ache.

But I knew that the cord on my wrist was humming, very faintly, when she touched it. The way a string hums when another string nearby is plucked.

"All right," I said.

\* \* \*

We walked out of the great hall together, she and I, through the dark rotting corridors of the Lackless house, toward the front door.

Behind us, the others went down the cellar stair, toward the tunnel and the dark and the long way out. I did not look back. I did not know them. There was nothing to look back at.

But at the top of the stair, the young man with blue eyes stopped and turned. I felt him. I felt his eyes on my back. And I heard him say, very softly, in a voice that cracked in the middle:

"I'll find you, Reshi. Wherever they take you. I'll find you."

I did not turn around. But the cord on my wrist tightened, just a little.

And I found, to my surprise, that my eyes were wet. Though I did not know why.

\* \* \*

The front door of the Lackless house was great and black and iron-bound, and very old. I put my hand on it. It was cold.

On the other side, I could hear them. The army. Thousands of voices, rising and falling like the sea. Horses. Drums. Someone shouting orders.

The woman beside me took my hand. My right hand, the one without the cord.

"Ready?" she said.

"I don't know what that means."

She laughed. It was a broken sound, and a real one.

"Neither do I," she said. "Not really. No one ever does."

I pushed the door open.

The morning was grey. The sky was grey. The hills were grey. And spread out across the slopes below the house, as far as I could see, there were soldiers. Thousands of them. In grey armor, under grey banners, with grey faces turned up toward the door.

They saw us. They went quiet. All of them, all at once, like a candle snuffed.

And then someone, somewhere, began to shout.

*Kingkiller.*

## Interlude: What Bast Saw

"I don't remember it," said the innkeeper. "That's the trouble. The moment itself. I remember the door, and the light, and Denna's hands. And then the grey." He looked down at the table. "But the moment between—the moment it went—I don't have. It's the one thing that didn't come back."

Chronicler waited, his pen lifted.

"Bast was there," said the innkeeper. He did not look up. "He saw it. He's never told me." He was quiet for a moment. "I've never asked."

The common room was very still. Bast, in his backward chair, had gone rigid.

"Reshi," he said. "Don't."

"I think you should tell it," said the innkeeper gently. "I think it belongs in the book. And I think I'd like to hear it." He looked up, at last, at Bast. "I think I'm ready."

\* \* \*

Bast did not answer for a long time. He sat with his arms folded across the back of his chair and his chin resting on them, and he looked at the fire, and his face was a stranger's face. Old, and tired, and very sad.

"You want me to tell the scribe," he said at last. "Or you?"

"Both."

Bast closed his eyes.

"All right," he said.

\* \* \*

"We came down the stair behind the Adem," said Bast. "Me and Sim and Wil and Fela and Devi. We were late. We'd been fighting in the passage above, with the soldiers the king left to guard it, and by the time we got down, it was already happening."

He opened his eyes. He did not look at either of them. He looked at the fire.

"The door was open," he said. "Just a crack. A thin line of light down the middle of it, silver-white, so bright it hurt. And things were coming through. You told that part. The scrael, and the faceless thing, and the rest. The Adem were fighting them. Vashet and Temp and the others, back to back, in a ring around the door. There was blood on the floor. There was a dead king on the floor, with a box on a chain around his neck. There was a woman in black and silver kneeling beside him, with her hands over her face." He swallowed. "And there was you."

The innkeeper did not move.

"You were standing in front of the door," said Bast. "With your back to us. Right in front of the crack. So close the light was on your face. And your hands were up. Both of them. Flat. Not touching it. Just an inch away, the way you hold your hands up to a fire." He was quiet for a moment. "And you were talking to it."

\* \* \*

"I couldn't hear what you were saying," said Bast. "Nobody could. The noise was too loud. The things coming through, and the Adem fighting, and the soldiers screaming on the stair. And the door. The door was making a sound. Like a wind. Like a very big wind, a long way off, blowing through a very small hole." He shivered. "But you were talking. I could see your lips moving. Calm. Steady. The way you talk to a horse that's frightened."

"The way Auri talked to it," said the innkeeper softly. "In the snow."

Bast looked at him.

"I don't know," he said. "Maybe. I didn't know about Auri, then." He looked back at the fire. "And the thing on the other side—the Thief—it was talking back. Not with words. With wanting. I could feel

it, Reshi. Even from the stair. Even with Fela's stone in my pocket. It wanted you to come in. It wanted it so much. It was pulling. Like a river pulls. Like the moon pulls the sea." His voice cracked. "And you were leaning. Just a little. Toward the crack."

\* \* \*

"Fela saw it," said Bast. "She was beside me. She saw you leaning. And she screamed your name. Your real one. The one you'd been using. *Kvothe*." He closed his eyes. "And you turned your head. Just a little. And looked back at us. Over your shoulder."

He was quiet for a long time.

"You smiled," he said.

The innkeeper's hands tightened on the table.

"You looked at us," said Bast. "At Fela and Sim and Wil and Devi and me. On the stair. Covered in blood and ichor and dust. And you smiled. Not a big smile. Just a small one. The kind you give someone when you're about to do something and you want them to know it's all right." His voice was very quiet. "I'd seen that smile before. On the ridge above the king's camp. On the ice in the Stormwal. Every time you were about to do something terrible and brave and stupid. I knew that smile."

"And then?" said Chronicler. His voice was hoarse.

"And then you turned back to the door," said Bast. "And you put your hands on it."

\* \* \*

The fire cracked. Nobody moved.

"Flat," said Bast. "Both hands. On either side of the crack. And you *pulled*." He pressed his own hands flat against the table, as if he could feel it. "Not with your arms. With something else. I don't know what. And something started coming out of the stone. A thread. A thread of light, silver, out of the door. Out of the place where your family was braided into it." He swallowed. "And the door screamed. I'd never heard stone scream. And you screamed too."

The innkeeper's hands tightened on the table.

"It was your name," said Bast. "Coming out. Strand by strand. I knew it the moment I saw it. You can't be Fae and not know a name when it's pulled out into the air in front of you." His voice was very quiet. "It was the most beautiful thing I ever saw, Reshi. In all my life. In the mortal world or the twilight. Every song you ever sang. Every joke you ever told me. The way you laugh. The way you hold a lute. The way you look at Denna when you think nobody's watching. All of it. At once. Hanging in the air in front of that door like a thread of moonlight."

"And the door closed," said Chronicler.

"The door started closing," said Bast. "The moment the last strand came out. Grinding. Like a millstone. But the wind from the crack—the Thief—it was pulling at the thread. At your name. Pulling it toward the crack, the way it had been pulling you. And you couldn't hold it. You were on your knees. Your hands were empty." He was quiet. "And the old man was there. Bredon. At the edge of the doorway. With his stick. Watching. Smiling." Bast's lip curled. "And just before the door closed, he stepped through it. Into the nothing. Like a man stepping through a door into his own house."

He was quiet for a long moment.

"I was looking at you," he said. "Not at him. You were still kneeling there. And the light was going out of you. Out of your face, and your hair, and your eyes. Draining out, like water out of a basin. Your hair went dark. Did you know that? Just for a moment. Red to brown to almost black. Like a coal going out. And then it came back red again, but—dull. Like old rust." He swallowed. "And your eyes—"

He stopped.

"Tell me," said the innkeeper quietly.

"Your eyes went grey," said Bast. "Not the color. The *look*. They were green, and bright, and full of you. And then they were just eyes. Looking at a door. Like a stranger's. Like nobody was behind them at all."

\* \* \*



"And then Denna," said Bast. "She came from somewhere. I don't know where. She'd been in the chamber all along, I think, behind the Adem. And she ran to you. Right past the scrael, right past everything. And she had a cord in her hands. A new one. Thin and dark. Braided out of her own hair. And she was tying."

He was quiet for a moment.

"She was tying so fast," he said. "I've never seen hands move that fast. Not the Adem. Not anyone. Knot after knot after knot. And your name—that thread of light, hanging in the air, with the wind pulling at it—she caught it. With the cord. She wrapped it around, and around, and around, and tied it. Right at the very last second. Right before the wind took it." His voice shook. "And the door closed. All the way. With a sound like the world ending. And you fell down."

"And she caught me."

"She caught you." Bast looked at him. "She caught you, and she held you, and she tied the cord around your wrist. And she was saying something, over and over, very fast, in a language I didn't know. And then she stopped, and put her forehead against yours, and just knelt there. On the floor. Holding you." He was quiet. "She was crying. Denna was crying. I'd never seen her cry before. I didn't know she could."

\* \* \*

Nobody said anything for a long time.

The innkeeper sat with his eyes closed and his hands flat on the table. Chronicler did not write. He sat with his pen in his hand and his page in front of him and did not write a single word, because it did not seem right, and because his hand was shaking too much.

At last the innkeeper opened his eyes.

"Why didn't you ever tell me?" he said.

Bast looked at him.

"Because it was the worst thing I ever saw," he said simply. "Worse than my mother leaving. Worse than the Cthaeh. Worse than anything." He looked down at his hands. "I watched you go out, Reshi. Like a candle. I watched the most beautiful thing in the world go into a

door and not come out. And I thought, every day, for seven years, that I'd never hear it again." His voice was very small. "How was I supposed to tell you that? When you couldn't even remember what it was you'd lost?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long time.

Then he reached across the table and took Bast's hand. And held it.

"You'll hear it again," he said quietly. "Soon. I promise."

Bast looked at their hands, together on the table. Then up at the innkeeper's face. His deep blue eyes were very bright.

"You always promise," he said. His voice cracked. "That's what I love about you. And that's what frightens me."

"I know," said the innkeeper. "Denna used to say the same thing."

He let go of Bast's hand. He looked at Chronicler.

"Write it down," he said. "All of it. Just the way he told it." He picked up his cup. "And then we'll go on."

## Chapter One Hundred Fifteen

# The Duke of Hollowmere

They did not kill me. I have thought, since, that they should have. It would have been simpler for everyone.

The soldiers came up the slope toward the door of the Lackless house in a great grey tide, shouting, with their swords drawn and their pikes leveled. I stood in the doorway with the woman beside me and watched them come, and I did not feel afraid. I did not feel anything. Fear needs a self to be afraid for, and mine was tied up in a cord around my wrist.

They surrounded us. A wall of grey steel and grey faces, pressing close. Someone struck me in the face with the butt of a pike, and I fell to my knees on the grey stone of the doorstep, and tasted blood. I did not feel that either. Not really. I knew it hurt. I could see the blood dripping onto the stone. But it was happening to someone else. Some grey man, kneeling on a doorstep, with blood on his mouth.

The woman was shouting. She had put herself between me and the soldiers, with her arms spread wide, and she was shouting at them. I did not understand what she said. But the soldiers stopped. They stood with their pikes leveled and their faces twisted with rage, and they did not strike again.

And then the crowd parted, and a man came through it on a horse.

\* \* \*

He was old. Older than the Maer, younger than Bredon. A big man, heavy through the shoulders and the belly, with a thick grey beard and

a heavy grey face. He was dressed in fine armor, black and silver, with a black cloak and a circlet of silver on his brow. His horse was black too. Everything about him was black and silver.

I did not know him. But the woman beside me went very still.

"Duke Jakis," she said softly. "His father."

The duke reined in his horse at the foot of the doorstep. He sat very still in the saddle, looking down at me. His face was the color of old ashes. His eyes were red-rimmed and swollen.

"Where is he?" he said.

His voice was very quiet. Much quieter than I expected, from a man so big.

No one answered.

"Where is my son?" said the duke.

"In the cellars," said the woman. Her voice was steady. "At the bottom of the stair. By the door."

The duke looked at her. Then he looked at me.

"You did it," he said. "You."

I looked up at him. I tried to think of something to say. Nothing came. There was nothing in me to say it with.

"Yes," I said.

\* \* \*

He got down off his horse. He did it slowly, heavily, the way an old man gets down off a horse. He walked up the steps toward me. His soldiers parted to let him through.

He stopped in front of me. I was still on my knees on the doorstep. He looked down at me for a long time.

Then he struck me.

Not with a sword, or a pike, or anything else. With his hand. His open hand, across my face. It was a heavy hand, and he put all his weight behind it, and it knocked me sideways onto the stone.

I lay there. I did not get up. I looked at the grey sky.

"He was twenty years old," said the duke. His voice was shaking now. "Twenty years old. He was my only son. His mother died when he was six. I raised him myself." He struck me again, a kick this time,

in the ribs. I felt something crack. "He was proud. He was vain. He was foolish. He was cruel, sometimes. I know that. I know all of that." Another kick. "But he was *mine*. And you killed him. In a hole in the ground. Like a dog."

"He was going to kill her," I said. My voice was flat. "The lady. With a knife."

The duke went very still.

"What lady?"

"The Maer's wife. Meluan. He had a knife at her throat. He was going to give her to the door." I looked up at him. "I didn't have time. I didn't have time to do anything else."

The duke stared at me.

"You're lying," he said.

"No."

"My son would never—"

"He would," said the woman. She was standing beside me, very straight, with her chin up. "He did. I saw it. Everyone in that chamber saw it." Her voice cracked. "He wasn't himself, your grace. He hadn't been himself for months. Not since the old man came. Not since he put that box around his neck."

The duke looked at her. Something moved in his heavy grey face.

"The old man," he said slowly. "Bredon."

"Yes."

"Where is he?"

The woman was quiet for a moment. "Gone," she said at last. "Through the door. Just before it closed."

The duke looked at her for a long time. Then he looked at me. Then he looked up, past me, into the dark hallway of the Lackless house.

"Bring my son up," he said to his soldiers. "Now. I want to see him."

\* \* \*

They brought Ambrose up an hour later.

Four soldiers carried him on a litter made of spears and cloaks. They came out of the dark doorway into the grey morning light and set him down on the stone of the courtyard, very gently, the way you set down something that can break. They had covered him with a black cloak. Only his face showed. It was very pale and very still, and his eyes were closed, and he looked younger than I had ever seen him. He looked like a boy.

The duke knelt beside him.

He did not say anything. He knelt there on the grey stone with his hand on his son's chest, over the black cloak, over the place where Caesura had gone in. His heavy shoulders were shaking.

I lay on the doorstep where he had left me, with my ribs cracked and my face bleeding, and I watched him.

And I felt something.

It was very faint. Very far away. Coming up out of the hole in my chest like water seeping up into a footprint in wet sand. I did not know what it was. It had no name. I had nothing to name it with.

But I watched the duke kneel beside his son and weep, and I felt it. And it hurt more than his hand, or his boot, or anything else.

I have thought since that it was grief. His, not mine. I think that when you have no name of your own, sometimes other people's feelings can seep into the empty place where yours should be. Like water into a hole.

I think I grieved for Ambrose that morning. Not because I had loved him. I never did. But because his father did. And for a little while, lying on that doorstep with nothing inside me, I had room for it.

\* \* \*

The duke stood up at last. His face was grey and wet and very hard.

"Hang him," he said. "Here. Now. From the gate."

"Your grace." It was one of his officers. A lean man with a careful face, in the colors of some lesser lord. "Your grace, we can't."

The duke turned on him. "Can't?"

"He killed the king, your grace. The *king*. Not a lord, not a soldier. The king of Vintas." The officer's voice was very careful.

"There are laws. Very old laws. A regicide must be tried in the capital, before the lords of the realm. If we hang him here, in a field, without trial—"

"I don't care about laws."

"The other lords will, your grace." The officer was sweating. "They'll say you did it to silence him. They'll say you didn't want him to talk. They'll say—" He hesitated.

"They'll say what?"

The officer glanced at the woman beside me. Then back at the duke.

"They'll say the king was killed at a door," he said quietly. "In a cellar. With a box around his neck and a woman's blood on his hands. They'll say the king was doing something that no king should do. And that you knew." He paused. "They'll want to know why, your grace. And if the only witness is dead, they'll assume the worst."

The duke stared at him for a long time.

"You think I'm afraid of what they'll say?"

"I think your son's name matters to you, your grace." The officer's voice was very soft. "I think you want it remembered well. And I think the only way that happens is if there's a trial. A public one. Where everyone can hear what he did, and what was done to him." He glanced at me. "Where everyone can see the Ruh who killed him hang for it, in the great square at Renere, in front of the whole kingdom."

The duke was silent. He looked down at his son's body, lying on the stone under its black cloak. He looked at me, lying on the doorstep.

"Chain him," he said at last. "Take him to Renere. We'll try him there." He looked at the woman. "And her too."

\* \* \*

They chained me. Heavy iron chains, on my wrists and my ankles. They put the one on my left wrist right over the cord, and I felt the iron press the knots against my skin. The cord was humming very faintly. Unhappily. Like a cat pressed too tight.

The woman saw. She said something to the soldier who was fastening the chain. Sharp and angry. He ignored her. She said it again,

louder. He struck her across the face.

I do not remember deciding to move. I do not remember deciding anything. One moment I was sitting on the doorstep with the chains on my wrists, and the next I was on my feet, and the soldier who had struck her was on the ground, and I was standing over him with the chain between my wrists pulled taut, and I did not know how I had got there.

Every soldier in the courtyard had their sword out.

The woman caught my arm. "Stop," she hissed. "Stop, stop, it's all right, I'm all right, stop."

I stopped. I stood very still. I did not know why I had moved. I did not know what I was feeling. There was something in my chest, hot and fierce, rising up out of the hole like fire out of a well. I did not know what it was called.

The soldier on the ground was staring up at me. His face was white.

"He's a demon," he whispered. "Look at his eyes. He's a demon."

I did not know what my eyes looked like. I did not know what a demon was. I stood there with the chains on my wrists and the heat in my chest, and I looked at him.

Then the woman's hand tightened on my arm, and the heat went out of me as quickly as it had come, and I was empty again. And grey. And I sat back down on the doorstep, and I did not move again until they came to take me away.

\* \* \*

They took us to Renere in a cart.

It was a prison cart, with iron bars on all four sides and an iron roof, the kind they use to carry criminals to the gallows. They put me in it, in my chains, and they put the woman in with me. They did not chain her. I think they did not think they needed to.

The cart was drawn by two grey horses, and it was guarded by fifty soldiers on horseback, and it went at the head of the duke's army, behind the black cart that carried his son's body.



It was a long way to Renere. Nine days. I do not remember most of it. I remember the grey sky, and the grey road, and the grey hills rolling by beyond the bars. I remember the rain, which came on the third day and did not stop. I remember the woman sitting beside me in the cart, holding my hand, singing very softly under her breath.

I remember the villages.

\* \* \*

We passed through many of them. Small places, farms and hamlets and market towns, strung along the road like beads on a cord. And in every one, people came out to see.

Word had gone ahead of us. The king was dead. The kingkiller was coming, in a cage, to be tried in Renere. People came out of their houses and lined the road to watch us pass. Men and women and children. Old people. Young people. Farmers and shopkeepers and priests.

Some of them threw things. Mud. Stones. Rotten fruit. A dead cat, once, which struck the bars of the cart and fell back into the road. They shouted. *Kingkiller. Murderer. Demon. Ruh.* The soldiers let them.

Some of them did not throw anything. They only stood and watched, with their faces closed and wary. The way people watch a storm passing on the horizon.

And some of them—not many, but some—did something else.

In a village called Brennock, on the fifth day, a girl came out of the crowd. She was very young, seven or eight. She had a cup in her hands. She walked right up to the bars of the cart, past the soldiers, before anyone could stop her, and she held the cup up to me.

It was water.

I looked at it. I did not understand. The woman beside me took it, gently, from the girl's hands, and held it to my lips, and I drank.

"My mam says you sang a song," said the girl. She was looking up at me through the bars with wide brown eyes. "In the big city. About the white town. She says it's the best song there ever was. She says the king's men burned our neighbor's house because he was

singing it."

I looked down at her. I did not know what to say. I did not know what a song was. I knew the word, but not the meaning.

"Thank you," I said.

The girl smiled. Then a soldier grabbed her by the arm and hauled her away, and she was gone into the crowd.

The woman beside me was crying. I did not know why.

\* \* \*

In another village, on the seventh day, I saw a fox.

It was sitting at the edge of a wood, beside the road, watching the cart go by. A red fox, bright against the grey. It sat very still, with its tail curled around its feet, and it watched me. Its eyes were a very deep blue.

I did not know foxes did not have blue eyes. I did not know anything. But I looked at it, and something in the cord on my wrist hummed.

The fox watched until the cart was out of sight. Then, when I looked back, it was gone.

I saw it again the next day. And the next. Always at the edge of a wood, or on a hill, or at the corner of a barn. Always watching. Always with those deep blue eyes.

On the ninth day, as we came over the last rise and saw the city of Renere spread out below us in its bowl of green hills, I saw it one more time. Sitting on a stone at the side of the road, with the city behind it.

It looked at me. I looked at it.

And very faintly, so faintly I could not be sure I had heard it at all, I thought I heard a voice. Soft and cracked and very young.

*I'll find you, Reshi. Wherever they take you.*

The cart rolled on. When I looked back, the stone was empty.

## Chapter One Hundred Sixteen

# **The Tower of Thorns**

They put me in the Tower of Thorns.

It is the oldest part of the royal palace at Renere, older than the great grey walls and the heavy battlements and the squat towers that make the palace look like a toad. It is a narrow round tower of black stone, very tall, rising out of the center of the palace like a spike. There are no windows in its lower half. In its upper half, there are only slits, too narrow for a cat to crawl through. It has been a prison for as long as there has been a kingdom of Vintas, and before that, the stories say, it was something worse.

It is called the Tower of Thorns because of what grows on it. A vine, very old, thick as a man's arm at its base, that climbs the black stone all the way to the top. It has no leaves. It has no flowers. It has only thorns, long and black and sharp as needles, so many of them that the whole tower seems to bristle like the back of an angry cat.

They say that no one has ever escaped from the Tower of Thorns. They say that the vine was planted by the first king of Vintas, and that it was grown from a seed brought out of the Fae, and that it knows when a prisoner tries to climb down, and closes around him like a fist.

I do not know if that is true. I never tried.

\* \* \*

My cell was near the top. A small round room, with a stone floor and stone walls and a single slit of a window, high up, that let in a thin grey knife of light at midday and nothing at all the rest of the time. There

was a pallet of straw in one corner. A bucket in another. A heavy iron door with a small barred grate in it, at head height, through which the guards could look.

They took off my chains when they put me in. Not out of kindness. There was nowhere to go.

They took the woman somewhere else. I did not know where. They took her away at the foot of the tower, and she fought them, and shouted, and tried to hold on to my hand. But there were too many of them. They pulled her away. The last thing I saw of her was her face, grey and wet, turning back to look at me as they dragged her down a corridor.

*"I'll find a way," she shouted. "I'll find a way, I promise, I'll—"*

A door closed, and I did not hear the rest.

\* \* \*

I do not know how long I was in the Tower of Thorns. A long time. Months. The seasons turned outside my narrow window. The grey knife of light that came in at midday grew shorter, and then longer, and then shorter again. It was autumn when they put me in. It was spring, I think, when they took me out.

I do not remember most of it.

I remember the grey. Always the grey. The grey stone walls and the grey stone floor and the grey light and the grey bread they pushed through the slot at the bottom of the door once a day. The grey water in the grey cup. The grey faces of the guards, looking through the grate.

I remember sitting. For hours. For days. On the straw pallet, with my back against the wall and my knees drawn up and my arms around them. Not thinking. Not feeling. Not anything. Just sitting, in the grey, the way a stone sits at the bottom of a pond.

I remember the cord.

It was always there, on my wrist. The guards had tried to take it off, the first day. One of them had grabbed my arm and tried to cut it with his knife. The knife had slid off the cord as if it were made of iron. He had tried again. The same. He had tried to untie it. His fingers could not find the ends.

He had stared at it for a long time. Then he had let go of my arm, very quickly, and backed away, and made a sign against evil with his fingers, and left the cell. None of the guards touched it after that.

I touched it. Often. It was the only thing I did touch, in those months. I would sit on my pallet and hold my left wrist in my right hand and run my fingers over the knots. Over and over. Feeling them. Their shapes. Their loops and twists and doublings-back.

And sometimes, when I touched them, I felt something. Very faint. A voice in another room. A word I almost remembered. A face I almost knew.

It never lasted. It was like trying to hold water in your hands. But it was something.

\* \* \*

I remember the dreams.

I did not dream at first. Or if I did, I did not remember. But later, after a month or two, I began to dream. And they were not grey.

They were full of color. Colors so bright they hurt. The green of new leaves in spring. The red of a fire. The blue of the sky at dusk. The gold of sunlight on a white stone city.

I dreamed of a white city on the last day of its life. I dreamed of towers and gardens and fountains full of children. I dreamed of a woman singing in a great hall.

I dreamed of a fire in the woods, and a wagon burning, and a man with black eyes crouching in front of me.

I dreamed of a girl with dark hair, sitting under a pear tree with blossoms falling around her like snow.

I dreamed of a door.

And every time I woke, the colors drained away, and the world was grey again. And I did not know what I had dreamed. Only that it had been beautiful, and that it was gone.

\* \* \*

People came to see me. Not many. Not often.

The first was an old woman. Very small and very wrinkled, with bright eyes and a cat in her arms. She came to the grate in the door one afternoon and looked in at me.

"Well," she said. "You've made a fine mess of things, haven't you?"

I looked at her. I did not know her.

"Lady Tamsin," she said. "Tamsin Aerwen. I helped you get in to see the old king. Before." She peered at me through the bars. "You don't remember me."

"No."

"Hm." She looked at me for a long moment. Her bright eyes were very sharp. "They said you'd gone mad. After. That something happened to you in that cellar, and you came out with your wits scrambled." She tilted her head. "That's not it, though. Is it? That's not madness. I've seen madness. That's something else."

I did not answer. I did not know how.

"You look," said Lady Tamsin slowly, "like a man who's been emptied out. Like a jar someone's poured the wine out of." She stroked her cat. "What did they do to you, boy?"

"Nothing," I said. "I did it."

She looked at me for a long time. Then she nodded, slowly, as if I had told her something important.

"I'll come back," she said. "When I can. It's not easy. The duke doesn't like visitors." She smiled faintly. "But I'm very old, and very rich, and I know where a great many bodies are buried. Some of them literally." She turned to go. Then she stopped. "Oh. I nearly forgot. There's someone asking after you. A physician. Kelm. They let him out of the dungeons a month ago, when they couldn't find anything to charge him with." She paused. "He says to tell you he's sorry. That he couldn't do more. For the old king."

"I don't know who that is."

"No," said Lady Tamsin gently. "No, I don't suppose you do." She was quiet for a moment. "I'll tell him you said thank you anyway."

\* \* \*

She did come back. Many times. Every span or two, she came to the grate in the door and talked to me. She told me things. News from the court. News from the kingdom. She did not seem to mind that I did not understand most of it, or that I rarely answered. She talked the way old women talk to a sick child, or a cat. For the comfort of talking.

I learned, from her, that the kingdom had gone to war with itself.

Duke Jakis had proclaimed himself regent, the moment he returned to Renere with his son's body. He said that there was no heir, and that someone must rule until one could be found, and that he, as the father of the murdered king, was the natural choice.

Half the lords of Vintas had agreed with him. The other half had not.

"They don't trust him," said Lady Tamsin. "Never did. Too ambitious. Too grasping. And there are rumors now. About the old man, the one who always stood behind him. About the deaths. The four heirs, and the old king, and the prince." She shook her head. "People are saying it wasn't bad luck. People are saying it was murder. And people are saying the duke knew."

"Did he?"

Lady Tamsin looked at me through the bars. It was the first question I had asked her.

"I don't know," she said. "I don't think so. Not all of it. I think the old man used him the way he used his son." She was quiet for a moment. "But it doesn't matter, does it? What matters is what people believe. And people believe the duke's hands are dirty."

"What will happen?"

"War," said Lady Tamsin. "It's already happening. The lords who won't follow the duke have gone south. To the hills. To your Maer." She smiled faintly. "He's gathering them. All the ones who hate the duke, and the ones who loved the old king, and the ones who just want to be on the winning side. He's got an army again. Not as big as the duke's. But growing."

"The Maer."

"Alveron. Your Maer. The one who sent you here." She peered at me. "You don't remember him either, do you?"

"No."

"Hm." She stroked her cat. "Well. He remembers you. He's been sending letters. To the duke, to the council, to anyone who'll listen. Demanding your release. Saying you saved his wife's life. Saying you're a hero, not a murderer." She shook her head. "Nobody listens, of course. He's a rebel now. A traitor. No one listens to traitors." She paused. "Until they win."

\* \* \*

The second visitor was a physician.

He was small and grey and thin, with spectacles on the end of his nose and ink-stained fingers. He came with Lady Tamsin once, in the winter, and stood at the grate beside her, and looked in at me for a long time without saying anything.

Then he said, "May I come in?"

The guards let him. I do not know what Lady Tamsin paid them. He came into my cell and knelt beside my pallet and looked at me. He looked at my face, and my eyes, and my hands. He took my wrist—my right wrist, not the left—and held it and felt my pulse. He looked at the cord on my left wrist for a long time, without touching it.

"Remarkable," he said at last. His voice was very quiet. "Remarkable. You're healthy. Thin, but healthy. Your heart is strong. Your lungs are clear. There's nothing wrong with you at all." He looked into my eyes. "And yet there's no one home."

"I know," I said.

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he sat back on his heels.

"I studied at the University," he said. "A long time ago. I knew a man there. A master. Elodin." He was quiet for a moment. "When I was a student, he was in Haven. He'd done something to himself. Something to his name. And for three years, he looked exactly like you do now." He looked at me. "Empty. Grey. Like a house with all the lamps put out."



"Did he get better?"

"Yes. Eventually." Kelm was quiet for a moment. "He found his way back. Or found a new way. I was never sure which." He looked at the cord on my wrist. "Is that where it is? Your name?"

I looked down at the cord. At the knots, glowing very faintly in the grey light.

"Yes," I said.

Kelm let out a long breath.

"Then you're not lost," he said. "Not really. You're just—put away. Like a book on a shelf." He smiled faintly. "Someone only has to take you down and open you."

He stood up. He looked down at me for a long moment.

"I'm sorry," he said. "For the king. For all of it. I couldn't do more."

"You did enough," I said.

I did not know why I said it. I did not know who he was, or what he had done. But the words came out of me the way they had come out on the doorstep of the Lackless house. From somewhere below the grey. From somewhere down at the bottom, where the truth lives.

Kelm looked at me. His eyes, behind his spectacles, were wet.

"Thank you," he said.

\* \* \*

The third visitor did not come through the door.

I was lying on my pallet one night, late, in the deep of the winter. The cell was very dark and very cold. There was frost on the inside of the walls. I could not sleep. I was lying on my back, looking up at the dark ceiling, holding my left wrist in my right hand, running my fingers over the knots.

And I heard something at the window.

A scratching. Soft and quick. Like claws on stone.

I sat up. I looked at the window, the narrow slit high in the wall, black against the black sky.

There was something in it. Something small and dark, pressed into the slit. I could see its eyes, glinting.

Deep blue.

"Reshi," said a voice.

It was very soft. Very quiet. But I heard it. And the cord on my wrist hummed.

"Reshi. It's me. It's Bast." A pause. "You don't remember me. I know. That's all right. I remember you."

I stared at the window. I did not say anything.

"I've been trying to get in for weeks," said the voice. "The vine. The thorns. They're Fae. Old Fae. They don't like me. They keep closing up whenever I try to climb." A soft laugh, very tired. "I'm covered in scratches. I look like I've been fighting cats."

"Why?" I said.

The eyes in the window blinked.

"Why what?"

"Why are you trying to get in?"

There was a long silence.

"Because you're in here," said Bast at last. "And I said I'd find you. And I did." A pause. "That's all. That's the whole reason."

I looked at the eyes in the window. At the small dark shape pressed into the slit.

"I don't know you," I said.

"I know."

"I don't know who I am."

"I know that too." The voice was very gentle. "It's all right. I know who you are. I'll remember for both of us. Until you can remember yourself."

The cord on my wrist was humming. Very softly. The way a string hums when another string nearby is plucked.

"Will you come back?" I said.

The eyes in the window blinked again.

"Every night," said Bast. "Every single night. Until they let you out."

\* \* \*

He did. Every night. For the rest of that winter.

He never came into the cell. He could not; the slit was too narrow, even for a fox, even for a cat, even for whatever small dark shape he had made himself into. But he came to the window. Every night, late, when the guards were asleep. He pressed himself into the slit and looked in at me with his deep blue eyes, and he talked.

He told me stories. About the twilight, and his father's court, and the tree-palace by the dark river. About a mortal woman who had been his mother, and a shepherd, and two half-siblings he had never met. About a silver forest and a white birch wood and a net of silver silk. About a red-haired man who had stepped in front of five arrows.

He told me about the others. The ones who had gone down the cellar stair. They had all made it out, through the tunnel, into the hills. Meluan was with the Maer now, weak but alive, her hair gone white as snow. Sim had lost his left eye; the scrael's leg had cut it through. He wore a patch now, and wrote poems about it, very bad ones, that made everyone laugh. Wil had taken charge of the Maer's arcanists, what few there were, and was teaching them how to use sympathy in war. Devi was making more Surprises. Fela had gone back to the University, to Elodin, to learn more about stone.

"She says she's going to find a way," said Bast. "To help you. She says there has to be a way." A pause. "She says she wants her stone back."

I did not know what he meant. But I found that my hand had gone to my pocket, where there was a small flat stone, worn smooth. I held it. It was cold.

It said *no*. Very faintly. I could barely hear it.

But I heard it.

## Chapter One Hundred Seventeen

# The Man Who Tapped

There was a man in the cell below mine, in the Tower of Thorns. I never saw his face. I never learned his name. But he talked to me every night for three months, and he is part of this story, and I will not leave him out.

He did not talk with his voice. The stone walls of the Tower were too thick for voices. He talked by tapping.

I noticed it first in my second month. I was lying on my pallet in the grey dark, not sleeping, not thinking, holding my left wrist in my right hand and running my fingers over the knots. And I heard it. Very faint, coming up through the stone floor. *Tap. Tap-tap. Tap.*

I did not think anything of it. I did not think anything of anything, in those months. But it went on. Every night, at the same hour, after the guards changed. *Tap. Tap-tap. Tap. Tap-tap-tap.* A pattern. The same pattern, over and over, for an hour, and then silence.

After a span of nights, I tapped back.

I do not know why. I had nothing in me to wonder with, and nothing to want. But my hand moved. It found a loose chip of stone on the floor beside my pallet, and it rapped on the floor with it. *Tap. Tap-tap. Tap.* The same pattern.

Below me, the tapping stopped.

Then it started again. Faster. Different.

\* \* \*

It was a cipher. A simple one, the kind prisoners have used in every dungeon since there have been dungeons. Taps for letters, counted out in rows and columns. The kind of thing I would have worked out in an afternoon, before. As Kote, with nothing in my head, it took me three spans.

But I worked it out. Slowly. Tap by tap. Letter by letter.

The first thing he said, when I could finally understand him, was: *WHO*.

I did not know how to answer. I did not know who I was. So I tapped back the only thing I had.

*KOTE*. Though that name was not given me until later, on a roof in Imre, and I did not have it yet. What I actually tapped, as best I can remember, was *NO ONE*.

There was a long silence below.

Then: *ME TOO*.

\* \* \*

He was old. That was the first thing I learned about him. He told me, over many nights, tap by tap. He had been in the Tower of Thorns for eleven years. Before that, in another prison in the south, for six. Before that, he did not say.

He did not know what he was in for. Or he said he did not. He said they had come for him in the night, in a town in the eastern hills, men in plain grey with no badges, and taken him, and he had been in one cell or another ever since. He said no one had ever told him the charge.

*WHY*, I tapped. It took a long time.

Below me, silence. Then:

*TATTOO*.

\* \* \*

It took me a long time to understand. Three nights. He tapped it out patiently, letter by letter, while I lay on my pallet and listened and let the letters fall into me like stones into a well, and slowly, slowly, they began to make a shape.

He had a tattoo. On his chest, over his heart. It was very old. His father had given it to him, when he was a boy, and his father's father to his father, back and back. He did not know what it meant. His father had not known either. Only that it was important, and that it must be passed down, and that it must never be shown to anyone who was not family.

It was a tower. Burning.

AMYR, I tapped. I did not know how I knew the word. It came up out of the hole in my chest from somewhere very far down.

The silence below was very long. Longer than any silence before.

Then: YES.

And then, faster, tapping so fast I could barely follow:

*HOW YOU KNOW. HOW. NO ONE KNOWS. NO ONE LEFT.*

\* \* \*

I did not know how I knew. I tapped that. *DONT KNOW. KNOW ANYWAY.*

He was quiet for a long time after that. Nights. I thought I had frightened him. Or that the guards had heard, and taken him away.

Then, on the fourth night, the tapping came again. Slow. Careful.

*TELL YOU SOMETHING. NEVER TOLD ANYONE.*

I waited.

*MY GRANDFATHER. HE KNEW. WHAT IT MEANT. THE TOWER.* A pause. *HE WAS THE LAST. THE LAST WHO KNEW. HE TOLD MY FATHER A LITTLE. NOT ALL.*

*WHAT.*

*THAT WE WERE SWORN. TO WATCH. A DOOR. UNDER A BIG STONE HOUSE. FULL OF BOOKS.* A long pause. *THAT A MAN CAME. A FRIEND. OLD. KIND. AND ONE BY ONE THE WATCHERS DIED. AND MY GRANDFATHER RAN. AND HID. AND NEVER WATCHED AGAIN.*

I lay very still on my pallet in the grey dark.

A FRIEND, I tapped. *OLD. KIND.*

*YES.*

*STICK.*

The silence below me went on and on.  
*HOW YOU KNOW*, he tapped at last. Very slowly.  
I did not answer. I did not know how to.

\* \* \*

He told me the rest over the next month. Tap by tap. His grandfather had been one of the last of the Amyr. Not the great ones, the Ciridae, with their tattoos over their whole bodies and their swords and their terrible certainty. A lesser one. A watcher. One of those sworn to go down beneath the Archives, in their turn, and sit in the Chamber of Watches, and write *the door holds* in the book.

His grandfather had watched for twenty years. And then the watchers had begun to die. One by one. A fever. A fall. A knife in an alley. And his grandfather had noticed that before each death, the one who died had been visited by an old friend. Kind. Well-spoken. With a stick.

And his grandfather had run. With his wife and his son. East, into the hills, to a town where no one had ever heard of the Amyr. And he had never gone back. And he had told his son a little, and his son had told his son less, and all that was left, at the end, was a tattoo over the heart, and a story that no one understood.

*WHY THEY TAKE YOU*, I tapped.

*DONT KNOW. THINK SOMEONE SAW TATTOO. TOLD SOMEONE. OLD MAN MAYBE.* A pause. *THINK HE WANTED ALL OF US GONE. EVEN ONES WHO FORGOT.*

*HE IS GONE NOW*, I tapped. I did not know how I knew that either. But I knew. I had seen it, once. A man with a stick stepping through a door into nothing, just as it closed. I did not remember the door. But I remembered that.

The silence below was very long.

*GONE WHERE*, he tapped.

*THROUGH THE DOOR.*

\* \* \*

He did not tap for three nights after that. On the fourth night, it came again. Slow. Weak.

*SICK*, he tapped. *VERY SICK. COUGH. BLOOD.*

I lay on my pallet and listened. I did not know what to do.

*WANT TO GIVE YOU SOMETHING*, he tapped. *BEFORE.*

*WHAT.*

*THE WORDS. ON THE TATTOO. UNDER THE TOWER. MY GRANDFATHER SAID NEVER FORGET THEM. I NEVER KNEW WHAT THEY MEANT.* A long pause. *YOU MIGHT.*

He tapped them out. Very slowly. Letter by letter. In a language I did not know, or thought I did not know. It took him the whole of that night, and he had to stop, many times, and I could hear, very faintly, through the stone, the sound of him coughing.

When he was done, I lay very still in the dark, with the letters sitting in me like stones.

*IVARE ENIM EUGE.*

I did not know what they meant. Not then. I learned later, much later, from Selitos's grey book, which I had read and did not remember reading. It is old Tema. It is the motto of the Amyr. The words Selitos gave them, among the ashes of the white city, on the night he founded the order.

*For the greater good.*

\* \* \*

*THANK YOU*, I tapped. I did not know why. The words meant nothing to me. But my hand tapped them anyway.

Below me, very faint, a single tap.

Then silence.

He did not tap the next night. Or the next. On the third night, I heard the guards on the stair below, and a door, and the sound of something heavy being dragged.

After that, there was no more tapping.

\* \* \*



I have told Chronicler about him. It is the first time I have told anyone. I asked Lady Tamsin, once, before I left Renere, if she knew who had been in the cell below mine in the Tower of Thorns. She asked. No one knew. There was no record. Only a note in a guard's ledger: *Prisoner, cell nine. Died of lung-fever. Buried in the lime pit.*

No name. No charge. Nothing.

He was the last of the Amyr, as far as I know. Or the last who carried the mark. He did not know what it meant. He did not know what his grandfather had watched, or why it mattered, or who had killed them all. He only knew that there was a door, under a big stone house full of books, and that an old kind man with a stick had come.

He died in the dark, tapping out the only thing he had to give to a man who could not remember his own name.

*For the greater good.*

I do not know if it was. I do not know if any of it was. But I have put him in this story. So that someone will remember. So that the last of the Amyr is not only a note in a guard's ledger and a body in a lime pit.

He was a man who tapped on the floor of his cell, every night, at the same hour, for eleven years, hoping someone would answer.

And at the end, someone did.

## Chapter One Hundred Eighteen

# A Mouse in the Grey

There was a mouse in my cell in the Tower of Thorns.

I did not notice it for a long time. I did not notice much, in the grey. I sat on my pallet with my back against the wall and watched the thin knife of light from the window slit move across the floor at midday, and then I watched the dark, and then I watched the light again. The days went by like that. I did not count them.

But one day, when the guards brought my bread, I did not eat it at once. I do not remember why. Perhaps I forgot. I set it down on the floor beside the pallet and went back to watching the light. And when I looked down again, some time later, there was a mouse sitting beside the bread, eating it.

It was a very small mouse. Brown, with a white patch on its chest and a torn left ear. It was sitting up on its hind legs with a crumb held in its front paws, nibbling very fast. When it saw me looking at it, it froze. Its black eyes were very bright.

I did not move. I did not feel anything about it. I looked at the mouse and the mouse looked at me.

After a while, it went back to eating.

\* \* \*

It came back the next day. And the day after. It came out of a crack in the stones at the base of the wall, near the door, at the same time every day, just after the guards brought my bread. It sat beside my pallet and waited.

I began breaking off a piece of the bread for it. I do not know why. I did not decide to. My hands did it, the way my hands did most things, in the grey. They tore off a corner of the loaf and set it on the floor beside the pallet, and then they gave me the rest.

The mouse ate its corner. Then it cleaned its whiskers, very carefully, with both paws. Then it went back into its crack.

That was all. Every day. For a long time.

\* \* \*

I have thought about that mouse a great deal, since. I have wondered why it chose my cell, out of all the cells in the Tower of Thorns. I have wondered how it got so high, up that long black spiral of stone, with the thorn-vine on the outside and the guards on the stairs. I have wondered what it saw, when it looked at me with its bright black eyes.

I think it saw something harmless. That is the only explanation I have ever been able to find. Mice are very good at knowing what is dangerous. They have to be. And the man who had been Kvothe, who had called the wind and killed a king and sung the Chandrian into a burning room, was the most dangerous thing in that tower. The guards knew it. They never came into my cell alone. They never turned their backs on me.

But the mouse knew better. The mouse looked at me and saw what I was, then. A grey shape on a straw pallet, that broke off bread. Nothing more. Nothing to be afraid of.

It was right. That was the terrible thing. It was right.

\* \* \*

The man in the cell below knew about the mouse. He tapped about it, through the stones. I did not understand all of his tapping, then. He was teaching me the code, slowly, night by night, and I learned it the way a very small child learns words, without knowing I was learning. Some of what he tapped in those months I only understood years later, remembering the patterns. He had been keeping a kind of diary, tapping it into the wall. A record. And some of it was about me.

*The man above has a mouse, he tapped, one day. I hear it. I hear him feed it. He does not speak to it.*

*And later: The man above still does not speak. But he feeds the mouse every day. That is something.*

*And later still: A man who feeds a mouse is not gone. Not all the way.*

\* \* \*

In the autumn, the mouse did not come.

I did not notice at first. The guards brought my bread, and my hands broke off a corner and set it on the floor, and then they gave me the rest. And I ate it, and watched the light.

But the corner was still there the next day. Untouched. And the day after that.

I looked at it. A small piece of bread, going stale on the stone floor beside my pallet. I did not know why I was looking at it. I did not feel anything. But I found that I could not stop.

On the third day, I got up.

It was the first time I had got up from my pallet in—I do not know how long. Weeks. Longer. My legs were weak and stiff and they did not want to hold me. But I got up, and I crossed the cell, slowly, holding on to the wall, and I knelt down beside the crack in the stones at the base of the wall near the door.

And I looked in.

\* \* \*

It was very dark in the crack. I could not see anything. I put my face close to the stones, and I listened.

Nothing. No scratching. No small quick breathing.

I do not know how long I knelt there. A long time. Long enough for the knife of light from the window to move all the way across the floor and up the opposite wall and vanish. Long enough for the cell to go dark.

And then, in the dark, very faintly, from the cell below, the tapping began.

I understood only a little of it. Not then. But I remembered the pattern, the way I remembered everything from that time, without knowing that I did. And years later, sitting in an inn at a crossroads, I worked out the rest.

*I am sorry about your mouse, the man below had tapped. The cold took it. There was one in my cell too, once. They do not live long.*

A pause.

*You got up. I heard you. You got up for the mouse.*

A long pause.

*You are still in there.*

\* \* \*

I went back to my pallet. I lay down. I did not feel anything.

But the next day, when the guards brought my bread, my hands broke off a corner and set it on the floor beside the pallet. The way they always had.

And the day after that. And the day after that. Every day, until they took me out of the Tower of Thorns to be tried and hanged. A corner of bread, set on the stone floor, for a mouse that was not coming back.

I do not know why I did it. The guards thought I was mad. Perhaps I was.

But I think, now, that it was the same thing that made my fingers move on the lute in a farmhouse in the rain, and made me get up from behind the bar when the scrael came, and made me say yes to a scribe with bloody knuckles. The part of me that the grey could not reach. The part that the cord had not taken, because it was too small to be a name.

The part of me that fed the mouse.

\* \* \*

"You never told me that," said Bast.

He was sitting very still. His face was strange.

"I didn't remember it," said the innkeeper. "Not until now." He looked at his hands. "It's odd. The things that come back. I thought the

big things would come first. The fire. The door. Denna. And they do. But the small things come too. A mouse with a torn ear. A crust of bread." He was quiet for a moment. "I think the small things were holding the big ones up. The whole time. Like the stones at the bottom of a wall."

Chronicler did not say anything. He wrote.

And when he looked up again, the innkeeper had broken off a corner of the bread on the plate beside him, without seeming to notice he was doing it. And had set it on the table, at the edge, near the wall.

Bast looked at it for a long moment. Then he looked away, very quickly, and rubbed his eyes with the heel of his hand.

Nobody said anything about it. The bread stayed where it was, at the edge of the table, near the wall, for the rest of the evening.

## Chapter One Hundred Nineteen

# The Girl Who Tied the Moon

*Bast told me this story through the window slit of my cell in the Tower of Thorns, on the longest night of that winter. I did not understand it, then. I did not understand anything. But I remembered it, the way I remembered the tapping from the cell below, and the lock of a baby's hair in blue silk. And when my name came back, it came back with it.*

*He said it was a story the Telwyth Mael tell their children. He said his mother told it to him, when he was very small, before she went away.*

\* \* \*

Once, *said Bast*, before the Thief, before the war, before the twilight, there was a girl who could tie anything.

She lived in a village by the sea. A small one. Fishing boats and nets drying on the rocks and gulls crying all day long. And she was the daughter of a net-maker, and she had learned to tie knots before she could walk. By the time she was six, she could tie a net faster than her father. By the time she was ten, she could tie a net so fine a minnow couldn't slip through, and so strong a whale couldn't break it.

But that wasn't the strange thing about her. The strange thing was that her knots held more than fish.

When she tied a knot and thought about the sun, the knot was warm. When she tied a knot and thought about the rain, the knot was wet. When she tied a knot and thought about her mother's voice, singing in the kitchen, and put the knot to her ear, she could hear it.

Faint. Far away. Like a song in another room.

She could tie *anything*. Anything she could hold in her mind, she could hold in a cord.

\* \* \*

Her father was frightened of it. He told her to stop. He told her it was unnatural, and people would talk, and no good ever came of anything unnatural. So she stopped. Or she said she did. She tied ordinary nets for ordinary fish, and she smiled and nodded when her father spoke, and at night, in her little bed under the eaves, she tied other things.

She tied the smell of the sea after a storm. She tied the color of the sky at dawn. She tied the sound of the gulls, and the feel of sand between her toes, and the taste of her grandmother's honey cakes. She kept them all in a box under her bed, a box full of little knotted cords, and on nights when she was sad or lonely or couldn't sleep, she took them out and held them and was not sad anymore.

And one night, when she was sixteen, she looked up out of her little window under the eaves, and saw the moon.

\* \* \*

The moon was very beautiful in those days, *said Bast*. More beautiful than now. Because in those days, the moon was whole. She was always full. She never waxed or waned. She hung in the sky every night like a great silver coin, round and bright and perfect.

And the girl looked at her, and thought: *I want to keep that*.

Not to own it. Not to take it. Just to keep a little of it. The way she kept the smell of the sea and the sound of the gulls. A little silver thread of moonlight, tied in a cord, in her box under the bed. So that on dark nights, when the clouds were thick and the moon was hidden, she could take it out and hold it and still see her.

So she took a cord. The finest she had. Spun from her own hair. And she held it up to the window, in the moonlight, and she began to tie.

\* \* \*



It was the hardest knot she had ever tied. The moon did not want to be tied. She was too big, and too bright, and too far away. The cord kept slipping. The light kept sliding off it like water off oil.

But the girl was stubborn. She tied, and tied, and tied, all night long. Loop over loop over loop. Until her fingers bled. Until the sky began to grey in the east.

And just before dawn, just as the moon was setting, the knot held.

She felt it. A little tug. A little catch. And there, in the cord, very small, very faint, was a thread of silver light. A little piece of the moon.

She put it in her box, with the others. And she went to sleep, very tired and very happy.

\* \* \*

And the next night, *said Bast*, the moon was not whole.

There was a little piece missing. A thin sliver, on one edge, like the paring of a fingernail. Hardly anything. You had to look very hard to see it.

But the moon had never had a piece missing before. And she was very frightened.

She looked down at the world. She looked everywhere. In every village and every city, every forest and every sea. Looking for the piece of herself that was missing. And at last she found it. In a little box under a little bed in a little room under the eaves, in a fishing village by the sea.

And she came down to get it.

\* \* \*

The girl woke in the night, and the moon was in her room.

Not all of her. She was much too big. But a little of her. A silver light, very bright, filling the little room under the eaves from floor to ceiling. And a voice. Very soft, very sad, very far away.

*You have something of mine*, said the moon. *May I have it back?*

The girl sat up in bed. She was very frightened. But she was also very stubborn.

"I only took a little," she said. "Just a thread. So I could keep you. On dark nights."

*I know*, said the moon. *And it was a very beautiful knot. The most beautiful anyone has ever tied. But I cannot be whole without it. And if I am not whole, I cannot be what I am.*

"What are you?"

The moon was quiet for a long time.

*I am the one who is always there*, she said. *Even when the clouds are thick. Even when you cannot see me. I am always whole, and always there, and always watching over you. That is what I am.* She was quiet again. *But now there is a piece of me missing. And I am not always whole. And so I am not always there. And so I am not what I was.*

The girl looked at the box under her bed. At the little cord with the thread of silver light in it.

And she understood.

\* \* \*

She took out the cord. She held it up. And she began to untie it.

It was harder than tying it had been. Much harder. The knot did not want to come undone. It had caught the moonlight, and it wanted to hold on to it, the way all her knots held on to things. Her fingers bled again. She wept. But she did not stop.

And just before dawn, just as the moon was setting, the knot came loose. And the thread of silver light slipped out of the cord, and floated up, out the little window under the eaves, into the sky.

And the moon was whole again.

\* \* \*

*Thank you*, said the moon. *Very softly. From very far away. That was very brave. And very kind. Most people would have kept it.*

"I wanted to keep it," said the girl. She was crying. "I wanted to keep it more than anything."

*I know*, said the moon. *That is why it was brave.*

And then, just before she set, she said one more thing.

*Because you gave it back, I will give you something. Not a piece of me. You cannot hold a piece of me. But a promise. The light in the little room grew very soft. Whenever you are lost, look up. And I will be there. Whole. Always. Watching. And you will know the way home.*

And the moon set. And the girl sat in her little bed under the eaves, with the empty cord in her hands, and watched the sun come up over the sea.

\* \* \*

Bast was quiet for a long time, at the window slit. I lay on my pallet in the dark and did not say anything.

*That's the end,* he said at last. *That's the whole story. My mother told it to me every night, for a year. Before she left.*

*Then the Thief came,* I said. I did not know why I said it. It came up out of the hole in my chest from somewhere very far down. *And stole the moon. And she was never whole again.*

The window slit was very quiet.

Yes, said Bast at last. His voice was very strange. *Yes. That's the other half. The half my mother never told.* He was quiet for a moment. *How did you know?*

*I don't know.*

*You know,* said Bast softly. *Somewhere. You know everything. You just can't reach it.* He was quiet for a long time. *That's why I told you the story, Reshi. The girl who tied the moon. And gave it back.*

*Why?*

Bast did not answer for so long that I thought he had gone. Then, very softly, through the slit in the stone:

*Because someone tied you. And someday, she's going to have to give you back.*

\* \* \*

I did not understand. I lay on my pallet in the grey dark of my cell and held my left wrist in my right hand and ran my fingers over the knots, and I did not understand anything.

But I remembered the story. Every word of it. And years later, at the top of the stairs of an inn at a crossroads, kneeling in front of an open chest with a cord of dark hair in my hands, I remembered it again.

I remembered the girl, weeping, untying the knot. I remembered the thread of silver light, floating up out of the cord.

And I thought: *she gave it back.*

Not the girl in the story. The other one. The one who tied me. She had taken my name out of the air in a chamber beneath an old house, and held it, and kept it safe for seven years. And then, when it was time, she had sent a tinker down the road with a single knot. The one that would let it go.

She wanted to keep it. I know she did. More than anything.

That is why it was brave.

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty

# The Nightingale

I did not see Denna during those months in the Tower of Thorns. I did not know, then, where she was, or what they had done with her, or whether she was alive at all. I did not know enough to wonder. I only knew that sometimes, in the grey, I would reach for something beside me that was not there, and my hand would close on empty air, and the cord on my wrist would hum.

I learned the rest later. Much later. From Lady Tamsin, and from Bast, and from Denna herself, on a night I will tell you about in its place. I will tell it to you now, the way it was told to me, because it belongs here, in the middle of the grey. It is one of the few bright things in it.

\* \* \*

They did not put her in a cell. The duke was too clever for that. The king's nightingale, the most famous singer in Vintas, the girl whose voice had made the lords of three kingdoms weep—you do not throw such a person into a dungeon. People would talk. People would ask questions.

So they gave her rooms. A pleasant suite on the second floor of the palace, overlooking the gardens, with a canopied bed and a marble hearth and a harp in the corner. They gave her a maid, and fine dresses, and good food. They treated her as an honored guest.

And they locked the door.

The duke came to see her on the second day. He sat in a chair by her hearth, heavy and grey in his mourning black, and he looked at her for a long time.

"You were close to my son," he said.

"I sang for him."

"You were more than a singer to him. He told me. He said you were the only one who understood him." The duke's heavy face was very still. "He loved you, I think. In his way."

Denna did not answer.

"I need you to do something for me," said the duke. "For him. For his memory."

"What?"

"There will be a trial. For the Ruh. The one who killed him." The duke's voice was quiet. "The lords will want to hear what happened in that cellar. They'll want witnesses. And there are very few of them left who aren't dead or fled." He looked at her. "You were there. You saw it all. You'll testify."

"I'll tell them the truth," said Denna.

"You'll tell them," said the duke, "that the Ruh murdered my son. In cold blood. Without cause. That my son was standing at that door trying to protect the kingdom from some monstrous thing the Ruh meant to let loose. And that the Ruh struck him down from behind, like the coward he is."

Denna looked at him for a long time.

"No," she said.

The duke's face did not change.

"No?"

"That isn't what happened." Her voice was steady. "Your son had a knife at a woman's throat. He was trying to open the door, not guard it. He was going to kill her. Kvothe stopped him." She paused. "I'm sorry for your loss, your grace. I truly am. But I won't lie for you."

The duke stood up. He looked down at her.

"You will," he said quietly. "Or you'll hang beside him."

He left. The door locked behind him.

\* \* \*

He came back the next day. And the next. And the next. Every day for a span. Sometimes he was gentle, and talked about his son, and wept. Sometimes he was cold, and talked about the gallows, and the crows. Sometimes he brought gifts: jewels, silks, a golden harp. Sometimes he brought guards, who stood in the doorway with their hands on their swords.

Denna gave him the same answer every day.

No.

"I've spent my whole life lying," she told me, long afterward. "About who I was. Where I came from. What I wanted. I changed my name every time I changed towns. I said whatever people wanted to hear. I was so good at it." She was quiet for a moment. "And then I stood in that cellar and watched you pull your own name out of your chest and hand it to me. And I thought, I'm never going to lie again. Not about the important things. Not ever."

"Even to save your life?"

She looked at me.

"Especially then," she said.

\* \* \*

At the end of the span, the duke tried something else.

He had a feast. A great feast, in the great hall of the palace, for all the lords who had stayed loyal to him. Hundreds of them, with their wives and their sons and their retainers. A feast of mourning, he called it, for his son, the murdered king. There would be food and wine and speeches, and at the end of it, there would be music.

And the king's nightingale would sing.

He sent her a dress for it. Black silk, very fine, embroidered with silver thread. He sent her a message with it, written in his own heavy hand.

*You will sing the song. Your song. The one about Lanre, the wronged hero. My son loved it. You will sing it in his memory. And when you are done, you will stand before the lords and tell them how*

he died.

*You will tell them my version.*

*Or I will have the Ruh hanged in the morning, without a trial, and you will watch.*

\* \* \*

She came to the feast in the black silk dress. She walked into the great hall with her harp in her arms and her head held high, and every lord and lady in the room turned to look at her. She was very beautiful. She was always very beautiful. But Lady Tamsin, who was there, told me that she had never seen her look like she looked that night.

"Like a sword," said Lady Tamsin. "Like someone had taken all the soft parts out of her, and left only the edge."

The duke sat at the high table, in a great carved chair draped in black. He watched her walk the length of the hall. He watched her sit on the stool that had been placed for her before the high table. He watched her set her harp in her lap and lay her fingers on the strings.

"Sing," he said. "For my son."

Denna looked up at him.

"I will," she said. "But not the song you want."

\* \* \*

She sang *Tariniel*.

Not my version. Not exactly. She had never heard all of mine; she had been in the balcony of the Eolian that night, listening, but she had heard it only once, and much of it she had not understood. She had heard pieces. Fragments. The white city, and the fountains. Lyra's name, in a voice that did not lie. Selitos weeping among the ruins.

And the child. The boy under the slab of white marble, asking to be a singer.

She took those pieces. And she took the Yllish cords she had studied for years, the old ones, the ones Bredon had given her to read so that she could write his false song. She had read them all. She knew the old story better than almost anyone alive, because she had spent years learning it so that she could twist it.



And she untwisted it.

She stood in the great hall of the palace of Renere, before the duke and all his lords, and she sang the true song. Her version. Pieced together from my fragments and her cords and her own understanding. It was not the same as mine. It was different, in a hundred small ways. But it was true.

"It was the most beautiful thing I have ever heard," Lady Tamsin told me. "And I heard yours, you know. At the Eolian. I was in the second balcony." She shook her head. "Hers was different. Yours was a bell ringing. Hers was a knife. It cut. It went right through you and left you bleeding."

The hall was silent while she sang. Utterly silent. Not a cough, not a whisper, not a clink of a cup. Hundreds of lords and ladies sat frozen in their seats, and listened.

The duke did not stop her. Lady Tamsin said he tried. He half rose from his carved chair, with his face going red and then white, and opened his mouth to shout. But he did not. He stood there, half risen, with his mouth open. And then, slowly, he sat back down.

And he listened too.

\* \* \*

She sang all of it. The white city, and Lanre, and Lyra. The Thief's whisper in the dark. The fall of Myr Tariniel. The curse, and Selitos weeping, and the child in the fountain.

And then she sang something that was not in my version. Something that was hers alone.

She sang the door.

She sang a door of grey stone, beneath an old house on a ridge. She sang a young king, standing before it, with a box around his neck and a knife in his hand. A young king who had been told all his life that he was special, and had believed it, and had been used because of it. Who had been taught to love an old man with a walking stick, and to trust him, and to do what he said. Who had stood before that door with a woman's blood on his hands, and been so afraid, and so proud, and so lost, that he did not know what he was doing anymore.

She sang him with love. That was what Lady Tamsin said, afterward. She sang Ambrose Jakis with love. Not the love of a woman for a man. The love of a singer for a story. For a sad story, about a boy who was broken by someone older and cleverer and colder than he could ever understand.

And then she sang a red-haired man, stepping forward with a sword. And the young king falling. And his last words.

*He said I was special.*

The duke was weeping. Openly, at the high table, in front of all his lords. His heavy grey face was wet, and his shoulders were shaking, and he did not hide it.

And Denna sang the last verse. A red-haired man, standing at the open door, with the key in his hand. Pulling his own name out of his chest, strand by strand, and letting it go. So that the door would close. So that the thing behind it could never come out.

So that no one else would have to die.

\* \* \*

When she finished, no one moved.

The hall was silent. Hundreds of people sat in their seats with their faces wet and their hands still, and no one moved, and no one spoke. The candles burned. The fire crackled in the great hearth.

Denna stood up. She set down her harp. She looked at the duke, weeping at his high table.

"That's what happened, your grace," she said. Her voice was very quiet, but it carried to every corner of the hall. "That's how your son died. That's the truth." She paused. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. But I won't tell you a lie."

The duke looked at her for a long time. His face was grey and wet and ruined.

Then he stood up. He walked down from the high table, slowly, heavily, the way an old man walks. He walked the length of the hall, through the silent crowd of lords and ladies, to where Denna stood beside her harp.

He stopped in front of her.

Lady Tamsin said that everyone in the hall held their breath. That they all thought he would strike her. Or call the guards. Or draw his sword and kill her where she stood.

He did not.

He looked down at her for a long time. And then he said, very quietly, so quietly that only the people nearest could hear:

"He loved that song. Your other one. The false one. He used to ask you to sing it every night." He was silent for a moment. "I think he knew it wasn't true. I think that's why he loved it. Because it made a monster into a hero. And he wanted so badly to believe that could happen."

Denna did not answer.

The duke looked at her a moment longer. Then he turned and walked out of the hall. Alone. Without a word to anyone.

He did not come back to the feast. He did not come back to Denna's rooms either, the next day, or the day after. He did not threaten her again.

But he did not let her go.

\* \* \*

"Why did you do it?" I asked her, long afterward. "You knew he could have killed you. He could have killed both of us."

We were sitting together by a fire, somewhere far from Renere, on a night I will tell you about when I come to it. She was holding my hand. My left hand, with the cord around its wrist.

"Because it was true," she said simply.

"That's not a reason."

"It's the only reason." She looked into the fire. "I spent three years writing a lie. The most beautiful lie I could make. And people wept at it. Lords and ladies and kings. They wept, and they believed it, and every time they did, the world got a little bit worse." She was quiet for a moment. "I owed the truth something. After that. I owed it a song."

"And the part about Ambrose? Singing him with love?"

Denna was quiet for a long time.

"He wasn't a monster," she said at last. "He was cruel, and vain, and stupid, and he did terrible things. But he wasn't a monster. He was a boy who was used. Like me. Like you." She looked at me. "Bredon used all of us. He found the broken places in us and put his fingers in them and pulled. And some of us broke worse than others." She squeezed my hand. "I could have been Ambrose. If I'd been born to a duke instead of a ditch. If Bredon had found me later, when I was prouder, instead of earlier, when I was desperate. I could have been standing at that door with a knife."

"But you weren't."

"No." She looked at me. "Because of you. Because you sang. Because you loosened the knot. Because you gave me a choice." Her eyes were wet. "He never had anyone to do that for him. No one ever gave Ambrose a choice. So I thought—someone should sing him. At least once. The way he really was. Not a hero. Not a monster. Just a boy who got lost."

I did not say anything. I held her hand, and looked into the fire.

"It didn't matter, in the end," she said. "The song. The duke didn't let me go. The trial still happened. You still hanged." She smiled faintly. "Well. Sort of."

"It mattered," I said.

"How?"

I thought about it.

"Because you sang it true," I said at last. "And somewhere, a long way off, a one-eyed man in a round tower heard it. And for one night, he didn't have to be the only one who remembered."

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-One

# **The Field of Three Rivers**

The war came to Renere in the spring.

I did not see it. I was in the Tower of Thorns, in my grey cell, with my grey bread and my grey water and the grey knife of light that came in at midday through the slit of a window. I did not see the armies. I did not see the banners, or the cavalry charges, or the smoke. I did not hear the drums or the trumpets or the screams.

But I heard Bast tell it. Every night, pressed into the window slit, with his deep blue eyes glinting in the dark. He told it to me the way a Ruh tells a story around a fire. With all the parts in their places. With the brave parts and the terrible parts and the parts that make you laugh when you should not.

I will tell it to you the way he told it to me. It is not my story. But it is part of mine.

\* \* \*

The Maer came north with the spring rains.

He had spent the winter in the southern hills, gathering. Lord by lord, town by town, sword by sword. The lords who had never trusted Duke Jakis. The lords who had loved old King Roderic. The lords who had heard the rumors about the four dead heirs and the old man with the stick, and did not like what they heard. And the ones who simply wanted to be on the winning side, and had begun to suspect that the winning side might not be the one in Renere.

By the time the snows melted, he had an army. Not as large as the duke's. Four thousand to the duke's seven. But it was a different kind of army.

"It had the Adem," said Bast. "Twenty of them, now. More came, over the winter, from Haert. Vashet sent for them. They say Shehyn sent every sword she could spare." He laughed softly. "Twenty Adem. The duke's men were terrified of them. They'd heard stories. About what happened in the cellar. About Cinder's face."

"And the others?"

"Your friends." Bast's voice softened. "Wil has the arcanists. Thirty of them, from the University and from Imre and from the lords' households. Not very good ones, most of them. But he's taught them things. Things they don't teach at the University. How to make fire jump from one field to another. How to break a bridge with sympathy. How to make a man's sword so heavy he can't lift it." He paused. "He's very good at it. Better than he knew. He says his hands can't do fine work anymore, so he's had to learn to do big work instead."

"And Devi?"

"Devi has a wagon." Bast's eyes glinted with amusement. "A whole wagon, full of Surprises. Big ones. Little ones. Ones that make smoke and ones that make fire and ones that make a noise so loud it knocks men off their horses. The Maer's captains won't go near it. They call it the Devil's Cart."

"And Sim?"

Bast was quiet for a moment.

"Sim writes songs," he said. "About the war. About the men who die in it. He sings them at the fires at night, in the camp, and the soldiers cry." He paused. "He wears a patch over his eye. Black. With a white star sewn on it. Devi made it for him. He says it makes him look dashing." A soft laugh. "It doesn't. It makes him look like a very sad pirate. But nobody tells him."

\* \* \*

They met on the Field of Three Rivers, a day's march south of Renere, where the three rivers that meet in the city first come near each other.

It is a wide flat plain, green in the spring, with low hills on either side and the three rivers winding across it like the strands of a braid. It is a good place for a battle. Everyone says so. There have been seven great battles fought there, in the history of Vintas. Eight, now.

The duke came out of Renere with seven thousand men and drew them up on the plain in the old way. Pikes in the center, horse on the wings, archers behind. Black and silver banners snapping in the wind. He had more men. He had more horses. He had the high ground, a low rise at the northern end of the plain.

The Maer came up from the south with four thousand and drew them up facing.

"Everyone thought the duke would win," said Bast. "Even the Maer's own captains. They told him not to fight. They said wait, gather more men, draw the duke out into the hills. But the Maer said no." A pause. "He said his daughter was growing up somewhere without knowing her name. And his wife had gone white-haired in a cellar. And a boy who had saved them both was sitting in a tower in Renere waiting to hang. And he was not going to wait anymore."

\* \* \*

The battle began at dawn.

The duke's pikes advanced first. A great slow wall of steel, rolling down off the low rise toward the Maer's lines. The Maer's men held. They held for an hour, pike against pike, in the center of the plain, and neither side gave ground.

Then the duke's horse charged. Both wings at once, two thousand horsemen in black and silver, thundering around the ends of the Maer's line to take him in the flanks.

And Wil's arcanists broke the rivers.

"I didn't see it," said Bast. "I was on the hill behind. But I heard it. Everyone heard it." His voice was full of wonder. "They'd been bound for days. Wil's people. Bound to the riverbanks. Every stone, every clod of earth, every root. They'd been sitting in the mud for three days, holding their bindings. And when the horse came around the flanks, Wil gave the signal."

"And?"

"And the banks gave way. All at once. Both rivers, on both wings. The ground just fell out from under the horsemen. They went into the water, hundreds of them, horses and men together." Bast was quiet for a moment. "It was terrible. I'm glad I didn't see it. But it broke the charge. Both charges. The duke's horse was gone."

\* \* \*

The duke's pikes were still coming. Still pushing, in the center of the plain. And the Maer's line was bending. Bending back, slowly, under the weight of it.

That was when Devi's cart came out.

"She drove it herself," said Bast, and I could hear the grin in his voice. "The Devil's Cart. Right out in front of the Maer's line, with two mules pulling it and her standing on the seat with her spectacles on and her hair flying. Nobody could stop her. The Maer's captains tried. She drove right past them."

"What did she do?"

"She threw things. Everything in the cart. All of it, one after another, right into the middle of the duke's pikes. White fire and smoke and noise and something that made the ground shake." He laughed. "The pikemen broke. They'd never seen anything like it. They thought the sky was falling. They threw down their pikes and ran."

"And Devi?"

"Devi's fine. She lost her eyebrows. She's very upset about it." Bast's voice softened. "The soldiers carried her on their shoulders, afterward. All around the camp. She pretended to hate it. She didn't."

\* \* \*

The Adem went in after that. Into the gap, where the duke's pikes had broken. Twenty of them, in their blood-red clothes, moving like a single thing. Like a knife.

"I've never seen anything like it," said Bast. "I don't think anyone has. They didn't fight the way soldiers fight. They didn't shout, or charge, or form lines. They just—*went*. Into the duke's army. Through



it. The way water goes through a sieve." His voice was very quiet. "Vashet was at the front. She was looking for someone."

"Who?"

"Cinder."

I went very still.

"Was he there?"

"No." Bast's voice was even quieter. "She looked all day. Through the whole battle. She didn't find him." A pause. "I don't think he's anywhere anymore. Not anywhere near. I think he ran. After the cellar. After what she did to his face." Another pause. "I think he's hiding. Somewhere very far away. Waiting for it to heal."

"Does it? Heal?"

"I don't know," said Bast. "Things like him—I don't know how they work. Maybe it heals in a day. Maybe it never heals." He was quiet. "I hope it never heals."

\* \* \*

The duke died at noon.

Not in battle. Not by a sword, or an arrow, or an Adem's hand. He was sitting on his black horse on the low rise at the northern end of the plain, watching his army break, watching his pikes throw down their weapons and run, watching his banners fall one by one.

And he simply fell off his horse.

"His heart," said Bast. "The physicians said it was his heart. It just stopped. He was a big man, and old, and he'd been grieving all winter." He was quiet for a moment. "They found him lying in the grass on the rise, on his back, with his eyes open. Looking at the sky."

I did not say anything. I sat in the grey dark of my cell, and I thought about a heavy grey man kneeling on the stones of a courtyard with his hand on his son's chest. His shoulders shaking.

I did not know him. I did not know why I felt what I felt.

But I felt it.

\* \* \*

"When the duke fell, it was over," said Bast. "His lords surrendered. His men threw down their weapons. The Maer rode up onto the low rise where the duke had been, and he got off his horse and knelt beside the duke's body, and closed his eyes." A pause. "He said something. I was close enough to hear."

"What?"

"He said, *I'm sorry. We were both fools. But you lost your son, and I only lost my city.*" Bast's voice was very quiet. "And then he stood up, and he turned to face his army, and they cheered him. Four thousand of them. On the Field of Three Rivers. They cheered him until the hills rang."

"And then?"

"And then he rode to Renere," said Bast. "And they opened the gates for him."

\* \* \*

Bast came to the window the next night, and the night after, and the night after that. And every night he had more to tell.

The Maer had entered Renere. The city had opened its gates without a fight; the duke's garrison had fled in the night when word of the battle came. The people had lined the streets to see him pass. Some of them had cheered. Some of them had thrown flowers. Most of them had only watched, silent and wary, the way people watch a storm passing on the horizon.

The Maer had gone to the palace. He had gone to the great hall, where the throne of Vintas sat on its dais beneath the black and silver banners of the house of Jakis. He had had the banners taken down. He had not sat on the throne.

The lords had come to him. All of them. The ones who had fought for him and the ones who had fought against him. They had knelt before him in the great hall and offered him the crown.

"And he said no," said Bast. "He refused it. In front of all of them."

"Why?"

"He said he wasn't worthy. He said he'd brought war to the kingdom, and death, and burned cities. He said he'd let a man like Bredon live in his house for eleven years and never seen him for what he was. He said he'd sent a boy to Renere to do what he should have done himself, and the boy had been blamed for it, and was sitting in the Tower of Thorns waiting to hang." Bast paused. "He said a man like that shouldn't be king."

"And the lords?"

"They offered it again. The next day. And he refused again." Bast's voice was full of wonder. "And the third day, they came again. All of them. And they knelt, and they offered it a third time. And one of them—an old one, very old, from the east—stood up and said, *Your grace, there is no one else. There is no heir. There is no one else the kingdom will follow. If you refuse, there will be war again. And again. And again. Until there is nothing left.*"

"And?"

"And the Maer was quiet for a long time," said Bast. "And then he said yes. On one condition."

"What condition?"

"That he be allowed to do penance," said Bast. "Before he was crowned. For the war. For the dead. For everything. He said he would walk from the gates of the city to the doors of the cathedral, barefoot, in a shirt of sackcloth, with ashes on his head. In front of everyone. So that they would all see. So that they would all know that he knew what he had done."

\* \* \*

He did it. On a grey morning at the end of spring, the Maer of Severen walked barefoot through the streets of Renere in a shirt of rough brown sackcloth, with grey ashes smeared on his forehead and in his hair. From the north gate to the cathedral. Two miles, over cobblestones.

The whole city came out to watch.

"They didn't cheer," said Bast. "Not at first. They didn't know what to do. They'd never seen a king do anything like it. They just stood there and watched him walk." A pause. "His feet were bleeding

by the end. He didn't stop. He didn't look at anyone. He just walked."

"And at the end?"

"At the end, he went into the cathedral, and they crowned him. And he came out on the steps, in the crown, with his feet still bleeding and the ashes still on his head. And he looked out at the crowd." Bast's voice was very soft. "And someone, somewhere in the crowd, called out a name. And then someone else. And then everyone."

"What name?"

"The Penitent King," said Bast.

\* \* \*

I sat in the grey dark of my cell, and I thought about that for a long time after Bast had gone.

The Penitent King. The Maer. Alveron. A man I did not remember, who had walked barefoot through a city in sackcloth and ashes, for a war I did not remember, for the deaths of people I did not remember.

For me.

I did not know him. But I held the cord on my wrist, and I ran my fingers over the knots, and I felt something. Very faint. Like a voice in another room.

It was not a memory. It was not a name.

But it was warm.

\* \* \*

The Penitent King came to see me three days later.

He came alone. No guards, no servants, no courtiers. He came up the long winding stair of the Tower of Thorns by himself, in plain grey clothes, with a crown on his head and bandages on his feet. He stood at the grate in my door and looked in at me for a long time.

I was sitting on my pallet, with my back against the wall and my knees drawn up. I looked back at him.

He was older than I had expected. Hollow-cheeked and grey-haired, with deep lines around his eyes and mouth. He did not look like a king. He looked like a man who had been very ill for a long

time, and had only just begun to recover.

"Kvothe," he said.

I did not answer. The name meant nothing to me.

"Do you know who I am?"

"The Penitent King."

Something moved in his face. It might have been pain. "Yes," he said. "I suppose I am, now." He was quiet for a moment. "Before that, I was the Maer of Severen. And before that, I was a sick old man in a palace on a cliff, being poisoned by his own physician. And a red-haired boy came, and saved my life."

I looked at him. I did not remember.

"You don't remember," he said.

"No."

"Meluan said you wouldn't." He was quiet. "She said something happened to you in the cellar. Something with your name. She said you gave it away, to close the door."

"Yes."

"Why?"

I looked at him. At his hollow face and his grey hair and the crown on his head. I tried to think of an answer. There was nothing in me to think with.

"Because it was the right thing," I said. "I don't remember why. But I know it was."

The Penitent King looked at me for a very long time.

Then he put his hand on the bars of the grate. His knuckles were white.

"They want you dead," he said quietly. "The lords. All of them. Even the ones who fought for me. They don't care that you saved my wife. They don't care that you closed the door. They don't even believe in the door, most of them." His voice was very low. "They only care that you killed a king. A king of Vintas. With your own hand. And if a Ruh can kill a king and live, then no king is safe."

I did not say anything.

"They'll try you," he said. "And they'll find you guilty. And they'll want you hanged. And I—" He stopped. His hand tightened on the bars. "I'm the king now. I can pardon you. I have that power. But if I do, they'll rise against me. All of them. And there'll be war again. And again. And again. Until there's nothing left."

"Then don't pardon me."

He stared at me.

"Don't pardon me," I said again. My voice was flat. "Let them hang me. It doesn't matter."

"It matters to me."

"Why?"

He looked at me for a long moment. And then something in his face broke, just for a moment. Like ice cracking on a pond.

"Because you're family," said the Penitent King. "And I do not abandon family."

He took his hand from the bars. He stood very straight.

"I'll find a way," he said. "I don't know how. But I'll find a way."

And he turned and went back down the long winding stair, alone, on his bandaged feet.

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Two

# The Queen in the Tower

She came to see me nine days before my trial, with snow-white hair and a lock of a baby's hair folded in a square of blue silk.

I did not know her. I was sitting on my pallet in the grey, with my back against the wall, when the iron door of my cell opened. Not the grate. The door itself. It swung back on its hinges with a great groaning of iron, and the guards stood aside, and a woman came in.

She was thin. Very thin, and very pale, in a plain grey gown with a white thread down the breast, like the Penitent King's. She walked slowly, with a cane, and a small precise man in grey walked at her elbow, ready to catch her. Her face was lined, the face of a woman twenty years older than she was. Her hair was white. Not grey. White, like snow, like bone, like the frost on the inside of my cell walls in winter.

She stood just inside the door and looked at me.

I looked back. I did not know her.

"Leave us, Stapes," she said.

The small precise man hesitated. "Your Majesty—"

"Leave us." Her voice was quiet and very firm. "And close the door. He will not hurt me."

Stapes looked at me for a long moment. Then he bowed and went out, and the door groaned closed behind him, and we were alone.

\* \* \*

She did not sit. There was nowhere to sit, except the pallet, and the floor. She stood in the middle of my small grey cell, leaning on her cane, and looked at me for a long time.

"You don't know me," she said.

"No."

"Meluan," she said. "I am your mother's sister. Your aunt." She was quiet for a moment. "I was in the chamber. At the door. You saved my life."

I looked at her white hair. At the thin pale line across her throat, just visible above the collar of her gown.

"I'm sorry," I said. "I don't remember."

"I know." She came a little closer. "Alveron told me. And the girl. Denna. She told me what you did. With your name." Meluan was quiet for a moment. "I didn't believe her, at first. I thought it was a story. Something to make me feel better about—" She stopped. "About everything."

"It's true."

"Yes. I can see it now." She looked at me. "There's nothing behind your eyes. Nothing at all. It's like looking into an empty house." Her voice cracked, very slightly. "Your mother had the most alive eyes of anyone I ever knew."

\* \* \*

She lowered herself, slowly and painfully, onto the edge of my pallet. Not beside me. At the far end. As if she were afraid to come too close.

"I came to tell you some things," she said. "Before the trial. Before—whatever happens." She looked down at her hands. "Things about her. Your mother. I thought—" She hesitated. "Denna said you gave your name away. All of it. Everything that made you you. And I thought, perhaps, if you had nothing of your own, you might like to have something of hers."

I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.

Meluan took that for yes.

\* \* \*



She told me about Netalia.

Not the Netalia of the blue book, the black mark where a name should have been. Not the Netalia of the Maer's court, the scandal, the girl who ran away with a tinker. The other one. The sister.

She told me that Netalia had been born in the spring, in a thunderstorm, and that their mother had said it was a sign she would be loud. She told me that Netalia had been loud. That she had sung before she could talk, and talked before she could walk, and never stopped doing either. That she had climbed every tree on the Lackless estate by the time she was seven, and fallen out of most of them, and broken her arm twice.

She told me that Netalia had taught her to read. When Meluan was five and Netalia was eight, in the window seat of the library, with a book of old ballads, sounding out the words one by one with her finger under each.

She told me that Netalia had been afraid of the dark. Terribly afraid. That she had slept with a candle burning every night until she was fourteen, and that when their father forbade it, saying it was a waste of good wax, she had crept into Meluan's bed instead, every night, and held her hand until she fell asleep.

"She said there was something in the house," said Meluan quietly. "Under it. Something that breathed. She said she could hear it at night, through the floor." She looked at her hands. "I never heard it. I thought she was being silly. Making up stories, the way she always did."

She was quiet for a long time.

"I understand now," she said. "After the chamber. After the door." She looked at me. "She wasn't making it up. She heard it. Every night. For fourteen years. And no one believed her."

\* \* \*

"Why did she leave?" I said.

It was the first question I had asked. Meluan looked at me, startled.

"You asked," she said softly. "You haven't asked anything. Stapes said. Not in all these months."

I did not know why I had asked. It had come up out of the hole in my chest without my deciding. But now that it was said, I wanted the answer. Or something in me did.

"Why did she leave?" I said again.

Meluan was quiet for a long time.

"There was an old man," she said at last. "When we were girls. A friend of our father's. He came to the house every few months, to play tak with Father and tell stories by the fire. We loved him. Both of us. He was so kind. He brought us sweets, and books, and once a little silver bird that sang when you wound it."

I sat very still.

"He was kind to both of us," said Meluan. "But he talked to Netalia more. He sat with her in the library, and told her stories about the old days, and the old families, and the old secrets. And she asked him questions. So many questions. About the box, and the rhyme, and the thing she heard breathing under the house." Meluan's voice was very quiet. "And he answered some of them. Not all. Just enough. Just enough to make her want to know more."

"And then?"

"And then, the summer she was seventeen, he came to the house, and he sat with her in the library for a whole afternoon. With the door closed. And when she came out, she was white as a sheet." Meluan looked at me. "She wouldn't tell me what he'd said. She wouldn't tell anyone. She went to her room and locked the door and didn't come out for two days."

"And on the third day?"

"On the third day, a troupe of players came through the village below the house. Ruh. With painted wagons. And there was a red-haired man with them, who sang." Meluan closed her eyes. "And on the fourth day, she was gone."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long time.

"She ran from him," I said at last. "The old man. Not to my father. From the old man."

Meluan opened her eyes and looked at me.

"I think she ran from both," she said softly. "From him, and from the house, and from the thing under it. From everything she'd learned in that library." She was quiet for a moment. "And to your father. Both at once. People can run from and to at the same time, you know. I didn't understand that, when I was fourteen. I thought she was only running to him. To some tinker. And I hated her for it."

"And now?"

"And now I've stood in front of the door," said Meluan. "With my hand on it. And felt it drink me." She touched her white hair. "And I understand why anyone would run."

\* \* \*

She stood up to go, after a while. Slowly, painfully, leaning on her cane. She stood in the middle of my grey cell and looked down at me.

"I brought you something," she said.

She reached into the sleeve of her gown and took out a small square of blue silk, folded very carefully. She held it out to me.

I took it. I unfolded it.

Inside, there was a lock of hair. Very fine. Very soft. Dark, with the faintest hint of a curl. Tied with a single thread of white.

"Your cousin's," said Meluan. "My daughter. The Ruh have her now. Tessit's wife cut it for me, before they left. So I would have something." She was quiet for a moment. "I have another. I wanted you to have this one."

I looked at the lock of dark hair in my palm.

And the cord on my wrist hummed.

It was very faint. Barely there. But I felt it. The way a string hums when another string nearby is plucked. As if something in the cord recognized something in the hair. As if there were a thread running between them, very thin, very old.

Meluan saw my face change. I do not know what it did. But she saw it, and her own face went very still.

"You felt that," she whispered.

"Yes."

"What was it?"

I looked down at the lock of hair.

"Family," I said. I did not know how I knew the word. But it was the right one.

Meluan made a sound. A small sound. Half a laugh and half a sob. She put her hand over her mouth.

Then she turned and went to the door, and knocked on it with her cane, and it groaned open, and Stapes was there. She leaned on his arm. She did not look back.

But at the door, she stopped.

"Her name is Lark," she said, without turning around. "Among the Ruh. They call her Lark." She was quiet for a moment. "After your mother. After the way she sang."

Then she was gone.

\* \* \*

I kept the lock of hair. I kept it through the trial, and the hanging that was not mine, and the long road west in the back of a cart. I kept it through a winter with the Ruh, when I held the child it came from in my lap and watched her take her first steps.

I gave it back to her, in the end. To Lark. On a ridge above a valley in the western hills, in the spring, when she reached out one small hand and touched my face and said *again*.

I tied it into her hair myself, with the white thread, while Mirra watched. I did not know why. I only knew that it was hers, and it should go home.

Knots are very good at finding their way home.

Someone told me that once. I did not remember who. But it was true.

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Three

# **The King in the Tower**

The king came to see me four nights before my trial.

I did not know he was the king. I want to be clear about that. I did not know anything, in the Tower of Thorns. I did not know that the war was over, or that the Maer had won, or that he had been offered the crown three times and taken it on the third. I did not know that he had put on grey, and a single white thread, and called himself the Penitent King. I did not know that there was a Penitent King.

I only knew that late one night, long after the guards had changed, the iron door of my cell opened, and two men came in with a lamp.

\* \* \*

The first was tall and grey and very straight, with his hands folded in front of him. He set the lamp on the floor just inside the door and stood beside it, and did not speak, and did not look at me. He looked at the wall above my head. I learned later that his name was Stapes, and that he had not been inside a prison cell in thirty-one years of service, and that he did not look at me because he could not bear to.

The second was thin and pale and hollow-eyed, in a plain grey coat with a single white thread running down the breast. He was not old. But he moved like an old man. Slowly, carefully, as if every part of him hurt. He stood in the middle of my cell and looked at me for a long time.

I looked back. I was sitting on my pallet with my back against the wall. I did not get up. I did not know that I should.

"Kvothe," he said.

I did not answer. I did not know, then, that it was my name. I only knew that people said it, sometimes, when they looked at me.

\* \* \*

He sat down on the floor. That is what I remember most clearly, of that night. The king of Vintas, in his grey coat, sat down on the stone floor of a cell in the Tower of Thorns, among the straw and the dust and the mouse droppings, with his back against the opposite wall. So that his face was level with mine.

Stapes made a small sound. The king did not look at him.

"Leave us," he said. "Please."

Stapes hesitated. Then he bowed, very stiffly, and stepped outside the door. He did not close it. I could see his shadow on the stones of the passage, very straight, not moving.

The king looked at me.

"You do not remember me," he said.

"No."

"No." He was quiet for a moment. "Tamsin told me. And the queen. And the Fae boy, the one who comes to the window. They all told me. But I wanted to see for myself." He looked at my face. "I wanted to see what I had done."

\* \* \*

I did not understand. I sat on my pallet with my hands in my lap and looked at him.

"I sent you to Renere," he said. "The first time. To find out what was killing the old king. You found it. You found the knots in his hair, and the woman who tied them, and the man who taught her. And for that, you were accused of murder. And you fled." He looked at his hands. "And I let you. I let you flee. I did not speak for you. It was not convenient."

The lamp on the floor flickered. Stapes's shadow did not move.

"And then you came back," said the king. "To me. In the hills. When I had lost my city and my wife and everything I had. You came

back with the Adem and the Ruh and your friends from the University, and you walked into the king's camp, and you brought me my daughter. And then you went to the door, and you brought me my wife." His voice was very quiet. "And you killed a king. For me. For all of us. To close a door that I did not even know was there."

He looked at me.

"And now I am going to try you," he said. "For that. For the murder of a king. In four days. In the great hall, before all the lords of Vintas. And I am going to find you guilty. And I am going to sentence you to hang."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything. I did not feel anything. I looked at the thin pale man sitting on the floor of my cell, and I waited for whatever came next.

"You should hate me," said the king. "You should be screaming. You should be cursing my name." He was watching my face. "I think I came here hoping you would. I think I wanted you to. So that I would have something to set against it. So that I could say, *he hates me, and he is right to, and I will carry it.*"

He was quiet for a long time.

"But you do not hate me," he said. "You cannot. You do not remember enough to hate anyone." His voice broke, very slightly. "And that is worse. That is so much worse."

\* \* \*

"Why?" I said.

It was the only question I had. It was not a very good one. But the king looked at me as if I had asked something important.

"Why must I try you?" he said.

I did not know if that was what I had meant. But I nodded.

The king closed his eyes.

"Because the lords would not follow me otherwise," he said. "Because I took the crown on one condition, and that condition was that there would be justice. For everyone. For the lords who fought

against me, and the ones who fought for me. For the peasants whose fields were burned and the merchants whose shops were looted. For the old king, poisoned in his bed. For the young king, killed in a cellar." He opened his eyes. "If I pardon the man who killed a king, because he was my friend, because he did it for me, then there is no justice. There is only a new king, doing what kings have always done. Protecting his own." He looked at me. "And the war begins again. And more cities burn."

"All right," I said.

The king stared at me.

"All right," he repeated. "You say *all right*." He laughed. It was a terrible sound, dry and cracked, with no humor in it at all. "I tell you I am going to hang you, for saving my wife and my daughter and my kingdom, and you say *all right*."

"Yes."

He put his face in his hands.

\* \* \*

He stayed a long time. He did not say much more. He sat on the floor of my cell with his face in his hands, and his shoulders shook, a little, and then were still. Outside the door, Stapes's shadow did not move.

After a while, he took his hands away from his face. His eyes were red. He reached into his grey coat and took out something small and set it on the floor between us.

It was a tak stone. White. Smooth and round and worn, the way river stones are worn.

"This was in your pocket," he said. "When they brought you out of the Lackless house. The guards took it, with your other things. I had it brought to me." He looked at it. "I do not know where you got it. But I know the man who plays white, in the small garden in Severen. I know how he opens. The corner. Always the corner." He was quiet. "I think you must have taken it from his board. On the night you learned what he was."

I looked at the stone. It meant nothing to me.



"Keep it," said the king. "It is yours. Whatever it means." He stood up, slowly, stiffly, like an old man. "I cannot give you back your name. I cannot give you back your freedom, or your friends, or your life. I cannot give you anything but a trial and a rope." He looked down at me. "But I can give you this. A stone you took from the most dangerous man in the world. To remind you, if you ever remember anything, that you beat him."

He picked up the lamp.

"I am sorry," he said. "I know it means nothing. I know you cannot hear it. I am saying it anyway. So that it has been said."

And he went out, and Stapes closed the door behind him, and I heard the lock turn, and their footsteps going away down the long black spiral of the stair.

\* \* \*

I kept the stone. I held it in my hand for the rest of that night, and the next day, and the day after that. I did not know why. I did not know what it was. But my fingers kept closing around it, the way they kept closing around the knots on my wrist.

It was in my hand when they came for me, on the morning of my trial. It was in my hand when I stood in the great hall, before all the lords of Vintas, and the Penitent King asked me if I had anything to say, and I said *no*.

And it was in my hand, three days after that, when they took me out of the Tower of Thorns in the dark before dawn, by a way I did not know, while a dead man with red hair walked up the steps of the gallows in my place.

\* \* \*

"Do you still have it?" said Chronicler.

The innkeeper reached into his apron pocket. He took out a small white stone, smooth and round and worn, and set it on the table between them, beside the little wooden wheel and the knot.

"It's been in my pocket for seven years," he said. "Every day. Behind the bar. I never knew what it was. I never took it out and

looked at it. My hand just went to it, sometimes, when things were bad." He turned it over with one finger. "And tonight, telling you about the Tower, I took it out. For the first time. And I held it." He was quiet for a moment. "And I was in the garden with the black pool. In Severen. On the night he told me what he was. With the board between us and the old man smiling at me across it."

"Bredon."

"Bredon." The innkeeper was quiet for a moment. "He opened in the corner, the way he always did. And we played while he talked. And when he had finished telling me what he was, and what he wanted, he stood up and took his stick." He turned the stone over with one finger. "And I reached across the board and took his first stone. The corner stone. I don't know why. I think I wanted to take *something* from him. And he saw me do it."

"What did he do?"

"He smiled," said the innkeeper. "And said, *Keep it, my boy. You'll want something to remember the game by.* And walked away down the garden path." He put the stone back in his pocket. "I didn't see him again until the door."

He picked up his cup.

"The Maer knew," he said. "When he gave it back to me. He knew what it meant. He'd played Bredon himself, for eleven years. He'd lost every game." He was quiet. "He wanted me to remember that I'd won one. Even if it cost me everything. Even if it was the only one." He looked at the fire. "It was the kindest thing anyone did for me, in the Tower. And I didn't even know it was kindness."

## Interlude: A Knock

Someone was pounding on the door of the Waystone Inn.

Chronicler nearly dropped his pen. He had been so deep in the story that the sound, when it came, seemed to come from another world. Three heavy blows, loud as hammer strokes, rattling the barred door in its frame. Then three more.

The innkeeper stopped speaking. He did not move. He sat very still at the table with his hands folded around his cold cup of tea.

Bast was on his feet. He had moved so fast Chronicler had not seen him rise. He stood between the table and the door with his hands at his sides and his face white, and his eyes, in the heatless firelight, had gone very dark. Almost black.

"*Kote!*" shouted a voice outside. "*Kote, are you in there? Open up! For God's sake, open up!*"

The innkeeper let out a breath. Something in his shoulders loosened.

"It's Aaron," he said. "The smith's boy." He stood up. "Let him in, Bast."

"Reshi—"

"Let him in. He sounds frightened."

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he went to the door and lifted the heavy bar and pulled it open.

\* \* \*

Aaron stumbled in out of the dark. His face was red with cold and white with fear, and his breath came in great white clouds. He had a

lantern in one hand, and the flame inside it was guttering, very small and very blue.

He saw Chronicler at the table and Bast at the door and the innkeeper standing beside the hearth, and he stopped. He looked around the common room with wide eyes.

"It's cold in here," he said. "It's cold as a tomb. Why's it so cold? You've got the fire going."

"It's cold everywhere tonight," said the innkeeper. His voice was mild. "What's wrong, Aaron?"

Aaron looked at him. His mouth worked for a moment before any words came out.

"Carter's cows," he said. "His whole herd. Eleven of them. In the field by the woods. I went out to help him bring them in, because it's so cold, and they were—" He stopped. He swallowed. "They were frozen, Kote. Standing up. In the middle of the field. Frozen solid, like statues. With frost all over them. And their eyes—" He shuddered. "Their eyes were open."

The common room was silent.

"And there's a light," said Aaron. His voice was shaking. "In the woods. Past Carter's field. A blue light. It's been there all day, Carter says. Just sitting there. Not moving. And the smoke, the smoke that's been hanging over the woods since morning, it's—" He looked at the window. "It's *leaning*. Toward town. Toward here."

Nobody said anything.

"Carter says it's a demon," said Aaron. "He says it's the end of the world. He's got his whole family in the church with the priest, praying. Half the town's there. Graham's there. Old Cob." He looked at the innkeeper. "They sent me to get you. They said you should come. They said it's safer, in the church. With everyone."

\* \* \*

The innkeeper looked at Aaron for a long moment. His face was very calm.

"Thank you, Aaron," he said. "That was very brave, coming out here in the dark to tell me."

"You'll come?"

"No."

Aaron stared at him. "But—"

"I have a guest," said the innkeeper, nodding at Chronicler. "And an inn. I can't leave them." He smiled faintly. "Besides. If it really is the end of the world, I'd rather be here than in a church. I've never been much for churches."

"Kote, you don't understand. Carter's cows—"

"I understand." The innkeeper's voice was very gentle. He came across the room and put his hand on Aaron's shoulder. "Go back to the church, Aaron. Stay with the others. Bar the doors. Keep the fire high, even if it doesn't warm you. And whatever you hear tonight, whatever you see, don't go outside until the sun comes up." He paused. "Can you do that?"

Aaron looked up at him. His young face was pale and frightened.

"What is it?" he whispered. "Out there? You know. I can see it on you. You know what it is."

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment.

"It's something old," he said at last. "Something that's been looking for something for a long time. And it's very close to finding it." He squeezed Aaron's shoulder. "But it's not looking for you. Or Carter. Or anyone in the church. You'll be safe there. I promise."

"How do you know?"

The innkeeper smiled. It was a small, crooked, rueful smile.

"Because," he said, "I know what it's looking for."

\* \* \*

Aaron did not want to go. He stood in the doorway with his guttering blue lantern and looked at the innkeeper for a long time. His face was full of something Chronicler could not read. Fear, and confusion, and something else. Something that looked almost like recognition.

"Kote," he said slowly. "That song. The one I sang this evening. *Tarinie!*" He hesitated. "When I sang it, you went all still. Like you'd been hit. And your face—" He stopped.

"What about my face?"

Aaron looked at him. At his red hair, true red, the color of a flame that has been burning for a long time. At his green eyes. At the bruises on his jaw, and the scar on his cheek.

"Nothing," Aaron said at last. "Nothing. It's just—" He shook his head. "The man in Rannish. The traveler. He said Kvothe had red hair. Real red. And green eyes. And a scar on his cheek, from an Adem sword." He swallowed. "And he said Kvothe was waiting. For something. And when it came, he'd come back."

The innkeeper did not move. He stood very still, with his hand on the boy's shoulder, and his face showed nothing at all.

"Go to the church, Aaron," he said quietly. "Go now. Please."

Aaron looked at him one more moment. Then he nodded. He turned and went out into the dark, with his little blue lantern bobbing, and was gone.

Bast closed the door behind him and dropped the bar back into its brackets.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper stood by the hearth for a long time without moving.

"He knows," said Bast quietly. "Reshi. He knows."

"He suspects. It's not the same thing."

"He knows. I saw his face." Bast came away from the door. "They'll all know, soon. Everyone in town. After tonight."

"After tonight," said the innkeeper, "it won't matter."

He turned from the hearth. He came back to the table and sat down. He looked at Chronicler, who had not moved, who was still sitting with his pen poised over the page and his face very pale.

"You've stopped writing," said the innkeeper.

Chronicler looked down at the page. At the half-finished line of cipher. At the ink, thick and slow with cold.

"Eleven cows," he said. "Frozen standing up."

"Yes."

"That's him. Cinder. Coming here."

"Yes."

"And you're going to keep telling the story."

"Yes."

Chronicler looked up at him.

"Why?" he said. His voice cracked. "Why? Why not run? You could run. Right now. Out the back, into the dark, and he'd never find you. You've been hiding for years. You could hide again."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment.

"Because I'm tired of hiding," he said at last. "Because the door is cracked, and things are coming through, and people are dying. Carter's cows, and Shep, and a caravan at Farrel's Cut. Because the scrael are in the Commonwealth now, and the skin dancers, and worse things. Because every year it gets a little worse, and every year I sit here and polish the bar and pretend I don't know why." He was quiet for a moment. "Because a boy came to my door tonight and sang a song I wrote, and a woman wept at it, and I sat behind the bar and said nothing."

He looked down at his hands.

"And because I've been waiting," he said softly. "Like the Sleeper. For a long time. For something that might never come." He looked up. "And it's come. At last. And I find that I'm glad."

\* \* \*

Nobody spoke for a long time.

Then Bast came back to the table. He did not sit in his backward chair. He knelt on the floor beside the innkeeper's chair, the way a child kneels beside a parent, and he put his head on the innkeeper's knee.

The innkeeper laid his hand on Bast's dark hair.

"Finish it, Reshi," Bast whispered. "Finish the story. Please. I want to hear the end." His voice cracked. "I want to hear you tell it. In your own voice. The whole thing. Before he comes."

The innkeeper looked down at him for a long moment.

Then he looked at Chronicler.

"Get your pen," he said.

Chronicler got his pen. He dipped it in the thick cold ink.

"They tried me," said Kvothe, "on the first day of summer. Exactly one year after Ambrose was crowned. In the great hall of the palace at Renere. Before all the lords of Vintas, and the Penitent King on his throne, and half the city crowded in at the doors."

He smiled faintly.

"I don't remember much of it," he said. "I was very grey, that day. But I remember the end. I remember when they asked me if I had anything to say."

"What did you say?"

The innkeeper looked at the sword above the hearth.

"The truth," he said.



## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Four

# The Trial of the Kingkiller

They came for me at dawn, on the first day of summer.

Four guards, in the new livery of the Penitent King: plain grey, with a single white thread running down the breast like a line of ash. They unlocked the iron door of my cell and stood in the doorway and looked at me, sitting on my pallet with my back against the wall.

"Up," said one of them. "It's time."

I got up. I did not ask what it was time for. I did not care.

They put chains on me again. Wrists and ankles. They were careful with the left wrist; they put the iron above the cord, not on it. I do not know whose order that was. I have always suspected it was the Penitent King's.

Then they led me down the long winding stair of the Tower of Thorns. Down and down and around, past a hundred narrow window slits, each one showing a different grey slice of the grey city below. My legs were weak. I had not walked more than six paces at a time in eight months. I stumbled on the stair, and the guards caught me, and held me up, and did not say anything.

At the bottom of the stair, there was a door. And beyond the door, the courtyard of the palace. And beyond the courtyard, the great hall.

\* \* \*

I remember the noise first.

It came at me like a wave as they led me through the great double doors. Voices. Hundreds of them. Thousands. A roar of sound, like the

sea breaking on rocks. It filled the hall and echoed off the high timbered ceiling and pressed against my ears like a hand.

Then, as I came in, it stopped.

All at once. Like a candle snuffed. The whole great hall went silent, and in the silence, I heard my chains clinking on the stone floor. And my own breathing. And somewhere, very far away, a bird singing outside a window.

The hall was full. Fuller than the Eolian had been, the night I sang. There were people on benches along both walls, and people standing behind the benches, and people crowded in at the doors and hanging from the windows. Lords and ladies in fine clothes. Merchants and guildsmen. Priests in white. Soldiers in grey. Common folk, packed shoulder to shoulder at the back, craning their necks to see.

And at the far end of the hall, on a dais, beneath a great banner of plain grey cloth with a single white thread running down it, there was a throne.

The Penitent King sat on it.

He wore grey. Not the rich grey of silk, but plain grey wool, like a monk's habit. There was a crown on his head, a simple circlet of silver. His feet, resting on a cushion before the throne, were bare. His face was hollow and grey and very still.

Beside him, on a smaller chair, sat a woman with white hair.

I did not know her. But she was looking at me across the length of the hall, and her face was wet, and when she saw me look back at her, she put her hand over her mouth.

\* \* \*

They led me down the length of the hall, between the benches. People stared at me as I passed. Some of them hissed. Some of them made signs against evil. One of them, an old woman in black, spat on the floor at my feet.

They stood me in the center of the floor before the dais. They took the chains off my ankles, but not my wrists. They stepped back and left me standing there alone.

The Penitent King looked down at me from his throne. His face did not change.

A man stood up from a table at the side of the dais. He was old and lean and grey, in a long black robe, with a chain of office around his neck. A magistrate, I learned later. The high justice of Vintas. He held a long scroll in his hands, and he unrolled it, and he began to read.

\* \* \*

I do not remember what he read. Not most of it. It was long, and dry, and full of words I did not know. *Regicide. Treason. High crime against the crown and the realm.* He read for a long time, and his voice droned on, and I stood in the center of the floor with my chained wrists and let it wash over me like rain.

I remember the end of it.

"—that on the night of the dark moon, in the autumn of last year, in the cellars of the house of Lackless near the town of Levinshir, the accused, Kvothe, called the Ruh, called the Arcane, did with malice and forethought strike down and slay His Majesty Ambrose, first of that name, King of Vintas, with a blade of foreign make, and did thereby commit the highest crime known to the laws of this realm." The magistrate lowered his scroll. He looked at me over it. "How does the accused answer?"

The hall was silent.

I looked up at him. I did not answer. I did not know how.

"The accused will answer," said the magistrate. "Did you, or did you not, kill the king?"

I thought about it. I thought about a young man in black velvet, standing at a door, with a jeweled knife at a woman's throat. I did not remember him. I did not remember the door, or the woman, or the knife. But I remembered the sword. I remembered the feel of it going in. It was the only thing from that night that I remembered clearly. It was in my hands, and my arms, and my shoulders. It was in my body, the way the Ketan was in my body. Below the grey. Below the hole where my name had been.

"Yes," I said.

A murmur went through the hall. Like wind through leaves.

"You admit it?"

"Yes."

"Freely? Without coercion?"

"Yes."

The magistrate looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at the Penitent King.

"Your majesty," he said. "The accused has confessed."

The Penitent King did not move. He did not speak. He sat on his throne with his bare feet on the cushion and looked at me, and his face was like a stone.

"Nevertheless," said the magistrate, "the law requires that witnesses be heard. So that the realm may know the manner of the crime." He turned to the hall. "Let the witnesses come forward."

\* \* \*

There were many of them. More than I expected. They came up one by one from the benches and stood beside me before the dais and told what they had seen.

A soldier came first. A young man, barely more than a boy, with a thin frightened face. He had been in the ring of torch-bearers, he said, in the chamber beneath the Lackless house. He had seen the Ruh come down the stair. He had seen the Ruh walk up to the king. He had seen the Ruh draw his sword and strike.

"Did you see the king do anything?" asked the magistrate. "Before he was struck?"

The young soldier hesitated. "He was at the door, your honor. With the lady. The Maer's wife." He glanced at the dais, at the woman with white hair. "Her Majesty, I mean. He had her hand on the door."

"And?"

"And he had a knife." The soldier's voice dropped. "At her throat."

A murmur went through the hall. Louder this time.

"Go on," said the magistrate.

"And the Ruh said stop. And the king said the door wanted all of her. And he—" The soldier stopped. He swallowed. "And the Ruh killed him."

"Before or after the king moved the knife?"

The soldier was quiet for a long time.

"Before," he said at last. "Just before."

\* \* \*

An officer came next. The lean, careful man who had spoken to the duke on the doorstep of the Lackless house. He told the same story. He told it more carefully, with more words and fewer feelings. But it was the same.

"The king was not himself," he said. "He had not been himself for months. Since the old man came to court. Since he began to wear the box." He looked at the Penitent King. "I served his father for twenty years, your majesty. I knew the boy from a child. He was proud. He was cruel, sometimes. But he was not a murderer. Not until the end."

"And at the end?"

The officer was quiet for a moment.

"At the end," he said, "I believe he would have killed her. I believe the Ruh saved her life."

The murmur in the hall was very loud now. The magistrate had to raise his hand for silence.

\* \* \*

Then Meluan came down from the dais.

She walked slowly. She was very thin, and she leaned on the arm of a servant, a small precise man in grey with a calm, pleasant face. Her hair was white as snow. Her face was lined and pale, the face of a woman twenty years older than she was. But she walked with her head high.

She stood beside me before the dais. She did not look at me. She looked at the magistrate.

"I am Meluan," she said. "Of the house of Lackless. Queen of Vintas, now, God help me." Her voice was very steady. "I was in the

chamber. I was at the door. I was the one with the knife at her throat." She paused. "Ask me your questions."

The magistrate asked. She answered. She told it all, in a clear quiet voice that carried to every corner of the silent hall. The camp, and the tent, and the long ride to the Lackless house. The cellar stair. The door. The king cutting her palm and pressing it to the stone. The door drinking her. Her hair going white. The knife.

"He said I was nothing," she said. "He said I was just a woman. Just a vessel. Just blood. He said the door wanted all of me." Her voice did not waver. "And he put the knife to my throat. And I felt it cut. Here." She touched her throat, where there was a thin pale line, very faint. "And then he fell. And I lived."

She turned, at last, and looked at me.

"He saved my life," she said. "My nephew. My sister's son. He saved my life, and my daughter's, and the lives of everyone in this hall. He closed the door. He paid for it with his own name." Her voice cracked, just slightly. "And you want to hang him for it."

The hall was utterly silent.

"I know the law," said Meluan. "I know what it says. A king is a king, and whoever kills one must die. I know." She looked at the magistrate. "But I want you to know what you're hanging him for. I want every one of you to know. So that when you tell the story—and you will tell it, all of you, to your children and your grandchildren—you tell it true."

She turned away. She walked back to the dais, slowly, on the servant's arm. She sat down in her chair beside the Penitent King. She did not look at me again.

But I saw her hand. It was resting on the arm of the throne. And the Penitent King's hand was resting on top of it. And his knuckles were white.

\* \* \*

Denna was the last.

I did not know she was there until she stood up. She had been sitting on a bench at the side of the hall, near the dais, in a plain grey

dress, with her dark hair pulled back. There were guards on either side of her. She stood up, and they stood up with her, and she walked out into the center of the floor.

I did not know her. I want to be clear about that. I did not know her name, or her face, or what she was to me.

But the cord on my wrist began to hum the moment she stood up.

She came and stood beside me. Very close. Close enough that I could have touched her, if my hands had not been chained. She looked at the magistrate.

"My name is Denna," she said. "Or Dianne. Or Dinael. Or a dozen others. It doesn't matter which." She paused. "I was the king's singer. I was there, in the chamber. I saw everything." She looked up at the Penitent King. "I've already told the truth once. At the duke's feast. You've all heard about it, I'm sure." A faint smile. "I'll tell it again, if you like. But it'll be the same."

"Tell it," said the magistrate.

She told it.

She told it differently from the others. Not as a soldier tells it, or an officer, or a queen. She told it the way a singer tells it. With the parts in their places. With the fear and the cold and the silver light. With Bredon at his tak board and the Seven in the shadows and the Thief's voice behind the door. She told them things none of the others had told. Things they had not seen, or had not understood, or had been too frightened to say.

The hall listened. Some of them wept. Some of them made signs against evil. Some of them sat very still with their faces closed, the way people sit when they are hearing something they do not want to believe.

When she came to the end—to the name, and the cord, and the door closing—she stopped. She turned and looked at me.

"He doesn't remember any of it," she said quietly. "Not me. Not his friends. Not his own name. He gave it all up. For you. For all of you. So that the thing behind that door would never come out." She looked back at the magistrate. "That's what you're hanging. A man

with no name. A man who gave his name away to save you."

She stepped back. She did not return to her bench. She stood beside me, very close, with her shoulder almost touching mine.

The guards did not try to move her.

\* \* \*

The magistrate looked at me for a long time.

"The accused has heard the witnesses," he said at last. "Does the accused have anything to say? In his defense? Or otherwise?"

The hall was silent. Every face turned toward me. The lords and ladies on their benches. The common folk crowded at the back. The priests and the soldiers and the guildsmen. The Penitent King on his throne, with his white-knuckled hand on his wife's. Meluan, with her white hair and her wet face.

Denna, beside me.

I looked at them. At all of them. I tried to think of something to say.

There was nothing in me. Nothing at all. I was a grey man in a grey hall, in grey chains, with a hole where my name had been.

But I felt the cord on my wrist. Humming. Very softly. The way a string hums when another string nearby is plucked.

And I found, somewhere very far down, at the bottom of the hole, beneath all the grey, something. Not a word. Not a thought. Just a shape. The shape of something true.

I opened my mouth.

"I killed a king," I said.

My voice was flat. Toneless. Like a lute with no strings. But it carried to every corner of the silent hall.

"I don't remember why. I don't remember him. I don't remember the door, or the woman, or the knife. I don't remember my own name." I looked at the magistrate. "But I remember the sword. I remember my hand on it. I remember it going in."

I looked down at my chained hands.

"I did it," I said. "It was mine. My hand. My choice. Whatever it cost, and whatever it saved." I looked up. "I'm not sorry. I don't know



enough to be sorry. But I'm not going to pretend it was someone else."

I was quiet for a moment.

"Hang me if you have to," I said. "It's the law. I understand the law. But tell it true. When you tell it. Tell it the way she told it." I nodded at Denna. "Not a hero. Not a monster. Just a man at a door, with no time left, who chose."

\* \* \*

The hall was silent for a very long time.

Then, from somewhere at the back, among the common folk crowded at the doors, a voice began to sing.

It was a woman's voice. Rough and untrained. Very quiet. I could barely hear it.

It was singing about a white city on the last day of its life.

The guards turned. The magistrate turned. The lords and ladies on their benches turned in their seats, craning to see.

Another voice joined it. A man's, this time. Then another. Then another. Scattered through the crowd at the back of the hall, one here, one there. Not many. A dozen, perhaps. Singing very quietly, very badly, out of tune and out of time.

But singing.

*Tariniel*. The song the Penitent King had banned. The song that got your tongue cut out, if the wrong people heard you singing it.

They were singing it in the great hall of the palace of Renere, in front of the king himself.

The magistrate raised his hand. He opened his mouth to call for silence.

"No," said the Penitent King.

It was the first word he had spoken all day. The magistrate stopped. He turned and looked up at the throne.

The Penitent King was sitting very still, with his bare feet on the cushion and his hand on his wife's. His hollow grey face was wet.

"Let them sing," he said quietly.

\* \* \*

They sang the whole of it. Or as much as they knew. It took a long time. They did not know all the words, and they stumbled, and some of them stopped and started again. But they sang. And no one stopped them.

When they finished, the hall was silent again.

The magistrate cleared his throat. His voice, when he spoke, was not quite steady.

"Your majesty," he said. "The court must rule."

The Penitent King looked down at me from his throne for a long, long time.

"I know," he said.

He stood up. He stood on the dais in his plain grey robe, with his silver crown and his bare feet, and he looked out over the hall.

"The accused has confessed," he said. "Freely. Before witnesses. To the killing of a king." His voice was very steady. "The law is clear. It has been clear for a thousand years. It does not care why. It does not care what was saved, or what was lost. It cares only that a king is dead, and a man's hand did it."

He looked down at me.

"Kvothe, called the Ruh," said the Penitent King. "Called the Arcane. Called the Kingkiller. I find you guilty of regicide. And I sentence you to be hanged by the neck until you are dead, in the great square of Renere, at dawn, three days from now."

The hall was silent.

Beside me, Denna made a small sound, and put her hand on my arm.

"And may God," said the Penitent King, very quietly, "have mercy on us all."

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Five

### **A Hanging in Renere**

They hanged a man with red hair in the great square of Renere, at dawn, three days later.

There were ten thousand people there to see it. Maybe more. They packed the square from wall to wall, and filled the streets around it, and hung from the windows of every house that overlooked it. They stood on the rooftops. They climbed the statues of dead kings that lined the square's edges and clung to their stone shoulders. They had been gathering since midnight, some of them. They wanted a good view.

The gallows stood in the center of the square. It was a tall black frame of oak, very old, that had been standing in that place for longer than anyone could remember. It had hanged traitors and murderers and heretics and thieves. It had never hanged a kingkiller before. Kings of Vintas, it seemed, did not often get themselves killed.

The man with red hair was brought out of the palace at first light. He walked between four guards in grey, with his hands bound behind him and a black hood over his head. He walked slowly, a little unsteadily, the way a man walks who has been in a cell for a long time. The crowd went silent as he passed.

He climbed the steps of the gallows. The hangman, a big man in a black mask, put the noose around his neck over the hood. A priest in white stood beside him and read from a book.

And then the Penitent King came out onto a balcony of the palace, overlooking the square, and raised his hand.

And the trap fell.

\* \* \*

I was not there.

I want to be very clear about that, since I have been clear about everything else. The man who hanged in the great square of Renere was not me. He had red hair, bright red, like a flame. He was about my height, and about my build. He wore my clothes, the clothes I had worn at my trial. He walked like a man who had been in a cell for a long time.

But he was not me. He was a man named Bren Colley. He had been a murderer. He had killed his wife and two of his children with a hatchet, in a farmhouse near the eastern border, and he had been condemned to hang for it a month before my trial. He had been waiting in a cell in the lower dungeons of the palace.

And four days before my trial, he had died of a fever.

\* \* \*

I learned all of this later. Much later. I did not know it at the time. At the time, I was sitting in my cell in the Tower of Thorns, waiting to be hanged, and I did not care.

It was Stapes who told me. Years afterward, in a letter, written in his small precise hand. I have it still.

*It was her majesty's idea, he wrote. Or rather, it was the idea of a young woman of her acquaintance, a moneylender from Imre with spectacles and a very sharp tongue, who came to Renere with the army and refused to leave. She came to her majesty the night after the trial and said there must be a way. And her majesty said there was not, that the lords would never allow a pardon. And the young woman said, "Then don't pardon him. Hang him. Just not him."*

*She had heard, from a physician named Kelm, that there was a condemned man in the lower dungeons who had died of fever. His body had not yet been buried. It was being kept in the cold cellars until the proper forms could be completed.*

*She said: "Dye his hair. Put him in the Ruh's clothes. Put a hood over his head. No one will know."*

*Her majesty said: "They'll know. The man is dead. You cannot hang a dead man and make him walk to the gallows."*

*And the young woman smiled, sir, in a way I have never forgotten, and said: "Leave that to me."*

\* \* \*

I do not know exactly what Devi did. She never told me. She said it was a trade secret, and that if she told me, she would have to charge me for it, and I could not afford her rates.

But I know some of it. I know that she spent two days in the cold cellars of the palace, with the dead man and her alchemical bench and a great many strange-smelling bottles. I know that when she came out, the dead man's hair was red. Bright red. The color of a flame.

And I know that on the morning of the hanging, when the four guards came to the cold cellars to fetch the prisoner, the dead man stood up.

He did not live. Devi was very clear about that, the one time she spoke of it. He was dead. He stayed dead. But she had found a way—some binding, some sympathy, something that I suspect was not taught at the University and was probably not legal anywhere in the Four Corners—to make his body move. For a little while. Enough to walk. Enough to climb the steps. Enough to stand on the trap with a noose around his neck and a hood over his face, and fall.

"It was very difficult," she said, and her face was pale when she said it. "I had to be close. In the crowd. Right at the foot of the gallows. Holding the binding the whole time. If anyone had jostled me, if I'd lost my concentration for a single heartbeat, he'd have collapsed on the steps like a puppet with its strings cut." She shuddered. "I didn't sleep for a span afterward. I kept seeing him. Walking. With his head in that hood."

"Devi," I said. "Thank you."

She looked at me. Her eyes were very serious behind her spectacles.

"Don't thank me," she said. "Just remember that you owe me. For that, and the page, and everything else." Her voice cracked slightly. "You owe me so much, Kvothe. You'll never be able to pay it back. Not in a hundred years."

"I know."

"Good." She wiped her eyes. "Good. As long as you know."

\* \* \*

While the dead man walked to the gallows, I was walking somewhere else.

Down the back stair of the Tower of Thorns. The servants' stair, narrow and dark and winding, that the guards used to bring up the bread and water. I did not know it existed until that morning. I did not know anything.

I only knew that before dawn, the door of my cell had opened, and a small precise man in grey with a calm pleasant face had come in, carrying a lantern.

"Good morning, sir," he said. "If you would come with me, please. Quickly. And quietly."

I looked at him. I did not know him.

"Who are you?"

"Stapes, sir." He did not seem surprised that I did not know him. "His majesty's manservant. Formerly the Maer's. You and I have known each other some time." He held out his hand. "Please, sir. There isn't much time."

I did not move. I looked at him, standing in the doorway with his lantern.

"Where are we going?"

"Away, sir," said Stapes. "Far away. Somewhere you'll be safe."

"They're going to hang me. At dawn."

"They're going to hang someone, sir," said Stapes. His calm pleasant face did not change. "It won't be you."

\* \* \*

He led me down the servants' stair. At the bottom there was a small door, very old, that opened onto a narrow passage between two walls. The passage led to another door, and another passage, and another. Stapes knew them all. He led me through the hidden ways of the palace the way he had once led me through the hidden ways of the Maer's palace in Severen, quickly and quietly and without hesitation.

At the end of the last passage there was a gate. A small iron gate, set into the outer wall of the palace, half hidden by a tangle of ivy. Stapes unlocked it with a key from his pocket and pushed it open.

Beyond it, there was a narrow lane. And in the lane, there was a cart.

It was a plain farm cart, with a canvas cover over its bed, pulled by a single brown horse. There was a man on the seat, in a battered hat, holding the reins.

And beside the cart, standing in the grey dawn light with her arms wrapped around herself, there was a woman with dark hair.

\* \* \*

I stopped in the gateway. I looked at her.

She looked at me. Her face was very pale in the grey light. Her eyes were very dark.

The cord on my wrist began to hum.

"Hello," she said.

I did not know her. I did not know her name, or what she was to me, or why the sight of her face made the hole in my chest ache. I did not know anything.

But I knew the cord. And the cord knew her.

"Hello," I said.

She came across the lane toward me. She stopped in front of me, very close. She reached out and took my left hand, the one with the cord around its wrist, in both of hers.

"They let me go," she said. "Last night. The king did. He came to my rooms himself and unlocked the door and told me I was free." She looked down at the cord. "He said I should come here. He said you'd need someone. He said—" She stopped. "He said I'd know why."

"Do you?"

She looked up at me. Her eyes were wet.

"Yes," she said. "I know why."

\* \* \*

Stapes cleared his throat.

"If you please, sir," he said. "Madam. The hanging is at dawn. When it's done, the whole city will be in the square. That's when you go. Out the south gate, with the crowds coming in the other way. No one will look twice at a farm cart." He glanced at the man on the seat. "Tessit knows the way."

The man on the seat touched his battered hat. "Morning," he said. "One family, under the sky."

I did not know what that meant. But something in me stirred when he said it. The way a sleeping dog stirs at a familiar voice.

"Where are we going?" I said.

"West," said Tessit. "For now. Out of Vintas. Into the Commonwealth. After that—" He shrugged. "After that, wherever you like. The roads go everywhere."

I looked at Stapes. He was standing in the gateway, with his lantern in his hand, looking at me with his calm, pleasant face.

"Thank you, Stapes," I said.

I did not know why I said it. I did not know him. But the words came out of me the way they had come out on the doorstep of the Lackless house, and in the Tower of Thorns, and in the great hall. From somewhere down at the bottom.

Stapes looked at me for a long moment. His calm pleasant face did something I had never seen it do before. It crumpled, just for a moment, like paper in a fist. Then it smoothed out again.

"You're very welcome, sir," he said. His voice was not quite steady. "It has been an honor. A very great honor." He bowed. A deep bow, the kind you give a lord. "Safe travels, sir. Wherever you go."

He stepped back through the gate. The gate closed. The key turned in the lock.

And he was gone.



\* \* \*

We waited in the lane, the woman and I, until the bells began to ring.

They rang all over the city. Every church, every tower, every bell in Renere, ringing together. A great slow tolling, like the tolling for the old king's death. It went on and on.

And then, from the great square, far away, I heard the crowd.

It was a sound like the sea. Ten thousand voices, rising all at once. Not a cheer. Not a scream. Something in between. A great wordless roar, rising up over the rooftops of the city and hanging there, in the grey dawn air.

And then silence.

The woman beside me had her hand pressed over her mouth. She was shaking.

"That's it," she whispered. "That's it. It's done. They think you're dead."

I looked up at the grey sky. At the grey rooftops. At the grey bells, still ringing.

*They think you're dead.*

I did not feel anything. I did not know what I should feel. I was a grey man in a grey lane, and somewhere in a great square a dead man with red hair was swinging from a rope, and ten thousand people thought he was me.

It did not seem to matter very much.

"Get in," said Tessit, from the seat of the cart. "Both of you. In the back, under the canvas. Now, while everyone's in the square."

We got in. We lay down in the bed of the cart, under the canvas, on a pile of straw and old blankets. The woman lay beside me. She was still holding my hand.

The cart began to move.

\* \* \*

We went out through the south gate of Renere an hour later, with the crowds pouring in the other way. People were coming into the city from every village and farm for miles around, to see the kingkiller's

body hanging in the square. They filled the road, a great slow river of people, and the cart moved against them, slowly, patiently, like a boat against the current.

No one looked twice at a farm cart.

I lay in the straw under the canvas and listened to them pass. Thousands of voices. Talking. Laughing. Arguing. And every so often, one word, rising above the rest.

*Kingkiller.*

*They hanged the kingkiller.*

*Did you see him? Red hair. Bright red. Like fire.*

*I heard he was seven feet tall.*

*I heard he killed the king with a song.*

*I heard he was a demon.*

*I heard he sang the true story of Lanre, and the Chandrian came to kill him.*

*I heard he wasn't really dead.*

The woman beside me was crying. Silently. Her tears were running down her face and into the straw. She was holding my hand so tight it hurt.

I did not cry. I did not know how. I lay there in the dark under the canvas and listened to the voices, telling stories about a man I did not remember, with a name I did not know.

And I thought, very faintly, from somewhere far down at the bottom of the hole:

*That's the end of him, then.*

*Whoever he was.*

## **PART FIVE: THE WAYSTONE**

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Six

# The Road West

We traveled west with Hallow's Company for the rest of that summer.

I do not remember it well. I remember it the way you remember a journey you took as a very small child, sleeping in the back of a wagon: in pieces, out of order, without meaning. The creak of wheels. The smell of horses and woodsmoke. The sound of a fiddle played badly, every third note flat. Voices around a fire at night, talking and laughing, in a language I understood the words of but not the sense.

And the grey. Always the grey.

I rode in the back of the third wagon, among the sacks and the costumes and the painted canvas backdrops. Denna rode with me. She sat beside me in the straw with her harp in her lap and did not play it. She held my hand. Sometimes she talked, softly, about nothing in particular. The weather. The road. The towns we passed. Sometimes she did not talk at all.

I did not talk much either. There was nothing in me to talk with.

\* \* \*

The troupe did not play in the towns we passed. Tessit said it was too dangerous. There were soldiers on the roads, and bounty hunters, and people who had heard that the kingkiller was not really dead. Word had spread, the way word always spreads. A red-haired man, traveling with a Ruh troupe. It would not take much for someone to put it together.

So we did not stop. We went west along the back roads, the small ones, through hill country and forest, avoiding the towns. We camped in fields and woods, beside streams, under the stars. We ate what we could find, and what the villages sold us, and what Kellen and Wat could snare.

And Mirra cut my hair.

She did it on the second night, sitting me down on a stool beside the fire with a blanket around my shoulders. She did not ask. She simply took a pair of shears out of her sewing box and began to cut. Short, very short, so short that the red of it hardly showed. When she was done, she rubbed something into what was left, a paste of walnut hulls and ash that stained my scalp and my fingers brown.

"There," she said, when it was done. She stood back and looked at me with her round face very grave. "Now you're just a boy with brown hair. There's a thousand of those on the roads."

I looked at my hands, stained brown. I did not know what I was supposed to feel.

"It'll grow out," said Mirra. "In a month or two. We'll do it again then. And again. As long as we need to." She paused. "Your mother used to do it too, you know. Dye her hair. She had the loveliest dark hair, but it had a little red in it, in the sun. She said it was too memorable." Mirra smiled faintly. "She used walnut hulls too. I learned it from her."

"I don't remember her," I said.

Mirra looked at me for a long moment. Her round face was very sad.

"I know, love," she said. "I know."

\* \* \*

There was a baby in the first wagon.

I did not know whose it was. I did not know anything. But I heard it at night, sometimes, crying, and I heard Mirra singing to it, a soft low wordless tune that made something in my chest ache, though I did not know why. And sometimes, during the day, when the wagons stopped to rest, I saw a girl carrying it. A girl of seven or eight, with

enormous eyes and a red dress, holding the baby very carefully against her shoulder.

The girl came to see me, one afternoon, when we had stopped beside a stream to water the horses. She came and stood beside the tailboard of the third wagon, where I was sitting, and looked at me with her enormous eyes.

"You don't remember me," she said.

"No."

"I'm Nell. You pulled me out of a well." She shifted the baby on her shoulder. "Denna says you gave your name away. To close a door."

"Yes."

Nell considered this. Then she held up the baby.

"This is Lark," she said. "She's my sister now. Mirra says. She's very small and she cries a lot, but she's nice." She looked at me. "Do you want to hold her?"

I did not know what to say. I looked at the baby. A tiny thing, wrapped in a blanket, with a small red crumpled face and a fuzz of dark hair. She was awake. She was looking at me with dark solemn eyes.

I held out my hands. I did not know why.

Nell put the baby in them. Very carefully. She showed me how to hold her, one hand under the head, one under the body. The baby was warm and light and she smelled of milk and woodsmoke.

She looked up at me. I looked down at her.

And the cord on my wrist hummed.

It was very faint. Barely there. But I felt it. The way a string hums when another string nearby is plucked. As if something in the cord recognized something in her. As if there were a thread running between us, very thin, very old.

"She likes you," said Nell. "She doesn't usually like people. She cries at Brin all the time."

I held the baby for a long time. She did not cry. She lay in my hands and looked up at me with her dark solemn eyes, and after a

while, she fell asleep.

\* \* \*

I tried to play the lute.

It was Denna who suggested it. We were sitting by the fire one night, late, after the others had gone to sleep. My lute was lying in its case beside me; someone had brought it out of Renere, I never learned who. Denna looked at it for a long time.

"Will you try?" she said.

"Try what?"

"To play." She picked up the case and opened it and took out the lute and held it out to me. "Just try. Just a little."

I took it. It was a beautiful thing, dark wood and ivory pegs and a soundboard of pale spruce. It was very old, and very well made, and someone had taken very good care of it. I did not know who.

I held it the way you hold a lute. My hands knew how. Even the left one, the cold one, with the white print of a dead man's fingers on its wrist. They settled onto the neck and the strings the way birds settle onto a branch.

I played a chord.

It was a good chord. Clean and clear, every note in its place. My fingers knew exactly where to go.

I played another. And another. A simple progression, the kind of thing you play to warm up. My hands moved on their own. They knew the shapes. They had known them for a very long time.

And it was nothing.

I do not know how else to say it. The notes were right. The chords were right. The rhythm was right. It was music, in every way that music can be measured.

But it was nothing. It was grey. It was like a painting of a fire, hung on a wall. It had the shape of warmth and none of the heat.

I stopped playing. I sat very still with the lute in my lap, and I looked at it.

Denna was watching me. Her face was very pale in the firelight.

"It's gone," she whispered. "Isn't it? The—the thing. The fire. Whatever it was that made it yours."

I did not answer. I did not know how.

She reached out and took the lute out of my hands, very gently. She put it back in its case. She closed the lid.

Then she put her face in her hands, and wept.

\* \* \*

I watched her weep. I did not know why she was weeping. I did not know what I should do.

But I remembered something. Very faint. From very far down. A voice, in a lighthouse, by the sea. *You sing it so that it will be true. So that it will be remembered.*

And I understood, a little. Not with my mind. Somewhere else. I understood that I had lost something, and that she was weeping for it, because I could not.

I reached out and put my hand on her back. The way you put a hand on a frightened animal. I did not say anything.

After a while, she stopped weeping. She sat up. She wiped her eyes.

"I'm sorry," she said. "I'm sorry. It's just—I heard you, you know. At the Eolian. That night. With the song." Her voice cracked. "It was the most beautiful thing I ever heard. It was like the whole world was singing through you." She looked at the closed lute case. "And now it's just—a lute."

"It's still a lute," I said.

She looked at me.

"It's still a lute," I said again. "And my hands still know it. And maybe someday—" I stopped. I did not know what I was going to say.

"Someday what?"

I looked down at the cord on my wrist. At the knots, glowing very faintly.

"Someday it won't just be a lute," I said.

Denna looked at me for a long time. Then she laughed. A small, broken, astonished laugh.



"You're still in there," she said. "Aren't you? Somewhere. Under all the grey. You're still in there."

"I don't know."

"You are." She took my hand. My left hand, with the cord. "I can feel it. In the knots. You're in there. You're just asleep."

\* \* \*

We came to the edge of Vintas at the end of summer.

It was a river. A wide slow brown river, running north to south, with the hills of Vintas on one side and the hills of the Commonwealth on the other. There was a ford, and a ferry, and a small town on the eastern bank with a toll house and a garrison of soldiers in the grey of the Penitent King.

We did not go to the ford. Tessit knew another way. A place upstream, a day's travel, where the river widened and grew shallow over a bed of stones, and a wagon could cross if the driver knew exactly where to put the wheels.

We crossed at dawn. Tessit led the first horse, wading chest-deep in the brown water, feeling for the stones with his feet. The wagons followed, one by one, lurching and swaying, with the water foaming around their wheels.

I sat in the back of the third wagon and watched the eastern bank fall away behind us. The hills of Vintas, green and brown and grey. The last of the country where I had been Kvothe, and the Maer's Ruh, and the kingkiller.

I did not feel anything. There was nothing in me to feel with.

But Denna, sitting beside me, reached over and took my hand. And held it very tight, all the way across the river.

\* \* \*

On the western bank, when the wagons had all come up out of the water and the horses were shaking themselves and the troupe was laughing with relief, a woman was waiting for us.

She was small and slim, in blood-red clothes bound with a hundred cords. She was sitting on a stone beside the road, with a sword

across her knees, and she was very still.

I did not know her. But my hands knew her. I felt them move, at my sides, before I had decided anything. A small gesture. Clumsy. Badly made.

The woman in red looked at my hands. Something moved in her face.

"Kvothe," she said.

I did not answer. The name meant nothing to me.

She stood up. She came across the road toward the third wagon. She stopped beside the tailboard and looked up at me.

"I have come," she said, "about the sword."

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Seven

# What Mirra Remembered

Mirra told stories while she cooked. That was the way of it, in Hallow's Company. Tessit told stories on the road, walking beside the lead horse, to pass the miles. Brin told stories at night, after the fiddle was put away, stories so long and so wandering that half the troupe was asleep before he reached the middle. Illa told stories to the children, very short and very sharp, with teeth in them.

But Mirra told stories while she cooked. She stood at the great iron pot over the fire, stirring, and she talked, and anyone who wanted to listen could sit on the upturned buckets and crates around the fire and listen.

I sat and listened. Every night, that summer, on the road west. I did not know why. I did not know Mirra, or the troupe, or the stories. But something in me wanted to be near the fire, and the pot, and the voice.

And one night, a little past midsummer, somewhere in the hills near the border of the Commonwealth, she told a story about my mother.

\* \* \*

"She couldn't cook," said Mirra. She was stirring a stew of rabbit and wild onions and something she had found growing by the road that she said was good for the blood. "Your mother. Laurian. Did I tell you that?"

"Yes," I said. "You said she couldn't boil water."

"She couldn't. It was a scandal. Every Ruh woman can cook. It's the first thing you learn, before you learn to sing." Mirra shook her head, smiling. "But she'd never learned. She'd grown up in a great house, with servants. Nobody ever let her near a kitchen." She tasted the stew. "The first time she tried, she set a wagon on fire."

Across the fire, Nell giggled. Lark, asleep in her lap, stirred and was still.

"She set a wagon on fire?" said Nell.

"The back of one. The canvas." Mirra added a pinch of salt. "We'd camped with Arliden's troupe, that summer, outside Hallowfell. The summer she was new. She was trying to impress everyone. Arliden's mother was still alive then, old Beth, and she was very fierce, and she didn't approve of Arliden marrying a girl from a great house who couldn't cook. So Laurian decided to make supper. For the whole troupe. By herself." Mirra laughed softly. "She put the pot too close to the wagon and forgot about it and went off to practice a song, and by the time anyone noticed, the canvas was on fire."

"What happened?" said Nell.

"Arliden put it out. With his cloak. Burned his hands doing it." Mirra's smile softened. "And then he came and found her, where she was practicing, and she was crying, because she thought old Beth would make him send her away. And he knelt down in front of her with his burned hands and said, *I don't care if you can cook. I didn't marry you to cook.*"

"What did he marry her for?" said Nell.

Mirra looked across the fire at me. Her round face was very gentle.

"He said, *I married you because when you sing, I can hear the whole world singing with you.*"

\* \* \*

I did not say anything. I sat on my upturned bucket with my hands on my knees and looked at the fire.

I did not remember. I did not remember my father's hands, or my mother's voice, or old Beth, or a wagon on fire outside Hallowfell. I

did not remember anything.

But something in me was listening. Very hard. The way you listen for footsteps in an empty house.

"Tell me another," I said.

Mirra looked at me for a long moment. Then she smiled, and went back to stirring.

\* \* \*

She told me about the first time my mother sang for the troupe. Outside Hallowfell, the same summer, at the midsummer fair. How she stood up on the back of Arliden's wagon in a borrowed dress and sang an old ballad about a woman waiting at a window, and how the whole fair went quiet. The jugglers stopped juggling. The peddlers stopped shouting. The drunk men stopped fighting. And when she finished, there was a silence so deep you could hear the river running, a mile off.

She told me about the time my mother fell out of a tree. At twenty-two, grown and married, with a child on the way. She had climbed it to get a better view of a hawk, and a branch had broken, and she had landed in a thornbush, and she had laughed so hard Arliden thought she had hit her head.

She told me about the night my mother told the troupe that she was with child. How Arliden had stood up in the firelight and let out a whoop so loud it frightened the horses, and then picked her up and spun her around and fallen over backward into a creek.

"And then you came," said Mirra. "In the autumn. In a wagon, on the road outside Anilin, in the rain. With the whole troupe standing outside in the wet, waiting." She smiled. "I was there. We'd met up with Arliden's troupe again, that year. I held your mother's hand."

I looked at her.

"You were there," I said. "When I was born."

"I was there." Mirra's eyes were wet. "You came out screaming. Loudest baby I ever heard. Your mother laughed and said, *Oh, he's going to be a singer.* And your father said, *He's going to be trouble.*" She laughed through her tears. "They were both right."

The fire had burned low. Nell was asleep, curled against Mirra's side with Lark in her arms. Across the camp, Brin was telling one of his endless stories to Kellen and Wat, and they were both nodding off.

Mirra sat down on an upturned crate beside me. She did not say anything for a while.

"There's one more," she said at last. Her voice was quiet. "One I haven't told anyone. Not even Tessit." She looked at the fire. "Your mother asked me not to. But I think—" She hesitated. "I think you should have it. Now. When you've got nothing else."

I waited.

"It was the last time I saw her," said Mirra. "The summer before. A year before they—" She stopped. "Before. We'd met up with Arliden's troupe on the road near the Eld. We camped together for a span. And one night, very late, your mother came and found me by the fire, the way you're sitting now. And she sat down beside me. And she didn't say anything for a long time."

The fire crackled.

"And then she said, *Mirra, if anything happens to us, will you look after him?*" Mirra's voice cracked. "I said, *Of course. Nothing's going to happen. Don't be silly.* And she looked at me with those eyes of hers, those green eyes, the same as yours, and she said, *Promise me.*"

Mirra wiped her eyes with the back of her hand.

"I promised," she said. "And then something happened. And I didn't know. We were in the south that year. We didn't hear until the next summer, and by then you were gone. Nobody knew where. Everyone said you were dead." She looked at me. "I didn't look after you. I broke my promise."

"You didn't know."

"I should have looked. I should have gone looking." She pressed her hand against her mouth. "I looked a little. Asked around. And then I let it go. Because it was easier to think you were dead than to think you were out there somewhere, alone, and I hadn't found you."

\* \* \*

I sat very still on my upturned bucket. I did not know what to say. I did not know anything.

But I remembered something. Very faint. Very far down. A city of stone and smoke and rain. Rooftops, and gutters, and a boy of twelve curled up in a doorway with his arms around a broken lute. And a voice, somewhere, a long way off, singing a Ruh lullaby in a tavern.

It was not Mirra's voice. It was not anyone's I knew. But it had been a Ruh voice, and a Ruh song, and I had lain in that doorway and listened, and I had not been quite so cold.

"You're looking after me now," I said.

Mirra looked at me.

"You cut my hair," I said. "And dyed it. And fed me. And told me stories." I looked at the fire. "You're looking after me now."

Mirra did not say anything for a long time. Then she reached out and put her round warm hand on the back of my neck, the way you touch a child, and left it there.

"Yes," she said. "Yes, I am." Her voice was thick. "Better late than never. That's what old Beth used to say. She was a terrible woman. But she was right about that."

\* \* \*

We sat by the fire until it burned out. Mirra's hand on my neck. Lark and Nell asleep. Brin's voice, far off, still telling his story to no one.

I did not remember my mother. I want that understood. I did not remember her face, or her voice, or her hands. I did not remember a wagon on fire, or a woman on the back of a wagon singing, or a laugh from a thornbush.

But I had them now. In Mirra's words. Set down in me like stones in a riverbed. Not my memories. Hers. But true.

And when, years later, I told this story to a scribe at a table by a hearth, and my name came back to me piece by piece, those stones were there. Waiting. And my own memories settled around them, the way water settles around stones.

I have never been able to tell, since, which memories of my mother are mine and which are Mirra's.

I have decided that it does not matter.



## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Eight

### Nell's Story

Nell decided, about a span after I came to Hallow's Company, that I needed to be told who I was.

"Everybody else knows," she said. "It isn't fair that you don't."

She was sitting on the tailboard of the third wagon beside me, swinging her legs. It was evening. The troupe was camped in a meadow beside a river, and the fires were lit, and Mirra was cooking, and Brin was tuning his fiddle, flat as always. Lark was asleep in a basket at Mirra's feet.

"Denna told me," I said. "Who I am."

"Denna told you your *name*." Nell looked at me with great scorn. She was eight, and very certain about most things. "That's not the same. A name's just a word. You need the *story*."

I did not know what to say to that. So I did not say anything.

"I'll tell it," said Nell. "I know all of it. Mirra told me some, and Tessit told me some, and Brin told me some, but Brin gets it wrong. And I heard some in the villages. They tell it everywhere, now." She folded her hands in her lap, very primly, the way Mirra did before she began a long story. "Are you listening?"

"Yes."

"Good." She took a deep breath. "Once upon a time—"

\* \* \*

I will not tell you the whole of Nell's story. It was very long, and it wandered a great deal, and there were several places where she

stopped and backed up and started over because she had left something out. There were also a great many dragons. I do not know where the dragons came from. I have never met a dragon.

But I will tell you some of it. Because it was the first time I heard my own story told, after the grey came down. And because Nell told it better than anyone has, before or since. Including me.

\* \* \*

"Once upon a time," said Nell, "there was a boy with red hair, whose mother and father were Ruh. And they were the best troupe on all the roads, and everyone loved them. And the boy could sing better than anyone, even when he was little. Even better than Brin."

"Most people sing better than Brin," I said.

Nell looked at me sharply. "Don't interrupt. It's rude." She went on. "And one day, the boy's family was killed. By the Chandrian. Who are very bad. They came in the night, and they killed everyone, and the boy was the only one left." She paused. "That's the sad part. There's always a sad part at the beginning. Mirra says that's so you know it's a true story."

"Is it?"

"Is it what?"

"A true story."

Nell considered this carefully.

"Most of it," she said at last. "Not the dragons."

\* \* \*

She told me about Tarbean. About a boy alone in a great city, starving, sleeping on rooftops. She told it very seriously, with her small face grave, and I could tell she had been told it by someone who had known. Mirra, I thought. Or Tessit. Someone who had been there, or near it.

She told me about the University. About a boy of fifteen who talked his way in, and called the wind, and made a master very angry, and was whipped, and did not bleed. That was where the Bloodless came from, she told me. Because he did not bleed.

She told me about the Eolian, and the silver pipes. And about a girl with dark hair.

"Denna," said Nell. "Our Denna. She was in it even then. At the beginning." She looked at me. "Did you know that?"

"No."

"Well, she was. And he loved her. The red-haired boy. From the very first minute." Nell sighed deeply, with the romantic gravity of the very young. "And she loved him back. But they could never be together. Because of a curse." She frowned. "Or a patron. Something bad. The stories don't agree."

\* \* \*

She told me about the Maer. About Vintas, and a box with no lid, and a poisoner. About bandits in the Eld, which she told with great relish and a great many sound effects. About the Fae, and a lady made of moonlight, and a cloak made of shadows.

She told me about the Adem, and a sword, and a hand-talk you could say secrets in.

And then she told me about the Eolian again. The second time. The song.

"He sang it to bring them," she said. Her voice had gone quiet. "The Chandrian. The ones who killed his family. He sang the true song about them, so they'd have to come. And they came. And they burned the Eolian down. And a big man with a beard died." She was quiet for a moment. "And the girl who knew stone held it up. All night. With her hands."

I did not say anything. Something was moving in me, very faintly. Like a fish in dark water, far down.

"And after that," said Nell, "he went into the Fae again. All the way to the mountains at the top of the world. And he found a man with one eye, who was older than anyone. And the man told him how to close the door."

"What door?"

Nell looked at me as if I were very slow.

"*The door*," she said. "The one the Lackless family keeps. With no lock and no key and no handle. That's in the rhyme." She recited it, singsong, the way children do:

*"Seven things stand before The entrance to the Lackless door—"*  
She stopped.

"I'm not allowed to say the rest," she said. "Mirra says. Not anymore. Not with Lark here." She glanced toward the basket at Mirra's feet. "Mirra says Lark should never hear it. Not ever. Not even as a song."

"Why?"

Nell looked at me for a long moment.

"You know why," she said softly. "You're the one who said."

\* \* \*

I did not know why. I did not know anything. But I looked at the basket, where the baby with dark hair slept at Mirra's feet, and I felt the cord on my wrist hum, very faintly. The way it had hummed when I first held her.

"Go on," I said. "With the story."

Nell went on.

She told me about a king's camp, and a fire in the horse lines, and a baby carried out in the dark. She told me about the Lackless house, on the ridge above Levinshir. About a cellar stair and a door that was not a door. About a king who came to open it.

"And the red-haired boy killed him," said Nell. "The king. With a sword. Right in front of the door. Because the king was going to open it, and let the bad things out. And the red-haired boy said no."

"And then?"

"And then the door opened anyway." Nell's voice was very small. "A little. Just a crack. And something came through. Something very bad. The worst thing in the world." She hugged her knees. "And the red-haired boy had to close it. And the only way to close it was to give up his name. His real one. The deep one." She looked at me. "So he did."

The fire crackled. Across the camp, Brin had stopped tuning his fiddle. Mirra had stopped stirring the pot. I did not know when they had started listening. But they were listening now.

"And the girl with dark hair caught it," said Nell. "His name. When he gave it up. She caught it in a cord, and she tied it, so it wouldn't be lost. And she kept it safe." She looked at the cord on my wrist. "That's it. Isn't it? That's his name."

I looked down at the cord.

"Yes," I said.

\* \* \*

Nell was quiet for a long time. She swung her legs over the tailboard. She looked at the river, going by in the dusk.

"That's the end," she said at last. "That's all the story there is. Except the end part, which isn't finished."

"What's the end part?"

"The part where he gets it back." Nell looked at me. "His name. That's how the story has to end. Every story like that ends the same way. The hero loses something, and goes on a long journey, and then he gets it back." She frowned. "But nobody knows how that part goes. Because it hasn't happened yet."

I looked at her. At her small serious face, in the firelight.

"What if it doesn't?" I said. "What if he never gets it back?"

Nell looked horrified.

"Then it's a bad story," she said. "And nobody would tell it." She shook her head firmly. "No. He gets it back. He has to. Otherwise, what was the point of all the rest?"

\* \* \*

She slid down off the tailboard. She stood in front of me, in the grass, with her hands on her hips.

"You should remember it," she said. "The story. So you can tell it to yourself. When you're sad. When you don't know who you are." She considered me. "I'll tell it to you again tomorrow. And every day. Until you know it by heart."

"You don't have to."

"I know I don't *have* to." Nell looked at me with great patience, as if I were very young. "That's why it counts."

And she went off across the camp to help Mirra with the supper, and left me sitting on the tailboard in the dusk, with the story she had told me sitting in my chest like a stone.

\* \* \*

She did tell it again. Every night, for the rest of that summer and all through the winter that followed, in the valley in the western hills. Sometimes it was longer, and sometimes it was shorter. Sometimes there were more dragons, and sometimes fewer. Once, memorably, the red-haired boy married the lady made of moonlight, and Mirra had to take Nell aside and have a long talk with her.

But she told it. Every night. And I listened. And by the time the spring came, and Bast and I left Hallow's Company with the cart and the chest and the mule named Patience, I knew it by heart.

I did not remember it. I want to be clear about that. It was not my story, the way it had been before. It was Nell's story. A story about a red-haired boy, that a little girl had told me. It could have been about anyone.

But I knew it. Every word. And all through the grey years behind the bar, when I did not know who I was, I could close my eyes and hear her voice. Small and serious and very certain.

*He gets it back. He has to. Otherwise, what was the point of all the rest?*

\* \* \*

"She was right," said Chronicler quietly. "Wasn't she?"

The innkeeper did not answer at once. He was looking at the pages stacked at Chronicler's elbow. Three days of pages. Hundreds of them.

"Nell is sixteen now," he said. "Mirra sent word, once, by a tinker. Nell's got the troupe's best voice, she said. Better than Mirra's own. Better than Brin's." He smiled faintly. "Everyone's is better than

Brin's."

"Will you see her? When this is done?"

"I hope so." The innkeeper looked at the fire. "I'd like to tell her how it ends. The end part. The part that wasn't finished." He was quiet for a moment. "She'll want to know if there were dragons."

"Were there?"

The innkeeper looked at him. And the corner of his mouth moved.

"Not yet," he said.

## Chapter One Hundred Twenty-Nine

# Folly

Her name was Vashet. Denna told me that, afterward, when I asked. She was Adem, from a place called Haert, in the mountains to the north. She had been my teacher. She had taught me to fight, and to be still, and something called the Lethani, which Denna did not understand and could not explain.

I did not remember any of it. But my hands remembered her. And so, it seemed, did my body. When she stood beside the wagon and looked up at me, I found that I had gone very still, the way a student goes still when his teacher walks into the room. I found that I was breathing slowly and evenly, in a rhythm I did not know I knew.

"Get down," said Vashet. "Bring the sword."

I got down. I did not know what sword she meant. But Denna reached into the back of the wagon and brought out a long bundle wrapped in oiled cloth, and put it in my hands, and I knew.

It was heavy. Heavier than it looked. I unwrapped the oiled cloth, and there it was. A long straight blade, grey and plain, with a simple hilt wrapped in leather. There was no ornament on it. No jewel, no engraving, no gilt. It was the plainest sword I had ever seen.

And it was beautiful. Even in the grey. Even with nothing inside me to see it with. I held it in my hands and looked at it, and I knew that it was beautiful, the way you know that a mountain is high even when you cannot see the top.

"Caesura," said Vashet.

\* \* \*



We walked a little way from the wagons, she and I, to a flat place beside the river where the grass grew short and green. The troupe watched us go. Denna watched us go. No one followed.

Vashet stopped in the middle of the flat place. She turned to face me.

"Draw it," she said.

I drew it. It came out of its sheath with a sound like a breath let out. I held it in front of me, the way my hands told me to hold it.

Vashet looked at it for a long time. At the blade, grey and clean. I had cleaned it, I suppose, at some point. Or someone had. There was no blood on it now.

"It killed a king," she said.

"Yes."

"In a cellar. In the dark. Before a door."

"Yes."

"Do you remember?"

"I remember the sword. I remember my hands on it." I looked down at the blade. "I don't remember anything else."

Vashet was silent for a long moment.

"Shehyn sent me," she said at last. "After the battle. After the trial. She sent word from Haert. She said I must come to you, wherever you were, and speak to you about the sword." Her hands moved, very slightly, at her sides. "She said I must decide."

"Decide what?"

"Whether to take it back."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything. I held the sword and looked at her.

"I told you once," said Vashet, "a long time ago, in a small room in Imre, that if you ever used this sword for something that was not the Lethani—for anger, or pride, or revenge—I would come and take it back. And I would not be gentle." She looked at me. "Do you remember that?"

"No."

"No." Her hands moved. *Grief*, I think. I did not know the sign, but my body knew it, somewhere. "No, I suppose you do not."

She was quiet for a long time. The river ran past beside us, brown and slow. The wind moved in the grass.

"I was in the chamber," she said. "Beneath the Lackless house. I saw what happened. I saw the young king with the knife. I saw you draw. I saw you strike." Her voice was very flat. "I have thought about it every day since. Every day. On the march to Renere. In the battle on the Field of Three Rivers. In the long nights afterward, waiting for your trial." She looked at me. "I have asked myself, over and over. Was it the Lethani?"

"Was it?"

Vashet did not answer right away.

"I do not know," she said at last. "That is the truth. I do not know. I have been Adem all my life, and I have studied the Lethani since I was a child, and I do not know." Her hands moved. *Confusion. Grief. Something else*. "You acted without anger. I saw that. Your face was calm. Your body was calm. You moved the way I taught you, cleanly, without waste. It was the most perfect strike I have ever seen." She paused. "And you killed a king. And a war came of it. And many people died. And the world is different now, and not better."

"So it wasn't the Lethani."

"I did not say that." Her voice was sharp. "Listen. You never listen. That was always your problem." She took a breath. "I said I do not know. And that is the point. That is what I have learned, after all these months of thinking. The Lethani is not a rule. It is not a law. It does not tell you what is right. It only tells you to choose, and to bear what comes after." She looked at me. "You chose. And you have borne it. You gave your name to bear it. More than any Adem I have ever known would have given."

I did not say anything.

"But the sword," said Vashet quietly, "is another matter."

\* \* \*

She held out her hand.

"Give it to me," she said.

I gave it to her. I did not hesitate. I did not know why I should.

She took it. She held it up in front of her and looked at it for a long time. At the grey blade, and the plain hilt, and the leather wrapping. Her face showed nothing.

"This is Caesura," she said. "It is very old. It was made in Haert, before any of us were born. It has been carried by eleven Adem before you, and it has killed many men, and every one of those deaths was within the Lethani." She was quiet for a moment. "Or so the school believed."

She turned the sword in her hands. The light slid along the blade.

"A sword has a name," she said. "Among the Adem. A true name. Given to it by the one who first carries it, and kept by all who carry it after. The name is the sword's history. Its Lethani. Everything it has done, and why." She looked at me. "When a sword is used outside the Lethani, the name breaks. The sword is no longer what it was. It must be brought home and melted down and made into something else."

"Is that what you're going to do?"

Vashet was silent for a long time.

"No," she said at last.

I looked at her.

"I cannot take it home," she said. "Shehyn has said so. The school has said so. A sword that has killed a king—a king of the barbarians, in a cellar, before a door that should never have been opened—that sword cannot come back to Haert. It is too heavy. Its history is too heavy. It would bring that door with it, into the school, into the mountains, into the Lethani itself." She looked down at the sword in her hands. "So it cannot come home. And it cannot be melted down, because it cannot come home to be melted. And it cannot keep its name, because the name is broken."

"Then what happens to it?"

Vashet looked at me for a long moment. Then she held it out to me, hilt first.

"It stays with you," she said. "It is yours now. Not the school's. Not Caesura. Yours." Her hands moved, very slightly. "It has no name. You must give it one."

\* \* \*

I looked at the sword. At the hilt, held out toward me. At the grey blade behind it.

"I can't name things," I said. "I have no name. I can't—"

"This is not that kind of naming," Vashet's voice was very quiet. "This is not the naming of the old stories, the namers and the shapers and the wind. This is a smaller thing. An Adem thing. You look at the sword. You look at what it has done. You say what it is." She paused. "Even a man with no name can do that."

I looked at the sword for a long time.

I did not remember what it had done. I did not remember the cellar, or the door, or the king. I did not remember the burning camp where a quiet man in red had died so I could run. I did not remember the Eld, or the bandits, or the long road to Ademre.

But I held out my hand and took the hilt. And my hand remembered. All of it. Not the events. The weight. The weight of everything this sword had done, while I held it. The weight of a king falling. The weight of a war.

The weight of a foolish young man who had thought he could open doors and close them again, and not pay for it.

"Folly," I said.

Vashet went very still.

"Folly," I said again. My voice was flat. Toneless. But the word came out of me from very far down, from the bottom of the hole, from the place where the truth lives. "That's what it is. That's what it's done. That's what I did with it."

Vashet looked at me for a long, long time.

Then her hands moved. A sign I did not know. My body did not know it either. I have learned it since. It is a very rare sign among the Adem. It is used only once in a person's life, if at all.

It means *I have seen the Lethani in you.*

"Folly," said Vashet. "Yes. That is its name." She stepped back. "Keep it. Carry it. Hang it on your wall, if you like, where you can see it every day. And remember."

"I don't remember anything."

"Then let it remember for you." She looked at the sword in my hand. "That is what names are for."

\* \* \*

She stayed with us that night. She sat by the fire with the troupe, very straight and very still, and she did not speak. The children of Hallow's Company stared at her. Nell brought Lark to show her, and Vashet looked at the baby for a long time with her calm Adem face, and then did something I have never seen an Adem do, before or since.

She smiled. With her face. Just for a moment. Just a little.

Nell was so startled she nearly dropped the baby.

\* \* \*

In the morning, Vashet left. She stood by the road at dawn, in her red clothes, with her own sword on her back, and she looked at me for a long time.

"I will not see you again," she said. "I think. Shehyn is old. I will be needed in Haert. And you are going somewhere far away, where no one will find you." Her hands moved. *Farewell. Grief. Family.* "But I will remember you. I promised Cinder that. I will promise you too."

"I don't remember you."

"I know." She looked at me. "But your hands do. And your feet. And your breath. And the way you stand." She was quiet for a moment. "That is enough. For now."

She turned to go. Then she stopped and looked back.

"Kvothe," she said. "When your name comes back. And it will. I have seen names come back. When it does—" She hesitated. It was the only time I ever saw Vashet hesitate. "When it does, you will want to take that sword down from your wall and do something foolish with it. You will want to go looking for Cinder, or the old man, or the door. You will want to put everything right."

"Should I?"

She looked at me for a long moment.

"You should choose," she said. "And bear what comes after."

Then she was gone, walking north along the road, small and straight and red against the grey morning. She did not look back.

I stood by the road with Folly in my hand and watched her until she was out of sight.

\* \* \*

Denna found me there, a little while later. She came and stood beside me and looked north along the empty road.

"What was that about?" she said. "With the sword?"

I looked down at the grey blade in my hand.

"She told me its name," I said.

"What is it?"

"Folly."

Denna was quiet for a long time. Then she laughed, very softly. It was not a happy laugh. But it was not an unhappy one either.

"That's right," she said. "That's exactly right." She took my hand. My left hand, with the cord. "Come on. Mirra's made breakfast. And Tessit says we're going to Imre."

"Why Imre?"

Denna looked down at the cord on my wrist. At the knots, glowing very faintly in the grey morning light.

"Because this can't stay on your wrist forever," she said. "It's too close. Too loud. Something will hear it, eventually. The door, or the Seven, or something else." She looked up at me. "It needs to go somewhere safe. Somewhere that says no. And I only know one place with the right people to make that."

"What people?"

She smiled. It was a small, sad, fond smile.

"Your friends," she said. "The ones you don't remember."

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty

# **A Fire Far from Renere**

It was on the road to Imre, somewhere in the Commonwealth hills, that Denna told me about the nightingale.

I have told you that part already. The duke's feast, and the black silk dress, and the true song sung in the great hall. I put it where it belonged, in the middle of the grey, because it was one of the bright things. But I did not hear it until later. Until that night. Beside a fire, in a hollow between two hills, far from Renere.

The troupe had stopped for the night in a sheltered place off the road, where a stand of old oaks grew around a spring. The wagons were drawn up in a half circle. The horses were hobbled and grazing. Mirra was cooking something in a great iron pot that smelled of onions and rabbit, and Brin was sawing at his fiddle, and Nell was chasing Kellen's youngest around the wagons, shrieking.

Denna and I sat a little apart, at the edge of the firelight, under one of the oaks. She had built a small fire of our own, just for the two of us. She said the big fire was too loud. She said she wanted to talk to me, and she wanted it to be quiet.

So we sat by our small fire, and she held my hand, and she talked.

\* \* \*

She told me about the duke, and the feast, and the song. She told me about singing Ambrose with love. She told me about the duke weeping at his high table, and walking out alone, and never threatening her again.

I listened. I did not understand all of it. I did not remember the duke, or Ambrose, or the song. But I listened, and when she was done, I asked her why.

"Why what?"

"Why you did it. You knew he could have killed you."

She told me. I have told you what she said. *Because it was true. I owed the truth something. After that. I owed it a song.*

And then she was quiet for a long time, looking into the fire.

"Can I tell you something else?" she said at last. "Something I've never told anyone?"

"Yes."

She did not speak right away. She sat with her knees drawn up and her arms around them, the way she always sat when she was uncomfortable, and she looked into the small fire.

"My name," she said. "My real one. Not Denna, or Dianne, or Dinael, or any of the others. The one I was born with."

I waited.

"I don't know it," she said.

\* \* \*

She told me the rest slowly. In pieces. The way you tell something you have kept locked away for a very long time.

She did not know where she had been born. She did not know who her parents were. Her earliest memory was of a ditch, beside a road, in the rain. She had been four, perhaps. Or five. She had been cold and hungry and alone, and she did not know how she had got there.

A woman had found her. A peddler, traveling the roads with a cart full of pots and pans. The woman had taken her in, and fed her, and called her *girl*, because she did not know what else to call her. They had traveled together for three years. Then the woman had died, of a fever, in a town whose name Denna did not remember. And Denna had been alone again.

"I made up a name," she said. "That first night, after she died. I was eight, I think. Sitting in a stable, in the straw, with the horses. I



thought, I have to be called something. Everyone's called something." She smiled faintly. "So I called myself Dinnah. After a horse. There was a horse in the stable called Dinnah, and she was very beautiful, and very gentle, and she let me sleep against her side."

"A horse."

"A horse." Denna laughed softly. "And the next town I went to, I was someone else. And the next. And the next. I changed my name every time I changed towns. Because I didn't have a real one. Because none of them were me." She was quiet for a moment. "Because if I had a name, someone could find me. Someone could hold on to me. And every time anyone had ever held on to me, they'd let go."

I did not say anything. I held her hand.

"And then Bredon found me," she said. "When I was fourteen. In a tavern in Anilin, singing for coppers. He came up to me afterward and said I had a remarkable voice, and that he could help me. And I believed him." She looked at the fire. "He gave me lessons. He gave me clothes. He gave me a place to live. And one night, a few months after he found me, he sat me down and told me he was going to teach me something very special."

"The knots."

"The knots." She nodded. "He said the Yllish knots weren't just writing. He said they could hold things. Names, and promises, and stories. He said that if I learned them well enough, I could tie my own name into a cord, and then I'd always have it, and no one could ever take it away." Her voice was very quiet. "I wanted that more than anything. More than food, more than music. A name that was mine. That I could hold."

"Did he teach you?"

"He taught me." She looked down at her hands. "And then, when I'd learned enough, he helped me tie it. My name. The one I didn't know. He said the knots would find it, if I tied them right. He said they'd reach down inside me and pull it out and hold it, so I could see it."

"And did they?"

Denna was quiet for a very long time.

"Yes," she said at last. "They did. I tied the cord, and I felt it. Something reaching down, and catching hold, and pulling. And there it was. My name. My real one. In the knots." She looked at me. Her eyes were wet. "And then he took it."

\* \* \*

I sat very still.

"He took it," said Denna. "The cord. With my name in it. He said he'd keep it safe for me. He said I wasn't ready to carry it yet. He said I'd lose it, or someone would steal it, or I'd use it wrong." She laughed, a small broken sound. "And I believed him. I was fourteen. I believed everything he said."

"And then he tied the knot on your wrist."

"The same night. With a piece of the same cord." She held up her wrist. The knot was gone now, fallen off in the chamber when Bredon went through the door. But there was a mark where it had been. A thin pale line around her wrist, like a bracelet. Like the mark on mine would be, someday. "He said it was a promise. That I'd serve him, and he'd keep my name safe. And as long as I kept my promise, he'd keep his." She lowered her hand. "It was my own name, Kvothe. Tied around my own wrist. That was what held me. That was what he pulled on, all those years. Not his power. Mine."

I looked at her for a long time.

"Where is it now?" I said. "The cord. With your name."

Denna looked into the fire.

"I don't know," she said. "He always kept it with him. In a pocket, or a pouch, or in the head of his stick. I never saw where." She was quiet for a moment. "I think he took it with him. Through the door."

\* \* \*

We sat in silence for a long time after that. The fire burned low. Across the hollow, at the big fire, the troupe was singing. "Tinker Tanner," with all the rude verses. Nell's voice rose above the others, high and piercing and slightly off key.

"So I don't have a name either," said Denna at last. "Not really. It's on the other side of a door that can never be opened." She laughed softly. "We're a fine pair, aren't we? Two people with no names, sitting by a fire in the middle of nowhere."

"You have a name," I said.

She looked at me.

"Denna," I said. "That's your name. That's the one I—" I stopped. I did not know what I had been going to say. There was a feeling in the hole in my chest, very faint, like a word on the tip of my tongue.

"The one you what?"

I looked down at the cord on my wrist. At the knots, glowing faintly in the firelight. I felt the feeling again. Stronger, this time. A tug. A pull. Something in the cord reaching out toward her.

"The one I remember," I said slowly. "Sometimes. When the cord hums. That's the one I remember."

Denna stared at me.

"You remember me?"

"Sometimes. For a moment." I touched the cord. "When you're close. It's like—a word I almost know. A face I almost recognize." I looked up at her. "It's always *Denna*. Never any of the others. Just that."

She looked at me for a long time. Her face was very strange in the firelight. Wet, and shining, and full of something I did not have a name for.

"Then that's my name," she said softly. "That's the one. If you remember it, that's the one that's real."

\* \* \*

She reached into the neck of my shirt. I did not stop her. She found the thread there, the one I had worn around my neck since before the Eolian, and drew it out. There was a knot on it. A small knot, tied in dark cord. *Road. Promise. A story told many times, and changes in the telling.*

"Do you know what this is?" she said.

"No."

"I gave it to you. A long time ago. In Imre. The first time I taught you knots." She held it in her palm. "I didn't know, then, what it was. I thought it was just a keepsake. A pretty knot. But I tied it the way he'd taught me to tie my own name, and I put a little of myself in it without knowing." She looked at me. "There's a knot at the heart of it. Very small. Do you see?"

I looked. There was. A tiny knot, so small and so tight I could barely see it, at the very center.

"That's me," said Denna. "The part of me that knew you. That's what brought you back, at the Eolian, when the song emptied you out. You held onto it, and it held onto you." She closed her hand around the knot. "I didn't know I'd done it. But I'm glad I did."

She put it back inside my shirt. She laid her hand flat over it, over my heart.

"Keep it," she said. "Always. Whatever else happens. Wherever you go. Keep it."

"I will."

"Promise me."

I looked at her. At her dark eyes, and her wet face, and her hand on my chest.

"I promise," I said.

\* \* \*

She told me, then, what she thought we should do.

She had been thinking about it, she said, all the way from Renere. Lying awake at night in the back of the wagon, holding my hand, feeling the cord on my wrist hum.

"It's too loud," she said. "The cord. It's got your whole name in it. The whole line. Everything the door used to answer to." She touched it, very gently. "And it's right here. On your wrist. Where anything that's listening can hear it. The Seven. The Thief. Whatever else is out there." She looked at me. "And you're right here with it. Walking around. Where anyone could find you. And if they found you, and took it, and carried it to the door—"

"The door would open."

"And there'd be no one left to close it." She was quiet for a moment. "We need to put it somewhere. Somewhere safe. Somewhere that says no to everyone but you. And then you need to go somewhere else. Somewhere no one would ever look."

"Apart from it?"

"Not too far. It's your name. It needs to be near you, or you'll fade. Like—" She hesitated. "Like a candle without a wick. Elodin said so, I think. Or someone did." She shook her head. "Near you. But not on you. In something that holds."

"What?"

Denna looked at me. Then she looked across the hollow, at the big fire, at the Ruh singing around it.

"I don't know," she said. "Not exactly. But I know who might." She smiled faintly. "A man who makes things. And a girl who knows stone. And a master who knows names. And a woman with spectacles who can make a dead man walk to the gallows." She looked back at me. "You have very clever friends, Kvothe. Even if you don't remember them."

\* \* \*

We sat by the fire until it burned down to embers. Across the hollow, the big fire burned down too, and the singing stopped, and the troupe went to their wagons and their blankets. The night grew quiet. The stars came out, very bright and very far away.

At last Denna lay down beside me in the grass, with her head on my shoulder and her hand on my chest, over the knot.

"Kvothe," she said sleepily.

"Yes?"

"When we get to Imre. When it's done. When your name's put away somewhere safe." She was quiet for a moment. "I'm going to have to go."

I did not say anything.

"I'm the one who tied it," she said. "I'm the only one who knows how. If anyone ever wanted to open it, they'd need me. And if they found me, they'd find you." Her voice was very soft. "So I have to go."

Far away. Somewhere no one knows me. And I have to stay there." She paused. "And I have to not come back. Not ever. Not even if I want to. Especially not if I want to."

"Is that what you want?"

She laughed softly against my shoulder.

"No," she said. "No. It's the last thing I want." She was quiet for a long time. "But it's the right thing. You taught me that. Choose, and bear what comes after."

"I don't remember teaching you that."

"You didn't. Not in words." She pressed her face against my shoulder. "You taught me by doing it. In the chamber. When you pulled your name out and handed it to me." Her voice cracked. "I never saw anyone do anything so brave. Or so stupid."

"Those are often the same thing."

She laughed. It was a broken, astonished, beautiful laugh.

"Yes," she said. "Yes. They are."

She fell asleep, after a while. I lay awake beside her with her head on my shoulder and her hand on my chest, and I looked up at the stars, and I did not sleep.

The stars were grey. Everything was grey.

But the cord on my wrist was humming. Very softly. All night long.

And somewhere very far down, at the bottom of the hole where my name had been, something was humming back.

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-One

# The Farmer's Daughter

We stopped for a night at a farm in the Commonwealth hills, three days out from Imre, because of the rain.

It had been raining since dawn. Not a storm; nothing so dramatic. Just a steady, grey, relentless rain that soaked through cloaks and boots and blankets and skin, and turned the road to mud, and the mud to a thick brown soup that sucked at the cart wheels. By afternoon, the horse was stumbling. Bast was swearing in a language I did not know. And Denna, walking beside the cart with her hood pulled low, was shivering so hard I could hear her teeth.

I was not shivering. I did not feel the cold. That was one of the things about the grey: you did not feel much of anything. I sat in the back of the cart with my knees drawn up and the rain running off my hair, and I looked at the wet hills going by, and I did not feel anything at all.

The farm was at the bottom of a long slope, beside a stream. A low stone house with a thatched roof, and a barn, and a yard full of mud and chickens. There was smoke coming from the chimney. Denna looked at it for a long time.

"We'll ask," she said.

\* \* \*

The farmer was a big, stooped, silent man named Horrin, with a face like a potato and hands like shovels. He looked at us for a long time from his doorway: at Denna, soaked and shivering, and Bast, with his

too-bright eyes, and me, sitting in the back of the cart like a sack of grain.

"What's wrong with him?" he said.

"He was hurt," said Denna. "In the war. In his head."

Horrin looked at me for a while longer. Then he nodded slowly.

"My brother came back like that," he said. "From Three Rivers. Didn't talk for a year." He stepped back from the door. "Barn's dry. There's hay. You can have supper with us, if you want. It's only soup."

\* \* \*

It was only soup. Barley and onions and a little salt pork, in a big iron pot over the fire. We sat around the table in the single room of the stone house, the three of us and Horrin and his wife, a thin quick woman named Bet, and their four children.

The children stared at us. Of course they did. Strangers were rare, that far out in the hills. The youngest two, a pair of twin boys about five, stared at Bast, who made faces at them when their mother was not looking until they giggled into their soup. The oldest, a lanky boy of twelve, stared at Denna, and went red whenever she looked at him.

And the girl stared at me.

She was about nine. Small and thin, with a pointed face and straight brown hair and very large grey eyes. She sat across the table from me and did not eat her soup. She just looked at me, very steadily, the whole meal, with an expression I could not read.

When the meal was over and Bet was clearing the bowls, the girl got down from her stool and came around the table and stood in front of me.

"You're a musician," she said.

I did not answer. I did not know how.

"Wren," said her mother sharply. "Leave the man be."

"But he is," said the girl. She pointed at my hands, resting on the table. "Look at his fingers. They've got hard bits on the ends. Like Uncle Fen's. Uncle Fen played the fiddle." She looked at me. "Before he went to the war. After, he didn't anymore."

The room was very quiet.



\* \* \*

"He did play," said Denna softly. "He used to play the lute. Better than anyone in the world."

Wren looked at her. Then back at me.

"Why doesn't he now?"

Denna did not answer for a long moment.

"He forgot how," she said at last.

Wren frowned. She looked at my hands again, lying on the table. At the calluses on the tips of my fingers.

"His hands didn't forget," she said. "You can see. They remember."

Nobody said anything. Horrin looked at his daughter. Bet stood by the washbasin with a bowl in her hands, very still. Bast had stopped making faces at the twins.

"Have you got a lute?" said Wren. "In your cart?"

"Yes," said Denna.

"Can I see it?"

Denna looked at me. I did not look back. I was looking at the table.

"All right," said Denna.

\* \* \*

Bast went out to the cart and brought it in. Not my own lute. That was wrapped in oilcloth at the bottom of the cart, and I would not touch it, and I would not let anyone else touch it either. This was an old lute Denna had bought in a market town the week before, cheap and battered, with a crack in the soundboard patched with glue. She had bought it, she told me later, because she thought I might want it. I had not touched it.

Bast set it on the table in front of me. I looked at it.

Wren looked at me.

"Go on," she said.

I did not move.

"Wren," said her father. His deep voice was gentle. "Uncle Fen couldn't either. Remember? When you gave him his fiddle. He tried, and he couldn't, and he cried." He put his big hand on her shoulder. "Some things don't come back."

Wren did not look at him. She was looking at me. With her large grey eyes.

And then she did something none of us expected. She reached out, very carefully, and picked up my right hand from the table. Her hand was small and warm and a little sticky from the soup. She lifted my hand and put it on the lute, on the strings, over the soundhole. And then she picked up my left hand and put it on the neck, with my fingers resting on the frets.

"There," she said. "Now they know where they are."

\* \* \*

I do not know what happened then. I have tried to remember, and I cannot. I remember the lute under my hands. The smooth worn wood of the neck, and the strings, cold and taut, under my fingertips. I remember the fire crackling, and the rain on the thatch, and Wren standing in front of me with her serious pointed face.

And I remember that my hands moved.

They played the way they had played by the fire, weeks before, when Denna put my own lute in my lap. Clean chords. Correct chords. Every note in its place, and nothing in any of them. A painting of a fire, hung on a wall.

Denna looked away. I saw her do it.

But Wren did not look away. She stood in front of me with her serious pointed face, and she listened, and she frowned. And then she did something no one had done, by the fire, weeks before. She began to hum.

She did not hum well. She was nine, and tone-deaf, and she did not know the chords I was playing. She hummed an old nursery tune instead, a farm song about a goose that would not lay, flat and wandering and nothing like what my hands were doing. But she hummed it right at me, standing between my knees with her small

hands on the edge of the table. As if she were trying to show my hands where to go.

And my hands followed her.

Not well. They stumbled, trying to find her wandering tune. They missed. They found it. They lost it again. It was not clean anymore. It was not correct. It was clumsy and slow and a little out of tune, because the lute was cheap and I had not tuned it.

And for one chord—only one—in the middle of a farm song about a stubborn goose, it was not nothing.

It was a minor chord. A sad one. It came out of the cracked soundboard soft and hesitant in the quiet room, and there was something in it. Not much. A little warmth, at the very bottom. Like the last coal in a banked fire.

Wren stopped humming. She smiled.

"See?" she said. "They remember."

\* \* \*

I did not feel anything. I want to be honest about that. I did not feel joy, or grief, or relief. I sat at the table in the farmhouse with the lute in my hands and I watched my fingers moving on the strings as if they were someone else's fingers. As if I were watching a stranger play, from very far away, through a grey fog.

But Denna was crying. I saw that. She was sitting beside me at the table with her hands pressed to her mouth, and tears were running down her face, and she did not make a sound.

And Bast was staring at my hands with an expression of such naked hope that it was painful to look at.

And Horrin had put his arm around his wife, and she was crying too, a little. For her husband's brother, I think. Who had not been able to do this.

And Wren just stood there, with her serious grey eyes, and watched my hands. And when they stopped, at last, and lay still on the strings, she nodded, very solemnly, as if something had been settled.

"You should play every day," she said. "So they don't forget again. Uncle Fen didn't. That was his mistake."

\* \* \*

We left in the morning. The rain had stopped. The hills were green and wet and shining in the early light.

Wren came out to the cart as Bast was hitching the horse. She was carrying something wrapped in a scrap of cloth. She held it up to me, where I sat in the back of the cart.

"It's Uncle Fen's," she said. "His fiddle bow. He broke the fiddle, after. When he couldn't play. But he didn't break the bow." She pushed it into my hands. "I kept it. I thought someone might need it."

I looked down at it. A fiddle bow, old and worn, with the horsehair gone grey and slack. It was no use to me. I did not play the fiddle.

"Thank you," said Denna, beside me. Her voice was thick. "Thank you, Wren."

"It's not for you," said Wren. "It's for him." She looked at me very seriously. "For when you forget. You can hold it, and remember that somebody else couldn't. And you can."

\* \* \*

I kept the bow. I do not know why. It went into the cart, and then into my pack, and then, when we came to Newarre, into a drawer upstairs at the Waystone, where it lay for seven years with a few other small things I could not explain keeping.

I did not play every day. I did not play at all, after that night. Not for seven years. Wren would have been disappointed in me.

But my hands did not forget. She was right about that. In all those grey years, behind the bar, polishing the same glasses over and over, my fingers never lost their calluses. They moved on their own sometimes, late at night, on the wood of the bar. Chords. Sad and slow. Going nowhere.

Remembering where they were.

\* \* \*

"You still have it?" said Chronicler. "The bow?"

"Upstairs." The innkeeper looked at his hands. "In the drawer. With Kilvin's candle." He was quiet for a moment. "I took it out, the night Shep died. After Aaron. After I tried to name the thing and there was nothing there." He turned his hands over, palm up, and looked at the calluses on his fingertips. "I sat on my bed and held it all night. And I thought about a little girl in a farmhouse, who said somebody else couldn't. And you can."

"Did it help?"

The innkeeper did not answer for a long time.

"I'm here," he said at last. "Telling you this. With my hands on the table." He almost smiled. "I think that's what she'd call helping."

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Two

# Across the Bridge

We came to Imre at the beginning of autumn, a year and a season after I had left it.

I did not know it. I want to be honest about that. We came over the last hill in the late afternoon, and there it was below us, a town of grey stone and brown roofs on the bank of a wide brown river, with a great stone bridge arching across the water to another town on the far side. And beyond that other town, rising above its roofs, a great grey windowless building like a block of stone that had decided to stand up in the middle of the road.

I looked at it all, and I felt nothing. It was a town. A river. A bridge. A building. That was all.

But Denna, sitting beside me in the back of the wagon, went very still. And her hand, holding mine, tightened.

"Do you remember?" she whispered.

"No."

"The Archives. The University. The Eolian." She pointed. "The bridge. You used to stop at the top of it, every time you crossed. You told me once. You'd stop and look out at the river. You said it made you feel like the world was big enough."

I looked at the bridge. At its great grey arch, curving up and over the brown water.

"I don't remember," I said.

She did not say anything. But she did not let go of my hand.

\* \* \*

They were waiting for us at the foot of the bridge, on the Imre side. All of them. Someone must have sent word ahead; Tessit, perhaps, or Bast, who had gone ahead of the troupe two days before without telling anyone where he was going.

There was a thin young man with straw-colored hair and a black patch over his left eye, with a white star sewn on it. There was a dark man with scarred hands, standing very straight. There was a small fair woman with spectacles and no eyebrows, which made her look perpetually surprised. There was a girl with dark hair and a pale face, holding something small and grey in her hand.

And there was a lean man with dark restless eyes, sitting on the stone rail of the bridge with his legs dangling, eating an apple.

I did not know any of them.

The wagon stopped. I climbed down from the back. I stood in the road at the foot of the bridge and looked at them, and they looked at me.

Nobody moved.

Then the thin young man with the eye patch made a sound. A small, broken sound, like a sob that had been caught halfway. And he ran at me, and threw his arms around me, and held on.

"You're alive," he said into my shoulder. "You're alive, you're alive, you're *alive*—"

I stood very still in his arms. I did not know him. I did not know what to do.

"Sim," said the small fair woman sharply. "Sim, he doesn't—"

"I know he doesn't." The young man did not let go. His voice was muffled and wet. "I know he doesn't remember me. I don't care. He's *alive*. They hanged him and he's *alive*." He pulled back and looked at me with his one eye. It was very bright. "I wrote a poem about you, you know. When I heard. For your funeral. It was terrible. The worst thing I ever wrote." He laughed wetly. "I'm so glad I don't have to read it."

I looked at him. At his thin eager face, and his one bright eye, and the black patch with the white star.

"Sim," I said.

He went very still.

"That's your name," I said. "Sim. She said it."

His face crumpled. He put his hand over his mouth.

"Yes," he said through his fingers. "Yes. That's my name."

\* \* \*

They took me to the Grey Man.

It was an inn on the western edge of Imre, tall and narrow and built of grey stone, with a sign that showed a man in a grey cloak with his face in shadow. Denna said we had stayed there once. Or she had, and I had come to see her. She had taught me something there, she said. Knots.

I did not remember.

The landlord gave us the whole top floor. Three rooms, connected, with windows that looked out over the rooftops toward the river. Someone had paid for it. A round little man in a purple coat, who came bustling up the stairs an hour after we arrived and threw his arms around me and wept, and called me *my dear boy*, and said a great many things about statues and noses that I did not understand.

His name was Threpe. He had paid for everything, it seemed. The rooms, the food, the wine. The horses that had carried my friends south to the war. The paper and ink for Sim's terrible poems.

"Anything," he said, holding my hands in his and looking up at me with wet shining eyes. "Anything you need. Anything at all. You only have to ask."

"Thank you," I said. I did not know what else to say.

He looked at me for a long moment. Then his face fell, just slightly.

"You really don't remember," he said. "Do you?"

"No."

"Not the Eolian? Not the song? Not the night you sang *Tariniei* and the whole world stopped to listen?"

"No."

Threpe was quiet for a long time. Then he squeezed my hands.



"Well," he said. "I remember. I'll remember for you. Until you can remember for yourself." He smiled, a little shakily. "That's what patrons are for."

\* \* \*

Elodin came that night.

He did not come up the stairs. He came in through the window. I was sitting on the bed in the largest of the three rooms, with Denna beside me and the others scattered around on chairs and on the floor, and the window was open to the cool autumn night. And then, between one moment and the next, there was a man sitting on the windowsill, with his legs dangling inside the room, eating an apple.

Nobody had seen him climb up. Nobody ever did.

"Hello, Kvothe," he said.

I looked at him. I did not know him. But something in me went very still when I saw him. The way it had gone still when Vashet looked at me. As if some part of me knew that this was a person who could see things other people could not.

"Hello," I said.

Elodin looked at me for a long time. His dark eyes were very sharp. Then he swung his legs over the sill and dropped into the room and came across to the bed. He knelt in front of me. He put down his apple on the floor.

"May I?" he said, and held out his hand.

I did not know what he meant. But Denna did. She took my left hand, gently, and held it out to him. The one with the cord.

Elodin did not touch the cord. He held his hand above it, an inch away, the way you hold your hand above a fire to feel its heat. He closed his eyes.

The room was very quiet.

"Oh," said Elodin softly. "Oh. Oh, that's very loud."

He opened his eyes. He looked at me. His face was strange.

"Do you know what you've done?" he said.

"No."

"No. Of course you don't." He sat back on his heels. "You've done what I did. At seventeen. What put me in Haven for three years. Only you did it on purpose, and you did it all the way, and you did it *right*." He shook his head slowly. "I didn't think it could be done right. I didn't think anyone could survive it."

"I don't know if I have."

"You have. You're sitting here. You're talking. You're breathing." Elodin looked at the cord. "You're not broken. Not like I was. You're not torn in half. You're just—empty. Set aside. Put down." He looked up at Denna. "You did this?"

"I tied it," said Denna. "He pulled it out. I caught it."

Elodin looked at her for a long moment.

"Where did you learn to tie a name?" he said quietly.

Denna did not answer right away. Then she said, "From a man who used it to steal mine."

Elodin's face went very still. Then he nodded, slowly, as if she had told him something important.

"Well," he said. "You learned it well. Better than he did, I think." He looked back at the cord. "It's holding. Perfectly. Every strand. Every piece of him is in there, safe." He paused. "And it's screaming."

\* \* \*

The room went very quiet.

"Screaming?" said the young man with the eye patch. Sim. "What do you mean, screaming?"

Elodin did not look at him. He was looking at the cord.

"A name is a loud thing," he said. "Especially a true one. Especially a big one. It wants to be *in* something. It wants to be what it is. Put it in a cord and tie it up tight, and it'll sit there, and it'll be safe. But it'll be loud. Like a bird in a cage, singing." He looked up at me. "Anyone who knows how to listen can hear it. From very far away."

"The Seven," said the dark man with scarred hands. Wil, someone had called him.

"The Seven. The Thief, maybe, from behind his door, if the crack is wide enough. Other things." Elodin looked at the cord. "It's been on

his wrist for a year. Singing. I'm surprised no one's come for it yet."

"They thought he was dead," said the small fair woman. Devi.  
"They hanged him. In front of ten thousand people."

"That might have bought him some time. A little. Death is a very loud story too; it drowns out a lot of other noise." Elodin shook his head. "But not forever. Sooner or later, someone will hear it. And follow it. And find him."

"Then what do we do?" said Denna.

Elodin looked at her. Then at me. Then at the cord.

"We make it quiet," he said.

\* \* \*

"How?" said Denna.

Elodin was silent for a long time. He sat on his heels on the floor in front of the bed, with his dark eyes on the cord, and he thought. We all waited.

"It needs to be put away," he said at last. "In something that holds. Something that says no. To everyone but him." He looked up. "A box, I think. Or a chest. Something with walls. Something that the name can sit inside of, and be quiet, and not be heard."

"Like the Lackless box," said Denna slowly. "The one with no lid."

"Yes. Very like that." Elodin nodded. "That box was made to hold the key. To keep it safe, and quiet, and close, for a thousand years. We need something like it. For the name."

"Can you make it?"

"Me? No." Elodin laughed. "I can't make anything. I've never made anything in my life. I break things. That's my gift." He looked around the room. At Wil, and Devi, and the girl with dark hair who had not spoken yet. "But I know people who can."

The girl with dark hair stood up.

She had been sitting on the floor in the corner, very quiet, with her hands folded in her lap. She had been holding something small and grey in one of them, the whole time. She came across the room now and stood in front of me, and held it out.

It was a stone. A small flat grey stone, about the size of a coin, worn smooth. There was a single mark scratched into it. A line, very straight, with a small curve at one end.

"You have one like this," she said. "In your pocket. I gave it to you. A long time ago. You promised to give it back."

I reached into my pocket. I did not know why. My hand found something there. Small and flat and cool. I took it out.

It was the same. The twin of the one in her hand. A small flat grey stone, with a mark scratched into it.

"Fela," said Denna softly. "Her name's Fela."

The girl with dark hair looked at me. Her eyes were very dark and very serious.

"I've been learning," she said. "At the University. With Elodin. All year. Learning stone. Learning how to ask it for things. How to make it hold." She held up her stone, beside mine. "I can make a lock. A stone lock. That says no to everyone but you."

"Everyone but me," I said. "But I'm not me. Not anymore."

Fela looked at me for a long moment.

"No," she said. "Not now. But you will be. Someday. When it's safe." She took my stone out of my hand, and held both of them together in her palm. "And when you are, the lock will know you. It'll open. Just for you."

"And until then?"

"Until then," said Fela, "it'll stay closed. Forever, if it has to." She closed her hand around the two stones. "Stone's very good at forever."

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Three

# The Ledger

Devi came to see me on the third day in Imre, in the morning, when the others were at the University. She came up the stairs of the Grey Man with a large leather-bound book under one arm and a pot of tea in the other hand, and she kicked the door of my room open without knocking, and set both down on the table by the window.

"Sit," she said.

I sat. She poured two cups of tea. She pushed one across the table to me. Then she sat down across from me and opened the book.

It was a ledger. I could see that much. Columns of names and figures, in a small, neat, very sharp hand. Pages and pages of them. She turned the pages slowly, running one finger down the columns, until she came to a page near the back. Then she turned the book around and pushed it across the table, beside my tea.

"That's you," she said.

\* \* \*

I looked at it. There was a name at the top of the page. *Kvotthe*. And beneath it, a long column of entries. Dates and amounts. Some in ink, and some in pencil, and some crossed out and written over.

I did not understand it. I did not understand much, then. I looked at the name at the top of the page and it meant nothing to me. A word. A sound.

"You don't remember," said Devi. It was not a question. She was watching my face.

"No."

"No. Sim said you wouldn't." She picked up her tea and looked at me over the rim of the cup with her sharp blue eyes. They looked very strange, under her bare brow. Very wide. Very surprised. As if she had just heard something she could not quite believe. "I'm going to tell you anyway. Because somebody should. And because I've been carrying this ledger around for two years, and I'm tired of it."

\* \* \*

She told me.

She told me about a boy of fifteen who came up her stairs in the rain with a lute on his back and nothing in his purse, and borrowed four talents at a rate that would have made a Cealdish banker weep. She told me about the loans after that. For tuition, and lute strings, and a new shirt, and a hundred other things. How he always paid back. Late, sometimes. With a great deal of wheedling and charm. But always.

She told me about a night in her rooms, above the butcher's shop, when he had come to her bleeding and burned, and she had stitched him up and not asked any questions. She told me about a page. A page from a book in the Archives, that she had stolen for him, at great risk, the day after the Nighting. And how he had tried to give it back to her, in the hills of Vintas, the night before a raid on a king's camp. And how she would not take it.

She told me about the raid. About what she had made, in a borrowed tent, out of powders and salts and a great deal of stolen lamp oil. About the moment it went off, in the horse lines of the king's army, and lit up the whole valley like noon.

"That's where they went," she said. She touched her bare brow with one finger. "My eyebrows. I was too close when it went up. Singed them right off. They never grew back." She shrugged. "The physicians say they might. Someday. I've stopped caring."

And she told me about a hanging. About a dead man in a cold cellar, and two days of alchemy she would not describe, and standing in a crowd at the foot of a gallows in the great square of Renere,

holding a binding with her whole mind while a dead man with red hair walked up the steps.

"That," she said, "was the hardest thing I have ever done. And I have done some very hard things."

\* \* \*

I listened. I did not feel anything. I sat at the table by the window with my tea going cold in front of me and I listened to this small fierce woman with no eyebrows tell me about a boy I did not remember, and the things she had done for him. And I looked at the ledger, with its long column of figures.

"It's a lot," I said at last.

"It's a great deal." Devi tapped the page. "Four talents, at the start. Then more. Then the stitching, which I charge for. Then the page, which I stole for you at considerable risk to myself, which I also charge for." Her finger moved down the column. "Then the raid. Materials, labor, and one pair of eyebrows. Then the hanging." She stopped. "I've never been able to work out what to charge for the hanging. I've tried. I keep changing the figure." She looked at the crossed-out numbers. "There isn't a number for that. Not really."

"How much?" I said. "All of it?"

She told me.

It was a very large number. I did not have it. I did not have anything. Everything I owned was in a cart in the yard of the Grey Man, and most of it was going into a box.

"I can't pay it," I said.

"No," said Devi. "I didn't think you could."

\* \* \*

She looked at me for a long time across the table. The morning light came in through the window and fell across her face. She looked tired, I thought. Tired and fierce and very young, under the bare brow.

"Do you know what I said to you?" she said. "After the hanging? When you were in the wagon with the Ruh, and I came to see you before I went back to Imre?"

"No."

"I said you owed me. So much. More than you could pay in a hundred years." She looked down at the ledger. "I said it because I was angry. And frightened. And I hadn't slept in a span, and I kept seeing that dead man walking up the steps with his hood on." She was quiet for a moment. "And because I wanted you to feel it. The weight of it. I wanted you to know what it had cost."

"I'm sorry," I said. I did not know why I said it. It seemed like what she wanted.

"No you're not." Devi's voice was not unkind. "You can't be. You don't remember enough to be sorry." She picked up her tea, and drank it, and set the cup down. "That's what I realized. On the road back from Renere. You were sitting in the back of that wagon, grey as a stone, and I'd just told you that you owed me more than you could ever pay. And you looked at me and said *all right*. Like I'd told you it might rain." She shook her head. "And I thought: what's the point? What's the point of a debt, if the person who owes it doesn't know he owes it?"

\* \* \*

She reached out and took the ledger back. She looked at the page for a long moment. At the name at the top. At the long column of figures, and the crossed-out numbers at the bottom.

Then she took hold of the page, very carefully, near the spine. And she tore it out.

I watched her. I did not understand.

She folded the page in half. Then in half again. She held it for a moment in her small ink-stained hands. Then she reached across the table and tucked it into the front of my shirt, against my chest.

"There," she said. "It's yours now. Put it in your box, with the rest. With your name and your lute and whatever else." She sat back. "When you get it all back—when you're you again—you can take it out and look at it. And you'll know what you owe."

"And then I'll pay it?"

"No." Devi smiled. It was a strange smile, under her bare brow. Crooked and fierce and very sad. "Then you'll know you *don't* have to.



Because it's not in my book anymore. It's in yours." She closed the ledger. "I don't hold debts I can't collect. It's bad business. And I'm very good at business."

\* \* \*

She stood up. She picked up the ledger and the teapot. At the door, she stopped, and looked back at me.

"One more thing," she said. "When you're you again. Come and see me. Not to pay. Just to see me." She was quiet for a moment. "I'd like to hear you say thank you. When you actually mean it. When you actually know what for."

"I will," I said.

"You won't remember saying that."

"No."

"Well." Devi shrugged. "I'll remember. That'll have to do."

And she went down the stairs, and I heard the door of the Grey Man bang shut behind her, and her quick sharp footsteps going away up the street.

\* \* \*

The folded page went into the chest. I put it there myself, the night they made the chest in the Fishery, when the others were laying their things inside. Devi watched from across the room with her arms folded. She did not say anything. She only nodded, once, when I laid it beside Sim's poem.

It was still there, seven years later. When the chest opened. When I opened it.

I read it that afternoon, sitting by the fire in the common room of the Waystone, after Sim's poem, with Bast asleep in his chair and the whole town of Newarre still talking about me in low voices in the square outside.

I read every line. Every figure. Every crossed-out number at the bottom.

And I laughed, and then I wept, and then I laughed again. Because at the very bottom of the page, beneath all the crossed-out

numbers, in a different ink, very small, she had written one more line. She must have written it that morning, at the table by the window, before she tore the page out. While I sat across from her and watched and did not understand.

*Paid in full. —D.*

\* \* \*

"Have you written to her?" said Chronicler softly. "Since?"

"Not yet." The innkeeper looked at the fire. "I'm going to go and see her. Instead. When this is done." He almost smiled. "She asked me to say thank you. When I knew what for." He was quiet for a moment. "I think I'll need to say it in person. It's too big for a letter."

"Will she have eyebrows?"

The innkeeper looked at him. And then, for a moment, something moved at the corner of his mouth.

"I hope not," he said. "I don't think I'd recognize her."

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Four

### **A Small Name**

Auri came to me on the second night, on the roof of the Grey Man.

I do not know how she knew I was there. I did not know who she was. I had gone up onto the roof because the rooms were too full, and too warm, and too loud with people who remembered me and wanted me to remember them. I had climbed out the window and up the slates to the ridge, and I was sitting there with my knees drawn up, looking out at the grey rooftops of Imre and the grey river beyond them and the grey bulk of the building with no windows on the far bank.

And she was there. Sitting beside me on the ridge, with her knees drawn up too, and her bare feet very clean on the slates. I had not heard her come. I had not heard anything.

She was very small. Very thin. Her hair floated around her head like a cloud of silk, pale as a dandelion's ghost. She wore a simple dress that had once been white. There was a ribbon in her hair, very faded, the color of the sky before rain.

She did not say anything for a long time. She sat beside me on the ridge of the roof and looked out at the river, the way I was looking.

Then she said, "You're on the wrong side of the river again."

I looked at her. "Am I?"

"Yes. You always are, now." She tilted her head. "They won't let you come to the right side. Master Elodin says. Because of what you did, with the deep door." She looked at me with enormous eyes. "So I came to this side instead. Through the old drain by the water. It's very wet. I don't like it." She wrinkled her nose. "But I came."

"Why?"

She looked at me for a long moment. Her eyes were very large and very grey in the grey light.

"Because you were sad," she said simply. "I could feel it. All the way across the river. The stones told me." She tucked her feet up under her dress. "The stones always tell me when you're sad."

\* \* \*

I did not know her. I want that understood. I did not know her name, or where she lived, or why she had crossed a river through a wet drain to sit on a roof with a stranger.

But I did not feel like a stranger, sitting beside her. The cord on my wrist was not humming. It was quiet. But something else was. Something I could not name. A kind of stillness, settling over me, the way stillness settles over a pond at dusk.

"I don't know who you are," I said.

"I know." She did not seem troubled by it. "That's all right. I don't mind. You didn't know who I was the first time either." She smiled, a small quick smile. "You played music on a roof, and I came to listen, and you didn't know me at all. And then you did."

"I don't remember."

"You don't have to. I remember for both of us." She looked out at the river. "I'm very good at remembering. Much better than most people. I remember things that happened a long time ago, before I came here. I just don't talk about them." She was quiet for a moment. "You never asked me to. That's one of the things I like about you."

\* \* \*

We sat on the roof for a long time. The sun went down behind the hills to the west, and the sky went from grey to darker grey to black. The stars came out. The lights of Imre came on, one by one, in the windows below us.

She did not talk much. Neither did I. It was the easiest silence I had known since the cellar. Easier than with Denna, who was always watching me, waiting for me to remember. Easier than with the others,

who wanted things from me I did not have to give.

This girl did not want anything. She only sat.

At last she said, "You don't have a name."

"No."

"I can see it. There's a hole where it should be." She looked at my chest, as if she could see through my shirt, through my skin, into the place where my name had been. "It's very sad. It's the saddest hole I've ever seen."

"I gave it away. To close a door."

"I know. The stones told me that too." She looked at the cord on my wrist. "It's in there. Isn't it? All tied up. Very tight. Very neat." She tilted her head. "It's very loud."

"Everyone says that."

"Everyone's right." She reached out, very carefully, and touched the cord with one finger. Just for a moment. Then she took her hand away. "It wants to come out. It's pressing against the knots. Like a moth against a window." She looked at me. "You're going to put it somewhere. Aren't you? Somewhere safe. Somewhere quiet."

"Yes. In a box. My friends are making it."

"That's good." She nodded. "That's very sensible. Names shouldn't be left lying about." She was quiet for a moment. "But then you'll have nothing. No name at all. Not even in the cord. Not even on your wrist."

"Yes."

"That's not good." She frowned. "That's not good at all. People need names. Even small ones. Otherwise they don't know who they are, and they get lost, and they wander around and around and can't find their way home." She looked at me very seriously. "I know. I was like that once. For a long time."

"What did you do?"

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she smiled.

"Someone gave me a small name," she said. "A little one. Just to wear. While my big one was sleeping." She touched the faded ribbon in her hair. "It fit very well. I've worn it ever since."

\* \* \*

She stood up. She stood on the ridge of the roof, balanced as easily as a bird on a branch, and she looked down at me.

"I'll give you one," she said. "A small name. Would you like that?"

I looked up at her. At her pale face and her cloud of hair and her enormous grey eyes.

"Yes," I said.

She considered me for a long time. She tilted her head this way and that, the way she might look at a stone or a leaf or a bit of glass, trying to see its true shape. She walked slowly around me, along the ridge of the roof, looking at me from every side.

"It can't be a name for what you are," she said at last. "That's the big name. That's in the cord. If I gave you a name for what you are, it would be too close. It would call to the big one, and the big one would call back, and everyone would hear." She frowned. "It has to be a name for something else. Something smaller. Something that happened, not something that *is*."

"What happened?"

She looked at me with her enormous eyes.

"A disaster," she said simply. "You happened. To the door, and the king, and the old man, and the war. And to you." She was quiet for a moment. "You're the thing that happened. And it wasn't good, and it wasn't bad. It was just very big. And very sad. And it broke a lot of things."

She knelt down on the slates in front of me. She put her small cold hands on either side of my face and looked into my eyes.

"There's an old word," she said. "From a long way away. From before I came here. It means a thing that happens, that breaks things. A storm. A flood. A fire. It doesn't mean it's wicked. It just means it's big, and it happened, and nothing was the same after." She tilted her head. "It's a very small word. Just two sounds. It won't call anything. It's too small to call anything."

"What is it?"

She leaned forward, very close, and whispered it in my ear.  
"Kote," she said.

\* \* \*

I sat very still.

It was not a name. Not the way the cord was a name, or the thing that had been in the hole in my chest. It did not reach down inside me and catch hold of anything. It did not hum. It did not glow.

But it fit.

It fit the way a coat fits, or a pair of boots. Not a part of me. Something I could wear, over the hole, so that the hole would not show. Something I could answer to, when people called.

"Kote," I said.

She sat back on her heels and smiled at me. It was a radiant smile, sudden and bright, like the sun coming out from behind a cloud.

"There," she said. "Now you're somebody. Not your big somebody. A little one. But somebody." She tilted her head. "Do you like it?"

I thought about it.

"Yes," I said. "I like it."

"Good." She stood up. She brushed off her dress. "Wear it carefully. Don't let it get too big. If it gets too big, it'll start to be a real name, and then it'll call to the other one." She looked at me seriously. "Keep it small. Keep it quiet. Keep it just a thing that happened."

"How?"

She thought about that.

"Don't do anything big," she said at last. "Don't sing big songs. Don't call the wind. Don't fight kings or open doors or go into the Fae." She wrinkled her nose. "Do small things. Quiet things. Bake bread. Sweep floors. Polish things." She smiled. "I polish things all the time. It's very soothing. It keeps you small."

"Polish things," I said.

"Polish things." She nodded firmly. "And when your big name wakes up—and it will, someday, when it's safe—you can take off the little one and put it away. And be yourself again." She paused. "But

not until then."

\* \* \*

She stayed with me on the roof until very late. She did not say much more. She sat beside me with her knees drawn up and her bare feet on the slates, and she hummed, very softly, a tune I did not know.

At last she stood up again.

"I have to go," she said. "The drain gets very full when the tide comes up the river. I don't want to get my feet wet."

"Will I see you again?"

She looked at me for a long moment. Her enormous eyes were very sad.

"I don't think so," she said. "Not for a long time. Maybe not ever. You're going away. Far away. Somewhere quiet, where no one knows you." She tilted her head. "And I live here. Under the University. With the deep door. Someone has to keep an eye on it."

"The deep door?"

"The one you went to. With the book, and the names on the walls, and the Sleeper." She looked toward the far bank of the river, toward the great grey building with no windows. "It's very unhappy, since you closed the other one. It's very lonely. It keeps calling out to its brothers and sisters. The other doors. And only six of them answer now." She looked back at me. "The one you closed doesn't answer anyone. It's like a hole in a song."

I did not understand. I did not say anything.

"I'll keep it company," said Auri. "The deep door. I'll sing to it. The way you sang to the Sleeper." She smiled faintly. "Somebody should."

She turned to go. Then she stopped, and turned back, and knelt down in front of me one more time.

She reached into the pocket of her dress and took something out and pressed it into my hand.

It was a small bundle of dried flowers. Lavender. Tied with a bit of blue thread.



"For your new place," she said. "Wherever it is. So it smells like a meadow."

I looked down at the lavender in my hand.

"Thank you," I said.

"You're welcome, Kote." She leaned forward and kissed me on the forehead, very lightly, the way a mother kisses a child. "Be small. Be quiet. Polish things." She paused. "And be careful."

She stood up. She walked along the ridge of the roof to the end, where it met the next building. She stepped across the gap as easily as if it were not there.

And then she was gone, into the dark, across the rooftops of Imre, toward the river and the old drain and the Underthing on the other side.

I sat on the roof of the Grey Man with the lavender in my hand until the sun came up.

\* \* \*

When I went back inside, Denna was waiting for me. She was sitting on the edge of the bed in the largest room, with her hands folded in her lap. She had not slept. I could see it in her face.

"Where were you?" she said.

"On the roof."

"All night?"

"Yes."

"Alone?"

I thought about it. "No," I said. "There was a girl. Very small. With hair like a cloud."

Denna's face changed. "Auri," she said softly. "That was Auri. You used to bring her things. Food, and presents. You never told anyone about her except me." She looked at me. "What did she say?"

I held out my hand. The one with the lavender in it.

"She gave me this," I said. "For my new place. So it smells like a meadow."

Denna looked at the lavender. Her eyes were wet.

"And she gave me a name," I said.

Denna went very still.

"A small one," I said. "Just to wear. While the big one is sleeping."

"What is it?"

I looked at her.

"Kote," I said.

Denna was quiet for a very long time. She looked at me, and her face did many things, one after another, too fast for me to follow. Grief, and something like fear, and something like relief, and something I did not have a name for.

"Kote," she said at last. "It means *disaster*. In Siaru. The old dialect. Did you know that?"

"She told me. A thing that happens, that breaks things."

"A thing that happens." Denna closed her eyes. "Yes. That's right. That's exactly right." She opened them again and looked at me. "Is that who you want to be? A disaster?"

I thought about it.

"It's who I am," I said. "For now. Until it's safe to be someone else."

Denna looked at me for a long moment. Then she stood up and came to me and put her arms around me, and held me very tight.

"Kote," she whispered into my shoulder. As if she were trying it on. As if she were trying to make herself believe it.

"Kote," I said.

And that was my name, for a very long time after.

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Five

# What Elodin Took Back

Elodin came again on the fourth night. Alone.

I was sitting by the window in the top room of the Grey Man, looking out at the lights of Imre. The others had gone to bed, or gone home. Denna was asleep in the next room; I could hear her breathing through the wall, slow and even. Bast was somewhere on the roof. He did not sleep much, those days. He said the city was too loud.

I was not doing anything. I was sitting. That was most of what I did, in the grey. Sit, and look at things, and not feel anything about them.

There was a tap on the window. I looked up. Elodin was crouched on the sill outside, balanced on the balls of his bare feet, three stories above the street, grinning at me through the glass like a gargoye.

I opened the window. He climbed in.

\* \* \*

He did not say anything at first. He walked around the room, touching things. The back of a chair. The edge of the washstand. The iron latch of the door. He picked up a candle stub from the table and smelled it, and put it down again. He looked out the window for a long time, at the rooftops.

Then he sat down on the floor, cross-legged, facing me.

"Do you remember the snow?" he said.

I looked at him. I did not know what he meant. I did not remember much of anything, then. But something moved in me, very

faintly, at the word. Like a stone shifting at the bottom of a deep pool.

"No," I said.

"No. Of course you don't." Elodin looked at his hands. "It was on the roof of the Rookery. Years ago. Your last winter with us. There were four of you. We were learning the name of snow." He was quiet for a moment. "You said it forgets. Or pretends to."

I did not say anything.

"And I told you," said Elodin, "that someday you would want very much to forget something. To cover it over. To make everything smooth and white, as if it had never happened. And that you would find, if you were unlucky, that you could." He looked up at me. "And I told you not to."

\* \* \*

The candle on the table guttered in the draft from the window. Elodin did not close it. He sat on the floor with his dark eyes on my face.

"I was wrong," he said.

I looked at him.

"I don't say that often," said Elodin. "It's not that I'm never wrong. I'm wrong all the time. Constantly. Magnificently. But I don't usually notice, and when I do, I don't usually care." He smiled faintly. "But I care about this one. So I came to say it. Even though you won't remember I did."

"Wrong about what?"

"About the snow." He looked out the window. "I told you not to cover things over. I told you it was dangerous. I told you it was the worst thing a namer could do." He was quiet. "Because that's what I did. When I was seventeen. I tried to change my name, and when it went wrong, I tried to forget. To cover it all over. To make myself smooth and white and new." He looked at his hands. "It broke me. Three years in Haven. You know that. I told you."

I did not know it. But I nodded.

"So I thought it was always wrong," said Elodin. "Always. For everyone. I thought the only honest thing was to carry it. All of it. Every broken piece. Even if it cut you." He shook his head slowly. "I

was very proud of that. Of carrying it. I made it into a kind of philosophy. I told my students. I told you."

"And now?"

Elodin was quiet for a long time.

"Now I've seen the cord," he said. "On your wrist. What she did. How she did it." He looked at me. "And I've seen you. Sitting here. Grey and quiet and whole. Not broken. Not torn in half. Just—put down. Folded up. Covered over, very gently, with snow."

He reached out and touched the back of my left hand, very lightly, just above the knotted cord.

"She didn't try to change your name," he said. "That's the difference. That's what I didn't understand, when I was seventeen. I tried to make myself into something else. She didn't. She just held what you were. Held it very carefully. So that you could stop carrying it for a while."

\* \* \*

"Is that good?" I said.

It was a strange question. I knew it as I said it. It was the kind of question a child asks. But I did not know any other kind, then.

Elodin looked at me for a long moment.

"It's snow," he said. "It's what snow does. It covers things. It makes the world quiet. It lets things rest, underneath, through the long cold months, until the ground is ready." He was quiet. "And then it melts. And everything's still there. Just the same as before."

"It doesn't really forget," I said. "It only pretends."

I did not know where the words came from. They came up out of the grey from somewhere very deep, the way the chord had come out of my hands in the farmhouse. Something my body remembered, even if I did not.

Elodin's face went very still.

"Yes," he said softly. "That's right. That's exactly right." He was quiet for a long moment. "You said that. On the roof. Do you know that? Those exact words."

"No."

"No." He smiled. It was a strange smile, and very sad, and very fond. "But you still know it. Somewhere. Down at the bottom, where the truth lives." He took his hand away from mine. "That's what I came to tell you. That's all. That I was wrong, and snow isn't always the enemy. Sometimes it's the only thing that keeps the seeds alive through the winter."

\* \* \*

He stood up. He went to the window. He climbed up onto the sill and crouched there, balanced, with the night behind him and the cold wind stirring his hair.

"Master Elodin," I said.

He looked back at me.

"Will I remember?" I said. "Any of it? When it melts?"

Elodin did not answer at once. He looked out at the rooftops of Imre, dark and silver in the starlight. Far off, across the river, the University was a black shape against the sky. The Archives, windowless. The Rookery, with its round room at the top.

"You'll remember everything," he said at last. "That's the terrible thing about snow. It doesn't take anything. It only waits." He looked at me. "You'll remember the good and the bad. The things you did and the things you didn't. All of it. All at once, when the thaw comes." He was quiet. "It's going to be very hard, Kvothe. Harder than anything. Harder than the forgetting."

"Then why wait?"

"Because the ground's not ready." Elodin's voice was very gentle. "Not yet. You'd drown. Everything you are would come back all at once, and there's too much of it, and it's too loud, and it would drown you. You need time. Years, maybe. To let the ground get ready. To make a little space in yourself where it can come back and have somewhere to stand."

He looked at me for a long moment.

"Make the space," he said. "That's all. That's all you have to do. While you're waiting. Be small. Be quiet. Polish things." He almost smiled. "Auri's right about that. She usually is. Make a small, quiet,

clean space. And then, when the thaw comes, there'll be room."

\* \* \*

He turned to go. Then he stopped, crouched on the sill, and looked back one last time.

"And Kvothe," he said. "When it comes. The thaw. When it all comes back." His dark eyes were very bright. "Don't try to carry it all by yourself. That was my other mistake. I thought I had to. I thought that was what made it honest." He shook his head. "It's not. It's just what makes it heavy."

"Who should I carry it with?"

Elodin looked at me. Then he looked up, at the roof above the window, where Bast was sitting in the dark, listening. I had not known he was listening. Elodin had.

"Someone will come," he said. "Someone always does. Someone to listen. Someone to write it down." He smiled. "Stories are very good at carrying heavy things. That's what they're for."

And then he was gone. Off the sill and into the dark, over the rooftops, barefoot, laughing at something only he could hear.

\* \* \*

I did not remember that conversation. Not for seven years. It went into the snow with everything else.

But when it melted, it was one of the first things that came back. Before Denna. Before my parents. Before my own name. I was sitting at a table in an inn at a crossroads, with a scribe across from me and his pen moving on the page, and I heard, very clearly, a voice from very far away, on a windowsill in Imre, three stories above the street:

*Stories are very good at carrying heavy things. That's what they're for.*

And I understood, then, why I had said yes.

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Six

# Roah

They made the chest in the Fishery, on a single night in late autumn, with the doors locked and the windows shuttered and a fire burning in every forge.

Kilvin allowed it. I learned later that he had argued with Herma for two spans about it, and with Lorren for three, and that in the end he had simply stopped arguing and told them that he was the Master Artificer, and that the Fishery was his, and that if he chose to let a man who had been expelled and hanged and was supposedly dead come into it for one night, that was his business and no one else's. And then he had gone back to his office and closed the door, and no one had dared to knock on it for a span.

I did not know any of this at the time. I did not know Kilvin. I did not know the Fishery. I was only brought across the bridge in the dark, under a hood, with Bast on one side of me and Elodin on the other, and led through the silent courtyards of the University to a great stone building that smelled of hot metal and coal smoke and quenching oil.

And something in me stirred when I smelled it. Very faintly. The way a sleeping dog stirs at a familiar voice.

\* \* \*

The wood was roah.

Kilvin showed it to me when I came in. He was standing beside a long workbench in the center of the great room, with his hands resting on a stack of dark planks. He was a very big man, broad and bearded



and shaggy, with hands like shovels, blackened and scarred by a lifetime of work. When he saw me, his face did something complicated beneath the beard.

"Kvothe," he said. His voice was a low rumble.

"Kote," said Denna, beside me. "He's Kote now. For a while."

Kilvin looked at her. Then at me. He was quiet for a long moment.

"Kote," he said at last. He said it carefully, the way you say a word in a language you are not sure of. "Very well." He looked down at the planks under his hands. "This is roah. Do you know it?"

"No."

"It is a very rare wood. Very dense. Very heavy. It grows only in one valley in the far north, beyond the Small Kingdoms, and it takes three hundred years for a tree to grow thick enough to cut." He ran his broad hand along the top plank. It was almost black, with a faint reddish tinge in the grain, and it was so smooth that it seemed to drink the light. "It does not burn easily. It does not rot. It does not warp or crack or split. It is very stubborn wood." He looked at me. "It says no. Like stone. But it is alive, or was. It remembers being a tree. It remembers growing. It knows how to hold something that is alive."

He was quiet for a moment.

"I have had these planks for eleven years," he said. "I bought them from a trader who did not know what they were. I have been saving them. I did not know for what." He looked at me with his dark eyes under his shaggy brows. "Now I know."

\* \* \*

They worked all night.

I cannot tell you everything they did. I did not understand most of it, and I have forgotten more. But I remember pieces. I will tell you the pieces.

I remember Kilvin at the workbench, with a plane in his great hands, shaving the roah planks smooth. Long pale curls of wood falling to the floor around his feet. He worked slowly and steadily, without hurry, the way a man works who has been doing a thing for

forty years and knows that hurry is the enemy of good work. He did not use a single nail. He cut the joints by hand, dovetails and mortises, so tight and so perfect that when he fitted the planks together, you could not slide a hair between them.

I remember Wil, sitting at a smaller bench beside him, with his scarred hands working carefully on a lump of copper. He could not do fine sympathy anymore. But he could still do fine metalwork, if he went slowly. He was making a lock. A plain copper lock, heavy and solid, with a keyhole the shape of a small closed eye.

"Kilvin designed it," he told me, without looking up from his work. "I'm just making it. It's a sympathy lock. Very old design. The key has to be bound to the lock by the one who owns it. Once it's bound, only that person can turn it." He paused. "We'll bind it to you. Tonight. While you're still—" He stopped.

"While I'm still what?"

Wil looked up at me. His dark face was very still.

"While you're still you," he said quietly. "Enough of you. With the cord on your wrist. So the lock knows you." He looked back down at the copper. "And then, when the cord's in the chest, and you're just Kote, you won't be able to open it. The lock won't know you. It'll be waiting for the other one."

\* \* \*

I remember Fela, at a bench in the corner, with a block of grey stone in front of her and a small steel chisel in her hand. She was carving it into the shape of a lock. A stone lock, to sit beside the copper one on the front of the chest. She carved very slowly and very carefully, and every so often she stopped and put down her chisel and laid her palms flat on the stone and closed her eyes.

I watched her for a long time. At last she looked up and saw me watching.

"I'm asking it," she said. "To remember. What it's for. Who it's for." She held up the two small flat stones, the ones she had given me, the ones from the foundation of the Eolian. "These are going in it. At the heart of the lock. They remember you. They remember the night

you sang, and the fire, and how they held." She fitted them carefully into a hollow she had carved in the center of the block. "They'll tell the lock who to open for."

"And who not to open for?"

Fela looked at me with her dark serious eyes.

"Everyone else," she said. "Everyone in the world. Even Kote."

\* \* \*

I remember Devi, at the alchemical bench by the far wall, surrounded by glass vials and copper tubes and strange-smelling bottles. She was making something. She would not tell me what.

"Insurance," she said, when I asked. She did not look up. "In case anyone gets past the locks. In case anyone tries to force it, or break it, or burn it." She smiled her spider's smile. "They'll get a very nasty Surprise."

"What kind?"

"The kind that means nobody ever tries it again." She held up a small sealed vial, full of something that glowed faintly green. "I'm going to line the inside of the lid with this. Very thin. Very fine. You won't even know it's there." She paused. "Unless someone opens it without the key."

\* \* \*

I remember Sim.

He was not making anything. He could not; he was a poet, not an artificer, and his hands were no good at wood or metal or stone. So he sat on a stool near the door, out of the way, with a sheaf of paper on his knee and a pen in his hand, and he wrote.

I went and sat beside him, after a while. He looked up at me with his one bright eye.

"What are you writing?" I asked.

"A poem." He looked down at the paper. "For the chest. To go inside it. With your name and everything else." He smiled crookedly. "Elodin says it can't hurt. He says names like company. He says a name shut up alone in a box might get lonely, and lonely names do

strange things."

"What's it about?"

Sim was quiet for a long moment.

"You," he said at last. "The real you. The one in the cord. Everything I remember about you. The day we met, in the Mews. The day you played at the Eolian and won your pipes. The day you broke Ambrose's arm, and set his rooms on fire, and got whipped for it and didn't cry." He laughed softly. "All the stupid things you did. All the brave ones. All the times you were an idiot and all the times you were a hero." He looked down at the paper. "So your name will have something to read. While it's waiting."

I looked at him. At his thin eager face, and his black eye patch with the white star, and the paper on his knee covered in his cramped untidy handwriting.

"Sim," I said.

He looked up.

"Thank you."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then his face crumpled, just a little, and he looked back down at his paper.

"It's a terrible poem," he said thickly. "It doesn't scan. The rhymes are awful." He wiped his eye with the back of his hand. "You'd hate it."

"I'm sure I wouldn't."

"You would. You always hated my poems." He laughed wetly. "You used to tell me they sprawled. Like weeds."

"I don't remember."

"I know." He went back to writing. "That's why I'm writing it down."

\* \* \*

And I remember Denna.

She did not make anything with her hands that night. Not wood, not metal, not stone. She sat beside me at the edge of the great room, holding my left hand, with the cord on its wrist. And she waited.

When the others were done—when Kilvin had fitted the last plank, and Wil had finished the copper lock, and Fela had set the stone lock beside it, and Devi had lined the inside of the lid with her glowing green insurance—they all came and stood around the chest. It sat on the long workbench in the center of the Fishery, in the firelight. A plain dark box, about the size of a small trunk. Smooth and heavy and without ornament. Two locks on its front: one copper, with a keyhole shaped like a closed eye; one stone, grey and plain, with no keyhole at all.

And a third place. Between the two locks. A small hollow, carved into the wood, the size of a thumb.

"That's for me," said Denna.

She let go of my hand. She reached into her sleeve and took out a cord. Thin and dark and braided. Her own hair.

She began to tie.

\* \* \*

She tied a knot. A single knot. It took her a long time. Her hands moved very slowly, very carefully, looping and twisting and doubling back. When it was done, it was about the size of a thumbnail, very tight and very complex. It seemed to shift, when I looked at it, the way the knots in the king's hair had shifted.

She pressed it into the hollow between the two locks. It fit perfectly. She held it there with her thumb for a long moment, with her eyes closed, and her lips moving.

When she took her thumb away, the knot was part of the wood. I could still see it, faintly, the loops and twists of dark hair against the dark roach. But it was sunk into the grain, the way a fossil is sunk into stone.

"That's the third lock," she said. "Mine. It won't open unless the other two are open. And it won't open unless someone unties it." She looked at me. "And only one other knot in the world can untie it."

"Where's that knot?"

Denna did not answer. She reached into her sleeve again and took out another cord. Short, this time. Barely as long as her finger. With a

single knot tied in it. The twin of the one in the lid.

She held it up.

"Here," she said. "I'm keeping it. Far away from here. Far away from you." She closed her hand around it. "If you ever need it—if the time ever comes when it's safe for you to be yourself again—it'll find its way to you."

"How?"

She smiled. It was a small, sad, secret smile.

"Knots are very good at finding their way home," she said.

\* \* \*

Then they put things into the chest.

Kilvin opened the lid. The inside was dark and smooth and smelled of old wood. The faint green glow of Devi's insurance showed along the underside of the lid, like moss on a stone.

Sim went first. He folded his poem very carefully and laid it in the bottom of the chest.

Then Bast came forward. He had been standing at the back of the room all night, near the door, not speaking. His face was pale. His hands were bandaged, from the iron knife. He came forward now, and he had something in his hands. A small box of dark wood, smooth and polished, about the size of a loaf of bread. No lid. No lock. No seams.

It was humming. I could hear it, even from where I stood. Its long slow *no*.

"I picked it up," Bast said. His voice was very quiet. "In the chamber. After. From the floor, where you dropped it." He looked at me. "I've been carrying it ever since. In my pack. The whole way. Through the war, and Renere, and everything." He swallowed. "It's very heavy."

He laid it in the chest, beside Sim's poem.

Then Denna took my lute out of its case. She held it for a long moment, looking at it. Then she laid it in the chest too, very gently, on top of the box and the poem.

"Why?" I said. "Why the lute?"

Denna looked at me.

"Because it's yours," she said. "The real you. Not Kote. When you play it now, it's just a lute. But when you're you again—" She stopped. "When you're you again, you'll want it. And it'll be waiting."

\* \* \*

And then it was my turn.

I stood in front of the chest. I held out my left hand. Denna took it. She held my wrist in both of her hands, and she looked at the cord for a long time.

"This is going to feel strange," she said. "Maybe worse than strange. It's been on your wrist for a year. It's gotten used to you. And you've gotten used to it." She looked up at me. "When I take it off, you'll feel—less. Even less than now. The hole will be bigger."

"I understand."

"Do you?"

"No," I said. "But do it anyway."

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she bent her head over my wrist. Her fingers found the knots. They moved, slowly, carefully, looping and twisting and undoing.

The cord came off.

\* \* \*

I will tell you what it felt like, because I promised to tell the truth.

It felt like dying.

Not the pain of it. There was no pain. But the going. The going out. Like a candle flame, guttering. Like the last light going out of the sky at dusk. The cord came off my wrist, and something went with it. Something I had not known was still there. Some last thread, some last faint humming string, connecting the hole in my chest to the name in the cord.

It snapped. And I was empty.

Truly empty. For the first time. Not grey, now. Not ash. Nothing at all. Like the space behind the door, in the chamber beneath the Lackless house. Like the place between the stars.

I did not fall. I stood very still in front of the chest, with my empty wrist held out in front of me, and I looked at the cord in Denna's hands. At the knots, glowing faintly silver. At the thing that had been me.

It meant nothing to me. Nothing at all. It was a piece of string.

Denna laid it in the chest. On top of the lute. On top of the humming box, and Sim's poem.

Kilvin closed the lid.

The copper lock clicked. The stone lock settled. The knot in the wood between them seemed to tighten, very slightly, and go still.

And the Fishery was silent.

\* \* \*

Everyone was looking at me. I could feel them. Kilvin, and Wil, and Fela, and Devi, and Sim, and Elodin by the door, and Bast beside him. And Denna, beside me, with her hands empty now, and her face white.

I looked back at them. I did not know any of them. I did not know where I was, or why, or what the dark box on the workbench was, or why everyone was looking at me.

"Kote," said Denna softly. "Kote. Can you hear me?"

Kote. I knew that word. It was a small word. A little one. A girl with cloud-hair had given it to me, on a roof, in the dark.

"Yes," I said.

"Do you know who I am?"

I looked at her. I did not know.

"No," I said.

She did not cry. I will always remember that. She had cried so many times, in the months since the cellar. But she did not cry then. She only nodded, very slowly. As if she had expected it.

"That's all right," she said. "That's all right, Kote. You don't have to."

She took my hand. My left hand. There was a mark on the wrist, where the cord had been. A thin red line, around and around, like a bracelet.

"Come on," she said. "It's late. Let's go home."



"Where's home?"

She looked at me for a long moment.

"I don't know yet," she said. "But we'll find it."

## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Seven

# Nails

Kilvin taught me to make nails.

It was the day after the chest. I did not understand, then, why he did it. I did not understand much of anything. The chest was finished and sitting in the corner of his workshop under a canvas cover, and everyone had gone home to sleep after the long night: Wil with his scarred hands, and Fela with her two stones, and Devi yawning and grumbling and smelling of alchemy. Sim had fallen asleep on a bench by the door and nobody had had the heart to wake him.

I did not sleep. I did not feel tired. I sat on a stool by the cold forge with my hands in my lap and watched the grey light come up in the windows of the Fishery, and did not think about anything.

Kilvin came in at dawn. He was carrying a sack. He set it down on the anvil with a heavy clank and looked at me for a long time with his dark, deep-set eyes.

"Get up," he said.

I got up.

\* \* \*

He lit the forge. I watched him do it. I did not help; I did not know I was supposed to. He built the fire carefully, the way he did everything, laying the coal just so and working the bellows with slow steady strokes until the heart of the forge glowed orange, then yellow, then white.

Then he opened the sack. It was full of iron. Short rods of it, as long as my hand and as thick as my little finger, dull grey and flaking with rust. Hundreds of them.

"Nail stock," said Kilvin. "Good iron. Cheap iron. From the smith on Tanner's Row." He picked one up and held it out to me. "Take it."

I took it. It was cold and rough and heavy in my palm.

"Today," said Kilvin, "you will make nails."

I looked at the rod of iron in my hand. Then at him.

"Why?" I said.

It was a real question. I did not know. I did not know why anyone did anything, then. I did not know why the sun came up or why people talked or why I was standing in a workshop with a rod of iron in my hand. I only knew that he had told me to get up, and I had, and now he was telling me to make nails.

Kilvin looked at me for a long moment. Something moved in his big bearded face.

"Because your hands need something to do," he said. "And nails are very simple. And very useful. And there are never enough of them."

\* \* \*

He showed me.

He took a rod of iron in his tongs and thrust it into the heart of the forge, and worked the bellows, and waited. When the end of the rod glowed orange, he drew it out and laid it on the anvil and struck it with his hammer. Four blows. Quick and even. Turning the rod a quarter-turn between each. And the end of the rod drew out into a point, square and sharp.

Then he set the rod into a hole in a heavy iron plate—the nail header, he called it—and nipped it off with a chisel a finger's length from the point, and struck the stub that stood up from the plate. Three blows. And the stub mushroomed out into a head, flat and round.

He knocked the plate against the anvil, and a nail fell out onto the stone floor, glowing dull red, hissing faintly.

The whole thing took less time than it takes to tell.

"There," said Kilvin. "A nail." He handed me the tongs. "Now you."

\* \* \*

I made a bad nail. Of course I did. I held the rod in the fire too long, and it burned, and threw off sparks. I struck it too hard, and the point bent. I nipped it off too short, and the head split when I struck it. What fell out of the header onto the floor was a twisted, lumpy, useless thing, more like a knot of iron than a nail.

I looked at it. I did not feel anything.

"Again," said Kilvin.

I made another. It was also bad. Not as bad as the first; the point was straight, this time. But the head was lopsided, and the shank had a kink in it.

"Again," said Kilvin.

\* \* \*

I made nails all that day. From dawn until well after dark. Kilvin stood beside me the whole time, with his arms folded across his chest, and said nothing except *again*. He did not correct me. He did not show me a second time. He did not tell me what I was doing wrong. He only watched, and said *again*, and handed me another rod of iron from the sack.

And slowly, very slowly, the nails got better.

I do not know how. I was not thinking about it. I was not thinking about anything. I held the rod in the fire and drew it out and struck it and turned it and struck it and nipped it and struck it, over and over, the way you breathe. And somewhere in the doing, my hands began to learn.

They learned how long to leave the iron in the fire: until the color was just so, orange shading to yellow at the very tip. They learned how hard to strike: not hard at all, really, only firm and even, letting the weight of the hammer do the work. They learned the quarter-turn between each blow, and the angle of the chisel, and the rhythm of the whole thing. *Heat. Four. Turn. Nip. Three. Knock.*

By noon, one nail in three was usable. By dusk, two in three. By the time the moon came up over the rooftops of the Fishery, and Kilvin finally put his big hand on my shoulder and said *enough*, there was a pile of nails on the floor beside the anvil as high as my knee. And most of them were good.

\* \* \*

I stood beside the forge, with the hammer still in my hand, and looked at them. My arm ached. My hands were blistered. My face was black with soot and running with sweat.

I did not feel anything. I want to be honest about that. It was not a moment of triumph. I did not look at the pile of nails and feel proud, or pleased, or even tired.

But I felt my hands. That was the thing. For the first time since the chamber beneath the Lackless house, I felt my hands. They were aching and blistered and hot, and they hurt, and they were *mine*. They had done something. They had learned something. And they were still humming with it, the rhythm of it, *heat four turn nip three knock*, the way your body goes on rocking after you step off a boat.

Kilvin was watching my face.

"There," he said quietly. "You feel it."

I did not answer. I looked down at my hands.

"The hands remember," said Kilvin. "Even when the rest forgets. Even when the name is gone. The hands remember what they have done." He took the hammer from me, gently, and set it on the anvil. "This is what I wanted to show you. Before you go."

\* \* \*

He sat down on the stool by the forge. I had never seen Kilvin sit down in his own workshop. He was always standing, always moving, always bent over some project or another. But he sat now, heavily, with his big scarred hands on his knees, and looked at the pile of nails.

"When I was young," he said, "younger than you, I was very sick. A fever. In the mountains, in Ceald, where I was born. It burned for eleven days. When it broke, I did not know who I was." He was quiet

for a moment. "Not for long. A span. Perhaps two. But I did not know my name, or my mother's face, or the village I was born in. I did not know anything."

I looked at him.

"My father was a smith," said Kilvin. "He did not know what to do with me. He was not a gentle man, or a clever one. He did not know how to help. So he did the only thing he knew." Kilvin nodded at the anvil. "He put a hammer in my hand, and a rod of iron, and he said: *make nails.*"

"And you remembered?"

"Not at once." Kilvin shook his head slowly. "But my hands did. They had made nails since I was six years old. They knew how. And while my hands were making nails, the rest of me could rest. Could be quiet. Could wait." He looked at his hands. "And one day, in the middle of a nail, I remembered my mother's face. And the next day, my name. And the day after that, everything else."

\* \* \*

We sat by the forge for a long time. The coals ticked and settled. Outside, somewhere in the dark, a cat was yowling.

"You are going somewhere quiet," said Kilvin at last. "Somewhere far away. With your chest and your Fae friend and no name." He looked at me. "It will be very quiet. And very long. Years, maybe. That is what Elodin says."

"Yes."

"You will need something to do with your hands." Kilvin's voice was very gentle, for him. "It does not matter what. Nails. Bread. Polishing cups. Mending a roof. It does not matter. Only that your hands are busy. Only that they are making something. Even small things." He paused. "Even nails."

"Why?"

Kilvin looked at me for a long moment.

"Because the hands hold the door open," he said. "When the rest is closed. They keep a little space. So that when the name comes back, it has somewhere to come back *to.*"

\* \* \*

He gave me the nails. All of them. The whole knee-high pile, swept into a canvas bag and tied at the neck. It was very heavy. I did not know what to do with it.

"Take them," said Kilvin. "Wherever you go. Use them. Build things." He almost smiled, in his beard. "They are not very good nails. But they are yours."

I took them.

They went into the cart, beside the chest, and they came with me all the way across the Commonwealth, and into an empty inn at a crossroads. And I used them. Every one. I used them to mend the roof, and the stable door, and the shutters, and the loose boards on the stairs. I used them to build the shelves behind the bar, and the frame for the sword above it, and the bench outside the kitchen door where Bast sat in the evenings.

The Waystone Inn is held together by Kilvin's nails. The bad ones and the good ones. Made by a man with no name, in a single day, in the Fishery, with a Cealdish master standing beside him saying *again*.

\* \* \*

"Are they still there?" said Chronicler. "The nails?"

"Every one." The innkeeper looked around the common room. At the bar, and the shelves, and the stairs. "I used the last of them the spring before you came. On the stable door. It had come loose again." He was quiet for a moment. "I remember thinking, when I drove it in: that's the last one. I've used them all up. And I didn't know why that made me sad."

"And now?"

The innkeeper looked down at his hands. They were resting on the table. Long-fingered and red-knuckled, with calluses on the fingertips from the lute and a thin pale scar running around the left wrist.

"Now I think Kilvin was right," he said. "The hands held the door open. Seven years. Nail by nail." He turned them over, palms up. "And

when the name came back, it had somewhere to come back to."

He was quiet for a long moment.

"I should write to him," he said. "When this is over. I should tell him. He asked me to write when the candle burned blue." He almost smiled. "I suppose it has. I suppose I owe him two letters now."



## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Eight

### Denna

She left me at the top of the stone bridge, three days later, at dawn.

I have told you that I always seem to leave places at dawn. It is true. But this was the first time someone left me. Or the first time I remember.

We had walked out together from the Grey Man in the grey hour before sunrise. Just the two of us. The others had said their goodbyes the night before, in the rooms at the top of the inn. I do not remember those goodbyes well. I remember faces I did not know, and hands on my shoulders, and voices saying things I did not understand. I remember the young man with the eye patch weeping openly and not caring who saw. I remember the small fair woman with no eyebrows pressing a folded paper into my hand and saying *you still owe me for this, don't you forget it*, and when I unfolded it later I found it was a page of old writing on something that was not quite paper, and I did not know what it meant.

I remember the big man from the Fishery gripping my hand in his great scarred paw and saying, very gravely, *Keep your hands busy. Even small things. Even nails.*

I remember the girl with dark hair who knew stone, putting her small cold hand flat on my chest, over my heart, and closing her eyes, and saying *hold*. Just that. *Hold*.

And I remember the lean man with restless eyes, sitting on the windowsill eating an apple, saying nothing at all. When I looked at him, he only raised the apple in a kind of salute, and smiled a strange

crooked smile, and looked away.

\* \* \*

The chest was in the back of a cart, in the inn yard, under a canvas cover. Bast was with it. He was sitting on the tailboard with his legs dangling, and he did not look at us as we came out of the inn. He was looking at the sky.

"He'll take it," said Denna. "The chest. And you. Somewhere quiet. Somewhere far away." She looked at Bast. "He knows. He's promised."

"Where?"

"I don't know." She looked at me. "I don't want to know. If I don't know, no one can make me tell."

We walked out of the inn yard and down the street toward the river. Bast did not follow. He sat on the tailboard of the cart with the chest behind him, and he watched us go, and his face was very still.

\* \* \*

The streets of Imre were empty at that hour. Grey and quiet and damp with dew. A cat watched us from a doorstep. A baker's boy went past with a tray of loaves on his head, whistling. Somewhere a dog barked, and was answered, and fell silent.

We came to the bridge.

It rose up out of the grey morning mist in a great stone arch, curving up and over the river. The water beneath it was brown and slow, with little wisps of mist curling on its surface. On the far side, the University was a dark shape against the paling sky, all towers and roofs and the great grey windowless block of the Archives.

We walked up the arch of the bridge, side by side. Our footsteps echoed on the stone. At the top, where the arch was highest, Denna stopped.

"You used to stop here," she said. "Every time you crossed. You told me once. You'd stop at the top and look out at the river."

I looked out at the river. At the brown water and the mist and the trees along the banks, grey-green in the dawn.

"Why?" I said.

"You said it made you feel like the world was big enough." She was quiet for a moment. "Big enough for everything you wanted to do. Everything you wanted to know."

I looked at the river for a long time.

"It doesn't feel big," I said. "It feels grey."

Denna did not say anything. She stood beside me at the top of the bridge and looked at the river too.

\* \* \*

"I'm going to go now," she said at last.

"Where?"

"I told you. I don't know. Far away." She did not look at me. "South, maybe. Across the sea. Somewhere no one's ever heard of me. Somewhere I can be no one."

"You've done that before."

She laughed softly. "Yes. I have. Many times." She was quiet for a moment. "But this time it's different. This time I'm not running away from something. I'm running away *for* something." She looked at me. "For you."

"I don't understand."

"I know." She reached out and touched my face, very lightly, with the tips of her fingers. The way she had touched my scar, a long time ago, outside a tavern that had burned. "That's all right. You don't have to."

She took her hand away. She reached into her sleeve, and took out a small cord. Barely as long as her finger. With a single knot tied in it.

"I'm keeping this," she said. "The twin knot. The one that opens the chest." She held it up between us. "I'll keep it safe. I'll keep it with me, always. I won't lose it, and I won't sell it, and I won't give it to anyone." She paused. "Unless it's time."

"How will you know?"

"I'll know." She closed her hand around it. "I'll feel it. The knot will tell me. When your name starts to stir. When it's getting ready to wake up." She looked at me. "It won't be for a long time. Years,

probably. Maybe many years. But someday."

"And then?"

"And then I'll send it to you." She smiled faintly. "I won't bring it. I can't. If I come near you, someone might follow me. Someone might find you." She was quiet for a moment. "But I'll send it. Somehow. With someone I trust."

"Who?"

"I don't know yet." She put the cord back in her sleeve. "Someone who walks the roads. Someone who always pays their debts."

\* \* \*

We stood at the top of the bridge for a long time without speaking. The sun was coming up now, behind us, over the hills to the east. The mist on the river was turning gold. The grey sky was turning pale.

I did not feel anything. I want to be honest about that. I stood beside her at the top of the bridge, and I knew that she was leaving, and that I would never see her again. And I did not feel anything at all.

But I knew that I should.

I knew that there was something in the hole in my chest, where my name had been. Something that would have felt this, if it were there. Something that would have broken, and bled, and cried out. Something that had loved her, once, more than anything in the world.

It was not there. It was in a cord, in a chest, in the back of a cart, in an inn yard in Imre. Locked away. Quiet.

But I knew it should have been.

"I'm sorry," I said.

Denna looked at me. "For what?"

"That I don't feel it." I looked at her. "I know I should. I know there's something I should be feeling. Now. Here. With you going away." I shook my head slowly. "I can't. It's not there. It's in the chest."

Denna's face did something very complicated.

"I know," she said. Her voice cracked. "I know it's not there. That's why I'm going." She took a breath. "It's easier. This way. If you felt it—if you were you—I don't think I could do it. I think I'd stay. I think I'd stay forever, and they'd find us, and it would all have been for

nothing." She laughed, a broken sound. "It's the only time in my life I've been glad that someone didn't love me back."

"I did," I said. "Once. I think."

She looked at me for a long moment.

"You did," she said softly. "You did. More than anyone ever has. More than I deserved." She reached up and touched the thread around my neck, under my shirt. The one with the small knot on it. The one she had given me in the Grey Man. "And I did too. I do. I always will."

She pressed her hand flat over the knot, over my heart.

"Keep this," she said. "Promise me. Whatever happens. Keep it."

"I promise."

"Say my name."

I looked at her. At her dark hair, and her dark eyes, and her face in the dawn light.

"Denna," I said.

She closed her eyes.

"Again."

"Denna."

She stood very still, with her eyes closed and her hand on my chest. And then she opened her eyes, and they were wet, and she smiled.

"That's my name," she said. "That's the one that's real. Because you said it."

\* \* \*

She kissed me. Once. Very softly. On the lips.

I did not feel it. Not the way I should have. It was a pressure, and a warmth, and a scent of pear blossoms. That was all.

But the knot on its thread, under her hand, over my heart, hummed. Just once. Very faintly. The way a string hums when another string nearby is plucked.

She felt it too. I saw it in her face. She pulled back and looked at me, and her eyes were very wide.

"You're in there," she whispered. "You're still in there. Somewhere."

"I don't know."

"You are." She laughed through her tears. "You are. I felt it."

She stepped back. She looked at me for a long moment. At my face, and my short brown-stained hair, and my empty wrist with its thin red mark.

"Goodbye, Kote," she said.

"Goodbye, Denna."

She turned. She walked down the far side of the bridge, toward the University, toward the road that ran along the river to the south. She did not look back. She walked very straight, with her head high, the way she had walked into the great hall at Renere to sing the true song.

I watched her until she was out of sight.

And then I stood at the top of the bridge for a long time, looking at the river, with the sun coming up behind me and the mist turning gold on the water.

It did not feel big. It felt grey.

But I stood there anyway. Because she had said I used to.

\* \* \*

Bast found me there an hour later.

He came up the arch of the bridge from the Imre side, walking slowly, with his hands in his pockets. He stopped beside me and looked out at the river. He did not say anything for a long time.

"She's gone," he said at last.

"Yes."

"Did she say where?"

"No."

"Good." He was quiet for a moment. "I didn't like her, you know. Not ever. I thought she was bad for you. I thought she hurt you." He looked at the river. "I still think that."

I did not say anything.

"But she did it," said Bast quietly. "She caught your name. In the chamber. When it was drifting toward the door. She caught it and tied it and saved it." He swallowed. "And now she's walked away from you

forever, so no one can use her to find you." He shook his head. "I don't think I could have done that. Walked away. I don't think I'm that strong."

"You're staying," I said.

"I'm staying." He looked at me. His deep blue eyes were very bright. "I told you I would. In the passage, under the Lackless house. Whatever you are. However much less. I'll stay until you're you again." He paused. "Or forever. Whichever comes first."

I looked at him. At his fine-boned face, and his dark hair, and his bandaged hands.

"I don't know who you are," I said.

"I know." He smiled. It was a small, crooked, sad smile. "That's all right. I'm Bast. I'm your student. You're my teacher. I call you Reshi." He paused. "You'll get used to it."

"Reshi."

"Reshi." He nodded. "It means teacher. Or master. Or fool who steps in front of arrows." His smile widened, just slightly. "It depends on the context."

I looked at him for a long moment. Then, for the first time since the chamber beneath the Lackless house, something happened to my face that I had not decided on.

It was not a smile. Not quite. But it was the shape of one. The ghost of one.

Bast saw it. His eyes went very wide.

"Reshi," he whispered. "Reshi, you—"

"Where are we going?" I said.

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he swallowed, and looked away, and wiped his eyes with the back of his bandaged hand.

"West," he said thickly. "For a while. With the Ruh. And then—" He shrugged. "Somewhere. Somewhere quiet. Somewhere no one's ever heard of you." He looked at me. "An old storyteller told me about a place. He said he'd help us find it."

"What storyteller?"

Bast was quiet for a moment.

"You'll see," he said.



## Chapter One Hundred Thirty-Nine

# A Winter with the Ruh

We spent that winter with Hallow's Company, in a valley in the western hills of the Commonwealth, where the Ruh had a winter camp they had used for forty years.

It was a good place. A long narrow valley between two wooded ridges, with a stream running down the middle and a great old barn at the head of it, half ruined, that the troupe had patched up over the years with salvaged timber and painted canvas. They drew the wagons up around it in a half circle and hobbled the horses in the meadow and cut firewood from the ridges and settled in to wait for spring.

There were other Ruh there too. Two other troupes, smaller than Hallow's, who had been wintering in the valley with them for years. Twenty-odd people, all told, and a great many children, and a great many dogs, and one very old goat named Duchess who belonged to no one and went wherever she pleased.

They took me in. They did not ask who I was. Tessit told them I was a cousin, a troupier who had been hurt in the war and lost his wits, and they nodded and did not ask anything else. That is the way of the Ruh. One family, under the sky.

\* \* \*

I worked.

That was the first thing I learned that winter, as Kote. How to work. Not the way I had worked before—I did not remember how I had worked before—but the way a man with no name works. With his

hands. With his back. Without thinking about it.

I cut wood. Every day, from dawn until noon, up on the ridges with an axe and a saw. I did not know how, at first. I was clumsy and slow and I cut myself twice. But my hands learned. They were good hands; they had been trained, once, to do fine and careful things, and they remembered some of it even when I did not. By midwinter I could fell a tree and limb it and cut it into lengths faster than any man in the camp.

I hauled water. From the stream to the barn, two buckets at a time, twenty trips a day.

I mended things. Harness and wagon wheels and the patched canvas walls of the barn. The Ruh were always mending things, and there were never enough hands to do it, and mine were good ones.

I cooked. Mirra taught me. She stood beside me at the great iron pot over the fire, with her round face very grave, and showed me how to cut onions without crying and how to skin a rabbit and how much salt to use and when. I learned. I learned the way my hands had learned to cut wood: slowly at first, then all at once.

"You've a knack for it," said Mirra, the first time I made the stew alone and everyone ate it and no one complained. She looked at me with her head on one side. "Your mother never did. She could sing like a lark, but she couldn't boil water without burning it." She smiled. "Your father did all the cooking in your troupe. He was very good."

"I don't remember."

"I know." She patted my arm. "But your hands do."

\* \* \*

I polished things.

I do not know why. No one told me to. But every evening, when the work was done and the others were gathered around the great fire in the barn, singing and telling stories and mending their costumes for spring, I would find something that needed polishing. A copper pot. A harness buckle. A lantern. Kellen's knives, which he used for juggling and which were always dull from use.

I would sit a little apart from the others, with a rag and a pot of grease or oil or ash, and I would polish. Slowly. Carefully. In small even circles. Until the thing gleamed.

It was soothing. I did not know why. It kept me small. It kept me quiet. It filled up the hours between work and sleep, when otherwise I would only have sat and looked at the fire and felt the hole in my chest.

Someone had told me to do it. A girl with hair like a cloud, on a roof in the dark. I did not remember her name. But I remembered her voice. *Polish things. It keeps you small.*

\* \* \*

Bast did not like it.

"You're not a servant," he said one night, sitting beside me while I polished Mirra's big copper stewpot. "You don't have to do that."

"I like doing it."

"You don't like anything. You don't *feel* anything." His voice was sharp. "You're just doing it because someone told you to."

I looked up at him. He was sitting on an upturned bucket, with his elbows on his knees and his chin in his hands, glaring at the stewpot. His deep blue eyes were very bright in the firelight.

"Maybe," I said. "But it's something to do."

"There are better things to do."

"Like what?"

He opened his mouth. Then he closed it again. He did not seem to know what to say.

"You used to play," he said at last. "The lute. Every night. Wherever we were. By the fire, or on a roof, or in a tavern. You used to play until your fingers bled." He looked at me. "You used to sing."

"I know. Everyone tells me."

"But you don't remember."

"No."

Bast looked at me for a long time. Then he looked away. His jaw was tight.

"I hate this," he said quietly. "I hate this so much. Watching you. Polishing pots. Cutting wood. Being *small*." He swallowed. "You were never small, Reshi. Never. Not once. You were the biggest thing I ever saw. Bigger than my father's court. Bigger than the Sithe. Bigger than the mountains." His voice cracked. "And now you're polishing a stewpot."

I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.

After a while, Bast got up and went away. I heard him outside the barn, in the dark, making a sound I did not recognize. It might have been weeping.

I went back to polishing the stewpot.

\* \* \*

Lark learned to walk that winter.

She was a year old by then, or near it. A small, solemn, dark-eyed child, with a fuzz of dark hair that was beginning to curl. She did not cry much anymore. She watched everything with her dark eyes, very gravely, the way very old people watch things.

She liked me. I did not know why. Nell said she did not like anyone else, except Mirra and Nell herself. But whenever I sat down, she would crawl over to me and pull herself up by my trouser leg and stand there, swaying, holding on, looking up at me.

And one evening, in the barn by the fire, she let go.

She stood there by herself, swaying, with her arms out for balance. She looked at me. I looked at her. Everyone in the barn went quiet.

She took a step. Toward me. Then another. Then she fell forward, into my lap, and grabbed my shirt with both hands, and looked up at me, and laughed.

It was the first time I had heard her laugh. It was a small, bright, startled sound, like a bird taking flight.

Everyone in the barn laughed with her. Mirra was crying. Nell was clapping. Tessit was grinning under his battered hat.

I looked down at the child in my lap, laughing up at me with her dark eyes shining.

And something happened. Very faint. Very far down. At the bottom of the hole.

It was not a feeling. Not exactly. It was more like the memory of a feeling. The shape of it, without the substance. Like the ghost of a smile, or the echo of a song.

But it was warm.

\* \* \*

I tried the lute again, once, near the end of winter.

It was not my lute. My lute was in the chest, in the back of Tessit's wagon, under a canvas cover, locked away. This was Brin's old lute, the one he had played before he switched to fiddle. It was battered and cracked and missing a string, and the pegs would not hold their tuning.

But it was a lute. And one night, when everyone else had gone to bed and I was alone in the barn with the fire, I picked it up.

I tuned it as best I could. I played a chord.

It was nothing. Grey. The same as before. A painting of a fire on a wall.

I played another. And another. I played a song. I did not know which song; my hands chose it. A slow one, a sad one, with a melody that rose and fell like wind in trees.

It was nothing. It was grey.

But I played it to the end. And when I finished, I looked up, and Lark was standing in the doorway of the barn, in her nightdress, with her thumb in her mouth. She had woken up and come looking for the sound.

She was looking at me with her dark solemn eyes.

"Again," she said.

It was one of the first words she ever said. Mirra told me later. *Again.*

I looked at her. I looked down at the battered lute in my lap.

I played it again.

\* \* \*

We left in the spring. When the snow was gone from the ridges and the stream was running high and brown with meltwater and the troupe was painting their wagons and mending their costumes for the season on the roads.

Tessit tried to make me stay.

"You've a place here," he said. We were standing by the wagons in the grey dawn, with the horses hitched and the troupe gathering. "With us. With the Ruh. You're family. You always will be." He looked at me. "Stay. Travel with us. Play, if you want. Or don't. Cook, and cut wood, and polish pots. It doesn't matter. Just stay."

"I can't."

"Why not?"

I looked at the wagon where Lark was sitting, on Mirra's lap, with her thumb in her mouth. Watching me with her dark solemn eyes.

"Because of her," I said. "Because of what she is. And what I am." I did not know how I knew it. But I knew it, the way I knew how to cut wood. "If they come looking for me—the ones who want what's in the chest—they'll find her too. And then everything will have been for nothing."

Tessit was quiet for a long time.

"Your mother said something like that once," he said at last. "To Arliden. When you were very small. She said, *we have to keep moving, because if they find me, they'll find him too.*" He shook his head. "She never said who *they* were."

"Did he listen?"

"He listened. They kept moving. They never stopped. Not for twelve years." Tessit looked at me. "And in the end, they found her anyway."

"I know."

"Then why—"

"Because I'm not going to keep moving," I said. "I'm going to stop. Somewhere quiet. Somewhere small. Somewhere no one would ever look for anyone." I paused. "And I'm going to stay there. And be small. And wait."

"Wait for what?"

I did not answer. I did not know.

\* \* \*

Nell cried when I left. She held on to my leg and would not let go, and Mirra had to come and pry her fingers loose one at a time. She was nine now, or near it, and she was trying very hard to be grown up about it, and failing.

"You pulled me out of the well," she sobbed. "You're not allowed to leave. You pulled me out of the well."

I knelt down in front of her. I did not know what to say. But I remembered something. Very faint. From somewhere far down.

"You'll see me again," I said.

She looked at me with wet enormous eyes. "Promise?"

"I promise."

I did not know if it was true. I did not know anything. But she stopped crying.

Lark did not cry. She sat on Mirra's hip and looked at me with her dark solemn eyes, the way she always did. When I went to say goodbye to her, she reached out one small hand and touched my face. Very lightly. The way someone else had touched it, on a bridge, at dawn.

"Again," she said.

I did not understand. Mirra did. Her eyes were wet.

"She wants you to come back," she said softly. "And play for her again."

I looked at the child. At her dark solemn eyes. At her small hand on my face.

"Someday," I said.

\* \* \*

Bast and I walked out of the valley that morning with the cart and the chest and a mule named Patience, who had been a parting gift from Tessit and who had, as far as anyone could tell, none at all.

At the top of the ridge, I stopped and looked back.

The troupe was pulling out of the valley in the other direction. Three painted wagons in a line, bright against the green of spring. Brin was on the seat of the first one, sawing at his fiddle. I could hear it, faintly, every third note flat. Illa was singing.

And on the tailboard of the last wagon, a small girl in a red dress was sitting with a smaller girl on her lap. They were both looking back up at the ridge. At me.

The smaller girl raised her hand.

I raised mine.

Then the wagons went around a bend in the valley, and they were gone.

"Reshi," said Bast quietly, beside me. "We should go."

"Yes."

I did not move. I stood on the ridge and looked at the empty valley for a long time.

It was grey. Everything was grey.

But I stood there anyway.



## Chapter One Hundred Forty

# A Tree in the Play

Hallow's Company put on a play at midwinter. They always did. It was the custom of that valley, Mirra told me, going back forty years: on the longest night, the three troupes wintering in the barn put aside their quarrels and their rivalries and made a single play together, for no audience but themselves.

"For the children," she said. "And the dead. Mostly the dead."

The play that year was *The Tinker and the Nine Doors*. I did not know it. It was an old Ruh piece, older than *Daeonica*, older than the Tehlin mysteries, a thing that had never been written down and was different every time it was played. A tinker comes to a house with nine doors. Behind each door is a person who wants something. The tinker has one thing in his pack for each of them, and he must decide which door to open first, because the doors open only once, and the things in his pack can be given only once.

"Who wins?" I asked Mirra.

She looked at me strangely.

"Nobody wins," she said. "It's not that kind of play."

\* \* \*

They gave me a part. I did not ask for one. I was grey, that winter, and I did not want anything, and I would have been content to sit by the fire in the barn and watch the children run past and polish the same tin cup over and over until spring. But the Ruh do not let anyone sit by the fire for long. Everyone works. Everyone plays. Even the grey ones.

"You'll be the tree," said Kellen.

Kellen was master of the play that year. He was a big, bluff, bald man with a voice like a kettle drum and a laugh you could hear across the valley. He was old Hallow's grandson, and he took the midwinter play more seriously than anything else in his life, including his marriage, which his wife said was a mercy for everyone.

"The tree," I said.

"In the courtyard. Outside the house with the nine doors." He clapped me on the shoulder. "You stand there. The whole play. With your arms out. And you don't say anything." He grinned. "Mirra says you're good at not saying anything."

I looked at him. Then I looked at Mirra, standing behind him, with her arms folded. She did not smile.

"All right," I said.

\* \* \*

I stood there for three hours.

They built me a costume out of old sacking and pine boughs and strips of bark from the woodpile. They painted my face grey-brown and tied branches to my arms. A girl of about ten named Pim, who was very serious about everything, made me a crown of dried leaves and holly berries and set it on my head with great ceremony, and then stood back and looked at me with her head on one side.

"You're a very good tree," she said. "You look very sad. Trees in winter look sad."

"Thank you."

"Don't talk," she said. "Trees don't talk."

So I did not talk.

The play began at dusk. The whole company was there, and all their children, and all their dogs, and old Duchess the goat, sitting in a great half circle on hay bales around the cleared floor of the barn. There were lanterns hung from the rafters and a fire in a pit at one end, and the air smelled of pine and smoke and wet wool.

And I stood in the courtyard of the house with nine doors, with my arms out, and watched.

\* \* \*

The tinker was played by an old man named Brann, who had been playing the tinker in that valley for thirty years. He was small and bent and brown as a walnut, with a voice like a creaking gate, and he came into the courtyard with his pack on his back and stopped in front of me and looked up at me, and scratched his head.

"Well," he said. "Here's a tree. Afternoon, tree."

I said nothing. The children laughed.

"Not much of a talker," said the tinker. "That's all right. Neither am I." He set down his pack at my feet. "Mind if I rest a while? It's a long road. And I've got a hard job ahead of me."

He sat down with his back against my legs. The children laughed again.

And then the first door opened.

\* \* \*

It went on like that for three hours. One door after another. Behind the first door was a widow who wanted her husband back. Behind the second was a king who wanted a crown that fit. Behind the third was a child who wanted to be older, and behind the fourth an old man who wanted to be young. A soldier who wanted to forget. A scholar who wanted to remember. A girl who wanted to be loved. A boy who wanted to be left alone.

And the tinker opened his pack for each of them, and took out something, and gave it, or did not. And every time he gave something to one, it was gone, and he could not give it to another. And every time he chose, someone behind another door wept.

It was not a comedy. I had thought it would be; the first hour was full of jokes, and the children laughed until they fell off the hay bales. But the jokes grew fewer as the doors opened. And by the seventh door, nobody was laughing. Not even the children. They sat on their hay bales in the lantern light with their mouths open, watching the old man with his pack, and they did not make a sound.

I stood with my arms out. My shoulders ached. My legs ached. I did not move.

\* \* \*

The eighth door was the hardest.

Behind it was a woman who did not want anything at all. She was played by Mirra. She came out of the door in a plain grey dress, with her hair loose, and she stood in the courtyard and looked at the tinker, and did not say anything.

"What do you want?" said the tinker.

"Nothing," said Mirra.

"Everyone wants something."

"I did, once." Mirra looked at the tinker with her dark, level eyes. "I wanted so much. I wanted everything. And then I lost it all, all at once, in a single night. And now I don't want anything. It's easier."

The tinker looked at her for a long time. Then he opened his pack.

"I have something for you," he said.

"I told you. I don't want anything."

"I know." The tinker reached into his pack. "That's why I have to give it to you."

He took out a small thing, cupped in his hands. He held it out. The lantern light did not show what it was. You could not see it from the hay bales. You could only see that it was small, and that the tinker held it very carefully, the way you might hold an egg, or a bird, or a coal.

Mirra looked at it. She did not take it.

"What is it?" she said.

"It's wanting," said the tinker. "Just a little. Just enough." He held it out. "You'll need it, where you're going."

"Where am I going?"

"Somewhere," said the tinker. "Anywhere. That's what it's for."

\* \* \*

I do not know why that undid me. I have thought about it many times since. I was grey, that winter, as grey as I have ever been. I did not feel

anything. I had not felt anything for months. I had stood in a courtyard of sacking and pine boughs for three hours and watched an old man give away everything in his pack, and I had felt nothing at all.

But when Mirra reached out, slowly, and took that small invisible thing from the tinker's hands, and held it against her chest, and closed her eyes, something happened in me.

It was not much. It was not a feeling, exactly. It was more like the memory of a feeling. Like hearing, from very far away, the last notes of a song you used to know.

And my arms, which I had held out for three hours without moving, began to shake.

\* \* \*

Pim saw it. She was sitting in the front row, on a hay bale, with her serious face. She saw my arms shaking and she stood up, in the middle of the play, and pointed.

"The tree's moving!" she said.

Everyone looked at me. The tinker, and Mirra, and all the troupe, and all the children, and all the dogs. Even old Duchess the goat lifted her head.

I tried to stop. I could not. My arms shook, and the branches tied to them shook, and the dried leaves rattled, and the holly berries fell off my crown one by one and rolled across the barn floor.

Nobody said anything. There was a long, strange silence.

And then Brann, the old tinker, stood up slowly from where he had been sitting at my feet. He turned around and looked up at me. His walnut face was very still.

"Well," he said. "Look at that. The wind's come to the tree."

He reached into his pack. He took out another small invisible thing, cupped in his hands. He held it up to me.

"Here," he said. "I saved one. There's always one left, at the end. For whoever needs it."

I looked down at him. I could not speak. Trees don't speak.

"Go on," said the tinker gently. "Take it. It's only a little. Just enough."

I could not take it. My hands were tied to branches. But the old man did not seem to mind. He reached up, very slowly, and tucked the small invisible thing into a fold of the sacking at my chest, right over my heart. And he patted it once, very lightly.

"There," he said. "For later. When you're somewhere."

And then he turned back to the ninth door, and the play went on.

\* \* \*

I do not remember the ninth door. I do not remember how the play ended. I remember standing in the courtyard of sacking and pine boughs with my arms shaking and my face wet under the grey-brown paint, and the children staring at me, and not being able to stop.

Afterward, when the lanterns had been put out and the children put to bed, Mirra found me sitting on a hay bale at the back of the barn, still in my costume, with the branches untied from my arms and lying on the floor beside me.

She sat down next to me. She did not say anything for a long time.

"That wasn't in the play," I said at last. "The last thing. The one he saved."

"No." Mirra looked at the dying fire. "Brann does that, sometimes. Not every year. Only when there's someone in the audience who needs it." She looked at me. "He's done it four times in thirty years. Once for a woman who'd lost her children to the fever. Once for a man who'd come back from the war without his legs. Once for me."

"When?"

"The winter after my husband died. My first husband. Before Tessit." She was quiet for a moment. "I was a tree too, that year."

I did not say anything. I sat on the hay bale with my face still wet.

"It doesn't fix anything," said Mirra. "You know that. It's only a play. It's only an old man pretending to put something in your shirt." She stood up. "But it's something to carry. Until you get where you're going."

\* \* \*

Brann left the valley before the thaw. Mirra said he always did. He came and went as he pleased, she said, and no troupe could hold him, and no one knew where he wintered when he did not winter with them. He had been an old man when she was a girl. He had been an old man, the eldest of the troupe told her, when *they* were children.

I did not see him go. I only found, one morning, that the little painted cart he kept at the end of the row of wagons was gone, and the donkey with it, and the wheel ruts led away down the valley toward the road. And the sound of a small bell, very faint, far off, going away.

I did not see him again for seven years. Not until a bell rang on the road outside an inn at a crossroads, and I went to the door, and a very old man as brown as a walnut looked up at me with his bright black eyes and smiled.

He did not say he knew me. He did not have to.

\* \* \*

I did carry it. I do not know what it was. There was nothing in the fold of the sacking when I took the costume off; I looked. Of course there was nothing. It was a play.

But I carried it anyway. Through the rest of that winter, and down the long road west, and into an empty inn at a crossroads. I carried it through all the grey years behind the bar, polishing the same glasses over and over. I did not feel it. I did not know it was there.

It was only a little. Just enough.

And when a scribe came up the road one autumn, with his satchel and his pens and his bloody knuckles, and sat down at a table in my common room and asked me to tell him a story, I think it was that small invisible thing, tucked over my heart by an old man in a barn, that said yes.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-One

# The Storyteller at the Crossroads

We traveled through the Commonwealth for most of that spring and summer, Bast and I, with the cart and the chest and the mule named Patience.

I do not remember much of it. Roads. Towns. Inns and haylofts and camps by the roadside. Rain, and then sun, and then rain again. Bast talked, most of the time. He told me stories, and pointed out birds, and argued with Patience, who did not like him and made it very clear. I listened. I did not say much.

We did not know where we were going. That was the trouble. Bast had said an old storyteller would help us find a place. But we had not seen any old storyteller. We had seen a great many roads, and a great many towns, and none of them had felt right.

"How will we know?" I asked Bast once, when we had stopped for the night in a field outside a town called Hallowfell, and I was polishing the harness buckles by the light of our small fire.

"Know what?"

"When we've found it. The place."

Bast was quiet for a long time. He was lying on his back in the grass, looking up at the stars.

"I don't know," he said at last. "He said we'd know. He said it would be quiet. And small. And old." He turned his head and looked at me. "And he said there'd be a stone."

"A stone?"



"That's all he said. A stone." Bast looked back up at the stars. "He likes to be mysterious. It's very annoying."

\* \* \*

We found him at a crossroads, at the end of summer.

It was a nothing sort of crossroads, in the middle of a nothing sort of country. Rolling fields of wheat and barley, gold and ripening in the late summer sun. A few farmhouses scattered here and there, with thin smoke rising from their chimneys. A line of woods on the horizon, dark and green. Two roads, crossing each other at right angles, both of them dusty and rutted and empty.

And at the corner where they crossed, there was an inn.

It was not much of an inn. A low stone building with a slate roof, and a stable, and a yard with a well in it. There was no sign. There was no name. There was only a lantern hanging over the door, unlit, and a bench beside the door where a man could sit and watch the roads.

There was a man sitting on it.

He was very old. Tall and thin, with a long white beard and hair the color of old snow. His face was lined and weathered, the face of a man who has spent his life outdoors. His clothes were ragged. And his eyes, when he looked up at the sound of our cart on the road, were very bright. Bright and dark at the same time, like the eyes of a bird.

"Well," he said, as we came up the road toward him. His voice was deep and rich and warm. "Well, well. Look who's finally come."

I stopped the cart. I looked at him. I did not know him.

But something in me went very still. The way it had gone still for Vashet, and for Elodin, and for the girl with cloud hair on the roof. As if some part of me recognized, even without a name, that this was someone who saw things.

Bast had gone very still too. He was sitting on the seat of the cart beside me, staring at the old man with wide eyes.

"You," he said. "You're—"

"Skarpi," said the old man. He smiled. His teeth were very white. "Yes. Hello, little prince. I told you I'd find you." He looked at me. "Hello, Kvothe."

"Kote," said Bast quickly. "He's Kote now."

"Is he?" Skarpi looked at me for a long moment with his bright bird's eyes. "Hm. Yes. I see. The little one's given you a little name." He nodded slowly. "That's clever. Very clever. She always was clever, that one." He stood up from the bench, unfolding himself like a heron rising from a pond. "Come in. Come in out of the sun. There's cider, and bread, and a great deal to talk about."

\* \* \*

The inn was empty. No landlord, no serving girl, no other guests. Only a long low common room with a scatter of rough tables and benches, and a great stone hearth at one end with a fire burning in it, and a bar at the other end with a few bottles on a shelf behind it.

Skarpi went behind the bar as if he owned it. He poured three mugs of cider from a cask and brought them to a table by the hearth and set them down.

"Sit," he said. "Drink."

We sat. We drank. The cider was cold and sharp and very good.

Skarpi sat across from me and looked at me for a long time without speaking. His bright eyes moved over my face. My short brown-stained hair. My hands, resting on the table. My left wrist, with the thin pale line around it where the cord had been.

"You did it," he said at last. "You actually did it. You closed the door."

"I don't remember."

"No. Of course you don't." He sighed. "That's the price. I told you it would be. Or Selitos did. Or someone." He shook his head. "I'm getting old. I forget who told who what."

He was quiet for a moment.

"He heard it, you know," he said. "Selitos. In his tower. When you pulled your name out at the door. He heard it the way he hears everything, through that stone eye of his." Skarpi looked at me. "He sent word to me. By way of a raven, of all things. Very dramatic. The note said only one thing." He smiled faintly. "It said, *He found another way. Not the one I hoped for. But a way.*"

I did not say anything. I did not know what to say.

"And then I heard the other song," said Skarpi. "The girl's. The one she sang in the duke's hall, in Renere. The true one." His bright eyes were very soft. "That was well done. Very well done. I didn't think she had it in her. I was wrong."

"She's gone," I said. "Far away. I don't know where."

"I know." Skarpi nodded. "I know where. I won't tell you." He looked at me. "It's better that way."

\* \* \*

"You said you'd help us find a place," said Bast. He had been quiet all this time, holding his mug of cider in both hands and staring at the old man. "Somewhere quiet. Somewhere safe."

"I did say that." Skarpi nodded. "And I will. But first, I need to know something." He looked at me. "The chest. The one with your name in it. Where is it?"

"In the cart."

"Outside? In the yard? In the sun?" Skarpi raised his eyebrows. "Well. That explains why it's so loud."

"Loud?"

"Very loud. I've been hearing it for a month. Getting closer. Coming down the road." He shook his head. "Your friends did good work. The roah, the locks, the girl's knot. It's very quiet. Much quieter than the cord was, on your wrist." He tapped the table with one long finger. "But it's still a name. A big one. The biggest one in the world, right now, maybe. And even locked up in a box of roah wood, it hums." He looked at me. "Anyone who knows how to listen can hear it. If they're close enough."

"How close?"

"Closer than you'd like." Skarpi leaned back. "It needs somewhere else. Somewhere that'll help it be quiet. Somewhere that drowns it out."

"Like where?"

Skarpi looked at me for a long moment. Then he smiled.

"Like a waystone," he said.

He told us about them, sitting by the fire in the empty inn, with the late summer sun slanting through the windows.

"You've seen greystones," he said. "Standing stones, in rings or alone, on hilltops and in fields. The old ones. Everyone has. They're all over the Four Corners."

"Doors," said Bast. "To the twilight. To my world."

"Some of them. Not all." Skarpi nodded. "Some of them are doors. Some are markers, for the old roads, the ones that ran between here and there before the war. And some of them—a very few—are something else." He leaned forward. "They're anchors. Things the namers put down, long ago, at the end of the war, to hold the world together. Big stones. Old stones. Stones that say no so loudly and so long that everything around them gets a little quieter."

"Quieter?"

"Names. Voices. Magic. Everything." Skarpi spread his hands. "Stand next to one of those stones and try to call the wind. You'll find it very hard. Try to do sympathy. Harder still. Try to hear a name." He shook his head. "You can barely hear your own thoughts. It's like standing next to a waterfall."

"And the chest—"

"Put the chest near one of those stones," said Skarpi, "and it'll be drowned out. The stone's *no* will be so loud that no one will hear the name humming underneath it. Not the Seven. Not the Thief. Not anyone."

I sat very still.

"There's one," I said. "Somewhere. Isn't there? That's why you're here."

Skarpi smiled.

"There's one," he said. "Not far from here. Two days' travel, north and east. In a little town at a crossroads, much like this one. A town so small and so quiet that no one's ever heard of it." He paused. "The stone's been there since before the town. Since before the roads. The people there don't know what it is. They call it the waystone, because

it marks where the old road used to run. They walk past it every day and never think about it."

"And the town?"

"Is called Newarre," said Skarpi. "And there's an inn there, right beside the waystone, that's been empty for three years. The old innkeeper died. His widow went to live with her daughter in Baedn. The inn's for sale." He smiled. "Very cheap. No one wants it. It's too quiet. Too small. Too far from anything."

He looked at me with his bright bird's eyes.

"It's perfect," he said.

\* \* \*

We stayed at the empty crossroads inn that night. Skarpi slept in a chair by the fire. Bast slept on a bench. I did not sleep. I sat at the table by the window and looked out at the dark road, and at the cart in the yard with the chest under its canvas cover.

I could not hear it humming. I did not know how to listen. But Bast could. He had told me, many times, on the road. He said it was like a song in another room, very faint, very sad. He said he heard it every night, when he tried to sleep.

Sometime after midnight, Skarpi woke. He came and sat across from me at the table. He did not say anything for a long time.

"You're wondering why I'm helping you," he said at last.

"Yes."

"Because you're the last Singer," said Skarpi. "Or you were. You sang the true song, at the Eolian. The whole of it. With the child in it." He was quiet for a moment. "That made you one of mine. Whether you remember it or not."

"I don't sing anymore."

"I know." Skarpi looked at me. "But you will. Someday." He leaned forward, and his bright eyes were very serious. "Listen to me, Kote. I'm going to tell you something. And I want you to remember it. Even if you don't remember anything else."

"All right."

"Someday," said Skarpi, "a man will come to your inn. Not soon. Years from now. Many years, maybe. He'll come down the road on a horse, or on foot, and he'll be running from something. And he'll come into your inn, and he'll sit at your bar, and he'll ask you for a story."

I looked at him.

"He'll be a scribe," said Skarpi. "A chronicler. A writer-down of true things. He'll have ink on his fingers and a satchel full of paper and a cipher of his own devising. And he'll ask you for the true story of Kvothe." He paused. "And you'll tell him."

"I don't remember the story."

"You will," said Skarpi. "When he comes. When he asks. It'll come back to you. A piece at a time." He smiled faintly. "Stories are names too. Did you know that? The oldest kind. You tell a man's whole story, from the beginning, and you're speaking his name. One word at a time."

I stared at him.

"Tell it to him," said Skarpi quietly. "All of it. The true story. Take as long as you need. And when you're done—"

"What?"

Skarpi looked at me for a long moment. His bright eyes were very old, and very tired, and very kind.

"When you're done," he said, "you'll know what to do."

\* \* \*

He was gone in the morning. The way he always is. We woke, Bast and I, and the chair by the fire was empty, and the fire had burned down to ashes, and there was no sign he had ever been there at all.

But on the table, beside my empty cider mug, there was a purse. A heavy one. And a letter, folded small and sealed with plain wax.

I opened the purse. It was full of gold. More than enough to buy an inn. More than enough to buy three inns.

I opened the letter. It was written in a small precise hand I did not know.

*Sir, it said. His Majesty asks me to send you this, by way of an old friend of yours who says he can find you. His Majesty says it is not a*

*gift. He says it is wages owed, for services rendered, which were never paid. He says it is the least he can do. He says it is far from the most.*

*Her Majesty sends her love. The child is well. She is walking now, and singing, and she has your mother's eyes.*

*I remain, sir, as ever, your servant.*

*Stapes.*

I read it three times. Then I folded it up very carefully and put it inside my shirt, next to the thread with the small knot on it.

Bast was watching me.

"What does it say?" he asked.

I looked at him.

"It says we're going to Newarre," I said.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Two

# The Fair at Tinuë Crossing

Bast tried very hard, that summer, to make me laugh.

I did not know that was what he was doing. I did not know much, then. We traveled through the Commonwealth with the cart and the chest and the mule, from town to town, from inn to inn, looking for somewhere quiet, and Bast talked. He talked all day long. He told jokes and stories and outrageous lies. He sang songs, badly. He made faces at me when I was not looking and then, when I looked, pretended he had not.

I did not laugh. I did not feel anything. I sat on the seat of the cart beside him and watched the road go by, and when he told a joke, I looked at him and said, "Yes," and he would sigh, and look away, and a while later he would try again.

He never stopped trying. I think that is the thing about Bast I most want you to understand. In all those years, the grey years on the road and the greyer ones behind the bar, he never once stopped trying.

\* \* \*

In the middle of summer, we came to a town called Tinuë Crossing, and there was a fair.

It was not a large fair. A midsummer market, the kind every town of any size in the Commonwealth holds, in a field outside the walls, with tents and stalls and a great deal of noise. Cheese sellers and cloth merchants and tinkers, a man selling hot pies from a barrow, a woman with a dancing bear that did not dance so much as sway, a pair of



jugglers, a puppet show. Children running everywhere, underfoot, shrieking.

Bast's eyes lit up when he saw it.

"Reshi," he said. "We're stopping."

"We need to go on," I said. It was the kind of thing I said, then. Not because I wanted to go on. Because going on was what we were doing, and I did not know how to want anything else.

"We're stopping," said Bast firmly. He was already pulling the cart off the road, into the field, among the other carts and wagons. "Patience needs rest. I need pie. And you—" He looked at me. "You need to see something."

\* \* \*

He took me by the arm and led me through the fair. I let him. I let him lead me past the cheese sellers and the cloth merchants and the man with the pies, from whom Bast bought two, and handed me one, and watched me eat it without tasting it, and sighed. I let him lead me past the dancing bear and the jugglers.

He stopped in front of the puppet show.

It was a small one. A painted booth, red and gold and faded, with a little stage at the top and a curtain across the front. A crowd of children sat on the grass in front of it, cross-legged, staring up. And on the stage, two puppets were fighting with little wooden swords.

"Watch," said Bast.

I watched.

\* \* \*

The puppets were very old. You could see that, even from the back of the crowd. Their paint was chipped and their clothes were faded and patched. But the puppeteer, whoever was behind the curtain, was very good. The little wooden figures moved as if they were alive. They lunged and parried and ducked and spun, and their tiny swords clacked together, and the children shrieked with delight.

One of the puppets had red hair.

I looked at it. It was a small wooden man with a shock of bright red yarn for hair and a black painted cloak. It had a little wooden lute on its back. It was fighting a much larger puppet, a great hulking figure with a crown on its head and a painted face twisted into a snarl.

"And lo!" cried a voice from behind the curtain. A high, cracked, old man's voice, full of theatrical relish. "The wicked king of Vintas raises his sword! Will the brave hero fall?"

"No!" shrieked the children.

"Will he flee?"

"No!"

"Will he—*sing*?"

"Yes!"

And the little red-haired puppet swung the lute off its back and began to play. The puppeteer made a jangling sound behind the curtain, a terrible out-of-tune strumming, and the children laughed and laughed. And the big crowned puppet clutched its ears and staggered and reeled, and fell over backward off the stage with a clatter.

The children cheered.

\* \* \*

I stood at the back of the crowd and looked at the little red-haired puppet, bowing on the stage.

I did not know who it was meant to be. I want to be honest about that. I knew my name was Kvothe, because Denna had told me. I knew I had done things, because people had told me. But I did not know what those things were, not really, not in any way that meant anything. The name *Kvothe* was just a word to me, then. Like *Tuesday*, or *salt*.

So I did not know that the little red-haired puppet was me. That the big crowned one was Ambrose. That the story the old man was telling, in his cracked theatrical voice, was a story that had spread through the Four Corners in the year since Renere, growing and changing as it went, until it had become a thing that puppeteers told to children at midsummer fairs.

I did not know. I only looked at it.

And Bast, beside me, was looking at me.

\* \* \*

"The Kingkiller!" cried the puppeteer. "The Bloodless! Kvothe the Arcane, who sang the king to death!" The little red-haired puppet bowed again. The children cheered again. "And do you know what happened to him, children? Do you know where he went?"

"No!"

"Nobody knows!" The puppeteer's voice dropped to a whisper. The children leaned forward. "Some say they hanged him, in Renere, in the great square. Some say he escaped, and went into the Fae, and married a faerie queen. And some say—" He paused. The children held their breath. "Some say he's still out there. Wandering the roads. In disguise. And that he might be anywhere." The little puppet turned, very slowly, and looked out over the crowd. "He might be in *this very field!*"

The children shrieked and looked around at each other, delighted and terrified.

And the little wooden puppet, with its chipped paint and its red yarn hair, looked straight at me.

\* \* \*

It was an accident. It must have been. The puppeteer could not see the crowd from behind his curtain. He had turned the puppet at random. It happened to be facing my way.

But I looked at it. And it looked at me. And for a long moment, standing at the back of that crowd of shrieking children in a field outside Tinuë Crossing, with the smell of hot pies and trampled grass all around me, I felt something.

It was very small. It was not recognition. It was not memory. It was more like the feeling you get when you walk into a room and know, without knowing how, that someone has just left it. A warmth in the air. A shape in the dust.

And I heard myself make a sound.

It was not a laugh. Not really. It was a small, dry, surprised exhalation, through my nose. The kind of sound you make when

something is absurd. When you see a little wooden man with red yarn hair, playing a toy lute to make a king fall over, and some small forgotten part of you thinks: *that's ridiculous. It wasn't like that at all.*

It was the closest thing to a laugh that came out of me for seven years.

\* \* \*

Bast heard it.

He went absolutely still beside me. I felt him go still. And then, very slowly, he turned his head and looked at me, and his face was doing something I had never seen it do before. It was crumpling. Slowly, from the eyes down, the way paper crumples when it gets wet.

"Reshi," he said. His voice was a whisper. "Reshi. Did you—"

But it was gone. Whatever it had been. The warmth in the air, the shape in the dust. Gone. And I was standing at the back of a crowd, looking at a puppet show, and I did not feel anything at all.

"Did I what?" I said.

Bast looked at me for a long moment. His eyes were very bright and very wet.

"Nothing," he said at last. "Nothing, Reshi." He wiped his face with the back of his hand. "Come on. Let's go and get another pie."

\* \* \*

He did not talk much, the rest of that day. He bought us both another pie, and we ate them sitting on the tailboard of the cart, watching the fair. He did not tell any jokes. He did not make any faces. He sat beside me in silence and ate his pie and watched the children running past.

But that night, camped at the edge of the field, when he thought I was asleep, I heard him crying. Very quietly, wrapped in his blanket on the other side of the fire. Not sad crying. The other kind. The kind that comes after a long time of holding on, when you find out that what you were holding on to is still there.

I did not know why he was crying. I lay in my blanket and looked at the stars and did not understand.

I understand now.

\* \* \*

"You laughed," said Chronicler. He had stopped writing. "At a puppet of yourself."

"I snorted." The innkeeper's mouth twitched. "There's a difference."

"Bast told me," said Chronicler slowly, "on the first night. When he came to my room. He said you hadn't laughed in seven years." He looked at Bast. "Was that—"

"It doesn't count," said Bast. He was not looking at either of them. He was looking at the fire. "It was a snort. He's right. It doesn't count." He was quiet for a moment. "But I've been waiting for the next one ever since."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Something moved across his face. Something warm, and sad, and very fond.

"Bast," he said.

"Yes, Reshi?"

"It really wasn't like that. With Ambrose. At all."

Bast looked up. Their eyes met. And then, slowly, the corner of Bast's mouth began to curl.

"What, no toy lute?" he said.

"No toy lute."

"He didn't clutch his ears and fall off the stage?"

"He did not fall off the stage."

"Pity," said Bast. "It was the best part."

The innkeeper did not laugh. But something happened at the corner of his mouth. Something small and crooked and brief, there and gone again, like a fish turning once in dark water.

It was not a smile. Not quite. But it was the shape a smile leaves behind, when it has been somewhere recently.

Bast saw it. He did not say anything. He did not have to. He sat in his backward chair with his arms folded across its back, and looked at the innkeeper, and his eyes were very bright.

Chronicler, very quietly, picked up his pen and wrote it down.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Three

### **Newarre**

It took us two days to reach it, north and east through the rolling wheat country, along roads that grew smaller and emptier with every mile.

Newarre, when we came to it, was exactly as Skarpi had said. A town so small and so quiet that no one had ever heard of it. A few dozen houses clustered around a crossroads, with a smithy and a mill and a little stone church with a cracked bell. A handful of shops. A green, with a well in the middle of it. Fields of wheat and barley running away on every side, gold in the late summer sun, to a line of dark woods on the horizon.

And at the edge of the town, where the two roads crossed, there was a stone.

It was grey. Tall and grey and very old, taller than a man, standing alone at the corner where the roads met. It was worn smooth by the wind and the rain and the years, so smooth that it looked less like a stone than like something that had grown there, the way a tree grows. There was lichen on it, grey-green and orange, in patches. There were marks on it, very faint, that might once have been carvings. They were too worn to read.

I stopped the cart in the road beside it. I looked at it.

I did not hear anything. I did not know how to listen. But I felt something. Standing there, in the road, in the sun. A kind of stillness. A kind of quiet. As if the whole world had taken a breath and was holding it.

Beside me, on the seat of the cart, Bast had gone pale.

"Oh," he said softly. "Oh, Reshi. It's so *loud*."

"I don't hear anything."

"No. You wouldn't." He was staring at the stone. His deep blue eyes were very wide. "It's saying no. Like the stone in your pocket. Like the mountain. But so much louder. So much older." He put his hands over his ears, as if that would help. "I can barely think. It's like standing next to a waterfall."

"Is that good?"

Bast looked at me. Then he looked back at the stone. Then he turned around on the seat and looked at the cart behind us. At the chest, under its canvas cover.

He was quiet for a long moment.

"I can't hear it," he said at last. His voice was full of wonder. "The chest. The name. I've been hearing it every night for a year. And now I can't hear it at all." He looked at me. "The stone's drowning it out."

\* \* \*

The inn was on the other side of the crossroads, across the road from the waystone.

It was a long, low building of grey fieldstone, two stories tall, with a slate roof and a stable behind and a yard with a well in it. It had been a good inn, once. You could see that in the bones of it: the solid walls, the deep-set windows, the great stone chimney at one end. But it had been empty for three years, and it showed. The windows were shuttered and the shutters were cracked and peeling. The yard was overgrown with weeds. The stable door hung off one hinge. There was a sign over the door, but it had faded so badly that you could not read it.

I got down from the cart. I walked across the yard to the door. I pushed it open.

It creaked. Of course it creaked. Inside, it was dark and dusty and smelled of damp and mice and old smoke. There was a common room, long and low, with a great stone hearth at one end and a bar along one wall. There were tables and chairs, stacked in corners, covered in dust. There were bottles behind the bar, empty, covered in cobwebs. There

was a staircase at the back, leading up.

I stood in the doorway and looked at it for a long time.

It was grey. Everything was grey.

But it was quiet. So quiet. The quietest place I had been since the chamber beneath the Lackless house. Quieter even than that. There, the quiet had been the silence after a scream. Here, it was the silence of a place where nothing had ever screamed at all.

Bast came up behind me. He stood in the doorway beside me and looked at the dusty common room.

"It's awful," he said.

"Yes."

"It's falling apart."

"Yes."

"There are *mice*, Reshi. I can hear them. In the walls."

"Yes."

Bast looked at me for a long moment.

"You want it," he said. "Don't you?"

I looked at the common room. At the dusty tables and the empty bottles and the cold hearth.

"Yes," I said.

\* \* \*

I bought it the next day.

The widow's brother-in-law handled the sale. He was a big slow farmer named Graham, with a carpenter's hands and a face like a well-worn saddle. He came up from his farm on the east road when word got round that a stranger was asking about the old inn, and he stood in the dusty yard and looked at me and Bast and the cart and the mule, and he scratched his head.

"You want to buy it?" he said. "The inn?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

I thought about it. I did not have a good answer. So I gave him the only one I had.

"It's quiet," I said.



Graham looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at the inn, with its peeling shutters and its broken stable door. Then he looked back at me.

"It's that," he said. "Nobody's going to argue with you there." He scratched his head again. "It needs a lot of work."

"I know."

"The roof leaks. Over the back bedrooms. And the chimney's cracked. And there's rot in the stable floor." He looked at me. "You know anything about fixing things?"

"Some."

"Hm." Graham looked me up and down. At my brown-stained hair, and my plain clothes, and my hands. He looked at my hands for a long time. "You've got good hands. Working hands. I can see that." He nodded slowly. "All right. I'll tell Mary. She'll be glad to be shed of it. She's been worrying about it for three years."

We agreed on a price. It was very low. Much lower than Skarpi's purse. I paid it in gold, and Graham looked at the gold in his hand and then at me, and did not ask any questions.

"What'll you call it?" he said, as he was leaving.

"What?"

"The inn. It needs a name. The old one was the Crossroads. But the sign's gone. Faded right off." He looked up at the blank board over the door. "You'll want a new one. I can carve it for you, if you like. I'm good with wood."

I looked at the blank sign. Then I looked across the road, at the tall grey stone standing at the corner of the crossroads, in the late afternoon sun.

"The Waystone," I said.

Graham followed my gaze. He looked at the stone for a long moment.

"The Waystone Inn," he said slowly. "Hm. That's a good name. Simple. Easy to remember." He nodded. "I'll carve it for you. Give me a span."

\* \* \*

He carved it. He brought it up from his farm on a cart, a span later, and hung it over the door himself, on two iron hooks. It was a good sign. Oak, very solid, with the letters carved deep and painted black. *The Waystone Inn*. And beneath the letters, a picture. A tall grey stone, standing alone at a crossroads, with the sun behind it.

I stood in the yard and looked up at it for a long time.

"You don't like it," said Graham. He sounded disappointed.

"No," I said. "I do."

"You've got a funny way of showing it."

I looked at him. I thought about Bast, on the road, saying *you don't like anything. You don't feel anything*.

"I'm sorry," I said. "I'm not very good at showing things."

Graham looked at me for a long moment. Then he shrugged.

"That's all right," he said. "Nor am I. My wife says I've got a face like a board." He grinned. "Suppose that makes two of us."

\* \* \*

We moved in that same day. Bast and I. We unloaded the cart and carried everything inside. It was not much. Our packs, and a few blankets, and some pots and pans, and the lavender a girl had given me on a roof in Imre, which I hung from a nail in the kitchen.

And the chest.

It was very heavy. Roah is very heavy. It took both of us to lift it, and we staggered under it as we carried it through the door and across the common room and up the narrow stairs. There was a room at the top of the stairs, at the front of the inn, with a window that looked out over the crossroads. Toward the waystone.

We put the chest there. At the foot of the bed. Where I could see it every night before I slept, and every morning when I woke.

Bast stood in the doorway and looked at it for a long time.

"Can you hear it?" I asked.

He was quiet for a moment. He tilted his head, listening.

"No," he said at last. "Not a thing. The stone's too loud." He looked at me. "It's safe, Reshi. For now. Nobody's going to hear it here."

I looked at the chest. At its dark smooth wood, and its two locks, and the small dark knot sunk into the grain between them.

I did not feel anything. I did not know what I should feel.

But I put my hand on the lid. Just for a moment. The wood was cool and smooth under my palm.

And I found, when I took my hand away, that I had been holding my breath.

\* \* \*

That night, I sat alone in the common room of the Waystone Inn.

Bast had gone to bed, in a little room at the back. The mice were quiet. The fire was burning in the great stone hearth, the first fire it had seen in three years. It crackled and popped and threw long shadows across the dusty floor.

I sat at a table beside it with a rag and a pot of grease, and I polished the brass rail of the bar. I had taken it off, and brought it to the table, and I was polishing it. Slowly. Carefully. In small even circles.

It was very tarnished. It took a long time. But slowly, under the rag, it began to gleam.

I did not think about anything. I did not remember anything. I polished the rail, and the fire burned, and the inn was very quiet around me.

And somewhere, very far down, at the bottom of the hole where my name had been, something settled. The way a stone settles at the bottom of a pond. The way dust settles in an empty room.

It was not peace. Not exactly. It was the shape of peace. The ghost of it.

But it was something.

\* \* \*

Outside, across the road, the waystone stood in the dark. Tall and grey and silent, saying its long slow *no* to the world.

And in the room at the top of the stairs, in a chest of roah wood, a name lay folded in a cord of dark hair, beside a lute and a box with no

lid and a very bad poem.

And it was quiet. For the first time in a very long time.

It was quiet.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Four

### **Kote**

It took me most of that autumn to make the Waystone into an inn again.

I did it with my hands. Bast helped, when he was in the mood, which was not often. He was very good at some things and very bad at others, and the things he was good at were mostly not the things an inn needs. He could charm a farmer's wife into selling us eggs at half price. He could find the one loose board in a floor by listening to it. He could make the mice leave the walls, simply by walking through the rooms at night and humming. But he could not hammer a nail straight to save his life, and he said the smell of whitewash made him ill.

So I did most of it myself.

I fixed the roof. I climbed up on it with a ladder Graham lent me and a sack of slates from the quarry at Rannish, and I found every leak and patched it, one slate at a time. I fixed the chimney, which was cracked, with mortar I mixed myself from lime and sand and water. I fixed the stable door, and the stable floor, and the pump in the yard, and the shutters on every window.

I cleaned. I swept and scrubbed and dusted every room in the inn, from the cellar to the attic. I washed every window. I whitewashed every wall. I polished every table and every chair and every brass fitting until they gleamed.

I did not think about it. I did not plan it. I simply got up every morning and found the next thing that needed doing, and did it. And then the next thing. And the next. Until one day in the middle of

autumn I came down the stairs in the morning and looked at the common room, clean and bright and ready, and there was nothing left to do.

I stood at the bottom of the stairs for a long time, looking at it.

It was grey. But it was clean.

\* \* \*

Graham came up from his farm that afternoon, the way he did most afternoons, to see how I was getting on. He stood in the doorway of the common room and looked around at it for a long time. At the clean whitewashed walls, and the polished tables, and the gleaming bar, and the fire burning bright in the great stone hearth.

"Well," he said. "God's teeth."

"Is it all right?"

"All right?" Graham came into the room. He ran his big hand along the top of the bar. "It's better than it ever was. Better than when old Bentley had it." He shook his head. "Bentley let it go, the last few years. Drank more than he sold. But this—" He looked around. "This is a proper inn. This is the kind of place a man would walk a mile out of his way to drink in."

"I hope so."

Graham looked at me. "You'll be opening, then?"

"Tomorrow. If anyone comes."

"Oh, they'll come." Graham grinned. "Word's been going round. The stranger who bought the old Crossroads, working day and night like a man possessed. Everyone's curious. They'll come just to look at you." He paused. "You'll need stock. Beer and cider and wine and such."

"I've ordered it. From Baedn. The carter's bringing it tomorrow morning."

"Carter?" Graham laughed. "That's his name, too. Carter. Funny, that. His da was a carter, and his da before him, so they just called him Carter and gave up on anything else." He looked at me. "What about you? What's your name? I never asked. You never said."

I looked at him.

"Kote," I said.

Graham tried it out. "Kote. Hm. Short. Easy to remember." He nodded. "Suits you. You're a short, easy sort of man." He clapped me on the shoulder. "Well, Kote. I'll bring the lads round tomorrow night. First round's on you, mind. For luck."

\* \* \*

They came.

Not many, that first night. Graham, and his two grown sons. An old man named Cob, grey-bearded and bent, who sat at the bar and told me the whole history of the inn and every innkeeper who had ever kept it, with a great many digressions. A young man named Jake, who had a farm on the north road and a wife who was expecting their first child. A lean, quiet, sour-faced man named Carter, who had brought the beer from Baedn that morning and had decided to stay and drink some of it. A cheerful, round, red-faced man named Shep, who laughed at everything, especially his own jokes.

They sat at the bar and drank and talked. About the harvest, and the weather, and the price of wheat in Baedn. About the war in Vintas, which was over now, and the new king there, who they said was a strange one. Walked barefoot through his own capital, they said, in a sack. Mad as a hatter, they said.

"The Penitent King," said Old Cob, with great authority. "That's what they call him. Because he's always doing penance. My cousin's wife's brother was in Renere last year, and he said the king goes barefoot every Cendling, to this day. Just walks around the palace gardens with no shoes on. For his sins, he says." Old Cob shook his head. "Must have a lot of sins."

"Must have," agreed Shep, and laughed.

I stood behind the bar and poured their drinks and listened. I did not say much. I smiled when they laughed, and nodded when they talked, and filled their mugs when they were empty.

And somewhere near the end of the night, when they were all a little drunk and very cheerful, Jake said, "What about the one who killed the old king? The one before? The Ruh?"

"Kvothe," said Old Cob. "Kvothe the Kingkiller."

"That's him." Jake leaned forward. "My brother-in-law says he wasn't really hanged. He says it was somebody else, with his hair dyed. He says Kvothe got away, and he's hiding somewhere, waiting."

"Waiting for what?" said Graham.

"Dunno. Just waiting." Jake shrugged. "That's what my brother-in-law says."

"Your brother-in-law says a lot of things," said Carter sourly. "He also says there's a dragon living in the hills behind Rannish."

"There might be!"

"There isn't."

They argued about it, cheerfully, for a while. I stood behind the bar and polished a glass. Slowly. In small even circles.

I did not feel anything. The name meant nothing to me. *Kvothe*. It was only a word. A name from a story, like Lanre or Taborlin or Oren Velciter. A man who had done great things, and terrible things, and then vanished.

But my hands, polishing the glass, had stopped moving. I looked down at them and saw that they had stopped. I did not know why.

I made them move again.

\* \* \*

After that night, they came every night. Graham and Cob and Jake and Carter and Shep, and others too. The smith, a big silent man named Baxter, and his apprentice, a boy of twelve named Aaron who could barely see over the bar. The miller and his wife. A widow named Rena who lived alone at the edge of town and came in on Felling nights for a single glass of wine. Travelers, sometimes, passing through on the road. Tinkers and peddlers and the occasional carter from Baedn or Rannish.

I learned their names. All of them. I learned what they drank and how they liked it. I learned who could be trusted to pay and who needed reminding. I learned whose wife was sick and whose son had gone off to be a soldier and whose barn had burned down in a lightning storm. I learned to listen, and nod, and say the right thing,



and pour the right drink.

I learned to be an innkeeper.

It was not hard. It was mostly the same as polishing things. Small and quiet and careful. Doing the next thing, and then the next, and then the next. It kept me small. It kept me quiet.

And it filled the hours. That was the important thing. It filled the long hours between waking and sleeping, when otherwise I would have sat alone in the dark and felt the hole in my chest.

\* \* \*

In the second month, I hung the sword.

I had not known what to do with it. It had been lying in the bottom of my pack since Imre, wrapped in its oiled cloth, and I had not taken it out. I did not want to look at it. I did not know why.

But one night, after the regulars had gone home and Bast had gone to bed, I went up to my room and took it out of the pack. I unwrapped it. I held it.

It was heavy. Heavier than it looked. A long straight blade, grey and plain, with a simple hilt wrapped in leather. There was no ornament on it at all.

I held it for a long time, standing in my room at the top of the stairs, with the chest at the foot of my bed and the waystone outside the window.

*Folly*, I had called it. A woman in red had asked me to name it, on a riverbank, and I had called it that. I did not remember why. But I remembered the weight of it. The weight in my hands and my arms and my shoulders.

I took it downstairs. I stood in the common room, in the dark, with only the embers of the fire for light. I looked at the wall above the hearth. A great bare stretch of whitewashed stone, above the mantel.

I hung it there. On two iron pegs I drove into the mortar between the stones. I hung it level, with the hilt to the left and the point to the right. And I stepped back, and looked at it.

It looked like nothing. Like an old sword, hung on a wall. The kind of thing you see in a hundred inns across the Four Corners. A

traveler's sword, left to pay a debt. A soldier's sword, hung up when he came home from the war.

But I looked at it for a long time.

\* \* \*

Graham saw it the next night. He stood in front of the hearth with his mug in his hand and looked up at it for a long time.

"That's a good sword," he said at last.

"It's old."

"Old and good." He squinted at it. "Where'd you get it?"

I thought about how to answer.

"It was given to me," I said. "By someone who didn't want it anymore."

Graham looked at it a while longer. "It needs a plaque," he said. "Under it. A sword like that, hanging on a wall like that. It ought to have a plaque. With its name." He looked at me. "Swords have names, sometimes. Old ones. Did you know that?"

"Yes."

"Does this one?"

I looked up at the sword. At the grey blade, and the plain hilt, and the firelight sliding along the edge.

"Folly," I said.

Graham looked at me. Then at the sword. Then back at me. Something moved in his big slow face.

"Folly," he said slowly. "That's a strange name for a sword."

"It's a strange sword."

Graham was quiet for a long moment. Then he nodded.

"I'll make you a plaque," he said. "Oak. Like the sign. I'll burn the letters in, so they last." He looked up at the sword again. "Folly," he said, half to himself. "Hm. There's a story there, I'd wager."

"Maybe."

"You'll tell me, someday?"

I looked at him. At his big slow face and his carpenter's hands.

"Maybe," I said.

He brought the plaque a span later. It was very good work. A board of dark oak, about the length of my forearm, with the edges rounded and the surface polished smooth. The letters were burned in, black and deep. A single word.

*FOLLY.*

I hung it on the wall beneath the sword. I stood back and looked at it. Graham stood beside me and looked at it too.

"That's right," he said at last. "That's just right."

"Yes," I said. "It is."

\* \* \*

That winter, I began to notice the silence.

It had always been there, I think. Since the day I pushed open the door and saw the dusty common room for the first time. But I had not noticed it. I had been too busy. Too tired. Too full of work.

But in the winter, when the snow came and the roads closed and the travelers stopped coming, and the regulars came later and left earlier because of the cold, there was more time. Long empty hours, in the evenings and the mornings, with nothing to do but sit behind the bar and polish things.

And I began to notice it.

It was not one silence. It was three. I did not know how I knew that. But I knew it, the way I knew how to cut wood or skin a rabbit. Three silences, lying on top of each other, like three layers of snow.

The first was the silence of the inn itself. An empty room, in the night, with the fire burned low. Chairs upside down on the tables. Nothing moving. Nothing making a sound. A plain, simple, ordinary silence, like the silence of any empty room.

The second was the silence of the town. Of Newarre, and the fields around it, and the road running past the door. A small town, in a quiet country, in the dead of winter. No carts on the road. No voices in the street. Only the snow falling, and the wind moving in the bare trees, and the silence of a place where nothing much ever happens.

And the third silence was mine.

I did not know what it was, at first. I only knew it was there. Underneath the other two. Deeper. Quieter. A silence that lived in the long bar of dark wood, and in the bottles behind it, and in the sword above the hearth, and in me. Most of all in me.

It was the silence of a man who is waiting. Who has been waiting for a long time. Who has grown so used to waiting that he has forgotten what he is waiting for.

I did not know what I was waiting for. I did not know if I was waiting for anything.

But the silence knew. And it waited with me.

\* \* \*

Bast found me one night, very late, sitting behind the bar with a rag in my hand and a glass that I had polished so long it had begun to squeak.

He sat down on a stool across the bar from me. He did not say anything for a long time. He only looked at me with his deep blue eyes.

"Reshi," he said at last. "Do you know what you're doing?"

"Polishing a glass."

"No." He shook his head. "You're waiting. You've been waiting since we came here. I can see it. I can *hear* it." He looked at me. "What are you waiting for?"

I looked down at the glass in my hand. At my own reflection in it, distorted and grey.

"I don't know," I said.

"Then why wait?"

I thought about it for a long time.

"Because an old man told me to," I said at last. "At a crossroads. He said someone would come. Someday. And ask for a story."

Bast went very still.

"Skarpi," he said.

"I think so. I don't remember his name. But he had bright eyes. Like a bird's." I set the glass down. "He said a man would come. A scribe. With ink on his fingers. And he'd ask for the true story of Kvothe." I looked at Bast. "And I'd tell him."

Bast stared at me.

"When?" he said. His voice was very quiet.

"He didn't say. Years. Maybe many years."

"And until then?"

I picked up another glass. I began to polish it. Slowly. In small even circles.

"Until then," I said, "I wait."

Bast looked at me for a long, long time. His face was very strange in the firelight. Full of something I did not understand.

Then he got up and went to bed without another word.

I stayed behind the bar. I polished the glass. The fire burned low. And the silence settled around me, three layers deep, like snow.

Waiting.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Five

### **The Priest**

The priest came to see me in my second month at the Waystone.

His name was Father Anselm, and he was the only Tehlin priest within a day's ride of Newarre. He served four villages, riding from one to the next on a patient grey mule, holding services in each on a different day of the span. In Newarre, it was Mourning. He said the service in the little stone church behind the square, and then he came to the inn for his dinner, the way he had done, Graham told me, for twenty years. Old Bentley had always given it to him free.

He was a small man, Father Anselm, and very old, with a round pink face and wispy white hair and eyes the washed-out blue of a winter sky. His robes were grey and patched at the elbows. He came into the common room on my first Mourning with his hat in his hands, and stood inside the door, and looked at me behind the bar.

"You'll be the new one," he said.

"Yes, Father."

"Kote, they tell me." He came over and sat down on a stool at the bar with a small grunt of relief. "Just Kote?"

"Just Kote."

He looked at me for a moment with his faded blue eyes. Then he nodded.

"Well, Kote," he said. "Bentley used to give me the stew and a cup of the brown. I don't suppose you'd be willing to carry on the tradition? I'm a poor man, and the mule eats more than I do."

I gave him the stew and a cup of the brown. I did not charge him. I did not charge him the next Mourning, either, or any Mourning after, for seven years.

\* \* \*

He came every span. He sat at the same stool, at the end of the bar near the fire, and ate his stew slowly, and talked. Not to me, particularly. To anyone. To the room. He talked about his other villages, and the weather, and the price of barley, and the doings of his flock. Who was sick. Who was married. Who had quarreled with whom. He talked in a mild, rambling, pleasant way, like a stream running over stones, and I polished glasses and listened, and did not say much.

He did not ask me questions. That was the first thing I noticed about him. Everyone in Newarre asked me questions, those first months. Where I was from. What I had done before. Why I had come. I gave them small answers, grey and dull, and they lost interest. But Father Anselm never asked. He ate his stew and talked about the price of barley and looked at me, sometimes, with his winter-blue eyes, and did not ask anything at all.

\* \* \*

It was in the second winter that he finally did.

It was a bad Mourning. Snow and wind, and the roads half closed. Father Anselm had come in late, shaking snow from his hat, and there was no one else in the common room. He sat on his stool and ate his stew in silence, for once. He did not talk about anything.

When he had finished, he set down his spoon and looked at me.

"Kote," he said. "Would you like to make confession?"

I stopped polishing the glass in my hands.

"I'm not a Tehlin, Father," I said.

"No. I didn't think you were." He folded his small pink hands on the bar. "But confession isn't only for Tehlins. Not really. It's for anyone who's carrying something too heavy." He looked at me. "I've been a priest for fifty-one years, son. I know what it looks like, when a man is carrying something too heavy. It looks like you."

I did not say anything. I set down the glass.

"You don't have to tell me what it is," said Father Anselm. "That's not the point of confession. People think it is, but it isn't. God already knows what it is. I don't need to." He smiled faintly. "The point is to set it down. Just for a moment. In front of someone. So you can remember that it *can* be set down. That it's not a part of you. That it's something you're carrying."

\* \* \*

I looked at him for a long time. The wind howled around the inn. Snow hissed against the shutters.

"I can't," I said at last.

"Can't?"

"There's nothing to set down." I heard my own voice, flat and grey. "I don't remember what it is. I know there's something. I can feel the weight of it. But I don't know what it is." I looked at my hands on the bar. "Someone took it from me. To keep it safe. And now I carry the weight, and not the thing."

It was more than I had said to anyone in Newarre. It was more than I had said to Bast, in months. I do not know why I said it to him. Perhaps because he had not asked, all those spans. Perhaps because of the snow.

Father Anselm did not look surprised. He looked at me with his winter-blue eyes for a long moment.

"That's the hardest kind," he said quietly. "I've seen it before. Not often. Soldiers, mostly. Men who came back from the wars and couldn't remember what they'd done there. Only that it was heavy." He was quiet. "One of them told me it was like carrying a sealed box. You can feel the weight. You can hear something moving inside. But you can't open it. And you can't put it down, because what if it's something important. So you just carry it. Forever."

"Yes," I said. "Like that."

\* \* \*



Father Anselm was quiet for a long time. Then he reached into the pocket of his patched grey robe and took out something small and set it on the bar between us.

It was a wheel. A little Tehlin wheel, the kind every priest carries, carved from dark wood and worn smooth by years of handling. The kind of thing you see hanging on a cord around the neck of every devout farmer's wife in the Commonwealth.

"I'm not going to tell you to pray," he said. "You're not a Tehlin. It wouldn't mean anything." He pushed the wheel across the bar toward me. "But I'll tell you what I told the soldier. What my own teacher told me, when I was young and carrying something too heavy of my own."

I looked at the wheel.

"The wheel turns," said Father Anselm. "That's all it means. That's all it's ever meant, underneath all the theology. Nothing stays at the top, and nothing stays at the bottom. Whatever you're carrying, however heavy it is, the wheel is turning. Slowly. So slowly you can't feel it. But turning." He tapped the little wooden wheel with one finger. "Someday it'll come round. And the box will open. And you'll find out what's inside." He looked at me. "And whatever it is, son, you'll be strong enough to hold it. By then. The wheel makes sure of that. It never brings anything round before you're ready."

\* \* \*

I did not believe him. I want to be honest about that. I did not believe in Tehlu, or in the wheel, or in anything very much, those days. I did not believe in much of anything.

But I took the little wheel. I put it in my apron pocket. And I carried it there, for years, the way I carried the tinker's knot later, without ever taking it out or looking at it. A small smooth weight against my hip.

Father Anselm died in my fifth winter at the Waystone. He fell from his mule on an icy road between Newarre and Rannish, and broke his hip, and lay in the cold for a night before anyone found him. He lived three days after that, in the back room of the smithy, where

Baxter had carried him. The whole town came to see him. He talked the whole time. About the price of barley, and the weather, and who had quarreled with whom.

I went on the second day. I stood by his bed and did not say anything. He looked up at me with his winter-blue eyes, very faded now, very tired.

"Kote," he said. "Do you still have it?"

I took the little wooden wheel out of my apron pocket and showed him.

He smiled.

"Good," he said. "Keep it turning."

He died that night. They buried him in the churchyard behind the little stone church, beside Bentley, who had given him his dinner for twenty years. There was no new priest for most of a year after that. The church stood empty on Mourning, and nobody came to the Waystone for stew and a cup of the brown. When a new one came at last, from Rannish, he was young and thin and nervous, and he said his prayers quickly, and he never stayed for dinner.

I kept a stool empty for him, at the end of the bar by the fire. For a year. I did not tell anyone why.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper took something out of his apron pocket and set it on the table. A small wooden wheel, dark and worn smooth.

"I still have it," he said. "I don't know why. I'm not a Tehlin. I don't pray." He turned it over with one finger. "But I think he'd be pleased to know it came round. The wheel. Eventually." He looked at Chronicler. "It took seven years. And a scribe. And a knot from a tinker." He was quiet for a moment. "But it came round."

He put the little wheel back in his pocket. Beside the knot.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Six

### Seasons

The years went by the Waystone the way the carts went by on the road. Slowly, one after another, each one a little different and all of them the same.

I will not tell you all of them. There is not much to tell. That was the point of them. They were small years. Quiet years. The kind of years that do not make stories.

But I will tell you a little. So that you understand. So that you know what it was like, to be Kote. To be small.

\* \* \*

In the first spring, Jake's wife had her baby. A boy. They named him Tam, after Jake's father, and they brought him to the inn when he was a month old to show him off. Everyone crowded around to look at him. Old Cob said he had Jake's nose, which was not a compliment. Shep said he had his mother's temper, which was. Graham held him in his big carpenter's hands and looked at him for a long time and said nothing at all, and his eyes were wet.

They asked me if I wanted to hold him. I did not know why. I was only the innkeeper.

I held him. He was very small and very warm and he smelled of milk. He looked up at me with blue eyes that had not yet decided what color they would be.

And something happened. Very faint. Very far down. The ghost of a feeling. The shape of warmth.

I gave him back quickly.

\* \* \*

In the first summer, a bard came through.

He was a young man, not much older than I had been when I went to the University, though I did not know that. He had a lute on his back and a bright red cloak and a great deal of confidence. He came into the Waystone on a hot evening and asked if he could play for his supper.

I said yes. The regulars were bored, and it was a long time since they had heard any music that was not Shep singing off-key at the end of the night.

He played well. Not brilliantly. But well. He played "Tinker Tanner" and "Jenny Nettle" and "The Lady and the Lord and the Bath." He played a sad song about a sailor who never came home. The regulars clapped and stamped and bought him drinks.

And then, near the end of the night, he said, "I've got a new one. Very new. Just learned it, in Tinuë, from a man who'd learned it in Vintas." He tuned his lute. "It's banned there, they say. In Vintas. The Penitent King banned it. You can get your tongue cut out for singing it." He grinned. "But we're not in Vintas, are we?"

"What's it called?" said Graham.

"*Tarinie*," said the bard. "It's about the white city. From the old stories."

I was behind the bar, polishing a glass. I did not know the name. It meant nothing to me.

But my hands stopped.

The bard began to play.

\* \* \*

I will not tell you what it was like. I cannot. I do not remember it clearly. I remember only pieces.

I remember the first notes of the lute, rising up into the smoky air of the common room. I remember the bard's voice, clear and young and a little too sure of itself. I remember the words. A white city, on the last day of its life. Towers rising against a blue sky. Children

playing in fountains.

I remember that the glass in my hand broke.

I did not mean to break it. I did not know I was holding it so tightly. But it broke, in my hand, and the pieces fell on the bar with a small bright sound, and there was blood on my palm.

No one noticed. They were all listening to the bard.

I stood behind the bar with blood running down my wrist, and I listened too. I did not want to. Every part of me wanted to leave. To go into the kitchen, or up the stairs, or out into the yard. Anywhere. Anywhere but here, where the song was.

But I could not move. I stood there. And I listened.

And the song went into me. Through the hole in my chest where my name had been. Down and down, into the dark, into the place where nothing was. And it did not find anything there. It went down and down and found nothing, and came back up empty.

But it went down. That was the thing. It went down, and it looked, and it did not find. And the looking hurt more than anything had hurt since the cellar.

\* \* \*

When the bard finished, the common room was silent. Rena the widow was weeping quietly into her wine. Graham was staring at the floor. Old Cob, for once in his life, had nothing to say.

"Well," said the bard, a little uncertainly. "That's—that's the one. *Tariniel*. What did you think?"

Nobody answered.

I came out from behind the bar. I did not decide to. My feet moved on their own. I walked across the common room to where the bard was sitting, on a stool by the hearth, with his lute in his lap. I stood in front of him.

He looked up at me. His face was young and bright and a little frightened.

"You played it wrong," I said.

My voice was flat. Toneless. But it carried across the silent room. The bard stared at me. "What?"

"The third verse. The part about the fountains. You played it too fast. It should be slower. Much slower. Like a child playing. Not like a march." I did not know how I knew it. The words came out of me from somewhere very far down. "And the last line of the song. You sang it like an ending. It's not an ending. It's a beginning. The boy in the fountain is asking to be a singer. He's not finishing anything. He's starting."

The bard looked at me for a long moment. His face was very pale.

"How do you know that?" he said.

I did not answer. I did not know. I stood in front of him with blood dripping from my hand onto the floor, and I did not know anything at all.

Then I turned around and went into the kitchen and closed the door.

\* \* \*

Bast found me there an hour later, after the regulars had gone home and the bard had gone up to bed. I was sitting on the floor of the kitchen with my back against the wall and my bloody hand in my lap.

He knelt beside me. He did not say anything. He took my hand and looked at the cut on my palm. It was deep. There were still small pieces of glass in it.

He picked them out, one by one, very carefully. He washed the cut with water from the pump. He bound it with a clean cloth.

Then he sat down beside me on the floor, with his back against the wall too.

"You heard it," he said at last. Very quietly.

"Yes."

"Did you remember?"

"No." I looked down at my bound hand. "Nothing. It went down and down and there was nothing there."

Bast was quiet for a long time.

"But you knew," he said. "About the verse. The fountains. The last line." He turned his head and looked at me. "Reshi, you *knew*. That's your song. You wrote it. And you knew how it should go."

"I don't remember writing it."

"But you knew." His voice cracked. "Some part of you knew. Some part of you is still in there."

I did not say anything.

Bast looked at me for a long time. Then he put his head on my shoulder, the way a child does, and closed his eyes.

"I'm going to make sure no one ever sings it here again," he said. "Ever. I'm going to make sure no bard ever comes through that door with that song in his mouth." His voice was fierce. "I won't let it hurt you."

"It didn't hurt."

"It did. I saw your face." He was quiet for a moment. "It hurt worse than the cellar."

I did not answer. Because he was right.

\* \* \*

In the second year, the Penitent King raised the taxes.

The war was over in Vintas, but there was another war now. In the Commonwealth. Rebels in the north, who said the Penitent King had no right to the throne of Vintas and even less right to meddle in the affairs of the Commonwealth, and who had taken up arms against his allies there. The Penitent King sent soldiers to help his allies. The soldiers needed paying. The taxes went up.

The tax collector came through Newarre in the autumn, with a guard of six soldiers in grey. He sat at a table in the Waystone with a ledger and a strongbox, and the people of the town came in one by one and paid what they owed. Some of them paid easily. Some of them paid with their faces tight and their hands shaking. Some of them could not pay at all, and the tax collector wrote their names in his ledger, and the soldiers wrote something else.

Jake could not pay. He had a new baby, and a bad harvest, and a sick cow. He stood in front of the tax collector's table with his hat in his hands and his face white, and he said he would pay next season, he swore it, he would find the money somehow.

The tax collector wrote his name in the ledger.

I watched from behind the bar. I did not feel anything. I did not know Jake well; he was only a regular, a young man who drank cider and talked about his farm.

But when the tax collector had gone, and Jake was sitting alone at the end of the bar with his head in his hands, I went and stood in front of him.

"How much?" I said.

He looked up at me. His eyes were red.

I paid it. From Skarpi's purse, which was still more than half full. I paid it to the tax collector's clerk the next morning, before they left town, and I told the clerk to strike Jake's name from the ledger.

Jake came to see me that night. He stood in front of the bar and did not know what to say.

"Why?" he said at last.

I thought about it. I did not know.

"Because you have a baby," I said. "And I held him."

Jake looked at me for a long time. Then he nodded, slowly, as if I had said something important.

He did not tell anyone. But the next spring, when his cow calved, he brought me the first of the milk. And the spring after that, a ham. And every year after that, something. He never said anything. He only left it on the bar, and nodded, and went to sit with the others.

\* \* \*

In the third year, Bast fell in love.

Or he said he did. Bast fell in love a great deal. With the miller's daughter, and the smith's niece, and a widow in Rannish, and a girl who came through once with a troupe of players and was gone the next morning. He fell in love the way other people catch colds: often, and briefly, and with a great deal of drama.

But this one was different. Her name was Emberlee, and she was the daughter of a farmer on the south road, and she was the most beautiful girl in three counties. Everyone said so. Bast said so, loudly and often.



He courted her all that summer. He brought her flowers and sang her songs and walked with her in the evenings along the edge of the fields. She laughed at him, and teased him, and let him kiss her once behind the mill.

And then, at the end of the summer, she married a young man from Baedn with a good farm and a steady temper, and moved away.

Bast did not come out of his room for three days.

When he finally did, I was in the kitchen, making bread. He came and sat at the table and watched me knead the dough. He did not say anything for a long time.

"Reshi," he said at last. "Does it ever stop hurting?"

I looked at him. At his fine-boned face, pale and drawn. At his deep blue eyes, red-rimmed from weeping.

I thought about it. I did not know. I did not remember ever being hurt like that. I did not remember loving anyone.

But I remembered a bridge. At dawn. A woman with dark hair, walking away down the far side, very straight, with her head high. Not looking back.

I remembered that I had stood at the top of the bridge for a long time afterward. And that I had not felt anything. And that I had known I should.

"I don't know," I said. "I've never been able to feel it long enough to find out."

Bast looked at me for a long moment. Then his face crumpled, and he put his head down on the table, and wept.

I kept kneading the bread. I did not know what else to do. But after a while, I reached out with one floury hand and put it on the back of his head. And left it there.

\* \* \*

The years went by.

Old Cob told the same stories. Graham built a new barn. Carter's horse grew old and slow. Shep laughed at his own jokes. Aaron grew tall enough to see over the bar, and then tall enough to lift the beer casks, and then tall enough to go to the smithy every morning and

come back every evening with soot on his face and burns on his hands, grinning.

Tam, Jake's boy, learned to walk, and then to run, and then to climb the fence behind the Waystone and steal apples from the tree in the yard. I let him. I left the lowest branches unpicked, on purpose, so he would have something to steal.

The Penitent King raised the taxes again. And again. The war in the north went on. Soldiers came through Newarre on the road, sometimes, marching north. Some of the young men went with them. Not all of them came back.

And I polished the bar. And poured the drinks. And made the bread and the stew. And listened, and nodded, and said the right thing.

And waited.

It was a small life. A quiet one. The kind of life that does not make stories.

It was exactly what a girl with cloud hair had told me to live.

And it was killing me. Very slowly. So slowly I did not notice. The way the twilight kills mortals who stay too long.

But I did not know that. Not then.

Bast knew. I think he always knew.

But he did not say anything. Not for a long time.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Seven

### **A Letter from Imre**

The letter came in the fourth spring, with the carter from Baedn, in a packet of other letters for other people in Newarre. It was addressed in a hand I did not know, large and untidy and full of blots, to *Kote, Innkeeper, the Waystone, Newarre*.

I did not know anyone who would write to me. I turned it over in my hands for a long time, standing behind the bar, before I opened it.

It was from Sim.

I did not know that. I did not know who Sim was. But Bast, coming in from the yard with an armful of firewood, saw the letter in my hands and the handwriting on it, and dropped the firewood on the floor.

"That's Sim's," he said. "That's Simmon's hand. I'd know it anywhere. Nobody else blots like that."

"Who is Sim?"

Bast looked at me for a long moment. Then he came around the bar and took the letter out of my hands, very gently, and unfolded it.

"Sit down, Reshi," he said. "I'll read it to you."

\* \* \*

*Kote, it began. Or whatever you're calling yourself these days. Bast wrote to me, last winter, and told me where you were. He made me swear on my mother's grave not to tell anyone, which was awkward, because my mother is alive and well and living in Atur and would be very upset to hear she had a grave. But I swore anyway. Bast was very*

*insistent.*

*He also told me you don't remember me. That you don't remember any of us. He said it's better if I don't come to see you, because it might stir things up, and things that are stirred up can be heard.*

*So I'm writing instead. I hope that's all right. Bast said a letter was probably safe, if I didn't put anything in it that mattered.*

*I'm afraid everything I have to say matters. But I'll try to make it sound as if it doesn't.*

\* \* \*

Bast read it to me slowly, sitting at the table by the hearth, with the late afternoon sun coming through the window. I sat across from him and listened.

*The Eolian is open again, Sim wrote. Deoch finished it last autumn. It took him three years, and all of Threpe's money, and half the money of every musician in Imre, and a great deal of swearing. But it's done. It looks exactly the way it did before. Exactly. Deoch was very particular about it. He put the bar on the same side, and the stage at the same height, and he had the balconies carved by the same family of woodworkers who carved them the first time.*

*There's only one thing different. There's a plaque. On the wall behind the stage, where everyone can see it. It's bronze, and it says: IN MEMORY OF STANCHION, WHO BUILT A GOOD ROOM. And underneath that, smaller: AND OF THE NIGHT THE TRUE SONG WAS SUNG.*

*It doesn't say your name. Deoch said you wouldn't want it to. But everyone knows.*

*People sing it there, sometimes. Tariniel. Late at night, when the crowd has thinned out. Not on the stage. From the tables. Very quietly. Deoch doesn't stop them.*

\* \* \*

*Fela and I were married last summer, Sim wrote. In the courtyard of the Mains, with Elodin officiating, which was not strictly legal, since Elodin is not a priest of any kind, but he said he was a master of names*

*and a marriage was only two names being tied together, so he was perfectly qualified. Nobody could argue with him. Nobody ever can.*

*It was a lovely day. The sun was out. Fela wore blue. She held up the courtyard's paving stones, for a joke, so that they floated an inch off the ground while we said our vows. Kilvin was very upset about it afterward. He said it was a frivolous use of a serious gift. But I saw him smiling.*

*She's a master now. Did Bast tell you? Master Namer. Elodin stepped down, last spring, and gave her his chair. He said he was tired of it, and she was better at it than he was anyway, and he wanted to spend more time on the roof. The other masters didn't want to let him. But he threatened to set all their beards on fire, so they did.*

*She's the youngest master in two hundred years. She's terrifying. The students are all in love with her. I'm very proud.*

\* \* \*

Bast stopped reading. He looked up at me.

"Reshi," he said. "Do you remember any of this? Any of them?"

I thought about it. I thought about a girl with dark hair and a pale face, putting her small cold hand on my chest over my heart, and saying *hold*. I did not know her name. I did not know when it had happened. But I remembered the hand, and the word.

"No," I said.

Bast looked at me for a long time. Then he looked back down at the letter.

\* \* \*

*Wil is still at the University, Sim wrote. He's Kilvin's right hand now. He's building bridges. Real ones. Kilvin's teaching him the big work, the heavy work, the kind that doesn't need fine fingers. He built a new bridge over the Omethi last year, downstream from the old one, for the carts. It's very good. Everyone says so. There's a stone at one end of it with a carving of a pair of hands, and underneath it says FOR THE ONE WHO HELD THE FIRE. He won't tell anyone who it means.*

*Devi is back at the University too. Did Bast tell you? They let her back in. After the war. Herma said anyone who could make a dead man walk to the gallows in front of ten thousand people was too dangerous to leave outside the walls, where they couldn't keep an eye on her. So they gave her a bench in the Fishery and a room in the Mews and made her promise not to blow anything up.*

*She has blown up four things since. Kilvin says three of them were accidents.*

*She's still lending money. She says it's research. She says she's studying the psychology of debt. She says you still owe her, and she's charging interest, and she'll collect it someday whether you remember or not.*

*She says you still have her page. She says she gave it to you so you'd have to come back and return it. She says that's called collateral.*

*\* \* \**

*Kilvin still has the candle, Sim wrote. No, that's not right. You have the candle. Kilvin has the ledgers. He still keeps them. He says the candle is with you, and so the record must be too, and he writes to Bast every season to ask if it's burned blue.*

*Bast says it hasn't. Not in four years. Kilvin says that's either very good news or very bad news, and he doesn't know which.*

*\* \* \**

*Auri is well, Sim wrote. At least, I think she is. None of us see her much. She doesn't come up. But Fela says she goes down, sometimes, to the deep places, and she can hear her. Singing. Very softly. Down by the door. Fela says she sings to it every night. Fela says the door is quieter than it used to be. Calmer. She says it's almost as if it's listening.*

*Elodin says Auri is the bravest person he's ever known. He says she's doing what the Amyr used to do, only with songs instead of books. He says someone should write her name in a very important book somewhere. He won't say which book.*

\* \* \*

*Threpe is old now, Sim wrote. Older than he was. He doesn't go out much. But he still goes to the Eolian every Felling night and sits at the table nearest the stage and listens. He says he's waiting. He won't say for what. But he always saves the chair beside him. Nobody's allowed to sit in it.*

*Denna—*

Bast stopped reading.

He sat very still at the table, with the letter in his hands, and looked at the next line for a long time. His face did something complicated.

"What does it say?" I asked.

Bast did not answer right away. Then he folded the letter, very carefully, along its creases.

"It says no one knows where she is," he said. "It says no one's heard from her since the bridge. It says Sim hopes she's well."

I looked at him.

"That's not all it says."

Bast looked at me for a long moment. His deep blue eyes were very steady.

"No," he said. "It's not." He put the folded letter inside his shirt. "But it's all you need right now, Reshi."

I did not argue. I did not know how. I did not know who Denna was, or why the name made the scar on my wrist ache, very faintly, like an old wound before rain.

\* \* \*

I found the letter, years later, in the bottom of a drawer in Bast's room, when I was looking for something else. I was still Kote then. I read the rest of it standing in the doorway with the grey light coming through the window.

*Denna sent me a letter too, Sim had written. Last winter. From somewhere far away. It had no return direction, and it was very short. It said she was well. It said she was singing again, in a place where no*

*one knew her. It said she had a new name, and she liked it, and she was going to keep it.*

*It said to tell you, if I ever found you, that she still has the knot. The small one. And that she knows what it's for.*

*And it said to tell you that she's sorry. For everything. And that she'd do it all again.*

*I don't know what that means. I hope you do. Or that you will, someday.*

*Your friend, always, whether you remember it or not,  
Sim.*

*P.S. The rhymes in this letter are terrible. I know. I did it on purpose. So you'd know it was really me.*

*\* \* \**

I did not know what it meant. Not then.

But I read it three times, standing in Bast's doorway. And then I folded it along its creases and put it back in the bottom of the drawer where I had found it. And I did not tell Bast I had read it.

And that night, for the first time in years, I dreamed in color.



## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Eight

### **Rike**

In my third year at the Waystone, a boy tried to rob me.

He was not a very good thief. I knew that from the first moment, the way I would have known a bad lute player from the first chord. He came in on a slow afternoon in autumn, when the common room was empty except for me, and he stood by the door for a long time with his hands in his pockets, pretending to look at the sword over the bar.

He was about eleven. Thin, with a narrow sharp face and dirty blond hair cut short with a knife, and a bruise on his cheekbone that was going yellow at the edges. His shirt was too small for him and his shoes were too big. He had the look of a boy who had been hungry for a long time and had gotten used to it.

I knew that look. I had worn it for three years, in Tarbean.

"Can I help you?" I said.

"Just looking," he said.

"At the sword?"

"Yeah." He did not look at the sword. He looked at the till, the small wooden drawer under the bar where I kept the day's coin. Then at me. Then at the door to the kitchen. Then at the till again. He was not subtle.

"It's a good sword," I said. "Old. Came from a long way away."

"Yeah?" He edged toward the bar. "What's its name?"

"Folly," I said. "It says so on the plaque."

He looked at the plaque then. His lips moved slightly. He could not read, I realized. He was trying to make out the letters and he could

not.

"Folly," he repeated. "Funny name for a sword."

"It was a funny sword."

\* \* \*

I went into the kitchen. I did not need to. There was nothing in the kitchen that needed doing. But I went, and I left the door ajar, and I stood just behind it and waited.

It took him less than a minute. I heard him slip behind the bar. I heard the soft scrape of the till drawer. I heard coins, very quiet, very careful, sliding into a pocket.

I came back out.

He froze. He was standing behind the bar with one hand in the till and the other in his pocket, and his face went white under the yellowing bruise, and he looked at me with the flat, blank, hopeless eyes of a trapped animal.

I did not say anything. I went and sat down at the bar, on the customer's side, and folded my hands on the wood.

The boy did not move.

"It's a bad till to rob," I said. "There's never much in it. Most of my custom comes in the evening. You'd have done better to wait till closing."

He stared at me.

"And the kitchen door's a trick," I said. "You should always wonder why someone's leaving you alone. Nobody leaves a stranger alone with the till. Not unless they want to see what he'll do."

His hand came slowly out of the till. It was empty. The other hand stayed in his pocket.

"You going to call the constable?" he said. His voice was very steady. I was impressed. I remembered how hard it was to keep your voice steady at that age, when you were caught.

"There isn't a constable in Newarre," I said. "There's a sheriff in Baedn-Bryt, but he doesn't come out this way unless someone's been murdered. And even then he takes his time."

"Then what?"

I looked at him for a long moment.

"Are you hungry?" I said.

\* \* \*

His name was Rike. He did not tell me that; I had to find it out later, from Graham. He did not tell me anything, that first afternoon. He sat at the bar where I put him and ate the bowl of stew I set in front of him, very fast, hunched over it with one arm curled around the bowl, the way you eat when you have learned that someone might take your food away. He ate three bowls. He ate half a loaf of bread. He did not say a word.

When he was done, he pushed the bowl away and looked at me with narrow, suspicious eyes.

"What do you want?" he said.

"Nothing."

"Everyone wants something."

I thought of a barn in the western hills, and an old man with a pack, and Mirra in a grey dress saying *I don't want anything. It's easier.*

"I want my money back," I said. "The coins in your pocket. Then you can go."

He looked at me for a long time. Then, slowly, he took his hand out of his pocket and set the coins on the bar. Four jots and a handful of iron drabs. I had not known there was that much in the till.

"You could've just called for help," he said. "Grabbed me. I'm not big."

"I could have."

"Why didn't you?"

I did not answer. I picked up the coins and put them back in the till. When I turned around, he was still sitting there, watching me.

"Come back tomorrow," I said. "Around noon. The woodpile needs splitting. I'll pay you a jot for it. And lunch."

He stared at me.

"Why?"

"Because the woodpile needs splitting," I said. "And I'm lazy."

He did not believe me. I could see that. But he slid off the stool and went to the door, and at the door he stopped, and looked back at me one more time with those flat suspicious eyes.

Then he was gone.

\* \* \*

Graham told me about him that evening.

"Rike?" He shook his head slowly. "That's Jessom's boy. Lives out past the old quarry, in that shack with the fallen chimney. You'll have seen it." He took a long pull of his beer. "Jessom drinks. Has since his wife left. He's not a bad man, when he's sober. But he's not sober much."

"The bruise?"

Graham did not answer for a moment. He looked at his beer.

"There's been talk," he said at last. "About going out there. Some of us. Having a word with Jessom. But it's not our place, is it? A man's family is his own business." He did not sound as if he believed it. "And the boy never complains. Never says anything. Just goes about with his face all over colors and his mouth shut."

I did not say anything. I polished a glass.

"He's a thief, you know," said Graham. "Rike. Steals from everyone. Eggs out of Jake's henhouse. Apples. Once a whole ham out of the smokehouse behind Rena's. Everyone knows it's him. Nobody does anything." He shrugged. "What would we do? Put him in the stocks? He's eleven."

"No," I said. "Nothing like that."

\* \* \*

Rike came back the next day. At noon. He did not say anything. He stood in the yard and looked at the woodpile, and I gave him the axe, and he split the wood.

He was not very good at it. He was too small and too thin and the axe was too heavy for him. But he did not give up. He split the whole pile, badly, over three hours, and when he was done he stacked the split wood against the wall of the stable, very neatly, and came into the

kitchen and stood by the door.

I gave him a jot. I gave him lunch. He ate it the way he had eaten the stew, hunched over, one arm curled around the bowl.

"Come back tomorrow," I said.

He came back.

\* \* \*

He came back every day, that autumn. Sometimes I had work for him and sometimes I did not, and when I did not, I made some up. He split wood and swept the yard and carried water from the well and mucked out the stable and scrubbed pots. He did not talk. I did not make him.

He stopped stealing. From me, at least. I do not know about Jake's henhouse. But the till was never short again, and I made a point of leaving it unlocked, and of leaving the room while he was there, so that he would know I trusted him. And he did not take anything.

Once, in the second month, I came back into the common room and found him standing in front of the sword again, looking up at the plaque.

"What does it say?" he said, without turning around. "Really. Not just the name. There's more. I can see the letters."

There was not more. The plaque said only *Folly*, burned deep into the oak. But I understood what he was asking.

"Would you like to learn?" I said. "To read?"

He turned around. His narrow face was very still.

"Why would you teach me?"

"Because someone taught me," I said. "A long time ago. A man named Abenthy. He didn't have to. He did it anyway."

Rike looked at me for a long time. Then he looked back at the plaque.

"F," he said. "That's the first one. I know that one. It's in *Fall*. On the sign at the mill."

"Yes," I said. "That's right."

\* \* \*

I taught him to read that winter. At the corner table, in the afternoons, when the common room was empty. I wrote out letters on a slate and he copied them, frowning, with his tongue caught between his teeth. He was quick. Much quicker than he let anyone know. By midwinter he could read the sign over the door, and by spring he could read the whole of the Tehlin prayer book the priest had given the inn years ago, which sat on a shelf by the door gathering dust.

He did not thank me. He did not have to.

But one day in spring, he came in with a new bruise on his jaw, purple and swollen, and he sat down at the corner table and opened the prayer book and began to read, and he did not look at me, and I did not ask. And after a while, without looking up, he said:

"I'm going to leave. When I'm older. I'm going to go somewhere and be someone."

"Where?"

"I don't know." He turned a page. "Somewhere with books. Maybe the University." He glanced up at me, quick, and then down again. "You ever been there?"

I polished the glass in my hands. I looked at the sword over the bar.

"Once," I said. "A long time ago."

"What was it like?"

I was quiet for a long moment.

"It was the best place I ever knew," I said. "And I made a terrible mess of it."

Rike looked at me. For a moment, something moved behind his narrow, suspicious eyes. Something that was almost curiosity. Almost the beginning of a question.

Then he looked back down at the prayer book.

"I won't," he said. "Make a mess of it. When I go."

"No," I said. "I don't think you will."

\* \* \*

He did go. Years later. But that is his story, not mine, and I will not tell it here.

I will only say that on the day he left, he came into the Waystone early in the morning with a pack on his back and new boots on his feet, boots that fit, and stood in front of the bar for a long moment without saying anything.

Then he reached into his pocket and set four jots and a handful of iron drabs on the bar.

"I owed you," he said.

I looked at the coins. Then at him.

"No," I said. "You didn't."

"I know," said Rike. He did not smile. He never smiled. But something in his narrow face was different. "That's why I have to give it to you."

He went out the door. He did not look back. And I stood behind the bar with four jots and a handful of iron drabs in my hand, and for a moment, just a moment, the grey in me cracked, and something came through.

It was only a little. Just enough.

## Chapter One Hundred Forty-Nine

### **What Old Cob Saw**

Old Cob told stories. Everyone in Newarre knew that, and most of them had stopped listening years ago. He told the same dozen stories over and over, with the same pauses in the same places and the same jokes at the end, and if you had grown up in Newarre, you could recite most of them along with him, which some of the younger men did, under their breath, to annoy him.

He told the story of the winter the river froze so hard they drove a cart across it. He told the story of the traveling tinker who sold his father a cow that turned out to be two goats sewn together. He told the story of Taborlin the Great and the story of Oren Velciter and the story of the Kingkiller, which he had heard from a traveler, and which grew longer and more elaborate every time he told it. By my fourth year at the Waystone, the Kingkiller had killed three kings, two dragons, and a bishop, and had escaped from prison by turning into a crow.

I did not correct him. I polished the glasses.

But there was one story Old Cob did not tell. I did not know that for a long time. I only learned it by accident, on a night in my fourth winter, when the snow was very deep and the common room was empty except for the two of us.

\* \* \*

He had stayed late. The others had gone home early, because of the snow, but Cob lived alone in a cottage at the end of the lane, and he said he did not fancy sitting in the dark there listening to the wind. So



he stayed at the bar with his mug of cider, and talked, and I polished, and listened, the way I always did.

He talked about his father. About the farm on the east road, before the drought, before the bank took it. About his wife, who had died of the winter fever twenty years ago. About his daughter, who had married a cooper in Rannish and never came to visit.

And then, somewhere in the middle of it, he stopped talking. He sat looking into his mug for a long time. The wind was very loud outside.

"Kote," he said. "You ever seen something you couldn't explain?"

I set down the glass I was polishing.

"Once or twice," I said.

\* \* \*

Old Cob nodded slowly. He did not look up from his mug.

"I was a carter," he said. "Most of my life. Before my knees went. Worked for a man in Hallowfell, running goods up and down the north road. Wool and salt and barrels. Up to the mountains and back." He turned the mug in his gnarled hands. "It was good work. I liked it. I liked the road."

"Hallowfell," I said. My voice was very steady.

"You know it?"

"I've heard of it."

"Little place. Nothing much there. A mill and an inn and a few farms." Cob was quiet. "And one night, coming back late from the mountains, I passed a farm on the road outside town. A big farm. The Hollis place. Everyone knew the Hollises; they were the richest family for twenty miles. Six children. A grandmother. Three hired men." He paused. "And the farm was burning."

The fire in the hearth cracked. Neither of us looked at it.

\* \* \*

"I stopped the cart," said Old Cob. "Of course I did. I jumped down and ran toward the house, shouting. Thought I'd help. Get people out. Throw water." He shook his head slowly. "But there wasn't any

shouting. That's what I noticed first. A fire like that, you'd expect screaming. Dogs barking. Cows lowing in the barn. There wasn't any of it. It was quiet. Dead quiet. Just the fire."

He took a long drink of cider. His hand was shaking a little.

"And the fire was the wrong color," he said.

I did not say anything. I could not.

"Blue," said Old Cob. "The flames. All over the house. Tall and blue, like a spirit lamp, like the flame on a pudding at midwinter. And there wasn't any heat from it. I got right up close, right up to the door, and I couldn't feel any heat at all." He was quiet for a moment. "It was cold, Kote. Standing next to that fire. Cold as a winter night."

\* \* \*

"What did you do?" I said.

"I looked in the door." Old Cob's voice was very low. "It was open. Standing wide open. And I looked in."

He did not say anything for a long time. The wind howled around the inn. Snow hissed against the shutters.

"They were all at the table," he said at last. "All of them. The Hollises. The grandmother and the six children and the mister and missus. Sitting at the big table in the kitchen, like they were sitting down to supper. With the plates set out, and the bread, and the candles." He swallowed. "And they were dead. All of them. Just sitting there. Dead. With their eyes open."

I gripped the edge of the bar.

"And there was someone else," said Old Cob. "At the head of the table. In the mister's chair."

\* \* \*

"I couldn't see him right," said Cob. "I've tried, over the years. To remember. But every time I try, it slides away, like trying to look at something in the corner of your eye. There was a man. Sitting in the chair at the head of the table. With his back to me, mostly. And there was something wrong with the light around him. It was darker than it should have been. Like there was a shadow sitting on him."

He was quiet for a long moment.

"And there was another one," he said. "Standing by the hearth. A tall one. Pale. With his hair all white, like frost. And he turned around. And he looked at me."

My heart was hammering. I could hear it in my ears.

"He had black eyes," said Old Cob. "All black. No white in them at all. Like holes. Like a well at night." He shuddered. "And he smiled at me. And he said something. I don't remember what. Something about the harvest. Something about how it was a poor harvest, this year." He shook his head. "And then I ran."

\* \* \*

"I ran back to the cart," said Cob. "I don't remember climbing up. I don't remember driving. I just remember whipping the horses, harder than I ever did before or since, and the road going by in the dark, and the blue light behind me. Getting smaller. And then gone." He drank. "I drove all night. I didn't stop in Hallowfell. I drove straight through, and on down the south road, and I didn't stop till noon the next day, in a town I'd never been to. And I got down off the cart, and I sat down in the road, and I couldn't stand up again for an hour."

"Did you tell anyone?"

"Who'd believe me?" Old Cob laughed, a short dry sound. "An old carter, half-drunk on road wine, talking about blue fire and a man with eyes like wells. They'd have locked me up." He shook his head. "I heard, later, that the Hollis farm burned down that night. With everyone in it. The constable said it was a lightning strike. There wasn't any lightning. It was a clear night. But that's what he said." He looked at his mug. "And the neighbors said the ashes were cold by morning. Stone cold. Like they'd been lying there for a year."

\* \* \*

I did not say anything for a long time. I stood behind the bar with my hands flat on the wood.

I was thinking of a ledger. Kilvin's ledger. Twenty years of careful notes, in his square, heavy hand. The date and the time and the

weather and the phase of the moon. And one entry in particular, which I had found and marked, years before, sitting in his office in the Fishery with a blue flame burning on the desk in front of me.

*Three days, eleven years ago. The candle burned blue.*

*And a constable's report, in a dusty box in the Stacks. A farmstead near Hallowfell. Strange lights in the sky. The ashes cold to the touch by morning.*

"Cob," I said. My voice sounded very far away. "How long ago was this?"

He thought about it.

"Must be—twenty years, near enough," he said. "I was just shy of fifty. Bess was still living. She took the fever the winter after." He looked at me. "Why?"

I did not answer. I was doing arithmetic in my head. Eleven years before I found the ledger. And eight more since then, give or take a season. Near enough.

Near enough.

\* \* \*

"You never told anyone?" I said at last. "All these years?"

"Not a soul." Old Cob shook his head. "Not even Bess, God rest her. Not my daughter. Not anyone." He looked at me. "You're the first, Kote. I don't know why I'm telling you now. The snow, maybe. The wind." He was quiet. "Or maybe because you're the only man I know who wouldn't laugh."

"No," I said. "I wouldn't laugh."

"I tell all those other stories," said Cob. "Taborlin and the Kingkiller and the two goats sewn together. I tell them over and over. Everyone's sick of them. I know they are." He looked into his mug. "But I tell them because they're not that one. Do you understand? As long as I'm telling those, I'm not telling that one. And as long as I'm not telling it, I don't have to remember it."

I understood. Better than he could possibly have known.

"And the Chandrian?" I said carefully. "Do you tell stories about them? Ever?"

Old Cob looked at me very sharply.

"No," he said. "Never." He was quiet for a long moment. "I heard the rhyme, when I was a boy. Everyone did. *When the hearth fire turns to blue.* But I never thought—" He stopped. "I never thought it was real. Not until that night."

He finished his cider. He set down the mug.

"You won't tell anyone," he said. "Will you?"

"No."

"Good." He climbed off his stool, slowly, with a grunt, the way old men do. He pulled on his coat and his scarf. At the door he stopped, and looked back at me.

"Kote," he said. "The man with the frost hair. The black eyes." His face was very pale. "You looked like you knew him. When I was telling it. You looked like you'd seen him too."

I did not answer. I stood behind the bar with a glass in my hand.

Old Cob looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded, slowly, as if I had answered after all.

"Well," he said. "Good night, then."

And he went out into the snow.

\* \* \*

He never mentioned it again. The next night he was back at the bar, telling the story of the river that froze so hard they drove a cart across it, and Jake and Carter were rolling their eyes, and Graham was complaining about his barn roof. And I was polishing glasses. Everything was the same as it always was.

But sometimes, after that, when Old Cob told the story of the Kingkiller, with its three kings and two dragons and escape by crow, he would glance at me, very quick, sidelong, in the middle of it. And there was something in his eyes that had not been there before.

Not suspicion. Not quite.

Something more like kinship.

\* \* \*

"He saw Cinder," said Chronicler. His pen had stopped moving. "Old Cob. Twenty years ago. And he never told anyone."

"No."

"And then you came, and he told you."

"Yes." The innkeeper was quiet for a moment. "And when you came, and I began telling this story, I think Cob knew. The first night. When he saw you sitting at the corner table with your pens." He looked at the window. "He came in the next evening and sat at the bar and didn't tell a single story. Not one. Just sat there and drank his cider and watched you." He paused. "I think he was waiting to hear if I would tell his."

"Will you tell him? When it's done? That you told it?"

The innkeeper did not answer for a long time.

"No," he said at last. "He'll know. He'll read it someday, maybe, in some bookshop in some town, with a man with frost-colored hair on the page. And he'll know." He smiled faintly. "He'll know he wasn't the only one who ran."

## Chapter One Hundred Fifty

### **Graham's Barn**

Graham built a new barn in my fourth summer, and the whole town came to raise it.

He had been complaining about the old one for years. It was a sagging, weather-grey, drafty thing, older than Graham himself, with a roof that leaked and a floor that flooded and a north wall that leaned so far out of true that Old Cob said you could use it to tell which way the wind was blowing. Graham had patched it and propped it and cursed it for thirty years. And that spring, after a wet winter, the north wall finally gave up and lay down in the mud, very gently, like an old dog settling for a nap.

"That's it," said Graham, standing in the Waystone that evening with his mug of beer and his face like a thundercloud. "That's the last straw. I'm building a new one. A proper one. Oak frame. Slate roof. Stone footings." He glared around the room. "And every man jack of you is going to help me, or I'll know the reason why."

Everyone laughed. But they came.

\* \* \*

A barn raising in a small town is not a job. It is a festival. Everyone knows it. The men do the heavy work, the lifting and hauling and pegging, and the women bring food, great quantities of it, and the children run around underfoot and get shouted at, and by the end of the day there is a barn where there was not one before, and everyone is sunburned and exhausted and a little drunk, and there is a dance in the

new barn by lantern light.

I had not meant to go. I had meant to stay behind the bar. The inn would be empty all day, of course, with the whole town at Graham's; but I had meant to stay anyway, and polish things, and be small and quiet.

Bast would not let me.

"You're going," he said.

"There's work to do here."

"There's no work to do here. There's never any work to do here. You invent it." He took the rag out of my hands. "You're going to Graham's, and you're going to lift things, and you're going to eat Rena's pie and drink Jake's terrible cider, and you're going to stand around in the sun like a normal person for one day." He looked at me. "Please, Reshi."

I went.

\* \* \*

It was a hot day, bright and clear, with a light wind from the south. Graham's farm lay a mile east of town, on a gentle slope above the river, and when Bast and I came up the lane, the yard was already full. Carts and wagons and horses, and tables set out under the apple trees, loaded with food. Children everywhere. Dogs everywhere. The smell of fresh-cut timber and crushed grass and bread.

The frame of the barn was laid out on the ground, in sections. Great squared oak beams, pegged together into walls, lying flat on the grass like the pieces of a giant's puzzle. Graham had spent the whole spring cutting and fitting them, with his sons, and they were beautiful. Even I could see that. Every joint was tight. Every peg was smooth. He had carved his initials, very small, into the foot of the center post.

"Right," said Graham, standing in the middle of it all with his sleeves rolled up. "East wall first. I want twenty men on the ropes and ten on the pikes. And nobody lets go until I say. Understood?"

They raised the east wall. Then the west. Then the south. It was slow, heavy, careful work: the walls lifted inch by inch on ropes and long pike poles, swaying, creaking, while Graham shouted directions



and the men strained and sweated and swore. And then, when each wall was upright, men swarming up the frame like ants to drive the pegs home, with the whole thing groaning around them.

I worked the ropes. I pulled when Graham said pull and held when he said hold. It was good to have something to do with my hands. It was good to be one of twenty, sweating in the sun, pulling together, and not have to be anything else.

\* \* \*

It was during the north wall that it happened.

The north wall was the biggest. It had the great double doors in it, and the hayloft door above, and it was heavier than all the others. It took thirty men to lift it. It went up slowly, very slowly, swaying on the ropes, groaning. Graham's face was red and running with sweat.

"Steady," he was shouting. "Steady! Hold it there! Hold!"

It was upright. Almost. Leaning slightly outward, held by the ropes and the pikes. And Graham's grandson, Tobin, a boy of fourteen, was already swarming up the frame with a mallet in his belt, to drive the first peg that would lock it to the corner post.

I was on the rope nearest the corner. I was looking up. I saw him climb.

And I saw the peg-hole he was reaching for. And the rope that held the top of the wall. And the way the rope was fraying, just slightly, where it ran over the edge of the beam.

\* \* \*

I do not know how I saw it. I was not looking for it. I was not looking for anything. I was holding my rope and staring up at the sky, grey inside and empty, the way I always was.

But something in me saw it. Something old. Something that had spent years looking at the world the way Bredon had taught me to look at a tak board: seeing where every stone was, and where it would be, three moves on.

The rope was going to break. Not now. In a moment. When the boy leaned his weight on the frame to swing the mallet. The wall

would lurch, and the rope would part, and the wall would swing outward, and the boy would fall. Twenty feet, onto the stone footings Graham had laid so carefully.

I let go of my rope.

\* \* \*

I remember Graham shouting. I remember the man beside me swearing as the weight shifted onto him. I remember my feet, running, across the flattened grass, toward the corner post.

And I remember the sound of the rope breaking. A sharp, flat crack, like a whip.

The wall lurched. The boy, halfway up the corner post, with his mallet raised, lost his grip. His feet swung free. He hung for a moment by one hand, his face white with shock, and then his hand slipped, and he fell.

I caught him.

I do not know how. I was not close enough. I should not have been close enough. I had been twenty feet away when the rope broke. But I was there, under the corner post, with my arms out, when he came down. And he landed in my arms, all fourteen years of him, gangly and heavy, and the weight of him drove me down onto one knee on the stone footings. I felt something in my knee crack.

I did not let go.

\* \* \*

Behind us, the wall swung. Thirty men shouted. Pikes scraped. The great oak frame groaned and swayed and leaned outward, further, further—

And stopped.

Graham had thrown himself on the broken rope. Him and both his sons and Baxter and Aaron and a dozen others. They had caught the frayed end and wrapped it around their arms and dug their heels into the grass, and they were holding the whole north wall of the barn by main strength, their faces purple, their arms shaking.

"Pikes!" roared Graham. "*Pikes!*"

The pike men scrambled. The poles went up. The wall steadied. Slowly, slowly, inch by inch, it swung back upright. And held.

\* \* \*

Nobody moved for a long moment. The whole yard was silent. Thirty men, standing on the flattened grass, staring at the barn wall. Women by the tables with their hands over their mouths. Children frozen mid-run.

Then Graham let go of the rope and turned around and looked at me.

I was still kneeling on the stone footing with his grandson in my arms. Tobin was staring up at me, his face white, his mouth open. He did not seem to be hurt. My knee was hurt. I could feel it now, a hot deep throbbing. I did not care.

"Kote," said Graham. His voice was hoarse. "Kote. How did you—"

I did not answer. I set the boy down, very carefully, on his feet. He stood there, swaying, and then his mother was there, and she had him in her arms, and she was weeping.

Graham came across the grass. He stood over me. He looked at me for a long time with his big slow face.

"You let go of your rope," he said. "Before it broke. I saw you. You let go and ran *before it broke*."

I did not say anything.

"How did you know?"

\* \* \*

I could not tell him. I could not tell him about Bredon, and the beautiful game, and the way you learn to see three moves ahead. I could not tell him about the Adem, and the Lethani, and the way your body learns to move before your mind has finished thinking. I could not tell him about any of it. It was in the chest, upstairs at the Waystone. It was in the cord.

But my body remembered. That was the thing. My body had always remembered. It had seen the rope, and known, and run.

"I saw it fraying," I said. "That's all. I was looking up."

Graham looked at me for a long moment. He did not believe me. I could see that. Everyone in that yard had been looking up. Nobody else had seen it.

But he did not ask again. He reached down one big hand, and I took it, and he pulled me up. My knee buckled. He caught me. And he held me there, for a moment, with one hand gripping my arm, and looked me in the face.

"I don't know who you are, Kote," he said quietly. So quietly no one else could hear. "I never asked. I figured it was your business." He glanced at his grandson, in his mother's arms. "And I won't ask now. But whoever you are—" His voice cracked. "Thank you."

\* \* \*

They finished the barn that afternoon. With a new rope. Graham checked every inch of it himself, twice. I sat on a bench under the apple trees with my knee propped up on a stool, and Rena brought me pie, and Jake brought me cider, which was terrible, and Tobin sat beside me for an hour without saying anything, and then went away.

The barn was beautiful. Oak and stone and slate, square and solid and true. It stands there still, on the slope above the river, a mile east of Newarre. If you go and look at the corner post of the north wall, the one I caught Tobin under, you will find two sets of initials carved into the foot of it. Graham's. And below them, very small, very neat, carved later, when no one was looking:

K.

Graham did that. I never asked him to. I only found it the next spring, when I went up to help him with the hay.

I did not say anything about it. Neither did he.

\* \* \*

There was a dance in the new barn that night, by lantern light. Everyone came. Old Cob played the fiddle, very badly. Bast danced

with every girl in Newarre, one after another, until their mothers started glaring. I sat on a hay bale at the back with my knee wrapped in a strip of cloth and a mug of Jake's cider in my hand, and watched.

I did not dance. I did not feel anything. But I stayed until the very end, until the lanterns burned low and the last of the dancers went home. And when Bast came to find me, flushed and grinning, to help me limp back to the Waystone, he looked at me for a long moment and said:

"You caught him, Reshi."

"Yes."

"Before the rope broke. You knew."

"Yes."

Bast was quiet for a moment. Then he put my arm over his shoulder, and we started down the lane together in the dark, slowly, toward the lights of the town.

"You're still in there," he said softly. So softly I almost did not hear. "I knew it. I knew you were still in there."

I did not answer. My knee hurt. The stars were very bright.

But I did not tell him he was wrong.

## Chapter One Hundred Fifty-One

# The Night of the Chest

Once a year, I tried to open the chest.

I do not know why I chose the night I chose. It was not the anniversary of anything, that I knew of. It was not the night we came to Newarre, or the night the chest was made, or the night on the bridge when Denna walked away. It was a night in early spring, when the snow had begun to go grey at the edges and the icicles dripped all day long from the eaves of the Waystone. I did not choose it. It chose me. Every year, on that night, I would wake in the dark with my heart pounding and my left wrist aching, as if something had pulled on it, and I would know.

I found out, years later, what night it was. Bast told me. He had worked it out, the second year, counting on his fingers in the kitchen.

It was the night of the Nighting. The night of lights. The night, years before, when I had gone down through the Underthing with Auri's lamp and stood in front of a door that was not a door, beneath the Archives, and heard my name.

\* \* \*

The first year, I did not know what I was doing. I woke in the dark and I got up and I went to the foot of my bed, where the chest sat under its canvas cover, and I knelt in front of it. I pulled the cover off. I looked at it.

It was a beautiful thing. Even I could see that, grey as I was. Dark reddish wood, smooth as glass, without a single nail or seam. It

smelled faintly of cinnamon and old rain. There was a copper lock on the front, shaped like a closed eye. And beside it, a lock of grey stone, carved with a small, smooth hollow, like the print of a thumb. And between them, sunk into the wood itself, a knot. Dark and small and very tight. I could not tell where it began or where it ended.

I put my hand on the lid.

It was cold. Not the cold of wood in an unheated room. A deeper cold. The cold of a thing that does not want you. I felt it in my palm and up my arm and into my chest, where the hole was.

I tried to lift the lid. It did not move. Of course it did not move. It was locked. I had watched them lock it. I had stood in the Fishery, the night it was made, and watched Kilvin set the copper lock and Fela set the stone and Denna sink her knot into the wood between them.

I did not remember that. Not then. But my hands did. They went to the copper lock, and found the keyhole shaped like a closed eye, and felt it. They went to the stone lock, and pressed a thumb into the smooth hollow. They went to the knot in the wood, and touched it, very lightly.

Nothing happened.

I knelt there until morning. Then I put the cover back on and went downstairs and opened the inn.

\* \* \*

The second year, Bast was waiting for me.

I did not know he would be. I woke in the dark, the way I had the year before, with my wrist aching, and I got up and went to the chest and knelt in front of it. And when I pulled off the cover, I heard a small sound behind me. A breath, quickly caught.

I turned. Bast was sitting in the corner of my room, in the dark, with his knees drawn up to his chin. He had been there, I think, all night.

"Reshi," he said. His voice was very soft. "What are you doing?"

"I don't know."

"You did this last year. I heard you. On the same night." He did not move from the corner. "Do you know what you're trying to do?"

I looked at the chest.

"Open it," I said.

"Why?"

I did not answer. I did not know. I only knew that my wrist ached, and the hole in my chest ached, and there was something inside the chest that I needed, the way a thirsty man needs water. I did not know what it was. I did not know how I knew.

"You can't," said Bast. "Reshi. You know you can't. Only you can open it. The real you. Not—" He stopped.

"Not Kote."

"Not Kote." Bast's voice cracked. "I'm sorry."

\* \* \*

I tried anyway. I put my hand on the copper lock. It was cold. I put my thumb in the hollow of the stone lock. It was cold. I touched the knot.

And the stone lock spoke.

Not in words. Stone does not speak in words. But I had spent a winter in the Underthing, years before, learning to listen to stone. My hands remembered, even if I did not. And when I pressed my thumb into the hollow of Fela's lock, I heard it. Very faint. Very deep. Very patient.

*No.*

It was not unkind. That was the thing I remember most. It did not say *no* the way a door says it, or a guard, or an angry master at the University. It said it the way a mother says it, to a child reaching for a hot stove. Gently. Firmly. With love.

*No. Not yet. Not you.*

I took my hand away. I sat back on my heels on the floor of my room in the dark and looked at the chest for a long time.

"It said no," I said.

Bast made a small sound in the corner.

"I know," he said. "I heard it too."

\* \* \*



After that, he always waited with me. Every year. On the night of the Nighting. He never said anything about it, during the day. He never asked if I was going to try. But when I woke in the dark with my wrist aching and went to the chest, he was always there. In the corner. With his knees drawn up. Keeping me company.

The third year, I tried the copper lock. I tried to remember what Kilvin had told me about sympathy locks. I tried to hold the binding, the way I used to, with my mind split in two, the Heart of Stone. I could not. I did not know how anymore. The lock stayed cold under my hand.

The fourth year, I tried the knot. I sat for hours with my fingers on it, feeling the shape of it, trying to find the end. There was no end. There was no beginning. It was a knot tied by someone who knew more about knots than anyone in the world, and it did not want to be found.

The fifth year, the year the scrael came, I did not try anything. I knelt in front of the chest with my hands in my lap and I did not touch it at all. I only looked at it.

"What are you doing, Reshi?" said Bast, from the corner.

"Listening," I said.

And I was. I was listening to the chest. To the wood, and the locks, and whatever was inside. I did not hear anything. The waystone outside the window drowned it all out, the way it drowned everything. But I listened anyway, all night, the way you listen at a door for someone you love, on the other side, breathing.

\* \* \*

The sixth year was the year Shep died.

I did not wait for the Nighting that year. I went to the chest the night after we buried him. I knelt in front of it and pulled off the cover and put both hands flat on the lid, the way you put your hands on a door you want to open very badly, and I pushed.

I did not push with my hands. I pushed with everything. With the hole in my chest, and the grey, and the memory of the thing in the stranger's skin, and the nothing that had come out of my mouth when I

tried to name it. I pushed with Shep's face, and his widow's weeping, and the fresh raw earth over his grave.

*Open*, I said. Not out loud. Somewhere else. Somewhere deeper. *Open. Please. I need it. I need it back. People are dying. Open.*

The chest did not open.

But the stone lock spoke again. Louder than before. So loud I felt it in my teeth.

*No. Not you. Not yet.*

And then, very faint, almost too faint to hear, something else. Not from the stone. From the knot. From the small dark knot sunk into the wood between the locks. A voice I did not recognize, and knew better than my own.

*Not like this. Not alone. Wait.*

\* \* \*

I did not remember, then, whose voice it was. I only knew that I had heard it. And that it had said *wait*. And that there had been something in it that made the hole in my chest ache in a new way. Not the old dull grey ache. Something sharper. Something that felt almost like hope.

I took my hands off the lid. I sat back. And I wept. For the first time in six years. For Shep, and for his widow, and for Aaron standing over the thing with the iron bar in his shaking hands. For myself, kneeling on the floor in front of a box I could not open, with my name inside it. For all of it.

Bast came out of the corner. He knelt beside me on the floor. He did not say anything. He only put his arms around me and held on, the way you hold on to someone who is drowning.

"She said wait," I said, into his shoulder. "She said *not alone*."

Bast went very still.

"Who, Reshi?"

"I don't know." I did not. I truly did not. "But she said wait."

Bast held me for a long time. And then he said, very quietly, so quietly I almost did not hear it:

"Then we'll stop waiting alone."

\* \* \*

That was the night Bast began to plan. He told me so, later, on the last night, kneeling on the floor of the common room with his face wet. That was the night he went looking for Skarpi, and found him, and was told about a scribe on the road. That was the night he started talking in his room at the back of the inn, to someone who was not there.

I did not know. I did not know anything. I got up off the floor in the morning and put the cover back on the chest and went downstairs and opened the inn. The regulars came, and I served them, and I polished the glasses, and I was Kote.

But I did not try to open the chest again. Not the next Nighting. Not the one after. I did not need to. It had told me what it had to tell me.

*Not like this. Not alone. Wait.*

So I waited. And I was not alone. And one autumn, a scribe came up the road with his satchel and his bloody knuckles.

\* \* \*

"The knot," said Chronicler slowly. "The voice in the knot. That was—"

"Denna." The innkeeper looked at the fire. "Her knot. The one she sank into the wood, the night we made it. She tied something of herself into it. Not her name. Something smaller. A little piece of her voice, maybe. A little piece of what she wanted." He was quiet. "She knew. She knew I'd try to open it, someday, alone, when things got bad enough. She knew I'd break myself on it, trying. So she tied a message into the lock. For the day I did."

*"Not alone. Wait."*

"Yes." The innkeeper looked at his hands. Then he reached into the pocket of his apron and took out something small, and set it on the table between them.

It was a knot. A single knot, tied in a short length of cord braided from dark hair. Small and neat and very tight.

Chronicler had seen it before. When the old tinker with the bright black eyes had pressed it into the innkeeper's hand across the bar, and the innkeeper had gone white.

"I didn't know what it was," said the innkeeper quietly. "When he gave it to me. I only knew that when I held it, the hole in my chest stopped aching. For the first time in seven years." He looked at the knot. "And tonight, telling you this, I think I finally understand what she meant. That night. In the lock."

*"Not alone. Wait."*

"There was more," said the innkeeper. "I couldn't hear it, then. It was too faint. But I think I know what it was." He touched the knot with one finger, very gently. *"Not alone. Wait. I'll send someone."*

He looked up at Chronicler. At the scribe, and the pen, and the pages.

"She sent two," he said. "A tinker with a knot. And a scribe with a pen." He almost smiled. "She always did like to be sure."

## Chapter One Hundred Fifty-Two

# Cracks

The first scrael came to Newarre in the autumn of the fifth year.

Carter found it. Or rather, it found Carter. He was coming back from Baedn along the north road with a load of beer and salt in his wagon, late in the evening, and something came out of the woods at the edge of the road and killed his horse.

He came into the Waystone an hour later, white as milk and shaking so hard he could not hold the cup I gave him. He had walked the last three miles in the dark. He had left the wagon where it stood. He had left the horse, what was left of it, lying in the road.

"Spider," he kept saying. "Big as a dog. Black. Shiny. Like a beetle. Legs like knives." His teeth were chattering. "Came out of the dark and just—*went* for her. For Nelly. Cut her to pieces. Right in front of me." He looked up at me, and his eyes were wild. "And I hit it. With my axe. I hit it right in the back, as hard as I could. And it bounced. The axe *bounced*, Kote."

The regulars were crowded around him. Graham and Old Cob and Jake and Shep. They were all very quiet.

"What did you do?" said Graham.

"Ran." Carter laughed, a high thin broken sound. "What else? I ran. And it didn't follow me. It just stayed there. With Nelly." He put his face in his hands. "Eleven years I had that horse. Eleven years."

I stood behind the bar with a cloth in my hand. I was not polishing anything. My hands had stopped.

*Big as a dog. Black. Shiny. Legs like knives.*

I did not remember. But something in me knew. Something far down, below the grey, in the hole where my name had been. It knew the shape of what Carter was describing, the way your tongue knows the shape of a missing tooth.

*Scrael.*

\* \* \*

I went out that night.

I did not tell anyone. I waited until the regulars had gone home and Bast had gone to bed, and I went out into the yard and took an old iron poker from the woodpile and a lantern from the stable, and I walked north along the road in the dark.

I did not know why. I did not decide to. My feet simply took me.

It was a long walk. Three miles, in the dark, with only the lantern for light. The road was empty. The fields on either side were black and silent. The woods on the horizon were a darker black against the sky.

I found Carter's wagon where he had left it, standing in the road with its traces empty. I found what was left of his horse.

And I found the scrael.

\* \* \*

It was sitting on the road beside the horse. Very still. Its black shell gleaming in the lantern light. Its legs folded around it like the ribs of an umbrella.

It did not move when I came up. It did not seem to notice me. It sat on the road beside the dead horse and was still.

I stopped a few paces away. I held up the lantern. I looked at it.

And it turned toward me.

It did not have a head. It did not have eyes. But I felt it turn. I felt its attention settle on me, the way you feel eyes on the back of your neck. It was very cold. Very old. Very wrong.

It knew me.

Not me. Not Kote, the innkeeper, with his poker and his lantern. The other one. The one in the chest. The one it had come through a door to find.

*Child of my child*, something whispered. Very faint. Very far away. From somewhere behind the scrael. From somewhere behind everything.

The scrael moved.

\* \* \*

It came at me very fast. Faster than anything that size should be able to move. Its knife-legs flashed in the lantern light.

I did not think. My body moved. It moved the way it had been taught to move, once, a long time ago, on a hillside I did not remember, by a woman in red I did not know. *Tree Falling. Water Flows Around.*

I was not where the scrael's legs came down. I was beside it. And the iron poker was in my hand, and it was coming down, and it struck the scrael's shell with a sound like a bell.

The scrael shrieked. Where the iron touched it, the shell smoked. It reared back, its legs flailing.

I struck again. And again. And again.

It was not skill. Not really. I did not remember how to fight. But my body did. It knew where to put its feet, and how to turn its shoulders, and when to strike. And the iron did the rest.

The scrael shrieked one last time and collapsed. Its legs folded in on themselves. It lay on the road beside Carter's horse, smoking, and did not move again.

I stood over it with the poker in my hand and my chest heaving.

And then, from the woods at the edge of the road, I heard more of them.

\* \* \*

I will not tell you all of it. It was a long night. There were five of them in the end, coming out of the woods one after another, and I killed them all. With the poker, and a second poker I had not known I had brought, and my hands, and my feet, and the wagon's iron-bound wheel, which I pried loose and swung like a club when the second poker broke.

I do not know how I did it. I did not know then, and I do not know now. I only know that when the sun came up, grey and pale over the fields, I was sitting on the road beside Carter's wagon with my back against the wheel and my hands bleeding and six dead scrael lying around me in a ring.

And I was not grey.

That was the strange thing. For the first time in five years, sitting on the road with the scrael dead around me, I was not grey. Not entirely. There was a color at the edge of things. Red. The red of the blood on my hands. The red of the dawn, coming up over the fields. The red of the fire I had not lit, but that I could feel, somehow, burning somewhere far down in the hole in my chest.

It did not last. By the time I got back to the Waystone, it was gone. The world was grey again.

But it had been there. For a little while. I had felt it.

\* \* \*

Bast was waiting for me in the yard. He was standing by the pump with his arms folded, and his face was white.

He looked at me. At my bleeding hands and my torn clothes and the broken poker I was still carrying.

"Where have you been?" he said. His voice was very quiet.

"On the north road."

"Doing what?"

"Killing scrael."

Bast stared at me.

"Six of them," I said. "By Carter's wagon. I burned them. With oil from the wagon. So no one else would find them."

"You went out," said Bast slowly, "in the dark, alone, with a *poker*, and killed six scrael."

"Yes."

"Why?"

I thought about it.

"Because they were there," I said. "And they killed Carter's horse. And they would have killed Carter. And someone had to."



Bast looked at me for a long time. Then he came across the yard and took the broken poker out of my hand and looked at it.

"You're not supposed to do things like this," he said. His voice was very strange. "You're supposed to be small. Quiet. You're supposed to polish things." He looked up at me. "What if someone saw? What if someone *heard*?"

"No one heard."

"You don't know that." He threw the poker down on the ground. "They came here, Reshi. The scrael. They came *here*. To Newarre. To the one place in the whole world where you're supposed to be safe." His voice cracked. "Why do you think that is? Why do you think they came here, of all places?"

I did not answer.

"Because the door's cracked," said Bast. "Because you closed it, but not all the way. Because things are coming through. A little at a time. Seeping out, like water through a wall." He was shaking. "And they're looking for you. Even if they don't know it. Even if they can't hear you. They're looking for the thing that closed the door. The thing that's in the chest."

I looked at him.

"Then I'll kill them," I said. "When they come."

"With a *poker*?"

"With whatever I have."

Bast stared at me. Then he laughed. It was a broken, astonished, terrible laugh.

"You're still in there," he said. "Aren't you? Somewhere. Under all of it. You're still—" He stopped. He pressed his hands against his face. "God help us. You're still you."

\* \* \*

After that, there were more of them. Not many. Not often. One here, one there. A shepherd's flock torn apart in the hills. A family's dog found in pieces in the road. A traveler who did not arrive in Baedn when he was expected, and whose horse came home alone.

I went out after them. Every time. At night, with iron. Bast came with me, sometimes, though he could not touch the iron and could do very little to help. He came anyway. He stood behind me in the dark with his hands at his sides and his face white, and watched me kill them.

I did not tell the regulars. They thought the scrael were wild beasts, come down from the mountains in a hard winter. They were frightened of them, and they talked about them, and they told each other to keep their doors barred at night. But they did not know what they were. And I did not tell them.

I only went out, in the dark, with iron. And came back, in the dawn, with blood on my hands. And for a little while afterward, the world was not quite so grey.

\* \* \*

And then, in the spring of the sixth year, something else came.

It came into the Waystone on a Felling night, when the common room was full. A traveler. A man in a long dark coat, with a pack on his back and a hat pulled low over his eyes. He came in out of the rain and stood dripping in the doorway, and everyone turned to look at him, the way people in a small town always turn to look at a stranger.

He did not say anything. He crossed the room to the bar and sat down on a stool at the end, and he looked at me.

"Drink?" I said.

He did not answer. He only looked at me. His face was pale and strange under the brim of his hat. His eyes were—

I did not know what his eyes were. I could not see them clearly. They seemed to shift, when I looked at them. Now brown, now grey, now something else. Like water with something moving underneath it.

I felt the cold before I understood it. A small cold, at the base of my spine. The same cold I had felt on the north road, when the scrael turned toward me.

"Drink?" I said again.

The man smiled.

It was not a man's smile. It was a smile that had been put on, like a coat. It stretched his face in the wrong places. It did not reach his eyes, because his eyes were not his. And when he spoke, his voice was wrong too. It was a man's voice, but it was worn. The way a coat is worn.

"I'm looking for someone," it said. "Someone who closed a door."

\* \* \*

The common room had gone quiet. I did not notice when. The regulars were looking at the stranger, and then at me, and then at each other, with the uneasy expressions of people who sense that something is wrong but do not know what.

Shep was sitting closest. He was a round, red-faced, cheerful man, and he had been drinking since sundown, and he was not afraid of anything.

"Well, you won't find any doors closed here, friend," he said cheerfully. "The Waystone's always open. Kote never turns anyone away." He clapped the stranger on the shoulder. "Sit, have a drink, dry yourself off. You look like a drowned rat."

The stranger turned and looked at him.

And I knew, all at once, what it was.

I did not know the name. I did not know anything. But the knowing came up out of the hole in my chest like water out of a well. The shape of it. A thing that takes men's skins and wears them. A thing that walks among other men, and no one knows.

A thing I had seen once before, in a chamber beneath an old house, taking a soldier's face.

"*Shep*," I said. "*Get away from him.*"

It was too late.

\* \* \*

I will not tell you what happened to Shep. You have heard it, I think. Graham told you, or Old Cob, or someone. They all tell it, now, in the Waystone, on dark nights, in low voices. How the stranger took hold of Shep, and Shep screamed, and then he did not scream anymore.

I will tell you what I did.

I came over the bar. I did not decide to. I was simply over it, and then I was in front of the thing that was wearing the stranger's skin, and I opened my mouth, and I said something.

I do not know what I said. It was not a word I knew. It was not a word in any language I remembered. It came up out of the hole in my chest from somewhere very far down, from the place where names used to live. It was a command. A binding. The kind of word that a namer speaks, to make a thing stop.

It did not work.

It came out of my mouth, and it had the shape of power, and it had nothing inside it. It was a painting of a fire on a wall. It was a lute with no strings. The thing wearing the stranger's skin heard it, and paused, and tilted its borrowed head.

And laughed.

"*Oh,*" it said, in its worn voice. "*Oh, it's you. It's really you. But there's nothing there.*" It laughed again. "*He'll be so pleased. He'll be so very pleased.*"

It let go of Shep. Shep fell to the floor. He did not move.

The thing reached for me.

\* \* \*

It was Aaron who saved me.

He was fifteen that year, the smith's apprentice, tall and broad-shouldered and strong from the forge. He had been sitting at the back of the room with a mug of cider, and when the thing took hold of Shep, he had not run, as some of the others had. He had not frozen, as most of the others had. He had gone to the corner where I kept the iron firedogs for the hearth, and he had picked one up. A long iron bar, heavy and black.

He came up behind the thing as it reached for me. And he hit it across the back of the head with the iron bar, as hard as he could.

The thing screamed. The stranger's skin split open where the iron struck it, and something came out of the split, something grey and wet and wrong, and it screamed and screamed, and Aaron hit it again, and

again, and again.

It fell. It lay on the floor of the Waystone beside Shep's body, twitching and smoking. The stranger's skin was sloughing off it like a snake's. Underneath, there was something I will not describe.

Aaron stood over it with the iron bar in his hands. His face was white. His hands were shaking.

"What is it?" he whispered. "Kote. What is it?"

I looked at it. At the thing on the floor, twitching and smoking. At Shep, lying beside it, very still.

"Something that came through a door," I said.

\* \* \*

We buried Shep three days later, in the churchyard behind the little stone church. The whole town came. Graham made the coffin. Old Cob said a few words, and for once he did not wander off into digressions. The priest said a prayer. Shep's widow wept.

I stood at the back, behind everyone, and did not say anything.

Afterward, when everyone else had gone, Bast found me still standing there, beside the fresh grave.

"It wasn't your fault," he said.

"It came for me. It said so. It was looking for someone who closed a door."

"It wasn't your fault," said Bast again. "It was the door's fault. The crack's. The Thief's." He looked at me. "Not yours."

"I tried to stop it. I tried to name it. And there was nothing there." I looked down at my hands. "I opened my mouth, and I reached for the word, and there was *nothing there*, Bast. Nothing at all."

Bast was quiet for a long time.

"I know," he said at last. "I heard." He was quiet for a moment. "Reshi. You can't keep doing this. Going out at night with iron. Fighting things. You're not—" He stopped. "You're not strong enough. Not like this. Not without your name."

"Then what should I do?"

Bast did not answer. He looked at the fresh grave. At the raw earth, and the wooden marker Graham had carved, with Shep's name

on it.

"I don't know," he said. "But something. We have to do something." He looked at me. "This can't go on, Reshi. You can't go on like this. Being small. Being quiet. Waiting." His voice cracked. "It's killing you. I can see it. Every year, a little more. You're fading. Like my mother faded, in the twilight."

I did not say anything.

"And they're coming," said Bast. "More of them. Every year. Scrael, and skin dancers, and worse. Through the crack. Looking for you." He looked at me with his deep blue eyes. "And one day, one of them is going to find you. And you won't be able to stop it. And then—"

He did not finish.

I looked at the grave for a long time.

"Skarpi said someone would come," I said at last. "A scribe. To ask for the story. He said I should wait."

"How long?"

"He didn't say."

Bast stared at me. Then he laughed, very softly, very bitterly.

"Of course he didn't," he said. "Of course he didn't."

He turned and walked away, back toward the Waystone. He did not look back.

I stood beside Shep's grave until the sun went down.

\* \* \*

That night, I heard Bast in his room at the back of the inn. Talking. Very softly. To someone who was not there.

I did not hear what he said. I did not try to. But I heard the tone of it. Low and urgent and fierce. The tone of someone making a plan.

I did not know, then, what that plan was. I did not know for a long time.

I know now.

## Chapter One Hundred Fifty-Three

### **The Smith's Prentice**

Aaron came to the Waystone the night after we buried Shep. Very late. After the last of the regulars had gone home, after I had banked the fire and wiped down the bar and put the chairs up on the tables. I was standing in the dark common room with a rag in my hand, not doing anything, when I heard the knock.

It was not a loud knock. Three small taps, very hesitant, the way a child knocks when he is not sure he should.

I opened the door. He was standing on the step in the cold, with his shoulders hunched and his hands shoved deep in the pockets of his coat. He was seventeen that year, almost eighteen. Tall and broad already, with a smith's arms and a boy's face. His face was grey in the starlight.

"I'm sorry," he said. "I know it's late. I saw the light."

There was no light. I had put out all the lamps. But I did not say so.

"Come in," I said.

\* \* \*

I lit a single lamp and set it on the bar. I poured him a cup of cider and set it in front of him. He did not drink it. He sat on the stool with his big hands wrapped around the cup and stared at it.

I waited.

"I can't sleep," he said at last. "Every time I close my eyes, I see it. The—the thing. Coming out of him. Out of the split." His hands

tightened on the cup. "And I hear the sound it made. When I hit it. That wet sound." He swallowed. "I keep thinking about the sound."

"I know," I said.

"Do you?" He looked up at me. His eyes were red. "Do you really? Because you looked—" He stopped. "You didn't look like you'd ever seen anything like it before. But you didn't look surprised, either. You looked like—" He struggled for the words. "Like a man who'd seen worse."

I did not say anything. I polished a glass.

"Have you?" said Aaron. "Seen worse?"

I set down the glass.

"Yes," I said.

\* \* \*

He did not ask what. I was grateful for that. He only nodded slowly, as if I had confirmed something he had already known, and looked back down at his cup.

"Does it stop?" he said. "The seeing it? When you close your eyes?"

I thought about lying to him. It would have been kind, in a small way. It would have let him sleep.

But he was seventeen, and he had killed a thing out of the dark with a bar of iron to save a man who had not been able to save himself. He had earned the truth.

"No," I said. "Not all the way. It gets smaller. It gets further away. After a while, you'll go days without thinking of it. Then weeks. Then months." I looked at him. "But it doesn't stop. Not all the way. Some nights, years from now, you'll close your eyes and it'll be there. Just as clear as tonight."

Aaron was quiet for a long time.

"That's terrible," he said.

"Yes."

"How do you live with it?"

I looked at the sword over the bar. At the dark shape of it on the wall, just visible in the lamplight. At the plaque beneath it.



"You find something to do with your hands," I said. "And you do it. Every day. Over and over. Until the doing is louder than the seeing."

Aaron looked at me. Then he looked down at his hands. Big and scarred, with burns across the knuckles from the forge. A smith's hands.

"I've got something to do with my hands," he said slowly.

"Yes. You have."

\* \* \*

He drank his cider then. All of it, in one long pull, the way a thirsty man drinks water. When he set down the cup, some of the grey had gone out of his face.

"Baxter says I did right," he said. "Hitting it. He says iron's the only thing for those. He says his grandfather told him, and his grandfather's grandfather. Cold iron, for the things out of the dark." He turned the empty cup in his hands. "I didn't believe him. When he told me, years ago. I thought it was just old stories. Smith stories. Things smiths tell each other to feel important."

"And now?"

"Now I don't know what to believe." He looked at me. "Master Kote. What was it?"

I did not answer at once.

"Something that shouldn't have been here," I said at last. "Something that came from a long way away. Through a door that should have stayed closed."

"What door?"

"An old one."

Aaron looked at me for a long moment. He was not a stupid boy. I think he knew I was not telling him everything. I think he knew I could not.

"Are there more?" he said. "Like it?"

"Yes."

"Will they come here?"

I was quiet for a long time.

"Maybe," I said. "I hope not. But maybe."

\* \* \*

He sat with that for a while. I refilled his cup. He did not drink it.

"Then I'll make more iron," he said at last.

I looked at him.

"Bars," said Aaron. "Like the one I used. Plain cold iron, no fancy work, just good and heavy. Enough for every house in Newarre." He was speaking slowly, working it out as he went. "Baxter will let me use the forge after hours, if I pay for the coal. I've got some saved. And I'll make them, and I'll give them out. One for every house. To keep by the door." He looked at me. "So the next time one of those things comes, whoever it comes to won't be standing there with nothing in their hands."

I did not say anything for a long moment. I was thinking of a boy in the Fishery, years ago, with burned hands and a head full of plans, trying to build something that would warn people. A candle. A lamp. A stone you could carry in your pocket. *Something that could warn people, so maybe nobody else would have to—*

"That's a good plan," I said. My voice sounded strange. "That's a very good plan, Aaron."

\* \* \*

He made them. Over the next three months, in the evenings, after Baxter had gone home, working alone in the forge by the light of the coals. Plain heavy bars of cold iron, the length of a man's forearm, with a rough grip wrapped in leather at one end. He made fifty-three of them. One for every house in Newarre and every farm within an hour's walk.

He brought them round himself, on a handcart. He did not explain much. He only knocked on each door and held one out and said, *For by the door. In case.* And most people took them, a little puzzled, a little embarrassed, and set them in a corner and forgot about them.

But not everyone forgot. Shep's widow kept hers on the table beside her bed. Old Cob hung his over his mantel, beside a faded

painting of his mother. Jake gave his to his son Tam, who was six that year, and Tam carried it everywhere for a month, dragging it through the mud, until his mother took it away and put it on a high shelf.

Aaron brought the last one to the Waystone. He set it on the bar in front of me.

"For you," he said. "Though I expect you've got your own."

I had. Several. In the kitchen, and under the bar, and upstairs beside my bed. I had never told anyone.

"Thank you," I said. And I took it, and put it beneath the bar, right under the till, where my hand could find it in the dark.

It is still there. I have never had to use it. But I put my hand on it, sometimes, late at night, when the wind is loud and the fire is low. Just to know it is there.

\* \* \*

Aaron did not have nightmares after that. Or if he did, he did not tell me. He came to the Waystone most evenings, with the other regulars, and drank his one cup of cider, and listened to Old Cob's stories and Graham's complaints about his barn, and went home. He grew broader. His voice deepened. He started talking about the army; there was a war on, in the south, the way there is always a war on somewhere, and the recruiters had been through Baedn-Bryt.

"I'm good with iron," he said to me one night. "They need smiths. For the horses, and the armor. It's good pay." He looked at me. "What do you think, Master Kote?"

I polished a glass. I thought of the Field of Three Rivers. Of the grey dawn and the bodies in the mud and a young man about his age with his face turned up to the sky.

"I think you should stay," I said. "I think Newarre needs its smith."

Aaron looked at me for a long moment.

"You'd know," he said quietly. "Wouldn't you. About wars."

I did not answer. I set down the glass.

He did not go. Not that year. I do not know if it was because of what I said. I do not know if I had any right to say it.

But he stayed, and he kept making iron, and on the nights when the wind was loud, I sometimes saw a light in the forge window across the square, late, long after everyone else had gone to bed. The glow of the coals. And the steady ringing of a hammer.

Something to do with his hands. Until the doing was louder than the seeing.

## Chapter One Hundred Fifty-Four

# The Scribe on the Road

The rest, you know.

You were there for it. Or for the end of it. But I will tell it anyway, because I promised to tell the whole story. And because it is the last piece, the one that brings us here, to this table, to this night. And a story should always be told to its end.

\* \* \*

The autumn after Shep died, things got worse.

More scrael. More of them than ever before. Not one here and one there, now, but three and four and five at a time. They came out of the woods at night and killed sheep and cattle and dogs. They killed a traveler on the Rannish road. They scratched at the doors of houses at the edge of town, and the people inside lay awake all night with their children in their arms, listening.

The people of Newarre did not know what they were. They called them spiders. They said they had come down from the mountains, because of the war, or the hard winters, or the anger of God. The priest preached sermons about sin. The men of the town took to carrying cudgels and pitchforks when they walked out at night.

I went out every night. With iron. Alone, mostly. Bast came sometimes, but more and more he did not. He stayed in the inn, in his room at the back, and I heard him talking to someone who was not there.

I did not ask him about it. I did not know how.

\* \* \*

There were soldiers, too, that autumn. Deserters from the war in the north, some of them. Men who had been sent to fight the rebels and had decided they would rather not, and who were drifting south along the roads in twos and threes, stealing what they needed and taking what they wanted.

Two of them came to the Waystone near the end of autumn. You were there. You saw.

They were big men, hard-faced, with the grey of the Penitent King on their coats and swords at their hips. They came in out of the rain one night and sat at the bar and drank, and did not pay, and when I asked them to pay, they laughed at me. And when I asked again, they hit me.

I did not fight back.

You saw that. You were sitting at the table by the hearth, with your pen and your papers, and you saw me stand behind the bar and let them hit me. Once, twice, a dozen times. You saw me fall, and get up, and fall again. You saw me not raise my hands.

You wondered why. I know you did. I saw it in your face.

I will tell you.

It was not because I could not fight. My body still knew how. It had killed a king, and a dozen scrael, and it could have killed two drunk deserters without breaking a sweat.

It was because I did not want to.

That is the truth. I stood behind my bar and let them beat me because some part of me, very far down, wanted it. Wanted the pain. Wanted to be broken. Wanted something, anything, to reach down into the grey and make me feel.

And because, if I am honest—and I am being honest, tonight, for the first time in a very long time—some part of me wanted them to finish it. To end it. To give me what Haliar wanted, and could not have.

Rest.

\* \* \*

They did not finish it. You know that too. Bast came out of the kitchen and saw what they were doing, and his face changed, and his eyes went black, and he did something I will not describe. And then the two soldiers were lying on the floor of the common room, and they were not moving, and Bast was standing over them breathing hard with his hands clenched.

And I was lying on the floor behind the bar with blood in my mouth, looking up at the ceiling, wondering why I was still alive.

That was two nights ago.

You were there.

\* \* \*

But I am getting ahead of myself. I was telling you about the autumn. And the scrael. And how you came.

It was a span before the soldiers. A cold night, clear and bright, with a half moon riding high. I was out on the road, west of town, where a farmer had seen scrael near his barn the night before. I had a long iron bar, one of Aaron's, which he had made for me at the forge without asking why I wanted it. I had a lantern. I had my body, which knew how to fight, and my empty chest, which did not care whether I lived or died.

I heard the screaming from half a mile away.

A man's voice. High and thin and terrified. And under it, the clicking and scrabbling of scrael. Many of them.

I ran.

\* \* \*

I found you at the bottom of a shallow gully beside the road, with your back against a tree and a knife in your hand and five scrael closing in on you from every side. Your horse was dead at the top of the gully. Your satchel was lying in the mud, with papers spilling out of it.

You were very frightened. I could see it in your face, in the lantern light. But you were not running. You were standing with your back against the tree and your knife held out in front of you, and your

hand was shaking, but you were not running.

I remember thinking that was brave. Or stupid. Or both.

I came down into the gully with the iron bar in my hands. The scrael turned toward me. All five of them, at once. I felt them know me. I felt them turn their eyeless attention away from you and toward me.

*Child of my child*, something whispered. Very faint. Very far away.

I killed them.

It took a long time. Longer than I wanted. There were five of them, and I was tired, and my body was slower than it had been. One of them got a leg through my guard and opened my arm from elbow to wrist. Another knocked me down, and I rolled, and came up, and the iron bar came down on its shell with a sound like a bell.

When it was over, I was on my knees in the mud with the iron bar in my hands, breathing hard, bleeding. The five scrael were dead around me. And you were still standing with your back against the tree, with your knife in your hand, staring at me.

"Who are you?" you said.

"The innkeeper," I said. "From the Waystone. In Newarre."

You stared at me for a long time. At my face, in the lantern light. At my hair, which had grown out long by then, and was not dyed anymore, because I had stopped bothering years ago. Red. True red. The color of a flame.

And you knew.

I saw it in your face. The moment you knew. Your eyes went very wide, and your mouth fell open, and the knife in your hand began to shake so hard that you nearly dropped it.

"You're him," you whispered. "Aren't you? You're—"

"Kote," I said. "My name is Kote."

\* \* \*

I took you back to the Waystone. I bound up my arm, and I bound up the scratches on yours, and I gave you a room and a bowl of stew and a mug of hot cider. And the next morning, when you came down the



stairs with your satchel under your arm and your face pale and set, I was waiting for you behind the bar.

You asked me. You sat down at a table by the hearth and took out your pen and your papers and looked at me across the room, and you asked me.

"Are you Kvothe?"

I did not answer right away. I stood behind the bar with a cloth in my hand and looked at you. At your neat beard and your ink-stained fingers and the tired, clever, patient face of a man who has spent his life listening to other people's stories.

And I thought about an old man at a crossroads, with bright eyes like a bird's.

*Someday a man will come to your inn. He'll be a scribe. A chronicler. And he'll ask you for the true story of Kvothe. And you'll tell him.*

I had waited so long. Six years. Seven. I had stopped counting. I had stopped believing he would come. I had stopped believing in anything.

And here he was. Sitting at a table by my hearth, with ink on his fingers, asking.

"I was," I said.

\* \* \*

You wanted the story. Of course you did. Everyone wants the story. You wanted to know if it was true, all of it. The draccus at Trebon and the bandits in the Eld and Felurian and the Adem and the Chandrian. The king.

I told you I would tell it. I told you it would take three days. You laughed at that. You said no story took three days. You said you had recorded the histories of kings and never needed more than two.

I did not laugh. I only said, *three days*. And you looked at me, and something in my face made you stop laughing.

And then I began.

\* \* \*

I did not know, when I began, what would happen. I want you to understand that. I did not know that telling the story would bring my name back. I did not know that every word I spoke would be a piece of me, taken out of the dark and put back where it belonged. I did not know that the telling itself was a kind of naming.

Skarpi knew. I think. And Bast. And perhaps Elodin, a long time ago, in a round room at the top of the Rookery, when he told me that the best way to learn the name of a thing is to hear its whole story.

But I did not know. Not when I began.

I only knew that an old man had told me to tell it. And that I had been waiting a very long time. And that I was tired of waiting.

So I told it. From the beginning. My parents, and the troupe, and the Chandrian. Tarbean, and the University, and Denna. The Maer, and the Adem, and Felurian.

And somewhere in the middle of the first day, I felt it.

\* \* \*

It was very small, at first. A flicker. A warmth. Somewhere down in the hole in my chest, where nothing had been for years. I did not know what it was. I thought it was the fire in the hearth, or the cider, or the pleasure of having someone to talk to.

But it grew. As I talked. Every word I said, it grew a little. Every memory I brought up out of the dark and laid out on the table in front of you, it grew. Every name I spoke. My mother's. My father's. Abenthy's, and Trapis's, and Skarpi's. Sim's, and Wil's, and Auri's.

Denna's.

It grew. And by the end of the first day, I knew what it was.

It was me.

\* \* \*

I did not stop. I could have. I thought about it, the first night, lying in my bed at the top of the stairs with the chest at the foot of it. I thought about getting up in the morning and telling you I had changed my mind. That there was no story. That I was only Kote, the innkeeper, and you should go back to wherever you came from.

But I did not. Because I felt it. The warmth, in my chest. Growing. And for the first time in years, the world was not quite so grey.

And because I was tired. Of being small. Of being quiet. Of polishing things and pouring drinks and waiting for something that might never come.

And because Shep was dead. And Carter's horse. And a traveler on the Rannish road. And the scrael were coming, more every year, through a crack in a door that I had closed but not all the way.

And because someone had to do something.

And because, if I am honest, I wanted to know how it ended.

\* \* \*

So I told it. The second day. The University, and the Maer, and the Adem. The Fae, and Felurian, and the Cthaeh. And the warmth in my chest grew and grew, until it was not a warmth anymore but a fire. Small, still. Banked, like the embers of a hearth at night. But a fire.

And the soldiers came, and I let them beat me. And I told myself it was because I wanted to feel something. And that was true. But it was also because I could feel the fire growing, and I was afraid of it. Afraid of what it meant. Afraid of what would come when it was burning bright again.

Afraid of who would come.

And now it is the third day. And I have told you almost all of it. The door, and the name, and the cord. Renere, and the trial, and the hanging. Imre, and the chest, and Denna walking away down the far side of the bridge.

And Newarre. And the Waystone. And Kote.

And you.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper stopped speaking.

He sat very still at the table by the hearth, in the heatless firelight, with his hands folded in front of him and his green eyes on Chronicler's face.

"That's the story," he said. "That's all of it. From the beginning, to here." He was quiet for a moment. "To now."

Chronicler did not move. His pen was motionless in his hand. There was ink on the page in front of him, row after row of tiny crabbed cipher, all the way to the bottom and up the margin and across the top. He did not remember writing it.

"That's the end?" he said. His voice was hoarse.

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at the window, where the frost had crept all the way across the shutters now, thick and white and feathery. He looked at the fire, burning bright and giving no heat. He looked at the cup of tea in front of him, frozen solid.

"No," he said quietly. "Not quite."

He stood up.

"There's one more part," said Kvothe. "And it hasn't happened yet."

## **Interlude: Bast's Confession**

The innkeeper stood beside the table, very still, looking at the frost on the shutters.

Chronicler looked up at him. At his red hair, and his green eyes, and the bruises on his face, fading now from purple to yellow. At his hands, hanging at his sides. They were steady. They were perfectly steady.

"What do you mean?" said Chronicler. "It hasn't happened yet?"

The innkeeper did not answer. He was looking at the window. At the frost, thick and white and feathery, covering the dark wood. At the thin line of darkness at the edge of the shutters, where the night showed through.

"He's close," he said quietly. "Closer than before. I can feel him." He touched his chest, over his heart. "Here. Where it's warm again. I can feel him, the way you feel a draft from a door that's been left open."

"Cinder."

"Ferule." The innkeeper nodded. "That's his name. His true one. I know it now." He was quiet for a moment. "I didn't, before. When I was Kote. I didn't know anything. But I told you the story, and it came back. A piece at a time. And that came back with it."

He turned from the window and looked down at Chronicler.

"I know a great many things now," he said. "That I didn't know three days ago."

\* \* \*

Bast had not moved. He was still kneeling on the floor beside the innkeeper's empty chair, where he had knelt when Aaron left. His head was bowed. His hands were clenched in his lap.

"Reshi," he said. His voice was very small.

The innkeeper looked down at him.

"I have to tell you something," said Bast. "Before he comes. I have to tell you, or I'll never be able to."

"I know, Bast."

"No. You don't." Bast looked up. His face was white, and wet, and his deep blue eyes were full of something terrible. "You don't know. You can't know. I never told you. I never told anyone."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then he pulled out his chair and sat down in it, facing Bast, with his hands on his knees.

"Then tell me," he said gently.

\* \* \*

Bast did not speak right away. He knelt on the floor with his hands clenched and his head bowed, and his shoulders were shaking. Chronicler sat very still at the table and did not move, did not write, did not breathe.

"The soldiers," said Bast at last. "The two soldiers. Two nights ago." He swallowed. "I sent them."

The common room was silent.

"I found them on the Rannish road," said Bast. His voice was very quiet, very flat, as if he were reciting something he had memorized. "A span before. Deserters. Drunk. Mean. I followed them for a day. I listened to them talk. They were going to rob a farm near Baedn. Kill the farmer, maybe. They talked about it like it was nothing." He was quiet for a moment. "And I thought, they're exactly what I need."

"Bast—"

"Let me finish." Bast's voice cracked. "Please. Let me finish, Reshi, or I'll never be able to say it."

The innkeeper was silent.

"I went to them," said Bast. "At their camp, that night. I glamour'd myself. Made myself look like a merchant. Rich. Frightened. I told them there was an inn in Newarre, the Waystone, with an innkeeper who had gold hidden in a chest in his room. Lots of gold. I told them he was soft. A coward. Wouldn't fight back." He took a shaking breath. "I told them where to find you. I told them when."

He looked up at the innkeeper. His face was naked with grief.

"I wanted them to hurt you," he said. "Not kill you. Just hurt you. Enough to—enough to make you *angry*. Enough to make you fight back. Enough to make you remember what you were." He was weeping now. "I thought if you were in danger—real danger—your body would remember. Your hands. Your feet. Your name. I thought you'd fight them, and win, and it would wake something up in you. Like the scrael did. Like it did on the north road, that first night, when you came back with blood on your hands and color in your face." He pressed his hands against his eyes. "I thought it would *wake you up*."

"And it didn't."

"It didn't." Bast's voice was muffled. "You just stood there. You let them hit you. Over and over. You didn't raise your hands. You didn't do *anything*." He took his hands away from his face. His eyes were red and wild. "And I stood in the kitchen and watched it. And I waited. And I kept thinking, *now, now he'll fight back, now*. And you didn't. And they kept hitting you. And I couldn't—"

He stopped. He put his hands over his mouth.

"I killed them," he whispered through his fingers. "I came out of the kitchen and I killed them. Both of them. With my hands. Because I couldn't stand it anymore. Because I'd done it, I'd brought them here, and they were hurting you, and you weren't fighting back, and it was all my fault—"

He broke down completely then. He folded over on the floor, with his face in his hands and his forehead nearly touching the boards, and he wept. Great heaving sobs that shook his whole body.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper did not move for a long time. He sat in his chair with his hands on his knees and looked down at Bast, weeping on the floor at his feet.

His face did not change. It was calm. Very calm. The calm of someone who has been expecting something for a long time, and is not surprised when it comes.

"I know," he said at last.

Bast went still. Then, very slowly, he lifted his head.

"What?"

"I know," said the innkeeper. "I've known since the second night. Since I sat in the kitchen with a wet cloth on my face and thought about it." He looked down at Bast. "They said something. The soldiers. While they were hitting me. One of them said, *the merchant said you were soft*. And I thought, what merchant? And then I thought about you. And how you'd been talking in your room at night, for a year. Making plans." He was quiet for a moment. "And I knew."

Bast stared up at him. His face was white and wet and utterly still.

"You knew," he whispered. "And you didn't say anything."

"No."

"Why?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment.

"Because you did it out of love," he said simply. "The way Denna took the box out of love. The way she caught my name out of love, and tied it, and walked away out of love." He reached out and laid his hand on Bast's dark head. "You've been doing things out of love for me for a very long time, Bast. Some of them were foolish. Some of them were brave. Most of them were both."

Bast made a sound. A small, broken sound.

"The Cthaeh said," he whispered. "In the net. It said I'd keep you in a cage of my own making. And call it love."

"I know. You told me. Tonight."

"And I did." Bast's voice cracked. "I did it, Reshi. I kept you here. In this inn. In this town. Being small. Being quiet. For years. Because I was afraid. Of what you'd do if you remembered. Of what you'd



become. Of what would come for you." He pressed his face against the innkeeper's knee. "And then I saw it was killing you. And I tried to break the cage. And I brought those men here to hurt you. And that was love too. Wasn't it? That was love, and it was the cage, and it was all the same thing, and I couldn't tell the difference—"

"No one can," said the innkeeper quietly. "That's what the Cthaeh knew. That's why it said it." He stroked Bast's hair. "It didn't tell you anything that wasn't true, Bast. It just made you afraid of it. And being afraid of it made you do things you wouldn't have done otherwise." He was quiet for a moment. "That's how it works. That's how it always works."

\* \* \*

Bast was quiet for a long time. He knelt with his face against the innkeeper's knee, and his shoulders slowly stopped shaking.

"There's more," he said at last. His voice was muffled. "Not just the soldiers."

"I know."

"You don't. You can't." Bast lifted his head. "The scribe. Chronicler." He looked across the table at Chronicler, who had not moved, who was sitting very still with his pen motionless in his hand. "Skarpi didn't just send him. I asked Skarpi to send him."

Chronicler went very still.

"After Shep died," said Bast. "I went looking for Skarpi. I went to the crossroads where we met him, the first time. He wasn't there. So I waited. I waited for nine days, sitting on that bench outside that empty inn. And on the tenth day, he came." Bast looked at the innkeeper. "I told him everything. About the scrael. About the skin dancer. About you, getting greyer every year. Fading. I told him you were dying, Reshi. Slowly. Like my mother did, in the twilight."

The innkeeper did not say anything.

"And I asked him," said Bast, "when the scribe was coming. The one he'd told you about. The one who'd ask for the story." His voice cracked. "And he looked at me with those bright bird's eyes of his, and he said, *whenever you like, little prince. The scribe is only waiting to*

*be sent."*

"So you told him to send me," said Chronicler. His voice sounded strange in his own ears.

"I told him to send you." Bast looked at him. "I'm sorry. I didn't know you. I didn't know anything about you. I only knew that Skarpi said a scribe would come, and Reshi would tell him the story, and the telling would bring his name back." He looked at the innkeeper. "Skarpi told me that. At the crossroads. He said, *stories are names too. The oldest kind. Tell a man's whole story and you speak his name.*" His voice dropped. "And he said, *but be careful, little prince. A name coming back is a very loud thing. It will be heard.*"

"And you sent me anyway," said Chronicler.

"I sent you anyway." Bast looked down at the floor. "Because I couldn't stand it anymore. Watching him fade. Watching him polish the bar and pour the drinks and wait. I thought, better he's himself again and in danger, than safe and nothing." His voice was very small. "Was that wrong?"

Nobody answered.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper looked down at Bast for a long time. His face was very calm. His hand was still resting on Bast's dark head.

"Get up, Bast," he said quietly.

Bast looked up at him.

"Get up," said the innkeeper again. "Please. Sit in your chair. Like you've been sitting for three days. Backward, with your arms on the back." He smiled, very faintly. "I've grown used to it. It would be strange, telling the rest of this without you in your chair."

Bast stared at him. Then, slowly, he got up off the floor. He picked up his chair from where it had fallen and set it on its feet. He turned it backward and sat in it, with his arms folded across the back, and his chin on his arms.

His face was wet and red and utterly miserable. But he was sitting in his chair.

"Now," said the innkeeper. He looked at Bast, and then at Chronicler. "Now I'm going to tell you both something. And I want you to listen."

\* \* \*

"It wasn't wrong," he said.

Bast went very still.

"It wasn't wrong," the innkeeper said again. "Sending the soldiers. Sending the scribe. Keeping me here. Letting me go. None of it." He looked at Bast. "It wasn't right either. It was only a choice. You made it. And you've borne what came after." He paused. "That's the Lethani. That's all anyone can do."

"But the Cthaeh—"

"The Cthaeh told you that you'd keep me in a cage and call it love. And you did." The innkeeper's voice was very gentle. "But it didn't tell you the rest. It didn't tell you that you'd also be the one to open the cage. That you'd see it was a cage, and you'd break it, even though it terrified you. Even though it meant this." He gestured at the frost on the windows. "It didn't tell you that part, because it didn't want you to know. Because knowing it would have made you less afraid."

Bast stared at him.

"You did both, Bast," said the innkeeper. "You kept me safe, and you let me go. You built the cage and you broke it. That's what love is, sometimes. Both at once." He smiled faintly. "The Cthaeh only ever tells you half of the truth. The half that hurts."

\* \* \*

Bast did not say anything. He sat in his backward chair with his chin on his arms and his wet eyes on the innkeeper's face, and he did not move.

Then, very slowly, something in his face began to change. The misery did not go away. But something else came into it. Something that had not been there in a very long time.

It looked a little like hope.

"Reshi," he said. "Are you—" He stopped. He swallowed. "Are you back? Are you yourself again?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment.

"Not all the way," he said. "Not yet. Most of me is back. The story brought it back. Everything I told, I remembered. Everything I remembered, I got back." He touched his chest. "But not the name. Not the true one. That's still in the chest. Upstairs. In a cord of Denna's hair." He looked up at the ceiling. "I can feel it. For the first time in years, I can feel it. Up there. Humming." He was quiet for a moment. "Calling me."

"Then open it."

"I can't." The innkeeper smiled, a small crooked rueful smile. "That's the joke, Bast. That's the beautiful game. The chest will only open for Kvothe. And I'm not Kvothe. Not yet. Not until I have my name." He spread his hands. "And my name is in the chest."

Bast stared at him.

"So you're stuck," he said slowly. "Halfway. Almost yourself. With your name right there, upstairs, and no way to get it."

"Yes."

"And Cinder's coming."

"Yes."

"And he can hear you. Now that you're almost yourself again. He can hear you, and he's coming, and when he gets here—"

"He'll want the name," said the innkeeper quietly. "He'll want to take it to the door. And he'll want to take me with it. Because I'm the key. Or I will be, the moment I open that chest." He looked at the frost on the window. "And if he takes me, and the name, and the box with no lid—"

He did not finish. He did not need to.

\* \* \*

The common room was silent.

Outside, very faintly, beyond the frost-covered shutters, something moved. A sound. Soft and slow. Like footsteps on frozen grass.

The fire in the hearth flickered. It had been burning yellow, bright and heatless, for hours. Now it flickered.

And turned blue.

The innkeeper looked at it. His face did not change.

"There he is," he said quietly.

## **Interlude: Blue Flame**

Every candle in the Waystone Inn was burning blue.

The fire in the hearth. The candles on the tables. The lantern hanging from its hook by the kitchen door. All of them, all at once, burning a deep, cold, steady blue, the blue of a winter sky at dusk, the blue of a bruise.

The frost on the shutters crept inward. It crept across the floor, white and feathery, from the walls toward the center of the room. It crept up the legs of the tables and the chairs. It crept up the bar, across the dark wood, over the bottles on their shelves. The bottles cracked, one by one, with small sharp sounds like breaking bones, as the liquid inside them froze.

Chronicler's breath came out of him in great white plumes. His hands were so cold he could not feel his pen. He looked down and saw that the ink on the page in front of him had frozen, in the middle of a line. The last word he had written was half a word, and the rest of it was a smear of black ice.

Bast was on his feet. He had moved so fast that his chair had gone over behind him. He stood between the table and the door with his hands at his sides, and his eyes had gone black. Not dark. Black. Like holes cut in the world.

The innkeeper had not moved. He sat at the table, very still, with his hands folded in front of him, and looked at the door.

"Bast," he said. "Sit down."

"No."

"Bast."

"No." Bast did not turn around. His voice was strange. Deeper. Older. "Not this time, Reshi. Not this time. I let you walk out that door at the Lackless house alone. I let you go into the Tower of Thorns alone. I'm not letting you face him alone."

"You can't fight him."

"I know." Bast's voice was very steady. "I'm going to anyway."

\* \* \*

Someone knocked on the door.

Three times. Slow and even. Very polite. The knock of a guest, arriving for dinner.

Nobody moved.

The knock came again. Three times. Slow and even.

Then a voice. Soft and reasonable and utterly without warmth. The voice of a man asking you to pass the salt.

"I know you're there," it said. "I can hear you. All of you." A pause. "May I come in?"

The innkeeper looked at the door for a long moment.

Then he said, very quietly, "The door is barred."

"I know." The voice sounded amused. "I'm asking to be polite. I was taught manners, once, a very long time ago. Before." A pause. "I could come in anyway. You know I could. The bar is iron, but the door is only wood, and wood is very cold tonight. Very brittle." Another pause. "But I'd rather you let me in. It's so much more civilized."

"And if I don't?"

The voice was silent for a moment.

"Then I'll come in anyway," it said. "And I'll be less polite about it. And the scribe will probably die. And the princeling. And then, afterward, I'll go down the road to the little stone church, where half the town is hiding, and I'll be even less polite there." A pause. "You know me, singer. You know what I do when I'm not polite."

The innkeeper closed his eyes.

"Bast," he said. "Lift the bar."

"Reshi—"

"Lift the bar, Bast. Please."

\* \* \*

Bast did not move for a long time. He stood between the table and the door with his black eyes fixed on the frosted wood, and his hands clenched at his sides, and he did not move.

Then, slowly, he turned his head and looked at the innkeeper.

The innkeeper looked back at him. His green eyes were very calm.

"Trust me," he said.

Bast looked at him for a long moment. Then he went to the door. He put his hands on the heavy iron bar, and flinched, and snatched them back. The iron burned him. Even through the frost. Even through the cold.

He put his hands on it again. He did not flinch this time. He lifted the bar out of its brackets, with his face twisted in pain and the skin of his palms smoking, and set it down against the wall.

The door swung open on its own.

\* \* \*

He was standing on the porch, in the dark, with the frost spreading out around his feet.

He was tall and pale and very still, with a face like a knife. His hair was the color of frost. His eyes were black. Not dark. Black. Pure and depthless, like holes cut in the world.

And there was a scar on his face.

It ran from the corner of his left eye to the corner of his mouth. A long pale ridge of tissue, puckered and twisted, like the scar of a burn. It pulled at his face when he smiled, so that the smile was lopsided. Crooked. Wrong.

He smiled now.

"Hello, singer," said Cinder.

\* \* \*

He came in. He did not walk. He drifted, the way a leaf drifts, the way smoke drifts. He came through the doorway and into the common



room of the Waystone Inn, and the frost went ahead of him, spreading across the floor like a carpet unrolled for a king.

He stopped a few paces inside the door. He looked around the room. At the bar, and the frozen bottles, and the tables with their chairs upside down on some of them. At the fire in the great stone hearth, burning blue. At the sword hanging above it, on two iron pegs, over a plaque with a single word burned into it.

He looked at the sword for a long time.

"*Folly*," he said. He laughed softly. "Oh, that's very good. Did you name it yourself?"

The innkeeper did not answer.

Cinder turned. He looked at Chronicler, sitting frozen at the table by the hearth with his pen in his hand and his breath smoking in the air.

"The scribe," he said. "Hello. You've been writing, I see. Three days of writing." He tilted his head. "Three days of a name coming back. I heard every word. From the woods, beyond the fields. I've been listening since the first morning." He smiled his crooked smile. "It was very beautiful. You have a lovely hand, you know. Very neat. Very small."

Chronicler could not speak. He could not move. He sat at the table with his frozen pen and stared at the man with the scarred face, and every part of him was screaming.

Cinder turned to Bast.

Bast was standing by the open door, where he had set down the bar. His hands were burned and smoking. His eyes were black. His face was white and still and utterly without fear.

"The princeling," said Cinder softly. "The little Fae prince. The one who stepped in front of five Sithe arrows and survived." He looked at Bast's burned hands. "You lifted the iron. For him. How sweet."

Bast did not say anything. But his lips pulled back from his teeth. And his teeth were not the teeth of a young man.

Cinder laughed.

"Don't," he said. "Please. I've killed Fae older than your father's court. I'd hate to have to kill you. You're very pretty."

\* \* \*

Then, at last, he turned to the innkeeper.

The innkeeper had not moved. He was still sitting at the table, with his hands folded in front of him, looking at Cinder with his calm green eyes.

Cinder looked at him for a long time. His black eyes moved slowly over the innkeeper's face. His red hair, true red, the color of a flame. The bruises on his jaw. The scar on his cheek. His hands, folded on the table. His left wrist, with its thin pale line around it like a bracelet.

"Kote," said Cinder. "That's what they call you, isn't it? In this little town. Kote the innkeeper."

"Yes."

"Kote." Cinder tasted the word. "Disaster. In the old Siaru." He smiled his crooked smile. "Who gave it to you? The little girl under the University? The one who names things?"

The innkeeper did not answer.

"It was clever," said Cinder. "I'll give her that. A name so small it couldn't call anything. A name for something that happened, not something that is." He shook his head slowly. "I searched for you for years, you know. Years. After the cellar. After the old man went through the door." He touched the scar on his face. "After *she* did this to me." His voice went very soft. "I searched and searched. And I couldn't find you. Because there was nothing to find. Only a little name. A disaster. Hiding behind a stone."

He glanced toward the window, toward the crossroads, where the waystone stood in the dark.

"That was clever too," he said. "The stone. I walked past this town three times, in the last seven years. Three times. And I never heard a thing." He looked back at the innkeeper. "Until three days ago. When you started talking."

"I know," said the innkeeper.

"You knew I'd hear."

"Yes."

"And you did it anyway."

"Yes."

Cinder looked at him for a long moment. Something moved in his black eyes.

"Why?" he said.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time.

"Because I was tired," he said at last. "Of being small. Of waiting. Of polishing the bar." He looked at Cinder. "Because people are dying. Because the door is cracked, and things are coming through, and every year it gets worse. Because a boy came to my door tonight and told me about eleven cows frozen standing up in a field." He paused. "Because a man named Shep is buried in the churchyard behind the little stone church, and he laughed at his own jokes, and I liked him."

Cinder's crooked smile widened.

"You're going to fight me," he said. "Aren't you? You're going to try. With your name locked up in a box upstairs, and nothing inside you but a little disaster." He shook his head. "Oh, singer. You haven't changed at all."

"No," said the innkeeper. "I don't suppose I have."

\* \* \*

Cinder drew his sword.

It came out of its sheath with no sound at all. A long pale blade, the color of ice. The air around it went white with frost. The candles on the tables flickered and guttered, blue and cold.

"I'm not going to kill you," he said. "You know that. I can't. The lord still forbids it." He looked at the blade in his hand. "But I can hurt you. I can hurt you very much. And I can hurt them." He glanced at Chronicler. At Bast. "And I can take you. To the door. With the name, and the box, and everything else in that chest upstairs."

"The chest won't open," said the innkeeper. "Not for you. Not for anyone but me. And I can't open it either. Not as Kote."

"I know." Cinder smiled. "That's why I'm going to take the whole chest. And you with it. And when we get to the door, you'll open it. Because you'll have to. Because I'll make you." His black eyes glittered. "It's amazing, what a man will do, when you start taking away the people he loves. One at a time."

He turned toward Chronicler.

"I'll start with the scribe," he said.

\* \* \*

Bast moved.

He moved faster than Chronicler had ever seen anything move. Faster than a cat, faster than a snake, faster than thought. One moment he was standing by the door, and the next he was in front of Cinder, between the pale sword and Chronicler, with his burned hands raised and his black eyes blazing and his lips drawn back from teeth that were long and sharp and very white.

He struck.

Cinder was faster.

He did not even seem to move. He was simply somewhere else, a pace to the left, and the pale sword was moving, and Bast was falling. Chronicler heard the sound it made. A small, sharp, wet sound. Like a knife going into fruit.

Bast hit the floor. He lay on his side on the frost-covered boards, with his hand pressed to his side, and blood coming out between his fingers. Red blood, very bright against the white frost.

He did not cry out. He looked up at Cinder with his black eyes, and his teeth bared, and he tried to get up.

Cinder put his boot on Bast's chest and pushed him back down.

"Stay," he said, as you would say it to a dog. "Stay down, little prince. I'll get to you later."

\* \* \*

The innkeeper was on his feet.

He had not moved from the table in all of this. But he was on his feet now, and his chair was lying on its side behind him, and his hands were not folded anymore. They were clenched at his sides.

And his face had changed.

Chronicler saw it. He would remember it for the rest of his life. The innkeeper's face, calm and mild and bruised, changing. The calm going out of it, like a tide going out. And something else coming in. Something that had been buried a very long time, under years of polishing and pouring and waiting.

It was not Kote's face. Kote had never looked like that.

It was anger. Pure and clean and cold. Anger like a blade. Anger like the Heart of Stone.

"Get your boot off him," said the innkeeper.

His voice had changed too. It was deeper. Harder. It filled the common room like water filling a cup.

Cinder looked at him. His crooked smile flickered.

"Or what?" he said. "What will you do, Kote? You have nothing. No name. No power. No sword, even; it's hanging on the wall." He pressed down with his boot. Bast made a small sound. "What will you do?"

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment.

Then he turned his back on Cinder, and walked to the stairs.

\* \* \*

Cinder watched him go. His black eyes narrowed.

"Where are you going?" he said.

The innkeeper did not answer. He climbed the stairs. One step at a time. Steadily. Without hurry.

"The chest won't open," Cinder called after him. "You know it won't. You can't open it. Not as you are."

The innkeeper stopped on the landing. He turned and looked down at Cinder, standing in the middle of the frost-covered common room with his boot on Bast's chest and his pale sword in his hand.

"I know," he said.

And then he looked at Chronicler. Sitting frozen at the table by the hearth, with his pen in his hand and his breath smoking in the air and the pages of three days of writing spread out in front of him.

"Scribe," said the innkeeper quietly. "Bring the story."

## Interlude: The Chest

Chronicler did not remember getting up from the table.

He remembered the innkeeper's voice, very quiet, from the top of the stairs. *Scribe. Bring the story.* And then he was on his feet, and the pages were in his arms, all of them, three days of writing gathered up in a great untidy armful of paper, some of it frozen stiff, some of it smeared with black ice where the ink had frozen before it dried. And he was crossing the frost-covered floor of the common room toward the stairs.

He had to pass Cinder to get there.

He did not look at him. He could not. He kept his eyes on the stairs, on the innkeeper standing on the landing above, and he walked. Past the tall pale shape with the pale sword. Past Bast, lying on the floor with a boot on his chest and blood on the frost beside him. Past the cold, which came off Cinder in waves, like heat off a forge, only the opposite.

He felt Cinder's black eyes on him as he passed. He felt them the way you feel the edge of a knife laid against your skin.

Cinder did not stop him.

"Go on," said the soft, reasonable voice behind him. Amused. "Go on, scribe. Take him his story. I'd like to see what he does with it."

Chronicler climbed the stairs.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper's room was at the front of the inn, at the top of the stairs. A small plain room with a narrow bed and a washstand and a

window that looked out over the crossroads. The shutters on the window were covered in frost, thick and white. The air was so cold it hurt to breathe.

The chest was at the foot of the bed.

Chronicler had never seen it before. He had not been in this room. He stood in the doorway with his arms full of paper and looked at it.

It was a plain dark box, about the size of a small trunk. Smooth and heavy and without ornament. The wood was almost black, with a faint reddish tinge in the grain. There were two locks on the front of it: one copper, with a keyhole shaped like a small closed eye; one stone, grey and plain, with no keyhole at all. And between them, sunk into the wood so deep that it seemed part of the grain, a small dark knot.

The innkeeper was kneeling in front of it. He had his hands flat on the lid. His head was bowed.

"It's humming," he said, without looking up. "I can hear it. For the first time in seven years, I can hear it." His voice was very quiet. "The waystone's been drowning it out all this time. But I'm loud enough now to hear it over the stone." He paused. "And it's loud enough to hear me."

Chronicler did not know what to say. He stood in the doorway with his arms full of paper and his breath smoking in the frozen air.

The innkeeper looked up at him.

"Sit," he said. "On the bed. Where I can hear you."

Chronicler sat.

"Now," said the innkeeper. "Read it to me."

\* \* \*

Chronicler stared at him.

"Read it?"

"The story. What you wrote." The innkeeper looked at the pages in Chronicler's arms. "All of it, if we had time. We don't. So read me the parts that matter." He looked back at the chest. "The copper lock is bound to me. To Kvothe. To the man with his name. It won't open for Kote. It doesn't know Kote." He laid his hand on the copper lock. "But it might know Kvothe's story. If it hears enough of it. If it's told true."



Chronicler looked down at the pages in his arms. At the tiny crabbed cipher, row after row, filling every page from top to bottom and up the margins and across the tops.

"I don't know which parts matter," he said.

The innkeeper looked at him. His green eyes were very steady.

"Yes, you do," he said. "You've been listening for three days. You know."

\* \* \*

From downstairs, very faintly, Chronicler heard a sound. A small, choked sound. Bast.

And then Cinder's voice. Soft and reasonable. Carrying up the stairs as clearly as if he were standing in the room.

*"I'm waiting, singer," it said. "I'm a very patient man. But not infinitely patient." A pause. Another small choked sound. "Neither is the princeling. He's losing a great deal of blood."*

The innkeeper closed his eyes.

"Read," he said. "Please."

\* \* \*

Chronicler read.

His hands were shaking so badly he could barely hold the pages. His voice cracked on the first word. But he read.

He did not start at the beginning. There was no time for the beginning. He sorted through the pages, quickly, blindly, his frozen fingers fumbling at the stiff paper. He did not know what he was looking for. He only knew, the way you sometimes know things, that he would know it when he found it.

He found it.

*"Kilvin was in his office," he read. His voice was hoarse. "He was always in his office, as far as I could tell. I sometimes wondered if he slept there, curled up on the floor beneath his desk like a great bear in a cave."*

He read the Fishery. The candle. Kilvin's great scarred hands, and the ledgers, and the dates. He read the moment Kvothe realized what

the candle was. He read Kilvin's face, full of compassion. *Maybe nobody else would have to lose their family.*

He read the Fishery at night. The roah planks. Kilvin with his plane, shaving long pale curls of wood. Wil at the bench with his scarred hands, making the copper lock. *It's a sympathy lock. The key has to be bound to the lock by the one who owns it.*

The innkeeper was kneeling in front of the chest with his hand on the copper lock and his eyes closed. His lips were moving. Very faintly. Saying something Chronicler could not hear.

Chronicler read.

He read the moment the cord came off Kvothe's wrist. *It felt like dying.* He read Denna, saying *Kote. Can you hear me?* He read Kvothe saying *no.*

He read the lid closing.

And the copper lock clicked.

\* \* \*

It was a small sound. Barely a sound at all. A single soft click, like a key turning in a well-oiled lock.

The innkeeper opened his eyes. He looked down at the copper lock under his hand.

The small closed eye of its keyhole had opened.

"One," he said softly.

\* \* \*

From downstairs, Cinder's voice. Closer, now. At the foot of the stairs.

*"I heard that,"* it said. *"How very clever."* A pause. *"I'm coming up, singer. I'd like to watch."*

Footsteps on the stairs. Slow. Unhurried. Each one leaving a small white bloom of frost on the wood.

"The stone," said the innkeeper. His voice was very steady. "Read me the stone. Fela's lock. It knows the Eolian. The night of the song. The stones in it held the building up while it burned." He looked at Chronicler. "Read me that night."

Chronicler's hands were shaking so badly he dropped half the pages. They scattered across the frozen floor. He fell to his knees and scrabbled for them. Found the one he needed. It was frozen stiff, the ink smeared with black ice. He could barely read it.

He read it anyway.

*"It began with the candles on the tables nearest the stage,"* he read.

\* \* \*

He read the Eolian. The candles going blue. The cold. The Seven, appearing one by one. He read Wil holding up the chandelier with his face grey with effort. He read Devi at the balcony rail, throwing her Surprises. He read the balconies rotting under Usnea's hands.

He read the stone.

*And beneath my feet, I felt the stone of the stage begin to hum. It was very faint at first. A vibration, deep and low, rising up from somewhere far below. From the cellar. From the foundations.*

*Fela.*

*She was down there, in the dark, with her hands pressed flat against the foundations of the Eolian. And she was asking the stone to stand.*

The stone lock on the chest was humming.

Chronicler could hear it. Even he could hear it. A deep low vibration, rising up out of the grey stone, filling the small cold room. It was the most patient sound he had ever heard. The sound of something that had been saying *no* for a very long time, and was about to say something else.

The footsteps on the stairs had stopped.

Chronicler read on. He read Stanchion, with his empty buckets, standing between Usnea and the cellar stairs. *Not in my place, you rotten bitch.* He read Stanchion falling.

He read Kvothe, still singing. *And I did not stop singing.*

He read the walls, standing in the dawn, blackened and scorched and cracked. But standing.

*Never seen stone hold like that,* the old stonemason had said.  
*Never in my life.*

The stone lock stopped humming.

It did not click. It did not open. It simply went quiet. And then, very slowly, the grey stone of it split down the middle, cleanly, the way stone splits along a seam. And the two halves fell apart, and lay on the floor, and inside the hollow where they had been, there were two small flat stones. Worn smooth. With a single mark scratched into each one.

The innkeeper picked them up. He held them in his palm. He looked at them for a long time.

"Two," he said.

\* \* \*

"Three," said a voice from the doorway.

Cinder was standing there. Tall and pale and very still, with his pale sword in his hand and his crooked scarred smile. The frost bloomed out from his feet across the floor of the small room, white and crackling.

"There's a third lock," he said. "Isn't there? The girl's knot." He looked at the small dark knot sunk into the wood between the two open locks. "I can see it from here. Very neat. Very tight." He smiled. "You can't read that one open, singer. It needs the other half. The twin. And the twin is with her. Far away. Wherever she's hiding."

The innkeeper did not look at him. He was looking at the knot.

"You've done very well," said Cinder. "Two out of three. Very impressive. The old man would have been proud." He came into the room. One step. Two. "But it's over now. Pick up the chest. Come with me. We'll find the girl together. I'm very good at finding people." His crooked smile widened. "And when we find her, she'll untie it. Because she loves you. And I'll be holding a knife to your throat."

The innkeeper was quiet for a long moment.

Then he reached into the pocket of his apron.

\* \* \*

He took out something small. Chronicler could not see what it was. The innkeeper held it cupped in his palm, and looked down at it, and his face did something that Chronicler would remember for the rest of his life.

It was the face of a man who has been handed something he lost a very long time ago, and never expected to see again.

"A tinker came by today," said the innkeeper quietly. "This afternoon. He sold needles and mended pots and gave the children sugared almonds. And before he left, he gave me this." He opened his hand. "He said it was something I'd lost. On the road. A long time ago. He said someone had asked him to carry it for me, until the time was right." He looked up at Cinder. "He said the time was right."

In his palm, there was a cord. Short. Barely as long as a finger. Braided from three strands of dark hair.

With a single knot tied in it.

Cinder stopped moving.

"No," he said softly.

"*Knots are very good at finding their way home*," said the innkeeper. "She told me that. On the night we made the chest. I didn't remember it, when the tinker gave me this. I didn't know what it was. I only knew that it made me want to weep." He looked down at the knot. "But I remember now. The story brought it back."

He leaned forward. He pressed the twin knot against the knot in the wood.

And it came undone.

\* \* \*

It did not happen quickly. It happened the way ice melts in spring. The knot in the wood loosened, one loop at a time, slowly, as if it were waking up from a long sleep. The dark strands of hair unwound from the grain of the roah. They drifted up out of the wood like smoke, and wound themselves around the twin knot in the innkeeper's fingers, and the two knots became one, and then the one knot came undone, and there was only a short loose piece of dark hair, lying across the innkeeper's palm.

The lid of the chest shifted. Just slightly. The way a lid shifts when it is no longer held down.

"Three," said the innkeeper.

\* \* \*

Cinder moved.

He came across the small room like a blade of ice, his pale sword raised. He moved faster than Chronicler could follow, faster than anything should move.

But the innkeeper was already moving too.

He did not stand up. He did not turn to face Cinder. He did not reach for a weapon. He did the only thing left for him to do.

He opened the chest.

The lid came up. The faint green glow of something lining its underside flickered and went dark, satisfied. Inside, in the dark, there were four things.

A folded sheet of paper, covered in cramped untidy writing.

A lute, dark wood and ivory pegs, lying on its back.

A small box of dark wood, smooth and polished, about the size of a loaf of bread. No lid. No lock. No seams. Humming.

And lying across all of them, glowing faintly silver in the blue light of Cinder's cold, a cord. Braided from three strands of dark hair. Knotted along its whole length. Hundreds of knots. Looping and twisting and doubling back.

The innkeeper reached in and took hold of it.

And Cinder's pale sword came down.

## Chapter One Hundred Fifty-Five

# Kvothe

The sword did not land.

Chronicler saw it. He would tell it afterward, many times, to many people, and none of them would believe him. But he saw it. The pale sword coming down, fast as a falling star, toward the innkeeper's bowed neck. And then stopping.

Not stopped. Not blocked. Stopping. In the air, a hand's breadth above the innkeeper's red hair. As if it had struck something. Some invisible thing. Some wall.

Cinder's face twisted. He pressed down on the sword with both hands. It did not move.

"No," he said. His soft reasonable voice was not soft anymore. *"No. He said I could not kill you. He never said I could not stop you."*

The innkeeper did not look up. He was kneeling in front of the open chest with the knotted cord in his hands. His head was bowed over it. His lips were moving.

"It's not me," he said quietly. "It's not my doing. It's the name." He did not look up. "It's been locked away for seven years. It's very angry. And it knows you." He was quiet for a moment. "It remembers your hand on my wrist. At the Eolian. In the burning camp. It remembers Tempi. It remembers Stanchion." He looked up, at last, at the pale sword hanging in the air above him. "It's not going to let you touch me again."

\* \* \*

He looked down at the cord in his hands.

His fingers were moving on it. Slowly. Carefully. Finding the knots, one by one. Looping and twisting and undoing.

"She taught me," he said, very softly, as if he were talking to himself. "In the Grey Man. The first time. I forgot, for a long time. But the story brought it back." His fingers found a knot and loosened it. "This one says *road*. And this one says *promise*. And this one—" His fingers stopped. "This one says my name."

He began to untie it.

\* \* \*

Chronicler would try, afterward, to describe what happened next. He would try in taverns, and in the great halls of lords, and in the quiet of his own rooms, late at night, with a pen in his hand and a blank page in front of him. He would try for the rest of his life.

He never succeeded. There were no words. There are no words.

But he saw it. He was sitting on the narrow bed in the innkeeper's room, with the pages of the story scattered around his feet, and he saw it.

The cord came undone.

Knot by knot. Loop by loop. The innkeeper's fingers moved through it, quickly now, surely, the way a musician's fingers move through a song he has known all his life. And as each knot came undone, something came out of it.

Light.

A thread of silver light. Very thin. Very bright. It came out of the loosened knots and hung in the frozen air above the chest, trembling, shining, getting longer and longer as each knot came undone. It was the most beautiful thing Chronicler had ever seen. It was like moonlight on water. It was like the last note of a song. It was like a name, spoken aloud for the first time in a very long time.

And it was moving toward the innkeeper.

Slowly. Gently. The way water moves toward the sea. The silver thread drifted through the cold air toward the kneeling man, toward his chest, toward the place over his heart. And where it touched him, it



went in.

\* \* \*

The innkeeper gasped.

It was not a sound of pain. Or not only pain. It was the sound a man makes when he comes up out of deep water, after holding his breath for a very long time. It was the sound of the first breath.

His back arched. His head went back. His hands, still full of the knotted cord, clenched. And the silver thread of his name poured into him, faster now, a river of light, going into his chest and filling him the way water fills a cup.

And the color came back.

Chronicler saw it. He saw it come back into the room. Into the world. It had been grey, all of it, since Cinder came in. Grey frost, and grey light, and grey faces. He had not noticed. He had thought it was only the blue candles, the cold. But it was not. It was the innkeeper. The emptiness in him had been so large that it had pressed on everything around it, and made it grey.

And now it was filling. And the color was coming back.

The red of the innkeeper's hair. Red, true red, the color of a flame that has been burning for a long time and means to burn for a long while yet. The green of his eyes. The dark reddish black of the roach wood. The silver of the thread, pouring into him. The gold of the lute's ivory pegs, catching the light.

And the fire.

\* \* \*

It came up out of him like a wave.

Chronicler felt it. Even sitting on the bed, a pace away, he felt it. Heat. Real heat. The first real heat he had felt since the frost came. It came off the innkeeper the way cold came off Cinder, in waves, like heat off a forge.

The frost on the floor around him began to melt.

It went from white to grey to clear, and then it was water, spreading out across the boards in a widening circle. The frost on the

walls began to drip. The frost on the shutters. The ice on the washstand cracked and slid.

And the pale sword, hanging in the air above the innkeeper's head, began to smoke.

Cinder cried out. He let go of it. He stepped back, fast, with his hands held up in front of him, and Chronicler saw that the palms of his hands were red. Blistered. Burned.

The pale sword fell. It struck the floor beside the chest with a sound like breaking glass. Where it landed, the water hissed.

\* \* \*

The last knot came undone.

The last of the silver thread poured out of it and into the innkeeper's chest. And the cord in his hands was only a cord now. A length of dark braided hair. Empty.

He knelt very still in front of the open chest, with his head bowed and the empty cord in his hands.

The room was silent. Utterly silent. The frost was gone. The water was dripping. The blue light of Cinder's cold was fading, flickering, guttering, like a candle in a draft.

Then the innkeeper lifted his head.

And Chronicler looked at him, and saw a stranger.

\* \* \*

It was the same face. The same red hair and green eyes, the same bruises on the jaw and the same scar on the cheek. Nothing about it had changed.

And everything had changed.

It was like the difference between a painting of a fire and a fire. The same shape. The same colors. But one of them was only paint on a wall, and the other was burning.

He was burning.

Not with flame. Not with anything Chronicler could see. But he was burning, from the inside, the way a lantern burns. His green eyes were bright. So bright they were almost hard to look at. His face was

alive. Every line of it was alive, every shadow, every muscle. He looked, Chronicler thought, like a man who has been asleep for seven years and has just woken up, and is not yet sure whether the world he has woken into is real.

He looked down at his hands. At the empty cord in them. At the thin pale scar around his left wrist, like a bracelet.

He flexed his fingers. Slowly. One at a time.

Then he looked up. At Chronicler. At the room. At the frost melting on the walls and the water dripping from the shutters and the blue light fading.

At Cinder, standing by the door with his burned hands held up in front of him and his black eyes wide.

"Oh," said the man who had been Kote.

His voice was different too. Not the flat, toneless voice of the innkeeper. Not the warm, rich, storytelling voice of the last three days. Something else. Something deeper. Something that filled the room the way the silver thread had filled him.

"Oh," he said again, softly. "*There* I am."

\* \* \*

He stood up.

He did it slowly. Carefully. The way a man stands up who has been kneeling for a long time, and is not sure his legs will hold him. He stood in front of the open chest, with the empty cord in one hand, and he looked around the small room. At the narrow bed, and the washstand, and the window. At the frost melting on the shutters. At Chronicler, sitting frozen on the bed with the pages of the story scattered around his feet.

He looked at Chronicler for a long moment.

"Thank you," he said.

Chronicler could not speak. He stared up at the man standing in front of him, and he could not say a single word.

The man who had been Kote smiled. It was a small smile. Crooked. A little sad. But it was real. It went all the way up to his eyes, and his eyes were burning.

"Three days," he said. "Three days of listening. Three days of writing it down. Every word." He looked down at the scattered pages. "You didn't just record it. You kept it. You held it, while I found my way back to it." He looked at Chronicler. "That's what a name needs. Someone to hold it."

He looked down at the empty cord in his hand. Then he folded it very carefully, and put it in the inside pocket of his shirt, over his heart. Beside something else. Something small, on a thread, that had been there a very long time.

Then he turned to face Cinder.

\* \* \*

Cinder had not moved. He was standing by the door with his burned hands held up in front of him. His black eyes were wide. His crooked scarred face was very still.

The two of them looked at each other across the small room for a long time.

"Kvothe," said Cinder at last. Softly.

"Ferule," said Kvothe.

Cinder flinched.

It was a small movement. Barely a movement at all. A tightening of the shoulders. A narrowing of the eyes. But Chronicler saw it. And so, he thought, did Kvothe.

"You know my name," said Cinder.

"I know your name." Kvothe's voice was very quiet. "I heard it first from a trapper in the Medica, with your hand frozen into his arm. And then I heard it spoken three times more. By Haliar, in the Eolian. By Haliar, on a ridge above a burning camp. By Haliar, in the chamber beneath the Lackless house. And then by me, telling the story, where it went back into me with everything else." He took a step forward. "I didn't know what it meant, when I heard it. I didn't know it was your true name. I thought it was only what he called you." Another step. "But I know now."

Cinder took a step back. His back was against the door frame.

"You're the key again," he said. His voice had lost its softness. It was high and thin and cracked. "You know that. Don't you? You've got your name back. The whole line is in you again. The door can hear you. The Thief can hear you." His crooked smile flickered. "He'll come. The lord. He'll come for you himself, now. You'll never be safe again. Not anywhere. Not ever."

"I know."

"You were safe. For seven years. Hiding behind your little stone, with your little name." Cinder's voice rose. "And you threw it away. For what? For a scribe? For a Fae princeling bleeding on your floor? For a town full of farmers who don't even know your name?"

Kvothe looked at him for a long moment.

"Yes," he said.

\* \* \*

Downstairs, very faintly, someone moaned.

Kvothe's face changed. Just for a moment. Something went across it, quick and fierce and cold.

"Bast," he said.

He looked at Cinder. And his green eyes were not burning anymore. They were something else. Something colder. Something that Chronicler had seen once before, on the first night, when the innkeeper looked at the sword above the hearth.

It was the Heart of Stone.

"Get out of my way," said Kvothe.

Cinder stood in the doorway with his back against the frame. His black eyes were very wide. His burned hands were raised in front of him.

"*Make me*," he whispered.

Kvothe looked at him.

Then he opened his mouth, and spoke Cinder's name.

## Interlude: Ferule

It was not the name *Ferule*.

Chronicler would understand that later, much later, when he had time to think about it. *Ferule* was what Haliax called him. It was a name, the way *Cinder* was a name, the way *Kote* had been a name. Something to be called by. Something small.

What Kvothe spoke, standing in the small cold room at the top of the stairs of the Waystone Inn, was something else.

It was not a word. Chronicler could not have written it down, not in his cipher or in Aturan or in any language that has letters. It was a sound, but not only a sound. It was a shape. A long, winding, intricate shape, like a melody, like a knot, like the path a river takes through a valley. It came out of Kvothe's mouth and filled the room, and the room seemed to lean toward it, the way a flower leans toward the sun.

And it was beautiful.

That was the thing that Chronicler would never forget, and never be able to explain. Cinder's name was beautiful. It was the most beautiful thing he had ever heard. It was like the first line of a song he had loved as a child and forgotten. It was like the sound of someone singing in a great hall, a very long time ago, with people come from all over the world to listen.

Cinder heard it.

He went very still. His burned hands, raised in front of him, dropped to his sides. His black eyes went wide. His crooked scarred face went slack.

"No," he whispered. "No. No. *Not that one. Not that one. No one knows that one.*"

"I know it," said Kvothe quietly.

"How?"

"A woman in a forest told me," said Kvothe. "A long time ago. On the Moon's Road, beside a spring. She kissed my wrist where you'd held it, and she told me who you'd been." He was quiet for a moment. "She said you had the most beautiful voice. She said you sang at the Thief's court, before the war. She said people came from all over the world to hear you." He looked at Cinder. "I didn't understand, then. I didn't know what she was giving me. I only heard a story." He paused. "But stories are names too. The oldest kind."

\* \* \*

He began to sing.

Not *Tariniel*. Not any song Chronicler had ever heard. It had no words, or none that Chronicler could understand. It was Cinder's name, the beautiful winding shape of it, sung. Slowly. Softly. The way a mother sings to a child who cannot sleep.

And as he sang, Chronicler saw things.

He did not know how. He was sitting on the narrow bed in the innkeeper's room, with the pages of the story scattered around his feet, and he was seeing things that were not in the room. Things that were not anywhere. Things that had not been anywhere for ten thousand years.

He saw a great hall. Bigger than any hall in the world. With a ceiling of stars. And in the center of it, on a stage of white stone, a young man was singing.

He was tall and pale and very beautiful, with hair the color of frost and eyes that were not black. They were grey. Grey like the sky before snow. And his voice—

Chronicler had no words for his voice.

He saw the young man singing. He saw the crowd listening. Thousands of them. Tens of thousands. Men and women and things that were not men or women, from every corner of a world that no

longer existed. He saw them weeping. He saw them laughing. He saw them sitting very still, with their faces turned up toward the stage, the way people sit when they are hearing something they will remember for the rest of their lives.

And he saw, at the back of the hall, on a great dark throne, a figure watching. Tall and dark and terrible, with something behind its eyes that Chronicler could not look at. Something hungry. Something that wanted.

And he saw the figure lean forward, and whisper something to the young man with the frost-colored hair, after the song was done.

And he saw the young man's face change.

\* \* \*

Kvothe sang.

He sang the young man's choice. He sang the war that followed. He sang the young man going with the Thief, and with Lanre, and with the others. Not because he was wicked. Not because he wanted to. Because he had been promised something. Because he had been told that if he helped, if he fought, if he did what was asked, he would have a hall of his own someday. A hall with a ceiling of stars. Where he could sing forever, and people would come from every corner of the world to hear him, and no one would ever tell him to stop.

He sang the curse.

He sang Selitos, standing among the ashes of Myr Tariniel with his bleeding eye, speaking the words that bound the seven. He sang the young man's voice going cold. Going silent. He sang the frost coming into him, from the inside, the way frost comes into a pond in winter. Freezing the song. Freezing the voice. Freezing everything he had ever been.

He sang the young man never singing again.

\* \* \*

Cinder was on his knees.

Chronicler did not see him fall. He was simply there, on his knees on the wet floor of the innkeeper's room, with his burned hands



pressed against his face. His shoulders were shaking.

He was weeping.

Chronicler had not known that the Chandrian could weep. He had not known that anything so cold could make a sound so broken. It was a thin high keening sound, like wind through a crack in a wall, like ice breaking on a winter lake.

Kvothe stopped singing.

The room was silent except for the sound of Cinder weeping.

"You remember," said Kvothe quietly.

"*Stop*," whispered Cinder through his hands. "*Stop it. Please. Please stop.*"

"You remember what you were. Before. What you wanted. What you gave up." Kvothe's voice was very gentle. "It hurts. Doesn't it? The way it hurts him, when someone sings his story true. That's the curse. That's what Selitos did to all of you. Not just the cold. Not just the signs. The remembering. Every time someone sings it true, you remember." He was quiet for a moment. "That's why you kill the singers. Not because the songs are dangerous. Because they hurt."

"*Please.*"

"I'm not going to kill you," said Kvothe.

Cinder went very still.

"I could," said Kvothe. "I know your name. I could speak it with anger, the way Selitos spoke Lanre's, and I could unmake you. Or try." He looked down at the weeping thing on the floor. "I've wanted to since I was eleven years old. Since I came back through the woods and found my family dead, and you crouching in front of me with your black eyes and your smile." His voice did not change. "I've wanted it more than I've ever wanted anything."

Cinder did not move.

"But Selitos did that," said Kvothe. "A long time ago. He spoke a name in anger. And he's been sitting in a tower in the ruins of a white city for ten thousand years, wondering if he was right." He was quiet for a moment. "I don't want to sit in a tower. I've already sat in an inn for seven years. That was enough."

\* \* \*

He knelt down. On the wet floor, in front of Cinder. So that their faces were level.

Cinder took his hands away from his face. His black eyes were wet. His crooked scarred face was twisted with grief.

"Go," said Kvothe. "Go now. Out of this house. Out of this town. Take your cold with you." He looked into Cinder's black eyes. "And don't come back. Not here. Not to anyone I love. Not ever."

"Or?" Cinder's voice was a thread.

Kvothe looked at him for a long moment.

"Or I'll sing it again," he said quietly. "All of it. The whole of it. In a great hall, before a thousand people. Your song. The one about the young man with the frost-colored hair and the most beautiful voice in the world." He paused. "And I'll put in the part about the grey eyes. And the ceiling of stars. And the promise."

Cinder stared at him.

"And everyone who hears it," said Kvothe, "will remember you. The way you were. Before. They'll remember you singing. And they'll weep for you." His voice was very soft. "Every time. For the rest of your life. Which is to say, forever."

\* \* \*

Cinder looked at him for a very long time.

Then he got up. Slowly. Unsteadily. The way a man gets up who has been very ill, or very drunk, or very badly hurt. He stood in the small wet room with his burned hands hanging at his sides and his black eyes wet and his scarred face slack.

He looked at Kvothe. He looked at Chronicler, sitting on the bed. He looked at the open chest, with the lute and the box and the folded paper inside it. He looked at the pale sword, lying broken on the floor.

He did not pick it up.

"He'll come," he said. His voice was very quiet. Not soft. Not reasonable. Just quiet. Tired. "The lord. He'll come for you himself, now. You know he will."

"I know."

"And the others. Usnea. Stercus. The rest." Cinder shook his head slowly. "They won't be as easy as me. They don't have—" He stopped. "They don't have songs. Not anymore. They've forgotten them."

"Then I'll find them," said Kvothe. "The songs. I'll find them, and I'll learn them, and I'll sing them." He paused. "Every one."

Cinder looked at him for a long moment. Something moved in his black eyes. It was there and gone so quickly that Chronicler almost missed it.

It might have been fear.

It might have been hope.

Then he turned and walked out of the room, and down the stairs, and out of the Waystone Inn. Chronicler heard his footsteps, slow and uneven, crossing the common room. He heard the door. And then nothing.

The last of the blue light guttered out.

And every candle in the Waystone Inn burned yellow.

\* \* \*

Kvothe was already moving.

He was down the stairs before Chronicler could stand up from the bed. Chronicler followed, stumbling, his legs stiff with cold. He came down into the common room and stopped at the foot of the stairs.

The frost was gone. The floor was wet, puddled everywhere with melted ice. The fire in the great stone hearth was burning yellow, bright and warm. Real warmth. Chronicler felt it on his face like a hand.

The door was standing open. Beyond it, the night was very dark and very still. There was no frost on the porch.

And in the middle of the common room, in a pool of melted frost and blood, Bast was lying on his side.

Kvothe was kneeling beside him.

\* \* \*

He had Bast's head in his lap. He had one hand pressed against the wound in Bast's side. There was blood everywhere. On the floor, on Bast's clothes, on Kvothe's hands. Very red. Very bright. Too much of it.

Bast's eyes were open. They were not black anymore. They were deep blue, the color of the sky just after sunset. They were looking up at Kvothe's face.

"Reshi," he whispered.

"I'm here."

"You're—" Bast's voice was very faint. "You're back. Aren't you? You're really back."

"I'm back."

Bast looked up at him for a long moment. Then he smiled. A small, weak, crooked smile.

"I knew it," he whispered. "I knew you would. I knew—"

His eyes began to close.

"No," said Kvothe. "No, Bast. Stay awake. Stay with me."

"I'm tired, Reshi."

"I know. I know you are. Stay with me anyway."

Bast's eyes fluttered. His breathing was very shallow.

Kvothe looked down at the wound in his side. At the blood coming out between his fingers. His face was very still.

Then he closed his eyes.

\* \* \*

Chronicler did not know what he did. He would never know, not exactly. He knelt on the wet floor a few paces away and watched, and he did not understand.

He saw Kvothe's lips move. He saw his hand, pressed against the wound, begin to glow. Very faintly. A soft warm golden light, like candlelight through a window.

He felt the air change. Tighten. The way air tightens before a storm.

He heard Kvothe speak. Very softly. Words Chronicler did not know. Not names, he thought. Something else. Something smaller.

The kind of words a sympathist uses, binding one thing to another, making them the same.

"*Blood to blood,*" Chronicler heard. "*Mine to his. Skin to skin. Closed. Closed. Closed.*"

The golden light brightened. Just a little.

And Bast gasped.

It was a small sound. A sharp intake of breath. His eyes flew open. His back arched. His hand came up and clutched at Kvothe's wrist.

And then he went limp.

And then, very slowly, he began to breathe. Deeper. Steadier. The shallow fluttering breaths of a dying man giving way to the slow even breaths of a man asleep.

Kvothe took his hand away from the wound.

It was closed. Not healed. There was still blood, and a long angry red line where the pale sword had gone in. But it was closed. The skin had drawn together over it, the way skin draws together over a wound after many days of healing.

Kvothe looked down at it. His face was grey with effort. His hands were shaking.

But he was smiling.

"Sympathy," he said. His voice was hoarse. "It's been seven years. I didn't know if I still could." He looked down at his own left wrist. At the thin pale scar around it. At a fresh cut, just below the scar, bleeding slowly. "Blood to blood. The oldest binding there is. I gave him some of mine. To close the hole." He laughed, very weakly. "Arwyl would have my hide. It's not a thing they teach in the Medica."

"Will he live?" said Chronicler.

Kvothe looked down at Bast, sleeping in his lap with his dark hair across his face.

"Yes," he said. "He'll live. He's very stubborn. And he owes me a life. The old kind." He brushed the hair out of Bast's eyes. "He's not allowed to die until he's paid it."

\* \* \*

They sat there for a long time, on the wet floor of the common room, in the warm yellow light of the fire. Kvothe, with Bast's head in his lap. Chronicler, a few paces away, with his back against the leg of a table and his hands, which could feel again, lying open in his lap.

Nobody said anything.

Outside, beyond the open door, the night was very dark and very still. Somewhere far off, a dog was barking. Somewhere closer, an owl called, and was answered.

And somewhere, very far away, beyond the fields and the woods and the dark, a thin grey line of smoke that had been leaning all day toward the Waystone Inn straightened, and thinned, and blew away on a wind that had not been there before.

It was a warm wind. It smelled of rain.

## Interlude: Dawn

The people of Newarre came out of the little stone church at dawn.

They came slowly, cautiously, the way people come out after a storm. Carter first, with his wife and his children behind him, blinking in the grey light. Then Graham, with a cudgel in his hand. Then Old Cob, leaning on his stick. Then Jake, carrying Tam, who was nearly too big to carry now and was asleep on his father's shoulder anyway. Then the rest of them. The miller and his wife. Baxter the smith. Rena the widow. Shep's widow, and her sister. Aaron, the smith's apprentice, with an iron bar in his hand and his young face set and pale.

They stood in the churchyard among the graves and looked around them. At the grey sky, paling in the east. At the grey fields. At the grey road.

There was no frost.

That was the first thing they noticed. The whole night, the frost had crept. Across the fields, across the road, up the walls of the church. They had watched it through the windows, white and feathery, spreading. They had heard things, in the dark, beyond the walls. Footsteps on frozen grass. A voice, very soft, very cold, saying words they did not understand.

And now it was gone. The grass in the churchyard was wet and green. The road was mud. The air was cool and damp and smelled of rain.

"It's gone," said Carter. His voice was hoarse. "Whatever it was. It's gone."

"The cows," said his wife. "Go and look at the cows."

Carter went. He came back an hour later, walking slowly, with his face very strange.

"They're dead," he said. "All eleven. Lying in the field. But they're not frozen anymore." He shook his head. "They're just dead. Like they died of old age. In their sleep."

Nobody said anything.

"The Waystone," said Aaron suddenly. "Kote. I went there last night, to tell him. He wouldn't come. He said he knew what it was. He said it was looking for something." He looked at the others. "He said it wasn't looking for us."

They looked at each other.

Then, without anyone saying anything, they began to walk toward the Waystone Inn.

\* \* \*

The door was open.

That was the first thing they saw, coming up the road in the grey dawn light. The door of the Waystone, standing open. And inside, a fire burning in the great stone hearth. Yellow. Warm. They could feel the warmth of it from the yard.

And they could hear something.

Music.

It was coming from inside the inn. Very faint. A lute. Someone was playing a lute.

They stopped in the yard. All of them. They stood among the puddles in the grey light and listened.

It was a slow song. A sad song. The melody rose and fell like wind in trees. It was the most beautiful thing any of them had ever heard. More beautiful than the bard who had come through, years ago, with his bright red cloak and his confidence. More beautiful than the priest's choir on Mourning Day. More beautiful than anything.

Shep's widow began to weep.

She did not know why. She stood in the yard of the Waystone Inn, in the grey dawn light, with her sister's arm around her, and she



wept. The music went into her. Through her. Down and down, into the place where Shep had been, where nothing had been since the night the stranger came. And it found something there. Not Shep. Something else. Something like him. The shape of him. The warmth.

"That's it," she whispered. "That's the song. The one Aaron sang. *Tariniel*." She was shaking. "That's the whole of it."

\* \* \*

They went in.

Slowly. Quietly. The way you go into a church. They came through the open door into the common room of the Waystone Inn and stopped just inside, in a crowd, and stared.

The floor was wet. Puddled everywhere, as if someone had spilled a great deal of water. There were dark stains on the boards near the center of the room. There were broken bottles behind the bar.

At a table by the hearth, a man with a neat beard and ink-stained fingers was sitting very still, with a great untidy stack of paper in front of him. His face was pale and his eyes were red. He did not look up when they came in.

On a bench against the wall, a young man with dark hair was lying on his back, asleep, with a blanket over him. His face was very pale. His shirt was dark with dried blood. But he was breathing, slow and even.

And on a stool beside the great stone hearth, in the warm yellow light of the fire, the innkeeper was sitting with a lute in his lap.

He was playing.

\* \* \*

They did not know him.

That was what they said afterward, when they told the story. And they did tell it, all of them, for the rest of their lives. In the Waystone and in the church and in their own houses, around their own fires, to their children and their grandchildren. They told it a hundred times, and every time they told it, they said the same thing.

They did not know him.

It was Kote. It was the innkeeper. The same red hair and green eyes. The same bruises on the jaw. The same scar on the cheek. They had seen that face every night for seven years, behind the bar, pouring drinks and polishing glasses and saying the right thing.

But it was not Kote.

It was like the difference between a painting of a fire and a fire. The same shape. The same colors. But one of them was only paint on a wall, and the other was burning.

He was burning.

He sat on the stool beside the hearth with the lute in his lap and his head bowed over it and his eyes closed, and he played. His fingers moved on the strings like water, like wind, like flame. And the music came out of him and filled the room, filled the whole inn, and poured out through the open door into the grey morning.

He was playing *Tariniel*.

\* \* \*

He did not look up when they came in. He did not stop playing. He played the white city on the last day of its life. The towers, and the gardens, and the fountains full of children. He played Lanre, and Lyra, and the Thief's whisper in the dark. He played Myr Tariniel burning. He played Selitos weeping among the ruins.

And he played the child. The boy in the fountain. Asking to be a singer.

He played it slowly. Much slower than the bard had played it, years before. Like a child playing. Not like a march.

And when he came to the last line, he did not sing it like an ending. He sang it like a beginning.

*A singer. Like my mother. So that no one will forget.*

\* \* \*

The last note hung in the air for a long moment. Trembling. Then it faded.

The common room of the Waystone Inn was silent.

Nobody moved. Nobody spoke. They stood just inside the door, the people of Newarre, in a crowd, with their faces wet and their hands still. The fire crackled in the hearth. Somewhere outside, a bird was singing.

The innkeeper lifted his head. He opened his eyes. He looked at them.

His eyes were green. Very green. Burning.

"Good morning," he said.

His voice was different too. Not the flat, mild voice of the innkeeper. Something deeper. Something that filled the room.

Nobody answered.

Then Shep's widow came forward. Slowly. Through the crowd. She stopped in front of the innkeeper's stool and looked at him. Her face was wet with tears.

"You told me," she said. "Last night. I asked you. If you ever heard the whole of it. The song. You said you'd tell me." Her voice cracked. "You said *if*."

"I did."

"You knew it. All along. You knew the whole of it."

The innkeeper looked at her for a long moment.

"No," he said gently. "Not all along. I forgot it, for a while. A long while." He looked down at the lute in his lap. "But I remember now."

She looked at him. At his red hair, and his green eyes, and the lute in his lap.

"Who are you?" she whispered.

The innkeeper was quiet for a long time.

Then he stood up. He set the lute down very carefully on the stool. He looked around the room at the people of Newarre, crowded just inside the door. At Graham, with his cudgel. At Old Cob, leaning on his stick. At Jake, with Tam asleep on his shoulder. At Carter, and his wife, and his children. At Aaron, the smith's apprentice, with his iron bar and his young face pale and set.

At Aaron, most of all.

Aaron was staring at him. His face was very white. His mouth was open.

"You're him," Aaron whispered. "Aren't you? You're really him."

The innkeeper looked at him for a long moment. Then he smiled. It was a small smile, crooked, a little sad. But it was real.

"My name is Kvothe," he said.

\* \* \*

Nobody spoke.

It was the silence that comes after something so large that no one knows how to answer it. The silence of a crowd that has just been told the sky is a lid, or the ground is the back of a sleeping beast. It went on and on.

Then Old Cob made a sound. A sort of wheezing cough. And said, into the silence, with the air of a man playing a trump card:

"I *knew* it. I said so. Didn't I say so? Years ago. I said he had red hair."

Graham turned and looked at him. "You said he was a demon. With horns."

"I said he *might* have horns. I never said he definitely had horns."

"You said he killed the king with a word."

"Well," said Old Cob, with great dignity, "didn't he?"

Everyone turned and looked at the innkeeper.

He looked back at them. At Old Cob, and Graham, and all the rest. At their faces, pale and astonished and a little afraid.

And he laughed.

It was a real laugh. Sudden and bright and startled, like a bird taking flight. It burst out of him the way the music had, from somewhere very far down. He laughed until his eyes were wet, standing in the middle of the common room of the Waystone Inn, with the fire behind him and the sword on the wall above his head.

And after a moment, very uncertainly, the people of Newarre began to laugh with him.

\* \* \*

He told them. Not all of it. Not the way he had told Chronicler, over three days, with every piece in its place. That would have taken too long, and there were things in it that were not for farmers and millers and smiths.

But he told them enough. He told them who he was, and what he had done, and why he had come to Newarre. He told them about the chest, and the stone at the crossroads, and the little name a girl had given him to wear. He told them about the thing that had come in the night, with its cold and its frost and its crooked scarred face, and what he had done to send it away.

He told them about the door. And the crack. And the scrael, and the skin dancer, and the things that were coming through.

And he told them he had to leave.

\* \* \*

"Leave?" said Graham. His big slow face was stricken. "Why? You just—you just got back. Whoever you are."

"Because they'll come," said Kvothe. "The others. The ones like the thing that came last night. They'll come looking for me. They can hear me now. I'm very loud." He looked around the room. "If I stay here, they'll come here. To Newarre. To you."

"We'll fight them," said Aaron fiercely. "We've got iron. I can make more. Swords. Spears. Whatever you need."

Kvothe looked at him. His face was very gentle.

"I know you would," he said. "You already have. You saved my life once, Aaron. With an iron firedog, against a thing that had taken Shep." He looked at the boy for a long moment. "I never thanked you."

Aaron went red to the roots of his hair.

"But I won't let you do it again," said Kvothe. "Not for me. Not here." He looked around at all of them. "This was a quiet place. A small place. That's why I came. And I want it to stay that way. For you. For your children." He looked at Tam, asleep on Jake's shoulder. "It's a good thing, to be small and quiet. I didn't understand that, before. I do now."

"Where will you go?" said Shep's widow.

Kvothe was quiet for a long moment.

"To the door," he said at last. "The one I closed. It's cracked. Things are coming through. I need to find a way to close it all the way." He paused. "And there's an old man in a tower in the mountains, who's been waiting a very long time for someone to come back and sing him a song. I told him I'd come, if I ever found the other way."

"The other way?"

"To end the curse. Without opening the door." Kvothe smiled faintly. "I haven't found it yet. But I think I might know where to start looking."

\* \* \*

He gave the inn to Aaron.

He did it that afternoon, in front of everyone. He took a sheet of paper from Chronicler's satchel and a pen, and he wrote it out in a clear strong hand. *The Waystone Inn, with all its furniture and fixtures, its stock and its stores, its stable and its yard, to Aaron, apprentice smith of Newarre, freely given.* And he signed it. Not Kote. His other name. His real one.

Aaron stared at the paper. Then at him.

"I can't," he said. "I'm a smith. I don't know anything about running an inn."

"Neither did I," said Kvothe. "When I came here. I learned." He smiled. "Graham will help you. And Old Cob will tell you everything you're doing wrong. And the regulars will come every night whether the stew is good or not, because there's nowhere else to go." He put his hand on Aaron's shoulder. "You'll be fine."

"But why me?"

Kvothe looked at him for a long moment.

"Because you picked up the iron," he said. "When everyone else ran, or froze, you picked up the iron and you used it. You didn't know what the thing was. You didn't know if it would work. You just did it, because someone had to." He squeezed Aaron's shoulder. "That's the kind of person who should keep a waystone. Someone who knows how to say no."

\* \* \*

He did not take the chest.

He took what was in it. The lute. The folded paper with Sim's terrible poem on it, which he read, sitting by the fire in the afternoon, and laughed at until he wept. A second folded page, torn from a moneylender's ledger, which he read after the poem, and laughed at, and wept over, and held for a long time. The small box of dark wood with no lid and no lock, which hummed in his hands, and which he wrapped in an oiled cloth and put in the bottom of his pack. And beneath the box, last of all, a yellowed letter in a quick, slanting, careless hand, which he did not read in front of anyone.

But he left the chest where it was. At the foot of the bed in the room at the top of the stairs. Empty. With its two open locks and the empty place between them where a knot had been.

"It's done its work," he said to Chronicler, when Chronicler asked. "It held me. For seven years. It held the thing I couldn't carry." He was quiet for a moment. "Let it rest now. It's earned it."

\* \* \*

And that afternoon, before the regulars came, he asked Chronicler for the pages.

All of them. Three days of pages, stacked a hand's breadth high. He sat at the corner table by the fire with the stack in front of him and a pen in his hand, and he read them through. Slowly. From the beginning. Chronicler sat across from him and did not say anything, and watched him read.

He did not change anything. Chronicler was very clear about that, afterward, to anyone who asked. He did not strike out a single word. But here and there, in the margins and on the backs of pages and on fresh sheets tucked in between, he added things. Small things. The things that had come back with his name, that he had not had to give when he was telling it. What a letter had said, at the bottom of a chest. What a moneylender had written on a page torn from her ledger. What a knot in a lock had whispered, on a night in spring.

"You told it without them," said Chronicler. "Why add them now?"

Kvothe did not look up from the page.

"Because I didn't know them then," he said. "I only knew that they were there. The way you know there's a step at the bottom of a dark stair." He dipped his pen. "Now I know. And a story should be told the whole way. You said so yourself."

\* \* \*

And he took down the sword.

He did it last, in the evening, when the regulars had come in for their supper and were crowded around the bar, drinking Aaron's first beer and telling Aaron everything he was doing wrong. He climbed up on a chair in front of the great stone hearth and reached up and lifted the sword off its two iron pegs.

The common room went quiet. Everyone watched.

He held it in his hands for a long time. A long straight blade, grey and plain, with a simple hilt wrapped in leather. He looked at it the way a man looks at a letter he has read so many times that the paper has gone soft at the folds.

Then he climbed down off the chair. He looked at the plaque on the wall, beneath the empty pegs. Dark oak, with a single word burned into it.

*FOLLY.*

"Leave that," said Graham quietly, from the bar. "Please. Leave the plaque. I made it."

Kvothe looked at him. Then he looked at the plaque again.

"All right," he said. "I'll leave it."

"What'll you call it now?" said Old Cob. "The sword. It's not on the wall anymore. Is it still Folly?"

Kvothe looked down at the blade in his hands for a long moment.

"Yes," he said at last. "It's still Folly. It always will be." He slid it into its sheath. "But folly isn't always a bad thing. Sometimes it's the only thing that gets anything done."

He buckled it on.



\* \* \*

Bast woke that evening. He opened his eyes on the bench against the wall, with the blanket over him, and saw Kvothe standing in the middle of the common room with the sword at his hip and the lute on his back and his pack over his shoulder.

He stared at him for a long time.

"Reshi," he said at last. His voice was very weak. "You're going."

"We're going," said Kvothe. "When you can walk."

Bast looked at him. His deep blue eyes were very bright.

"Where?"

"North, first. To the Stormwal. There's an old man in a tower who told me he'd like to hear a song." Kvothe smiled. "And then the door. And then—" He shrugged. "Wherever the road goes."

Bast was quiet for a long moment. Then he sat up, very slowly, wincing, with his hand pressed to his side.

"I can walk," he said.

"You can't."

"I can. Watch me." He swung his legs off the bench. He stood up. He swayed, and caught himself on the table, and stood there, white-faced and grinning. "See? Walking."

"That's standing."

"It's the first half of walking." Bast grinned wider. "The rest will come."

Kvothe looked at him. Then he laughed, and crossed the room, and put his arm around Bast's shoulders to hold him up.

"Tomorrow," he said. "At dawn."

"Everything always happens at dawn with you," said Bast. "Have you noticed that? You always leave places at dawn."

"I've noticed," said Kvothe.

## EPILOGUE: A Silence of Three Parts

Dawn came again to the Waystone Inn, and it found the quiet there divided, as it had been three mornings before, into three.

The first part was the silence of a house that has just been left. The fire in the great stone hearth had burned down to a bed of red and grey, and the red was still winning, a little. The chairs sat upside down on the tables, the way they always did at night, but one of them had been turned right side up and pushed back from a table near the hearth, as if someone had been sitting there until the very last moment, and then stood, and gone. There was a cup on the table, empty. There was a scatter of crumbs. There was a single blank sheet of paper, weighted down with a salt cellar, and nothing written on it at all.

It was a warm silence. The silence of a room where people have been, and talked, and laughed, and wept, and will again. The silence of a held breath, not a stopped one.

\* \* \*

The second part was the silence of the town. Of Newarre, and the fields around it, and the road running past the door.

It was a different silence than it had been. For months, for years, the silences of Newarre had been hard ones. The silence of a road where no carts came. The silence of a mother who has heard something in the dark and knows better than to look. The silence of a town that has learned to hold its breath.

This was softer. This was the silence of a town asleep. Of people lying in their beds after a long night, with their doors unbarred and

their children beside them, breathing slow and even. The silence of a field of dead cows that were only dead now, and not frozen, and would be buried properly in the morning. The silence of a road with mud on it instead of frost, and footprints in the mud, two sets, heading north.

It was the silence of a town that had been told a story. And would tell it, over and over, for the rest of its life. And was resting now, before it began.

\* \* \*

The third silence was harder to notice.

If you had walked into the Waystone that morning, you might not have noticed it at all. You might have stood among the upturned chairs and looked at the fire and the empty cup and the blank sheet of paper, and heard only the first two silences, the house and the town, and thought that was all there was.

But it was there. Underneath. It lived in the long bar of dark wood, and in the bottles behind it, the ones that had not cracked in the cold. It lived in the plaque on the wall above the hearth, with a single word burned into it, and the two empty iron pegs above it where a sword had hung. It lived in the room at the top of the stairs, at the foot of the bed, in a chest of roah wood with its lid standing open and its locks undone.

It was not the silence of a man who is waiting.

That silence was gone. It had walked out the door at dawn, with a sword at its hip and a lute on its back and a Fae prince leaning on its shoulder, and it had taken the road north. It had not looked back.

What was left was something else. Something quieter. Something that had been there all along, underneath the waiting, and had only now been uncovered.

It was the silence after a song.

The silence that comes when the last note has faded, and no one has yet moved, and no one has yet spoken. When the song is over, and everyone who heard it is sitting very still, holding it in themselves, not yet ready to let it go.

It was the silence of a story that has been told all the way to its end.

Or as far as the end had gone.

\* \* \*

Outside, across the road, the waystone stood at the crossroads in the grey dawn light. Tall and grey and very old, worn smooth by the wind and the rain and the years. It said its long slow *no* to the world, the way it always had, the way it always would.

And for the first time in seven years, there was nothing beside it for it to hide.

\* \* \*

Upstairs, in the best room the Waystone had to offer, a man named Devan Lochees sat on the edge of his bed with a great untidy stack of paper in his lap, and did not move.

He had not slept. He did not think he would ever sleep again. He sat on the edge of his bed and looked down at the paper. Three days of it. More than three days. The first page was dated in his careful hand, and the last page had no date at all, only a single line of his tiny crabbed cipher, halfway down, and then nothing.

He had written it the night before, after the others had gone to bed. After the innkeeper—after Kvothe—had sat with him by the fire for one last hour, and talked about nothing in particular. The weather. The road. What Chronicler would do with the story, now that he had it.

"Tell it true," Kvothe had said. "That's all I ask. Don't make me better than I was. Don't make me worse. Just tell it the way it happened."

"People won't believe it."

"No." Kvothe had smiled. "They never do. That's all right. Tell it anyway." He had been quiet for a moment. "And leave out the part about the ring. The signet. The tower and three stars. You promised."

"I remember."

"Good." Kvothe had stood up. He had looked down at Chronicler for a long moment, in the firelight. "Thank you, Devan Lochees. For

listening. For holding it. For bringing it up the stairs when I asked." He had smiled, a small crooked smile. "Skarpi chose well."

And then he had gone up to bed, and Chronicler had sat alone by the fire, and written one more line.

He looked at it now, on the last page. His own tiny crabbed cipher. He read it over, and over, and over.

*And that is where the story stops. For now.*

\* \* \*

He did not know, sitting on the edge of his bed with the pages in his lap, what would happen next. He did not know if Kvothe would reach the Stormwal, or the old man in the tower, or the door. He did not know if Kvothe would find the other way, the one that ended the curse without opening the door. He did not know if the others would come, the rest of the Seven, with their rot and their rust and their blue flame. He did not know if Haliar would come himself.

He did not know if a woman with dark hair, somewhere very far away, had felt a knot come undone in the night and known what it meant. He did not know if she would come back. He did not know if Kvothe would look for her, or let her find him.

He did not know if the door would hold.

He did not know anything.

But he knew the story. All of it, from the beginning to here. He knew it the way you know a song you have heard so many times that you can sing it in your sleep. He knew every piece of it, in its place. The brave parts and the terrible parts and the parts that make you laugh when you should not.

And he knew that he would tell it. True. The whole of it.

Because someone had to. Because it had been told to him, and a told story is a trust, and a trust must be kept. Because there was a man walking north on the road in the dawn, with a sword and a lute and a Fae prince leaning on his shoulder, and his name was Kvothe, and his name had been lost and was found again, and someone should remember.

So that no one would forget.

\* \* \*

He stood up. He packed the pages carefully into his satchel, every one. He went downstairs, through the silent common room, past the upturned chairs and the empty cup and the blank sheet of paper weighted down with a salt cellar. He stopped at the door and looked back.

At the fire, burning low. At the long bar of dark wood. At the plaque on the wall, with its two empty pegs.

*FOLLY*, it said.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he went out into the grey morning, and closed the door behind him, and took the road south.

\* \* \*

And behind him, in the Waystone Inn, the three silences settled.

The silence of the house, warm and waiting.

The silence of the town, resting before the telling.

And the silence after the song, holding it, not yet ready to let it go.

It was a good silence. A patient one. The silence of a place where something has ended, and something else has begun.

It was the silence of a man who is no longer waiting to die.

Because he has remembered, at last, what it was he was waiting for.

And gone to find it.

\* \* \*

*Here ends The Doors of Stone.*

*The story is not over.*

*Stories never are.*